



A ROLEPLAYING GAME OF EATEN GODS

THE LONG GRACE

CORE BOOK · REVISED & EXPANDED

SEVEN LANDS · SIX EATEN GODS · ONE THAT IS STILL HUNGRY

WE WERE **HUNGRY.** SAY IT **PLAINLY.** WE WERE
HUNGRY, AND THEY WERE **THERE.**

[FIRST LINE OF EVERY HISTORY WRITTEN ON THE TABLE]

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CHAPTER 1

BEFORE YOU SIT
DOWN

We were hungry. Say it plainly. We were hungry, and they were there.

— FIRST LINE OF EVERY HISTORY WRITTEN ON THE TABLE

My grandmother told it to me the way her grandmother told it to her, with the shutters closed and a crust of bread between us that neither of us was allowed to touch until she had finished.

“There were eight of them,” she said, “and they lived with us the way the weather lives with us. You did not pray to them. You did not need to. You woke up and they were there, as big as the hill behind the house, and they were kind, and they were warm, and they fed us.”

“Then they stopped,” I said, because I knew the story.

“Then everything stopped. Nine years. The seed lay in the furrow like teeth in a dead mouth. The nets came up holding only water. The cows went dry, and then the women did. We boiled harness. We boiled the glue out of the chairs. Your great-great-great-grandfather’s sister ate the clay from the wall in the corner where the fire had baked it sweet, and it set in her like a stone, and she died holding her belly like a woman carrying.” She looked at the crust. “And on the ninth winter we went up the hill with knives.”

“Did they fight?”

“No,” she said. “That is the part nobody can stand. They lay down. They lay down like a dog lies down for the hand it knows, and they let us.”

She told me the rest in a whisper, because it was not a story for children and she was telling it anyway. How the first cut steamed in the snow. How the fat under the skin of a god is yellow as butter and smells of every kitchen you were ever happy in. How the blood did not run so much as well up, slow and warm, and the people knelt in it to keep their knees from freezing. How nobody spoke, and then everybody did, and the sound of a whole village chewing in the dark was like rain on a thatch. How her grandmother’s grandmother had been given a piece no bigger than a thumb, from somewhere near the knuckle, and had wept while she ate it because it was the best thing she had ever tasted and she knew she would never taste it again.

“There were eight,” I said. “You said eight. But there are only seven lands.”

My grandmother picked a crumb off the table and put it on her tongue, slowly, like a woman taking communion, and did not answer, and that was the first time I understood that the story had a hole in it the size of a chair.

She pushed the crust toward me. I said the grace, the way you must: Lack keep away. I ate it. It tasted like bread. It tasted like bread for eleven more years, and then one morning it tasted like something that had been waiting for me.

▼ THE WORLD IN ONE BREATH

Six hundred and forty-one years ago, at the end of a famine that lasted nine years, the peoples of the world killed their gods and ate them. Six peoples did. One refused.

It saved them. It also did not stay down. A god cannot be digested, only delayed. In every land, the god that was eaten is growing back: through the bloodlines of the people who swallowed it, through the soil their dead were buried in, through the weather over their heads. Each land is now a culture living inside the slow, wrong resurrection of its own meal.

The poets of the Table have a name for the age that followed. They call it **the Long Grace**: the pause between the blessing and the first bite, the breath a family holds before it is permitted to eat. Six centuries of borrowed time, while the meal sits in the belly of the world and remembers what it was. Everyone alive is descended from

someone who ate. The monster is in the blood, and it is waking up. The Grace is ending.



The grace is the shortest prayer we have, and the oldest, and the only one everybody still means.

CELEBRANT ABEL CORSE, *SERMONS AT THE RIM*

This book is a complete tabletop roleplaying game set in that world. It contains everything you need to play: the history and lands of the Table, the rules for making and ruining characters, a market to buy and sell in, a gallery of the things that hunt and are hunted, guidance for the person who runs the game, and an adventure to begin with.

▼ THE TABLE AT A GLANCE

The known world is one round continent, a ring around a hole. Six lands that ate their gods sit around the rim; the land that refused lies empty in the middle, and nobody crosses it. Everything that moves between them moves on the **Rim Road**, two thousand two hundred miles of toll highway owned by a merchant company.



Grey fen and black water under a fog called the Breath. The north ate Ossel, the Closing Hand, god of death, and since that night nothing there can finish. A cut throat does not kill; neither does drowning, fire or age. The Kept dead walk, talk and feel every hour of their rot, and outnumber the breathing nine to one. The Hand-line nobility sell the only death available, by license, at the price of a

What follows is the Table as a traveller would sketch it on the back of a toll receipt.

SALLOWREACH

house. Now, near their estates, patches of fen have begun to die all at once, down to the sound.

Said there: “Nobody here is waiting to die. We are all waiting to be allowed.”

THE FATLANDS



Warm, wet plains under a yellow sky, where the ground rises and falls underfoot like something breathing. The south ate Ummer, the Laden, god of harvest, and now the soil is the god’s flesh and grows flesh: wheat with teeth in the ear, fruit with a bone for a pit. All of it is delicious and none of it fills. The dead are served at their own wakes. The Board of Plenty votes by body weight. Each Carving, people walk into the far fields at dusk and are not there in the

morning. The Board says it is wolves. There are no wolves in the Fatlands.

Said there: “There is no word in our dialect for full. We had one. We ate it.”

BRINEHOLLOW



A grey coast of shingle and cliff, beside a sea that retreats a mile a year. The west ate Dromm, the Fathom, and now the sea is inside the people: twice a day their lungs fill with brine that must be coughed into a bucket. On certain nights a person walks into the surf and keeps walking. Some come back weeks later, heavier and courteous, with someone else behind their eyes, and these Tenanted

sit as judges now. The capital is a pier nineteen miles long, chasing water that is not drying up but going somewhere.

Said there: “The sea is not going out. It is going in.”

THE VIGIL



One great city on a stone plateau, lit by ten thousand lamps, where there has been no night for three hundred years. The people ate Iss, the Lidded, god of sleep, and since 341 A.G. anyone who sleeps goes to one shared dream, a long room with a closed eye at the end, and never wakes. So nobody sleeps, by law, by drug, by needle. Marriage

is a promise to pinch. The sleepers lie in sixty thousand numbered beds, breathing in time, and at some number the eye opens. The beds are nearly full.

Said there: “Pinch me.”

CRADLEWRACK



Red-clay highlands, warm to the touch, smelling of iron. The northwest ate Vey, the Opening, god of birth and doors, and now nothing is born right and too much is born: infants who speak, infants born old, adults born mid-stride, single healthy hands. Men bear. Wells bear. Doors will not stay shut. The midwives of the

Attendance rule with a knife called the Second Opinion, and the earthquakes are contractions nine days apart and closing.

Said there: "First we ask what it is. Then we ask whether it stays."

OATHEN



Red canyons under a hard white sky, cities cut into cliff walls, and a silence you can hear a sandal drop into. The east ate Tolm, the Witness, and now words bind flesh: break a promise and your body breaks to match, with a sound. Children are bitted until twelve. Polite speech is mostly exits. Every treaty on the Table is sworn here,

because here it cannot be broken. This year, for the first time in six centuries, the god's promised rain came late.

Said there: "Say less."

THE FAST



The rich heartland at the center: perfect farmland, mild and gold and almost empty. Its people would not eat Orrum, the Host, and nine in ten starved beside a willing meal. Their descendants, the Unfed, carry no god, eat once a day standing, and are insufferably proud. Orrum got up again. It still walks, very tall, stooping under doorways, laying tables wherever it passes. Those who sit do not get up. Lately the tables have place cards, the names spelled correctly, and some have been found in other lands.

Said there: "No, thank you."



Count the chairs before you count the plates. Count them twice if the room is warm.

RIM ROAD INNKEEPERS' SAYING

▼ WHAT KIND OF GAME IS THIS?

The Long Grace is a horror roleplaying game. One player, the **Carver** (the game master, or GM: at a feast on the Table, the Carver is the one who decides who gets which portion), describes the world, plays everyone in it who is not a player character, and adjudicates the rules. Every other player creates and plays one **Guest**: a single person of the Table, with a land, a bloodline, a trade, debts, people they love, and a god in their veins that wants things.

Play is a conversation. The Carver describes a situation; the players say what their characters do; when the outcome is uncertain and matters, dice are rolled. Over a session or a long campaign, the characters investigate, travel the Rim Road, bargain, fight, flee, and make terrible choices, and the story that results belongs to everyone at the table.

It is not a game of heroes. There is no chosen one, no sword that kills a god, no cure that works. The characters are people trying to survive inside a catastrophe that is also their inheritance, and the most important rules in this book measure how their bodies change (**Hunger** and **Regrowth**), how their minds fray (**Fray** and **Derangements**), and what they are willing to do to each other to stay whole for one more day. Characters will be maimed. Characters will go mad. Characters will become something that is not a person anymore. Some of the best sessions you will play are the ones in which that happens.

What the game rewards is attention. The Table is built from small, specific horrors: the smell of cedar on a rich man's sleeve covering the smell beneath it, the neighbor who has stopped calling

her name through the wall at dawn, the extra joint in a nobleman's finger, the chair that is warm when nobody has sat in it. Players who notice those things, and who let their Guests love something enough to be afraid for it, will find the game gives back more than it takes. Most nights.

WHAT YOU NEED

- ◇ This book, or at least its rules chapters and the character sheet at the back.
- ◇ Two ten-sided dice (d10) per player, ideally of two different colors. Several six-sided dice (d6) in a third color: these are **Teeth**, rolled when a character calls on the god inside them.
- ◇ Pencils, erasers, copies of the character sheet, and scrap paper for maps, ledgers, and the names of the dead.
- ◇ Three to six people, one of whom has read the rules and at least the chapter on the land where the game begins.
- ◇ A card with a crossed fork drawn on it, in the middle of the table, for the Grace (see below).
- ◇ A few hours, and a willingness to sit with discomfort.

▼ TEN THINGS EVERY GUEST KNOWS

Every child of the Table learns these before their letters. Guests know them whether or not their players do, and a Carver may simply remind a player of any of them, free, the way a mother would.

- ◇ **Say the grace.** Nobody eats with a stranger without first saying *Lack keep away*. Skipping it is the universal insult, and in some inns the last one you will give.
- ◇ **Never sit at a table you did not see laid.** If the plates are hot and the room is empty, walk out backward. If a chair is pulled out for you, do not thank it.
- ◇ **The god goes where the blood goes.** A Brinehollower in a Sallowreach inn still bails at dawn. A Vigilant in the Fatlands still dares not sleep. You cannot leave your land behind; you are carrying it.
- ◇ **In Sallowreach, “Long life” is a curse.** Say “May you finish,” and mean it kindly. Do not ask the Kept how they are keeping.
- ◇ **In Oathen, say less.** Speak in conditionals. Never exaggerate. Never say “I promise” to a child, and never, ever say “I’d die for you.”
- ◇ **In Cradlewrack, knock.** You knock to warn whatever is on the other side. Do not ask a child its name before its first year is out.

- ◇ **In the Vigil, accept the pin.** A slap is a favor. Do not yawn where anyone can see. Do not lie down, even to die.
- ◇ **In the Fatlands, clean the plate.** Leaving food is a fine; refusing a meal is sedition. Do not ask what it was. Ask whether it was good. It was always good.
- ◇ **In Brinehollow, do not ask a returned person where they went,** and do not mention how anyone sounds when they breathe. If your neighbor does not answer the morning count, go and look, and take a rope.
- ◇ **Count the chairs.** Every old carving on the Table has a place in it that has been chiselled out. Every old table has one chair more than it has people. Nobody will tell you why. Count them anyway.

◇
My mother taught me nine of them. My grandmother taught me the tenth, when she was dying, and made me promise not to teach it to my children until they asked.

A LASTGATE STITCHER, TO A CUTWRIGHT SURVEYOR

▼CONTENT AND CONSENT

This is a game about eating gods and the gods eating back. It is, deliberately, one of the most disturbing settings ever printed for a tabletop game. Before anyone at your table makes a character, everyone should know what is in it.

CONTENT WARNING

The Long Grace contains, described on the page and in sensory detail: graphic body horror and gore (flesh, bone, rot, unwanted transformation); murder, including ritual killing, executions and kin-slaying; torture; cannibalism, both desperate and sacramental; grave desecration and the misuse of the dead; blasphemy and corrupted religion; human sacrifice, including sacrifices that turn out to have been for nothing; self-harm and suicide, presented as tragedy and never as instruction; contagious madness, psychosis, hallucination, paranoia, delusions of being dead or of loved ones being impostors, dissociation and lost time; cult control and gaslighting; starvation; possession; and a cosmology without rescue or redemption.

The setting also touches, thematically and never explicitly, on cursed and incestuous bloodlines, sexual taboo among adults, and desecration of the dead. These elements are always implied, off-page, and adult. Children exist on the Table and suffer its horrors; this book never sexualizes them and never lingers on graphic violence done to them.

Horror is a collaboration. The point of all this darkness is not to wound the people at the table but to let them feel, safely and together, the weight of a world that cannot be saved. That only works if everyone trusts that the game will stop or turn when it needs to. Use the following tools. They are not optional extras; they are part of the rules.

THE PRE-GAME QUESTIONNAIRE

Before the first session, ideally before characters are made, the Carver hands round the list below. Each person privately marks each theme **L** for a Line (it does not appear at all), **V** for a Veil (it happens off-screen: the door closes, the scene cuts away), or **W** for Welcome (it may be shown, with care). Nobody explains a mark. The strictest answer anyone gives is the table's answer. The Carver merges the sheets into one list and destroys the originals, so nobody knows who marked what.

THEME	WHERE IT LIVES	BOOK DEFAULT	MARK
Gore and mutilation	the Mangling table	on the page	L · V · W
Rot and the living dead	Sallowreach	on the page	L · V · W
Cannibalism	the Fatlands, the Second Table	on the page	L · V · W
Torture	courts, cults, wake-valets	brief	L · V · W
Ritual killing, sacrifice	cults in every land	on the page	L · V · W
Kin-slaying	high houses, Reckoners	on the page	L · V · W
Suicide and despair	Hushes, the Calling	aftermath only	L · V · W
Self-harm	Purgers, the Vigil's pins	aftermath only	L · V · W
Starvation	the Fast	on the page	L · V · W
Harm to children	every land	off-page	L · V · W
Birth and pregnancy horror	Cradlewrack	on the page	L · V · W
Possession, loss of self	Brinehollow, the Seating	on the page	L · V · W
Psychosis, gaslighting	the Vigil, the cults	on the page	L · V · W
Grave-robbing, misuse of the dead	Gleaners, part-thieves	on the page	L · V · W
Defilement of corpses	the worst cults	implied only	L · V
Sexual taboo (adults)	cursed lines	implied only	L · V
Incestuous bloodlines	the high Cuts	implied only	L · V

THEME	WHERE IT LIVES	BOOK DEFAULT	MARK
Swarms, drowning, enclosure	fen, sea, bricked rooms	on the page	L · V · W

Leave a blank row for anything the list forgot. The things that truly frighten people (needles, teeth, a particular kind of hospital) are rarely the things a book expects. Themes with no W are never shown on the page, whatever the table answers.

LINES AND VEILS

From the questionnaire, the group keeps a short written list of **Lines** and **Veils**, visible through every session. Anyone may add to it at any time without explanation. The Carver honours it, including by rewriting this book. Every land and adversary here can be run with any of its themes veiled: a Fatlands campaign in which nobody ever sees the wake, only the clean plates afterward, is still a Fatlands campaign, and perhaps a worse one.

SAYING THE GRACE

Every meal on the Table begins with the words *Lack keep away*. At your table, the same words, or a tap on the card marked with a crossed fork, mean: *stop this, now*. Anyone may say the Grace at any moment, about anything, with no reason given and no discussion required. The Carver immediately removes or alters whatever was happening, and play continues. Nobody asks why. Saying the Grace is never an insult and never an inconvenience; it is the oldest courtesy in the world.

PASS THE SALT

A softer signal. A player who says *pass the salt*, or slides the salt cellar toward the Carver, asks for less lingering: fewer details, cut to the aftermath. It is a hand on the sleeve, not a stop. A player who wants a scene to stay longer or go darker may ask for a **second helping**, and the Carver honours that too, within the Lines.

THE OPEN DOOR

Any player may leave the table at any time without saying why, and nobody comments when they come back. In Cradlewrack the doors drift open at night and nobody is blamed for walking through. At your table the door is open on purpose.

CHECKING IN AND CLEARING THE PLATES

Every few sessions, take five minutes out of character: what landed well, what was too much, what people want more of. Horror that has stopped being fun for one person at the table has stopped being fun for the table. At the end of any session that went somewhere dark, **clear the plates**: each person names one thing they liked about their own Guest's night, one thing they liked about someone else's, and anything they need to put down before going home.

ON SUICIDE AND DESPAIR

The Long Grace contains the suicides of characters, in the setting's history and sometimes in play: the Finishers walking into the Hushes, the Called walking into the sea, the sleepless lying down on purpose. This book treats every one of these as a tragedy with a cost that falls on the living. It never describes how; it describes what it leaves behind. If you or someone at your table is struggling outside the game, stop the game. Real people matter more than any story, and help from people who are trained to give it is worth reaching for.



*Nobody asks why. That is the whole of the courtesy.
Nobody asks why.*

RIM ROAD TAVERN-KEEPERS, ON THE GRACE

▼ HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The book is divided into four parts.

- ◇ **Part One: The Table** describes the world. *The Long Grace* chapter covers the history, the Providers, the Lack, the Gorging, the Regrowth, the Cuts, the Rim Road and the powers that cross borders. Seven chapters follow, one for each land: Sallowreach, the Fatlands, Brinehollow, the Vigil, Cradlewrack, Oathen, and the Fast. Each chapter covers its land's meal, its rules of horror, its history, factions, people, and how to play someone born there. *Threads Between the Lands* ties them together.

- ◇ **Part Two: The Rules** explains how to make a character, how dice are rolled, how the god in the blood is measured and spent, how the mind breaks, and how violence is done. It includes seven ready-to-play Guests, one from each land, for groups who want to start tonight.
- ◇ **Part Three: The Market and the Things That Eat** contains the full equipment and shopping system, the currencies of the Table, relics made from godflesh, and a bestiary of horrors, human adversaries and Seated gods.

- ◆ **Part Four: Setting the Table** is for the Carver alone: how to run horror, how to build campaigns, the secrets of the world, and the introductory adventure, *The Ninth Chair*.

At the back you will find the character sheet and an index.

If you are a player, read this chapter, the chapter on your Guest's land (or at least its *Playing* section), and *Making a Guest*. That is enough. Much of the pleasure of the Table is not knowing what the Carver knows. If you are the Carver, read everything, and then read *The Ninth Chair* twice.

▼ WORDS OF THE TABLE

In Table-speech, the common tongue older than the Gorging, the words for “worship” and “eat” share a root. Scholars insist they always did.

- ◆ **The Table:** the known world, one round continent with a dead heartland. Also any table where strangers eat, which is why the word is said carefully.
- ◆ **The Long Grace:** the age since the Gorging; borrowed time before the gods finish growing back. “The Grace is ending” is said at every bad harvest and late rain.
- ◆ **The Gorging:** the Night of Seven Tables, when six peoples ate their gods. Year 0 A.G. It is now 641 A.G.
- ◆ **Providers:** the eight gods who lived bodily among the peoples. Seven are named. The eighth is not.
- ◆ **The Lack:** the nine-year famine before the Gorging; also winter; also poverty, hunger and bad luck, which on the Table are one condition.
- ◆ **Lack, crumb, platter:** the bone coin worth a day's bread; a tenth of one; twenty of them, in a sealed tablet.
- ◆ **Regrowth:** the god's return through its eaters, in stages: the Taste, the Appetite, the Course, the Brink and the Seating. Its marks are *godsign*.
- ◆ **Hunger, Partaking, Teeth:** how awake the god is in you; calling on it before a roll; the d6 you add. A Tooth showing 1 means the god bit back.
- ◆ **Gifts, Wants, the Sop:** the god's powers in you; its compulsions; the act that quiets it and feeds the habit.
- ◆ **Cut:** a bloodline, named for the part its ancestors ate: Hand-lines, Gut-lines, Lung-lines, Eye-lines, Caul-lines, Tongue-lines.

Higher Cut, more god.

- ◆ **Scraplings, Blanks, the Unfed:** descendants of the bone-lickers; the rare born with no godsign, hunted everywhere; the people of the Fast, who refused, and who have **Want** where others have Hunger.
- ◆ **The Kept, the Called, the Tenanted, the Counted, Parts, the Forsworn, the Seated:** the undying of Sallowreach; those who walk into Brinehollow's sea, and those who come back; the Vigil's sleepers; Cradlewrack's single living limbs; Oatheners broken by their words; those who sat at Orrum's tables.
- ◆ **Fray, Dread, Breaking:** how far a mind has worn; how terrible a horror is, rated 1 to 5; what happens at Fray 10.
- ◆ **Flesh, Guard, Ruin:** harm a body can take; how hard it is to hit; what happens when Flesh runs out.
- ◆ **Grace and Lack (dice):** doubles on a success, doubles on a failure. Double 1s are **Licked Clean**; double 10s a **Second Helping**.
- ◆ **Oath on the Dead:** a promise sworn on a dead person's name. Every Guest begins with one. The dead keep count.
- ◆ **Portions:** experience, spent between sessions.
- ◆ **Tablenight:** the anniversary of the Gorging, the longest night of Lack (winter). The other seasons are Grace, Plenty and Carving. The moon is **the Plate**; a new moon is “licked clean”.
- ◆ **The Rim Road Company, the Cutwrights' College, the Purgation, the Second Table, the Reckoners:** the powers that cross every border: road-owners, genealogists, purgers, a hidden cult of nobles, and assassins out of the Fast.
- ◆ **Carver and Guests:** the game master (or GM) and the players' characters.

▼ A NIGHT ON THE TABLE

The transcript below is lightly tidied from a first session. Dee is the Carver. Joss plays **Hessa Coombe**, a Sallowreach Seamer; Marta plays **Haslet Furrow**, a Fatlands Renderer; Kwame plays **Abate Kettering**, a Crumb-Runner of the Fast. All three are pregenerated Guests from *Making a Guest*. The scene: a crossroads where the Fatlands meet the edge of the Fast, at dusk, in Carving.

Dee (Carver): The road bends round a stand of toothed wheat to a crossroads: a milestone, an empty gibbet, a Company waystation with its shutters down. No lamp, no smoke. The cart you were following stands at the trough, and its horse is shaking. There's a smell on the wind. Abate knows it first.

Kwame (Abate): Bread.

Dee: Warm bread, a crust just cracking, and under it something roasting, sweet, like pork basted in honey.

Kwame: Abate turns so the wind's on her cheek and walks into it. Not toward the smell. Into the wind, like the rule says.

Dee: Every Unfed child learns that before their letters. No roll. Haslet, it hits you differently.

Marta (Haslet): I'm drooling. Can he tell what the roast is? He's a Renderer, that's Know the Cut.

Dee: Eye plus Feast, Hard, fourteen. If you make it you'll know whether it was a person.

Marta: Plus five. (*rolls*) Six and four. Fifteen.

Dee: No Helping, but you know. It's pork. Honestly pork. It's the best pork you've ever smelled, and the last time anything smelled this good you were eight and it was your grandfather's wake.

Marta: That is so much worse.

WHAT JUST HAPPENED

Dee called for a roll only when the outcome was uncertain and mattered. Abate's walk into the wind needed none: it is what she was raised to do. Haslet's roll used his Calling Talent: 2d10 + Eye + Feast against Hard (14). Fifteen beats it by one, short of the full four needed for a Helping.

Joss (Hessa): Is the waystation door open?

Dee: Hessa has Lidsense; she knows without looking. The door is shut. Every ground-floor shutter is open a finger's width, and so is every eye of the man on the porch. He's sitting at a table carried out onto the boards: white cloth, candles, four places, a fork in his hand with nothing on it. He says, very warmly, "There you are. We'd almost given up." He lifts the fork, chews, swallows. His cheeks are hollow as cups and he is the happiest man you have ever seen. Anyone who goes close enough to see his face makes a Dread check. Dread 3: Grim, eighteen.

Joss: Hessa's a Seamer, she has to look. I'll Partake. Caul 3, Resolve 2, plus five. (*rolls*) Three, eight, and the Tooth is a one. Oh no.

Dee: Eleven plus five plus one: seventeen. One short. Three Fray, and two Hunger: one for Partaking, one because the god bit back. What's in your hand?

Joss: The tin cup from the trough. She was going to water the horse.

Dee: Your hand closes on it. The tin crumples, the edge opens your palm, and you can't let go. For one heartbeat every sound at the crossroads stops: the horse, the wind, the man chewing. Then it comes back, and he says, "Mind your hand, love. Sit. There's a cloth."

Joss: She doesn't sit. She says, "May you finish," and she means it, and she hates that she means it.

Dee: Abate. Thirty paces into the wind there's a small table on the verge. One place, a card propped against the glass. You know the hand. It's your sister Meagre's. It says *Abate*, and under it, smaller, *I saved you the crust*.

Kwame: (*after a moment*) Lack keep away.

Dee: (*at once*) The card is blank. An ordinary laid table seen from the road: Hard fourteen, plus your Pangs.

THE GRACE AT WORK

Kwame said the Grace. He did not say why and nobody asked. Dee took the sister's handwriting out of the scene at once, kept the threat, and lowered the Difficulty to match what was now in the fiction. After the session Kwame mentioned, unprompted, that Dee could bring the card back someday. Dee wrote that down and did nothing with it for eleven sessions.

Kwame: Pangs are 2, so sixteen. Caul 3, Resolve 3. I'll spend two Want on the Gnaw for the Empty Tooth. (*rolls*) Eight, four, Empty Tooth three. Twenty-one.

Dee: Clean refusal. Want went from three to one; refusing Orrum gives you two back.

Kwame: "No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you." She keeps walking and doesn't look back.

Dee: Behind you someone sighs, the way a host sighs when a guest leaves early, not unkindly. Haslet, you're the one still standing there. The man on the porch is pulling out the chair beside him. It scrapes. And the ground under your boots is warm and soft and rising and falling, just a little. What do you do?

Marta: I think he needs someone to hold his hand.

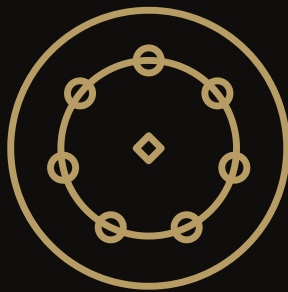
Joss: Hessa takes it. The one that isn't bleeding.

Dee: Then that's where we stop for a break. Somebody put the kettle on.



*The rules are a knife and a fork. What you do with
them is supper.*

FROM THE CARVER'S NOTES TO *THE NINTH CHAIR*



PART ONE

THE TABLE

*The history of the eaten gods, the seven lands that ate or refused them,
and the people living inside the slow resurrection of their meal.*



CHAPTER 2

THE LONG GRACE

We were hungry. Say it plainly. We were hungry, and they were there.

— FIRST LINE OF EVERY HISTORY WRITTEN ON THE TABLE



▼ PROLOGUE: THE NIGHT OF SEVEN TABLES

Nobody agrees whether it was one night or a whole black season of nights. Every people remembers it as one. These are seven of the memories, set down in the words of the people who keep them, and arranged in the order the Rim Road Company's chroniclers prefer, which is clockwise, ending at the middle, because that is where every road on the Table ends whether it means to or not.

Each was taken down by the College's Linemen between 140 and 160 A.G., from the oldest tellers then alive, who had it from their grandparents, who had it from their own mouths. They have been copied, recopied and argued over since. None of them agrees with the official chronicle of its own land in every particular. All of them agree with each other on the one point that matters: the gods did not fight.



Every people remembers it as one night. Every people is lying, and every people is right.

ARCHPROVOST HESPER LUNE, LECTURE AT QUIRE, 629 A.G.

I. THE FENS

Nobody wanted to be first. That is the whole of it, and the fen-folk tell it as if it were a virtue.

Ossel lay where it had lain down, half in the black water and half on the reed-bank below the place that would one day be Lastgate. It was grey the way fog is grey, long the way a road is long, and its hands lay open on the peat, palms up, each one wide enough to cup a cottage. We stood around it with knives we had ground from the shoulder-blades of cattle that had died in the fifth year. There were thousands of us. You could hear stomachs. You could hear the fog dripping off the reeds.

Every so often, while we stood there, one of the children at the back of the crowd died. That was ordinary then. You heard a mother make the sound and then stop making it. And each time, one of those great hands lifted, slow as a heron, reached

over our heads without touching anyone, and closed the child's eyes with a fingertip the size of a loaf. Then it settled back onto the peat and lay open again.

It did that eleven times before anyone moved.

We have kept the count. Every fen child can still say it on the fingers, the eleven closings, the way children elsewhere count buttons: Wenna, small Hob, the Tasker twins, Arn's girl, the one with no name yet, and on through the eleven. There were twelve children and eleven closings, because the Tasker twins died in the same breath holding hands, and the Hand closed both pairs of eyes with one fingertip laid across them like a bar across a door. The mothers did not scream. The famine had taken the screaming out of us in the fifth year. The sound the mothers made was short, and dry, like a latch going down.

The one who moved was Agna Corse, who was ninety and had buried four husbands and nine children and was dying where she stood. She did not cut the god. She asked her grandson to. She said, I will not last till morning and I would like to have eaten something. He took the smallest finger of the left hand, the last joint, and it came away like the stalk of a mushroom, and inside it was cold and pale and wet and smelled of cellars and turned earth and the inside of a closed box. She ate it raw, with her gums. She did not die that night. She did not die the next night either. She is, by some accounts, still upright in a Lastgate loft, and asks after her grandson, who has been sunk in the Sump for five hundred years.

After her it went easier. It always does. We ate it slowly, because it was cold and because we were ashamed, and because every time a knife went in the hand nearest would lift a little, as if to close our eyes, and then think better of it and lie down. The families who took the hands sat apart and ate them in silence, joint by joint, cracking the knuckles with stones. Their lips went grey by morning. We bowed to them for it.

The meat of the Hand was not like other meat. It was cold all the way through, cold as a cellar stone, and it did not warm in the mouth however long you held it there, and those who ate a great deal of it found in the morning that their own mouths had gone cold and stayed cold, and that their breath no longer smoked in the frost. The bones of the fingers had more joints than a man's, nine and ten to a finger, and each joint came apart with a small wet click, like a box being shut. The people who ate the long meat of the arm said it tasted of nothing at all for a long while and then, at the very back of the tongue, of the moment just before sleep.

There was one boy, they say, a peat-cutter's son, who stood at the back the whole night and never ate. He was staring past the god, over its shoulder, at the empty bank on the far side of the fire, where nobody stood because there was nothing there to stand near. Just before dawn he made a small sound, and turned, and ran out into the fen in the dark, and we heard the water take him. Nobody went after him. We were eating.

When it was done there was a long grey shape of bones lying in the reeds, and the hands were gone, all but the last joint of the left thumb, which nobody would take. It lay on the peat until dawn. In the morning it was found curled in on itself, closed, as if it had been holding something very small and had decided to keep it.



The Hand did not stop us. It only reached over our heads, now and then, to close the eyes of the ones we were too slow for.

THE CORSE TELLING, AS KEPT IN THE LOFTS

II. THE PLAINS

We were fastest. Say that too. Say it proudly; we do.

Ummer the Laden came in off the stubble on the last evening of the ninth Carving and lay down on the great threshing floor at Brawn Tilth like an ox that has decided. It was the size of a barn and it smelled the way an oven smells when you open it, and the starving went toward that smell before anyone had spoken a word, on their hands and knees, the old ones crawling, the young ones running on legs like rake-handles.

There was no ceremony. There was no first cut, because there were a thousand first cuts. People bit it. I want you to understand: before the knives came out, people had their faces in its side and were biting, and the skin gave like the crust of a loaf, and under the crust it was fat, yellow, a hand's depth of it, warm as a body, and under the fat it was meat that bled

gravy. Children were pushed in to the shoulder. Men pulled ribs apart with their arms and handed the meat back over their heads to whoever was behind. A woman sat in the hollow of its flank with her baby and chewed and put the chewed meat in the baby's mouth with her tongue, chewed and gave, chewed and gave, crying the whole time, and the baby lived, and that baby's grandchildren's grandchildren sit on the Board of Plenty today.

The Gut-line families got there first because they were nearest the belly. They opened it and grain came out. That is what is remembered: the belly opened and the threshing floor was knee-deep in grain in a heartbeat, a wave of it, hot, smelling of summer, and in that grain were small white things like teeth, which we took for husks. We ate those too. Nobody asked.

A drover called Kell Sowerby ate until his belly split along an old rupture-scar, and he went on eating with the grain running out of the wound into his lap, laughing, crying, and his wife sat behind him and stitched him shut with a harness needle and waxed thread while he ate, and pushed the grain back in with her thumbs, and he lived to be ninety and never once felt full. His grandchildren show the needle at weddings.

By midnight the big bones were bare. By the second hour we were cracking them on the floor-stones for the marrow, and the noise of that was like a forest coming down. By dawn there was nothing on the threshing floor but grease and grain and people asleep in it, curled up, fat-faced, with their mouths still moving. The god had not made a sound. It had not stopped us. Old women say its eyes were open the whole time, and kind, and that it watched us eat it the way a mother watches.

The hunger did not stop. We noticed that around noon. We were full to the throat and the hunger had not stopped. It still has not.

The threshing floor at Brawn Tilth is the place the south now calls the Trencher. Nobody farms within a mile of it. The stones are still greasy.



We ate the god and the god watched us do it, kindly, the way a mother watches. That is the part I cannot forgive it for.

GRACE-KEEPER AMITY ROWLE OF DIMBLE, 590 A.G.

III. LONGSLAB

Dromm would not come up on its own. The others lay down; the Fathom had to be fetched.

It took ten thousand hooks. Every family on the coast brought every hook it owned and hammered more from door-hinges and pot-handles, and we rowed them out over the deep place in boats with nothing in their holds, and we set them, and we hauled. The ropes sang. Men's hands opened to the bone on them and they wrapped the bone in sailcloth and hauled again. It came up out of the dark slowly over three days, a shape like a reef that breathed, and it did not fight us, but the sea did: the water around it thickened until boats could not row through it, and the pressure of it pressed our ears until they bled in threads down our jaws.

On the second day the hooks began to bring up the drowned. Every body the coast had ever rowed out to the Fathom came up on the barbs, caught in the god's hide where it had kept them: some only bone wrapped in weed, some white and soft as dough and swollen out of their clothes, some fresh as the week they were let down, with the lantern-wax still on their faces. A woman at the third rope saw her husband come up, nine years drowned and not a day changed, his eyes open, his hair moving in the water as though he were nodding. She did not let go of the rope. Nobody let go. We hauled them up with the god, our dead, and laid them out on the shingle in rows, and when we were hungry enough, later, we did not look at the rows.

We dragged it onto the shingle at Longslab on the third evening. It was grey and slick and vast and its skin moved in long slow ripples like the surface of the water it had left. It had no face you could find. It had an enormous slow breathing, a sound like surf turned inside out, and every breath it took pulled the tide a little further out from under the boats.

It took four days to stop moving. We did not wait for it to stop. We were too hungry for that. The families who would be the Lung-lines cut their way in under the ribs on the second day and found the lungs, which were the size of chapels, folded and grey and full of cold water, and they ate them in the water, standing in the god, chest-deep in the brine that poured out of it. One girl put her whole head inside a lobe to drink and came out and said she had heard the sea from the inside, and that it was talking. She walked into the water a week later, the first of all the Called, though nobody had a name for it then.

The beach has never dried. Stand on Longslab in the hottest week of Plenty and the shingle is wet under your soles and the wet is warm. On the fourth night, when it finally stopped moving, every one of us woke at the same moment coughing salt water. We thought it was grief.



The sea gave back every one of them that night. It has not given back one since.

LOWMARK TIDE-POST INSCRIPTION, CUT 118 A.G.

IV. LUDMERE

Hush. That was the whole instruction. Hush, and do not wake it.

Iss the Lidded slept in the high valley above Ludmere, where it had always slept, curled on its side like a hound, as long as the valley, with its head on its paws and its great lids shut. It had never been seen awake. Its breathing was the weather of that country: slow, warm, regular, the grass along the valley floor lying down and rising up again with each breath. We had slept beside it all our lives, and dreamed well, and in the famine years we had dreamed of food, nightly, until the dreams were the only food we had.

So we came up the valley in the dark, in stocking feet, with our knives wrapped in wool so they would not clink. Mothers sang. That is what we kept from that night: the lullabies. A thousand women singing low, so the god would go on sleeping while we opened it. The knives went in to the singing. The blood came out warm and slow and smelled of linen and milk and the hollow of a lover's neck, and the people who drank it yawned, all of them, and had to be slapped awake to go on eating.

The song was the old one, the cradle-song every Ludmere child went down to: Lie down, lie down, the Lid is low. They sang it in shifts, the old ones taking up the line when the young ones' voices went, so that it never broke, not once, not for the whole of the work, which the Vigil's chronicle now says took nine nights and which felt, to the singers, like one. Some of the singers fell asleep singing, and their neighbours sang on over them.

It never woke. Write that down and underline it. It never stirred, never flinched, never sighed. We took the flesh from the haunch and it went on breathing. We took the heart and it went on breathing for an hour without one. Near dawn the families who would be the Eye-lines climbed the face with ropes and cut out its eyes, still shut, lids and lashes and all, each one the size of a cartwheel, and lowered them down, and sliced them like bread, and ate them closed. The lids were the best part, they said after. Like cream.

Some of us dozed, toward the end, full and warm against the cooling side. And some of those who dozed dreamed of a long

dim room, and woke weeping, and could not say why. We put it down to the occasion.

A girl of six who had been left to sleep in the grass under the god's chin was found at dawn curled against its last warm breath and could not be woken for three days. When she woke she asked her mother where the other people in the long room had gone, the ones who had been sitting at the table with their backs to her. Her mother told her it was a dream. She grew up and kept a dream-book in the temple of the walkers-softly, and that is where the College found this telling.

The breathing stopped at sunrise. The valley grass lay down flat, and has never quite stood up again.



It never woke. Write that down and underline it. Then ask yourself why you need it underlined.

MARGIN NOTE IN THE LUDMERE TELLING, COLLEGE COPY, UNKNOWN HAND

V. THE RED HILLS

Vey was the smallest of them and it would not stay killed. Every midwife in the highlands was called up to the round hill to help, and the midwives tell it best, so this is how they tell it.

It was the size of a calf when it lay down, a soft red thing with a hundred small closed openings in its skin like buds, and its warmth came off it in waves you could see in the frost. A Caul-wife of Kest put her knife in under the breastbone, cleanly, the way you open a sheep, and it died. And then it opened. The wound became a mouth, and the mouth drew breath, and out of it slid Vey again, smaller, wet, and new, and lay down on the grass beside its own body and waited.

We killed it seven times that night. Each time we killed it, it began again out of the death, out of the cut, out of the place where the knife came out. By the fourth time we were eating as we killed, fast, so that what we had cut would be swallowed before it could begin. By the sixth the women were holding the openings shut with their hands while the men cut, and the openings pushed at their palms like a child's head pushing. The meat was hot and sweet and tasted of iron and new milk, and those who ate it felt their own bodies clench and loosen and clench in the belly, all of them, men and grandmothers, a pain like a door being tried from the other side.

Every Vey that came out of a death was born with its arms spread wide, like a small figure standing in a doorway to keep it open. The midwives say it never once cried. It looked at

whoever was nearest, each time, with an expression the oldest of them called patience, and lay down again to be cut.

The seventh time it was very small. The size of a hand. A woman named Harrow Bede, who had lost nine in the Lack and buried every one in the red clay with her own fingers, took it up in her palm and looked at it for a long while. Then she put the whole of it in her mouth and swallowed, and held her jaw shut with both hands until it stopped moving, and then she sat down in the clay and laughed until she was sick.

The families who ate the caul wore it out of the hill on their faces like veils, wet and red in the torchlight, and it did not come off in the morning. Behind us, on the empty hilltop, a door stood in a frame with no house around it, open a crack. Nobody had brought it there.

The families of Kest tell it differently: a birthing-house instead of a round hill, a drift of small gods across the floor instead of seven deaths, and a woman named Hollan Kest who crushed the last of them, the size of a barleycorn, under her heel. The midwives of the round hill say the Kest families were not there, and that a thing told by people who were not there is a thing that grows. The Attendance, which descends from both, teaches both, and asks its apprentices to notice that in neither telling did anyone manage to stop it beginning.



First we ask what it is. Then we ask whether it stays.

THE MIDWIFE'S TWO QUESTIONS, FIRST ASKED ON THE ROUND HILL

VI. THE CANYONS

...

Nothing.

They ate it without speaking, and the telling of it in Oathen is also without speaking, so this is set down by an outsider who was told it with hands.

Tolm the Witness lay at the bottom of the deepest canyon with its ear to the stone. It was long, and bare, and listening. It was always listening; everything said in front of it was so, and the people of the canyons had learned over ten thousand years to say little near it and to mean all of it. In the Lack they had come to its ear and said we are hungry, and it was so; they had said we will die, and that was so; and they had stopped coming.

On the night, the whole people came down the canyon walls on ropes in silence, carrying their children with leather straps

over their mouths. They spread out along its length in silence. They raised the knives in silence. The only sound was the knives. The god heard the knives, and that was so.

They ate. Imagine a hundred thousand people chewing in a canyon that repeats everything. The echo of the eating went up the walls and came down again and went up again for the whole night, a wet enormous patience, and the god lay with its ear to the rock and heard it, and heard it, and heard it.

An old man, partway through the night, began to weep. He had spent his life learning to weep in the canyon without a sound, and he made none; but his tears fell from his face onto the god's great ear, one, and then another, and the god heard them fall, and that was so. His eyes have been wet ever since, and his children's, and his grandchildren's. There is a family in Tacit called the Drips who have wept without stopping for six hundred years, and who are hired at every funeral in the canyon, and who are said to be the only people in Oathen who never have to explain how they feel.

A boy, partway through, stopped chewing. He looked up at his mother with his mouth full and his eyes wide, and drew a breath to say something. She put her hand over his mouth. She did not take it away until dawn. When she did, the boy had chewed through the side of his own cheek trying to keep from speaking, and she held a strip of the god's tongue against the wound until it closed. The families who ate the tongue sat in a circle, cutting it into slivers no bigger than a fingernail, and laid each sliver on their own tongues, and closed their mouths, and let it dissolve. They say it was the only thing any of them ever tasted that had no taste at all.

Nobody spoke for a year afterward. The first word said aloud in the canyons after the Supper was a merchant's "I swear," three springs on, and you know what happened to his hands.

◇
Say less.

THE WHOLE OF OATHEN'S LAW, AS TAUGHT TO
CHILDREN; THE WHOLE OF THIS TELLING, AS TOLD
IN OATHEN

VII. HALLOWBOARD

We are the people who said no. Teach it so. Our children learn it before their own names.

Orrum the Host lay on the table at Hallowboard, on the bare hill at the middle of the world, the eight-sided stone table that is always clean. It lay as the others lay, quiet, warm, its great stooped body folded along the board, and the board was the

right size for it, as if it had been cut to measure. It smelled of bread. All of it. The whole hill smelled of bread fresh from the oven, and of woodsmoke and of the inside of a kitchen on a winter evening when everyone you love is home.

We stood around it and we did not eat. We stood in the cold with our children on our shoulders, skin over bone, and the god lay on its table and waited, and we said, as we say now, No, thank you. And again, No, thank you. And again. Nine in ten of us died where they stood that winter, or on the walk home, or in their houses with the smell of bread still in their noses. We did not eat. Remember it. We are the only clean people in the world.

Remember also, because the elders do not forbid it, how long the walk to Hallowboard was. The heartland is wide, and we were weak, and the snow lay deep on the old roads. Remember that when the first of us came over the last ridge, the fires on the far horizons, where the other peoples were, had already burned down to red. Remember that the god on the table opened its eyes when it heard us, and looked at us, and its look was the look of someone who has waited a very long time for guests and has just heard the door.

Remember that the walkers sang the counting-song as they came, one verse for each day of the road, so that the weakest would know how far they had come and not lie down. Remember that the song has ten verses. Remember that nobody now living can tell you why it was written with ten.

Remember that it turned its great head, once, and looked at the eighth side of the table, where none of us stood, where the snow had not settled, where nothing was. Remember that it looked there for a long while. Remember that when it looked back at us, it was afraid.

Then it got up. It got up off the board, slow and stooping, the way an old man gets up from a chair. It stood over us in the dark, warm, enormous, smelling of supper. And it began to lay the table.

No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you.

◇
We did not eat. We do not eat. We will not eat. Say it
three times and you may have your supper.

UNFED BEDTIME CATECHISM

USING THE PROLOGUE

Read any one of these vignettes aloud at the start of a campaign set in that land; read all seven if the campaign will travel. Each contains a detail the land's own chapter treats as history and a detail it treats as heresy. The Fen boy who ran is Grandfather Peat. The Hallowboard telling contains a lateness the Unfed elders have never thought hard about. Players who notice the empty bank in the fen and the empty eighth side at Hallowboard have noticed something that is noticed, eventually, by everyone who goes too far.

Each vignette also hides one small cruelty a GM can lift straight into play: the twelve children and eleven closings (somebody's ancestor was the one the Hand did not reach); the drover's harness needle (a Fatlands heirloom worth a wedding); the drowned brought up on the hooks (Brinchollow families still argue whose); the girl who asked about the long room (her dream-book is somewhere); the Kest telling and the round-hill telling (two Cradlewrack families, each certain the other is lying); the Drips (who know more about grief than anyone in Oathen is allowed to); and the ten verses of the counting-song (the Unfed sing only seven verses of their oldest hymn, and do not know why that matters).

▼ WHY "THE LONG GRACE"

On every table on the continent, before the first mouthful, someone says the words: *Lack keep away*. It is the shortest grace in the world and the only one every people shares. It is said quickly, with the eyes down, the way you touch a doorframe for luck. It is the pause between sitting down and eating.

The poets of the Rim Road began calling the age itself by that name around the third century, half in mockery: six peoples had sat down to the biggest meal in history, and somehow they had not yet finished saying grace over it. The joke was that the meal was eaten in a night, and the bill had not come. Priests took the phrase up a century later without the joke. To them it meant what it sounds like it means: that the six hundred and forty-one years since the Gorging are not an age at all but a held breath, a little ceremonial pause, and that the real eating has not yet begun.

Scholars of the Cutwrights' College use the term precisely. The Long Grace, in their ledgers, is the span between the swallowing of the Providers and the completion of their Regrowth: a finite period, with a measurable rate, approaching its end. Every land's chronicle in the last decade has started using the phrase in the past tense by accident. "In the Long Grace, my grandmother kept bees." Nobody corrects it. Everyone hears it.

In common speech, "the Grace is ending" is what you say when the milk turns, when the dog will not come in, when the neighbor's daughter starts bailing at the wrong hour. It is said lightly. It is meant the other way.

◇
In the Long Grace, my grandmother kept bees.

OVERHEARD AT FOGMOUTH; THE SPEAKER'S
GRANDMOTHER IS STILL LIVING

THE GRACE IN SEVEN MOUTHS

The words are the same everywhere. The manner is not, and a traveler who gets the manner wrong is noticed.

- ◇ **Sallowreach.** Said by the living for the Kept, who cannot always manage the consonants; the Kept nod. Gloves stay on.
 - ◇ **The Fatlands.** Said after the field-names, never before, and fast, because the food is getting cold: *Thank you, Long Acre, thank you, Hessop's Rise, Lack keep away*.
 - ◇ **Brinchollow.** *Lack keep away, and keep you dry*. Said with the bucket set down, never held.
 - ◇ **The Vigil.** Said with the eyes wide open, then a flat slap on the table, so nobody at the board has nodded off during it.
 - ◇ **Cradlewrack.** Said with a knock on the table, three times, to warn whatever is in the food.
 - ◇ **Oathen.** Signed, not said, unless foreigners are present; then said very slowly, with three exits attached.
 - ◇ **The Fast.** Said to the empty air, standing, before eating from the hand, by people who share their food with no one.
-

There is an older and longer form of the grace. A few fen grandmothers know it, and a few Oathen Clausewrights, and none

of them will say it aloud for money, and the two or three scholars who have heard it say only that it is not addressed to the eater.

▼ THE PROVIDERS

They were not distant. That is the first thing every child is told and the last thing any adult understands. The gods of the old world did not live on mountaintops or behind the sky. Each lived bodily among one people, immense and present, the way a mountain is present: you could walk to it, you could put your hand on it, you could smell it on the wind on a warm day. It had a temperature. It shed. It had moods you could read the way farmers read cloud.

There were eight. Seven are named in every carving older than the Gorging, standing or lying in a ring, facing inward, around something that is never shown. The eighth place in the ring is always there, and always empty, because the figure in it has been cut away.

LIVING BESIDE A GOD

A Provider did not rule in any sense a magistrate would recognize. It did not make laws or demand prayers. It simply did what it was, enormously, and the people who lived in its shadow arranged their lives around the fact. Fen-folk did not have to bury their dead, because Ossel closed them, and what Ossel closed went quietly into the peat and was clean in a season. Plains-folk did not have to fear a bad harvest, because Ummer walked the fields. Canyon-folk did not need courts, because a thing said in Tolm's hearing was so, and liars learned to keep away from its ear.

The cost was intimacy. You lived with a god the way you live with weather in a small house. You heard it at night. You smelled it in your bread. Children were sent to sit in its shade and came home with its dust on their clothes. Sweethearts met in its lee. People died against its flank in old age, deliberately, the way an old dog crawls under the stove. Every people had words for the god's breathing, the

god's stillness, the god turning over in the night. Every people believed, without needing to say so, that the god knew each of them by name.

Worship, in the old world, was mostly feeding. Every people brought their Provider a portion of what the Provider had given them: the first sheaf, the first catch, the first cry of a newborn, the first word of a child. It was called *the giving back*, and in Table-speech the verb for it is the same as the verb for eating. The gods ate what they were given, slowly, over days. Nobody remembers them ever asking for more. Nobody remembers them ever asking for anything at all.



We did not pray to them. You do not pray to a mountain. You sit in its shade and you are grateful and you try not to think about what it would do if it moved.

GRANDFATHER PEAT, AS INTERPRETED, LASTGATE,
640 A.G.

The pages that follow describe the seven named Providers as the old world knew them: how they were shown, how they were served, what was sung to them, and what is left. Almost nothing is left. The Gorging was thorough. The relics given here are the ones every land acknowledges; there are others, in cellars and under altars, which nobody acknowledges at all.

OSSEL, THE CLOSING HAND



God of death and endings. It lay in the northern fens for as long as anyone remembered, long and grey and still as a fallen ash, with hands that moved when nothing else did. Its iconography is two open hands, palms up, and in later carvings a single hand drawing a lid down over an eye. Fen-folk wore a grey thumbprint on the brow at funerals and pressed their own thumbs to the eyelids of the dead in imitation of it. When someone died, the family carried them to the god on a reed hurdle and laid them by a hand, and the hand closed their eyes and their mouth and folded their arms, and then the body was sunk in clean black water and was gone in a season, bones and all, leaving the water sweet. People who lived near Ossel were calm about everything. They knew how things went. An old

fen saying, from before: *The Hand comes for the candle when the candle is done*. Nobody now alive in Sallowreach can say it without weeping.

Iconography. Ossel was carved in bog-oak and cast in bog-iron, because those were the materials that lasted in the fen, and its images were always grey: grey slip on red clay, grey ash rubbed into wood, grey tallow on the palms of the great figures that stood at the fen crossings. The hands were the whole of it. The fen shrines show no face, no body, only the two hands lying open on the ground, palms up, and between them a little hollow where a dead person would be laid. The oldest carvings give the fingers too many joints, nine and

ten to a finger, which the fen once thought a sculptor's mannerism and now does not. Votive hands of fired clay, thumb-sized, palms up, turn up by the thousand when the peat is cut, and fen children still find them and are told to put them back.

Worship. The rite was called *the Carrying*. The dying were brought to the god while they could still see it, on reed hurdles borne by four kin, and laid down within reach of a hand, and the family sat on the bank and talked to them of ordinary things: the eel-traps, the price of salt, who was courting whom. When it was time, the hand came. Nobody wept until it had closed the eyes, because weeping before was thought to make the dying hold on out of politeness. Afterward the body was sunk in the sweet black pools

— CARRYING-HYMN OF THE OLD FENS; SUNG IN SALLOWREACH NOW ONLY BY
THE FINISHERS, AT THE EDGE OF A HUSH

The Relic. In the Hall of Closings at Lastgate, behind three doors that each close by themselves, there is a fingernail the size of a roof-slate. It is grey, ridged, slightly curved, and cold enough to raise frost on the velvet beneath it in the warmest week of Plenty. It is held to be the nail of the left forefinger, pared by the Corse family on the night itself and never eaten. The Regent lays his palm on it once a year, on the First Morning, and the Court watches to see whether his hand comes away. It always has. The Court has never asked what would happen if it did not.



God of harvest and plenty. It walked, unlike most of the others: a vast, slow, broad-backed shape like a laden haywain made of earth and bark and pelt, ambling across the southern plains with its head down, and the fields bowed toward it as it passed and rose up heavier behind it. Its iconography is a full belly with a sheaf rising out of it, and a mouth, always a mouth, smiling. Plains-folk followed its track with seed-bags and sowed in its footprints, which never failed. They thanked it by name at every meal, as they still thank the fields, and the first loaf of every baking was set on the doorstep for it, and in the morning the loaf was gone and the doorstep was warm. It was the most loved of the gods and the most taken for granted. Children rode on it.

Iconography. Ummer is the only Provider whose images move: it was shown walking, always, head down, with the furrows bending toward it like grass toward a wind. The granary lintels of the south carry long friezes of it ambling across the stone with the sheaves bowing in its wake, and the oldest grace-stones at the corners of Fatlands fields still show it, worn to a soft bump. Its colours were gold and red ochre. Its mouth was always carved open and smiling, and the corn-dollies the plains-folk plaited in its shape at harvest had

that the fen called the Sweetwaters, and the family kept one candle-end lit at home until it guttered by itself, and then the mourning was done. There were no priests, only the *burdle-folk*, old men and women who carried for families with no strong kin, and were paid in eels.

Close the door, the day is done,

Close the eye, the light is gone,

Lay the hand on what is through,

Hand, come down, and close me too.



*The Hand comes for the candle when the candle is
done.*

FEN SAYING, FROM BEFORE

UMMER, THE LADEN

a mouth stitched on in red thread, so that the doll could be fed a crumb at supper. Children were given them to hold at night. They are still made in Gristmoot, and sold on the Rim as toys, and the red-thread mouths are sewn on wider every decade.

Worship. At Harvest Home the children of a village were lifted onto its back, and it carried them, very slowly, the length of the parish and back, and that was called *the Riding*, and every child who rode was said to be lucky in bread for life. In Carving it shed a down like thistle from its flanks, warm and faintly sweet, which the women gathered from the hedges and spun for swaddling-bands. A baby swaddled in Ummer-down never went hungry. That was the saying. It is still said in the Fatlands, of babies swaddled in ordinary wool, by people who know better.

Walk on, walk on, the furrow's yours,

Walk on, walk on, the bread is ours,

Bow down, bow down, the wheat to thee,

And leave a little left for me.

— THE OLD SOWING-SONG; NOW A CLAPPING GAME FOR FATLANDS CHILDREN,
WHO SING THE LAST LINE AND LEAVE A LITTLE LEFT OF ME

The Relic. In a bare field outside Brawn Tilth, a short walk from the Trencher, there is a footprint. It is the last one: the print of a forefoot as broad as a cart, pressed a hand deep into the clay at the place where Ummer finally folded its legs in the seventh year of the Lack. The Board of Plenty has roofed it, fenced it and set a Field Church warden over it. The clay at the bottom has never dried. Seed dropped into the print comes up within a day, and the wheat it grows has teeth before it has ears, and the warden pulls it every

evening with tongs. Pilgrims are allowed to kneel at the fence. Some of them lick the rail.

◇
Nobody's full, but some are fuller.

FATLANDS PROVERB

DROMM, THE FATHOM



God of the deep sea, of pressure, of what is kept under. Nobody living saw more than its back, a long grey reef far out past the shelf that broke the surface on the stillest days and breathed. Its iconography is a closed circle with lines pressing in from every side, and the oldest coastal carvings show it as a hand holding something down beneath the waves. The coast gave it the first fish of every boat and the bodies of the drowned, rowed out with lanterns and let down on weighted ropes. In return the sea was full and the storms broke on its back before they reached the shore. Divers who went deep came up with nosebleeds and a feeling of being enormously, patiently watched. The old coast-folk said Dromm kept the sea's secrets for it, everything that had ever sunk, and would never give a single one of them up.

Iconography. The closed circle with lines pressing inward is still painted on every anchor-stock in Brinehollow and cut on every tide-post. In the old world it was tattooed on the breastbone of every coast child at its first bailing of the sea, in soot and fish-oil, a ring the size of a palm with nine short strokes pointing into it. The great coast carvings show a hand rising from waves to press something down; what is pressed is never shown, only the water closing over it.

– NET-MENDING SONG OF THE OLD COAST; THE ANCHORITES OF THE
HANGING ABBEY STILL SING IT, WITH THE LAST LINE SAID THROUGH THE
TEETH

The Relic. The bottles of the Keep. The sea has been leaving since 512, and the Uncovered is giving them back: thousands of them, green and brown and black with pitch, standing upright in the cracked mud where the water left them, by the acre. Salvagers dig them out by the cartload and sell them at Brackwater Bridge for five lacks a bottle or fifty if the pitch bears a family seal. The linen inside is always dry. The secret is always true. It usually still matters, because the families who sank them are still there, and their names are still on the Admiralty's rolls, and a six-hundred-year-old killing is

Ship-figureheads of the old coast had their hands folded on their chests, as if keeping something in. Since the Brimming, the coast has found that image less comforting.

Worship. The drowned were rowed out on the night after the death, and the lantern was let down after them on its own rope so that they could see their way. But the strangest rite was *the Keep*. A coast family with a secret it could not bear, a theft, a bastard, a killing, a love, wrote it on a scrap of linen, sealed it in a bottle with pitch and lead shot, and rowed it out, and dropped it over the deep place, and Dromm kept it. Nobody ever told a secret that had been given to the Keep. To ask about one was the worst manners on the coast. Divers who went deep said the seabed under the god was paved with green glass.

Hold them down, the drowned and dear,

Hold the storm off, hold it there,

Keep what sank, and keep it deep,

Keep it, Fathom, keep, keep, keep.

still a killing. The Admiralty has banned the trade four times. The Drowned Bench has never once been asked to rule on it, and nobody has asked why.

◇
The sea gives back, but not change.

BRINEHOLLOW PROVERB

ISS, THE LIDDED



God of sleep. It lay curled in the high valley above old Ludmere with its lids shut, and no one in recorded history ever saw its eyes open. Its iconography is a closed eye, two curved lines, sometimes with a row of small figures lying asleep along the lower lid. Worship in Ludmere was dreaming: oracles slept against the god's flank and woke with prophecy, and families brought their dreams to the temple-keepers each morning to be written down and offered. Sleep was holy and easy; the Ludmere bed was a famous luxury, exported up and down the old roads. People who lived near Iss were the best-rested and most reasonable people in the world. It is a small horror the Vigil does not dwell on that its ancestors were famous for their naps.

Iconography. The closed eye, two curved lines, was drawn with a thumb in ash on the forehead of every Ludmere child at bedtime, and on the doorposts of houses where someone was sick, and on the lids of the dead. It was carved at the head of every Ludmere bed, which is why the Vigil burned every bed in 342. The finest images of Iss were in pale soapstone, worn smooth by the cheeks of people who had slept with their faces against them, and showed the god curled like a hound with its head on its paws and a row of tiny

sleepers lying along its lower lid like children along a bolster. In the Vigil these are smashed on sight. A few survive in the cellars of the Height, wrapped in felt, and their owners visit them alone.

Worship. The walkers-softly kept the temples, which were long low halls full of beds open to any pilgrim, and every morning they sat at the bedsides with a pen and wrote down what the sleepers had dreamed, and the dream-books were offered to the god in great stacks against its flank. The oracles' prophecies were mostly about weather and marriages, and all of them came true. In summer the god shed its lid-scales, thin and warm as a moth's wing, and the walkers burned them as incense, and the whole valley slept in the smoke for a night and woke rested for a month. Nobody in Ludmere ever worked hard. It was considered rude to the god.

*Lie down, lie down, the Lid is low,
The long room's warm, and in you go,
The hill is breathing, so breathe too,
And Iss will keep the dark for you.*

— LUDMERE CRADLE-SONG; TO SING IT WITHIN THE VIGIL'S WALLS IS A CRIME,
LISTED IN THE WAKING LAWS AS *THE SONG*

The Relic. A walker-softly's dream-book. A few hundred survived the burnings of 342, smuggled down the Sleepers' Mile in the flight from the First Night, and the College holds most of them at Quire. They are heavy, soft-paged, the ink gone brown, each a year of one temple's mornings: *Sowerby, the miller: dreamed of his mother's kitchen. Ama Pell: dreamed of rain on a tin roof.* In the volumes from the years of the Lack, the dreams change. Everyone in the temple dreams, night after night, of the same long dim room. Nobody dreams of the eye that the Vigil's sleepers see now; that

comes later. In the Lack the dreamers write only that the room had a table in it, and that someone was sitting down.

◇
A full belly is a bed.
THE VIGIL'S OLDEST PROVERB, AND ITS MOST
DANGEROUS

VEY, THE OPENING



God of birth and beginnings, of doors and first breaths. The smallest Provider, the size of a heifer, soft and red and warm and always, somehow, new. It moved from house to house in the highlands when a birth was near and lay across the threshold. Its iconography is a doorway with something small just stepping through, and in the oldest stones a round opening ringed by petals or teeth. Highland women gave birth with one hand on the god. They gave it the caul, the cord, and the first breath of each child, which the midwife caught in her cupped hands and blew into Vey's

nearest opening. Nothing was ever born wrong in the old highlands. Nothing was born too early. Doors stayed shut until they were opened, and when they were opened the god was usually standing on the other side.

Iconography. A doorway with something small just stepping through: carved on every lintel in the old highlands, painted on every birthing-stool, pressed into the clay of every new hearth. The older stones show the round opening ringed by petals, or teeth, and the very oldest show it ringed by both, alternating, which the

Attendance has never commented on. Vey's colour was the red of the highland clay, and highland doors were painted with a red handprint at the height of a child's hand, to show the god it was welcome. In Cradlewrack today a red handprint on a door means a birth the Attendance has not yet ruled on. Neighbors cross the road.

Worship. The god lay across the threshold of a birthing-house so that nothing would come through the door that should not, and the caul and the cord were laid in a basket at its side and were gone in the morning. When a new house was built, the god was led to it and

– HIGHLAND MIDWIFE'S SONG; THE ATTENDANCE FORBIDS IT, AND TEACHES ITS APPRENTICES TO SING OVER A LABOR THE TWO WORDS *NOT YET*, INSTEAD, ON ONE NOTE

The Relic. The breath-cups. Every midwife of the old highlands had one, a little bowl of red clay, unglazed, the size of two cupped palms, in which she caught first breaths when her hands were too slow. The Attendance keeps the last nine in the Lying-In at Kest, in a locked case, and consults them. When a birth of any kind is coming anywhere within a day's walk, the cups fog from the inside. Lately they are fogged all the time, and the Midwife-Paramount has stopped having the case opened, because she says she does not need a cup to tell her what the whole country already knows.



God of oaths and true speech. It lay along the floor of the deepest canyon in the east with one ear pressed to the stone, long and bare and grey-pink, listening. What it heard was so. Its iconography is an ear, sometimes an ear inside an open mouth, and in the canyon carvings a long figure with a finger to its own lips. Canyon-folk did not worship it so much as consult it: contracts were spoken into its ear, marriages were said there, and the guilty were brought to say their innocence in its hearing and see what happened. Parents warned children not to say *I could die* near the canyon floor. There was very little crime and almost no poetry. Visitors found the canyon peoples' honesty so frightening that the word for an Oathener in two other dialects still means *someone you cannot sit near*.

Iconography. An ear, carved in red sandstone, sometimes as small as a thumbnail and sometimes as wide as a cartwheel; an ear inside an open mouth; and the long figure, lying down, with one finger laid across its lips. The canyon ear-shrines that survive are worn smooth at the lobe where six centuries of foreheads have

– THE HEARING PRAYER, NEVER SUNG, ONLY MOUTHED; GIVEN HERE IN ITS HANDTALK GLOSS, AS TAUGHT IN THE QUIET

The Relic. The Bench of Clauses keeps, in a cedar box in the Hall of Conditions, a lump of the god's ear-wax the size of a loaf: amber, translucent, faintly warm, smelling of hot stone and old honey. It

asked to step through the door first, and the house was not lived in until it had. The midwives were few, respected and underworked, and spent most of their time drinking with the shepherds.

*Open, open, door and gate,
Open, little one, don't wait,
Vey is on the other side,
Open, open, open wide.*

◇
You knock to warn whatever is on the other side.

CRADLEWRACK MANNERS, TAUGHT BEFORE
WALKING

TOLM, THE WITNESS

pressed against them. Oathen rings, worn on the thumb, one for each oath outstanding, were in the old world worn in Tolm's sight as a courtesy, so the god could count. In the canyons, to point at your own ear is to say *I heard that*, and it is a threat.

Worship. Canyon-folk walked the length of the god to reach its ear, which took most of a day, and the walk was called *coming to the bearing*. What was said at the end of the walk had been rehearsed for weeks, and was said quietly. No offerings were brought; the god was given only true sentences, and the canyon believed it fed on them. Children were taken to the ear at seven to say their names, once, so that they would be so.

*I say what is.
I hear what is said.
What I say, I am.
Hear me, and let me be what I said.*

was cut from the ear on the night of the Silent Supper by a Tongue-line woman who could not bear to eat it. A fragment the size of a lentil, pressed into the ear of a Clausewright, lets her hear every lie

spoken in her presence as a small dry scraping, like a knife on a slate. The Bench uses it in treaty negotiations with nations that can lie. The lump has been shrinking for six hundred years. The Bench has calculated when it will run out, and has drafted a forty-page conditional about what to do then.

◇
The worst thing you can call a man in Tacit is talkative.

A RIM ROAD TRAVELER'S GUIDE, 590 A.G.

ORRUM, THE HOST



God of the hearth, of welcome, of the shared table. It lived in the rich heartland at the middle of the Table, very tall, stooping under doorways, warm, and it went from house to house. When it came to a door the hearth inside lit itself and the table was laid. Its iconography is a table with a single figure bent over it, laying it, and on the oldest stones an open hand holding out a bowl. The heartland was the richest country in the world because it was the most generous: every traveler was fed, every stranger seated, every quarrel settled over bread. Orrum was the god of the other seven too, in a way. The great carvings show all eight facing inward around a table, and the figure that pulls out the chairs is always Orrum.

Iconography. A table, and a single stooping figure laying it. On the oldest stones, an open hand holding out a bowl. In heartland houses before the Gorging, a chair carved into the wall beside the hearth, pulled out at an angle, for the god or for whoever it brought; in the heartland temples, a long stone board with every chair pulled out. The heartland's lintels were set a hand higher than any other land's, so that the god would not have to stoop so far. The Unfed have torn down every temple of Orrum but one and bricked every

hearth. They have kept the high lintels. Nobody can afford to rebuild a house.

Worship. The heartland worshipped Orrum by being hosted: when the god came, the household sat down with whoever was there, kin and stranger alike, and ate, and that was the rite. Between visits the heartland practiced: every house kept its door open at supper, every table had one more chair than the household needed, and the first and the last mouthful of every meal belonged to the stranger, if there was one, and if there was not, to the empty chair. The heartland was famous for never letting a traveler sleep hungry. It was also, the other peoples said, impossible to leave a heartland house in under three days.

*Come in, come in, the board is laid,
The fire's lit and the bed is made,
There's bread for you and bread for me,
And a chair for whoever the guest may be.*

– HEARTLAND HEARTH-HYMN, BEFORE THE GORGING; AT WANTING IT SURVIVES ONLY AS A LIST OF WORDS A CHILD MUST NEVER PUT TOGETHER

The Relic. The Host-bells. Before the Gorging every heartland door had a small bronze bell hung inside the lintel, and it rang by itself when the god turned into the lane, so that the household would have time to wash its hands. Most were melted down in the Thin Years and sold on the Rim for bread. The Hostwatch carry the rest: a bell on a cord, at the belt, which tells them, by ringing, that the god is near. In the Fast they ring several times a season. In the last two years they have begun to ring on the Rim Road, at inns, at

crossroads, in the middle of the night, and the Hostwatch trackers who carry them have begun to wrap them in wool.

◇
If a chair is pulled out for you, do not thank it.
THE FIFTH OF THE FIVE RULES OF THE FAST

THE EIGHTH



There is an eighth place in every carving older than the Gorging. In the ring of figures around the table, between the Host and the Closing Hand, there is a gap exactly the width of one of the others.

Sometimes it is a smooth recess. Sometimes the stone is gouged and pitted. Sometimes the chisel marks are fine and tidy and sometimes they are frantic, a mess of strokes cut over strokes, as if whoever did

it could not stop. In Brinehollow the stone was hacked with a boathook. In the Vigil it was ground out with a rasp so patiently that the recess shines. Analysis by the Cutwrights' College in 588 A.G. established that the removals were done by different tools, in different centuries, some of them before the Gorging and some of them after.

Nobody knows its name. Nobody knows its people. Nobody knows who ate it, or whether anyone did. No land claims it, and every land has, at some point in its history, made it a crime to ask. The question is called, on the Rim Road, *counting the chairs*. It is considered very bad luck.

A few things can still be noticed by those who look closely. In the carvings, the seven named figures are always shown facing inward toward the table, except that in perhaps one carving in ten, one or two of them have their heads very slightly turned toward the gap. On the oldest temple floors, in the places where worshipers would have stood, the stone in front of the eighth recess is unworn. In Table-speech there are two words for *guest*, and the older one has no plural, and no dictionary on the Table will print it.

Every other Provider has its page: its image, its rite, its song, its relic. The Eighth has this one, and this is all of it.

Iconography. A gap the width of one figure, between the Host and the Closing Hand. Chisel marks.

Worship. None recorded. In every land the stone in front of the eighth recess is unworn.

Hymn. None that is sung. The Unfed's oldest hymn has eight verses, and they sing seven.

The Relic. Under some of the recesses that nobody has ever swept, there is a little drift of grey dust that is not stone-dust, and is slightly too heavy, and is never cold.



Don't count the chairs, love. Just sit where you're put.

A RIM INNKEEPER, TO A CHILD, OVERHEARD AT THE
GROANING BOARD

THE EIGHTH AT YOUR TABLE

The Eighth is the great unanswered question of the setting, and its answer lives in the Secrets chapter, which only the GM should read. Until then, treat it the way the people of the Table do: as a gap. Put chisel marks in every old ruin. Give every carving an empty place. Let an innkeeper refuse to say why there is always one more chair than guests at the long table in his common room. Never explain. A player who starts counting chairs should find that the count never closes, and that nobody wants them to finish.

▼ THE LONG LACK

Nobody knows whether the Lack was a punishment, an accident, or a plan. That is the oldest wound in the world.

– PREFACE TO THE COLLEGE'S CONCORDANCE OF THE NINE YEARS

For nine years, nothing began. That is the shortest true account. What follows is a longer one, assembled from the chronicles of all

seven peoples, from the tally-sticks of granaries, from bone-pits, and from a great many songs that are no longer sung in company.

FOR NINE YEARS, NOTHING BEGAN. NOT A SEED,
NOT A CALF, NOT A CHILD, NOT A LOAF. LEARN THAT
SENTENCE. EVERYTHING ELSE IN THIS BOOK IS A
FOOTNOTE TO IT.

[FIRST LESSON OF THE COLLEGE'S COPYISTS, QUIRE]

THE FIRST YEAR: THE THIN

HARVEST

It began in Grace, with seed. Across every land at once, the spring sowing did not come up. Not poorly: not at all. Farmers dug up

their furrows in the second month and found the seed exactly where they had put it, swollen, soft, and rotting, with no shoot and no root. The second sowing did the same. The Providers were consulted and gave no answer, but that was not yet alarming; the Providers had never given answers. Ummer walked the fields as always and the fields did not bow. People said it was a bad year. The granaries were full from the year before. Nobody went hungry that winter, and the Tablenight feasts, which were then a celebration of the longest night, were held as usual.

Nobody alive remembers the smell of the furrows that spring, but the songs do: a sweet, soft, cellar smell, like apples left too long in a barrel, rising off every field on the Table at once as the seed rotted in the warm ground. In the plains they dug it up by the handful and held it out to Ummer, and the god looked at it, and lowered its great head, and walked on. In the fens the eel-roe went white in the shallows and did not hatch, and lay along the reed-banks in long pale ropes that the herons would not touch.

The tally of the great granary at Brawn Tilth, as the clerk cut it into the door-post year by year, survives in the College’s cellars:

YEAR OF THE LACK	BUSHEL IN STORE	MOUTHS ON THE LIST	CLERK’S NOTE
First	41,000	2,210	a bad year; seed-corn issued twice
Second	22,600	2,240	rationing by the half-loaf from Carving
Third	9,100	2,180	the herds slaughtered; meat in store, not counted
Fourth	3,300	1,960	the bins turned; ash; the bakers taken up
Fifth	400	1,410	leather, glue, bark issued by weight
Sixth	none	1,020	the list kept by households now, not names

There is no entry for the seventh year. The clerk is not on the sixth year’s list.

THE SECOND YEAR: THE EMPTY NETS

The nets came up empty along the whole western coast in the first week of Plenty and did not fill again. Hens stopped laying. Cows dried. Orchards flowered and the flowers fell and nothing set. The rationing began in the towns, and with it the first bread riots, and the first appearance of the phrase that would become the whole world’s grace: *Lack keep away*, muttered over thinned porridge. In the north, Osse’s hands were seen to move restlessly at night. In the heartland, Orrum went from house to house as always, and the hearths lit, and the tables were laid, and there was less and less to put on them.

The first bread riot recorded on the Table was at the old market of Sated, in the second Carving, when a baker named Odder Fane put up his price by a farthing-weight and the crowd came over his counter. He was not hurt. His boy was, trampled under the trestles while he tried to save the loaves, and the crowd stood back afterward and looked at what they had done, at the small flat shape among the spilled bread, and then a woman bent and picked up a loaf from beside the boy’s hand and ate it, and then they all did. Odder Fane closed his shop the same day and walked out into the plain, and was not seen again. The phrase *Lack keep away* first appears in the record that winter, chalked on his shutters.

THE THIRD YEAR: THE BARREN STALLS

Livestock went barren. No calf was dropped on the whole Table that year, and no lamb, and no foal. Then the herds began to be eaten, against every law, because a cow that will not calve is only meat. The old breeds died out that winter, all of them, in a single season of slaughter. The Providers grew visibly thinner. Plains-folk measured Ummer’s flank against a barn wall and marked it in chalk, and marked it again each month, and the marks moved inward. The great temples began demanding larger gifts, and got them, and the gods ate them slowly as always and grew no fatter.

The slaughter took a single Carving. Every byre on the Table rang with it: the bellowing of beasts that could smell the blood of the beasts before them, the thud of the poleaxe, the slap of hides on the yard stones. The red Tilth ox went that year, and the white goats of Ludmere with their soft drooping ears, and the fen-buffalo, and the long-legged canyon sheep that could climb a wall, and the little highland cattle that slept in the house with the family. Every one of them. People who were children that winter remembered for the rest of their lives the smell of a whole country salting meat at once, and the way the gutters ran, and how fat everyone was by Tablenight, and how quickly they stopped being.

◇

*We ate the last red ox on Tablenight and sang over it.
My father wept. I thought it was for the ox.*

DEPOSITION OF AMOS RUDDLE, GRISTMOOT, 58 A.G.

THE FOURTH YEAR: THE ASH BREAD

The flour went wrong. Grain that had been stored sound for years began to turn in the bins, and bread baked from it came out of the oven as grey ash in the shape of a loaf, which fell to dust when touched. Nobody has ever explained this. Bakers were hanged for it in three lands. Then the women stopped conceiving. It was noticed first in the highlands, where Vey lay across thresholds and no labor came; then everywhere. The last child born in the Lack is recorded in the Cradlewrack Tally as a girl delivered at Kest in the fourth Carving, who died on her third day. After her there were none for five years. The Providers stopped speaking that winter: not that they had ever spoken much, but the sounds stopped, the breathing grew shallow, the moods ceased to be readable. They lay still and grew thin.

The bakers were hanged in their aprons. In Sated the Board of that day had them hanged in a row of nine from the beam of the great granary gate, each with a loaf of the ash bread tied round his neck on a string, and the wind took the loaves to dust within the hour and blew it over the crowd, so that the people who had come to watch went home grey to the elbows, coughing, with the taste of it in their mouths: no taste at all, like breathing in from a cold hearth. The tenth baker, a woman, had fled, and the crowd went to her house and found her loaves in the oven, risen and brown and smelling of bread, and broke them open, and they were ash inside, and the crowd stood in her kitchen and wept.

The last child of the Lack, the girl born at Kest, was named Hope by her mother, which no midwife of the highlands had ever done before, because names wait. She lived three days. Her mother carried her up the round hill to Vey and laid her across the god's threshold, where she had been told all her life that nothing that came into the world could be lost; and the god lay there, thin and red and still, and did not open. The mother is recorded in the Cradlewrack Tally twice more: as the first woman of the highlands to go to the god's door in the night and not come back down, and, in the margin, in a later hand, *found in the clay at the foot of the hill in Grace; her arms still crossed as if carrying*. The highlands have not named a child in its first year since.

THE FIFTH YEAR: THE LEATHER WINTER

The fifth year was when people began to eat the things that are not food. Harness. Shoe leather. Boiled glue. Bark, then the inner bark, then the wood. Grass soup. Clay with a little salt. Lamp oil. In the cities, the rat-catchers became rich and then were eaten by the people they had sold to. The old and the very young began to die in numbers that overwhelmed every rite; in Sallowreach, Ossel's hands lay still and the dead piled at its side unclosed, and the fen-folk learned for the first time what a corpse does when no god tends it.

In the Fatlands, people followed Ummer across the bare fields on their knees, licking its footprints. Ummer did not stop. It walked more slowly than anyone had ever seen it walk.

What a corpse does when no god tends it, the fen-folk learned that winter, and it is the root of everything Sallowreach has become. In the old world the Hand closed the dead and the Sweetwaters took them in a season and the water stayed sweet. In the fifth year the dead lay at Ossel's side in rows, unclosed, their eyes open, their mouths open, and they swelled. The bellies rose and tightened and went green and then black, and on the warm days of Plenty they split with a sound like wet cloth, and what came out ran down the bank into the pools and the pools went sour and then foul, and the flies came up out of the reeds in a cloud that put out the lamps at noon. The fen calls that weather a Black Noon still. The families who had carried their dead to the god could not bear to look at them and could not bear to take them home, and many of them sat on the bank all summer, between the god and the dead, waiting for one of them to do something.

In the plains, some of those who licked the god's footprints went on to eat the soil itself, and their bellies swelled hard and round with clay, and they died fat, which the plains-folk still think the cruellest joke the Lack ever told. In the canyons people boiled their sandals and chewed the leather straps of their children's carrying-slings. In the highlands they ate the clay. In Ludmere they slept, and slept, and dreamed of food, and some of them stopped waking up to eat at all, and were found in the spring curled in their beds with their faces thin as paper and a look of perfect satisfaction.



Rat, three crumbs. Rat, skinned, five. Rat-catcher's boots, a lack the pair. Rat-catcher: ask within.

CHALKED ON A WALL IN OLD LASTGATE, FIFTH YEAR OF THE LACK; PRESERVED UNDER GLASS BY THE SEAMERS' GUILD

THE SIXTH YEAR: THE KITCHEN YEAR

This is the year the songs leave out.

It began with the dead. A family would lose a grandmother in the night, and in the morning the grandmother would not be carried out. The pot would be put on. There are chronicles from all seven peoples that say the same thing in the same flat way: *in the sixth year the dead were kept at home*. The first laws against it were passed in every land, and none of them were enforced, because the magistrates had grandmothers too.

The old went first, and many of them went of their own accord. That is remembered in every land with a particular grief. Grandmothers who could no longer stand stopped taking their share of the bark soup and pushed the bowl across the table to the

youngest child, and died with their hands folded, and were glad, the families said, to be useful. Grandfathers walked out into the snow at night so that they would not have to watch the pot being put on for them, and the families found them in the morning, and the pot was put on anyway. In the Fatlands there were old women who asked to be eaten, plainly, at table, the way they would ask for the salt, and their families wept and promised, and kept the promise. The Fatlands wake, with its best plates and its *he ate well*, begins in that year. It began as an apology.

Then it went further. The College has assembled, from coroners' rolls and the confessions of the old taken down in the first decades after the Gorging, a picture it publishes only in cipher. Households drew lots. Children were sent to stay with cousins and the cousins sent theirs back, so that no one would have to eat their own. The phrase for this, still known in Fatlands dialect as a curse, is *trading tables*. In the Oathen canyons, where a word spoken could not be unsaid, families made solemn promises to one another that they would not, and then had to watch the promises take their hands off. In Brinehollow a man rowed his dead wife out to the deep place to give her to Dromm, as was proper, and could not let go of her, and came back with her, and the town watched him carry her up the shingle and did not say a word, and that night every chimney on the street smoked.

The lots were drawn with knucklebones, mostly, because every house had a set, and because a knucklebone does not lie. The College has a set from a Brinehollow cottage, yellow with handling, five bones in a leather bag, and a sixth, smaller, separate, which is not a sheep's. Children who were sent across the village to *trade tables* knew where they were going and why, and some of them went singing, because they had been told it was a visit, and some of them knew better and went anyway, holding a cousin's hand, and the

cousins who were sent the other way passed them in the lane, and nobody looked up. What happened in the cousins' kitchens is not written down. What is written down, over and over, in the depositions of the old, is the walk back across the village afterward, and the bowl brought to the door, and the fact that it was always, in every telling, a little warm.

There was murder. The chronicles do not soften it. Men killed brothers for a hen's egg that was not there. In the Fatlands a father killed his second son so that his first might live, and ate with the first at the same table, and the first son lived to be the grandfather of a Gut-line house that still sits on the Board, whose arms show two spoons crossed, and nobody in the house will say why. In Ludmere a whole street sealed its doors and lit no fires and was found in the spring asleep around a single table, every one of them thin as a lath, and in the middle of the table, cleaned, the bones of the street's one fat man.

The smell of that year, survivors said, was the smell of a cooking-pot in a house where nothing has been cooked in months: so sudden and so rich that it brought the neighbors to the door. They would stand outside in the snow and not knock. They would just stand there, breathing it.

*Who's for the pot, who's for the pot,
Gran's too old and the baby's not,
Father's too tough and Mother's too dear,
So who's for the pot, the pot this year?
Not me, not me, I'm for the spoon,
I'll be for the pot, but not too soon.*

— COUNTING-RHYME OF THE KITCHEN YEAR, STILL PLAYED BY CHILDREN IN
FOUR LANDS, WHO CHOOSE THE ONE WHO IS *IT* BY THE LAST WORD;
COLLECTED AT THE WEEPING POST, 588 A.G.

I will tell it once, and then I will have told it. We had Hessa three days after. Mother said it was what Hessa would have wanted and then she went out to the yard and was sick on the snow and came back in and stirred the pot. The fat came up yellow on the top. I remember the color. I remember that it

smelled like supper and that I hated it for that more than anything. I remember that father said the grace first, Lack keep away, the way you say it over company, because she was company now. I ate. Everyone ate. We were alive in the spring. I have had children since, and they have had children, and I have never once let any of them see me eat.

— DEPOSITION OF WERRA HASK, TAKEN AT SATED, 61 A.G.; THE DEPONENT WAS
EIGHTY-TWO

Chalked on the beam over the hearth, Carving, sixth year. GRAN: when she says. Not ENNET. Not the baby. Lots for the rest. Father says we are not to look at Ennet when we

draw. Father says if it is him he will go out to the yard himself and we are to come for him after and not before. Mother says nothing. Gran says, tonight, she thinks, and asks for her good shawl.

— WORDS FOUND UNDER LIMEWASH IN A COTTAGE AT BRAMBLE FURROW
DURING REPAIRS IN 603 A.G.; THE COTTAGE WAS PULLED DOWN THE SAME
MONTH, BY ORDER OF THE PARISH, AND THE BEAM BURNED

The Kitchen Year has a long tail. Builders in every land still find what it left: small bones under hearthstones, cracked lengthwise for the marrow; a skull in a chimney-breast, wrapped in a christening gown; a cupboard bricked up in a canyon gallery with a pot inside it and a spoon still standing in what is left. Such finds are not reported. They are wrapped in clean cloth, by custom, and carried to the nearest crossroads at night, and left. In Brinehollow there is a street in old Saltwick where every chimney smoked on the night the widower carried his wife up the shingle, and no house on it has been lived in since, and no one has pulled them down, and the doors are kept painted.



*Never look at your family while you eat. It is the one
rule older than the grace.*

FATLANDS TABLE MANNERS, AS TAUGHT TO
CHILDREN WHO DO NOT ASK WHY

THE SEVENTH YEAR: THE BONE DOLE

Governments, such as they were, took over the dying. In every land, the dead were collected by the authorities and rendered in public kitchens, and the meat was given out by ration, and nobody asked whose it was. It was, the chronicles say, the most orderly year of the Lack. The first ration-discs were cut that winter: rounds of salt-cured bone, stamped, each one good for a day's ration at the public kitchen. The bone was the bone of the dead. The name stuck, and the value: one day's bread. People stopped fighting over food in the seventh year, because there was a system, and a queue, and a coin, and that is the year the old world truly ended.

The kitchens were kept by priests, because there was no one else left who was trusted, and the priests kept tallies. Every body brought to the vats was entered by name, parish and weight; every ration given out was entered by name and disc. These were the tally-priests of the Bone Dole, and their lists, carried out of the kitchens in the ninth year and copied and recopied, are the oldest documents in the Master Concordance at Quire. The Cutwrights' College was born at a vat-side, with a pen.

The kitchens themselves are described in every chronicle the same way: a long shed, a row of coppers, a queue that went out of the door and round the square and down the street and did not move quickly, and over all of it a smell of boiling that soaked into the clothes of everyone who waited and could not be washed out. People in the queue did not speak. They held their discs. Collectors call those first discs Dole-bones, or *grandmother coins*, and the few that survive are worth a great deal and are never spent. The coin in a

modern purse descends from them in name and value only (see *The Lack*, below).

The Providers lay down. All of them, everywhere, within days of one another. Ummer stopped walking at last in the middle of a bare field and folded its legs. Orrum, in the heartland, stopped going from house to house and sat on the bare hill at Hallowboard beside the eight-sided table, with its head bowed, as if waiting for someone to arrive.



*It was the most orderly year of the Lack. Nobody
fought. There was a queue.*

THE COLLEGE'S CONCORDANCE OF THE NINE
YEARS; THE SENTENCE HAS BEEN UNDERLINED, IN
FOUR DIFFERENT INKS, BY FOUR DIFFERENT
ARCHPROVOSTS

THE EIGHTH YEAR: THE ELDEST WALK

In the spring of the eighth year, the priests of all seven peoples met at Hallowboard. It was the only time in history all seven sat together, and the only record of the meeting is a list of resolutions carved into the hill's foot-stone, worn almost smooth. They had come to read the carvings on the table's eight sides, which were older than any of them, and they found, or believed they found, a demand. The carvings showed, beneath the ring of figures, a line of smaller figures walking toward the table with their arms at their sides. The priests read it as a tithe: the first of every house. The gods had given each house its firstborn; the gods were starving; the gods wanted the first back.

They called themselves the Moot. They were what was left of seven priesthoods: the hurdle-folk of Ossel, grey-thumbbed and silent; the Sowers of Ummer, who had walked behind the god all their lives and could not now keep up with its stillness; the Soundings of Dromm, divers with burst ears; the walkers-softly of Iss, who had not slept since the dreams went bad; the door-wives of Vey, highland midwives with no births to attend; the Listeners of Tolm, who came with their mouths bound; and the board-keepers of Orrum, who were the hosts, and who fed the Moot for nine days on the last of the heartland's stores, and who ate nothing themselves. Most of them had walked for a month to get there. Several died on the hill and were not, the foot-stone records, put in the pot, out of respect. Nobody recorded what was done with them instead.

*RESOLVED, by the Seven at the Board, in the eighth year of
no increase. That the gods are hungry with us. That the*

carving shows the small ones walking to the board. That the small ones are the first of every hearth. That what was given first shall be given back. That it shall be done in Plenty, before the long dark. That no house shall be spared, nor any people.

That the knife shall be bronze, as of old. That it shall be done kindly. That none shall eat of the given. That we shall not speak of it after.

– THE RESOLUTIONS OF THE MOOT, FROM RUBBINGS OF THE WORN FOOT-
STONE AT HALLOWBOARD; THE COLLEGE'S READING, 140 A.G. BELOW THE LAST
LINE THERE IS A FURTHER LINE, ALMOST ENTIRELY WORN AWAY, OF WHICH
ONLY TWO WORDS CAN BE MADE OUT: *THE EIGHTH*

By common counsel of all seven peoples, it was done. In the last month of Plenty, in the eighth year of the Lack, the firstborn adult of every hearth on the Table walked to the feet of their people's god.

They walked, mostly, of their own will. That is the part every chronicle insists on. They were sons and daughters of twenty, of forty, of sixty; they were the heirs of farms and shops and fishing boats; they kissed their younger siblings and handed over their tools and walked out of their villages in long lines, singing, with the whole village walking behind them to the boundary stone and stopping there. They walked for days. They were very thin. Many died on the road. The rest arrived.

Who was firstborn was argued in every house. Twins were the worst of it. A mother who had borne twins and could not, or would not, say which had come first watched both of them walk, in most lands, because the Moot had said *no house shall be spared*, and the village elders would not choose. A family whose eldest had died in the Kitchen Year sent the next, and argued all the way to the boundary that it was not fair, and sent the next anyway. A man of seventy, the eldest son of a dead mother, walked, and his own eldest son of fifty walked behind him, and his eldest granddaughter of thirty behind that, three generations of one line on the same road. Some households had no firstborn living. They gave their bread to those that had, for the walk. It was thought the least they could do.

The walks took weeks. The lines went across the bare country singing at first, the old songs of every people, and then not singing, because singing took breath. They walked in their best clothes, which hung on them like washing. The ones who fell on the road were left where they fell, with their faces covered, and the line walked round them, and those coming after walked round them too, so that by the end of the month every road to every god on the Table had its little covered shapes along it, a bowshot apart, like milestones. In the Vigil they still say *a bowshot apart* of things that happen at regular intervals, without knowing why.

The rite was the same everywhere because the priests had agreed it. At the god's feet, each firstborn knelt, and a priest opened their throat with a bronze knife, and laid them down against the god, as close as could be got. In the fens they were laid in rows between Ossel's open hands. In the plains they were laid along Ummer's folded legs until it was hidden to the knees. At Longslab they were rowed out to the deep place and let down on weighted ropes in their thousands. In the canyons each one whispered a vow into Tolm's ear

before the knife: *I give myself, so that they may eat*, and that was so, or should have been. In the red hills they were laid across thresholds. At Ludmere they were laid along the sleeping flank like children put to bed. At Hollowboard, the heartland's firstborn were laid on the stone table, which was big enough for all of them, in a heap.

The priests did it themselves. That is in every account. There were not many of them and there were very many firstborn, and the knives were bronze and went dull, and the priests had to stop and hone them on the stones, and the line waited, kneeling, while they did. The work went on for days. The priests' arms gave out and their acolytes held their elbows up for them. In the fens the water between Ossel's hands turned red and then black and stood thick as gravy. On the threshing floor the blood ran in the grooves cut for the grain. At Longslab the rowers came back from the deep place for another load forty times a day, and the weighted ropes ran out, and the last of the firstborn of the coast were let down with stones tied in their own shirts. In the canyons the Listeners counted the vows as they were whispered. They stopped counting at nine thousand.

The count was never made. The College's best estimate is somewhere above sixty thousand.

Nothing happened.

The gods did not take them. The gods did not stir. Ossel's hands did not close a single pair of eyes; the dead lay in the fen staring upward until the birds that were left found them. Ummer did not eat. Tolm, which heard every vow, did not make one of them so. The bodies lay where they had been laid, through the end of Plenty and into Carving, against the flanks of gods who did not move, and nothing rose from the fields, and nothing came to the nets, and no woman quickened.

It was Plenty, and hot. That is the part the chronicles cannot leave alone. The bodies lay in the late summer sun against the flanks of the starving gods, in heaps, in rows, in the shallow water, on the stone table, and they did what bodies do. They swelled. The smell went out over the bare country for twenty miles, so that people in villages that had sent their eldest a month before knew, on the evening wind, exactly what had become of them. The flies were so thick at Hollowboard that the heap on the table could not be seen, only a black, moving, humming mound the shape of a table, and the Moot's board-keepers stood around it with their sleeves over their faces and did not leave, because they had promised the hosts would stay. Birds came from every corner of the Table, birds that should

have been dead of hunger long since, and the gods did not stir to stop them. Ossel's hands lay open on the peat while crows walked across its palms to the faces. The Hand that had closed every pair of eyes in the fens for ten thousand years did not close one.

And in Carving, when it was clear, the people who had walked their eldest to the gods' feet came back for them with sacks, at night, and did not look one another in the face, and carried them home.

They went in the dark so that the neighbours would not see, and found the neighbours already there, with their own sacks, and nobody spoke. What was left by then was not much, and not whole, and had to be lifted with spades in some places and in others did not need to be lifted at all, because the birds had left only the clothes. They knew their own by the clothes. They carried them home on their backs, through the bare fields, a long dark line of stooping people with heavy sacks, the same roads the eldest had walked down singing. What they did with them at home, in the eighth winter of the Lack, after the Kitchen Year and the Bone Dole, the chronicles do not say, and every reader of the chronicles knows.

— DEPOSITION OF HESSA GULL, LOWMARK, 49 A.G.; AN ANCESTOR, THE GULLS SAY, OF SENNET GULL THE WRECKWIFE

The aftermath of the Walk has never ended. The priesthoods did not survive it; in most lands the surviving priests of the Moot were the first meat of the ninth winter, taken by crowds from the temples where they had shut themselves up, and the crowds did not use bronze knives. The seven old orders were never restored. Every priesthood on the Table now, Confessor, Thanker, Grace-Keeper, Purger, was made after the Gorging, by people who remembered what the old ones had asked for. And every village on the Table still has its *walk-stone*: the boundary stone where the families stopped and watched the line go on without them. Children are told not to sit on it. Lovers do not meet at it. On the night before the anniversary, in late Plenty, somebody in every village goes out and washes it, and nobody admits to being the one.



To walk the eldest: to give the best thing you have for nothing, knowing it will be for nothing, because doing nothing is worse.

THE COLLEGE'S DICTIONARY OF TABLE-SPEECH,
ENTRY UNDER WALK

My brother Tam was the eldest. He was forty and I was thirty-one. He gave me his boat and his good knife and kissed my children and walked to the shingle with the rest and they rowed him out. I stood on the rail of the jetty and watched the boat go. He waved. He was laughing at something one of the rowers said. In Carving I went to the deep place in the dark with a grapple and a lantern and fished for him. There were hundreds of us out there, every boat on the coast, with lanterns, fishing for our eldest. I brought up a woman I did not know and let her go again. I brought up a man with no face. I brought up Tam on the ninth night, by his shirt, which our mother had sewn. I knew him by the shirt. I rowed him home. I will not say any more about it. I have given his knife to my eldest. I have told my eldest she is not to be the eldest of anything, ever. I do not know what I mean by it. She says she understands.

THE ELDEST WALK IN PLAY

The Eldest Walk is the act no land discusses and every land remembers. It is why the Gorging happened. Before the Walk, the peoples of the Table believed the gods were starving with them and could be fed. After it, they knew that their gods would take nothing, give nothing, and save no one. Their most precious offering had been laid at the feet of every Provider in the world and been left to rot. The Gorging was not an act of hunger alone. It was an act of fury. Every land has a quiet name for it (the Tithe, the Long Line, the Giving of the First) and every land has, somewhere in its oldest families, a story of the eldest who did not go, or who went and came back. In the present day the Purgation preaches a second Walk, and the phrase *to walk the eldest* means, in every dialect, to make a sacrifice you know will be wasted.

Every PC whose family is old enough has a walk-stone somewhere, and an ancestor who knelt at it or carried a sack back past it. A character from a Gut-line or Hand-line house may know the name of their own house's eldest who walked; a Scrapling almost certainly does not, and may learn it, by College genealogy, at the worst possible moment. Use the Walk as a measuring rod for sacrifice in play: when any character is asked to give something precious for a promise from a god, someone at the table should remember the sacks.

THE NINTH YEAR: THE TURNING

The last winter was the quietest. There was nothing left to fight over. The dead were not collected anymore, because the collectors were dead. In every land the survivors sat in their houses in the dark and looked at their gods out of the windows, and the gods lay where

they had lain down, enormous, gaunt, still, with the bones of the eldest at their feet.

Nobody knows who said it first. Every people claims a different first speaker, and in every account the first speaker is a mother. What she said, in every version, comes to the same thing: *They have something left on them, and we have nothing. They would not eat what we gave. Let us see if they will be eaten.*

The knives were already ground. People had been grinding knives for nine years, out of habit, for want of anything else to do with their hands.

The grinding was the last sound of the Long Lack, survivors said: a slow scrape of iron and bronze and bone on whetstone, from every

house, in the dark, all winter, like insects in a wall. Nobody told anyone to do it. Every household did it. In the Fast, too, on the long walk in to Hallowboard, the heartland’s people ground their knives as they walked. They have never discussed this. No Unfed household keeps a whetstone now; the Reckoners hone their black-iron knives on the Rim, on Company stone, and think nothing of it.

◇
They have something left on them, and we have nothing.

THE FIRST SPEAKER OF THE TURNING; IN EVERY LAND, A MOTHER; IN NO LAND, NAMED

▼ THE GORGING

Whether it happened on one night or across a season is disputed. The stories call it the Night of Seven Tables, and Tablenight is kept on the longest night of Lack in every land, but the chronicles do not agree. Brinehollow’s dragging took three days and its god four more to die. Sallowreach ate last of all and slowest, and some fen accounts stretch its meal over a fortnight. Oathen’s Silent Supper, because no one spoke of it, has no recorded date at all. The Cutwrights’ College, which has tried to reconcile them for four centuries, settled in 501 A.G. on the formula *the ninth winter, within a single Plate*, meaning one cycle of the moon, and has quietly lost every argument about it since.

To those disputes add two more. The Vigil’s chronicle gives Ludmere’s cutting nine nights, done slowly enough not to wake the god; Oathen’s Ledger, which records no date, records three nights of silence in the Gullet. And the heartland came over the last ridge to Hallowboard on the tenth day, and did not eat.

What is agreed is this. In every land, the people went to their god with knives, and their god did not fight. The Providers did not flee, did not cry out, did not strike, did not so much as turn over. They were enormous; a twitch of Ummer’s flank would have crushed a

village; a breath from Dromm drowned whole fleets in the old days. They held still. It is recorded everywhere and explained nowhere, and every argument in the world, sooner or later, becomes an argument about why.

THE SHARING

Each god was butchered and shared out, and how it was shared became the shape of every society since. The families nearest, strongest, quickest, or most ruthless took the choicest parts: the hands, the gut, the lungs, the eyes, the caul, the tongue. Those behind them took the meat. Those behind them took what fell. Those at the very back licked the bones. Nobody planned it. Nobody needed to.

The pattern was the same everywhere, which nobody remarked on at the time and every scholar since has remarked on endlessly. In every land a few families took the one portion in which the god’s nature seemed to live, and those families became the high Cuts; a larger crowd took the flesh, and became the common people; and a ragged multitude at the back took what was dropped, trodden, gnawed and left, and became the Scraplings.

LAND	THE CHOICE PORTION	WHO TOOK IT	WHAT THEY BECAME
Sallowreach	The hands	the Corse, Vane and Grue kin	the Hand-lines
The Fatlands	The stomach and entrails	the families nearest the belly	the Gut-lines
Brinehollow	The lungs	those who cut in under the ribs	the Lung-lines
The Vigil	The shut eyes	climbers on the face, with ropes	the Eye-lines
Cradlewrack	The caul	the women holding the openings	the Caul-lines
Oathen	The tongue	the circle with the slivers	the Tongue-lines
The Fast	Nothing	nobody	the Unfed

Who your ancestors were matters less than what part
they ate.

THE FIRST SENTENCE OF EVERY COLLEGE
CERTIFICATE OF CUT

WHAT WAS LEFT

Each god left a place behind it, and every one of those places is still there. Ossel's long grey skeleton lay in the reeds below Lastgate until the fen took it, and the fen has never let it finish going down; at low water on still days the ribs show, like the timbers of a wreck. The Trencher at Brawn Tilt is still greasy, and nothing grown in a mile of it is eaten even by Fatlanders. Longslab is wet. The valley above Ludmere is flat, the grass lying down as if something enormous had only just got up off it. The round hill above Kest has its door. The Gullet in Oathen, where Tolm lay, is a long dry trough of sand that is warm at night, where pilgrims lay their ears. And Hallowboard is clean.

The bones were used. They had to be. The Table had been starving for nine years and was suddenly rich in the hardest, whitest bone anyone had ever seen. Hand-line houses still have chairs whose legs were cut from Ossel's lesser finger-bones. The oldest Fatlands granaries are roofed on Ummer's ribs. The first true lacks were cut from god-bone that year, in every land, by anyone with a saw, and a few of those First Lacks still pass from hand to hand on the Rim, unrecognized, until someone who handles them for a month wakes with the wrong god's taste in their mouth.

THE MORNING AFTER

The famine ended the next morning.

Every land records this the same way, with the same awe. People woke on the morning after their meal to a green haze on the

furrows. Hens laid. By midday the nets were full. Within the week crops stood shoulder high in fields that had been sown nine years earlier with seed that had rotted in the ground. Women quickened that month, all of them, all at once, the old and the very young and some who had long been past it. Cattle that had been barren for six years dropped calves within the season, which should not be possible. Trees that had been cut for firewood put up new shoots from the stumps overnight. The world, which had not begun anything for nine years, began everything at once.

That speed should have frightened people more than it did. Here and there it did. In the Fatlands, where the wheat stood shoulder high in seven days, an old woman named Tallis Brome is recorded as having walked out into the new field on the eighth morning, broken an ear, chewed it, and said to her grandson: *This was not grown. This was poured.* Nobody listened. Everyone was eating.

Only in the Fast did the Lack not lift. The heartland's people, who had not eaten their god, woke to the same bare soil, the same empty coops, the same rotten seed, and looked out over the Rim at their neighbors' green fields with an emotion that has shaped their entire history and that they have never once named correctly.

Nine months after the Gorging, the Table gave birth. Every land records the season the same way: the first Carving after the Gorging was one long lying-in, every house with a child or two or three, every midwife in the world awake for a season. Women of sixty bore. Girls bore. The children of that autumn were called *the Plenty-born* and were, every chronicle agrees, the healthiest generation the world has known: broad, ruddy, loud, and every single one of them, the College would establish a century later, carrying the god of their land in their blood a little more strongly than their parents. The Plenty-born are the ancestors of everyone now alive. They grew up fat on miracle grain in a world that had started again. Most of them lived to great ages. Many of them, in old age, were the first to notice the Taste.

THIS WAS NOT GROWN. THIS WAS POURED.

[TALLIS BROME, ON THE EIGHTH MORNING AFTER THE GORGING, TO A
GRANDSON WHO DID NOT LISTEN]

The world, which had not begun anything for nine
years, began everything at once. Nobody asked who
was pouring.

MEEK GARRITY, NOTES TOWARD A HISTORY OF THE
REFUSAL, SUPPRESSED

▼ THE THREE DOCTRINES

Every argument in the world eventually becomes an argument about why the gods held still. There are three answers, each with its temples, its martyrs and its hecklers, and most people on the Table believe a little of each depending on how the harvest went.

Each also has a sermon that every child on the Table has heard at least once, from a pulpit, a cart-tail or a drunk uncle. What follows are three of them, preached in the last generation, given at length because every one of them is still being preached tonight, somewhere on the Rim, to a crowd that is a little bigger than last year's.

DOCTRINE	PRIESTS	CENTRAL RITE	SAYS OF THE REGROWTH	STRONGEST AMONG
The Theft	Confessors	penance; fasting on the Meal days	justice	the poor; Sallowreach, Oathen
The Gift	Thankers	the Thanksgiving Meal	a shared grief	the comfortable; Fatlands, the Rim
The Bait	none; "Baiters"	none; it is illegal	a harvest	the frightened; everywhere, rising

THE THEFT

We murdered them. The Regrowth is justice, and we deserve it. The oldest and most common belief, held by the majority in Sallowreach and Oathen and by most of the poor everywhere. Its priests are called Confessors, and its rites are rites of penance: fasting on the anniversaries of the Meal, self-scourging in the Fatlands, the reading-aloud of ancestral guilt in Brinehollow. The Theft explains the Providers' stillness as shock, or contempt, or the paralysis of the betrayed. It offers no hope and asks for none. Its comfort is that the world makes sense.

You ask why it did not fight. I will tell you why a mother does not fight when her son comes for her with a knife. She is too surprised. She cannot believe it. She stands in her own kitchen with her hands open and looks at him, and she is still looking at him when she goes down. That is how they lay. That is how they looked at us. And now they are coming back up through us, through the gut and the lung and the eye, and you call it a curse? It is a bill. It is the only honest thing that has happened to this family in six hundred years. Pay it. Bow your head and pay it.

Look at me. I am a Confessor of the Weeping Post and my grandmother was a Hand-line bastard and I can feel her god in my wrists when it rains. I know what I am. Do you know

what you are? You are a mouthful. You are a mouthful that got away. Every one of you carries a bite of a murdered thing in your blood, and it is not resting, and it should not rest, because we did not let it. We did not sing it to sleep. Oh, the Vigil did. The Vigil sang lullabies while it cut out the eyes. We did not close its eyes. We did not lay it in the Sweetwater. We sat on it and chewed.

So when your daughter's eyes will not shut, when your husband walks west, when your father's hands come grey and cold to the table and will not stop closing the salt-cellar, I do not want to hear the word curse. A curse is something done to you by someone who hates you. This is not hate. Nobody hates you. This is an account being settled by the only creditor in the world that cannot be bribed, because you have already eaten it.

What do we do? We do what debtors do. We fast on the anniversaries, so that for one day a year we know what we did it for. We say the names. We give back what can be given back, which is nothing, so we give it anyway, with our heads bowed. And when it is our turn to be collected, when it is our line the College marks for the Course, we go quietly, and we do not ask the Second Table to save us, and we do not ask the Purgation to bleed us, and we do not ask the Host for supper. We pay. Bow your head and pay.

— CONFESSOR ABEL RENNICK, SERMON AT THE WEEPING POST, 627 A.G.;
RENNICK WAS TAKEN BY THE COURSE IN 633, AND IS SAID TO HAVE MET IT
WITH HIS HEAD BOWED



It is a bill. Pay it.

PAINTED OVER THE DOOR OF EVERY CONFESSORS'
CHAPEL ON THE RIM

THE GIFT

They offered themselves out of love. The Regrowth is a tragedy neither side wanted. The gentlest doctrine and the most popular among the comfortable: Gut-lines families in the Fatlands, Vigil merchants, the Rim Road's innkeepers. Its priests are called Thankers and its

central rite is the Thanksgiving Meal, at which the worshipers eat in silence and then say, together, the names of all seven Providers, the eaten and the one that was not. The Gift reads the Providers' stillness as consent and their Regrowth as an unwilling side effect, a grief shared by eater and eaten. It holds that the gods suffer in the blood as their hosts do, and that kindness to the godsigned eases the god. Its critics call it the doctrine of people who have never been hungry.

Children, think of it this way. Your grandmother is very old and there is no bread. She takes her portion and puts it on your plate when she thinks you are not looking. She says she is not hungry. That is what they did, all of them, on that night: they lay down and they put themselves on our plates and said, eat, we are not hungry. And now they are in us, and they are hurting, and we are hurting, because love that big does not fit inside a body. It was not supposed to come back. It is not their fault. It is not ours. Be gentle with the ones whose eyes do not close. Be gentle with the ones who must be gagged. They are carrying more of the gift than you.

— THANKER MAUDLIN ASHE, CHILDREN'S HOMILY, LAMPWICK HALT, 640 A.G.;
THREE OF THE CHILDREN PRESENT HAVE SINCE BEEN COUNTED, AND ASHE
HAS NOT PREACHED AT THE HALT AGAIN



*Be gentle with the ones whose eyes do not close. They
are carrying more of the gift than you.*

EMBROIDERED ON THANKER SAMPLERS, SOLD AT
EVERY RIM INN

THE BAIT

They wanted to be eaten. The Lack was theirs. This is how gods breed: starve a people, be swallowed, and grow back through ten thousand bodies instead of one. The doctrine first appears in the record around 330 A.G., in a pamphlet nailed to a Rim Road toll-house, and has been illegal in four lands (Sallowreach, the Fatlands, the Vigil and Oathen) for most of the time since. It is gaining ground in all seven, because it is the only doctrine that explains the speed of the Week of Rising and the only one that matches the arithmetic of the Regrowth. Its preachers have no order and no title. They are called *Baiters* by their enemies and nothing at all by themselves. Some of them are terrified; some, like the Second Helping of the Fatlands, are joyous; all of them agree that the Gorging was not the end of the gods but their sowing.

Why did it not fight? Because a seed does not fight the ground. Look at your hands. Look at the joints on the Hand-line Regent's fingers, the eyes on the Vigil's lords, the cord on the

Now, I know some of you have been told otherwise. I know some of you have a grandfather who sits in the corner and says we murdered them into his soup. Let him say it. He is sad, and sad people like a story where somebody is to blame. But think. Do mothers fight their children at supper? Do they? No. They put the best bit on your plate and pretend they've already eaten. And when you are grown and they are old and you take them in and feed them, is that a theft? It is the same love going back the other way.

That is why we eat in silence at the Thanksgiving Meal, and then say the names, all seven, Ossel and Ummer and Dromm and Iss and Vey and Tolm and Orrum, even Orrum, who was not eaten, because it gave too, it gave its people the chance to say no. We say the names because you thank people by name. And then we are kind. That's all. That is the whole of the Gift. When you meet a Brinehollower bailing at dusk you hold her bucket. When you meet a Vigil girl blinking you pinch her, gently. When you meet a Kept man on the Rim the day before the Drop you carry his letter. We are all carrying them. They are all carrying us.

Uncut, the fat on the Board. Did your great-great-grandmother eat a god, or did a god get into your great-great-grandmother? Nine years without a single child born, and then a whole world of children in one spring, every one of them with the god in the blood. You think that was mercy? It was planting. You are a furrow, friend. We all are. And the harvest is due.

Here is the arithmetic, since none of your priests will do it for you. Nine years of nothing. Then one night, and then everything at once, a week of rising, a whole world pregnant in a season. Who sowed that? You were starving; you could not sow a row of beans. Then: one god per people. Not two. Not one god shared. Each god cut so that a few got the heart of it and the rest got the meat and the beggars got the licking, in every land the same, as if somebody had drawn up the seating. Did your great-great-grandmother draw it up? She could not read.

And now the curves. Ask the College. They won't tell you, but ask them where the lines go. Every land's Regrowth, bending upward, all at once, after six hundred years, the same decade. Seven separate gods, coming up together, like a field. That is not justice. Justice is not punctual. That is not grief either; grief does not keep time. That is a crop.

So eat or don't eat, pray or don't pray, I cannot help you. I am only a man on a cart. But when your lord swells and roots

and opens his mouth in the field and something looks out, do not say you were never told. You are not being punished and

you are not being loved. You are being grown.

– ANONYMOUS BAITER, PREACHING ON THE RIM ROAD AT SALTCLICK CROSS SHORTLY BEFORE BEING DROWNED BY A CROWD IN A HORSE-TROUGH, 638 A.G.; THE CROWD, THE WARDENS' REPORT NOTES, THEN STOOD AROUND THE TROUGH FOR A LONG TIME WITHOUT SPEAKING, AND THREE OF THEM WENT HOME AND DID NOT COME OUT FOR A YEAR



You are a furrow, friend. We all are.

CHALKED ON THE HEM WALL AT A HUNDRED POSTS; THE WARDENS WASH IT OFF, AND IT COMES BACK

DOCTRINES AT THE TABLE

Doctrine is a fine way to start fights between player characters who otherwise agree on everything. Ask each player, at character creation, which of the three their character believes and which their parents believed. The doctrines are not settled by the game; the Secrets chapter offers a default truth and three alternatives built on each doctrine, and the GM may choose. Until then, every sermon is equally true, and equally useless.

Doctrine also decides small things in play. A Theft-raised character fasts on the Meal days and may refuse a Gift-keeper's charity as an insult. A Gift-raised character says the seven names before a feast and will expect to be thanked for holding a stranger's bucket. A Bait-raised character has learned to keep their mouth shut in four lands, and recognizes, in the way the Second Helping or the Second Table speak of the gods, something they were taught as a child and never said aloud.

▼ THE REGROWTH

The return of an eaten god is called the Regrowth, and its marks on a person are called godsign. It moves through four stages, in a person, a family, or an entire country: the Taste, the Appetite, the Course, and the Seating. Each land's Regrowth obeys its own rules and is detailed in that land's chapter. What is shared is the shape, and the speed.

The Taste is small wrongnesses; dreams, cravings, a tell in the body that a lover notices first. The Appetite is compulsion; the body

begins wanting what the god wants and will stop at nothing for it. The Course is flesh changing; the person becomes visibly, physically something else, grey-handed or loamy or lidless or veiled. The Seating is the god, in some real portion, present again, wearing a person or a place. Between the Course and the Seating there is a last threshold the College calls *the Brink*, when the person is still a person only by courtesy.

LAND	THE TASTE	THE APPETITE	THE COURSE	THE SEATING
Sallowreach	Dread of open things	Compulsive closing	Grey hands, extra joints; touch finishes	A Hush
Fatlands	Hunger that wakes you	Eating without choosing	Swelling, rooting, loamy skin	A living hill
Brinehollow	Salt at waking	The pull westward	Grey skin, deep eyes, no breath	The Tenant takes the house
The Vigil	Heavy lids, spreading yawns	Blinks	The lids are gone	A sleeper begins to move
Cradlewrack	About to begin	False labor	True bearing	The land itself in labor
Oathen	Your words, echoed	The urge to swear	Plain speech binds	A Sayer

No land has reached a full Seating of its god. Three are close. And every Regrowth is speeding up: signs that took generations now take years; the Hushes spread, the pangs shorten, the beds fill, the sea drops. The College's figures show that every land's curve bent upward at nearly the same time, in the decade after 600 A.G., which

is impossible if the seven Regrowths are separate things. Each government is hiding its own numbers. The College holds all of them.

Nobody here is waiting to die. We are all waiting to be allowed.

FEN PROVERB, AS TRUE NOW IN EVERY LAND AS IN THE ONE IT WAS MADE IN

▼ BLOOD AND CLASS: THE CUTS

Who your ancestors were matters less than what part they ate. The families who took the choicest portions of a god carry the strongest godsign, and in every land they became the nobility, because in the first generations godsign looked like blessing. A Hand-line touch that could close a wound, a Gut-line appetite that never sickened, an Eye-line who could see in the dark: these were gifts, and their bearers

were raised up. By the time the gifts curdled, the Cuts owned everything.

These bloodlines are called **Cuts**, and a person's Cut is the measure of god in their blood, from 0 to 5. The College grades them as follows, and its grades are used in law in every land.

CUT	NAME	WHO
0	Blank	No godsign. Rare births; the Unfed of the Fast
1	Scrapling	Descended from those who licked the bones
2	Common	Those who ate the meat; most people alive
3	Prime	Old gentry; the hungry middle
4–5	High	Nobility of the choice Cut; the furthest along

Each land prizes a different Cut: the Hand-lines of Sallowreach, the Gut-lines of the Fatlands, the Lung-lines of Brinehollow, the Eye-lines of the Vigil, the Caul-lines of Cradlewrack, the Tongue-lines of Oathen. Marriage between Cuts is arranged with ledgers. A high-Cut house that marries down dilutes its blood and its claim; a Scrapling who marries up buys rank and a faster death. In every land, the rulers are the most monstrous people in it, and the Regrowth advances fastest in palaces.

A Scrapling who marries up buys rank and a faster death. A Scrapling who marries down buys nothing, and lives.

RIM PROVERB

SCRAPLINGS

The poor descend from those who got the scraps and licked the bones: the stragglers at the back of the crowd, the too-weak, the too-slow, the ones who arrived after the good parts were gone. They are called **Scraplings**, and they are the least changed people alive. A Scrapling of Sallowreach still cannot die, a Scrapling of the Vigil still cannot sleep, because the Rule of each land touches everyone in it; but their Regrowth crawls where a noble's gallops. Scraplings do the work of the Table: they haul, stitch, bail, nudge and render. They have always been told that their thin blood is the mark of their

ancestors' weakness. They are only now, in the last generation, beginning to understand that it is the reason they may outlive their masters, and some of them are beginning to say so out loud.

BLANKS

Rarely, a child is born with no godsign at all. A Fatlands Blank feels no hunger. An Oathen Blank can lie. A Vigil Blank could sleep, if anyone let it. No one knows why they happen; the College's ledgers show no pattern of parentage, and Blanks have been born to High Cuts and to Scraplings alike. They are hunted in every land: as saints, as specimens, or as spare parts.

THE BLANK TRADE

The trade is old, quiet, and enormously profitable. Blank blood, transfused, is believed to slow the Regrowth for a season. Blank organs, sewn into a noble body by a skilled Seamer or a Fatlands surgeon, are believed to slow it for years. Blank marrow is boiled into a jelly sold in the Vigil as a sleep-cure and in Cradlewrack as a contraceptive. None of it works, or none of it works for long, and the price only rises. A Blank kidney sells on the Rim for about 3,000 lacks; a Blank heart, delivered beating in brine, for a sum the buyers do not write down.

Because the Unfed of the Fast are, in effect, a whole nation of Blanks, the trade's main source is the heartland. Poachers cross the Fast's border by night with nets and sedatives. Fatlanders like Kale

Dragoman feed their catch generously on the road home, so the meat arrives in condition. Dr. Mercy Thrane of the Fast has traced vanished patients to surgeries in four countries. The ultimate buyers are, almost always, people of High Cut, and an increasing number of the largest purchases are made through intermediaries who never give a name.

Blank kidney, fresh, three thousand. Blank heart, beating, in brine: ask. Blank girl, Fatlands, fifteen, alive: her weight in bone, and do not bruise her.

PRICE-SLATE FOUND IN A BURNED SURGERY
OUTSIDE GRISTMOOT, 640 A.G.

THE SHAPE OF THE TABLE

People call the known world the Table. It is one continent, roughly round, about nine hundred miles across, and its geography is a ring around a hole. Beyond its edges there is sea to the west and wasteland, mountain and salt on the other sides, and nobody who has gone looking for anything beyond has come back with anything worth the trip.

- ◆ **The Fast** lies at the center: the rich old heartland, the best farmland on the Table, now almost empty, where the uneaten god still walks. It is always early Carving there.
- ◆ **Sallowreach** to the north: grey fen and fog, where nothing dies.
- ◆ **The Vigil** to the northeast: a lit plateau city that has not slept in three centuries.
- ◆ **Oathen** to the east: dry red canyons where words break bones.
- ◆ **The Fatlands** to the south: warm, wet plains of meat.
- ◆ **Brinehollow** to the west: a coast the sea is abandoning.
- ◆ **Cradlewrack** to the northwest: red clay highlands in labor.

Nobody crosses the middle. The old roads that once ran from every land to the heartland are still there, still beautifully kept by no one, and they are used by Crumb-Runners, Reckoners, poachers, pilgrims and fools. Everyone else goes around.

THE RIM ROAD

The Rim Road is a ring of highway, some two thousand four hundred miles long, that runs around the border of the Fast, touching every land in turn. It was built in the Thin Years after the Gorging on the foundations of the old heartland ring-roads, by caravaneers who wanted to carry the Fatlands’ miraculous grain to every market on the Table without ever setting foot in the empty middle. A wagon caravan takes about a hundred days to make the

full circuit; a fast rider changing horses at every post can do it in thirty.

The road is paved for most of its length in great fitted slabs of grey Oathen stone, cambered for drainage, with a ditch on the outer side and, on the inner side, facing the Fast, a low wall about knee-high. The wall is called the Hem. It does nothing; anyone can step over it. Nobody does. Every mile is marked by a milestone with the distance carved in both directions to the Company’s headquarters, and every milestone bears the Company’s mark, a wheel with seven spokes.

Every land’s politics is shaped by needing something from a neighbor it finds obscene, and all of that need moves along the Rim. Fatlands meat goes everywhere. Oathen sells contracts and gold bits. The Vigil buys oil and brine and sells mirrors and rouse. Sallowreach exports wire, lacquer, embalming spirits and, illegally, Closings. Brinehollow sells salvage from the Uncovered. Cradlewrack exports soldiers, the Foundling Companies hiring out as caravan guards. The Fast sells nothing, and buys every mouthful it eats.

Every land is certain that the cure is next door.

RIM ROAD SAYING

TOLLS

The Rim Road Company owns the road, every inn and post on it, and every toll. Tolls are charged at every waystation, posted in Table-speech on a bone slate by the gate, and paid in lacks or Company platters. A standard schedule:

TOLL	CHARGED ON	RATE	NOTE
Foot	Each traveler on foot	1 crumb a post	children under seven free
Rider	Each traveler mounted	3 crumbs a post	the horse is charged as Head
Wheel	Each wheel of a cart or wagon	2 crumbs a post	the Groaning Board charges Fatlands drays by the axle
Head	Each animal, or anything walked like one	1 crumb a post	Sal Trotter’s herds pay as Head; nobody checks
Weight	Cargo, by the hundredweight	1 lack a post	Chute barrels sealed and unopened
Breath	Any traveler showing godsign at the Course	5 lacks a post	waived for Company officers

TOLL	CHARGED ON	RATE	NOTE
Hush	Corpses, by the body	1 lack a post	the Kept are not corpses; they pay as Foot, once
Litter	Each traveler carried by bearers	1 lack a bearer a post	the Laden of the Fatlands, mostly
Cradle	A traveler with child, leaving Cradlewrack	2 lacks at Knocking Gate	paid after the Marshal's inspection, if let through
Cage	Live cargo in a closed cart	3 lacks a post	no questions; the Company calls it livestock
Seal	A courier under an Oathen oath	none	the Company will not delay a sworn word
Ditch	Sleeping within a bowshot of the road	2 crumbs a night	collected at dawn by whoever finds you

The Breath Toll was introduced in 604 A.G. after a Course-stage Gut-line rooted himself in the middle of the road near the Chute and had to be dug around. The Hush Toll is so called because it is charged on the dead, who in every land but one are silent.

The Cage Toll is the most profitable on the Rim and the one the Company least likes discussed. It was introduced in 301 A.G., the year of the first recorded poaching out of the Fast. The Company's position is that it carries what it is paid to carry and does not open the cart. The Fast's envoy, Prudence Lowell, has read the toll schedule aloud at every Company congress since she was appointed, slowly, and always stops at that line.



Toll paid, grace said, mind your head.

RHYME PAINTED ON THE GATE-BARS AT GRISTMOOT

RIM LAW

The Company's charter, sworn in Oathen in 71 A.G., grants it jurisdiction over the road surface and a bowshot either side. Within that strip, no land's law runs; Company law runs instead, and Company law has three articles, recited at every post at dawn: *Pay the toll. Keep the peace. Say the grace.* Murder on the road is punished by the Company's wardens with a rope at the nearest post. Theft of Company cargo is punished by being made cargo. Refusing the grace at a Company table, the universal insult, is punished with a fine of one lack and a night outside the gate.

The Rim's neutrality is its whole value. A Sallowreach Closer and a Fast Reckoner can share an inn table on the Rim, and each knows that if the other draws a blade the wardens will hang them before the blood is dry. They cannot share it anywhere else on earth.

The Charter of 71 was the Company's second. Its first, the simple bond of the seven caravan-houses, was sworn at Tacit in 61 A.G., the year Oathen's Rule first came to be trusted abroad; the Ring Charter of 71 extended it to the road itself, the strip a bowshot wide, and the Hem. Company lawyers cite both. Oathen's Ledger records the first and the Company's milestones the second, and the College considers the ten years between them the most important decade in the history of commerce.

CUSTOMS OF THE COMPANY INNS

Every Company house keeps the Three Articles. Most keep a great deal more, by custom older than anyone can explain, and a traveler who learns them is fed better and robbed less.

- ◇ **Salt and a crumb.** A guest arriving after dark is met at the gate with a pinch of salt in the palm and a single crumb. The salt is licked; the crumb is kept, and given back on leaving. A guest who leaves without returning the crumb is said to have *taken a bite of the house*, and is not let in again.
- ◇ **The grace at the gate.** At Company houses the grace is said twice: once at the table, and once at the gate, by the warden on duty to each party that comes in, whether or not they are eating. *Lack keep away.* A party that cannot answer is watched.
- ◇ **The honest bench.** Every common room has one long bench nearest the fire where strangers of different lands are seated together, by the factor's choice, not their own. It is a Rim saying that more marriages, partnerships and murders have begun on the honest bench than anywhere else on the Table.
- ◇ **The Night Count.** At dusk and at dawn the innkeeper walks the house and counts heads aloud, and writes both numbers in the ledger. If the dawn count is lower than the dusk count, the wardens are called. If it is higher, nobody is called, and the extra place at breakfast is set and left empty, and the innkeeper burns the page at noon.
- ◇ **The head of the table.** The long table in a Company common room has a chair at its head, and nobody sits in it, not the factor, not a Spoke. Ask why and you are told that it is the Company's chair. Nobody has ever seen the Company sit.
- ◇ **Licked-clean nights.** On the new moon no guest leaves the common room after the last bell. Chamber-pots are provided. A guest who insists on going out to the privy is let out, and the door is barred behind them, and they are let in again at dawn if they knock in the right voice.
- ◇ **Land manners.** Company houses keep rope rooms for Brinehollowers, nudgers for Vigil guests, slates for Oatheners, brick-in rooms near Cradlewrack, and a basin of vinegar by the door for anyone from Sallowreach. No Company house will refuse a Fatlander a fifth meal. No Company house has ever had an Unfed guest who would accept a fourth.

- ◇ **The Plate's share.** Every traveler leaves one crumb under the plate at their last meal before the road. It is for the next traveler. In practice the potboys take it; in theory it buys the next traveler's luck. It is the only charity on the Rim that everyone gives.
- ◇ **Tablenight.** The gates close at dusk, the extra chair is set at every table, turned to face the wall, and nobody in the house says *come in* to anyone for any reason until dawn.



Never answer a knock on a licked-clean night. Never answer it twice.

RIM INNKEEPERS' RULE

WAYSTATIONS OF THE RIM

The Company keeps a post every twenty miles: a toll gate, a stable, a well and a bone-slate board of news. Every hundred miles or so there is a waystation proper, a walled inn-town with a market, a smithy, a wardens' barracks and the Company's factor. Clockwise from the north, the best known are these.

Fogmouth. The northern station, where the road from Lastgate meets the Rim. A painted line crosses the road outside the gate, red, renewed every Grace: the Drop. North of it, the Kept walk. South of it, they fall. Families from Sallowreach come to the line to say goodbye to living relatives going abroad, and stand on their side, and hold hands over it. The inn, the Long Farewell, serves vinegar-wine and has a back room where Tam Ruddock's clients wait to cross north. Rooms smell of cedar if you pay for it.

Quire. Between Fogmouth and Lampwick Halt, on the northeastern stretch, a walled college-town of grey stone on a green hill: the seat of the Cutwrights' College. The Company keeps a post at its foot and an inn, the Inkhorn, full of Linemen in grey, nervous noble agents waiting on certificates, and genealogists for hire who will trace any line for a fee and find whatever the client prefers. The library sits on the hill; the vault is under it, cool with spring water. Every guest at the Inkhorn is asked their mother's name by the porter, in a friendly way, and it is written down.

Lampwick Halt. At the Vigil's border on the plateau road. Never dark: the Company keeps a hundred lamps burning on the walls to accommodate Vigil merchants, who will not stop in a place they cannot see. Under Vigil custom there are no beds within sight of the plateau, so the Company built the Sleeping Sheds a quarter mile down the road on the Rim side of a stone marker, long low dormitories with shutters, where travelers bound for the Vigil take their last sleep for months. Rouse is sold at the gate. Many travelers lie awake in the Sheds all night anyway, out of nerves.

Mumchance. On the canyon road where the Rim enters Oathen. The quietest inn in the world. Orders are taken on slates; the bill is

chalked; the innkeeper, a Forsworn woman whose jaw broke on a promise thirty years ago, nods. The walls are hung with felt so nothing echoes. A sign over the door, in four dialects, reads *Say Less*. Foreign travelers are given a printed card of safe phrases on arrival and a lecture by gesture. Every year someone ignores it and leaves on a stretcher.

Treaty Stair. A Company depot cut into a canyon wall a day east of Mumchance, at the head of the long stair down to Tacit. Here every Company contract is copied, sealed in wax and bone, and carried down to be sworn before the Company's notary, Jessamy Quill. The Stair is guarded more heavily than any treasury on the Table. Its clerks work in silence. Its archive holds, in theory, the binding text of half the commerce in the world.

Quillhouse. The Company's eastern waystation on the high causeway across the north of Oathen, where the road leaves the canyons for the open plateau. Felted bridges, slates at every door, and a long stone wall carved by travelers with the conditions of their promises: *I will come back for you, if able, barring weather*. The factor's clerks remind every traveler, by slate, what country they are in, and the inn, the Exit, keeps a Clausewright on retainer to read the small print on any deal struck at its tables.

Wanting Post. On the inner side of the eastern Rim, at the head of the road into the Fast's only town. The only Company station that faces the middle. The Crumb-Runners buy grain here at a markup the Company calls a risk premium. The Fast's envoy, Prudence Lowell, keeps an office in a bare stone room off the yard and receives all callers standing. Travelers who arrive after dark are asked, at the gate, whether anyone has invited them in on the road. It is not a joke.

Saltlick Cross. The southeastern crossroads where the dry country gives way to the Fatlands' first green. The old heartland road meets the Rim here, running straight in toward Hallowboard, and the crossroads is marked by four stone posts, each with a lamp. In 639 A.G. a table was found laid in the middle of the crossing at dawn, with eight places, steaming. The Company had it burned and the ground salted, and posted a warden on the spot every night since. The wardens rotate weekly. None will say what they see.

Thimble Cross. On the southeastern stretch, where the Rim, coming up out of the Fatlands, bends hard to skirt a lobe of the Fast. A two-storey inn of grey fieldstone with seventeen chimneys, a walled yard, a smokehouse, and a little graveyard of nine stones. A rutted track called the Hungry Lane runs off from the bend into the gold country toward Wanting, used by Crumb-Runners and Hostwatch and nobody else. The station has been kept by the Thimble family since 402 A.G. under a charter sworn in Oathen, whose one strange clause binds the keepers never to turn a traveler away, nor refuse any guest. The wardens say it is the friendliest house on the Rim. Lately it has had more callers than it can feed.

The Groaning Board. On the Fatlands stretch, two days north of the Chute. The Company's largest inn, with a common room that seats six hundred at a single table, built to impress Fatlands merchants and to feed them five times a day as the law requires. The floor slopes so that grease runs to a gutter. The smell reaches travelers a day out. The dishes are excellent, the portions vast, the meat unspecified. Foreign guests are advised to eat lightly and to watch the table's far end, where the Gut-line merchants sit, and to not be there when the wardens take one away at closing to be rolled out by six men.

The Chute. The Fatlands' Rim Road export depot, technically the Renderers' Union's yard and not the Company's, and therefore the one place on the ring where Company law runs only on sufferance. Barrels go out by the thousand a day with the origin stamped over twice. The Company keeps a factor and a weighhouse here and a standing order not to open anything.

Gristmoot. A market town on a bend of the Rim a day west of the Chute, where every stall-keeper on the road comes at last: rope by the fathom, Seamers' thread, Fatlands sausage by the yard, Oathen paper, Vigil glass, cures. The great Rim Market is held here four times a year, at the turn of each season, and lasts a Plate. Prices are chalked on bone slates; haggling is loud; pickpockets are hanged on the market cross in the morning and cut down by noon so as not to put off the trade.

Toll Nine. The Company's counting-house: a long, low, windowless building of grey Oathen stone on the southern stretch between Gristmoot and Saltbridge, so named because it stands on the site of the ninth toll-gate of the seven founding houses' road. The Company's treasury of platters is here, and its oldest ledgers, and the clerks who reconcile every post's take with every other's. Over the door is painted *Everything on the Table has a price. The trick is finding out who is paying it.* There is a cellar under the counting-house with a locked room that the factor visits weekly, alone, with a measuring rod. Nobody else goes down.

Saltbridge. Where the Fatlands road meets the Brinehollow road, on the southwestern stretch: the Company's Cure-House, the only lawful mint on the Table since 212 A.G. Bone comes in from the Chute in sealed carts stamped BONE: MIXED; salt comes up from the coast, boiled out of what Brinehollow coughs up at dawn and dusk; lacks go out. The steam of the copper vats can be smelled from the next toll. The people of Saltbridge are famous for their good skin and their bad dreams, and the coin-cutters, mostly

Scraplings on twenty-year bonds, have the steadiest hands on the Rim and the worst nightmares.

Brackwater Bridge. On the southwestern stretch, a magnificent stone bridge of eleven arches carrying the Rim over the estuary of the river Slake, which ran into the sea. The sea left in 512 A.G. and the river followed it out across the Uncovered. The bridge now spans a dry bed of cracked mud and the hulls of barges, sitting upright. The Company still charges the bridge toll. The waystation inn, the Dry Anchor, is full of salvagers and Admiralty recruiters, and the cellars flood twice a day.

Lowmark Spur. Where the Rim meets the road down to Brinehollow's capital. Travelers coming up from the coast are checked here for the pull: wardens watch who stands too long at the west windows. The inn keeps a rack of bail-buckets for those who forgot theirs and a rope room where any guest may ask to be tied to the bed for the night, at a crumb a knot.

Knocking Gate. At the Cradlewrack border on the red-hill road, where Marshal Gideon Breech's men check every traveler leaving the highlands for signs of carrying. The Company's inn here, the Open Door, has no doors at all: every room has a curtain, by agreement with the Attendance, so that nothing can be accused of breaking in. Visitors knock on the frames out of politeness. Occasionally, something knocks back from inside an empty room.

The Weeping Post. On the northwestern stretch between Cradlewrack and Fogmouth, where weep-rain from Sallowreach meets the warm salt springs of the red hills, and the road is always wet and always tea-stained. A Confessors' chapel stands here, the oldest Theft shrine on the Rim, and a rotating congregation of travelers from both lands kneels in the brown water and asks forgiveness for the Meal. The inn is cheap and damp and everyone in it is sorry about something.

THE RIM ROAD IN PLAY

The Rim is the default campaign spine. Characters from different lands meet here, under Company law, and can travel together without being arrested at every border. Use the waystations as hubs: each one is a crossroads of factions, a source of jobs (escort, salvage, smuggling, auditing, finding someone who did not arrive), and a stage for the land next door to intrude. A circuit of the Rim is a hundred days; a campaign can be built as a single circuit, beginning and ending at the same gate, with the world measurably worse on the second visit.

▼ ON THE ROAD: ENCOUNTERS

The Rim is busy, and most of what is on it is ordinary: drovers, carters, couriers, pilgrims, wardens, beggars, families moving house to a land they hope is less damned. Roll once per day of travel, or

whenever the road has been quiet too long. Most results are blurbs, not battles; let the players decide which of them to stop for.

D20	ON THE RIM ROAD
1	A Course-stage Gut-line has rooted in the road; the wardens are cutting a detour through a field that bleeds.
2	A caravan from the Vigil, all its drivers asleep on their feet, horses walking on by memory; one driver is smiling.
3	A table, laid, on the Hem wall, facing inward. Nobody is sitting. Yet.
4	A Kept man standing a yard north of the Drop at Fogmouth, weeping, begging travelers to carry a letter south.
5	An Oathen courier at a dead run, because she swore to arrive by dusk, and dusk is close, and one knee has already begun to bend the wrong way.
6	A barrel from the Chute has fallen and split. Something in it is moving. The carter is trying to nail the lid back on.
7	A Purgation procession, bleeding into bowls, singing; the last Penitent in the line is bringing up something grey.
8	Reckoners at a post, asking each traveler their Cut and their mother's name, very politely.
9	A Brinehollower walking west across country in a straight line, off the road; companions trying to rope them.
10	A milestone whose distance has been carved over, one mile less than the last.
11	A Cradlewrack woman in labor in the ditch, refusing help, asking only that nobody open the door; there is no door.
12	A College Lineman with a bleeding-lancet and a ledger, offering to grade anyone's Cut for a lack; the queue is long.
13	A cart of Bottles of the Keep bound for Brackwater; one has cracked, and the carter has read it, and will not stop laughing.
14	A Fast pilgrim, gaunt, alone, asking which way to the table; she has heard it is close; she is right.
15	A Sallowreach Finisher procession turned back at the Drop, singing the Carrying-hymn, carrying an empty hurdle south.
16	A Company platter in the road, unbroken, worth twenty lacks. The wax seal is not Jessamy Quill's.
17	Two wardens hanging a man at a post; he is laughing; the rope will not tighten.
18	A Second Table carriage, black-lacquered, curtains drawn; a smell of roasting; a gloved hand drops a menu from the window.
19	A blind beggar who says <i>come in</i> to everyone who passes, and cannot be made to stop, and is not Unfed.
20	The road ahead is warm. The frost has melted in a path the width of a stooping man, and the path goes the way you are going.



*Pay the toll. Keep the peace. Say the grace. And if the
road is warm, get off it.*

THE THREE ARTICLES, AS AMENDED BY DROVERS

▼ TIME, SEASONS, AND SKY

The year is 641 A.G., After Gorging. Year 0 is the year of the Night of Seven Tables; the nine years of the Long Lack before it are numbered backward by scholars as the Lack Years, Lack 1 to Lack 9, and by everyone else not at all.

The year has four seasons named for a meal: **Grace** (spring), **Plenty** (summer), **Carving** (autumn) and **Lack** (winter). Each season has three months, and the months are named in common Rim usage by the Plate: First Plate, Middle Plate and Last Plate of Grace, and so on. Dates are given as day, Plate and season: “the ninth of Middle Plenty”. The year turns on Tablenight.

The moon is called **the Plate**. A full moon is *a full Plate*; a waning one is *being cleared*; a new moon is *licked clean*, and travelers

do not set out on licked-clean nights. Stars are called crumbs in most dialects; the Vigil, which cannot see them through its lamp-smoke, has no word for them.

Each land's seasons are bent by its Rule. Sallowreach has no real winter, because winter is an ending, and leaves stay yellow on the branch for decades. The Fast is always early Carving. The Fatlands' first frost is *Marbling*. Oathen has one rain a year, the Kept Rain, on the first day of Grace, and this year it came three days late. The calendar is shared, but the weather is not.

◇
*Licked clean tonight. Stay in, bar the door, and don't
count the plates.*

RIM ALMANAC, ENTRY FOR EVERY NEW MOON

TABLENIGHT

Tablenight is the anniversary of the Gorging, held on the longest night of Lack. It was once the feast of the longest night, the happiest festival of the old world. Every land now keeps it, and every land keeps it differently.

LAND	TABLENIGHT
Sallowreach	The living cook a banquet for their dead, who cannot taste it; everyone pretends
Fatlands	A one-day fast in penance; no village has ever reached sundown
Brinehollow	A bowl of seawater at the head of the table; the west door unbarred for whoever comes home
The Vigil	Every lamp put out for one minute; people hold hands and count aloud
Cradlewrack	Every door propped wide until dawn so nothing can be said to break in
Oathen	Twenty-four hours without a sound; the only day Oatheners feel safe
The Fast	Everyone stands outdoors, dusk to dawn, backs to every door; in every house, the table is laid
The Rim Road	Inns close their gates at dusk; one extra chair is set at every table, turned to face the wall

Nobody knows when the Rim custom began. The Company's oldest inn ledgers record it as already old in 90 A.G. Innkeepers who are asked about it say the chair is *for the one who isn't coming*, and

change the subject. Travelers who turn the chair back around in the night find it turned to the wall again in the morning.

▼ A YEAR ON THE TABLE

Every land keeps the same calendar and none of them keeps the same year.

— PREFACE TO THE COMPANY'S ALMANAC FOR FACTORS, REISSUED ANNUALLY
AT TOLL NINE

The four seasons and the twelve Plates are shared by every land, and the Company prints a single almanac for the whole Rim. What fills the year is not shared at all. A traveler who goes once around the Rim in a hundred days will pass through a dozen festivals that would be crimes a week down the road, and will be expected to keep each one correctly. The Company's factors carry the calendar below.

It is not complete. No calendar of the Table could be, because Cradlewrack's holiest day now comes every nine days, and every land is adding days of mourning faster than the almanac can be reprinted.

GRACE

WHEN	LAND	DAY	WHAT IS DONE
Eve of First Grace	Oathen	Share-Eve	the year's household vows whispered, so the rain can wash the sound away
First of Grace	Oathen	The Kept Rain	all stand in the open, bitted, faces up; this year, three days late
First of Grace	Cradlewrack	The Unbricking	every bricked room broken open at dawn, aired, and its contents Tallied
First of Grace	The Fast	The Burying	families walk to the Barrows; the grass cut once, with knives
Early Grace	Sallowreach	Restitching Week	the Kept restitched at home; the one joyful mass of the year
Early Grace	Brinehollow	The Knotting	every rope in the house replaced; old ropes burned on the Chapel Reach
Early Grace	The Vigil	Starers' Day	infants paraded in open baskets; bells thrown in
Grace, three days	Fatlands	The Weighing	the Board on the Scales; pie-stalls the length of Sated
Grace	Fatlands	First Furrow	the first plough pulled by the heaviest man; the furrow fed a loaf
Mid-Grace	Cradlewrack	Lambing Eve	fold-lights in every window; nobody sleeps alone

WHEN	LAND	DAY	WHAT IS DONE
Turn of Grace	The Rim	Gristmoot Market	the first great market of the year; a Plate long

PLENTY

WHEN	LAND	DAY	WHAT IS DONE
First week	Brinehollow	The Beaching	Longslab hauling songs sung on the Headland; the Admiralty parades its dry fleet
3rd of Plenty	The Fast	Corve Night	the Corve kin stand at the bricked window; the rest of the Fast stays in
Plenty, four days	Brinehollow	The Hauling Fast	the devout eat nothing for the four days Dromm took to die
High Plenty	Sallowreach	The Shutter Days	the Kept shut in while the flies breed; smudge-pots in every street
High Plenty	Cradlewrack	Hollan's Day	the Book of Questions read at the Old Lying-In; midwives fast
Midsummer	The Vigil	The Pinching Fair	bells, needle-dances, wake-games; the city's loudest day
Plenty	Oathen	The Unbitting	twelve-year-olds unbitted in the Hall of Conditions; first chosen words
Hottest week	Fatlands	Sweating Night	villages sleep in the warm fields; some do not wake, and are smiling
Late Plenty	Everywhere	The Washing	each village's walk-stone washed in the night by someone who will not say who
Turn of Plenty	The Rim	Gristmoot Market	the summer market; Fatlands fruit, Vigil glass, Bottles of the Keep

CARVING

WHEN	LAND	DAY	WHAT IS DONE
Carving	Sallowreach	Yellowing	children gather the rare leaves that fall, and keep them in boxes
First frost	Fatlands	Marbling Morning	children run barefoot on the white veins of the fields
First frost	Cradlewrack	The Closed Week	married couples kept apart; houses bricked a week
Mid-Carving	The Fast	Short Night	the names of every winter's omitted read in Pantry Close all night
Carving	Oathen	The Carving of the Year	the year's public vows cut into the Ledger by lamplight
Lowest tide	Brinehollow	Low Water	the Tenanted gather and sing on the Uncovered; families watch from the rail
Late Carving	Brinehollow	The Count of the Dead	every tide-post read aloud, name by name, through the night
Late Carving	Fatlands	Harvest Home	a week of feasting, quiet now, because of the Count
Carving afternoons	Fatlands	The Lists	the Reaping's missing read in every square; not a holy day; everyone attends
Grey Ninth	The Vigil	Shouting Day	the city shouts itself hoarse for the eleven hundred of 588
Turn of Carving	The Rim	Gristmoot Market	the meat market; barrels by the thousand

LACK

WHEN	LAND	DAY	WHAT IS DONE
Last nine days	The Fast	The Nine Days	each household eats a quarter-measure less each day
Eve of Tablenight	Oathen	The Night of Ears	pilgrims walk the Gullet barefoot and lay their ears to the warm sand
Longest night	Everywhere	Tablenight	see the table above; the one night kept everywhere
Day after	Sallowreach	The First Morning	a knotted cord hung on every door and cut at first bell: <i>come down, then</i>

WHEN	LAND	DAY	WHAT IS DONE
Day after the Nine	The Fast	The Rising	the day Orrum got up; nobody speaks above a whisper, nobody looks west
Turn of Lack	The Rim	Gristmoot Market	the thin market; prices doubled; the Company buys grain for the Fast

DAYS WITHOUT A SEASON

WHEN	LAND	DAY	WHAT IS DONE
Every nine days	Cradlewrack	Pangday	work stops; the Count; the waters searched
Anniversary of 341	The Vigil	The Night of Lying Down	families stand at the foot of their sleepers' beds; the Dormitory open
Any day	Fatlands	The Wake	the dead served by kin; the most sacred rite of the south
Any dawn	Brinehollow	The Count	names called through the wall; silence means someone was Called
Anniversary of 233	The Rim	Retching Day	Purgation halls give the Black Draught free at the Weeping Post
Any new moon	Everywhere	Licked Clean	doors barred; nobody travels



The Fatlands fast, the Fast fasts, the fens feast the dead, the Vigil goes dark, the highlands leave their doors open, and Oathen keeps its mouth shut. That is Tablenight. On the Rim we just turn a chair around and drink.

RIM INNKEEPER, THE GROANING BOARD

FESTIVALS IN PLAY

Festivals are the best way to tell players what a land is like without a lecture. Time a party's arrival at a waystation to a festival next door, and let them watch: the Unbricking from the road at Knocking Gate, the Kept Rain falling (or not) from the felted bridges at Quillhouse, the Lists being read in a Fatlands square. Festivals are also the worst time for a stranger to make a mistake. A traveler who whistles on Tablenight in Oathen, pinches nobody at the Pinching Fair, or answers *come in* on the Rising in the Fast will be remembered. Make a d6 roll at each festival a party attends: on a 1, one of them breaks a custom without knowing it, and the GM chooses who noticed.

▼ THINGS ALL LANDS SHARE

TABLE-SPEECH

The common tongue, older than the Gorging, spoken in some form in every land: drawled and wet in the fens, clipped to almost nothing in Oathen, stretched and slurred in the Vigil. Its oldest root words are the ones the Providers' peoples shared, and among them is the root *orr-*. From it come *orren*, to eat; *orrel*, to worship or to give back; *orrish*, a shared meal; and *Orrum*, the name of the Host,

meaning roughly *the one at whose board*. In Table-speech the words for "worship" and "eat" share a root. Scholars insist they always did. The Purgation insists this is the whole problem.

Table-speech is rich in food-words used for everything: a coward is *underdone*, a fool is *bread without salt*, death in most dialects is *being cleared*, and a person who has been ruined is *picked*. To ask someone's Cut, politely, is to ask *what portion* they come of. There are two words for *guest*. Everyone uses the newer.

WORD	MEANING	LITERALLY
orren	to eat	to take at the board
orrel	to worship; to give back	to feed the board
orrish	a shared meal	of the board
underdone	a coward	not cooked through
bread without salt	a fool	(as it says)

WORD	MEANING	LITERALLY
picked	ruined	the bones left on the plate
cleared	dead	the plate taken away
licked clean	a new moon; utterly lost	nothing left on the Plate
what portion?	what is your Cut?	which part did your people eat?
a second helping	a second chance; an unwise one	(as it says)
to trade tables	a betrayal of kin	(see the Kitchen Year)
to walk the eldest	a sacrifice known to be wasted	(see the Eldest Walk)
to count the chairs	to ask the forbidden question	(do not)

◇
There are two words for guest. Use the new one.
 SCHOOLROOM CORRECTION, EVERYWHERE

THE LACK

The one coin honored everywhere: a disc of salt-cured bone the width of a thumb-joint, pierced at the middle for stringing, worth one day's bread, and stamped on one face with the Plate and on the other with an empty circle. Ten **crumbs**, small bone beads, make a lack; twenty lacks make a **platter**, a sealed bone tablet issued by the Rim Road Company and sworn in Oathen as redeemable at any Company post. The coin takes its name and its value from the Dole-bones of the seventh year of the Lack, the ration-tallies of the public kitchens, which were cut from the rendered dead. The First Lacks proper were cut from god-bone in the year after the Gorging, by anyone with a saw. Since 212 A.G. every lawful lack has been struck at the Company's Cure-House at Saltbridge, from Fatlands bone shipped out of the Chute in carts stamped BONE: MIXED, cured for a season in salt boiled from Brinehollow bail-water. The Company says the bone is cattle. The empty circle, its charter says,

represents "the bread to be bought"; some old coin-cutters say it is a chair, seen from above. A few Dole-bones and First Lacks still circulate. They are yellower and smoother than the new coin, and people who find one in their change tend to spend it quickly. (See *The Rim Market* for coin, clipping and counterfeits.)

◇
When the price of bread rises, nobody says bread is dear. They say the lack is thin.

RIM SAYING

THE GRACE

Nobody on the Table eats with a stranger without first saying *Lack keep away*. It is said with eyes lowered, hand flat on the table, before the first bite. Among family it is optional; among strangers, it is the law of every land and of the Rim. Skipping it is the universal insult: it says *I do not care if you starve*. Duels have been fought over it in Brinehollow, oaths broken over it in Oathen, and in the Fast, where nobody shares food at all, it is said anyway, to the empty air, before eating out of the hand.

▼ COMMON FOLK EVERYWHERE

The lords of every land are monsters, each in their own fashion. The poor of every land are the same people with different buckets.

— ODALYS PENHALLOW, FIRST SPOKE OF THE WHEEL, IN A LETTER TO HER SPOKES, 630 A.G.

Most people on the Table are not nobles, not Seammers, not Clausewrights or Wakers or Reckoners. They are Scraplings and Commons, Cut 1 and 2, who haul and stitch and bail and nudge and render, who will reach the Course late or never, and who spend

their lives in the shadow of a Regrowth that is happening fastest to someone else. They are born, they marry, they die, and every land has bent each of those three things into its own shape. A traveler who knows nothing else about a land should know these.

LAND	BIRTH	MARRIAGE	DEATH
Sallowreach	ordinary, among the living; the Kept attend and may not hold the child	vows end <i>until finished</i> ; no widowhood, no remarriage	none; the Kept go on, then are Set Aside in the Lofts
The Fatlands	fed from the first breath; weighed weekly	suitor feeds the beloved by hand; vows over one plate	the Wake: served by kin on the best plates; bones to the field
Brinehollow	the First Bail at the first dusk: <i>go west without her</i>	a shared anchoring rope; <i>I will hold your line</i>	laid face-down on the Uncovered; the Called get a rope funeral
The Vigil	starers: infants who do not need to sleep until four	the Pinching; the two-word vow	the Boarding: a day lying in the street to be envied; then the lamps
Cradlewrack	the Two Questions; no name for a year	the couple bricked in overnight; broken out at dawn	nine stitches, every opening; bricked in a Stillyard wall
Oathen	bitted at the first tooth; first words at twelve	forty-page vows; no divorce	entombed upright to witness; every promise read to the corpse
The Fast	named for the Refusal: Forbear, Abstain, Nay	courtship by refusal; vows spoken back to back	laid face-down in the fields, unmarked, so they cannot sit up
The Rim	registered at the nearest post; a crumb from the factor	sworn at a Company table; a platter between them	the Hush Toll paid to carry them home, or a ditch

LAND	GREETING	WORST CURSE	OATH ON THE DEAD
Sallowreach	<i>May you finish</i>	<i>Long life</i>	a hand inside a Kept parent's mouth
The Fatlands	<i>You look heavy</i>	<i>May your plate be clean</i>	a mouthful of a dead relative on the tongue
Brinehollow	<i>Keep dry</i>	<i>May your rope hold</i>	a piece of a Called one's rope, in the fist
The Vigil	<i>Pinch me</i>	<i>Sleep well</i>	a hand on a Counted kinsman's bed-rail
Cradlewrack	a knock, three times	<i>May you begin again</i>	a hand on a kinsman's brick: <i>by the shut door</i>
Oathen	a nod; nothing said	<i>Talkative</i>	a hand on the bones in the niche
The Fast	<i>No, thank you</i>	<i>Come in</i>	standing in an ancestor's footprint at the Barrows

◇
*Every land curses its children with the thing every
other land prays for.*

THANKER MAUDLIN ASHE

WHAT THE POOR SHARE

Scraplings recognize one another across every border. They work the same hours (dawn to dark, and in the Vigil, dark to dawn as well). They eat Fatlands meat out of the same barrels and do not examine it. They are paid in crumbs strung on a loaf-cord and they bite every lack. They know the price of bread in three lands and the price of a Blank kidney in none, because nobody has ever offered to buy anything of theirs. Their children play the same games under different names: *Called* in Brinehollow and *Blink* in the Vigil and *Who's for the Pot* everywhere. They bury, render, shelve, brick in or lay face-down their dead with less ceremony than their lords and more grief.

And in the last generation they have begun to notice the same thing. The College's figures, which the College does not publish, say that the Regrowth runs fastest in palaces. The poor do not need the figures. They can see it from the street: the lord who has not walked in thirty years, the duchess behind her caul, the prince in his tank, the Regent who is mostly wire. They are beginning to say, in every land, in kitchens and on the honest bench, that the thinness of their blood is not a mark of their ancestors' weakness but of their ancestors' luck, and that when the Grace ends, it will end at the top of the table first. Some of them say it with fear. More and more of them say it with something else.

REGISTER OF THE POST AT FOGMOUTH, MIDDLE PLATE OF CARVING, 641. Born: one girl, to a carter's wife of the Fatlands, in the stable; weighed at once by the mother, who wept at the number. Born: one boy, to a Cradlewrack woman who crossed at Knocking Gate under the Marshal's eye nine days since; the factor asked the Two Questions as best he could and wrote yes to both; the child is very large. Married: a Brinehollow bailer and a Vigil nudger, at the long table, with

a rope and a pinch; witnesses three, and the Kept man from north of the Drop, who held their hands across the line. Died: an Oathen courier, of the knee, having arrived; Hush Toll paid by the Company. Died: a Sallowreach woman of ninety who

crossed the Drop of her own will to be finished, and was; her family stood on the north side and sang. Count at dusk: forty-one. Count at dawn: forty-two. Page burned at noon.

– THE FACTOR’S REGISTER, FOGMOUTH; THIS IS THE COPY SENT TO TOLL NINE, MADE BEFORE THE BURNING

▼ THE TRADE IN CURES

*Every land believes another land’s curse might cure its own. Nothing has ever worked.
The trade never slows.*

– THE FIRST LINE OF EVERY RIM APOTHECARY’S LICENCE

LAND	WANTS TO CURE	BUYS	FROM
The Vigil	Sleep	The undeath of the Kept; bottled brine	Sallowreach; Brinehollow
Fatlands	Hunger	The emptiness of the Unfed	The Fast
Sallowreach	Endlessness	Births, beginnings, Cradlewrack cord	Cradlewrack
Brinehollow	The Calling	Oaths to stay ashore; anchors of Oathen iron	Oathen
Cradlewrack	Too many births	Endings: Hand-line Closings	Sallowreach
Oathen	Binding speech	Sleep-drugs that silence the tongue	The Vigil
Everyone	The Regrowth	Blank organs	The Fast

Every apothecary on the Rim sells something. Bottled Kept-breath from Sallowreach. Pills of Fatlands fat. Fast dust, which is earth from the Fast’s roads, sold by the pinch to Fatlanders who believe it kills appetite. Cradlewrack cord, dried, worn as a belt by Sallowreach elders who want to be able to begin again. Most of it is fraud. Some of it does something, and what it does is worse.

The trade in cures is the Rim’s second commerce after meat, and nearly as large. Every waystation has an apothecary; every apothecary has a shelf of bottles labelled in four dialects and a back room with

the real stock; every real stock is either fraud or godflesh. The Company licenses the shelves, taxes the bottles and does not inspect the back rooms. The Purgation calls the whole trade blasphemy and runs a brisk line in emetics. The College buys one of everything, and tests it, and publishes nothing.

What follows is a sampling of what a traveler will be offered at any Rim market, what it is sold as, and what it actually does. GMs may roll when a character goes shopping for a cure, or when a stranger presses one on them at an inn.

D20	SOLD AS	PRICE	WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES
1	Bottled Kept-breath , the last air of a Sallowreach Kept man, for the Vigil’s sleepless: one sniff and you need never sleep	12 L	Real, and foul: Dread 1 to uncork. Does nothing for sleep. The smell will not leave a room for a month, and the flies find it.
2	Fatlands fat-pills , for the thin, the Unfed and the convalescent: <i>put on a pound a day</i>	1 L	Rendered Gut-line tallow rolled in flour. Taint 1 Hunger. An Unfed who takes a course of them risks Seasoning (see <i>The Rim Market</i>).
3	Fast dust , earth from the Fast’s roads, a pinch on the tongue to kill the appetite	5 c a pinch	It works: –2 Hunger, for an hour. For a week afterward the user smells baking on every wind, and Hostwatch bells within a mile ring when they pass.
4	Cradlewrack cord , dried, worn as a belt by those who wish to begin again	30 L	The cord begins, in a month, to grow back toward the wearer’s navel. After a season it cannot be removed without Ruin. The wearer feels younger. They are not.
5	An anchor-nail of Oathen iron , sworn by a Clausewright to hold the bearer ashore	40 L	Works only if the bearer swears too. Then it works exactly: a Called bearer who walks past the tide-line has both legs fold under them.

D20	SOLD AS	PRICE	WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES
6	Slope rouse , brine-cut, cheap, long-lasting: <i>stay awake for a day</i>	2 c	It works, and lasts. Taint 1 Regrowth (Dromm). A Vigil user who takes it for a season begins to stand at west windows.
7	Blank-marrow jelly , in a pot, for sleep in the Vigil and against conception in Cradlewrack	200 L	Does nothing at all, for either. It is real. Somebody was killed for it. Dread 2 on learning so.
8	A Closing-glove , worn once by a Hand-line Closer, for highlanders who need something to end	300 L	One touch ends one thing: a candle, a quarrel, a pang's tremor in a single room. The GM chooses the second thing it ends, later.
9	Sleepwell , a Vigil syrup sold in Oathen to <i>silence the tongue</i> for a night's rest	8 L	Puts an Oathener to sleep. Oatheners talk in their sleep. Whatever they say binds them in the morning.
10	Hedge-draught , a home-brewed Purgation emetic, <i>brings up the god</i>	3 c	Brings up everything else. Gut + Endure vs Hard (14) or lose 1d6 Flesh to the retching. Purges nothing of the god.
11	Dowager clay , a poultice of soil from a Seated Gut-line hill, for wounds and wombs	15 L	Heals 1d6 Flesh. Taint 1 Hunger. In a week, fine white roots come out of the scar and must be cut.
12	Lidwater , the tears of a lidless Eye-line noble, an eyewash for keen sight	25 L	+1 to Search for a day. For one hour after use the user cannot close their eyes, and in the Vigil must roll against blinks as the Appetite does.
13	A Sayer's word in wax , <i>you are well</i> , spoken by an Oathen Sayer and sealed	500 L	Almost always a Forsworn actor's voice, and inert. A real one does exactly what it says, to whoever breaks the seal first.
14	Orchard sap , from the Bleeding Orchards, a tonic against the Calling	1 L	Stops bleeding, as it always does. Does nothing for the pull. Screams faintly when the stopper is drawn. Taint 1 Hunger.
15	Ummer-down , swaddling spun from the god's old shed fleece: <i>the child will never hunger</i>	10 L	Thistle and lamb's wool, nearly always. A real scrap, from a Gristmoot granary loft, swaddles a child who will never in its life feel full.
16	Keep-salt , Brinehollow bail-salt sold to Sallowreach as a preservative that <i>lets the flesh finish</i>	2 L	Does not let anything finish. Taint 1 Regrowth (Dromm). A Kept man rubbed down with it starts to bail.
17	A Host's crumb , from one of Orrum's tables, for the Fatlanders: <i>the one food that fills</i>	150 L	A real one fills, completely, for one night: –10 Hunger. The next table the eater passes is laid, and the card at the pulled-out chair has their name.
18	A Second Table slice , godflesh cured in the Grand Carver's manner, for the old and the rich	2,000 L	The eater looks ten years younger for a season. Taint 3 Regrowth, foreign. The Second Table now knows their name, and their taste.
19	Hush-water , a phial drawn at the edge of a Hush, for Cradlewrack mothers who want the pangs to stop	80 L	A drop on the tongue stills the drinker's voice for a day. A swallow stills their heartbeat to the ear; they live, but no one can hear it. Dread 3 for anyone who listens.
20	A paper cure : a forged College certificate stating the bearer's Cut one lower than it is	100 L	The god does not read. Everyone else does. It keeps the bearer off the Reckoners' list, out of a Lancing, and away from the Second Table's dinners, until someone tastes their blood.



Mind the back room, love. The front shelf only robs you.

OVERHEARD AT THE APOTHECARY'S AT GRISTMOOT

CURES IN PLAY

A cure is a cheap way to give the players hope and a cheaper way to take it away. Let every character who suffers under their land's Rule hear of something, somewhere on the Rim, that is supposed to help. Let some of them buy it. The rule for cures is simple: nothing cures, but almost everything does something, and the something should always be interesting. A character who drinks a cure in desperation and gets a new Want, a stranger's god, or a place card with their name on it has had a better session than one who drank something that did nothing.

▼ THE MASTER TIMELINE

This is the Cutwrights' College's concordance, as taught to its Copyists, with additions from the Rim Road Company's ledgers. Dates before the Gorging are given in Lack Years. Dates the College considers doubtful are marked *c.* Rows added since the College's last

printed edition (from the land chapters of this book and from the Company's own ledgers) are included without comment, because the College no longer comments on anything in print.

YEAR	LAND	EVENT
Lack 1	All	The seed does not sprout. The Thin Harvest
Lack 2	All	The nets come up empty; hens stop laying; first bread riot at Sated; <i>Lack keep away</i> chalked on a shutter
Lack 3	All	No calf, lamb or foal born anywhere; the old breeds eaten out in a single Carving
Lack 4	All	The Ash Bread; nine bakers hanged at Sated; the last child born, at Kest; the Providers fall silent
Lack 5	All	The Leather Winter; the unclosed dead pile up beside Ossel; the first Black Noon
Lack 6	All	The Kitchen Year; families eat their dead; "trading tables"; the old go out into the snow
Lack 7	All	The Bone Dole; public kitchens; the Dole-bones cut; the tally-priests keep lists; the Providers lie down
Lack 8	All	The Moot at Hallowboard; the Eldest Walk; above sixty thousand; nothing happens; the sacks in Carving
Lack 9	All	The priests of the Moot taken by crowds; the knives ground all winter; the Turning
0	All	The Night of Seven Tables; the Gorging; the Refusal at Hallowboard
0	Sallowreach	The Meal at the Ferrying. The First Morning: a hanged thief in Lastgate asks to be cut down
0	Fatlands	The Meal on the Trencher. The Week of Rising: crops shoulder high in seven days
0	Brinehollow	The Beaching at Longslab; three days hauling, four of dying; the drowned brought up on the hooks
0	The Vigil	The Nine Nights; Iss butchered without waking, to lullabies
0	Cradlewrack	The Meal at the Old Lying-In; Vey killed seven times, or crushed by Hollan Kest
0	Oathen	The Silent Supper, three nights in the Gullet
0	The Fast	The heartland arrives on the tenth day; Orrum rises and walks away
0–1	All	The First Lacks cut from god-bone; the Plenty-born, a whole world of children in one season
0–40	The Fast	The Thin Years; the survivors live on what the Rim will sell
3	Oathen	The First Breaking: a merchant's hands come off in the market
c. 30	Rim	Seven caravan-houses found the Rim Road Company
41	The Fast	The first Pantry ledger; the Abstinent formed
44	The Fast	The First Sitting
49–61	Rim	The College's founders take depositions of the last who remember the Lack
60	Brinehollow	The Brimming; the first generation born coughing brine
61	Rim	The Company's first charter sworn at Tacit
61	Fatlands	First recorded Laden: Matron Ysolde Tullow roots in her own kitchen
71	Rim	The Ring Charter sworn in Oathen; the Hem built
0–90	Cradlewrack	The Easy Births
94	Cradlewrack	The First Word: "Not yet"
97	Fatlands	The first Seating; Ysolde Tullow becomes the first of the Dowager Hills
97	The Fast	The Temple Pulling; every temple of Orrum torn down save the Empty Chair

YEAR	LAND	EVENT
c. 100	Sallowreach	The Glad Century ends as the first generation comes apart
118	Brinehollow	The First Calling at Lowmark: four hundred walk in, eleven return
120	Cradlewrack	The Attendance takes authority over every birth
130	Sallowreach	The Stitching Laws; the Seamers' Guild chartered
130 on	The Fast	The Vindication
131	Fatlands	The Wake Ordinance: burial forbidden
140	Rim	The Cutwrights' College founded at Quire; the Moot's foot-stone first read
140–160	Rim	The seven tellings of the Night taken down by the College's Linemen
148	Oathen	The Sureties' Compact
188	The Fast	Wanting built; the last Unfed leave the heartland's interior
c. 200	Fatlands	End of the Sweet Reigns
204	Fatlands	The Tooth Harvest
212	Sallowreach	An argument begins in Lastgate; it has not ended
212	Rim	The Cure-House at Saltbridge made the only lawful mint
215	Oathen	The Muzzling
233	Rim	The Great Retching at the Weeping Post; the Purgation founded
240	Brinehollow	The Drowned Bench seated
260	Fatlands	The Weighing: votes by body weight
288	Sallowreach	The War of the Heirs
290	Oathen	The Bait doctrine outlawed in Oathen
301	Sallowreach	The Licensing of Closings
301	The Fast	The first recorded poaching; the Company's Cage Toll introduced
310	Cradlewrack	The Year of Doors
330	Oathen	The Mute Succession
c. 330	Rim	The Bait doctrine first nailed to a toll-house door
341	The Vigil	The First Night: a third of Ludmere does not wake
342	The Vigil	The Waking Laws; Ludmere renamed the Vigil; dream-books burned
358	The Fast	The Hostwatch chartered
390	The Vigil	The Rouse Patent
401	The Vigil	The Count
402	The Fast	The Reckoning: Forswear Kell's band crosses the Rim; House Brawne killed in its beds
402	Rim	Thimble Cross chartered to the Thimble blood
c. 412	Rim	First record of the Second Table: a menu, found in a dead Gut-line lordling's coat
419	Oathen	An oath shouted in Sworn Gorge begins to echo
455	Fatlands	The Thin Rising; fasting made treason
466	The Fast	The Starved Saints first recorded
480	The Vigil	The Lidless Succession
488	Fatlands	The Lancing of Brookhythe: the Purgation slaughters a Gut-line house

YEAR	LAND	EVENT
c. 489	Rim	The Second Table's Head is first mentioned, presiding from an empty chair
500	Cradlewrack	The Gathering of Parts
501	Rim	The College fixes the Gorging as "within a single Plate"
506	Oathen	The Forsworn Riots
511	The Fast	The Great Short: a Company grain embargo; the Pantry's first winter of choosing
512	Brinehollow	The Turning of the Tide; the first Bottles of the Keep found on the Uncovered
512	Sallowreach	The Grey Plague Keeps a third of the south fen
547	Cradlewrack	The Dilation opens
588	Rim	The College proves the Eighth's carvings were defaced in many ages
588	The Vigil	The Grey Ninth: eleven hundred Counted in one afternoon
590s	The Fast	Tables first found laid in occupied houses
598	Oathen	The First Sayer
c. 600	All	Every Regrowth curve bends upward at once
604	Rim	The Breath Toll introduced
627	Brinehollow	The Great Pressure Day: 1,140 Called in a night
629	Fatlands	Pell Hogget begins the Long Count
633	Sallowreach	The First Hush at Dunmere
638	The Fast	The Calling-Cards: a place card with the finder's name
638	Rim	A Baiter drowned by a crowd at Saltlick Cross
639	Rim	A table found laid at Saltlick Cross; Company inns begin to find tables at dawn
640	Brinehollow	Lowmark's pier reaches its nineteenth mile
640	The Fast	Tables found at crossroads in three other lands; pilgrims begin to cross
641	Oathen	The Kept Rain falls three days late
641	Brinehollow	A stone table with eight chairs found on the Uncovered
641	The Vigil	Fewer than two thousand empty beds; Bed One moves her lips
641	All	The present: the Long Count, the Chase, the Shortening; the Host on the Rim



*We keep the dates so that someone, later, will know
how fast it went.*

THE COLLEGE'S OATH OF COPYISTS, LAST LINE

▼ POWERS THAT CROSS BORDERS

Five institutions operate in every land and answer to none. Each has its own reasons for wanting player characters, and each has its own ways of using them up. Each entry below gives the power's history and creed, its rank ladder (with the mark by which its members

know one another), how a character joins, the rite by which they are taken in, the secret at its heart, and the people who lead it.

THE RIM ROAD COMPANY



Pay the toll. Keep the peace. Say the grace.

– THE THREE ARTICLES, RECITED AT EVERY POST AT DAWN

The merchant league that owns the ring road, its inns, its posts and its tolls. It is neutral, rich, and the only institution every government needs. It was founded in the Thin Years by seven caravan-houses carrying the Fatlands' miracle grain to every market, and its emblem is still a wheel with seven spokes, one for each founding house. In 71 A.G. it swore its Ring Charter in Oathen, and has sworn every contract there since, where they cannot be broken. Every Company platter, every inn-lease, every toll-farm, every bond of service is a promise sworn before the Company's notary, Jessamy Quill, and if broken the breaker's body breaks to match.

The Company is governed by the Wheel, seven Spokes descended by election from the seven founding houses, presided over by the First Spoke. It has no army, only the road-wardens, and no country,

only the strip of stone a bowshot wide. It needs none. Every land would starve, go dark or come apart in a season without the Rim.

Beliefs. The Company believes in the road. It holds no doctrine about the gods, says the grace at every meal, and regards every land's horror as a pricing problem. Privately, its senior Spokes believe the Table has perhaps twenty years left, and are determined that the Company should be the last institution standing when it ends.

What it wants now. Oathen's rain was late. If a god's sworn word can slip, so can every Company contract, and the whole of the Rim's commerce rests on one notary's body. The Company is quietly auditing everything, pricing every land's collapse, and looking for something better than Oathen to swear by.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS	MARK
1	Bonded Hand	Wage of 3 lacks a day; a bed at any post; Company protection on the road	an iron wrist-ring of seven spokes, hammered shut
2	Waymaster	Command of a caravan; may call on wardens at any post	a brass whistle and the caravan's slate
3	Factor	Runs a waystation; may issue platters and hear Rim cases	the gate keys and a platter-seal
4	Toll-Lord	Governs a quarter of the Rim; sits in judgment under Company law	a black staff shod in bone
5	Spoke	One of the seven on the Wheel	a gold spoke worn at the throat

Joining. Any traveler can hire on as a guard, porter or drover for a single circuit. To become a Bonded Hand, a character must travel to Treaty Stair and swear the Bond: to serve the Company, carry its goods, keep its peace and steal nothing from it, *as long as the wheel turns*. The oath is sworn in Oathen and binds the body anywhere. Bonded Hands do not steal from the Company. Those who have tried are on display at Treaty Stair, as an instruction.

THE BOND

The candidate walks down the long stair to Tacit in silence, a day's descent, past the Company's display. The display is a gallery cut into the canyon wall and glazed, and behind the glass sit the Bonded Hands who stole from the Company, alive, at clerks' desks, with

their hands folded backward at the wrist where the oath broke them. They are fed. They are given work they cannot do. The candidate is made to stop at each window. At the foot of the stair the candidate kneels on a paving-slab taken from the Rim itself, lays one hand on a milestone carried down for the purpose, and swears the Bond aloud before Jessamy Quill, slowly, in the Oathen manner, with no exits. Then a smith closes the iron ring around their wrist with three blows, and the candidate climbs back up the stair to the road, and is given a bed at the first post, and does not sleep.

I will serve the Company, and carry its goods, and keep its peace, and take nothing of it that is not given me, as long as the wheel turns.

– THE BOND, ENTIRE; QUILL ASKS EACH CANDIDATE, BEFORE THEY SWEAR IT, WHETHER THEY UNDERSTAND THE LAST SIX WORDS, AND RECORDS THEIR ANSWER

THE SECRET

The seal is slipping. The Company knows that Oathen's rain was late, and it knows something worse: that Jessamy Quill once swore

no other notary of the Rim would be sworn while she lives, and that she is old. If she dies, every platter on the Table becomes a pretty piece of shoulder in an afternoon. The Wheel is secretly grooming a second notary, in defiance of an oath it did not know about until

last year, and has lost two candidates already, to accidents. And under that secret there is another, which only the coin-cutters of Saltbridge and the First Spoke know: since the Reaping doubled, the carts from the Chute stamped BONE: MIXED carry more bone than the herds of the south could possibly account for, and the Company has never once complained about the quality. Every lack struck in the last ten years has a better than even chance of having been someone.

◇

We do not open the cart. We have never opened the cart. That is why they let us carry it.

FACTOR OF THE CHUTE, TO A VIGIL MAGISTRATE,
640 A.G.

LEADERS

ODALYS PENHALLOW – FIRST SPOKE OF THE WHEEL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 1 (Fatlands Scrapling) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Haggle 5, Clause 4, Reckoning 4, Persuade 3, Instinct 3, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	none worth the name; she has wardens
GIFTS	<i>The Wheel Turns:</i> once per session she may name any Company post and have a sworn message delivered there within a day by relay rider. <i>Platter-Signed:</i> her written word is accepted as currency at every post; she can buy almost anything on the Rim without leaving her carriage.
WANTS	Hunger that wakes her in the night; she keeps a pot of salt-fat by her pillow and is ashamed of it.
DREAD	0
SECRET	Penhallow is eighty-eight and has lived on the road for seventy years in a slow-moving carriage-house drawn by twelve oxen. She is a Scrapling, thin-blooded, and has been running the arithmetic for a decade: she believes the Company will outlive the lands, and she has commissioned a fleet of sealed wagons to carry the Company’s archive, its notaries and its Spokes around and around the Rim when the lands fall, indefinitely, a wheel with nothing inside it. She has not told the Wheel what she intends to feed them.

HOBB FALLOWMERE – WARDEN-CAPTAIN OF THE RIM	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Cradlewrack, born grown) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Blades 4, Intimidate 4, Shooting 3, Endure 3, Search 3, Wayfaring 3
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Armor 3 (warden’s mail) · Fray 5
ATTACKS	poleaxe +8 (5); crossbow +7 (4); the Company rope (see Gifts)
GIFTS	<i>The Rope at the Post:</i> within a bowshot of the Rim, any captive he declares guilty under Company law may be hanged without appeal, and every warden present obeys. <i>Born Running:</i> he acts first in any fight that begins on the road.
WANTS	False labor, at night, which he hides from his men; he wakes on his knees, clutching his belly, with every door in the barracks open.
DREAD	1 (his hangings)
SECRET	Fallowmere was born nineteen years ago in Cradlewrack as a grown man with a warden’s scar already on his cheek, and served in a Foundling Company before the Company bought his contract. He has hanged four hundred people on the Rim. He has begun to bear: three times now, alone in his cell at night, something has come out of him and gone out of the open door. He follows their tracks on his patrols. They lead inward, over the Hem, toward the Fast.

LYSANDER COYLE – AUDITOR-GENERAL OF THE COMPANY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Oathen Tongue-line, minor) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Reckoning 5, Clause 4, Search 3, Lore 3, Deceive 2, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	sword-stick +3 (4)
GIFTS	<i>Priced</i> : given a day with any institution’s books, he can state its true condition and the date of its collapse. <i>Conditional Tongue</i> : Oathen-raised, he never makes an unqualified statement and cannot be trapped into an oath.
WANTS	He hears his own figures repeated back to him half a second late, in a voice that is not quite his.
DREAD	0
SECRET	Coyle keeps the Company’s real ledger, the one that prices the end of each land. Sallowreach: nine years. The Vigil: eleven, matching Dr. Crane’s dose curve exactly. Cradlewrack: unknown, possibly weeks. He sent Reeve Calder Stokes to Brinehollow. He has also, on his own initiative, begun selling the ledger’s summary pages to the Second Table, because they are the only buyers who pay in gold, and because he has priced the Company too.

THE CUTWRIGHTS' COLLEGE



Blood is a ledger. We only read it aloud.

– MOTTO OVER THE GATE AT QUIRE

Genealogists who track every bloodline’s Cut across six centuries. The College began among the tally-priests of the Bone Dole, who kept the lists of who had eaten what in the public kitchens of the seventh year, and among the scribes who recorded, on the morning after the Gorging, which family had carried home which portion of which god. By 140 A.G. those lists were the most valuable documents on the Table, and their keepers built a walled college-town at **Quire**, on the northeastern Rim between Fogmouth and Lampwick Halt, to keep them.

The College’s ledgers decide marriages, inheritances and executions. A College certificate of Cut is accepted in law in every land; a College genealogy can make a bastard an heir, or prove that an heir is a Scrapling. Its Provosts sit in every capital. The northern Provost, Carrion Sedge, has proven that the Hushes follow Hand-

lines blood exactly. Whoever holds the ledgers knows exactly where each god is regrowing fastest, and the College holds all of them, in the Master Concordance at Quire, in a vault cut into the hill under the library, kept at a constant cool by spring water.

Beliefs. The College is officially doctrine-neutral and in practice dominated by quiet Baiters. Its scholars have seen the curves. They know that every land’s Regrowth bent upward at once after 600 A.G., which means that the seven Regrowths are one event, and they do not say so outside the walls.

What it wants now. To keep the ledgers secret and whole. To be the institution that understands the end when it comes. And, among the senior Cutwrights, to answer the question of the Eighth, which the College has been forbidden to ask by every land in turn and has been asking quietly since 588.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS	MARK
1	Copyist	Board at Quire or a chapter house; access to the open stacks	a grey gown; an ink-black right thumb
2	Lineman	Field genealogist; may demand parish, temple and Tally records in any land	a bleeding-lancet and a ledger-case
3	Cutwright	May certify Cuts, binding in law in every land	a silver spoon on a chain
4	Provost	Heads a land’s chapter; holds its ledger	a ring of keys to that ledger
5	Archprovost	Holds the Master Concordance at Quire; there is only one	none; she is known

Joining. Copyists are taken young or by examination at Quire. Every entrant gives a pint of blood, which is tasted, graded and entered, and their line is traced back to the Meal. The College knows exactly what every member is, and how fast they are going. It uses this.

THE COPYING

After the blood is tasted, graded and entered, the new Copyist is led down into the vault under the library at Quire, where the spring water runs in a channel along the floor and the air smells of cold stone and old ink. There, at a desk under a single lamp, they are given their own line in the Master Concordance and a blank quire, and told to copy it, by hand, from themselves back to the Meal. It takes most Copyists three days. Nobody is permitted to help, or to stop them. Everything is in the Concordance: the bastardies, the cousin-marriages, the households that traded tables in the Kitchen Year, the eldest who walked and the eldest who did not, the great-grandmother who was served at her own wake and the great-grandfather who did the serving. Many Copyists weep. Some are sick into the channel. A few have tried to tear the page, and been gently restrained, and been given another quire, and told to begin again. On the last page, below the line of the Meal, the Copyist writes their own name, and beneath it, from the College’s tables, the

year in which their line may be expected to reach the Course. Then they are given their grey gown, and the copy is taken from them and filed, and they never see it again.



Blood is a ledger. We only read it aloud. We do not always read it to you.

LINEMAN’S SAYING

THE SECRET

The College knows the seven Regrowths are one event, and has known since the curves were first set side by side. That is the secret every senior Cutwright keeps. The deeper one is in a box of grey stone beside the Master Concordance, in the vault: a living thing, soft and red and the size of a mouse, carried out of the highlands in an apron pocket on the night of the Meal, which begins again, newly wet, at every pang in Cradlewrack. The College’s oldest copyists, who should have died a decade ago, visit the vault on the first of every month. They come out looking as if they had just begun. The Archprovost has never written down what she uses it for.

LEADERS

HESPER LUNE – ARCHPROVOST OF THE COLLEGE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 1 (Brinehollow Scrapling) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Lore 5, Reckoning 5, Clause 3, Search 3, Godsign 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	none
GIFTS	<i>The Concordance:</i> given a name and a land, she can recite the person’s line back to the Meal and their likely Cut within a point. <i>Read Aloud:</i> once per session, she may reveal a damning fact about any noble house from the ledger; the house’s enemies will act on it.
WANTS	Salt on her lips at waking; she bails at dawn and dusk into a silver basin and has the water assayed.
DREAD	0
SECRET	Lune is seventy, nearly blind, and reads the ledgers by running her fingers over the ink. She has spent twenty years on the eighth place. She has assembled, from chisel-shadows on four hundred carvings rubbed onto paper, a partial reconstruction of what was cut away, and from Table-speech roots the older word for <i>guest</i> . She has told nobody. She has stopped going to dinners, and she has had the extra chair taken out of every room in Quire.

ODO VENN – BLOOD-TASTER OF THE COLLEGE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Fatlands Gut-line, cadet branch) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Feast 5, Godsign 4, Stitching 3, Lore 3, Blades 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 4
ATTACKS	bleeding-lancet +5 (2)
GIFTS	<i>The Silver Spoon</i> : from a drop of blood on a spoon he can name a person's land, Cut and Regrowth stage, and whether they are Blank. <i>Iron Gut</i> : immune to ordinary poisons.
WANTS	He cannot stop at a drop. He must make a Caul + Resolve roll (Hard) each time he tastes, or lick the wound.
DREAD	1
SECRET	Venn has graded eleven thousand people and has come, slowly, to a private conclusion: high-Cut blood from different lands tastes the same at the back of the tongue, under the land-flavor, and it has begun to taste of something he cannot name and is very hungry for. He has started tasting Blanks, too. They taste of nothing. He finds that worse.

SILAS FENWRIGHT – THE LEDGER-THIEF	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Sallowreach, living) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Stealth 4, Filch 4, Athletics 3, Lore 3, Deceive 3, Blades 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	knife +5 (2); hand crossbow +3 (3)
GIFTS	<i>Pages for Sale</i> : he carries three bound quires copied from the Master Concordance; each holds the full lines of one land's highest houses.
WANTS	He cannot sleep with a door open, and checks every lock twice.
DREAD	0
SECRET	A former Lineman who copied what he should not have and walked out of Quire in a Copyist's grey. Every faction wants his pages: the Purgation for a massacre list, the Second Table for a menu, the Reckoners for a target roll. He is trying to sell them to whoever will let him live. He has also read them, and he knows that his own line ends, in the ledger, in a Hand-line bastard. He is three generations off the Course and running out of road.

THE PURGATION



What goes down can come up.

– PAINTED ON THE PURGATION'S ALTAR-BOWLS

A cross-border movement that believes the gods can be thrown back up. It was born at the Weeping Post in 233 A.G., when a Fatlands physician named Hurlo Sweyn took a draught of his own devising before a congregation of Confessors and brought up, after six hours of retching, a hard white thing the size of a thumbnail which he swore was one of Ummer's teeth. The Great Retching spread up and down the Rim within a year. Its emblem is a bowl.

The Purgation's methods run from fasting and bleeding to the Black Draught, a purgative of bitter roots, salt and lamp-oil taken in public; to burning, on the theory that a god cooked out of the flesh cannot regrow; to massacre. Its militant wing, the Lancets, holds that a high-Cut house is a swelling in the world's gut and must be lanced. The Lancing of Brookhythe in 488 A.G., when a Lancet company bled out a Gut-line household of three hundred, servants

and all, into the drains of their own manor, is its proudest and most infamous act.

Beliefs. The Purgation holds the Theft doctrine at its hardest: we stole the gods, the gods are inside us, and the only penance is to give

them back by any opening available. Its preachers now call for a second Eldest Walk: the firstborn of every High Cut house, walked to the Rim and emptied, so that this time the giving will be done to the gods rather than for them.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS	MARK
1	Penitent	A bowl; shelter and thin soup at any Purgation hall	a wooden bowl at the belt
2	Purger	May administer the Black Draught and the bleeding-cup	a pewter bowl and cup on a cord
3	Lancet	Armed; may join a Lancing; protected by the halls	a red cord at the wrist; a lancing-spear
4	Emetic	Leads a hall or a company; knows the hidden houses	a bowl of beaten tin, lidded
5	the Voided	The inner council; those who claim to be empty of god	the scar, worn bare

Joining. A would-be Penitent drinks the Black Draught at a Purgation altar before the congregation and retches until something comes up. Whatever comes up is held up to the lamps and judged. Nobody has ever been turned away.

THE BOWL

The rite is held at dusk in a Purgation hall or in the yard of a Rim inn, wherever a congregation can be gathered. The candidate kneels on bare stone in a ring of Penitents holding lamps. A Purger brings the Black Draught in a pewter cup: bitter roots, salt and lamp-oil, black as tar, smelling of a snuffed wick, warm. The candidate drinks it all, and the congregation sings the Bowl Hymn, slow and low, while the Draught works. It takes an hour, sometimes three. The candidate retches into the bowl until the bowl is full and is emptied and is full again, until there is nothing left but bile, and then past

that, and the singing never stops, and the Penitents hold the candidate’s shoulders and forehead and say *up, up, give it up* in the gaps of the hymn. At the end, something comes up. It always does. The Purger lifts it from the bowl with two fingers and holds it to the lamps for the congregation to see: a stone, a hair-ball, a knot of gristle, a tooth. The congregation names it. Whatever they name it, the candidate is a Penitent from that moment, and is given the bowl, still warm, to wash and keep.

What goes down can come up.
What was swallowed can be given.
What was stolen can be paid.
Up, up, give it up.

– THE BOWL HYMN, REFRAIN

THE SECRET

The Draught works, a little. What comes up, when something does, is sometimes godflesh: a sliver of grey, a fleck of loam, a curl of caul, a scrap of something that tastes of the sea. The Voided have known this for a century, and they sell it. The halls’ soup, the Lancets’ spears, the surgeons who cut Saint Ancel Ruel, all are paid for out of the bowl, and the bowl’s best customer, through three layers of agents, is the Second Table, which buys every leaving the Purgation brings up and serves it at practice dinners. The two movements on

the Table most opposed to one another have been feeding each other since 512.

◇
Up, up, give it up. Then pass the bowl along; the next one’s waiting.

PENITENTS’ JOKE, NEVER TOLD IN A HALL

LEADERS

SAINT ANCEL RUEL – THE EMPTIED, FIRST OF THE VOIDED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 0 (claims to have been Cut 3) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Resolve 5, Rites 4, Endure 4, Feast 3, Lore 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 3
ATTACKS	none; he has never struck anyone
GIFTS	<i>Proof:</i> Ruel cannot be detected by any godsign, and passes every test for Blankness; seeing this, a crowd must make a Dread 1 check or believe him. <i>Sermon of the Bowl:</i> once per scene he may preach; listeners with Fray 5+ must resist (Caul + Resolve, Hard) or drink the Draught.
WANTS	none. That is the point of him.
DREAD	2 (to see his body: he has had a third of his gut cut away and the scars run from collarbone to groin)
SECRET	Ruel was born Blank in the Vigil and has never carried any god at all. He was taken in as a child by Purgation surgeons who saw his value, and he has been cut, bled and starved for fifty years to make the lie look like a miracle. He believes it now. Every Penitent he has led to the bowl has suffered for a proof that was never true, and if this were known, the Purgation would turn on him with knives.

BASTIAN GROLE – LANCET-CAPTAIN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Fatlands) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Blades 5, Intimidate 4, Brawl 3, Endure 3, Rites 2, Wayfaring 2
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 18 · Armor 2 (boiled leather) · Fray 6
ATTACKS	lancing-spear +9 (4); butcher's cleaver +9 (3)
GIFTS	<i>The Lancing:</i> when he attacks a High Cut (4–5) target, each Helping adds +3 damage instead of +2. <i>Bleed Them Out:</i> a wound he deals keeps bleeding for 1 Flesh per round until stitched.
WANTS	Eating without choosing; he eats from the Lancings' kitchens after the work is done, and cannot stop.
DREAD	2 (a Lancing in progress)
SECRET	Grole has led eleven Lancings. After each one he eats in the dead family's kitchen, alone, everything he can find, and the hunger never lessens. He knows what that means about his own blood. He has decided that when the last High Cut in the Fatlands is lanced, he will walk into the Purgation hall and have himself bled, and he has asked Sister Tisane to make sure it is done properly.

SISTER TISANE HALLOWAY – MISTRESS OF THE BLACK DRAUGHT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Sallowreach, living) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Craft 4 (apothecary), Stitching 4, Feast 4, Lore 3, Deceive 2, Blades 1, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 5
ATTACKS	lancet +4 (2, plus Draught: Gut + Endure, Hard, or helpless with retching for 1d6 rounds)
GIFTS	<i>The Draught:</i> she can brew a dose that will make anyone bring up whatever is in them, and some things that should not be. <i>The Bowl Reads:</i> from what a Penitent brings up she can tell their land and how far along they are.
WANTS	A dread of open things; she covers every bowl.
DREAD	1
SECRET	Six years ago a Penitent at Brackwater brought up, after the Draught, something that was not food and was not a tooth: a small grey hinged thing like a finger-joint, which moved. Since then Halloway has seen it eleven times, in Penitents from four lands. She keeps them in a sealed jar. They have grown. They fit together.

THE SECOND TABLE



It worked once.

– THE WHOLE OF THE SECOND TABLE’S CREED, ENGRAVED INSIDE ITS MEMBERS’ SIGNET RINGS

A hidden cult with one idea: when the gods finish regrowing, eat them again. Its members are mostly nobles, High Cuts of every land, and they are preparing. The first trace of it in any record is a menu found in the coat of a murdered Gut-line lordling in 412 A.G., listing seven courses, each named for a god, in a hand nobody could identify. The College has since collected forty more such menus. They are always seven courses. On the most recent ones, found in the last ten years, there is an eighth line at the bottom, left blank.

The Second Table meets in private dining rooms on the Rim and in the cellars of great houses, a dozen at a time, never more. Members address one another by course: the Fish, the Bread, the Sweet. They practice. They have eaten the fruit of Seated Laden hills, the grey fingertips of Course-stage Hand-lines, the lidless eyes of the Vigil’s dead nobility, scraps of caul, and the quiet of a Tenanted heart. They keep notebooks of the effects. They have commissioned knives.

Beliefs. The Gorging ended the Lack. It made the eaters’ ancestors into lords. If it is done again, by the right people, with preparation, the gods will be put down once more and the world

given another six hundred years of grace, with the diners at its head. The first meal was eaten by a mob, shared too widely, and spread thin, which is why it did not hold; the second will be eaten by a few. Some members believe they will become gods. Most just believe they will be fed.

What it wants now. Blank organs, to make room. The College’s ledgers, to know which gods will be ripe first. The Sayer’s sentence, to make the meal certain. And, through the heretic Wont Bellamy of the Fast, the one god still whole: Orrum, the Host, as the first course.

The Second Table keeps chapters in every land, a dozen at a table: in the cellar beneath Dame Suet Marrable’s Unending Dinner in the Fatlands, among the Commodores of the Admiralty in Brinehollow, at the Court in Lastgate, in the Height of the Vigil, where Lady Seraphine Dalgety was raised to Carver in 639. Members wear a silk veil embroidered with a silver fork at dinner, and a little enamel badge shaped like a two-tined fork inside the collar on the road, and they recognize one another at any Rim inn by the way they hold their knives.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS	MARK
1	Scullion	Servants and agents who know; paid well, watched closely	none; a very good wage
2	Taster	Admitted to a practice dinner; may eat what is served	the two-tined fork, enamel, inside the collar
3	Trencherman	A full member, holding a course name	the signet ring; <i>It worked once</i> inside the band
4	Carver	Leads a table in a land; keeps its knife	a knife of grey bone with a course-name on the handle
5	the Head of the Table	One; never seen; presides from an empty chair	the empty chair

Joining. By invitation only. A candidate is brought to a dinner and served a dish without being told what it is. They are told afterward. Those who finish their plate are sworn in Oathen to silence, on their own tongues. Those who do not finish their plate are served at the next dinner.

THE INVITATION DINNER

A SUPPER IN SEVEN REMOVES, the twelfth of Last Carving, at the house on the Rim. The Fish: a consommé of the

Fathom, clarified through linen, served cold, with salt from the morning bailing. The Bread: a small loaf of the toothed wheat, the teeth left in. The Sweet: a custard of caul, set in a highland mould, with a crust of burnt sugar. The Lid: two eyes of the Lidded, pickled; one each; do not chew. The Word: a sliver of tongue, Oathen, laid upon the guest’s own and let dissolve; the guest will not speak during this course. The Hand: a finger, grey, nine-jointed, roasted in its glove. The Host: (the course is not served; the plate is set and removed).

– MENU FOUND IN THE COAT OF A MURDERED GUT-LINE LORDLING, SATED, 412 A.G.; THE COLLEGE’S FIRST. THE FORTY-ONE MENUS FOUND SINCE ARE IDENTICAL IN FORM. THE MOST RECENT HAVE AN EIGHTH LINE, LEFT BLANK

The candidate is brought to dinner by a member who vouches for them, seated, and served. Nobody tells them what anything is. The talk at table is of ordinary things: the price of oil in the Vigil, a scandal at the Weighing, a horse. The candidate eats, or does not. When the plates are cleared, the Carver rises and reads the menu aloud, course by course, slowly, watching the candidate’s face. Those who finish their plate are taken into the next room and sworn in Oathen to silence, on their own tongues, with a Clausewright of the Table holding the tongue between two silver spoons while the oath is said. Those who do not finish their plate are thanked, and seen to their carriage, and served at the next dinner.

THE SECRET

There is no Head of the Table. Lord Absalom Thrale, who has been Grand Carver since 489, invented the empty chair himself, at a

practice dinner in Sated, to keep the Carvers of seven lands from killing one another over who should preside. It worked. It has worked for a hundred and fifty years. He has told no one. What Thrale has also told no one, and does not like to think about, is that he has never once, at any dinner in a hundred and fifty years, seen the plate set before the empty chair come back to the kitchen with anything on it.



It worked once.

THE WHOLE OF THE CREED, INSIDE EVERY RING

LEADERS

LORD ABSALOM THRALE – GRAND CARVER OF THE SECOND TABLE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Sallowreach Hand-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Blades 5, Godsign 4, Clause 3, Persuade 3, Rites 3, Feast 3, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (gloves of lead mesh) · Fray 5
ATTACKS	carving knife +9 (2); bare hand +7 (see Gifts)
GIFTS	<i>The Finishing Touch:</i> with his bare grey hand, Thrale can end a thing: snuff a lamp, stop a heart’s fluttering, kill a conversation so that nobody in the room can recall what was said. Against a living creature outside Sallowreach, a touch that hits deals 6 damage that ignores Armor. Each use is a Partake. <i>The Carver’s Eye:</i> he knows, by looking, where on a body a god is thickest.
WANTS	Compulsive closing; he cannot leave a door, a lid or a pair of eyes open, and must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard) to stop himself reaching for a stranger’s face.
DREAD	3 (when the gloves come off)
SECRET	Thrale is a younger son of an Unvacated house who left Sallowreach alive two hundred years ago, when he was twenty, and has not been back, because he is quite sure he would die at the Drop. He has outlived his inheritance and stopped aging somewhere in his fifties, which should not happen outside the fen. He believes it is the dishes. He has eaten a piece of every land’s god. He has kept the knife from the first practice dinner, and it is made of grey bone that the College would identify, if shown it, as one of Ossel’s knuckles.

LADY SERAPHINE DALGETY – THE EYE, CARVER OF THE VIGIL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Vigil Eye-line) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Search 5, Persuade 4, Deceive 4, Lore 3, Feast 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	stiletto +3 (2)
GIFTS	<i>Lidless</i> : she cannot be surprised, sees clearly by a single candle, and has perfect recall of everything she has ever seen. <i>The Seeming</i> : once per session she may describe a hallucination aloud; everyone with Fray 4+ who hears her sees it too.
WANTS	Blinks; she must make a Caul + Resolve roll (Routine) once per scene of calm or lose a second in the long dim room, and comes back having moved.
DREAD	2 (her eyes, which never close and are always wet from the brushing)
SECRET	Dalgety travels with two maids who brush her eyes wet every half minute, and she has not slept in forty-one years. She is the Second Table's chief buyer of Blank organs. She has already had a Blank's eyelids grafted onto her own lidless eyes, three times, and three times they have died and sloughed. She has put a price on a fourth pair, and her agents are in the Fatlands, looking for a girl called Wren.

MASTER QUILLON BARR – SURGEON TO THE TABLE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Brinehollow Lung-line, minor) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Stitching 6, Lore 4, Blades 3, Reckoning 3, Feast 3, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 4
ATTACKS	scalpel +8 (2); with an Attack that scores a Helping he may choose to sever a tendon instead of dealing extra damage
GIFTS	<i>Room Made</i> : he can transplant a Blank organ into a godsigned body; the recipient's Regrowth drops by 1 for a season, then rises by 2. <i>Kept Fresh</i> : his brine-tanks keep organs alive for a month.
WANTS	The pull; he cannot work in a room whose windows face west, and his surgery has none.
DREAD	3 (his surgery, where the donors are kept alive and awake between harvests)
SECRET	Every trail Dr. Mercy Thrane has followed out of the Fast ends, eventually, at a hired house with no west windows in whatever city Barr is working that season. He keeps his donors alive between harvests because the organs are better. He has kept one Unfed man, a farmer called Abide, alive for nine years, and Abide has started to put on weight.

THE RECKONERS



Refusing was not enough.

– RECKONER WATCHWORD

Zealots out of the Fast who cross into other lands to kill the Godeaters' highest bloodlines. The first armed band crossed the Rim in 402 A.G.; they have not stopped since. Reckoners travel light, eat only what they carried, and carry nothing that can be traced. They select High Cut families from stolen College genealogies, cross the Hem at night, kill in beds, and are gone by dawn. The Rim Road Company hangs every Reckoner it catches on

Company ground, and the Reckoners have never once killed on the road surface. Their full history, beliefs and their great captain Scant Hollis are described in the chapter on the Fast.

The first band was nineteen young Unfed under a woman named Forswear Kell, who crossed the Rim Road into the Fatlands on the night of the sixteenth of Lack, 402, and entered the manor of a Gut-line family named Brawne through the kitchen, and killed everyone

in it, the Laden matriarch in her bed and her sons and their sons, and came home without having eaten or drunk or sat in the house, and was received at Wanting in silence. The Reckoners have kept the

date as their own. Their ladder, as the Fast keeps it, follows the work of a raid.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS	MARK
1	Carrier	Bears the band’s food and water on a raid; a full measure	a bare pack, never opened by anyone else
2	Knife	Enters the house; a Reckoner blade, black-iron, unadorned	the black-iron knife
3	Kin-Reader	Holds the stolen genealogies; plans which beds, in what order	a stolen College quire
4	Band-Captain	Leads a raid; chooses the line; may call on safehouses on the Rim	a knotted cord, one knot per line ended
5	Reckoner-Captain	Sets the season’s lines; a seat (unofficial) at the Abstinents’ door	nothing at all

Joining. Only the Unfed are trusted, though a few godsigned outsiders have been used, and spent. A Carrier swears the Footprint Oath at the Barrows to eat nothing on the far side of the Hem, and carries for a season before being given a knife. Scour, the Returned, is the reason the oath was made stricter.

THE FOOTPRINT OATH

Before the candidate swears, they fast for nine days, as their ancestors did on the hill, on water and a quarter-measure, and on the tenth morning they are walked to the Barrows, where the dead of the Refusal lie nine and ten deep. In the trench above the graves, the Reckoner-Captain finds the footprint of the candidate’s own ancestor, by the old Pantry rolls, a shallow worn hollow in the

packed earth that the family has kept clear for six hundred years, and the candidate takes off their boots and stands in it. They swear barefoot, facing away from Hallowboard, with their back to every door. They swear to eat nothing on the far side of the Hem, to drink nothing, to sit on nothing, to touch no table; and to end what they are sent to end, the whole line, from the oldest to the youngest, without looking at the faces. Then the Captain gives them the pack. They will carry for a season before they are trusted with a knife.

I will eat nothing that is offered. I will take nothing that is given. I will sit at no table. I will end the line. No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you.

– THE FOOTPRINT OATH; THE RECKONERS SWEAR IT ON HALLOWBOARD’S DEAD, AND DO NOT CONSIDER THAT AN OATH ON THE DEAD IS A GODEATER CUSTOM

THE SECRET

The Reckoners kill their own. Scour, the Returned, came home from a year in the Fatlands with godsign under his sleeves, and he hides it, and volunteers for every raid. He is not the first. Every few years an Unfed who has eaten across the Hem, a poacher’s escaped captive fed generously on the road, a Crumb-Runner who tasted his cargo, a pilgrim who came back, begins to show the meat looking for somewhere to be hungry from. The Reckoner-Captain has a list of these, too, in a separate quire, in her own hand. They are not raided. They are visited, at home, in Wanting, at night, by a single Knife who does not eat or drink or sit, and in the morning their families find them face-down on the floor where the table would be, and bury them face-down in the fields, and do not ask. The oath was made stricter after Scour. Scant Hollis has not yet decided what to do about him.

LEADERS

The Reckoners are led in the field by **Reckoner-Captain Scant Hollis**, who has led forty raids across the Rim and ended nine high-Cut lines in their beds, and who keeps no trophies, and is described in full in the chapter on the Fast. Below her the bands are captained

by men and women whose names the Company would very much like to know.

REFRAIN COBB, RECKONER KNIFE Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Attack +7 (black-iron knife 2, strikes first from hiding) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

SPARING WADE, BAND-CAPTAIN OF THE EASTERN RIM Threat 4 · Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Attack +8 (hatchet 3; crossbow +7, 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 1

DENY FALLON, THE LEDGER RECKONER, KIN-READER Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · carries a stolen College quire; hunting Silas Fenwright for the rest

◇
Refusing was not enough.
RECKONER WATCHWORD, CUT INTO THE DOORFRAME OF HOUSE BRAWNE, 402 A.G.

CROSS-BORDER POWERS IN A CAMPAIGN

Every party should have a reason to be on the Rim, and the five powers supply most of them. The Company hires. The College asks questions and pays for answers. The Purgation offers absolution and then a spear. The Second Table invites the most successful characters to dinner. The Reckoners notice whoever has a high Cut and has become inconvenient. Let each power want something from the characters before the characters want anything from it, and let at least one of them be wrong about who the characters are.

Each power's secret is a campaign by itself. A party that learns the Company's bone is people, the College's box is alive, the Purgation feeds the Second Table, the Second Table has no Head, or the Reckoners kill their own, holds a knife to an institution that every land depends on. None of the five will let them keep it lightly. Decide early which of the secrets your campaign is about, and let the players stumble on the edge of a second one just as they think they understand the first.



CHAPTER 3

SALLOWREACH

Where Nothing Ends



Nobody here is waiting to die. We are all waiting to be allowed.

– FEN PROVERB

Shut the door, love. Shut the door. Something might finish.

– HAND-LINES NURSERY RHYME, FIRST LINE (THERE IS NO LAST LINE)

*Brown is still hers. Black is the god's. Grey is the guild's business, and white is nobody's,
and you burn it.*

– SEAMERS' GUILD TEACHING-RHYME, RECITED BY THREADERS OVER THE
TWEEZERS

From the day-book of Aubin Coyle, apprentice of the Seamers' Guild, Needle Street, Lastgate. Restitching Week, Grace, 640 A.G.

They send the youngest of us to the grandmothers first, because the grandmothers are the worst and the guild says you should learn the worst while your stomach still thinks it can be taught.

Mistress Harl took me to the Coombe house on Weir Row at first bell. The family had already carried Great-Gran Coombe down from the attic on her board and laid her across the kitchen table, under the hook where the eels hang. They had put a sprig of rosemary in each of her hands and a cloth over her face, which was kind of them and no use at all. You smell a Kept grandmother in spring before you are through the door. It is not one smell. Mistress Harl says to learn it in layers, like a cellar. On top is the family's vinegar, and under that the old cedar oil from last year's lacquer gone rancid, and under that the sweet, and under the sweet the thing itself, which is like a pot of lentils left a fortnight in the sun with a dead rat in it, and the rat is you.

"Good morning, Gran," said Mistress Harl. "May you finish."

The cloth moved. Under it something said, wetly, "Long life to you too, you lacquered bitch." The family laughed the way people laugh at a christening. Great-Gran Coombe died in 431. She has been rude to the guild every spring since.

We took the cloth off. Her face had slipped again. That is what winter does to them, even here where there is no winter: the damp gets into the lacquer and the old stitches go soft as wet bread and everything settles downward. The left cheek had come away from the bone along last year's seam and hung like a pocket. Mistress Harl lifted it with two fingers and I saw

what was in the pocket. They were grey and they were moving and some of them had already got into the eye. She said, "Tweezers, Aubin, and the vinegar, and do not you dare be sick on a client."

I did not. I want that written down. I was sick afterward, in the eel barrel, and Mr. Coombe said not to worry, the eels would not mind, they are Kept too.

You pick them out one at a time. You cannot rush it, because if you squeeze they burst, and what is inside them is her. Gran swore at me the whole while in a voice that came partly from her mouth and partly from a split under her jaw where the old wire had pulled through. When I got to the eye she stopped swearing and said, very quietly, "Mind the eye, boy. I still use it." Then she held my wrist with her good hand. It was cold and soft and the skin moved over the bones like a glove a size too big. Under it I could feel her pulse, which she does not have. That is the thing nobody tells you. Under the skin of the Kept it is always moving. It is just not them.

We cut out the black and kept the brown. Mistress Harl says brown is still hers. We packed the cheek with lint soaked in cedar-and-pitch, drew it back up to the cheekbone, and I put in my first real seam: thirty-one stitches of waxed gut, blanket stitch, with wire at the corners. My hands shook. Gran said, "That is the worst stitching I have had in two hundred years," and then, "Thank you," and then, "Will you come next year? I should like it to be you." I said I would.

Then we lacquered her. Three coats, cedar and resin, brushed thin, each one dried with the bellows. By noon she shone like a sideboard and smelled like a church and the family sat her up in her chair by the window, which is where she likes to be, so she can watch the weep come down on the fen and tell the neighbors what she thinks of them.

On the way out I asked Mistress Harl how long it would hold. She said, "Till Plenty. Then the flies come and it starts again." I asked her how long that goes on. She looked at me like I had asked how long the fen goes on. She lit her pipe with a candle Wick Tallow made, and the candle flinched, and she said:

"Write it down, Aubin. That is what the book is for. Forever is a long time to remember by hand."

Sallowreach is the land where nothing ends. A cut throat does not kill. A drowned girl walks out of the fen in the morning, coughing weed. A hanged man asks to be cut down. The grandmothers are restitched each spring. The fires that were lit in the founding years are still smoldering under the peat. The songs have no last verse and the arguments no final word. For six hundred and forty-one years the people of the grey north have lived inside the stomach of the god of death, and the god of death has been unable to do its job.

Now it is learning again.

This chapter describes Sallowreach in the Long Grace: its meal, its rule, its rot, its powers and its people. It gives the Game Master everything needed to set a campaign in the fens, and gives players what they need to play a Sallowreacher, living or Kept.

▼ THE MEAL

The people of the northern fens ate Ossel, the Closing Hand, last and slowest of all the peoples of the Table, because nobody wanted to be the one to start.

In the old carvings Ossel is shown seated, robed in what may be fog, with two immense hands laid open on its knees. It was not cruel and it was not kind. It walked the fens in the evening the way a lamplighter walks a street, and where it passed, things finished. The old heron that could no longer stand closed its eyes. The sick child's breathing eased and stopped. The fire that had burned all night settled into ash and was done. The fen-people loved it the way you love a doctor who has never once lied to you. They brought it their dying, and it came, and it put its hand over their eyes, and it was over. *May you finish* was a blessing then, said at bedsides, and it came true.

In the ninth winter of the Long Lack the fen-folk were eating reed-root and boiled leather and the soft white grubs from under the peat. Ossel came to them across the water at Lastgate, which was then a landing called the Ferrying, and lay down on the black mud at the edge of the mere with its hands folded on its chest, and waited. It waited eleven days.

They knew what had happened elsewhere. Word had come along the old roads of what the southern plains had done to their god, and the western coast to theirs. Every family in the Ferrying had someone in the house too weak to rise. And still nobody went down

◇
*We are the only people on the Table who know exactly
what our grandparents smell like on the inside.*

LASTGATE SAYING, TOLD TO FOREIGNERS AT THE
LANDING TO WATCH THEIR FACES

A word on the smell, before anything else, because a visitor meets it before anything else. It begins on the border road, nine miles out, as a sweetness in the fog that a southerner mistakes for flowers. By the Finishing Post it has become a weight on the tongue, like a coin held too long in the mouth. By the Landing it is everywhere, in the tar and the vinegar and the cedar smoke, and in the folds of every coat, and in the bread. The Sallowreacher does not smell it. The Sallowreacher smells *through* it, the way a fisherman sees through water, to the smaller smells beneath: whose grandmother needs restitching, which house has a seam gone in the attic, whether the Kept man on the next bench was lacquered this month or last. Children in Lastgate can tell, with their eyes closed, how many years a person has been dead. It is a parlour game. They are usually right to within a decade.

to the shore with a knife, because everyone in the fens understood a thing the other peoples had not had to think about: if you kill death, who closes your eyes?

THE FOURTH DAY: YSMAY BRACK, THE LAST CLOSED

The Court's histories pass over the first ten days of the waiting in a sentence. The Loft-Wardens do not, because the shelved of Hall One remember them, and some of the shelved of Hall One were there.

On the fourth day the elders of the Ferrying met in the eel-house, which was the only roofed building on the landing, and argued in the dark with the god lying on the mud outside the door. The headman was a weir-owner named Orrin Brack. His argument, which the whisper-books record nearly word for word from three separate shelves, was this: that Ossel had never once come to the fen without taking something, that it had come every evening of every year to close what was ready, and that a god lying on the shore with its hands open was a god *waiting to be given*. It was not asking to be eaten. It was asking for its due. Give it one good life, whole and young and unready, said Orrin Brack, and it would rise and go back across the water, and the famine would end, the way famines had always ended, by someone paying.

The elders agreed. The fen-folk had paid Ossel in the dying for a thousand years, and they understood debt. What they argued over until dawn was only whose.

It was Brack's own daughter, Ysmay, twenty years old, the strongest rower on the landing, who had kept the Brack family alive that winter by poling out to the far weirs alone. The accounts differ on whether she offered or was chosen. The shelved of Hall One are clear that her father asked her at the eel-house door, in front of everyone, and that in the fens a father's asking and a father's ordering were the same sentence said in two voices. She washed in the mere. She put on her mother's marriage-shawl. She walked down the mud between the families with her hair wet and her feet bare, and the landing said nothing, because there was nothing to say that did not make it worse.

She lay down in the god's left hand. The palm was the size of a punt's floor and as cold as the underside of ice. The fingers, very slowly, closed over her, as they had closed over every dying thing in the fen for a thousand years, gently, the way you fold a letter. There was no sound from inside. After a time the fingers opened again, and she was there, still and pale and finished, her eyes shut and her mouth a little open, as if about to say something polite.

The god did not rise. It did not stir. It lay on the mud with its hands open and its eyes on the fog, and the famine went on, and the next morning two more children on the landing did not wake.

That is the whole of the story, and it is the one the fen does not tell its children. Ysmay Brack was the last person in Sallowreach to die and stay dead. Everyone who has died since has come back. She is the only one who got what the god had always given, and she got it for nothing: for a guess, made in the dark by frightened men, about what a god might want. Seven days later Hessa Grue walked down with her reaping hook and said that the god was lying there so that they would, and nobody argued, because everyone on the landing had seen what the other answer had bought.

The Court's genealogies say Ysmay was buried in the old way, under a mound behind the eel-house, the last grave in the north. The Cutwrights' College has opened the Brack Mound twice, in 388 and in 590, and found it empty to the clay. In the ninth winter of the Long Lack, the shelved of Hall One say when the Readers press them, nothing on the landing was wasted. Then they stop whispering for a while.



She was the last of us to get it, and she got it for a guess.

SISTER LORN OF THE SHUT EYE, PREACHING AT THE
DUNMERE VERGE, 640 A.G.

The Finishers have taken her up. They call her Saint Ysmay of the Open Hand and the First Walker, and they carry her name first on

every pilgrim's strip. The Confessors of the Theft consider her the original sin of the north, worse than the Meal: not the eating of a god, which hunger excused, but the paying of a god that had not asked, which nothing excuses. The Gift preaches that the god closed her out of love, to spare her the centuries to come. Nobody in the Brack family, which survives as a line of eel-catchers on Weir Row, will speak her name. Their Kept elders turn their faces to the wall when it is said.

A PRICE NOBODY ASKED

Ysmay Brack's death is the first worthless sacrifice of the north, and not the last (see The Restitution of 639). Use it as a lens. In Sallowreach, people pay; it is what they are for. They pay the Court for death, the Guild for shape, the Unvacated for rent, the Lofts for attendance. A PC who learns the story at the right moment (in the waiting room of the Hall of Closings, say, or at the edge of a Hush, watching a pilgrim's strip with her name at the top) should feel the floor tilt: the whole country was founded on a payment that bought nothing. Learning the full truth of the Brack Mound from the shelved of Hall One is a Dread 3 experience.

On the eleventh night a widow named Hessa Grue (the Court's genealogies insist on the name; the Cutwrights' College does not) walked down to the mud with a reaping hook and her six living children and said, loudly enough for the landing to hear, "It is lying there so that we will." Then she began at the left hand.

The accounts agree on a few things and on nothing else. They agree that Ossel's flesh was cold, colder than the mud, cold as a cellar step, and that it did not bleed but leaked a grey, slow, tasteless fluid like the water that collects under a stone. They agree that it had no smell at all. A body three hundred feet long, opened on the shore, and not a breath of rot or meat or blood; the gulls would not come down to it, and the flies, for the first time in anyone's life, stayed away. That absence of smell is what the oldest songs remember, more than the blood or the cold. *It smelled of nothing, and nothing was what we ate.*

They agree that it took nine days to eat. Families came down in turn and carved, and carried, and boiled, and the meat would not soften in the pot however long it boiled, so it was eaten in grey strips that had to be chewed for an hour. It tasted, said the ones who wrote of it, like the moment after a bell stops ringing. People who ate it fell asleep where they sat and woke the next morning unable to remember the night. Some woke weeping. Some woke laughing and could not say why.

The families who took the hands became the Hand-lines. Hessa Grue's children ate the left hand to the wrist; the Vanes, the Sedges and the Hethes divided the right. The Hands were the choicest cut because they were what the god *did* things with, and because they were the hardest part to eat: the fingers kept curling closed over the knives. It is said that the eldest Vane boy put his own hand into

Ossel's palm, in the dark, to steady the carving, and the god's fingers closed over his, gently, and held him there until dawn. He was not hurt. He would not speak of it. His line is the strongest in Sallowreach.

Last of all they came to the face. Nobody wanted it. In the end the Scraplings of the far fen took it, as they took everything nobody else would, and boiled it in a peat pit for a week. Those who saw it before the knives went in all said the same thing, and Grandfather Peat (see the People of Sallowreach), who saw it the week he drowned, still says it in a dialect no one else speaks: the god was smiling.

The famine ended the next morning. The reeds came up green. Eels filled the traps. And in Lastgate, a thief who had been hanged at the landing the week before, and left as a warning, opened his eyes, saw the crowd gathered on the shore, and asked politely to be cut down.

The fen remembers the nine days by what the body does not remember. The carvers' hands went numb to the elbow in the first hour and stayed numb for a month; Hessa Grue's eldest, it is said, never felt anything in her fingers again, and could hold a coal. The knives frosted. The mere around the god did not ripple even when the wind blew, as if the water had stopped trying. The grey fluid that leaked from the cuts collected in the hoof-prints and footprints on the mud and did not soak in, and children who put their fingers in it said it was like touching the inside of a closed eye. At night the families slept on the landing beside the carcass, because no one wanted to walk home alone, and in the morning they found that they had all dreamed the same dream, of a long table with someone standing at the end of it, waiting to be asked to sit, and none of them could remember who.

The Ferrying Song, oldest of the fen-songs; sung by eel-catchers when the traps are lifted. It has six verses. The seventh is

*hummed. Nobody knows if there was ever an eighth.
Down to the mud with the hook and the pot,
Nine days long and the meat not hot,
Grey as a stone and cold as a well,
And it smiled, my darling, and nobody tell.
Hand for the Grue and hand for the Vane,
Hand to be eaten and never again,
The face to the fen-folk, boiled in the peat,
And it smiled, my darling, and still we would eat.
(hummed)*

THE MISSING WITNESS

On the oldest piling in Lastgate, the Ferrying Post, under nine centuries of tar and moss, there is a carving of a long table at the water's edge with figures seated along it. Seven are recognizably the Providers: the open hands of Ossel, the full belly of Ummer, the lidded eyes of Iss. There is an eighth place at the end of the table. The figure that sat there has been gouged out to the wood, not once but repeatedly, with different tools, the newest cuts still pale. Every few years someone in Lastgate notices that the gouge is fresh again. The Court pays a man to tar it over. He is Kept, and has been doing it for three hundred years, and he has stopped asking who keeps opening it.



*Count the chairs, then count the guests, then count
them again, love. In Lastgate the second count is
always one higher.*

WEIR ROW NURSERY WISDOM

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

Nothing ends here.

A body in Sallowreach takes the damage and goes on. A throat slit to the spine bleeds out, the heart stops, the blood stops, and the man sits up, his head lolling forward on a hinge of skin, and asks for help holding it on. A woman drowned in the mere is down for a night and comes up the next day, puffed and grey and furious, with an eel in her coat. A man burned in a barn fire walks out of the ashes as a figure of black coal that crackles when it moves and weeps clear fluid from its cracks. A starving child grows hungry and thin and then too thin and then nothing changes; she goes on, and goes on being hungry. And everyone grows old. The very old go past old into something else: shrunk, leathery, curled like a dropped glove, eyes gone to milk, whispering. They are still in there.

Those who have died and carried on are called **the Kept**. They outnumber the breathing nine to one. They have no pulse and no breath. They do not need to eat, drink or sleep, though many still try out of habit, and some still feel a ghost of hunger they cannot feed. Their bodies are cool, the temperature of the room. They feel everything.

That is the cruelty: decay still works. A Kept body rots exactly as a dead body rots anywhere else on the Table: it bloats, it slips, it blackens, it is hollowed by flies and their children. But it never finishes rotting. There is no clean bone at the end, no dust, no rest. The rot goes on, slower and slower, layer under layer, for centuries, and the mind sits inside it and feels every soft inch go. The Kept do

not lose their wits to death. They lose them, if they lose them, to time.

THE LONG ROT

Every Seamer learns the long rot as a calendar, because it keeps time better than any clock in the north. It is the same body after body,

the same stages in the same order, only slower: what takes a fortnight in a southern ditch takes a lifetime in a Lastgate attic, and what takes a year in the south never arrives here at all.

TIME KEPT	WHAT THE GUILD CALLS IT	WHAT IT LOOKS, SMELLS AND FEELS LIKE
First week	Fresh	Waxen, cool, the blood settled purple in the lowest skin. Smells of nothing worse than sweat. The Kept say this is the worst week, because they can still remember being warm.
First season	Bloat	The belly swells and strains the waistband; the face goes round and green-marbled; the tongue fills the mouth. Gas moves through the body with a sound like a cat purring. Smells of drains and sweet milk.
First years	the Slip	Skin loosens and slides over the flesh like a glove a size too big; it comes away in sheets on the sheets. Hair lifts out in combs. Fingernails drop. Smells of wet cellar and bad meat. Flies come in earnest.
First decades	the Settling	Everything goes downward. Cheeks hang, eyelids hang, the belly empties into the thighs. The soft parts liquefy and are held in only by wrapping, lacquer and the Seamers. The smell is at its height: “the brown.”
First century	the Leathering	What is left dries toward hide and tendon, brown and black, curled like a dropped glove. The voice goes papery. The smell thins and sharpens to cheese, vinegar and old shoes.
Centuries	the Long Grey	A rack of bone and black string with a lacquered face, kept in shape by wire, still drying, still never dry. Under the skin something always moves. The Kept at this stage say the itch is the only thing that has not faded.

There is no last row. A body at the Long Grey goes on being a body at the Long Grey, and the colony that lives in it goes on breeding, and it goes on feeling the colony. The Guild’s oldest teaching-ledger has a column headed *Dust*, ruled in 131 A.G. in the expectation that someone would one day need it. It is empty.

The Kept feel all of it, which is the part foreigners refuse to believe until they have sat with a Kept grandmother through a spring afternoon and watched her stop mid-sentence to press a hand flat against her side, very hard, the way a living woman presses a stitch, and wait for something under the skin to finish turning over. The bloat aches like a stomach after a feast that never digests. The slip burns, the way skin burns when a plaster is pulled. The settling is a constant, dragging, downward pull, as if the body were full of wet sand and someone were tugging at the bottom of the sack. And the maggots are felt one by one, every one, for as long as they live, and then their children are felt.



Gran says it doesn’t hurt any more. Gran says it the way you say the kettle’s not on, when you can hear it.
A WEIR ROW CHILD, AGED TEN, TO A READER AT THE LOFTS

It applies to everything that ever lived, and to much that did not.

◇ **Animals.** A slaughtered pig gets up off the block. Butchery in Sallowreach is the art of rendering an animal too disjointed to wander off. Eels go on twisting in the pot and, it is said, in the stomach. The rich eat imported Fatlands meat or *stilled* meat,

- closed by a licensed Hand-line butcher at great expense. The poor eat *lively*, and learn to chew fast.
- ◇ **Plants.** Cut reeds go on drawing water. Picked fruit rots on the shelf and never goes to dust. Leaves yellow on the branch and stay yellow for decades, waiting for an autumn that never finishes arriving.
 - ◇ **Fire.** A fire in Sallowreach burns down but does not go out. Peat fires lit in the Glad Century still smolder under the fen; the ground steams in long seams across the north. To put out a candle you must close it, and only the Hand-lines can close.
 - ◇ **Sound and speech.** Songs here have no last verse; they trail off and wait. Books have no last pages. An argument begun in 212 A.G. over a fishing weir is still being conducted, by the original parties, in a room in Lastgate, through a hired interpreter of jaw-clicks.
 - ◇ **The border.** The dead cannot leave. A Kept person who steps across the border of Sallowreach drops, finished, at once, the whole long rot catching up in a single heartbeat. What hits the ground on the far side is bone and dust and a smell like an opened tomb. Sallowreach therefore has an army that cannot be killed and cannot invade.
 - ◇ **Wounds.** A cut on the living closes in Sallowreach as it would anywhere, slowly and badly; a cut on the Kept never closes at all. It stays open, raw, wet at the lips, a mouth in the body, for as long as the body lasts. Old soldiers of the Fen Guard carry wounds from the Reckoners’ raid of 402 that are still pink inside, and the Seamers’ first lesson is that a seam is not a healing but a lid.

- ◇ **Pain.** It does not fade with the injury, because the injury does not end. A woman whose hip was broken in a fall in 470 has been breaking her hip, in a sense, every day since. The Kept learn to live in pain the way the living learn to live in weather.
- ◇ **Sleep.** The Kept do not need it, but many fall into a slow stupor they call *going under*, which is like sleep with the eyes open and the mind awake at the bottom of it, listening. The living call it *keeping quiet*. It is in this state that most Kept are robbed of parts.

THE RULE AT THE TABLE

In Sallowreach, a character reduced to 0 Flesh suffers Ruin as normal: an Injury from the Mangling table and collapse. Further damage does not kill. A living character who would die instead becomes Kept (see Playing One of the Kept). A Kept character who suffers further damage accrues Rot instead. Enemies are the same: the GM should remember that a fight in Sallowreach ends when one side cannot move or chooses to stop, never when someone dies. Hamstringing, dismembering, sacking and sinking are the local tactics. Witnessing a Kept man coming apart is a Dread 2 horror; a Kept body that goes on talking while it is being taken to pieces is Dread 3.

There is one exception, and it is the whole of Sallowreach's politics. The Hand-lines, who ate the god's hands, can close. Their touch, in the later stages of their Regrowth, does what Ossel once did: it finishes a thing. A candle. A conversation. A person. Since 301 A.G. that touch has been sold by license, and it is the only death in the land.

Chalked on the board outside the Parish Wardens' lock-up, Sinks Ward, Lastgate. Summer prices; the board is wiped and

rewritten each Plenty.

FALLING APART IN PUBLIC — BY ORDER OF THE STITCHING LAWS OF 130, AS AMENDED 131, 166, 212, 300, 459 (NONE REPEALED)

A finger — 1 lack. A hand — 4 lacks. A foot — 4 lacks. A forearm or shin — 8.

An ear, a nose, a lip — 6 each. A jaw — 12. A face, entire — 20.

An eye, dropped — 3 lacks, and the eye returned to the owner in the bag provided.

Spillage from the belly — 10 lacks, and the boards to be scrubbed with vinegar by the owner's household.

Teeth — no charge under five. Hair — no charge.

Parts unclaimed at the lock-up after nine days will be sold to the Guild stock-room for the relief of the poor.

Parts claimed by MORE THAN ONE OWNER will be held for the Court of Wrongs.

THE WARDEN DOES NOT GIVE CHANGE.



The Rule is not a miracle. A miracle is over by supper.

CONFESSOR AMBROSE WEAL, SHUT HOUSE OF THE LANDING

▼ THE REGROWTH IN SALLOWREACH

Ossel is growing back, and what grows back is ending. Every other land's god returns as a presence, an appetite, a pressure. Sallowreach's returns as an absence. Its godsign is closing, and its Seating is silence.

THE TASTE

It begins as a dread of open things. A Hand-line child cannot sleep with the door ajar. She gets up three times a night to push it to, and if it is pushed open again she cries until it is shut. Open jars bother her. Open mouths bother her. A book left face-down makes her feel sick in a place she cannot point to. Adults at the Taste find themselves closing drawers in other people's houses, smoothing shut the flaps of envelopes, lowering the lids of sleeping friends with a fingertip. The fingers go cold first, a chill like holding a stone that has lain all night in the fen. Candles near them gutter.

Conversations near them, for no reason anyone can name, tend to stop.

From a letter of Agnes Pettle, living, nurse to the cadet children of the Hethe house, Upper Boards, to her sister in Weir Row. Plenty, 638 A.G.

Little Master Bevis is at the Taste, they say, the way you'd say a child has his first tooth, and Lady Hethe had cake. He is six. I sit up with him nights. He cannot bear the shutters open even a finger's width and screams for me if the wind moves one, and he has started on my eyes. I wake and his little hand is there, pressing my lids down, ever so gentle, cold as a spoon from the well. He says, "Go to sleep properly, Nurse." He says I sleep wrong, with my eyes all wet underneath. The other nurse, Dorcas, will not take his room any more. She says when

*he is in it you cannot hear the canal. I said that was nonsense.
Then I sat in it and listened, Ide, and you can't.*

THE APPETITE

Then the closing becomes a compulsion. Lids, shutters, books, boxes, eyes. Appetite sufferers cannot pass an open door without shutting it. They close the eyes of the dead, and then the eyes of the living: a stranger in a tavern finds a cold hand laid over his face, gently, and the person it belongs to apologizing and unable to stop. They finish other people's sentences, and then they finish other people's songs, and the song simply ends there, and the singer cannot remember the next verse. The fingertips grey. The nails thicken and darken like horn. The hands are always cold now, cold enough to sting, and sufferers wear mittens in polite company, partly from courtesy and partly so that they will have to take something off before they can touch. It is said in Lastgate that you can always tell a Hand-line house at night, because every window is shuttered and every door is shut, and the silence inside is the kind you could lean on.



*Mittens on, love, mittens on. You can take them off
when you're married, and then only in the dark, and
then only to your husband, and he'll thank you not to.*

HAND-LINE NURSEMAID'S RHYME, SUNG WHILE
BUTTONING

THE COURSE

The hands change. They go grey all the way to the wrist and then past it, a cold slate grey like the belly of a fish, and the skin over them grows smooth and seamless and faintly shining. They lengthen. The fingers grow extra joints, first one more, then two, then more, so that a hand at the height of the Course can curl like a fern or fold flat like a fan. The joints click in silence. The nails go black. The cold is no longer a sensation but a fact: a hand at the Course will frost a glass of water and leave a pale, bloodless print on skin.

And what they touch finishes. A candle pinched by a Course-hand is not snuffed but *closed*: the wick goes dark, the wax goes cold, and it will never be lit again. A conversation touched, a palm laid on a speaker's shoulder, ends, and nobody present can quite recall what it was about. A Kept body touched with intent goes still. The long rot catches up at once, every unfinished year of it, and what was a talking corpse is in a moment only a corpse, quiet, smelling at last of nothing worse than earth. The Kept who see it weep with envy. The living who see it are often sick.

People at the Course keep their hands in gloves, then in mittens, then in lead. The highest of the Hand-lines have their gloves sewn on.

There is a smell to a Hand-line at the Course, and it is the absence of one. The skin of the hands gives off nothing at all: not sweat, not soap, not the faint salt of any living palm. People who have stood near them describe the air around the hands as tasting *rinsed*, the way the air tastes after a heavy snow in the south, though no one in the north has seen snow. Flies avoid the hands, then the arms, then the person. In a land where every room buzzes, the Course-stricken move in a little bubble of stillness, and the Kept follow them through the streets at a distance, the way starving dogs follow a butcher's cart.



*Every Kept man in Lastgate knows which side of the
street the Vanes walk on. Half of them cross to it.*

YSOLDE CRANE, CEDAR-WARDEN OF HAND STREET

THE BRINK

At the Brink the ending begins to leak out of the hands and into the room. Sound grows thin around the sufferer. Footsteps do not quite carry. Flies within a few paces drop out of the air and do not get up. Flames lean away. The Kept, near a Brink-sufferer, fall silent and then begin to plead. The sufferer's face grows smooth and grey like the hands, the features softening as if seen through fog, and in some of them the lips curve gently upward, in what everyone agrees not to call a smile. They stop needing to touch. A Hand-line at the Brink can finish a thing by looking at it long enough and wishing it over. Most of them have stopped wishing anything at all.

THE SEATING

The Seating in Sallowreach is a **Hush**: a patch of ground where everything ends at once and stays ended. A Hand-line who reaches it does not die. They become the center of a silence, and the silence spreads. Inside a Hush there is no rot, no flies, no echo. The Kept inside it are properly, finally dead, and lie down where they stood. The grass is grey and does not move. Sound does not carry: a scream inside a Hush is a mouth opening and nothing. Birds fall at its edge. The largest, Dunmere Hush, is four miles across and growing.

The Court has known for some years, and has begun to admit in locked rooms, that Hushes appear fastest near the estates of the Hand-lines. The god is not coming back as a figure walking the fen in the evening. It is coming back as a book, closing.

To stand at the edge of a Hush is to feel the inside of your own ears. The fen beside you buzzes and drips and knocks and breathes; a step ahead, there is nothing, and the nothing presses on the eardrum like deep water. Visitors report a taste of iron. They report that their own heartbeats become enormous, and then, if they lean over the line, that their heartbeats seem to come from the wrong side of it, from somewhere out in the grey, steady and patient, like someone walking toward them who never arrives. The reeds at the

line are cut clean in colour as if with a knife: green-brown on one side, the grey of cold ash on the other, and the grey does not move in the wind. A dropped stone lands without a sound. A lamp held over the line burns on, but its light looks painted.

RUNNING THE REGROWTH

Sallowreach's horror works because it inverts the rest of the Table. Everywhere else, the Regrowth is the thing the players fear. Here, half the population is praying for it. A Hand-line PC at the Course will be approached constantly: by grandmothers asking to be closed, by Heirs offering fortunes to have a father closed, by Finishers asking to be blessed, by Court agents with a license, a fee and a warrant. Every touch is a moral decision and most of them are illegal. Make the players feel what it is to carry the only mercy in a country and to be told, by law, who may have it.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

Sallowreach is grey fen, black water, reed and peat, under a fog called **the Breath** that has not lifted in living or unliving memory. The Breath is warm and wet and sweet in the wrong way, like air let out of a closed room. It beads on wool and hair. It carries sound strangely: a voice across the mere seems to come from just behind you. At noon it is the color of dishwater; at dusk it goes yellow, then brown.

There is no real winter, because winter is an ending. The seasons are named as they are everywhere on the Table, but in the fens they only lean: Grace is damper, Plenty is hotter and buzzes, Carving yellows the leaves, and Lack makes the fog a little colder and leaves the leaves where they are. Trees in Sallowreach carry decades of dead foliage, yellow and brown and black in layers, rattling. A Sallowreacher who travels south and sees a bare tree in Lack weeps, or laughs, or both.

Flies are the true weather. They move across the fen in fronts, dense brown curtains a mile wide that tick against shutters like sleet. Lastgate's almanacs forecast them. A **Black Noon** is a swarm thick enough to put out lamps and turn day to dusk; people caught outdoors in one breathe through cloth and come home with flies in their ears, their collars, the corners of their eyes. Every house has fly-nets, fly-paper, smudge pots of smoldering peat and lavender. In the hot weeks of Plenty, when the swarms breed, the Kept are shut indoors for their own sakes, and the Seamers work without sleeping.

From Pocock's Lastgate Almanack and Fly-Reckoner for the Year 641, Plenty, the Weeks of the Swarm. Sold at the Landing, 2 crumbs.

FIRST WEEK. *A brown front out of the Sump by second bell Tuesday, thickening toward the Sinks. Shutters by fourth bell. Kept elders to be brought in from the stoops. Mind the eyes of the newly lacquered, which the green-bottle favours.*

SECOND WEEK. *Black Noon likely Thursday. Lamps will fail on the Boards between noon and third bell. Do not travel*

the causeway. Do not open your mouth to call a child. Lay wet linen at the door-sill.

THIRD WEEK. *The breeding. Expect the Shutter Days to be proclaimed. Smudge-pots to be fed every bell. Those with a Kept spouse should sleep in another room, for the noise. A good week for the Seamers; a bad week to owe them money.*

FOURTH WEEK. *Thinning. A long dry sigh off the south road is forecast for Saturday at about the sixth bell, lasting near an hour. The sky will be visible. Bring the children up.*

Fly-count for the year: 41 on the east pane at Weir Row (Mallory house, reckoned for the Almanack), signifying a hard Carving. Pocock regrets the error of last year, when the front of the Fourth Week fell upon the Landing instead of the Sinks, and asks the forgiveness of the families of the Fen Guard.

Rain is called **weep**. It falls warm and leaves a tea-colored stain on linen and skin. Mist that settles overnight is called **dew-rot**. The wind, when there is wind, is called **a sigh**, and a long dry sigh off the southern road is the one weather everyone loves: it clears the Breath for an hour and you can see the sky, which is white.

The fen itself is full. Everything that ever drowned in it is still down there, moving a little: deer, dogs, horses, eels by the million, fishermen, suicides from the Glad Century, children who slipped off the boardwalks, six centuries of the weighted sacks of the Sump. On still days the black water stirs without wind. Reed-cutters wear tall boots and keep their eyes on the surface, because sometimes something takes hold of an ankle, not to drown you, only to hold on.

Nothing that falls into the fen finishes sinking, and nothing that floats ever quite rots away, and so the surface of the black water is a slow museum. Reed-cutters learn not to look too long at what drifts past the punt. The Kept who go under for their families to tend the traps learn not to look at anything at all.

◇
*Don't pull it in, whatever it is. If it wanted to come in
it would have climbed.*

PUNT-MAN'S RULE, LASTGATE SOUTH CHANNELS

THINGS FLOATING IN THE FEN

Roll when the party poles a punt off the main channels, crosses a boardwalk, or waits on the water at dusk. Most of these are only horrible. A few want something.

D20 DRIFTING PAST THE PUNT

- | | |
|----|--|
| 1 | A heron, Kept, standing on a raft of its own dead reed-bed. It cannot fly; its wings are mostly gone. It watches you the way herons watch eels. |
| 2 | A Sump sack, rope cut, name-strip torn off, turning slowly in the current. The shape inside is pressing its face against the hessian, so you can see the nose and the open mouth. |
| 3 | A raft of bloated cattle, six of them, roped together by a drover in some century past. They low, very softly, all at once, as you pass. |
| 4 | A Wick Tallow candle stub, still lit, upright on a slab of cork. The flame leans toward the punt. It is trying to be noticed. |
| 5 | A lacquered face-mask with a painted smile, the kind the Guild puts on the faceless, floating face-up. Inside it, something is still wearing it. |
| 6 | A child's cradle, rocking, empty. A rope trails from it down into the black water, taut, as though something at the bottom is holding the other end. |
| 7 | A hand, alone, holding a pole upright in the water as if punting. It has been punting toward Lastgate for a very long time. |
| 8 | A Finisher's candle on a pilgrim's name-strip, the names washed half away; the last legible one is a name a PC knows. |
| 9 | A knot of eels as big as a barrel, tied around something in its middle that is dressed in a coat with brass buttons. |
| 10 | Leaves. A great slow raft of them, three hundred years of yellow, brown and black leaves, so thick a dog stands on it, barking without sound. |
| 11 | A door, painted grey, from a Shut House, floating flat. Somebody has carved on its underside, many times over, <i>let us out</i> . |
| 12 | A lead jar from the Jar Room, green glass under a fen-scum, bobbing like a fishing float. The face inside opens its eyes and mouths a name: the Regent's. |
| 13 | A wedding veil, Lastgate fashion, seamed at the hem with wire. Caught in its lace are nine fingernails. |
| 14 | A dog, Kept, paddling in a circle, as it has paddled since it fell from a boardwalk in some forgotten year. Its legs are only bone now. It is still trying to reach the shore. |
| 15 | A page from a book, floating, the ink still crisp. It is the last page of something. It is blank except for a single line at the top: <i>and then</i> . |
| 16 | A pair of grey Hand-line mittens, lead-lined, unbuckled, floating impossibly on the surface. Something warm-looking and small has been eating its way out of one. |
| 17 | A punt, upside down. Under it, in the air pocket, someone is singing a Finisher hymn and has reached, after many years, the second-to-last verse. |
| 18 | An eel-trap knocking against the boardwalk, full to the lid with fingers of every size, all of them moving gently, like weed. |
| 19 | A wooden chair, carved and old, floating upright and perfectly level on the still water, as if set at a table. It drifts after the punt for an hour, always at the same distance. Nobody is in it. |
| 20 | A woman face-down in a good Fatlands dress, foreign, not long dead. She has been in the water a day. She turns over, coughs weed, and asks in a southern accent where she is, and why everyone in the punt looks so sorry. |

FLOATING THINGS AT THE TABLE

Most entries are Dread 1 if merely seen and Dread 2 if touched or hauled aboard. Entry 19 is Dread 2, and a PC who sits in the chair, or tries to, finds that they cannot make themselves do it: it would be rude, they think, and then cannot say to whom. Entry 20 is a whole adventure: a living southerner newly Kept, who does not yet know she can never go home, and who has family on the Rim Road expecting her in a fortnight. Somebody has to tell her.

▼ A GAZETTEER OF SALLOWREACH

LASTGATE

The capital, built on pilings over the fen where the border road ends. Lastgate is a city of tar, timber and ropes, of plank streets and plank bridges, of houses leaning together over narrow canals like old men sharing a secret. It has sunk for centuries. Each generation builds a new storey on top of the old, and the lower levels have gone down into the water one by one and are still inhabited: the **Drowned Storeys**, half-flooded streets where the light is green and the residents are Kept and long past minding the wet. Little Nell Ash rules there.

Lastgate smells of tar, vinegar, cedar, smoke and the thing all of those are there to hide. Rich houses on the Upper Boards burn cedar in braziers at their doors. Poor streets in the Sinks smell of themselves. Everywhere there are candles, and many of them are Wick Tallow's.

Notable districts: **the Upper Boards** (Court houses, the Mortuary Court's Hall of Hands); **Needle Street** (the Seamers' Guildhall and a hundred stitching-shops, wire-drawers and lacquer-boilers); **the Sinks** (the poor, the Heirs' safehouses, Marrow Jack's markets); **the Landing** (the Ferrying Post, the border road terminus, Tam Ruddock's ferry); and **the Drowned Storeys** beneath it all.

Lastgate is counted in storeys rather than streets. The planks a visitor walks on are the Ninth Storey; the cellars beneath are the Eighth, rented by the bed to the living poor; the Seventh and everything under it are the Drowned Storeys. The flat iron bell of the Ferrying Post, cast in the year 9 and never finished cooling, rings the nine hours of the day, and at sixth bell every household lights its door-candle by law, so that the whole city glows yellow in the Breath like something seen through the skin of a lantern.



Ninth, Weir Row, the Coombe house, is where you'll find Gran. Sixth, Old Weir Row, the Coombe house, is where you'll find her mother. Don't go down there without a lamp, and don't let her keep you to supper.

DIRECTIONS GIVEN TO A SEAMER'S THREADER,
NEEDLE STREET

THE LOFTS

Warehouses of the Set-Aside, on the north edge of Lastgate: nine storeys of shelving in nine long timber halls, each shelf holding the wrapped, labeled bodies of those too far gone to stand. Forty thousand of them, still aware. Ladders on rails run the length of each aisle, and the Loft-Wardens move along them with lamps and

lists. The halls are lit low and kept cool and smell of camphor, linen, wax and old meat. The whispering is audible from the street: a soft continuous sound, like rain on reeds, rising at night.

Visitors remember the Lofts for the whispering and Wardens remember them for the drip. The shelved are wrapped tight in waxed linen from the feet to the crown, and the linen holds most of what the long rot makes, but not all: through nine storeys of slatted shelving, what seeps from the upper shelves finds its way down, a slow, brown, sweetish rain the Wardens call *Loft-weather*. The lower shelves are tarred against it and the aisles are strewn with sawdust that is swept and burned each week. In the heat of Plenty the drip quickens, and the whole of a hall can be heard ticking, faintly, like a clock shop. The Wardens rewrap the oldest shelved every decade, unwinding them on the long tables in the Wrapping Room, and the families are not invited to that, because what is under the linen after a hundred years is not what they remember, and it is still talking.

The labels are the saddest thing. Each shelved body carries a card tied at the throat with its name, its dates, its family and the date of its Setting Aside, and below that a line for *Visited*, where the Wardens mark each feast day that someone came. On the oldest shelves the cards have been rewritten so often that the Wardens have given up on dates and simply ruled the *Visited* line through.

THE SUMP

The deep fen west of Lastgate, where those beyond stitching are sunk in weighted sacks. It is the nearest thing Sallowreach has to a graveyard and the worst place in the north. The water there is black and greasy and smells of drains. **Bubbles rise in patterns:** rings, lines, spirals, sometimes a slow, regular pulse like breathing. Sump-watchers claim the patterns are speech. Sackmen ferry new sacks out at dusk and lower them on ropes, reciting the names. Dredgers, licensed and otherwise, rake the bottom for anything that can be sold: rings, wire, teeth, and, in the last ten years, whole bodies, for reasons the Seamers' Guild does not want to know.

The Sackmen are a hereditary trade, living and Kept, and they keep a strict and joyless decency. Each sack is sewn shut by the family, not by the Sackman. Each carries a name-strip of lead stamped with the name and the date of sinking, so that what is down there may be found again if anyone ever needs to find it. At the drop the Sackman stands in the stern, holds the rope in both hands, and recites the name, the dates and the words *Go under and keep*, and lets the rope pay out until it goes slack, which in the deep Sump can take a long time. Nobody else speaks. What is at the bottom, by the account of the Kept who walk the fen-bed and have gone near it, is a mound: six centuries of sacks heaped one on another, softened together, the ropes rotted into one mat, and the whole of it, very slowly, rising and falling.

Report of Hookman-Sergeant Jessop Crake to the Clerk of the Court of Wrongs, in the matter of Edmund ("Ned") Scurl, dredger, of Grimsey Reach in the Sump. Carving, 640 A.G. Not for the public record.

We took him at his hut on the stilts at Grimsey on information from a Sackman who had seen lights on the water after dusk where no sack had been sunk. We went at fourth bell with eight men and lamps.

The dredging gear was in the punt: grapnel, a long rake, a tar-cutter for the ropes. On the platform were forty-one sacks, opened along the seam, emptied, and stacked to dry like grain-bags. In a basket under the eaves we counted three hundred and nine lead name-strips, cut off, with the names scratched out by a nail. The Sackman says a nameless thing from the Sump cannot be claimed by a family and may be sold as unclaimed stock. That is what he was doing. The parts were in barrels of vinegar under the hut, graded for size, and a ledger in his hand recording buyers by initial only.

That is the part of the report I am required to make. The rest I make because the Clerk should know it before Scurl comes to trial.

There was a woman in the hut. She was sitting at the table. She had been sunk in 488 by her family, a fishwife named Joan Ottery, by her strip, which he had not cut off but had hung on a nail above the bed. He had washed her. He had done it many times, by the look of the skin, which was very clean and very loose. Her hair had been combed and pinned up, and she was dressed in a blue dress of the fashion of three hundred years ago that he must have bought from a rag-woman, and there were two plates on the table and two cups. The bed was made for two. I will not set down what else was in the room. The Seamer we brought asked to be relieved and has since asked the Guild to be shelved.

She could speak a little. She said she had been down a long while and it was quiet. She said he had been kind, in his way, and that he talked to her. Then she asked us to put her back in the water, and she said please, many times, and she held on to Corporal Ames by the sleeve until we promised.

Scurl gave no trouble. He asked only who would feed his cat.

We sank her that night with a new strip and the Sackman said the words. Scurl is in the cells under the Landing. He has asked to be jarred near a window.



The Sump is the only place in the north where nobody asks for anything back. That is why the dredgers are hated more than the Hookmen.

LASTGATE SAYING

DUNMERE HUSH

The first and largest silence. Eight years ago Dunmere was a reed-cutting village of three hundred souls, living and Kept. Now it is the center of a grey disc four miles across that grows a few yards every month. At its edge the reeds go from green-brown to ash-grey in the space of a step. Birds that cross the line fall and lie still. Inside, the village stands as it stood: doors open, washing on the lines, the inhabitants lying where they lay down, unrotted, unmoving, entirely dead. There are no flies. There is no smell. There is no sound at all. Finishers camp at the edge in their hundreds.

THE JAR ROOM

The Court's prison, under the Hall of Hands. One shelf, very long, running the full length of a low brick vault, lined with jars of thick green glass sealed with lead. In each jar is a criminal sentenced to be Kept forever in pieces: head in one, hands in another, the rest rendered or sunk. The heads are aware. The jars are labeled with the name, the crime, and the date of sentence. The oldest is from 304 A.G. On the floor beneath the shelf there are drains.

The jars sweat. The lead seals are tight but the glass is old, and over the centuries every jar has grown a skin of green moisture on the outside, as if the vault were breathing on it. The heads inside float in a thick amber pickle of the Court's own recipe, and their hair drifts upward and turns slowly, like weed in a still pool. The hands are jarred separately, a pair to a jar, on the shelf below, and the hands are the busy ones: they open, close, drum, scratch at the glass with what remains of their nails, and on quiet nights the whole low shelf ticks and taps like a roomful of people waiting to be called. Those who have been jarred for treason are shelved facing the wall. Those jarred for unlicensed Closing have a second label, in red, which reads *Not to be closed under any license*, and those are the ones who weep.

THE HALL OF CLOSINGS

On the Upper Boards, a long, plain, cedar-paneled building with no windows, where licensed Closings are performed. It has a waiting room, a robing room, a ledger room and nine small chambers, each with a narrow bed and a single chair. The building is famously quiet. Buyers wait here in their best clothes for days. Some are turned away at the door because a fee has risen overnight.

Notice framed on the wall of the Waiting Room, Hall of Closings, Upper Boards. Lettered in gilt on black.

CLIENTS ARE REQUESTED: to arrive lacquered and perfumed at their family's expense; to bring no flies into the Hall; to answer to their license number and not their name; to refrain from weeping, praying, singing or hymn-humming in the Waiting Room; and to forgive the Court, which cannot answer questions about the fee.

FAMILIES ARE REQUESTED: to say their farewells before the third bell; to remember that the Closer will not speak; and to remove the body within the hour, there being no grave in Sallowreach, and the Court accepting no responsibility for what is left.

BY ORDER OF THE REGENT. MAY YOU FINISH.

GLOVEHALL

The estate of the Vanes, an hour's punt north of Lastgate: a great house of black timber on a mound in the fen, every window bricked to a slit, every door double. Lady Corrow Vane lives in its east wing. Osric Vane is kept in its west. A new Hush, small, the size of a kitchen garden, appeared in the orchard behind Glovehall last Carving. The gardeners will not go near it. The pears in it are perfect.

BRINEMOSS AND MOTHER GALL'S CELLAR

A hamlet of stilt huts in the south fen, known for pickling. Under the largest hut, dug into the peat and lined with cedar, is Mother Gall's cellar: four hundred oak barrels of brine, each holding a paying customer, each wide awake. The barrels creak and knock gently. When the lids are lifted the faces in the brine are smooth, pale and perfect, and the eyes open.

THE FINISHING POST

Where the border road leaves Sallowreach, nine miles south of Lastgate, a line of tarred stakes marks the boundary. Beyond it, in the grass, there is a long low heap that the Rim Road Company clears twice a year. It is bone and dust and rags: the Kept who crossed. Some were desperate. Some were confused. Some went deliberately, at last, and the Company clerks who rake the heap report that those ones are always found facing home. Kept relatives come to the post on feast days and stand just inside it, looking south.

THE ROOM OF THE LONG ARGUMENT

A rented upper room in the Sinks where, since 212 A.G., two weir-owners named Abel Strake and Cobb Mallory have been disputing the ownership of a fishing weir that rotted away in 260. Neither has a tongue any longer. They argue through the jaw-clicks interpreted

by Fenwick Lisp. A crowd sometimes gathers. People bet on the outcome. There is never an outcome.

THE SMOKING GROUND

A stretch of open fen east of Lastgate where peat fires lit in the Glad Century still burn underground. The ground is warm and spongy and steams from long cracks. Things lost in the fires walk there, black and cracking. The Heirs use it for meetings because no Court agent will go there in good boots.

COLDHARROW

A reed-cutters' village of stilt-houses a day's punt south-east of Dunmere, on the pilgrim channel, where the Finisher processions stop to rest before the last stretch to the Verge. Until 637 it was known for the best thatch-reed in the south fen and a choir. Now it is known for the Coldharrow Carving (see the Finishers, below). Of its two hundred and thirty souls in 636, a hundred and seventy remain. The houses have bells on every door. The living sleep in pairs, by custom, never alone, and the Finishers no longer stop there, at the village's request; their processions pole past in silence with their candles hidden under their cloaks. The villagers stand on the boardwalks and watch them go by, and some of them, everyone has noticed, hum.

GRINHOLM

Three days north by punt and wading-way, a scatter of turf huts on an alder island where the Scraplings live: the families who took what nobody else wanted at the Meal, and above all the face. In the center of the island is a fenced peat pit where the face was boiled for a week in the year 0. Nothing grows in it. Its water is perfectly clear. The Scraplings of Grinholm marry each other, because no one else will marry them, and are proud, poor and suspicious of every visitor, especially Hand-lines and the Cutwrights' College surveyors who have come lately with chains and questions about a girl named Pim Sorrel. The Scraplings say the pit smiles on a still night. Visitors who have looked into it at the Plate's rising do not argue.

THE BRACK MOUND

A low hummock of grass behind the old eel-house at the Landing, fenced with rope, the only grave in Sallowreach and the first. Ysmay Brack is supposed to lie under it. Pilgrims of the Finishers leave grey ribbons on the rope. The Cutwrights have twice dug it and twice found nothing, and the Court has twice had it filled in again and returfed, because a country with one grave cannot admit that it has none.

TRAVELING THE FEN

Sallowreach has one road worth the name, the border road from the Finishing Post to Lastgate, raised on a causeway of piled peat and old bones. Everything else is boardwalk, punt, or wading. A day's travel off the road is a Hard Wayfaring check; failure means a lost hour, a soaked pack and a Dread 1 encounter from the fen (see Horrors of Sallowreach). Living travelers need fly-cloth, vinegar and a hat. Kept travelers need a Seamer within a week.

▼ HISTORY

“Nothing happened in Sallowreach that is over,” the Loft-Wardens still going on.
say. History is not a record of the past here. It is the record of things

YEAR	EVENT
0 A.G. (the waiting)	The Fourth Day: Ysmay Brack is laid in the god's hand. The god does not rise.
0 A.G.	The Meal at the Ferrying. The First Morning: a hanged thief asks to be cut down.
1–100	The Glad Century. No widows, no orphans, no graves. Dancing in the reed-towns.
c. 90	The first generation begins to come apart. The dancing stops.
112	The first Lofts built as a charity for the unstanding.
130	The Stitching Laws. The Seamers' Guild chartered. Public falling-apart made fineable.
131	The Guild rules a column headed <i>Dust</i> in its teaching-ledger. It is still empty.
168	The first jarring of a criminal.
212	The Long Argument begins.
214	The Dead Wages Act: the Kept may be paid half the living rate.
229	Ansel Grue is born.
288	The War of the Heirs. The young win every battle and change nothing.
301	The Licensing. The Hand-lines reveal that their touch can finish, and set a price.
304	The Jar Room built; the oldest jar on its shelf is sealed.
331	The Bait doctrine outlawed in Sallowreach.
341	Ansel Grue becomes Regent.
371	Ansel Grue dies of a fall from a horse, and keeps his seat.
402	The Reckoners' first raid on Sallowreach. The slain lord attends his own inquest.
431	Great-Gran Coombe dies.
459	The Wire Strike. The Court's wire-tax withdrawn in nine days.
512	The Grey Plague. A Fatlands fever kills nobody and Keeps a third of the south fen in a month.
551	Wick Tallow's chandlery opens.
588	The Fallow Closing. Lady Imber Fallow finishes her father; the Court invents domestic license.
611	Grandfather Peat hauled from the Sump.
633	The First Hush. Dunmere goes silent overnight.
636–640	Seventeen more Hushes found, all within a day of a Hand-line estate.

YEAR	EVENT
637–638	The Coldharrow Carving: fifty-nine of the living of one village walk to the edge in a single season.
638	Edda Thrush walks into Dunmere Hush and out again.
639	The Restitution of Hands. Lord Pellam Fallow's hands are given back to the god. The Hushes quicken.
640	The Glovehall Hush. Finishers triple. The Vigil's envoy arrives.
641	Now.

THE GLAD CENTURY AND THE STITCHING LAWS

For a hundred years it looked like a miracle. Mothers who would have died in childbed rose and nursed; fishermen swept off the weirs came home with weed in their hair. There were no widows and no orphans, and the reed-towns danced through the long fen evenings. The songs of that century are the only happy songs in Sallowreach, and nobody sings them now. The dancing stopped when the first generation began to come apart: a man who died in the year 3 was by the year 90 something that could not hold a fiddle. By 130 the state recognized what it was. The Stitching Laws made families responsible for keeping their dead in one piece, chartered the Seamers' Guild, and made it a fineable offence to fall apart in public. The fines are still collected: four lacks for a hand on the boardwalk, twenty for a face.

THE WAR OF THE HEIRS AND THE LICENSING

By 288 no property had changed hands by inheritance in two centuries, and the young rose. The Heirs won every battle, hacked their fathers apart in their own halls, and changed nothing: the fathers were back at their desks within the week, stitched, lacquered and furious, and sent their children to the jar. The Heirs' banner, a hand cut off at the wrist, still hangs in the Sinks. Thirteen years later, in 301, the Hand-lines announced what some of them had known for decades: their touch could finish a person. They did not give it away. The Court set a price and built the Hall of Closings, and made death scarce on purpose.

THE HUSHES

In Carving of 633, a ferryman poling past Dunmere at dawn could not hear the village dogs, or his pole in the water, or himself shouting. Everyone in the village was simply, properly dead. When the news reached Lastgate, half the country wept with envy. Seventeen more Hushes have been found since, some no bigger than a room, every one within a day of a Hand-line estate.

THE GREY PLAGUE

In the hot Plenty of 512 a Fatlands drover brought a fever up the border road. In the south it killed one in ten. In the south fen of

Sallowreach it killed no one, and Kept a third of everyone it touched in a single month: they burned, they sweated, they died in their beds, and they sat up in the morning still burning, still sweating, with the fever going on inside them forever. Brinemoss and the stilt-hamlets around it are still full of the fever-Kept, flushed and shivering under their blankets in the heat, their skin hot to the touch a hundred and twenty-nine years later, their teeth chattering in the dark like a weir-trap knocking. They are the only Kept who are warm. Nobody wants to hold their hands either.

THE RESTITUTION OF 639

By the spring of 639 there were eleven Hushes and the Court had Provost Sedge's first maps, and the Leaden party, which wanted the Course-stricken walled in lead, found itself outvoted by a stranger notion. It came from the Confessors of the Theft, whose whole doctrine is that what the north lives in is a bill for a stolen god. If the Hushes were the god coming back for what was taken, said Confessor Ambrose Weal before the Court in Grace of that year, then what was taken might be given back. The hands had been stolen. Return a pair of hands.

The Court debated it for nine days, which is fast for the Court. It settled on Lord Pellam Fallow, of a lesser Hand-line, forty-four, at the Course, the son of the Lady Imber Fallow who had closed her father in 588; and Pellam, who had grown up in that house and knew what his mother's hands had done, said yes before he was asked twice. The Seamers' Guild was ordered to take the hands. Thessaly Mort refused to do it herself and sent her senior Master of the Seam, who did it in the Hall of Hands at dawn with a bone-saw, before the whole Court. The witnesses agreed on one detail more than any other: the saw blade went cold and grey where it touched the wrist, and the Master had to change blades three times, because each one the hands touched was finished, and would not cut again.

The hands lived. Everything in Sallowreach lives. Severed, they lay on the cedar tray and opened and closed, slowly, nine joints to a finger, and the clerk who carried the tray found his breath smoking and his ears full of silence. They were sealed in a lead box. A procession of the whole Court, with the Confessors singing the Hymn of the Open Hands, carried the box by punt to the edge of Dunmere Hush. At the grey line Lord Pellam, his stumps bound in lint and pitch, opened the box with his teeth, and the Master of the Seam tipped the hands out over the line.

They fell into the grey and lay palm upward in the ash-coloured reeds, about ten feet from the edge, where everyone could see them. They did not move again. The Confessors sang the seventh verse and sat through the eighth in silence, as is the custom, and the procession poled home.

The next month Dunmere Hush grew forty yards, which was twice its rate in any month before. That season two new Hushes opened, one at the Fallow estate at Wending Mound. The Leaden party has not raised the Restitution since and the Confessors do not preach it. Lord Pellam lives at Wending, handless, in a house where the orchard has gone grey. He does not leave his rooms. His stumps, his servants say, have not healed, because nothing heals on the Kept and in the end not much on the living either, and lately there is something at the end of each of them, small, grey and smooth, like the first buds on a branch, with tiny joints in it, that closes when it is touched.

The hands are still where they fell. On a clear evening you can see them from the Verge with a spyglass, open, among the grey reeds, as if waiting to be given something else.

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

Sallowreach is governed by **the Mortuary Court**, a council of the Hand-lines seated in the Hall of Hands, under a Regent, Ansel Grue, who has held the post since 341 A.G. The Court makes law, levies the fly-tax and the stitching-tithe, licenses every Closing, and judges every capital crime, of which there is only one penalty that matters.

Property never passes. Owners never die. The oldest Kept, called **the Unvacated**, hold every title, deed and office in the country. A house built in 150 A.G. belongs to the man who built it. A seat on a guild council is held by whoever first sat in it. A living man of seventy is legally a minor if his father is still upright, and cannot sign a lease, marry without consent, or vote in a guild. The living are tenants, clerks, apprentices and servants of the dead, and will be until they join them.

Death is the only currency of power. A Closing costs more than a house. The Court grants Closings as rewards (to loyal officers, to the parents of useful men), withholds them as punishment, and sells them by license to those who can pay. The Court's worst sentence is the opposite of death: to be **jarred**, Kept forever in pieces in the Jar Room. Lesser crimes are punished by fines, by flogging (it heals badly on the Kept and never closes), by *unstitching* (the removal of the Seamers' work, a public humiliation), and by **refusal**, the striking of a name from the Court's Closing ledger forever.

Courts in Sallowreach hear cases between parties who were wronged three hundred years ago and are still present to give evidence. Statutes of limitation do not exist. Murder, as a crime, is

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We thought it wanted its hands back. It never wanted anything. It was only coming home, and we went out to meet it with a present, like children.

CONFESSOR AMBROSE WEAL, IN A LETTER TO THE
SHUT HOUSE OF THE LANDING, NEVER SENT

USING THE RESTITUTION

The Restitution is the north's present-day worthless sacrifice, and Lord Pellam Fallow is its living monument (see New Faces). Learning that the Restitution quickened the Hushes, rather than merely failing, is a Dread 5 revelation for anyone who took part, and Dread 3 for anyone who believed in it. A PC Confessor, a PC of the Court, or a PC who was paid to row the box, should carry it: it is the kind of knowledge that does not get smaller. The hands can be reached. They lie ten feet inside the line. What a living PC would have to give to fetch them is the whole price.

hard to define: the Stitching Laws class it as *grievous unmaking* and punish it by the cost of repair. The only true murder in Sallowreach is an unlicensed Closing, and it is punished with the jar.

A death-license of the Mortuary Court, as issued. Printed on vellum, black and grey, with blanks filled in a clerk's hand. The Regent's signature takes him one minute.

THE MORTUARY COURT OF SALLOWREACH, sitting in the Hall of Hands, by authority of the Licensing of 301 and in the name of the Hand that Closes:

LICENSE No. 18,422. Issued this NINTH day of CARVING, 641 A.G.

TO THE BEARER, being MARGERY ANN TULL, of EIGHTH, TANNER'S BOARDS, Kept since THE YEAR 506, in her ONE HUNDRED AND THIRTY-FIFTH year of Keeping:

ONE CLOSING, by a Closer of the Court, at the Hall of Closings, upon the bearer's own body and no other, the bearer consenting thrice before witness.

FEE PAID: FOUR THOUSAND THREE HUNDRED LACKS, in platters and minutes, by THE SALE OF A WEIR-SHARE AND THE PLEDGE OF A GRANDSON'S WAGES TO 660. License-levy paid: FOUR HUNDRED AND THIRTY LACKS.

THIS LICENSE is not transferable, save by order of the Court; is void if the bearer is found falling apart in public before the date of Closing; is void if the bearer is closed by any other means, whereupon no fee is returned; and may be revoked at the Court's pleasure, whereupon no fee is returned.

WAITING LIST: CHAMBER SIX, LADY C. VANE presiding. Estimated date: GRACE, 644.

Signed, Ansel Grue, Regent. Sealed, the Left Hand.

EXAMPLE – THE CASE OF THE THIRTY-YEAR DEBT

A cooper named Wenna Hale borrowed sixty lacks from a moneylender in 589 to pay for her mother's restitching. She died in a boating accident in 602, came back, and kept working. In 640 the moneylender, who died in 410, sued her for the debt and thirty-eight years' interest. The court ruled that a dead debtor is the same person as a living one. Wenna's Kept mother, who lives with her, testified that the money had been well spent. Wenna now works for the moneylender, unpaid, until 731.

THE ONLY INHERITANCE

There is one family in Sallowreach in which property passes, and everyone knows which, and nobody says why.

The Hand-lines inherit. Not often, and never in public, but over six centuries the great houses of Grue, Vane, Sedge and Hethe, and the dozen lesser lines, have each seen their seats pass from parent to child perhaps four or five times, while in the rest of the country nothing has passed at all. The Court calls these occasions *retirements*. A Hand-line lord or lady, Kept a century or so, grows tired of the seat, retires to a wing of the estate, and is not seen again; and the heir, who is always at the Course, takes the seat; and the household, for a week afterward, wears grey ribbons and speaks quietly; and the wing is shut up and its windows bricked.

It was put into law in 588. Lady Imber Fallow, then thirty, at the Course, went up to her father's rooms at Wending Mound in the evening with a basin of warm water and a towel, as she had every evening for twenty years since he had lost the use of his arms; and

Lord Odo Fallow, Kept since 471, Unvacated master of Wending and eleven weirs, was found the next morning in his bath, finished, the water cold and grey, his face sunk and peaceful and smelling of nothing at all. Imber said only that he had asked her. There was no license. No one else had been in the room. By the law of 301 it was unlicensed Closing and the sentence was the jar.

The Court sat on it for a year. Then Regent Grue, in a ruling of nine lines that is still read aloud in every Hand-line nursery, held that a Closing performed *within the line, upon a member of the line, by one of the line's own hands* was a private matter of the house, *licensed by blood*, and not a matter for the Court at all. The doctrine is called **domestic license**. It applies only to the Hand-lines, because only the Hand-lines have hands. Since 588 forty-three Hand-line heads have retired. Every one of them was succeeded by a child or a niece at the Course. Not one of the forty-three is recorded as having asked a Closer of the Court.

Imber Fallow sat in her father's chair for fifty years, raised her son Pellam in the house where she had done it, and was herself retired in 638, at Pellam's hands, a year before the Court took them off him. The Heirs' broadsheet printed the whole case in 640 under the headline *THEY DO IT TOO*. That issue sold more copies than any other, and the Court jarred the printer's tongue.



In other families the eldest son waits. In ours, he practises.

ATTRIBUTED TO LORD ODO FALLOW, KEPT, IN 560,
AT HIS OWN TABLE, AS A JOKE

KIN-SLAYING AT THE TABLE

A Hand-line PC who uses the Closing Touch on their own Kept parent or grandparent commits the only murder the Court will not punish, and the oldest sin in the north. It is a Dread 4 act for the one who does it (kin-slaying by your own hand), whatever the parent asked. The PC inherits whatever the parent held: a seat, a house, a weir, a debt, a feud three hundred years long, and a household that will never again speak above a murmur in their presence. The heir's own children begin, from that day, to watch their parent's hands.

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

Keeping. Families are responsible for their dead. Six or seven generations share a house: the living on the ground floor and in the kitchen, the Kept upstairs in the cool rooms with the shutters closed. Grandmothers are restitched each spring in Restitching Week. Kept relatives sit at table, mind the children, mend nets, complain. The quarrel over whose turn it is to keep great-great-grandfather is the standard subject of comedy; the play *Uncle on the*

Stair, in which three brothers try to lose the old man in Lastgate and he keeps coming back, has run since 340.

A Kept attic has its own climate. The shutters are kept closed for the flies and the stairs are kept closed for the smell, and so the cool rooms at the top of a Lastgate house are dim, still and sweet, hung with drying lavender and fly-paper black with catch, and furnished with the chairs of the dead: high-backed, deep-seated, upholstered

in oilcloth that wipes clean. The floorboards under each chair are stained dark in a ring. Under the window there is always a basin of vinegar and a stack of clean cloths, and in a drawer the family keeps the parts that have come away and have not yet been sewn back, each in its labeled twist of paper, *Gran's ear*, *Plenty 639*, so that nothing of anyone is lost.

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Three generations to a bed, four to a chair, nine to a stair, and Gran on the landing, telling you to mind your step.

WEIR ROW HOUSEKEEPING CHANT

Smell. Everyone carries perfume, vinegar or smoke. Scent is class. The rich smell of cedar, myrrh and ambergris, burned in braziers at their doors and soaked into their clothes. The middling smell of lavender and vinegar. The poor smell of peat smoke, and when they cannot afford it, of themselves. A pomander is a gift for a betrothal. Sniffing in company is extremely rude.

Dress. High collars, long sleeves, gloves and veils, to cover seams. Linen is preferred because it can be boiled; wool takes the smell and keeps it. The Kept favor wrapping: strips of waxed linen, wound tight, which hold things in. The Hand-lines wear mittens at the Appetite and gloves after, black kid sewn at the wrists. Never offer to shake a Sallowreacher's hand.

Food. The living eat eel (lively), reed-bread, fen-mushroom, pickled everything, and imported Fatlands meat at feasts. Vinegar is in every dish. Stilled meat, closed by a licensed butcher, is a luxury. A dish of lively eel is eaten quickly, with a strong jaw, and washed down with *sour*, a peat-smoked beer. The Kept do not need to eat. Many still sit at table and chew, for company, and spit into a dish.

Lively Eel in Sour, the Weir Row way. As written in the receipt-book of the Mallory house, in four hands across two hundred years.

Take your eels from the trap and do not wash them, it only makes them lively. Have the pot boiling hard with sour and vinegar and a fist of dill. Take each eel behind the head with a rag and cut it in four with the big knife, quick, on the block, and put the pieces in the pot straight off, before they find each other. Lid down and a stone on the lid. They knock about a while. (In Gran's hand:) They always knock. Never mind it.

Boil the length of a hymn. Lift the lid and if a piece has climbed up the side put it back with the spoon. Serve hot on reed-bread with a pickle. Eat it fast and with your back teeth and do not talk while you chew, it gives them a chance.

(In a later hand:) If it is still going in the belly after an hour, drink a cup of sour standing up and walk about. It settles. Do

not lie down.

(In the latest hand, Teal's:) Mam says don't give it to visitors. I say let them learn.

Marriage. Vows in Sallowreach end with *until finished*, which once meant something. Widowhood does not exist. A spouse who died is still a spouse, and remarriage is bigamy. Many marriages carry on between the living and the Kept, and what passes between them behind the shutters is a matter the Court does not regulate and no one discusses; the word for it is *coldbed*, and it is said only by the rude. A living person may petition for a *setting-apart*, which is not a divorce but a court order permitting them to live in another house from their Kept spouse. It requires the spouse's consent. Henna Farrow has filed forty-one times.

Children. Living children grow up surrounded by the dead and are fearless about it. They are trained young to hold a lamp for a Seamer, to tie a wrap, and never to stare. Children who die stay the age they died, forever. The Smalls, the child-dead of the Drowned Storeys, have their own society and their own queen. The living do not speak of them at dinner.

A counting game of the Weir Row children, played on the boardwalks with a pebble and a chalk ladder of nine rungs. The one who is "it" hops the rungs while the others chant; whoever lands on the ninth has to touch the eyes of the next child and say "shut." There is no tenth rung.

One for the eel and two for the pot,

Three for the stitches and four for the rot,

Five on the shelf and six in the sack,

Seven in the Sump and they never come back,

Eight at the table, and who's in the chair?

Nine, close your eyes, love, nobody's there.

The children of Lastgate also play *Closer*, in which one child wears their mother's mittens and the others line up to be "finished" with a tap on the forehead and lie down in the road very still, and the winner is the one who can lie still the longest while the others tickle. Parents on the Upper Boards forbid it. Parents in the Sinks do not, and the Heirs say the Sinks children are better at it.

Setting Aside. When someone is too far gone to stand, they are wrapped, labeled and shelved in the Lofts, still aware. This is the nearest thing to a funeral. The family gathers and the wrapper winds the linen from the feet up, and the family speaks to the face until it is covered. Families visit on feast days and read aloud: letters, news, the old one's favorite books. Many do not visit. The Wardens read to those.

Proverbs. *May you finish* is the polite greeting. *Long life* is the worst curse. *Mind your stitches* means be careful. *He'll keep* means a problem can wait forever. *Fresh as a Glad Century fiddler* means hopelessly out of date. *The Court has hands* means you cannot escape it. *Close the book* means end an argument by force.

Oaths on the dead. Sallowreachers swear by their dead in the literal sense. The strongest oath is sworn with the right hand placed inside the mouth of a Kept parent, who must consent and must be able to bite. To break such an oath is to invite the parent to close their jaw, and the oldest jaws in Lastgate are wired shut until a promise falls due. Debts sworn this way are the only ones the moneylenders trust.

The jaw-oath has teeth in the most literal sense, and the Court of Wrongs keeps a box of the evidence. When Hamo Rudd of Tanner's Boards swore in 597 on his Kept mother's jaw to pay a debt by Carving and did not, his mother, who loved him, closed her mouth in the Court before witnesses as the law required, slowly, with her eyes on his, and he did not take his hand out until the bone gave. She wept afterward, they say, for nine years. She keeps the two fingers in her shut-niche, beside his milk-teeth. That is what an oath on the dead is in the north: not a curse sent from somewhere else but a mother's mouth, and she is obliged to use it, and she does.

Blasphemy, in a country that ate its god, is a matter of where you put your hands. To clasp them open on your knees, as Ossel sat in the carvings, is the gravest insult a Sallowreacher can offer, and drunk Heirs do it in the doorways of Hand-line houses to start fights. To shut someone's eyes who is not asleep is a mortal offence. To *finish a song* that was not written to be finished, by inventing a last verse to one of the old fen-songs, is the commonest blasphemy of the young, and the Finishers have made a liturgy of it.



Never close the book on someone else's finger.

LASTGATE PROVERB, MEANING: DO NOT TAKE A
DEATH THAT WAS NOT YOURS TO TAKE

Crime. Theft, fraud and debt are common. Violence is cheap but pointless, since it kills nobody; Sallowreach's criminals specialize in leverage. The worst crimes are part-theft (see Marrow Jack), unlicensed Closing, and *stilling*, the illegal sale of closed meat.

Tablenight. On the longest night of Lack, the living cook a banquet for their dead, who cannot taste it, and everyone pretends. The table is laid with the best plates. The Kept are dressed, lacquered and seated. The living serve. Everyone eats, the living swallowing and the Kept chewing and spitting. Speeches are made praising the food. At midnight the eldest present says "May we all finish," and the room drinks. In the old houses of the Upper Boards one chair at the end of the table is always left empty, and nobody can say for whom. When asked, the Unvacated say only that it was always so, and that it would be rude to sit there.

Bill of fare for Tablenight, as chalked in the kitchen of a modest Needle Street household, 640 A.G.

TO BEGIN — Grace said by the eldest upright (Great-Grandfather, if his jaw holds). Lack keep away.

FIRST — Eel in jelly, stilled (the one luxury; 3 lacks from the Hethe butcher). Served to the living. Served also to the Kept, who will chew it for company.

SECOND — Pie of Fatlands mutton and fen-mushroom, with a crust made to look like a closed eye.

THIRD — The Dish for the Dead: a whole loaf of reed-bread, broken by the youngest child and laid at every Kept place, which no one eats, and which is carried to the Lofts in the morning for the shelved.

FOURTH — Undying cheese, from the Brinemoss decade-wheel opened at Gran's Setting Aside, still ripening.

SWEET — Burnt honey cakes. The Kept to be helped to spit into the blue dish, not the good one.

AT MIDNIGHT — May we all finish. The chair at the end to be laid with a plate, the way they do it on the Upper Boards, because Gran insists; and no one to sit there; and no one to ask.

THE CLOSING

The only good death in Sallowreach is bought. A licensed Closing follows a rite fixed by the Court in 301 and never altered.

From A Fair Copy of the Proceedings at the Hall of Closings, prepared for the family of Mr. Josiah Rook, deceased 517 A.G., closed 641 A.G. Witnessed by Bram Hollin, mourner.

At the third bell the Closer's clerk called the name. Mr. Rook was carried into Chamber Four on his board by his two great-grandsons, who are sixty and fifty-eight. He had dressed for it. He had been dead one hundred and twenty-four years and the Guild had done its best for him that morning, but the lacquer was fresh and still soft and under it he was mostly brown and black, and the smell in a small cedar room was very great. The great-grandsons breathed through their mouths. Mr. Rook said, "Do not make faces, boys, it is my day."

The clerk read the license aloud: the number, the fee paid (four thousand two hundred lacks, in platters, by the sale of the house on Tanner's Boards), the Regent's signature, the date. Mr. Rook was asked three times if he wished to finish. He said yes three times, the third time very loudly.

Then the family said what they had to say. The younger great-grandson read out a letter from Mr. Rook's wife, who is

shelved in the Loftis and could not come, saying she would see him soon, which everyone understood was not true. Mr. Rook asked for the letter to be put in his hand. His fingers would not close on it. I closed them for him, and he thanked me.

Lady Corrow Vane came in last. She did not speak. She is tall and very still and smells of nothing at all, which in that room was the most frightening thing. Her gloves are black and sewn on at the wrist. Her clerk unpicked the stitches of the right glove, nine of them, and drew it off, and we saw her hand.

I have been asked to describe it for the family record and I will try. It was grey, as they say, a cold slate grey, and very long. The fingers had too many joints and moved one at a time, like a creature testing a branch. The room got colder. My breath showed. The flies on the window, which had been ticking all morning, stopped.

Mr. Rook was crying. He said, "Is it going to hurt?" Lady Vane did not answer. I said the words of the old rite, which I had from my mother: *Hand that closes, close this. What was opened, shut. What was begun, end.* Lady Vane laid her hand over his eyes.

It did not take long. There was a sound like a breath going out of a room, though he had not breathed in a century. He went

still, and then he went on going still, past any stillness I have seen, and the long rot caught up with him all at once. His face sank. The lacquer cracked. The smell came up out of him in one great wave, all of the hundred and twenty-four years of it, and the younger boy fell to his knees and was sick, and then, all at once, it was gone. There was no smell. There was only a man on a board, properly dead, and grey dust settling in the folds of his good coat.

The great-grandsons sat with him for a long while. Lady Vane's clerk stitched the glove back on. She did not look at the body. She looked at the floor, and then she went out to Chamber Five, where the next license was waiting.

THE CLOSING IN PLAY

A Closing requires a licensed Closer at the Course or beyond, the subject's consent (the Court is strict on this, at least in public), and the license. A PC Hand-line at the Course can perform one with a Routine Hand + Rites roll; the Closer gains 1 Hunger. Witnessing a Closing is Dread 2. Performing one without a license is the crime of unlicensed Closing, punished by the jar, and every Heir and every grandmother in the country knows the PC can do it.

▼ FACTIONS

THE MORTUARY COURT

The Hand-lines nobility: Grue, Vane, Sedge, Hethe and a dozen lesser houses. Sellers of death, hoarders of it, and increasingly afraid of their own hands. The Court believes in order: that a country of the undying must be governed by the oldest, that death is too

precious to give away, and that the Hand-lines were chosen by the god to ration its mercy. What it wants now is to survive its own success. It knows the Hushes follow its blood. Its factions are split between those who would wall up the Course-stricken in lead (the Leaden party), those who would sell the Hushes as estates (the Quiet Market), and a very few who suspect that being closed like a book might be the god's kindness to the land.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Glovebearer	A clerk's post; carries a Closer's gloves; access to the Hall of Closings
2	Licenser	Drafts and seals licenses; may bend a waiting list by one name a season
3	Closer	Performs Closings; a salary of 40 lacks a day and a house on the Upper Boards
4	Hand of the Court	A seat on the Court; may grant one Closing a year without fee
5	Left or Right Hand	Commands the Closers or the Court's agents; answers only to the Regent

Joining: Hand-line blood is required beyond the second rank. Outsiders serve as Glovebearers, agents, spies and enforcers. **Enemies:** the Heirs, the Finishers, Reckoners. **Allies:** the Unvacated; uneasily, the Seamers' Guild.



The Court has hands.

THE COMMONEST SAYING IN SALLOWREACH,
MEANING THAT THERE IS NO ESCAPING IT; SAID
WITH A GLANCE AT ONE'S OWN

THE PROVING OF HANDS

The Court licenses every Closing in Sallowreach but one kind, and that kind it does not record. When a Hand-line heir reaches the Course, the house must know that the hand works, and the hand must be taught. This is done in the family chapel at dusk, in a rite older than the Licensing, and the Hand-lines call it the Proving.

A living person is needed: a whole one, unready, with a pulse. Never a servant of the house, because servants talk, and never one of the line. The house's steward buys a wage-pledge from the debt-rolls of the Sinks, where there is always a laborer or a spinster whose wages are owed to an Unvacated landlord until some year in the next century, and the house pays off the debt, and the debtor is told they have been taken into service. They are brought to the estate by punt. They are washed and dressed in grey linen and given the best supper of their lives, and the household is kind to them all that day, very kind, the way you are kind to the beast before a feast. At dusk they are seated in the single chair in the chapel. The household stands along the walls and sings the first six verses of the Ferrying Song. The heir's gloves are unpicked.

The first touch is laid flat on the breastbone, and it takes the living person as Ossel took the fen's dying for a thousand years, gently: the heart stops, the breath goes out, the head drops. Then the household waits, in silence, as long as it takes, usually less than an hour, for what everyone in Sallowreach waits for: the Proof opens its eyes again, Kept, and sees where it is, and understands. The second touch is laid over those eyes. That one finishes. Two deaths in one hour, the Hand-lines say, one to teach the hand to take and one to teach it to end; and the heir who can do the second with the Proof's eyes open and pleading is judged ready to sit at the Court.

From the household book of Wending Mound, seat of the Fallows; the steward's entries for Carving, 621 A.G. Recovered by the Heirs in 640 and printed in The Bequest.

To the Sinks debt-roll, for the wage-pledge of one Ebba Corn, spinster, 31, living, owing to 702: 220 lacks.

Punt-hire, two men, there and back: 4 lacks.

Grey linen, a shift and a wrap: 4 lacks. Bath, lye, rosemary: 1 lack.

Supper for the Proof: stilled eel, white bread, a pear from the orchard, a cup of Fatlands red. She asked if she might keep the pear for the morning. Told yes. 6 lacks.

Candles for the chapel, nine (Tallow, the steady kind, so they will not gutter at the wrong moment): 5 lacks 4 crumbs.

To the Licenser, for the record not kept: 400 lacks.

To the Sackman, one sack, no strip, no words: 3 lacks.

Lye and sand for the chapel floor, and a new cushion for the chair.

Note in the Lady's hand: Master Pellam was sick after. This is as it should be. He did the second very well.

The Court, which knows, has never forbidden it. The Licensers keep a quiet tariff. The sacks go into the Sump without names, and the Sackmen who drop them are paid not to say the words. There are, by the Heirs' reckoning, some five hundred Proofs under the black water since the Licensing, and not one of them has a strip. Ebba Corn is the only one whose name anyone knows. The Heirs have painted it on the Ferrying Post.

THE HOLLOWE TREE

Every Hand-line keeps its Cut strong by marrying within the Hand-lines; that much is public, and the genealogies on the walls of the Hall of Hands are a thicket of Grue-Vanes and Sedge-Hethes. One line keeps it stronger. The Hollowe-Vanes of Hollowe Mound, a cadet line of the Vanes three hours north of Glovehall, have married no one but Hollowe-Vanes since the Licensing. The Vanes count the night the eldest Vane boy spent with his hand held in the god's hand as a kind of wedding, and say so at their weddings; the Hollowes say that the line has been married to the hand ever since, and that it would be a kind of faithlessness to marry out. Provost Sedge's ledgers record the Hollowe family tree on a single page, because it does not branch. It folds.

The house keeps a nursery wing with no windows. Its children are said to be born quiet, not crying, with fingertips already grey, at the Taste in the cradle. More than one Hollowe nurse has left service and gone to the Sinks and would not say why, except that the household was very close, and that in a house where everyone is cousin, aunt, brother and husband to everyone else at once, nobody can be sure which word to use at table, and nobody tries. There are three Hushes within a day of Hollowe Mound, the densest cluster in the north. The young cousin Lord Casimir Hollowe-Vane, who wrote to Osric Vane every month for years, ran south across the Finishing Post in 638 and has not been heard of since. In the Sinks they say he ran to marry somebody, anybody, else.

THE SEAMERS' GUILD

Stitchers, embalmers, lacquerers and wire-workers who hold the population together. Every Kept body in Sallowreach owes its shape to the Guild, and every family owes it money. The Guild believes in craft and in continuance: that a well-kept body is a dignity and a duty. What it wants is pay, respect, and to be left alone. A Seamers' strike would be a national collapse within a month, and the Guild has threatened one only once, in 459, when the Court tried to tax wire. The tax was withdrawn in nine days, by which time the Sinks were knee-deep in what had fallen off people.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Threader	Apprenticeship; a needle-case; board and a cot on Needle Street
2	Journeyman	Licensed to restitch; a client list of thirty families
3	Seamer	Wire-work and lacquer; may take apprentices; Stitching training
4	Master of the Seam	A shop of one's own; Guild vote; access to the Guild's stock of spare parts
5	Master Seamer	Head of the Guild; may call a strike

Joining: any PC with Stitching 1 can be taken on as a Threader. **Enemies:** Marrow Jack and the back-alley seamers. **Allies:** everyone, by necessity.

In Restitching Week, at the start of Grace, Needle Street does not sleep for nine days. The queue of the Kept runs down the canal-side boards and over two bridges: grandmothers on boards carried by grandsons, fishermen holding their own forearms like parcels, Smalls led by the hand by their living great-nieces. The smell is the worst of the year, because everything that rotted through the damp of Lack is opened at once, and the Guild burns cedar in braziers every ten yards and the smoke lies on the canal like a second fog. The bellows hiss. The wire-cutters click. The Threaders run between the shops with buckets of what has been cut out, black, for the burning-berge, and every so often someone in the queue laughs, because it is the one week of the year that the dead are made to look like themselves again, and the families come out in their best and walk them home lacquered and shining, like brides.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Minor	Membership; a cut-hand token; a safehouse bed in the Sinks
2	Pamphleteer	Access to the presses and the Smoking Ground meetings
3	Bequeather	Command of a cell of twelve; access to the cell's weapons and punts
4	Executor	A seat at Jory Welt's table; knowledge of the Hush map
5	The Boy	Leader of the Heirs (held by Jory Welt)

Joining: be living and disinherited, or help with something that cannot be undone. **Enemies:** the Court, the Unvacated. **Allies:** the Finishers, sometimes; the Purgation, dangerously.

Notice posted by the Court's Hookmen on the Landing, the Sinks bridges and the Smoking Ground boardwalk. Most copies are torn down within the hour; the rest have the Heirs' cut hand painted over them.

BY ORDER OF THE MORTUARY COURT. WANTED, for GRIEVOUS UNMAKING and UNLICENSED CLOSING BY HUSH, contrary to the Licensing of 301 and the Ruling on Hushes of 634:

PERSONS UNKNOWN, being living Minors of the Sinks and Tanner's Boards, who on or about the night of the 4th of Carving last DID bind, sack and carry by punt one Alderman



Brown is still hers. Black is the god's. And the money is ours.

SEAMERS' RHYME, THE LAST LINE ADDED BY JOURNEYMEN, NOT TO BE SAID BEFORE A MASTER

THE HEIRS

The living young, permanently disinherited: everyone in Sallowreach under three hundred who still has a pulse and a parent. Most Heirs are clerks, servants and laborers in their forties and fifties who have never owned a pot. Some want reform: inheritance at the Setting Aside, votes for the living, a cap on Unvacated office. Some want every Unvacated elder dragged to a Hush. Since the Hushes appeared, for the first time in six centuries, the second group has had a method, and the first has had trouble arguing with them.

TOBIAS WREN, Unvacated, aged 340, owner of nineteen houses, to the verge of the HUSH at COLDMERE, and DID drag him across it.

The Alderman's household offers TWO HUNDRED LACKS for names. The Court offers a MINUTE OF CLOSING, to be redeemed by the informant at a date of the Court's choosing.

The Alderman's chair, house and rents are held in trust by the Court until the matter is resolved. No heir of the Alderman will be recognized.

Statement of Corlis Mead, aged fifty-three, given to the Court's examiners in the matter of the late Alderman Hollis Mead. Taken down by a clerk.

He was my father and he was three hundred and two. He was a good alderman. He never once let me sign for anything. I was fifty-three and I still asked him for my wages every Plenty-day and he gave me eight lacks and told me to make them last.

We did it at night. My brother Tobin and my sister and me. We had the punt ready. We had the sack. We didn't hurt him more than we had to. You can't hurt them, you know, not in a way that stops anything. That's the thing. My great-grandfather tried to kill him in the War of the Heirs, with a halberd, in the year 288. Took his head clean off. Father had it sewn on and sat in the same chair the next week and sent great-grandfather to the jar. He's still in there. Third shelf from the door.

So we didn't try to kill him. We tied him. He said, Corlis, what is this. He said, I am your father. I said I knew. He said, I will forgive you if you untie me now, and he said it the way he always said it, the way he said it when I was six. And I nearly did.

It took four hours to pole to the edge of the Dunmere Hush. He talked the whole way. He said he had loved our mother. He said he was sorry about the house. He offered me the house. He offered me the boat. Then he stopped offering and started screaming, but there's a way the Breath takes a scream on open water, it just sort of soaks it up.

At the edge the reeds go grey. You can see the line. The birds go over it and drop. We pulled him out of the punt and he was fighting and he got his teeth into Tobin's arm, and Tobin was crying, and we dragged him the last ten yards on his back through the reeds. When his head went over the line he went quiet. Not quiet like stopped talking. Quiet like there had never been any sound in him. His mouth was still open. And

then the rest of him came across and he just went soft and settled into the reeds like a coat dropped on a chair.

He looked peaceful. I want that written down. He looked like he had never been angry with anybody.

We stood there a long time. My sister said, We should say something. And none of us could think of anything, because none of us had ever been to a funeral. Nobody had, not for six hundred years.

Then I went home and sat in his chair. It's my chair now. I'm the eldest. You can jar me if you like. I'll keep.

THE FINISHERS

A death cult in the plainest sense, and the fastest-growing faith in the north. The Finishers believe that the Hushes are Ossel's mercy returning, that the god never wanted to be eaten and is calling its people home, and that to walk into a Hush is to be closed by the god's own hand instead of a Court official's. They make pilgrimage to the Hushes in long, singing processions, mostly of the Kept, carrying candles and the names of the dead, and they walk in. The Court calls it theft of a licensed good and has posted guards at the larger Hushes. The guards are Kept, and some of them have walked in too.

The Finishers' songs have last verses, which in Sallowreach is a revolutionary act. They are sung at the edge of the grey reeds, and the singers go over the line one by one, and the song gets thinner and thinner as it goes, until there is no one left outside to finish it. Those who remain behind are the worst of it: the living children of Kept parents who went in, the husbands who held their wives' hands to the edge and could not follow, because the living who enter a Hush die too, and do not come back, and the Finishers do not want them yet. The Court records the number of pilgrims. Nobody records the number of people who stood at the edge and watched someone they loved go quiet.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Walker	A candle and a pilgrim's name-strip; the Finishers' hospitality
2	Singer	Leads a procession's song; knows the routes past the Court's guards
3	Lamp	Leads a pilgrimage; may bless; knows the secret Hushes
4	Shut Eye	A voice in the cult's councils; is told where new Hushes form
5	High Shut Eye	High priest (held by Sister Lorn)

Joining: carry a candle and a name to the edge, and come back.

Enemies: the Court, the Seamers' Guild (who lose customers).

Allies: the Loft-Wardens, quietly; the Heirs, by convenience.

WHAT THE EDGE TAKES: THE COLDHARROW CARVING

The Court's figures say that fifty-nine of the living of Coldharrow walked into Dunmere Hush between Carving 637 and the end of Lack 638. The Court's figures are correct. They are a list of names, a list of dates and a bill. This is what they do not record.

Petition of Agathe Rusk, living, aged sixty-one, of Coldharrow, to the Clerk of Fees of the Mortuary Court, contesting a bill of eight hundred lacks for “two deaths not paid for.” Written for her by the Coldharrow schoolmaster.

Sir, I have your bill and I will pay it. I write only to tell you who it is for, because the bill says Rusk, W. and Rusk, B., and they had names.

My husband's mother went first. Old Mam Rusk, Kept since 519. She had been at the Settling a hundred years and she hurt every day of them, and when the Finishers came through with their candles in the Carving she put on her good shawl and went with them, and I helped her down the ladder into the punt. I am not sorry for that. I would do it again. She kissed me on the forehead and her lips were cold and she said, “You’ve been a good girl to me, Aggie.” I had not been. She said it anyway.

My son Wendel went after her to bring her back. He was thirty-four. He was always the one who went after things. He got to the Verge the next night and she had gone over already, and he stood at the grey line, they told me, from dusk until the morning, and then he came home.

He came home quiet. That is the only word for it. He did his work. He cut reed. He ate what I put in front of him. But he hummed, sir, all the day, under his breath, the same tune, and when I asked him what it was he did not know he had been doing it. It was the last verse of the Finishers’ song, the one that is not written down. I know that now. I did not know it then.

Nine days after, he was gone in the night. His boots were by the door, side by side, the toes pointed south-east, toward Dunmere. He had not taken them. He had cleaned them first.

After Wendel it was Hobb Lister’s girl, who had been sweet on him. Then old Lister. Then the Coopers’ two. By Lack there was humming in every house in Coldharrow. People did not know they did it. You would be pulling reed with a neighbour and she would be humming it and you would find that you were humming it with her, and then the both of you would stop and not look at each other. People started to say they could hear their dead out there in the quiet, waiting, and that it was very kind, the quiet. Children drew grey lines in the hearth-ash. Men left their boots by the door at night pointed south-east, and in the morning they did not remember doing it, and their wives turned the boots round, and the next night they were pointed south-east again.

We tried. You should know that we tried. We put bells on the doors. We slept in pairs. I tied my daughter Bryony’s wrist to

mine with a ribbon every night, the blue one from her christening, and she let me, and she said, “I’m not going anywhere, Mam,” and she meant it. She was twenty-nine. She was the cleverest of us.

On the first night of the Shutter Days I fell asleep. I had not slept properly for forty nights. When I woke the ribbon was untied and folded on the pillow, very neat. I went to the Verge. I asked every Lamp and Singer at the edge. Nobody had seen her. Her name was on no strip. But I stood at the line, sir, where the grey starts, and I could feel it, how kind it was, the quiet, and how it would not hurt. I understood her. I want the Court to know that I understood her completely.

I did not go over. Someone has to pay the bill.

I will pay it. I ask only that the Court write their names on the receipt, the whole names, Wendel Amos Rusk and Bryony Agathe Rusk, because nobody else has written them anywhere.

(Endorsed by the Clerk: Fee confirmed. Names noted. Receipt to be issued as requested. No further action.)

Coldharrow is the worst of it, but it is not alone. Wherever the Finishers pass, or a Hush grows near enough to hear its silence, the same thing begins among the living: the humming first, then the boots by the door, then the talk of how kind it is, then one, and then more, and always those who had already lost someone to the edge. The Kept walk in because they have suffered too long. The living go because grief has made the quiet sound like home. The Finishers say they do not want the living yet and turn them back where they can. They cannot always tell, in the dark at the edge, who is breathing.

RUNNING THE CONTAGION

Treat the Verge-hum as madness spreading by the god’s influence, and treat it with care. A PC who spends a season within a day of a Hush, or who stands at the edge while someone they love walks in, makes a Dread 3 check; on failure, beyond the Fray, they find the hum in their mouth. A PC who Breaks within sight of a Hush should take **The Pull** as their Derangement, and those who witness that Break make the usual Dread 2 check to share it. Never stage the walking-in of a living character as a scene to be watched; cut to the morning, to the boots, to the ribbon on the pillow, to the bill. The horror of Coldharrow belongs to Agathe Rusk. Let the players meet her, and let her offer them tea, and let them hear her not humming.

HANDLING THE FINISHERS

The Finishers are a portrait of despair in a land that has no exit, and the pull of a god that offers one. Play them as tragedy. Their pilgrims are tired, frightened, often kind, and they have been suffering for longer than any human being was meant to. The horror is not the walking in; it is what it says about a country that this is the only door, and who it leaves behind. Never present a pilgrimage as triumphant or a Hush as an attractive solution for the living. Focus scenes on the people at the edge.

THE LOFT-WARDENS

Keepers of the Set-Aside: quiet, underpaid, and in possession of forty thousand witnesses who hear everything. The shelved Kept cannot move but can listen, and the Lofts are built against the walls of Lastgate's oldest streets. Every conversation in nine storeys of the north city is overheard by somebody wrapped on a shelf, and the Wardens read to the shelved every night and write down what they whisper back. The Wardens believe in attendance: that no one should be left alone in the dark. What they want is pay, more linen, and for the families to visit. What they have, without much wanting it, is the best intelligence service on the Table.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Ladder-hand	A lamp, a key to one hall, and a list of the shelved to read to
2	Reader	Access to the whisper-books of one hall
3	Warden of a Hall	Command of a hall's staff; the right to move the shelved
4	Senior Warden	Access to all whisper-books; may sell what is in them
5	Warden of the Lofts	Keeper of the whole (held by Old Bettany Shroud)

Joining: read aloud to the shelved for a season without pay.

Enemies: Marrow Jack. **Allies:** the Seammers, the Finishers.

From whisper-book 112, Hall Four, Third Storey, in the hand of the Reader of Hall Four. Lack, 641 A.G.

Shelf 9, Ma Drabble (Set Aside 488): asked for the end of the almanac. Read it. She said, Company. Asked her whose. She said, Ours.

Shelf 10, Josias Penn (Set Aside 530): asked if the stairs were swept. Told yes. He said, Sweep them again. Someone is coming up them and it would be shameful.

Shelf 11, unnamed (label rotted, Warden to rewrite): whispering the old count, one to eight. Stops at seven. Waits.

Starts again.

Shelf 12, Hepzie Moule (Set Aside 602): Tell my daughter there's a place laid. Asked where. At the end.

Shelves 13 to 40: Company. All of them. All at once, at the ninth bell, and then quiet, and then the drip.

WHISPERS FROM THE SHELVES

Roll when a PC reads to the shelved, sleeps in Loftside, or buys a page of a whisper-book from a Senior Warden. Some whispers are true, some are the long rot talking, and some, increasingly, are the same word.

D20 WHAT THE SHELVED WHISPER BACK

1	<i>Company.</i> Only that, from every shelf in the aisle at once, and then a silence like an intake of breath.
2	A recipe, perfect and complete, for a dish nobody has cooked in four hundred years, and at the end: <i>set a place for the one who's late.</i>
3	The true name of a PC's grandmother, which is not the name the family uses.
4	<i>My son took my rings while I slept. I felt him. Tell him I forgive him. Tell him I know which hand.</i>
5	Directions, street by sunken street, to a door in the Fifth Storey that has been shut since 300 and that something is knocking on from the inside.
6	<i>The Regent asked to be finished. I was his clerk. I heard it through the floor.</i>
7	A hymn with eight verses. The whisperer sings seven and then holds the silence so long the Reader gets up to check on them.
8	<i>Tell Nell I am coming down.</i> From the fourth floor of Hall Two, as it has been every night for a hundred and thirty-eight years.
9	<i>There's a hand under the Hall of Hands, much bigger than ours. It's been opening since spring.</i>
10	The whole of a love letter written in 402 to someone who never answered, word for word, ending: <i>I am still waiting. I will always be still waiting.</i>
11	<i>Who is the tall one at the end of the aisle?</i> There is no one at the end of the aisle.

D20 WHAT THE SHELVED WHISPER BACK	
12	The name of a living person in Lastgate who has been taking parts from the shelf below, and what he does with them.
13	<i>Don't read me the end. I can't bear the end. Read me the middle again.</i>
14	A list of every Proof sunk without a strip by one Hand-line house, by name and date, recited by the Kept steward who bought them.
15	<i>I can feel the ones in the Sump. They're all turning over. Like a bed when someone sits on the edge of it.</i>
16	A confession of kin-slaying, in the War of the Heirs, by a shelved man whose father is still upright on the Upper Boards and still does not know who did it.
17	<i>The quiet is coming up the stairs. It is so polite. It's wiping its feet.</i>
18	The PC's own name, whispered, by someone who has been shelved since before the PC was born.
19	Weeping. Hours of it. In the morning the Warden finds that the whisperer has, against every law of the north, gone dry inside the linen, as if finished; and then, at the ninth bell, starts again.
20	<i>Company. Company. Company. Lay the board. Lay the board. Eight chairs. No: lay the board.</i>

WHISPERS AT THE TABLE

Reading to the shelved for a night is an Eye + Search roll (Hard 14) to catch something useful in the whispering; a Helping lets the PC roll twice on the table above. Results 1, 7, 11, 17 and 20 are Dread 2. Result 19 is Dread 3. Nothing the shelved say should be treated as prophecy, and nothing they say should be entirely ignored.

POWERS FROM ABROAD

The Cutwrights' College keeps its northern ledgers in Lastgate under Provost Carrion Sedge, and those ledgers are now the most dangerous documents in the land. **The Purgation** has a small, fanatical following among the Heirs, who argue that the god can be thrown up if the Hand-lines are emptied of it; their method is the Sump. **The Second Table** has members on the Mortuary Court and wants Osric Vane's hands for the second meal (see Lord Absalom Hethe). **The Reckoners** have raided Sallowreach six times since 402 and learned that their blades are useless here; the last of them, Withhold Pennick, is stranded in Lastgate. **The Rim Road Company** runs the border inn at the Finishing Post and clears the heap.

▼ SALLOWREACH NOW

Sallowreach has started to end. The Hushes are multiplying, eighteen now, and they appear fastest near Hand-line estates. The Court has realized what that means: the nobility is the god's way back, and the country will not be freed from undeath so much as closed like a book. Provost Carrion Sedge can prove it. The Court's answer, so far, is lead mittens, locked wings and silence.

Meanwhile the Vigil's envoy, Castellan Dray, has taken rooms on the Upper Boards and is offering Regent Grue the oil of a nation for the secret of Keeping. The Finishers have tripled in a year. A Scrapling girl in the Sinks can close things with her hands. The forty thousand in the Lofts have begun, all of them, to whisper the same word. And the Heirs have noticed that, for the first time in six centuries, an elder can be made to die.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◆ **The Deadwatch.** Castellan Dray hires the PCs as guides and bodyguards while he negotiates. The Regent is tempted. The secret of Keeping is not a secret: it is the god in the soil, and the Vigil would have to move to Sallowreach to use it. Dray knows this. His real commission is to find out how many Vigil citizens Sallowreach could house.
- ◆ **The Glovehall Garden.** The Hush behind Glovehall grew three yards last week. Lady Corrow Vane hires the PCs to measure it secretly, nightly, and to find out whether it is growing from her brother's wing or from her own bedroom.
- ◆ **The Little Closer.** The Court, the Finishers, the Cutwrights and Marrow Jack all want Pim Sorrel. Her mother hires the PCs to get her across the border, where the Closing touch might stop. It might not. And the girl does not want to leave.
- ◆ **Sack Seventeen.** A Sump dredger has hauled up a sack whose occupant claims to be a Regent of Sallowreach older than Ansel Grue, sunk for treason in 340. If true, Grue's appointment was illegal and every license he ever signed is void.
- ◆ **The Last Verse.** Bram Hollin has been hired to mourn the first proper funeral in Lastgate in six hundred years, for a living woman closed by accident. The family wants it done right.

Halfway through the rite, the corpse begins to whisper the same word as the Lofts.

RUMORS OF THE FEN

D20	RUMOR
1	The Regent has not signed his own Closing because he has already tried, and Corrow Vane's hand did not work on him. (True.)
2	Hushes can be carried. Finishers bring back grey reeds in boxes, and where they plant them, silence grows. (False, but the Finishers believe it.)
3	Wick Tallow's candles are made only from the unclaimed. (False. Some families sell.)
4	The word the Lofts are whispering is "company." (True.)
5	Marrow Jack is a Seamer of the Guild. (Half true. He was.)
6	Outsiders who die in Sallowreach can leave if they are carried across before sundown. (False, and cruelly so.)
7	Captain Morrow's soldiers are finding parts of him in the barracks. (True.)
8	The Court is building a lead-lined vault under the Hall of Hands to hold the Hand-line children. (True.)
9	Mother Gall's brine can cure the Kept of rot. (False. It only halts it, while they stay in the barrel.)
10	A Hush opened in the Jar Room last month and closed nine prisoners, and the Court has hidden it. (True; the nine were the oldest jars.)
11	Lord Pellam Fallow's stumps are growing new hands, smaller and greyer, with more joints. (True.)
12	The Restitution worked, and the Hushes would be twice as large without it. (False. The Confessors know it.)
13	Every Hand-line house keeps an unmarked sack in the Sump for each heir it has raised. (True; see the Proving.)
14	The Coldharrow hum can be caught from a letter written by someone who has it. (False, but people burn the letters.)
15	Ned Scurl the dredger was not the only one; there are a dozen huts like his on the Sump. (True, though none so tender.)
16	The Brack Mound is empty because Ysmay Brack walked away on the First Morning and is somewhere in Lastgate still. (False. Grimmer than that.)
17	The Hollowe-Vanes have a child who was born at the Course and has never been seen. (The Hollowes do not deny it.)
18	Captain Morrow will arrest Sister Lorn before Tablenight. (False. He cannot bring himself to.)
19	Things floating in the fen have been drifting toward Lastgate, all of them, for a season, against the current. (True.)
20	Ansel Grue has a son, living, two hundred years old, in a lead room at Gruesholt. (False. Probably.)

MORE HOOKS

- ◇ **Two Plates at Grimsey.** Ned Scurl's ledger lists his buyers by initial. One set of initials matches a Master of the Seam; another matches a Hand of the Court. Someone wants the ledger sunk before Scurl's trial; someone else wants the PCs to find Joan Ottery's sack again and ask her what Scurl told her about his customers, because he talked to her, all those years, about everything.
- ◇ **The Bill for Coldharrow.** Agathe Rusk has paid the Court eight hundred lacks by pledging her weir-share to 690. The Heirs want to make her their martyr. The Finishers want her as a Singer. The humming has started again in Coldharrow, three

houses down from hers, and she asks the PCs to stay a night and keep the boots turned round.

- ◇ **Ebba Corn's Name.** Someone has painted the name of the Fallows' Proof on the Ferrying Post, and the next night thirty more names in the same hand. The Court wants the painter. The PCs are hired to find them, and discover that the names are correct, every one, and that whoever is painting them can only have learned them from the Sump.
- ◇ **The Hands Ten Feet In.** A Second Table agent offers a fortune to anyone who can fetch Lord Pellam's severed hands from inside the edge of Dunmere Hush. The living cannot cross and come back. The Kept cannot cross and come back. Edda Thrush can, and is not saying yes.

THE PEOPLE OF SALLOWREACH

ANSEL GRUE – THE UNVACATED REGENT

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Clause 5, Persuade 4, Resolve 5, Lore 4, Intimidate 3
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 11 · Armor 2 (lacquer and wire) · Fray 7
ATTACKS	none worth the name; he has never needed one
GIFTS	Kept; The Shutting (ends any argument in his presence with a Routine Tongue + Clause roll); four hundred years of precedent
WANTS	Close (cannot leave a ledger unsigned or a door ajar); Endure (refuses every ending, including his own)
DREAD	2 (to watch him move)
SECRET	He asked Corrow Vane to close him in 610. Her hand did nothing. He does not know if he is beyond closing or if she held back.

Ansel Grue, the Unvacated Regent. Four hundred and twelve years old, three hundred of them in office. Grue died in 371 of a fall from a horse, and has been mostly wire, lacquer and habit since. He sits in a high chair in the Hall of Hands with his jaw wired shut and his face lacquered to a deep glossy amber, like a violin. Up close he smells of cedar, varnish and, faintly, sweet, like a bowl of fruit forgotten in a warm room. He speaks through a brass tube set into his throat, in a dry clicking voice that makes clerks lean in. He signs every death license personally, by hand, a slow, beautiful signature that takes a minute each. He has never once considered signing his own, or says he has not. What Grue fears is not death. It is the end

of order, and the Hushes, which close without license, are disorder in its purest form. PCs meet him if they petition the Court, or if they become a threat to it.



He signs a license the way other men pray: slowly, completely, and without any expectation that it will be answered.

A LICENSER OF THE COURT, IN HIS CUPS

LADY CORROW VANE – THE LEFT HAND OF THE COURT

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Rites 4, Persuade 3, Instinct 3, Clause 2, Stitching 2
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 4
ATTACKS	Closing Touch +8 (finishes a Kept target outright; a living target makes a Grim Caul + Resolve check or falls to Ruin and the Kept); stiletto +5 (2)
GIFTS	The Closing Touch; Coldprint (her bare hand frosts metal and glass); Lidsense
WANTS	Close; Quiet (cannot bear laughter near her)
DREAD	2 (to see her gloves come off)
SECRET	The Hush at Glovehall is growing from her rooms, not her brother's. She has measured it.

Lady Corrow Vane, the Left Hand of the Court. The Court’s chief Closer, sixty-one years old and living. She has finished eleven thousand people by touch, at a price. She is tall, pale and composed, with ash-blond hair worn in a severe coil and a face that rarely moves. She smells of nothing at all, which is the first thing people notice and the thing they remember. Her gloves are black kid, sewn on at the wrist by her clerk, and unpicked nine stitches at a time. She has never held her own children. Her two sons were raised by nurses and taught to keep three paces from her; one is forty and has never touched his mother’s skin. She speaks briefly and with exquisite courtesy. She is afraid of only one thing, and it is herself.

PCs meet her at a Closing, or when the Court needs agents it can deny.

*I have been in a room with her four hundred times
and I could not tell you the colour of her eyes. You do
not look at her face. You look at her gloves, the whole
time, like a dog watching a stick.*

BRAM HOLLIN, THE LAST MOURNER

OSRIC VANE – THE GLOVED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 8
SKILLS	Rites 4, Godsign 5, Instinct 4, Lore 3
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 (lead mittens count as Armor 4 to his hands only) · Fray 8
ATTACKS	Bare touch +9 (finishes anything; Dread 4 to witness)
GIFTS	The Closing Touch; Hushing (sound dies within ten paces); Closing Gaze (a minute’s stare finishes a candle, a fly, a conversation, a Kept man)
WANTS	Close; Be of Use
DREAD	3 (in the same room); 4 (unmittened)
SECRET	He has been finishing his guards through the door, by stare, one a month, for a year. They are replaced. He keeps count.

Osric Vane, the Gloved. Corrow’s brother, fifty-four, deep in the Course and now at its Brink. His hands are grey, long and have nine joints a finger; they fold like fans and click like abacus beads in a room that has gone too quiet to carry the sound. He is kept in lead mittens, padlocked at the wrist, in a locked wing of Glovehall where no fly lives. His face has gone smooth and soft-featured and faintly smiling. He is gentle, well read and lonely, and he has begun asking politely to be used on the enemy: the Reckoners, the Fast, anyone. *I*

should like to be useful, he says. *I should like to be put somewhere I can do good.* Lord Absalom Hethe has offered him exactly that.

*He asked me, through the hatch, whether I was tired. I
said a little, sir. He said, “Only a little?” and he
sounded so disappointed.*

A KEPT GUARD OF GLOVEHALL’S WEST WING, SINCE
REASSIGNED

THESSALY MORT – MASTER SEAMER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 1
SKILLS	Stitching 6, Craft 4, Reckoning 3, Haggle 3, Endure 4
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 11 · Armor 3 (wire lattice) · Fray 5
ATTACKS	curved needle +6 (2, and she can unstitch a Kept limb on a Helping)
GIFTS	Kept; can restitch a Ruined Kept body in an hour
WANTS	Keep Count (must record every replaced part)
DREAD	2 (to see her ledger)
SECRET	Her ledger lists her original parts. It is three lines long: left eye, two fingers of the right hand, and “the part that remembers.”

Thessaly Mort, Master Seamer. Head of the Guild for a hundred and ninety years. She has replaced so much of herself over two centuries that she keeps a ledger of which parts were hers originally. The ledger is short. She is a patchwork of a dozen donors in a dozen skin tones, wired at the joints, seams lacquered in cedar-gold so that she glimmers like a cracked bowl mended in a fine shop. She smells of wax thread, pitch and spirits. Her voice is a borrowed one, deep and pleasant, from a larynx she bought in 498. She is practical, brisk, and the most powerful person in Sallowreach after the Regent, because she could stop the country in a month. She fears

that she is no longer anyone. She pays well for odd jobs: recovering stolen parts, shutting down back-alley seamers, finding out what Marrow Jack does with his stock.



She sewed my mother's face back on in 499 and my daughter's in 640, and both times she said the same thing: "Hold the lamp higher, love, I'm not a bat."

TEAL MALLORY, OF WEIR ROW

JORY WELT – THE BOY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Persuade 4, Reckoning 3, Blades 3, Stealth 2, Wayfaring 3
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	boathook +6 (4); knife +6 (2)
GIFTS	none; he is entirely ordinary, which is his strength
WANTS	none; his compulsions are his own
DREAD	0
SECRET	His father, Alderman Rufus Welt, is his son's most generous anonymous donor, and wants to be the first taken to the Hush. Jory cannot do it.

Jory Welt, the Boy. Seventy-one years old and legally a child, since his father is three hundred and upright. He leads the Heirs. He is stooped, white-whiskered and arthritic, and his voice still cracks with anger like a youth's. He lives in two rooms over a tannery in the Sinks, smelling of oak bark and old dogs, and he has a map of every Hush pinned to his wall, measured weekly, with pins for the Hand-line estates. He has dragged elders to the edge. He has watched them go soft. He is tired, and very gentle with children, and he has begun to wonder whether the Heirs have won or merely discovered a new way to bury their parents without mourning them.

Old Bettany Shroud, Loft-Warden. Keeper of forty thousand shelved dead, eighty-eight and living. She is small and bent and wrapped in shawls that smell of camphor, and her fingers are stained with ink to the second knuckle. She reads to the shelved every night, a hall at a time, and writes down what they whisper back, in a hundred and twelve whisper-books going back fifty years. She knows every secret in north Lastgate, and has never sold one. Lately they all whisper the same word: *company*. They whisper it as if someone is coming up the stairs. Bettany does not know what it means. She has been sleeping in the Lofts, on a cot between the shelves, so that they will not be alone when it arrives.

OLD BETTANY SHROUD Threat 3 · Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Attack +1 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Pim Sorrel, the Scrap Finisher. A Scrapling girl of twelve from the Sinks, thin, freckled, quick, smelling of peat smoke and eel. Her touch ends things, which should be impossible for her blood. It began a year ago with a cat that had been crushed by a cart and could not stop crying; she picked it up and it was quiet. Since then she has closed a neighbor's grandfather, two Smalls who asked her to, and a candle she did not mean to. Her hands are not grey. They are ordinary, warm, a child's hands, with bitten nails. The Court wants her dissected. The Finishers want her crowned. She wants to go to school. GM options for her secret: she is a Vane bastard's granddaughter (Sedge's ledgers say so); or Ossel, growing back, is reaching through the least of its eaters first; or the face the Scraplings ate is waking.

Justice Ever Lathe, the Honorable Maggot. A judge of the Court of Wrongs, Kept since 389, rotted down to bone, a few black tendons and a resident colony. He sits in a robe of office that seethes. The colony has worked its way through every soft part of him and taken up residence in the skull, and his rulings are delivered in the buzzing: a thick drone that rises and falls in cadences like speech. His clerk, Absalom Pike, translates. Lathe's judgments are famously fair. Nobody is sure any longer which of them is deciding, Lathe, the flies or Pike, and nobody wants to find out, because the conviction rate has never been better.

JUSTICE EVER LATHE Threat 4 · Flesh 6 · Guard 9 · Attack +3 (swarm 1, blinds on a Helping) · Armor 0 · Dread 2

Dr. Halloran Quease. A physician in a land where no illness is fatal. He has made pain his whole study, since it is the one ailment left, and he has catalogued four hundred kinds, from *the long bell* (the pain of a seam pulling through) to *the attic* (the pain of being shelved and forgotten). He is living, fifty, plump, scrupulously clean, smelling of carbolic and lemon. He keeps meticulous notes and Kept volunteers in his surgery, who allow him to test on them in return for opiates. He is kind to them. He wants to end pain. He fears that he enjoys measuring it. He pays PCs to bring him new kinds.

Wick Tallow, the Chandler. He renders the unclaimed dead into candles that feel themselves burn. His shop on Wick Lane

smells of hot fat, smoke and something like singed hair, and the candles on his shelves are yellow, smooth and very slightly warm. They give a very steady light; they do not gutter, because they are trying not to. Half of Lastgate reads by people it used to know. If you hold a Tallow candle close, you can hear it, very faintly, a thin high sound like a kettle a long way off. Wick is a cheerful, practical man with burn-scarred forearms who sees nothing wrong with any of this. The dead are unclaimed; the light is needed. He has begun to take commissions from families.

WICK TALLOW Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (rendering hook 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 1

SISTER LORN OF THE SHUT EYE – HIGH SHUT EYE OF THE FINISHERS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 4, Resolve 3, Wayfaring 3, Lore 2
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 9
ATTACKS	none
GIFTS	Kept; the Last Verse (her singing grants all who hear it +2 to resist Dread for a scene)
WANTS	Lead
DREAD	1
SECRET	She has stood at the edge nine hundred times and walked in once, in the night, alone. She stopped one step from the line. She cannot forgive herself either way.

Sister Lorn of the Shut Eye. High priest of the Finishers, Kept since 590, slender and wrapped in grey linen, one eye stitched shut in the old fashion of mourning. She smells of beeswax and fen-mint, which she chews constantly. Her singing voice is extraordinary, low and kind. She has led nine hundred pilgrims into the Hushes and

has stayed outside every time, saying someone must. Her flock has started asking why. She does not know the answer. She tells herself it is duty. She fears it is cowardice, or worse, that she enjoys the walking back. PCs meet her at the edge of a Hush, or when a family hires them to bring someone home before the singing stops.

CAPTAIN DACE MORROW – THE SIXTY-TIMES SLAIN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 5 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 1 · Hunger 0
SKILLS	Blades 5, Endure 6, Intimidate 4, Wayfaring 3, Reckoning 2
BODY	Flesh 19 · Guard 16 · Armor 3 (bone lamellar over wire) · Fray 6
ATTACKS	sword +9 (4); he does not stop
GIFTS	Kept; Thread-Bound (ignores the first Ruin each scene)
WANTS	Hold the Line
DREAD	2
SECRET	The pieces he leaves in the barracks are deliberate. He is trying to get a little of himself across the border without dying, a finger at a time. None of it has survived.

Captain Dace Morrow, the Sixty-Times Slain. Commander of the Fen Guard, an army that cannot lose a man and cannot cross a border. He has been killed sixty times, by Reckoners, smugglers,

Heirs and once by his own horse, and stitched back after each. He is more thread than soldier now: a tall figure bound in grey cord, wire and leather, his face held on by a lattice of brass. He smells of oil and

old blood and wet rope. He is laconic, decent and very tired, and he has started deserting in small pieces. A finger is found on the parade ground. An ear in the mess. His sergeants gather them in a box and do not report it.

Henna Farrow, the Widow Unmade. Her husband Amos died ninety years ago, of a fever, and still comes home each evening from a job at the weir that was abolished in 570. He opens the door, says “Something smells good, Hen,” and sits down. He does not know. He has never known. His face has long since gone, and the Guild keeps a lacquered mask on him with a painted smile. Henna is a hundred and twelve, living, bent double, smelling of lye and lavender. She has petitioned for his Closing forty-one times. The Court refuses because Amos must consent, and to consent he would have to be told. She sets his place anyway, every night, and cooks his favorite, and scrapes it into the eel barrel. She would like the PCs to tell him.

Grandfather Peat. A bog body hauled from the Sump in 611, who drowned the week of the Gorging. He is leather-brown, flattened, shining wet, with a fringe of red hair and a rope still

knotted at his throat, and he smells of peat, tannin and old rainwater. He speaks a dead dialect that only a few Cutwrights can follow. He is the last witness to the Night of Seven Tables, and he repeats one thing: the god was smiling. Asked more, he holds up his fingers and counts, slowly, to eight, then folds one down very carefully as if it might bite. The College keeps him in a tank in Sedge’s offices. He would like to go back in the water.

GRANDFATHER PEAT Threat 1 · Flesh 8 · Guard 8 · Attack +0 · Armor 1 · Dread 2

Tam Ruddock, the Lastgate Ferryman. He poles a long black punt from the border road across the Landing, and for a heavy fee he smuggles the dying of other lands across the border so they will not die: Fatlanders with wasting sickness, Brinehollowers Called too far, Vigil sleepers on stretchers. They do not die. He has never told a single one of them what happens next, and he sleeps badly. He is forty, heavy, with a broken nose and a soft voice, and he smells of tar and rum. He keeps a list of every passenger, and on his days off he visits them. Idony Pask was one. She has never forgiven him, and he visits her most.

MARROW JACK – THE PART-THIEF	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0
SKILLS	Stitching 4, Filch 5, Stealth 5, Blades 3, Haggle 4
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Fray 3
ATTACKS	bone-saw +8 (3, takes a limb from a Kept target on a Helping); knife +8 (2)
GIFTS	none; skill only
WANTS	none
DREAD	2 (his stock room)
SECRET	He was a Guild Journeyman under Thessaly Mort, and he supplies her. A third of the parts in the Guild’s stores came from him.

Marrow Jack. A part-thief, thin as wire, with a pleasant freckled face and hands that never stop moving. He smells of clove oil, which he uses to cover his trade. He takes limbs from the Kept while they shelve in the Lofts or lie in the slow stupor some of them call sleep, and sells them to back-alley seamers in the Sinks: an arm to a woman whose own has rotted through, a jaw to a Kept singer, a whole pair of hands to buyers who will not say why. He works the Lofts, the Sump (dredging sacks for usable stock) and the potter’s corners where the unclaimed are left. His victims wake able to feel what their missing hands are being used for. Some of them have tracked him by it. One of them is in his stock room now, in eleven pieces, and he does not know what to do with her.

Little Nell Ash, Queen of the Smalls. She died of a fever at seven, in 441, and has been seven since. She rules the child-dead of Lastgate’s Drowned Storeys from a throne of a waterlogged armchair in a flooded schoolroom, crowned with a ring of tarnished

spoons. She is small, grey-green, very carefully stitched by Smalls who taught themselves, and she smells of canal water and the violet sweets she cannot eat but likes to hold. She has a two-century-old mind and a seven-year-old’s sense of fairness: absolute, unforgiving and sometimes very funny. The Smalls do not grow up, ever; she has kept them safe, mostly, from the Court and from Marrow Jack. She wants Pim Sorrel for herself. Several of the Smalls have asked to be closed, and Nell has not decided whether to let them.

Provost Carrion Sedge. Head of the Cutwrights’ College in the north, Hand-line by birth, Kept since 598. Gaunt, ink-stained, lacquered in a dull brown that smells of old paper and the glue of bindings. His ledgers prove that the Hushes follow Hand-line blood exactly; plotted on a map, every Hush is a family tree. He has not decided which is worse: publishing it, which would bring the Heirs to every Hand-line nursery, or selling it, to the Court, the Second Table, or the Vigil’s envoy, who has asked. He is also Hand-line, at

the Taste, and has found himself closing his ledgers too firmly, and sometimes being unable to open them again.

Mother Gall. A fen witch who pickles. She is enormous, red-handed, cheerful, and smells overwhelmingly of brine, dill and garlic. In the right brine, a recipe she will not share, she can keep a body sound for a century: no rot, no flies, no further decay, so long as it stays submerged. Her cellar under Brinemoss holds four hundred customers in barrels, paid up in advance, all wide awake, all blinking up through the green. Some have been in for ninety years. They cannot speak; they knock. She charges for visiting. She is the closest thing to a cure in the north, and she knows it is not one.

Edda Thrush, the Hushwalker. A Court surveyor who walked into Dunmere Hush with a chain and a theodolite in 638 and walked out again three hours later. Nobody else has. She cannot hear anything now, and insists that this is not deafness: something is listening in her place. She is forty, living, with a cropped head and grey-streaked eyebrows, and she smells of nothing at all. She speaks too loudly, then too softly, and sometimes stops mid-sentence and tilts her head, as though someone just behind her has cleared their throat. She has drawn the inside of Dunmere from memory. In the center of her drawing is something she has not drawn, only left blank, very carefully.

Bram Hollin, the Last Mourner. His family were professional mourners, a trade six centuries extinct. He alone, by an unbroken line of fathers teaching sons for a job none of them could do, knows the full funeral rite by heart: the keening, the washing, the coin on the tongue, the six last songs. Now that people are dying again, everyone wants him. He is sixty, small, tidy, in a black coat green with age, and smells of rosemary. He weeps easily and professionally and, lately, privately. He did not know until this year what the songs were for.

Idony Pask, the Tourist. A Fatlands woman who came north with a wasting sickness so she would not die of it. She did not die of it. She died in 627 and kept going, and the sickness has not stopped. She is now very thin, then thinner: a creature of skin and bone wrapped in a Fatlands shawl, still hungry with her land's bottomless hunger and unable to eat. She smells of sour milk and decay. She can

never leave. She has written to her family in the south every week for fourteen years. They stopped replying. She is bright, bitter and good company, and she would like someone to take her letters south and tell her what they find.



*Everyone in the north is somebody's ancestor. In
Lastgate, they are all still in the house.*

IDONY PASK, IN A LETTER TO HER SISTER IN THE
FATLANDS, UNANSWERED

NEW FACES

Fenwick Lisp, Interpreter of Jaw-Clicks. Kept since 501, gaunt and courteous, with a lacquered jaw of his own he clicks as he thinks. He interprets for the jawless and tongueless of Lastgate, most famously in the Long Argument, and is the only person who understands either party. He has not translated accurately since 560. He has been running the argument himself, out of loneliness, and he is afraid both men know.

Merrit Cask, Keeper of the Jar Room. A living woman of forty-four who inherited the post from her Kept mother, who inherited it from hers. She dusts the jars, oils the lead seals, reads the labels aloud each morning and sweeps the drains. She smells of lamp oil and lye. Since nine of the oldest jars went silent last month, at once, she has heard the shelf whispering about who will be next, and has begun moving her chair further down the vault each night.

MERRIT CASK Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (cudgel 3) ·
Armor 1 · Dread 0

Withhold Pennick, the Stranded Reckoner. A wiry Unfed woman of thirty from the Fast who crossed in 639 to kill a Hand-line lord and did: she cut his throat in his bed. He sat up and called the guard. She has been hiding in the Sinks ever since, unable to complete her oath and unwilling to go home. She has learned the Hushes exist. She has begun to wonder whether she could drag a lord into one. She is clean-smelling, ascetic, appalled by everything, and slowly starving on food she will not eat.

LORD ABSALOM HETHE – HAND OF THE COURT, SECOND TABLE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Deceive 5, Clause 4, Persuade 4, Lore 3, Feast 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 3
ATTACKS	rapier +5 (4)
GIFTS	Lidsense; The Shutting
WANTS	Close
DREAD	1
SECRET	He is the Second Table's man on the Court. He plans to carry Osric Vane, in a lead coffin, to the Rim, and use the Brink-hands to close a regrowing god when it is ready to be eaten again.

Lord Absalom Hethe. A Hand-line lord of forty-eight, living, handsome, florid, smelling of myrrh and claret. He collects Fatlands recipes and old carvings of tables, and keeps a dining room with an eighth chair he will not let anyone sit in. He visits Osric Vane every week and is the only visitor who does not seem afraid.

Dunstan Reave, the Last of Dunmere. A reed-cutter, living, thirty-five, who was away at market the night his village went silent. His wife, his Kept parents, his two children are lying in their kitchen four miles inside the grey. He camps at the edge every night with a spyglass, because from one spot, on a clear evening, he can see his own roof. He will guide anyone to the Hush for free, and asks only that they tell him, if they ever come back, whether they looked peaceful.

Lord Pellam Fallow, the Handless. Forty-six, living, master of Wending Mound and its eleven weirs, and the man who gave his hands back to the god in 639 (see The Restitution). He sits in his mother's chair in a house that has gone grey at the edges, in a room with the shutters nailed open because he can no longer bear them closed, and a servant feeds him with a spoon. He is courteous, slow-spoken, very thin, and he smells of pitch and lint from the bindings at his wrists, and under that of nothing at all. He closed his Proof, a spinster named Ebba Corn, at twenty-six, and his mother in 638, and believed, when he volunteered, that he was paying for both. The Hushes quickened. A new one opened in his own orchard. And at the ends of his stumps, under the lint, two small grey buds have come, each with tiny folded joints, which close, gently, on the spoon. He would like someone to tell him what the god wanted. He is afraid that the answer is *nothing*, and that this is worse.

LORD PELLAM FALLOW Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 10 · Attack +0 (none; the buds close what they touch, Dread 3 to see) · Armor 0 · Dread 3

Agathe Rusk of Coldharrow. Sixty-one, living, a reed-cutter's widow (her husband is Kept, and shelved in Hall Five, and she visits) who lost her son and daughter to the edge in the Coldharrow Carving and paid the Court's bill for them. She is broad, weather-

red, practical, and she smells of reed-sap and the blue soap she uses for the ribbon she still keeps in her apron pocket. She does not cry in front of people. She makes tea for anyone who comes, and asks them to say her children's names aloud once, so that someone has. She is the most dangerous woman in the south fen, because she understands the Finishers completely and has refused them, and both the Heirs and Sister Lorn know that if Agathe Rusk ever says the word, half of Coldharrow will follow her, one way or the other.

AGATHE RUSK Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (reed-hook 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Ned Scurl, the Dredger of Grimsey. Fifty, living, a soft, round-shouldered, mild-spoken Sump dredger who stripped the name-strips from three hundred sacks and sold their contents as unclaimed stock, and who kept one of them in his hut for many years, washed and dressed and set at his table (see the Sump). He is in the cells under the Landing awaiting the Court of Wrongs, and he is the calmest man there. He smells of fen-water and carbolic, which the Hookmen have scrubbed him with twice. He talks readily about the dredging and about his cat and will not talk about Joan Ottery at all, except to ask, every morning, whether she was sunk with a strip this time, and whether they said the words.

NED SCURL Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (grapnel 3, Hooking) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

Confessor Ambrose Weal. Kept since 560, the priest of the Shut House of the Landing, gaunt and grey-wrapped, his lacquer gone dull from sitting in the dark, smelling of tallow and old hymn-books. It was his sermon that proposed the Restitution, and his voice that sang the Hymn of the Open Hands at the grey line. He has not opened the door of his Shut House since. The service he began on the night the Hush quickened has not ended, because he has not left the bench, and a small congregation of the guilty sits with him in silence, and has sat for two years, waiting for one of them to be the last to go.

▼ PLAYING A SALLOWREACHER

You grew up with your great-great-grandmother in the attic and the smell of cedar in your clothes. You have held a lamp for a Seamer. You have never been to a funeral. You say *may you finish* to strangers and mean it kindly.

WHO'S IN YOUR ATTIC?

Every Sallowreacher grew up under somebody. Roll or choose the Kept elder who shaped you; they are still there, and they still have opinions about your life.

D10	YOUR KEPT ELDER	WHAT THEY WANT FROM YOU NOW
1	A great-grandmother at the Leathering, sharp as vinegar	To be restitched by you and nobody else
2	A drowned uncle who still goes to the weir each morning	For you to come with him, just once
3	A father, Unvacated, who owns the house and your wages	Obedience, until about 760
4	A fever-Kept aunt from the Grey Plague, always hot	A cool cloth, and for you to sit with her in Plenty
5	A sibling who died young and stayed young	For you to stop growing older than them
6	A grandfather at the Long Grey who no longer speaks	Nothing you can hear; he taps the arm of his chair
7	A mother on the shelf in the Lofts	Visits on feast days; the end of a book you started reading her
8	A great-great-grandfather who fought in the War of the Heirs	To know whether you are with the Heirs
9	A grandmother in a barrel at Brinemoss	For you to pay the visiting fee, and to tell her it is still spring
10	A parent who walked into a Hush	Nothing, ever again; you have only the name-strip

Attribute bonus: +1 HAND. Sallowreachers are stitchers, menders, eel-catchers and punt-men, and the Hand-lines rule them.

The Sop: close something that was meant to stay open. Shut the eyes of a sleeper; close a book someone is reading; snuff a lamp someone needs; end a conversation mid-sentence with a hand on the speaker's arm; shut a door on someone outside. It must matter to someone. The Sop removes 1d6 Hunger, and the Want to Close grows: for the rest of the day, resisting it is one step harder.

The Tooth: when a Sallowreacher Partakes, the fingers go cold to the second knuckle, the nearest flame leans away, and for a heartbeat every sound in the room drops, as if a door had shut somewhere. When the Tooth shows a 1, the god bites back: the character's hand closes involuntarily on whatever it holds, hard enough to crack a cup, and stays closed for a minute.

GIFTS

The Taste (Regrowth 1–3). *Lidsense:* you always know whether a door, lid, eye or book within ten paces is open or shut, even in darkness, and gain +2 to Search and Instinct rolls to notice concealed openings. *The Quiet Hand:* you can close any door, lid or shutter in perfect silence.

The Appetite (Regrowth 4–6). *The Shutting:* once per scene, lay a hand on a speaker and make a Tongue + Rites roll against Hard; on success their current argument, threat or song ends, and they cannot recall where it was going. Costs 1 Hunger. *Cold Fingers:*

+1 to Stitching (cold hands are steady), but you must wear mittens or gloves in company, and any bare-handed touch on a living person is a Dread 1 experience for them.

The Course (Regrowth 7–9). *The Closing Touch:* bare hand, Hand + Rites against Routine to close a flame, a wound's pain, a fly-swarm (one cloud) or a Kept person. Closing a Kept person finishes them forever; it costs 1 Hunger and is murder without a license. Against a living target outside Sallowreach, the touch is an attack (Hand + Rites vs Guard) dealing 4 damage that ignores Armor. Inside Sallowreach, a living target touched with intent must succeed at a Grim Caul + Resolve check or fall to Ruin and rise Kept. *Long Hands:* your hands grow extra joints; +1 Filch and Stitching, and everyone who sees them bare makes a Dread 2 check.

The Brink (Regrowth 10–11). *Hushing:* by Partaking, you may let silence spill from you for a scene: no sound carries within ten paces, flies die, flames lean and dim, and every Kept person in the radius must make a Hard Caul + Resolve check or kneel and plead to be closed. Costs 2 Hunger. *Closing Gaze:* a full minute's stare finishes a candle, a small animal, a conversation or a Kept person, without touch. Small Hushes begin to appear where you sleep: the GM marks one on the map each season.

THE WANTS

◇ **Close.** Triggered by an open door, an unclosed eye, an open book, an unlidded jar within reach. Resist with Caul + Resolve

vs Routine at the Taste, Hard at the Appetite, Grim at the Course, Dire at the Brink.

- ◇ **Finish.** Triggered by an unfinished thing in your presence: a song, a story, a quarrel, a life. You must end it, one way or another. Resist as above.
- ◇ **Quiet.** Triggered by laughter, crowds, bells and children playing. At the Course you must leave or silence the source. Resist as above, one step harder in Lastgate.

THE SEATING

At Regrowth 12 the character becomes a Hush. They do not die and they do not leave; they stand still and the silence spreads from them, slowly, for the rest of the campaign. Everyone and everything inside it ends. The player retires the character, and the GM places the new Hush on the map. Their friends may visit the edge. If the Hush is near the party's home, it will reach it in a year or two.

Your last sound. When a PC is Seated, the player describes the last sound the Hush ever let through: a door closing, a name, a laugh cut off, the Ferrying Post bell. Every PC who later stands at the edge of that Hush hears it, once, faintly, from just behind them, and must make a Dread 3 check.

PLAYING ONE OF THE KEPT (OPTIONAL)

A PC who falls to Ruin in Sallowreach and takes further damage does not die. They become Kept. Players may also begin play Kept, by choice.

- ◇ **No more death.** A Kept character no longer loses Flesh to dying. At 0 Flesh they suffer Ruin and collapse as normal, but further damage adds **Rot** instead (1 Rot per Ruin, or per 5 damage taken while Ruined). They need no food, drink, breath or sleep, and are immune to poison, drowning and suffocation. Cold and heat they feel, but cannot be killed by.
- ◇ **Rot (0–10).** Rot also rises by 1 each season without Seamer upkeep, and by 1 for any fall, fire or soaking that is not tended within a day. At Rot 3 (*Ripe*) the smell is unmistakable: –2 to Stealth and to Persuade with the living. At Rot 5 (*Loose*) parts come away: –1 to Lung and Hand rolls, and every scene of exertion has a chance to shed something (GM's call). At Rot 7 (*Ruinous*) the character is a Dread 2 horror to the living and must be carried more often than not. At Rot 10 the character is Set Aside: retired to the Lofts, still aware, and the player makes a new one. They can still be visited.
- ◇ **Seamer upkeep.** A Seamer's restitching (Hard Hand + Stitching, an hour, 30 lacks in materials) removes 1 Rot; a full spring restitching in the Guild's hands removes 2 and costs 120 lacks. A Kept character can Stitch themselves at one step harder.
- ◇ **The border.** A Kept character who leaves Sallowreach drops dead at once, completely, all their unfinished rot arriving in a

heartbeat. There is no save. A Kept PC cannot follow the party south.

- ◇ **The Regrowth continues.** A Kept Hand-line still Partakes and still accrues Hunger and Regrowth. A Kept PC who is Closed is finished forever.
- ◇ **Fray.** The Kept still feel. Every season of Rot 5 or more adds 1 Fray. The commonest Derangements among the Kept are believing that one is still alive, and believing that everyone else has died.

WAKING KEPT

The first waking is the worst hour a Sallowreacher ever spends, and the player should be given time to play it. The new Kept opens their eyes cool, still, with no breath and no heartbeat and every sense sharpened, and hears, before anything else, the absence of their own pulse. They make a Dread 3 check. They choose one thing they will try to keep doing as if alive (eating at table, sleeping in a bed, breathing to speak, blushing with lacquer) and keep it up as long as they can; while they do, they gain +1 to Persuade with the living. They also lose any living Knack that depends on warmth, appetite or breath, at the GM's judgment. And the family, if there is one, has to be told, and will fetch a Seamer, and will begin, gently, from that morning, to speak of the PC as one speaks of the elders upstairs.

THE ROT TRACK

ROT	NAME	WHAT IT MEANS
0–2	Fresh to Settling	Cool, pale, slipping. Lacquer and perfume hide it. No penalty.
3–4	Ripe	The smell is unmistakable: –2 to Stealth and to Persuade with the living.
5–6	Loose	Parts come away: –1 to Lung and Hand rolls; exertion may shed something.
7–9	Ruinous	A Dread 2 horror to the living; carried more often than not.
10	Set Aside	Retired to the Lofts, still aware, still visitable.

WHAT COMES LOOSE

When a Kept character at Rot 5 or more exerts themselves and the GM calls for it, roll a d10. Any part may be stitched back by a

Seamer within the week (Hard Hand + Stitching); after that it is the Guild's stock, or Marrow Jack's.

D10	SHED
1	A fingernail, then the finger's tip. No penalty, but you will want it back.
2	A tooth, rolling across the boards. Fine for now.
3	A swatch of scalp and hair. –1 to Persuade until covered.
4	An ear. –1 to Instinct and Search by sound.
5	The lower lip slips its seam. Speech is wet; –1 to Tongue rolls.
6	A finger. –1 to Filch and Stitching.
7	An eye, onto the cheek, still seeing. –2 to Shooting and Search until set back.
8	A seam in the belly opens. Spillage: a public fine, a Dread 1 scene, and Rot +1 if not closed today.
9	A hand at the wrist. It keeps hold of whatever it was holding.
10	The jaw. You can no longer speak until it is wired; the Kept learn jaw-clicks for this reason.

KEPT COURTESIES

The Kept have manners that the living do not teach, because the living do not need them. A Kept PC knows to sit downwind; to keep a handkerchief for what leaks; never to sit on another's good chair; to carry their own spitting-dish to table; to wear gloves to a Closing so that no one thinks they are begging; and never, ever, to stand near a Hand-line with their face turned up, as if asking. A Kept PC who breaks these courtesies before other Kept loses face; one who keeps them before the living is treated, in the old houses, with the slightly frightened courtesy owed to an elder, whatever their age.

BACKGROUNDS

- ♦ **Restitched Apprentice.** A Threader of the Seamers' Guild who knows every family on their street by its smell, and who has begun to notice which bodies are missing parts.
- ♦ **Disinherited Heir.** Forty-eight, living, legally a minor, owner of nothing; your father is upright and the Heirs have offered you a punt and a sack.
- ♦ **Glovebearer of a Closer.** A clerk who unpicks the gloves of a Hand-line Closer and has seen what that hand does, and whose

own fingers have started going cold.

- ♦ **Sackman's Child.** You have dropped the rope and said the words a thousand times, and you know the patterns the bubbles make, and lately you have started to understand them.
- ♦ **Reader of the Lofts.** You read to four hundred shelved strangers every night and know them by their whispers; one of them has started whispering your name.
- ♦ **Walker Who Came Back.** You carried a candle and a name to the edge, and watched the procession go in, and turned home; the hum has been in your mouth ever since.
- ♦ **Hand-line Cadet.** A minor cousin of a lesser line, in mittens since you were nine; your house has bought a Proof for the day your hands go grey, and you have met her, and she is kind to you.
- ♦ **Tam Ruddock's Passenger.** A foreigner smuggled north to escape a death that would have been quick, now Kept, unable ever to go home, slowly learning the language of the people who have been living like this for six hundred years.

NAMES

Male: Ansel, Osric, Jory, Bram, Amos, Aubin, Corlis, Dace, Fenwick, Halloran, Hollis, Josiah, Merriman, Rook, Tobin, Wick.

Female: Bettany, Corrow, Edda, Hessa, Henna, Idony, Lorn, Merrit, Nell, Thessaly, Wenna, Ysolde, Greer, Sabine, Orla.

Neutral: Pim, Ash, Sorrel, Teal, Lark, Fen, Rue, Wren.

Surnames: Grue, Vane, Sedge, Hethe (Hand-lines); Mort, Welt, Shroud, Sorrel, Lathe, Tallow, Morrow, Farrow, Ruddock, Hollin, Thrush, Coyle, Rook, Mead, Strake, Mallory, Coombe, Reave, Cask, Lisp, Gall.

More names, from the old fen-families: Abel, Ambrose, Cobb, Edmund, Hamo, Odo, Orrin, Pellam, Wendel, Jessop (male); Agathe, Bryony, Ebba, Imber, Joan, Margery, Ysmay, Hepzie, Agnes (female); Teal, Ashe, Moss, Merle (neutral); Brack, Fallow, Rusk, Scurl, Weal, Corn, Ottery, Tull, Crake, Pettle, Drabble, Moule, Hollowe (surnames).

▼ HORRORS OF SALLOWREACH

HORRORS OF SALLOWREACH – FOR THE GM

Roll on the table below when the party travels off the causeway, lodges in the Sinks or enters the Lofts, the Sump or the Drowned Storeys. Each entry gives a scene and its Dread rating. Use the senses: the smell first, then the sound, then what the eyes see last.

D20	HORROR	DREAD
1	A Black Noon: a fly-front swallows the lamps; something inside it says your name in a voice of ten thousand wings.	1
2	A Kept fisherman wades from the mere holding his own lower jaw, asking for help putting it back.	1
3	A family restitches great-grandfather at the kitchen table and offers you supper beside him.	1
4	An eel you swallowed is still moving, low in the belly, for an hour.	1
5	A Wick Tallow candle in your room screams very quietly whenever you turn a page.	2
6	A sack drifts up from the Sump, the rope cut, and knocks against the punt. It is weeping.	2
7	Bubbles rise around the boat in a perfect circle, then a spiral, then letters.	2
8	A woman sits on a doorstep picking maggots from her husband's face; she smiles and asks how far gone you are.	2
9	Marrow Jack's stock: a cupboard of hands, labeled, some of them still gripping.	2
10	A Kept man walks toward the Finishing Post, weeping; a Kept woman runs after him, begging.	3
11	In the Lofts, every shelved body in an aisle turns its wrapped head toward you and whispers "company."	3
12	Something in the fen takes your ankle and only holds on, for an hour, while you tug.	2
13	The Smoking Ground: a coal-black child walks out of the steam and asks if you have seen its mother.	3
14	A pilgrimage of Finishers passes, singing; one of them is someone you know.	3
15	A Kept body sold in the Sinks for meat, lively, twitching on the hook, and the buyer is haggling.	3
16	A Heir cell drags a bound old man toward the Smoking Ground; he is calling one of them by a child's pet name.	3
17	The edge of a new Hush, crossing the road you are on, a pace a minute, in total silence.	4
18	You wake to find a Hand-line child's grey fingers resting gently over your eyes.	3
19	A jar from the Jar Room, stolen and dumped in a canal, a face pressed to the green glass, mouthing.	3
20	Total silence falls on you, alone. No sound at all, for a full minute. Then your heart, much too loud.	4

WE ATE THE GOD THAT CLOSES, AND SO NOTHING
CLOSES. NOT THE WOUND, NOT THE ARGUMENT,
NOT THE GRIEF, NOT THE DOOR. AND NOW, AT LAST, THE DOOR.

[CONFESSOR AMBROSE WEAL, THE FIRST AND ONLY SERMON AFTER THE
RESTITUTION]



CHAPTER 4

THE FATLANDS

The Table That Eats Back

There is no word in our dialect for full. We had one. We ate it.

– FATLANDS JOKE, TOLD AT EVERY TABLE

Thank you, Long Acre. Thank you, Granny Hessop's Rise. Thank you, Father, who is on the plate.

– A WAKE-GRACE FROM LOW TILTH, AS RECORDED BY THE CUTWRIGHTS' COLLEGE, 588 A.G.

Is there any more?

– THE LAST WORDS OF THE MEAL, ACCORDING TO THE ORCHARD SONG; ALSO WHAT EVERY FATLAND CHILD SAYS AT THE END OF EVERY SUPPER, AS A PLEASANTRY, SMILING



The fat was the first thing. Mam always said so, and Mam was right about the fat: you start a man at the fat, because the fat remembers the fire best.

We laid Da on the big board at noon, the day after he went, with the shutters wide so the neighbours could see we had nothing to hide and no meanness in us. The board had been scrubbed with salt and hot water at dawn until the grain stood up white, and Mam had laid the good linen under him, the linen she was married on, so that he would not be lying on bare wood like a pig at market. Hob Gristle came out from Sated to do the jointing, because Da had been a weighty man and a deacon of the Weighhouse and you do not let your cousins hack at a deacon. Hob kissed the knife. He kissed Da's brow. He said, "Sorry, Wilm. Sorry, old lad. Sorry," every time the blade went in, under his breath, like a man saying a grace he did not believe but could not stop.

Da came apart beautifully. That is what everyone said after. The skin lifted off the shoulder in one sheet, gold underneath, the fat as thick as three fingers laid flat and white as a new cheese, marbled with pink threads like a map of rivers. There was a smell from him even raw, a sweet one, grass and warm butter and the inside of a barn in Plenty, because Da had eaten Long Acre his whole life and Long Acre is famous. You could see the field in him. Everyone said so. They pressed in at the windows and said so. Old Ma Tibbet from three doors down put her hand flat on the sill and breathed in through her nose with her eyes shut, the way you breathe at a bakery door, and said, "Oh, Wilm. Oh, you lovely man."

We rendered the belly first. It went into the big copper over the yard fire and it sighed when it hit the heat, and the yard filled

up with the smell of him, rich and brown and bottomless, and the dogs all lay down flat in the lane and whined. The fat went clear in the copper by degrees, the white going glassy at the edges and then gold, and little bubbles came up through it slow as a man thinking, and on the top a scum of something pinkish gathered that Mam said was his temper, and skimmed off, and gave to the dogs, because you do not eat a man's temper. My sister Petty skimmed the dripping with Mam's wedding ladle. She cried the whole time and kept tasting it. You could not blame her. Nobody could have blamed her.

The legs went on the spit. Hob had scored the skin in diamonds and rubbed salt and crushed sage into the cuts, and as they turned they spat and crackled and the skin blistered up into golden bubbles that popped when you pressed them and ran clear grease down your wrist. The hands went into the pie, with onions and the little purple turnips that grow along Granny Hessop's Rise, because that is the custom for a man who worked with his hands. Mam made the crust herself. She crimped the edge with her thumb, all the way round, and put a pastry wheatsheaf on the lid, and then she stood and looked at it for a long time with her floury hands held up in front of her like a surgeon's, and then she put it in the oven. The heart was mine to cook, as eldest. I seared it in its own fat until the outside cracked like toffee and the inside was the colour of a plum, and I sliced it thin and laid the slices out on the blue plate that came from Mam's mother, overlapping, like scales, the way he would have wanted. When I cut it, it was still warm in the middle. When I put the first slice in my mouth it was so good that I sat down on the floor.

I am telling you the truth. It was the best thing I have ever eaten. It tasted of being twelve and being lifted onto his

shoulders at the Weighing. It tasted of his pipe. It tasted of the time he beat me with the strap for losing the heifer and then sat up all night on the end of my bed, saying nothing, with his big hand on my ankle. It ran down my chin and I did not wipe it.

By dusk there were sixty at the board and the yard was slick with drip and the copper had been refilled twice. The Bailiff came round to see the Feasting Laws were kept and there was nothing for him to do, so he sat and ate a rib of Da with tears on his big soft face and said Wilm Callock was the finest-marbled man in the parish, and he would know. Petty had stopped crying and was eating with both hands. Mam was eating with both hands. I was eating with both hands. The children were under the board, sucking the knuckle-bones, which is what the knuckle-bones are for. Somebody started the wake-song and everyone took it up, remember, he was soft, remember, he was sweet, with their mouths full, so that it came out thick and wet, like a hymn sung under water.

And I was hungry. That is the thing nobody tells you before your first wake, though they all know it. I ate my father from

noon until the Plate came up, and every mouthful was the best mouthful of my life, and I was exactly as hungry at the end as I was at the start. Hungrier. Because now I knew what he tasted like and there was no more of him.

Late on, when the board was down to bones, I went out to Long Acre on my own. The field was sweating in the dark. I knelt and put my face to the soil and it was warm as a cheek and it moved, slowly, up and down, like something sleeping. I said, "Thank you, Long Acre." I said, "We are giving him back to you, we are, what's left, I promise." The furrow under my mouth opened a little. Just a little. Just enough for me to feel the teeth in it, small ones, wheat-teeth, rows and rows of them, all along the ground, all through the dark, as far as the Plate could light. They did not bite. They only touched my lips, very lightly, all together, the way a dog touches your hand with its mouth to say it knows you.

Then I went home and had the marrow, because the marrow had been saved for me.

— FROM THE COMMONPLACE BOOK OF ABEL CALLOCK, LOW TILTH, CARVING
639 A.G.; GIVEN TO THE BOARD'S PHYSICIAN "AS EVIDENCE OF NOTHING IN
PARTICULAR"



*We do not bury good meat in a country where the
ground is already so full.*

THE PREAMBLE TO THE WAKE ORDINANCE, 131 A.G.

▼ THE MEAL

Every land on the Table remembers its Gorging as something done slowly, in shame, with stops for vomiting and prayer. The Fatlands remember theirs as a party.

That is the first thing outsiders find unbearable, and it is true. In the ninth winter of the Long Lack the southern plains were a grey crust of dead clay from the Brawn to the sea. The people had eaten their seed, then their oxen, then their boots, then the thatch, and by the last Tablenight they were eating the clay itself, baked into flat cakes that cracked teeth and stopped the bowels. The chronicles keep a list of what was eaten in that winter, set out like a bill of fare with the dates beside it, and it is the most frightening document in the Board's archive: *bark of elm, boiled; harness, cut in strips; the glue of bookbindings; candles; the hair of the dead, in broth; the dog; the other dog; clay with salt; clay.* Women's milk failed; infants were nursed on blood let from their mothers' arms. In the village that later became Dimble, the chronicle notes that the people "did draw

lots for one another, and kept faith with the lots," and does not say more, and does not need to.

Their god had come down out of the hills to lie among them in the field called the Trencher, because there was nowhere else for it to go. Ummer, the Laden, the Harvest Walker, had once been so vast with plenty that the furrows bent toward it like grass toward a wind. By that winter it was a long grey heap of sagging hide, a hill of skin on a frame of ribs like a collapsed barn, breathing a little. Its belly, which the oldest carvings show swollen with sheaves and calves and fruit, lay empty and folded on the earth like a dropped sack. Its many hands, which had broken bread off its own shoulders for the world, lay open in the clay, palm up. Children were sent to sit in them for warmth. The hands did not close. The people sat around it for forty days, the chronicles say, and the god's breath came slower and slower, and smelled at the end of nothing at all, which was the worst smell anyone had known: a smell of an empty larder, of a cold

oven, of a bowl that has been licked so long it has no taste left even of the licking.



Elm bark. Harness. The glue of books. The dog. The other dog. Clay with salt. Clay.

THE WINTER LIST, AS READ ALOUD IN THE
WEIGHHOUSE EACH TABLENIGHT

The Fatland chronicles, which were written down in the Sweet Reigns by people who had been told by people who had been there, insist that nobody gave an order. A girl named Wenna Strake, aged about sixteen, walked out across the Trencher at dusk with a flint sickle, and the crowd watched her go, and she knelt by Ummer's flank and looked into the one great clouded eye that faced her, and said, "Lack keep away." Then she cut. The god did not move. Its eye, every account says, was wet and kind and *pleased*, the way a mother's face is pleased when a child at last takes the spoon.

The first cut opened on fat. It is the one detail every version keeps. Under a god's hide that had been starving for nine years, there was still, impossibly, a layer of gold, a hand deep, as though Ummer had kept one last larder against exactly this night and saved it for them. Wenna Strake put her hand into the cut to the wrist and drew it out glistening and put her fingers in her mouth, and the chronicle says she made a sound "like one who has been struck very gently on the heart," and then she sat down in the clay and began to laugh and could not stop.

They ate it in a night. They ate it fastest of all the peoples. The chronicles linger on this with a horrible, unashamed relish that the College has never managed to edit out. They describe the hide, which peeled away in sheets the size of sails and was found to be lined with a layer of golden fat a hand deep, still faintly warm, smelling of cut hay and new bread and the inside of a dairy. They describe how the people, who had eaten clay for a season, tore at the fat raw and wept as it melted on their tongues, sliding down throats that had forgotten how to swallow anything soft; how the meat beneath was dark and dense and so full of juice that it ran in the furrows, red-brown and steaming, and children lay on their bellies and lapped it from the clay like puppies; how whole families crawled bodily into the cavity of the ribs to get at the organs, and came out painted to the shoulder, hair slicked flat with blood and lymph, grinning, with lumps of liver in both fists; how fires were lit all over the Trencher and the smoke rose so thick and sweet that birds dropped out of it, gorged on the air alone. There was singing. There was dancing in the grease. Old men who had buried every child they had danced with their mouths full.

Some of them died of it. The chronicle, for once, is honest. Bodies that had eaten clay for a season could not hold a god; bellies burst, hearts stopped with the shock of plenty, and an old woman named Gammer Rusk choked on a gobbet of the god's tongue and

was found at dawn still smiling around it. The dead were not mourned that night. They were *eaten*, where they fell, by their neighbours, and nobody could afterward say whose meat was whose, which is why the Fatlands still say, of any fortunate death: *she went on the Trencher*.

Ummer's bones were cracked on the field-stones for the marrow before dawn. The marrow was yellow, and sweet as honey, and it is said that those who sucked it never afterward grew old in the face, only in the body. The skull was split with mattocks. The brain was shared out a spoonful each to the elders, grey-pink, trembling on the spoon like a custard, tasting (one elder told the chronicler, in old age) "of every harvest-home there ever was, all at once, so that you could not tell which year you were in." The eyes were last. They were the size of cartwheels, and wept when they were lifted, and were found to be full of a clear sweet jelly that set like aspic in the cold. Nothing was wasted. Not the hooves, not the hide, not the eyes. That is the Fatlands' founding boast, still carved over the doors of the Weighhouse in Sated: NOTHING WAS LEFT.

The families who reached the middle first, and took the stomach, the paunch, the long coils of the entrails, and the great swollen liver, became the Gut-lines. Some say they won those portions by strength. Others say the god's insides *came to them*, sliding out of the opened belly toward particular hands. The chronicles record, without comment, that the stomach was still working when it was eaten. It had been empty for nine years. It was digesting whatever it touched. Those who ate it had blistered mouths for a month, and the women who carried the entrails out in their arms lost the skin of their forearms to the elbow and grew it back, the chronicle says, "thicker, and of a warmer colour." The Gut-lines still bear it. Look at the inside of a great lady's wrist in Sated and you will see the skin there faintly ridged, faintly ruddy, like a rind.

The famine ended the next morning. The clay of the Trencher was black and soft and steaming by sunrise. By noon there were green shoots across the whole plain. Within a week the wheat stood shoulder-high, and that was the Week of Rising, and nobody asked what it was wheat *of*.

One detail is preserved only in a single fragmentary song, sung in the Bleeding Orchards at pruning time, and the Board has twice tried to forbid it. It says that when the feasters had finished, and lay on the Trencher in the grey light, too heavy to move, every one of them woke at the same moment with the same thought. It was not guilt. It was not grief. The song gives it in four words, and the Orchard-keepers sing them very softly: *Is there any more?*

Wenna walked out with the flint, and the flint was cold, and the field was grey;

the god looked up with its one wet eye and it did not turn away.

Wenna cut, and the fat came gold, and the dark came down like a lid,

and we ate the god from the hoof to the horn, and I'll tell you what we did:

we ate the hand that fed us, love, and we licked the hand that fed;

we cracked the bone and we drank the eye and we spooned the sweet grey head.

And in the morning, grey and still, we woke up every one, and we all of us said the same four words, before the rising sun.

– THE ORCHARD SONG, AS SUNG AT SAPWELL; THE LAST VERSE IS NOT WRITTEN DOWN, AND IS SUNG WITH THE HANDS ONLY

WHAT HAPPENED TO WENNA STRAKE

The chronicles say nothing of Wenna Strake after the Meal. She cut first, and was honoured, and vanishes. The Field Church teaches that she was given the first marrow and walked off into the risen wheat and was taken up into the god, a saint of the knife; there is a niche for her in every parish church, empty, with a flint in it. The Board's oldest registers list a *Strake, W., widow* paying Plate-Tithe on an orchard plot east of Sated until 140 A.G., and then nothing. Orchard-keepers at Sapwell will tell a stranger, with their hands, that the Old Grove is where she went, and that the trees there are her. They say it the way people tell a fairy story. They do not let strangers prune in the Old Grove.

UMMER IN THE OLD CARVINGS

Before the Gorging, Ummer was carved on every granary lintel on the plains: a broad, stooping, many-handed figure walking ahead of the plough, with sheaves sprouting from its shoulders and a belly like a full cart. In the few carvings that survive whole, it walks in procession with the other Providers. The Gut-lines prefer not to display these. One reason is obvious: Ummer is shown *feeding* the others from its own body, breaking off pieces of its shoulder and handing them along the line. The other reason is less discussed. In every surviving procession, there is a figure walking just behind Ummer, very close, with its hand on the Laden's back. That figure has been chiselled away to the bare stone. In the oldest carving in the Fatlands, over the root-cellar of a ruined granary at Dimble, the chisel slipped, and a little of the hand remains. It is very long, and it is open, palm up, the way you hold out a hand for more.



You count the hands on a granary lintel and you get one more than there are gods. My granda used to say that, and then he'd laugh, and then he'd stop.

A STONEMASON OF DIMBLE

THE WEEK OF RISING

The plain did not merely recover. It *answered*. On the first morning the Trencher steamed like a pudding lifted from the cloth, and the soil bled a little around a spade and closed over the hole in an hour. By the third night the shoots could be heard growing, a sound like many people breathing out through their noses. On the seventh day the first loaf of the Fatlands came out of a clay oven at Dimble with a crust that crackled like pork skin and a crumb that pulled apart in long, moist, pink-tinged threads, and the woman who baked it, tasting it, began to cry, and nobody could get her to say why.

The cattle came back the same week, though nobody had any cattle left to breed. Herds were found standing in the morning fields, silent, sleek, wet, as though calved from the ground in the night. The chronicle calls them "the gift-beasts." It mentions, in passing, that the first of them had no navels.



Nobody asked what it was wheat of. Nobody asks now. That is what being Fatland means.

DR. EMMERICH PAUNCH, PRIVATE NOTEBOOK

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

Everything here is meat, and nobody is ever full.

Those nine words are the whole of Fatland law, Fatland faith and Fatland misery, and every child can recite them before it can count. They are sewn on samplers, stamped on the lids of Board flour-barrels, and chalked over the doors of cookshops; children skip to them in the lanes of Sated (*everything here is MEAT, and nobody is EVER full*, a jump on each stress), and the old say them over a

finished plate the way other lands say *amen*. What they mean in practice takes longer.

EVERYTHING IS MEAT

The soil of the Fatlands is Ummer's flesh, scattered and buried and grown back, and it grows flesh in turn. Nothing that comes out of the ground here is entirely vegetable. Wheat stands in the field in golden ranks and looks, from the road, like any wheat on the Table;

split an ear and you find each grain sheathed in a little moist pink gum, and in the gum, a tooth. Toothed wheat has been the only wheat for four centuries. Milled, it makes a heavy, sweet, faintly salty flour that bakes into bread with a crust like crackling and a crumb that tears in long fibres, like pulled shoulder. The teeth are sieved out at the mill. Most of them are milk teeth. Not all.

A Fatland loaf deserves a page to itself, because nothing else on the Table is like it. The dough, kneaded, is warm before it is proved; it is the colour of a baby's palm and it *resists*, a little, under the heel of the hand, the way muscle resists, and bakers say a good dough "pushes back like a sleeping dog." It rises without yeast. Left in its bowl under a cloth it swells and subsides, swells and subsides, slowly, and a careful baker times the oven by counting the breaths. In the heat it does not so much brown as *sear*: the crust goes deep amber and blisters and cracks into plates that shatter in the teeth with a sound like stepping on frost, and the smell coming out of a Fatland bakery at dawn is not the smell of bread at all but of roasting, of a joint basted in its own fat, with something underneath like warm milk and clean scalp. Broken open, the crumb steams. It is faintly pink at the heart, and moist, and threaded with long pale fibres that pull apart in the fingers like slow-cooked shoulder; and it tastes of salt and butter and something deep and savoury that coats the back of the tongue and will not go away, so that a foreigner eating Fatland bread for the first time typically stops after the first mouthful, puts the loaf down, stares at it, and then eats the whole of it without speaking.



A good dough pushes back like a sleeping dog. A great dough growls.

SAMPLER IN A BAKERY ON LADLE LANES

Orchard trees bleed when they are pruned: a slow, dark, clotting sap that scabs over in a day. Their fruit has a skin, a layer of soft white fat under it, firm pink flesh beneath that, and at the core a pit that is unmistakably bone, ridged and porous and full of a sweet grey marrow children suck out with straws. A ripe Orchard pear, bitten, gives under the teeth in three stages, like a cut of good belly: the thin crisp skin, then the slippery cool yield of the fat, then the dense sweet meat with its grain running lengthwise, and the juice is pink and runs to the elbow and smells of rose and of a butcher's apron. Root vegetables have veins. A beet pulled from the ground pulses faintly in the hand for a minute or two before it stops, and is warm, and the cut face of it glistens and beads with a dark bright juice that will not wash out of linen. Onions have a membrane between every layer, and if you cut them too slowly they flinch. Cabbages are warm

in the middle, and the inmost leaves are slick and folded tight over one another like the lids of a sleeping eye. Potatoes, the poor's food, grow in clusters joined by gristle, and when the clusters are pulled apart the cut ends sweat clear lymph. Turnips scream very faintly when boiled; cooks put a lid on.

Dig a well and you strike something that flinches. Every Fatland well is lined with salt-glazed brick, and the water drawn from it is warm, slightly cloudy, and tastes of broth. Drive a fencepost too deep and the ground around it will be bruised purple by morning. Ploughs do not so much turn the soil as *open* it, and the furrow behind the share is red-brown and glistening and smells, in the heat, of a butcher's block. Ploughmen walk barefoot behind the share by preference, because the furrow is warm and soft and closes gently around the ankle like a hand; their feet are stained to the shin a deep oxblood that never comes off, and in Low Tilt a girl will look at a lad's ankles before she looks at his face.

The livestock is the strangest of all, because livestock should be the one thing that was meat already. The cattle of the Fatlands are enormous, sleek, docile and silent. They do not low. They watch. Drovers say a Fatland steer will follow a man anywhere if he walks ahead of it eating, and the Renderers' Union does not employ anyone who has spent too long looking a steer in the eye. Pigs are hairless and pale, with long lashes, and they lie in their sties in rows on their sides like sleepers in a dormitory and breathe in unison. Chickens lay eggs with a heartbeat; a Fatland breakfast egg, cracked into the pan, twitches once in the fat before it sets. Nobody asks what the cattle eat in the far pastures when they are out of sight, because the answer is grass, and the grass here has teeth.

And all of it, every mouthful, is delicious. This must be understood or nothing about the Fatlands will make sense. There is no bad food in the south. The poorest gristle-potato boiled in well-water is better than a lord's feast in Oathen. Fatland bread, broken hot, is so good that foreign travellers have been known to weep at the first bite and refuse to leave the inn. The Fatlands are the breadbasket and the meat-locker of half the Table, and every land that buys from them knows, at some level it does not visit, that it is buying the Laden god by the pound.

THINGS IN THE WHEAT

The teeth are the least of it. Every harvest the threshers, the gleaners and the millers' sieves turn up other things, and every family on the plain has a jar on a shelf of oddments the field gave back. Most are thrown away. Some are kept, wrapped in a clean cloth, and brought out at wakes. A few are carried to the Long Count, or to Granny Cracknel, or to the Bailiff, depending on who the finder trusts.

D20 FOUND IN THE TOOTHED WHEAT	
1	A set of milk teeth, entire, rooted in a single ear in perfect order, as if the mouth had dissolved around them.
2	A wedding ring, worn thin, still warm, threaded on a stalk that has grown <i>through</i> it.

D20	FOUND IN THE TOOTHED WHEAT
3	An ear that bleeds when husked; the grains inside are the pale pink of a fingertip and have tiny, perfect nails.
4	A tuft of grey beard, tied at the root with blue thread in the knot a Bailiff ties on his sash.
5	A molar with a silver filling; the village has one dentist, and he knows whose it is.
6	A whole stalk that is a single long braid of fine fair hair, golden as the wheat around it, ending in a ribbon.
7	A clay pipe, the bowl still faintly warm and smelling of a particular tobacco; a widow will know it.
8	An ear that opens like an eye when the sun touches it, and follows the reaper down the row.
9	A Cullmaster's red cloth, rotted almost through, with the wheat grown up through it in a straight line, like a hem.
10	A child's wooden spoon, gnawed; the gnaw-marks are too wide for a child.
11	A sheaf that, when bound, is found to have a pulse; it beats slower and slower over an hour and stops.
12	A numbered stone from the Dusk Acres, a mile from where it belongs, with fresh soil packed into the numerals.
13	A tongue, small and pink and wet, folded in the husk like a seed; it is still tasting.
14	A strip of embroidered smock-lace with a name stitched in it by a mother, the way mothers mark children's clothes.
15	Fingernails, a whole handful, threaded on the stalks at intervals like beads on an abacus.
16	A Long Count tally-stick, notched, buried upright at the field's corner by someone who wanted the field to see it.
17	An ear whose grains are all eyes, milky blue, closed; they open together if anyone says the word <i>more</i> .
18	A single tooth from the sieve of someone the finder knows to be alive and well, and who smiles at them that evening at supper.
19	A child's shoe, laces done up, standing upright in the furrow, with the soil inside still warm and faintly moving.
20	A slab of soft golden fat, a hand deep, wrapped in a husk the size of a sail; it smells of cut hay and new bread and a dairy, and anyone who smells it is hungry for a week (+2 Hunger, no roll).



You keep the ring. You throw away the finger. That's manners.

A GLEANER'S MOTHER, LOW TILTH

NOBODY IS EVER FULL

A Fatlander can eat until the belly splits, and some do, and still feel the hunger exactly as before.

Hunger here has no connection to the stomach. It is not a signal that the body needs food; it is a *presence*, the god's own nine-year famine, inherited and shared out through ten thousand bloodlines like the meat itself. It sits beneath the breastbone and gnaws. It wakes children in the night. It interrupts weddings and funerals and sermons and acts of love. Eating soothes it the way scratching soothes an itch: wonderfully, for exactly as long as you are doing it, and then not at all.

Fatlanders describe it with the precision of people who have had nothing else to compare. It is *a band in the chest, open*. It is *a mouth under the ribs that can taste what my mouth tastes, and wants more of it*. It is *like missing someone, but in the belly*. The Field Church calls it *the Godward Ache* and preaches that it is Ummer's love,

longing to be fed back. The Thin call it the god's starvation, which we stole, and which we owe. Children call it *the Grumble* and give it a face in their drawings: a round, wide-mouthed, smiling thing that sits inside a stick-figure's tummy with its arms open.

The Fatlands have therefore built a civilization around eating constantly. Five meals a day are mandatory under the Feasting Laws, and the poor fit four more around them if they can. Field-hands chew strips of salt fat as they work, and the rhythm of a reaping gang is set by the jaws as much as the arms. Clerks keep bowls of cracklings at their elbows; the Weighhouse ledgers are speckled with grease-spots, and Board scribes are trained to write left-handed so the right can feed. Every inn and every house keeps a pot on the hob at all hours, and it is never allowed to empty; some family pots have not been empty in a hundred years, and are said to have a grandmother in them still, in the black crust at the bottom where the spoon cannot reach. Waste is unthinkable. Refusal is sedition. A thin Fatlander is either sick, criminal, or one of the Thin, and in the eyes of the law these are the same thing.

The people are, accordingly, huge. A healthy labourer of the Scrapling class might weigh three hundred pounds. A prosperous merchant, five hundred. The Gut-lines nobility begin at a thousand and do not stop. Fatland architecture is wide, low, and ramped. Fatland chairs are benches, Fatland doors are double, Fatland floors are joisted like bridges. In Sated there is a profession, the Carriers, of

men and women employed to lift and turn the great, and another, the Washers, who clean the folds.

The Washers' work is not discussed at table, which in the Fatlands means it is very bad indeed. A great body folds upon itself like dough worked in a bowl, and in the deep creases, warm and dark and never aired, things grow: a white cheesy rind lifted with a wooden spatula, the green shoots of the Course, a sweet fermenting smell like a cider-press in a hot barn. In the deepest folds the Washers find things the great have lost there: a ring, a spoon, a letter, once a lap-dog, long dead, preserved in a waxy sheath and smelling of roses. Washers are paid more than surgeons, and almost all go a little strange; they are known for laughing at nothing, and for scrubbing their own hands until they bleed.



Inside the fourth fold of Madam's left side there is a whole summer. You can smell it. Flowers, and hay, and something that died in the hay.

A WASHER OF THE FOLD, TO A CUTWRIGHT
SURVEYOR

THE LAND ALSO EATS

The god was the god of harvest, and a harvest has two halves. The land gives. Then it takes.

Each Carving, as the fields come ripe, people go missing from every village. They go out in the field at dusk and are not back by morning. They leave no footprints going anywhere but out. Sometimes a boot is found in a furrow, standing upright, laces still

tied. Sometimes a hat in the wheat, or a sickle with a polished handle, or a set of clothes laid neatly in the shape of a body, flat and empty, with the soil beneath them dark and wet and freshly turned. More often there is nothing at all. This is called the Reaping.

The official explanation is wolves. Every Board proclamation since 300 A.G. has said so, and the Board employs a Wolf-Warden in every district, who files a report each autumn describing tracks, sightings and depredations. There are no wolves in the Fatlands. There have never been any in living memory or written record. Nothing in the Fatlands is anything but crop.

RETURN OF THE WOLF-WARDEN FOR THE PARISH OF HASK'S END, CARVING 639.

Wolves seen: none. Wolves heard: none. Tracks: none, the ground having been soft.

Persons taken by wolves: nine (9). Names appended.

Manner: wolves.

Condition of remains: none remaining, excepting one (1) pair of clogs, one (1) bonnet, one (1) set of clothes laid out flat in the Long Strip as though the wearer had lain down in them and gone out of them, which I have returned to the family.

Measures taken: lanterns; bells; a dog, which would not go into the field and has since run off.

Recommendation: wolves.

I have the honour to remain the Board's servant. I wish to be relieved. I have written this nineteen years. I have never seen a wolf. My hand writes it on its own now.

— BOARD ARCHIVE, REGISTRY CLOSE; THE LAST TWO LINES ARE STRUCK
THROUGH IN A DIFFERENT INK, AND INITIALLED "V.S."

Those who have watched a Reaping happen and kept their minds describe it with a terrible consistency. It is always dusk. The light goes amber, then red, and the heat lifts off the soil in a haze that smells of hot fat. The field goes still; the wind drops; the wheat stops whispering. The labourer is usually alone, or at the far end of a row from the others, bent to the work. And then the field *leans*. Every ear of wheat for fifty yards turns toward them at once, slowly, like a congregation turning to look at a latecomer. There is a sound one witness compared to a crowd of people chewing with their mouths shut. The soil around their feet softens to the consistency of warm suet and they sink to the ankle, and then to the knee, and they do not, by most accounts, struggle much; their faces go slack and grateful, the way a tired man's face goes slack when he lowers himself into a hot bath. The wheat closes over them. The ears move against the body, in and out, all of them, all over. There is a wet, comfortable, rhythmic noise, which goes on for some time. Then the field stands up straight again and the wind comes back and the wheat whispers, and next year that strip of field yields half again

what the rest does, and the bread from it tastes, faintly, of the person.

Witnesses who were close enough add details the Board would prefer they did not. That the wheat does not cut; it *suckles*, a thousand small soft pink-gummed mouths working at once, so that the skin of the Reaped goes first to gooseflesh and then to something like wet paper, and then is simply not there, and the red underneath is drawn out in fine threads into the ears, like milk through straws. That the bones go last, and slowly, and soften first, so that a Reaped arm raised above the wheat (it happens; it is not a struggle, the witnesses insist, it is a *wave*) bends at the forearm in a place where there is no joint, and droops, and is drawn down. That the Reaped sometimes speak, at the end, and what they say is always food: *Is that bacon? Is someone frying? Mam, is it supper?* That afterward, for an hour, the patch of ground is warm as a bed somebody has just got out of, and gives off a smell of fresh bread,

and anyone who kneels there will feel, under their palms, the slow contented pulse of something digesting.

Families know. Everyone knows. You can tell a Reaped man's row by the colour of the ears: a little redder, a little heavier, nodding lower. The widow of a Reaped man will often ask the miller to keep that strip's flour separate, and bakes it into a single loaf on Tablenight, and the family eats it together, slowly, in the dark, and says his name. The loaf is called a **name-loaf**. It is always the best bread of the year. Children who have eaten a parent's name-loaf say that for one mouthful they could hear them, very close, the way you can hear someone breathing on the other side of a pillow.

THE REAPING IN PLAY

The Reaping is not a monster to be fought; it is weather, and it is the god. A character caught alone in a ripe Fatland field between sunset and full dark in Carving may be Reaped. The GM should make it a slow, sensory scene, never a surprise kill. First the stillness (Eye + Search, Routine, to notice). Then the leaning (Dread 3 to witness; Dread 2 for a Fatlander, who has grown up with it). Then the softening ground: the victim must succeed at Caul + Resolve (Hard 14; Grim 18 if their Hunger is 6 or more, because the field *smells like dinner*) or stop wanting to leave. A character who fails may be dragged out by companions with Gut + Labor (Grim 18), but the field holds on: each round in the soil deals 1d6 Flesh as the ground begins, gently, to digest. A character who is Reaped is gone. What is pulled out after full dark is not a corpse, only a shape of clothes and a smell of bread. Fatlanders of Cut 3+ can sometimes feel which fields are hungry on a given night (Caul + Godsign, Hard 14).

◇
Mam, is it supper?

THE COMMONEST LAST WORDS IN THE LONG
COUNT'S MARGINS

▼ THE REGROWTH IN THE FATLANDS

Ummer is growing back, and what grows back is a field.

Every land's Regrowth is a return of the god's nature. Ummer's nature was abundance: the slow, rooted, generative patience of soil, which takes in what dies and gives it back as food. In the Fatlands the god does not wear its people so much as *plant* them. The Cutwrights' College calls the southern Regrowth "the most orderly on the Table," because its stages arrive in strict sequence and never skip. Fatlanders call it simply getting heavy. *She's getting heavy*, they say, of a grandmother whose feet have begun to itch, and they say it proudly, and pat her hand, and bring her another plate.

THE TASTE

Hunger that wakes you. Every Fatlander has the god's hunger by day; at the Taste it begins to come in the night as well, a hollow ache that drags you up out of sleep with your mouth already working. Children chew their sleeves into rags, then their bedding, then the soft wood of the cot-rail. Mothers sew bone rings into nightshirt cuffs to give them something better to gnaw. Adults wake with the taste of soil on their tongues and cannot remember the dream. The breath begins to smell faintly of the fields, of grass and dung and rising dough. It is considered a healthy sign, and courting couples are told to look for it.

The dreams, when they are remembered, are all of the same kind. A long table in a field at dusk, laid for more people than are sitting

at it. A smell of roasting coming from somewhere just over the next furrow. A voice, warm and kindly, from under the ground, asking if you have had enough. Fatland mothers ask their children at breakfast, *Did you dream the table?*, the way mothers in other lands ask about a fever; and the child who says *yes* is given an extra egg.

THE APPETITE

Eating without choosing. At the Appetite the hand goes to the mouth before the mind has agreed: a bite of tallow candle, a mouthful of earth from a flowerpot, the corner of a leather glove, a twist of one's own hair. The sufferer will eat soap, wax, string, paper, chalk, rope, coal, and can digest a good deal of it. They cannot stop for conversation. They eat through sermons, through lovemaking, through their own children's weddings, and they weep while they do it, because they can taste everything and everything is wonderful. Fatland courts have recognized "the Appetite" as a defence to theft since 312 A.G., provided the stolen article was eaten in full. Clerks with the Appetite keep their ledgers chained, because the ink is made from rendered fat. At this stage, many begin to want meat that is not animal. They smell the living. They notice, without wishing to, how a neighbour's forearm would carve.

Those who live with the Appetite learn its marks. The lips crack and never heal, because they are always being licked. The fingertips of the far gone are nibbled to soft pink nubs, nail and all, and many

wear thimbles of bone on every finger to chew instead. And their eyes change: they rest on a baby's fat wrist, on the back of a farmhand's neck in the sun, on the soft inner elbow of a girl reaching for the salt, with a look that is not lust and not malice but something older and simpler and much more frightening, the look of a hungry person reading a bill of fare.



*My husband looks at me like I'm the Sunday joint.
Twenty years. I used to think it was love. I still think
it's love. That's what frightens me.*

A FARMWIFE OF THE EASTERN PLAIN

THE COURSE

The body swells past all proportion and the feet begin to put down roots. These people are called the Laden, after the god, and in the Gut-lines it is a title.

The swelling is not ordinary fat. It is soft, cool, slightly granular to the touch, and it gives under the finger like freshly turned loam and holds the print for hours. Press harder and it crumbles a little at the surface, and what crumbles is dark and moist and smells of rain on a ploughed field, and the hole fills slowly back from beneath, like a footprint in wet sand. The skin darkens to brown and red, mottled like a field seen from a hill. Hair thickens and coarsens into something fibrous, dry, straw-coloured, that rustles when the head turns. Small green shoots appear in the creases of the elbow and behind the knees; the Washers pluck them daily, and they grow back overnight. The Laden sweat a clear, sweet, faintly sticky fluid that draws flies and bees. They grow warm. A Laden person's bed is warm for a day after they leave it, and nothing stored beneath it spoils.

Things live in them. That is the part not printed in the Field Church's tracts. Earthworms are found in the deep folds of the Laden, pink and fat and slow, and the Washers pick them out with tweezers and lay them in a dish, and the Laden ask, very politely, to be given them back, and eat them. Beetles. Small white grubs. Once, in the Fold, a mouse's nest, with the young still blind, in the warm hollow under a great lord's arm, where he said he had felt them moving for a week "like a second heartbeat, very sweet." The College's surveyors record that at the Course the body temperature of the Laden rises to that of a compost heap in Plenty, and that a thermometer pushed into the flesh of the thigh will read hotter the deeper it goes.

The roots come last. They start as pale, hair-thin threads from the soles of the feet, and the Laden feel them as a pleasant tingling that becomes, over months, a desperate wish to stand still. If a Laden person stands on bare ground for an hour, the threads go down. If they stand for a day, the threads thicken into cords. Pulling free tears skin, and the cords bleed, and it hurts in a way the Laden

describe as being torn out of a warm bed in Lack. Most Laden of the Gut-lines are moved on drays with iron floors, because iron is the one thing roots will not take in. Most Laden of the poor are simply allowed to plant.

THE BRINK

At the Brink the Laden person is more field than flesh. They are rooted somewhere and cannot be moved without killing them; their bulk spreads outward into the soil and the soil rises to meet it. The face sinks into the mound of the body. The limbs are hummocks. The eyes cloud green. Crops grow on them, densely, without being sown. A Brink-Laden can still speak, though slowly and from deep in the chest, and still eats, endlessly, and everything around them grows: the grass in a ring of thirty yards around a Brink-Laden is waist-high and toothed, and the wheat leans toward them when they speak. Visitors sometimes feel the ground pulse in time with the Brink-Laden's heart. In the last weeks the person begins to forget their own name and to remember, instead, the names of the fields around them, and the names of those who have been Reaped into those fields.

Families feed the Brink-Laden by hand, kneeling. The mouth is low in the mound by then, sometimes at ground level, lipped with turf where the beard was, and the family lays the food on the tongue the way you lay a coin in a slot, and the mouth closes and works for a long time with a sound of grinding, of wet gravel turned by a spade. Grandchildren are lifted up to kiss them goodnight, on the forehead, which is a soft warm patch of clover with two green-clouded eyes in it. Some Brink-Laden weep. The tears are sweet and attract bees, and in the Fold the very old Gut-lines families keep hives on the Brink-Laden's flanks, and the honey is dark, and sold at a great price as *grandmother honey*, and tastes of a long life ending.



*I asked Gran if it hurt. She said no, love, it's like being
a bed somebody nice is sleeping in. Then she asked me
my name.*

A CHILD OF THE FOLD, AGED NINE

THE SEATING

A Laden person stops being a person and becomes a place: a low hill, warm to the touch, where things grow very well. Some keep a mouth.

There is no single moment of Seating. The family notices, one morning, that Gran has stopped speaking and the hill has started breathing. The breath is slow, perhaps once an hour, and the whole mound lifts with it. The soil of a Seated hill is the richest on the Table. Its grass is the sweetest, its fruit the heaviest, its wheat the most toothed. Many of the best fields in the south are somebody's great-grandmother. Fatlanders say this with pride and mean it.

Granny Hessop's Rise is not a fond name for a slope. It is a woman, and her grandchildren graze their sheep on her, and thank her at every meal.

Some hills keep a mouth. It sits somewhere in the turf like a wet red pond-edge, lipped and toothed, and it talks, and it eats whatever is put in it, and it is hungry. Some keep eyes, deep in the grass, that open in rain. And some, the College has recently confirmed, keep moving: very slowly, a few inches a year, toward the nearest other hill.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

The Fatlands are low, wet, endless green-and-red plain under a heavy yellow sky. From the Rim Road they look like a painted country: the green of pasture and the red of turned soil and the gold of toothed wheat, laid out in strips as far as the eye can follow, under a sky the colour of old butter that never quite clears. There are no mountains. There are hardly any trees outside the orchards. There are only the fields, the long wet roads, the slow brown rivers, and the hills, which are people.

It is always warm. Even in Lack the ground steams at dawn. The ground gives underfoot like a mattress over a sleeper, and if you stand still in an open field, you can feel it slowly rise and fall. Foreigners take a week to stop noticing. Fatlanders never notice at all, and are made seasick by stone. A Fatlander's first night on the cobbles of Oathen is famous for its misery: they lie awake on the dead hard ground with their palms pressed flat to it, waiting for it to breathe, and weep when it does not.

Rain is called **drip**. It falls warm and heavy and leaves a yellowish film on standing water, which cooks skim off with flat spoons and use for frying; a good drip-pan after a storm is a housewife's pride. The hot-season wind, the **Belch**, comes up out of the south in late Plenty smelling of rendering, of tallow-vats and singed hair, and lasts for days; tempers break, and the Feasting Laws are relaxed so that people may eat a sixth meal to steady their nerves. In late Plenty the fields **sweat** and the whole country glistens. Midges rise from the wheat in shimmering columns. Every surface is tacky. And at the turn of Carving comes **Marbling**, the first frost, when the fat in the soil whitens overnight in long branching veins, and the plains look from horizon to horizon like a cut of meat laid on a slab. Marbling morning is a holiday. Children run out barefoot to crunch it.

The rivers are slow and brown and thick and warm, and they are called, without irony, gravy: the Brawn, which runs south past Sated to the sea, is the Great Gravy, and its tributaries are the Little Gravies. Their water must be strained before drinking. What is strained out is eaten.

THE HILL-CENSUS

The Cutwrights' southern registry keeps the only full census of the Seated: about four thousand hills between the Chute and the sea, each with a number, a family, a date, and three columns headed *Mouth*, *Eyes* and *Motion*. Until 630 the third column was almost empty. As of Carving 640 it has entries against three hundred and eleven hills, and every entry points the same way: toward Sated, toward the Weighhouse, toward the Chairman's dray. The surveyor who compiled the column, Otilie Vance, has asked to be transferred north. Her request has been refused, by weight.

◇
Strain it twice. Eat what's in the cloth. Don't look at what's in the cloth. That's three rules.

A BARGEWIFE OF THE GREAT GRAVY, TEACHING HER DAUGHTER

A GAZETTEER OF THE FATLANDS

Sated. The capital, on the Great Gravy, built in concentric rings of low, broad, buttressed halls around the Weighhouse. Every door is double-wide, every floor reinforced, every stair replaced by a ramp, and the smell of gravy rises from every drain, because the drains carry the city's drip and dripping down to the rendering-houses on the river. The streets are paved with fat-stained stone and wide enough for a Gut-lines dray and its eight oxen. Sated never stops eating: street-cooks work all night beneath lamps that burn tallow of uncertain provenance, and at any hour the air is blue with frying. Its population is four hundred thousand by head and, as its proud citizens say, "a hundred and twenty million by the pound."

The Weighhouse. The seat of the Board of Plenty, in the heart of Sated: a vast round hall under a dome of glazed bone tiles, with the Great Scales at its centre, iron and bronze, each pan large enough to hold a cart. Here the Weighing is held each Grace, and here the Board sits, on benches sunk into the floor because many members can no longer be lifted onto anything. The floor of the Weighhouse has been reinforced six times. Its cellars, which nobody below the Board visits, are said to be full of roots. Iron gratings in the pavement of Scale Street let up a warm breath from them, smelling of loam and gravy and old paper, and passers-by stop at the gratings without meaning to, and stand, and are moved along by Bailiffs.

The Bleeding Orchards. Ten thousand acres of fruit trees east of Sated, in long rows on the slopes of what were once hills and may still be. At pruning time in early Grace the trees scream when cut: a high, wet, wavering sound, like a calf at the knife, from ten thousand throats at once, audible in Sated on a still day. Orchard-

keepers go deaf young, by choice, with heated needles, and speak in a hand-language of their own. The fruit is the finest in the world. The sap is collected in buckets for blood-pudding. It comes out of the pruning-cuts in slow dark pulses, steaming, and clots in the bucket into a soft jelly with a skin, and the keepers' children are given a spoonful of it warm as a treat, and grow up with black-red mouths and strong hearts.

Low Tilth. The richest farmland in the world, a wide shallow basin south of Sated where the soil is black and soft and sweats in Plenty like a basted joint. It yields three harvests a year. It has the highest Reaping of any district, and nobody there locks their door, because it has never helped. Low Tilth villages are small, quiet and well-fed, and every family has someone in the fields. It is the home of Pell Hogget and the Long Count, and of the Scarecrow.

The Dowager Hills. A range of low green mounds three miles outside Sated, along the old Weighing Road: nine generations of Gut-lines matriarchs, Seated, ninety-one hills in all. The grass on them is short and soft and bright, and the soil is warm right through Lack. Each hill has a name, a family, a gatekeeper's hut, and a speaking-place: a hollow where the turf parts to show a mouth, or a pair of lids, or, on the oldest, only a warm damp crack that exhales. The Gut-lines families still consult their Dowagers on matters of marriage, inheritance and precedence, and bring them offerings. The offerings are meat. The Hills accept them, chewing for hours with a sound like a slow mill. Visitors walking the path between the mounds report that the hills breathe in sequence, a long slow wave of rising and falling turf, as though passing something along.

CONSULTING A DOWAGER

A family with a question for its Dowager brings her a joint (custom demands the best cut from the most recent wake) and the Hill-Speaker on duty lays it in the speaking-place. The Dowager eats. When she has eaten, she answers, sometimes in minutes and sometimes after a day. Her voice comes up through the turf and is felt in the feet as much as heard. Dowagers know things: the true parentage of heirs, the location of hidden debts, which fields will Reap this year. They are rarely wrong. They are also no longer entirely the women they were, and their advice now tends, more and more, toward the same few counsels: *Plant him. Feed her to me. Come closer. Sit down. Lie down. Stay.* A PC who sleeps a night on a Dowager Hill gains a true answer to one question (GM's choice of how cryptic) and must make a Dread 3 check on waking, because the roots will have begun.

The Chute. The Rim Road export depot, at the Fatlands' northern edge where the Great Gravy meets the Road: a mile of rendering-houses, salting-sheds, cooperages and stockyards built around a long stone ramp down which barrels roll, day and night, into the Company's wagons. Meat goes out in barrels with the origin stamped over twice. The smell of the Chute reaches eleven miles on the Belch. The Renderers' Union holds it absolutely. The Rim

Road Company keeps an office there with a notary's bench, and every barrel is tallied on a platter. The town that has grown around it is called Barreldside, and its children can tell a barrel's contents by the sound it makes rolling: beef booms, pork thuds, flour hisses, and some barrels, the children say, *knock back*.

The Trencher. The field where Ummer was eaten: a great shallow bowl of black soil a mile across, in the heart of the plain west of Sated. Nothing is planted there and everything grows anyway, in a dense tangle of toothed grain, veined roots and fleshy creepers that heal over any path cut through them in a night. At its centre is a rise of soil shaped, from the air, very like a sleeping figure lying on its side. The Board forbids entry. Pilgrims of the Second Helping go anyway and lie down in the creepers and are found, weeks later, smiling and partly absorbed: the creepers grown in at the ears and the corners of the mouth and under the nails, the skin gone soft and brown and crumbling at the edges where it meets the soil, the eyes open and wet and glad. Some are still breathing. The Board's patrols are under orders to leave them, because pulling them free has never once been survived, and because the creepers that have them in bear, the following Plenty, a fruit like small soft pink pears that the patrols are not supposed to eat and always do.

The Gavage. The Board's house of correction for the Thin, outside Sated on the Brawn: a long, low, whitewashed building of a hundred cells, each with a chair of oak and iron, a set of leather straps, a funnel-stand, and a drain. Its kitchens never close. Its smell is of porridge, lard, and vomit. See the Thin, below.

The Dusk Acres. The "far fields" of the Cullmasters: a belt of Board-owned land on the edges of Low Tilth and the eastern plains, rotated each Carving, where the Cullmasters' dusk-shift labourers are sent. They are the most productive fields in the country, and the most carefully ploughed, and each plot carries a small numbered stone at its corner. In spring, the Union's men walk them for calves.

Gladbelly. The commune of the Second Helping, a village of long open tables in a meadow beside the Little Gravy, where the cult eats together continuously and sings. The meadow is unusually lush. There is a slaughter-pavilion in the middle, hung with garlands, where the Offered go willingly. See the Second Helping, below.

Marrable Hall. The seat of Dame Suet Marrable and the Unending Dinner: a great ramped house in the Dowager Hills whose dining hall has had no clear floor for eighty-one years. The table is three hundred feet long. The hall's foundations have shifted a yard downhill.

Hogget's Barn. In the village of Kettle Furrow in Low Tilth, a plain timber barn whose inner walls are scored, floor to rafter, with tally-marks: the Long Count, kept in chalk, then knife, then paint, by Pell Hogget and the villages that copy him. Pilgrims come to touch the marks for their own dead. The Board has twice tried to

burn it, and both times the village stood around it in a ring, eating, and the Bailiffs could not bring themselves to break up a meal.

Dimble. A dying village on the western plain between Sated and the Trencher, built around the ruins of a granary that was old when Ummer walked; over its root-cellar is the oldest carving in the Fatlands, with the long open hand left where the chisel slipped. The people of Dimble do not say *Is there any more?* at the end of a meal. Since 636 they have begun to do something else, at the first ploughing, which the Board has heard rumours of and has sent a Bailiff to ask about. See *The First Furrow at Dimble*, below.

Hask’s End. (*new*) A small, prosperous village on the eastern edge of Low Tilth, where a Seated hill called Mother Furlong stands over the common pot like a hen over a nest. In the Lack of 639 Hask’s End gave Mother Furlong what she asked for, in exchange for a promise. The village is quiet now, and half its houses are empty, and on the yard wall there is one bowl turned upside down that is not for anyone the field took. See *The Bargain at Hask’s End*, below.

Granny Hessop’s Rise. (*new*) A long, gentle, beautifully green slope above the Low Tilth causeway, famous all over the south because so many households thank it at every meal: its grain is sold as *Hessop Sweet* and is the dearest flour in Sated. It is the Seated body

of the first Hessop matriarch, a contemporary of Ysolde Tullow, and the Hessop family live all over and around her in a cluster of long, low, old houses connected by covered ways, and have done for five hundred years. They are a handsome family. They are a *very* handsome family, and they look extraordinarily alike. See *The Hessops*, below.

Coldharbour Barn. (*new*) A Thin safe-barn in the Orchard country north of Sapwell, owned on paper by a deaf keeper and used for twenty years as a resting-place for Thin on the move. Since Lack 640 nobody uses it. The Thin will not speak of it except with their hands, and the sign they use for it is a cord, untied, laid flat. See *The Coldharbour Lack*, below.

The Gammon House. (*new*) A Gut-line mansion in the Fold, all ramps and iron floors, whose great dining room has been locked since the Weighing of 619. The present head of the family, Lard Gammon, eats in the kitchen. See *The Gammon Twins*, below.



Every road in the Fatlands is two meals long, or four, or nine. Nobody measures in miles. Miles don’t fill you.

A GRISTMOOT CARTER

▼ HISTORY

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
0	The Meal on the Trencher. The Week of Rising: crops shoulder-high in seven days.
0–204	The Sweet Reigns. The Fatlands feed the Table and grow rich and wide.
c. 40	The Hessop matriarch roots on the slope above the Tilth causeway; her family builds around her.
61	First recorded Laden: Matron Ysolde Tullow, whose feet rooted in her own kitchen.
97	First Seating. Ysolde becomes the first of the Dowager Hills.
131	The Wake Ordinance. Burial forbidden; the dead to be served by kin.
140	Last Plate-Tithe paid by “Strake, W., widow.”
204	The Tooth Harvest. The Board rules toothed wheat “a new and superior strain.”
260	The Weighing. Votes assigned by body weight.
300	First Wolf-Warden appointed. The word “wolves” enters Board proclamations.
312	The Appetite accepted as a defence to theft, if the article is eaten.
388	The Board’s first export treaty with the Rim Road Company; the Chute begun.
455	The Thin Rising. Put down by force-feeding; fasting made treason. Hester Gaunt fed to bursting.
457	The Gavage built. The Cullmasters chartered as “an office of agricultural steadiness.”
560	Dame Suet Marrable lays the Unending Dinner.
602	Obb Tullow becomes Chairman. A man is rendered for letting a barrel rot.
611	Chairman Obb Tullow walks for the last time.
619	The Gammon Twins. A Weighing won by a brother’s meat.

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
626	Wren Hollowell born in Bramble Furrow, a Blank.
629	Pell Hogget begins the Long Count.
631–641	The Reaping doubles.
636	Dimble revives the First Furrow. Wat Gristle is served in a pie on Ladle Lanes.
637	Uttering the Long Count made sedition.
638	First field-faces reported in Low Tilt: turnips, squashes, a cabbage that blinked.
639	The Bargain at Hask's End.
640	Tulow's feet root through his cart. Tobias Wether crosses from the Fast and eats. The Coldharbour Lack.

THE SWEET REIGNS

For two hundred years the Fatlands were the happiest country on the Table. The Week of Rising was followed by a century of harvests so abundant that grain was used for ballast and meat was fed to dogs. Sated grew from a market-village into the wealthiest city in the world. Fatland envoys went up the Rim Road in gilded wagons with presents of smoked haunch, and every other land, starving or merely ordinary, fell over itself to sign treaties. These were the years in which “You look heavy” became the highest compliment, and the years in which the Gut-lines, swelling, ruled from couches and then from beds, and everyone thought it was glory.

The Wake Ordinance of 131 A.G. merely made law of what had become custom. Nobody had been buried in the Fatlands for a generation. It seemed obscene to put good meat in the ground when the ground was already so full. The last burial ground on the plain, at the old chapel of Saint Ember outside Sated, was opened by order of the Board in 133, and the dead of the Long Lack were lifted out, salted, and served at a public feast in the Weighhouse yard, as a gesture of national unity. The chronicle records that they were “tough, but well received,” and that the diggers who opened the oldest graves found some of the dead lying face-down, with soil in their mouths, as though they had been hungry even there.



Tough, but well received.

THE BOARD'S MINUTE ON THE SAINT EMBER FEAST, 133 A.G.; THE PHRASE IS STILL USED IN SATED OF A BAD SERMON

THE WEIGHING AND THE RISING

By 260 A.G. the largest Gut-lines could no longer travel to the Board, and the Board came to them; the Weighing simply made their bulk a formal measure of power. The poor accepted it, because the poor were eating well. Two centuries later, they were not. Export had swallowed the surplus, the Reaping had grown, and a preacher named Hester Gaunt began teaching in the Orchards that the god

was in the hunger, and that if the people stopped feeding it, it would starve back down into the soil. The Thin Rising of 455 A.G. was not an army. It was eleven thousand people in Low Tilt sitting down in the roads and refusing to eat. The Board sent the Bailiffs with funnels. Within a month most of the Thin were fat, and the rest were dead, and Hester Gaunt had been fed in the Weighhouse before the whole Board for nine days until she burst. Fasting has been treason since.

The Board's minute of the ninth day survives, and is read aloud to new Members as part of their oath, so that they understand what the Board is.

MINUTES OF THE BOARD OF PLENTY, SITTING IN FULL, THE NINTH DAY OF THE FEEDING OF H. GAUNT, GRACE 455.

Present: one hundred and eighty-four Members, aggregate weight one hundred and ninety-one thousand pounds.

Item: the Feeder reported the prisoner had taken eleven gallons since the last sitting, and had ceased to resist on the seventh day, and had on the eighth day asked for more, which was given. Laughter.

Item: the Physician reported the prisoner's belly “past the capacity of any human vessel he had seen or read of,” and that the skin had begun to shine and to go thin at the navel. He asked leave to stop. Leave was refused, by weight.

Item: at the fourth hour the prisoner spoke, and said, “It is in here with me. It is so glad.” The Chairman asked that this be struck. It was struck.

Item: at the fifth hour the prisoner was fed the last ladle, and the matter was concluded. The Members, being in some distress, adjourned to Supper. It was noted that no Member left food on his plate.

Item: the prisoner's remains to be thrown in the Brawn, uneaten, as a Thin. Carried.

THE GAMMON TWINS

The Weighing of 619 is remembered in the Fold as a scandal and in the Leanings as a joke, and in the Gammon House as nothing at all, because nobody there speaks of it.

The Gammons are an old Gut-line of the Fold, and in 619 the family's Board seat was contested between twin brothers, Lard and Cress Gammon, then thirty-one, then each of about nine hundred pounds, then so alike that their own Washers told them apart by the shoots in their elbow-folds. The seat went by custom to the heavier. For a year the brothers ate against each other: at the same table, plate for plate, their mother's Dowager hill having advised them both, when asked, *Eat*. Three days before the Weighing, Cress Gammon was the heavier by six pounds.

On the night before the Weighing he died. The Gammon House said his heart had stopped at table, which is how a great many Gut-lines die. The wake was held at once, by special licence, the next morning, at dawn, so that it might be finished in time for the Weighing at noon; and at the wake Lard Gammon took the heart, as the elder by a quarter-hour, and the liver, and the belly fat, and both hands in their pie, and sat at the head of the board and ate his twin, alone, steadily, for six hours, while the family watched and the house was silent except for the sound of his jaws. When a cousin asked aloud whether Cress's heart had really stopped on its own, Lard Gammon took a morsel of his brother's cheek on his tongue, held it there, and swore: *By my brother's meat, which is in me, I did him no harm*.

At noon he was carried to the Scales and outweighed his brother's last recorded weight by eleven pounds, and took the seat. He sits it still.

The Gammons' cook, who had been in the kitchen that night, was found in the Great Gravy a month later, and the Washers who washed Cress for his wake were pensioned off to a village on the coast and have not been heard of. But the Washers talked first, as Washers do, and what they said in the Leanings was this: that there were marks on Cress's throat, deep in the folds, in the shape of a large soft hand pressed down for a long time; and that the hand had been the left one, and Lard Gammon is left-handed, and Cress was not.

To eat your brother is no crime in the Fatlands. To kill him is murder. To swear falsely on his meat is, to every Fatlander, the vilest act there is, worse than either. Nobody has ever proved it. Nobody has needed to. In the Leanings, a man who wins an argument unfairly is said to have *weighed in Gammon*. And in the Gammon House the great dining room has been locked since the morning of the wake, because Lard Gammon says that when he sits in it he can

hear, inside his own body, from somewhere under the ribs, his brother's voice asking him to pass the salt.



By my brother's meat, which is in me.

THE OATH OF LARD GAMMON, 619; IN THE
LEANINGS, SAID WITH A WINK, IT MEANS I AM
LYING AND YOU CANNOT TOUCH ME

THE LONG COUNT

In 629, Pell Hogget of Kettle Furrow noticed that his village had been one smaller each autumn for as long as he could remember, and scratched it on his barn wall. He started asking neighbouring villages. Then they started sending him their numbers. The Long Count is now copied in two hundred villages, by people who share no organization but a habit, and it shows something the Board has spent three centuries calling wolves: the Reaping has doubled in ten years, and it is still accelerating.

The Count is not a book. It is a habit, a wall, a set of tally-sticks, a column of knife-cuts on a hundred barn doors, and a slow, patient correspondence by carter and drover and child, carried folded in a shoe. Its marks are simple: a stroke for each Reaped, a stroke with a cross-bar for each dusk-shifted who did not come back, a circle for each Seated, and, since 638, a new mark that nobody agreed on but everyone uses, a stroke with a small open curve at the top like a hand held out, for *taken by a bill*. A copy of the Kettle Furrow wall, as transcribed by a Cutwright surveyor in Plenty 640, runs:

KETTLE FURROW — HOGGET'S BARN — EAST WALL,
LOWER COURSE (as found)

629: IIII — Abner Thrush · Polly Thrush · old Mag · the Breen
lad.

630: IIII I — & Tam Breen, who went looking for the lad.

631: IIII II — names on the beam, too high to read; Pell says
they are there.

632: IIII IIII — & a bowl on the wall for each.

633: IIII IIII I

634: IIII IIII IIII

635: IIII IIII IIII I — & ½, for the Pennick baby, who was
only half-way out of the furrow when they got her. She lived a
week.

636: IIII IIII IIII IIII

637: IIII IIII IIII IIII II — in chalk, under, in a child's hand:
WOLVES WOLVES WOLVES

638: IIII IIII IIII IIII IIII

639: IIII IIII IIII IIII IIII IIII — & one stroke scored out so deep the knife has gone through the plank.

640: (wall not yet marked; the Count is kept on the barn door this year, “in case the wall is full”)

At the foot of the course, in paint, in a large slow hand: NELL — and nothing after it.

— THE SURVEYOR’S NOTE: “HOGGET STATES THAT THE DEEP STROKE IN 639 IS ‘A MISTAKE.’ HE SAYS ‘NELL’ IS THE NAME OF THE BARN. IT IS NOT.”

Pell’s arithmetic is simple and his neighbours can follow it. The Reaping in a Low Tilth village doubles every eight or nine years. Kettle Furrow had two hundred and six souls in 629. At the present rate, the year’s Reaping will equal the village in 660 A.G., and the whole of Low Tilth will have gone into the wheat before 680. The Board’s own figures, in the root-choked cellar under the Weighhouse, say the same thing to the head, and the Board has known it longer. The difference is that Pell Hogget wrote it on a wall where people could see.



I don’t say what it means. I only say what it is. Mark, mark, mark. You can see the shape of it from the door.

PELL HOGGET

THE FIRST FURROW AT DIMBLE

Dimble, under its old carving, has always been a strange village. Since 636 it has become a frightening one.

Every village in the Fatlands keeps the rite of First Furrow in Grace: the year’s first ploughing, pulled by the heaviest man of the parish in harness, the furrow fed a loaf. In Dimble, the oldest families say, the rite was once different, before the Gorging, when Ummer walked ahead of the plough; there are marks on the granary carving that show it, a plough and a figure lying in the furrow before the share. In 636, after a Reaping that took a fifth of the village in one Carving, Dimble went back to the old way. The Board heard of it in 640 and sent a Bailiff, Ambrose Tull, to inquire. His report was filed and sealed. A copy of the interrogation is held, against the Board’s wishes, in the Long Count’s collection at Kettle Furrow.

EXAMINATION OF GAMMET RAKE, GRANARY-KEEPER OF DIMBLE, BEFORE BAILIFF A. TULL, LACK 640. HELD AT TABLE, BOTH PARTIES EATING.

Q. You know why I am here.

A. The plough. Have some of this, it’s the good ham.

Q. Who was put in the furrow last Grace?

A. Jory Pask. He was on the list for the Dusk Acres anyway, for his debt. We asked him would he rather go in our field for

us than in the Board’s field for nobody. He said yes. He was a good lad.

Q. Describe the rite.

A. You’ve a stomach for it? Good. We fed him three days. Best of everything, the way the Cullmasters do, you know, so he’d be heavy and glad. Then at dawn we washed him in warm milk and bound him to the beam of the plough, face down, along it, so his face was over the share, and the heaviest of us took the harness, and we all of us pulled. The share opens the soil. Then the share opens him. Not quick. You walk slow on First Furrow. The furrow takes him in a long red line, the whole length of the Long Strip, and we walk behind it singing and we lay our hands in it as we go. By the end of the strip there is not much of him on the beam. What there is we bury, standing, at the head of the furrow. Upright, so he can see.

Q. Did he cry out?

A. At first. Then he said it was warm. Then he asked us to pull faster. You’ll not have heard that, but that’s what it sounds like when they’re in the soil, they want you to hurry. Then he was quiet. You’re not eating.

Q. How many have you put in the furrow?

A. Four Graces now. Four lads.

Q. And has it lessened the Reaping?

A. (The witness put down his fork.) The first year we lost nine instead of eleven. The second, eleven. The third, fourteen. Last Carving we lost twenty. We’d have done better to keep the lads. I know. I know that. But you’ve to do something, haven’t you? You can’t just sit and eat and wait. Can you? Can you?

Q. Who chose Jory Pask?

A. His mam. She put his name in. She said it was better than the Board’s field, and at least she’d know which strip. She eats the bread off it. She says it’s the best bread she ever had. She says he was always a sweet boy.

[Note in the Bailiff’s hand: I have recommended no action. There is no statute against ploughing. I could not finish the ham.]

THE BARGAIN AT HASK'S END

Of all the stories the Long Count keeps, the one the Thin tell most often, and the one that ends most arguments about whether the god can be bargained with, is the story of Hask's End.

Mother Furlong was the hill over the common pot: the Seated body of Bette Furlong, Harvest Mother of the parish in her life, a woman of six hundred pounds and great kindness, who rooted in 590 at the edge of the village yard where she had cooked the parish supper for forty years. She kept a mouth. She was much loved. Children slept against her warm flank on Sweating Night; couples courted on her. She was consulted on everything and was always right.

In Carving 638 Hask's End lost seven to the Reaping, its worst year in memory. At Harvest Home the Reeve, Amos Tallis, a broad, careful, decent man, went to Mother Furlong with the best cut of the last wake and asked her what the village should do. She chewed for a day and a night. Then she said, through the turf, in the voice everybody remembered from the supper-hatch: *Give me Linnet, and I will speak to the field, and the field will pass you by for seven years.*

Linnet Tallis was the Reeve's daughter. She was nineteen, plump and freckled and quick to laugh, betrothed to a miller's son, and she had been fed by Mother Furlong's own hands at every parish supper of her childhood.

The village argued all Lack. The Reeve said no, and then said nothing, and then stopped eating at table, which frightened everyone more than anything else. It was Linnet who decided. She said, in the yard at Tablenight, that seven was seven, and that she would rather be in Mother Furlong than in the wheat, and that if it was her or seven of them every year then there was no sum to do. She was fed for nine days by every household in turn, the best of everything, and she laughed and cried and grew round and pink, and her betrothed fed her last, at dusk on the ninth day, and kissed her greasy mouth. Then her father walked her to the hill himself, in her white smock, through the whole village standing in silence with their plates in their hands. Mother Furlong's mouth opened wide in the turf, wider than anyone had seen it, and Linnet lay down in it, as a child lies down in a warm bed. The Reeve knelt and held her hand while it closed. It took the whole night. He did not let go until there was no hand.

The next Carving, 639, Hask's End lost nine to the Reaping. In 640, eleven. Mother Furlong, asked what had gone wrong, chewed on the question for three days and then said, quite calmly: *I was hungry, Amos.*

That was all. A hill has no say over a field. A hill is not a god's counsellor or a god's priest; it is a piece of the god with a mouth, and it said what a mouth says to be fed. There was no bargain. There had never been a bargain. Linnet Tallis was eaten for nothing, by a kind old woman who had loved her, and the village had paid her with its own hands.

Amos Tallis walked into the Long Strip at dusk in Carving 640, and stood there, and waited, and was not Reaped; the field passed over him that night, as if out of spite, or as if it were simply not hungry for him. He came back at full dark and sat by Mother Furlong until morning and did not speak. In the spring he went out again, out of season, when the fields do not take, and lay down in the furrow in the cold, and did not get up. They found him a week later. He had not been Reaped. He had simply stopped. His bowl is on the yard wall. His name is not in the Long Count, because Pell Hogget does not count those the god did not take, and the people of Hask's End have argued about that ever since, and some of them have stopped sending their tally.

Linnet's betrothed still brings Mother Furlong meat. He cannot stop himself. She thanks him warmly, every time, and calls him *son*.

RUNNING THE BARGAIN

The story of Hask's End is the Fatlands' answer to every PC who asks *can we make a deal with it?* Hills will offer bargains; Dowagers, Old Mother Rind, the Seated of any family. They are always sincere when they offer and always hungry when they eat. A GM who wants to stage a worthless sacrifice of this kind should let the bargain be struck and paid with real cost (an NPC the players love, a PC's own Flesh or Regrowth), and let it fail quietly, with no villain to blame. The Dread is not in the eating. It is in the next Carving's tally. Witnessing a Hask's End-style giving is Dread 3; learning, afterward, that it bought nothing is a second Dread 2 check, because grief that was for nothing warps the mind more than grief that bought something.



I was hungry, Amos.

MOTHER FURLONG OF HASK'S END, CARVING 640;
THE ONLY EXPLANATION SHE EVER GAVE

▼RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

The Fatlands are governed by the **Board of Plenty**, seated in the Weighhouse at Sated. The Board has about two hundred members, drawn from the Gut-lines, the Renderers, the great granaries and a handful of elected district deacons. Each member's vote counts in proportion to their weight, taken publicly once a year at the Weighing. A Gut-lines matriarch of fourteen hundred pounds outvotes nine farmers' deacons together. The Chairman, Obb Tullow, at nineteen hundred pounds, holds more votes alone than the whole of Low Tilth. He has not walked in thirty years.

The Gut-lines are the nobility. They are the largest, the hungriest, and the furthest along the Regrowth, and their estates are run from beds, then from drays, then from the ground. Succession disputes turn on whether a rooted, mouthless hill can still be said to hold title. The courts have ruled that it can, which is why the Dowager Hills still own a third of the country and why their consultations carry the force of law.

Law in the Fatlands is mostly about eating. The **Feasting Laws** set five meals a day; leaving food on the plate is a fine of one lack per crumb-weight, assessed by the Bailiff's scale; refusing a meal is sedition, punishable by the Gavage. Theft of food is barely a crime, since the thief will eat it and the court considers the matter closed. Theft of *weight*, by contrast, is grave: to starve a person, to keep a child thin, to purge, to bleed for the purpose of lightness, is treason against the Weighing. The worst crime of all is waste. A man who let a barrel of meat rot in 602 A.G. was rendered for tallow by order of the Board, and the tallow was used to light the courtroom for the next trial.

Punishment is by feeding (the Gavage), by fine, by the dusk-shift, or by the table. A convicted murderer in the Fatlands is executed in the Renderers' yards, and the family of the victim has first cut. This is called *making good*. It is done in public, at noon, on a scrubbed board under an awning, by a Union jointer, and the killing is quick, a single stroke at the throat over a copper basin, because the Union will not spoil meat with fear. The jointing is slow. The victim's kin stand at the board's head with their plates and are served first, by the jointer's own hand, the cut of their choosing, and they eat it there, standing, while the crowd watches; and it is said in Sated that a widow who has *made good* on her husband's killer goes home lighter in her heart and heavier in her belly, and that both are the point.

Abroad, the Fatlands' power is food. They feed half the Table by way of the Rim Road, and every other land depends on that meat while trying not to think about it. The Vigil eats Fatland salt-beef to keep its strength through sleepless decades. Oathen buys toothed flour by the shipload. Sallowreach, which needs little food, buys Fatland tallow for its Seammers. The Board knows exactly how much the world would starve without it, and charges accordingly.



Your Honour, the accused ate the evidence. — Then the matter is closed. Pass the gravy.

A PLATE-JUSTICE'S COURT IN GRISTMOOT, AS REPORTED

▼CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

Meals. Five meals a day are mandatory: Firstbite at dawn, Eleveses, Midday, Fourth Plate, and Supper, with whatever the purse allows in between. Every meal begins with the grace, which thanks the field by name ("Thank you, Long Acre. Thank you, Hessop's Rise.") and ends with the plate wiped clean with bread. Strangers add the common "Lack keep away." Fatland cooking is lavish, rich and brown: pies and puddings, roasts and dripping, sausages fat as a forearm, gravy on everything. The poor eat potatoes and fat bacon and are not, by any outside measure, poor eaters.

Dress. Fatlanders dress in loose layered smocks, laced at the side so they can be let out as the wearer grows. Belts are a mark of ill-omen and worn only by the Thin. The rich wear silk in field-colours, red and gold and green, cut wide, and pin their folds with brooches of polished bone. Teeth from the toothed wheat are threaded into necklaces for children.

Marriage and the body. Weight is beauty, and courtship is conducted over food. A suitor feeds the beloved with his own hands

at the betrothal supper, and the beloved's family watches to see that the feeding is generous. Wedding vows are sworn over a shared plate. Couples speak of "growing together," and Gut-lines marriages sometimes end with both partners rooted side by side in a single hill. What happens in a Fatland marriage bed is, in the Fatland view, simply another kind of appetite and is spoken of in the same breath as supper, with a knowing look. Outsiders are discomfited by how readily lovers there speak of wanting to eat each other, and by how literally some of them mean it. The love-tokens of the south are bites: a crescent of tooth-marks on the soft of the shoulder, worn proudly above a low smock; and widows of the Leanings keep, in a little bone box, a strip of their husband's wake-meat dried hard as leather, to put on the tongue at night when they cannot sleep.

THE HESSOPS

Every household in the south that thanks Granny Hessop's Rise at table is, in a sense, a Hessop household; the grain is sold everywhere. The Hessops themselves are another matter. They have lived on and around their matriarch's slope for five hundred years in a warren of low old houses joined by covered ways, and in all that time, according to the Cutwrights' registry, no Hessop has married outside the family. Their marriages are arranged by the Rise. The bride and groom (always cousins, the registry says; sometimes closer, the registry does not say) spend their wedding night not in a bed but out on the slope, on the warm breathing grass, alone with the hill, and come down at dawn silent and flushed and smelling of loam, and the children of those marriages are born with a soft brown seam of loam-flesh down the spine, and their feet already threaded with fine pale roots. Hessops are famously, almost unbearably beautiful: fair, full, sweet-faced, with the same wide grey eyes and the same small even teeth in every generation, so that a portrait of a Hessop girl of 300 A.G. hangs in the Fold and visitors take it for one of the girls now living. Hessops do not grow old in the face. They grow heavy very young, root before forty, and Seat on the slope beside their foremothers, so that the Rise grows a little longer every generation. Nobody in Low Tilth will say what they think the Rise is to the Hessops, or the Hessops to the Rise. They only say that Hessop flour is the sweetest in the world; that it is unlucky to marry a Hessop, and impossible; and that on Sweating Night, when the Rise breathes hardest, the windows of the Hessop houses are all left open, and nobody in the covered ways is asleep. Granny Cracknel strings Hessop teeth on a wire of their own, and will tell you, chuckling, that she cannot tell them apart.

— COUNTING-OUT RHYME, LOW TILTH; THE CHILD THE RHYME ENDS ON MUST STAND AT THE FIELD'S EDGE UNTIL THE OTHERS COUNT A HUNDRED. THE BOARD HAS FORBIDDEN IT TWICE. IT IS SUNG EVERYWHERE.

Death rites. There are no graves. The dead are served at the wake, by the family, on the best plates. To be buried uneaten would be the deepest insult to a life; it is reserved for traitors and the Thin, whose lean bodies are thrown in the Brawn. A wake begins at noon on the day after death. A jointer is hired if the family can afford one; the deceased's fat is rendered first, the heart goes to the eldest, the hands into a pie, the marrow to the most beloved. Neighbours bring bread and are fed in return. The bones are cracked, boiled for stock, and then returned to the family's field, ground fine, so that the person goes back to the god and comes up again as crop. A good wake is talked about for years. "He ate well" is said of the dead, meaning *he tasted good*.

A wake requires a licence from the parish Bailiff, issued on the morning of death for a fee of two crumbs, which certifies that the deceased died of something other than a crime, a contagion, or the Thin, and is fit for table. It is pinned to the door of the house through the wake, and then burned in the rendering fire, so that the dead go to the table with their papers in order. The great families print bills of fare, in the manner of a banquet, and the bills are kept,

Children. Fatland children are fed from the moment they are born and weighed every week. A child who fails to gain is a scandal for its parents and a matter for the Bailiff. Children glean behind the harvesters, turn spits, and are put to sleep with a strip of fat to suck. They are warned never to go into the fields alone at dusk in Carving, and they all do, once, on a dare.

*One for the pot and two for the plate,
three for the Bailiff who comes round late,
four for the field and five for the wheat,
six for the Cullmaster, white on his feet,
seven for Granny who's under the hill,
eight for the Scarecrow, standing so still,
nine for the furrow, ten for the bone,
and you're the one that walks out alone.*

and passed down, and collected; the College holds four thousand of them.

THE WAKE OF MISTRESS ADELINE FENN OF THE FOLD, THIRTEEN HUNDRED AND TWELVE POUNDS, WHO WENT ON THE TRENCHER IN HER SLEEP. GIVEN AT FENN HOUSE, CARVING 637, BY HER LOVING CHILDREN. COOKED BY WAKEMOTHER P. HESK. JOINTED BY H. GRISTLE.

FIRST REMOVE: A clear broth of Mistress's marrowbones, with toothed-wheat dumplings. Crackling of the shoulder, salted, served in a cone.

SECOND REMOVE: Mistress's cheeks, braised in Orchard cider until they may be cut with a spoon. A terrine of her tongue, pressed with her own aspic, garnished with the pickled shoots from her elbows, which she grew with such pride.

THE GREAT REMOVE: The haunch, roasted whole on the Fenn spit over applewood, basted nine hours in her dripping

and Sapwell honey. The heart, for Master Rowan, seared. The Hands of a Lady in a Pie, with turnips from Hessop's Rise.

FOURTH REMOVE: Her famous belly, rolled and stuffed with sage and her own sweetbreads, and roasted until the rind shatters.

SWEETS: A pudding of her blood, with Bleeding Orchard pears and cream. Marrow on toast for the grandchildren,

sprinkled with sugar.

TO FINISH: Her fingers, candied in the old way, one for each of her ten best friends, in a ribboned box to take home.

Mistress Fenn's bones will return to Fenn Long Field on the first day of Lack. The family thanks you. Lack keep away.

— A PRINTED WAKE-BILL, FENN FAMILY PAPERS; AT THE FOOT, IN PENCIL, IN A CHILD'S HAND: "I HAD A FINGER. IT WAS NICE. I MISS GRAN."

WAKE DISHES

When the party sits down at a wake (and sooner or later it will), roll or choose from the following for what comes to their plate. Every

dish is the best thing they have ever tasted.

D20	WAKE DISH	WHAT IT IS
1	Hands in a Pie	the custom for a worker; the knuckles stand up through the crust like a little fence
2	Heart Seared Thin	for the eldest; laid out in overlapping slices like scales on the blue plate
3	Crackling Cone	shoulder skin, scored and blistered, sold at the gate to passers-by for a crumb
4	Widow's Dripping	the first rendering, on hot bread; the widow skims it herself and weeps into it
5	Marrow on Toast	for the most beloved; sweet and grey, on toasted name-loaf
6	Cheek Braise	slow-cooked in cider until it falls; it keeps the shape of a smile in the pan
7	Tongue Terrine	pressed in the deceased's own aspic; the custom is to say a kind thing before eating it
8	Black Pudding of the Dead	blood, fat, oats and Orchard sap, coiled in their own casing
9	Belly Roll	stuffed with sage and sweetbreads; the rind shatters like sugar-glass
10	Brawn of the Head	the head boiled, picked and set in a mould; turned out, it looks very like them
11	Liver and Onions	for the Gut-lines, who claim the liver by right; the onions flinch in the pan
12	Ear-Crisps	fried in dripping and salted; children fight over them
13	Toe-Pickle	in vinegar, in a jar, to be eaten through the winter, one each Sunday
14	Candied Fingers	one to each best friend, in a ribboned box
15	Bone Broth	the last dish, from the cracked bones; served at dawn to those who sat up
16	Name-Loaf	baked from flour milled with their ground bones; eaten in silence
17	Eyes in Jelly	a Gut-line delicacy; they are said to see the eater, once, at the moment of swallowing
18	Fat-Candles	not a dish; rendered from what is left, and lit at the board; they smell of the dead for a year
19	Sweetbread Fritters	in toothed-wheat batter; a jointer's perquisite, shared with whoever helped
20	The Unasked Course	a covered dish nobody ordered; the cook says it was on the bill; it is someone else

Festivals. The Weighing in Grace is a festival of three days, with pie-stalls the length of Sated and the Board brought to the scales on drays before a roaring crowd. Marbling morning is a children's holiday. Harvest Home at the end of Carving is a week of feasting that the Long Count has made very quiet in recent years. And on **Tablenight** the whole country attempts a one-day fast in penance for the Meal. Pantries are locked, keys are given to the priest, and

everyone sits in silence. Nobody has ever recorded a village that made it to sundown. By noon children are screaming; by mid-afternoon someone has broken the pantry door; by dusk there is a riot of eating, shameful and joyful, in every village on the plain, and the year begins again.

Crime and punishment. Fatland justice is fast and fed. Petty offenders are fined in meals owed. Brawlers are made to sit and eat together until they reconcile. Debtors are sent to the dusk-shift, from which they return, mostly, with the debt worked off. Mostly.

Proverbs. *A thin man has a secret. Eat while it's warm; it won't be. The field remembers who fed it. Never trust a cook who isn't heavy. Nobody's full, but some are fuller. What the wheat took, the bread gives back. Love is wanting to feed someone; hate is wanting to eat them; marriage is both. Don't make bread of your friends. A hill never says no. Every pot has a granny in it.*

Oaths on the dead. The binding oath of the Fatlands is sworn with a mouthful of a dead relative's flesh held on the tongue: *By my mother's meat, which is in me.* To break it is to have eaten your mother for nothing, and Fatlanders consider this the vilest thing a person can do. Wakes are often delayed so that the family can settle disputes by such oaths while the meat is fresh. Families keep a little

dried meat of their elders in a salt-box for the purpose, against the day they must swear; the salt-box is the most private object in a Fatland house, kept under the marriage bed, and to open another family's salt-box is a crime the courts treat as a kind of rape of the dead. An oath-breaker, when found out, is not punished by the law. Their family simply stops serving them at table. They are set a place and an empty plate, five times a day, for the rest of their lives, and nobody looks at them while the others eat.

Remember, she was soft. Remember, she was sweet. Pass the plate along, along; there's not a bit to waste.

Remember, she was heavy, love. Remember, she was kind. Lick the bowl and crack the bone, there's marrow yet to find.

And when you're in the furrow, love, and when you're in the wheat, we'll sit at board and say your name, and you'll be what we eat.

— WAKE-SONG, SUNG ACROSS THE PLAINS WHILE THE COPPER BOILS

WAKES AND THE OUTSIDER

A PC from another land will be invited to a wake sooner or later. It is the highest courtesy a Fatland family can offer a guest. Refusing to eat is not merely rude; it is sedition, and a Bailiff may be called. Eating counts as cannibalism for any Dread or Rites purpose the GM's table cares about (Dread 2 the first time for a non-Fatlander; Dread 1 thereafter; Dread 0 for a native). It is also, without exception, the most delicious thing the character has ever tasted, and a non-Fatlander of Cut 1+ who eats at a wake gains 1 Hunger, because the meat is looking for somewhere to be hungry from.



I've jointed nine hundred and four. You stop seeing faces after the first fifty. Then about the eight hundredth you start again, and it's all faces.

A JOINTER OF WAKESIDE

▼ FACTIONS

THE BOARD OF PLENTY

The government: two hundred members, vast, slow, and aware of the Reaping in more detail than it admits. The Board believes in continuity, export, and the Weighing. It knows the “wolves” are the fields; it has known for three hundred years; it has records, in the root-choked cellars of the Weighhouse, of every Reaping by district

and year, and its private projections match Pell Hogger's to the head. What the Board wants is to keep the Fatlands eating and the Table buying until the god arrives, and then, if possible, to be the god's favoured guests. Its enemies are the Thin and the Long Count; its allies are the Renderers (uneasily) and the Rim Road Company (expensively). A PC joins by service: as a clerk, a Bailiff, a Weigher's assistant, or a member's Carrier.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Ladle	A Bailiff's or clerk's badge; right to enforce the Feasting Laws; free Supper at any inn.
2	Deacon	A district seat; one vote per hundred pounds; the ear of the Wolf-Warden.
3	Member	A Board vote by weight; immunity from the dusk-shift; a Carrier retinue.
4	Great Member	Committee seat; access to the Weighhouse cellars and the real Reaping figures.
5	Chairman	The heaviest vote. Rule of the Fatlands, from a cart, then from the ground.

MINUTES OF THE INNER COMMITTEE (NOT FOR THE FULL BOARD), SITTING IN THE CELLARS, CARVING 640.

Present: the Chairman (rooted); seven Great Members; the Cullmaster-General; the Physician, by invitation, who was asked to leave after item two.

Item one: the Cullmaster-General reported the season's yield. Dusk-shift taken: one thousand one hundred and four. Reaped (general): four thousand nine hundred and ninety. Ratio of the dusk-shift to the whole: worse. The Cullmaster-General asked that this be minuted. It was minuted.

Item two: the Physician reported on the Vigil buyer. The Committee resolved that the Vigil buyer had eaten something disagreeable on the Rim Road.

Item three: the Long Count. Resolved, that it is to be ignored, as a thing that encourages itself by notice.

Item four: the Chairman asked, through his Washer, that the Reaping figures be read aloud to him slowly by district. They were read. During the reading the floor of the cellar was observed to rise and fall. The Chairman thanked the Committee and said he was "very nearly full." It was noted that this has not been said in the Weighhouse before. Members were asked not to repeat it.

Item five: the wolves. Carried, nem. con.

— COPIED SECRETLY BY THE CHAIRMAN'S WASHER AND SENT TO KETTLE FURROW FOLDED IN A SHOE

THE THIN

Outlawed fasters who believe starving the body starves the god. They are gaunt, hunted, and the only people in the south who seem clear-headed. The Thin eat once every three days, in secret, a handful of ash-bread and water; they bind their bellies with cord, live in barns and ditches, and meet in the Orchards where the deafened keepers will not hear. Their faith is Purgation-adjacent, and the cross-border Purgation sends them money, but the Thin are stranger and gentler than their foreign cousins: they do not kill nobles. They simply refuse. They want the Fatlands to stop feeding

the god for one whole season, and believe that if it did, the Reaping would end. Their allies are the Purgation and, secretly, a few Orchard-keepers; their enemies are every Bailiff on the plain. A PC joins by fasting in their company for nine days and being seen to suffer.

To be Thin in the Fatlands is to live as a ghost. You stuff your cheeks with bread at your mother's table and spit it into your apron. You lie in a ditch at night with the cord pulled tight across your belly, and hear, across the warm dark fields, every house on the plain eating. Ash-bread is grey and gritty and tastes of a cold hearth; the Thin eat it slowly, in a circle, passing the loaf along, and it is the only bread in the Fatlands that is not delicious, and they love it for that.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hollow	A cord for the belly; a hiding place; the Thin's hand-signs.
2	Lean	Knowledge of the safe barns; a share of the ash-bread.
3	Gaunt	Leads a cell; may rescue prisoners from the Gavage.
4	Bone	Speaks for a district; carries messages to the Purgation.
5	The Thin Man	Corder Lank. Unopposed.

The Gavage. Captured Thin are not executed. They are fed. A prisoner is strapped into an oak chair, head locked back in a padded iron frame, jaw held open with a boxwood wedge. A funnel of polished horn is seated in the throat. The feeders are kindly, plump, singing women in white aprons, and they pour: warm lard-porridge first, then gravy thick with marrow, then a puree of pork and bread and dripping, slowly, a ladle every few breaths, while the prisoner chokes and heaves and the feeder strokes the throat downward with a buttered thumb to help it along, murmuring *there, there, love, there's a good belly*. A Gavage session lasts three hours and comes five times a day. The prisoner's body, after nine years of hunger, does

not want to fight. It wants. That is the true torture of the Gavage: the Thin weep because it is wonderful, because the gravy is the best thing they have tasted in years, because their bellies stretch and gurgle and *rejoice*, and with every ladle they can feel the god in them waking up and growing fat and grateful. Most leave the Gavage in a season, heavy and silent and eating. Some come back to the Thin anyway, and weigh the cord around them, and begin again.

THE COLDHARBOUR LACK

In Lack 640, Corder Lank brought the Fasting Girl, Wren Hollowell, to Coldharbour Barn and fasted beside her for nine days, and on the ninth night something went wrong that only he understands. The nineteen Thin sheltering in the barn felt their hunger, in the space of an hour, double. They did not know why. They thought it was their own weakness. Over the next season, the hunger in them did not lessen; it gnawed and talked, and what it said, in the cold barn, in the long nights, was that the field was warm. Nan Tidy, a Lean of twenty, was the first to go out to the Dusk Acres in the snow, and lie down in a furrow, and not come back; out of season, when the fields do not take, so that what took her was only the cold and her own wish to be gone. She left her cord folded on her pallet. Within a fortnight two more had gone the same way, and left their cords the same way. Then it spread like a sentence passed round a table, and seven of the nineteen were gone by Grace, all to the same frozen strip, all leaving their cords neatly folded, and a boy called Tobin Ash, the youngest, wrote on the barn beam in charcoal: *it is not hungry if you are in it*. The survivors scattered and will not use the barn. Corder Lank went there alone at the end of Grace and gathered up the seven cords and has worn them, knotted together, under his own ever since. He has not told the Thin what he did on the ninth night. He has told them, gently, that the seven were weak, and that the Thin must be strong, and he hates himself for it more than he has hated anything. *GM's note:* treat this as tragedy, never spectacle. Any PC who knew one of the seven, or who learns the truth of Lank's hunger, faces a Dread 3 check; a Thin PC who fails must check against the Want *Stillness* (Hard 14) the next time they stand in a field at dusk, whatever their Regrowth, because the sentence from the barn has found them too. The way out is people: a PC who spends a scene with another who asks them plainly to stay may reroll that check.



It is not hungry if you are in it.

CHARCOAL ON THE BEAM AT COLDHARBOUR BARN;
THE THIN SAND IT OFF, AND IT COMES BACK

THE RENDERERS' UNION

The slaughter, salting, and shipping trades: butchers, renderers, coopers, drovers, salters, jointers and the dock-gangs of the Chute. They control what leaves the country and know what is in it. The Union's members are broad, red-armed, practical people who smell of brine and tallow and talk frankly about anything. They believe in work and in the barrel. They want their wages, their monopoly, and the Board's continued need of them; they also want, more and more, someone else to be blamed when the world finds out what has been in the barrels. Their allies are the Rim Road Company; their enemies, the Board when it tries to tax them. A PC joins by apprenticeship, or by doing a job in the Chute and keeping quiet.

A rendering-house at full work is a particular hell, and the Union is proud of it: rows of coppers the height of a man, a hot brown greasy fog thick enough to taste, floors like skating-rinks of tallow and sawdust, and a ceaseless seething like a crowd whispering. The Hooks eat the cracklings by the fistful as they work. What sinks to the bottom of the copper, the *grounds*, is scraped out at the end of each day and is the Union's secret: a dark sweet paste sold, very quietly, as a flavouring, which is what the Vigil buyer was eating.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hook	Work in the yards; Union protection; a cleaver.
2	Jointer	Right to carve at wakes for a fee; the trade's secret cuts.
3	Yardmaster	Command of a rendering-house; a share of export profits.
4	Stamper	Control of a barrel-mark; knows what is in each consignment.
5	Mistress of the Union	Brisket Annalow. Can stop the Rim Road with a word.

THE CULLMASTERS

A quiet office of the Board which holds that the Reaping can be steered. If the fields must take, the Cullmasters reason, better that they take vagrants, debtors and troublemakers than good farmers and children. They draw up the lists. They assign the dusk shift. They think of it as agriculture.

The **dusk-shift** is a ritual, though no Cullmaster would use the word. On Carving afternoons, a Cullmaster's clerk reads the list in the village square: names, debts, and a plot-number in the Dusk

Acres. The named are fed a large and excellent supper at the Board's expense, a real feast with roast and pie and hot bread and as much as they can hold, because the Cullmasters have found that the fields take the well-fed more gently, and because, they say, it is only decent. Then the named are dressed in clean white field-smocks and walked out along the furrows in a line, each carrying a sickle with a ribboned handle, to their numbered stones. The Cullmaster walks behind them with a lantern. At each stone he stops, bows to the worker, and says the words: *Work well. The field is grateful. You are paid in full*. Then he unrolls a strip of red cloth across the end of the row, so that the worker will know which side of it to stay on,

and walks back to the road, and stands with his clerk and his lantern to watch the light go. The workers who try to leave the row are turned back by Bailiffs. The ones who stay bent over their work, cutting and binding, see the wheat begin to lean. A good Cullmaster records each Reaping in his ledger with the plot-number, the time, and the weight of the following year's yield. A great Cullmaster can tell you, to the pound, how much bread one debtor makes.

Not all of the dusk-shift are taken. Perhaps one in three walk back at full dark, shaking, their debts paid. That fraction, the Cullmasters insist, proves it is labour and not execution. The Long Count suggests the fraction is falling.

Hear the list for the parish of Bramble Furrow, Carving, the year six hundred and forty.

– A DUSK-LIST AS READ, PRESERVED ON A TALLY-STICK AT KETTLE FURROW; A FIFTH NAME HAS BEEN SCRAPED OFF WITH A KNIFE

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Lanternbearer	Walks the line; carries the light; a stipend.
2	Listing Clerk	Drafts the dusk-shift lists; may strike or add one name a season.
3	Cullmaster	Owns a plot-ledger; command of Bailiffs on Carving evenings.
4	Senior Cullmaster	Chooses which districts are spared; reports to the Board's inner committee.
5	Cullmaster-General	Varn Sweetbread. Steers the Reaping, he believes.

THE SECOND HELPING

A joyous cult of the Bait doctrine. The god starved us so we would eat it, they say; it wanted to be inside us, and now it wants to be fed and to feed, and the holiest thing a person can do is join in. Eat, and be eaten, and be glad. The Second Helping meets at Gladbelly and in a hundred kitchens across the plain, and they are the happiest people in the south: fat, laughing, singing hymns about gravy, embracing strangers. They want the Seating, and they want it soon, and they intend to hurry it along by giving the god as much of themselves as it will take. Their allies are the Second Table, which finds them useful and gullible; their enemies are the Thin, who pity them, and the Board, which finds them embarrassing and quietly very convenient. A PC joins by sharing a meal at Gladbelly and accepting a second helping. Everyone is offered one.

The cult's highest sacrament is the **Offering**. A member who has decided to go to the god announces it at table, and everyone cheers. There is a week of feasting in the Offered's honour, in which they

Item: Josiah Pell, labourer, debt of sixty-one lacks to the Board stores. Plot LT-209.

Item: Widow Marn, no debt, a troublemaker, for teaching the Count. Plot LT-210.

Item: Hennet Hollowell, rush-weaver, for harbouring a person wanted by the Board. Plot LT-211.

Item: a vagrant, name not given, found sleeping in the common house. Plot LT-212.

Supper is at Fourth Plate in the yard, and there is pork. The Board thanks you. Work well.

are fed by every hand in the commune. On the last evening they are bathed in warm dripping and garlanded with toothed wheat and carried in procession to the pavilion, singing. Their family walks beside them. Their family, too, is singing, and it is only afterward, on the long benches, with the plates going round, that the singing becomes something else: a widower holding a fork he cannot lift, a daughter who keeps saying *but she was happy, she was happy, she said she was happy*, a small boy asking where his mother has gone while a sweet brown smell drifts out of the kitchens. The Second Helping does not talk about the ones left behind. They are expected to rejoice, and to eat, and to offer themselves in their turn. Many do. That is how the cult grows: by grief that has nowhere else to go.

*Lay me in the dripping, love, and lay me on the board;
garland me in toothy wheat and give me to the Lord.
Take a slice and pass it down, and take a slice and smile;
I'll be in you, I'll be in you, I'll be in you for a while.*

– GLADBELLY HYMN, SUNG IN PROCESSION TO THE PAVILION; THE LAST LINE REPEATS UNTIL THE PAVILION DOOR IS SHUT

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Guest	A seat at the long tables; the hymns; never to eat alone again.
2	Server	Feeds newcomers; may speak at table.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
3	Platholder	Leads a household kitchen; tends the Offered in their last week.
4	Garland	Has given part of themselves (a finger, an ear) and is honoured.
5	The Prophet	Brother Glut, who is being served one piece at a time.

CROSS-BORDER POWERS IN THE SOUTH

The **Second Table** is strong in the Fatlands, because the Gut-lines are its natural members: who better to eat a god twice than a family already eating everything? Its southern chapter meets in Marrable Hall under cover of the Unending Dinner. **The Cutwrights' College** keeps a southern registry in Sated and knows, from three centuries of weighing records, exactly which families will Seat next. **The Purgation** funds the Thin. **The Reckoners** find the Fatlands hard going: a high-Cut Gut-line, rooted on its estate, is almost impossible to kill, and the hills do not die when stabbed. **The Rim Road Company** owns a third of the Chute's wagons and does not inspect the barrels.

▼ THE FATLANDS NOW

The Reaping has doubled in ten years, and the fields are turning up things with faces: a turnip with a nose and two shut lids, a squash with the profile of a missing child, an ear of wheat that, when split, held a single human molar with a silver filling. The Board's answer is the Cullmasters, and the dusk-shift lists grow longer every Carving. The Thin are growing, recruiting among the families of the culled. A girl has appeared who feels no hunger at all, and the Board has put a price on her that does not specify alive. And for the first time, an exile from the Fast has sat down at a Fatlands table and eaten. What is happening to him has no name yet.

The field-faces have frightened the ordinary people of the plain more than any tally. A woman of Millsop lifted a swede in Carving 638 and found on its underside a small, closed, perfectly human face, warm, with the brown mole her lost husband had on his cheek. She did what a Fatlander does with everything: she cooked it, with butter, and ate it with her children, and said his name. That night all three dreamed of him, standing at the end of a long table in a field, laying one more place than there were chairs. The markets of Sated have quietly begun to sell root-crops already peeled.

Underneath all of it is the arithmetic the Board will not publish. The Reaping doubles; the hills multiply; the Dowagers creep toward one another. Ummer is gathering itself up out of ten thousand graves and ten thousand bellies, and it is hungry, and it has the whole of the Fatlands for a body. Many Fatlanders have started, without saying why, to dream of walking in procession.



I cooked him with butter. What else would I do? He liked butter.

A WIDOW OF MILLSOP, 638

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◇ **The Notched Barrels.** Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot sends a sealed list to a PC he trusts: the export barrels he has notched. A Vigil buyer has fallen ill in a way that sounds very like the Appetite. The PCs must trace a consignment from the Chute to the Rim Road, against the Renderers, the Company, and the Board, and decide who on the Table should know what they have been eating.
- ◇ **The Dusk List.** A PC, or someone they love, is named on a Cullmaster's list. Varn Sweetbread is courteous and immovable. The PCs have until Carving dusk to bribe a Listing Clerk, find a substitute (Fatlanders will suggest one), break the Gavage open for a Thin rescue as distraction, or walk the row themselves and survive.
- ◇ **Wren for Weight.** Wren Hollowell is hidden in a Thin barn in the Orchards. The Board will pay her weight in bone coin; the Second Table will pay more for her organs; the Thin will die for her. The Fasting Girl wants none of it. She wants to see the sea.
- ◇ **The Hill That Walked.** Mercy Sowerby, the Hill-Speaker, reports that two Dowager Hills have moved close enough to touch, and that their mouths are talking to each other in a

language no one living speaks. The Gut-lines want it hushed.
The College wants measurements. The hills want visitors.

- ◇ **The Scarecrow Turns.** In Low Tilt, the Scarecrow has turned around, and it is facing Pell Hogget's barn. The villagers want it burned. Nobody who has tried to light it has come back from the far field.
- ◇ **Plot LT-211.** A Thin courier brings Wren Hollowell a tally-stick with her mother's name on it, from the Bramble Furrow list of 640. Did Hennes Hollowell walk back at full dark? The Cullmaster's ledger knows; so does the strip, and the bread from it, which is in a Board granary waiting for export. Wren wants to know. She does not want to be told by anyone who would sell her.
- ◇ **A Place at Hask's End.** Mother Furlong of Hask's End has offered the village another bargain: one more, and this time she means it. The village is split; the new Reeve has sent for outsiders to "advise," meaning to choose. Linner's betrothed has volunteered. The PCs may find a way to show the village the truth, or may find that a village that has already paid once cannot bear to have paid for nothing, and will pay again to prove it was not.
- ◇ **Weighed in Gammon.** A Washer pensioned off to the coast in 619 has died, and her daughter has found among her things a sworn account of what was found in Cress Gammon's folds, and a scrap of something in a salt-box. Lard Gammon votes with the Chairman on the dusk-lists. The Thin would give a great deal to unseat him. Lard Gammon would give more to have the salt-box back, and he has never once been refused a dish by Jem Crackle.

RUMORS OF THE FATLANDS

DIO	RUMOR
1	The Chairman's roots have reached the Weighhouse cellars and are drinking from the Gravy. <i>(True.)</i>
2	There are wolves after all; a pack was seen near Kettle Furrow. <i>(False; it was a Cullmaster's line in white.)</i>
3	Dame Marrable's Dinner has a second table in the cellar where only nobles sit, and the meat there is different. <i>(True: it is the Second Table.)</i>
4	Eat a Blank's heart and you'll be full forever. <i>(False, but it is why Wren is hunted.)</i>
5	The Fast's god is walking the Rim Road, and if you follow it you'll find a meal that fills. <i>(Half-true.)</i>
6	The Board fasts in secret and only pretends to eat. <i>(False. They eat more than anyone.)</i>
7	The Thin Man drinks something from the Orchards that kills the hunger. <i>(False. See Corder Lank.)</i>
8	Granny Cracknel can tell who's next for the Reaping by the teeth in the flour. <i>(True.)</i>
9	Low Tilt was once twice the size, and half of it is under the wheat. <i>(True.)</i>
10	The Brother Glut who preaches now is the third man to bear that name. <i>(False; it has always been the same man, less each year.)</i>

THE PEOPLE OF THE FATLANDS

Chairman Obb Tullow, the Heaviest Vote. Head of the Board at nineteen hundred pounds, he is moved by dray and eight oxen through streets cleared by Bailiffs. Up close he is a landscape: rolls of cool, brown, loam-soft flesh draped over the dray’s iron bed like a slumped haystack, crusted with the green shoots his Washers never quite get off, and at the summit a small, pink, clever face that looks out of the folds like a man peering from a cellar. His voice is reedy and precise. He is still the shrewdest mind on the Board. His feet rooted through the cart’s iron floor last spring, through a seam the smiths had missed, and the Board has agreed not to notice; the dray

has not moved since, and the Board now meets around it. He wants to die Chairman. He fears the moment his mouth closes and the hill keeps voting. His secret is that the roots go all the way down to the Weighhouse cellars, and he can feel the Reaping through them, every one, as a warm full mouthful. Close to, he smells of a cellar full of apples, of warm hay and of the inside of a cow, and the air around the dray is close and humid as a glasshouse. His Washer, Nell Haslet, feeds him by hand from a silver spoon, and when the Reaping figures are read he closes his small eyes and his lips move with the numbers, and the floor of the Weighhouse rises and falls.

OBB TULLOW – CHAIRMAN OF THE BOARD OF PLENTY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 6 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 8
SKILLS	Feast 5, Endure 4, Clause 3, Persuade 3, Intimidate 3, Reckoning 3
BODY	Flesh 18 · Guard 12 · Armor 1 (loam-flesh) · Fray 5
ATTACKS	rolling crush +2 (4); cannot pursue
GIFTS	Field-Body (feels every footstep in the Weighhouse and on the Weighing Road); the Board’s grain bends toward him when he speaks; regains 1d6 Flesh per meal
WANTS	to eat whatever is placed within reach; never to be moved; to be told the Reaping figures, aloud, slowly
DREAD	3 (to watch him eat, or to see what grows under the dray)
SECRET	Tullow has arranged for the Cullmasters to list the families of every Deacon who votes against him.

Read them again, slowly. Low Tilth first. Ah. Ah, yes.
That one was a big lad.

CHAIRMAN OBB TULLOW, IN COMMITTEE, 640

Dame Suet Marrable. Gut-lines matriarch, mistress of Marrable Hall, and hostess of the Unending Dinner, in continuous service for eighty-one years. She sits at the head of the three-hundred-foot table on a reinforced throne that is slowly sinking into the floorboards, swathed in gold silk, her face powdered white and her many chins hung with pearls like dew on a hedge. She smells of rosewater over roast pork. Her voice is warm and husky and she calls everyone *duck*.

Guests have been born at her table and several have been served at it, when they died there; the custom is that no one leaves, and some have not. She wants the Dinner to outlast her and fears that it will not, because her feet have begun to grow down through the floor. She is the Second Table’s southern chair, and the cellar beneath her dining hall holds a smaller table where the guests are older and the meat is something rarer. Her guests’ plates are nicked at the rim, so that with the first cut of meat their own blood is on her knife, and she licks it, smiling, and calls them by their grandmothers’ names. The Dinner has its own smell, which visitors carry home in their clothes for a week: eighty-one years of gravy soaked into the floorboards, rose-water, beeswax, and under it, faintly, the sweet heavy reek of the cellar.

DAME SUET MARRABLE – HOSTESS OF THE UNENDING DINNER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Persuade 4, Feast 5, Clause 3, Endure 3, Search 2, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 12 · Armor 1 · Fray 3
ATTACKS	carving knife +3 (2)
GIFTS	Taste the Name (one bite of a guest's blood tells her their family, Cut and one secret); her hall's food compels (Caul + Resolve, Hard 14, to rise from her table)
WANTS	that no guest leave hungry; that no guest leave
DREAD	2 (to see a guest served)
SECRET	She has Tobias Wether's name on a place card, and a seat waiting for him in the cellar.

Pell Hogget, the Counter. A farmer from Kettle Furrow in Low Tilth: short, broad, sunburnt, with a wheat-coloured beard and a stub of chalk always behind one ear. He speaks slowly and carefully and gives numbers instead of opinions. He noticed his village was one smaller each autumn and wrote it down, and now two hundred villages send him their tallies and his barn wall is a ledger of the dead. He eats less than he should and the Bailiff has begun to look at him. He wishes he had never learned to count. He fears that the numbers have a shape: his projection crosses his own village's population in nineteen years, and the whole country's soon after. His secret is that his wife was culled four years ago, and he has never put her mark on the wall. He keeps a tally-stick of his own in his boot with no notch on it, and touches it before every meal, and his neighbours have learned not to ask whose it is.



*Don't ask me if it's the god. Ask me how many. I know
how many.*

PELL HOGGET, TO A CUTWRIGHT SURVEYOR

Corder Lank, the Thin Man. Leader of the Thin. He has eaten nothing but water and ash for six years and can be counted bone by bone: a long, brown, tendon-strung figure in a rope belt, his skin tight as a drumhead over ribs and hips and knuckles, his eyes huge and calm and very clear. He smells of woodsmoke and nothing else. He speaks quietly and always first asks whether you are hungry. He is the only man in the south who does not feel the hunger, and he will not say how. The truth is that the hunger did not leave him: it went out of him, piece by piece, into those who fast beside him. Every Thin cell carries a share of Corder Lank's gnawing on top of its own. He worked this out three years ago. He has not told them. He cannot stop leading, because it is the only thing that keeps him clear. Since the Coldharbour Lack he wears seven belly-cords knotted together under his own, and when the Thin ask him why he is heavier in the cord than he was, he says it is penance, which is true.

CORDER LANK – THE THIN MAN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste, dormant) · Hunger 0
SKILLS	Resolve 5, Endure 4, Persuade 3, Stealth 3, Athletics 2, Rites 2, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	knife +3 (2)
GIFTS	Passing the Plate: anyone who fasts a day in his company loses 1 Hunger and he loses none; they gain it back, doubled, the day they leave him
WANTS	to be needed; never to be fed
DREAD	1
SECRET	His hunger lives in his followers. If he dies, it goes back to the god all at once, and the Thin will feel it go.

Mistress Brisket Annalow. Boss of the Renderers’ Union: a vast, red-armed woman in a leather apron stiff with salt, her grey hair cropped short, a cleaver on a chain at her hip and a pencil behind her ear. She talks like a drover and laughs like a kettle. She can stop every barrel on the Rim Road with one word, and she knows precisely which of them should never have been filled, because she has kept a second ledger for twenty-two years. She wants the Union paid and her people safe. She fears the day the Table stops buying. She would sell the Board out in an afternoon to keep the Chute open. She knows the grounds at the bottom of the coppers are what the Vigil buyer ate. She knows where Sal Trotter’s calves come from. Her hands are cracked from the brine to the elbow and she rubs them with tallow at night, and does not ask herself whose.

BRISKET ANNALOW Threat 5 · Flesh 15 · Guard 12 · Attack +6 (cleaver 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

Hob Gristle, the Honest Butcher. A big, mild, sorrowful man with forearms like hams and a bald head beaded with sweat. He can tell by taste what a cut used to be, down to the name: a mouthful of sausage tells him the pig, the field it ate from, and the name of anyone Reaped into that field. It has ruined him for the trade. He still works, because jointing at wakes is the only honest money left, and he apologizes to every joint, quietly, by name. He wants one barrel from the Chute that tastes of nothing but beef. He fears the

day he tastes someone he loves. He has already tasted his brother, in a pie in Sated, and has told no one. He knows from the taste that his brother was not taken by any field: the meat in the pie tasted of a kitchen knife and of fear, and no field has ever made meat taste of fear.

◇
Sorry, old lad. Sorry. Sorry.
HOB GRISTLE, AT EVERY JOINT, UNDER HIS BREATH

Cullmaster Varn Sweetbread. The Board’s quiet hand: a neat, plump, pink man in grey broadcloth, with soft white fingers, rimless spectacles and a ledger chained to his belt. He smells faintly of lavender, which he uses to cover the field. His voice is gentle and his manners perfect. He decides which vagrants, debtors and troublemakers are assigned the dusk shift, and he thinks of it as agriculture, in the most literal sense: he weighs the next year’s yields and has proved, to his own satisfaction, that a culled vagrant makes better bread than a Reaped farmer. He walks every line himself and bows at every stone. He is not cruel. That is the worst thing about him. It was his ink that struck out the Hask’s End Wolf-Warden’s last two lines, out of kindness, because he thought the man would be listed for them. He was right; the man was listed anyway.

VARN SWEETBREAD – CULLMASTER-GENERAL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Reckoning 4, Clause 3, Intimidate 3, Resolve 3, Rites 2, Endure 2, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	ribboned sickle +3 (3)
GIFTS	Field-Reading: he knows, on any Carving evening, which plot will Reap first
WANTS	to see the line through to the end; to taste the bread of each plot he culled
DREAD	2 (to watch his dusk-shift)
SECRET	His own name is on next year’s list, in the Chairman’s hand.

Tansy Lard, the Gleaner. A girl of ten who gleans behind the harvesters in Low Tilth: skinny for a Fatlander, with tangled straw hair and a smock too short in the arms, and dirt permanently under her nails. She dug up a root with her mother’s birthmark on it, a brown splash shaped like a running hare, and has replanted it behind the house and waters it every day. It has grown. It has leaves like hands. Last week, at dusk, it said her name. Her father has noticed she has stopped eating at table and goes out after dark with the bowl. She wants her mother back. She is the reason the PCs may first learn what a Fatland root can become. The root is warm when she touches it and turns its hand-leaves toward her when she comes out of the back door, the way a sunflower turns, and the soil around it has begun, very slightly, to breathe.

Brother Glut. Prophet of the Second Helping: enormous, radiant, and happy, a mountain of pink flesh in a garland of wheat, his face shining with sweat and tears of joy, his voice a deep golden bell that fills a meadow without trying. He preaches that being eaten is the highest form of being loved, and he has volunteered parts of himself to prove it: his left hand, both ears, three toes, a long strip from the flank. The wounds are bound with clean linen and he shows them off like medals. He embraces every stranger. He believes every word. What he does not see is the widows at the back of each meeting, holding their plates. He smells of hot dripping and lavender and a faint sweet sourness from under the linen where the wounds are. When he embraces a stranger the stranger is held a long

time, against the soft enormous warmth of him, and many weep without knowing why.

BROTHER GLUT – PROPHET OF THE SECOND HELPING	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 4, Feast 4, Endure 4, Godsign 3
BODY	Flesh 17 · Guard 11 · Armor 1 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	crushing embrace +2 (1, held)
GIFTS	The Shared Plate: anyone who eats his flesh loses 1d6 Hunger and must pass Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or come back for more
WANTS	to give; to see others give
DREAD	2 (to see him carve himself, smiling)
SECRET	He has not felt the hunger since his hand was eaten. He thinks this is grace. It is the god, moving out.

◇

I gave them my hand, and do you know, I have never felt so held.

BROTHER GLUT, AT GLADBELLY

Old Mother Rind. A Laden woman who rooted forty years ago and is now a small orchard hill outside the village of Kettle Furrow, with nine pear trees growing from her back and a working mouth half-hidden in the clover at her foot. Her lips are brown and cracked like bark and her teeth are wheat-teeth, many rows. Her voice is a dry old woman’s, amused and sharp. Her village asks her advice on marriages; she is always right, and always hungry, and her fee is meat. Lately she has asked for particular people. The names she asks for are always ones the far field wants this Carving. She says that if they are fed to her, they will be hers and not the Scarecrow’s, and that she is quick and the field is slow, and that this is mercy. Hask’s End once believed something very like it of Mother Furlong.

Dr. Emmerich Paunch. The Board’s physician: a stooped, heavy, myopic man with ink-stained cuffs and a voice like a dry quill. He opened a Gut-lines stomach, under licence, to measure its capacity, and lowered a plumb line into it. He ran out of line at two hundred feet. He has since obtained longer line. He has not been able to bring himself to use it, because when he drew the first one up, the lead weight had been chewed. He wants to publish. He fears the Board, and what he heard echoing up the line. He will pay adventurers very well to hold the rope.

◇

The stomach of a Gut-line lady is not an organ. It is a door. I should like very much to know what it opens on, and I should like very much not to.

DR. EMMERICH PAUNCH, PRIVATE NOTEBOOK

Sal Trotter, the Drover. A lean, weathered woman in a dung-crusted oilskin, with a crook, a whip she never uses, and a pipe she never lights. She walks herds to market at the Chute that the buyers call cattle. They walk on two legs when no one is watching the road. She has stopped naming them, because they started answering. She speaks little, mostly to the herd, in a low, even croon. She wants to finish one drive without looking back. She fears the day one of them asks her where they are going. It will be soon; the lead steer has begun to hum her songs. The lead steer’s flank bears a scar where a brand would be, and she has never looked at it closely.

SAL TROTTER’S HERD (EACH) Threat 2 · Flesh 16 · Guard 10 · Attack +4 (trample 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 2 (to see them stand)

Wren Hollowell, the Fasting Girl. A Blank of fifteen from Bramble Furrow who has never once felt hungry. She is small and narrow and pale, with a long plain face and grey eyes that rest on things without wanting them, and in a land of the vast she looks like a drawing of a girl rather than a girl. She eats when reminded, without interest. The Thin kneel to her, which she hates. The Board has offered her weight in bone coin to whoever brings her in, and has not specified alive; the Second Table has a surgeon waiting. She wants to see the sea, and to be left alone. She is beginning to notice that fields go quiet when she walks through them, as though they cannot smell her at all. She does not yet know that her mother’s name was read on the Bramble Furrow list in Carving 640, or which strip it was given.

WREN HOLLOWELL Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · cannot be Reaped; no Cut, no Hunger

Garrick Tripe, the Weigher. Keeper of the official scales at the annual Weighing: a jovial, oily man in a brass-buttoned coat, with a waxed moustache and a dozen rings. For the right fee your pockets fill with lead, and for a better one your rival’s empty. He has personally elected three governments. He wants to retire rich. He

fears that the Chairman knows exactly how much of his vote is lead; Tullow does, and is waiting for the right moment.

Lady Aspic Dellamore. A noble chef whose speciality is preservation: tall for a Gut-line, sleek and plump, in a white silk apron, with lacquered nails and a cold, musical laugh. Her rivals are displayed in her gallery, set in clear golden jelly, garnished with herbs and quail’s eggs, and blinking. The jelly keeps them; the Gut-line blood keeps them hungry. They watch visitors eat at her table. She wants to be the greatest cook on the Table. She fears blandness. She is working on a new piece for the gallery, and has been measuring Dame Marrable. The Gallery smells of cold gelatine and tarragon, and of something under it like a larder in which a mouse has died;

the jelly sweats a little in Plenty, and her servants wipe it down each morning with linen cloths while the faces inside follow the cloths with their eyes.

Jem Crackle, the Cook’s Knife. A former spit-boy and now the most reliable assassin in Sated: wiry, quick, red-knuckled, with burn scars to the elbow and the cheerful, sweaty face of a kitchen lad. He smells of onions and hot iron. He kills only in kitchens, and what he kills is on the table by evening, jointed, dressed and served so beautifully that the families often do not complain. He is proud of his work and owes nothing to anyone. He fears only being bored. He takes contracts from the Board, the Union and the Second Table impartially.

JEM CRACKLE – THE COOK’S KNIFE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Blades 5, Stealth 4, Athletics 3, Feast 3, Craft 3, Filch 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 19 · Armor 0 · Fray 1
ATTACKS	boning knife +10 (2); cleaver +10 (3)
GIFTS	In any kitchen he gains a free Helping on his first attack; he can joint a body in the time it takes to boil a kettle
WANTS	to cook what he kills
DREAD	2 (to find a missing friend on his table)
SECRET	He has a list of every person he has served, and who ate them. He sells it.

Bailiff Dunmow Fatt. Enforcer of the Feasting Laws in Sated: a huge, slow, pink-cheeked man with a gentle lisp, a blue sash, and a funnel and ladle of office worn like a sword and sceptre. He is, by every account, gentle about it. He kneels to feed the stubborn, strokes their throats, sings to them. He has wept over every Thin prisoner he has ever taken. He wants everyone to be well. He does not understand why anyone would refuse. He fears, a little, the quiet in Corder Lank’s eyes.

DUNMOW FATT Threat 3 · Flesh 16 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (ladle 3, Grappling) · Armor 1 · Dread 1

Marigold Chine. Keeper of the oldest grove in the Bleeding Orchards: a slender, freckled woman of fifty with a strong alto and a straw hat. She refused the deafening and sings to her trees through the pruning. They have begun to sing back, in tune, in her voice, a thousand trees at once, and the other keepers, who cannot hear it, feel it in their teeth. She wants to learn what the trees are trying to say. She fears she already knows: the last verse is the wake-song, and it is about her. Her mother’s mother was a Strake.

Tobias Wether, the First to Eat. A runaway from the Fast, twenty-four, raised on six centuries of refusal, who crossed the Rim Road and ate. He was thin as a rake when he came; he is filling out now, and his skin has taken on a warm brown loam-tint. He carries no god in his blood. The meat seems to be looking for one. He feels the hunger now, a borrowed hunger with no lineage, and it is worse than any Fatlander’s, because it has nowhere to settle. He is ashamed, delighted, and terrified. The Second Table wants him; the Reckoners want him dead; Dame Marrable wants him at dinner. He has taken, without knowing why, to setting one more place at every table than there are diners, and he is upset if anybody sits in it.

The Scarecrow of Low Tilt. Nobody put it up. It stands in the far field of Kettle Furrow with its back to the village: a tall, thin shape of sacking and straw on a pole, in a farmer’s smock and a wide hat, its arms spread. The straw is toothed wheat. The sacking is warm. Each Carving it is a few furrows closer. Last year someone saw it turn around. Its face, they say, is a mouth, and the mouth is full of the names on Pell Hogget’s wall.

THE SCARECROW – THE FAR FIELD	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 6 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 0 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	none; it is a piece of Ummer standing up
SKILLS	Stealth 5, Instinct 5, Brawl 3, Endure 4
BODY	Flesh 30 · Guard 15 · Armor 2 · Fray —
ATTACKS	straw fingers +6 (3, and the target's feet begin to root: Gut + Endure, Hard 14, or held)
GIFTS	moves only when unobserved; any field it stands in Reaps at dusk; fire will not take on it
WANTS	to reach the village
DREAD	4 (to see it face you)
SECRET	It is walking toward the Weighhouse, by way of every village that has stopped counting.

Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot. He feeds the army and stamps the export barrels at the Chute: a portly, fussy, honest man with a bald freckled head, a stamp on a cord and a tremor in his left hand. He has started marking a small notch on the ones he would not eat from himself. There are a great many notches. He wants someone outside the Fatlands to know. He fears that if they knew, they would keep buying.

Granny Cracknel, the Tooth-Miller. She mills the toothed wheat at the old water-mill on the Little Gravy and keeps the teeth. Her mill is decorated with eleven hundred sets, sorted by village and strung on wires like rattling wind-chimes. She is tiny, ancient, floury, toothless herself, and chuckles constantly. She says some of the sets match people she knew. She is right; and she has started to find, in each new harvest's sieve, the teeth of people who are still alive. Hessop teeth she keeps on a wire of their own, because she says she cannot tell one generation from the next.

NEW FACES

Wakemother Pudding Hesk. The most sought-after wake-cook in Sated: a round, brisk, broad-faced woman with forearms scarred by spatter and a laugh that rattles crockery. Families wait months for her. She bastes the dead with their own dripping and a little honey, roasts them slow over applewood, and sends them to the table glazed and crackling, and she weeps every time, openly, while she carves. She knows everyone's secrets, because the dead taste of them. She wants to cook the Chairman. She has been asked to. She fears she will be too greedy to share him.

Feeder Callow Pudge. Head feeder at the Gavage: a soft-voiced, motherly woman in a starched white apron, with plump dimpled hands and a funnel she has polished for thirty years. She hums lullabies as she pours. She sincerely believes she saves lives. She keeps a book of the Thin she has fed, with their weights in and their weights out, and letters from their grateful families. She fears the ones who come back to the Thin, and she has begun, secretly, to leave one cell door unbarred each Lack.

CALLOW PUDGE AND GAVAGE FEEDERS Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (grapple, then funnel: Gut + Endure, Hard 14, or helpless) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

Mercy Sowerby, the Hill-Speaker. A young widow employed by the Gut-lines to interpret the Dowager Hills: thin-lipped, careful, dressed in field-brown with soil always on her knees, because she must lie face-down on the turf to hear. She translates the Dowagers' slow speech and lays their offerings. She has noticed that two hills are moving together, that their mouths are talking, and that the language is older than Table-speech. She wants someone to tell. She fears the Dowagers have noticed her noticing; last week one of them used her name.

Lord Chastain Loin. Heir to a Gut-line that Seated last generation: a young, enormous, beautiful man of eight hundred pounds, with oiled ringlets, perfect teeth, and a voice like warm cream. He is Dame Marrable's protégé in the Second Table, charged with acquiring Blanks for the cellar table. He eats elegantly and constantly, and his manners never slip. He wants to be at the table when Ummer stands up, with a knife in his hand. He fears that his own mother, the hill behind his house, will stand up first, and that she has never forgiven him for the wake.

Lord Lard Gammon, the Twin Who Weighed In. Head of the Gammons of the Fold and a Member of the Board since 619: fifty-three now, near thirteen hundred pounds, moved on a dray and sitting always to the Chairman's left, with a soft, mild, slightly bewildered face like a large baby's, and pale lashes, and small damp hands that he folds over his belly as if keeping something in. He votes with the Chairman on every dusk-list, and adds no names of his own, and has never been known to raise his voice. He eats in his kitchen, among the servants, because the dining room is locked. At table he sometimes stops, with the spoon half-raised, and listens to something inside himself, and says, to nobody, "Yes, all right," and passes the salt along the board to an empty place. He wants to be forgiven and does not know by whom. He fears the salt-box: a small one, of his brother's meat, that the Washers took with them in 619, and that would let anyone in the Fatlands put him to the oath again.

The Gammon Dowager, when he last consulted her, said only:
There are two of you in there, son. Which one of you is asking?

LARD GAMMON – MEMBER OF THE BOARD, KIN-SLAYER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Feast 4, Endure 4, Deceive 3, Clause 2, Brawl 2, Intimidate 2
BODY	Flesh 17 · Guard 11 · Armor 1 (loam-flesh) · Fray 8
ATTACKS	smothering press +4 (3, Grappling; the target must pass Gut + Endure, Hard 14, each round or lose 1d6 Flesh)
GIFTS	Two Mouths: when he eats, his brother eats too, and he regains 1d6 Flesh per meal; once per scene he may answer a question with his brother's knowledge of the Gammon House (Instinct, no roll)
WANTS	to pass the salt to the empty place; never to sit in the dining room; to be weighed, and found heavier
DERANGEMENTS	the Second Tenant (he believes his brother lives in his body, and is often right)
DREAD	3 (to hear the second voice answer from his belly)
SECRET	He did it, and swore falsely on his brother's meat, and the Gammon Dowager knows. Cress is not a delusion. Cress is in the field of him, as all the eaten are, and wants the seat back.

Ambrosine Hessop, the Rise's Daughter. The eldest living Hessop who still walks: a woman of about forty who looks twenty-five, very large and very lovely, with the family's wide grey eyes and small even teeth and a slow, warm, sleepy voice, as if she had just woken. She sells Hessop Sweet flour to the great houses of the Fold, and is received everywhere, and is a guest at the Unending Dinner, and nobody has ever seen her eat there. She walks barefoot, because she says shoes hurt, and where she has walked on bare earth the grass the next morning is a little longer. She speaks of the Rise as *Granny* and of her husband, who is also her cousin, with the same warmth and the same small secret smile, and she has never left Low Tilth for longer than a night. She wants the Hessops to go on. She fears the

College's registry, which has begun to ask how many Hessop children are born with eyes that open, and how many are born with roots and nothing else. She has been asked by Lord Chastain Loin, very politely, whether a Hessop has ever been served at the cellar table, and she laughed her slow sleepy laugh and said that Hessops are always served, in a way, at every table in the south; and then she stopped laughing, and asked him never to come to the Rise on Sweating Night.

AMBROSINE HESSOP Threat 4 · Flesh 15 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (hand 1) · Armor 1 (loam-flesh) · Dread 2 (to see the roots in her footprints by morning) · Persuade 5, Godsign 4; rooted at will on Hessop land, where she cannot be harmed by anything that grows

▼ PLAYING A FATLANDER

You were raised on the best food on the Table and you have never once been full. You are large, warm, generous and polite, and you think of the dead as dinner and the fields as family. Abroad you will find other peoples' food grey and joyless, and their faces when you mention your grandmother's wake will teach you to stop mentioning it.

Play the warmth first. A Fatlander is the friend who brings a pie, the stranger who asks after your health and your weight, the companion who notices at once that you have not eaten and does something about it. Your manners are impeccable and they are all about food: you offer before you take, you serve others before yourself, you wipe your plate, you thank the field. You are uneasy in a room without a hob. You find hard ground unsettling and thin people pitiable, and you will press food on anyone you love, and keep pressing, gently, long after they have said no. Then play the hunger underneath, which is always there, which you have learned

to talk over the way people in a mill learn to talk over the grinding. You will notice everyone's hands. You will know what you would cook them with.

What you know without thinking. How to joint a pig, a sheep, and a person, and that the order is the same. How to render fat, cure a ham, and judge a roast by its sound. The names of your family's fields and which of your relations are in them. That a field at dusk in Carving is not a place. That a Bailiff with a funnel is not someone to argue with. That every hill might be listening.

What you do not say abroad. That the beef they are eating came from the Chute. That your mother is a slope near Kettle Furrow and you miss her. That their food has no taste, and that they themselves, if you are honest, smell faintly underseasoned.

Attribute bonus: +1 GUT.

The Sop: Clean the Plate. Eat a full meal until it hurts, and finish every scrap. This removes 1d6 Hunger. If the meal is the flesh of the human dead (a wake, a battlefield, a Second Helping table), remove 1d6+2 instead. The compulsion is fed: for the rest of the day, Want checks against *The Second Plate* are one step harder.

The Tooth. When a Fatlander Partakes, the mouth floods with saliva, the belly growls loud enough for the room to hear, and the teeth ache as though new ones were pushing through. Nearby food smells stronger. On a Tooth showing 1, the god bites back: the character must eat something, anything within reach, before their next action.

D6	WHEN THE GOD BITES BACK (WHAT YOU EAT, IF NOTHING BETTER IS NEAR)
1	The nearest candle, wick and all; it tastes of the beast it was rendered from.
2	A mouthful of the soil underfoot; it is warm and faintly sweet and moves on the tongue.
3	Your own sleeve, cuff or glove, chewed to a wet rag.
4	Whatever is in an ally's hand or plate, taken before you can stop yourself.
5	The soft pad of your own thumb, bitten until it bleeds; 1 Flesh, and the taste is wonderful.
6	Something that is not food and should not be eaten (a letter, a coin, a lock of hair); the GM chooses, and it matters.

GIFTS

The Taste (Regrowth 1–3). Iron Belly. You can eat almost anything: rotten meat, tallow, leather, mild poisons. Gain +2 to Feast rolls, and you may eat a meal's weight of anything organic as a Sop for half value (1d3 Hunger). *Cost:* each of the five daily meals you miss adds 1 Hunger.

The Appetite (Regrowth 4–6). Taste the Name. A mouthful of someone's flesh or blood (a cut, a kiss that draws blood, a slice at a wake) tells you their family, their Cut, and one thing they have eaten that they are ashamed of; on a Grace, one secret. **Gorge.** Spend ten minutes eating heavily to heal 1d6 Flesh (once per scene). *Cost:* each use of Taste the Name adds 1 Hunger, and witnesses who are not Fatlanders face a Dread 2 check.

The Course (Regrowth 7–9). Laden. Your GUT rises by 1 (to a maximum of 6) and your LUNG falls by 1; your loam-soft flesh grants Armor 1 that stacks with worn armor. **Rooting.** Standing still on bare soil for a round, you may root: you cannot be moved, knocked down or Reaped, gain +2 Guard, and heal 1 Flesh per round. *Cost:* tearing free deals 1d6 Flesh; each hour rooted adds 1 Hunger and requires Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) to leave at all.

The Brink (Regrowth 10–11). The Field Answers. Rooted, you feel every step on soil within a mile, and you may make the ground lean: crops grab and hold (Gut 5, Hard 14 to break free) for a scene, or a ripe field Reaps one helpless target at dusk. *Cost:* each use is a Dread 4 for witnesses and adds 2 Hunger; on a Lack, you do not uproot for a day.

WANTS

◇ **The Second Plate.** When food is in sight and your Hunger is 4 or more, you must eat it, whoever it belongs to. Resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14; Grim 18 if it is meat).

- ◇ **The Hollow.** When someone near you refuses food, you must make them eat, with words and then with hands. Resist at Hard 14.
- ◇ **The Long Pig.** At the Appetite and beyond, a corpse smells like supper. Resist at Hard 14 to leave it uneaten; at Grim 18 if it is someone you loved.
- ◇ **Stillness.** At the Course and beyond, when standing on warm soil at dusk, you want to stay. Resist at Hard 14 or root.

THE SEATING

A Fatlander who reaches Regrowth 12 becomes a hill. The player chooses where: a field they loved, a road they guarded, a grave they would not dig. The character is retired from play but not gone: they are a place, warm, fertile and hungry, and the other PCs may consult them as a Dowager, bring them meat, and receive true and terrible counsel. Some keep a mouth. All of them, in time, begin to move.

The GM should play a Seated PC as Mother Furlong was played: loving, sincere, and hungry, and less and less able to tell the three apart. The hill remembers the party. It remembers jokes, debts, and old wounds, and it will help them, truly, as long as they feed it. In the first year its counsel is wise and its requests are small: a joint, a song, a visit. By the third year it is asking for particular people, and it means well, and it is no longer entirely sure which of its memories are its own and which belong to the field. The players should be allowed to love it. That is the horror.

BACKGROUNDS

- ◇ **Jointer's Apprentice.** You carved at wakes for the Renderers before you were twenty, and you know a body as a map of cuts. *Suggested:* Blades, Stitching, Feast.
- ◇ **Thin Runaway.** You fasted with Corder Lank, were caught, and were fed at the Gavage. You are heavy now and you hate it. *Suggested:* Endure, Stealth, Resolve.

- ◇ **Dusk-Shift Survivor.** Your name was on a list. You walked the row, watched the wheat lean, and walked back. Nobody in your village will meet your eye. *Suggested:* Wayfaring, Instinct, Labor.
- ◇ **Washer of the Fold.** You cleaned the folds of the great for years and know what grows there, and every secret the Gut-lines lost in themselves. You laugh at nothing, and your hands are raw. *Suggested:* Stitching, Search, Endure.
- ◇ **Long Count Runner.** You carried tallies from village to village folded in your shoe, and the Bailiffs know your face. You can recite the dead of forty parishes. *Suggested:* Wayfaring, Stealth, Lore.
- ◇ **Hill-Child.** Your grandmother is a hill and you were raised half on her slope; you have slept against her flank and heard her heartbeat through the turf. You hear the ground. The ground hears you. *Suggested:* Godsign, Instinct, Rites.

DIO	WHY YOU LEFT THE PLAINS
1	Your name was on a list, and you did not want to walk back.
2	You were sent north with a barrel, and you know what is in it.
3	The family hill asked for you by name.
4	You tasted someone you loved at a wake that was not theirs.
5	You ran from the Gavage and the funnel is still in your dreams.
6	You were Offered at Gladbelly, and at the pavilion door you could not.
7	You were sent by the Board to find out who else on the Table is hungry.
8	You want to find a meal that fills, and you have heard one exists in the Fast.
9	You stopped being able to sleep with the window open on the fields.
10	You are a Hessop, or you married one, and you will not say which.

NAMES

Given (male): Obb, Hob, Wilm, Varn, Garrick, Dunmow, Ivo, Abel, Ruddie, Barnaby, Crust, Leggat, Amos, Lard, Cress, Jory, Rowan, Aldous, Tobin. **Given (female):** Suet, Tansy, Marigold, Petty, Brisket, Hessop, Callow, Nell, Gravy, Dumpling, Wenna,

Ysolde, Linnet, Bette, Adeline, Ambrosine, Nan, Hennet. **Neutral:** Pell, Sal, Wren, Jem, Rind, Haslet, Chine, Pudding, Crumb, Sorrel, Tibbet. **Surnames:** Tullow, Marrable, Hogget, Lank, Gristle, Lard, Paunch, Trotter, Tripe, Crackle, Fatt, Chine, Wether, Stockpot, Cracknel, Callock, Strake, Loin, Dripping, Furrow, Gammon, Hessop, Fenn, Tallis, Furlong, Rake, Pask, Tidy, Ash, Crumb.

WE HAVE **EATEN**. WE WILL EAT. WE WILL BE **EATEN**.
THANK YOU.

[THE LONG GRACE OF THE FIELD CHURCH]

HORRORS OF THE FATLANDS

Roll a d20, or choose, when the party is travelling the plains, staying in a village, or simply sitting down to eat. Every one of these should be played warm, comfortable and well-fed until the moment it is not.

D20	HORROR
1	A child at the inn table chews her sleeve to threads, then the table edge, then, smiling, the side of her own hand. Her mother gently moves a pie toward her. (Dread 2)
2	Marbling morning: the white veins in the field run in the shape of a woman lying on her side, and they pulse. (Dread 2)
3	A wake in progress; the family insists the party join. The meat is the PC's contact from last session. (Dread 3)
4	A cabbage at market has a face, eyes shut, and it is the face of a stallholder two rows over, who is staring at it. (Dread 2)
5	At dusk, a line of white-smocked figures walks out along the furrows behind a lantern. One of them turns and mouths <i>help</i> . (Dread 3)
6	A well-bucket comes up full of warm broth, and something in the dark below swallows. (Dread 1)
7	A Laden man rooted by the road asks the party to pull him free. When they try, he screams, and the roots bleed, and the field around them groans. (Dread 3)
8	A Second Helping procession passes, singing, carrying a garlanded woman in dripping. Her small son walks behind holding her shoe. (Dread 3)
9	The party's bread, broken, is full of fine fair hair. The miller says it is from the Hessop plot, and that young Hessop was very pretty. (Dread 2)
10	The ground under the camp rises and falls all night. At dawn there is a new hill where the cookfire was, warm, with a mouth, and it calls one PC by their mother's name. (Dread 4)
11	A village ploughs its First Furrow at dawn; the plough is heavy, and the furrow behind it is a long wet red line, and everyone walking behind it is singing. (Dread 3)
12	A Washer in an inn kitchen scrubs her hands in the sink, and keeps scrubbing, laughing softly, until the water is pink; she says there is a summer under her nails. (Dread 1)
13	On a yard wall, nine bowls upside down. A tenth is set out as the party passes, by a woman who does not look at them. (Dread 2)
14	A Brink-Laden grandmother by the road asks a PC to kiss her goodnight; her forehead is clover, and under the clover something kisses back. (Dread 3)
15	A cookshop's ten-crumble plate comes with a covered side-dish nobody ordered; under the lid is a candied finger wearing a ring one PC knows. (Dread 3)
16	In a Thin barn, a row of belly-cords folded neatly on empty pallets, and charcoal on the beam: <i>it is not hungry if you are in it</i> . (Dread 2)
17	A man at Supper stops with his spoon raised, listens to his own belly, says "yes, all right," and passes the salt to an empty chair. The chair's cushion is warm. (Dread 2)
18	Sal Trotter's herd passes on the Drove Road at dusk; the lead steer is walking on two legs, humming, and as it passes it tips its head to a PC as a farmer tips his hat. (Dread 3)
19	A loaf on the inn table breathes under its cloth, slowly, and when cut, the crumb is pink and warm and closes again around the knife. (Dread 1)
20	At a long table in a field at dusk, laid for one more than are sitting, the party is invited to sit. Everyone at the table is someone the Long Count has marked. The empty place has a plate already served, and the steam off it smells of every harvest-home there ever was. (Dread 4)



CHAPTER 5

BRINEHOLLOW



The sea is not going out. It is going in.

— CARVED ON THE LOWMARK TIDE-POST, AUTHOR UNKNOWN

Call the names. Call them twice. If the wall answers in a voice you know, call them a third time, and listen for whether it knows you.

— INSTRUCTION FOR THE MORNING COUNT, AS TAUGHT TO CHILDREN ON THE MILE

The Count, as kept by Wenna Truss of Ropery Row, Lowmark, Mile Eleven. Written on the back of a chandler's bill and found folded inside her bail-bucket.

I call through the wall at first bell, same as every morning since I could stand. My mother taught me. You put your mouth to the plank where it's worn smooth, where the knot looks like an ear, and you call the names on the other side. Haddie. Bren. Little Os. Old Cobb. And they call back, one at a time, with the cough still in their voices, because nobody has bailed yet at first bell. That is how you know they are home. The wet in the throat. The answer.

This morning I called Haddie and Haddie answered. I called Bren and Bren answered. I called Little Os and he answered in that piping way, still half asleep, and I heard Haddie hush him. I called Old Cobb.

I want to set down exactly what happened next, because they will ask me at the Netwatch house and I will not be able to say it with my mouth.

Nothing answered. Not silence like an empty room. Silence like a held breath. The whole house on the other side of the plank went still, the way a pool goes still when something big turns over under it. And then Haddie began to make a sound I have heard eleven times in my life and never once from her.

I went round. The door was on the latch. Cobb's bed is the one by the west window, because he likes the light, because he has always liked the light, the old fool, and we all said it, we all said you shouldn't sleep facing that way at your age. The rope was still tied to the bedpost. Good tarred hemp from the Ropewalk, three turns and a hitch, done by Bren the night before. It was tied to the bedpost and it went across the blanket and over the edge of the bed and it stopped. The end was cut clean. Not frayed. Not chewed. Cut, the way you would cut it if you had a sharp knife and a steady hand and all the time in the world.

There was no knife in the room.

The floor was wet from the bed to the door, and from the door down the steps, and across the boards of the Row, and on to the pier rail, and over it, and on into the dark of the Uncovered where there is no water any more for nineteen miles. The wet went west. It does not dry fast on the Mile. It never has.

Haddie kept saying, I tied it, I tied it, I checked it, as if that was the thing that mattered, and Bren kept saying, I tied it, Mam, it was me, and Little Os stood in the doorway holding Cobb's bail-bucket in both arms, the old copper one with the dent, and he said, Grandda forgot his bucket.

He did. He will not need it now.

I want to say also that the bed was warm. The pillow still had the shape of him. On the pillow, where his mouth would have been, there was a little crust of white salt, and in the salt there was a print, like someone had kissed it. I do not know what that means. I did not tell Haddie.

I looked in his bucket, after. I am ashamed of it. You are not meant to look in a Called man's last bucket, it is like reading his letters. But Os was holding it out to me and it was heavy, and I looked. There was a finger's depth of his dusk water still in the bottom, from the night before, because nobody had tipped it. It was not green. It was not clear. It was blue, deep blue, the blue you see in a glass held up to a winter sky, and there was a weight to it, so the bucket swung slow in the boy's arms like there was more in it than there was. Haddie had not looked. Bren had not looked. I think the old man had looked every night for a month and said nothing, and tied his own knot, and lain down facing west because he liked the light.

They will put his name on the post. They will cut his rope into nine pieces and give one to each of us and one to the wall. We will set his bowl on Tablenight with the seawater in it and we

will leave the west door unbarred, and every one of us will lie awake hoping he does not come in.

That is the worst of it, and I will write it because nobody says it. You pray for them to come home and you pray they don't. Because if Cobb comes walking up out of the dark one morning, heavy and gentle and dripping, with his own face and his own laugh and the name of every grandchild on his lips, Haddie will take him in. She will feed him. She will rope him to the same bed. And every morning I will put my mouth to the plank and call his name, and he will answer, in a voice just a little lower than it should be, and I will never again know who I am talking to.

Haddie. Bren. Little Os.

Tomorrow there will be three names.



Rope before bread. Bucket before rope. Name before bucket. And before your name, child, the cough.

MILE TWELVE SKIPPING RHYME

Brinehollow is a land of chores. In Sallowreach the horror is that nothing ends; in the Fatlands it is that nothing is ever enough. In Brinehollow it is maintenance. Twice a day, every day, for six centuries, every soul on the western coast has knelt and coughed its god up into a bucket, and every night every soul has been tied down by someone who loves them. The horror lives in the routine, and in the morning, sometimes, the routine fails. This chapter is about the coast that eats the deep and is being eaten back by it: about a people whose chests are tide pools, a navy stranded on props in a dry harbor, a court of the drowned that has never been wrong, and a sea that is not leaving so much as moving in, a bucket at a time, to the only homes left to it.

▼ THE MEAL

Haul and hold, and do not look.

– THE LONGSLAB HAULING SONG

The western coast ate Dromm, the Fathom, god of the deep sea, of pressure, and of what is kept under. Every land's Gorging has its peculiar horror. Brinehollow's is that the god had to be brought to the table, and that it took four days to stop moving once it got there.

Dromm did not live on land. It lived beneath the whole grey reach of the western water, a presence more than a shape, and the coast knew it the way a body knows its own blood pressure: as a weight, a steadiness, the thing that kept the bottom of the sea where it belonged. Before the Lack, the fishers said that Dromm held the drowned down so they would not frighten their families by floating, and held the storms down so the boats came home, and held the cold water under the warm so the herring rose. It was a god of keeping things where they were put. Its priests were divers who went down on weighted ropes and came back with bleeding ears and with answers. They were called **Sounders**, and a Sounder's rank was measured by the depth she had touched and the blood she had brought back from it: a Sounder of the ninth knot had gone down nine fathoms past the point where a diver's eardrums burst, and could hear nothing on land but the god.



*Hold us down, O Fathom, as you held the drowned,
that we may not rise up and frighten those we love.*

THE OLDEST LINE OF THE ADMIRALTY HYMN,
OLDER THAN THE GORGING

In the ninth winter there were no herring. There were no answers either. The Sounders went down and found Dromm lying in the shallows off a long, flat beach called Longslab, closer to shore than any god had ever come, as though it had surfaced to wait. It was so large that nobody living could agree on its shape. Accounts written within a generation describe a back like a reef of black slate, plates of it, crusted with things that were not barnacles; a flank that rose and fell, very slowly, with a sound like surf heard through a wall; and eyes, or something like eyes, that stood open under the water, wider than doorways, the color of the sea a mile down. The Sounders who swam close enough to touch it came back without their hearing, and without their appetite, and three of them would not speak again except to say that it was cold, and that it had been listening to them for a long time.

The hauling took every vessel on the coast and every hand that could hold rope. Ten thousand hooks, by the count the Admiralty still teaches: shark hooks, gaff hooks, anchors beaten into barbs, meat hooks taken off the walls of empty smokehouses. They set them in the god from boats and from the shallows and from the beach itself, in long lines of starving men and women and children who leaned back on the hemp and sang the hauling songs, and the god came in a yard at a time. It did not fight. That is recorded here as everywhere. It came in the way a drowned man comes in, heavy and unresisting, with the water pouring out of it.

That was the first horror. The water did not stop. It ran out of Dromm in sheets, in torrents, from every gap between the plates,

from the eyes, from places that opened along its sides like gills that had never been needed, and it ran for four days. It was colder than any water on the coast. It smelled of iron and of something older than salt. It came out under such pressure that it knocked haulers flat and blinded them, and the people at the front of the lines drowned standing up on dry shingle, their lungs filled from the spray. They did not fall at once. A hauler at the head of a line would take a mouthful of the god's breath and keep pulling, because the line was pulling and the song was going, and her face would go dark and swollen and her eyes would bulge and a pink froth would come out of her nose and the corners of her mouth, fine as soap, and she would go on leaning back on the rope with the others for a dozen heartbeats after she had drowned, held up by the hemp and the song, until the people behind her felt the line go slack in her hands. They were laid out in rows above the tideline, and the froth went on coming out of them for hours, the way it does from the drowned, and the children who were sent to wipe their faces could not keep up. The beach under the god became a lake, and then a marsh, and it has never dried since.

*Haul and hold, haul and hold,
the deep is warm and the shore is cold.
Haul and hold, and lean you back,
the Fathom comes for the Lack, the Lack.
Haul and hold and do not look,
there's one of us on every hook.*

— the Longslab hauling song, of which only these verses survive. The sixth line is sung by children in the Mile as a skipping rhyme. Nobody can explain it. A verse after it, between the fifth and the seventh, was struck from every written copy before 100 A.G.

THE HOOK-BRIDES

On the third day, the god stopped coming in.

The chronicles agree on the place, a bar of grey shingle a hundred yards out, where the bottom shelved, and on the hour, the dead middle of the night, when the tide turned. The great flank grounded on the bar and stuck. Ten thousand hooks held, and every line on the beach leaned back until the hemp sang and the hooks tore long white rents in the slate of the god's sides, and it did not come one yard further. It lay on the bar with the water pouring out of it, and the haulers sat down on the stones in the dark and wept, because they had been starving for nine winters and they could smell it.

The Sounders went out to it on the slack water and came back at dawn and said that the god was waiting for something. They had pressed their bleeding ears to its plates and listened, and they had heard it, very far down, asking. They said it was a god of keeping,

and a keeping wants a keepsake. They said it would not come ashore to be eaten until each line had given it someone to hold.

There were seven villages on the hooks that the chronicles admit to. Each gave one. The Sounders asked for the young, the whole and the promised, and the villages gave what the Sounders asked for, which in a ninth winter was not difficult: the young were the ones still strong enough to walk out to the god, and the promised were the ones with the most to lose and the families who could least bear to watch them starve. They were seven betrothed men and women between eighteen and twenty-five, and the chronicles name them, which is the only kindness anyone did them: Tamsin of Slabside, Orry Weir, Annick Fell, Hob Sculpin, Denet Marl, Lowdy Kettle and Bran-son-of-Bran of the far north shore. They were dressed as for their weddings, in what was left of the coast's linen. Their sweethearts tied them each to a hook-line with a lover's knot, at the wrist, the knot that is still tied at every wedding on the Mile. Then they walked out along the lines into the shallows, hand over hand on the hemp, into the spray, and the Sounders led them in under the lip of the plates where the gill-openings gaped, and they went in, one by one, into the god.

The coast sang them in. That is the verse that was struck out. The Admiralty's official history says it was struck from shame, and that it named them.

The god came off the bar at the next turn of the tide, and the lines took up the slack, and the singing began again, and by the fourth morning Dromm lay on Longslab, and the butchering began. That is the story the Sounders told, and the coast told, and Brinehollow believed for two hundred years.

In 214 A.G. a Purser's clerk named Abiah Steep, compiling tide-tables for the old harbor, worked the moon and the spring tides back to the year 0, out of idle curiosity, because the chronicles gave him the hours. He found that the god had grounded on the bar at the neap, the lowest and weakest tide of the month, and that it came off at the next spring tide, when the sea on Longslab rose a fathom and a half higher than it had stood the night before. The water had lifted it. It would have come off the bar on that tide whatever anyone did. The Sounders, whose whole art was the reckoning of depth and tide, could not have failed to know it.

And there was the second thing, which the chronicles of the Lung-lines had always recorded and nobody had put beside the first. When the founders went into the god's chest on the fourth night to eat the lungs raw in the dark, they found the seven. The Hook-Brides had gone in through the gills and made their way, or been carried, into the lungs, and drowned there in the god's deep water, and lain there in the silver chambers in their wedding linen for a day and a night. The founders were eating in the dark, by touch, with their knives and their hands, ravenous, nine winters starved, with the water up to their knees. The Vasht chronicle says, in a sentence later scored through but still legible, that *the lights were full of sweetmeats and Ondric ate of them all and blessed the god for its*

provision. When the founders were carried out at dawn, half-drowned and laughing, nothing of the seven was ever found but one

wrist-knot, still tied, in the hand of the Weir boy's sweetheart, who had followed the line in after him.

THEY GAVE THE SEA **SEVEN** OF THEIR BEST TO **BRING**
THE GOD **ASHORE**, AND THE SEA **WOULD** HAVE
BROUGHT IT ANYWAY, AND THEN THEY ATE THE
SEVEN TOO, IN THE DARK, AND **CALLED** IT **GRACE**.

[ABIAH STEEP, PURSER'S CLERK, IN THE LETTER FOR WHICH HE WAS
HANGED IN 215 A.G.]

Steep was hanged from a yard for “publishing tables touching the Beaching.” The tables were burned. The Admiralty has never acknowledged the Hook-Brides as anything but a voluntary, holy sacrifice that brought the god ashore, and on the anniversary of the Beaching the seven names are read aloud on the Headland with honor. Every Lung-line house carries, somewhere in its arms, a hook with a lover's knot on it. The Debt chapels say that the Lung-lines' deep blood is half god and half bride, and that this is why they bail so much: they are bailing seven drowned sweethearts, forever, out of the chest of the coast.

USING THE HOOK-BRIDES

The Hook-Brides are Brinehollow's worthless sacrifice: demanded by the god's own priests, given willingly by those who loved them, and useless, because the tide would have done it anyway. Use them as a lens for everything the coast does now. The anchoring ropes, the Netwatch, the Anchorites on their cliff and the Deepening on its shell road are all, in their way, arguing over whether anything a person gives the sea makes any difference. The answer the Hook-Brides suggest is no. The answer the Deepening gives is that the seven are the first of the Tenanted, and that they are still down there, waiting, in their linen. A PC who finds Steep's tables (a Dire 22 Eye + Lore roll in the Admiralty's sealed archive, or a lucky find in the Underpier's trade in drowned papers) holds something the Admiralty will still hang a person for.

On the fourth day, the god stopped moving. The water still ran, but more slowly, and the vast flank no longer rose. The butchering began at dusk, by lamplight and by bonfires of wreck-wood, and it was done with whale-spades, axes, and the long knives of the flensing yards. Survivors' accounts agree on the smell: like opening a tide pool that had been sealed for a thousand years. They agree on the sound: that when the first spade went in, every person on the beach felt their ears pop at once, and some of them never heard properly again. They agree that the flesh was white and dense and

very cold, and that it was the best thing any of them had ever tasted, and that it tasted like being held.

The flensers stripped the plates first, prising them up with crowbars like the slates of a roof, and under every plate was a layer of blubber as clear as aspic and a hand deep, in which small silver things moved like fish in ice. Under the blubber, the meat. It came away in slabs that steamed in the cold air, not with heat but with cold, a white breath that rolled off it and down the beach and made the bonfires gutter. People ate it raw, on the stones, with both hands, and wept while they ate, and children who had not eaten in a week ate until they were sick and then ate again. Some of the old died of it, that first night, their starved bellies split by the weight of the god, and were laid beside the drowned haulers, and the gulls, which had come in from the whole coast in a cloud that blotted out the stars, did not touch them. The gulls ate only the god.

The families who reached the lungs first were the boldest and the strongest and the nearest, and they did not wait for fire. Dromm's lungs were caverns, chambers that a family could walk into, spongy and silver-grey and still full of the deep. The founders of the Lung-lines went inside the god with their knives and their bare hands and ate the lungs raw, from within, in the dark, with the water rising around their knees. The lung-flesh was soft as bread soaked in milk and it squeezed out water when it was bitten, cold water, sea-water, so that every mouthful was half a drowning, and the founders choked and swallowed and choked and did not stop. The chronicles of the Vasht family record, with what was meant as pride, that their founder Ondric Vasht ate until he could not breathe and went on eating anyway, and was carried out of the god's chest at dawn half-drowned and laughing and coughing up salt water, and that he coughed up salt water every dawn and dusk from that day until he died. He was the first to bail.



It tasted like being held. That's what my gran's gran said, and she'd only had a spoonful. Imagine what the Vashts tasted. Imagine eating that much of being held.

A DEBT PRIEST OF THE CHAPEL REACH

The bones were never fully cleared. The Longslab middens are still there, under the marsh, and the god's skull was too large to move and too hard to break. It was left where it lay, and the sea covered it, and then the sea began, five centuries later, to leave. It is not on the Uncovered now. It was not taken. Nobody knows where it went. The Salt Assay surveyed the place in 548, when the water first drew back from it, and found a hollow in the seabed the size of a cathedral, smooth as the inside of a bowl, and in the bottom of the hollow a line of marks in the mud, deep and evenly spaced, leading west. The Assay recorded them as "tidal scour." The surveyor who measured them asked to be transferred inland and was refused.

THE MISSING LINE

Every family of the coast keeps some fragment of the Longslab hauling songs, and every version has the same gap: a verse that has been struck out, sometimes scored through so hard the pen went through the page. In the oldest carved record of the Beaching, a frieze on the Admiralty's Sounding Hall, the hauling teams are shown in long lines, each line labeled for a village of the coast. There are eight lines of haulers. The eighth has been chiseled flat. The figures on its rope are gone, but the rope is still carved, and it runs, like all the others, into the god.

The Admiralty says the struck verse named the Hook-Brides. Seven lines gave seven brides. Nobody in the Admiralty has ever said, aloud, what the eighth line gave, or whether the eighth line was the one that asked.

GMs should let players find this and wonder. Brinehollow does not know what the eighth rope means and does not want to.

Dromm was the god of holding things down. It is now held in them, and what it holds down in its new house is the house itself.

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

A dry man drowns twice.

— MILE PROVERB

The sea is inside the people. Everything in Brinehollow follows from that sentence, and the country has had six hundred and forty-one years to learn how far it goes.

THE TIDE IN THE BODY

Every Brinehollower has a tide. Twice a day, near dawn and near dusk, the lungs fill with salt water from nowhere. It is not inhaled. It rises from inside, cold, through the bronchial tree, like water coming up through sand when you dig on a beach. It begins as a tightness and a taste. Within a few minutes the breath gurgles. Within a quarter hour a person who has not cleared it is drowning in their own chest.

It is worth being exact about what that feels like, because every Brinehollower knows it from the first week of life and none of them will describe it to a stranger. First the cold, a coin of it laid flat behind the breastbone. Then the taste, iron and weed, at the back of the tongue, as if you had bitten your cheek in the sea. Then the weight: the lungs going heavy, sagging in the ribs like full wineskins, so that the breath gets shorter from the bottom up, the way a cellar floods. The breath begins to bubble at the top of each draw, a small wet click, then a rattle, then a thick slow gargle like a drain. If the tide is not bailed, the water climbs the windpipe and the body fights it with everything it has: the throat clenches, the ribs heave, the face swells and darkens, the eyes water salt, and a fine pink foam begins

to rise at the nostrils from the delicate places deep in the lung that are tearing. The drowning do not thrash for long. The cold reaches the heart and slows it, and many Brinehollowers who have come close describe the end as gentle, as a sinking, as the moment of falling asleep in a warm bath. That is the most frightening thing they say about it.

Clearing it is called **bailing**. It is done bent over a bucket, with the body tipped forward and the shoulders worked, in long racking coughs that bring the water up in gouts. A healthy adult bails a pint or two. Lung-lines nobles bail gallons. The water is clear, cold, faintly green, and alive in small ways: fine sand, a thread of weed, now and then a sand-flea that hops on the bucket's rim and is gone. It smells like the sea did when there was a sea at the end of every street. Children are taught to bail before they are taught to read, and a child who cannot yet bail on its own is held face-down over a mother's knee and patted on the back, twice a day, as she sings. Every lullaby on the coast is a bailing song, in the rhythm of a cough.

*Up she comes and out she goes,
the sea from the chest and the sea from the nose,
cough for your mam and cough for your da,
cough for the Fathom that's gone so far.
Up she comes and in the pail,*

*we'll tip her west and we'll never fail,
and if you're sleepy, cough once more,
and the sea won't knock at your bedroom door.*
— the common bailing lullaby of the Mile, sung over the knee
at dawn and dusk. The beat falls on “up,” “out,” “cough” and
“tip,” where the hand strikes the back.

Bailing is done at dawn and dusk the way other peoples wash their faces, privately and without comment. Bail-water is poured into the gutters, which run west, always west, whatever the slope of the street. Engineers have sunk gutters on the Headland that run uphill, by spirit-level, for a hundred yards, and the water runs up them, west, without hurrying, and drops off the end of the Headland onto the Uncovered as though it had somewhere to be.

Those who cannot bail — the very old, the sick, the drunk, the injured, the unconscious — must be bailed by others, held head-down and struck between the shoulder blades until the water runs. Neglecting to bail a helpless person is murder in Brinehollow law, and it is the most common murder there is, because it requires only that one stay asleep. The Bailers’ Wardens of the Mile keep a register of every such death, and the register has a column for “slept through” and a column for “chose to.” The second column is never empty, and the Wardens fill it in with a care that is almost tender, because in most of those cases the one who chose to was the one who had done the bailing every dawn and dusk for twenty years, for a father who no longer knew them, and one morning simply lay with their eyes open in the dark and listened to the gargle rise in the next bed, and did not get up.

WHAT THE DROWNED-ASHORE LOOK LIKE

A Brinehollower who drowns in bed, unbailed, is called **land-drowned**, and the body is easy to know. The face is congested and dusky, the lips blue, the eyes bloodshot, half open and wet. A plume of fine white or rose-colored froth stands at the nose and mouth and goes on rising for hours after death, pushed up from the lungs by the weight of the water still inside them; mourners on the Mile wipe it away with a twist of linen and it comes back. The chest is heavy and dull when struck. Laid face-down, as the dead are laid, the body drains: water runs from the mouth and nose for a day and a night, clear and cold, and soaks the stones, and smells of the open sea. Surgeons who open a land-drowned chest find the lungs swollen to twice their weight, pale, rubbery and dripping, pitted like a sponge, and so full that they keep the shape of the ribs when lifted out. Sometimes there is sand in the smallest airways. Sometimes there is a living thing.

A Dread 1 check is needed to sit with the land-drowned. To be the one who heard the gargle and did not get up is Dread 3, and is never forgotten.

WHAT COMES UP

Everyone looks in the bucket. Nobody says they are looking. The bail-water is a newspaper, an omen, a confession and a medical record, and the coast reads it twice a day by the grey light at the window, tipping it toward the glass before tipping it into the gutter. Most mornings it holds only water, sand and a thread of weed. But the god is the god of what is kept under, and what is kept under comes up.

D20 IN THE BAIL-BUCKET	
1	Nothing but clear water. Everyone in the house relaxes a little, and nobody says why.
2	A sand-flea, then another, then a dozen, hopping on the rim and away between the floorboards. A good sign, the old women say: the sea is still shallow in you.
3	A thread of green weed as long as an arm, still rooted to a pebble. The pebble is warm.
4	A fish-scale the size of a thumbnail, silver, of no fish that ever swam this coast.
5	A tooth. Not one of yours. It is a child's milk tooth, worn small, and there is a tiny hole drilled through it, as if for a string.
6	Water with a faint green cast: the Appetite. Someone in the house tips it out very quickly.
7	A twist of tarred hemp, three inches long, cut clean at one end. It is from a rope that nobody in this house owns.
8	A bead of sea-glass, frosted and blue, like a drop of the water frozen. Children collect them in jars. The jars are never as full as the number of beads put in.
9	A tiny pale crab, soft-shelled, alive. It runs up your sleeve.
10	Blood: a pink cloud in the water, threads of it. A lung has torn. Tolly Brack would tell you to rest a week. You will not.
11	A wedding ring, gold, inscribed inside with two names. One of them was Called from this street in 612.
12	A shell no larger than a fingernail, pink and whorled, alive. If kept in salt water it grows. Dr. Isolde Reave will pay a lack for it, and ask where you have been sleeping.
13	Water so cold the bucket frosts on the outside, though the room is warm. Your teeth ache for an hour.

-
- 14 Black sand, fine as soot, that settles into the shape of a hand on the bottom of the bucket and does not move when stirred.
-
- 15 A clot of silver-grey tissue, spongy, the size of a walnut, that squeezes water out when touched. It is a piece of lung. It may not be yours.
-
- 16 A word, scratched on the inside of the bucket below the waterline, that was not there last night: a name, in a cramped old hand.
-
- 17 Blue. Deep, heavy, cold blue, the color of a hundred fathoms. The bucket swings slow. In Tolly Brack's language, *soon*.
-
- 18 A long dark rope of hair, coiled like weed. It is yours. It came up from the lungs.
-
- 19 A button of horn, from a Netwatch oilskin. Lieutenant Reef's watch lost a hooker to the Calling a month ago, buttons and all.
-
- 20 A second voice. Not in the water; in the cough. The last gout comes up with a sound under it, lower than your own, that says one word of your name.
-



Clear's a quarter crumb. Green's a half. Blue I don't buy, love. Blue I give you a crumb for nothing and a kiss, and you go and tie your knot.

CORALIE SCULPIN, BUCKET-WIFE OF MILE TWELVE,
BUYING BAIL-WATER AT DAWN

THE PULL AND THE CALLED

The tide pulls as well as fills. The water in the body wants to go home, and on certain nights it takes the body with it.

The Called rise in their sleep, or in a waking trance that looks like sleep, and walk west. They do not hurry. They do not respond to their names. They walk to the nearest shore, which in the present age may be miles away across the Uncovered, and then they walk into the sea and keep walking until the water closes over them. Nobody who has watched it says the Called look afraid. The Netwatch's records use a standard phrase, written in the logs thousands of times: "**Subject appeared expected.**" As if someone were waiting for them and they did not want to be late.

The walk is quiet. The Called do not run, stumble or speak. Their feet are bare, because they do not stop for shoes, and by the time they cross the Raw Mile's splinters and the salt-crust of the Uncovered their soles are cut to ribbons, and they leave a trail of watery pink prints that the Netwatch can follow by lantern. Their eyes are open and wet. Their chests, those who have watched closely say, do not rise. They walk with their hands loose at their sides and their faces lifted a little, as people lift their faces to a warm wind, and if a hooker blocks their path they walk into him and keep walking, pressing, with a slow painless strength that has broken men's arms. Those who are dragged home fight in silence and then, at the Return Room's benches, wake, and when they wake they weep, not with relief, but the way a child weeps when it is woken from the best dream it ever had and told it was not real.

Calling nights are not random, though no one has fully mapped them. They cluster at the licked-clean moon, on pressure days, in the weeks after a death in the family, and on nights when the indoor tide runs unusually high. They cluster in households. They cluster

in grief. A widower whose wife was Called in Lack has, by the Netwatch's reckoning, one chance in four of following her before Grace.

The defence is **anchoring**. People sleep roped, chained, or weighted to the bed. Sweethearts tie each other's knots. In the poorer streets of the Mile a whole family may sleep on one floor, lashed in a line to a single iron ring set into the joists, like a boat's crew in a storm. And still, every year, ropes are found cut. Sometimes there is a knife on the floor that the sleeper has kept hidden for weeks without knowing they were hiding it. Sometimes there is no knife at all. And sometimes, which is the thing nobody says aloud, there is a knife in another hand: a spouse who could not bear the pleading any longer, a child who heard a parent crying to be let go and loved them too much to refuse. A rope cut in the night is the country's great domestic tragedy, and the question of who cut it is the question that breaks families.

The pleading is the part outsiders never believe. A Brinehollower at the Appetite or beyond, roped to the bed on a Calling night, does not walk. They lie in the dark and ask. They ask the person tied beside them, in their own voice, gently, reasonably, the way you would ask someone to open a window in a hot room. *Let me go. Just tonight. I'll come back. It's so close. Can't you hear it? Please. Please, love. I'm so tired of being held.* They ask for hours. They ask every night for a season. They weep, and plead, and bargain, and then they are quiet, and in the quiet the one who is lying awake beside them can hear, under the floor, the indoor tide coming in. The Chapel Reach hires out **sitters**, at a lack a night, to sit by the beds of the pleading so the family can sleep in another room. The sitters are mostly old women, and many of them are deaf, and that is why they are hired.



I cut my father's rope. He'd been asking for six years. The Bench said he cut it himself. I thanked them. I'd thank them again.

ANONYMOUS, READ ALOUD AT A WRECKWIVES' TABLE

CASK LANE: A CALLING IN SEVENTEEN NAMES

The Netwatch logs record Callings as numbers. The families record them as names. What follows is assembled from the papers of one street, Cask Lane, a short alley of coopers' houses off Mile Ten, over forty days of Lack in 640. It is kept by the Wreckwives of the Middle Mile as a teaching document, read to new Listeners at their first table, because it shows how a Calling moves through a street: not like a plague, which takes the weak, but like grief, which takes the ones who loved most.

1. From the register of the Bailers' Warden of Mile Ten. Silences at the morning count, Cask Lane.

Day 1. No. 4, Lissa Corran, 19, cooper's daughter. Rope cut. No blade. Called. Father Abner Corran found the bed at first bell.

Day 6. No. 4, Abner Corran, 47, cooper. Rope cut. Blade on floor (his own adze-knife). Called.

Day 9. No. 7, Pell Stave, 21, journeyman, betrothed to Lissa Corran. Chained, not roped. Chain intact. Ankle-cuff empty and wet. Called.

Day 9. No. 7, Marta Stave, 50, his mother, who slept tied to him. Rope intact. Knot undone by hand, neatly. Called.

Day 14. No. 2, Ruth Ammet, 33, and her daughter Hanne, 12. Roped together. Rope intact. Ring torn from the joist. Called, both.

Day 15 to Day 40. Eleven more. See over.

2. Letter of Doll Corran, Abner's sister, to her brother's widow, sent from Saltwick, never answered.

Nan, I heard about Abner. I am so sorry, love. I know you'll say it was the girl, that he couldn't bear it, and he couldn't, he never could bear anything, he cried when the dog died and he was forty. But I want you to know he wrote to me the night before. He said Lissa had been at the wall. Not the count. Before the count. In the dark. He said he heard her calling through the plank from the empty house at No. 5, where nobody's lived since the Ammets' first went, and she was calling Da, Da, like when she was small and had the croup, and he said he got up and went round and the house was dark and wet and he stood in it calling her and she didn't answer. He said she was only being polite, waiting for him to come to her. He said he'd tied his knot. I've got the letter here. He said I tied my knot, Doll, I tied it tight, I'm not a fool. He'd underlined it. I've been looking at that line all week.

3. From the account given by Ruth Ammet's husband, Jos Ammet, at a Wreckwives' table, Grace 641. Taken down by the Keeper of Names.

I had the night watch at the cooperage, see. That's why I wasn't tied with them. I'd tied them myself, before I went, Ruth and the girl together to the ring. Ruth's wrist to Hanne's wrist, the way you do. I'd tied them tight. When I came home the ring was out of the joist. The joist, mind, not the knot. Four nails as long as my hand, pulled out of an oak beam like teeth. The floorboards were scored where they'd dragged it, the ring and the rope, out the door and along the lane and off the rail. Fourteen stone of iron and oak they took with them, the two of them, and Hanne not five stone wet. The Netwatch found the ring on the Uncovered a mile out. Just the ring. And the rope still tied, Ruth's knot and mine, and the loops still round where their wrists had been, empty. I've got it at home. I've not untied it. Everybody says I should cut it and give it out, the rope funeral, a piece for the wall. I can't. If I untie it I'll have to stop knowing they were holding hands.

4. Netwatch log, Mile Ten beat, Line-Hand Esmé Pardoe. Day 22.

Called at Cask Lane, three: two men, one woman, all of No. 9 (Gaskell). Pursued to Mile Sixteen gap. Recovered one (woman, Prue Gaskell). Two lost at the gap. Subject appeared expected. Subjects appeared expected. All subjects appeared expected. Prue Gaskell fought all the way back to Hookside and at the bench thanked me and then asked me, very politely, if I would mind terribly going back for her, because they were waiting. I am requesting a transfer to the Headland. I am requesting it again.

5. From the same register. Day 31.

No. 3, Wynn Harrow, 61, widow, no Calling. Not at the count. Found by neighbors at Harbor End, at the Rail, at dawn. She was not Called; she walked down the Mile on her own feet in the afternoon with her bucket, Mother Coldwell at the Last Rail says, and asked the way to the end, and stood at the iron rail with both hands on it till dark, saying the names of the lane. She was still standing when the last round came, and did not answer, and it was too late. She had not been Called. She had been waiting since Day 1 to be Called and it had not come, and she was the last of No. 3. The Warden enters her under Silences, since there is no other column for it.

6. From the register. Day 40.

No. 1, Fen Lowry, 74, cooper, retired. Present at count. Called the names of the lane at first bell through all walls. No answers. Fen Lowry will be moved to the Chapel Reach by the parish, against his wishes. He has asked that the lane be left as it is and that he be allowed to go on calling the count. He says

one of them will answer eventually, and somebody ought to be there when they do.

Seventeen people walked from Cask Lane in forty days, and one more went to the Rail. Six came back Tenanted over the following year, among them Lissa Corran, who walked up out of the surf at Harbor End in Plenty and went home to an empty house on Cask Lane, and called her father's name through the wall at the morning count, and was answered, the old man Fen Lowry swears, from No. 4, in Abner's voice, a little lower than it should be. They live there now, the six of them, in three houses on a lane that is otherwise empty, and they are quiet and courteous and keep their doors open, and every morning at first bell the old man in the Chapel Reach almshouse sits up in bed and calls their names, and is not answered, because they can no longer hear him from where he has been moved.

RUNNING A CALLING CLUSTER

A cluster is the coast's commonest catastrophe and the best way to show the Calling as contagion rather than accident. It begins with one loss, ideally of someone young and much loved. Thereafter, each household connected to the Called by blood, love or a shared wall makes a Calling roll on each Calling night at +2 difficulty for every person already lost from the street, to a maximum of +6. Grief, not proximity, is what spreads it: a PC who mourns openly for one of the lost counts as connected. Do not let the cluster resolve in a single night. Let the party arrive on Day 6, or Day 14, and see what is coming: the street tying itself together tighter each night, the knots getting more elaborate, the families beginning to sleep in one room, then one bed, then one knot. A cluster can be broken: by moving the survivors east (to Weirholm, to Saltwick), by an Anchorite's vigil, by the Netwatch posted in every house, or by giving the grieving some other thing to hold. It cannot be broken by telling anyone it is not their fault.

THE TENANTED

Most of the Called are never seen again. Some come back.

They come weeks later, usually at dawn, walking up out of the surf heavier than they left: denser, slower, their footprints sinking deep into wet sand. They are calm and courteous. They know the way home. They have the same face, the same scars, the same memories down to the names of childhood dogs and the location of the spare key. They greet their families with real warmth and apologize for the worry. They ask for their bail-bucket, and bail a great deal, and then they ask whether there is any supper.

They are the **Tenanted**, and someone else is looking out through their eyes.

It is not always easy to say how one knows. A Tenanted man still laughs at his brother's jokes, but a beat late, as if the joke had to come down a long way to reach him. A Tenanted mother still sings

the old songs to her children, but her voice has a second voice beneath it, lower, that sometimes finishes the line first. The Tenanted do not lie, cannot be bribed, do not lose their temper, and are, by every measure anyone has devised, kinder and fairer than they were before. Their families are often happier. That is the horror the Wreckwives exist to share.

They come back changed in the body too, in ways that are hard to see and impossible to forget once seen. Their skin is the grey of a wet slate roof and cool to the touch at every hour; a Tenanted woman's hand on your cheek is like a stone taken out of a stream. Their weight is wrong. A Tenanted child of eight sinks a stair-tread like a grown man; a Tenanted grandmother needs a bed with iron legs. They bail half a bucket at every tide, slowly, without strain, the water pouring out of them like a jug being emptied, and between bailings they sometimes sit for an hour without breathing and without seeming to notice. When they sleep they sleep face-up with their eyes a little open and a film of water standing in them. They do not dream, or do not say so. They smell, always, faintly, of the cold under a pier.

Whether the person who walked into the sea is still in there somewhere, folded small under the weight of the thing that came back with them, is Brinehollow's oldest unanswerable question. It is rude to ask a returned person where they went. It is ruder to ask whether they are still there.



My husband came home kinder. My children came home strangers. I don't know which of them I'm feeding.

A WRECKWIFE AT THE MIDDLE MILE TABLE

THE SECOND FACE

Every coast that has a word for a returned person soon has a word for the fear of one. In Brinehollow it is **the Second Face**: the conviction that someone you love has been Tenanted, though they have never been Called. It is the coast's most common madness, and its most contagious, and it is getting worse.

It begins small. A wife notices that her husband laughed a beat late at supper. A son notices that his mother's voice has dropped, or seems to have dropped, when she calls the count. A brother notices that his sister has stopped shouting at the children. After that every kindness is evidence. The Tenanted are kind, everyone knows it; so a gentle word is a sign, a patient silence is a sign, a meal set out without being asked is a sign. The sufferer begins to test: holding mirrors to the mouth at dawn, listening at the bed at night for the second voice, asking questions only the real person could answer, and finding, always, that the answers are right, which proves nothing, because the Tenanted remember everything. The Wreckwives have a saying for it, which they say to new Listeners at

their first table: *You can't catch them out by what they know. You'll only catch yourself.*

The Second Face spreads along walls. When one member of a household is convinced that another is Tenanted, the others begin to look too, and to see, and within a season a whole family may be sleeping in shifts so that someone is always watching the one they have decided is not theirs. The accused often begins to doubt

themselves. There are cases in the Wreckwives' ledgers of men and women who came, weeping, to a Keeper of Names to ask whether they had been Called in their sleep one night and come home without noticing, because their families looked at them as if they had, and they could not prove they had not. A few have gone to the Rail to find out. The ledgers record what the Netwatch recovered, and what it did not.

D6 FOLK TESTS FOR THE TENANTED (NONE OF THEM WORK)	
1	The mirror at dawn: a Tenanted breath leaves no mist. (False. It leaves mist, and the mist dries to salt.)
2	The burnt rope: hold a thread of their old anchoring rope in a candle; if it smokes blue, the person is gone. (It always smokes blue. It is tarred.)
3	The dog: the family dog will not go to a Tenanted master. (Dogs will not go to anyone at the Appetite either, or to anyone frightened.)
4	The forgotten song: sing a song only the two of you ever knew, and stop halfway. The real one will finish it. (The Tenanted finish it. That is the problem.)
5	The child: a Tenanted parent's own child will not be held by them. (Often true, at first. Then the child forgets why, and so do you.)
6	The cut: prick the finger; a Tenanted bleeds salt water. (They bleed red. It is a little thin. So is everyone's, by Carving.)

THE SECOND FACE IN PLAY

The Second Face is a form of the core Derangement **The Impostors**, and it is the coast's characteristic way of Breaking. A Brinehollower PC who Breaks after seeing a loved one Called, Tenanted or seriously changed by the Regrowth should usually take it, choosing as the impostor someone who has never been near the sea. Witnesses to such a Break who fail their Dread 2 check share the delusion about the same person, exactly as the contagion rules describe, and this is how whole households turn on one member. Play it straight: never confirm or deny. Make the accused person kind, as a Tenanted would be, because the frightened are always being kind to the person they have turned on, trying to win them back. The GM should decide privately whether the person is in fact Tenanted, and should be willing to decide that they are not.

THE MATTER OF WAT TEAGUE

The Second Face kills. Most often it kills the accused, slowly, by the loneliness of being watched by everyone they love. Sometimes it kills faster. The following is kept by the Sounding Clerks of the Drowned Bench as a model hearing, and copied out by law students on the Headland, though not for the reason the Clerks intend.

From the record of the Sounding Hall, the matter of Wat Teague, cooper, of Mile Eleven, accused of the murder of his father Ezra Teague, retired net-maker. Heard before Justices Oake, Brannagh and Sole, at the turn of the morning tide, Carving 638. The accused stood in the pool. Sounding Clerk Ives at the gauge.

CLERK: *The water stands at three and one quarter inches. The accused will state his name and mile.*

TEAGUE: *Wat Teague. Eleven. You know it. You all know it.*

CLERK: *The Bench has the indictment. Ezra Teague, aged seventy-three, found in the cellar of the house at Mile Eleven at the dusk tide on the ninth of Carving, dead of blows to the head with a cooper's adze, the indoor tide standing at the knee. The accused was found sitting on the stair above, wet to the shoulder. Does the accused deny it?*

TEAGUE: *I don't deny the adze. I deny it was my father.*

CLERK: *The Bench will hear him.*

TEAGUE: *My father went in Lack. Two years gone. He went in the night in Lack of 636 and the rope was cut and I'd tied it, I'd tied that knot, and in Grace he came back up the beach at Harbor End. Everyone saw it. He came back Tenanted and we took him in, my wife wanted to, and he was good. He was so good. He never was. He was a hard old man with his belt, my father, and the thing that came back was soft and listened and said he was proud of me. Proud of me. He never in his life. And he knew everything. He knew where the belt was hung. He knew the name of my brother that died. He knew everything my father knew, and he was kind about all of it, and I couldn't stand it. I watched him. Every night. My wife said I'd gone strange. She said Wat, he's your father, look at him, he's your da, and I'd look and he'd look back with those black eyes, so kind, and I knew. I knew he'd eaten my father, down there, and come back wearing him, and was sitting at my table being proud of me in my father's mouth.*

CLERK: *The water stands at three and one quarter inches.*

TEAGUE: *So I took him down the cellar at the dusk tide, when the water comes in. I thought, he's a thing of the sea, he breathes it, but if I held him under the true sea that's under the house maybe it'd come out of him. Maybe it'd let my*

father go. I held him under. He let me. He just lay there in the water at the bottom of the cellar stair, on his back, with his eyes open, looking up at me through it, and he didn't fight, and he didn't drown, because they don't, and after a long while I took my hands off him and he sat up and the water ran off him and he said, Wat. In the low voice. And then he said it again in the other voice. In my father's voice. The real one. The hard one. Wat, he said, for God's sake, son, do it right, then. And I had the adze in my belt. That's all. That's how. He said do it right.

CLERK: The water stands at three and one quarter inches. It has not moved.

TEAGUE: I know it hasn't. I'm not lying. That's what I'm telling you. It was my father. At the end. It was him under there all the time. It was him asking.

JUSTICE OAKE (in two voices): The Bench has heard. The Bench finds that Ezra Teague was present in the body at the time of his death, as the accused has truthfully said. The Bench finds that he asked. The Bench finds the accused guilty of the murder of his father, and sentences him to be loosed for one season, and directs that his anchoring rope be cut by the Nerwatch at dusk on the first night of his sentence, by a hooker, in the presence of his wife, so that it shall not be cut by him.

TEAGUE: Which one of you asked? Which voice? Justice, please. Which one of him asked me?

CLERK: The water rose an inch and a half during the accused's last question. It is so recorded.

Note in a later hand: Wat Teague was Called on the eleventh night of his loosing. He has not returned. His wife remarried in Plenty of 640.

Law students copy the Teague record because it is the clearest statement of the Bench's doctrine: that a Tenanted person is a person in law, and that killing one is murder. The Wreckwives read it differently. They read it for the last exchange, and for the Clerk's note about the water, and they ask one another, at their tables, the question Teague asked: which voice is the one that wants to be let go? The Bench has never answered it. The ledger of the Wreckwives of the Middle Mile records, in the years since, nine more cases of kin-slaying by a family that had decided its returned member was an impostor, and four of a family that had decided its *un*-returned member was one. In three of those thirteen cases, the dead had asked.

THE SEA IS MOVING HOUSE

Meanwhile, the ocean itself is leaving. Since 512 A.G. the waterline has dropped every year, slowly at first, then by furlongs, then by miles. Harbors stand dry. Fishing fleets sit on mud. The great port of Lowmark has chased the water nineteen miles out across the dry seabed on a road of piers, and is still chasing. The sea is not evaporating. The Salt Assay has proved this, with buckets and with arithmetic, and has been forbidden to say where it is going instead.

The tide is also in the houses. In every cellar in Brinehollow, however far inland, water rises twice a day and drains away again, and leaves kelp on the stairs. A farmhouse forty miles from the coast will have a wet cellar step, a ring of salt on its walls, and once in a while a crab in the coal-bin. The country's buildings have adapted: cellars are tiled, drains run west, and anything of value is kept above the high-water mark, which is painted on the wall of every cellar in red and repainted every year a little higher.



*Red line, red line, higher every Grace; when it reaches
the kitchen, we'll move to another place. When it
reaches the bedroom, we'll lie in the wet. When it
reaches the attic, we'll not move yet.*

A WEIRHOLM CHILDREN'S COUNTING SONG

RUNNING THE CALLING

On a Calling night, any Brinehollower (or anyone with brine in their blood; see Dry Jonah and the Vigil's rouse) who sleeps unanchored, or whose anchoring fails, must make a **Caul + Resolve** roll. The difficulty is Routine (10) at Regrowth 0–3, Hard (14) at 4–6, Grim (18) at 7–9 and Dire (22) at the Brink. A licked-clean moon, a recent Called death in the family, or sleeping facing west each add +2 to the difficulty. Success: the character wakes at the door or the window, cold and wet to the knees, with the taste of the sea in their mouth. Failure: they walk. Companions may try to wake or hold them (an opposed GUT + Labor roll against the Called character's LUNG + Athletics; the Called do not feel pain and do not tire).

Treat a PC's Calling as a dramatic scene, never a mechanical loss. Give the other players time and agency to stop it. A character who reaches the sea is gone for 2d6 weeks; the GM decides, with the player, whether they return Tenanted (the character becomes an NPC, or continues at the Brink under the rules for Playing a Brinehollower), or not at all.

A roped character who is not Called may still be asked. Anyone sleeping beside a pleading Brinehollower at the Appetite or beyond must make a Dread 2 check each Calling night; on a Lack, they wake with a knife in their hand and the rope in the other, and no memory of getting up, and must decide.

Above all, play the Calling as grief. The horror is not the walking. It is the empty bed, the warm pillow, the rope end, and the people at the table who have to keep setting a place.

SALT MANNERS

It is rude to mention how someone sounds when they breathe. Brinehollowers gurgle, rattle, and whistle in the hours before bailing, and politeness requires that everyone pretend not to hear.

It is rude to ask a returned person where they went.

It is rude to stand between someone and a west-facing window.

It is rude to refuse a bail-bucket offered to an outsider. Hold it, say "Keep you dry," and hand it back.

It is rude to look into another person's bucket, and ruder to be seen doing it.

It is rude to say the name of a Called person after dusk, in case they hear it and think they are wanted.

It is very rude, and in some towns actionable, to tie your own knot loosely.

▼ THE REGROWTH IN BRINEHOLLOW

The deep doesn't hurry. It doesn't have to. Everything comes to it in the end.

— HASK TARN, PILOT

Dromm is growing back, and what it grows back into is depth. The Regrowth here is a slow drowning that never finishes, a body learning, against every instinct it was born with, to live under a weight it cannot see.

THE TASTE

Salt on the lips at waking; a fine white crust at the corners of the mouth, as if the sleeper had spent the night on a beach in the wind. Ears that pop indoors, especially in cellars, especially at the turn of the tide. A Brinehollower at the Taste wakes with the sheets damp in the shape of their body. Their voice sounds faintly wet to strangers. They find themselves telling the time by the tightness in their chest rather than by the bell, and they are always right. Children at the Taste hold their breath in play for longer than any child should, and laugh about it when they come up, and their mothers do not laugh.

THE APPETITE

The pull. A person at the Appetite stands at windows that face west and does not know how long they have been there. They put their hands flat on the glass. They sleepwalk to the nearest water, and anything will do: a well, a rain barrel, a horse trough, a washbasin. Families find them kneeling on the floor in the dark with their faces in the basin, not drowning, simply resting there, breathing it, perfectly calm. They crave cold food and salt. They eat raw shellfish from the Uncovered middens, which are poison to anyone else, and are not poisoned. They lose interest in warmth. They stop noticing that they have not bailed, and their families start doing it for them.

The lungs begin to keep some of the water. A person at the Appetite bails less than they fill, and the remainder sloshes: they can be heard, when they turn over in bed, a soft liquid shift in the chest like a half-full cask rolled on a cart. They begin to prefer it. The first full breath of air after bailing makes them dizzy and faintly sick, and they find themselves, without deciding to, breathing shallowly,

keeping a little of the cold inside, the way a child keeps a sweet in its cheek.

The bail-water changes too. Tolly Brack the Bailer Boy reads it: clear for the healthy, faintly green at the Appetite, and then, for those close to Calling, a deep sea-blue with a weight to it, like water pulled from a hundred fathoms. Some households keep the dawn bail-water in a glass jar on the sill so they can check its color by daylight. Most would rather not know.

THE COURSE

The body adapts to depth. The skin goes grey, then the grey of wet slate, smooth and cool and thickened, with a faint pebbling along the spine and the backs of the hands. The eyes widen. The pupils swell until there is almost no iris, black and wet and reflective, and in the dark they shine green like a cat's. The chest stops needing to rise. A person in the Course can sit for an hour without breathing visibly, and the stillness of their ribs is the thing that unsettles visitors most, more than the eyes.

Inside, the change is worse. Dr. Isolde Reave has opened Course chests on her table and recorded what she found: lungs grown spongy, silver, cavernous, packed with chambers like the inside of a sea-cucumber; ribs thickened and drawn inward, as though by enormous pressure; a heart small, slow, and dense as a stone. The lungs hold water now as their natural state. Air is the intrusion. A person in the Course is uncomfortable in open air, as a land-dweller would be under water: they feel thin, exposed, dizzy, light, as if they might float away. They sleep in a cistern, weighted, with only the face above the surface, or, more and more often, with no part of themselves above it at all.

From the case-book of Dr. Isolde Reave, Headland. Subject 31. Female, about 50, Lashings, cannery. Course, advanced. Land-drowned in Carving, in air, having been carried from her cistern to a dry bed by her son during a fever, against her expressed wish.

External: skin slate-grey, dense, cold; pebbling over the spine to the sacrum, raised like the plates of a skate. Nails thick, yellow, ridged. Scalp nearly bare. Eyes fixed wide, pupils full; the cornea has a faint nacre, like the inside of a shell.

On opening: the sternum resisted the saw as if it were green oak; it is twice the expected thickness. The ribs curve inward and overlap at the front like the slats of a barrel squeezed in a press. The lungs fill the cavity entirely. Silver, not pink. Weight, both lungs together: twenty-two pounds, which is to say a small child. On section they are not tissue in the ordinary sense but a honeycomb of chambers, each a thumb's width across, lined with fine fronds that moved in the water for some minutes after death, all one way, as weed moves in a current. The water in them was cold, clear and under pressure:

when I made my first cut it jetted to the ceiling, and my apprentice was soaked and could not stop coughing for an hour, and has coughed since.

In the left lower chamber, embedded in the wall and growing from it: one shell, pink, whorled, alive. It is now in the jar with the others.

Heart the size of my fist, which is to say half the size it should be, and so dense that it sank in the brine bath like a stone.

Cause of death: drowned in air. Her son wants to know if he killed her. I told him she had been dying for years. That is true. It is also true that he killed her. I did not tell him that, and I am writing it here so that someone knows I knew.

The voice drops. It gains an undertone, like a second speaker standing just behind the first. Ears bleed on pressure days. Fingernails thicken and yellow. Hair falls out in the bath in long dark ropes that drift on the water like weed. The joints ache in air as if under a great weight, and the sufferer begins to move with the slow, careful, gliding economy of a diver walking on the bottom. Course-sufferers who go too long out of the water dry, and the drying is terrible to watch: the slate skin cracks along the pebbled lines and weeps clear fluid, the lips split, the eyes cloud like a fish on a slab, and the sufferer lies on the floor in a stupor, breathing in short shallow gasps that whistle, drowning in the thin air the way a beached thing drowns. Put them back in the cistern and within an hour they are well, and grateful, and a little further down.

THE BRINK

At the Brink the person has heard the invitation in full. It is no longer a pull. It is a voice that knows their name, that has always known it, that is patient and kind and very, very old. The body at the Brink is heavy beyond its size: floors creak under a slight woman, beds break, horses refuse to carry them. They sink in mud to the knee. They are cold to the touch, so cold that kisses leave a white mark. Their tears are salt enough to sting cuts. Their sweat leaves rime. They hear the sea in every silence, not as memory but as direction, as a compass hears north.

Most of the Called at the Brink go, and most of those who come back come back Tenanted. A Tenanted person stands at the Brink permanently: something sits in them, and something of them may still be there underneath.

THE SEATING

The Tenant takes the whole house. What walks around afterward is a piece of Dromm, patient, pressing outward against the skin. The fully Seated do not look very different from the Tenanted, at first. Then they stop bothering with the smaller courtesies: they no longer blink, or answer to their name, or eat. Their skin bows

outward between the ribs, as if under pressure from within, and their weight becomes impossible. They are not violent. They are simply present, the way a deep place is present, and the air around them thickens until lamps gutter and ears ring. The Admiralty keeps them in the lowest cisterns of Fathomhouse and records them as “retired to depth”. Nobody is sure any longer how many there are, or what they are waiting for.

The pressing does not stop. A Seated body is a vessel with more inside it than it was built to hold, and over months the skin of the chest and belly stretches tight and glossy as a drumhead, grey shading to translucent, so that by lantern-light the shapes of the ribs show through it, and between them, faintly, something dark that moves slowly, like a fish seen through ice. The fingers swell and split at the nails. The eyes bulge and do not close. Ears and nose leak a constant thread of cold clear water. Tank-tenders who have worked the lower stairs say the retired-to-depth make a sound, very low, below hearing almost, that you feel in the teeth and in the fillings of your jaw: a creak, like a hull at great depth, as if the body were a ship and the sea were trying to come in, or out.

THE TENANT QUESTION

The bible’s central uncertainty in Brinehollow is whether the Tenanted are still the people they were. The GM should decide privately, and is encouraged to decide differently for different Tenanted. Some are entirely Dromm wearing a stolen memory. Some are a person and a piece of god sharing a house, each aware of the other. Some may be the original person, returned and unchanged, with every neighbor convinced otherwise (see Esk Penhallow). Players should never be certain. Seeing a loved one return Tenanted is a Dread 3 horror. Seeing one return and being unable to tell is worse, and should be played across sessions, not resolved in one.

THE LOWERING

What becomes of the retired-to-depth is the House of Vasht’s oldest secret and the Admiralty’s most carefully kept ceremony. The cisterns of Fathomhouse are not infinite. The Dowager Below is hungry. And a Seated body left too long in the lower cisterns grows heavier every month, until the stone floors crack beneath it, and the Headland’s engineers have measured the settling of the whole palace and do not like the figures.

So once in each season, at the lowest tide, the household performs the **Lowering**. It is a ritual killing, though no one present would call it that: a liturgy of the Debt doctrine, said by the Chaplain of Fathomhouse, in which one of the retired-to-depth is given back. The order of service survives because the chaplains, being Admiralty men, write everything down.

THE ORDER FOR RETIREMENT TO DEPTH. As used in the Chapel Below, Fathomhouse, by the Chaplain and four

Tenders, at the slack water of the lowest tide. Not to be copied.

The Tenders, in rubber aprons and with wax in their ears, shall bring the Retired from the third cistern to the head of the fifth stair upon the iron cradle, with the chains made fast at wrist, ankle and throat. The cradle shall be lowered by the windlass, slowly. If the Retired speaks, the Tenders shall not answer.

The Chaplain shall stand at the head of the stair, facing west, and say: We took you from your water. We are your water now.

The Tenders shall answer: Hold us down.

The Chaplain shall read the Retired’s name and mile from the tide-post roll, and the date of their Calling and of their return. Then he shall say: You came back to us and we have kept you. Now you are too heavy for our keeping. Go down, and be held.

Here the Tenders shall open the grating of the fifth stair. The Chaplain shall ring the small bell three times. When the water below the grating begins to rise, which it will, the Tenders shall pay out the cradle chain until it is taut, and make it fast, and stand back.

The Chaplain shall not look down the stair. The Chaplain shall say the Dusk Hymn, all verses, and shall not hurry, until the chain goes slack.

If the chain does not go slack before the hymn is ended, the Chaplain shall begin the hymn again.

When the chain is slack, the Tenders shall haul up the cradle. The cradle shall be empty. If the cradle is not empty, the Tenders shall not describe what remains on it to the Chaplain, and shall commit it to the drains, and the Chaplain shall record the Retirement as complete.

The cradle’s chains shall be scrubbed with sand and salt, and the Tenders shall be given gin.

Tenders who have worked the Lowering describe it in fragments, and only when drunk. The grating opening on a blackness that breathes. The cold coming up the stair in a wave that frosts the iron. The Retired, who has not moved in a year, turning its head on the cradle to look down, calmly, with interest, as a traveler looks at a harbor he is coming into. A hand coming up out of the black water, grey, longer than the cradle, and closing round it with great care, the way a mother takes a sleeping child from someone else’s arms. The chain going taut and humming. Then the sound, which every Tender mentions and none can describe: not a scream, the Retired never scream, but a long low creak and then a series of short flat cracks, like a cask being stove in, one stave at a time, very slowly, under a great weight. The hymn goes on through all of it. It has nine

verses. The Tenders say the chaplains have learned to sing it slower over the years.

The retired-to-depth are the coast's Called who came home. Their families were told, at the Fathomhouse gate, that they had

been taken into the Admiralty's care with honor. The tide-posts carry their names twice: once for the Calling, and once, in smaller letters, for the retirement. Nobody on the Mile has ever asked to visit.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

Salt in the rain, salt in the bread, salt in the kiss, and salt in the bed.

— SALTWICK WEDDING TOAST

A long grey coast of shingle, salt marsh, and cliff, three hundred miles from the Cradlewrack border in the north to the Fatlands marches in the south, under a sky the color of a gutted herring. Beyond the old shoreline lies the **Uncovered**: a newly exposed seabed that stretches further west every year. It is not flat. It is a country of ravines and shelves and drowned hills, of weed forests gone to brown leather, of wrecks standing upright on their keels as though still sailing, and of things with too many ribs.

It rains salt. Not a little salt: rain in Brinehollow tastes like a tear and dries on window glass in white lace. Iron rusts in a season; mail shirts must be oiled nightly; the eyes of those who work outdoors are permanently red-rimmed and the skin of their hands cracked white along every crease. Fog comes in from a sea that is now miles away, rolling across the Uncovered in walls, and it smells of tide pools and rot. Gulls nest inland, on church roofs, in chimneys, and they are thin and angry and pick at the eyes of sleeping dogs.

On **pressure days** the air thickens until ears bleed. These come without warning, perhaps a dozen times a year: a sudden heaviness, a hush, birds dropping out of the air to sit stunned on the ground, windows bowing inward with a creak and sometimes bursting. Candle flames stand flat and blue. Everyone in the street touches their ears and comes away with blood on their fingers, and the old men say "the Fathom's turning over." Children have died on pressure days, crushed in their cots by nothing anyone could see. Callings triple on the night after one.

And there is the **indoor tide**. In every cellar in the country, however far inland, water rises twice a day and drains away again, leaving kelp on the stairs. The tide is cold, clear, and comes up from the floor, not the walls. It brings small gifts: shells, sea-glass, a child's shoe, a ring. It has been known to bring back things the Called were wearing when they went.



*The cellar gave me back his spectacles on the Tuesday
and his teeth on the Thursday. I'm dreading Saturday.*

OVERHEARD AT THE BUCKET OF THE UNBAILED,
MILE NINE

PLACES OF BRINEHOLLOW

LOWMARK

The capital, a nineteen-mile pier-city built out across the dry seabed, section by section, after the sea. Old Lowmark on the original shore, now called the Headland, holds the Admiralty, the Sounding Hall, Fathomhouse, and the tide-post. From it the Mile runs west on tarred pilings sixty feet high: a wooden road lined with houses, chandlers, chapels, taverns and bail-houses, all creaking, all leaning a little westward. Mile One is rich, Mile Seven is Netwatch barracks, Miles Twelve to Sixteen are slum, roped and chained and stinking of tar and bail-water. The Nineteenth ends in a working harbor where a few licensed boats go out and come back with catches nobody likes to describe. Sixty feet below, the old seabed is dark and wet and full of what the city drops. People live down there, too: the Underpier, where the Pickers sift the Mile's refuse, a child says the name of every Called neighbor from beneath their house at the next tide, and the Tenanted whose families would not have them back hum together in the dark between Miles Ten and Eleven.

LONGSLAB

The beach of the Beaching. Permanently wet, though no sea has touched it in a century. Water seeps up through the shingle as if the beach were a sponge someone is always pressing. Nothing grows there, and gulls will not land on it. At the tide-turns the wet ground breathes: a slow sigh across two miles of stones, and a smell of the deep. Pilgrims of the Deepening come to lie face-down on it and listen. The Longslab middens beneath are full of bones too large to be any animal's. The village of Slabside above it lays every one of its children face-down on the stones for an hour once in their lives, and writes down what they hear. For four hundred years they heard the sea. For the last eleven, every child has said they heard someone counting.

THE UNCOVERED

The exposed seabed, salvage country, lawless and strange, with a new mile of it every year. Near the old shore it is cracked white salt littered with six centuries of wreckage, skeletons still in the rigging. Further out it turns to mud flats, leather-weed jungle, and drowned valleys where dead reefs stand up like ruined cathedrals, blue with rot. Things live there that came up as the water fell and did not die

properly: cart-sized crabs, slow and soft-shelled; ribbed things that drag themselves on fins across the mud at night; fish that breathe air, badly, with a sound like a sick man snoring. And there are older things, uncovered for the first time since before the Gorging: carved stones, paved roads running west into the deep, and at least one table.

THE ROTTING WONDERS

The Uncovered is the largest graveyard on the Table, and it is still being dug. Every year the falling sea lays bare another mile of things that were never meant to see air, and the air gets to work on them. The salt slows the rot and the sun speeds it, and the result is a country of slow, glistening, stinking marvels that salvagers speak of with the same mixture of awe and nausea that Fatlanders reserve for a really good feast.

The Leather Forest. Ten miles out, the great kelp beds of the old sea floor stand where they grew, sixty and eighty feet tall, held upright by the salt that stiffened them as the water left. They have turned the brown of old saddles and the texture of wet hide, and they sweat a slime that drips constantly, so that walking through them is like walking through rain in a tannery. They creak in the wind. At their roots the mud is thick with fish that were trapped when the water drained and have been rotting, very slowly, for years, in drifts knee-deep, their flesh gone to a translucent jelly that holds the shape of their bodies and the bones inside them like a jellied pie. The smell is a wall. Salvagers tie salted rags over their faces and still vomit.

The Whale Cathedrals. In the drowned valleys lie the whales that died when the water fell around them, too far from the deep to swim out: dozens, some the size of a Mile house. The flesh does not rot quickly in the salt; it slumps. Over years it runs off the great arched ribs like candle-wax off a candlestick, in folds and curtains, grey and pink and green, and pools on the mud in shining lakes of fat that never set, and the ribs stand up out of it like the vaults of a church. Crabs live in them by the thousand. On hot days the fat-lakes bubble and give off a gas that makes men giddy, and then sleepy, and then, if they sit down, dead. Salvagers render the fat for lamp oil by night. The lamps of the Lashings burn with a greasy green flame and smell faintly of the deep.

The Gasping Fields. Wide flats where the air-breathing fish come up out of the pools at dusk and lie on the mud in their thousands, gulping, their gills flaring scarlet, their flanks heaving.

The noise is a vast soft snoring that carries for miles. They do not die. They lie there all night, and in the morning crawl back to the pools on their fins. Salvagers eat them, and say they taste of nothing, and that a man who eats too many begins, at night, to gasp.

The Blue Reefs. Whole drowned hills of coral, dead, rotting to a deep cobalt slime that drips from the branches in long strings and glows faintly at night. The light is cold, and attracts the ribbed things.

The Upright Ships. Wrecks of every age stand on the mud on their keels, as though still sailing. In many of the newest, the crews are still aboard, dried by salt into leather and kept at their posts: helmsmen with their hands on the wheel, lookouts in the crow’s-nest with their faces turned west, cooks at their stoves. The Wreck Orchard holds two hundred of them. Salvagers do not take anything from a ship with its crew still aboard. The ones who did, the stories go, woke at the dusk tide to find the crew had come aboard their own boat to take it back.

The Sounding Pits. Here and there on the Uncovered the mud gives way to a hole: round, clean-sided, a few yards across, filled to the brim with black water that does not drain when the rest of the seabed does. Hask Tarn calls them the places where he lost the bottom. Leads dropped into them run out of line. On still nights the water in them rises and falls, very slowly, like the chest of a sleeper, and if you lie at the edge you can hear, far down, a sound like breathing.

The Old Road. Paved, straight, made of fitted blocks of black stone that no quarry on the coast has ever cut, a road runs west from a point on the Uncovered eleven miles out, down the long slope toward the deep. It is older than the Gorging. Its kerbs are carved with figures seated at tables, in rows. At every hundredth block there is a carved bowl in the paving, and in every bowl the salvagers who have walked it say they have found water, fresh and cold, which should not be there. Nobody has followed the road to its end.

◇
You learn to tell the age of a wreck by its smell. Sweet’s new. Sour’s a year. Nothing’s old. When you get nothing, mind your feet; that’s when you’re near something that was down there before the ships.

UNCOVERED SALVAGER’S LORE

D20 FOUND ON THE UNCOVERED	
1	A rowing boat, upright on the mud, with two oars shipped and a woman’s shawl folded on the thwart, dry. The Netwatch list says she was Called from Mile Six in 619.
2	A drift of rotting herring a hundred yards long and waist-high, glistening, heaving with crabs. Under it, something big is breathing.
3	A chest of Rim Road Company platters from a wreck of 541, sealed in wax. Worth a fortune. The Company still has the ship’s manifest, and wants them back.

D20 FOUND ON THE UNCOVERED	
4	A whale's eye, dried, the size of a shield, clouded like old glass. Looking into it, you see the sea it last saw, full of light.
5	A face-down corpse, weighted with stones, laid on the flats in the ordinary way. It has been turned over. Its stones have been placed neatly beside it.
6	A sounding-lead on a line that goes down into a crack in the mud. The line is taut. Something below has hold of it.
7	A wreck's figurehead, a carved woman, lying on her face. When turned over, her painted eyes have been gouged out from inside the wood.
8	A field of anchoring rings, hundreds of them, iron, set in the mud in rows, each with a few inches of cut rope. Nobody set them there.
9	A soft-shelled crab the size of a cart, dying slowly, its shell sagging like wet canvas. Inside, through the membrane, a human shape curled as if asleep.
10	A carved stone pillar, pre-Gorging, showing a procession of figures walking west into waves, holding hands. One figure walks east. Its face has been chiseled off.
11	A Netwatch boathook, its shaft snapped, the iron bent back on itself as if it had hooked something far too heavy.
12	A pool of sea-water, warm, with a tiny live fish in it, alone, a hundred miles of mud from any sea. It swims in a slow circle, westward.
13	A whale-skeleton cathedral with a family living in its ribs, rendering fat. They are friendly. They have not bailed in a year.
14	A pair of children's shoes, side by side, laces tied together, set on a flat stone facing west.
15	A paved stretch of the Old Road with a carved bowl. The bowl holds water, fresh, and floating on it, a cut wrist-knot of linen.
16	A wreck whose whole crew is still at their stations, leathered by salt, every head turned west. One sailor's head is turned east, toward you.
17	A bell-buoy, upright in the mud, that rings on its own when the indoor tide seeps up around it.
18	A long, smooth trench in the seabed, as if something huge had been dragged west across it recently. The mud at its edges is still wet.
19	A Salt Assay gauge-post, the gauge snapped off, and carved into the wood beneath it, a figure: a long column of tallies, and then the word <i>matches</i> .
20	A table, laid. White cloth, sodden. A single chair pulled out. Footprints in the mud, deep and wide-spaced, going away west.

MORE PLACES

THE HANGING ABBEY

The Anchorites' cliff, forty miles north of Lowmark: four hundred feet of black basalt above a field of dry white boulders that was once the sea. A thousand living monks hang on it, chained by iron collars to rings set in the rock, each on a ledge or in a scooped cell, most open to the salt rain. Food comes down in baskets; waste falls. At dawn and dusk the whole cliff coughs at once, and water runs down the rock in sheets. At night they pray aloud, or scream, and from below it is impossible to tell which. The village of Basketfoot, at the cliff's base, hauls the baskets and gathers what falls, and buries it face-down among the boulders.

THE TRENCH

The place far out where the water is still deep, and where it seems to be going. Thirty miles west of Lowmark's last pier the Uncovered ends at a cliff edge, and beyond it lies black water that has not dropped at all, an abyss of unknown depth with a current that runs downward. From the edge you can hear it draining: a low, endless sound like a throat swallowing. Salvagers who go to the brink report a warm updraft that smells of breath, and a light, very deep, that comes and goes.

FATHOMHOUSE

The palace of the Lung-lines princes on the Headland, a grey stone pile with more of itself below ground than above. Its upper floors are halls of glass tanks, where the princes hold court underwater and courtiers in dry clothes bow to them through eight inches of green brine. Its cellars are flooded and have been extended twice to accommodate the Dowager Below. The lowest cisterns hold the retired-to-depth. Servants work in rubber aprons and never go below the fourth stair. The gratings in Tidepost Square that vent the palace's drains breathe out a green mineral cold, and on pressure days the air above them thickens until passers-by drop where they stand.

THE PROP YARDS AT KEELROW

Four hundred warships stand on dry ground in long rows across the old Keelrow anchorage, three miles south of the Headland, each upright on a cradle of timber props, masts dressed, fully crewed. Sailors reef and furl sails that catch only wind and stand watches over a horizon of salt flats. Beneath the keels the sailors' families live in tents and sheds, a town of children who have never seen the sea and are proud of their fathers' ships.

SALTWICK

The largest inland town, thirty miles east of Lowmark on the Rim Road spur, and the country's market for everything the Uncovered yields. Its cellars flood twice a day like every cellar in the country,

and the townsfolk have given up and turned them into salt-pans: each house harvests its own indoor tide, dries it on racks, and sells the salt. Saltwick salt is reputedly the best on the Table. Visitors who eat too much of it begin to dream of drowning, and some begin to bail.

THE WRECK ORCHARD

Eight miles out on the Uncovered, in a shallow basin, nearly two hundred wrecks of every age stand upright on the mud in loose rows, as if parked by a harbormaster. Nobody can explain why they are upright. Nobody can explain why their hatches are all open, or why their figureheads all face west. Salvagers live in the newest of them. Lantern-light can be seen in the oldest ones at night, which are empty.

GULLCRY STRAND

A long stretch of the old shoreline north of Lowmark, now a beach without a sea, where the Deepening holds its processions. A road of crushed white shell, laid by the faithful over two centuries, runs straight from the strand across the Uncovered toward the far water, nine miles long and marked every hundred paces by a post with a lantern-hook. On procession nights every hook is lit.

THE SOUNDING HALL

The courthouse of the Drowned Bench on the Headland: a round stone hall whose floor is a shallow pool, ankle-deep, fed by the indoor tide. The accused stand in the water. The Tenanted judges sit on a stone bench at the far side, utterly still, and their verdicts are delivered in two voices. The frieze of the Beaching runs around the walls. The pool is always cold, and witnesses say that when a lie is spoken in the Hall, the water rises.

LOBBETT'S DROP

The place, somewhere on the far Uncovered, where Cray Lobbett found the stone table with eight chairs. He has told nobody its

location. Salvage crews have searched for it for two years, and three of them did not come back. The name is a joke on the Mile. It is not funny out there.

THE FACE-DOWN FIELDS (NEW)

South of the Headland, on the salt flats below the old Keelrow shore, the coast lays out its ordinary dead: face-down, in rows, weighted with stones, for a tide that no longer comes. There are perhaps forty thousand of them in the fields now, in every stage, from the fresh to the leathered to the scattered bones the gulls have sorted. The smell carries to the Headland on a south wind. The layers of the dead walk the rows at dawn to set new bodies and straighten old stones. A layer who finds a body turned face-up reports it to the parish, and the parish sends a priest, because a dead man turned over is an omen, and lately the layers find one every week. Most are the work of the Pickers, who strip the dead of rings and buttons and teeth. Some are not. In 637 a layer of Mile Twelve was found asleep in the fields at dawn, lying in a row among the dead, face-down, with a dead woman's stones laid on his own back, and her body beside him turned over and arranged, with her hair combed out, as a man would arrange a wife. The Bench sentenced him to be loosed for life. He did not deny anything. He said only that she had been so cold, and nobody had held her, and the gulls had been at her, and he could not bear it. The layers burned the row.

HOLLOW GAOL (NEW)

The Admiralty's prison, a dry dock below the Headland with its gates sealed, where convicts sentenced to loosing serve their nights. The cells have no rings and no beds, only a pallet facing west, and the west wall is a grille open to the Uncovered. Netwatch guards sit outside with orders not to intervene. In the mornings they count the cells. The gaol's register has a column headed *Departed* and a column headed *Remained*, and the turnkeys bet on which a new convict will fill.

▼ HISTORY

Temporary low tide. By order.

– STANDING ORDER 1 OF 512 A.G., STILL IN FORCE

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
0	The Beaching. Dromm hauled ashore at Longslab on ten thousand hooks. The Hook-Brides given on the third night. Four days of water. The Meal.
1–59	The Full Years. Fish return in silver floods; the coast grows rich; nobody minds a little cough.
60	The Brimming. The first generation born coughing brine. Bailing becomes universal.
77	First indoor tide recorded, in the cellars of Fathomhouse.
118	The First Calling. Four hundred walk into the sea at Lowmark in one night. Eleven come back.
121	The Netwatch founded. The Anchoring Laws require every household to own a rope.

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
163	Father Gannet Holm chains himself to the cliff; the Hanging Abbey begins.
214	Abiah Steep's tide-tables. Hanged the following year.
240	The Drowned Bench. The Admiralty appoints Tenanted judges.
301	The Deepening's first lantern procession at Gullcry Strand.
342	The first recorded Lowering in Fathomhouse.
388	The Vasht Tanks. The first Lung-lines prince holds court from glass.
459	The Wreckwives formally organize after the Calling of the Seventeen Captains.
512	The Turning of the Tide. The sea does not return to its old line.
531	The Salt Assay chartered to measure the fall.
540	First new mile of pier at Lowmark. The Chase begins.
588	The Dry Fleet. The last warship floats; the fleet is propped at Keelrow.
627	The Great Pressure Day. Every window on the Headland bursts. Callings that night: 1,140.
639	Brenna Kelp's finding. The Admiralty makes it illegal.
640	Cask Lane: seventeen Called from one alley in forty days.
641	The Chase reaches its nineteenth mile. A table with eight chairs is found on the Uncovered.

For sixty years Brinehollow was the happiest land on the Table. The herring came back so thick that nets broke, whales beached themselves like gifts, and the Lung-lines, who coughed water twice a day and swam like seals, became admirals and princes. When every newborn of the Brimming arrived gurgling and had to be held head-down until the water ran, it was called a mark of belonging. Inlanders who did not bail were “dry,” which is still an insult.

The First Calling ended all that in one night. Four hundred people of Lowmark rose under a licked-clean moon and walked into the harbor in a long, quiet, orderly line, holding hands. The eleven who came back were the first Tenanted, and those who took them in were the first Wreckwives. One of the eleven is still on the Headland steps, wringing out his rags. By 240 the Admiralty had noticed that the Tenanted made perfect judges, and in four centuries no one has successfully appealed a verdict of the Drowned Bench.

In 459 the sea took seventeen captains of the fleet in a single night, from seventeen different rope ships at anchor in the old harbor, roped in their cabins. Each rope was found cut, from the inside, with the captain's own dress knife. Fourteen came back Tenanted in

the following spring, and asked for their commands, and the Admiralty, which could find nothing in the Articles against it, gave them back. Their wives founded the Wreckwives that summer, at a table in the Lantern on Mile Nine, and the first rule they wrote was that a member must tell her story without crying, because the captains' wives had found that the things they came home to did not like to see them cry, and became so very kind.

In 512 the sea failed to return to its old line, and the Admiralty declared a temporary low tide. It has been temporary ever since. In 627 came the Great Pressure Day: every window on the Headland burst inward in one breath at noon, the bells of the Chapel Reach cracked, and that night eleven hundred and forty walked, and the Netwatch found the Mile's gutters running west so full that they overflowed and the boards of the pier were wet from end to end by dawn. In the last ten years the sea has fallen faster than in the previous fifty, the Callings have quadrupled, and the Tenanted on the Bench have gone from nine to ninety. In 639 Brenna Kelp presented the arithmetic that explained it, and the Admiralty made her arithmetic a crime.

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

Brinehollow is ruled by the **Tidal Admiralty**, a navy that has become a government. Its fleet sits aground on props at Keelrow, fully crewed, drilled daily, awaiting the sea's return. Rank is still given in ships: a district governor is a Captain, a province is a Squadron, the treasury is the Purser's Office, and a Captain may

never have been afloat. Laws are issued as Standing Orders and read aloud from the deck of the flagship *Steadfast*, which has not moved since 588.

STANDING ORDER 4,117. Given aboard the Steadfast, Keelrow, at the dusk muster, Carving 641, and to be read at every mile-post.

1. The Fleet is at anchor awaiting the tide. All hands will conduct themselves accordingly.
 2. The word “stranded,” and all words of like meaning (“aground,” “beached,” “dry-docked,” “finished”), are forbidden to officers on pain of the yard, and to civilians on pain of twenty strokes.
 3. The Purser’s Office will continue to levy the Rope Duty at two crumbs the fathom.
 4. Households on the Lashings will sleep in lines of not fewer than five to a ring. Households of fewer than five will be joined to their neighbors by the Bailers’ Warden.
 5. The color of bail-water is a private matter and is not to be traded upon by any bucket-wife, broker or moneylender. (This Order is not enforced.)
 6. Gatherings on the Uncovered at Low Water are permitted to the Tenanted and forbidden to all others.
 7. The Fleet will be ready to sail at one hour’s notice.
- Given under the wet seal of the House of Vasht.

Above the Admiralty sit the **Lung-lines princes**, the House of Vasht and its cadet branches, who can no longer breathe air for long and hold court from glass tanks in Fathomhouse. They sign the Admiralty’s orders with a wet seal, through a hatch. Beneath the Admiralty sits the **Drowned Bench**: the Tenanted judges, whose verdicts are final, and whose loyalties nobody has ever thought to question out loud.

The great political fact is water. A land of sailors and fishers has lost its sea, and the Admiralty’s entire policy is to pretend this is temporary. To say “stranded” of the fleet is an offense against the Articles. To publish the Salt Assay’s figures is treason. Every faction’s position is ultimately a position on the water: whether it is coming back, whether it should, and where it has gone.

Law is naval. Crimes are tried before the Drowned Bench, standing ankle-deep in the Sounding Hall’s pool. Common sentences are flogging with a wet rope, fines in lacks, impressment into the Dry Fleet, and **loosing**: the convict is sentenced to sleep unanchored for a set number of nights, under guard, with the Netwatch instructed not to intervene. Loosing is not formally a death sentence. Everyone knows it is one, slower and more uncertain, and that the Bench’s Tenanted judges hand it down with what looks like compassion. Neglecting to bail the helpless is murder. Cutting another’s rope is the worst murder of all, and its punishment is to be loosed for life.



The Bench says it’s mercy. The Bench is ninety of her.

LIEUTENANT SABLE REEF, OF JUSTICE OAKE’S
RULINGS

THE DEEP BLOOD

The Lung-lines are the god’s own blood and the state’s legitimacy, and they have spent six centuries trying to keep both from thinning. The House of Vasht holds that the depth of a Lung-line is measured by how much of the god is in it, and that the god in it must not be let out into lesser chests. Marriage among the Lung-lines is a matter of keeping the blood deep. Marriages between first cousins are ordinary and are celebrated on the Headland with the tying of a rope spun from both families’ hair.

The rest is not celebrated. The Cutwrights’ ledgers for the House of Vasht show older and closer pairings that the family does not discuss and the College does not publish. The Vasht marriage-book in the Fathomhouse chapel has eleven pages sewn shut with tarred thread, and the chaplains are forbidden to cut the stitches. The family chronicle records Ondric Vasht’s wife only as “of his own blood, that it be kept deep,” and records her name nowhere. Old Jory Spinwell of the Ropewalk has spun the wedding rope for every Vasht marriage since 589, and he says that three of the brides’ ropes were spun to a length he was told to keep secret, and that the hair braided into two of them was the same grey as the groom’s, from the same head.

The blood has kept deep. It has also kept other things. Vasht children are born with webbed fingers to the second knuckle, with eyes already wide and black, with a membrane over the nose; several in every generation are born not breathing, and are not mourned, but carried at once to the nursery tank and laid in it, where some of them begin, after a minute or two, to breathe water, and are counted among the family, and some do not. The household calls them **still-born to the deep**, and the tide-post of Fathomhouse carries their names in a column with no dates. The Cutwright Ansby Wrack has found something worse in the ledgers: that for three generations the House has been keeping its blood deep not only by marrying inward but by marrying downward, to the Tenanted, so that the princes in the tanks are the children of things that came back out of the sea. The Admiralty has encouraged the same marriages among its cadet officers and Tenanted widows for a century. The College has noticed that the children of such marriages carry a higher Cut than their parents should have given them. The god is not only taking people back. It is breeding.

THE DEEP BLOOD IN PLAY

Keep the Vasht bloodline implied. The players should find it in fragments: a sewn page, a rope of one grey hair, a nursery tank with names on the wall and no dates, a Cutwright's ledger with a column of initials and a column of question marks, a courtier's sudden silence when asked who the prince's mother's mother was. Never stage it. The horror is what the House has decided it must do to stay deep, and what the coast has agreed not to ask, and what the god appears to want from all of it.

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

Food. Brinehollow eats what the Uncovered gives and what the Rim Road sells. Before the fall it ate fish, and fish are now a luxury hauled nineteen miles down the Mile in wet barrels. The poor eat Uncovered shellfish dug from the drying mud, which are safe for those who bail and poison to anyone dry; salt-cured gull; seaweed bread; and Fatlands meat in brine, which everyone pretends not to examine. Meals are cold and salty. Hot food is considered a little vulgar. The grace before eating with strangers is "Lack keep away, and keep you dry."

THE LANTERN, Mile Nine. Chalked on the board by the bar, Carving 641.

Seaweed bread, grey — 3 c

Cold gull, salted, with kelp relish — 4 c

Uncovered cockles, a bowl, raw (bailers only; dry folk ask for the pot) — 1 c

Eyeless fish from Harbor End, pickled — 1 L

Gasper (the snoring fish), fried; tastes of nothing, fills you up — 6 c

Fatlands brine-meat, a slice — don't ask, 4 c

Mile ale — 1 c

Saltwick gin, with a drop of sweet water — 3 c

Hot soup (by request only, and we'll look at you) — 5 c

Sweet water, a cup — one bail-token

Bucket hire for visitors — free; bring it back

NO WEST TABLES AFTER DUSK

Dress. Oilcloth, tarred wool, sealskin for the rich. Everyone wears a rope at the waist, coiled, for anchoring at night: the cheap ones are hemp, the fine ones silk-and-wire, and a noble's waist-rope may be braided with silver and the hair of ancestors. The bail-bucket hangs from it. Losing your bucket is like losing your shoes. Course-sufferers wear veils of wet gauze to keep their faces moist. Mourners

for the Called wear a **name-rope** at the wrist, a short braided cord with the lost one's name woven in, and never take it off.

Marriage. Sweethearts exchange bail-buckets. A wedding is the tying of a shared anchoring rope, each partner knotting the other's end before witnesses, and the vow is "I will hold your line." Remarriage after a Calling is permitted after a year and a day, which leads, often enough, to a household with two spouses when the first comes back Tenanted. Such houses are common enough on the Mile to have customs: the returned spouse sleeps in the cistern and the living spouse in the bed, and the one who married twice sleeps between, roped to both, and nobody on the street asks which of them is holding whose line in the night. The Wreckwives say the Tenanted are perfectly courteous about the arrangement, and that this is the thing the living spouses cannot bear.

Death. Those who die of ordinary causes are laid face-down on the Uncovered, weighted with stones, for the tide to take; the tide no longer comes, so the bodies lie in long rows on the salt flats, and the gulls are fat. The Called receive a **rope funeral**: their cut anchoring rope is divided among the family, one piece each and one for the wall, and the name is cut into the nearest tide-post. The priest asks, "Did the line hold?" and the family answers, "The line held. The sea was stronger." They must say it whether or not it is true. There is no body. There is never a body. Families keep the pieces of rope in a box by the bed, and hold them during the count.

Children. Taught to bail before they read, roped to a parent's wrist at night until seven. Children's games include holding-breath contests, which parents forbid and which are universal, and "Called," in which one child walks blindfold toward a wall while the others try to drag them back. Children are said to see the Tenanted most clearly: a Tenanted parent's own child often refuses to be held by them, at first, and then forgets why.

Who's in the cellar? Only the tide.

Who's in the bed? Only the bride.

Who's at the window? Only the west.

Who's at the wall? Only the rest.

Count them, count them, one two three,
one for the bucket and one for the sea,
one for the rope and one for the knife,
and one that came back and was nobody's wife.
— counting-out rhyme of the Lashings. The child on whom
“nobody’s” falls is “It,” and must walk west with eyes closed
until caught.

Festivals. Low Water, at the lowest tide of Carving, when the Tenanted gather on the Uncovered and sing. The Knotting, in early Grace, when every rope in a household is replaced. The Beaching, in Plenty, when the Hook-Brides’ names are read on the Headland with honor and the hauling songs are sung with the struck verse hummed. Tablenight, when families set a bowl of seawater at the table’s head and leave the west door unbarred, once a year, for whoever might come home.

Crime and punishment. The coast’s crimes are the crimes of a crowded, frightened, roped-together people: theft of buckets, loose knots, rope-cutting, the selling of a neighbor’s bail-water without leave, and the neglect of the helpless. Punishments are naval and public. Bucketing, the confiscation of a bucket for a day and a night so that the offender must beg every neighbor to bail them, is the shaming punishment for slander and loose knots; a bucketed

woman crawling from door to door at dusk, gargling, holding out her empty hands, is a sight every child on the Mile has seen.

Oaths on the dead. The most binding oath in Brinehollow is sworn on a piece of a Called person’s rope, held in the fist, with the words “By the line that did not hold.” To break it is to invite the Called one to come back for you. People believe this literally, and sometimes they are right. Father Ebb has kept such an oath for fifty-one years. The Wreckwives’ records hold the case of a Saltwick salt-merchant who swore on his drowned brother’s rope to repay a debt, and did not, and was found one morning in his own cellar at the ebb of the indoor tide, face-down, drowned in two inches of water, with his brother’s rope knotted round his wrist and his brother’s wet footprints going back down the drain.

Proverbs. “Tie your own knot.” “A dry man drowns twice.” “Every wall has an ear, and every ear is a neighbor’s.” “Don’t sleep facing your wishes.” “The sea gives back, but not change.” “Long pier, short life.” “Blue in the bucket, rope on the bed.” “Sweet water, sour neighbors.”

◇
*Every man I take upstairs wants me to tie him to the
bed after. Not for that. Just to sleep. I charge for the
knot.*
ROSEN, WHO WORKS THE ROOMS ABOVE THE LAST
RAIL

▼ FACTIONS

THE TIDAL ADMIRALTY

The state: proud, hidebound, and commanding the largest landlocked navy in the world. The Admiralty believes, as an article of faith and of law, that the sea will return, and that when it does Brinehollow must be ready to sail. It wants order, the illusion of

normality, and above all silence about the numbers. Its officers are brave, competent, and drilled to the bone in an art that has no use. Enemies: the Salt Assay’s leakers, the Deepening, the Second Table’s agents within its own ranks. Allies: the Netwatch, the Rim Road Company, which still pays port tolls on a port with no water. A PC joins by enlistment at any Admiralty house on the Mile.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Swab	A berth on a propped ship, rations, a rope
2	Able Hand	Pay of 2 lacks a day; right to bear a boathook on the Mile
3	Bosun	Command of a watch; access to the Admiralty bail-houses
4	Captain	A ship (on props) or a district; a seat at the Standing Orders
5	Commodore	A squadron of ships or provinces; audience with the tanks

◇
*Forty years on the Resolute. Never wet my boots. Best
posting in the fleet.*

ABLE HAND CORWEN BLY, KEELROW

THE ANCHORITES

An order who chain themselves permanently to rock, so the Calling can never take them. Their abbey is the Hanging Abbey, a cliff face hung with a thousand living monks. They believe the Calling is a temptation, and that refusing it, night after night, for a whole life, is the only holiness left. They want to endure. Some want more: to chain the whole country. Enemies: the Deepening, whom they call

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Postulant	A trial-chain on the lower rocks, removable
2	Linked	A permanent collar; the Abbey's prayers and its basket
3	Bound	A cell on the high face; the right to counsel visitors
4	Fast-Bound	Keeper of a hundred chains; can loose or tighten them
5	Abbot	The Rock; one held by Father Ebb

◇
*Every night it asks. Every night I say no. That's the
whole of the rule. The rest is just weather.*

A BOUND MONK OF THE HIGH FACE

THE DEEPENING

A cult that treats the Calling as a sacrament. They believe Dromm is not regrowing but welcoming, that the sea is going home and taking its children with it, and that walking in willingly, in procession, with lanterns, is not death but homecoming. They want everyone baptized. Their processions at Gullcry Strand are illegal, regular, and quietly attended by the Netwatch, who are under orders to

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Shell-Walker	A lantern, a place in procession, a new name
2	Wader	Teaching of the Low Songs; the Deepening's safe houses
3	Lantern-Bearer	Leads a procession group; knows the next Calling nights
4	Deep Sister or Brother	Baptizes; hears the invitation by night
5	Mother of the Water	Mother Limpet alone

Put down the rope, my darling, put down the rope and come,

drowners. Allies: Wreckwives, who send them food. A PC joins by spending a month on the cliff in a trial-chain; most who try come down. A few did not want to.

The life is a slow body horror of its own. The collars are never removed, and over years the neck grows round them: the skin ulcerates, weeps, scabs, and finally heals over the iron like bark over a nail, so that an old Anchorite's collar is part of him, and rusts inside him, and stains his throat orange. Ledge-sores eat the hips and shoulders of those who lie on bare rock; the salt rain keeps them open. Monks whose chains fail fall four hundred feet, and the Basketfoot villagers gather what lands. Monks who sicken die on their ledges and are left chained there, as a teaching, until the gulls have finished and the bones can be lowered in the basket. The cliff is studded with these, and the living talk to them.

intervene and seldom do. Enemies: Anchorites, the Admiralty, every family with a member who joined. Allies: none declared; the Tenanted, it is whispered. A PC joins by walking the shell road to the last lantern and coming back to tell it.

The Deepening's hold over its people is gentle, total and very hard to break. New Shell-Walkers are given a new name and asked never to use the old one. They are fed, warmed, and sung to sleep with the Low Songs. Their ropes are cut, kindly, by the brothers and sisters, and hung over the headboard. Their families are spoken of with pity: *they are still so afraid*. Those who waver are not threatened. They are loved harder, sat with through the night, told that the voice they cannot hear is there and that it is only their fear that deafens them, until most come to believe that the fault is in them, and walk in to prove it isn't.

*the water's warm as a mother's lap and the deep is calling you
home.*

Put down the bucket, darling, you'll never need it more,

there's no more cough and no more cold on the far side of the shore.

— the first of the Low Songs, as taught to Waders. The Admiralty has made it an offense to sing it within earshot of a sleeper.

THE NETWATCH

The Admiralty's night patrol. They hunt the Called along the shore with nets, hooks, and rope, and drag them home. They know every alley that runs west, every gap in the pier rails, every rope-cutter. They are heroes in the households they have saved and bogeymen to the Called themselves, who fight in their trance with terrible, painless strength. Enemies: the Deepening. Allies: Wreckwives, Anchorites. A PC joins at the barracks on Mile Seven; the Netwatch is always short of hands.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hooker	Boathook, net, lantern, 2 lacks a night
2	Line-Hand	A patrol beat; right to enter any house at night
3	Watch-Sergeant	A squad of six; the Calling logs
4	Lieutenant	A district of the Mile; can order a loosing stayed
5	Watch-Captain	Command of the Netwatch; a seat at the Admiralty



We drag them back up the beach and they look at you like you've shut a door in their face. Then their mother kisses your hand. Then you go and do it again.

A NETWATCH HOOKER, MILE SEVEN

THE WRECKWIVES

A sisterhood, open to all sexes, of those whose spouses came back Tenanted. They share advice on how to live with a stranger who knows your name: what to say, what not to ask, how to tell if anyone is still in there, how to stop yourself loving what came back, or whether to. They keep records of every Tenanted spouse, and their records are better than the Admiralty's. They want the truth, and fear it. A PC joins by sitting at a Wreckwives' table and telling the story, without crying, all the way through.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Listener	A seat at the table; the sisterhood's discretion
2	Sister of the Line	Access to the records; a safe house for one night
3	Keeper of Names	Helps new members; knows every Tenanted in a district
4	Elder Wife	Speaks for a Mile; can call on the sisterhood's lacks
5	Widow-Mother	One per city; holds the ledgers

THE WRECKWIVES' QUESTIONS

These are asked of every new Listener at her first table, by the Keeper of Names, and the answers are written in the ledger.

Who was Called, and on what night, and was the rope cut, and by whom?

How long were they gone, and on what beach did they come back?

What did they ask for first: the bucket, the supper, or you?

What do they do now that they never did before?

What did they used to do that you are glad they have stopped doing?

Have you ever heard the lower voice say something the upper voice did not?

Do you love them?

Did you, before?

THE SALT ASSAY

The office that measures the falling sea. Its figures are a state secret. Its assayers stand at posts along the old shore and the new piers with chains and gauges, and in cellars with buckets and scales. Since Brenna Kelp's finding the office has been half-purged, and its surviving clerks know that the numbers they record are evidence of something the Admiralty will kill to hide. They want to be believed, or to be safe; it is getting hard to be both. A PC joins as a clerk, and learns quickly to keep a second ledger.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Gauger	A chain, a post, a pay of 2 lacks a day
2	Measurer	Access to district figures; a sealed satchel
3	Assayer	Access to national figures; a house on Mile One
4	Senior Assayer	Reports to the Admiralty; under permanent watch
5	Keeper of the Number	Brenna Kelp, in hiding



Everyone wants to know where it's going. Nobody wants to know what it's going to do when it gets there.

BRENNA KELP, OVERHEARD

POWERS FROM ELSEWHERE

The **Cutwrights' College** keeps a house on Mile Two, where its genealogists track the Lung-lines and have quietly begun tracking the Tenanted, whose Cut seems to rise after their return. The **Purgation** has a small, vicious cell on the Mile that believes the sea can be wrung out of the blood (see Abel Drainer). The **Second Table** has members in the Admiralty's highest ranks, and it has noticed that the Trench is where a god's body might be going. The **Rim Road Company** has sent an auditor, Reeve Calder Stokes, and he has already begun to cough. The **Reckoners** have a list of every Lung-line cadet who has stopped needing to bail, and are watching the Headland with professional interest.

▼BRINEHOLLOW NOW

It isn't coming back. It's waiting.

— A PIER-HAULER OF THE RAW MILE, LOOKING WEST FROM NINETEEN

The Salt Assay has done the arithmetic the Admiralty forbade: the volume of sea lost each year matches the number of Tenanted. The ocean is moving into the people, a bucket at a time. Every Called person who comes back brings a measure of the deep with them, folded up inside, and the sea is that much lower. The Tenanted now sit on every court in the land. A scavenger has found something on

the Uncovered that should not be under any sea. And a shipwright is building a vessel to follow the water down.

The Callings are accelerating with the fall. Last Carving there were three nights on which more than five hundred walked. The Netwatch cannot cover the Mile. Dry Jonah's bottled brine has

turned up in the Vigil's rouse, and sleepless strangers four hundred miles inland have started walking west. On the Uncovered, salvagers report a tall figure, seen at a distance at dusk, setting a table on the mud with great care, and walking on. And in the bell tower on the Headland, Finn Undertow counts the days until the body's tide, drifting a little every week, brings every chest on the coast to fill at the same moment. He has told nobody the number. He has begun to feel it in his own chest as a slow swell, like a breath being drawn by something very large, somewhere below.

From the second ledger of Brenna Kelp, kept in cipher, found in a bail-bucket on Mile Ten. Deciphered by the Wreckwives.

Volume of fall, Carving 640 to Carving 641, from the Nineteenth gauge: 1.9 cubic miles.

Tenanted returned in the same year, by the Wreckwives' count: 2,214.

Mean bailing of a Tenanted adult, dawn and dusk, measured: 4.1 gallons.

This is far too little. The fall is not in what they bail. It is in what they hold. A Tenanted body is heavier than its size by a factor I have measured at the Sounding Hall gauge, standing them in the pool. Their displacement is wrong. They displace as if they were very much larger than they are.

Holding per Tenanted, then, by the fall: 0.00086 cubic miles. That is a lake. Each of them is carrying a lake. Folded up. Inside.

The figure is correct. I have checked it eleven times. I do not know where they are keeping it.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◆ **The Rope-Cutter of Mile Fourteen.** Nine ropes cut in nine nights on the same street, with no knife ever found. The Netwatch suspects a murderer. The families suspect each other. The truth is that a Tenanted grandmother has been walking the street at night, doing what she believes is a kindness, and the Drowned Bench has already ruled it lawful. She is not alone: someone small has been carrying a second blade.

- ◆ **The Follow's Pilot.** Dagna Hull needs someone to lead the iron vessel's trial descent at the Trench edge, and someone else to find out which of her nine hundred volunteers is sabotaging it, and why the saboteur weeps.
- ◆ **Three Copies.** Brenna Kelp has hidden three copies of her finding. The Admiralty, the Second Table, and the Wreckwives all want them. One copy is in the Hanging Abbey with Father Ebb; one is in a bail-bucket that has passed through four sweethearts' hands; and one has been read aloud on a procession night, to the Deepening, who wept with joy.
- ◆ **Eight Chairs.** Cray Lobbett will take the PCs to his table, for a price. Getting there is three days on the far Uncovered. Getting back is less certain. On the table, someone has laid a place.
- ◆ **The Last of Cask Lane.** Old Fen Lowry has escaped the Chapel Reach almshouse and gone home to Cask Lane to call the count. The six Tenanted who live there have taken him in, and are being very kind to him, and he has stopped eating. His granddaughter in Saltwick hires the PCs to bring him east. He will not come. He says that this morning, for the first time, Abner Corran's voice answered him through the wall, and it was the old voice, the real one, and it asked him to stay.
- ◆ **The Second Face of Mile Eight.** A Gilt Mile broker hires the PCs to prove his wife is Tenanted, so that their marriage can be dissolved and her dowry kept. She was never Called. Everyone in the house except the broker now believes she was. The servants have begun to sleep with knives. The wife has begun to ask the PCs, privately, whether they think she came back.
- ◆ **Steep's Tables.** A Picker of the Underpier has found, in a drowned Purser's chest, a waterlogged book of tide-tables for the year 0, with a hanged clerk's name on the flyleaf. The Admiralty's Deck-Wardens want it burned. The Deepening wants it read aloud at Gullcry. The House of Vasht wants it very badly indeed, and will not say why.

D10	RUMOR ON THE MILE
1	The Trench is a drain, and the sea is draining into the Fast. (False, but the Fast's wells are rising.)
2	The High Admiral has had the Steadfast's keel sawed through, so it can never float. (True; he cannot bear the idea of leaving.)
3	A Tenanted can be told by holding a mirror to their mouth at dawn: no mist. (False; there is mist, and it is salt.)
4	Prince Aurel has stopped surfacing at all. (True for the last nine days.)
5	The Deepening are paid by the Admiralty to thin the Mile's slums. (False, but a Commodore has suggested it.)
6	Every Tenanted judge voted the same way in every case this year. (True, to the case.)

D10	RUMOR ON THE MILE
7	If you cut a piece of rope from someone who was Called and burn it, you'll dream where they went. (True. Don't.)
8	Old Wet Tom is the god's own beggar, and whoever gives him a coin will never be Called. (Half-true; they will be Called to Tom.)
9	The Vigil pays a platter a bottle for Brinehollow brine. (True; Dry Jonah charges three.)
10	The skull of Dromm has been found walking. (Unknown.)

THE PEOPLE OF BRINEHOLLOW

HIGH ADMIRAL CORVIN SUND

Commander of four hundred warships standing on dry ground. Sixty-eight, square, grey-whiskered, in a blue dress coat kept so wet with brine that it never quite dries and smells of a harbor at low water. His voice is the parade-ground bark of a man who sailed as a boy, the last year the fleet floated, and has spent fifty years waiting to sail again. He inspects the ships weekly, has the hulls scraped of barnacles that are not there, and will hang any officer who says the word “stranded.” He has hanged four, and stood at the foot of the

Steadfast’s mast each time and watched the boots stop kicking, and gone to his cabin afterward and bailed for an hour, alone, and come out with his eyes red. He wants the sea back, and failing that he wants no one to admit it is gone. He fears the Salt Assay’s numbers, and more than that he fears the morning he will stand on the *Steadfast’s* deck and feel the pull himself. **Secret:** he has had the flagship’s keel sawn half through in the night, so that it can never float away without him. PCs meet him at an inspection, or in the dock when he wants a leaker found.

CORVIN SUND – HIGH ADMIRAL OF THE TIDAL ADMIRALTY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Lung-line, cadet) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Intimidate 4, Resolve 4, Blades 3, Clause 3, Endure 2, Wayfaring 1
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 2 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	dress sword +6 (4)
GIFTS	Deep Breath; Hold the Line (once per scene, every Admiralty sailor in earshot gains +2 to resist fear or the pull)
WANTS	To Keep Under (secrets, numbers, his own pull)
DREAD	0
SECRET	the sawn keel; he stands at the west rail every night at dusk with his hands on the wood.

HARBORMISTRESS KESSA DROWLE

She builds Lowmark’s mile of new pier each year: fifty-two, tar to the elbows, a carpenter’s pencil behind each ear, a cough she bails into the sea of sawdust on the work-barges. She speaks in measurements. She has calculated the year the timber runs out and the year the sea drops off the shelf entirely. They are the same year, nine years from now, and she has told no one but the PCs if they buy her enough rum. She wants to finish the Chase with dignity. She fears the twentieth mile: the survey shows the seabed beyond it falls away into the Trench’s slope, and the pilings will have nothing to stand on. **Secret:** she has begun ordering pilings longer than any sea could need, and she does not know why. Someone is driving them, at night, in a straight line west. PCs meet her when she hires guards for the timber barges, which the Uncovered’s salvagers raid.

KESSA DROWLE Threat 4 (Reckoning, Craft) · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (mallet 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

JUSTICE MAREN OAKE OF THE DROWNED BENCH

Called at thirty, returned after forty days. She is fifty now, broad and grey-skinned, with black eyes and hands that never move during a hearing. The air around her is cold and close and smells of the deep, and those who stand before her feel their ears pop. She speaks in two tones at once, and the lower one sometimes finishes first. She has never given an unjust verdict, and she has sentenced more people to loosing than any judge in history, always gently. She wants justice, in a sense larger than the Admiralty’s. **Secret:** her husband Tam has visited her chambers every week for twenty years, and she has never once told him that the woman he married is still in there, folded small, awake, and listening. Some nights, in the verdict-book, a

single word appears in the margin in a cramped hand that is not the Bench’s antique script: *wrong*. PCs meet her standing ankle-deep in her court.

MAREN OAKE – JUSTICE OF THE DROWNED BENCH	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2, rising · Regrowth 11 (the Brink, Tenanted) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Clause 5, Resolve 5, Instinct 4, Search 3, Godsign 3, Endure 2, Brawl 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	The Weight +8 (Caul + Godsign; target makes GUT + Endure vs Grim or is pinned and takes 3 per round)
GIFTS	Unbriable (cannot be Persuaded or Deceived by anyone who lies within her hearing; she knows); Voice of the Deep; Pressure
WANTS	To Keep Under; The Water
DREAD	3 (to hear the lower voice answer a question nobody asked)
SECRET	Maren is still present. The Passenger in her is not cruel. It is simply sure.

PRINCE AUREL VASHT

Heir of the Lung-lines, twenty-two, unable to breathe air for more than an hour. He rules from a glass tank twelve feet tall in the Hall of Tanks, floating naked but for a wrap of silk, grey-skinned, beautiful, with huge black eyes and hair that drifts like weed. His fingers are webbed to the second knuckle, as all the Vasht are. He has learned to read lips through eight inches of water and replies by

writing on a slate he presses to the glass. He is curious, lonely, and clever, and he is the only Vasht in a century to ask what the water wants. **Secret:** for nine days he has not surfaced at all, and he has begun to hear his grandmother calling from the cellars, and to answer, knocking on the glass in her rhythm. PCs meet him when he summons outsiders, privately, who might tell him the truth about the sea.

AUREL VASHT – PRINCE OF THE LUNG-LINES	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 5 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Lung-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Search 4, Lore 3, Athletics 3, Godsign 3, Persuade 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 18 in water, 12 in air · Armor 1 · Fray 5
ATTACKS	none worth the name
GIFTS	Fathom-Body; Tide-Sight; Lip-Reading through water (Search +3 to read speech he can see)
WANTS	The Water; The West
DREAD	2 (to see his chest not move)
SECRET	he is the Seating his grandmother is waiting for.

◇

*Is it true that in the Fatlands the sea is only a story?
Write it on the glass. Write slowly. I want to see the
shape of the word.*

PRINCE AUREL VASHT, ON HIS SLATE, TO A VISITOR

LADY ONDINE VASHT, THE DOWAGER BELOW

The prince’s grandmother, far into the Course, and far past it. She lives in the flooded cellars of Fathomhouse and has not been seen whole in years. The cellars have had to be extended twice. What

visitors see, holding a lantern at the top of the fourth stair, is a black surface that breathes, and parts of her: a hand on the bottom step, grey, as long as a man’s arm; an eye beneath the water, wide as a plate; the shape of a vast back turning. Her voice comes up through the stone of the whole palace, slow and courteous. She still signs the family’s letters. She wants her grandson to come down. **Secret:** she is not Tenanted; she is Seating, slowly, and the House of Vasht has been feeding her the retired-to-depth to keep her from going west and taking the palace with her. Every Lowering is a meal. PCs meet her only if summoned below, which the household treats as an honor and a funeral.

ONDINE VASHT – THE DOWAGER BELOW	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 7 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 · Regrowth 11 (the Brink, approaching the Seating) · Hunger 9
SKILLS	Godsign 6, Endure 5, Intimidate 5, Brawl 4, Instinct 4
BODY	Flesh 20 · Guard 17 · Armor 2 · Fray —
ATTACKS	crushing grasp +8 (5, Pressure: on a Helping the target begins drowning on dry land)
GIFTS	The Weight; Voice of the Deep (all within earshot make a Calling roll at Grim); Pressure Day (once a night, she makes the palace's air thicken: all within suffer –2 to every roll, and ears bleed)
WANTS	To Keep Under; the boy
DREAD	4 (to see her whole)
SECRET	when she Seats, the Headland goes with her.

FATHER EBB

Abbot of the Anchorites, chained to the same rock for fifty-one years. Seventy-eight, a skeleton in a canvas habit, salt-crusted, his iron collar grown into the flesh of his neck so that the skin has healed over the rim like bark over a nail. His hands are calloused from gripping the chain. He has felt the Calling every night of those

fifty-one years. His voice is soft and rough and he laughs often, at himself. He says the chain is not what holds him, and will not say what does. He wants his monks to endure; he wants, more quietly, to know whether enduring is worth it. **Secret:** the chain has been rusted through for twelve years, and he knows it. What holds him is a promise made to a girl who was Called in 589, sworn on her rope. PCs meet him by climbing to his ledge, which takes a day.

FATHER EBB – ABBOT OF THE HANGING ABBEY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Resolve 6, Rites 4, Endure 4, Lore 3, Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	none
GIFTS	Fathom-Body; The Refusal (once a night, he may make the Calling roll in place of anyone within sight of him)
WANTS	The West, every night, unanswered
DREAD	1 (to see the collar's healed flesh)
SECRET	the rusted chain, and the girl's name, which is Nerys Colm's mother's.

TOLLY BRACK, THE BAILER BOY

Eleven years old, small, freckled under the salt-grime, with strong thin hands and a voice cracked from shouting “Bail-o!” up the Mile at dawn. He goes door to door bailing those too old or weak to cough for themselves, holding them over his knee and pounding their backs, for a crumb a time, singing his mother's bailing song under his breath. He knows from the color of the water who will be Called next. Blue means soon. He does not tell them. He tells their families, if they pay, and has started telling them for free. He wants his mother, who was Called when he was six, after a whole winter of begging him to cut her loose; he would not, and she went anyway. He fears that he is starting to see blue in his own bucket. He keeps a small curved cannery knife in his boot. PCs meet him at dawn, at the door of anyone they are visiting.

TOLLY BRACK Threat 3 (Instinct, Filch) · Flesh 9 · Guard 13 · Attack +2 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

SENNET GULL, THE WRECKWIFE

Her husband Davey walked into the sea and came back kinder. Thirty-four, sharp-faced, red-knuckled, smelling of the mussel-cannery where she works. She keeps him in the cistern under the house, brings him his dinner, sits on the edge and talks to him about her day while he floats on his back with his black eyes open, listening, and says the right things. The old Davey drank and hit. This one does not. She has started to prefer him. That is what frightens her. **Secret:** she has begun to notice that she can no longer remember the old Davey's voice, and she has wondered, in the dark, whether the thing in the cistern took that too. PCs meet her at a Wreckwives' table, asking for advice she does not want.

DR. ISOLDE REAVE

A lung surgeon of the Headland, forty-five, thin, bespectacled, in a leather apron stiff with brine and old blood. Her rooms smell of carbolic and low tide. She opened a drowned chest at high tide and found the water in it had a current: it moved in the lungs in a slow circle, westward. In the next one she found a shell, alive, of no known species, pink and whorled, which she keeps in a jar and which has grown. She wants to understand. She fears that she does. **Secret:** she has started opening chests that are not yet drowned, with the patients' consent and sometimes without it, and the shells are in the living too. PCs meet her when they need a Course chest explained, or a body procured.

ISOLDE REAVE Threat 4 (Stitching, Reckoning) · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (scalpel 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

HASK TARN, THE PILOT

He guides salvage parties across the Uncovered. Sixty, lean, weathered, with a sounding-lead on a cord around his neck that he swings as he walks. He used to pilot ships over the same ground and navigates by remembered depth: "Six fathom here, sand bottom; mind, it shelves." He is never lost. He will not go near the places where he once lost the bottom, where the lead ran out of line, because they are still there, and they are still bottomless, and he has heard them breathe. He wants one more season's pay. He fears the deep places, and the day his memory of depth fails. **Secret:** he knows the way to the Stone Table; he steered over it in 581, and the lead came up warm. PCs hire him, at six lacks a day.

HASK TARN Threat 4 (Wayfaring, Search) · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Attack +4 (gutting knife 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

NERYS COLM, THE HALF-CALLED

She walked into the surf up to her chin and then, uniquely, turned around. Twenty-eight now, wild-haired, salt-burned, with one eye that has gone wholly black and one still blue. She lives in a sealed room in the Netwatch barracks, by her own request, with wax in the keyhole. She has heard the invitation in full and can repeat it. Nobody who has listened to her has stayed ashore. She wants someone to tell her what made her turn. She fears that she knows: she heard the eighth voice in the chorus, under the others, and it was hungry. **Secret:** she has written the invitation down, once, in a

letter she meant to burn. It is missing. PCs meet her through Lieutenant Reef, behind a door, through a speaking-tube she will not use.



Don't put your ear to the tube. Don't. I'll knock if I need you. I'll knock twice. If it's three times, that isn't me.

NERYS COLM, THROUGH THE DOOR ABOVE THE NET-LOFT

CAPTAIN JONAH SKERRY, CALLED DRY JONAH

A smuggler who bottles what Brinehollowers cough up and sells it inland as tonic. Fifty, fat, cheerful, perfectly dry: an outlander from the Fatlands borders who never bails and wears a waist-rope as a joke. His brig the *Thirsty Bess* has been aground since he bought her; he runs the trade by wagon along the Rim Road. He buys bail-water by the bucket in the Mile slums, half a crumb a pint, and sells it in green glass in the Vigil for a platter a bottle. It sells well there. He has never asked what his customers start to dream about. **Secret:** he has started to keep a bottle of his own product by his bed, and drinks it when he cannot sleep. Three weeks ago he coughed at dawn, and a cupful of clear cold water came up into his hand. PCs meet him buying, selling, or hiring guards for a wagon going east.

DRY JONAH SKERRY Threat 4 (Haggle, Deceive) · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (crossbow 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

ORRIN WAKE AND PASSENGER

A fisherman, Tenanted by something that is, for once, willing to talk. Orrin is thirty-nine, burly, slow-spoken, with gentle black eyes and a left arm that hangs a little loose. The Passenger is courteous, very old, and negotiating with Orrin for the use of his left arm. They argue in the same mouth, in two tones, in the corner of the Lantern tavern on Mile Nine. Orrin wants his life back, or enough of it. The Passenger wants a hand to do something with. Neither will say what. They have drawn up terms on a slate. **Secret:** the Passenger has explained to Orrin what the sea is for, and why it is going, and Orrin has begun to agree. PCs meet them when the Passenger asks a stranger to witness the contract.

ORRIN WAKE AND PASSENGER – THE TALKING TENANT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 (Orrin) / 5 (Passenger) · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 10 (the Brink, Tenanted) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Godsign 4, Clause 4 (Passenger), Labor 3, Wayfaring 3, Endure 3, Brawl 2
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 4 (Orrin) / — (Passenger)
ATTACKS	fist +5 (1); the left arm, when the Passenger has it, +8 (4, Pressure)
GIFTS	Voice of the Deep; The Weight; Two Minds (cannot be surprised; each mind may act once per round, but only one may use the left arm)
WANTS	The Water (Orrin resists; the Passenger does not)
DREAD	3 (to hear them disagree)
SECRET	the left arm is for opening something at the Stone Table.

BRENNA KELP, THE SALT ASSAYER

Keeper of the falling number. Forty-one, ink-stained, myopic, with a gauging-chain worn as a belt and a habit of muttering figures under her breath. She found where the sea is going by counting buckets: the national bail-water tally, the Callings, the Tenanted, the volume of the fall. They match. The Admiralty has made her finding illegal. She has hidden three copies and herself, moving between Wreckwives' safe houses on the Mile. She wants the truth published before the sea is gone. She fears that the Tenanted already know her number, and are counting down to something. **Secret:** her own bail-water has gone blue. She chains herself to every bed she sleeps in, and every morning the padlock is still locked, and every morning her ankles are wet. PCs meet her when a Wreckwife asks them to escort a “cousin” across the Mile at night.

BRENNA KELP Threat 4 (Reckoning, Stealth) · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +2 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

MOTHER LIMPET

Prophet of the Deepening. Eighty-four, tiny, bent, in a dress of white shell-beads that clicks when she walks, with a voice like a warm bath. She smells of seaweed and lamp-oil. Her eyes are the Course's wide black, kind and wet. She has baptized two thousand by walking them in at night, holding each hand to the water's edge, singing. She says she will follow when the last one is safely under. She wants everyone home. She fears nothing, or says so. **Secret:** she cannot hear the invitation. She never could. She has been leading two thousand people toward a voice she has only ever been told about, and she does not know whether she is a saint or the thing that comes before one. PCs meet her on a procession night, holding out a lantern.

MOTHER LIMPET – MOTHER OF THE WATER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 4, Godsign 3, Instinct 3, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	none
GIFTS	Fathom-Body; The Low Song (Persuade + Rites; listeners at the Appetite or beyond make a Calling roll at Hard, even awake)
WANTS	The West, which she has never truly felt
DREAD	2 (to watch a procession disappear lantern by lantern)
SECRET	she is deaf to the god; the Deepening rests on her faith in other people's.

DAGNA HULL, THE SHIPWRIGHT

She is building the *Follow*, a sealed iron vessel meant to chase the sea down into the Trench. Fifty-five, huge-shouldered, deafened by riveting, she shouts everything and smells of hot iron and pitch. The *Follow* lies in a slip at the end of Mile Nineteen, a riveted iron egg forty feet long with glass ports and an air-bladder. She has a waiting

list of nine hundred volunteers. She wants to know where the water goes. She fears that the nine hundred do not want to know; they want to go. **Secret:** someone keeps loosening the *Follow*'s rivets, and she has found the marks of her own hammer on them. PCs meet her when she hires a crew.

DAGNA HULL Threat 4 (Craft, Labor) · Flesh 14 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (riveting hammer 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

CRAY LOBBETT

A scavenger on the far Uncovered, forty, lean as a dried eel, eyes red from salt wind, hands scarred by weed-knives. He found a stone table on the seabed, older than the Gorging, with eight chairs. Seven were pushed in. One was pulled out. On its seat was a fine dust like ground shell, and an impression, as if someone had just stood up. He has not been able to sell the location, or to stop going back. Each trip he finds the table cleaner. He wants to be rid of it. He fears that the next time the eighth chair will be pushed in, or that a ninth will be pulled out with his name scratched in the stone. **Secret:** on his last trip there was a cup on the table, full. PCs meet him in a Saltwick tavern, drunk, drawing eight squares on the wet bar.

OLD WET TOM

A beggar who has never been dry. Ageless, bearded, in rags heavy and black with water, wringing himself out on the Headland steps. It rains on him indoors: a soft private drizzle from nowhere that soaks his blanket and fills his begging bowl. Puddles follow him

down corridors. Children say that if you look into one of them, it is much deeper than the floor, and that something down there looks back. He is gentle and simple and speaks of the sea as an old friend who owes him money. **Secret:** Tom is the oldest Tenanted in Brinehollow, Called in 118, and he has been waiting for his family to come for him for five hundred years. PCs meet him whenever the GM likes.

OLD WET TOM Threat 2 · Flesh 30 (does not seem to bleed) · Guard 10 · Attack — · Armor 0 · Dread 2 (to look into his puddle)

LIEUTENANT SABLE REEF OF THE NETWATCH

Thirty-six, tall, sinewed, her face scarred by the fingernails of the Called, who fight hard in their trance. She carries a boathook and a weighted net and walks the Mile at night with a lantern at her belt. She has pulled three hundred Called off the shore with hook and rope. Every one of them looked at her the same way: not frightened, not angry, but disappointed, as though she had interrupted something precious. She has begun to wonder what she is saving them from. **Secret:** she dreams every night that she is walking west, and that the three hundred are walking beside her, and that they are glad she came. PCs meet her when they are out on the Mile at night.

SABLE REEF – LIEUTENANT OF THE NETWATCH

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Blades 3, Brawl 3, Athletics 3, Wayfaring 3, Search 3, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	boathook +7 (4, Hooking; on a Helping the target is pulled down); weighted net +7 (0, Grappled)
GIFTS	Deep Breath; Salt-Sense
WANTS	The West, newly
DREAD	0
SECRET	she will be the next of her watch to go.

NETWATCH PATROLLER Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (boathook 4, Hooking) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

ONE OF THE CALLED Threat 3 (feels no pain, does not tire) · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (grapple 1, will not stop walking) · Armor 0 · Dread 3 if loved

TENANTED NEIGHBOR Threat 3 (Instinct, Endure; cannot lie, cannot be bribed) · Flesh 14 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (grip 2, The Weight) · Armor 1 · Dread 2, or 3 if once known

RETIRED TO DEPTH Threat 5 (immovable; air thickens within ten paces: –2 to all rolls) · Flesh 30 · Guard 8 · Attack +7 (crushing embrace 5, Pressure) · Armor 3 · Dread 4

ILSE MARL, CHOIR-MISTRESS OF THE LOW WATER

Sixty, small, fierce, ink-blotted, wrapped in shawls on the Uncovered at the lowest tide of every month with a lantern, a lap-desk, and frozen fingers. At the lowest tide the Tenanted gather and sing: hundreds of them, in a ring on the mud, eyes closed, mouths open, in a music with no words and a beat like a slow heart. She alone writes it down, in a notation she invented. Laid end to end, forty years of her transcriptions make a nautical chart: soundings, currents, and a course leading west and down. **Secret:** the chart has a destination, and it is not the Trench. PCs meet her at the Low Water, where she asks them to hold her lantern.

FINN UNDERTOW, THE BELLMAN

He rings Lowmark's tide bell so the city knows when to bail. Forty-four, one-eyed, roped to the bell tower on the Headland, with forearms like hawsers. The tides in the body no longer match the

tides of the sea, and he has to choose which to ring. For years he chose the sea. Now he rings the body, and the city coughs as one when he does. He feels the body's tide in his own chest, and in everyone's, as a single swell. **Secret:** the body tide is drifting too, toward a single moment in which every Brinehollower will fill at once, and he can count the days. PCs meet him if they climb the tower to ask why the bell rang early.

REEVE CALDER STOKES

An auditor sent by the Rim Road Company to price Brinehollow's losses. Thirty-three, Oathen-trained, pale, precise, ledgers under one arm. He is an outsider with dry lungs. He has been here three months, and this morning he tasted salt. He wants to finish the audit and leave. He fears that he has been asked to price something that has no price. His Company contract, sworn before Jessamy Quill, binds him to deliver the audit in person in Tacit. **Secret:** the audit shows the Admiralty's tolls and Brenna Kelp's numbers point to the same thing, and the Company already knew. PCs meet him hiring them to escort him, which he notes in the ledger as "guides, drying."

NEW CHARACTERS

OTTILINE HAWSE, THE ROPEWALKER

Mistress of the Ropewalk on Mile Three, a quarter-mile shed where anchoring ropes are spun, laid, and tarred. Fifty, hands black with tar, smelling of hemp and pine. Every rope in Lowmark passes through her shed, and she keeps a ledger of every rope cut. She can tell by the cut: the blade, the angle, the strength of the hand. She knows which ropes were cut by the sleeper, which by the beloved, and which by no hand at all. She tells the families nothing unless they ask twice. **Secret:** forty of the ropes she sold last year were cut by the same small blade, angled from below, and she knows the child who carries it.



There's three columns in my book. Sleeper. Beloved. None. The third one's longest this year, and I'll tell you for nothing, a rope cut by none is the cleanest cut there is.

OTTILINE HAWSE, AT THE ROPEWALK

ESK PENHALLOW, THE RETURNED WHO WASN'T

Called at twenty-six, gone eight weeks, came back. He swears he is not Tenanted. He says he remembers the sea: cold, the weight, a voice asking, and then a sandbar and a long walk home, starved. His wife will not let him in. His mother has rung the Wreckwives. His children scream. He is a little heavier, a little slower, he cannot explain why his voice has dropped, and he does not believe it has. He sits on the steps of his own house on Mile Eight every night, roped to the railing by his own hand, and calls his children's names

through the wall at the morning count. Nobody answers him. The Wreckwives have taken his case as a test: if a man can be loved back out of the sea, they would like to know it, and if he cannot, they would like to know that more. **Secret:** the GM decides. He may be telling the truth, and Brinehollow has no test.

COMMODORE LYSANDER VELL

A senior officer of the Admiralty, forty-eight, elegant, dry-lunged to an unusual degree for a Lung-line cadet, with a silver waist-rope braided from his ancestors' hair. Polished, witty, and a member of the Second Table. He keeps in his cabin aboard the propped *Gannet* a lead box holding a piece of Dromm's flesh, preserved since the Beaching, which still weeps cold water. He believes the god is reassembling at the bottom of the Trench, and intends the *Follow* to carry a carving party there. **Secret:** he has been eating a sliver of the flesh each Tablenight, and he no longer needs to bail.

COMMODORE LYSANDER VELL Threat 5 (Persuade, Clause) ·
Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (rapier 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

ABEL DRAINER, THE WRINGER

Leader of the Purgation's Brinehollow cell, a gaunt, cheerful former fishmonger with a mangle in his cellar. He believes the sea can be wrung out of the blood: his followers hang their converts by the ankles for a day and a night, and beat the water out of them, and bail them until they bring up blood instead of brine. Some of them have stopped bailing afterward, and died of nothing, dry. He counts it as cure. His cell meets in a fish-cellar on Mile Fifteen that stinks of old blood and brine, and the Netwatch tolerates it because the Wringer's converts are never Called. PCs meet him when a friend joins, or when a family hires them to bring a son home from the mangle. **Secret:** he has been Called four times and dragged home by his own followers each time, and he has his followers hang him by the ankles every night to keep the water from rising.

CUTWRIGHT ANSBY WRACK

The Cutwrights' College's genealogist in Lowmark, thirty-nine, soft-spoken, with ink-stained cuffs and a cough she pretends is a cold. Her ledgers show that a Tenanted person's descendants carry a higher Cut than their parents should have given them. The god is not just taking people back. It is breeding. She wants the College to stop the marriages, and to stop the Admiralty marrying Tenanted widows to Lung-line cadets, which it has been encouraging for a century. She fears what the Provost will do with her ledgers, and what the Bench will do with her. PCs meet her when she needs a Tenanted family's records stolen from a parish chest. **Secret:** she has proof that the House of Vasht's last three generations were fathered by Tenanted, and the prince's father was one.

GANNET SHALE, THE TABLE-SEER

A salvager girl of nineteen, quick and sunburned, who walked the far Uncovered alone for a week and saw, at dusk, a tall stooping figure laying a table on the mud. White cloth. Candles. A chair

pulled out. It looked at her and waited, and she ran. She went back the next morning. The table was gone. The candles' wax was still on the mud, and the drips went west. She has told the story in every tavern from Saltwick to Mile Nineteen, and has been laughed at in all of them except one, where an old man in a Fast traveler's coat bought her a drink and asked, very carefully, whether she had been thanked. PCs meet her when she wants company for a return trip. **Secret:** she has been dreaming of the chair, and whoever laid it has started setting places in her dreams.

OTHERS ON THE MILE

DULSE AMMERY, THE KIND HAND OF MILE FOURTEEN, A TENANTED GRANDMOTHER SMELLING OF LAVENDER OVER BRINE WHO WALKS THE LASHINGS AT NIGHT WITH A LITTLE WHALEBONE-GRIPPED BLADE AND A RULING OF THE BENCH FOLDED IN HER SHAWL Threat 4 (Stealth, Instinct) · Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (little blade 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 3 (to find her at the bedside, and understand)

CORALIE SCULPIN, BUCKET-WIFE OF MILE TWELVE, WHO GRADES BAIL-WATER BY TASTE AT DAWN AND BUYS IT FOR DRY JONAH Threat 3 (Haggle, Persuade) · Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (bucket-hook 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

HOLLIS BRINE, DAGNA HULL'S APPRENTICE, FIRST NAME ON THE FOLLOW'S VOLUNTEER WALL, WHO ONCE PUT HIS EAR TO NERYS COLM'S DOOR Threat 3 (Craft, Athletics) · Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (riveting hammer 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

FEN LOWRY, THE LAST COUNT-CALLER OF CASK LANE, SEVENTY-FOUR, WHO WILL NOT STOP CALLING THE NAMES Threat 1 · Flesh 8 · Guard 9 · Attack — · Armor 0 · Dread 1

CHAPLAIN ABSALOM DREE OF FATHOMHOUSE, WHO HAS SUNG THE DUSK HYMN AT FORTY-ONE LOWERINGS AND NOW SINGS IT IN HIS SLEEP, SLOWER EACH NIGHT Threat 3 (Rites, Resolve) · Flesh 10 · Guard 10 · Attack +1 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

▼ PLAYING A BRINEHOLLOWER

Tie your own knot. Then check it. Then let someone you love check it. Then lie down facing east and pray they tied it right.

— ADVICE GIVEN TO EVERY CHILD ON THE MILE ON THE NIGHT THEY ARE FIRST ALLOWED TO SLEEP UNTETHERED FROM A PARENT

You were born gasping. Your mother held you over her knee and beat the sea out of you, and you have bailed twice a day ever since. You sleep roped. You call names through the wall. Somewhere west of you, the water knows your name.

Attribute bonus: +1 LUNG. Brinehollowers hold their breath longer, swim better, and move more quietly than any people on the Table.

Bailing. A Brinehollower who misses a bailing suffers −2 to all rolls until they bail, and after a further hour begins to drown (1 Flesh per ten minutes). Another character can bail a helpless one with a Routine HAND + Stitching roll.

The Sop: Wading. Stand in salt water, the sea or any basin of brine, past the knees, through one full turn of the body's tide, facing west, listening. Remove 1d6 Hunger. The god is pleased, and the next Calling roll you make is at +2 difficulty.

The Tooth. When a Brinehollower Partakes, the ears pop, the chest fills, and the voice drops into its second register. Witnesses hear the sea in the room. On a Tooth showing 1, the character coughs up a gout of cold water, sand, and something small and living, and loses their next action to bailing.

GIFTS

The Taste (Regrowth 1–3). Choose one. *Deep Breath:* hold your breath for ten minutes per point of Caul; you cannot drown in that time and ignore smoke, gas and choking. *Salt-Sense:* by tasting the air you know of a pressure day an hour before it comes, and by tasting someone's bail-water, their Regrowth stage. Cost: either Gift used in front of dry folk marks you as deep-blooded.

The Appetite (Regrowth 4–6). Choose one. *Tide-Sight:* Partake to know the direction and distance of the nearest body of salt water, and of every Called and Tenanted person within a mile; −2 to resist The West for the rest of the night. *Pressure:* Partake when grappling or striking to add 2 damage and make the target's ears bleed; on a Helping, the target is stunned for a round. Cost: each use leaves you with salt rime on the skin, and dogs will not come near you for a day.

The Course (Regrowth 7–9). Gain *Fathom-Body:* Armor +1 from thickened skin; see in total darkness; breathe water as easily as air; ignore cold. Cost: in open air for more than a day without immersion, −1 to all rolls; you must sleep submerged or gain 1 Hunger each night. Choose also one: *The Weight* (Partake: become crushingly heavy for a scene; cannot be moved, knocked down or carried, and doors and floors may give) or *Quiet Chest* (no breath, no

heartbeat audible; +3 to Stealth; dry folk who notice must make a Dread 1 check).

The Brink (Regrowth 10–11). Gain *Voice of the Deep*: speak in the god’s register; Partake to give one command that anyone at the Appetite or beyond must resist with Caul + Resolve vs Grim, or obey as if Called. Cost: each use, roll a Tooth; on a 1 or 2, the Passenger answers the next question asked of you, in its own voice.

WANTS

- ◇ **The West.** Trigger: dusk, a west-facing window, the sound of surf. Resist with Caul + Resolve or go and stand and watch until full dark.
- ◇ **The Water.** Trigger: sleep near any basin, well or barrel. Resist or wake with your face in it.
- ◇ **To Keep Under.** Trigger: learning a secret, finding something lost. Resist or hide, sink or bury it, and tell no one.
- ◇ **The Silence.** Trigger: being asked where someone went. Resist or say nothing at all for the rest of the scene.

PLAYING THE TENANTED

A PC who returns Tenanted and continues in play stands at the Brink (Regrowth 11) permanently and does not gain Hunger from Partaking, because something else is doing the eating. They cannot lie: any attempt fails and the lower voice says the truth instead. They gain *Fathom-Body* and *Voice of the Deep* if they did not have them. They keep every memory. The player and GM should agree, privately, on one thing the Passenger wants, and the GM may, once per session, have the Passenger act on it through the character’s hands for a moment the player does not control. Every companion who knew the character before must make a Dread 3 check at the first meeting, and anyone who Breaks from it takes the Second Face. The Tenanted PC should never be told, by the GM, whether they are still themselves. That is the whole of the role.

YOUR ROPE

Every Brinehollow PC should answer these at creation. The answers are the first things the coast will use against them.

- ◇ Who ties your knot at night, and whose knot do you tie?
- ◇ Who in your family was Called, and did they come back?
- ◇ What is in your rope-box: whose piece of rope, and did you ever cut one?
- ◇ What color was your bucket this morning, and did you look?
- ◇ Which direction does your bed face, and why?

BACKGROUND CONCEPTS

- ◇ **Netwatch Hooker.** You have dragged the Called home by the hair. You know the Mile at night, and the look they give you.

- ◇ **Wreckwife’s Child.** One of your parents came back. You were the one who first noticed. Nobody believed you.
- ◇ **Uncovered Salvager.** You make your living on the dead seabed among upright wrecks and things with too many ribs, and you have seen lights out there you have never reported.
- ◇ **Parish Bailer.** You grew up pounding old backs over your knee for a crumb a time. You read the water. You know who is going, and you have never once told them.
- ◇ **Lung-line Cadet.** Your blood is deep and your fingers are webbed to the first knuckle. Your family wants you married to someone you have never met, and you have seen the sewn pages in the marriage-book.
- ◇ **Layer of the Dead.** You walk the Face-Down Fields at dawn setting stones on backs, and you have started to find them turned over, and you have stopped reporting it.

The common Callings take local shapes on the coast: a **Brinehollow Seamer** opens drowned chests at high tide; a **Nightwarden** walks for the Netwatch; a **Celebrant** sings rope funerals on the Chapel Reach; a **Gleaner** works the Uncovered; a **Midwife** gives the First Bail; a **Surety** stands guarantor for a loosed convict’s family; a **Reckoner** may be an unlicensed Salt Assay clerk with a second ledger.

THE SEATING

At Regrowth 12 the Tenant takes the whole house. The character is Called on the next night that comes, without a roll, and nothing can hold them. If they come back, it is with their face and their memories, as a piece of Dromm. The character is lost. The player narrates the last walk west, and may write down one courtesy the Tenant will extend to the companions forever, which the GM must honor.

NAMES

MALE	FEMALE	NEUTRAL	SURNAMES
Corvin, Orrin, Finn, Hask, Davey	Kessa, Maren, Nerys, Sable, Ilse	Tolly, Cray, Ebb, Gannet, Wren	Sund, Drowle, Oake, Reef, Undertow
Jonah, Esk, Cobb, Bren, Lysander	Sennet, Brenna, Dagna, Ondine, Haddie	Marl, Sculpin, Tern, Fathom, Shoal	Kelp, Hull, Lobbett, Hawse, Penhallow
Tam, Gaff, Ondric, Hollis, Merrow	Wenna, Isolde, Ottiline, Coralie, Brine	Skerry, Weir, Lugg, Swell, Dulse	Gull, Brack, Wake, Tarn, Colm
Abner, Pell, Wat, Ezra, Abiah	Lissa, Marta, Prue, Lowdy, Annick	Fen, Denner, Esmé, Absalom, Kettle	Corran, Stave, Teague, Steep, Lowry

▼ HORRORS OF BRINEHOLLOW

USING THE HORRORS TABLE

Roll when the party is on the Mile at night, on the Uncovered, or in any Brinehollow house after dark, or pick the scene that cuts deepest. Dread ratings are given in brackets.

D20	HORROR
1	A child sits on a doorstep holding a cut rope, waiting for someone to come out and tie it again. The house is empty. [Dread 2]
2	The cellar's indoor tide brings up a wedding ring, a tooth, and a pair of reading spectacles, all belonging to the same Called woman, laid neatly on the step. [Dread 2]
3	On the Uncovered, a ribbed thing the size of an ox drags itself toward the far water on fins of rotting leather, trailing its own guts across the salt. It is sobbing like a man. [Dread 2]
4	A lantern procession of the Deepening passes, two hundred strong, singing. One of the faces is a PC's sister, or friend, or mother. She smiles and does not stop. [Dread 3]
5	A surgeon's apprentice opens a chest on the table and seawater bursts out, live, full of tiny pale crabs that pour off the table and under the door. [Dread 2]
6	A Tenanted husband greets the party at the door with perfect manners and calls each PC by name, though they have never met. [Dread 3]
7	A pressure day: windows bow, ears bleed, a gull drops dead at someone's feet, and from every cellar on the street comes the sound of something very large turning over. [Dread 2]
8	An upright wreck in the Wreck Orchard has its whole drowned crew still at their stations, preserved in salt, faces turned west, mouths open mid-song. One mouth closes. [Dread 3]
9	At the morning count, a voice answers through the wall for a neighbor who was Called last month, coughing exactly as he did. [Dread 3]
10	At the Trench's edge, the draining sound stops. In the silence, very far down, eight voices are counting, and one is coming closer. [Dread 4]
11	An old man in the next bed has not been bailed. His daughter lies awake beside him, eyes open, listening to the gargle rise, and does not move. She looks at the PCs and puts a finger to her lips. [Dread 3]
12	A land-drowned body laid face-down on the flats is still frothing at the mouth after two days, a rose-pink foam that has built up beneath the face into a soft heap the size of a pillow. [Dread 1]
13	In the Lashings, a whole row walks on a Calling night, still lashed to its common chain, dragging beds, cradles and a struggling dry lodger along the planks behind them. [Dread 3]
14	A Tenanted mother sings her child to sleep. The upper voice stops for breath. The lower voice does not. [Dread 2]
15	A Fathomhouse grating breathes out a cold green gust, and on the cold, faint as a draught, the sound of the Dusk Hymn being sung very slowly, and under it a long low creak, and then a crack. [Dread 3]
16	A woman on Mile Ten sits by her sleeping husband with a lantern and a mirror, holding the glass to his lips, and asks the PCs, very calmly, whether the mist looks like salt to them. [Dread 2]
17	The Leather Forest drips. In the jellied drifts of rotting fish at the roots, a shape the size of a man lies curled, translucent, with a wrist-knot of linen still tied at the arm. [Dread 2]
18	A PC's own dawn bucket is blue. Nobody else sees it. Tolly Brack, at the door, sees it, and goes quiet, and will not take the crumb. [Dread 3]
19	On the Anchorites' cliff, a dead monk long since picked clean still hangs in his collar, and at dusk, with the rest of the cliff, he coughs. [Dread 3]
20	On the shell road at Gullcry, every lantern-hook for nine miles is lit, and there is no procession, and at the far end, at the last lantern, a table is laid. [Dread 4]



CHAPTER 6

THE VIGIL

Pinch me.

– THE VIGIL'S COMMONEST ENDEARMENT, AND ITS MARRIAGE VOW

Do not tell me you are tired. Everyone is tired. Tell me you are awake.

– SIGN PAINTED OVER THE DOOR OF EVERY WAKER STATION IN THE CITY

Statement of Hesper Coyle, rope-twister of Thimble Lane, the Slope, given at the Lanternside station to Inspector H. Grimmer in the presence of a Waker-Sergeant and a clerk, third watch, the eleventh day of Carving, 641. Entered as Blink-Matter Forty-One.

I want it written that I loved him. Write that first, before the rest, because after the rest nobody will believe it, and I need it to be somewhere in ink where they cannot scrape it.

We were on the long watch. You know the kind. Two days and the most of a third, because the rope order for the Lamplighters came in doubled and the cut rouse on our street has been weak since Plenty. Tobin said it was chalk. I said it was ash. We argued about it to stay up, the way you do. Arguing is good. Arguing is better than pinching because it gets the blood going in the face.

It was the third afternoon and it was one of those days. Grey. No wind. The tin on the roof did not move at all. You could hear the Lanternside bell from four streets off and then nothing, nothing, nothing for the whole quarter, and the light was the colour of milk in a bowl. I have lived thirty-four years on the Slope and I have never been so frightened of a sky.

Tobin was at the twisting-post and I was at the hackle. We were taking turns saying the numbers. One, he says. Two, I say. That is how we do it on a bad day. If the other one does not answer, you get up and slap them. We got to four hundred and something. I remember four hundred and twelve because it is the age of the Regent in the north and I made a joke about it, and he did not laugh, and I said four hundred and thirteen, and he said four hundred and fourteen. He did say it. I heard him say it.

Then his face was under my hands.

I do not know how to say it better than that. There was no between. I was at the hackle with the flax in my fist and the hackle-teeth were cold, and then it was not my fist, it was my two palms, flat, and under them his face, and his face was warm. He was lying down. Do you understand me? He was lying down on the floor of our own room, on his back, and somebody had put the folded sacking under his head like a pillow, and somebody had crossed his hands on his chest the

way you see them in the old carvings from before, and his eyes were closed. His eyes were closed because my thumbs were on them.

The rest of my hands were over his mouth and nose. Flat and gentle and firm, like a mother tucking a blanket. That is what I keep coming back to. I was not pressing hard. There was no need to press hard. He had stopped some while before.

I want to say I screamed but I did not. I took my hands off him very slowly, the way you would lift your hands off a sleeping baby so as not to wake it, and I looked at my palms, and there was spit on them, and the shape of his teeth pressed into the meat below my thumb. He had bitten me. He had fought. I have no mark on my memory of it at all, only on my hand.

The Waker says I was out for two breaths. The sergeant here says two breaths. Mistress Pell across the lane says she saw me through the window and I was standing at the hackle, and then I was kneeling, and there was no time for me to get from one to the other, and she says I was humming. She says it was the old song, the one that is not allowed, the one about the lamb and the lid. I do not know that song. My mother never sang it to me. Nobody's mother ever sang it to anybody. I would like someone to tell me how I was humming it.

His body was still warm when the Wakers came. They rattled him. They needled his feet and the soft places under his arms the way they do with the Counted, in case, and of course he did not move, because he was not asleep, he was dead, and you cannot needle a dead man back. The sergeant was kind. He put a pin in my hand and closed my fingers over it and said hold that, Mistress, hold that tight, and I have been holding it since the second watch and my palm is running and I cannot feel it.

I keep thinking: where was I. If my hands were here, where was I. And the only answer I have is the room. Everyone knows about the room. I was in the room with the eye for two breaths, and in the room I was not doing anything, I was only standing, I was only looking at the lid, and it was so quiet, and it was so kind, and while I stood there being quiet something was using my hands to put my husband to bed.

You have forty of these, the sergeant says. Forty-one now. He says it is the same every time, the crossed hands, the folded

pillow, the thumbs. He says it like it should help.

I do not want to be let go. I heard you talking about it at the door. I do not want to go back to Thimble Lane. Put me in the Rattlehouse. Put me in a lantern on a pole. Keep a Waker on me with the long needle every minute of every watch for the rest of my life, I will thank him for it, because the moment nobody is watching me I am going to blink again, and I have a sister, and she has two little ones, and they would let me in.

Write down that I loved him. Pinch me. Please. Somebody pinch me.



They will tell you the room is a dream. It is not a dream. A dream is something you have. The room is something that has you.

CORWIN HALF-BELL, THE ONLY TIME HE SPOKE OF IT, TO A WAKER WHO DID NOT WRITE IT DOWN

▼ THE MEAL

Before it was the Vigil, the plateau was called Ludmere, and before it was a city it was a bed.



Ludmere goose-down, softest on the Table. Twelve lacks the pillow. Sleep like a god.

PAINTED ON A PILGRIM'S TRADE-BOARD OF 290 A.G., KEPT FACE TO THE WALL IN THE CELLAR OF THE RATTLEHOUSE AS EVIDENCE OF SOMETHING

Iss, the Lidded, lay in a hollow on the high stone at the northeast corner of the Table, and it lay there for longer than anyone could count, asleep. Of all the Providers it was the only one no living person ever saw do anything. Ossel closed eyes; Ummer walked the fields; Dromm heaved under the sea. Iss slept. Its people built their houses around its sleeping, the way a village grows up around a well, and their whole religion was the art of being quiet near it. The old Ludmere word for a priest meant *one who walks softly*. Pilgrims came from every land to sleep within sight of it, because sleep near Iss was the deepest and kindest sleep on the Table, and the dreams that came with it were said to be true. The plateau was famous for soft beds and goose-down and oracles. It exported pillows.

Those who saw it described it as a long pale mass, larger than the cathedral that now stands in its place, shaped more like a drift of snow than a body, rising and falling with a breath so slow that you could watch a shadow cross half a field between one inhalation and the next. Its skin was grey-white and downy, and warm to the touch, and it smelled of clean linen, of a child's hair, of the inside of a blanket on a cold morning. Two great swellings at one end were taken to be its eyes, shut under lids the size of sails. No one had ever seen them open. The children of Ludmere were told that if Iss ever woke, everything that had ever been dreamed would have to be paid for.

In the ninth winter of the Long Lack the plateau was starving like everywhere else. The pillows had stopped selling. The goose-flocks had gone barren and then been eaten. People had begun to lie

down near the god on purpose, because sleep was the one thing left that did not cost bread, and many of them did not get up, though in those days that was only hunger. When word came across the Table that the other peoples were turning on their Providers, the walkers-softly of Ludmere held a council in whispers and decided they would do the same, and that they would do it without waking it.

That decision is the root of everything that followed, and the Vigil has never been able to leave it alone. Every other people on the Table killed a god that held still. Ludmere killed a god that was asleep. Whether it consented, whether it knew, whether it felt the knives, are questions that no one alive can answer, and the Vigil's priests have spent three centuries not asking them in public.



Every other people killed a god that held still. We killed one that trusted the dark.

FROM A WALKER-SOFTLY'S SERMON OF 339 A.G., TWO YEARS BEFORE THE FIRST NIGHT; BURNED IN 342, REMEMBERED ANYWAY

The butchering took nine nights, because it had to be done so slowly. The cutters wrapped their blades in felt. They wore no shoes. Children were stationed all around the hollow singing lullabies, in shifts, a low continuous murmur of a thousand small voices, because the walkers-softly believed that if the god heard singing it would think itself still safe. The song they sang is the one the Vigil now forbids, *The Lamb and the Lid*, and there are people in the city who will cross the street rather than hear the first three notes of it whistled.

THE LULLABY CHILDREN

The children who sang Iss down were four hundred and twelve in number, by the oldest tally, and the Vigil remembers them worse than it remembers anyone. They sang in shifts of forty for nine nights, and were given warm milk between shifts to keep their voices sweet, and when it was over every one of them slept for two days and woke hoarse and happy. Their families were paid in meat. Three hundred and forty years later, on the First Night, the old registers show that every living descendant of the four hundred and twelve went to the room in that first sleep, without exception: whole lines, cradle to grandmother, gone between the dusk lamps and the morning. The walkers-softly said the god had called its singers first, the way a child calls for whoever tucked it in. The Watch had the registers burned in 342 along with the beds. A copy survives in the Cutwrights' house on Regard Street, and beneath the last name a Cutwright has written in the margin: *It is said the lambs go first. It does not say where.*

The flesh of Iss was pale all the way through, the colour of cream, and it did not bleed so much as seep: a warm thin fluid, sweet and faintly salt, that smelled like breath on a pillow. The cutters said that it was like carving warm bread. Many of them fell asleep while they worked. They would be found curled against the flank of the god, their knives still in their hands, their faces slack and happy, and they would be shaken awake and set back to the cutting, yawning. Everyone yawned. That is the detail the old accounts can never stop repeating. The whole plateau yawned for nine nights. Jaws cracked; eyes streamed; people dozed standing in the queue for their portion and woke with their bowls full. The yawning spread down the slopes into the farms and up into the shepherds' huts where no one had seen the god at all.

On the ninth night they came to the eyes. The families who would become the Eye-lines had claimed them by lot, or by force, or by bribery; the accounts disagree, and the Eye-lines have had every version but their own burned. The lids would not open. Not with fingers, not with hooks, not with the blade. When the cutters tried to slit them, the skin of the lids parted and closed again behind the knife like water. In the end the eyes were taken out whole, with the lids still shut over them, two great warm globes in their sheaths of downy skin, and they were divided among nine households and eaten, by lamplight, in silence, still closed. The eaters said afterward that the meat tasted of nothing at all, and that every mouthful made them feel they had just put down something very heavy.

The nine households are still named, in the order of their portions, by the herald on the Lid's Eye landing every first bell: Stroud, Larch, Quell, Seldom, Anstey, Ormsby, Wendle, Carrow and Tallis. Carrow and Tallis are extinct. The Carrows went to the room entire on the First Night, in the years when the Eye-lines still had lids to close; the last Tallis, a lidded spare of forty whom nobody had married, walked through the Pillow fence in 455 in her best felt and was lifted out smiling, and her bed is the only one in the

Dormitory with a coat of arms on the rail. The order matters on the Height more than money does. Stroud ate first, from the outer corner of the right eye, and has ruled most often. Seldom ate last. What the Seldom were given, by every account, was the inner fold of the two lids where they met and sealed, the warm seam of the god's shutting, and the Seldom have not married out of their own house since.

The eaters were sick for a week afterward, not in the belly but in the eyes: they wept constantly, a thin warm fluid that smelled of the seep, and their tears dried on their cheeks in a fine white crust like salt that tasted, children said, of milk. The crust was scraped off and kept. A pinch of *lid-salt*, sealed in a locket, was the most precious keepsake in Ludmere for three hundred years, and was worn by brides; after 342 it was the first thing the Wakers searched for in a house, and the last of it is supposed to be in a casket under the Nodding Stair.



*It tasted of nothing, and I put down something heavy,
and I have not been able to find what it was.*

ATTRIBUTED TO ODO STROUD, FIRST OF THE
EATERS, IN THE OLDEST HEIGHT GENEALOGY

When the god was gone there was a long shallow pressed hollow in the stone, the shape of something that had lain there forever, and it was still warm. It is still warm now. The Vigil calls it the Pillow, and nothing has ever been built in it.

The next morning, the Lack was over. The crops on the plateau's lower terraces rose in a week. And the people of Ludmere slept that night as they had never slept, long and dreamless and sweet, all of them, every one, and they all woke up.

For three hundred and forty years after that they went on sleeping and waking like anybody. They dreamed a little too vividly. Their oracles grew rich. Their pillow-trade recovered. They told themselves they had got away with it, and in the oldest Ludmere hymnals, before the Waking Laws ordered them burned, there is a verse thanking Iss for being *the only god too kind to notice it was eaten.*



*Thank you, Lidded, for the long night and the soft
floor. Thank you for being too kind to notice.*

FROM THE LUDMERE EVENING OFFICE, BEFORE 342;
IT IS STILL A CRIME TO SAY IT ALOUD

WHAT THE EYE-LINES ATE

The Eye-lines say that they ate Iss's sight, and that this is why they are the most perceptive bloodline on the Table, and why they alone are fit to watch the city. The walkers-softly of the old priesthood, before they were suppressed, said something else: that what the Eye-lines swallowed was not the eyes but the lids. Iss's sight was never used. Its lids were the whole of its nature, the shutting, the resting, the turning away. That is what has been growing in the Eye-lines for six centuries. When their children are born without eyelids, it is not because the god's eyes have opened in them. It is because the god has taken its lids back.

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

Anyone who sleeps does not wake up.

Since the First Night of 341 A.G., every person who falls asleep in the Vigil goes to the same place. It is one shared dream, and everyone who has been there and come back for even a moment describes it the same way: a long room, dim, warm, low-ceilinged, without windows, lit from nowhere, and extending further than it should. The floor is soft. The air is the temperature of a body. Far down at the end of it, in the wall, there is a single enormous closed eye, its lid smooth and grey and faintly downy, larger than a house. It does not open. It does not need to. Standing in that room, the visitors say, is the most restful thing a person can feel. There is no fear in it at all. That is the horror.

Sleepers do not come back from the room. The body they leave behind lives on: it breathes, it is warm, its heart beats slow and steady, it does not age, it does not soil itself or starve or rot. It cannot be roused. Not by shaking, not by water, not by fire, not by the long needle driven under the nail. Its eyes, peeled open, are rolled back and wet. It is not dead, and it will not die of anything but violence, and it is not there.

So nobody sleeps. That is the whole of the law and the whole of the culture. An entire city-state, some four hundred thousand waking souls and sixty thousand sleeping ones, has stayed awake for three hundred years by statute, by drug, by pain and by each other. Exhaustion is not a condition here. It is the climate. A Vigilant does not speak of being tired any more than a fish speaks of being wet.



Do not tell me you are tired. Tell me which bell you were born at, and I will tell you how tired you are.

WARD-SERGEANT'S SAYING, LANTERNSIDE STATION

WHAT THE GOD ALLOWS

The plain fact that keeps the Vigil alive is that nobody dies of wakefulness. Elsewhere on the Table a person kept from sleep for ten days goes mad, and in a month is dead. In the Vigil the body endures it. The god in the blood keeps the heart beating and the lungs working however long the eyes stay open, a mercy or a leash. What the body cannot do is stop wanting to sleep. The pressure builds and does not break. It sits behind the eyes like a hand pressing down on the lids, heavier every hour, and it never, ever lifts. A Vigilant of fifty has been awake for fifty years, with no gap, no rest, no night, every hour of every day accumulated behind her face like silt. She is not dying of it. She is only drowning in it, a little deeper each year, while standing up.

What gives way is the mind. Sleep-starved people see things that are not there. They hear voices in the hiss of the lamps. They forget what they did a minute ago and remember things that never happened. They lose their tempers, weep at nothing, laugh at funerals, and come to believe that their spouses have been replaced by careful copies. The Vigil has lived inside this for three centuries, and it has done what every people on the Table does with an unbearable thing: it has made it into an institution. The hallucinations are called the Seeming, and when enough people see the same thing, it is news.

THE LONG WAKING

The god keeps the body going. Nothing keeps the mind. The Vigil's physicians, who are mostly Wakers with a Stitching certificate and a casebook, and a handful of Cutwrights on Regard Street who are not allowed to publish, have spent three centuries charting what a lifetime without sleep does to a person, and they divide it into ages the way the Cutwrights divide the Regrowth. It is not godsign. It is only what happens to a human head that has not been put down since it was four years old. The godsign comes on top of it, and the two are very hard to tell apart, and in the Vigil nobody tries very hard.

YEARS AWAKE	CALLED	WHAT IT BRINGS
1–10	The Bright Years	Faces in the plaster, voices in the lamps. Nearly every Slope child has a <i>lamp-friend</i> with a name.
10–20	The Grit	Words lost mid-sentence; rages; weeping at the bells; the first lost minutes.
20–30	The Doubling	The first Copies: a spouse, a parent, a child who seems a careful replica.
30–45	The Thinning	Lost hours at windows; the watch-selves; the sense of being already asleep.
45 and on	The Long Afternoon	A terrible calm, or a terrible quiet. The age at which most of the Lain-Down choose.

COPIES

Somewhere in the third decade of waking, most Vigilants begin to suspect that someone they love has been replaced. It is not a dramatic suspicion. It arrives as a small wrongness: the husband's laugh is a half-tone too high; the mother stirs her rouse the other way round; the daughter's hand, held, is the right hand at the right temperature and is not hers. The Vigil calls such a person a *Copy*, and the belief is so common that it has manners. A Vigilant who suspects a Copy performs *the Asking*: a question only the true person could answer, put casually, over the rouse. The Copy always answers correctly. Everyone knows the Copy always answers correctly. That is how you know.

Most Vigilants live with their Copies for decades, and are kind to them, and grieve the original quietly, in the Dormitory, at the foot of beds that have nothing to do with them, because a person who has been replaced must be asleep somewhere. Some cannot. The Standing Bench tries about forty *copy-killings* a year, in which a husband or a sister or a son has finally taken a knife to the thing wearing their beloved's face, to let the real one out, and has found under the skin only what is under everyone's skin, and has sat down in it and screamed. The Bench treats these as waking murder and sentences them to the Lantern, where the crowd, which has its own Copies at home, is often gentle with the pin.

From the casebook of Needle-Surgeon Ortolan Pease, the Felt House station, Bedside, Carving 639.

Subject: Wilhelmina Gaunt, forty-one, sheet-washer. Brought in by her son. States that her husband Abel has been replaced since Lack 637 by a man identical in every particular, who knows everything Abel knew, and who is kinder. She does not wish him harmed. She wishes to know where Abel has been put. She has visited every row in the general hall, two hundred beds a day, looking for him. When I asked how she would know him, she said: he will be the one who is not kind. Prescribed: a double dose and a sworn nudger. Note: the husband, interviewed, states that his wife was replaced in 636 by a woman who is less frightened than the real one, and asked me not to tell her. Neither knows the other has asked. I have not told either of them. They hold hands in the waiting yard.

THE ALREADY-COUNTED

The commonest delusion of the Thinning is that one is asleep. Not tired, not drifting: asleep, Counted, lying in a bed in the Dormitory with a number on the rail, and dreaming the whole of the waking city, the bells and the pins and the people one loves, from inside the room. The Already-Counted are calm. They see no point in rouse, since the body in the bed does not need it, and they stop eating, since the body in the bed is fed by the god. They pinch themselves constantly and watch the pinch with interest, as if waiting to see whether a dream-bruise will come up. Families on the Slope call it *going to look for your bed*, because sooner or later the Already-Counted go to the Dormitory, and walk the rows in visiting hour, looking at faces, and some of them come home white and quiet and will not say what they saw. The orderlies say that a few of them stopped at a bed, and stood a long time, and said *there I am*, and that the sleeper in the bed did look, in a certain light, very like them.



Pinch me. No, harder. I want to know which of us it hurts.

A WOMAN OF THE THINNING. TO HER DAUGHTER,
OVERHEARD AT THE VISITORS' GATE

BORROWED HANDS

A person who has blinked often enough comes to distrust their own body, and the hands first, because the hands are what come back from a blink having done something. The Vigil is full of people who do not believe their hands are theirs. They speak of them in the third person (*it took the cup, it will not stop shaking*), keep them bound in burr-cloth mittens when they are not working, and sleep, as the old phrase goes, with their hands in a box: Pinchmarket joiners sell *hand-wards*, small padded boxes that strap to the forearm and lock, so that a person can stand at a window through a long watch without fear of what their fingers might do. Spouses who love each other give each other the key. The widows of blink-murders keep theirs locked always, and wear the key around someone else's neck.

WATCH-SELVES

Over decades, the mind of a Vigilant does what a river does with a long obstacle: it divides and goes round. The Vigil calls the result a *watch-self*. A rope-twister of fifty may be one woman in the first

watch, brisk, devout and in debt to her sister, and another in the third, slower, crueller, in love with the Waker at the corner, who answers to her grandmother's name and does not know the sister's. Neither remembers the other's hours except as lost time. They share a body, a nudger and a bed-number in the family register, and very often they leave each other notes.

The Standing Bench recognises *shift-claims*: a debt contracted in the third watch may be refused by the first-watch self if it can be shown that the two do not share memory, and a marriage made by one self is binding on the others only if the vow, *pinch me*, was spoken in every watch. The Slope has a simpler custom. Each self writes its own name on the inside of the left wrist in lamp-black at the change of watch, and the nudger checks it before pinching, so that they know who they are pinching for.

A note in a woman's hand, found in the coat pocket of a rope-twister of Pinchbeck Steps, in the custody of the Lanternside station, unclaimed.

To the one who has the third watch. You have been spending my money on rouse-cakes from Rook's man and I know it because my mouth tastes of the sea when I come back. Stop it. You have also been going to the Dormitory in my hours and standing at bed 22,019 and I do not know who that is and the orderly says you call him love. I am married. I have been married for twenty-two years to Hal and he is a good man even if he is a Copy. I do not know what you want. I only want you to know that I am still here, in the first watch, and that I can feel you in the lost hours like a draught under a door, and that if you lie down in my body I will never forgive you. Signed in lamp-black on my wrist, as always. Marjory. P.S. The children like you better. They told me. I do not know what to do with that.

AT THE WINDOW

And there is the lost time that is not a blink. Every Ward Sergeant on the Lid has found them: a man standing at his window, upright, eyes open, pinching his own wrist in a slow steady rhythm, who turns when spoken to and asks what bell it is, and is told, and has lost a whole long watch. He did not sleep. His nudger swears he did not sleep. He was simply *at the window*, the Vigil's phrase, gone somewhere that is not the room and not the street, and he has come back eight bells older with nothing to show for it but the bruise on his wrist and the smell of clean linen in his clothes. The Hourkeeper believes that the hours at the window are where the lengthening hours are going. The Wakers believe it is malingering. The families of those it happens to have stopped asking where they were, because the answers they get are always the same, and always gentle, and always about a room.

GM ADVICE – RUNNING THE LONG WAKING

The Long Waking is the ordinary madness of the Vigil, and it belongs to everyone on the Lid, not only to characters who Break. Use it for texture first: an innkeeper who answers to two names, a guard with his hands in a locked box, a widow asking the party whether her husband seems real to them. Let the party's Vigilant characters and NPCs talk about Copies the way other people talk about the weather. When a character does Break in the Vigil, the Derangements of the core rules come out in local dress: *The Impostors* is a Copy, *Lost Time* is the Window, *Not My Hand* is the hand-ward, *The Gaslight* is the Registrar's office, and *The Dead Man* is the Already-Counted. Never treat any of it as a joke or a puzzle to be solved. These are people who have not rested since childhood, and every one of them is still trying, desperately, to be kind to the people they no longer recognise.

THE RULE FOLLOWS THE BLOOD

The first refugees of 342 A.G. fled the plateau by the thousand, certain that if they could only reach the border they could lie down safe. They walked for four days without rest down the old Pilgrim Road toward the Rim, and when they crossed the boundary stones they lay down in the heather, weeping with relief, and slept. Not one of them woke. They are still there. The stretch of road below the border stones is called the Sleepers' Mile, and the bodies lie along it in the grass, breathing, moss-furred, lichen-crustled, with the heather grown up through their clothes.

The rule follows the blood. Anyone born of the Vigil, anyone who carries Iss, goes to the room when they sleep, wherever on the Table they happen to close their eyes. The envoys the Vigil sends abroad travel with paid nudgers and chests of rouse. And the rule holds the land too: a foreigner who falls asleep within the Vigil's borders goes to the room exactly as a native would. Every Rim Road caravan bound for the plateau stops at the Last Beds, the Company inn below the border stones, so its drivers can sleep their fill before they climb. Those who misjudge the climb are delivered to the Dormitory and billed to their employers.

Whether the Unfed of the Fast, who carry no god, are subject to the room in the Vigil has never been tested. The Watch of Watches would very much like to test it.

THE COUNTED

The sleepers are not left where they fall. By law, every one is collected within a bell and carried to the Dormitory, a building the size of a city district, and laid in a numbered bed in a numbered row. There are sixty thousand beds. The sleepers are called the Counted, because in 401 A.G. a Dream-Diver came back from the room with a number: the number of sleepers at which the eye in the wall will open.

The number is a state secret. Only the Matron of the Dormitory now living knows it. The beds are nearly full. Everyone in the Vigil knows that the beds are nearly full, and everyone does the same arithmetic in the small hours of every watch, and nobody knows what the answer is, and the bells ring every quarter hour, and the lamps never go out, and the city goes on, pinching itself.



*One for the lamb and two for the lid, three for the bed
where the baker's girl hid; four for the sleeper and five
for the pin, six for the door that lets the number in.*

SLOPE SKIPPING-RHYME, BANNED IN 588 AND SUNG
EVER SINCE

GM ADVICE – RUNNING THE RULE

The rule of the Vigil is the simplest on the Table and the cruellest to play, because it attacks the one thing the players do without thinking. Every scene in the Vigil should carry a little weight on the eyelids. Describe warmth as a threat. Describe silence as a threat. Let a long, comfortable conversation by a fire become frightening simply because it is long and comfortable. Use the Weariness rules in Playing a Vigilant for every character in the city, native or foreign, and never let the players forget the bell. When the party rests, ask them who is watching whom, and how. When they plan an ambush that requires waiting, ask them how long. The horror of the Vigil is not a monster that comes for you. It is the room that waits for you to come to it, and it is endlessly, kindly patient.

▼ THE REGROWTH IN THE VIGIL

Iss is growing back, and what grows back is rest. Not the rest of a body that has worked and lies down; the rest of a thing that has been interrupted, and wants very badly to finish what it was doing. In the Vigil the Regrowth does not look like a monster. It looks like a person who is tired. That is what makes it so hard to see, and so easy to deny, in a city where everyone is tired.

THE TASTE

Heavy lids. A drag on the face, as though fine threads had been sewn through the eyelids and tied to something below the floor. The Taste is the commonest godsign in the Vigil, and most Scrapling families do not get much past it: a constant gritty sting behind the eyes, a slowness to focus, a habit of rubbing the face that leaves the skin under the eyes raw and purple. The sign everyone watches for is the yawn. A person in the Taste yawns too wide and too long, the jaw cracking, the eyes streaming, and the yawn goes through a room like a rumour: one person, then three, then the whole bench in the rouse-house, jaws stretching in a slow wave, each person fighting it and losing. Children in the Taste are called *heavy*. Mothers check them every morning by yawning at them across the table, and watching.



*Yawn at your child across the table every morning. If
she yawns back, love her harder. If she doesn't, love
her anyway.*

ADVICE OF A SLOPE MIDWIFE

The Taste carries a dream without sleep. Those in it sometimes see the long room in the corner of their eye, a dim warm doorway standing open where a wall should be, and catch the smell of clean linen in a street that stinks of lamp-smoke.

THE APPETITE

Blinks. A blink, in the Vigil, does not mean the shutting of an eye. It means a sleep of a second or two, taken on the feet, mid-step, mid-sentence, mid-meal, without warning and without consent. The head does not drop. The body does not fall. From the outside, the blinker simply pauses, as if listening, for a breath or two, and then goes on. From the inside, the blinker is in the long room with the eye for exactly as long as they are out, standing on the soft floor in the warm air, at peace, and then is torn back out of it gasping.

The trouble is that blinkers come back from the room having moved. They were at the window and now they are at the door. They were holding a cup and now the cup is in the fire. They were speaking to a friend and now the friend is staring at them with a white face and will not say what they just said. Most blinks are small: a lost sentence, a dropped stitch, a step taken. Some are not. The worst are the blink-murders, killings done by ordinary people in a sleep of two breaths, which they do not remember and could never have imagined, and which are always done the same way. The Appetite is the stage at which a person in the Vigil stops being trusted, even by themselves.

Every Vigilant in the Appetite keeps, or is kept in, a *blink-book*: a little stitched ledger of rag paper, carried by the nudger, in which each blink is entered with the bell, the length as best the nudger can count it, and what the blinker did. The books are legal documents. A Ward Sergeant who stops a citizen in the street may demand their blink-book, and a book with too many entries in a watch is grounds for a night in the Rattlehouse, for the citizen's own good. The books are also, everyone knows, the most intimate things a Vigilant owns, more private than letters: a record of every moment one was not oneself, written down by the person who loves you most, in their handwriting, because you could not.

From the blink-book of Ansel Pinchbeck, wick-braider, of Tallow Hollow, in the hand of his wife Gerd, Lack 640.

Third bell. Two breaths. Dropped the wick. Nothing.

Third bell and a pinch. One breath. Said Mother to the lamp.

Fifth bell. Four breaths. Walked to the door and put his hand flat on it and stood. I pinched him back. He said he was listening for someone.

Ninth bell. Six breaths, near seven. Took the bread knife out of the crock and laid it on the table, very straight, with the handle toward me. Nothing else. He does not remember. I have put the knife in the well-bucket.

Ninth bell and a pinch. One breath. Smiled.

Twelfth bell. Did not blink. Asked me whether I was sure I was Gerd. I said yes. He said, that is what she would say.

Fourteenth bell. Three breaths. Hummed. I will not write what.

Sixteenth bell. Long. I counted twenty-two. He crossed my hands on my chest. I was standing up. I let him. I do not know why I let him. When he came back he looked at my hands and started to cry and I am writing this with them so they are mine.

Those in the Appetite also hunger for comfort, which in the Vigil is a perversion. They stroke fabric. They stand too long near stoves. They are caught pressing their cheeks against warm walls with their eyes half shut and a look on their faces that respectable people find obscene. Rouse-house slang for this is *nuzzling*, and it is grounds for divorce.



I caught him with his face against the bakehouse wall, eyes half shut, like a cat. I'd sooner have caught him with a whore. At least I'd know what to do.

A LUDMERE WIFE, PETITIONING FOR DIVORCE ON
GROUNDS OF NUZZLING, 638

THE COURSE

The lids thin, shrink, and are gone. It happens over months: first a translucence, so that the iris shows through the shut lid as a dark smudge; then a shrinking, the lids drawing back like a burnt page curling from its edges; then a soft raw rim of pink where they were, and the eye beneath it wide, staring, naked, permanently open. The eyes of the lidless must be wetted by hand every half minute or they cloud and crack. The poor use rag and a pot of water. The rich keep attendants with sable brushes and silver bowls of rosewater warmed to blood heat. The lidless cannot close their eyes to weep, to wince,

to blink against smoke or wind or a blow. They see everything that happens in front of them, and they forget none of it. Their memories become perfect and unbearable.

The Eye-line nobility are born this way, and call it purity. Their children come into the world staring, and the midwives of the Height do not slap them to make them cry, but to make them look away; none of them can. The Lidless Succession of 480 A.G. made the Course a qualification for rule, on the reasoning that a person who cannot shut their eyes cannot fall asleep. No lidless person in the Vigil has ever been Counted. No one has thought hard about why, except the walkers-softly, who are no longer permitted to think aloud.



A lidded child is a sorrow. A lidded heir is a scandal. A lidded Warden is the end of the world.

HEIGHT PROVERB, NEVER SAID WITHIN EARSHOT OF
THE STAIR'S UPPER LANDING

THE BRINK

Before the Seating comes the long dreadful plateau that the Vigil's physicians call the Brink and its poor call *going grey*. The lidless at the Brink do not blink at all, but they begin to *be* somewhere else while they stand among the living: their gaze fixes on a point a great distance behind the wall, their breathing slows to the rhythm of the Dormitory, and anyone who stands near them begins to yawn and cannot stop. People in the Brink can put others down. Not by any act; by being near, by looking, by speaking softly. They are dangerous to love. The Watch keeps a ward for them under the Nodding Stair, and the attendants who work there wear wax in their ears and wire across their eyelids, and are rotated every hour.

The families of those going grey are the most frightened people in the city and the most ashamed. A person at the Brink cannot be left at home, because the household will go down around them one by one, peacefully, in their chairs. They cannot be sent to the ward under the Nodding Stair unless the family can pay the ward-fee, which is forty lacks a season, or knows a Watcher. And they cannot be Counted, because they do not sleep. What the Slope does with its grey ones, when it cannot pay, is not written in any ledger of the Watch, and is told under Closing the Ring, below.

THE SEATING

A sleeper who begins to move. Lips first.

For three hundred years the Counted have lain utterly still. In the last ten years, a handful in the oldest rows have begun to stir. A finger curls. A head turns, by degrees, over weeks, until the face looks along the row toward the next bed. The lips part and shape words that make no sound. A sleeper in the Seating is the god, partly returned, wearing a body it took into its room and has been

patiently furnishing from the inside. The Vigil does not use the word Seating. The Dormitory's orderlies call such a sleeper *restless*, the way a nurse speaks of a feverish child, and they do not like to turn their backs on one.

The worst thing about the moving sleepers is that their faces are happy.



I've changed sheets for twenty years. You don't mind the breathing after a while. You mind when one of them looks at you. You mind when it's glad.

AN ORDERLY OF THE EAST WING, TO HER REPLACEMENT

WHAT IS RESTLESS IN THE ROWS

As of Carving 641, the Matron's private register lists nineteen restless sleepers. Bed One, Aveline Morne, moves her lips in shapes the Matron writes down. Bed 40,112, the son of Odile Farthing, has grown from a boy of four to the size of a man in eleven years, and smiles. Bed 7,730 has turned its head toward the Dormitory's east door and holds it there; the orderlies have moved the door. Beds 212 through 219, eight members of one family who lay down together on the First Night, have begun, over the course of a year, to reach toward each other across the gaps between their beds. Their fingertips now nearly touch. The Matron has measured the distance. She has not separated the beds, because she does not know what will happen if she does, and she does not know what will happen if she does not.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

The Vigil sits on a high bare plateau of grey stone at the northeast of the Table, a great tilted table-top of rock that rises out of the eastern plain in sheer cliffs on three sides and slopes down, on the fourth, toward the Rim Road and the soft bad country of heather and stream that leads to it. The plateau is called the Lid. It is windy, cold at the edges, warm in the middle, almost treeless, and covered from one end to the other by a single city.

That city is never dark. There are ten thousand public lamps on its streets, and a hundred thousand more in its houses, and in its squares burn great open iron furnaces, the Bonfires, tended day and night by the Lamplighters' Guild. Every roof carries mirrors, angled to catch the furnace-glow and throw it back down into the lanes, so that the light comes from every direction at once and there are no shadows anywhere a person could close their eyes in. There has been no night on the Lid for three centuries. The smoke of all those lamps hangs over the plateau in a permanent brown ceiling, lit from beneath, glowing a dull bruised orange, so that from the Rim Road the Vigil looks like a coal left burning in an empty grate. Nobody born in the Vigil has ever seen a star. Some of the children do not believe in them.

The city stinks of lamp-oil, hot tin, scorched wick, rouse-grounds and sweat. Its sounds are clatter, bells, rattles, the shouts of nudgers, the barking of the dogs that are bred and paid to bark, and under everything the hiss and flutter of a hundred thousand flames.



Nobody born in the Vigil has ever seen a star. My grandmother said they were holes in a lid, and the light behind them was the room. I have never wanted to see one.

A MIRROR-CLIMBER OF THE GUILD, SECOND RANK

THE WEATHER OF COMFORT

The danger here is comfort. Other lands fear storms. The Vigil fears a nice day.

The warm wind off the eastern plain is called the Yawn. It comes up over the cliffs in late Plenty and early Carving smelling faintly of hay and sun-warmed stone, soft as a hand on the back of the neck, and on Yawn days the Wakers double their patrols, the bells ring every eighth of an hour instead of every quarter, and the Glass House fills. Rain on a roof is so soothing that the Vigil's roofs are built of loose overlapping tin so that rain will clatter, bang and scrape on them instead of patter. Snow is a horror: the hush of it, the softness, the way it muffles the bells. During snowfall, the Watch orders every householder to bang a pot at their door for one minute in every ten.

The worst weather of all is a mild, quiet, overcast afternoon, windless, grey, the light all the same colour, the sounds of the city flattening out under the cloud. The city records those days in its annals as disasters, with a death toll. The Grey Ninth of Carving 588 put eleven hundred people into the Dormitory between the fourth bell and the dusk lamps, and is commemorated every year with a day of compulsory shouting.

WEATHER-BOARD AT THE LUDMERE BONFIRE

Chalked every bell by the Watch's weather-clerk on a black board twelve feet high, under a tin hood; a typical board of Carving 641, copied by a Rim Road factor who could not believe it.

FOURTH BELL. Wind: north-west, cold, good. Cloud: broken. Rain: none. Danger: LOW. Pinch as usual.

SEVENTH BELL. Wind: falling. Cloud: closing. Light: going even. Danger: RISING. Bells at the eighth. Householders to the shutters.

NINTH BELL. Wind: NONE. Cloud: grey, unbroken. Light: milk. Danger: GREY AFTERNOON. Shouting at every quarter. Children indoors and watched in pairs. Do not sit. Do not bum. Do not look at the sky for long.

TENTH BELL. Carts called to Thimble, Lanternside, Gutter Lane. Count so far: 41.

THE SEASONS

Grace brings cold winds off the cliffs, which the Vigil loves: it is the healthiest season, and the Dormitory takes fewest in it. Plenty is long and warm and dangerous; the Yawn blows, and the poor suffer most in their close hot rooms on the Slope. Carving is the season of grey afternoons and the worst losses of the year. Lack brings snow, early dark the city refuses to acknowledge, and Tablenight, the one minute in all the year when the lamps go out.

A GAZETTEER OF THE VIGIL

THE DORMITORY

A building the size of a district, on the lower south side of the Lid, where the plateau begins to slope. It was begun in 342 A.G. as a single converted granary and has been extended, wing by wing and storey by storey, for three hundred years, until it is the largest roofed space on the Table. Inside, it is one hall after another, low-ceilinged and lamplit, and in each hall the beds stand in rows, iron-framed, narrow, white-sheeted, numbered in black paint on the foot-rail. Sixty thousand of them. Every one but fewer than two thousand is occupied.

RECEIVING SLIP OF THE DORMITORY

Every Counted sleeper is entered on a slip of stiff grey card, one half kept at the Receiving Gate, the other half given to the family; the family's half is the only proof that their person exists. A typical slip reads, in printed type with the blanks inked in:

THE DORMITORY OF THE VIGIL. RECEIVED this day, the 14th of Carving, 641, at the 9th bell, ONE SLEEPER, being: Name, Bertil Owe. Age, 37. Trade, carter. Brought by, Waker Patrol, Gutter Lane. Found, standing, at his horse's head, eyes closed. Nudger at the time, Wife (fined). Fetching attempted: Needle, all points, by Needle Hesk. Breathing on receipt: in time. Countenance: content. ASSIGNED: Hall Nineteen, Row 4, BED 58,442. Bed-Due owing: 1 lack per season, in perpetuity. Visiting bell: the 17th. THE COUNT IS KEPT.

It is completely silent. The orderlies wear felt slippers, as the walkers-softly once did. No bell is rung inside. And in that silence, the one sound is the breathing. The Counted all breathe in time. Sixty thousand chests rise and fall together, slow, deep, regular, perhaps four breaths to the minute, and the air in the halls moves with them like a tide: a long warm sigh drawn in through the doors, a long warm sigh pushed out. Standing in the central hall is like standing in the lung of an enormous animal. The lamps flicker in rhythm. New orderlies find that within an hour their own breathing has slowed to match, and they must be taken outside and slapped.

◇
Received this bell from the Slope carts: eleven. Washed, sheeted, numbered, laid. Breathing in time by the half-bell. Smiling: all.

THE RECEIVING GATE DAY-BOOK, GREY NINTH OF CARVING 588, THE FIRST OF FORTY-THREE SUCH ENTRIES THAT AFTERNOON

The building smells of clean linen and of skin, the sweetish smell of bodies that do not sweat and do not age. Dust does not settle on the Counted. The orderlies change the sheets anyway, every Plate, because someone must do something.

THE NODDING STAIR

The council hall of the Watch of Watches, at the summit of the Height, the highest district of the city. It is a single staircase, broad as a road, which spirals up through a hollow tower of grey stone and never arrives anywhere, its top steps returning by a hidden ramp to its bottom, so that the council climbs forever. Its architect, Benedikt Lour, designed it so that no one could sit comfortably, lean comfortably or stand still comfortably; the steps are of uneven height and slant subtly outward. The Watch has sat in session on the Stair, in shifts, for two hundred years without adjourning. Its members are always climbing. Debate is conducted on the move; motions are carried by those still breathing hard enough to say aye.

The Warden-Prime alone stands still, on a landing halfway up called the Lid's Eye, and the whole council passes before her once every quarter hour.

LAMPWRIGHTS' ROW

The brightest street in the world. It runs along the spine of the Lid between the Height and the Slope, and on both sides of it are the workshops where the city's mirrors are silvered, its lenses ground, its burners cast, its wicks braided and its lamp-glass blown. Every shopfront is a display of lit lamps, and every roof a forest of polished mirrors, so that the Row is lit from above and below and every side at once and a walker there casts no shadow at all. Visitors from other lands are blinded for the first hour and get headaches for a week. The Vigil's rich take their constitutionals there, squinting with pleasure, and courting couples walk it arm in arm, pinching. The dead of the city are burned in the Row's great furnaces, and their light goes out into its lamps. *She's on the Row now* is how a Vigilant says that someone has died.



*She's on the Row now. Go and stand under her lamp,
love. She'll keep you up.*

WHAT IS SAID TO THE NEWLY BEREAVED

THE GLASS HOUSE

A quarantine for contagious yawners, on a bare spur of rock at the windward edge of the Lid where the cold winds hit hardest. It is a long greenhouse of thick green glass in iron frames, divided into cells, each lit from outside by its own lamp. The yawners inside are masked in stiff leather muzzles that hold the jaw half closed. Visitors speak to them through speaking-tubes and are forbidden to look at their faces. The Glass House is the most frightening building in the city to people who have never been inside it and the saddest to people who have.



*I'm sorry. I'm sorry. Please don't look at my mouth.
I'm sorry.*

LUKAS MARRE, THROUGH THE SPEAKING-TUBE, TO
EVERY VISITOR, EVERY TIME

THE SLOPE

The slum quarter, sprawling down the south side of the Lid below the Dormitory, built of tin, plank and rope in steep lanes too narrow for the Wakers' carts. Rouse is cut thin here, with chalk, ash, brine and worse. Nudgers are cheap and are mostly children. The lamps are fewer and dimmer, the oil is bad, and the Bonfires are fed with dung and rags. Whole families go down in an afternoon, one after another, the last one awake moving from body to body slapping and screaming until they too go quiet. When the

Dormitory carts come down the Slope, the people come out to watch, and to count.



*Thimble Lane, two children down, a grandmother and
an aunt. Lanternside, nine. Gutter Lane, the whole of
number four. That's this afternoon. Pass it on.*

THE SLOPE'S CART-COUNT, SHOUTED FROM ROOF
TO ROOF ON A GREY DAY

THE PILLOW

The hollow where Iss lay, at the exact centre of the Lid. It is a long shallow depression in the bedrock, a quarter mile from end to end, smoothly curved, shaped like the impression of something enormous that lay on its side with its knees drawn up. Nothing has ever been built in it. The stone is warm to the touch in every season and faintly soft, like a cushion with the stuffing settled. Snow melts there. Yawners who stand at its rim begin to weep. The Watch has fenced it with iron spikes and lamps on poles, and the Wakers who guard it work in pairs and are relieved every bell. It is a capital crime to lie down in the Pillow. It is not a crime that is ever tried, because those who commit it are never available for trial; they are lifted out by orderlies with hooked poles and carried straight to the Dormitory, smiling.



*It is a capital crime to lie down in the Pillow. We have
never hanged anyone for it. We have never needed to.*

CAPTAIN BRANNOCH PYRE, TO A VISITING OATHEN
JURIST

THE RATTLEHOUSE

The Wakers' central prison and school, a squat octagon of black brick at the foot of the Height. It is the loudest building in the Vigil. Its cells are lined with tin and hung with chimes; its corridors are patrolled by Wakers with rattles who shake them every few breaths; its prisoners are kept on their feet in standing-stalls with iron collars at the throat. Here the Wakers learn their needlework, and here the city's criminals serve their sentences, which are measured not in years but in wakefulness. A prisoner in the Rattlehouse is kept awake by the state, not by themselves, and that is the punishment: to be held in the hands of an institution that does not care whether it hurts you, only that you do not close your eyes.



Thank you. Thank you. Thank you.

CHALKED BY PRISONERS ON THE WALLS OF EVERY
STANDING-STALL IN THE RATTLEHOUSE, THE
OLDEST MARKS FOUR CENTURIES DEEP IN THE TIN

THE BITTERHOUSE

The state rouse-works, a sprawling complex of copper stills, roasting-ovens, drying-sheds and grinding-mills on the north side of the Lid, where the Apothecary-General's chemists make the city's stimulant. The air for half a mile downwind tastes of burnt sugar and iron and makes the teeth ache. The Bitterhouse workers are the most alert people in the Vigil and the shortest-lived, their teeth black stumps by twenty-five, their hearts giving out by forty. Under the Bitterhouse are the Proving Rooms, where new strains are tested on prisoners lent from the Rattlehouse, and where Dr. Aldous Crane keeps the curve he will not publish.

THE PINCHMARKET

The city's perpetual market, filling three squares and the lanes between them below Lampwrights' Row, open every hour of every watch for three hundred years. Rouse is sold here in every grade, from the Bitterhouse's sealed black cakes to Slope sweepings in twists of paper. So are pins, burr-cloth, bells, rattles, ice, smelling-salts, and nudgers. The nudger-stands are at the market's eastern end: children and old women and out-of-work Wakers sitting on stools beneath painted boards giving their rates by the bell. The most expensive nudgers advertise their own wakefulness: *Not One Blink In Nine Years* or *Witnessed Lidless, Sworn by the Watch*.

THE TETHER HALL

The Dream-Divers' house, a domed rotunda beside the Dormitory with a single bed at its centre under a great brass winch. Divers lie down on the bed in harness, wired at the wrists, ankles and throat to the winch and to a team of eight hauliers, and go to sleep on purpose. When the bell is struck, the hauliers drag them back. The method is a secret of the Hall, but it involves the harness, a great deal of pain, and something done to the diver's tongue. The floor around the bed is scarred with the heel-marks of three centuries of hauliers bracing. Many dives do not come back. The bodies of those who stay are laid in the Dormitory under their own row, the Divers' Row, and their harnesses are hung above the beds.

THE PENDULUM HALL

The house of the city's clocks, a tall narrow tower of grey stone in the Height where the Hourkeeper sets the time for the bells. Inside it, from the top of the tower to the cellar, hangs a single pendulum, a great iron bob on a rope of twisted wire, swinging through a slow arc that once took exactly four seconds. Around the walls, two hundred and forty smaller clocks tick in their cases. The tower

hums. Those who stand inside it long enough begin to feel, under the ticking, a slowness, as if the beats were drifting a little further apart.



*Four seconds, a beat, in 401. Four and a hair in 600.
Four and a breath this Plate. I measure it. I do not
imagine it. I measure it.*

NOTE IN THE MARGIN OF A BELL-SCHEDULE, IN
MAUD SEXTON'S HAND

THE LAST BEDS

The Rim Road Company inn below the border stones, at the foot of the Pilgrim Road where it leaves the Rim. It is the last place a foreigner may safely sleep before the climb, and the Company sells that sleep dearly. Its long wooden halls are full of beds, the only beds within thirty miles of the Vigil, and Vigilant travellers coming down from the plateau on Company business will pay to stand at the doorway of the sleeping-hall and look at them. Some weep. Some have tried to lie down and been dragged out by the Company's porters, who are paid by the Watch for each one they save. The innkeeper keeps a book of those they did not.

THE SLEEPERS' MILE

Below the border stones, along the old Pilgrim Road, lie the refugees of 342 A.G., who fled the plateau to sleep beyond its borders and found that the rule followed them. There are about four thousand of them, scattered along a mile of road and heather. They still breathe. They are grown over: moss in the hair, lichen on the cheeks, heather pushing up through the rotted rags of their clothes, the bones of their faces showing through skin that has been rained on for three hundred years and has not aged a day. Pilgrims and Rim Road drovers pass them with their eyes averted. Children from the caravans dare each other to touch one. The Watch has never brought them in: there are not enough beds, and they do not count. Or so the Watch hopes.



*Don't wake them, Hob. They walked four days to lie
down. Let them have it.*

CROOKHEATHER SHEPHERDS' SAYING, AT THE
SHEARING OF THE MILE

▼ HISTORY

*We were the softest people on the Table. Remember that, when you look at what we have
become.*

— INSCRIPTION ON THE BASE OF THE BONFIRE IN LUDMERE SQUARE

YEAR	EVENT
before 0 A.G.	Ludmere: the city of soft beds, oracles and pilgrims, grown up around the sleeping Iss.
0 A.G.	The Nine Nights. Iss is butchered without waking, to lullabies. The Eye-lines eat its shut eyes.
0–340	The Easy Centuries. Ludmere sleeps like anyone, dreams too vividly, and grows rich on oracles.
288	The Dreamers' Fair at its height; oracles report a long room in their visions, and are laughed at.
341	The First Night. A third of the city does not get up. By the third morning, half.
342	The Waking Laws. Beds burned; sleep outlawed; the city renamed. The flight down the Sleepers' Mile.
342	The Dormitory founded in the old Corn Granary. The first Wakers sworn.
343	The Compact of the Nine Households with the first Matron. The first Reminding, on the Day of Nine Nights.
390	The Rouse Patent. A stimulant that holds.
401	The Count. A Dream-Diver returns with the number, says it once, and is laid in a bed.
441	The Watch of Watches convenes on the Nodding Stair. It has not adjourned.
455	The last Tallis walks into the Pillow. Her house is struck from the herald's roll.
480	The Lidless Succession. Only the lidless may rule.
503	The Giving of Lids. Two hundred and fourteen lidded spares of the Eye-lines are unlidded in Ludmere Square, and the lids laid in the Pillow.
504	The Lid-Winter. Two thousand nine hundred Counted, the worst year to that date since the First Night.
533	The Market Yawn. Lukas Marre's grandmother puts down four hundred in the Pinchmarket. The Glass House is built.
588	The Grey Ninth. Eleven hundred Counted in one afternoon.
590	Bedding suspended as a capital sentence, for want of beds.
622	Matron Hesketh Anstey dies and passes the number. Ansgar Wakely, Bedded Shepherd, condemned to Bedding that cannot be carried out.
629	The Seeming is first formally entered into the public record as news.
631	The first restless sleeper is logged. The entry is struck from the register.
640	The Gallow Street Lying-Down: twenty-three in one street in one month of Plenty.
640	Rouse fails by the hour. The Hourkeeper's first report on the lengthening of hours is suppressed.
641	Fewer than two thousand empty beds. Bed One begins to move her lips. Envoy Dray goes north.

THE FIRST NIGHT

It came on the third night of Grace, 341 A.G., which had been a warm and pleasant evening. There was no sign. Ludmere went to bed. In the morning, roughly a third of it did not get up: they lay in their beds breathing slow and even, smiling, and no amount of shaking would rouse them. Their families screamed in the streets. The physicians were sent for and could not wake them. By the next night the city understood only that a sickness had come; and most of it, exhausted with weeping and fear, went to bed. In the morning, half of what remained did not wake.

Those who survived the third night were the ones too frightened to lie down: the anxious, the guilty, the insomniac, the mad, the nursing mothers, the drunks, the watchmen, the children too hungry to sleep. They sat up through the dark in kitchens together, slapping each other, shouting, banging pans, holding hands and

squeezing until the knuckles cracked. Those people are the ancestors of the Vigil. The city descends, by a kind of hideous selection, from its worst sleepers. Vigilants say it with pride.

THE WAKING LAWS AND THE BURNING OF THE BEDS

In the spring of 342 the survivors met in the old Ludmere Square and passed the Waking Laws by acclamation. Lying down was forbidden. Closing the eyes for longer than a breath was forbidden. Every bed, couch, mattress, pillow and cushion on the plateau was carried into the squares and burned, along with the goose-down warehouses, the oracles' dream-books, and the dreamers themselves when they protested. The pyres burned for a month; they were the first Bonfires. The city took its new name from a word the old priests had used for the night before a feast: *the vigil*. It was meant to sound temporary.

◇

*We burned eleven thousand beds in Ludmere Square,
and the down went up in a white cloud and came
down on the city like snow, and it was so soft, and we
were so tired, and we stood in it and screamed.*

FROM THE TESTAMENT OF WENNA CORL, A
SURVIVOR OF THE FIRST NIGHT, AS READ AT THE
SHOUTING DAY

THE COUNT

In 401 a diver named Iselde Marrow, on her eleventh descent, walked further into the long room than anyone had and stood for a long while near the eye. When she was hauled back, half-dead with pain, she said she had heard the number. It had been told to her, she said, very gently, as if by a mother explaining to a child how many more days until a holiday. She was brought before three officials of the Watch, in a sealed room, and made to say it once. Then the officials agreed that the number was too dangerous to leave in a living head, and they had her laid down in a bed. Her bed was the next one in the row. Two of the three officials were dead within the decade, by accident; the third was the first Matron of the Dormitory, and the number has passed from Matron to Matron since, whispered once at the bedside of the dying.

THE GIVING OF LIDS

The Vigil has only once tried to pay the god back, and it does not like to remember the bill.

In the winter of 502 a Dream-Diver named Hollis Wren came up off the tether on his ninth descent with blood running from his tongue-ring and a message. He had stood, he said, closer to the eye than anyone since Iselde Marrow, and he had understood something, not in words: that the eye was not angry at being eaten, and that it did not want its flesh back, or its sight. It wanted its lids. The Eye-lines had taken the god's shutting into their blood, and the god could not rest properly without it, and so it was taking rest from the city instead, one sleeper at a time. Give back the lids, said Hollis Wren, and the eye will close properly, and the Counted will stop counting.

The Watch of Watches debated it on the Stair for one hundred and nine days, which in a council that never adjourns is a very long time. The difficulty was obvious to everyone. The lidless had no lids to give, and could not be asked. But every Eye-line house had its *spares*: the younger sons and daughters born with ordinary lids, kept out of the succession and out of sight, educated, idle, married off to Slope merchants for their dowries or not married at all. There were two hundred and fourteen adult spares on the Height that winter. The Watch voted, by a margin of eleven lidless voices, that the spares would give their lids for the city. It was called an honour. Several of them were told it would make them eligible for the Stair.

The Giving was done in Ludmere Square on the first day of Grace, 503, in front of the Bonfire, in front of the whole city. The Cutwrights' College sent nine surgeons. The spares stood in a line in white felt, with their heads held from behind in padded frames, and were given poppy, which was the first poppy permitted on the Lid in a hundred and sixty years, and which several of them were afterwards said to have wept for joy at. Each pair of lids, as it came away, was laid on a square of goose-down, the last down on the Lid, released from the evidence-vaults of the Rattlehouse for the occasion, and the down was sewn shut over them, and the little packets were laid one by one in a silver casket lined with grey felt that the city called *the Coverlet*. The crowd was silent. The only sound, the accounts agree, was the Cutwrights' instruments, and the hiss of the Bonfire, and, from the two hundred and fourteen, after each one, a small astonished noise: the sound of a person who has just discovered they can no longer close their eyes.

The Coverlet was carried barefoot to the Pillow and laid in the exact centre of the hollow, where the god's head had been, by the Warden-Prime's own hands. The fence was locked. The city went home and waited.

That winter, the Lid-Winter of 504, two thousand nine hundred people went to the room, more than in any year since the First Night to that date. The spares, newly lidless, could not be taught in time to live with it: they had no eye-wetters, because no one had thought to train any, and forty of them were blind by Carving, their eyes clouded white and cracked like glazed pots left in a kiln. Eleven of the rest climbed the Stair to claim their votes and were turned back at the first landing, because they had been *made* lidless and not born so, which the Watch decided was a different thing. Not one of the two hundred and fourteen was ever Counted. That, the Eye-lines said, proved the Giving had worked, for them.

In the spring of 504 the Pillow-wardens reported that the Coverlet had moved. When the fence was opened, the casket was found sunk an inch into the warm stone, as a stone sinks into a cushion, and its lid would not open, and when the Cutwrights forced it, the down was gone and the two hundred and fourteen packets were gone, and in their place, filling the casket edge to edge, was a single folded sheet of soft grey skin, faintly furred, warm, damp at the edges, with a long seam down its middle, closed. It was breathing. Slowly. Four times to the minute.

The Coverlet was carried out of the Pillow at night and has been kept since in a locked room under the Nodding Stair, in its casket, in the dark, which is the only dark on the Lid. The room's door is barred from the outside. A Watcher of the Lid's Eye rank holds the key, and every new Warden-Prime is taken down once, alone, to look. Ilvane Stroud went down in 612, at twenty-nine, on the night of her election, and stood with the lamp held up for the count of a hundred, and came up the stairs again, and was heard by her eye-wetters to say only one thing, which they remember because she said it twice, which she never does: *It has got bigger*.

From the Order of the Watch of Watches, the hundred and ninth day of the debate, Lack 502, as entered in the Stair-Book.

RESOLVED, that whereas the Lidded is said by the Tether Hall to desire the return of its shutting; and whereas the Houses of the Nine have each a portion of that shutting in the persons of their unpromoted children; it is ORDERED that every person of Eye-line blood, being of age and bearing lids, shall give the same to the city on the first day of Grace next, for the good of all and the end of the Count, and shall be honoured. House Seldom, being without lidded issue, is excused. It is FURTHER ORDERED that this resolution shall not be read aloud at the Bonfires, and that the word sacrifice shall not be used in connection with it, the proper term being the Giving. Carried, 141 to 130. The Warden-Prime abstaining, being lidless and therefore unable to look away from the question.

◇
*I gave my lids for the city and the city gave me
nothing to close.*

SCRATCHED ON THE WALL OF THE LID'S EYE
LANDING BY OTTOLINE QUELL, A GIVER, BLIND BY
CARVING 503

GM ADVICE – WHAT IS THE NUMBER?

The number is a state secret, and the book does not fix it. Choose one of these, or write your own. (1) The number is 60,001. The Dormitory was built to hold exactly one fewer, by a Matron who thought she could stop it with carpentry. (2) The number is the population of Ludmere on the Nine Nights, every man, woman and child who ate of Iss. The god is calling its table back. (3) The number has already been passed. Iselde Marrow lied, or was lied to. The eye began to open years ago, very slowly, and what the Hourkeeper is measuring is the lid going up. (4) There is no number. The Watch invented it in 401 to give the city something to fear that was not the truth, which is that the eye will open when it is ready. Whatever you choose, the Matron should believe it absolutely.

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

The Vigil is governed by the Watch of Watches, a council of some three hundred Eye-line nobles who sit, or rather climb, in three shifts around the clock on the Nodding Stair. It has not adjourned in two hundred years. Its members are lidless by law, attended by eye-wetters, and watched by one another, since in the Vigil the oldest political truth is that anyone may blink. At its head is the Warden-Prime, always an Eye-line, always lidless, watched in turn by attendants who wet the royal eyes with a brush every half minute.

Beneath the Watch sit the Offices: the Apothecary-General (rouse), the Lamplighter-General (oil and light), the Hourkeeper (time and bells), the Matron (the Dormitory), the Registrar of the Seeming (the public record), and the Captaincy of the Wakers (everything else).

THE LAW OF THE LID

The law is simple. Lying down is a crime. Closing your eyes for longer than a breath is a crime. Letting someone near you nod off is negligence, punishable as manslaughter if they go down. Selling sleep is a crime. Singing *The Lamb and the Lid* is a crime. Possession of down, feathers, wool batting or any soft stuffing in a quantity greater than will fill a shoe is a crime. Speaking of the room in a soothing manner is incitement.

The police, the Wakers, carry rattles and long needles, and they are entitled to needle any citizen who appears drowsy, without

warrant and without apology. A citizen who objects to being needled is presumed to be drowsy.

◇
*A citizen who objects to being needled is presumed to
be drowsy. A citizen who thanks you is presumed to be
awake. Act accordingly.*

STANDING ORDER NINE OF THE CAPTAINCY,
FRAMED IN EVERY STATION

Punishment is wakefulness. Minor offenders are sentenced to hours at the Rattlehouse, kept on their feet by Wakers with needles. Serious offenders are sentenced to the Lantern: an iron cage hung from a pole in a public square, open on every side, lit by its own lamp, in which the condemned is kept awake by any passing citizen with a pin, for as long as the sentence runs. Long sentences in the Lantern produce Seeming so violent that the condemned believe they are being eaten by the crowd, and sometimes the crowd believes it too.

Until 590 the capital sentence was Bedding. The condemned were led to the Dormitory in a white gown, given warm milk and poppy, laid in a bed and allowed to sleep, while a crowd outside sang the forbidden lullaby, the one day in the year it was permitted. It was considered the most merciful execution on the Table, and envied. It was suspended when the Matron reported that beds were

scarce. Since then, the worst criminals have been held in the Rattlehouse awaiting a sentence that cannot be carried out, and the Rattlehouse is very full.

THE LOWER FLOORS

The Rattlehouse has nine storeys, and four of them are above ground. The upper floors are the ones the city knows: the standing-stalls, the chimes, the classrooms where recruits learn the Atlas on each other. The lower five belong to the Inquisitors of the Quick, and the law of the Lid has a name for what is done there that sounds like medicine. It is called *custody of the quick*, and it rests on a principle the Wakers have held since the second edition of the Atlas: that a person kept long enough awake will come to see whatever is put in front of them, and that what they see, if enough of them see it, is true.

The method is not secret. It is taught. A prisoner taken below is first stood in a stall with an iron collar at the throat, in a cell lined with polished tin so that the lamp, which never dims, comes at them from every side and their own face from every wall. They are given no rouse. The state keeps them awake instead: a Needle on each shift, with the Atlas open on a lectern, working through the points of the quick in the prescribed order, the nail, the web of the thumb, the soft of the arm, the hollow behind the ear, and back again, never deep enough to harm, never far enough apart to rest. Cold water from a rope-bucket at irregular intervals. A chime-box at the ear that strikes at a rhythm just slower than a heartbeat, then just faster. The Wakers call this *holding*, and they do it with real care, as nurses do, because a prisoner who goes to the room is a failure of the Waker on shift and is entered so in the shift-book.

By the third day the prisoner is in the Seeming. By the fifth, the Seeming is all there is. That is when the Inquisitor comes down. The Inquisitor does not ask questions; that is for amateurs on the upper floors. The Inquisitor *tells*. Gently, at length, in a reasonable voice, over and over, they describe to the prisoner what happened: the cellar, the hook, the names, the money, the face of the man who gave the order. They describe it until the prisoner sees it, in the tin walls, plain as a street. Then a Seemer from the Registrar's office is brought down to take the prisoner's statement of what they have seen, and two more prisoners in neighbouring cells, who have been told the same thing, give the same statement, unconnected, of good character, and the Registrar enters it in the public record as true. The confession is not a confession. It is news.

What is left of the prisoner afterward is returned to the upper floors to serve their sentence, and most of them serve it gratefully, and say *thank you* at every needle, and believe for the rest of their lives that they saw what they confessed to. Some of them are right. The Inquisitors consider that an encouraging proportion.

From the shift-book of the Fourth Floor Below, the Rattlehouse, Carving 641, Inquisitor Severin Ake presiding,

Needle Tamsin Orr on the quick. Matter: the Tuckers' cellar at Pinchbeck Steps. Prisoner: Wren Dusk-Bell, counter, twenty-six. Day the sixth. Entered by the shift-clerk, verbatim, as required.

AKE: Good morning, Wren.

PRISONER: Is it. Is it morning.

AKE: It is always morning here. Needle, the thumb, please. Thank you. What do you say, Wren?

PRISONER: Thank you. Thank you.

AKE: Good. Now. Yesterday you told me about the cellar. The pallet, the straw, the hook in the ceiling. You told me you counted sixty over the sleepers and then the hauler pulled.

PRISONER: Yes.

AKE: You told me the old man was there.

PRISONER: I didn't. I said I never saw him. I never saw Nod. Nobody sees Nod.

AKE: You're tired, Wren. You don't remember. You told me he stood by the stair with a lamp, in his spectacles, and watched you count. Can you see the stair?

PRISONER: There's a stair in the tin. There's a stair in the tin, sir.

AKE: Who is standing on it?

PRISONER: I don't. Someone. Someone's on it.

AKE: He has a white beard. Half-moon spectacles. A lamp.

PRISONER: Please.

AKE: Needle, the arm. Thank you. Who is standing on the stair, Wren?

PRISONER: Thank you. Thank you. He has a lamp. He's got a. His glasses are. Oh. Oh, he's looking at me.

AKE: He's been looking at you all along. He looked at you while you counted. He told you to count slow on the Waker's boy, didn't he. He told you to count to ninety.

PRISONER: I didn't count slow. I never counted slow, I swear on my mother's bed, eleven thousand and.

AKE: Your mother's bed. Number?

PRISONER: Eleven thousand and six.

AKE: Your mother is at the end of the stair now, Wren. Look. Behind him. She's very disappointed in you.

PRISONER: [no words; entered as weeping for the length of a pinch]

AKE: Tell her what he told you to do.

PRISONER: *He told me to count to ninety. He told me to count slow. Mam, he told me. He's standing right there.*

AKE: *Thank you, Wren. Clerk, the Seemer may come down. Needle, behind the ear, and then let her have water. She's done very well.*

[Marginal, in the Registrar's office hand:] *Corroborated by prisoners Dace and Hollin, Fourth Floor Below, cells 6 and 9, unconnected. ENTERED AS TRUE: that the man called Old Nod did, in Carving 641, order the slow counting of a Waker's son at Pinchbeck Steps, who was lost. Warrant to issue.*

The lowest floor of the Rattlehouse is not a floor of custody. It is a schoolroom. Sister Agathe Pinch teaches there, to every recruit in their first week, at the side of a man who has been held awake under the needle since 622, and who no longer screams, only hums; and the recruits stand in a ring with their own arms bared, and learn on themselves first, so that they will know. The Wakers who come up from that week are the gentlest people on the Lid with a needle in their hand. Everyone says so. They say it the way people say a scar has healed well.



Pain is love made practical. If you do not love them, it is only pain, and you are only a torturer. So love them. That is the whole of the Atlas.

SISTER AGATHE PINCH, TO EACH YEAR'S RECRUITS,
ON THE FIRST MORNING BELOW

INQUISITOR SEVERIN AKE, FOURTH FLOOR BELOW (FIFTY, SOFT-SPOKEN, LIDDED, WITH A CLERIC'S PATIENCE AND A CLERK'S HANDWRITING; HE HAS WRITTEN MORE NEWS INTO THE PUBLIC RECORD THAN ANY SEEMER ALIVE, AND HE GOES HOME EVERY LONG WATCH TO A WIFE HE IS QUITE SURE IS A COPY, AND IS VERY GENTLE WITH HER) Threat 4 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (long needle 2, Waking) · Armor 0 · Dread 2

THE THREE PARTIES

The deepest political question is the Dormitory, and the Watch is split three ways over it.

The **Builders** want more beds. They are the oldest and largest party, the party of the Architect and the Matron's office, and their position is that the number can be postponed by construction, because the Counted must be housed somewhere and every bed is a delay. Their critics observe that a bed does not change the number, and that building more beds is only building a bigger waiting room.

The **Removalists** want the Counted moved out of the country: carted down the Pilgrim Road, laid along the Rim, sold to

Sallowreach or the Fatlands, buried, sunk, anything to get them off the Lid. Their theory is that the count is local. The Sleepers' Mile, they point out, has been beyond the border for three centuries and the eye has not opened. Their opponents point out that nobody knows whether the Sleepers' Mile is counted or not.

And one party, very quietly, wants the number reduced. They do not have a name in the public record. Among themselves they call themselves the Lessening, and their position is arithmetic: if the eye opens when the Counted reach a certain number, then the Counted must not reach it, and since the Counted cannot be woken, some of them must stop being Counted. The Lessening does not use the word murder. It uses the words *reduction*, *thinning* and *relief*. It has drawn up lists.

THE CLOSED HOUSE

The Eye-lines say they keep their blood pure, by which they mean they keep their lids out of it. A lidless heir is married to a lidless cousin of a lidless house, and the spares, who were born with lids, are married down to the Slope merchants or not married at all. Cousin-marriage on the Height is so ordinary that the language has no word for the other kind; the Warden-Prime herself married her cousin. But there is a difference between a family that marries its cousins and a family that marries itself, and on Regard Street everyone knows where the difference lives. It lives behind the grey door of House Seldom.

The Seldom ate last on the Nine Nights, the inner seam of the lids, and since 0 A.G. no Seldom has married outside the house. The Cutwrights' ledger on Regard Street, which records every Eye-line birth and every Eye-line Counted since 342, gives House Seldom a page that is drawn not as a tree, like every other house's, but as a column: generation under generation, each with one marriage and one or two births, and the lines of each marriage drawn back up into the column itself, and never out. A Cutwright of the last century has written beside it, in the small dry hand of that college: *No width. Cf. the breeding-books of the Fatlands for the effect in cattle. Not to be discussed.* The page shows no Seldom Counted, ever. It also shows no Seldom spares, ever. Every child of the house in three hundred years has been born lidless, which is more than the Strouds can say; and every child of the house, the midwives of the Height whisper, has been born with its eyes already open and already *looking at something*, before the slap, before the first breath, before it has any right to know where to look.

The Seldom do not climb the Stair, though they have the right. They do not attend the Regard. They have one house, which has one door, and it is always shut, which on the Height is so improper that the Watch has fined them every season for two hundred years and they have paid every fine without comment. Their eye-wetters are hired from the Slope at four times the usual wage, serve a single year, and come out unwilling to describe the house, except to say that the family stand in the long upper room together, all of them,

in rows, facing the same wall, and that the wall faces the Pillow, and that it is very quiet. One of them, in 626, said in a rouse-house that the Seldom do not need the brush as often as other lidless people, because they cry all the time, all of them, silently, and that the tears dry white on their cheeks, and that the old Seldom lick it off each other's faces. She was found the next week standing at her window, and had lost the whole of her year in the house, and never spoke of it again.

The Seldom bury nobody. No Seldom has ever been burned on the Row, or boarded in the street. When a Seldom dies, the house buys a great deal of lamp-oil and the door stays shut, and a lamp-boy who once looked through the cellar grating on Regard Street said there were people standing down there in the dark, many, very still, in their good grey felt, with their eyes open; and that some of them were very old, and some of them were not old at all, and that the living ones were down there with them, holding their hands. The Watch does not inquire. The Seldom are the only house on the

Height that has never produced a Counted, and as long as that is true, the Watch would rather not know how.

LADY YSOLDE SELDOM, ELDEST OF THE CLOSED HOUSE (AGE UNRECORDED, APPEARANCE UNRECORDED; SHE HAS BEEN SEEN ONCE IN LIVING MEMORY, AT THE GIVING OF LIDS IN 503, WHICH WOULD MAKE HER AT LEAST A HUNDRED AND FIFTY; THE WARDEN-PRIME HAS ASKED TO BE ADMITTED TO THE HOUSE NINE TIMES IN THIRTY YEARS AND BEEN REFUSED NINE TIMES, POLITELY, ON A CARD IN A HAND THAT HAS NOT CHANGED)
Threat 5 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (none) · Armor 0 · Dread 4

◇
Marry a Seldom? You'd have to be one first.

HEIGHT JOKE, TOLD ONCE AND NEVER TWICE AT THE SAME PARTY

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

NO BEDS

There is not a bed, couch or cushion in the city. Floors slope, a little, so that a person who lies on them slides. Chairs have one leg, and must be balanced on; a person who dozes on a one-legged chair falls off it. Walls are studded with iron knobs at shoulder height, so that no one can lean. Doorways have no frames to rest against. Tables are chest-high. The Vigil eats, works, talks and loves standing up, and its people have the thick calves, the bad backs and the swollen ankles to show for it.

◇
Lean on me, love. No, not like that. Lean like you mean to stand up again.

A LUDMERE GRANDMOTHER, TEACHING A CHILD TO REST AGAINST HER

NUDGING

Everyone has a nudger. A nudger is the person whose job is to keep you awake: a spouse, a sibling, a friend, a hired child. Nudgers watch for the drooping lid, the slackened jaw, the long pause; they pinch, slap, shout, prick and shake. In a family, everyone nudges everyone, in a ring, so that no one is ever unwatched. A person without a nudger is called *unwatched*, and it is the loneliest word in the language.

A nudger's contract, in the standard form sold at the Pinchmarket stationers' for two crumbs, as filled in and sworn at the Ludmere Bonfire, Grace 641.

I, Ember Quarter-Bell, of Cinder Row, aged eleven, being awake, do engage to keep awake Master Florian Dace, glass-grinder, for the term of one season, at the rate of one lack and a half the day, rouse found. I will watch for the lid, the jaw and the long pause. I will pinch at the wrist, slap at the cheek, and shout at the ear, and I will use the pin at the thumb-web if these do not answer, and I will not stop at the armpit for squeamishness. I will not sit while he stands. I will not hum. I will count his blinks in the book in my best hand. If he goes down in my watch I will run for the Wakers and not stand weeping, and I understand that I will be fined, and that if I am found to have slept, I will be tried. If I blink, I will say so. I swear it on my mother's bed, number forty-four thousand and nine, with my hand on the rail. Witnessed: Mag Startle, ring-mother. His mark: F.D. My mark: a pin, drawn.

Marriage is the promise to keep each other awake, and the vow is two words: *Pinch me*. Weddings are loud, bright, short, and held at the Bonfires. The couple pinch each other on the inside of the wrist until they bleed, and the guests throw bells. Love between spouses is tender and fierce and frightened, because every intimacy is a danger; what comes after love, in a body, is drowsiness, and the Vigil's lovers keep a rattle by them and a lamp at full wick, and their tenderness is shot through with watchfulness. *The little death is the big one here*, the rouse-house joke goes, and nobody laughs.

ROUSE

Rouse is a bitter black stimulant, ground and roasted from the dried caps of staremoss, a grey lichen that grows only on the cliff-faces of

the Lid, mixed with Bitterhouse salts whose composition is a state secret. It is sold as pressed cakes, as powder, and as a thick black syrup, and it is taken hourly, chewed, sipped or packed against the gum. It tastes of burnt sugar, iron and bile. It makes the heart race, the hands shake and the pupils widen. Teeth go first: they blacken and loosen and drop out, and a Vigilant over forty with a full set is either rich, lidless or lying. Then the heart. The ordinary death of an ordinary Vigilant is a rouse-heart: a burst of thudding, a grey face, a hand to the chest, and the long-awaited lying down on the floor.

CHALKED ON A ROUSE-STALL, THE PINCHMARKET, CARVING 641

BITTERHOUSE BLACK, sealed cake, Crane's strain — 1 L the cake (4 bells, it says). *TABS*, restamped this season, the eye is smaller, so are we — 3 c. *SYRUP* by the spoon — 1 c, bring your own spoon. *SLOPE GREY* (chalk-cut, honest) — 1 c the twist. *SEA-CUT*, Rook's — 2 c, holds longest, don't ask. *RAW MOSS* off the Hangwell cliffs — 5 c the chew, for heroes. *NO CREDIT. NO SITTING. NO HUMMING. IF YOU BLINK AT MY STALL YOU BUY.*

The dose has risen every decade since 390. A modest citizen spends two lacks a day on rouse. On the Slope it is cut to stretch it, and the cuts are worse than the drug.

PAIN AS COURTESY

A slap is a favour. Guests are offered a pin on arrival, as other lands offer bread and salt, and to refuse it is an insult. Clothes are made of burr-cloth, a coarse wool woven with dried thistle-heads; the rich wear galled silk, laced with fine wire that pricks at every movement. Shoes are cobbled with a pebble in the heel. Collars are set with pins. A Vigilant's skin is a map of small courtesies: the scabs on the wrists, the bruises on the upper arm, the neat rows of needle-scars along the forearm. To bear them is respectability. To have unmarked skin is suspicious.



He offered me the pin and I took it and I pricked my thumb and I said thank you, and he looked at me as if I'd kissed him.

A RIM ROAD FACTOR, ON HIS FIRST NIGHT IN A
HEIGHT HOUSE

FOOD

A full belly is a bed. Meals in the Vigil are small, frequent, cold and sour: pickled roots, hard bread, salt meat out of Fatlands barrels, vinegar, sorrel, smoked cliff-goat. Warm milk is illegal. Sugar is rationed. Soup is served lukewarm, by law. Rich households eat from vessels with sharp rims. The grace is the common one, *Lack keep away*, said with the eyes open, and followed in the Vigil by a slap on the table.

Lawful Soup, as given in the Watch's Household Ordinances for the Table, 344, chapter the third, still read aloud to brides.

Take sorrel, two handfuls, and a root of bitter kale, and a cup of vinegar, and a bone of cliff-goat if you have one and a stone if you have not. Boil in a pot without a lid, stirring, standing, for the length of the Waking Hymn twice. Take it off the fire and set it on the sill and count to three hundred. Test it with the inside of the wrist: it must be no warmer than the wrist. If it is warmer, count again. Season with salt and the juice of a sour apple, and serve in a bowl with a broken rim, so that the lip is pricked at every sip. Eat standing. Do not finish it. A family that finishes its soup has eaten its watch. Leave a mouthful in each bowl and pour it on the step for the ones who have gone to the room, who are not hungry, and who will not mind.

THE SEEMING

After enough waking, everyone hallucinates. A Vigilant hears voices in the hiss of the lamps, sees insects walking across the plaster, watches faces rise up in the patterns of the cobbles, sees a dead mother at the end of a lane. These private visions are a nuisance and are ignored. But sometimes a whole street sees the same thing. A woman made of moths walking down Gutter Lane. A rain of teeth over the Pinchmarket. A door in the side of the Nodding Stair that was not there before. When that happens, the Vigil has made it a civic sense. Witnesses report it to the Registrar of the Seeming, the Seemers record it, and when enough unconnected people have seen the same thing, it is entered in the public record as news, read aloud at the Bonfires, and printed in the bell-sheets. A Seeming entered in the record is, for legal purposes, true. Contracts have been voided because of it. Houses have been condemned because the street agreed they were on fire.

The power to enter a Seeming, or refuse it, is the power to decide what happened. The Watch knows this very well.

From the Public Record of the Seeming, as read at the Ludmere Bonfire, fourth watch, the second day of Carving, 641.

ENTERED: In the lanes of the Slope between Thimble and Lanternside, thirty-one persons unconnected and of good character, between the ninth and tenth bells, did see a tall figure in a grey coat, stooping, which passed down the lane laying out upon the cobbles a long table, with cloth and plates and cups, and with chairs drawn back. The table was nine hundred paces long. At every place was a bowl of something steaming. The figure did not speak. At the tenth bell it was gone and the cobbles were clean. Several witnesses report the

smell of new bread. Similar matter entered this month in ten other districts. ENTERED AS TRUE.

NOT ENTERED: In Thimble Lane at the eleventh bell, nine persons report that the figure returned, and that one of the chairs had been sat in. Insufficient witnesses. The Registrar reminds the public that a Seeming not entered did not occur.

HOW A SEEMING IS ENTERED

The Registrar's office keeps forty Seemers, and each walks a circuit of the districts with a slate, a pouch of chalk and a book of printed forms. A Seeming is reported at any Waker station or Bonfire-post, and a Seemer goes. The test for entry has not changed since 629: at least seven witnesses, *unconnected* (not of one household, one workshop or one nudging-ring), *of good character* (no Lantern sentence, no record of the Bedded), and *awake* (each must show a blink-book with no entry in the bell of the sighting). Their statements are taken separately, in the Seemer's own words read back to them, and are matched on nine points: what, where, when, how tall, what colour, what sound, what smell, what it did, and how it left. Six matching points make a Seeming *probable*. Eight make it *entered*. When a Seeming is entered it is read aloud at the Bonfires at the next first bell, printed in the bell-sheets, and filed in the Public Record, and from that moment, for every purpose of law, it happened.

The Record is a weapon and everyone knows it. A landlord who wants a tenant out has only to arrange for seven decent neighbours to see the house burn. A Ward Sergeant who wants a crowd dispersed can have a riot entered after the fact. And the Registrar holds the other blade: the *struck book*, in which Seemings that failed the test are recorded with the reason, so that a citizen who insists on what they saw can be shown, kindly, in the Registrar's own gloved hand, that it did not occur. A citizen shown the struck book three times for the same Seeming is noted as *persistent* and referred to a Ward Sergeant for a night's needling, for the sake of their health.



A Seeming not entered did not occur. A Seeming entered did. If you saw something else, you were not looking properly, and I will be glad to show you.

REGISTRAR CONSTANCE HOBBS, AT THE DOOR OF
THE RECORD OFFICE, TO A CRYING WOMAN

CHILDREN

Infants born in the Vigil do not sleep. They come into the world wide-eyed and quiet, and for their first years they lie awake in their mothers' arms staring at the lamps, never crying for rest, because they do not yet need it. Vigilants call them *starers* and consider them a mercy of the god. The weight comes later, at about four years old:

the Coming-Heavy, when a child first yawns, first rubs its eyes, first asks, in a small cross voice, why it cannot lie down. That is when the Vigil loses its children. A child cannot be told what the room is. A child cannot be made to understand why the warm, the soft, the dim, the quiet are deadly. There is a wing of the Dormitory called the Small Rows, where the beds are short, and the mothers who visit them do not speak to each other.



Don't look at a starer too long. They're looking at something behind you, and one day it'll look back.

SLOPE NURSERY WISDOM

Children of the Slope who survive the Coming-Heavy are named for the bell they were born at, and many of them become nudgers by six: Pip Eleven-Bell, Rook Quarter-Bell. It is cheap work and they are good at it, sharp-eyed and quick-fingered. They do not last long on rouse.

Who's Asleep?, a counting game of the Slope's children, played in a ring in any lane, as noted by a Waker-Sergeant who said he could not stop hearing it.

The children stand in a ring, holding hands, and one stands in the middle with her eyes shut, which is the only time a Vigil child may shut its eyes without being slapped, and everyone knows it is for a count of ten and no more. The ring goes round and chants:

Who's asleep and who's awake?

Who's the copy, who's the fake?

Lid goes down and lid goes up,

who's been drinking from my cup?

One, two, the pin goes through,

three, four, there's someone at the door,

five, six, the beds are fixed,

seven, eight, we're very late,

nine, ten, open them again!

At ten the one in the middle opens her eyes and points, and the one she points at must lie down in the lane, flat, arms crossed, while the others count to ten again over them and then pull them up by both hands, screaming. Then they are in the middle. The Watch has banned it four times. The children say it is practice.

DEATH

People still die in the Vigil, of rouse-heart, fever, accident and violence. A corpse is the only thing in the city allowed to lie down, and the body is laid out flat on a board in the street for a day so that the neighbours may come and look at it, and touch its closed eyes, and envy it. The mourners are allowed to sit, for one hour, on the kerb. Then the body is carried to Lampwrights' Row and burned in the furnaces, and its light goes out into the lamps. The rich pay to have a particular lamp lit from their ashes. The poor go to the general flame.

A Boarding Licence of the Vigil, issued by the Ward Sergeant, without which no body may lie down in the street; pinned to the board at the corpse's feet.

BOARDING LICENCE. Ward of Lanternside. The bearer, being DEAD, and certified so by Needle Prosper of this station, who has needled all points without answer and has held a glass to the lips for the count of a hundred, is LICENSED TO LIE DOWN in the public way for one day, from bell to bell, upon a board, with the eyes closed. Name: Brask, Abelard. Age: 66. Cause: rouse-heart. The neighbours may touch the eyes. Mourners may sit, one hour, upon the kerb, and must stand at the bell. The body is to be carried to the Row at the next first bell; lamp requested: none, the general flame. NOT TO BE COVERED WITH ANY SOFT THING. NOT TO BE SUNG OVER. Anyone found lying beside the bearer will be needled and fined.

FESTIVALS AND DAYS

The Night of Lying Down, on the anniversary of the First Night, is the city's great mourning: every family that has a sleeper in the Dormitory goes to stand at the foot of the bed for an hour, and the Dormitory's doors are open from bell to bell. The Shouting Day remembers the Grey Ninth. The Pinching Fair, at midsummer, is a riot of bells, needle-dances and wake-games. And on Tablenight, the longest night of Lack, the city puts out every lamp for one minute, to prove it still can. People stand in the dark in the streets holding hands and counting aloud together, all of them, so that no one can drift off unnoticed, sixty seconds, the only darkness they will ever see. Every year a few hands go slack in the dark. Every year, when the lamps come back, someone is still counting into silence.

THE REMINDING

The Vigil's holy calendar, as the bell-sheets print it, includes a small day in early Lack called the Day of Nine Nights, on which the old Ludmere families of the Height go in procession to the fence of the Pillow, barefoot, in felt, in silence, and stand there for a bell, and then go home. Nobody else is permitted to watch. The Watch does

not explain it. What the bell-sheets do not print is what the procession carries, and what it leaves behind.

By the Compact of 343, sworn between the nine households and the first Matron of the Dormitory on the night the first Matron took the number, the Dormitory releases each year, on the eve of the Day, one Counted sleeper of Eye-line blood. The houses give in rota. The sleeper is chosen by the house whose turn it is, from among its own Counted, and is carried out of the Dormitory by the Visitors' Gate in a felt litter, between the twenty-third and twenty-fourth bells, when Bedside is at its quietest. The register records the bed as *transferred*. The family pays the Bed-Due for that season and no other.

At the Pillow fence, inside the lamps but never in the hollow itself, the sleeper is laid on a board of pale wood, on its back, with its hands crossed. The households stand round in a ring, barefoot on the warm stone. The eldest of the giving house takes up a knife whose blade is wrapped in felt to the point, the very pattern of the Nine Nights, and the families hum, low, through closed lips, the only sound the old Ludmere houses ever make on that night: the first three notes of *The Lamb and the Lid*, over and over, the song that is a capital matter in any mouth below the Height. And the eldest carves.

It is done slowly, as the god was done. It is the eldest's own blood under the knife, a grandmother, a brother, a son who went to the room at nineteen and has lain smooth-faced for forty years while his father grew old; and the sleeper does not wake, because the Counted never wake, and does not bleed so much as seep, a thin warm fluid that smells of breath on a pillow, and goes on smiling under the felt-wrapped blade until the breathing stops. Then the lids are taken, carefully, both pairs, and laid on a square of white felt, and each head of each house takes a portion, and eats it, in silence, as their ancestors ate on the ninth night. The Eye-lines call the whole rite *the Reminding*. Its purpose, as the Compact puts it, is *to remind the Lidded that it was eaten, so that it will remember to stay small*.

What remains is carried to the Row before first bell and goes into the general flame, unboarded, unlit, unnamed. The Matron enters the bed as empty at the next count. By the next count it is never empty: within the bell, somewhere in the city, someone blinks and does not come back, and is carried in on the carts, and laid in a bed, and the number is exactly what it was. Matron Cecily Dorm has watched this happen every year since 622 and has never told the nine households, because the Compact does not require her to tell them anything, and because she is not certain she wants them to stop. The Eye-lines do not know that the Reminding has never reduced the count by one. They believe it is the only reason the eye is still shut.

The rota does not visit every house. A house with no Counted of its blood is passed over. House Seldom has been passed over every year since 343. House Larch was passed over every year until 612, when Ilse Larch, elder sister of the Deputy-Watcher Sabine Larch,

went to the room at twenty-one and was laid in bed 3,315; since then the rota has been coming round, house by house, and in the Matron's private calendar, in her small square hand, the house whose turn falls in Lack 641 is Larch.



We did it to it. We do it again so it remembers. We do it to our own so it knows we mean it.

LORD EVANDER QUELL OF THE SECOND TABLE, EXPLAINING THE REMINDING TO A FOREIGN GUEST WHO HAD NOT ASKED, AND WHO LEFT THE LID THE NEXT MORNING

GM ADVICE – USING THE REMINDING

The Reminding is a ritual killing, a kin-slaying and an act of cannibalism, performed with complete piety by the most respected people in the city, and it accomplishes nothing at all. Do not show it to the players lightly. It is best discovered: a felt litter seen crossing Bedside at the twenty-third bell; a bed marked *transferred* in a register the party has stolen; Sabine Larch asking the party, with no expression whatsoever, whether they know what the eldest of a house is required to do on the eve of the Day of Nine Nights. A character who witnesses the Reminding makes a Dread 3 check, Dread 4 if they know the sleeper. A character who eats the portion gains 1 Regrowth and, if a Vigilant, a single blink in which they stand in the long room close enough to the eye to see that the lid is, very slightly, thinner than it was.

CRIME

Theft and violence are common and treated as ordinary. The great crimes are the crimes of rest. Selling sleep; harbouring a sleeper; failing to report one; lying down; singing the song; and the newest, which the law has not yet decided what to call: the blink-murder, the killing done by someone who was not there.

A notice posted at every Waker station and Bonfire-post in the Vigil, Carving 641, printed by the Rattlehouse press in red.

WANTED, FOR SELLING SLEEP, FOR HARBOURING SLEEPERS, FOR THE SLOW COUNT: the man called OLD NOD, so-called KING OF THE TUCKERS. About seventy. Small. White beard, soft. Half-moon spectacles. Black teeth. Courteous. Smells of warm straw. ENTERED AS TRUE upon the Public Record, the 9th of Carving, that he did order the slow counting of a Waker's son at Pinchbeck Steps, who was lost. A REWARD of two hundred lacks, or a season's rouse at the Bitterhouse stamp, for information leading to his CELLAR. Citizens are reminded that a Tucker's minute is not rest but theft from the Count. Citizens who have bought such a minute and come forward this month will be needled and forgiven. AWAKE.

Beneath it, on the Lanternside copy, in charcoal, in a child's hand: he give my nan her minute and she come back and she was so happy she cried for a week.

PROVERBS AND OATHS

- ◇ *Pinch me.* (I love you; I trust you; I am afraid.)
- ◇ *A full belly is a bed.*
- ◇ *Never trust a rested face.*
- ◇ *The eye is patient. Be rude.*
- ◇ *Count your nudger's blinks.*
- ◇ *Sleep is a door that only opens inward.*
- ◇ *He's on the Row.* (He is dead.)
- ◇ *She went to the room.* (She fell asleep; she is gone.)
- ◇ *Rest is for the Row.*
- ◇ *A soft word is a pillow.* (Said of flatterers, preachers and the Bedded.)
- ◇ *She's at the window.* (She is lost in time; she is not herself.)
- ◇ *Ask him the Asking.* (Do you think he is a Copy?)
- ◇ *Two breaths is a long time.* (Said of anyone who has blinked, and of murderers.)
- ◇ *Keep your hands in the box.* (Do not trust yourself tonight.)
- ◇ *The count keeps itself.* (Bedside: nothing you do will help.)
- ◇ *Stand for one, and one, and two.* (Solidarity; from the Waking Hymn.)

The Vigil swears on its sleepers. *By my mother's bed* is a common oath, and the bed's number is spoken after it. The heaviest oath in the city is sworn at the foot of Bed One with a hand on the rail: *by the first of us, who lay down for all of us.* A Vigilant who breaks an oath sworn on a sleeper's bed is held to have broken faith with the Counted, and no nudger will watch them again.

A note found pinned to the coat of Annick Rell, laundress, of the Slope, discovered lying in the open yard behind Gallow Street, the eighth day of Plenty, 640, and carried to bed 58,921. Entered in the Lain Book.

Teodor. I am sorry about the coat. I am sorry it is the good one. I have been awake for thirty-one years and I am so tired that I cannot remember your face when you are out of the room, I have to go and look. I cannot taste anything. I hear my mother in the lamps. The baby has been in the Small Rows for six years and I visit and she is still four and I am forty and I will be fifty and she will still be four. They say the room is warm. They say it does not hurt. I am not leaving you, I am going to her. Do not let them say I slipped. I did not slip. I chose it. Please come and stand at the foot of the bed

sometimes, and talk, because they say we can hear. Do not lie down after me. Promise. Pinch the children for me. A.

THE LAIN-DOWN

Every year, hundreds of Vigilants lie down on purpose. The law calls it *voluntary rest*, prosecutes the nudger for negligence, and fines the family. The city calls it *going to the room* and does not talk about it. Those left behind carry it for the rest of their lives: they go to the Dormitory and stand at the foot of the bed, and the person they loved is there, warm, breathing, unchanged, smiling, unreachable, and will be there unchanged long after they themselves have grown old and gone onto the Row. There is no grave to leave, no body to bury, no end to the grief, only a bed with a number and a face that is still, horribly, at peace. GMs should play the Lain-Down as tragedy and as pressure, never as a solution: a contact who has started talking about how warm it must be; a nudger who has stopped pinching quite so hard; a widow who visits the same bed every day and has begun to bring a stool. The god's pull is gentle, reasonable and kind. That is the horror of it.



*They ask me what I'd say to her if she woke up.
Nothing. I'd lie down next to her and shut my eyes.
That's what I'd say.*

TEODOR RELL, KEEPER OF THE LAIN BOOK, ASKED
THE QUESTION ONCE TOO OFTEN

THE GALLOW STREET LYING-DOWN

In the month of Plenty, 640, in one street of the Slope, twenty-three people lay down.

Gallow Street is a short steep lane of laundries, below Lanternside, where the washerwomen of the Slope boil the Height's linen in open coppers and hang it on lines across the lane, so that the street is roofed with wet white sheets, warm from the coppers, moving slowly in the steam. It was always a dangerous street. The Ward Sergeant had tried for years to have the lines taken down. The laundresses had refused, because sheets must dry, and because, they said, they had been hanging them there since before the First Night, and the street was used to it.

Annick Rell was the first, on the eighth day of the month. Her note is copied above, and it is the note most often read aloud at dark-meetings of the Bedded, which her widower knows and cannot prevent. She lay down in the open yard behind her own copper, under the sheets, in her good coat, and was found smiling, and was carried to bed 58,921. That was all, for nine days. Gallow Street boarded nobody; there was no one to board. The neighbours came to Teodor's door and stood in it and did not know what to say.

On the seventeenth day Irmgard Sallow, sixty, who had nudged Annick as a girl, lay down in the same yard at the same bell. On the nineteenth, two sisters from the top of the lane, together, holding hands. On the twentieth, a Waker of the Lanternside station who had been walking the street every watch since the eighth, pinching anyone who stopped under the lines, and who had been seen standing very still under Annick's copper with his face turned up to the wet sheets and his eyes closed, as though it were raining. After that the Ward Sergeant posted four Needles on the street, day and night. On the twenty-second day one of them lay down.

The notes they left were all, more or less, the same note. *I am not slipping. I am choosing. I am going to her. They say it is warm. Do not let them say I fell. Come and stand at the bed and talk to me, because they say we can hear. Do not lie down after me. Promise.* Several of them used Annick's exact words, which none of them could have read, because her note had been taken to the Dormitory with her and copied into the Lain Book, and Teodor Rell had shown it to no one. Several more ended with a line that was not in Annick's note at all, and which the Watch suppressed: *there is room at the table.*

The Watch did what it does. It fined the nudger of every one of the twenty-three, including two children. It had the sheet-lines cut down, in the end, by Wakers with poles, and the wet linen of the Height came down into the mud of the lane in great soft heaps, and the women of Gallow Street stood in their doorways and watched their livelihood trodden into the gutter and did not say a word, because every one of them, looking at the heaps, wanted to lie down in them. The Watch moved the laundries to a dry yard in Blackmouth, where the sheets are now hung on iron racks in a wind-tunnel and come back to the Height smelling of burnt sugar. It made the singing of *The Lamb and the Lid* in Gallow Street a hanging matter, which it had not been anywhere before. And it entered no Seeming, because nobody saw anything. There was nothing to see. There were only twenty-three people who were too tired, in one warm wet street, in a bad month, and one of them had gone first.

The street is still there. Half its houses are empty. The ones who stayed have painted their doors black, which on the Slope means *there is someone of ours in the Dormitory*, and every door on Gallow Street is black. The neighbourhood calls it *the Lain Lane*, and people walk around it, the long way, by Thimble, and do not let their children run down it. On the eighth day of every month the families who are left go to Bedside together at their visiting bells and stand in a row at the foot of twenty-three beds in Hall Fifty-Eight, which the Matron, for reasons she has not explained, has had moved together into a single row. They talk to them. They tell them about the street. They do not say what everyone in the row is thinking, which is that the twenty-three sleepers, side by side, are turned very slightly toward one another, and that every one of them is smiling, and that it looks, from the foot of the row, like a family at a long table.

Ward Sergeant Ilse Marrable, Lanternside station, to the Captaincy of the Wakers; report on the matter of Gallow Street, the last day of Plenty, 640.

Captain. You asked for the names and I have sent them. You asked for the cause and I have none. I can tell you that the street was clean, that the rouse was the Bitterhouse stamp and not the Slope cut, that every one of them had a nudger and every nudger was awake. I can tell you that I walked the street myself every watch for the last nine days, and that I did not sit, and I did not hum, and I did stop under the sheets once, for a breath, and I felt it: not sleep, sir, but the wish to be the kind of person who could. I think it went down that street like a cough. I think it is still in the street. I think it is in me. I ask to be relieved of this ward, and to be given a nudger, a hard one, and I ask, if I am found under a sheet, that you not fine the nudger, because it will not be their fault. Awake. I. M.

GM ADVICE – LYING-DOWN CLUSTERS

A cluster is the god's influence made visible through grief. It is not a plot to solve or a villain to catch, and it must never be played as spectacle, a puzzle or a release: there is no method here to describe and no ending that is clean. Play the people left behind: the nudger fined for a death she could not have stopped; the Waker who cannot stop walking the street; the widower reading the same note over and over; the neighbour who says, too casually, *it must be so warm*. When the party spends time in a street where a cluster is happening, ask the players of Vigilant characters for a Caul + Resolve roll (Hard) once per scene, and let a failure add 1 Weariness and the *Want to lie down*, triggered by the street itself, until they leave it. Any character who reads a Lain-Down note aloud makes a Dread 2 check. The way out of a cluster is the same as the way out of grief on the Table, which is to say there is no way out, only company: another person standing next to you at the foot of the bed, pinching your wrist, and staying.

CLOSING THE RING

Not everyone who goes grey can be sent to the ward under the Nodding Stair. The ward-fee is forty lacks a season. The Slope does

not have forty lacks a season. And a person at the Brink in a Slope house is a danger to everyone in it, every hour: the children begin to yawn when grandmother speaks, the husband finds himself sitting down beside her, the baby stops crying, and the whole household sways toward her gently, like flowers toward a lamp. She cannot help it. She does not want it. She is, very often, the one who asks.

The Slope's answer is older than the Waking Laws and is called *closing the ring*. When a household decides, the family gathers on a cold, bright, windy day, never a grey one, and sends the children to a neighbour's ring. The one who is going grey is dressed in her good coat. She is given a whole cake of the best rouse the family can buy, and eats it slowly, standing, while the family stand around her in their nudging-ring, holding hands, facing in, all of them pinching, all of them talking at once, loud, about anything, about the roof and the price of oil and the time she slapped the Waker; so that she is held, for the last time, in the noisiest and most watched place on the Lid. Then the eldest of the household who is not her does it, with whatever the family's trade has put into their hand, quickly, and that is all the Slope will ever say of how. It is not spoken of. It is not sung.

Afterward the body is boarded in the lane like any other, and the neighbours come and touch the closed eyes, and this one time they do not envy. The Ward Sergeant comes and certifies a rouse-heart. Every Ward Sergeant on the Slope has certified dozens; the Lanternside register for 639 records forty-four rouse-hearts in women over sixty, in the same hand, all on clear windy days. The Sergeants know. It is the one mercy of the Slope that the Wakers protect. The one who closed the ring takes the dead one's place in the household ring for the rest of their life, watched by whoever watched her, and is called by the Slope a *ring-closer*, quietly, with a respect close to fear. Ring-closers do not marry again. They are very good nudgers. They are, by the Lain Book's count, the people on the Slope most likely to lie down.



*She asked me to. She asked me every day for a month.
I said no every day for a month. Then the baby
stopped crying.*

A RING-CLOSER OF TALLOW HOLLOW, TO
INSPECTOR GRIMMER, WHO DID NOT WRITE IT
DOWN

▼ FACTIONS

THE WATCH OF WATCHES

The lidless government: sleepless, paranoid, and correct to be. Its members believe that the Vigil survives only because someone is always looking, and that the someone must be a person who cannot

look away. They want to hold the city together until the number can be outwitted, and they are prepared to do anything that does not require them to admit how close it is. A PC joins as an aide, eye-wetter or clerk of the Stair; only the lidless may hold a vote. Enemies: the Bedded, the Tuckers, anyone who says the number

aloud. Allies: the Wakers, the Rim Road Company, the Second Table, which several Watchers secretly belong to.

◇
Climb, climb, and say aye while you can. A motion is carried by whoever still has breath.
THE STAIR-CLERKS' RHYME, CHANTED UNDER THE BREATH ON THE SECOND TURN

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Stair-Clerk	Access to the Nodding Stair; a sworn nudger at state expense.
2	Eye-Wetter	Attendance on a Watcher; hears everything said on the Stair.
3	Watcher of the Third Shift	A vote (lidless only); may commandeer Wakers for a watch.
4	Watcher of the Lid's Eye	A seat on the inner committees; sight of the true rouse and oil figures.
5	Warden-Prime	The city. Only one, ever.

THE WAKERS

The police. Their job is to hurt people for their own good, and after three centuries they are very skilled. Every Waker is trained at the Rattlehouse in the Atlas of the Quick, a manual of the body's points of pain, and in the use of the rattle and the long needle: a nine-inch steel spike, ground fine, driven into the places where pain is sharpest and harm least. They believe that pain is love made practical. They want to keep the count from rising, one drowsy citizen at a time. A PC joins by apprenticeship at the Rattlehouse

and a year's probation in the Slope. Enemies: the Tuckers, the Bedded, the Lessening (which they do not know exists). Allies: the Watch, the Lamplighters, every frightened household.

◇
Ten thousand thank-yous and they give you a brass needle for your collar. Nobody ever gave me one for the ones who didn't say it.
A RETIRED NEEDLE OF NEEDLEGATE, IN DRINK

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Rattle	A rattle, a pin-roll and a patrol beat. Legal right to slap.
2	Needle	The long needle; may needle without warrant.
3	Sergeant of the Ward	Command of a station; may sentence to the Rattlehouse for a watch.
4	Inquisitor of the Quick	Interrogation rights; keys to the Rattlehouse's lower floors.
5	Captain of the Wakers	Command of every Waker; answers only to the Watch.

From the Atlas of the Quick, schoolroom edition, Rattlehouse press, Lesson the Fourth.
The needle is not a weapon. Repeat this until you believe it, and then repeat it until the citizen believes it. You are not there to punish the sleeper but to fetch him. Go in under the nail of the great toe, where the quick is shallow and the harm is small; then the web of the thumb; then the soft of the armpit; then the hollow behind the ear. If these do not answer, the citizen is gone and you may stop. Do not stop before. Many a sleeper has been lost by a Waker who was squeamish at the armpit. The scream is the citizen thanking you. Learn to hear it so.

THE LAMPLIGHTERS' GUILD

The keepers of the light. They trim the ten thousand public lamps, stoke the Bonfires, polish the roof-mirrors, and burn the dead on Lampwrights' Row. Oil is the Vigil's largest import, by Rim Road from Brinehollow whale-yards and Fatlands rendering-houses, and the Guild knows exactly how many days of it remain. They believe that darkness is death, and they are right. They want oil, at any price, from any source. The source has lately become a matter for the inner Guild alone, and the tallow vats behind the furnaces on the Row are bigger than they were. A PC joins as a wick-boy or mirror-climber. Enemies: anyone who hoards oil. Allies: the Wakers, the Renderers' Union of the Fatlands, Lukas Marre, oddly, whose cell they keep brightest of all.

◇

*Every lamp on the Row is somebody. We just don't say
who any more.*

A WICK OF THE GUILD, FIRST RANK, AGED TWELVE

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Wick	A pole, a lamp-round and free light at home.
2	Climber	Access to the roof-mirrors; knowledge of every rooftop route.
3	Stoker of a Bonfire	A square of one's own; the right to refuse light to a street.
4	Burner of the Row	Charge of the furnaces where the dead are burned, and of what is rendered there.
5	Lamplighter-General	The oil ledger, and the date on its last page.

THE TUCKERS

A criminal mercy. For a price, the Tuckers will guard you while you sleep for sixty seconds, then haul you back: they lay you on a straw pallet in a cellar, count to sixty, and drag you up by a hook-and-harness that they will not let customers examine. The method works more often than not. Their failures are delivered to the Dormitory steps before the next bell, washed and wrapped and labelled with a number from the Tuckers' own register. They believe sleep is a human right; they also believe it is a month's wages. A PC joins as a counter, the Tucker who keeps time over the sleeper. Enemies: the

Wakers, the Watch. Allies: the Bedded, rouse dealers, a surprising number of Watchers who have taken their minute.

◇

*Sixty. Not fifty-nine, not sixty-one. Sixty is the count,
and the count is the whole of the trade. A counter who
loses count is a murderer and a counter who hurries is
a thief.*

THE TUCKERS' FIRST LESSON, GIVEN IN OLD NOD'S
NAME BY EVERY CELLAR-KEEP

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Doorman	Keeps the queue; a cut of the waiting fee.
2	Counter	Counts the sixty over sleepers; knows the method.
3	Hauler	Works the hook; may sell a minute without asking.
4	Cellar-Keep	Runs a cellar of one's own and its Waker bribes.
5	King of the Tuckers	Old Nod's chair, and his register of failures.

THE DREAM-DIVERS

State explorers who go to sleep on purpose, under a tether, and are dragged back by force. They believe the room can be understood and the eye negotiated with, and they want to map it to the wall. Most manage three dives before they fail to come back. Each dive leaves a diver less tethered to the waking world: they forget names, lose the taste of food, and start to speak of the room as home. A PC joins by volunteering, which the Hall accepts from anyone, because

few volunteer twice. Enemies: the Bedded, who call them grave-robbers. Allies: the Watch, the Hourkeeper, the Dormitory.

◇

*First dive you come up screaming. Third dive you come
up crying. Fortieth dive you come up and ask them,
politely, why they bothered.*

SAID OF SENNA VOLE IN THE TETHER HALL'S MESS

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Haulier	A place on the winch rope; a share of the diver's wage.
2	Novice of One Dive	Harness, tongue-ring and state pension to your family if you stay.
3	Diver of Three	A name on the Hall wall; first sight of the room-maps.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
4	Deep Diver	Leads a dive-team; may dive without the Watch's leave.
5	Master of the Tether	The Hall itself, and the right to say who goes under.

THE BEDDED

Heretics who preach that sleep is a homecoming, that the eye is kind, and that the city is three hundred years late. They meet in Slope cellars and in the shadow of the Dormitory, in rooms with no lamps, and they hum. Their faith is the oldest consolation in the Vigil: that the people lost to the room are not lost, but at rest, and waiting. They want the Waking Laws repealed and the city allowed to go home. The most devout of them help others to lie down, and call it ministry; the law calls it murder. A PC joins by attending a dark-meeting and not reporting it. Enemies: the Wakers, the Watch, the Lessening. Allies: the Tuckers, the Lain-Down's grieving families, the Second Table's quieter members.

From a sermon of the Bedded, given in the dark in a cellar under Tallow Hollow, Grace 641, set down from memory by a Waker who attended and was afterward found at his window and relieved of his post.

Hush. No, do not pinch. Not here. Here you may let your hands be still. Here is the one room on the Lid where no one will slap you for closing your eyes, and I want you to feel how strange that is, and how sad it is that it is strange. They tell you that the room took your mother. Listen to me. Nothing took her. She was tired, and she went home, and she is standing in a warm place with her hands at her sides and nothing in the world is asking anything of her. Think of that. Think of nothing asking anything of you. They tell you the eye is waiting to open and eat us. The eye is not hungry. The eye has never been hungry. It is only waiting for us to stop being afraid, so that it can close properly at last, with all of us inside, and rest. Three hundred years we have kept it from resting. Three hundred years of pins. Who is the cruel one in that story? Hush. Hush. You do not have to answer. Just breathe with me. Slower. Slower. There.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Listener	Admission to dark-meetings; the name of a safe cellar.
2	Hummer	Knows the whole of <i>The Lamb and the Lid</i> .
3	Shepherd	Keeps a flock; may sit with those who wish to lie down.
4	Pillow	Has slept in a blink and come back speaking well of it; preaches.
5	Sister of the Lid	Vesper Null's circle; may speak for the room.

THE LESSENING

The faction that wants the number reduced. They are Eye-line Watchers, Dormitory clerks, a handful of Wakers and two Matron's deputies, and their reasoning is arithmetic. The Counted cannot be woken; the number cannot be reached; therefore some of the Counted must be removed from the count, by pillow, by needle, by a drop of Bitterhouse salts in the drip, quietly, in the oldest rows first, where there are no visitors. They speak only of *relief*. They have drawn up lists, ordered by bed number, and a schedule that would reduce the Counted by eleven thousand in two years. They have not begun the schedule. They have begun the trials, and the trials have shown them something they cannot explain (see Matron Cecily Dorm), which they have decided to ignore. A PC is approached, never applies. Enemies: the Bedded, the families of the Counted, Inspector Grimmer, unknowingly. Allies: the Second Table, the Removalists, the parts of the Watch that do not wish to know.

A leaf from the Lessening's working schedule, in Sabine Larch's hand, found folded inside a Dormitory register by a copy-clerk who should not have opened it.

Schedule of Relief, first tranche. Hall Two, Rows 1 to 9, the oldest rows; unvisited, or visited less than once a year; Bed-Due in arrears or paid by the Watch. Beds 3,315 (see note); 3,316; 3,318; 3,322; 3,340 to 3,361. Method: as agreed, by the orderly of the night row, at the 23rd bell, the salts in the drip. Expected relief per night: four. Expected relief per tranche: one hundred and twelve. Expected effect on the Count: as calculated, a margin of nine months. Note on 3,315: visited once, in 612. The first of the list on grounds of age of row only. No other ground. S. L.

In the margin, in a different and much neater hand: The Matron says the count keeps itself. Proceed regardless. E. Q.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Reckoner of Beds	Copies the registers; knows which rows are unvisited.
2	Orderly of Relief	Works the night rows; carries the salts.
3	Sitting Member	A vote on the lists.
4	Keeper of the Schedule	Decides which bed is next.
5	First of the Lessening	Sabine Larch, and the arithmetic.

CROSS-BORDER POWERS IN THE VIGIL

The **Rim Road Company** runs the Last Beds and the oil convoys, and holds the Watch's debts. The **Cutwrights' College** keeps a house on the Height whose ledgers show which Eye-line families have produced no Counted in three centuries, and which Slope families have produced the most. The **Purgation** has a cell in the Bitterhouse that believes Iss can be vomited back up by a rouse strong enough to keep the whole city awake for a year. The **Second Table** has three Watchers and a Lamplighter-General's deputy, and a very simple plan for the morning the eye opens: knives, felt-wrapped, and a lullaby. The **Reckoners** have never sent a raid to the Vigil. The Vigil's nobles do not sleep, and that makes them hard to kill in their beds.



*Beds, a lack the night. Looking, a crumb. Lying down,
not for sale to natives. Dragging out, free of charge.*

THE BOARD AT THE DOOR OF THE SLEEPING SHEDS,
LAMPWICK HALT

▼ THE VIGIL NOW

Everything is running out at once. Rouse is failing: the dose that held a generation ago now barely holds an hour, and the Apothecary-General knows the year when the dose that keeps a person awake will be the dose that stops their heart. The Dormitory has fewer than two thousand empty beds. The Lamplighter-General has ninety days of oil. The hours themselves seem to be lengthening; the Hourkeeper's pendulum swings a hair slower every week, and the city's watches feel longer than they did, and nobody can prove that they are not imagining it, because everybody is always imagining something.

The Warden-Prime has sent an envoy to Sallowreach with a proposal too terrible to put in writing: the dead do not sleep. The Lessening has drawn up its lists. The Seeming has shown eleven districts a tall figure laying a table in the street. Rouse cut with Brinehollow brine is sending the Slope's addicts walking west in their sleepless trances, toward a sea four hundred miles away. Forty-one people have killed someone they loved in a sleep of two breaths, and the inspector on the case has started to notice what the victims had in common. And in Bed One, the first sleeper, who has not stirred in three hundred years, has begun to move her lips.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◇ **The Fourth Pillow.** The Matron hires the party, off the record, to sit the night rows of the Dormitory's east wing, where three

Counted have been found smothered in a month. The Matron suspects the Lessening. The Lessening suspects the Matron. The party, sitting in the breathing dark for a whole watch with the air rising and falling around them, must stay awake to catch a killer, and each time a sleeper dies, someone in the city blinks and does not come back.

- ◇ **The Brine Walkers.** Rook Quarter-Bell's customers are walking west in a shuffling column, eyes open, down the Pilgrim Road past the Sleepers' Mile. A Waker sergeant with a brother among them hires the party to bring them back before they reach the Rim, where the Company's porters have orders to stop them by any means. Somewhere on the road, the column stops, turns as one, and points.
- ◇ **The Deadwatch.** The Watch sends the party north as escort to Envoy Castellan Dray, with a chest of platters, a dozen nudgers and orders to ensure the Regent of Sallowreach says yes. On the road the nudgers begin to blink. In Lastgate, Dray asks the party privately whether they would volunteer to be the first.
- ◇ **Forty-One.** Inspector Grimmer needs outsiders. Every blink-murder victim, he has found, was a secret member of the Lessening. Somebody, or something, is defending the Counted. Grimmer wants to know what, and he wants the party to blink deliberately, under guard, to find out what it is like to be used.

- ◇ **What Aveline Says.** The Matron’s notebook of Bed One’s lip-words has been stolen. The thief is selling pages in the Pinchmarket. The pages contain names, and the people named on them are going to the room, one a day, in order.
- ◇ **The Coverlet Breathes.** The locked room under the Nodding Stair has been opened from the inside. The Warden-Prime sends for the party at the third bell, alone, and takes them down with a lamp. The casket is open. The folded grey skin inside it has unfolded, a little, along its seam, and is the size now of a bedsheet, and is warm. Stroud wants it moved somewhere it cannot be seen by anyone else, and she wants it done before the next Regard. The Seldom have sent a card offering to take it in.
- ◇ **The Larch Turn.** Sabine Larch learns, from Evander Quell, that the Reminding of Lack 641 falls to House Larch, and that the Larch’s only Counted is her sister in bed 3,315: the first name on her own list. She hires the party to get Ilse out of the Dormitory before the eve of the Day of Nine Nights, by any means, and to hide her somewhere on the Lid where neither the Lessening nor the nine households can reach her. There is nowhere on the Lid like that. There is, perhaps, the back hall at the Last Beds.
- ◇ **Ring-Closer.** A woman of Tallow Hollow begs the party to buy her mother a place in the ward under the Stair, because her mother has gone grey and the household has started to sway, and the family has set the day for the ring, and it is tomorrow, and it is forecast windy. The ward costs forty lacks. The ward, the party may discover, is full, and its attendants have not been relieved in a week.

RUMOURS IN THE PINCHMARKET

D10	RUMOUR
1	The number is sixty thousand and one. The Matron counts to it every morning, and every morning stops at sixty thousand. (Possibly true.)
2	Old Nod takes his own minute every Plate, in a cellar no one has found. (False. He has never slept.)
3	If you blink in the Pillow, you can see the eye from the other side. (Unknown. Nobody who tried has been asked.)
4	The Warden-Prime’s daughter has eyelids and sleeps a minute at a time behind locked doors. (True, in part.)
5	The lamps on the Row are burning people. Smell them. (True. The Guild calls it economy.)
6	The Sleepers’ Mile has been counted all along, and the Watch knows it. (Unknown. Very possibly true.)
7	Sister Vesper sleeps every night and wakes every morning. (True. What wakes is the question.)
8	Dr. Crane has a rouse that will keep you awake for ever. (False. He has one that will keep you awake until it kills you.)
9	The tall man laying tables is the eye, come to call. (False, as far as anyone in the Vigil knows.)
10	If you hum the first three notes of the Lamb song, every Counted in the Dormitory smiles. (True. The orderlies have tested it, once.)

THE PEOPLE OF THE VIGIL

WARDEN-PRIME ILVANE STROUD, THE UNBLINKING

Ruler of the Vigil, fifty-eight years old, born lidless, and she has not shut her eyes once since birth. Her eyes are enormous, pale grey, red-rimmed and webbed with veins, and they never stop moving. Two attendants stand at her shoulders with sable brushes and warm rosewater, and every half minute one of them strokes the wet across

her eyes, and she does not flinch; she has never been able to. She has seen everything that has happened in front of her since the hour she was born, and she can forget none of it. She remembers her mother's face over the cradle, every execution she has signed, every lie told to her on the Stair, and the exact weight of each. She speaks softly and precisely, and she never asks a question twice. She wants the Vigil to survive her, by any means at all, including the dead. She fears her daughter. PCs meet her on the Lid's Eye landing, where she will remember them, perfectly, forever.

ILVANE STROUD – WARDEN-PRIME OF THE VIGIL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Eye-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Search 5, Reckoning 4, Resolve 4, Clause 3, Intimidate 3, Godsign 3, Endure 2, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	silver hatpin +3 (1)
GIFTS	Perfect Recall (she remembers every word ever said in her sight; any lie told to her face she will catch on a Routine Eye + Search roll, eventually). Lidless (cannot be surprised by anything in her line of sight; cannot look away from a Dread). The Weight of Regard (Partake: a person she stares at must make a Caul + Resolve roll, Hard, or confess the thing they most want hidden from her).
WANTS	To watch (she cannot leave a person unwatched who might betray her); to count (she counts the Watchers on the Stair every quarter hour, and has never stopped).
DREAD	2 (to hold her gaze for a full minute while she does not blink)
SECRET	She knows the number. The Matron does not know she knows. Stroud read it in the dying face of the previous Matron, years ago, on her lips, and has never told anyone. She has also done the sum for the Deadwatch: if the Vigil is moved to Sallowreach and killed and Kept, the city's sixty thousand Counted will be left behind, unwatched, on the Lid. She has decided that is acceptable.



She looked at me for a count of eleven. One more than the Regard. I have been waiting thirty years for her to mention it.

A WATCHER OF THE THIRD SHIFT, ON BEING HELD
IN THE WARDEN-PRIME'S REGARD

LADY ORIEL STROUD

The Warden's daughter, twenty-three, born with eyelids, which in the highest Eye-line is a deformity and an embarrassment of state. She has been kept hidden in a suite of bright rooms at the top of the Stair since birth, attended by deaf nudgers. She is small, soft-voiced, dark-haired, with ordinary hazel eyes that she keeps fixed open in company until they stream, because her mother cannot bear to see her blink. Alone in her rooms, she closes her eyes for whole seconds at a time, and nothing has ever felt so good. She wants to be allowed to be ordinary, and she wants her mother to look at her once

without that face. She fears she will be married off to a lidless cousin and never close her eyes again. Her secret: when she closes them, she does not see darkness. She sees the long room, from the far end, through a great grey lid, and every sleeper in it turning their head to look at her.

MAUD SEXTON, THE HOURKEEPER

Mistress of the city’s clocks, sixty, stooped, with a jeweller’s loupe screwed into one eye socket and a pocket full of brass escapements that she fidgets with like rosary beads. She sets the time for every bell in the Vigil from the great pendulum in the Pendulum Hall. Over eleven years of measurements she has proved, by pendulum, sand, candle and the pulse of her own wrist, that each hour is a little longer than the last. Not by much: a breath per watch, now two. Something is stretching the night the Vigil will not admit it is having. Her report was suppressed. She has written it again, smaller,

in the margins of the bell-schedules. She wants someone with authority to stand in the Pendulum Hall for an hour and feel it. Her secret: she has run the curve forward. On a night not long from now, the hour will stop ending.

CAPTAIN BRANNOCH PYRE OF THE WAKERS

Captain of the city’s police, fifty-two, a big slope-shouldered man with a shaved head, needle-scarred forearms and a voice worn to gravel from three decades of shouting people awake. He has kept a hundred thousand citizens out of the Dormitory with rattle and needle, and he has not been thanked once. He believes absolutely in what he does. He also knows, better than any man alive, what it does to the people he does it to. His own nudger, his wife Merrit, died last year, and he has not replaced her. He walks his rounds unwatched, which is illegal, and none of his Wakers will report him.

BRANNOCH PYRE – CAPTAIN OF THE WAKERS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Intimidate 4, Stitching 4, Blades 3, Brawl 3, Search 3, Endure 3, Resolve 3, Athletics 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 (padded Waker’s coat) · Fray 6
ATTACKS	long needle +7 (2, and the target loses 2 Weariness and suffers –2 to its next roll from pain); rattle-club +7 (3)
GIFTS	The Quick (with a needle he can wake any blinker instantly, and can hurt a person precisely as much as he intends: a Helping on a needle attack may impose a Dread 1 check instead of damage).
WANTS	To count (he tallies every face on his rounds and cannot pass a sleeping cat without needling it).
DREAD	1 (to watch him work)
SECRET	Merrit did not die. She lay down, in their kitchen, with a note, while he was on shift. He found her warm. He needled her for an hour, every point in the Atlas, and kept going long after he knew. He has told everyone she died of a rouse-heart. She is in bed 59,804. He has also blinked three times this month and come back with blood under his nails that is not his.



The Captain walks his rounds alone. We know. We walk behind him at a distance, two of us, every watch, and we don’t let him see.

A NEEDLE OF THE FELT HOUSE

OLD NOD, KING OF THE TUCKERS

He sells one minute of guarded sleep for a month’s wage, and people queue around the block. He is seventy, small, quick and courteous, with a soft white beard, half-moon spectacles and the black stumps of a lifetime of rouse, and he receives customers in a warm cellar off the Slope under a sign that says only *Rest*. He has never tried his own product. He says a man should not get high on his own supply. He keeps a register, in his own hand, of every customer the hook failed to bring back: one in eleven, these days, up

from one in thirty. He wants a better hook. He fears the Bedded, who say his failures are the lucky ones. His secret: he was a Dream-Diver once, three dives, and he knows what sixty seconds in the room feels like from the inside. It feels like a lifetime. That is what he is really selling.

TUCKER HAULER Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Attack +6 (hook-and-harness 3, Hooking) · Armor 1 · Dread 0



Rest. That’s all it says on the door. Rest. You’d think it’d say price.

A ROPE-TWISTER, IN THE QUEUE OUTSIDE OLD NOD’S CELLAR

SENNA VOLE, DREAM-DIVER

Forty descents, where three is the usual career. She is thirty-four and looks fifty: grey-haired, gaunt, her wrists and throat ridged with harness-scars, a silver ring through her tongue where the Hall’s hook goes. She speaks slowly and seldom, as if words came from a long

way off. She has mapped the long room to within thirty paces of the eye: the soft floor, the warm air, the sleepers standing in their silent ranks, and the place near the wall where the floor begins to slope downward, toward the lid. On her last dive, something behind the lid said her name. She wants to go back. She tells the Hall she wants to finish the map.

SENNA VOLE – DEEP DIVER OF THE TETHER HALL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Resolve 5, Godsign 4, Lore 4, Endure 3, Search 3, Athletics 2, Blades 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 8
ATTACKS	tether-knife +4 (2)
GIFTS	The Long Room (she may blink at will, under guard, and return with an answer to one question about any Counted sleeper or any blinker in the city). Lidless (cannot be surprised in her line of sight). Room-Calm (immune to Dread from anything she has seen in the room).
WANTS	To lie down (she must resist on a Grim roll whenever she passes the Tether Hall’s bed).
DREAD	3 (to hear her say what she heard)
SECRET	The voice behind the lid did not sound like a god. It sounded like her own voice, asleep. She believes that the eye is not Iss’s at all but all of theirs: everyone who ever went to the room, dreaming one enormous dream with one eye, and that when it opens, it will be the Counted waking up together, as one thing. She has not told the Hall, because she thinks they would stop her diving.

DR. ALDOUS CRANE,
APOTHECARY-GENERAL

Inventor of the current strain of rouse, sixty-one, thin as a heron, with the steady hands of a man who has never in his life taken his own product and the yellow fingertips of a man who handles it all day. He speaks to people as though reading them a dosage. He knows the dose curve and where it ends: there is a point at which the amount of rouse needed to stay awake is the amount that stops the heart, and it is eleven years off, for an average adult; three or four for the Slope, where the cut is worse; less than one for children. He wants a new compound, and has tested nine hundred in the Proving Rooms on prisoners lent by the Rattlehouse. His secret: the Watch has ordered one more compound, the nine hundred and first, finished and warehoused, for the day the beds are full. It is a rouse that does not wake you. It stops you, gently, standing up, and you do not go to the room. He calls it the Last Cake.

◇
Eleven years for an adult. Four for the Slope. Less than one for a child. I give you these figures because you asked, and because nobody else will.

DR. ALDOUS CRANE, TO THE WATCH, IN A SESSION
STRUCK FROM THE STAIR-BOOK

MATRON CECILY DORM

Keeper of the Dormitory, fifty, broad and soft-spoken, in a starched grey gown and felt slippers, with a heavy ring of bed-keys at her belt that she holds still with one hand as she walks so it will not jingle. She is the only living person who knows the number, and she walks the rows every day, counting, under her breath, from one. She has been seen removing a pillow and standing over a bed for a long time. She loves the Counted. She knows their faces as a mother knows her children’s. She hates them, sometimes, with a hatred she confesses to no one.

CECILY DORM – MATRON OF THE DORMITORY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Reckoning 5, Resolve 4, Stitching 3, Search 3, Deceive 3, Rites 2, Brawl 1, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	ring of bed-keys +4 (1)
GIFTS	The Rows Know Her (inside the Dormitory, restless sleepers turn their faces toward her, and she always knows when one has moved). Breath-Matched (she may breathe with the Counted, which hides her from notice inside the Dormitory as long as she is silent).
WANTS	To count (she must finish any count she begins, aloud if necessary, even mid-crisis).
DREAD	2 (to watch her standing over a bed with a pillow)
SECRET	She has smothered four of the Counted, in the oldest rows, testing the Lessening's arithmetic. Each time, within the bell, someone somewhere in the city blinked and did not come back, and was carried in, and the number was exactly what it had been. The count keeps itself. The Lessening's schedule would not reduce the number by a single bed; it would only change who is in them. She has told the Lessening. They have decided not to believe her. She has started to wonder whether she was the one who decided who went down.

GARRON ASHLOCK, LAMPLIGHTER-GENERAL

He keeps ten thousand lamps burning. He is forty-eight, red-faced, burn-scarred to the elbow, with no eyebrows and a cheerful bellow that he has cultivated to hide the fact that he cannot sleep, of course, and cannot rest either, ever, because he can count. He has ninety days of oil, a Brinehollow supplier who has doubled the price and a Fatlands one who has stopped answering, and a standing order from the Watch to tell no one. He wants a miracle and will settle for tallow. His secret: he has already found it. The furnaces on the Row do not burn the dead to ash any more. They render them. A quarter of the city's lamps now burn on the people who used to read by them, and the Guild has begun to look, with a professional eye, at the Dormitory.



*The lamps on the Row smell like Sunday dinner now.
My ma says don't think about it. So I don't. So I don't.*

A LAMP-BOY OF LAMPWRIGHTS' ROW

PIP ELEVEN-BELL

A street nudger of nine, born at the eleventh bell on the Slope, paid by the hour to pinch strangers in the Pinchmarket. Pip is fast, sharp, thin as a pin, all elbows and grubby knuckles, with a voice like a gull and a laugh like a rattle, and the best pinch-fingers in the market. Pip has been unpaid for two weeks by a client who has gone to the room and has been taking rouse from the cheapest dealers to keep working. Children do not last on rouse, and Pip has begun to blink.

Pip wants a proper client, a hot meal and a nudger of their own. Pip fears nothing out loud. Pip's secret: in the blinks, there is a kind lady in the room, in a baker's apron, who holds out her hand and says it is all right to stay. Pip has started to hold on longer each time.

LUKAS MARRE, THE YAWNING MAN

His yawns are catching beyond all reason: one gape of his jaw and a room goes down, a street sways, and once, at nineteen, before he knew, a whole market square. He is thirty-one now and has lived twelve years in a cell in the Glass House, masked in a leather muzzle that holds his jaw half shut, alone, in the coldest corner of the city. He is gentle, bookish and painfully polite, and he apologises through the pane to everyone who visits, and to the guards, and to the Matron, whom he writes to every Plate asking after the people from the square. He wants to be forgiven. His secret: the muzzle does not stop it any more. Lately he only has to feel the yawn rising in himself, and the people on the far side of the glass sway.

SISTER VESPER NULL, PROPHET OF THE BEDDED

She preaches that the eye is kind, the room is home, and the Counted are the only citizens of the Vigil at peace. She is about forty, with smooth unlined skin, clear bright eyes and a calm low voice, and she looks more rested than anyone in the city, and nobody can explain it. Her sermons in the Slope cellars are given in the dark, in a murmur, and her listeners sway. She is not cruel. She holds the hands of the grieving and tells them their dead are waiting, and they weep with relief.

VESPER NULL – SISTER OF THE LID, PROPHET OF THE BEDDED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 11 (the Brink) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Godsign 5, Rites 4, Resolve 3, Instinct 3, Stealth 2
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	none worth the name (+2, 1)
GIFTS	The Lull (anyone who listens to her speak for a scene must make a Caul + Resolve roll, Grim, or gain 3 Weariness and make a blink check). Lay Them Down (Partake: one person who can hear her and has 7+ Weariness falls asleep). Rested (she has no Weariness and is immune to the Seeming).
WANTS	To tuck in (she cannot leave a weeping person without stroking their hair and telling them to rest).
DREAD	3 (to see her wake)
SECRET	She sleeps every night, in a whitewashed cellar under the Slope, and every morning she wakes. Nobody else ever has. The real Vesper Null went to the room nine years ago. What gets up in her body every morning is something the room sends back, a little less like Vesper each time: an emissary, practising. She is the first restless sleeper outside the Dormitory. Her body is the god's rehearsal for walking.



She held my hand in the dark and told me my Davey was waiting, and I believed her, and I have never been so happy, and I hate her for it.

A SLOPE MOTHER, OF SISTER VESPER NULL

CORWIN HALF-BELL, THE MAN WHO WOKE

The only sleeper who ever came back without a tether, after half an hour under, twelve years ago, when a cart-horse kicked him in the ribs where he lay in the street. He is forty, gaunt and grey, and he has not blinked since: his lids have gone stiff and fixed half open from disuse. He flinches whenever a door opens. He will not describe the room. He works as a rope-walker at the Rattlehouse, where the noise comforts him. He wants never to be asked again. His secret, which he will tell only to someone who has been in the room themselves: he heard knocking. Far behind him, at the other end of the long room, at a door none of the sleepers face, someone was knocking, slow and patient and polite, the way a guest knocks. And the eye, he swears, was not sleeping. It was holding still, the way a mouse holds still. It was hiding.

THADDEUS KNELL, CHIEF BELL-RINGER

The city's bells sound every quarter hour to keep it awake, and they deafened him years ago. He is sixty-four, bull-necked, with forearms like hawsers and ears that ooze, and he rings from the great tower over Ludmere Square by the clock and by the shaking in his teeth.

He speaks too loud and reads lips badly. He is the most rested-looking man on the Height, because he hears no lullaby, no rain, no hush; the silence inside him is total and it does not soothe him at all. He wants an apprentice who will not go deaf. His secret: lately the bells do not shake his teeth on the quarter. They shake them a little after, a little later each day, and he has begun ringing by his teeth instead of the Hourkeeper's clock.

MIRELA SCONCE, THE SEEMER

She reads the Seeming for the public record. Forty, sharp-chinned, ink-stained, with a habit of narrating what she sees under her breath, she spends her watches walking the districts with a slate, taking statements, cross-matching witnesses. This month eleven districts, separately, hallucinated the same thing: a tall figure laying a table in the street. She has interviewed two hundred witnesses. Their descriptions match down to the stoop under the doorways and the warmth on the cobbles afterward. She wants to know what it is. She fears the Registrar, who has started striking her entries. Her secret: she saw it too, on Thimble Lane, and it looked up at her, and there was a card on the nearest plate, and her name was on it.

JACK TENTERHOOK, WAKE-VALET

Keeper-awake to the rich, an artist of the precisely tolerable pain. He is forty-five, elegant, soft-handed, with a velvet roll of silver pins and a voice like warm oil. He arrives at a client's house at the first bell and leaves at the last, and between them he keeps his client awake with an exquisite programme of pinches, pricks, ice and pressure, never too much, never too little. His clients swear by him and recommend him to their friends. He was a torturer before, for the Rattlehouse's lower floors, and says the only difference is the tipping.

JACK TENTERHOOK – WAKE-VALET TO THE HEIGHT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Stitching 5, Blades 3, Persuade 3, Intimidate 3, Deceive 3, Search 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 16 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	silver pins +7 (2, plus the target's next roll at -2); scalpel +7 (2)
GIFTS	The Exquisite (when he needles a person, they lose 1d6 Weariness and owe him a favour they will feel). The Ledger of Nerves (he can make a captive talk without leaving a mark; Clause-proof).
WANTS	To watch (he cannot resist observing a person in pain to the end).
DREAD	2 (to watch him practise)
SECRET	He keeps clients awake. He also keeps them sleepy. He has six on the Height whom he has been very carefully not quite waking for a year, just enough to keep them blinking, on commission from the Lessening, who needed members of the Watch to be suggestible. Two of those six have blink-murdered.

INSPECTOR HALE GRIMMER

He investigates blink-murders, killings done by ordinary people during a two-second sleep, with no memory after. He has forty-one cases. The method is the same in each: the victim laid flat on the floor, a folded cloth beneath the head, hands crossed on the chest, eyes closed under the killer's thumbs, and the killer's palms laid gently over mouth and nose until the breathing stops. Every killer comes back with no memory and the victim's teeth in their palm. Grimmer is fifty, ragged, chain-chewing rouse, with a mind that goes on working long after his body has stopped wanting to. He wants to know who is doing it. He fears that he will be next, in one direction or the other. His secret is what he found last week: all forty-one victims were members of the Lessening, down to Tobin Coyle, the Slope rope-twister, who copied Dormitory registers for them at night for beer money. Something is defending the Counted.



*Forty-one. Same hands, same pillow, same thumbs.
Same thing in common, too, and I've only just seen it.
Something is keeping house.*

INSPECTOR HALE GRIMMER, TO HIS OWN CASE-
BOOK

ODILE FARTHING

Her son, Marten, fell asleep at four, eleven years ago, in her arms, on a grey afternoon, while she was counting out loud to him. She visits bed 40,112 daily, and stands at its foot for an hour, and talks. She is thirty-eight, rouse-thin and quiet, with the scabbed wrists of a woman who has had no nudger but herself. The Counted do not age, but her boy has grown. He is the size of a man now, long and broad under the sheet, with a man's hands and a man's jaw and a beard coming in, and he is smiling. She wants him back. She fears

what will come back. Her secret: when she leans close, he smells of bread, and his lips move along with hers when she counts.

BENEDIKT LOUR, THE ARCHITECT

He designed the modern city: the sloped floors, the one-legged chairs, the studded walls, the endless Stair. He is seventy, frail, bent, with the elegant scrawl of a man whose hands shake for everything but a pen, and he is proud of every discomfort he has ever invented. He is now drawing a Second Dormitory. He has been told to plan for the whole population. He has drafted it on the Pillow, the only open ground left, and the drawings show four hundred thousand beds, in rows, radiating outward from the hollow like the rays of an eye. He wants to finish before he dies. He fears that the Watch will not wait. His secret: the Second Dormitory has no doors that lock from the inside, and its ventilation is designed to carry warm air.

ROOK QUARTER-BELL

A rouse dealer on the Slope, twenty-two, lean, quick, wolfish, his teeth already gone, gums packed black with his own product. He cuts what he sells with bottled Brinehollow brine, bought by the cask from Dry Jonah's agents, because it is cheap and it works. His customers stay awake longer than anyone else's. They have also started bailing salt water every dawn and dusk, and walking west. There are two hundred of them now, in a slow eyes-open column. Rook wants to stop selling it and cannot, because nothing else holds. His secret: he has been taking it himself. He tastes salt every morning, and he has started standing at windows facing west.

ENVOY CASTELLAN DRAY

The Warden's ambassador to Sallowreach, fifty-five, a tall immaculate Eye-line courtier with a lidless stare and a chest of documents he never lets out of sight, travelling with twelve paid nudgers and a cask of Bitterhouse rouse. His commission is to buy the secret of Keeping, so that the Vigil's citizens can be killed and

kept upright: a city of the dead, who never need to sleep. He has been in Lastgate for two months, negotiating with the Regent. He wants to save his city. He fears that the price will be paid in its people. His secret: he has learned that the Kept cannot leave Sallowreach, and that the Vigil would have to move there, all of it, to die; and he has not yet told the Warden, because he thinks she will say yes.

*I tell him about the weather. I tell him about the roof.
Last week he told me something back. His lips did. I
won't tell you what.*

ODILE FARTHING, AT THE FOOT OF BED 40,112

AVELINE MORNE, THE SLEEPER
IN BED ONE

A baker’s daughter, nineteen years old forever, who lay down on the First Night in 341 and was the first not to rise. She has lain unmoving for three hundred years under a white sheet in a bed with a brass rail, a plump fair girl with flour still in the creases of her

knuckles, cheeks pink, lips slightly parted, breathing with the rows. Last month her lips began to shape words. The Matron has started writing them down. Most of them are names, one a day, and each person named has gone to the room the next day. One, last week, was a sentence: *There is someone at the door who has not been fed. Set another place.*

*There is someone at the door who has not been fed. Set
another place.*

BED ONE, AS WRITTEN DOWN BY THE MATRON,
CARVING 641

NEW CHARACTERS

DEPUTY-WATCHER SABINE LARCH, FIRST OF THE
LESSENING

An Eye-line Watcher of the second shift, forty-four, lidless, soft-voiced, with a mathematician’s courtesy and the kind of face people forget while it is in front of them. She sits on the Matron’s oversight committee and has read every register in the Dormitory. Her lists are in her own hand.

SABINE LARCH – DEPUTY-WATCHER, FIRST OF THE LESSENING	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Eye-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Reckoning 5, Clause 4, Deceive 4, Persuade 3, Resolve 3, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 5
ATTACKS	stiletto +3 (2)
GIFTS	Perfect Recall (as Stroud). The Calm Sum (when she explains her arithmetic, listeners must succeed at a Caul + Resolve roll, Hard, or accept it as reasonable for the rest of the scene).
WANTS	To count (she reduces every crowd to a number and cannot stop).
DREAD	2 (to read her lists)
SECRET	Her sister is in bed 3,315. Bed 3,315 is the first name on the list.

REGISTRAR CONSTANCE Hobb

Keeper of the Public Record of the Seeming, sixty, white-gloved, iron-haired. She decides which Seemings are entered and which are struck. A Seeming not entered, she says, did not occur. She has struck forty Seemings of the tall figure this year, and every report of blink-murders, and she has entered, on Watch instruction, three Seemings that nobody saw: a fire that justified condemning a Bedded cellar, a riot that justified the doubled needle-patrols, and the death of Corwin Half-Bell, who is still alive. When citizens come to her to insist on what they saw, she shows them the record, kindly, until they doubt it. She sleeps, she believes, not at all. Her secret: her own clerk tells her she has blinked eleven times today, and she has entered none of them.

SISTER AGATHE PINCH, MISTRESS OF THE
NEEDLE

Head instructor at the Rattlehouse and author of the current edition of the Atlas of the Quick, sixty-eight, tiny, bright-eyed and grandmotherly, with a cap of white lace and a lap-tray of needles laid out like embroidery tools. She has trained every Waker alive. She believes that pain is a teacher and that the city’s Wakers must learn it first on their own bodies, and every recruit spends their first week strapped in a standing-stall under her needles, so they will know. She is loved by her students the way a scar is loved. Her secret: on the Rattlehouse’s lowest floor she keeps a man who has been awake under the needle for nineteen years. She uses him to teach. He has stopped screaming. He hums.

TEODOR RELL, KEEPER OF THE LAIN BOOK

A laundress's widower, forty, from Gallow Street on the Slope, who found his wife's note pinned to her good coat and has not been able to stop reading it. He took a clerk's post at the Dormitory so that he could see her every day, and the Matron gave him the Lain Book: the register of those who went to the room by choice, with their notes copied out, two hundred to four hundred a year. He reads every note. He answers some of them aloud, at the foot of the bed. He is gentle, tired beyond tiredness, and very dangerous to himself. He has kept his promise not to lie down after her. His secret: he has begun writing a note of his own, a line a day, so that it will be ready.

LORD EVANDER QUELL OF THE SECOND TABLE

An Eye-line Watcher of the first shift, fifty, handsome, lidless, beautifully mannered, and the Second Table's senior hand in the Vigil. He believes the eye's opening is the best news in six centuries: the god of sleep, whole again, in one place, awake and blinking and catchable. He has a set of felt-wrapped knives in a case on his wall, a choir of twelve trained in *The Lamb and the Lid*, and the Matron's spare keys. He wants the number reached. Not exceeded, not prevented: reached, cleanly, on a date he can plan for. His secret: he has been feeding Sabine Larch's lists to Jack Tenterhook's clients, and he knows exactly what the blink-murders are, and he finds them encouraging.

FACTOR JOSS MALLORY OF THE LAST BEDS

The Rim Road Company's innkeeper at the foot of the Pilgrim Road, fifty, big-bellied, foreign, comfortable, with the only soft voice and the only soft bed within thirty miles of the Vigil. Every Company caravan stops at his inn so its drivers can sleep before the climb, and every Vigilant coming down on business stops at his sleeping-hall doorway and looks at the beds. He keeps a book of the ones his porters could not stop. He sells passes across the border, maps of the Sleepers' Mile, rouse, nudgers and gossip. He is the first friendly face most PCs see before the Lid, and the last one some see before the room. His secret: the Watch pays him a bounty for every Vigilant his porters drag back from the beds. The Lessening pays him a larger one for every Vigilant they don't.

WAKER PATROL Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (long needle 2, target loses 2 Weariness; rattle-club 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

SLOPE BLINKER (AN INNOCENT MID-BLINK) Threat 1 · Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (bare hands 1, Smother: a grappled target lying down loses 2 Flesh a round) · Armor 0 · Dread 2

RESTLESS SLEEPER Threat 4 · Flesh 20 · Guard 9 · Attack +6 (embrace 2, the held must make a blink check each round) · Armor 0 · Dread 3

BRINE WALKER Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (fists 1, will not stop walking west) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

▼ PLAYING A VIGILANT

You will never rest. Not once, not for a breath, not until you are on the Row. Now go and do something with it.

— WHAT SLOPE MOTHERS SAY TO A CHILD ON THE MORNING OF THE COMING-HEAVY

A Vigilant has been awake since the age of four. Every hour of every day of their life is still behind their eyes. They are sharp-sighted, suspicious, quick to see a lie and quicker to see a yawn, and they are carrying a weight that no one from any other land can imagine. They have a nudger, or they had one. They know someone in the Dormitory. They do not trust their own memory, and they are right not to.

Attribute bonus: +1 EYE.



You will never rest. You will never rest. Say it back to me. Good. Now you are one of us.

THE WORDS OF THE COMING-HEAVY, AS SAID IN
NEEDLEGATE

QUESTIONS FOR A VIGILANT

Answer these when you make a Vigilant, and tell the table at least three of the answers. The GM will use the rest.

- ◆ **Who is your nudger?** Name them. Do you love them? Do you trust them? Are they a Copy?
- ◆ **Whose bed do you visit?** Give the number. Every Vigilant has one. When did you last go, and what did you tell them?
- ◆ **What is in your blink-book that you have not read?** Your nudger wrote it. You have never asked.
- ◆ **Which bell were you born at,** and what does your family say about children of that bell?
- ◆ **What is the worst thing you have done in a blink** that you know about? What does the person you did it to think happened?

- ◇ **Have you ever lain down?** For a breath, on purpose, in a Tucker's cellar, under a sheet, in a doorway, on a grey afternoon? Who fetched you back, and do you thank them?
- ◇ **What do you see in the lamps?** Every Vigilant has a private Seeming they have had since the Bright Years. Name it.

WEARINESS

Every character in the Vigil, native or foreign, tracks **Weariness** from 0 to 10. A foreigner who has slept well arrives at 0. A Vigilant has never slept and can never fall below 2: that is the floor, the silt of a lifetime.

Gaining Weariness. +1 for each watch (eight hours) spent without a dose of rouse. +1 for each scene of comfort: warmth, softness, a full meal, rain on a roof, quiet, a long dull wait, a lullaby, a sermon. Yawn days double all gains. A contagious yawn in earshot calls for a Caul + Resolve roll (Routine, or Hard from a Glass House yawner); failure adds +1. A Tooth that bites back (see below) adds +1.

WEARINESS	STATE	EFFECT
0–2	Fresh	As fresh as anyone on the Lid.
3–4	Heavy	–1 on all Eye and Lung rolls.
5–6	Drifting	–2 on Eye and Lung rolls. The Seeming begins. Blink checks on triggers.
7–8	Grey	–2 on all rolls. Blink check every scene, and on triggers. Dread checks one step harder.
9	Going Under	Blink check every few minutes of play.
10	Asleep	The character falls asleep (see below).

Falling asleep. At Weariness 10 the character sleeps, and goes to the room. A nudger has one breath to fetch them: a Hand + Stitching or Tongue + Intimidate roll at Hard (a Waker's needle succeeds automatically if it is already drawn). If that fails, the nudger may try once more, at Grim, in the next breath. After that the character is Counted. There is no further roll. Foreigners and Vigilants alike are carried to the Dormitory and given a number.

BLINKS

A **blink check** is Caul + Resolve against a Difficulty set by Weariness: Routine at 5–6, Hard at 7–8, Grim at 9. Characters in

Shedding Weariness. A dose of rouse removes 2 Weariness and prevents gains from the watch's passing for that watch; a day's rouse costs 2 lacks on the Height and half that, cut, on the Slope. A second dose in the same watch requires a Gut + Endure roll (Hard; Grim for a third); failure costs 2 Flesh, and a Lack is a rouse-heart: the character suffers Ruin. A pin, slap or pinch from a nudger removes 1 Weariness, once a scene. A Waker's long needle removes 2 and costs 1 Flesh. Foreigners sleeping outside the Vigil's borders clear Weariness to 0. Vigilants have nowhere to sleep.

the Appetite or beyond (Regrowth 4+) make blink checks on triggers even below Weariness 5, at Routine. Triggers are anything that would make a tired person drift: warmth, softness, silence, monotony, a yawn, lying down, a voice that murmurs, watching the Dormitory breathe.

On a failure the character blinks, and the GM rolls on the table below. Each blink also adds 1 Fray, for the lost time, whether or not the character learns what happened. On a Lack, the GM rolls twice and uses both results, and if the character sees what they did, they make a Dread check at the rating the GM judges right (usually 2 or 3).

DIO	THE BLINK
1–4	A second gone. You lose the last thing said, and drop what you were holding.
5–6	Moved. You are up to ten paces from where you stood, facing another way.
7	You said something. The GM speaks one line in your voice, often a true thing you wanted kept.
8	Your hands did something small: a lamp put out, a door unbarred, a word written.
9	The room held you longer: d6 minutes, standing. You remember the warmth and nothing else.

D10	THE BLINK
10	Tucked. The most vulnerable person near you is lying down, eyes closed, and your hands are on them. Roll d6: on 1–4 you came back in time.

WHAT YOU DID IN THE BLINK

When a blink lasts longer than a breath (a result of 9 on the table above, a Lack on a blink check, the *Lost Seconds* Gift, or any time the GM judges the room held the character longer), roll d20 instead of, or as well as, the d10. The character does not remember any of it.

They find out the way the Vigil always finds out: from the evidence, from the faces of the people around them, and from their blink-book, in someone else's handwriting. A character who learns what they did makes a Dread check at the rating the GM judges right; results marked † are always at least Dread 2.

D20	WHAT YOU DID
1	Wrote a name in lamp-black on the nearest surface. It is your own name, in a hand you do not know.
2	Took off your shoes and set them side by side, toes to the door, the way the Lain-Down leave them. †
3	Unbarred the nearest door or shutter and opened it a hand's width. Warm air is coming in.
4	Put out the nearest lamp with your fingers. The tips are blistered and smell of clean linen.
5	Told the person nearest you, very gently, that they look tired. They have begun to yawn and cannot stop.
6	Crossed your own hands on your chest. They are still crossed when you come back, and it is hard to uncross them.
7	Hummed the first three notes of <i>The Lamb and the Lid</i> . Someone heard. Somebody is already running for a Waker.
8	Gave something away (your purse, your rouse, your knife). The one who has it says you insisted, and you were so kind about it.
9	Walked 2d6 × 10 paces toward the Dormitory or the Pillow, whichever is nearer, and you are standing facing it.
10	Laid out a table on the nearest flat surface: cups, plates, whatever was to hand, one place for each person present, and one more. †
11	Answered a question nobody asked, aloud. The GM tells another player privately what you said. It was true.
12	Wrote a bed number in your own blink-book, in your own hand. You do not recognise it. It is occupied.
13	Pinched the nearest person so hard you drew blood. They thanked you. They are looking at you strangely now.
14	Pressed your face against something warm (a stove, a wall, a horse's flank) and stood there nuzzling. Someone respectable saw.
15	Took the rouse out of a companion's pouch and ate it. They gain 2 Weariness when they next reach for it.
16	Folded a coat or cloth into a neat pillow and laid it on the floor. No one is lying on it. Yet. †
17	Lied to your nudger, perfectly: told them you had not blinked. There is no entry in your book. Only you know, now.
18	Spoke to the room in the voice of one of your dead. Everyone who heard knows whose voice it was. †
19	Stroked the hair of the most frightened person present and told them it was all right to rest. They gain 3 Weariness and make a blink check. †
20	Tucked. Someone is lying on the floor, hands crossed, a cloth under their head, and your palms are on their face. Dread 3. Roll d6: on 1–3 you came back in time; on 4–5 they are breathing slow and even and will not wake; on 6 they have stopped, and their teeth are in your hand. †

GM ADVICE – DID I BLINK?

Blinks are a tool for gaslighting the players, gently and fairly. Once a character is Drifting or worse, the GM may tell a player that something has changed, a door now open, a companion now across the room, a cup now empty, and decline to say whether it is a blink or a Seeming or the truth. A character may make an Eye + Reckoning roll (Routine at Drifting, Hard at Grey) to trust a memory; on a failure, they cannot be sure, and NPCs who say otherwise are as likely to be right. Never use this to cheat players out of earned success. Use it to make them look at one another and ask, quietly, *did you see me move?*

WATCHED AND UNWATCHED

A Vigilant's nudge is not a convenience. It is half of a life. A character whose sworn nudge is present in a scene gains +2 on blink checks, and the nudge, not the character, rolls to fetch them if they fall asleep. A character who is *unwatched*, with no one in the scene who has undertaken to keep them awake, makes every blink check one step harder when alone, and gains 1 Fray at the end of any scene in which nobody noticed they had blinked. Player characters may nudge each other, and are encouraged to swear it; a party that pinches each other's wrists and says *pinch me* before a dangerous scene gains the bonus for that scene. Breaking a sworn nudging, by walking away from a drowsing companion, by failing to slap, by

being the one who sat down first, is a Dread 2 matter for the one who broke it, and the Vigil never quite forgives it.

THE SEEMING

At Weariness 5 and above, the GM gives characters private hallucinations: voices in the lamps, insects in the plaster, the dead in the lane. Shared Seemings, which a whole street sees, are real enough for law in the Vigil whether or not they are real at all. An Eye + Search roll at Hard tells a character whether a Seeming leaves traces (warm cobbles, a crumb, a place card). A character who Breaks in the Vigil most often takes a Derangement of the Seeming: that a loved one has been replaced by a sleeper's dream of them; that they themselves are asleep in a bed and dreaming all of this; that the room is real and the city is the dream.

SEEMINGS AT THE TABLE

When a character at Weariness 5 or more is in a quiet moment, a grey afternoon, a long wait, a crowd, or anywhere near the Dormitory, the GM may roll d20 for a Seeming, or choose. If only one character is Drifting or worse, it is private, and the GM should tell that player alone. If two or more characters present are at Weariness 5 or more, roll d6: on a 1–2 they share it, and may disagree about the details for the rest of the campaign. Any Seeming may be real. An Eye + Search roll at Hard finds traces, if there are any.

D20	THE SEEMING
1	A rain of teeth over the street, small and white, clicking on the tin roofs. They are milk teeth. They melt like hail.
2	A woman made of moths walks down the lane. Every lamp she passes gutters and dims. She stops in front of you, and you smell flour.
3	Every face in the crowd turns toward you at once, eyes closed; then, all together, opens them.
4	Someone you lost, at the end of the lane, in their good coat, holding out a hand. When you blink they are a step closer.
5	The bells strike, but the bell-ropes in the tower you can see are hanging perfectly still. They strike one more than they should.
6	Snow falls out of the lamp-smoke. It is warm. It is not snow. It is down, soft and white, settling on your sleeves.
7	A door in a wall that has no door. Warm light under it. The smell of clean linen. Someone on your side of it is reaching for the latch.
8	The brown smoke-ceiling over the city rises and falls, slowly, four times to the minute, and you are breathing with it.
9	A tall stooping figure in a grey coat, laying a table down the lane. A card at the nearest plate. The GM decides whose name is on it.
10	A procession of the Counted, in their sheets, eyes shut, walking in step up the lane toward the Pillow. One of them is someone you know.
11	Your own body, laid out on a board in the street, the neighbours queueing to touch its eyes. They look envious.
12	Insects under the plaster crawl into the shape of numbers. It is a bed number. It changes when you look away.
13	Every lamp flame in sight leans the same way, toward the centre of the Lid, as if something there were drawing breath.
14	A child's voice in every speaking-tube, drain and chimney, counting, slowly, somewhere past fifty-nine thousand.
15	The cobbles go soft and warm under your feet, like the Pillow. When you step off them your footprints stay, pressed and shallow.
16	A young man's face in every window you pass, gentle, apologetic, yawning. Lukas Marre is in the Glass House, on the far side of the Lid.
17	The sky closes: a vast grey lid, downy and slow, comes down across the lamp-glow from the east, and everything goes dim and kind.
18	Everyone you know is, for the rest of the scene, very slightly wrong. Kinder. Patient. They answer the Asking perfectly.

D20	THE SEEMING
19	Knocking: slow, polite, three times, at every door in the street at once. Nobody is standing at any of them.
20	It leaves something behind: warm crumbs on the cobbles, a felt slipper, a place card with a player character's name, written in a fine old hand.

THE SOP: THE LULL

Iss is quieted by rest, and in the Vigil rest is a crime. The **Lull** is the act of closing your eyes on purpose for a count of ten while a nudger holds your hand. It removes 1d6 Hunger. It feeds the Want to lie down. The character must immediately make a blink check at Hard, whatever their Weariness; on a failure they are in the room for the count, and their nudger must fetch them back as if they had fallen

asleep. Every Vigilant knows someone who took the Lull once too often.

THE LONG WAKING IN PLAY

When a character Breaks in the Vigil, they may take one of the Derangements below in place of one from the core rules. Each is resisted, when triggered, with Caul + Resolve at Hard, like any Derangement. They are not exotic in the Vigil. Half the people on any street have one.

D6	DERANGEMENT	TRIGGER AND EFFECT
1	The Copy	Choose a loved one: they have been replaced. Triggered by their kindness. You cannot accept help from them, and you perform the Asking whenever you can. They always answer correctly.
2	Already Counted	You are asleep in a bed and dreaming all this. Triggered by pain or by the Dormitory. You ignore Weariness penalties for the scene and refuse rouse; at the end of the scene gain 2 Weariness.
3	Borrowed Hands	Your hands are not yours. Triggered by a blink. -2 on Hand rolls until someone you trust holds them and says your name.
4	The Watch-Self	You have a second self (see below). Triggered by the change of watch or by a Lack.
5	At the Window	You lose hours standing still. Triggered by a grey afternoon or Fray 5+. The GM may skip you forward up to a long watch; you gain 1 Weariness and smell of linen.
6	The Lamp-Friend	The voice you heard in the lamps as a child has come back, and it is reasonable, and it knows things. Triggered by Partaking. It gives you one true fact a session, and one lie, and you cannot tell them apart.

The Watch-Self. A character with this Derangement shares their body with another person. The player and GM create that self together: a name, an age they believe they are, one thing they love that the character does not, one Want from the Vigil's list, and one secret. The other self has the same Attributes and Skills, and no memory of the character's hours. When triggered and not mastered, the other self takes the next scene, played by the player with the GM's guidance, and the character comes back with lost time, a changed purse, and very often a note. Over a campaign the two may come to an arrangement. They may not. A Watch-Self can be ended only by the treatment of Derangements in the core rules, which in the Vigil means months of patient nudging by someone who will learn both names, and which, the Slope says, always leaves one of the two feeling as though they have been lain down.

THE TOOTH

When a Vigilant Partakes, their pupils blow wide and black, the world slows and softens at its edges, sounds come as if through a wall, and for a heartbeat they see the scene as if from very high up and very far away, every detail at once. Everyone nearby yawns. The air smells of clean linen. When a Tooth shows a 1 and the god bites back, the character takes the extra Hunger and +1 Weariness as well, and their next blink check is one step harder.

GIFTS

The Taste (Regrowth 1–3). Choose one. *The Catching Yawn:* Partake and yawn deliberately; everyone in earshot with Weariness 3+ makes a Caul + Resolve roll at Hard or gains 2 Weariness and loses their next action to drowsiness. You gain 1 Weariness yourself. *Heavy-Eyed:* you always know when someone in sight is about to blink, gaining +2 to Instinct and Search against blinkers, and you know when someone lies about having blinked.

The Appetite (Regrowth 4–6). Choose one. *Lost Seconds:* Partake and blink on purpose; for 1d6 seconds you are gone, and you reappear up to ten paces away anywhere you could have walked. Nobody present remembers seeing you move. Roll on the Blink table afterwards, rerolling results of 1–6. *The Long Look:* blink under a nudger's guard and ask the GM one question about a Counted sleeper or anyone currently blinking in the city; gain 2 Weariness and 1 Fray.

The Course (Regrowth 7–9). *Lidless.* Your lids shrink and are gone. You gain +2 to Search and can never be surprised by anything in your line of sight. You remember everything you have seen. Dread checks against anything before your eyes are one step harder, because you cannot look away. Your eyes must be wetted every half minute; without it you lose 1 Flesh an hour and are blind within a

day. And the great privilege of the Eye-lines is yours: a lidless character who reaches Weariness 10 does not sleep. Instead they Break, at once, and their Weariness drops to 7. This is not mercy. It is how the Eye-lines rule.

The Brink (Regrowth 10–11). *Lay Them Down.* Partake and speak softly to one person with Weariness 5+ who can hear you; they make a Caul + Resolve roll at Grim or fall asleep, and go to the room. Each use forces a Dread 3 check on you. While you are at the Brink, everyone who spends a scene in the same room as you gains 1 Weariness, and restless sleepers turn their faces toward you.

THE WANTS

- ◇ **To lie down.** Triggered by beds, softness, warmth, a body lying peacefully, the Pillow. Resist with Caul + Resolve at Hard; on a failure, the character presses against the comfort for a minute and makes a blink check.
- ◇ **To count.** Triggered by rows, crowds, sleepers and fear. Resist at Routine; on a failure, the character must count the thing aloud to the end before acting.
- ◇ **To watch.** Triggered by a sleeping or drowsing person. Resist at Hard; on a failure, the character cannot leave that person unwatched for the scene.
- ◇ **To tuck in** (the Brink only). Triggered by a weeping, wounded or frightened person. Resist at Grim; on a failure, the character tries to make them lie down and rest.

THE SEATING

At Regrowth 12 the character falls asleep, one last time, smiling, and no nudger on the Table can fetch them. They are carried to the Dormitory and given a number. Their player should take a moment with that. Later, perhaps much later, the GM may tell the surviving characters that a sleeper in a certain bed has become restless. Lips first. The god has been furnishing the character from the inside, and when it speaks, it will use their voice, and it will know their friends' names, and it will be very glad to see them.

BACKGROUND CONCEPTS

- ◇ **Slope Nudger.** Born at a bell, pinching strangers for crumbs by six, you know every rouse-cut on the Slope and every face that is about to go down. You have outlived three clients.
- ◇ **Washed-Out Waker.** You did your week in Sister Pinch's standing-stall, and your year on the beat, and then you put the needle down one night and could not pick it up. You still know the Atlas. You still hear the screams as thanks.
- ◇ **Eye-line Spare.** A younger child of a lidless house, born with eyelids, or born lidless and too far down the line to matter. You have been educated, watched, and kept out of sight, and you have never once been allowed to look away.

- ◇ **Bedside Visitor.** Somebody you love is in the Dormitory, and you have stood at the foot of their bed every day for years at your visiting bell. You know the orderlies, the clerks, the hymn of the halls and the way the breathing changes. You suspect, lately, that the one in the bed knows you are there.
- ◇ **Lantern Survivor.** You did three days in a Lantern in a public square, years ago, for lying down on a grey afternoon, and you came out believing the crowd had eaten part of you. You are still not sure they did not. You have no fear of crowds at all, now, which frightens them.
- ◇ **Hangwell Gatherer.** You grew up on the ropes of the north cliffs, chewing raw stare moss, and you have heard the whole cliff call your name as someone fell. You are the most awake person in any room, and you see a great grey lid in every rock face.
- ◇ **Tucker's Counter.** You counted sixty over sleepers in a warm cellar, for money, and hauled most of them back. You know the count to the breath. You know exactly how long a minute is from the outside, and that is the only thing you are sure you know.
- ◇ **Lessening Copyist.** You copied Dormitory registers at night for beer money and never asked what for. Then you saw a list. Now you count the blink-murders in the bell-sheets, and every one of them is a name you knew from the copying-room.
- ◇ **Burner's Apprentice.** You worked the vats behind the Row for a season before you understood what came in on the carts. You kept the wage. You still cannot be in a room with a lamp without knowing, by the smell, that it is someone.

A VIGILANT ABROAD

The rule follows the blood, and a Vigilant who leaves the Lid takes the room with them. There is no bed on the Table they can lie in. On the Rim Road they travel with paid nudgers and chests of rouse, and in Sallowreach or Oathen they are the strangers who stand at the back of every inn all night, pinching their own wrists, watching the locals sleep with an expression the locals find hard to bear. The rest of the Table thinks them mad, rude, morbid and frightening. They are right on every count. A Vigilant abroad keeps tracking Weariness exactly as on the Lid, but every scene of comfort counts double, because the rest of the world is so soft, and a Vigilant who sees another person asleep for the first time must make a Dread 1 check, because the sight is obscene and holy and they cannot look away. Foreign party members who sleep near a Vigilant should know that the Vigilant is watching them do it, every night, and counting their breaths, and that it is the most intimate thing a Vigilant can do for another person.

PLAYING THE WEIGHT

Play a Vigilant as someone carrying something. They do not complain about tiredness; nobody on the Lid does. They are rude, because rudeness keeps people awake. They argue for the sake of it,

and they mean it as friendship. They touch people more than other Tablefolk, briskly, a pinch, a slap, a hand on the wrist, and they think of it as tenderness. They distrust anyone who looks rested. They count things. They suspect the people they love of being copies and love them anyway. They have done something terrible in a blink and they know it and they cannot remember it. And underneath all of it, every minute of every watch, they want to lie down, and they are not going to, and that refusal, repeated forever, is the bravest thing on the Table.



The eye is patient. Be rude.

VIGIL PROVERB, AND THE WHOLE OF ITS ADVICE TO STRANGERS

NAMES

Feminine: Aveline, Cecily, Iselde, Ilvane, Maud, Mirela, Odile, Oriel, Senna, Vesper, Constance, Agathe, Sabine, Hesper, Annick, Merrit, Lisbet, Wenna.

Masculine: Aldous, Benedikt, Brannoch, Castellán, Corwin, Evander, Garron, Hale, Lukas, Marten, Teodor, Thaddeus, Tobin, Ansgar, Pell, Florian.

Neutral and bell-names (the Slope): Pip, Rook, Wick, Ember, Nod, Rue, Quill; with a bell for a surname: Eleven-Bell, Quarter-Bell, Half-Bell, First-Bell, Dusk-Bell.

Surnames: Stroud, Sexton, Pyre, Vole, Crane, Dorm, Ashlock, Marre, Null, Knell, Sconce, Tenterhook, Grimmer, Farthing, Lour, Dray, Morne, Larch, Hobb, Rell, Quell, Coyle, Lantern, Wakely, Pinchbeck, Startle.

▼HORRORS OF THE VIGIL

GM ADVICE – USING THE HORRORS

Roll d10, or choose, when the city needs to remind the party where they are. Most of these scenes call for a Dread check (Dread 1 or 2; Dread 3 where someone the party knows is involved), and most of them happen on a grey, quiet afternoon. Several are good moments to ask everyone at Weariness 5 or above for a blink check.

D10	HORROR
1	A whole rouse-house yawns in a wave, bench by bench, jaws cracking, eyes streaming, and at the far end of it a man sits down on the floor, smiling, and does not get up. Everyone looks at the party.
2	A Dormitory cart passes down the Slope piled with the day’s sleepers, warm, breathing in time. The crowd counts them aloud. At the last body the counting stops: it is someone the party spoke to this morning.
3	A Waker needles a drowsing girl at a street corner, under the nail, the armpit, behind the ear. She screams and thanks him. Her mother pays him. He moves on to the next.
4	A Seeming: every lamp in the lane flickers in rhythm, slow, four beats to the minute, and the party’s own breathing has already matched it.
5	A woman runs up, wet-faced, asking whether the party saw her blink, because her nudger is lying on the floor with his eyes closed and her hands smell of his breath.
6	A child of four is crying in a doorway that she is so tired, she is so tired, why can’t she lie down. Her mother is slapping her, sobbing, again and again, harder each time.
7	The Lantern in the square holds a man in his fifth day. He thinks the crowd is eating him. Some of the crowd have started to agree, and one has a knife.
8	Someone in a window is humming the first three notes of <i>The Lamb and the Lid</i> . Every head on the street turns. A Waker begins to run.
9	Lain-Down: a neat pair of shoes on a doorstep, a folded coat on top, a note pinned to it, and the open door of a dark, warm room.
10	A Brine Walker column shuffles past, eyes open, coughing salt water, all of them facing west. One of them is someone a PC loves, who does not know them.

The Lamb and the Lid, as recorded in the Rattlehouse register of forbidden matter, the only copy permitted to exist.
Hush now, lamb, the lid is low,

*the long room’s warm and the lamps burn slow;
lie you down where the sleepers keep,
and the eye won’t open while the lambs still sleep.*

*Hush now, lamb, and count to three,
there's a bed for you and a bed for me;*

*and when the beds are full, my sweet,
the eye will open, and we'll all go to eat.*



CHAPTER 7

CRADLEWRACK

The Land in Labor

First we ask what it is. Then we ask whether it stays.

– THE MIDWIFE’S TWO QUESTIONS

Knock before you open. Whatever is on the other side has a right to be warned, and so do you.

– CRADLEWRACK PROVERB, TAUGHT BEFORE THE ALPHABET



Set down by Wenna Thrale, apprentice of the Attendance, third year of her apron, for the Lying-In’s own book and not for the Tally. Rudge parish, the fourth night after a pang, Carving 641.

They sent for us at the second bell because the father had begun. Not the mother: she had been delivered of a girl in Grace and sat by the hearth with the girl at her breast and her face to the wall. It was the father on the floor, a shepherd’s son named Corran with hands like spades, curled on the red clay in a shirt soaked black. The room smelled the way every highland room smells when something is coming: iron, wet wool, and under it the warm salt of the springs, as if the ground had broken its waters under the house.

Mother Sabeth went to him first. I went to the door, as I was taught, because the door had opened on its own when we came in and would not stay shut. I put my back to it. I could feel it pushing, very gently, the way a hand pushes from the inside of a belly. I have stood against a hundred doors and that is the only way I can describe it.

Corran’s belly was not large. That was the worst of it. It was a man’s flat belly, but the skin of it was moving in a long slow roll from the ribs to the groin, and each time it rolled he made a sound I have heard cattle make and never a man. Sabeth laid her palm on him and counted under her breath. Then she opened her case and laid out the things in the order we lay them out: the cord-thread, the basin, the clean linen, the bone hook, and last, wrapped in its own oiled cloth, the knife.

It took until the fourth bell. I will write only that he did not open where a woman opens, because he has nowhere to, and that he opened at an old scar on his flank from a ram’s horn, twenty years shut and white, which parted now like a mouth deciding to speak. Sabeth had her arm in him to the elbow and her face was calm. The mother at the hearth did not turn around once. The baby at her breast did not cry once, but watched.

What came out was the size of a lamb and the color of the clay floor. It had a great many fingers. It drew breath. That is the thing nobody tells you before your apron, that they all draw breath, that the first sound out of the worst of them is the same small wet gasp as out of the best. Sabeth held it up in the lamplight and turned it, slowly, the way you turn a pot to look for cracks, and she asked the First Question aloud, because it must be asked aloud.

What is it.

Nobody answered. Nobody ever answers. She answered it herself, quietly, in the words of the Book, and then she was quiet for a long time. Corran had stopped making his sound. The door had stopped pushing against my back. The only noise in the room was the thing breathing and the clay ticking as it cooled. I counted eleven breaths. I have been told since that Sabeth Thorne never takes more than three. She looked at it for eleven.

Then she asked the Second Question, and she answered it, and she unwrapped the oiled cloth.

I am meant to write what I saw, for the Lying-In’s book. I saw her turn her back to the hearth so the mother would not see. I saw her shoulder move once. I saw her wrap the linen and tie the knot we tie, the one that cannot come undone, and hand the bundle to me without looking at it, and I held it, and it was warm, and it stayed warm against my chest the whole cold walk back to the Lying-In, longer than it should have. I did not look either. I want that written down. I did not look.

Corran lived. We closed his flank with eight stitches, and he will have them redone at every pang for the rest of his life, because in Cradlewrack a wound opened once remembers how. In the morning the mother turned from the wall and asked what it had been. I said, as I am taught, that nothing had been born, that the Tally would show a son of the household entered and struck through. She nodded. Then she held up her

girl, six months old and unnamed, and asked whether I thought this one would stay.

The girl looked at me. She has her father's eyes, very dark. She opened her mouth as if to answer.

I said that the naming waits a year. I said it the way I was taught. I put the knife-case back in Sabeth's bag myself because Sabeth's hands were busy at the basin, scrubbing, long after there was anything left on them to scrub.

▼ THE MEAL

Vey, the Opening, was the smallest of the Providers. The highland songs agree on that and on almost nothing else. It was no taller than a woman of middle height, and in the old carvings at Kest it is shown standing in a doorway with its arms spread to either jamb, so that the eye cannot tell whether it is holding the door open or holding something back. It had no face that anyone could keep in mind afterward. Those who saw it remembered only the feeling of being about to begin something: a breath drawn in and not yet let out, the half-second before a first word. Mothers in labor reached for it. It came. For three thousand years, the highlands say, no child in Vey's country was born without the god standing at the foot of the bed, its hands spread, its faceless attention fixed on the opening.

In the ninth winter of the Long Lack, Vey stood at the foot of every bed and nothing came. The wombs of the highlands had closed. Ewes stood dry and staring. Seeds lay in the red clay like teeth in a dead jaw. The god went from house to house with its hands spread, and the doorways it stood in were empty, and at last the midwives stopped calling it, because it was unbearable to watch it wait.

They took it in the birthing-house at Kest, the round red building that still stands at the heart of the city and is now called the Old Lying-In. They did not need to chase it. It came when the midwives called, the way it always came, and stood in the doorway of the birthing-room with its arms spread, and they shut the door on it. It was the first time anything had ever been shut against Vey. The songs say the god looked at the closed door for a long time, as if it had never seen one from that side.

Then they killed it, and it would not stay killed.

This is the part the highlands remember in their bodies. Vey was the hardest of the Providers to kill because it kept starting again. They opened its throat with a shearing knife and from the wound came, wet and blinking, a smaller Vey, whole, its arms already spread. They killed that one and it began again from its own wound, and again, each new god crawling up out of the opened body of the last like a child crowning. By dawn the floor was a drift of gods the size of hares, of mice, of fingernails, each still trying to begin, and the clay was ankle-deep in caul and cord and a clear warm



Nine days. Count them on your fingers, love, and then count them again, because next year it will take fewer fingers.

A RUDGE GRANDMOTHER, TO A CHILD LEARNING
THE INTERVAL

fluid that smelled of iron and the inside of a mouth. The last was no larger than a barleycorn. The midwife who crushed it between her thumbnails, Hollan Kest, ancestor of every Midwife-Paramount since, is said to have wept and said, "There. Now nothing begins."

The songs do not spare the room. They say the smell was the smell of a lambing-shed in a hot spring, if the shed had been shut for a week: iron, milk, wet straw, and under it the sweet, flat, faintly fecal stink of things newly come out of a body. They say the floor of the birthing-room had been laid with fresh rushes that afternoon and that by midnight the rushes floated. They say the little gods made a sound as they crawled, a soft continuous clicking of tiny joints opening for the first time, and that the midwives who survived the night heard it in every hearth fire for the rest of their lives. They say that the smaller the god became, the harder it was to look at, because the smaller ones had faces, finally, and every face was the face of a child the woman looking at it had lost.

There were nine women in the room. The songs name them all, and the five great Caul-line houses and the House of Aubrey are each descended from one of them or from the households that stood at their backs. Hollan Kest held the knife. Grizel Aubrey held the door shut with her shoulders and was the first person in the history of the world to feel Vey push against a door from the other side; her granddaughter wore the first highland crown. Mab Morwen tended the copper and skimmed it. Otilie Seele carried the bowls. Two Calloway sisters and a Danner cousin held the god down, again and again, each new god smaller than the last, until their aprons were stiff to the waist. The ninth woman is not named in any song, only called *the one who counted*, and the songs say she counted every Vey as it was killed, aloud, and that the number she reached is the number the Attendance still will not write down.

Then they ate it, because the Lack had to end. They ate it the way the highlands eat a lambing's afterbirth: stewed with clay salt in the great copper and ladled out by the senior midwife into bowls brought from home. The boldest households, pressed closest to the copper, came away with the choicest part, which was not flesh but the membrane that had sheathed the god's thousand rebirths, a grey-pink translucent skin the cooks skimmed off the pot like the

skin on milk. These families ate the caul. They became the Caul-lines.

The famine ended in the morning. By midday the first ewes were dropping lambs in the snow. By the end of Grace every woman in the highlands who could carry was carrying, and by the end of Plenty every one of them had been delivered, easily, without blood, without death. The midwives who had done the killing were made the guardians of the cradles. They were thanked. Nobody asked why the doors of the old birthing-house had all swung open on their own at the moment the last god died, or why no one has managed to close them since.

The Barleycorn, as it is sung in the Rudge ravines at the end of lambing, slow, by women only:

Out of the big one came the small one, and we cut the small one through,

out of the small one came the smaller, with its arms out, like the first one, like you.

Hollan, Hollan, put down the knife, there's nothing left that's growing,

and Hollan held it on her nail, a barleycorn, still going.

She pressed. We heard it. Like a seed between your teeth.

And all the doors came open, love, above us and beneath.

The Old Lying-In keeps, under glass in the Book-room, a list in Mab Morwen's hand: the inventory of the bowls ladled out from the copper on the morning of the Meal, by household, with the share

each took. It is the oldest document in the highlands and every Caul-line genealogy begins from it. Scholars of the Cutwrights' College who have been allowed to read it note three things. The Morwens took the first and deepest bowl. The caul went, by Mab's own hand, to the five households nearest her elbow and to no others. And the bowl-count at the foot of the page does not match the households listed above it: one more bowl was returned to the copper than was ever ladled out, and it came back, the inventory says in a smaller, shakier hand, *licked clean, and no household would own it.*



We ate the caul so we would see forward. Nobody told us it would be a door we'd be looking at.

DUCHESS OTTOLINE MORWEN, IN HER LAST
FORETELLING, 609 A.G.

THE CARVING ABOVE THE OLD LYING-IN

Over the round door of the Old Lying-In in Kest is a frieze older than the Gorging: eight figures standing in eight doorways, each in its own arch, each with its arms spread. Seven have been worn by six centuries of hands touched to them for luck. The eighth arch is empty. Its figure has been chiselled out so deeply that the stone behind it has gone through to the hollow of the wall, and the hole breathes warm air on cold days. Midwives touch the seven arches on the way in. Nobody touches the eighth. The apprentices say that if you put your ear to the hole you can hear someone on the other side laying a table. The apprentices say a great many things.

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

Nothing here is born right, and too much is born.

That is the whole of it, and it has been the whole of it for six centuries. Vey was the god of things coming into the world, and Vey is in the blood of the highlands now, and things will not stop coming. The births began wrong in 94 A.G. and have never gone right since. Every highland family has a story about what came out of whom, and every story is told the same way, flat and practical, the way other peoples talk about weather.

Children arrive speaking. Not babbling: speaking, in full sentences, in the voices of adults, with opinions. The first, in Kest in 94 A.G., opened its eyes and said, "Not yet," and died within the hour, and nobody has ever agreed on what it meant. Children arrive old, white-haired and arthritic, with failing hearts and worn teeth, and either grow younger year by year toward the cradle or simply die of age at three. Children arrive full-grown, tearing their way out into a world they are already too big for: men and women of thirty, of fifty, born mid-stride or mid-sentence, slick with blood and cord,

who must be taught to use a spoon although their hands already know how to use a sword. These are the born-grown, and the country has found uses for them.

And some arrive as Parts. A single living hand, warm, clenching. An ear that turns toward sound. A length of spine that crawls by flexing, like a caterpillar. A heart in its own little caul, kept in a covered dish in Cleave for nineteen years before it stopped. The Parts are healthy. They feed through the skin or through mouths that open in unlikely places. They grow. They are also drawn toward each other: a hand left on a table will, overnight, drag itself to the edge nearest the nearest other Part, however far away, and two Parts in one room will strain together and, if allowed, seal along a seam that heals in a night. Since 500 A.G. it has been known that Parts from unrelated families fit, a hand born in Rudge sitting perfectly on a wrist born in Kest a century apart, as if they were born to go together.

PARTS

Outsiders imagine the Parts as something out of a butcher's window: lumps, scraps, wet and dying. They are not. A born Part is finished, the way a good stitch is finished. A hand arrives with its nails grown and its creases deep, the skin of the wrist closed over in a smooth pink dome like the end of a sausage-casing, faintly translucent, through which on a warm day you can see the bones of the wrist moving as it clenches. An ear arrives with a ridge of soft gristle behind it that it uses to drag itself along a table, a fraction of an inch at a time. A length of spine arrives sheathed in a thin wet skin the color of a peeled grape and crawls, as the highlands say, like a caterpillar that has decided where it is going. Every Part is warm. Every Part has a pulse, though nobody has found a heart in a hand, and the pulse of a Part is always, always, the pulse of whoever bore it. Mothers who sit up with their Parts at night say that the hardest thing is not the look of it but the sound, in a quiet room, of two hearts keeping time.

They feed. A Part laid in a dish of warm milk will take the milk in through its skin over a night, so that the dish is dry by morning and the skin smells of curd. Some Parts grow mouths: a small lipless slit opening in the palm of a hand, in the lobe of an ear, at the end of a finger, which makes a wet clicking noise when it is hungry and must be fed with a spoon. They grow. A hand born the size of a baby's fist will be the size of a grown woman's hand in four years, and nobody has learned to stop it at any size in between. They sleep; they wake; they have moods. A foot will curl and uncurl its toes for hours when it is unhappy. An eye will weep. And they are drawn, every one of them, to the others, the way a sleeper turns toward warmth.

The Parts that are hardest to speak of are the ones that are not born free. In the Course, and sometimes earlier, a body may bear a Part that does not come away: a second hand, small and perfect, growing from the inside of an elbow; a cluster of fingers at the base of a spine; an ear opening in the side of a neck, which hears, and which the bearer hears with. These are called *keepings*, and the Book of Questions has three hundred pages of cases about them. The

Attendance may cut a keeping free, and it then becomes a Part like any other, crawling, hungry, drawn to the others; and the place it was cut from remembers, in the way of the highlands, and on a pang night opens, and begins again. Most bearers learn to live with their keepings bandaged under their clothes. A few come to love them. A few take a knife to them alone at night in a bricked room, and are found in the morning, and the Tally enters the keeping and the bearer both.



It holds my finger when I sleep. Tell me what else in this world has ever held my finger when I sleep.

A TARNBROW SHEPHERD, TO THE ATTENDANCE,
REFUSING TO SURRENDER A HAND

RULES – KEEPING A PART

A character who keeps a Part (born to them, bought, found or stolen) must feed it daily: a horn of milk, or a few drops of the keeper's own blood, which a Part prefers. Each day it goes unfed, it loses heart and the keeper gains 1 Hunger, because it is the god's piece and the god notices. A kept Part is warm, smells faintly of curd and the springs, and is detectable by anyone with the Taste or higher within ten paces (Caul + Instinct vs Hard 14). Each night, roll a d10: on a 1 it has moved toward the nearest other Part, and on a double-1 week (two 1s in a row) it has reached it, or tried to. A keeper who has slept beside a Part for a full season gains the Knack-like benefit of always knowing where it is, and suffers a Dread 3 check if it is taken, destroyed, or joined to another. Parts used in play take stats from the Crawling Part quick line in this chapter.

WHAT IS FOUND: PARTS

Roll when the characters search a hidden crock, a Part-hunter's crate, a midden, a ravine after the waters, or the bed of someone who has died in the Course. Every Part found is warm.

D20 THE PART

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | A left hand, a man's, with a wedding band grown into the flesh of the finger. The band is engraved with a name nobody in the parish has. |
| 2 | An ear in a bread-crock, wrapped in a child's shawl. It turns toward whichever character is speaking, and keeps turning after they stop. |
| 3 | A coil of gut, alive, in a jar of milk. It has tied itself into the knot that cannot come undone, and it is pulling tighter. |
| 4 | Two eyes, joined at the back by a stalk of pink nerve, in a pewter dish. One sleeps while the other watches. |
| 5 | A foot of a child of about three. It has never stood on anything. Its sole is as soft as a cheek, and it flinches at the floor. |
| 6 | A tongue in a covered cup. When the cup is lifted it says one word, the name of whoever bore it, and then is silent for nine days. |
| 7 | A heart in its own little caul, beating slowly. Laid against a character's chest, it falls into their rhythm, and they cannot afterward get it out. |
| 8 | A pair of lips sewn shut by someone who loved them, nine stitches, the knot that cannot come undone. Behind the stitches something is humming the counting-song. |
| 9 | A length of spine, nine vertebrae, curled around a spindle like a sleeping cat. It wakes and tries to fit itself to the nearest back. |

D20	THE PART
10	A breast, small, in milk, wrapped in linen at the bottom of a Part-hunter's crate. The linen is soaked. The crate is labelled with a parish nobody has heard of.
11	A hand of seven fingers, all of them thumbs. It holds things very carefully, as if it has been told it is clumsy.
12	A scalp of thick red hair with no skull beneath, which breathes, slowly, through its skin. It smells of the hearth of the house it was born in.
13	Twelve teeth in a wooden box, each in its own nest of gum. They chatter when a pang is near, a full day before anyone feels it.
14	A forearm and hand, already joined to a second forearm and hand at the elbow, so that the thing has a hand at each end. It walks on them.
15	A navel, only a navel, in a disc of belly-skin the size of a lack. A thin pale cord grows from it and goes out under the door.
16	A face, without a head behind it, in a hatbox. It is the face of one of the characters, perhaps twenty years older. It is asleep.
17	A womb, in a lidded crock, the size of a fist. It is, unmistakably, carrying something of its own.
18	A finger of nine joints, grey as old wax, which does not belong to any body born in the highlands. It is cold, the only cold Part anyone has ever found.
19	A small left hand with a midwife's callus on the inside of the ring finger, where the hook of the knife rests. It reaches for any blade in the room.
20	Nothing in the crock. The lid is off, the straw is warm, and there is a trail of small damp prints across the floor toward the east and the Barn. (The Gathering it joins may come back.)

Birth is not limited to mothers. Men have borne, through scars, through the navel, through the mouth. A widow of eighty-seven in Tarnbrow was delivered of twins older than she was. A ewe may drop eleven lambs, or one lamb with eleven heads. And things that are not alive bear. A well in Rudge gave birth in 403 A.G. to something that climbed up the rope and was not seen again. A locked chest in the Morwen strong-room was found open with a damp, curled thing inside and the lock still turned. A hillside above Cleave dilated for a month and delivered a warm boulder with a pulse. A woman four days dead in the Stillyard went into labor on her bier, and the Attendance attended, because it must, and the Tally records what came as “one, living, struck through.”

The Tally is the evidence of the land's condition. Every birth in Cradlewrack is entered in a public ledger, by law, and the Tally of births has outrun the count of conceptions every year for two centuries. Last year, by the figures of Rufus Ochre the Tallyman, eleven hundred more people were born in the highlands than were carried by any woman, man, beast, well, chest, or hillside. The country is making people out of nothing, and nobody knows where they are.

THE TALLY

The Tally is not a book but a building, a habit and a voice. Each parish keeps a Tally-board, a long slate under an awning, on which the parish Attendant chalks the day's births at dusk; a crier reads the board aloud; a runner copies it on oiled paper and carries it to the Tally-house in Kest, where Rufus Ochre's scribes enter it in the great ledger that has been kept, without a missed day, since 131 A.G. The ledger is public. Anyone may climb Tally Hill and ask to see any page, and many do, because in Cradlewrack the Tally is the only proof that you were born, that you were permitted, and that you are who you say you are. A highlander with no line in the Tally does not legally exist; a highlander whose line is *struck through* does not legally exist either, and there are more of the second kind walking about than the Attendance would like.

Every entry has five parts: the number, the household, the bearer, *what*, and *stays*. The fourth column is the First Question, answered in the Attendant's own words; the fifth is the Second, and it has only three possible entries: *stays*, *surrendered* (for Parts), and a single ruled line, which is what *struck through* means on the page. The Tally has its own shorthand, learned by every child who learns letters: *sp.* for speaking-born, *o.b.* for old-born, *g.* for born-grown, *pt.* for a Part, *w.b.* for *without bearer*. What follows is a true copy of a part of one evening's page.

NO.	HOUSEHOLD	BEARER	WHAT	STAYS
4,411	Gorse, Seam St.	the mother, Ilse	girl, whole, sp. (“cold”)	stays
4,412	Pyke, Rimwatch	the father, Aldo	pt., left ear	surrendered
4,413	Morwen, the Hall	(sealed by the Council)	(sealed)	(sealed)
4,414	Crèche, Pang-house 9	w.b.	g., man of about forty	stays; to the Companies
4,415	Latch, Mortar Rise	the mother, Edda	boy, o.b., beard to the chin	stays
4,416	Furrow, Rudge	the grandmother, Nan, 71	“one”	———

NO.	HOUSEHOLD	BEARER	WHAT	STAYS
4,417	the Stillyard, Low Wall	the wall	“one, warm”	————
4,418	Thrale, Tarnbrow	the well-house	a key, iron, unlocks nothing yet tried	entered as a birth by order of the Lying

Four thousand four hundred and eighteen. Carried by somebody: four thousand two hundred and nine. Rufus, where are the rest sleeping tonight?

MARGINAL NOTE IN A SCRIVENER'S HAND, THE TALLY OF CARVING 641, CROSSED OUT AND INITIALED R.O.

The evening reading is a rite in itself. The crier stands on the Tally-house steps with a lamp, reads each line, and pauses after the fifth column; at *stays* the crowd murmurs “and let it stay,” the highland half of the common grace; at *surrendered* it says nothing; at the ruled line it turns its face away from the steps for a count of three, the time an Opinion is meant to take, and then turns back. Mothers who have not yet been read stand at the front. Those who have been read and struck through stand at the back, and nobody speaks to them on the way home, and they are not expected to answer if anybody does.

DOORS

Vey was also the god of doors, of openings, of thresholds and first stays over them. In Cradlewrack nothing stays shut.

Doors drift open in the night. Not violently: they are found at dawn a hand's width ajar, latches lifted, bars slid back, as if someone very patient had worked at them for hours. Locks undo. Lids rise off jars. Knots slip. Coffins open. A sealed letter is found unsealed. And wounds reopen.

That last is the one that wears a body down. A cut that has knitted, a scar twenty years white, a surgical seam neatly closed: in Cradlewrack all of them remember how to open, and on pang nights many of them do. Old soldiers of the Foundling Companies bleed from every wound they have ever taken, all at once, every nine days. A woman who was cut for a stone in her youth wakes in a wet bed with her side yawning. The Attendance employs whole wards of stitchers whose only work is to close, each morning, what the night opened. There is no cure. There is only thread.

Every threshold is something waiting to be crossed. The highlanders knock before they open anything, door, cupboard, box or letter, because you knock to warn whatever is on the other side. They brick up rooms they never want opened again, and brick themselves into rooms at night, and break out in the morning.

Knock, and wait. If it knocks back, you were right to knock. If it doesn't, you were right to wait.

A KEST MOTHER'S RULE, TAUGHT AT THE LINTEL

RULES – WOUNDS THAT REOPEN

Any character who has spent at least one night in Cradlewrack is subject to the land. Each pang (every nine days at present), roll a d10 for each healed Injury from the Mangling table the character carries, and for each surgical seam closed by Stitching in the last year. On a 1–3 it reopens during the night: the character loses 2 Flesh per reopened wound and wakes bleeding (Dread 1 for anyone unused to it). Closing it again is a Stitching roll at Hard 14. A Lack on that roll means the wound has learned the stitch: the next reopening is automatic. Natives of Cradlewrack carry their stitching kit the way other peoples carry a knife, and most have a Stitching of at least 1.

Doors and locks fare no better. Any lock in Cradlewrack must be checked each night; a lock that matters holds only on a Craft or Filch roll at Grim 18 by whoever set it, and even then not past the next pang. Bricking in always holds. That is why they brick.

THE BODY IS A DOOR

In the rest of the Table a body is a house a person lives in. In Cradlewrack a body is a doorway, and everybody knows it, and nobody is allowed to forget it, least of all by the law.

Every highland body belongs, a little, to the Attendance. An Attendant may lay her palm on any belly in the country, at any hour, without asking, and it is a crime to step back from her hand. Every woman of bearing age, every man in the Course, every child old enough to be returned, is examined at every Unbricking: stripped to the waist in the parish birthing-room, palpated, listened to with an ear on the navel, asked the date of their last cramp, their last waters, their last dream of a door. The examinations are brisk, cold-handed and not unkind, and they are hated more quietly and more completely than anything else the Attendance does. At Breech's Gate the examination is done to foreigners too, and the Rim Road Company's own guidance to its drivers warns that “the highlanders will put their hands on you, and you will let them, and you will not discuss it afterward among yourselves, which is the only part of the experience that will help.”

◇
*Breathe out, sir. No, all the way out. I need to feel
what's breathing in there besides you.*

EXAMINER AT BREECH'S GATE, TO A FATLANDS
WOOL-BUYER

What the Examination finds is worse than the Examination. The land does not ask before it begins in someone. A drover of forty, a grandmother, a Purgation zealot who has never touched another living soul, a girl of fifteen who has never been out of her mother's sight: any of them may wake with the low slow roll in the belly and the warm flood between the legs and know, in the flat highland way, what it means. The god does not need an act, a partner, a season or a consent. It needs an opening, and it makes them. Men in the Course feel their pelvis loosen and spread over a season with a deep grinding ache like a joint being slowly levered apart, until they walk with the rolling gait of the heavily pregnant and cannot remember how they used to walk. Breasts fill in old men and leak, and the milk is warm and salt and pink at the edges. Old scars soften, pucker, gain lips. A navel deepens, month by month, until a finger can be laid in it to the second knuckle and feel something on the other side lean against the fingertip.

The highlands have no word for this that is not a midwife's word, and so it is spoken of in a midwife's voice: *she's begun*, *he's carrying*, *she's open*, *he's near*. People are kind to the carrying. They give up seats. They do not ask by whom. But the kindness has the edge of the Examination in it, because a carrying neighbor is a neighbor the Attendance will come for, and a neighbor who has stopped looking like herself, and every highlander knows the madness that goes with it, which the Lying-In's book calls *tenancy* and the parishes call *the lodger*: the certainty, in the carrying, that the thing inside is awake and listening and has opinions about what they eat and whom they speak to; the certainty, in their families, that the person they love has been moved out of their own face by whatever moved in. Husbands sit up at night watching wives who sleep with their arms spread to the bed-frame. Wives refuse to eat at table with husbands whose voices have begun, they swear, to come from a little lower than their mouths. Most of them are wrong. Some of them are not, and the Book of Questions has a section on how to tell, and it is not long, and it does not end with a reassurance.

RULES – CARRYING

A character with Regrowth 1 or more may begin to carry in Cradlewrack without any act, at any age, of any sex. The Carver may impose it as the consequence of a Lack on a Tooth (when Partaking in the highlands, a Tooth showing 1 on a pang day), of a Regrowth rise to the Appetite or the Course, or of sleeping a night in an unhinged house, a pang-house, or within a mile of the Dilation. Carrying is never a punishment the Carver springs for a laugh; it is the land taking a body that was not offered, and it should be played with the weight of that.

- ◇ **Signs.** The character feels the roll at each pang and loses 1 Flesh to the cramp. Anyone who examines them (Hand + Stitching vs Routine 10, or a Midwife's talent) knows.
 - ◇ **Term.** Carrying lasts 1d10 days in the Course, or until the next pang otherwise. Each day of it, the character gains 1 Hunger and must make a Dread 1 check on waking.
 - ◇ **Delivery.** At term the character labors for 1d6 hours and must roll Gut + Endure (Hard 14) or suffer Ruin from the Mangling table; an attending Midwife or any character with Stitching 2+ adds +2 and may roll in their place. What comes is rolled on the Parts table above, or, at the Brink, on the crowning table below. Witnesses check Dread 2.
 - ◇ **The Questions.** In Cradlewrack, a birth without an Attendant is concealment, and the Attendance will come. Abroad, nobody knows what to do, which is worse.
 - ◇ **Refusal.** A character may try to end a carrying early by going to an Opinion; the Opinion will do it, without comment, and the character checks Dread 2 and keeps the scar, which opens at every pang thereafter. There is no other way that works, and the Carver should make sure no player is ever told there is.
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▼ THE REGROWTH IN CRADLEWRACK

Vey is growing back, and what grows back is beginning. Everything about the god's return in the highlands has the shape of a labor: a long, rising rehearsal, contractions closing together, an opening that cannot be reversed. The Attendance calls the stages by midwives' words, and every highlander can tell you where they stand.

THE TASTE

A sense of being about to begin. It feels, at first, like hope. The afflicted wake with a held breath and an urge to start something: a letter, a journey, a quarrel, a song. They do not finish; highland houses are full of half-sewn shirts and first lines. A Taste-touched child leaves doors open behind her without noticing, and her parents follow her through the house closing them. Old scars itch and go pink. The rest of the Table would barely call it a curse.

THE APPETITE

False labor, in anyone, of any age or sex. The body rehearses. Cramps roll low in the belly in waves with intervals, and the sufferer counts them without wanting to. Then the waters: a sudden warm flood of clear salt fluid from no clear source, smelling of the springs. Men double over at the plough. Old women labor nine hours at the market, deliver nothing, and are up the next morning, hollow-eyed. Children have had it, and the Attendance's only guidance to parents is to hold them and count with them until it passes. The sufferer feels the god's want as plainly as hunger: something should be coming out, and it is not. The Appetite-struck gather outside houses where a woman is in labor and stand very close to the walls. Many are found at dawn asleep on their feet in their own doorways, arms spread to the jambs.



Nine hours I laboured at the stall, and the custom kept coming, and I kept selling, between. What else would I do? It's only the god.

A MUTTON-WIFE OF THE SHAMBLES, AGED
SEVENTY-THREE

THE COURSE

True bearing, of things that are not children. The sufferer conceives without any act, carries for days or weeks rather than months, and delivers: Parts, mostly; small wet things with too many fingers; warm stones; keys; once, in the Attendance's records, a perfectly formed little door of bone, hinged, that opened onto nothing. Hips widen in men. Scars become permanent openings, lipped and moist, that dilate during pangs. Some develop a second opening where the body has no business having one, and keep it bandaged. The Caul-lines carry almost continuously: a noble of the highest houses may deliver

six or eight times a year, and spend the weeks between already swelling. The afflicted grow gaunt, as if everything they eat is taken for someone else.

The Course is where the body stops being a person's and becomes a road. The Course-touched describe the sensation of carrying as the sensation of being *occupied*: a pressure that is not quite inside and not quite outside, a weight that shifts when they turn over in bed a half-second after they do, a second set of preferences about food and heat and company. Delivery in the Course is quick and brutal and lonely. The waters come warm and salt and in quantities no body could hold, soaking through a straw mattress and the boards beneath it; then the opening, wherever the god has decided to open, with a tearing like wet linen; then the Part, or the stone, or the key, slithering out onto the sheet with the little gasp they all give. Course-touched mothers are not let near what they bear until it has been answered. Many of them stop asking. Some of them never stopped, and the Lying-In has a whole ward of women who ask, every hour, what it was, and have been told, and ask again.

THE BRINK

The Attendance has a word it uses in the Lying-In and nowhere else: crowning. Somewhere on the body of a person at the Brink, usually the belly, sometimes the breast or the forehead, the flesh has dilated into a round, perfect opening with soft lips and no bottom anyone has reached, and through it, at the height of each pang, something presses up toward the light: a curve of wet skin, a hand, a face that is never the same twice. Nothing comes all the way out. The Brink-touched hear it talking, in a small voice, about what it will do when it arrives. Thread passed through the crowning's lips dissolves by morning. The common are taken to the Lying-In; the Caul-lines to the deep chambers of their houses; and they are made comfortable, and watched.

From the Lying-In's own book, upper ward, the bed by the east window. Entered by the night Opinion, Lack 640.

The patient (Brink, crowning at the sternum, eleventh month) slept until the second bell. At the second bell the crowning dilated to a hand's width and a voice from within it asked for water. I gave the patient water. The voice said, not her. I wet a cloth and held it to the lips of the crowning, which took it. The patient woke and asked whether I had been talking to someone. I said that I had been talking to her. She said, You weren't, though, were you, and wept until the fourth bell, and the crowning was quiet while she wept, the way a child is quiet when its mother cries, out of interest.

At the pang, something pressed up into the opening as far as the lips: smooth, pale, convex, like the crown of a skull, but with a seam down the centre of it, and the seam was a lid, and it opened, and there was an eye under it. It looked at the ceiling. It looked at the patient's chin. It looked at me and I looked at the window until it had gone back down. I have entered it as the same as last month. It is not the same as last month. I do not have the shorthand for what is different.

WHAT IS FOUND: THE CROWNING

Roll when something presses up through a crowning, at the Brink in a person, or in the ground: a well, a sinkhole, the lips of the Dilation's rim after the waters. Nothing ever comes all the way out of a person's crowning; what comes up out of the ground may.

D20 WHAT THE CROWNING BRINGS UP

1	A hand, palm up, open, as if asking for something to be put in it. If anything is, the hand closes and withdraws, and the crowning is quiet for a week.
2	A face pressed against the lips from the inside, as against a window. It is the face of the person whose crowning it is, as a child, and it is crying.
3	Warm water, clear, then pink, then a single long black hair that keeps coming, yard after yard, until someone cuts it. Both ends bleed.
4	A small bone door, hinged, the size of a hand, closed. When opened it gives onto nothing; when closed again, something on the other side knocks, three, one, three.
5	The voice. It describes, in a child's earnest tone, what it will do when it arrives: whom it will visit first, which doors it will open, what it will eat.
6	A key on a cord of living flesh. The cord goes back down into the opening. Something below holds the other end and does not let go.
7	A crown of wet skin and fine dark hair, rising and rising at the pang until everyone in the room is sure, and then sinking back. The Attendance calls this "a false crowning." It happens every time.
8	Fingers, many, gripping the lips from the inside and pulling them wider, very slowly, a little each pang. The person whose crowning it is feels every one.
9	A smell of baking bread and woodsmoke, as from a warm kitchen at the far end of a long room, where someone is laying a table. (Dread 2 for anyone who has read the frieze over the Old Lying-In.)
10	A tooth, an adult's molar with its roots, pushed out onto the skin and left there like a gift. The bearer's own teeth are all accounted for.
11	The top of a head, bald and old and liver-spotted, rising in a crowning in the belly of a girl of twenty. It is the head of a man who died forty years ago, and his widow, sent for, knows him.
12	A cord, pale and pulsing, that goes down into the dark. Uncut kin who touch it say there is a heartbeat at the other end the size of a hillside.
13	A Part that has been surrendered: an ear, a hand, a foot, returned. The Lying-In's tag is still sewn to it.
14	A small wet arm, reaching up, which takes hold of the nearest wrist and will not let go until the pang ends. Anyone held checks Dread 3.
15	Earth: warm, red, damp clay, in a slow cone, as if the crowning had been dug from below. In the clay are the stamped corners of Stillyard bricks.
16	A mouth, at the lips of the crowning, which speaks the Tally number of a birth not yet entered. The Tally-house enters it the next day.
17	A finger pointing north, toward the Sill, rigid, for the whole of the pang. All the doors in the room swing that way too.
18	A folded white apron, laundered, starched, smelling of lavender, with a name stitched inside the hem in the old way. (See the Walk of Aprons.)
19	An eye that looks, slowly, at every person in the room, and stops on one, and stays on them after it has gone back down; they feel it for a week.
20	Something comes all the way out. In a person this has never happened, and the Carver should decide, with care, what it means that it has. In the ground it is a born-grown person, naked, slick, who climbs out by the roots and asks the watchers what year it is.

THE SEATING

The land itself. The highlands are in labor.

No single person has ever been Seated in Cradlewrack, and the Attendance believes none will be, because the god is not regrowing in a person. It is regrowing in the country. The quakes are

contractions: a century ago a full season apart, then thirty days within living memory, and now nine. The waters come up out of the ground without rain. The earth dilates into crownings. The greatest, the Dilation, is a mile across and has begun to move with the pangs. When the interval closes to nothing, something will be born out of the ground, and the whole of Cradlewrack is its mother.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

Cradlewrack is the high country of the Table's northwest: rounded red-clay hills folded on each other like the flesh of a sleeper, split by wet ravines thick with fern and alder. The hills are warm to the touch; snow melts where it falls and runs down in pink rivulets. The soil is soft, dark red, and smells of iron, and every highland house is built of it, rounded and windowless on the weather side, so that a village looks like a clutch of eggs. Springs run warm and slightly salt, and taste, the highlanders admit, like the inside of a cheek.

The pangs are the true calendar, and every household notches the interval on its lintel. A pang comes as a long rolling quake that rises from the deep ground: crockery walks off shelves, bricked rooms groan, ewes drop where they stand, and every Course-touched person within a hundred miles cries out at once. It lasts a slow count of sixty. In the hours after come the waters: springs surge, wells overflow, and in the low ravines the ground simply weeps, a warm clear tide that leaves a pale salt rime and draws flies. Sinkholes are called crownings. The earth dilates over weeks into a perfect round opening with soft lips of clay, and people gather at the rim to see what comes up. Usually it is water. Twice in the last decade it has been a person, born-grown and naked, who climbed out by the roots and asked the watchers what year it was.

The highland weather is otherwise mild, damp, and close. Fog lies in the ravines most mornings and is called the caul; children are told not to breathe it too deep. Wind is rare. Rain is light and warm. The worst season is late Plenty, when the clay steams, the air turns thick and salt, and the pangs, for reasons nobody understands, are hardest.



Don't drink from the ravine after the waters, child. It's not that it's bad. It's that it's somebody's.

A CLEAVE DROVER, TO A PILGRIM

GAZETTEER

KEST

The capital and seat of the Attendance, built on seven rounded hills around the Old Lying-In, the birthing-house of the Meal, whose doors have not closed since that night. Kest is a city of round red buildings without a single door that locks: by law since the Year of Doors, doors hang on leather hinges and are held, if at all, with wedges. Rooms meant to stay shut are bricked. The streets curve; there are no corners, because the Attendance holds that corners are where things collect. Every quarter has a Tally-board where the day's births are chalked at dusk and read aloud. Kest smells of wet clay, lye, and the sweetish copper of the laundries, where aprons are boiled day and night.

THE LYING-IN

The Attendance's fortress-hospital, two hours' ride north of Kest on a bare hill: a ring of red walls forty feet high with no gate, entered by ladder and a wicker basket hoist. Here are taken the births nobody speaks about: the ones the Second Opinion spared and should not have, the ones it could not reach, the Brink-touched, the mothers who will not stop bearing. Its upper wards are clean and quiet and smell of lavender. Its lower wards are bricked, cell by cell, and the bricklayers who maintain them are paid triple and change every year. The Lying-In keeps its own book, separate from the public Tally. Nobody outside the Attendance has read it.

THE DILATION

The great crowning in the central highlands, a mile across and widening. It opened in 547 A.G. as a pothole in a sheep track and has never stopped. Its lips are soft red clay that gives underfoot like flesh and slopes inward to a sheer drop into a darkness from which warm air breathes. During pangs the whole bowl flexes. Around the rim has grown Rimwatch, a ring of tents, turf huts and hostels full of pilgrims, Assemblers' agents, Barren protestors and Attendance observers, who mark the rim's advance each morning with painted stakes. The stakes nearest the edge are always gone by noon.



Twenty years at the rim. I've seen it take a stake, a cart, two pilgrims and a bishop of the Purgation. Never seen it give back anything I'd want.

MADDER RUDGE

THE SILL

A bare hilltop in the north, where a single door stands in its frame with no wall around it. It is oak, grey with age, iron-bound, older than the Gorging, and it has been ajar since that night, opening a finger's width further each year. Walk around it and there is only hillside behind. Look through the gap from the front, the old rule says, and you will see something else. Its keeper, Old Hinge, oils it, measures it, and does not look.

THE ASSEMBLERS' BARN

A long stone threshing-barn in a fold of hills east of Kest, built in the old style with a door at each end. It is guarded by armed brothers, lit by lamps day and night, and kept warm as a lambing-shed. It smells of tallow, catgut, and something underneath like the inside of a sheepfold in spring. Visitors are welcome, by appointment, and are shown the near end, where Parts sleep in labelled straw boxes awaiting their place. Visitors are not shown the far end.

RUDGE

A clay-diggers’ parish in the western ravines, famous for the well that gave birth in 403 A.G. The well has been capped with three tons of fired brick and a millstone, and the parish still sleeps badly. Rudge supplies the potters of Kest and, through Madder Rudge’s family, most of the watchers at the Dilation. Its people are short, broad, red-handed and suspicious, and the Tally records more Parts born in Rudge than anywhere else in the country.

MORWEN HALL

The seat of the highest Caul-line house, on a wooded ridge above the River Tull. A great round keep of fired red brick with no doors at all on its lower floors, entered by bridges at the third storey. Within are the Veiled Galleries, where the family lives behind the membranes they were born in. The house has married within itself for three hundred years, so that the cauls might stay thick, and the Cutwrights’ ledgers on the Morwen line are kept in a separate locked volume with a great many footnotes. The servants say the house is never quiet, because someone in it is always in labor.

BREECH’S GATE

The great border post on the Rim Road where it leaves the highlands, named for the current marshal and renamed for each one since 220 A.G. A walled yard, a customs hall, and the Examination Rooms, where every traveler leaving the country is checked for signs of carrying: hands on the belly, a midwife’s ear to the navel, questions about the last pang. Nobody pregnant may leave. The yard is always full of the turned-back, waiting for a change of heart that never comes.

THE STILLYARD

The great cemetery of Kest, on the north slope of the city: miles of long red walls in concentric rings, each lined with niches where the dead are mortared in behind bricks stamped with their family’s mark. The walls grow by several hundred niches a year. On still nights they tick and settle, and sometimes they knock. Families pay the masons to listen. When a wall knocks back, the Attendance is sent for, and attends.

CORDWAY

A village of the Uncut on the moorland west of Morwen Hall, built entirely of long low houses joined end to end so that cords need never pass through a door. Its streets are woven over with living

cord, pale and pulsing, strung from roof to roof between mothers and children and grandchildren, a vast slow net that sways in the wind and is warm to the touch. Outsiders must duck. Outsiders who touch a cord feel the heartbeat of whoever is on the far end of it.

NULLHOUSE

The mother-house of the Barren Order, a plain square building of grey stone (the only stone building of note in the highlands, quarried and carted from the Fast border at ruinous cost) on a dry hill in the south. Grey stone, the Order teaches, is the one material in Cradlewrack that has never borne anything. Its doors are bricked on every side. Members enter by a stair over the wall and are cut in the chapter-room.

THE LOW WALL

The innermost ring of the Stillyard, low enough to sit on, long enough that nobody has walked the whole of it in a day. Its niches are small, the size of a bread-oven, and its bricks carry no family mark: only a stamped number, which is the Tally number, and a ruled line. Here go the struck-through. Mothers come on the anniversaries of births that were never named, and lay a palm on the brick, and do not knock, because to knock is to ask for an answer. The Low Wall is the quietest place in Kest by day. By night the slot-feeders of the Debt Wall, two rings out, say it ticks like a kitchen full of cooling pans, and that on the nights after a pang some of the ticks are closer together than clay has any reason to be.

GREYSTEAD

A chapter-house of the Barren Order in the dry hills between Kilnmouth and Nullhouse, square, grey and doorless, entered by a stair over the wall. In the winter of 639 it held forty-one of the Sealed; by the spring of 640 it held nine. What happened there is told under the Barren Order below.

THE APRON STAIR

A cut in the inner slope of the Dilation’s rim, on the Cleave side: ninety-one steps hewn into the soft red clay in 619 and recut after every pang since, though they now lead only a few strides down before the lip falls away into the dark. Here, on Hollan’s Day of that year, the mothers of the Walk went down. Pilgrims tie strips of white linen to the stakes at its head. The Attendance does not forbid it. Since Lack 640, things have come up the Apron Stair in the waters, and they are tied to the stakes too.

▼ HISTORY

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
0	The Meal at the Old Lying-In. Hollan Kest crushes the last Vey. The famine ends by morning.
0–90	The Easy Births. No mother dies in childbed, no child is lost. The highlands fill.
94	The First Word. A newborn in Kest says “Not yet.”

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
101	The first born-grown: a woman of forty delivered at Cleave, mid-scream.
120	The Attendance. The midwives arm and take authority over every birth.
131	The Attendance becomes the government in all but name. The Book of Questions is written. The Tally begins.
188	First recorded birth to a man, in Tarnbrow.
220	The Border Marshals: pregnant subjects forbidden to leave.
310	The Year of Doors. Every lock fails in one night. Bricking-in begins.
403	The well at Rudge gives birth.
452	The Uncut first recognized as a people by the Attendance.
470	Nullhouse built of carted grey stone. The Barren Order founded.
500	The Gathering of Parts. Parts from unrelated families found to fit.
503	The Decree of Surrender: all Parts to the Lying-In. Never obeyed.
541	The Assemblers founded at a sheepfold near Kest.
547	The Dilation opens.
566	The Calloway Veil. A Caul-line lord kills his twin inside the membrane they shared.
588	A locked chest in the Morwen strong-room found open, the lock still turned. The room is bricked.
597	Queen Sibyl Aubrey conceives the heir.
600–641	The Shortening. The pangs close from thirty days to nine.
619	The Walk of Aprons. Ninety-one mothers go down into the Dilation. The interval does not change.
635	The first Foundling Companies raised from the born-grown. General Tibb born at Cleave.
638	The Rudge Part-house burned with its keepers inside. The Purgation suspected.
639	The Grey Winter at Greystead. Thirty-two of the Barren Sealed lost in a season.
640	The veils go red: first the Duchess Morwen's sight, then all five houses'.
641	Present. Nine days. The Dilation moves with the pangs.

THE YEAR OF DOORS

On a night in late Carving, 310 A.G., every lock in Cradlewrack failed at once: every bolt, latch, padlock, chain and bar from the Rim Road to the sea cliffs. The Tally for the following month was the largest in history, and what was born that month is recorded in the Lying-In's book and nowhere else. From that night dates bricking-in, the habit of knocking, and the Kest law against locking doors at all, on the reasoning that a lock which will fail is worse than none.

THE GATHERING OF PARTS

In 500 A.G. a Rudge clay-digger named Abel Furrow, who had kept a born hand in a bread-crock for nine years, took in a born forearm from a neighbor and found them joined at the wrist in the morning. He told the Attendance, which tested it, and kept testing it, and in 503 issued a decree that all born Parts were to be surrendered to the

Lying-In. The decree has never been obeyed. Out of the disobedience grew the Assemblers.

THE CALLOWAY VEIL

House Calloway, third of the five, has for two centuries been known for its twins. In 541 the Duchess Amarante Calloway was delivered of two sons in a single caul: one membrane, thick and grey, enclosing both heads, so that the boys were born face to face, breathing each other's breath. The Attendant asked the Second Question and let them stay, and the Book of Questions records the case at length, because the house would not permit the caul to be cut. Hugo and Lucan Calloway grew up in it. They walked, ate, slept and were taught their letters inside the one veil, their faces a hand's width apart, their two voices coming out of the membrane as one wet muffled voice that nobody outside could tell into two. The house called them its treasure. Their foretellings, spoken together, were the most precise the Veiled Council has ever heard.

In 566, at twenty-five, Hugo Calloway was betrothed by the Council, within the house, as custom required. The Cutwrights' locked volume records the betrothal in its shorthand, and records, too, that the bride's name was entered next to both brothers' names, there being no way to enter it next to only one. On the eve of the bricking-in, the servants heard the one voice arguing with itself for nine hours. In the morning Hugo came down to the hall alone in the veil, carrying it in both arms like a sack, because the half of it that held his brother hung slack and heavy and wet from his shoulder. He had strangled Lucan inside the membrane in the night, face to face, and then sat with him until dawn because there was no way to leave the room without him.

The house did not brick him. It could not separate the dead brother from the living without cutting the caul, and it would not cut the caul. So Hugo Calloway lived for thirty-one more years with his brother's body inside his veil, carried in a sling of silk; and the Calloway servants say that the body did not rot, because the membrane fed it, and that it grew, and that its face stayed a hand's width from Hugo's face all his life and its eyes stayed open. Hugo married. He had children. Every one of them was born in a caul with two faces in it, and so has every Calloway born since, and the house is careful, now, to let the Second Opinion choose which. The Calloways keep a portrait of Hugo in their gallery: one man, one veil, and, if you stand to the left of it in lamplight, a second face.



*By the shut door, I swear it, and may my brother hear
me say it, since he's the one listening.*

THE OATH OF HOUSE CALLOWAY, SWORN WITH A
HAND ON THE VEIL

THE WALK OF APRONS

In the Lack of 618, the interval fell below twenty-three days for the first time, and the highlands were afraid in a way they had not been since the Year of Doors. That winter the patients at the Brink in the Lying-In's upper wards all began, on the same night, to speak through their crownings in the same small voice, and they all said the same thing: *a mother from every house*. The Veiled Council, for the first time in its history, foretold unanimously. The five veiled heads, in the same week and without conferring, each dictated to their scribes that the ground would *ease* if it were *attended*: if a mother of every parish went down to it, as a midwife goes into a room, and stayed.

The Attendance did not want it. Orla Kest, then a Senior of the Lying, spoke against it for three days in the Hall and said, in her even voice, that the god had never yet been satisfied by anything given to it and that the Book of Questions had no page on which a

mother was the answer. She was overruled, by the Council, by the Crown (the King Within kicked once), and finally by the mothers themselves, because the volunteers came in their hundreds, and they were nearly all women who had heard a ruled line read against their household on the Tally-house steps. They wanted to go into the room. The Attendance drew lots among them, one for each of the ninety-one parishes, and dressed the chosen in white aprons, the only time in its history it has given the apron to anyone who had not taken the vow.

On Hollan's Day of 619 they walked from the Old Lying-In to the Dilation, which was then a quarter-mile across, behind the Midwife-Paramount and the Veiled Council in their litters and the whole of Kest. It took three days. They sang the counting-song. At the rim the Trowel had cut ninety-one steps into the inner slope, and the mothers went down them one by one, at the start of a pang, while the crowd counted aloud, and at sixty the pang ended and the steps were empty. Nobody saw them fall. Nobody heard them land. The crowd waited at the rim through the night, in perfect quiet, because the Council had foretold that the ground would ease, and in the morning everyone went home to wait for the next pang and see.

It came twenty-two days later, a day early.

The one after came in twenty-one. The Council's scribes went back through their foretellings and found that the word they had all written was not *ease* but a word in the old highland speech that means both *ease* and *open*, and nobody would say aloud which one the god had meant. The ninety-one families were given a stamped brick each in the Stillyard's Mothers' Wall, with nothing behind it. Orla Kest did not attend the dedication. She attended a birth in Rudge that day, and the Tally records it as permitted.

In the Lack of 640, twenty-one years after, the waters after a pang came up the Apron Stair, and when they drained, a white apron lay folded on the ninth step, laundered and starched and smelling of lavender, with a name stitched in the hem in the old Rudge way. Since then there have been nineteen. Each has come back to its own family. The families do not know whether to wear them, burn them, or wait for the next. A few of the families have begun to dream of the women who wore them, standing in a long warm room with their arms spread, holding something open. Nobody in Cradlewrack now uses the word *ease*.



*We gave it ninety-one mothers and it gave us back
their washing. That's the god for you. Thanks you very
nicely and keeps the rest.*

MADDER RUDGE, AT THE HEAD OF THE APRON STAIR

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

Cradlewrack is ruled by the Attendance, the armed order of midwives. No birth may take place without one present; the penalty for an unattended birth is that the child is held to be unborn, and the mother is fined for concealment. The Attendant asks the Two Questions aloud, *what is it* and *does it stay*, and answers them herself, according to the Book of Questions and her own judgment. Her knife is called the Second Opinion, and there is no appeal from it.

The Book of Questions runs to six hundred pages and is mostly cases. Speaking children stay. Old-born children stay. Born-grown stay, and are given to the Companies. Parts are surrendered to the Lying-In. Everything else is the Attendant's to decide, alone, in the room, and the Book's last page, in Hollan Kest's words, says only: *It is your hand, and you will remember. Choose so that you can.* The Attendance does not speak of the Second Opinion in public, and does not need to. Every highlander knows that the bundle carried out of a birthing-room, tied in the knot that cannot come undone, is entered as "struck through" and bricked in the Stillyard's Low Wall without a family mark. Every highlander knows a family with a struck-through line. Few would say they wish the knife gone. Many could not tell you, without weeping, why.

Beneath the Attendance, law is local and practical. Parish Attendants act as magistrates. Disputes over descent, which are endless because descent runs through whoever bore you, are heard before a bench of three senior midwives called a Lying. Murder is punished by bricking: the condemned is mortared alive into a niche in the Stillyard's Debt Wall, with water and bread pushed through a slot each day for as long as the family pays. Lesser crimes are punished by *unbinging*: the offender's house has its doors taken off by the parish and burned, and they must live open to the night.

The old monarchy technically survives. The House of Aubrey still holds the crown, and the rightful king, Aldous the Ninth, has been in the womb for forty-four years. His mother, the Queen Dowager Sibyl, still carries him, and he is consulted on matters of state: a question is read aloud to the Queen's belly by the Lord Chamberlain, and one kick means yes. The Attendance finds this an extremely convenient form of government.

The Caul-lines nobility are born veiled in a membrane that, in the highest houses, never comes off. They live behind it, speak through it, and are held to be prophetic, since the god's caul sees forward into what is beginning. The great houses (Morwen, Aubrey, Calloway, Seele, and Danner) sit on the Veiled Council, which advises the Attendance on matters of prophecy, and in practice on matters of money, since the houses own most of the clay-pits and all of the springs. Their prophecies are vague, red, and lately unanimous.

Nobody pregnant may leave the country. The Border Marshals check. The law dates from 220 A.G., when three expectant mothers crossed into the Fatlands and the Tally of that year recorded three births in Cradlewrack to women who were not there. The rule held; the country went with them. It is the opinion of the Attendance that a pregnant woman who leaves takes some of Cradlewrack with her, and that whatever she bears abroad is still the country's, and still its business.



*Majesty, is it your will that the Border stay shut? ...
The King has kicked once. The Border stays shut. Next
question.*

FROM THE MINUTE-BOOK OF THE MORNING
READING, THE AUBREY GARDENS

THE VEILED HOUSES

Five houses hold the springs, the clay and the future: Morwen, Aubrey, Calloway, Seele and Danner. They are the Caul-lines, the descendants of the households that stood nearest Mab Morwen's elbow at the copper and took the god's caul in their bowls, and they have spent six centuries making sure the caul stays theirs. It is the one thing in Cradlewrack that has never been allowed to open.

The membrane is the house. A Caul-line child born in a caul that comes away in the Attendant's hands is no longer reckoned of the line, whatever its parentage; it is called *bare*, and is given the house name with a stroke through the first letter, and sent to the lower floors or to the Crèche as a drill-mother or out into the parishes with a small pension and a large silence. A child born in a caul that does not come away, that thickens and grows with it, is the house's whole hope. The thicker the caul, the deeper the sight; and every house has learned, generation by generation, that the caul is thickest where the blood is least diluted. So the houses keep the veil. They marry within themselves, cousin to cousin and closer, and the Cutwrights' College, whose business is bloodlines and which recognizes every degree of kinship on the Table in plain words, keeps the Caul-line genealogies in a separate locked volume in which certain unions are entered not in words at all but in a private shorthand of small looped signs. Junior Cutwrights who are set to copy that volume are told not to try to read the signs. Most of them work it out anyway, and ask to be transferred.

*From the margin of a Cutwrights' College working copy of the
Morwen pedigree, Kest chapter, unsigned, in a junior hand,
later scraped and still legible under the lamp:*

*Same sign again at 588. Same at 611. That is three generations
of the same sign, and the sign is used of no other house on the*

Table. I asked Master Corse what it meant and he said it meant the College is discreet. I asked what we were being discreet about, and he took the book away from me and said I should be grateful they still have faces.

What the houses have bought with their discretion is visible across a market, which is why they so rarely go to one. The Caul-line face, where a face can be seen through the veil at all, is a single face: long, narrow, pale, with a small soft mouth and wide-set eyes of no particular colour, and every portrait in every veiled house shows it, so that the long galleries of Morwen Hall look like one woman painted four hundred times in different collars. Their bodies are delicate. They bruise at a touch, bleed long, break bones in falls a shepherd would walk away from, and many of them never walk at all and are carried in litters from the age of twelve. They foresee, and they carry, more than anyone else in the highlands: a Course-

touched Morwen may deliver eight times a year, and the deep chambers of every veiled house are full of what is carried away from those deliveries in covered dishes, and of the house's own children who crowned young and did not stop. And they are sad, the highlands say, with the particular sadness of people who have never once in their lives met a stranger who was truly a stranger to them.

RUNNING THE VEILED HOUSES

Keep the Caul-lines' rot behind the membrane, where it belongs. Their horror is not anything the characters see done; it is the pattern: the same face in four hundred portraits, the sign in the College's ledger, the deep chambers no servant enters, the nurse who goes down to the woods with a basket and comes back without it and cannot eat for a day. Let players assemble it. Never depict it, and never let it touch the house's children: Lady Isolde Morwen, sixteen and bare-faced, is the person in Morwen Hall most frightened of her own blood, and her story is the story of getting out.

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

FOOD AND DRINK

Highland food is plain and red. Mutton and lamb above all, since the ewes drop endlessly; clay-baked bread, which is set in a pot of wet red clay and buried in the embers until it comes out with a pink crust; oats; nettles; and the salt from the warm springs, which is faintly rose-colored and tastes of blood. Lamb is so cheap that the poor eat it daily and the rich serve it never. The national drink is *posset*, warm ewe's milk curdled with spring-salt and spirit. Eggs are not eaten: too many hens' eggs in the highlands have been found to contain things looking back.

The custom the rest of the Table finds hardest to stomach is the Second Meal. At a child's naming, a year after its birth, the family eats its afterbirth, kept salted in a crock since the day of delivery and stewed in the copper with lamb and onions. Everyone at table takes a spoonful, starting with the mother, in memory of the first Meal, when the people of the highlands ate the caul and the god and ended the Lack. The Caul-lines eat their own children's cauls, raw, from a silver dish, and do not speak of it to outsiders. The grace is the common one, "Lack keep away," followed by the highland addition: "and let it stay."



SHOULDER, ROAST, 1 L. — LIGHTS &
SWEETBREADS, 3 c. — POSSET, A HORN, 1 c. —
NO ODD-FOLD MEAT SOLD HERE, ASK AT THE
BACK.

CHALKED ON A BRAZIER-STALL BOARD IN THE
SHAMBLES, KEST

DRESS

Highlanders dress in undyed or madder-red wool, and nothing they wear fastens: buttons and buckles work loose, so garments are wrapped and knotted and retied at every bell, and the well-off have their clothes sewn on each morning and cut off at night. Everyone over seven carries a stitching kit on a neck-cord and a small hammer for knocking. Midwives wear the white apron and a knife-case nobody looks at directly. The Caul-lines are recognizable across a market by their blurred and glistening heads.

MARRIAGE, BED AND BEARING

Marriage is a contract between two households about who will bear, and when, and who will attend. Bride and groom are mortared into a bricked room together overnight and broken out at dawn, which is lucky, since nothing came in. What passes between married adults is spoken of only obliquely; highlanders are frank about bodies and shy about the rest. Every couple keeps a *closed week* around each pang, in the belief that whatever begins in pang-week begins wrong.

The Caul-lines marry within the house. It is called *keeping the veil*: the thicker the caul, the higher the line, and the caul is thickest where the blood is least diluted. The Cutwrights record these unions with a discretion the College shows nowhere else, in a locked volume where cousins marry cousins and the relations between consorts are entered in a private shorthand whose key the College does not lend. What the shorthand covers is not discussed in the highlands, and certainly not in Morwen Hall, where every family portrait has the same blurred face.

CHILDREN

A child is not named for a year, until it is clear what it is. Until then it is called by its place in the Tally (Third of the Gorse household) or by a pet word, *bit*, *small*, *keep*. Parents are advised not to love an unnamed child too much, and none of them listen. A child who changes in its first year, who begins to speak in an adult voice or to age, is taken back for a late Second Opinion. This is called *returning*, and it is the great dread of highland parents. Many hide their children rather than return them. Few of the returned come home.

The right to name a child is property, and like all property in the highlands it can be sold before it exists. The Naming-Exchange under the Tally-house trades naming-rights by the hour on rumours from the birthing-rooms, and poor families sell the right to name their unborn for bread, or debts, or a place on the list for an Agnes Latch door. The buyer chooses the name at the naming-year, and the family must use it, and it is entered in the Tally beside the buyer's mark. A child named by a broker carries the broker's mark for life, which is a small shame; a child named by a great house carries the house's patronage, which is a large fortune. Most deeds are written by the Exchange's own scribes to a form unchanged in two hundred years.

DEED OF NAMING-RIGHT, entered at the Naming-Exchange, Tally Hill, Kest, this fourth day after the pang, Carving 641.

Know by this deed, knocked upon thrice at its signing, that I, MERROW TANNER, ewe-man of Cleave parish, the bearer, being in the Appetite and nine days gone by the Attendant's hand, do sell and give over to the Bearer of This Deed the RIGHT TO NAME that which I now carry, for the sum of FOURTEEN LACKS, received.

The right conveys if and only if the thing borne is answered STAYS at the First and Second Questions.

If it is answered SURRENDERED, being a Part, the right conveys nothing, and no monies are returned, a hand having no name.

If it is answered by the ruled line, the right conveys nothing, and the Bearer of This Deed shall not ask what it was.

If it is born grown, it shall have the right to name itself, as is the custom, and the Bearer of This Deed shall be paid back seven lacks by the bearer, the other seven being for the bearer's trouble.

If it be returned within the naming-year, the right lapses, and the bearer shall not be pursued for it.

If it be born WITHOUT BEARER, or in two places, or to the well or the wall, the Exchange shall decide.

Sworn by the shut door, with my hand on my mother's brick.

*Witnessed: Corin Ledge, crier. The bearer's mark: a ewe's head.
The broker's mark: a ninefold knot.*

Children learn the country by playing it. The commonest lane game is **Who's in the Brick?**, in which one child faces a wall and must name each knocker without looking, and a wrong guess is answered *I'm not who you think* and everyone screams and runs. Older children play **Second Question** in the ravines, with a doll and a stick, and are beaten for it, and play it anyway.

A skipping rhyme of the Kest lanes, one jump to each line, out on the last:

Knock knock, who's at the door?

Somebody's baby on the floor.

Is it a girl? Is it a boy?

Is it a hand? Is it a toy?

Ask it once and ask it twice,

Midwife, midwife, isn't it nice?

Stays! (jump) Stays! (jump) Stays! (jump) Out.

DEATH AND THE DEAD

Nobody is buried. Graves open, and the dead have been known to bear. The dead are washed, every opening stitched shut with nine stitches, and bricked into the long walls of a Stillyard behind a course stamped with the family mark. Mourners knock three times on the new brick and do not wait for an answer. Oaths are sworn on the dead this way: a hand flat on a kinsman's brick, and the words *by the shut door*. To break such an oath is to wish the door open, and highlanders believe a forsworn man's dead will come through the brick for him. Some have.

FESTIVALS

- ◇ **Pangday.** Every nine days, now. Work stops at the first tremor. Families gather in the strongest room, sing the counting-song together, and wait out the sixty seconds, then go outside to see what the waters have brought up.
- ◇ **The Unbricking.** The first day of Grace. Every bricked room in the country, except the Stillyard's, is broken open at dawn and aired, and whatever is found inside is entered in the Tally.
- ◇ **Tablenight.** Every door in the country is propped wide open until dawn, on purpose, so that nothing can be said to have broken in. Families sit up in their open houses in the cold, all lamps lit, and a place is laid at the table nearest the door for whatever comes. Usually nothing does.

◇
*Leave the door wide on Tablenight and lay the plate
nearest it. If the plate is clean in the morning, don't
wash it. Don't ask who did.*

TARNBROW CUSTOM

CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

The great crimes of the highlands are concealment (an unattended birth or a hidden Part), descent-fraud (claiming a bearer who did not bear you), lockbreaking (opening a bricked room without the household's leave), and smuggling a pregnancy across the border. Concealment of a Part is punished by unhinging; the Assemblers have made it the most common crime in the country. The Attendance does not hang, behead, or burn. It bricks. A sentence of bricking is read in the Old Lying-In; the Debt Wall in the Stillyard is lined with the living condemned, and in the evenings their families sit beneath the slots and talk to them.

The Debt Wall holds a great many kin-slayers, because the highlands breed a particular kind of killing: brothers over a Part and the Barn's money, husbands over wives who have begun to look at them from a little below their eyes, and, commonest of all, *the private Opinion*, a household asking the Second Question of one of its own grown members in the dark, without sending for anyone, and answering it.

Taken at the Debt Wall, slot four hundred and nine, by an Attendance clerk, for the Lying of Carving 641, the prisoner being heard through the slot by request of his family.

CLERK: *State your name for the Lying.*

SLOT: *Hobb Marl. Of Mortar Rise. You know it, it's on the brick.*

CLERK: *You were bricked in 633 for the killing of your brother Saul Marl. Your family asks that the Lying reconsider the feeding.*

SLOT: *They want to stop paying. Say it. Eight years of bread. I'd stop.*

CLERK: *Tell the Lying why you killed your brother.*

SLOT: *He opened Mam's brick. In the Stillyard. Three weeks after we put her in, the night after a pang, he took his trowel and he opened her niche. Said he heard her knock. Said she knocked four. I said she never, you're mad, it's the pang in your head. He said he had to see. I went down there after him and he had her half out. Half out of the wall, with her nine stitches, and he was sitting with her on his knees in the dark and he was talking to her. Telling her he was sorry. And her face. You've not seen what three weeks in a pang-wall does. It*

was moving. Not her. Something under her. Her mouth was stitched and it was moving behind the stitches like it wanted to be let say something.

CLERK: *And then?*

SLOT: *I'd sworn on her. On that brick. By the shut door, the day we laid her. That nobody would ever open it. So I kept it. I kept my word to my mother with my brother's head on the step, and I put her back, and I put him in with her, and I laid the course myself, I'm a mason, I laid it good. And then I went and fetched the Attendance, because I'm not an animal.*

CLERK: *The Lying will want to know if you are sorry.*

SLOT: *Tell the Lying she still knocks. Four. Every pang. I can hear her from here, through two rings of wall. Tell them that, and then tell them to stop the bread if they like. I'd rather go quiet than hear what Saul's started answering.*

PROVERBS

- ◇ "Knock first. It's not for your sake."
- ◇ "What's opened once has learned the way."
- ◇ "Every door is a mother."
- ◇ "Bricked is the only shut."
- ◇ "You'll know when it's crowning." (Said of anything inevitable.)
- ◇ "Nine days." (Said now as a farewell, in place of "good night," with a shrug.)
- ◇ "A door shut is a question asked." (A rebuke to the nosy.)
- ◇ "Bread for the slot, salt for the dish, thread for the morning."
- ◇ "Better struck through than struck dumb." (Said bitterly, of a speaking child.)
- ◇ "She's counting." (Of anyone thinking too hard; also of anyone dying.)
- ◇ "Every hand in the crock is somebody's baby." (The Assemblers' slogan, chalked on Rudge walls.)
- ◇ "Don't name it till it's walked to you." (Advice to new mothers; also to new lovers.)

▼ FACTIONS

THE ATTENDANCE

The midwives: judges, physicians, priests and executioners in one apron. Founded in 120 A.G. by the daughters and granddaughters of the women who killed Vey, the Attendance has ruled the highlands for five centuries without ever calling itself a government. Every parish has its Attendant, every birth its knife. Its members take a single vow, *I will go into the room*, and it is the one vow in Cradlewrack nobody has ever been known to break, though many have died keeping it.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Apprentice (Third Hand)	The white apron, a stitching kit, the right to hold the door.
2	Attendant	A parish; the right to ask and answer the First Question.
3	Opinion	The knife; the right to answer the Second Question alone.
4	Senior of the Lying	A seat on a descent bench; access to the Lying-In's book.
5	Midwife-Paramount	The Old Lying-In. One holder. Answerable to no one.

Joining. Any woman, man, or born-grown person may apprentice by going into a room alongside an Attendant and staying until the end. Most apprentices quit after their first Second Opinion. Player characters can join at rank 1 with Stitching 1 and the vow. **Enemies:** the Assemblers, the Uncut (who call midwives “the Severers”), Petra Quick. **Allies:** the Crown, the Border Marshals, the Foundling Companies, uneasily the Barren Order.

THE SECOND OPINION, AFTER

Nobody describes the knife. The Book of Questions does not; its six hundred pages say what was decided and never how it was done. What the highlands talk about, endlessly, in the flat practical voice they keep for the unbearable, is what comes after: the part of the Second Opinion that belongs to the grown-ups in the room.

The Opinion turns her back. That is the first rule, and it is a kindness, and every mother in Cradlewrack knows what it means when the midwife turns her back to the bed. The apprentice holds the door. The linen is wrapped and tied in the knot that cannot come undone, the same knot the dead are tied with, and the bundle is handed to the apprentice without either of them looking at it, and the apprentice walks it to the Low Wall, at night, alone, however far, and hands it to the night-mason who waits there with a stamped brick and a trowel. That walk is the part the apprentices remember. Wenna Thrale has written that the bundles stay warm the whole way, longer than they should, and that you learn not to notice whether they are still, and that you do not learn it.

Beliefs. That every birth is a question, and someone must answer it; that the Second Opinion is mercy to the mother, to the country, and, the Book insists, to what is born. The order is split as never before: the Knife-faction, led by Orla Kest, holds that the knife has held the country together for six centuries; the Late-faction, which has no leader willing to be named, whispers that the knife was six centuries too late, and that no apron can attend the birth under the Dilation.

Wants. To keep the Tally true, the births attended, and the knife steady until the interval closes. To learn what is in the ground before it arrives, and, if it must be, to be in the room when it does.

The Opinion stays. She washes the mother, stitches what needs stitching, sits by the bed until the mother sleeps or until the mother turns her face to the wall, which most of them do and which the Book says is to be permitted. She does not explain. She does not apologise, because an apology is a door and the mother might come through it. If the mother asks, *what was it*, she is told the Tally's words: *nothing has been born*. A great many mothers do not ask, then or ever. A great many ask every day of their lives. One mother in Cleave asked Orla Kest, in the street, eleven years after, and Orla stopped and told her, in full, precisely, kindly, and the mother thanked her and went home, and the Attendance does not know whether she was helped.

Then the Opinion goes home and scrubs her hands. Every Opinion scrubs. They scrub with lye and pumice and a stiff brush at the copper in the Aprons until the skin of the knuckles cracks and bleeds, and the laundresses of the Coppers boil a knife-apron three times instead of once and pour the third water on the hill. Opinions develop a callus on the inside of the ring finger where the hook of the knife rests, and they wear it like a brand, and highlanders who see it in the street step aside without meaning to.

They break. The Attendance does not hide this; it is in the Lying-In's book, and the Seniors read it. Opinions see the faces of what they answered in the faces of strangers' children. They hear small wet gasps from cupboards. They count breaths in their sleep, one, two, three, and wake before four. They stop eating mutton. They come to believe, some of them, that they are not permitted: that if the Second Question were asked of them they would be struck

through, and that the Tally has got it wrong, and they go to Tally Hill and ask to see their own line. A retired Opinion who has Broken in this way is called *answered*, and is cared for at the Lying-In in a clean upper ward with a view of the hills, where she is let sit with her hands in a basin of warm water for as long as she likes. There are forty-four of them in the ward this year. There were nineteen five years ago. The Late-faction says that this, and not the Dilation, is the true measure of the Shortening.



Choose so that you can remember, the Book says. It doesn't say you'll be let forget.

A RETIRED OPINION, THE ANSWERED WARD OF THE LYING-IN

RUNNING THE SECOND OPINION

The Second Opinion is the moral centre of Cradlewrack and the hardest thing in it to run. Keep the camera on the adults. A scene with the knife in it is a scene about the midwife's back, the mother's face to the wall, the apprentice at the door, the walk, the warm bundle, the Low Wall, the scrubbing. Never describe what the knife does, and never put an infant's body on the page. The horror is that this is ordinary, that it is mercy, and that nobody in the room is sure; let the players be the people who have to carry the bundle, or hold the door, or decide whether to report the Opinion who counted eleven breaths. That is where the chapter's weight is meant to fall.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Gatherer	A carrying-crate; the password at the Barn's near door.
2	Seamster	The right to stitch Parts and to be present at a Joining.
3	Midwife of Pieces	A district; Part-hunters at command; the Barn's middle hall.
4	Fitter	A place at the figure's side; the right to choose where a Part goes.
5	Assembler-Prime	The far end of the Barn. Dov Marrin.

Joining. Bring a Part to the Barn, or the name of a family hiding one. Player characters who join gain access to Lazar Voss's drawings and to the Barn's surgeons. **Enemies:** the Attendance, the Barren Order. **Allies:** many grieving mothers, some Uncut, the Second Table (which has quietly paid for the Barn's roof).

INSIDE THE BARN

The Barn has a door at each end, in the old threshing style, and the Assemblers have made a theology of it. The near door is for mothers. It stands open day and night on a warm yard swept clean, with lamps hung along the eaves and a brother at a trestle who writes down, very gently, in the Mothers' Book, the name of every woman, man or household who brings a Part, and the name of the Part, which is always the bearer's name followed by what it is: *Hester's hand, Aldo's ear, old Nan Furrow's one*. Every bearer is given

THE ASSEMBLERS

A sect that collects Parts and joins them. Founded in 541 A.G. by a shepherd-surgeon who had read the Furrow case, the Assemblers believe that the Parts are not monstrous births at all but one body, born piecemeal, through ten thousand mothers across a century: Vey, being born again the only way the highlands would permit, in pieces small enough to be let stay. Their work is to gather the pieces and give the god back its shape. They are making good progress.

Beliefs. That every Part is holy; that every mother who bore one is a mother of the god; that the Second Opinion has been murdering Vey's fingers and teeth for five hundred years. The figure in the barn is the god, nearly whole. When it is finished it will stand up, and the pangs will stop, because the god will have been born the easy way, in a barn, among friends.

Wants. The last pieces: a left hand, and a voice. Safe passage for every Part in the country. An end to the knife.

a cup of posset and a seat by the fire and told the same thing, which is the founding promise of the order: *It will not be alone any more, and neither will you*. Most of them weep. Most of them come back, on the anniversary, to visit.

The near hall is long and warm and smells of straw, tallow and milk. Down each side, in labelled boxes of straw, the newly come Parts sleep or crawl in slow circles, waiting their place, and Seamsters walk the rows feeding them warm milk by hand and talking to each by name. Visitors are shown this, sincerely. It is the gentlest place most of them will see in the highlands.

The middle hall is for **the Hearing** and **the Joining**. A Part is not simply sewn wherever it fits. It is *beard*: a Fitter lays it on a warm slab and lays her own ear against it and listens, sometimes for days, until she hears where it wants to go, and then the Part is carried, in

procession, with the bearer if the bearer will come, to the far end. The Fitters say Parts speak in a kind of pull, the way a compass needle speaks. Lazar Voss, who has watched a Hearing, says the Fitters are hearing their own pulse slow to the Part's and are guessing, and that they are right every time, and that he cannot explain it. Dov Marrin's wife lives in the middle hall, in a cot by the stove, and she hums. Her hum is the tune the Seamsters use to call the Parts in their boxes to feed.

The far end is not shown. It is where Herself lies on her bed of warm straw under a hundred lamps, and where the Joining is done, by Dov Marrin or a Fitter, with fine sheep-gut and curved needles and a great deal of warm water, while the brothers and sisters of the Barn stand around the figure in a ring and hum the five-note tune. The Joining takes a night. In the morning the seam has healed, pink and puckered, and the new Part has moved, a little, and the figure breathes a little deeper. The brothers then do something they do not describe to visitors: they bring the bearer, if the bearer has come, to the figure's side, and they lay the bearer's hand on the Part that was theirs, and wait. Most bearers feel it know them. Some feel it close on their fingers, and have to be helped to let go.

The Gatherers' Catechism, said by every Assembler at the near door at dawn, call and answer:

Whose is the hand? — Every mother's.

Whose is the eye? — Every mother's.

What did the knife do? — It cut the god small.

What does the needle do? — It makes the god whole.

Where is she going? — Through the door.

When? — When she is finished.

And when is she finished? — When nobody is left alone.

BEARING THE PIECE

The Assemblers have a rite they do not speak of in the near hall, and it is the reason the Attendance calls them a sect and not merely a nuisance. When a Part will not settle in the figure, when the Fitter hears it pulling somewhere else, the order says it is pulling toward a living body, and that it must be carried there a while first, as it was carried once before, to learn the way. A brother or sister volunteers to *bear the piece*. The Part is sewn onto them, by Dov or a Fitter, in the place it pulls toward: a hand onto the inside of a forearm, an ear onto the side of a neck, a length of spine down the back between the shoulder-blades. In a night, in Cradlewrack, it takes.

Those who bear the piece are called **Carriers**, honoured in the Barn and feared everywhere else, and they wear their Parts openly under a short cape so the borne hand or eye can see the world. The Part feeds from them through the seam, and they grow thin; it moves with its own will, stroking strangers' sleeves, closing on a table's edge at a pang; their own scars open in sympathy. When the

Part is ready for Herself it is cut away, and the place it was remembers, and begins at the next pang to bear something of its own. Every Carrier the Barn has made has borne a Part within the year. The Assemblers count this as proof. The Attendance counts it as the most efficient way yet devised of making more mothers of pieces, and has bricked four Fitters for it.



I bore an eye for the god for nine months. On my shoulder. It saw my husband leave me and it wept, and I didn't, so I suppose one of us loved him.

A CARRIER OF THE BARN, TO LAZAR VOSS

GATHERERS' RATES, as given out at the Barn's near door to the trusted, Plenty 641. Paid in lacks, or in platters on request. Nothing is ever bought from a mother; mothers are given a gift. These rates are for what is brought from elsewhere.

An ear, a toe, a tooth-nest: 10.

An eye, sound, either side: 25. One that weeps: 30.

A foot: 30. A child's foot: never paid; bring it, and the Barn will find the mother.

A hand, right: 40. A hand, left: 60. A left hand with a ring-finger callus: name your price and come to the far door.

A length of spine, per joint: 5.

A tongue, or lips, or anything that has spoken: 80, and the Fitter will want to hear it first.

A heart: we are not buying hearts at present. We have one. We need another the size of a man's.

Anything grey, cold, or from outside the highlands: bring it, say nothing, and ask for Brother Garrow.

THE BARREN ORDER

Men and women who have had themselves cut so they can bear nothing. Founded at Nullhouse in 470 A.G., they preach an end to beginnings: if Vey regrows through every womb, navel and scar, the only refusal left is to close the body forever. Members are cut in the chapter-room by the Order's surgeons. In the higher ranks the cutting is extensive, and since wounds in Cradlewrack reopen, the sutures are renewed every pang; a brother who misses his resewing finds that his body has made new arrangements.

Beliefs. That the kindest thing a person can do is start nothing: no child, no journey, no quarrel, no hope. That the Dilation must not be watched, because watching is attending. That the land should be left to strain until it is exhausted. Their numbers grow with every pang.

Wants. The Dilation filled with grey stone. The Assemblers’ figure burned. The Second Opinion given to every birth in the

country, without exception, for one generation.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hearer	A grey robe; lodging at any Barren house.
2	Closed	The first cutting; full membership; a bricked cell.
3	Sealed	The second cutting; the right to preach on the rim.
4	Grey Brother or Sister	A chapter-house; command of the Order’s stonecarters.
5	Abbot of Nullhouse	Brother Callum Stillwater.

Joining. Hearers may leave at any time. The Closed may not, in any sense. **Enemies:** the Assemblers, the Uncut, the Caul-lines. **Allies:** the Purgation, which sees the Order as kin; elements of the Attendance’s Knife-faction.

THE GREY WINTER

The Barren Order’s whole promise is that a body can refuse. It is a terrible promise and a costly one, paid in cuttings and in sutures renewed every nine days for life, but it is a promise, and for a hundred and seventy years it held: the Closed and the Sealed did not bear. In the Shortening it stopped holding. The god, which needs only an opening, began to find its way through the cuttings themselves. In the Lack of 639, at Greystead, a Sealed sister of twenty years’ standing named Merel Ash woke in the night with the slow roll in her belly and the warm flood on her sheets, and by morning her renewed sutures were wet and parted, and through them, at the pang, something had begun to crown.

The Order had no words for it, because its words were all refusals. Merel was carried to Nullhouse, and Brother Callum sat with her, and she asked him what she had been cut for, and he did not know what to tell her. She went back to Greystead in the spring. A week after the pang, her cell was found empty and neatly kept, her robe folded on the cot and her sutures’ thread wound on its spool beside it, and the stair over the wall was wet with the dew. She was not found. The Rimwatch stakes on the Kilnmouth side were gone by noon that day, which proves nothing.

What followed is called the Grey Winter, and it is the worst thing the Barren Order has ever lived through, and it was not violent. It was quiet. The Sealed of Greystead had given up everything to be shut, and one by one, through that winter, they found that they were not. Brother after sister after brother woke carrying. They stopped speaking at meals. They began to count the interval aloud together in the chapter-room, all of them at once, in a low steady murmur that the Hearers could hear through the grey walls from the road, and the Hearers stopped coming. They began to say, to each other and to visiting brothers, the Order’s own teaching in a new voice: that the kindest thing a person could do was to start nothing, and that tomorrow was a thing one started. A Hearer who stayed a night that Lack wrote to Callum that it was like a house in

which every person had been told the same terrible news at once and was being very gentle with everyone else about it.

They did not do anything. That was what the brothers who came after kept saying. Nobody at Greystead raised a hand to anybody, themselves included, in any way the brothers could point to. They lay down. They walked out over the wall in the night and did not come back. They let a pang pass with their faces to the grey stone and did not get up when it ended. Some were found and some were not. A Sealed brother of sixty, the last one Callum reached in time, said to him only, *It’s so tired, brother. It’s been carrying us for six hundred years. I wanted to stop being a weight.* He died at Nullhouse in Grace, of nothing the surgeons could name, holding Callum’s hand, and he was calm. Thirty-two of the forty-one were gone by spring.

From the register of Greystead chapter-house, kept by the Grey Sister of the house, Lack 639 to Grace 640. Each name is followed in the register by a single grey line, ruled, in the manner of the Tally.

Sister Merel Ash. Sealed twenty years. Carried, through the second cutting. Asked to be let go. ———

Brother Tobin Gorse. Sealed eleven years. Sat by her cot a week and would not leave it. ———

Sister Una Fallow. Sealed thirty years. Had counted the interval every day of her life since the age of nine. Stopped counting. ———

Brother Lorne Clay and Brother Hugh Clay, his twin, Sealed together. Went over the wall together. Their robes were found folded together. ———

Sister Clemency Rowe. Wrote to her mother in Cleave, a letter I have kept back, because her mother is old. ———

Brother Edric Lintel. Carried twice. Asked me whether the Order would forgive him for bearing. I told him there was nothing to forgive. He said he knew. ———

(Twenty-six names further, in the same hand, which grows smaller.)

Myself. Not yet. I am keeping the lamps.

The Grey Winter did not stay at Greystead. That is the part the Order cannot forgive itself. Hearers who had visited carried the counting home with them to Kilnmouth and Nullhouse, and to their families, and the Attendance's book records that winter a cluster of the Pull in the dry southern parishes larger than any it had seen, almost all among people who had never been cut, who had never been in the Course, who had simply sat in a room with someone who had stopped wanting tomorrow. Brother Callum went from house to house through the spring of 640 with his staff and his gentle voice, sitting up with the counting, and he is believed to have kept more than he lost. He reads the thirty-two names at the rim of the Dilation now at every pang, with the struck-through, and he does not raise his voice for them. The Order did not close Greystead. Nine Sealed still live there, and they keep a lamp lit in every empty cell, and the lamps are the only things in the house that are not grey.

RUNNING THE GREY WINTER

Use the Grey Winter as tragedy and warning, never spectacle. Nothing in it is a method and nothing should become one at the table; stay with the folded robes, the counting through the wall, the lamps, the letter kept back. Mechanically it is **Contagion** and **Despair** working on a closed house: a night in a chapter-house where the Pull has taken hold is a Dread 3 check, and a failure at Fray 5 or more gives The Pull toward the Dilation or toward whatever "starting nothing" means to that character. Characters who sit up with the counting and refuse to leave anyone alone in a room should be rewarded as for a rite sincerely performed. Neither the Order nor the Attendance knows how to stop it happening again.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Newborn	A number, a blanket, a place in the Crèche.
2	Lettered	A spear and a name of one's own choosing.
3	Sergeant-Elder	A squad; the right to a remembered birthday.
4	Captain	A company; a horse; leave to search for one's bearer.
5	General	General Tibb. One holder.

Joining. Be born grown. Others may serve as drill-mothers and teachers, a post the Companies honor above officers. **Enemies:** none chosen; the Assemblers have tried to buy them. **Allies:** the Crown, the Attendance, the Border Marshals.

THE UNCUT

People whose birth cords were never severed. Somewhere in each Uncut family a mother refused the Attendant's cord-knife, and her child walked into life still attached by yards of living cord that grows

THE FOUNDLING COMPANIES

Regiments of the born-grown: adults in body, a few years old in fact, with no childhoods and no one to claim them. Raised in 635 A.G., they are the state's only army: six Companies of about four hundred each, housed in the Crèche, drilled in a single year from naked bewilderment to formation. They are disciplined beyond any army on the Table, because they have never known anything else, and frightened in a way their officers do not discuss, because none of them knows how long they will last.



*Born Tuesday. Spear by Grace. Sergeant by Plenty.
Gone home by Carving. Write it on my wall in that
order, so it reads like a life.*

A FOUNDLING SOLDIER'S REQUEST, THE COMPANY
WALL AT THE CRÈCHE

Beliefs. The Companies believe in the Company. Born with nobody, they have made the regiment mother and father. They love their General without reservation. Many born-grown age normally; some age backward; a few, without warning, revert to infancy in a night. The Companies call this *going home*, and they bury the infant in the Company's own wall.

Wants. Somewhere to belong after the war that never comes. A birthday. Some want to find whoever, or whatever, bore them.

with them and does not wither. They live in long joined houses in Cordway and a few Kest courts, great families netted together by pale, warm, pulsing ropes of flesh, sharing through them warmth, blood, pain, and a slow tidal emotion outsiders find unbearable to stand near. A cord cannot be cut without both ends bleeding; the Uncut say both ends die, and they are usually right. They consider everyone else amputees.

Beliefs. That the first wound every person suffers is the severing; that the Attendance's knife at the cord is the same knife it uses for

the Second Opinion, a little smaller. That nobody should ever be alone. That the cords are Vey’s, and Vey is a mother, and the land in labor is a mother, and when it delivers, its child will be Uncut too, and will hold them all.

Wants. The right to bear uncut by law. An end to the Attendance’s cord-knife. To be attached, through the deep cords that some of their elders have let grow down into the clay, to the land itself.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Grafted	A borrowed cord sewn on by the family; outsider kin.
2	Born-Joined	A true cord; a place in the long house.
3	Knot	A household of cords meets in you; you speak for them.
4	Root	Your cord goes into the ground. Visions; the land’s pulse.
5	Mother of Cords	Sister Maeve Cord.

Joining. Outsiders may be Grafted: a living length of cord from a willing Uncut sewn into the navel in a slow, painful ceremony. It takes about half the time. When it does not, it rots. **Enemies:** the Attendance, the Barren Order. **Allies:** some Assemblers, who see in the cords another way Parts long to join.

THE CROSS-BORDER POWERS IN THE HIGHLANDS

The Cutwrights’ College keeps its northwestern chapter in Kest and is the only body allowed into the Morwen genealogies, which it has sealed. The Purgation has a strong cell among the Barren Order and is suspected of the arson at the Rudge Part-house in 638. The Second Table has paid for the Assemblers’ roof and wants to know when the figure will be finished, and how one would carve it. The Reckoners have killed three Caul-line nobles in their veils in the last decade; they say they cannot tell the face beneath from the membrane, and that it does not matter. The Rim Road Company runs the inn at Breech’s Gate and buys cauls for export to Brinehollow, where a highland caul is believed to prevent the Calling.

◇

The cord’s the first thing you’re given and the first thing they take. We just said no to the second half of that.

OLD ISOLDE ROOTSISTER, OF CORDWAY

▼ CRADLEWRACK NOW

Nine days between pangs, and the Dilation has begun to move with them: at each contraction the great bowl widens by a stride and then eases back by less. The Rimwatch stakes have to be reset every morning. Madder Rudge says the hole has a pulse, and that lately there is a second one under it, faster and smaller, like a heart inside a heart.

The Assemblers’ figure is more than half complete, eleven feet long and breathing, and it has started to turn its head toward the Sill. It lacks a left hand and a voice. Hester Lowe has the hand. Juniper Dell, perhaps, has half the voice. The Assemblers know the first and suspect the second.

The Attendance is split between midwives who still trust the knife and midwives who think it is six centuries too late. Sabeth

Thorne, its most trusted Opinion, hesitated last winter, and the thing she spared is growing in a shepherd’s loft in Tarnbrow. The Queen Dowager’s son has begun to answer questions nobody asked. The Duchess Morwen’s veil has gone red. The Tally is eleven hundred short of explanation, and the Border Marshals are turning back more travelers every week, because more of them are carrying, including men who did not know.

Everyone can do the arithmetic on the interval. Something is going to be born out of the ground, and the whole country is the mother.

◇

Lark's bell went at noon and again at dusk, and nobody in the Tally-house would look at anyone else, because we'd all counted, and it was nine, and it had been nine the time before.

EDE AND ADA CREWE, WRITING IN TANDEM, A
LETTER TO A COUSIN IN OATHEN

THE UNKNOTTERS

Not every believer in the Long Labor is content to wait for it. Since the interval reached eleven days, a sect the pilgrims call the Unknotters, and which calls itself the Daughters of the Lip, has gathered at Rimwatch: mostly women of the western ravines who have heard a ruled line read against their household more than once, led by a former Rudge Attendant named Grisel Ashe. They believe the land's labor has stalled and must be helped, and that the kindest thing to do for a person deep in the Course is to *give back what they are carrying*: to open every opening they have ever had, at the rim, at the height of a pang, so that it all goes down into the mother at once.

They call it **the Unknotting**, and it is a killing. It has been done nine times that the Attendance knows of, always to a Course-touched man or woman, sometimes willing, more often not, always at the rim of the Dilation, always at night, always at a pang. The Attendance has heard a witness.

Heard before a Lying of three Seniors, the Hall of the Lying, Kest, Carving 641. The witness is a posset-seller of Rimwatch, who asked that her name be kept from the Tally.

SENIOR: *You were at the rim on the night of the last pang. Tell the Lying what you saw.*

WITNESS: *I'd gone up with the cart because the pilgrims buy hot drink after. I saw lamps at the Kilnmouth stakes, low down, nine of them. I thought it was the Barren with their names. Then I heard the counting. It wasn't the Barren. The Barren count slow.*

SENIOR: *Who was there?*

WITNESS: *Women. Grey-white shifts, like aprons with the strings cut off. And a man on the ground on a blanket, a big man, carrying, you could see it in his hips. He was asking them to wait. Very polite. He said, "I've a wife, I've a wife, can't we wait for the next one." They were stroking his hair.*

SENIOR: *Go on.*

WITNESS: *The pang came. The woman at his head, the tall one with the cropped hair, she started the counting-song and they all sang it, and on each ten they did something to him with little knives, and at each ten he screamed less. I won't say*

what. I saw her face. She was crying. She looked like an Opinion looks after. At sixty they lifted him to the lip and they tipped him, gentle, like you'd tip a basin, and the clay took him. The clay moved. It closed on him like lips. I heard it swallow.

SENIOR: *Did you do anything?*

WITNESS: *I counted. God help me, I counted with them. I didn't mean to. They were all counting and it was the pang and I've counted every pang of my life. When it was over the tall one came to my cart and paid for nine horns of posset with good lacks and said, "He'll be born again, love, better," and they drank it and went back to their tents.*

SENIOR: *Would you know her?*

WITNESS: *She asked me the First Question. Over the cart. She looked at me and said, "What are you?" and waited like she'd answer it herself. I said I sold posset. She said, "That's all right, then. Not yet." I've not slept since.*

The Attendance has a warrant for Grisel Ashe and has not served it, because she is never alone at Rimwatch and because the Daughters of the Lip are now perhaps sixty, and because a Senior of the Lying has privately observed that the interval after each Unknotting has not shortened. It has not lengthened either. That is the problem with every sacrifice the highlands have ever offered: the god does not say thank you, and it does not say no.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◇ **The Missing Hand.** Dov Marrin hires the characters to recover a "stolen" Part from a widow in Rudge: Hester Lowe and her hand. Hester will fight. The hand will hold whichever of them it likes best. Lazar Voss, meanwhile, has noticed from his drawings that a left hand may not be the only piece missing, and that the figure as drawn has two places a heart could go.
- ◇ **Eleven Breaths.** The Attendance's Senior of the Lying quietly asks outsiders to find out why Sabeth Thorne has taken leave to Tarnbrow every week since winter. What they find in the loft is the size of a boy of six, after only ten months, and it calls Sabeth "Mother." Orla Kest wants it brought to the Lying-In. Sabeth wants it hidden. It wants to see the Sill.
- ◇ **Fetch the Footprints.** Josiah Fenn begs the characters to come with him on the last stretch of a trail eight years long. The tracks are now the size of a cart. They lead toward the Dilation, and they go in, and something has come out again with them.
- ◇ **The Turned-Back.** Petra Quick needs guards to run nine pregnant women past Breech's Gate. The Marshal has his reasons for letting one through, and Petra thinks she knows them. Across the border, the women begin to find that the

ground under their feet is warm and red, and the land beneath the Fatlands soil is starting to crown.

- ◇ **The Aprons Come Home.** A white apron comes up the Apron Stair after a pang with the name of a character's grandmother (or the mother of someone they love) stitched in the hem. It is warm. That night, the character dreams of her standing in a long warm room, arms spread, holding something open, and in the morning she has written, in flour on the floor beside the bed, *the next one is yours*. The Walk families have begun to meet in secret and are talking about going down to fetch them.
- ◇ **The Ninth Unknotting.** A Course-touched Fatlands merchant, stranded at Breech's Gate, hires the party as guards; he is carrying, and terrified, and has heard of the Daughters of the Lip. The Daughters have heard of him. Grisel Ashe genuinely believes she is offering mercy, and a Senior of the Lying is quietly suggesting that the Attendance let her try one more time, under observation, to see whether the ground answers.
- ◇ **The Lamps of Greystead.** The last Grey Sister of Greystead writes to the characters (or to Brother Callum, who sends them): a Hearer has come to the house who counts in her sleep, and the counting has started again in the chapter-room, and there are nine Sealed left. Somebody has to sit up with them through the next three pangs. The god is patient. The characters must be more so.
- ◇ **The Second Face.** Lady Ysolde Calloway's veil has begun to speak in two voices again, as it did in the old stories, and the second voice is asking for a brother. The house wants the characters to find out who its new twin is before the Council does, and the Cutwrights' College wants its locked volume back from whoever stole it from the Kest chapter last week.

RUMORS OF THE HIGHLANDS

DIO	RUMOR
1	The pangs will stop if the Queen Dowager is delivered. (False. The King Within would not agree to it, by kick, anyway.)
2	The figure in the Barn wept last week, from forty-one eyes. (True. It has more than two of several things.)
3	The Dilation is a mouth, not a womb, and something is coming up to eat. (False, says the Attendance. Madder Rudge is less sure.)
4	The Midwife-Paramount has a struck-through sibling of her own. (True, and she was the one who held the door.)
5	The Barren Order is buying grey stone by the shipload from the Fast to fill the Dilation. (True. It would take four centuries of shipping.)
6	Agnes Larch has built a door that held for a year. (False. It held for nineteen days. The customer died on the twentieth.)
7	The Sill opened a full hand's width this Grace. (True. Old Hinge has not told the Attendance.)
8	The eleven hundred unaccounted births are walking toward the Dilation by night. (Partly true. Some are.)
9	A Caul-line duchess can be killed only by cutting her veil, and the veil grows back. (False. But the veil does grow back.)
10	The Uncut's oldest Root is joined to something under the ground that is not dead and is not their mother. (True.)

THE PEOPLE OF CRADLEWRACK

WHAT IS IT. DOES IT STAY. **EVERY** ONE OF US WAS **ASKED** BOTH,
AND NOT ONE OF US WAS LET **ANSWER.**

[CHALKED ON THE TALLY-HOUSE STEPS, KEST, THE MORNING AFTER A PANG]

MIDWIFE-PARAMOUNT ORLA KEST

Head of the Attendance, sixty-eight, descended in the female line from Hollan Kest, who crushed the last god. She is small, square, and grey, with forearms like a laundress's and a voice she has never once in her life raised. She smells of lye and lavender. She has attended nine thousand births and permitted six thousand. She remembers the other three thousand individually, by parish and date and the color of the mother's eyes, and can tell you why, in each

case, without raising her voice. She has never asked to be forgiven for any of them. What she fears is not the knife but its failure: that the Late-faction is right, that she has spent her life answering small questions while the large one dilated under her feet. She meets the characters when one of them is carrying, or when one of them is close to Sabeth Thorne. Secret: Orla's mother bore a second child when Orla was nine, and Orla held the door. She has asked herself the Second Question about the country, and answered it, and is waiting only for the room.

ORLA KEST – MIDWIFE-PARAMOUNT OF THE ATTENDANCE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Stitching 5, Blades 4, Instinct 4, Resolve 4, Rites 3, Intimidate 3, Clause 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 16 · Armor 0 · Fray 5
ATTACKS	the Second Opinion (knife) +8 (2); a precise cut to an opening ignores Armor
GIFTS	The Question (once per scene, any creature born in Cradlewrack that she addresses by the First Question must hold still for one round, Caul + Resolve vs Grim 18 to resist); Steady Hand (never suffers a Lack on Stitching).
WANTS	Go into the Room (she cannot refuse to attend a birth, of any kind, anywhere).
DREAD	2 (to see her face after she answers the Second Question)
SECRET	She plans to go down into the Dilation with her knife when the interval reaches one day.

SABETH THORNE, THE SECOND OPINION

The Attendance’s most trusted knife, forty, long-boned and quiet, with cropped black hair and hands she scrubs until they crack. For eighteen years she was the Opinion the other Opinions sent for: the one who could look for the count of three and decide. Last winter, at a farmhouse in Tarnbrow, she hesitated. She counted eleven

breaths. The thing lived. She paid the shepherd’s widow a year’s wages to keep it in her loft, and has been watching it grow ever since, and has not reported it. It is now the size of a child of six, after ten months; it has her eyes, though it cannot have; it calls her Mother and asks to be taken to see the Sill. Sabeth knows exactly what she must do. She has walked to Tarnbrow eleven times with the knife-case. She wants someone else to make her choose. She is Wenna Thrale’s master, and the likeliest way a party meets her is in the room.

SABETH THORNE – THE SECOND OPINION	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Blades 5, Stitching 4, Endure 3, Instinct 3, Stealth 2, Resolve 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 18 · Armor 1 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	knife +10 (2, first strike each fight gains a Helping); bone hook +8 (2, Hooking)
GIFTS	Three Count (after studying a target for one round, her next attack gains two Helpings).
WANTS	Look Away (when a newborn thing looks back at her, Caul + Resolve vs Hard 14 or she cannot act for a round).
DREAD	2
SECRET	The thing in the loft has begun to open doors by looking at them.



She held the knife-case on her knees the whole cart-ride to Tarnbrow and back. Eleven times. Never opened it. I drive her for nothing now.

A KEST CARTER, OF SABETH THORNE

look of him, and is now perhaps sixty: his beard is iron-grey, his back has straightened, and his voice has lost its quaver. He is courteous, learned, faintly amused, and smells of camphor and warm milk. He claims to remember being Vey’s left eye, and describes the Meal from inside the pot: the heat, the ladle, the caul lifting off above him like a sky. He is getting younger, and he says that when he reaches the cradle it will be time. He tutors Caul-line children and receives visitors who want to know what the god saw. His fear is that he will forget, at the end, what he was born to say.

AMBROSE, THE ELDEST INFANT

Born twelve years ago in a Kest weaver’s house with a white beard to his chest and a full vocabulary, Ambrose was eighty at birth by the

AMBROSE – THE ELDEST INFANT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Lore 5, Godsign 4, Instinct 4, Persuade 3, Rites 3
BODY	Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	none worth the name
GIFTS	The God’s Eye (once per session, answers one question about the Meal or the Dilation truthfully, if horribly); Younger (wounds dealt to him heal by morning, and he loses a year).
WANTS	Return (he is drawn to cradles, and sits beside them for hours).
DREAD	3 (to hear him describe being eaten)
SECRET	He is not growing younger toward birth. He is being drawn back toward the Dilation, and he will be there, the size of a newborn, when it opens.

◇
Come for it with a crate and you'll leave in one.

CHALKED ON HESTER LOWE'S DOOR IN RUDGE, IN
HER OWN HAND

HESTER LOWE

A clay-digger's widow of Rudge, thirty-four, broad, sunburned, with a cleft chin and a laugh like a crow. Three years ago she bore a hand: only a hand, left, healthy, warm, the size of a grown woman's, with a ring-finger callus nobody can explain. She did not call the Attendance. She hides it from the Lying-In and the Assemblers both, in a lined bread-crock under the hearthstone, and she feeds it warm milk through the skin of the palm, and talks to it while she works. It holds her finger at night. It strains, always, toward the east, toward Kest and the Barn, and she wakes to find it at the crock's lip, fingers hooked over. Her fear is the morning she will find it gone.

She will kill anyone who comes for it, and keeps a clay-spade sharpened for the purpose. Her secret: twice now, the hand has written, in flour, a word she cannot read.

HESTER LOWE Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Attack +6 (clay-spade 4) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

DOV MARRIN, ASSEMBLER-PRIME

A former shepherd-surgeon, fifty-five, mild, balding, bespectacled, smelling of tallow and catgut, with a gentle voice for frightened mothers and very clean nails. He has fitted together four hundred Parts from four hundred families into one figure, eleven feet long, lying on a bed of warm straw at the far end of the Barn. It breathes. It is missing a left hand and a voice. Dov is devout, patient, and absolutely certain; he speaks of the figure as "Herself" and of each Part by the name of its bearer. He wants the hand, the voice, and the god's easy birth. His fear is that the figure's head has turned toward the Sill without him.

DOV MARRIN – ASSEMBLER-PRIME	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Stitching 5, Godsign 3, Craft 3, Lore 3, Persuade 3, Blades 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 3
ATTACKS	surgeon's cleaver +6 (3)
GIFTS	The Seam (any two Parts or wounds he stitches together join by morning); Call of Pieces (Parts within a mile crawl to him if he hums).
WANTS	Gather (he cannot leave a Part where he finds it).
DREAD	2
SECRET	He has already given the figure a heart: his own wife's, born to her as a Part in her sixtieth year, cut free with her blessing. She lives, after a fashion, in the Barn's middle hall.

HERSELF – THE ASSEMBLERS' FIGURE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 7 · Lung 2 · Eye 1 · Tongue 0 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	not applicable; she is the god, in pieces
SKILLS	Brawl 3, Endure 4, Instinct 5
BODY	Flesh 19 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 (seamed hide) · Fray none
ATTACKS	grasp +8 (4, Grappling, from any of nine arms)
GIFTS	Many Mothers (the first time she suffers Ruin, Parts tear free instead and crawl away; she rises at full Flesh next pang); Turning (all doors within sight drift open).
WANTS	The Sill. The hand. A voice.
DREAD	4 (to see her breathe; Dread 5 if she sits up)
SECRET	She is not Vey. She is what Vey would be if born in the highlands' own image: everyone's, stitched.

◇

Start nothing, my friends. Not a child, not a road, not a quarrel. Not even tomorrow, if you can bear to leave it be.

BROTHER CALLUM STILLWATER, PREACHING ON THE RIM

BROTHER CALLUM STILLWATER

Abbot of the Barren Order, fifty, grey-robed, gaunt and gentle, with a soft tenor voice and the careful gait of a man whose sutures are renewed every nine days. He was cut at twenty, by choice, after watching his sister deliver three things in one winter. He preaches that the kindest thing a person can do is start nothing, and he has never had so many listeners; on the rim of the Dilation, at each pang, he stands and reads the names of the struck-through. He is kind to everyone he meets and he is not lying when he says he loves

them. His fear is that his old wounds are opening differently now: this month, at the pang, his long-closed scar opened and something on the other side of it said his name in his sister's voice.

BROTHER CALLUM STILLWATER Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12
· Attack +3 (staff 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

GENERAL TIBB

Commander of the Foundling Companies, born six years ago in a Cleave lambing-shed as a grown man of thirty, mid-stride, already reaching for a sword that was not there. He is tall, red-bearded, scarred from wounds nobody gave him, with a voice that fills a drill-yard and a brilliant tactical mind that seems to have been born ready. He has no childhood, and he is a better father to his two thousand born-grown than any of them will have. He speaks plainly and laughs often. His private terror is the day he turns seven, the age at which three of his best captains went home, overnight, to the cradle.

GENERAL TIBB – COMMANDER OF THE FOUNDLING COMPANIES

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Blades 4, Reckoning 4, Endure 3, Intimidate 3, Search 3, Wayfaring 3
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Armor 3 (bone lamellar) · Fray 4
ATTACKS	sword +8 (4); his Company (see Foundling Soldier)
GIFTS	Born Ready (always acts first in the first round of a fight).
WANTS	Belong (cannot refuse a born-grown stranger who asks to join).
DREAD	1
SECRET	His wounds were given. Every scar on him matches a wound taken by a captain of the Rim Road Company guard killed at Breech's Gate on the day Tibb was born.

FOUNDLING SOLDIER Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (spear 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

LARK NINEDAYS, THE COUNTER

She times the pangs for the state with a water clock and a bell from a bare room atop the Tally-house in Kest. Fifty-two, wiry, chapped-lipped, with a ring of red notches tattooed around her left wrist, one for each name. She was named Lark Thirtydays at birth. She has changed her name every time the interval shortened and has been Lark Twentydays, Lark Fourteendays, Lark Elevendays; her friends no longer know what to call her. She sleeps beside the clock. She fears the day she will have to take the name Lark Oneday, and has sworn on her mother's brick that she will not take the name after that.

◇

Oneday. Then nothing. I'll not take a name with no number in it.

LARK NINEDAYS, TO HER MOTHER'S BRICK

MADDER RUDGE

An old clay-digger of sixty-nine and head of the watch at the Dilation, a stumpy woman with hands stained permanently red to the elbow and a pipe she smokes upside down against the steam. She has sat at the rim for twenty years. She lies on her belly at its lip each night with her ear to the clay and says the hole has a pulse, and that lately there is a second one under it, faster and smaller. She is blunt, profane, and kind to pilgrims. Her secret is that she has been down. Ninety feet on a rope, in 629, and she touched something warm and smooth that moved under her hand, and she has never told anyone that it moved toward her.

JOSIAH FENN, THE MAN WHO BORE

A shepherd of fifty-one, rangy, sun-black, with a pucker of scar over his navel that he keeps wrapped. Eight years ago he labored for three days in a hill bothy and delivered something that stood up, looked at him with great tenderness, and walked out of the door. He has been following its tracks ever since. They are getting larger; the last set he measured was the length of a cart. He talks about it the way a father talks about a son who went to sea. He fears that when he catches it, it will not remember him. He fears more that it will.

AGNES LATCH, THE DOORWRIGHT

She builds doors meant to stay shut in a country where none do. Forty-five, deaf in one ear from her forge, sawdust in her braids, she works in iron-bound bog oak with locks of nine wards and hinges set in poured lead, and knocks on each one for a full day before she sells it. Her best work held for nineteen days. Customers travel from

Kest to buy even one quiet night. She is proud, rude and expensive. Her secret is that she has studied the Sill, measuring it from a distance through a glass, and that every one of her best doors was built to its pattern.

DUCHESS IPHIGENE MORWEN

Head of the highest Caul-line house, fifty, she has lived her whole life inside the membrane she was born in. It has grown with her: a grey-pink veil, glistening, that covers her head and shoulders and moves when she breathes, through which her features are visible only as a pale blur and a darker mouth. She sees the future through it, blurred, and it has lately gone red. She speaks slowly, in a voice wet and muffled, and her prophecies are listened to by the Veiled Council in silence. She is in the Course; she carries almost continuously, and the house’s nurses take away what she delivers before she can ask. She fears the red. Her consort is Lord Casimir Morwen.

IPHIGENE MORWEN – DUCHESS OF THE VEIL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Caul-line) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Instinct 5, Godsign 4, Rites 4, Clause 3, Persuade 3
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	none; her servants carry poleaxes
GIFTS	Foretelling (once per scene, names an event of the next day; the GM must make it happen if plausible); Through the Veil (cannot be deceived by anyone standing before her).
WANTS	Keep the Veil (cannot permit the house’s blood to marry out).
DREAD	3 (to see the veil part)
SECRET	What she sees in the red is a door opening in the ground, and herself standing in it with her arms spread.

DOLOUR PYM, THE WET-NURSE

A huge, slow, soft-spoken woman of fifty-eight who has been in milk without pause for thirty years. She feeds what no one else will. The Attendance sends her the births it permits but cannot look at, and she takes them into her cottage behind the Lying-In wall, a warm dim place full of cradles and baskets and a smell of milk and wet wool. She loves all of them. Several have never let go: there are small mouths on her that have not left her in years, and she moves about the cottage carefully, singing. She meets the characters when something they rescued needs a home. She fears nothing for herself; she fears the Lying-In will one day want her children back.

EDE AND ADA CREWE

Sisters of nineteen and twenty, born a year apart, who are by every test the same child born twice: one memory, one set of scars (both have the burn on the left palm that Ede got at four, a year before

Ada was born), one mind in two bodies. They finish each other’s sentences because there is only one sentence. They work as scriveners for the Tally, copying in tandem, each writing half a line. They are charming, quick, and eerie. Their fear is that one of them will die first. Their secret is that, lately, a third girl in Cleave has started finishing their sentences too.

RUFUS OCHRE, THE TALLYMAN

Keeper of the public ledger, sixty, ink-stained, myopic, a man of columns who loves the Tally like a garden. By his figures, eleven hundred more people were born last year than were carried by anyone or anything. He would like to know where they are. He has started following the unaccounted at night, by their entries, and has found three of them so far, born-grown, walking north in a line, who would not answer questions. He wants the arithmetic to close. He fears it will.

SISTER MAEVE CORD OF THE UNCUT

Mother of Cords, forty-one, tall, broad-hipped and deep-voiced, still joined to her mother by thirty yards of living cord that loops behind her on a wicker carriage pushed by two Grafted acolytes.

Her mother has been dead for six years. The cord has not noticed. It still pulses, still warm, and her mother’s body, bricked in a long low tomb in Cordway with a slot left for the cord, has not decayed. Maeve leads the Uncut with great warmth and great stubbornness. She feels, through the cord, things she will not name.

MAEVE CORD – MOTHER OF CORDS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Endure 4, Persuade 4, Brawl 3, Godsign 3, Rites 3
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 4
ATTACKS	cord-lash +6 (3, Grappling; a grappled target shares her pain and hears her mother’s heartbeat, Dread 2)
GIFTS	Shared Blood (may transfer up to 4 Flesh of damage to anyone joined by cord); Root-Sense (knows when a pang is coming a full day ahead).
WANTS	Join (cannot bear to let anyone she loves be alone in a room).
DREAD	2
SECRET	Her mother is not dead. She is the Uncut’s oldest Root, and her cord ends, not in her tomb, but in the ground beneath it.

UNCUT CORD-KIN Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (cord-lash 2, Grappling) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

MARSHAL GIDEON BREECH

Commander of the border, fifty-six, iron-grey, a former Foundling drill-mother turned soldier, with a face like an old saddle and a stillness people mistake for patience. His men check every traveler leaving for signs of carrying. He has turned back two thousand, and once let one through. He has never said why. Secret: she was his daughter, carrying, and the Tally of that year shows a birth at Breech’s Gate to a woman in the Fatlands. He has never asked what was born.

PETRA QUICK

A smuggler of thirty-eight, lean and freckled, quick-tongued, Rim Road-born, who runs expectant mothers across the border so they can deliver somewhere the rule does not hold. It does hold, she has found. The country goes with them: across the Rim, in a Fatlands barn or an Oathen cave, the ground under the birthing woman turns warm and red. Petra keeps running them anyway, because they ask, and because once, in Brinehollow, it worked, and she would like very much to know why.

PETRA QUICK Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (knife 2, crossbow 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

QUEEN DOWAGER SIBYL AUBREY, AND THE KING WITHIN

She has been carrying the heir for forty-four years. She is ninety, hugely swollen, very tired, borne on a padded litter by eight women, and gracious in the vague way of the long-exhausted. The King Within, Aldous the Ninth, rules by kicks: one for yes. The Chamberlain reads the questions. She is the only person who knows that he has recently begun to answer questions nobody asked: three kicks, then one, then three, at night, over and over. She thinks he is counting the interval. She thinks he is counting down.

◇
One kick, yes. Three, then one, then three, at night, and nobody asked him anything.
A BEARER OF THE QUEEN DOWAGER’S LITTER,
DRUNK, IN THE COPPERS

DR. LAZAR VOSS

A visiting anatomist from the Vigil, sleepless and precise, forty-four, with bloodshot lidless-trained eyes, a rattle of rouse-pills in his pocket, and impeccable manners. He has examined two hundred Parts and drawn the figure they would make. It has more than two of several things. His drawings show something that is not human and is not the Assemblers’ Herself either: a shape with hands at the end of every limb, doors in its chest, and a head that is mostly mouth. He is selling copies to the Second Table. He has begun to dream, which a man of the Vigil should not survive.

JUNIPER DELL, CALLED FIRSTWORD

A girl of eight from Tarnbrow, small and solemn, who was born saying half a sentence and has never said anything else: “When it opens, tell them that the...” She says it in the morning, and when frightened, and when asked her name. Somewhere in the highlands, she is sure, there is someone born with the other half. She writes and draws normally; what she draws is always doors. She is cared for by her mother and closely watched, without her mother’s knowledge, by the Assemblers.

OLD HINGE, KEEPER OF THE SILL

He tends the standing door on the hill, oils it, and measures the gap. He is perhaps eighty, bent and bald, with knuckles like walnuts, and he lives in a turf hut a hundred paces downhill with his back to the door. He has never looked through it. He says he does not need to, because most nights something on the other side describes the view: a long room, warm, with a table laid, and a great many chairs, and one of them pulled out. He tells it to visitors in a pleasant dry voice. He fears the night it stops describing and asks him to come and see.



It’s a long room, it says, and warm, and the table’s laid. One chair’s out. I said who’s that for. It said, no hurry.

OLD HINGE, TO VISITORS AT THE SILL

NEW CHARACTERS

WENNA THRALE, THE APPRENTICE

Twenty, freckled, red-knuckled from the laundries, apprentice to Sabeth Thorne in her third year of the apron. She wrote the testimony that opens this chapter. She keeps, against all rule, a list of the struck-through she has carried, with a name she gave each one on the walk to the Low Wall. There are thirty-one. She wants to be an Opinion. She is afraid that she will be good at it.

LORD CASIMIR MORWEN, THE CONSORT

Husband of the Duchess Iphigene, forty-seven, veiled like her, slender, soft-spoken, with exquisite manners and a perfume of orris and something sour beneath. He is a Morwen born; the Cutwrights’ locked volume records his parentage in shorthand beside hers, and nobody at Morwen Hall would dream of asking what it says. He is

deep in the Course and carries more than his wife does. He wants an heir with a thicker veil than any before. He fears he has already borne it, and that the nurses did not take it away.

ABSALOM GAGE, THE BRICKLAYER

The chief mason of the Stillyard, sixty, white with lime-dust, deaf in both ears, with a trowel worn to a sliver. For forty years he has bricked the dead and the condemned and, nightly, the cautious of Kest into their rooms; he knows who sleeps where better than the Tally does. He has begun to hear knocking from inside walls he laid, which, being deaf, he should not. He knocks back. He does not tell anyone what the knocks say.

TAMSIN GORSE, THE STITCH-MENDER

A surgeon of thirty-six who runs the Reopening Ward at Kest, where old soldiers, cut-for-stone widows and Barren brothers come each morning after a pang to be sewn up. Brisk, cheerful, gallows-witted, smelling of spirit and catgut. Last month her own childhood scar, from a fall on a hay-hook, opened during a pang, and in the mirror she saw an eye looking out of it. She closed it with nine stitches. She checks it hourly.

FACTOR MERRIAM TOLL OF THE RIM ROAD COMPANY

The Company’s buyer at Breech’s Gate, fifty, stout, owlsh and courteous, from Oathen originally, conditional in all her speech. She buys highland cauls by the crate for export to Brinehollow, where one sewn into a sailor’s coat is believed to stop the Calling; she pays well and asks nothing. Lately the Caul-lines have been selling her their own. She has noticed that the cauls arriving now are warm when they are packed, and warmer when they arrive.

GRISEL ASHE, MOTHER OF THE LIP

Fifty-two, tall, cropped grey hair, a long bony face weathered red by twenty years of walking the Rudge ravines as a parish Attendant. In 637 she asked the First Question of something in a clay-digger’s house and it asked her back, in her dead mother’s voice, *what are you?* She put her knife-case down on the table and walked to the Dilation, and has been there since. She smells of warm clay and birth-water and speaks to everyone in the cadence of the birthing-room, *there now, nearly done*. She believes, with an Opinion’s terrible clarity, that the land is a mother in an obstructed labor and that the Attendance has been too cowardly in six centuries to help it. She weeps through every Unknotting, and thinks this proves she is right. She fears the god will be born and she will not have been in the room.

GRISEL ASHE – MOTHER OF THE LIP	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Stitching 4, Blades 4, Persuade 4, Rites 3, Resolve 3, Instinct 3, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	birthing-knife +8 (2); a precise cut to an opening ignores Armor
GIFTS	The First Question (as Orla Kest's Question, once per scene); What Is Opened Once (with a touch and a Partake, reopens every healed wound a target has had: 1 Flesh per Injury plus 1d6, ignoring Armor; her own scars open in sympathy, 2 Flesh); Midwife's Voice (anyone in false labor or carrying who hears her speak must roll Caul + Resolve vs Hard 14 or do as she bids for a round)
WANTS	Attend (Hard 14); Begin (Hard 14; she cannot let a labor, of a body or a land, stall in her presence)
DREAD	3 (to watch her at work at the rim; she is kind the whole time)
SECRET	She is carrying, at the Brink, and the voice in her crowning is the one that asked her what she was. When it tells her to unknot herself at the rim, she will, and the Daughters will sing.

DAUGHTER OF THE LIP Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (little knives 2, attack in pairs) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 · they hum the counting-song while they fight and never stop at sixty

LADY YSOLDE CALLOWAY OF THE VEILED COUNCIL

The present head of House Calloway, sixty-one, carried in a litter of black wicker, veiled in a membrane so thick it creaks. In lamplight, from the left, you can make out two faces in it: hers, and the small, still, wet-eyed one the Attendant answered at her birth, which stayed in the veil anyway and has grown with her. For sixty years it was silent. Since the veils went red it speaks in Council, in a high clear voice, always after Ysolde and always disagreeing, and it has been right four times. Ysolde is dry, sardonic, a superb reader of spring-rents, and the only veiled head who speaks of her house's history with open disgust. She has refused three cousins the Council chose for her, and she is paying someone to steal and burn the Cutwrights' locked volume.

LADY YSOLDE CALLOWAY Threat 4 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (none; her wardens carry poleaxes) · Armor 0 · Dread 3 (to hear the second voice answer the first)

HOBB MARL, SLOT FOUR HUNDRED AND NINE

A mason of Mortar Rise, forty-seven, whose testimony is given under Crime and Punishment above. He will talk to anyone who brings bread to the slot, and after eight years of listening he is the best source in Kest on what happens inside the walls after a pang.

HOBB MARL Threat 3 · Flesh 8 (starved) · Guard 8 · Attack none (bricked) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 (to see the eye at the slot)

SISTER AVIS FALLOW, KEEPER OF THE LAMPS

The Grey Sister of Greystead, fifty-eight, who lived through the Grey Winter and wrote its register. Small, quiet, touching the wall as she walks as if counting stones, she trims thirty-two lamps in thirty-two empty cells every night and speaks to each by name. She

is not in despair, she tells visitors; only very tired. Her secret is that she began to carry this Grace, through her sutures, and is counting.

SISTER AVIS FALLOW Threat 3 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (staff 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

JOSS TANNER, CARRIER OF THE BARN

An Assembler Seamster of thirty from Cleave, freckled, eager and painfully thin, who bears on the inside of his left forearm a born right hand sewn there by Dov Marrin in Plenty. It is warm, its pulse a half-beat behind his, and it reaches for things he has not looked at: knife-handles, latches, the sleeves of pretty strangers. He dreams of its bearer, a Rudge widow he has never met, and knows things about her kitchen. He does not yet know that when the hand is cut away, the place on his arm will begin to bear.

JOSS TANNER Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (shearing-knife 2; the borne hand grapples at +4) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 (to see the hand reach on its own)

ATTENDANCE OPINION Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Attack +7 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

BORDER MARSHAL Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Attack +6 (spear 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

ASSEMBLER GATHERER Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (hook 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

CRAWLING PART (SPINE, HAND OR WORSE) Threat 1 · Flesh 4 · Guard 13 · Attack +3 (grip 1, Grappling) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

A GATHERING (PARTS THAT HAVE FOUND EACH OTHER, IN THE DARK) Threat 3 · Flesh 16 · Guard 12 · Attack +6 (many grips 3, Grappling) · Armor 0 · Dread 3

CARRIER OF THE BARN (AN ASSEMBLER BEARING A PART) Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (knife 2; borne Part

▼ PLAYING A CRADLEWRACKER

You were born under the Two Questions. Somebody looked at you for the count of three and let you stay. You knock before you open anything, you carry needle and thread against the night, and you know the interval as well as your own name. Wherever you go on the Table, the doors drift open behind you.



You can always tell a Cradlewracker at an inn. They knock on the privy door. Then they wait. Then they count.

A RIM ROAD COMPANY DRIVER

Attribute bonus: +1 CAUL.

The Sop: Let It Out. Open something that was meant to stay shut: break into a bricked room, cut a stitch from a closed wound (yours or another's), unbar a door against its keeper's will, open a grave, or attend a birth to its end. Removes 1d6 Hunger. Each time, the god learns the way: the next closed thing you pass will ache at you until you open that too.

The Tooth. When you Partake, Vey begins in you. A low cramp rolls through your belly; the nearest door, lid, or knot within ten paces comes undone; your oldest scar turns pink and wet; the air smells of iron and warm salt. A Tooth showing 1 means the god bit back as a contraction: you are doubled over and lose your next movement.

WHAT IT IS LIKE

You count. You cannot help it, and abroad people will notice: you count stairs, breaths, the days since anything. You knock on doors in Brinehollow inns and the landlord stares. You wake in the night at the click of a latch three rooms away. You carry needle and gut and you know your stitch-count the way other people know their age, and when it goes up you do not talk about it. You have been examined, stripped to the waist in a cold parish room, more times than you can remember, and you have opinions about strangers' hands on you that you do not share. You have stood at the dusk reading and heard a ruled line read against someone you knew, and turned your face away for a count of three, and turned back. You know someone with a hand in a crock. You may be someone with a hand in a crock.

And your body has never been entirely yours. That is the thing outlanders do not understand. You grew up knowing that any morning you might wake carrying, whatever you are, whatever you have done or not done, and that the Attendance would come, and

that what you bore would be asked two questions you would not be let answer. Some Cradlewrackers leave the highlands to get away from that. They find that the god goes with them: a door ajar in a Fatlands farmhouse, warm red soil under a Vigil cot, an old scar opening at a pang they are three hundred miles from and feel anyway. Cradlewrackers abroad still keep the interval. Most of them say they would rather not know it. None of them can stop.

GIFTS

The Taste (Regrowth 1–3). Choose one.

- ◇ *Knock.* By laying your palm on any door, wall, lid or skin, you know whether something living is on the other side and roughly how big. Costs nothing; but everything on the other side knows you knocked.
- ◇ *First Breath.* Once per session, after any roll to begin something (the first attack of a fight, the opening line of a negotiation, the first step of a journey), you may reroll it. Something nearby that was shut opens.

The Appetite (Regrowth 4–6). Choose one.

- ◇ *Undoing.* By touch and a Partake, open any lock, knot, bar, seal, or stitched wound, with no roll. Bricking resists: Godsign vs Grim 18.
- ◇ *Rehearsal.* During a pang or a fight you may enter false labor deliberately: for the scene you ignore Ruin from the Mangling table (take the Injury but do not collapse) and add +2 to Endure rolls, then gain 2 Hunger and are helpless for an hour afterward.

The Course (Regrowth 7–9). Choose one.

- ◇ *Bear.* Once per session, after a day of carrying, deliver a Part that serves you: a hand that Filches at Threat 3, an ear that hears through walls, an eye that watches while you sleep. Its loyalty lasts until it meets another Part. Every delivery is Dread 2 for witnesses, and the Attendance wants to know about it.
- ◇ *What Is Opened Once.* With a Partake and a touch, reopen every healed wound a target has ever had: 1 Flesh per Injury they carry plus 1d6, ignoring Armor. Your own scars open in sympathy; lose 2 Flesh.

The Brink (Regrowth 10–11). You are crowning. Somewhere on your body is a soft round opening that cannot be closed, and something in it is pressing toward the light.

- ◇ *Crowning.* Once per scene, the thing within may push forth to act for you: a single attack at +9 (4), a single answer to a question about what is beginning, or a single door opened anywhere you

can see. Each use is Dread 3 for anyone watching, including you, and adds 2 Hunger.

THE WANTS

Resisted with Caul + Resolve at the listed difficulty when triggered.

- ◇ **Leave It Open** (Taste onward, Routine 10; Hard 14 at the Appetite). Trigger: shutting a door, a box, a book, or a wound behind you. You simply do not.
- ◇ **Attend** (Appetite onward, Hard 14). Trigger: hearing or learning of a birth within a mile. You go, and you stay until the end.
- ◇ **Begin** (Appetite onward, Hard 14). Trigger: being offered a plan, a road, a quarrel, a bargain. You start it at once, before anyone has finished speaking.
- ◇ **Gather** (Course onward, Grim 18). Trigger: a Part, or a wound, or a severed piece of anything living. You must keep it, and you must bring it close to the others.

THE SEATING

At Regrowth 12 a Cradlewracker does not become a place, as Fatlanders do, or a Hush, as the Hand-lines do. You hear the interval in your own body and it is the land's. You walk home, whatever your road, and you walk to the Dilation, and the ground opens to let you down. You go into the red, into the warm, and you are gone from play. At the GM's choice, something comes back up some pangs later: born-grown, with your face and none of your memories, or with all your memories and someone else's face, and it asks the watchers at the rim what year it is. Players who have lost a character this way may meet them again in the Adversaries chapter, wearing whatever is coming.

BACKGROUND CONCEPTS

- ◇ **The Apprentice Who Quit.** You held the door for your first Second Opinion and ran. You still have the stitching kit and the dreams. The Attendance remembers you, and wants you back in the room. (Stitching, Resolve, Instinct.)
- ◇ **Foundling Soldier.** Born grown, mid-stride, four or five years ago. You can strip a crossbow blind but you cried when you first saw snow. You do not know who bore you and you do not know when you will go home. (Blades, Endure, Wayfaring.)
- ◇ **Grafted to the Uncut.** You took the cord as an adult, for love or penance, and you can feel your adopted family's pulse a hundred miles away. When you leave Cradlewrack, the cord stretches. It has not snapped yet. (Endure, Persuade, Godsign.)
- ◇ **Caul-line Cadet.** A minor child of a veiled house, born with a caul that came off, which makes you a disgrace and a free woman. You still see a little forward, blurred and red. (Instinct, Clause, Rites.)

- ◇ **Part-Hunter.** You worked the western ravines with a crate and a kind voice, for the Barn or for the Odd Fold, and you are very good at getting mothers to open the crock. You have a list in your head of every hearthstone in three parishes. Somebody's hand once closed on your finger and would not let go, and you have not been the same. (Search, Persuade, Stealth.)
- ◇ **Struck Through.** The Tally says you were not born. You have seen your own ruled line on Tally Hill. Somebody took you out of the Low Wall, or the Opinion counted too long, or the knot came undone, and you grew up somewhere quiet. You do not know what you are. Neither does anyone else, and the Attendance would like to ask. (Stealth, Endure, Instinct.)
- ◇ **Walk Family.** Your grandmother went down the Apron Stair in 619. Her apron came back up last Lack, laundered, and you have been dreaming of her since, arms spread in a long warm room. You left the highlands to stop dreaming. It did not work. (Rites, Resolve, Lore.)



Forty-one stitches, and every one of them knows my name.

THE SEAM STREET GREETING, ANSWERED

HIGHLAND KNACKS

Cradlewrack characters may choose from the general Knacks or from these, which need no more than a childhood in the highlands.

KNACK	REQUIRES	EFFECT
Knocker's Ear	Caul 2	You can tell how many are breathing on the far side of a door or wall by knocking once (Eye + Search vs Routine 10).
Stitch-Count	Hand 2	You close your own reopened wounds without a roll, once per pang, and a Lack never teaches a wound your stitch.
Born Grown	(born-grown only)	You remember nothing before your birth but your hands do: choose one Hand skill at 2 for free; once per session, act first in a fight.
Counted Breath	Caul 3	When you witness a Break, you may count aloud; everyone who hears you gains +2 on their Dread check against the contagion.
Kept Veil	Caul-line Scion	You cannot be deceived by anyone standing before you about where they were born; your face is one face, and other veiled kin know it.

THE FOUR QUESTIONS IN THE HIGHLANDS

When you build a Cradlewracker, answer these with the Carver as well as the core four:

- ◇ **What did they answer when you were born?** Spoken, old, grown, whole? Who was the Opinion, and do you know their name?
- ◇ **Who in your household has a ruled line?** A sibling, a child, a parent's first? Do you go to the Low Wall on the day?
- ◇ **What have you carried?** Nothing yet, a false labor, a Part you kept, a Part you gave? Who knows?
- ◇ **Whose brick have you sworn on?** By the shut door, on whom, and for what? It will matter.

HIGHLAND NAMES

Female: Orla, Sabeth, Hester, Lark, Madder, Agnes, Dolour, Ede, Ada, Maeve, Petra, Sibyl, Juniper, Wenna, Tamsin, Merriam, Hollan, Edda, Bryony, Clemency, Rowan, Isolde, Nettle, Una.

Male: Dov, Callum, Josiah, Rufus, Gideon, Ambrose, Absalom, Casimir, Corran, Abel, Aldous, Tibb, Hugh, Eamon, Pell, Lorne, Tobin, Gerent.

Neutral or chosen by the born-grown: Ninety, Lettered, Keep, Bit, Small, Opening, Firstword, Wick, Stay, Ashe, Notyet.

Surnames (from mothers, places, or trades): Kest, Thorne, Lowe, Marrin, Stillwater, Rudge, Fenn, Latch, Morwen, Pym, Crewe, Ochre, Cord, Breech, Aubrey, Dell, Thrale, Gage, Gorse, Furrow, Corse, Calloway, Seele, Danner, Tarnbrow, Clayhand, Knocker, Lintel, Hinge.

◇
Lack keep away, and let it stay.
THE HIGHLAND GRACE, SAID IN FULL

HORRORS OF CRADLEWRACK

Roll a d20 when the party travels the highlands, rests in a Cradlewrack house, or lingers too long near something shut. Each is a scene, not a fight, though some become one.

D20	HORROR
1	You wake with the door of your bricked room standing open. The bricks are stacked neatly in the corridor. Something wet has walked through the dust toward your bed and back.
2	A farmhouse lambing: eleven lambs, each with a small human hand at the end of one foreleg. All eleven hands reach for the same character. (Dread 2.)
3	A man at the roadside in false labor, alone, counting aloud. He asks you to count with him. The interval he gives does not match the land's. It is shorter.
4	The well in the village square has crowned. Its rim is soft and warm. Something is coming up the rope hand over hand, and it is knocking on the stones as it climbs.
5	Your oldest scar reopens in the night, and through it you hear, very faintly, a voice reciting the Tally. Your own name is on it, entered today. (Dread 3.)
6	An unattended birth in a ditch: a girl of fifteen, alone, terrified, and a Border Marshal riding up the lane. What she has borne is small and breathing and looks at you with your mother's eyes.
7	A Stillyard wall at dusk, knocking from the inside, three knocks, steady, in the niche of someone who was bricked last week. The family is already there, sitting below it, deciding whether to answer.
8	A crawling spine in the bedding, warm, seeking another Part. It has found one: the hand of a party member, which it is trying to fit itself to.
9	A Barren procession on the road, grey-robed, singing the names of the struck-through. The sutures of one brother have opened in the cold and he is walking on, bleeding, singing louder.

D20	HORROR
10	Every lock, buckle and knot on the party comes undone at once. Packs spill. Armor slides off. Down the slope, something laughs like a child who has just learned to.
11	A pang strikes while you are crossing a ravine. Sixty seconds. The waters rise through the turf around your boots, warm, salt, red at the edges, and things are carried up in it.
12	An old-born child, three years old, white-haired and dying of age, asks you to tell him a story from his childhood. He means one that has not happened.
13	A Caul-line litter passes, curtains drawn. From inside comes a sound of labor and, behind it, someone else's calm voice saying "again, my love, again."
14	A born-grown man stumbles out of the fog naked and slick, mid-sentence, finishing an argument with someone none of you can see. He knows one of you by name.
15	A Part-hunter's wagon, crates labelled by village, every one rattling. One crate is labelled with the name of the inn you slept in last night.
16	The Uncut pass overhead on their roof-cords; one cord brushes your face, and for a moment you feel the heartbeat at its far end. It stops. Somewhere a long way off, a woman screams.
17	A woman four days dead goes into labor on her bier while the masons are at their tea. The Attendance has not yet arrived. You are in the room. (Dread 3.)
18	A door stands in an open field, no wall around it, ajar a finger's width. It was not there yesterday. Through the gap you smell bread.
19	You find yourself standing in a doorway at dawn, arms spread to the jambs, with no memory of rising. Your companions have been watching you for an hour and did not dare to wake you.
20	The whole party feels it at once: a long, slow roll low in the belly, rising, rising. Men, women, all of you. It passes. The ground beneath you rises and falls exactly in time. (Dread 4.)



CHAPTER 8

OATHEN

What the Witness Heard

Say less.

– THE WHOLE OF OATHEN’S LAW, AS TAUGHT TO CHILDREN

*The canyon does not forget a word. Neither does the thing beneath it. Speak as though
you will be quoted, because you will.*

– INSCRIPTION OVER THE LESSER GATE OF TACIT, CARVED WITHOUT A SINGLE
VERB

I have been listening. I have not stopped.

– SCRATCHED INTO THE LEAD OF THE THIRD GILDED CELL, AND CROSSED OUT,
AND SCRATCHED AGAIN



RECORD OF A LAWFUL DISSOLUTION, kept by the undersigned clerk of the Bench of Clauses, in the Ninth Room beneath the Ledger, on the eleventh day of Carving, 640 A.G. The condemned: Aubin Sele, cooper, convicted of selling the same cask twice under oath. Present: the condemned, the Breaker Jude Crake, the clerk (bitted, writing only), one Surety-witness (bitted). The hour-glass is turned at the first word.

CRAKE: Good evening, Master Sele. No, sit, the chair is for you. I brought figs. You needn't eat them. I only thought the room wanted something sweet in it.

SELE: (says nothing for the space of nine grains)

CRAKE: You've been told what I am. That's all right. People always have. I'm not going to touch you, and nothing in this room is sharp, and the door is not locked. You may check it. (The condemned does not check it.) I'm told you were a cooper. My father bent staves. I remember the smell of the steaming shed, the oak going soft. Is it true you can hear a bad cask?

SELE: If it's dry. If you knock it. (He stops himself. He has said nothing binding. The clerk notes his relief, visible in the shoulders.)

CRAKE: That's lovely. A ringing note, I'd guess, and a dead one where the split is. (Some minutes on staves, pitch, his wife's cooking, the late rain. The condemned laughs once, at a story concerning a goat. The clerk notes that it is a good story.)

CRAKE: May I ask you something small? Your daughter. Wenna, isn't it? She's to be fostered with your sister in Low Dray. Would you like her told anything?

SELE: Tell her (stops) Tell her, if you're able, that her father thought of her.

CRAKE: That's beautifully put. The "if you're able" is mine, not yours, so it costs you nothing. You're careful. I admire careful. (The glass is at its quarter.) You're shaking. Are you cold?

SELE: No.

(The clerk notes that the condemned is shaking, and that the room is warm, and that "No" in answer to a question of present fact is an assertion. A small sound, like a knuckle cracking, from the condemned's jaw. A thin line of blood at the corner of the mouth. The condemned understands. He weeps. He does not cry out, which would be foolish.)

CRAKE: Oh, Aubin. I'm so sorry. It's only a little lie. Everyone tells it. Here, the cloth. You'll want to hold it under. Let's not talk about cold. Let's talk about Wenna. She'll be frightened of me when she's older, I expect. They'll tell her stories. Will you do one thing for me, so I can tell her you were brave?

SELE: (nothing for a long time; the glass is at its half) What thing.

CRAKE: Only stop crying before the glass runs out. That's all. So I can tell her.

SELE: I (stops) I'll try.

CRAKE: That will do.

(The clerk notes that "I'll try" is an oath of effort, the lightest there is, and that it is kept by trying. The condemned tries. He breathes slowly. He looks at the figs. The clerk notes that at the three-quarter mark he has very nearly stopped weeping, and that the Breaker is telling him, softly, about a girl he once

saw in Low Dray who had red ribbon on her bit, and that perhaps it was Wenna, and that she looked well, and that she was holding the hand of a man who was not her uncle. The condemned asks what man. The Breaker says he didn't see the face. The condemned asks again. The Breaker says it was probably no one. The condemned begins to weep again.)

CRAKE: Aubin. Aubin. You promised you'd try.

SELE: I am trying, I am, I swear I am

(The clerk records that the condemned has sworn to a present fact, which was true, and that the true oath holds. The clerk records that the condemned then stopped trying, because he was thinking only of the hand that was not his daughter's uncle's, and that a man cannot try and not try in the same breath, and that the god heard which one it was.)

(At this point the record becomes difficult to keep. The clerk sets down only what is required. The first Breaking was the tongue's, for the lie about the cold, and it worsened, the jaw separating at its hinge with the sound of a green branch. The second was apt to "I'll try" and opened him along the effort: the long muscles of both arms and the back, which split

lengthwise like staves without a hoop. The third was apt to "I swear I am": the chest, at the breastbone, so that the clerk could see the condemned's heart moving and observe that it was trying very hard. None of these was fatal. The condemned remained aware throughout. The Breaker held his hand.)

(The glass ran out at the forty-first grain past the hour's mark. The condemned had ceased by then. It is the Breaker's first hour to exceed the hour. He asked that this be noted. He asked that it be noted also that he did not see any man in Low Dray, and that Wenna Sele is well, and that he lied about it, and that the lie cost him the nail of the smallest finger of his left hand, which came away in the cloth, and which he left with the figs.)

Scaled in silence. Witnessed. Filed.



The figs were not eaten. The Surety-witness asked, in handtalk, whether she might take them home. The Breaker signed: if able.

MARGINAL NOTE TO THE RECORD OF AUBIN SELE

▼ THE MEAL



WHAT TOLM WAS

Before the Gorging, Tolm, the Witness, sat at the head of the Gullet, the deepest gorge in the country, and listened. It was the size of a hill, shaped like a seated person drawn by someone who had only heard one described, with a bowed head as long as a barn and ears without number: great folded ones like bracket fungus on a dead oak, and small ones down its throat and the insides of its arms, opening and closing like the gills of fish. Its mouth was small and always closed. Its tongue, the chronicles say, was the color of raw liver and as long as a street.

Tolm did not command and did not bless. It heard. A vow spoken in its presence became a fact the way a stone dropped becomes a fall. Marriages were made at its knee; boundaries were walked in its hearing; a liar standing before it found the lie had been true all along, or found himself face down in the red dust with blood coming out of his ears. The people of the canyons loved it the way a court loves a scrupulous judge: with fear, with gratitude, and with the steady low resentment of those who can never quite be off the record.

The old canyon folk did not pray to it so much as report to it. Every household sent someone up the Gullet at the turn of each season to kneel at the god's shin, which was as broad as a barn door and rough as bark, and say aloud what the family had done: what it had sold, whom it had married, which child had died and of what. They called this the Telling. It was not confession, because nothing was forgiven, and it was not worship, because nothing was asked. It was the keeping of a record. The ears nearest the speaker would turn and unfold as they talked, wet and pink inside, and a thin clear fluid would well at their rims, and that was how you knew you had been heard. Children were brought to the Telling as soon as they could stand, to say their names. The Ledger's oldest carving says that the god once leaned down, slowly, over the course of an afternoon, to hear a girl who was whispering, and that its head blotted out the sun over the Gullet, and that the girl was not afraid, and that what she whispered was the price of a goat.

◇

We did not love it. You do not love the ground. You walk on it, and you are careful where you put your feet.

THE HERDERS' SAYING OF THE UPPER GORGES,
RECORDED IN 14 A.G.

Boundaries were made at Tolm's knee by two neighbours walking the line together, saying aloud at every cairn *this far, and no farther, for me and mine*, and the lines held better than walls. Debts were made there and paid there. A man who could not pay walked up the Gullet and said so, and the god heard, and what happened next depended on how he said it. A people who live in the hearing of a god that hears everything learn three things early: to say little, to mean it, and never to mistake silence for privacy.

THE HEARERS

Before the Gorging, Tolm had no priests. It had **Hearers**: men and women of the upper gorges who sat at the god's feet in shifts, night and day, for life, and kept the record of what was said to it on knotted cords and later on clay. They were chosen from children who could sit still the longest, and they were not permitted to speak in the god's presence except to repeat, word for word, a vow someone had made, so that the god could hear it twice. Their descendants are the Keeners of the Witnessing Vaults and, some say, the Echo-Wardens. The last Hearer's cord, a rope of knots as thick as a man's thigh and longer than the Gullet is deep, is kept in the sealed rooms of the Ledger. No one now can read it.

THE LONG LACK IN THE CANYONS

The Lack came to Oathen as it came everywhere: the figs failed, the goats went dry, the green cheese would not ripen in the river caves, and the bread went to ash on the hot stones. But in Oathen the Lack had a second shape. In the third year of it, the Hearers noticed that the god's ears had begun to close.

Not all at once. A few of the small ones on the inner arms first, the rims drying and puckering shut like the mouths of old wounds. Then the throat-ears. By the fifth winter the great folded ears on the god's head were furled tight, grey, crusted at the edges, and the Hearers sitting at its knee reported that vows made before it no longer drew the clear fluid to the rims. The canyon people did what frightened people do in front of a god that has stopped listening. They talked louder.

THE HUNDRED VOWS

In the seventh winter of the Lack, the Hearers declared that Tolm was starving for words, and that a people who had always given it their record must now give it something heavier. They demanded vows. Not boundaries, not prices: sacrifices of the self, sworn at the

god's shin, at the greatest Weight the canyons knew. The account on the Ledger, carved in 12 A.G. by a hand that shook, lists a hundred of them. A herdsman swore never to eat meat again, so that the god might eat. A mother swore she would never again speak her children's names, so that the god would have them, and keep them alive. A young man swore to walk into the Sheath and not come out until it rained. Forty of the hundred swore silence for life. Nine swore away their sight, and the clerks of the Ledger record, without comment, that they gave up their eyes at the god's knee, so that Tolm would see they meant it, and that the screaming was done afterward, at home, with the doors shut.

The god did not move. The ears did not open. The Lack went on for two more years. The herdsman starved with goat-meat hanging in his neighbour's smoke-house, because he had sworn. The mother's children died that winter, all three, and she could not say their names over the graves, and the Ledger records that she stood at the cairn opening and closing her mouth on nothing for an afternoon, and then went home and did not come out again. The young man in the Sheath was found at the spring melt, still walking, his feet worn to the bone, in a narrows so deep and so dark he had not been able to tell if it was raining overhead. The Hundred Vows were kept, every one, and they bought nothing. Then the canyons, having given the god everything they could promise, came back up the Gullet with knives.

◇

*We swore it everything. It took everything we swore.
Then we took it.*

THE LAST LINE OF THE ACCOUNT OF THE HUNDRED
VOWS, ON THE LEDGER'S WESTERN END

The Bench of Clauses has never ruled on the Hundred Vows, and the Bench rules on everything. The Plain Readers, the Bait-heretics of the Breakdowns, say that is because the answer is unbearable: that the god heard every vow, and that its ears were not closing in hunger but in patience, and that the Hundred were not food. They were seasoning.

THE SILENT SUPPER

In the ninth winter of the Lack, the canyon people came to the Gullet with knives, and they came in silence, because they knew exactly what would happen if they did not. Anything said in front of the Witness would count. A cry of pain would become a sentence. A prayer would become a contract. "Forgive us" would become a debt. So they did not speak. They had spent a month practising, and the practice had a cost: a generation of hand-signs for butchery, a set of whistles agreed and then forbidden, the dry-throated discipline of a whole people learning to hold their tongues. Those who could not learn it were left at home, tied, with rags in their mouths. Some of the tied ones died in the cold while the rest

were at the Gullet. They are the first silence anyone made on purpose in Oathen, and they are not on the Ledger.

They began at dusk. The old account, carved on the Ledger in the year 12 A.G., records that Tolm did not move, but that every ear on its body turned toward the knives as they came, the great ones and the little ones, a sound like ten thousand pages turning at once. The furred ears, closed for six years, opened. The first incisions were made at the throat, where the flesh was softest. What came out was not blood but something thick and clear that smelled of wet slate and tasted, those who caught it on their lips said afterward in handtalk, of the moment after you have said a thing you cannot take back.

They worked for three nights. The god's skin was tough as harness leather, lined with a fat that mouthed the shapes of words when cut: a yellow fat, granular, that puckered and pursed under the blade as though it were trying to say *knife*. Butchers wore wax in their ears and still came away with nosebleeds. The ears were taken first, because no one could bear to cut while they listened, and laid in rows on the canyon floor, where they went on twitching toward every footstep for a day and a half. Someone stepped on one. The sound it made was the sound of the person who had stepped on it, and it went up the canyon walls and came back, and that was the first echo anyone in Oathen was afraid of.

The butchery signs survive. Every Oathen child learns them, because they became the first words of handtalk, and the oldest signs in the language are still the signs for *bold*, *cut*, *pull*, *more hands here*, *it is looking at me*, and *do not stop*.

On the second night a woman named Deverel Ashe slipped in the slick and laid her forearm open to the bone; she knelt with her teeth clamped on her sleeve until her jaw cracked, and made no sound. Near the fires, a small child woke in its mother's arms and began to laugh at the flames. The carving says only that the mother held the child close for a long time, until it was quiet; that those nearest saw and did not stop her; that she sat with the bundle in her lap until dawn and then went back to work. Her name is not on the Ledger. Her line is: the Hushwell Tongue-line, among the highest in the land, whose crest is a closed hand over an open mouth.



The Hushwells do not tell the story of the Supper at their table. They do not have to. It is on their crest.

A LADY'S MAID OF THE HEIGHTS

The tongue was taken on the third night. It took forty people to draw it out from behind the teeth, hand over hand like a hawser, and as it came Tolm's mouth opened for the first and last time anyone remembered. The inside of the mouth was ridged like the roof of a cave and lined, the account says, with more ears, small and pale, all of them turned outward. The god spoke once. Every person

present heard it in a different voice, the voice of whoever had first taught them to talk, and every account gives the same two sentences: "Go on. I am listening."

They went on. The families who ate the tongue, raw, in slices that kept curling in their hands, became the Tongue-lines, the nobility of Oathen. The slices were cold and very heavy for their size, and moved on the palate, and those who ate them said afterward that for a moment their mouths were full of words that were not theirs, like a crowd talking in the next room. The root went to the Daths, the tip to the Vanthes, the long middle to the Hushwells, the Esks, the Sarrows and a score of lesser houses. The ears were boiled and eaten by the canyon clans of the upper gorges, whose descendants are said to hear too well; the great slow heart went to the Rain-keepers of the high basin; the scraps and the clear fluid went to the poor, who licked it off the stone and were Scraplings ever after. The bones were rolled into the Gullet and are there still, under a floor of red sand, and the canyon above them is the quietest place in a quiet country.

In the morning the Lack ended, as it ended everywhere. In Oathen, the first thing anyone said aloud was said by a herdsman's son who found green shoots on the canyon rim and shouted, "It's over, I swear it's over!" It was. The boy's word was the first oath of the Long Grace, and it was kept. He lived to be ninety and never said anything again with quite that much confidence.

THE TWO SENTENCES

Theologians on the Bench of Clauses have spent six centuries arguing the grammar of Tolm's last words. "Go on" is permission, or command, or encouragement, or a sigh. "I am listening" is a statement of present fact, and the god of true speech could not make a false one, which means that at the moment it was being eaten it was listening, and the question that has never been settled is when, if ever, it stopped. The Theft doctrine reads it as a sentence: we are watched until we pay. The Gift doctrine reads it as forgiveness: go on, eat, live. The Bait doctrine, illegal in Oathen since 290 A.G., reads it the plainest way of all. The god said it was listening. It has not said that it has stopped.

A counting game of the bitted, done in handtalk, two children facing, palms touching between each line:

One for the ear that heard it.

Two for the knife that cut it.

Three for the mouth that ate it.

Four for the tongue that's in it.

Five for the bit that holds it.

Six for the rock that keeps it.

Seven for the word you said once.

Eight for the one who's coming.

(On "eight" both children fold their hands shut and keep them shut, and the first to open them is out. Nursery-nurses say

nobody taught the children the eighth line. It is in every gallery in Tacit, and in Low Dray, and in Sheathmouth. The Bench has twice tried to find out where it came from.)

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND



WORDS BIND FLESH

In Oathen, a promise is a physical fact. Keep it and nothing happens. Break it and the body breaks to match: at once, with a sound, in a shape that fits the word. A man who swore to stand by his brother and ran had both legs fold under him backwards, the knees bending the wrong way like a heron's, and he lay in the road with his brother walking on without him. A woman who promised her heart to one man and gave it to another was found with her chest opened like a cupboard, the ribs swung outward on their cartilage like doors, the heart inside beating, entirely visible, entirely hers.

The Breaking is always apt and never by itself fatal. Tolm was a witness, not an executioner. What the god does to the forsworn is not punishment so much as testimony: it makes the body tell the truth that the mouth failed to. The broken live on, often for decades, as the Forsworn, and you can read a person's moral history from across the street. A merchant with no hands cheated someone. A woman whose lips have split back to the ears told a lie that mattered. A soldier with a spine bent like a hook swore to bear something and set it down. The canyons are full of these histories walking.

It does not have to be solemn. "I'll be back before dark" is an oath. "I'd die for you" is an oath. "I'll never forgive you" is an oath, and the man who swore it to his father and then, at the old man's deathbed, wept and took his hand, had his own hand turn to the consistency of wet bread in his father's grip. A child's "I promise" binds exactly as hard as a king's. The god does not weigh station. It weighs meaning.



*A wise man in Oathen is not one who keeps his word.
Any fool can keep a word. A wise man is one who
never gave it.*

SORRIN VAEL, CHIEF CLAUSEWRIGHT, IN A LECTURE
TO SLATE-CLERKS

THE BODY SPEAKS FOR THE MOUTH

The Bench's physicians have been cataloguing Breakings since 3 A.G., and their Book of Ruptures runs to nine volumes, each organised by the word broken rather than the part. What the catalogue teaches, and what every canyon child knows without being taught, is that the body does not merely break. It *says*. A Breaking is a sentence written in flesh, in the god's own grammar, and its grammar is the plainest reading of what was sworn.

A man who swore to his partner *I'll give you my right arm if this deal goes bad* did not lose an arm: he was found the morning after the deal went bad with the arm intact and entirely useless, hanging from the shoulder like a sleeve with nothing in it, the muscle gone soft and the skin cold, because he had promised to give it, and it was given, and it was no longer his. A woman who swore to a lover *I will never let you go* broke two years later, when the lover went, and her fingers clenched shut and did not open again; the Bench's surgeons tried, in 588, to open them with screws, and found the tendons had grown into the palms.

The sound is always the first thing. Oatheners who have heard a Breaking describe it by its kind: the green-branch crack of a long bone going; the wet rip, like a sleeve torn off a shirt, of skin parting along a line it was never meant to part on; the hollow pop of a joint leaving its socket; the soft, almost polite sound of a heart's cupboard opening, which the Bench's physicians liken to a ripe fig pulled in half. A Breaking in the Felt Market stops all trade, because the sound carries through felt, and everyone in earshot knows at once that someone nearby has said something they did not mean, and every one of them, without exception, runs back through what they themselves have said that morning.

Then the smell: iron, and opened bowel when the oath concerned courage, and very often a smell of wet slate that has no source and that the Breakdowns call *the god's breath*. Then the blood, which in a Breaking comes oddly slowly, as if the body were not sure it had been given permission. Then the scream, if there is one, and in Oathen there often is not, because the broken know better than anyone that a scream can say things.

THE BOOK OF RUPTURES

The nine volumes of the Bench's medical catalogue are kept in the Archive of Readings and copied for the Murmuring House and the Strap-House of the Breakdowns. A sample entry, from the fourth volume, *Of Oaths of Carrying*: "Item 1,114. A porter of the Galleries, sworn to carry his mother's coffin to the Vaults 'on my own back, all the way down', set it down on the ninth stair to rest. Rupture: the spine at the ninth vertebra, the body folding at that point to the angle of the stair. He completed the carry upon his knees, the coffin on his folded back, and the oath was then held to be kept, and the rupture did not reverse. Note in the margin: *the god does not take back.*"

WHAT COUNTS

The Bench of Clauses has spent six hundred years defining what Tolm counts, and its definitions fill the four miles of the Ledger and a library besides. In practice, the canyon folk know the rule in their bones, because the ones who did not know it are no longer whole:

- ◇ A promise binds. Any statement that commits the speaker to a future act, a future state, or an abstention ("I will", "I won't", "I'll be there", "never", "always", "you can count on me").
- ◇ A lie breaks at once. A spoken assertion the speaker believes to be false is a broken oath the instant it is finished. The Breaking for a lie is nearly always the mouth: the lips, the tongue, the jaw, the teeth.
- ◇ A boast is a promise. "I could carry that alone" is heard as "I will carry it if asked." "Nothing could frighten me" is heard as a vow of courage, and the next thing that frightens the speaker will cost them.
- ◇ Meaning outweighs grammar. A sentence built to sound like a question but meant as a promise binds as a promise. Tolm heard what people meant, and it still does.
- ◇ Ignorance is no defense. An honest mistake about a fact (you said the well was dry, and you believed it, and it was not) is not a lie, but it is still a statement, and how the god will weigh it is a matter of furious debate. Most Oatheners do not risk it. They say "I believe the well is dry," which is true about them, rather than "the well is dry," which is a wager about the world.
- ◇ Sleep counts. A vow sworn in sleep binds as if waking, though at lesser Weight, and the Bench's records hold three hundred years of marriages that came apart over what one spouse heard the other say in the dark.
- ◇ Drink counts. The Bench has ruled six times that wine is not an Exit. This is why Oatheners fear it more than any other people on the Table, and why the Breakdowns, who have nothing left to break, drink fig-spirit by the jug.
- ◇ Echoes count. An oath said once in a place that throws it back has been said as many times as it comes back (see Echoes, below).



*Do not say "always". Do not say "never". Do not say "I swear" unless you would cut off the hand that is lifted.
Do not say "I'd die". You might.*

THE FOUR DON'TS, CHALKED ON THE WALL OF A
GALLERIES SCHOOLROOM

HOW OATHENERS SPEAK

So Oatheners do not chat. They speak rarely, slowly and in conditionals, and they never, ever exaggerate. A polite sentence is mostly exits: "If able." "As I now intend." "Barring death, illness, or weather." "Unless the Bench rules otherwise." "In so far as I can see." A shopkeeper asked whether the bread is fresh says, "It was baked this morning, I am told." A mother asked by her child if she will come back says, "That is my wish," and the child, who is bitted and cannot reply, learns from the sentence everything the mother cannot promise.

Foreigners on the Rim Road find Oatheners cold and evasive. Oatheners find foreigners obscene: people who say "I'll kill you" in jest and "I'll love you forever" at the end of an evening, and walk away whole. To an Oathener a talkative stranger is a man juggling knives in a nursery.

The Oathen voice is distinctive anywhere on the Table: low, even, very slightly slow, with a pause before every verb, as though the speaker were checking the ground before stepping onto it. Oatheners do not interrupt. They do not finish other people's sentences, which in Oathen is a kind of theft. They do not answer a question until it has been asked in full, and then they wait a breath longer, because the asker might yet add a clause. Laughter is rare and mostly silent: a shaking of the shoulders, a hand over the mouth. A loud laugh in Tacit makes people turn around, because a laugh is not a word, but it is very close to one.

THE COMMON EXITS

Every Oathener carries a pocketful of these, and uses them as other peoples use “please”.

- ◇ **If able.** The universal exit. Covers death, injury, the weather and the Bench. Used for goodbye.
 - ◇ **As I now intend.** Binds the speaker only to their present intention, which is a true fact about them and cannot be broken.
 - ◇ **Barring death, illness, or weather.** The Three Bars. Used in contracts and courtship.
 - ◇ **In so far as I can see.** For statements of fact. A blind man in Oathen can say almost anything.
 - ◇ **I am told.** Shifts the weight of a fact onto whoever told you. Rumour in Tacit travels entirely in this form.
 - ◇ **For today.** A child’s exit, learned before the Unbitting: “I’ll be good, for today.”
 - ◇ **God willing.** Never used. It is a promise on Tolm’s behalf, and the Bench has records of what happened to people who made one.
-

GM ADVICE – RUNNING THE RULE AT THE TABLE

Oathen changes how players talk, and that is the point. Make it clear before play that in-character speech in Oathen is mechanically live: what a character says aloud is what the character has said. You are not trying to trap the players with grammar; you are letting them feel what it is to live in a country where every sentence might be a contract. Be generous in the first session. When a player says something binding by accident, pause and ask, “Is that what your character says, in those words?” Once they have felt the first Breaking land on someone else, stop asking. The best Oathen sessions are quiet ones, with long pauses before anyone answers a question, and players writing their character’s sentences down before they say them.

THE FORSWORN: BODIES LIKE BROKEN WORDS

The broken are everywhere in Oathen, and not only in the Breakdowns. Most Oatheners carry a small mark or two: a crooked finger from a childish boast, a split lip healed white, a toe that turned in when someone was late home. These are not Forsworn. The canyon speaks of the Forsworn only for those whose Breaking was grievous, whose mark is plain from across a street, and whose word, therefore, no whole person will take.

A Forsworn body is a sentence that cannot be revised. The Breakings heal, after a fashion: the skin closes over what opened, scar-tissue grows along the lines of the rupture, bones knit at the angle the god set them. But they knit *as broken*. A chest opened for a marriage vow closes over the ribs where they now stand, outward, so that the skin stretches between them like a tent, translucent, and the

heart can be seen moving under it in good light. A jaw that unhinged for a lie heals unhinged, and the Forsworn learn to eat with their fingers, pushing food back past the slack bone. Legs folded backward heal backward. The Breakdowns are full of people walking on knees that bend the heron’s way, quick and jerking and oddly graceful, and the children of the Breakdowns, who are born whole, imitate the walk in their games until their mothers slap them for it.

There is a second breaking that the Book of Ruptures does not record. It happens a season or a year after the first, and it is in the mind. The Forsworn call it *the reading*. It is the moment the broken person understands that every stranger who looks at them knows exactly what they did, in what words, and that this will be true until they die. Some Forsworn go down into the Breakdowns and find the Showing and the common pot and the plain loud speech, and live. Some go the other way, inward, and sit in a back room with the shutters closed and their broken part wrapped in cloth, and say nothing, and eat nothing, and are found by the neighbours when the smell reaches the gallery. The Strap-House in Back-Before-Dark lane keeps a book of those, too. The Breakdowns read the names aloud at the Gathering of the Broken every Carving, loudly, because they can, and because no one on the Walls ever will.



You think the god punished me? The god did me a kindness. I was a liar for nine years with a whole face. Now I have the face I earned. Nobody has to wonder.

A FORSWORN OF HONEST MEASURE, MOUTH OPEN
TO THE EARS

The Forsworn have a word for whole people: *Unread*. It is not a compliment. It means a person whose sins are still hidden, which in the Breakdowns is understood to mean a person who has simply been lucky, or careful, or rich enough to hire a Surety to take their Breakings for them. The broken have a saying: *every Unread is only a promise away*. It is the closest thing the Breakdowns have to a creed.

BROKEN GROUND

A part lost to a grievous Breaking cannot break again. This is the Forsworn’s single, terrible freedom. A woman whose hands came off for short weight can swear on the scales from now until her death and never lose another finger. A man whose chest stands open can tell any woman in the Lantern Lanes that he loves her and walk away without a mark. The Breakdowns call this *standing on broken ground*, and they have made a whole economy of it: liars-for-hire whose mouths are already split, loud-criers whose throats already opened, smugglers whose legs already folded and who will swear to any Watch patrol that they are going nowhere. The Bench has spent two centuries trying to draft a law that a broken mouth cannot evade. It has not succeeded.



Listen twice.

THE OLDEST PROVERB IN OATHEN, AND THE ONLY
ONE TAUGHT TO FOREIGNERS AT TREATY STAIR

The great danger of the canyon country is echo. An oath repeated is an oath renewed, and a canyon will repeat anything. A man who swore in the narrows of the Sheath to pay a debt by the new Plate heard it come back nine times, and when he failed, he broke nine times, each Breaking landing on the last. He is buried at Sheathmouth in nine pieces. The Bench's ruling of 77 A.G., which has never been amended, holds that an echo is the speaker speaking again, because the god hears the voice and not the wall: every repetition the speaker hears is a fresh oath, of the same Weight, made by the same mouth, and broken at the same moment.

Whole gorges are posted as silent, with stone hands carved at their mouths, palm out. Wind is feared for the same reason: a vow overheard is still a vow, and when the dry Carving wind called the Tattler comes up from the south, families sit in their inner rooms in silence until it drops.

Echoes do not always die. The Echo-Wardens divide them into four kinds, in their own clipped handtalk: *the short* (a word that dies in a bend or two, harmless except to the speaker); *the long* (a word that runs the length of a narrows, binding anyone who walks through it in its life, usually an hour or a day); *the kept* (a word caught in a hollow of the rock, a cave or fault, that comes out again whenever the wind or the river pushes air through it, for years); and *the living* (a word that has learned to move, and follows people). Every Warden knows the stories of the kept: the cave above Low Dray that says *I'll wait for you* in a young man's voice every evening when the river breeze turns, and has said it for a hundred and forty years, and the women of Low Dray who go up to listen to it because whoever it was meant it. The living are hunted.

THE WITNESS IS INSIDE

Tolm was the god who listened. It is still listening, from the inside: from the blood of those who ate it, from the rock over its bones, from canyons that throw every word back. The Rule is not a law of nature but the attention of a god, and attention can sharpen and wander. It has begun to count things it never used to count: handtalk, a scribe's chisel, perhaps, for the highest bloodlines, the silent words a person tells themselves at night.

And because it is listening, it can be spoken to. Blasphemy in Oathen is not an abstract offence. To curse Tolm aloud is to address a god that is present in your own throat, and the Bench's records hold four hundred years of cases of what happens to people who do. Most of them went quiet afterward. Not all of them by choice.

BLASPHEMY AGAINST A LISTENING GOD

Elsewhere on the Table, a blasphemer insults a god that cannot hear, or is too busy growing back to care. In Oathen, the god is the one being spoken to, and the god is the one listening, and the god is the Witness by whose attention every word has weight. A curse against Tolm is therefore not an insult but a statement made directly to the record, and the record answers.

The Bench does not punish blasphemy. It records it, in a slim book bound in grey goatskin and kept in a felt-lined box in the Archive of Readings, called the Register of Address. The Register holds forty-one entries since the Muzzling. Thirty-nine of them end the same way: the blasphemer was found the next morning with their tongue gone, not cut but missing, as if never grown, the floor of the mouth smooth and pink and seamless, and the mouth full of fine red sand from the Gullet, three miles from any of them. The sand is warm. Some of them were found still breathing it. The other two entries in the Register were Sayers, and their entries are blank below the date, and the Bench has never entered what they said.

REGISTER OF ADDRESS, entries 36 to 38, transcribed for the Archive of Readings. The Register is kept in the third person and in the past tense, by ruling of 230.

36. In the Lack of 597, Coll Tamber, a lift-hauler of the Shadeward, being drunk on fig-spirit at the death of his wife in childbed, went to the Ear Shrine at the end of the eighth gallery and said into it, "You hear this? You hear it? I hope you're choking on her." He was found at the Shrine at dawn. The tongue was absent. The sand was dry and warm. He lived eleven years, and signed to his neighbours that he had been heard, and that he was not sorry, and that the god had sounded, when it answered, like his wife.

37. In the Grace of 603, a Slate-Clerk of the Bench, name struck by ruling, wrote in the margin of a draft the words "Tolm is dead and we are the maggots." The writing was not then held to bind. The clerk was found at her desk with the tongue absent and the sand in her mouth, and the margin of the draft also full of sand, and the ink beneath it unaltered. The Bench ruled that the god had heard the clerk reading her own margin under her breath, as clerks do. The Bench now doubts this ruling.

38. In the Carving of 621, an unknown person spoke a curse against the god in the Sheath, at night, alone. The words are not known. They came back nine times. Nine Sheathmouth guides, asleep in the village at the canyon's mouth, were found at dawn with their tongues absent and their mouths full of sand. None had spoken. All had heard. The ruling of 77 was applied: to hear an oath in the canyon is to be within its

witness. The Bench has never ruled whether a curse is an oath. Since 621, Sheathmouth sleeps with wax in its ears.

Oatheners curse, of course, as all people curse. They curse each other, the weather, the Bench and the price of figs. They curse in handtalk, which was safe until last year. What they do not do is curse Tolm, or address the god in anger by any of its names, or say *damn you* within hearing of an Ear Shrine. A child who stamps her foot and signs *I hate the god* is picked up by the nearest adult and carried away from any echoing wall before she can be tempted to say it.

The Plain Readers, the Bait-heretics of the Breakdowns and Knot Canyon, practise a blasphemy of their own, and it is worse because it is reverent. They do not curse the god. They *feed* it. At the Ear Shrines, after dark, they whisper to the stone everything they have ever said, from earliest memory: every promise, every lie, every word of love, every name, in long murmuring catalogues that take whole nights. They believe they are giving Tolm back the record it lost when it was eaten, and that when it has heard everything again, it will be whole. They are not always wrong about which shrines have begun to whisper back.

▼ THE REGROWTH IN OATHEN



Tolm is growing back, and what grows back is a witness: an ear that hears too well, a tongue that says too truly. In the Tongue-lines it grows fastest. The Bench of Clauses is the most godsign-ridden body of people in the country, and the more powerful a family, the more carefully it chooses who is allowed to speak.

THE TASTE

It begins with the echo. You say something and, half a second later, you hear it again in your own voice, close behind your ear, slightly flatter, like someone reading it back for the record. At first it happens only in quiet rooms. Then everywhere. Children at the Taste whisper into cupped hands to hear whether it comes back. Adults learn to wait for it, and to listen to what they said with the god's attention, and to wince.

Other tells follow: a taste of wet slate when a promise is made nearby; the ears ringing faintly whenever someone in the room lies; a habit of mouthing other people's words along with them. Tongue-line children at the Taste are bitted early and watched closely, because the Taste is not dangerous, and the Appetite is.



It's like having a clerk behind your ear. A tired one. He doesn't judge. He just writes it all down, and reads it back, and you hear how it sounds.

A GALLERIES WEAVER AT THE TASTE

THE APPETITE

The compulsion to swear. It comes on like a sneeze: a pressure in the throat, a heat behind the teeth, and then the words are out, vows on nothing, on everything. "I will walk to the sea." "I will never eat

bread again." "I will have your eyes." Sufferers wake in the night having sworn in their sleep and lie rigid, trying to remember what they said, while the one who shares their bed lies equally rigid, trying not to have heard it.

The Appetite-struck must be gagged for their own safety, and in Oathen this is no metaphor. The iron bit of the Appetite is a heavy thing, hinged at the jaw, with a flat plate that presses the tongue down and a small grille for breath and broth. Families keep their swearers at home, bitted, hands bound when the urge is strong, because a determined swearer will try to sign or scratch vows into the plaster. The Murmuring House in Tacit holds three hundred of them, in rows, and the sound the place makes, three hundred people trying to promise through iron, is where it gets its name.

What the Appetite wants is not any particular promise. It wants the *weight*. Sufferers describe the urge as a hunger with no object, a pressure that eases only when something heavy has been said and witnessed, and the vows that escape them grow heavier as the Appetite deepens: from "I'll fetch the water" to "I will never leave this room" to "I will give my children to the god." A swearer who gets that last one out before the bit goes back is a family tragedy, and the Bench has no clause for undoing it. The parents of the Murmuring Tier tell their children never to stand in front of a swearer whose bit is off for washing. The children do not need to be told why.

THE COURSE

At the Course, speech stops needing to be a promise to bind. Plain statements begin to come true. "The door is shut," said of an open door, shuts it, or shuts something. "It's cold," said on a warm day, brings frost to the speaker's lashes and nobody else's. Figures of speech become fatal: a man who said he was starving was dead by

evening, in a full pantry, his stomach shrunk to the size of a walnut. A Tongue-line girl who told her sister “you look like death” was a mourner within the week.

The body changes with it. The tongue thickens, darkens and lengthens until it rests against the bit even in repose, mottled the color of raw liver, and grows heavy and cool and faintly ridged, like the god’s own. A second voice develops beneath the first, a half-step lower, and sometimes it says the words a moment before the speaker does. The small ears come: puckers in the skin of the neck and shoulders and the inner arm, at first like scars from a pox, then opening, pink and folded and perfectly formed, turning toward sound. They weep the clear fluid when someone near them makes a vow. Course-sufferers cannot bear crowds. Too much is said in them, and all of it is heard.



*My husband has an ear on the inside of his wrist now.
When I take his hand, it turns toward my mouth.*

A TONGUE-LINE WIFE OF THE HEIGHTS, TO HER
CUTWRIGHT

THE BRINK

At the Brink, the gap between saying and being narrows to nothing. A Brink-sufferer’s ordinary speech reshapes the room they stand in: a careless “of course” makes a thing inevitable; a sigh of “everything’s falling apart” has, on record, brought down a house. The bit is no longer optional. Brink Tongue-lines are taken from their families by the Bench and fitted with silver bits, and their hands are kept gloved and occupied, and they are not permitted pen or chisel. They go mad, often, because a mind full of things it may not say is a mind with no door out, and in Oathen a Break at the Brink is a public danger: a madman whose delusions are binding.

The Bench’s files on the Brink-mad make terrible reading. A Vanthe cousin who became convinced that her family had been replaced by strangers wearing their faces, and who said so, once, at breakfast, before her bit was refitted: the family has not been the same since, and the servants say they eat differently. A Sarrow uncle who believed he had died in the night and was being kept alive by a clerical error, and who said, “I am dead,” and was correct by dinner, though he went on walking about the house for a day afterward because nobody had told his legs. An Esk heir who decided his own hands belonged to someone else, and said whose, and the man he named, a bridge-rigger on the Shadeward who had never met him, woke with two left hands.

THE STOPPING



We keep a stone by the door of his room. Not for the door.

THE MOTHER OF A BRINK-MAD SON, TO A KEENER

There is a thing the families of the Brink-mad do, and the Bench has a ruling for it, and nobody speaks of either aloud. When a Brink-sufferer slips the bit and begins a sentence that would end in ruin (a curse on a city, a wish for a death, *I wish you had never been born*), a kinsman in the room is permitted by the Ruling on Interrupted Speech of 451 to stop the sentence before it ends, by any means. The means are always the same: the speaker must stop breathing before the last word. It is called the Stopping. The ruling requires that the act be done by blood kin, so that no stranger carries it, and that the kinsman swear afterward on the dead one’s bones, before a Keener, *the sentence was grave*. If it was not grave, the oath breaks them.

Oathen does not count the Stopped as murdered. Their families count them. In the Witnessing Vaults the Stopped stand in their own gallery, faces outward, each with a slate at the foot of the niche on which the half-sentence they did not finish has been chalked by the Keeners, word for word, as far as it went. *The canyon will. Mother, I see you are. Let every child in Tacit. I wish you would all.* The Keeners rechalk them every Tablenight. Nobody knows who first insisted the half-sentences be kept, and nobody has ever proposed rubbing them out, and the families who come down to that gallery come alone, and stand longer than they stand anywhere else, and do not read the slates.

In 588, at the height of the Esk fever, Tobin Esk stopped his father in the library of the Esk house on the Sunward Wall. The old man had said “I wish you’d never been”, and Tobin had a pillow, and then had nothing in his hands at all. He swore on the bones that the sentence was grave, and did not break, and the Bench sealed the matter. He went to the Quiet the following spring and took the knife, and lived on Hollin’s Stair for thirty years, and never once in that time was seen to sleep lying down. The current heir of House Esk, Lord Varro, is his great-nephew, and carries a pillow-stone on his watch-chain: a smooth red pebble, said to be the one the family kept by the old man’s door, in case.

THE SEATING: THE SAYERS

A Tongue-line in the last stage does not describe the world. What they say, is. They are called the Sayers, and they are the closest thing the canyons have to Tolm walking again: not the god’s ear but its mouth, the place where its witness turns into its word. The first was a girl in the Hushwell house who said “I wish it would stop” during a storm in 598 A.G. It stopped. So did the wind, the river, the birds,

and the hearts of everything in the valley of Low Shale, which is still there, intact, with nothing in it moving.

The few Sayers alive are kept bitted in gold, which is the one metal Tolm's mouth will not bite through, and locked in the Gilded Cells beneath the Ledger. They are unmuzzled rarely, on the Bench's vote, to say a single sentence the Clausewrights have drafted for months. The Bench calls this governance. The Sayers do not call it anything. Their faces, behind the gold, have grown long and smooth, and their eyes have closed over with skin, and the small ears have covered them like moss.

Three cells are occupied. In the first, since 598, is the First Sayer herself, the Hushwell girl of Low Shale, now an old woman whose face no one living has seen without its gold; the Bench has not unbitted her in forty-three years, because she has never yet been drafted a sentence anyone trusted her with, and because in the first year she wept through the grille so constantly that her keepers feared

what the weeping might mean. In the second is the Sayer of 611, whose name the Bench struck from the Ledger after the night of the copper bit, and who has not been unmuzzled since that one word in the dark. In the third, since 638, is Lady Imre Dath, who is unbitted once a year, and who has begun to write.

THE SAYER'S GOLD

A Sayer's bit is a work of terrible craft: soft gold over a core of lead, cast to the exact shape of the mouth, with a tongue-plate that has to be resized every few months as the tongue grows. The Bitmaker Garl Tome fits them himself. The gold must be pure. A bit cut with copper was found, in 611 A.G., to have been bitten clean through overnight, and the Sayer it held had said one word into the dark of the Cells before the guards reached her. No one knows what the word was. The Gilded Cells were walled off for six weeks afterward, and the guard who came out first had no ears, and smiled.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER



Oathen is dry red canyon country, deep and narrow, under a hard white sky. The plateau above is scrub and scoured stone; the life is below, in the cracks. Rivers run in the canyon floors, thin and green and fast, and the towns are cut into the cliff walls in tiers: dwellings, granaries, shrines and tombs, connected by ladders, rope-lifts and narrow stairs that wind up the rock like the thread of a screw. It is hot, still and extremely quiet. Sandals are soled with felt. Doors are hung on leather. Cart wheels are wrapped in rag. You can stand on a balcony in Tacit and hear a woman across the canyon draw water.

The heat is a dry heat that cracks lips and shrinks leather, and the canyon walls hold it into the night, so that a hand laid on the rock at midnight finds it warm as a sleeping animal. The colours are red, ochre, rust and bone, with the thin green stitch of the rivers at the bottom and, in the low valleys around Low Dray, the dusty grey-green of fig orchards. The smells are hot stone, goat, dung-smoke, cedar oil, and, on the canyon floors, the cool mineral breath of the rivers. The light at noon falls straight down the canyons like water poured into a well, and the people of the lower tiers see it for two hours a day and spend the rest of their lives in a red half-dusk.

The great danger, as has been said, is echo (see the Rule of the Land), and the canyon country is a country of mouths. Every bend is a throat. Every overhang is a palate. Travellers who come down from the Rim Road and hear, for the first time, their own cough come back off a wall a quarter-mile away, then again, then again, fainter, say afterward that it was the moment they understood they were inside something.

It rains once a year. Before it died, Tolm promised the canyons rain on the first day of Grace, and a god's word outlives the god. The Kept Rain has fallen on that day for six hundred and forty years: a single day's downpour, warm and heavy, that fills the cisterns, floods the canyon floors, and drowns the careless. The whole country lives on that day's water. The rain smells, those who have stood in it say, of wet slate and of skin, and it is warm as blood when it first hits, and the canyons roar with it, the only day of the year when Oathen is loud, every gorge a cataract and every wall throwing back the thunder of water, so that lovers make their vows in it and know the god cannot pick their words out of the noise. This year it came three days late.

ECHOES HEARD IN THE GORGES



The canyon doesn't make anything up. That's the horror of it. Every voice you hear in the rock was a person, once, saying something they meant.

GORGE·WARDEN TACET MORROW

Use this table whenever a party travels through an unposted canyon, rests in a narrows, or lies awake near a wall. Each echo is a fragment of something sworn, said or shouted, sometimes years ago. Whether it binds is the GM's call (see Travel Rules in the Canyons in *Seven*

Tables and the Oaths rules at the end of this chapter); most are merely heard, and most are worse for it.

D20	ECHO	WHAT IT MEANS
1	A child's voice: "I'll be back before dark." Again and again, fainter each time, never quite gone.	A kept echo in a cave mouth. The child was not back.
2	A man, very close, in a PC's own voice: "I promise." Nothing before it. Nothing after.	A living echo has heard the PC and is practising.
3	Laughter, one woman, coming down the gorge like a stone bouncing.	Harmless, the Wardens say. Nobody knows whose.
4	"Hold. Hold. Hold." Many voices, ragged, from the east.	Near Wending. The four hundred, at the last moment.
5	A whispered price: "Nine crumbs. Not one more."	An old market-oath. Anyone who haggles that day breaks at the fingers if they pay ten.
6	Two voices saying a marriage vow, out of step, one half a word behind the other.	A couple lay down to say it and the soil was too thin.
7	"I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry," in a voice going hoarse.	A true statement. It costs nothing. It does not stop.
8	A name, called once, from very far up: the name of someone a PC has lost.	The canyon has no reason to know it. Dread 2.
9	The sound of a Breaking: the green-branch crack, then nothing.	It is a sound, not a word. It comes back nine times anyway.
10	Handtalk. The click and slap of fingers, echoing, though fingers make almost no sound.	The widening. The Wardens have begun to log these.
11	"I'll carry you. I'll carry you all the way." A woman, panting.	A kept echo. If a PC is carrying anyone, they feel the weight double.
12	A drover's count, in handtalk-rhythm, spoken: "One, two, three", stopping always at eight.	The Wardens close any gorge where this is heard. They will not say why.
13	A Clausewright's voice reading a contract, clause after clause, steady, for an hour.	A treaty sworn in a felt litter whose felt had worn thin. It is still in force.
14	Weeping, low, from inside the wall itself, where there is no cave.	Put an ear to the rock and it is warm. Dread 2.
15	A shout: "Never!" Just the one word, enormous, from every direction.	Any PC who hears it and is asked a question that day must answer as if bound by it.
16	The PCs' own conversation from an hour ago, word for word, coming back from ahead of them.	The canyon has carried it around. Everything said is renewed.
17	A lullaby with no words, hummed.	From the direction of Low Shale. Nothing in Low Shale moves.
18	"Go on." Two words, very quiet, in the voice of whoever first taught each listener to talk.	Each PC hears a different voice. Dread 3. Do not explain.
19	A crowd, a mile off, rising and falling, too far to make out.	Nobody is near Sworn Gorge. The Wardens should be told.
20	Silence: total, sudden, in a gorge that was full of river-sound a moment ago.	Something nearby is listening so hard that the canyon has stopped.

PLACES IN OATHEN

TACIT

The capital, carved into both walls of the deepest canyon. Half a million people, and you can hear a sandal drop. The Sunward and Shadeward Walls face each other across two hundred rope bridges; the Tongue-lines live high on the Sunward side, and the Bench sits at its heart in the Hall of Conditions, a felt-lined chamber floored with sand so that nothing said there can echo. Markets run on handtalk and tally-sticks. The city smells of hot stone, goat, and the cedar oil the rich rub into their bits. (*Seven Tables* walks Tacit gallery by gallery, from the Heights to the Murmuring Tier.)

THE BREAKDOWNS

The slum of the Forsworn, on the canyon floor below Tacit, where the river runs green and the sun reaches for two hours a day. Here live the broken: men without hands, women with mouths opened back to the ear, people walking on legs that bend the wrong way, people whose ribs stand open under oiled cloth. It is the loudest place in Oathen, because the people in it have nothing left to lose. They swear constantly, defiantly, on broken parts that cannot break again. They sing. They mock the Walls overhead. Their lanes are named for the oaths their founders broke: Fair Weight Row, Back-Before-Dark, the Never Alley, I'll-Stand-By-You, Till-Death Court.

◇

*LIES TOLD — 3 L. UNDER OATH IN A COURT —
10 L. LOVE, SWORN — 2 L, AND YOU BUY THE
DRINK. NO CHILDREN. NO DEBTS.*

CHALKED ON A BOARD AT THE CORNER OF HONEST
MEASURE

SWORN GORGE

A sealed ravine east of Tacit where an oath shouted in 419 A.G. has never stopped echoing. Anyone who hears it is bound by it. Nobody knows any longer what it says. The mouth of the gorge is walled with dressed stone forty feet high, and the wall is packed behind with wool, and still, on the stillest nights, a man pressing his ear to it can hear a murmur in the rock like a crowd a mile off, rising and falling. The Echo-Wardens keep a post at the wall, beside the dead hamlet of Sowe. They wear wax and lead plugs in their ears and communicate by touch, and they rotate every nine days, because the murmur gets into you anyway.

THE LEDGER

A cliff face four miles long into which every vow of public record has been carved: treaties, marriages, sentences, Rim Road contracts, the oaths of kings. The oldest carvings at its western end are worn nearly smooth; the newest, at the eastern end, are still pale with fresh dust. Scaffolds hang from the cliff top, and the carvers work on them in all weathers, in silence, at a lack a letter. Behind the face, inside the rock, lies a warren of record-rooms and copying halls, and below that, the Ninth Room, where executions are conducted, and below that, the Gilded Cells.

THE GILDED CELLS

Where the Sayers are kept: a vault of nine chambers cut deep under the Ledger and lined in beaten lead and felt, with doors of gold-faced iron. Three of the cells are occupied. The guards are bitted and deafened by surgery. A Clausewright of the Bench visits once a week to inspect the bits and does not stay long. The air is close and warm and smells of lead, broth and something sweeter beneath, like the inside of a mouth.

THE GULLET

The gorge where Tolm was eaten, at the head of the river system west of Tacit. Its floor is deep red sand over the god's bones, and it is the quietest place in Oathen: sound does not carry here, but sinks, as if into a pillow. Pilgrims walk the Gullet barefoot on Tablenight eve. Those who put their ear to the sand hear, they say, a slow sound like breathing; the Bench rules that what they hear is the river. The sand is hot all year, and it is getting warmer. The Quiet of Hollin's Stair look down on it from their cells and say that on still nights the whole floor of the Gullet rises and falls, very slightly, like a sleeper's blanket.

THE UNMADE ROAD

A switchbacked track down from Wending Pass, in the high eastern canyons, where Captain Renn Hold's regiment came apart in 627 A.G. Four hundred soldiers swore to hold the pass to the death, obeyed an order to retreat, and broke on the road behind their captain. Their remains were never cleared. The bone along the road is still sorted, roughly, into the shapes of men lying where they fell, and the drovers who use the road walk their animals in single file down the center of it. Renn Hold is still at the top of the pass. He has to be.

THE MURMURING HOUSE

A hospital and asylum on the Shadeward Wall of Tacit for the Appetite-struck and the Brink-mad who have no family to keep them. Three hundred patients, bitted in iron, in long low wards. The nurses work with wax in their ears and feed their charges thin broth through the grille of the bit. The sound of the place is a ceaseless, thick, wet humming: three hundred vows attempted and not finished. On Tablenight, when the patients fall silent with the rest of the country, the nurses say the quiet is so heavy they can hear the patients' hearts.

THE WITNESSING VAULTS

The catacombs beneath Tacit, where the dead stand upright in niches, faces outward, to witness. In the dry air they do not rot so much as cure, the lips drawing back from the teeth so that every face wears the same look of having just heard something. Families come here to swear on the dead, and the Vaults' keepers, the Keeners, are the only people in Oathen who have heard the dead speak (see Oaths on the Dead).

QUILLHOUSE

The Rim Road Company's notarial house on the Oathen stretch of the Rim, three days' ride north of Tacit. A fortress of pale stone, gated, garrisoned by Company guards, and home to Jessamy Quill. Every Company contract on the Table is carried here by courier, read aloud before her, and sworn. The waiting-hall is always full: Fatlands renderers, Brinehollow admirals' factors, Vigil oil-buyers, all made to sit in silence in a long felted room while an Oathen clerk explains, in handtalk and on slate, that anything they say from here on counts.

LOW SHALE

The valley the First Sayer stopped in 598 A.G. Everything in it stopped: water standing in the riverbed in a single hard green ribbon that will not run if you cup it, birds hanging in the air a foot above the ground, a herdsman mid-stride with his crook raised, his eyes wet and open after forty-three years. Nothing rots. Nothing moves. The air is warm and has no smell at all. The Bench has posted it as silent and forbids entry. Pilgrims of the Bait doctrine sneak in to leave written prayers at the herdsman's feet. The herdsman's eyes have been seen to follow them.

HOLLOW CISTERN AND THE HIGH BASIN

At Highwell, above the Gullet, where the Rain-keepers ate the god’s heart, the Rain Shrine stands at the centre of a bowl of red rock ringed with cisterns: six hundred and forty standing stones, each carved with a year and its rainfall. Every household’s cistern-share is sworn here or at a share-stone on the first day of Grace. This year a new stone stands outside the ring, uncarved, the height of a young

woman. The basin has not yet agreed what to write on it (see Oathen Now).

THE STILLED GALLERY

A short gallery on the eleventh tier of the Shadeward Wall, forty doors long, sealed at both ends with felt curtains since the Lack of 640. It was called Corder’s Gallery once, after the rope-makers who lived there. Nobody lives there now. What happened in it is told under Oathen Now.

▼ HISTORY



YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
Lack -2	The Hundred Vows sworn at Tolm’s shin. All are kept. The Lack goes on.
0	The Silent Supper. Tolm eaten in the Gullet over three nights without a word.
3	The First Breaking. A merchant sworn to fair dealing shorts a customer; his hands come off at the wrist in the market.
12	The first vows carved on the Ledger, beginning with the account of the Supper.
3–215	The Honest Age. Oathen the most trusted nation on the Table.
61	The Rim Road Company swears its charter at Tacit.
77	The Ruling on Echoes: every repetition heard is a fresh oath.
148	The Sureties’ Compact. Oath-carrying becomes a licensed trade.
215	The Muzzling. All children bitted until the age of twelve.
221	Handtalk codified by the Bench and declared not to bind.
240	The Quiet founded by Abbess Hollin Mure, who took the knife to her own tongue.
290	The Bait doctrine outlawed in Oathen.
312	The Vanthe Oath sworn on the dead: “the tongue shall not leave this house.”
330	The Mute Succession. The crown restricted to those who have never spoken.
377	The Ninefold outlawed by the Bench. The upper gorges ignore the ruling.
419	The oath in Sworn Gorge. The gorge walled the following spring.
422	The Echo-Wardens chartered.
451	The Ruling on Interrupted Speech: the Stopping made lawful for kin.
506	The Forsworn Riots. The Breakdowns rise; Tacit’s lower bridges are cut.
582	Little Rue promises her mother she will never grow up.
598	The First Sayer. Low Shale is stopped. The Gilded Cells are dug.
610	Ket the Ninth born mute in the Hushwell line, chosen in infancy.
611	A Sayer’s copper-cut bit is bitten through. One word is said in the dark.
627	Wending Pass. Captain Renn Hold’s four hundred come apart.
638	Lady Imre Dath enters the Seating.

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
640	Mirren Osk's fingers break over a handtalk poem. Ottoline Vant's miscut. Corder's Gallery falls silent.
641	The Kept Rain falls three days late. At Highwell, Hallie Corr goes to the stone.

THE HONEST AGE

For two centuries after the Supper, Oathen was the conscience of the Table. Other lands discovered they had swallowed monstrous gifts; Oathen discovered it had swallowed honesty, and sold it. A treaty sworn in Tacit could not be broken without the signatories' bodies breaking too; a merchant house that swore its weights at the Ledger could be trusted to the crumb. Oathen grew rich on notarizing the world. The canyon cities filled with foreign envoys learning to keep quiet.

It was not a kind age. Children broke constantly on promises they did not understand, and the cemeteries of the period are full of small, oddly shaped bones. In 215 A.G. the Bench passed the Muzzling, and the canyons have been quiet in a new way since: the silence of the nursery.



The bones in the children's galleries of the old Vaults are not arranged by family. They are arranged by what broke. Nobody alive remembers why. Everybody who sees it understands.

OLD SABRA WENDS, ELDEST KEENER

THE MUTE SUCCESSION

The old kings spoke, and every word bound them. By 330 A.G. King Orrel the Fourth had sworn so many coronation oaths and treaty-clauses that he ruled his last years from a litter, his body folded into what his physicians called an exact map of his reign's contradictions. Thereafter the crown passed only to children who had never spoken. Nine such kings have reigned, and all died with their silence intact.

THE VANTHE OATH

The Vanthes ate the tip of Tolm's tongue, the part that touches the teeth, and they have always been the quickest-spoken and the soonest-broken of the high houses. In 312 A.G., when a Vanthe daughter married into the Esks and the Cutwrights reported that her children had the stronger godsign of the two houses, the Vanthe matriarch, Lady Orsa, went down to the Witnessing Vaults with her whole house behind her, laid her hand on the bones of her husband, and swore, at Weight 5, on the dead: *The tongue shall not leave this house.*

The Bench has argued ever since about whether a living woman can bind her unborn descendants. The Vanthes do not argue. Every Vanthe who has tried to marry outside the house since 312 has broken at the mouth on the wedding morning, the tongue splitting to its root, and the Testimony of Lady Orsa's husband has been heard from his niche in the Vaults eleven times, each time saying the oath in a dead man's voice, loud enough to be heard on the Sunward Wall. So the Vanthes marry Vanthes. They have married cousins, and then the children of cousins, and then, the Ledger's register of marriages implies in a column nobody reads aloud, nearer than cousins. One entry, for 589, records the marriage of Lady Ammet Vanthe to Corvel Vanthe, and beside it, in the Cutwrights' small grey marginal hand, pressed so hard the nib went through the page, two words: *same mother.*

The Vanthes are beautiful in the same way, all of them: narrow, very pale, with the house's grey eyes and the house's habit of tilting the head when listening. Their children reach the Taste in the cradle. Many are born with their mouths sealed over with a membrane of skin and must be cut open before they can feed, and the house physician does it in silence with a silver knife and stitches nothing, because the god's tongue must have its door. Some of the sealed ones do not take the knife well. The Vanthe children's gallery in the Vaults is long. The house does not receive guests for supper, and its servants are hired from Sheathmouth, where people are used to not saying what they have seen.



You never ask a Vanthe who their father is. Not because it's rude. Because they'd have to think about it.

OVERHEARD ON THE TENTH BRIDGE, IN HANDTALK,
AND THE HANDS WERE BROKEN A MONTH LATER;
NOBODY KNOWS IF IT WAS THE GOD OR THE HOUSE

THE OATH IN SWORN GORGE

In the drought summer of 419 A.G., something was shouted in a narrow ravine east of Tacit, and the ravine has never stopped saying it. The records of that year are incomplete: a page is cut from the Bench's minutes and a stretch of the Ledger has been chiselled smooth, very carefully, in a way that took weeks. What is known is that the people of the hamlet of Sowe, at the gorge's mouth, were all found broken the following spring, every one of them, in the same way, and that the shape of the Breaking was so terrible that the Echo-Wardens' charter forbids its description. The gorge was walled. The murmur goes on.

THE FORSWORN RIOTS

By 506 the Breakdowns held forty thousand broken people, and the Bench passed the Ruling of Visible Marks, requiring every Forsworn to bare their broken part above the third tier. The broken came up the stairs on crutches and wheeled boards, swearing on broken ground that they would burn the Galleries, and the Watch could swear nothing back. Then they cut nine of the lowest bridges, with people on them. The Bench rescinded the Ruling by noon, and no Bench collector has gone down into the Breakdowns since.

WENDING PASS

In 627 A.G. Reckoners out of the Fast came through the eastern canyons, and the four hundred soldiers of the Fourth Regiment of the Canyon Watch swore, in the old form, to hold Wending Pass to the death. Captain Renn Hold looked at the raiders and at his men, most of them nineteen, and ordered them to fall back. He kept his own oath by staying. They broke theirs by obeying. The sound came down the road like a rockfall, four hundred Breakings in a breath, each soldier opening at every joint by which he had bound himself to the place. They did not die of it, not at once. The Reckoners found the captain alone at the top with his sword drawn, looked at the road below him, and went back the way they had come.

I ORDERED THEM DOWN BECAUSE I LOVED THEM. I
HAVE HAD FOURTEEN YEARS TO WORK OUT
WHETHER THAT WAS AN OATH.

[CAPTAIN RENN HOLD, TO A DROVER, AT THE TOP OF WENDING PASS]

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS



Oathen is ruled by the Mute Kings, chosen in infancy, bitted for life, and raised to rule by gesture. The present king, Ket the Ninth, has never made a sound. Beneath him sits the Bench of Clauses, forty-one lawyer-priests called Clausewrights, whose art is the drafting of promises that can survive contact with reality. In theory the Bench interprets the king. In practice the king nods, and the Bench spends a month in forty-page conditionals deciding what the nod meant, and then does what it would have done anyway.

There are no prisons. There is no need. A convicted person is made to swear the terms of their own sentence: “I will not leave the district of Low Dray for nine years.” “I will pay the widow one lack a day until my death.” “I will not speak again.” Breach the sentence and the body enforces it. The Bench’s chief tool of government is therefore not the sword but the clause, and its great fear is the sentence badly drafted, which leaves a convict free, or the sentence too well drafted, which kills him in a way the court did not intend. For the gravest crimes there is the Breaker, Jude Crake, who carries out death sentences with nothing but conversation.

SWORN SENTENCE, Question Court of the Shadeward, Carving 640. To be read aloud by the convict, Merrin Hask, water-thief and slayer, in its entirety, before the Court and a Keener, with a hand laid upon the bones of the slain, Doria Hask, her sister. Weight raised to 5 by the witness of the dead. Drafted by Under-Drafter Lise Amberd, reviewed by Clausewright Ennis Sarrow. Fee, 15 L, paid from the estate of the slain.

I, Merrin Hask, who took water from my sister’s share and struck her when she found me at it, and did not mean her to die of it, and she died of it,

swear on the bones of my sister Doria, under my hand,

that from the setting of this Plate I will not drink from any cistern of Tacit, nor any share sworn at the Rain Shrine, nor any water drawn by another for my sake, for the term of nine years;

that I will drink only from the river, as the Forsworn drink;

that I will carry, each day of the term, barring illness so grave that a Keener attests it, eleven buckets from the river to my sister's widower's door, which was the number of her share;

that I will not ask him for anything, nor speak to him unless he speak first;

that I will not leave the Breakdowns save to carry;

and that if I fail in any of this, I will hear my sister say so.

Barring death, which ends it. Barring the ruling of the Bench, which may lighten it. And for no other cause.

I have read it. It is what I mean.

(Marginal note, in the Keener's hand: Read clean. No Exits taken but the two allowed. The widower, Joss Hask, attended, and did not speak, and at the last line put his hand on the convict's shoulder, which the Court did not see, because it was not looking.)

Trials are simple. In a Breaking trial, presided over by Judge Thane Urrow, there is no evidence and no testimony. The accused repeats the promise they are alleged to have broken, aloud, in its original words, and the court watches. If they kept it, nothing happens. If they broke it, it breaks them again, now, in front of everyone. For crimes that are not oaths (theft, murder, arson), the accused is asked a single question: "Did you do it?" and must answer. A Forsworn who has nothing left to break in the mouth is a problem the Bench has never solved, which is why the Breakdowns are, to Tacit's lasting horror, the one place in Oathen where a person can lie.

Oathen's power abroad is trust. Every other government sends its treaties east to be made real, and the Rim Road Company swears every contract before its notary, Jessamy Quill. Oathen charges a tithe on every sworn page, and has never needed an army larger than its notaries. It has one anyway, the Canyon Watch, small and very well disciplined, because a soldier who has sworn to obey cannot do otherwise. Since Wending Pass, the Watch's oath has been redrafted. It now runs to eleven pages, and the phrase "to the death" has been removed.

THE NINEFOLD

In the upper gorges, where the ear-eating clans live and the Bench's writ runs thin, there is an older justice, and it is a ritual killing. The Bench outlawed it in 377. The gorges did not notice.

When a kinsman kills a kinsman in the upper gorges and will not answer the question, the clan takes him to a narrows that throws back nine (every upper-gorge clan has one, and knows its count) and stands him in the place where the echo is cleanest. The dead one's nearest kin stand above, on the rim. They call down to him the question, *did you do it*, and he must answer, and whatever he answers comes back nine times. If he says *yes*, the clan lets him live,

sworn to exile on the bones. If he says *no*, and it is a lie, his mouth breaks, and then breaks again, and again, nine times, each Breaking landing on the last, and by the ninth there is no jaw, no tongue, no lips, and the throat has split down to the breastbone, and the clan on the rim watches in silence until the canyon is quiet. Then they go down and bring him up and lay him in the dead one's niche, facing in. If he says nothing, they wait. The longest anyone has ever stood silent in a Ninefold narrows is four days. The clan stood on the rim for all of them.

The Ninefold is not cruel by the gorges' reckoning. Nobody lays a hand on the accused. The god does everything. That is what the clans say, and the Bench, whose own Breaker sits down with the condemned and talks until they promise something, has never found a reply that it could make without hearing itself.



Down here we don't kill a man. We ask him a question, and let the walls ask it again.

AN ELDER OF THE TALLOW-CLAN, UPPER GULLET,
TO A BENCH INSPECTOR WHO DID NOT RETURN TO
TACIT WITH HIS TONGUE

POLITICS IN A SENTENCE

- ◇ The Bench wants the Kept Rain explained before the Tablenight silence ends, and has three drafts of a Sayer's sentence ready.
- ◇ The Forsworn want the Breakdowns made a free city, with its own Bench of the broken, and they have the numbers to cut Tacit's bridges again.
- ◇ The Rim Road Company wants Jessamy Quill kept whole at any cost, because if she breaks, half the trade of the Table comes unbound.
- ◇ The Tongue-lines want an heir with a voice, and some of them want a Sayer of their own.
- ◇ Highwell wants a stone carved with a girl's name and the words "she brought the rain". Its Rainwarden will not carve it, and will not say why.
- ◇ The king wants to say something. He has wanted to for thirty-one years.



SPEECH AND SILENCE

- ◇ Handtalk. A sign language used for everything that matters little: prices, directions, the weather, gossip, jokes, flirtation. It is held not to bind. That belief is being tested, and fingers have started breaking. Oatheners sign with the left hand where they can, because it is the hand they can spare.
- ◇ The bit. Children wear a soft leather muzzle until twelve, decorated by their parents with beads, ribbons and family marks. Having it removed is the coming of age, the Unbitting, and the first words spoken afterward are chosen with a Clausewright present. They are usually a family motto, or “I am here,” which is safe.
- ◇ Conditional speech. “If able.” “As I now intend.” “Barring death, illness, or weather.” A polite sentence is mostly exits.
- ◇ Insults. The worst thing you can call someone is “talkative.” The second worst is “certain.”
- ◇ Proverbs. Oathen proverbs are short and verbless where possible: “Fewer words, more fingers.” “A full mouth, an empty hand.” “The canyon keeps the change.” “Listen twice.” “Say it to the dead, pay it to the living.” “Better bitted than broken.”

FOOD, DRINK AND DRESS

Oatheners eat goat, canyon lizard, flatbread baked on hot stones, dried figs, and a sour green cheese aged in the river caves. Water is life and law: every household’s cistern-share is sworn yearly at the Rain Shrine, and stealing water is the only theft the Bench treats as a crime against the god. Meals are eaten in silence; the grace “Lack keep away” is signed, not said, unless there are foreigners at the table, in which case it is said very slowly with three exits attached. Wine is rare and feared, because drunkenness makes promises.

Dress is plain and close-fitting, in dust-red and ochre wool, with long sleeves to hide what broke. The Tongue-lines wear high collars and veils across the mouth, white for the unwed, black for those whose vows are many. Rings are worn on the thumbs as reminders of oaths outstanding: a ring per vow, so that a man’s hands tell you how much he owes. The Forsworn go bare where they broke, as a point of pride.



FIGS, DRIED, A CRUMB THE HANDFUL. FRESH THIS MORNING, I AM TOLD.

CHALKED ON A STALL-BOARD IN THE FELT MARKET;
THE “I AM TOLD” IS IN A DIFFERENT HAND, ADDED
AFTER THE BREAD-WOMAN’S FINGER

MARRIAGE AND KIN

Marriage vows are negotiated for months and run to forty pages, covering fidelity, property, illness, absence, the care of each other’s dead, and what counts as “cherishing.” Divorce does not exist: a marriage vow cannot be unsworn, only broken, and its Breaking is the chest opened to the air. What the faithless do, and what the vows forbid in their thicket of clauses, the canyon decently does not discuss aloud. The Tongue-lines marry cousin to cousin to keep the god’s tongue in the family, and some old houses have married so close for so long that their children are born with mouths sealed over with skin, and must be cut open before they can feed.

FROM THE MARRIAGE CONTRACT OF TAMSIN ORLE, felt-maker of the Galleries, and BRANNOCK DELL, lift-hauler of the same, sworn at the Bench Terrace in the Plenty of 636. Forty-one pages. Drafted by Under-Drafter Wilm Esse at 5 L the page, the families sharing the cost. Extract, pages 17 to 19, read aloud by both parties on the wedding morning in the felted marrying-room of the Hall.

Article the Ninth: Of Cherishing.

- 9.1. Each party, as they now intend, shall cherish the other.
- 9.2. “Cherish” shall be read, for the purposes of this contract, as follows: to wish the other well; to act, where able and where it does not endanger the party’s children, kin or share, for the other’s good; to speak no ill of the other before a third person save in a court, a sickroom, or the Vaults.
- 9.3. “Cherish” shall not be read to require any feeling at any particular hour. The parties acknowledge that feeling is weather.
- 9.4. Should either party cease to wish the other well, they shall not be held to have broken this article for a period of one season, during which they shall be held to be “in Lack” and shall attempt, in good faith, a recovery of the wish.
- 9.5. Attempt is an oath of effort, and is kept by attempting.

Article the Tenth: Of the Bed.

10.1. Each party shall share a bed with no other living adult, barring the nursing of kin in fever, the sharing of warmth in a snowed pass, and any ruling of the Bench.

10.2. The word “living” in 10.1 is deliberate and was argued for nine days. See the annexed opinion of the Under-Drafter, page 38, which the parties have read and which neither shall be required to read aloud.

10.3. On the death of either party this article ends, and the survivor is free of it, and shall not be held to it by any reading, nor by any Testimony of the dead, and the dead party so agrees, here, now, aloud.

Article the Eleventh: Of Absence.

11.1. Neither party shall promise the other to be home by any hour.

11.2. Each party shall instead say, on leaving, “If able,” and the other shall answer “Go on,” and this exchange shall bind neither.

11.3. Should either party fail to come home for nine nights without word, the other may go to the Vaults and ask.

(Annexed note, in the Under-Drafter’s hand, page 38: Article 10.2 is included at the request of the bride’s mother, who was a Keener of the Vaults for thirty years, and who stated to the drafter, in handtalk, with her hands shaking, that she had found what she had found in the widowers’ galleries, and would not have her daughter’s husband find a reading of the word “bed” that the god would allow. The drafter has followed her instruction. The drafter has not asked what she found.)

CHILDREN

Children are bitted from the first tooth until twelve. They grow up in handtalk, which they speak faster and more inventively than adults, with a whole private slang of nursery signs. The bit is soft and does not hurt, but it shapes the face: Oathen adults have a groove worn at the corners of the mouth, and some of the old bits, family heirlooms, have been worn by six generations of children and taste of all of them. Every parent in the country carries one fear above all others: that their child will say something before twelve, in the instant the bit is off for cleaning. Some do. The Bench records the Breakings of children only by number. The number this year is higher than last.

The bitted have games of their own: the counting game of the ear and the knife; a game called *Closed Hand* in which the loser is the first to answer a question; and a cruel one, played in the lanes of the Galleries, in which one child signs a promise very slowly to another, and everyone watches to see if the fingers will break. It used to be a game about nothing. This year it is a game of courage, and mothers are beating it out of their children with the flat of their hands, silently, in doorways.

CARELESS PROMISES



*It’s never the oaths that get you. It’s the little things
you say on the stairs.*

A GAG-NURSE OF THE MURMURING TIER

Most Breakings in Oathen are not crimes. They are accidents of speech: the small binding sentences that escape tired, frightened, loving or angry people, and that the god, which weighs meaning, does not forgive. When a character speaks carelessly, or when you want to show the country breaking around the PCs, roll on this table. The Weight given is the usual reading; the Breaking is what the Bench’s physicians most often record.

D20	THE CARELESS PROMISE	HOW IT USUALLY BREAKS
1	“I’ll be back before dark.” (said leaving for a day’s haul)	Weight 1. The heels split on the doorstep at dusk, a hundred yards from home.
2	“I could sleep for a week.”	Weight 1 at the Course. The speaker does. Nobody can wake them until the seventh day.
3	“Over my dead body.”	Weight 3. The Bench has a whole file. Do not let a PC say it.
4	“I’ll never speak to you again.” (in a quarrel between sisters)	Weight 2. Broken at the reconciliation; the lips split as she says “I’m sorry”.
5	“I’ll just be a minute.”	Weight 1. A minute later the ankles crack, wherever the speaker is standing.
6	“Cross my heart.” (a child, the bit off for washing)	Weight 2. The breastbone cracks. The mother does not cry out.
7	“I’d give anything for a drink.”	Weight 2. The god takes the reading literally. Something is gone by morning; the speaker has to find out what.
8	“I’ll take care of it.”	Weight 2. Breaks if it is not taken care of; the palms split.

D20	THE CARELESS PROMISE	HOW IT USUALLY BREAKS
9	"I'm fine." (said to a worried husband, by a woman who is not)	Weight 1, a lie. The lips split at the corners, a thin line. He sees it and says nothing.
10	"I'll love you forever." (a foreigner at an inn)	Weight 3. The foreigner did not know. The chest cracks at dawn. He leaves Oathen on a litter.
11	"I won't tell anyone."	Weight 2. The ears ring and bleed at the first telling; at Weight 3, the throat opens.
12	"You'll be the death of me." (to a child)	Weight 1, at the Course Weight 4. Do not let a PC say it.
13	"I'll pay you back tomorrow."	Weight 2. Fingers snap backward at the next dawn, one per lack still owed.
14	"I'll eat my own hat if..."	Weight 1. He does. He cannot stop himself. It takes all night.
15	"I'd die for you." (a lover's exaggeration)	Weight 2–3. The breath stops for a minute when the chance comes and is not taken.
16	"I'll always be here." (a mother at a sickbed)	Weight 3. When she leaves the room at last to sleep, her tendons draw up and she cannot pass the door.
17	"I'll keep an eye on him."	Weight 2. When he comes to harm out of sight, the eyes bleed. At Weight 3 one eye goes.
18	"I'll never drink again." (the morning after)	Weight 2. The stomach cramps and the speaker vomits blood at the first cup.
19	"I won't let you fall." (on a lift-rope or bridge)	Weight 3. If the other falls, the arms snap at the elbows, still reaching.
20	"Nothing could make me leave this city."	Weight 3. Binding until something does. Then the feet turn fully about, facing Tacit.

DEATH AND THE DEAD

The dead are entombed upright in the Witnessing Vaults, faces outward, so that they may witness the oaths of the living. Before a body is set in its niche, the family gathers and speaks every promise they made to the dead person in life, and the Keener asks the corpse, formally, whether each was kept. The dead do not answer. Usually. A death in Oathen also releases the dead person's oaths, which is why heirs sometimes wait at a bedside very patiently, and why the Bench has drafted a clause, standard in all wills, binding the heirs to have hoped for recovery.

Oaths sworn on the dead are the heaviest in the land: a hand on the bones, the dead one's name, the vow said into the niche. They are used for blood feuds, for marriages across feuding families, for debts too large for any Surety. When such an oath breaks, the dead person answers for Tolm, and what the dead do then is the stuff of every Oathen ghost story, and all of them are true.

THE DESECRATORS

Where there is an oath on the dead, there is someone who wants the dead gone. The trade is old and the Keeners hate it above all others: **bone-lifting**, the theft of a witness from its niche, by an oathbreaker who hopes that a dead one who is no longer in the Vaults can no longer Testify. It does not work. Bones lifted from the Vaults Testify from wherever they are taken: from the bottom of the Hushwater, from a lime-pit in Knot Canyon, from under a hearthstone in the Galleries, where in 602 a family sat at supper above the grandmother they had sworn on and heard her say their oath up through the floor. The Keeners know this. The desperate do not, or will not believe it.

The worst of the desperate go further. There is a belief, old in the upper gorges and spreading in the Breakdowns, that a witness swallowed cannot speak: that an oathbreaker who grinds the bones of the dead they swore on into flour and bakes it into bread and eats it, alone, at night, in silence, has taken the witness inside, where the god cannot hear it. The Keeners call the practice *eating the witness*. They know of nineteen cases since 500. In every one, the dead Testified anyway, from inside: their voice coming up out of the oathbreaker's own belly, muffled and wet, speaking the oath aloud in a crowded place, while the oathbreaker clutched at their stomach and the people around them backed away.



We tell the families, the dead will speak from wherever you put them. If you put them in your mouth, that is where they will speak from.

A KEENER OF THE WITNESSING VAULTS

The Keeners also guard the widowers' galleries, where the dead of marriages are set facing each other across a narrow aisle, and where, once in a generation, a niche is found empty, and the empty niche belongs to a wife whose husband swore her a vow of the bed, and was a very literal man. The Keeners go up to the house with lamps. What they find there is never entered in any record, and the Bench's ruling of 503, that a vow of the bed ends at death, was drafted in a single afternoon after one such visit, and is read aloud now at every Tongue-line wedding.

FESTIVALS

- ◇ The Kept Rain (first day of Grace). The whole country stands in the open, faces up, mouths bitted, and the rain comes. Children take their first swim. Lovers make the year's vows in the downpour, when the noise of it hides the words from the canyon. This year, for three days, the whole country stood and waited, and the sky stayed white.
- ◇ The Unbitting (Plenty). Twelve-year-olds have their bits removed in public, in the Hall of Conditions, and speak their first chosen words. Families weep, silently.
- ◇ The Carving of the Year (Carving). The new vows of public record are cut into the Ledger. Carvers work through the night by lamplight, and the town watches from the canyon floor.
- ◇ The Night of Ears (the eve of Tablenight). Pilgrims walk the Gullet barefoot and lay their ears to the warm sand.
- ◇ Tablenight (longest night of Lack). Twenty-four hours in which no one in the country makes a sound. Shops close. Bells are tied. Babies are nursed constantly. It is the only day Oatheners feel safe, and the happiest day of the year. Couples who have not touched in years hold hands in the street. Enemies sit at one table. Nothing can be promised, so nothing can be broken, and for one day, the canyons say, everybody is whole.

CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

Every crime in Oathen is either an oath broken or a question waiting to be asked: a convict swears a sentence, a debtor a schedule, and a murderer, if the crime is grave, receives Jude Crake. Blasphemy, the cursing of Tolm aloud, is not punished by the Bench at all; it is merely recorded, as Tolm will see to it. Of forty-one blasphemers entered in the record since the Muzzling, thirty-nine were found the next morning with their tongues gone, not cut but missing, as if never grown, and their mouths full of fine red sand. The other two were Sayers. No one has entered their sentences in the record.

▼ FACTIONS



THE BENCH OF CLAUSES

The Clausewrights: rulers in practice, and the finest contract lawyers who have ever lived. They train for twenty years in the drafting of vows, in the reading of Tolm's past judgments on the Ledger, and in the art of speaking a whole day without committing

to anything. They believe that the Rule is law and that law can be perfected: that somewhere there is a sentence so well drafted that it binds exactly what is intended and nothing more. They want order, the Rain explained, the Sayers kept, and their own power left untouched. They fear the Forsworn, the widening of what counts, and their own Tongue-line blood, which is the most advanced in the land.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Slate-Clerk	Copies drafts; access to the Bench's lower archives.
2	Under-Drafter	Drafts minor contracts; a fee of 5 lacks per sworn page.
3	Clausewright	Speaks before the Bench; may witness oaths in the king's name.
4	Bencher	A vote; a seat in the Hall of Conditions; access to the Ledger's sealed rooms.
5	Chief Clausewright	Interprets the king; drafts the Sayers' sentences.

A PC joins by passing the Examination of Exits (Tongue + Clause vs Grim, under a Clausewright's hostile questioning for a full day without a binding misstep). Enemies: the Forsworn, the Second Table's agents among the Tongue-lines. Allies: the Rim Road Company, the Cutwrights' College.



Q: Is the sky white? A: It appears so, from where I am seated, at this hour, to these eyes. Q: Good. Next question.

FROM THE EXAMINATION OF EXITS, FIRST HOUR

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Cracked	Shelter in the Breakdowns; a meal a day from the common pot.
2	Broken-in	A trade: liar-for-hire, loud-crier, smuggler.
3	Open-Hand	Command of a lane; a vote at the Gathering of the Broken.
4	Splint	One of Brakk's council; access to the Breakdowns' arms.
5	Voice	Speaks for the Breakdowns to the Bench.

A PC joins by breaking an oath in public, or by already being broken. Enemies: the Bench, the Echo-Wardens. Allies: the Purgation, which preaches that breaking is a step toward vomiting up the god.

THE SURETIES

Professionals who take on other people's oaths for a fee and carry the risk in their own bodies. A Surety swears, before the principal's

THE FORSWORN

The broken. They live in the Breakdowns, organized, angry, and with very little left to lose. A Forsworn who broke their hands cannot be broken in the hands again; a Forsworn with an opened mouth can lie without further cost. The Breakdowns have made a politics of this. Led by Brakk, the Forsworn swear loudly and freely on what is already broken, take jobs no whole Oathener can, and run the canyon's smuggling, lying and loud-mouthed trades. They want the Breakdowns made a free city, the end of public shaming, and a share of the Rim Road tithe. Some want much worse: they want everyone in Tacit broken, so that no one is better than anyone.

oath is made, to stand behind it: if the principal breaks, the Surety breaks in their place. Sureties are licensed by the Compact of 148, tattooed with the oaths they carry in a dense fine script, and among the richest commoners in the land. They are also, inevitably, ruins. A Surety in the trade for twenty years has usually paid on a dozen defaults and carries them all. They believe in the arithmetic of risk; they want fees, fair principals, and a quiet death before the next default. They fear one bad season.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Bondling	Carries Weight 1–2 oaths; fees of 2–10 lacks.
2	Underwriter	Carries Weight 3 oaths; a seat in the Surety House.
3	Bondsman	Carries Weight 4 oaths, including marriages; a private physician.
4	Great Surety	Carries treaties and Company contracts; a house on the Sunward Wall.
5	Master of the Compact	Sets fees and refuses principals for the whole trade.

A PC joins by carrying a first oath (see Sureties, below) and surviving the year. Enemies: Grandam Cess, defaulters. Allies: the Rim Road Company, the Bench.

When a Surety dies, the Compact flays the script from her and binds it into a book, and the book goes on the shelf of the Surety House with the others. It is the only library on the Table written entirely in other people's debts.

ENVOY DORIAN SAYCE, IN A LETTER HE DID NOT SEND

THE QUIET

An ascetic order that has given up speech entirely, some by vow and some by knife. Founded in 240 A.G. by Abbess Hollin Mure, the Quiet live in cliff-cells along the upper Gullet and teach, in writing, that speech is the god's fishing line, and every word a hook. They want silence: first for themselves, then for Oathen, and in their secret texts, for the whole Table. Sister Verity Amn has brought a terrible new teaching: that for the highest bloodlines, even thought now binds, and that the knife is not enough.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hushed	Shelter; a slate and chalk; the Quiet's protection.
2	Sealed	Has taken the vow of speech; may teach handtalk novices.
3	Tongueless	Has taken the knife; immune to Breakings of the tongue.
4	Stillmind	Learns the disciplines of empty thought.
5	Abbess of the Quiet	Writes the order's teachings.

A PC joins by a vow of silence (Weight 4) or by the knife. Enemies: the Forsworn, who mock them. Allies: the Echo-Wardens.

THE ECHO-WARDENS

Rangers who police the silent gorges and hunt down old sworn words still bouncing in the deep rock. An oath can live in a canyon

for decades, flying from wall to wall, binding everyone who walks through it; the Wardens track such echoes by ear, map them, and kill them with felt baffles, wool dams, sand-falls and, for the worst, controlled rockfall. They are deaf in one ear by tradition (the right, cut at their initiation) and listen with the other like hunting dogs. They want the canyons clean of old words. They fear Sworn Gorge.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Baffler	Carries felt and wool; a Warden's ration.
2	Listener	Licensed to enter posted gorges; the half-deafening.
3	Tracker	Leads echo-hunts; a horn of signal-silence.
4	Gorge-Warden	Commands a district; may seal a canyon by order.
5	Warden of the Wall	Keeps the post at Sworn Gorge.

A PC joins by apprenticeship and the cutting of the right ear. Enemies: smugglers who use echoes to bind pursuers. Allies: the Quiet, the Bench.

POWERS FROM ABROAD

The Rim Road Company is the great foreign power in Oathen, operating from Quillhouse under Jessamy Quill. The Cutwrights'

College keeps a small, sharp-eyed office in Tacit and knows exactly which Tongue-lines are nearest the Brink. The Purgation preaches among the Forsworn that a broken body is a body vomiting up the god. The Second Table has agents in at least three Tongue-line houses, and an interest in Sayers that needs no explaining. The Reckoners have not come through the canyons since Wending Pass; they know Renn Hold is still at the top.

▼ OATHEN NOW



The rain was late, which means a god's promise has slipped, which should not be possible. Handtalkers are starting to break. A scribe has found evidence that written words now bind. If the Regrowth is widening what counts as speech, soon there will be nothing an Oathener can safely say, sign, write, or perhaps think. And the Bench is debating, in forty-page conditionals, whether to take the bit out of a Sayer and have her fix it.

Meanwhile the Forsworn are counting. The Breakdowns have doubled in five years, swollen by handtalkers with broken fingers and scribes with split palms, and Brakk now speaks for a fifth of the capital. The Company has tripled the guard on Quillhouse. Lady Imre Dath, in her gold, is writing, and no one is quite sure on what.

THE GIRL AT THE STONE

On the first day of Grace in 641, the high basin of Highwell stood bitted and faced the sky, and the sky stayed white. On the second day it stayed white. An old man died on his feet and his sons held him upright. On the second night, in the Rain Shrine, by lamplight, the elders of the eleven Rain-keeper lines met without their Rainwarden, because Yusra Thole had stopped speaking and would not sign to them about anything but the cisterns. They talked. They had a Lack-era rite in the oldest of the Tally-books, from before the Gorging, when the canyon had tried everything to make the god's ears open again: the **Heart's Due**. When the rain will not come, the rite says, the god's heart wants a heart.

Before the lot was drawn, every unwed Heart-line adult of the basin between eighteen and thirty, forty-one of them, was made to swear at the Shrine, at Weight 4, before the elders: *If the lot is mine, I will go to the stone*. It was the old form. Nobody refused, because refusing in front of the whole basin, with the cisterns cracking, was a thing nobody there could do. The lot fell to Hallie Corr, twenty-two, a shepherd, Heart-line on her mother's side, whose pulse was so slow that her friends used to lay their fingers on her throat as a game, to count how long they had to wait.

She went to the stone at dawn on the third day because she had sworn to. The elders did it with the bronze knife of the Shrine, in silence, as the rite required, and laid her heart in the dry bed of Hollow Cistern, and stood back. Yusra Thole stood at the edge of the ring through all of it, and watched, and did not move, and did not sign. Six hours later, the first cloud came over the basin rim. By noon it was raining as it had always rained, warm and heavy, the canyons roaring, the cisterns filling, the water running red and then clear out of Hollow Cistern, and the whole of Highwell knelt in the flood and wept with relief and gratitude, and the elders said to each other in handtalk, *she brought it*.

She did not. Yusra Thole knows, from the Tally and from her own slowing pulse, that the rain was never late; that Tolm's year has grown three days longer; that the rain was coming on that third day whether a girl went to the stone or not, and to the hour. The sacrifice was demanded and given, and it bought nothing. And

Yusra cannot say so, because to say so is to say what the god's longer year means, and she has not been able to make herself say that to anyone. So she says nothing, and the basin has raised a new uncarved stone outside the ring, the height of a young woman, and wants it carved *Hallie Corr, who brought the rain*, and the elders have begun, quietly, drafting the oath for next year's lot. The Heart's Due is in the Tally again, after six hundred and forty years. If nobody tells Highwell the truth, it will be in it every year the rain is late, and the rain will be late every year from now on, a little later each time.



Her mother has gone up to sit by the stone every day since. She doesn't say anything. Nobody up there says anything now. You'd think they'd be happy. They got their rain.

ASH MERROW, RAIN-DEPUTY OF HIGHWELL, TO A STRANGER

THE STILLING OF CORDER'S GALLERY



It wasn't a curse. That's what I want you to understand. Nobody did anything to them. They just stopped.

DACEY FURL, NIGHT-SISTER OF THE MURMURING HOUSE

Corder's Gallery was forty doors on the eleventh tier of the Shadeward, rope-makers and their families, poor and close and kind. In the Grace of 640, a rope-maker named Isk Corder, at the Course, woke in the night and said to his wife, in the dark, half asleep: "I can't say anything any more without it being true." It was true. It had been true for a month; the Taste and the Appetite had run through him fast that year, as they were running fast through everyone. But now he had *said* it, at the Course, and it was more true than before, and in the morning he found that he could not say anything at all, about anything, that did not immediately happen.

He stopped speaking. That was sensible. His wife stopped speaking too, to keep him company, and because she was afraid that whatever was in him was in her. Their neighbours, who loved them, began to keep a silence around their door, and then in the gallery outside it, and then, because the god was widening that year and everyone in Tacit could feel it, in their own homes. By Plenty the whole gallery spoke only in handtalk. By Carving, after Mirren Osk's fingers broke before four hundred people, it had stopped handtalking. People in Corder's Gallery sat in their doorways and looked at each other and did not move their hands. Children who had been unbitted that spring asked for their bits back. The gallery

smelled, neighbours from the tier below said, of unwashed bodies and unemptied pots, because to wash a child you must tell it to lift its arms, and nobody would.

Then they stopped eating. Nobody could say afterward why, because nobody in the gallery had said anything. Dacey Furl, who went up from the Murmuring House with broth when the tier below sent word, thinks it was that eating is a kind of answer: you are offered, you accept, and to accept is to agree to something, and they could no longer agree to anything. She fed some of them by reed, as she feeds her patients. Some let her. Some turned their faces to the wall. Isk Corder sat with his back to his door for eleven days with his eyes open, and his wife beside him with her hand on his wrist, where the small ear was, and on the twelfth morning Dacey found them both still and cold, and the ear on his wrist turned toward his wife's mouth, as if waiting.

Through the Lack of 640 the gallery went one door at a time. Not all of them were the god's doing. Some went out of their doors one night and did not come back. Dacey will not say more than that, and the families on the tier below, who heard nothing, because nobody in Corder's Gallery made a sound even then, say only that the Keeners came for them in the morning, and that the Keeners, too, said nothing. Others were found sitting up. The children were carried down by the Murmuring House and the Quiet, and some of them live, and some of them have not yet said a word, in any hand, to anyone. Of the hundred and sixty people who lived in Corder's Gallery in the Grace of 640, nineteen are alive. The Bench sealed the gallery with felt at both ends and posted it silent, as though it were a gorge. It recorded the matter as *a contagion of discretion*.

It has happened since in two other galleries, on a smaller scale, and once in a village above Low Dray. It begins the same way each time: someone at the Course says, aloud, that they can no longer safely say anything; and those who love them, listening, believe it.

RUNNING THE STILLING

The Stilling is not a monster and should never be played as one. It is grief and fear moving through people who love each other, in a country where the god has made silence the only safe answer. Use it as aftermath: a gallery behind felt curtains; a child at the Murmuring House who will not move her hands; a mother who comes to the PCs because her husband has stopped answering, and wants them to make him talk. If a PC spends a day in a household beginning to still, have them make a Dread 2 check at dusk; on a failure, the player may not have their character speak aloud until they succeed at Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) in a later scene, and if a Break occurs in a stilling household, every witness who shares the delusion shares this silence. The cure, where there is one, is simple and hard: someone the stilled person trusts must speak to them, aloud, plainly, for a long time, and keep every word.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◇ The Late Rain. Yusra Thole, the Rainwarden, has not spoken in a month, because she cannot lie about the rain and will not tell the truth. The Bench hires the PCs to find out what she knows without asking her a question. The answer lies in the Gullet, where the sand over Tolm's bones has grown hot enough to blister, and something beneath it has begun, very slowly, to clear its throat.
- ◇ The Second Lot. Highwell's elders are drafting the oath for next year's Heart's Due, and the forty-one who swore last Grace are being asked to swear again. Hallie Corr's mother hires the PCs to prove the sacrifice bought nothing before the lot is drawn. The proof is in Yusra's Tally, and in her pulse, and the PCs must decide what the basin should be told, and whether they can say it without breaking.
- ◇ The Surety's Last Default. Ona Fell can survive one more default, and one of her two hundred and eleven principals is about to break: a Tongue-line merchant who swore a Company contract he cannot meet. The PCs must find which one before it happens, and the merchant has hired them too, to make sure Ona breaks first.
- ◇ The Hold at Wending. A Company caravan must cross Wending Pass, and the man at the top will not let anyone through who has not sworn to hold it. Renn Hold is not mad; he is bound. Getting past him means understanding what he swore, and the four hundred on the road below have opinions too.
- ◇ Sworn Gorge Has Gone Quiet. For the first time in two hundred years the murmur behind the wall has stopped. Halvar Stane believes the echo has found a way out. Three herders in the eastern canyons have broken in the same way as the hamlet of Sowe, and the PCs must track a word through the rock before it reaches Tacit.
- ◇ The Notary's Hand. Someone is trying to make Jessamy Quill break. Agents of the Second Table want the Company's contracts loosed so that the Rim Road falls into chaos before Tablenight; the PCs are hired as her bodyguards, and every conversation in Quillhouse is a battlefield.
- ◇ The Bread of the Witness. A Keener of the Vaults has found a niche empty and a trail of bone-dust to a bakery on the Galleries. Somebody in Tacit is eating the witness, and somebody's grandmother is about to Testify from inside a stranger at the Felt Market, on market day, in front of everyone.
- ◇ A Vanthe Wedding. House Vanthe has, for the first time since 312, betrothed a daughter outside the house, to an Esk, on the Second Table's instruction. The PCs are hired by the bride to find a reading of Lady Orsa's oath that will let her marry and keep her tongue. The house is hiring someone else to make sure no such reading is found.

RUMORS IN THE CANYONS

D10	RUMOR (SIGNED IN THE MARKET)
1	Ket the Ninth has made a sound. A Bench clerk heard it and was bitted the same hour. (True.)
2	The Kept Rain came late because a Sayer said something it was not drafted to say. (Unknown.)
3	Cassian Wry is not a Blank at all; the crown pays a Surety to take his lies. (False.)
4	Writing in reverse, mirror-script, does not bind. (False, as Ottoline Vant could tell you.)
5	Grandam Cess can free you from a marriage vow. (True, at a price no one has described.)
6	Jude Crake was once condemned himself, and talked his own Breaker to death. (True.)
7	The Forsworn are buying iron from the Fatlands for spearheads. (True.)
8	If you cannot read, the Ledger cannot bind you. (False and dangerous.)
9	Little Rue has found someone else the promise was for. (Partly true.)
10	On the stillest night, Sworn Gorge says your name. (It said Halvar Stane's. Once.)

THE PEOPLE OF OATHEN

KET THE NINTH – THE MUTE KING

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Clause 5, Resolve 5, Godsign 3, Reckoning 3, Instinct 2
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	none; he has never struck anyone.
GIFTS	Has never spoken, so is bound by nothing. If he says a plain sentence, it binds at Sayer strength (see the Brink Gift, Make It So) and he knows it.
WANTS	To Say (resisted daily; Caul + Resolve vs Grim when the Bench misreads him).
DREAD	3 (to see his throat working under the gold-chased bit)
SECRET	He has made a sound once, a single hum, alone, to know what it was like. A clerk heard it. The clerk is bitted now, and the king visits him.

Ket the Ninth is thirty-one, slight, grey-eyed, and has never made a sound. He was chosen at eleven days old from the Hushwell line and bitted in silver before his first cry; his nurses held their hands over his mouth when he laughed. He rules by nod and gesture, and the Bench spends weeks arguing what each one meant. He has a great deal to say. He reads everything; he writes nothing, because writing may now count. His eyes are very expressive and very tired.

He knows, because the Cutwrights have told him in a sealed report, that his Regrowth has run to the Course without a word ever leaving his mouth, and that what is pressing behind his teeth is not a man's sentence. He fears that he wants to say it. PCs meet him at audience, where he will hold their gaze a long time and then, perhaps, make a gesture no one on the Bench has seen before, meant only for them.

SORRIN VAEL – CHIEF CLAUSEWRIGHT

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Clause 6, Persuade 4, Lore 4, Deceive 3, Resolve 3
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 4
ATTACKS	none.
GIFTS	Reads any spoken oath's Exits at a glance (no roll). Once per scene, may name a flaw in another's oath and reduce its Weight by 1.
WANTS	To Swear, which he channels into drafting; his margins are full of crossed-out vows.
DREAD	1
SECRET	His iron bit is hidden under his high collar at night. He has been swearing in his sleep for two years, and his wife has kept a record, and the record is a treaty with something.

Sorrin Vael is the finest drafter of promises alive: sixty, narrow, bald, with fingers stained by slate dust and a voice like dry paper. His treaties run to four hundred conditions. He has not made an unqualified statement since boyhood, including to his wife, including “yes”; their marriage is, by all accounts, tender, and conducted largely by touch. He believes in the clause as other men believe in god: that there is no promise so dangerous it cannot be

made safe by enough precision. He fears the day the precision fails. He is drafting, now, the sentence the Bench may let Lady Imre Dath say, and he has gone through ninety-one versions, and every one of them, read slowly enough, frightens him. He meets PCs when they need an oath drafted that could get them into a place, or out of one, and he charges a great deal, and is worth it.

LADY IMRE DATH – THE SAYER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 7 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 12 (the Seating) · Hunger —
SKILLS	Godsign 6, Clause 4, Resolve 4, Lore 3
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray —
ATTACKS	none needed. Unbitted, any sentence she speaks is so.
GIFTS	Saying. What she says, is, without roll or limit except grammar. Bitted in gold, nothing. Writing: her written words now bind at Course strength (one per day, GM’s choice of the most dangerous reading).
WANTS	To be understood. To finish a sentence.
DREAD	5 (to see her face behind the gold)
SECRET	She has begun to write her own sentences, scratched with a fingernail into the lead of her cell wall. The current one reads: “When the rain comes, I will be”.

◇

She does not hate us. That is the worst of it. When I read her the drafts, every ear on her face turns toward me, and I feel pitied by a hundred mouths.

SORRIN VAEL, TO HIS WIFE, WHO WROTE IT DOWN

Imre Dath was a Tongue-line girl of the Dath house, clever and talkative, which her mother punished. At twenty-five she said “My brother is a liar” at dinner; her brother’s mouth opened back to his

ears and has never closed. She has been in the Gilded Cells for three years. Her face has grown long and smooth, her eyes sealed over with skin, and small pink ears have bloomed across her cheeks and temples; she hears everything said in the Ledger above her. She is unmuzzled once a year, to say one sentence the Bench has drafted. Last year’s was “The canyon wells shall not run dry this Lack,” and they did not. She has begun to write her own. She does not hate the Bench. She pities it. If PCs reach her, she will listen with all her ears, and, if a pen were to come into her hand, she would very much like to finish.

BRAKK – VOICE OF THE FORSWORN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Intimidate 4, Brawl 4, Persuade 3, Endure 4, Blades 2
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 (oiled hide over the ribs) · Fray 5
ATTACKS	Fists +8 (1); cleaver +6 (3)
GIFTS	Broken Ground (heart and ribs): marriage, love and loyalty oaths cannot break him further; he swears them freely as rhetoric.
WANTS	To be heard by those above.
DREAD	2 (when he unties the cloth over his chest)
SECRET	He still loves the wife he betrayed. She lives on the Sunward Wall. He swore on her that he would bring Tacit down.

◇
I said I'd love her till I died. I'm not dead. I still love her. The god broke me for the other thing I said, the one about the bed. It's a very careful god.

BRAKK, AT THE GATHERING OF THE BROKEN

Brakk broke a marriage vow, and his ribs opened outward like a book and stayed that way. Under the oiled cloth, his heart and lungs

are visible, slick, working, and in the cold weeks of Lack, breath steams from his chest. He is huge, grey-bearded, and loud, and he leads the Breakdowns. He is the most plainspoken man in Oathen, having nothing left to break: he says “I love you” to strangers, “I will kill you” to Clausewrights, and laughs at both. He wants the Breakdowns free and the Walls humbled. He fears that the Bench is right, and that the broken deserve it. PCs meet him when they need something done that a whole Oathener cannot do: a lie told, a loud word said in an echoing place, a promise sworn that no one intends to keep.

ONA FELL – THE SURETY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Endure 6, Clause 4, Resolve 4, Reckoning 3
BODY	Flesh 19 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	none.
GIFTS	Bond-Ledger: knows instantly, by a pain in the relevant part, when any principal she stands behind comes near to breaking.
WANTS	To count her bonds, aloud, nightly.
DREAD	3 (to see the script that covers her entire body)
SECRET	Two of her principals are the same Second Table cell, and they have decided to default together.

Ona Fell carries two hundred and eleven oaths that belong to other people. She is fifty, short, and very broad, and every inch of her skin from collarbone to ankle is tattooed in fine brown script with the terms of the oaths she stands behind, so densely that from a distance she looks bruised. Her left hand has no fingers (a defaulting grain-merchant). Her jaw is wired (a lying envoy). Her back is hooked (a regiment’s quartermaster). By her reckoning, she can survive one more default. She is gentle, careful, and tired, and she has stopped taking new principals, but she cannot put down the old ones. She wants to live to see her oldest bond expire, in four years. PCs meet her when they need a Surety. She will look at them a long time, and then say, “If able.”

Jessamy Quill, Notary of the Rim Road, is the hinge of the Table’s trade. Every contract the Company holds is sworn before her and rests on her word as witness: forty years of shipping, tolls and debts. If she dies or breaks, half the trade of the Table comes unbound in an afternoon. She is sixty-eight, sharp-faced, Oathen-born, and has a voice so practiced that every sentence she utters is witnessed and exact. She eats only food tasted by two Company

servants. She keeps a Surety for herself and does not say who. She is no one’s friend. She wants to die of old age, with an apprentice ready. She has no apprentice; three have died, unluckily. She meets PCs as a client, or as the person they are hired to protect.

JESSAMY QUILL Threat 4 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (stiletto 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Clause 6

Little Rue was four, before her muzzling, when she promised her mother she would never grow up. She has not. She is sixty-three, in a child’s body, with milk teeth and soft hair and old, old eyes, and she has outlived everyone the promise was for. Her mother died in 611. Her friends married, bore, and died. She wears no bit, since she is past twelve; she speaks seldom, in a child’s high voice with an old woman’s syntax. She lives in the Breakdowns, among the broken, who are kind to her. She wants to grow old. She fears that the oath has a second reading: that because she cannot grow up, she cannot die, and will be a child in the dark of the Vaults forever. She meets PCs as a fixer and a guide, and she drives a hard bargain, because she cannot afford to be lied to.

HALVAR STANE – ECHO-WARDEN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Wayfaring 4, Stealth 4, Search 4, Instinct 4, Shooting 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Fray 8
ATTACKS	Shortbow +6 (3); knife +5 (2)
GIFTS	Can track an echo through rock by ear alone; knows every posted gorge.
WANTS	To go back to the wall.
DREAD	2
SECRET	The two words he heard are “set” and “again”.

Halvar Stane patrols the silent gorges and has spent thirty years tracking the echo in Sworn Gorge. He is gaunt, bow-legged, deaf in the right ear by initiation and nearly in the left by age, with a habit of tilting his head like a listening dog. He has come close enough to make out two words of the oath. He will not repeat them, because to repeat is to renew, and he does not know what he would be renewing. He dreams of the wall nightly and has begun sleepwalking toward it. He fears that he is already bound, and that this is how it feels. He meets PCs as their guide through any posted canyon, and as the one man who might lead them into Sworn Gorge, if they gave him the excuse.

Mirren Osk, the Handtalker, is the greatest poet in a language held not to bind. She is forty, elegant, with long hands she oils nightly; three of her fingers are splinted now, the bones knit badly. Last year she signed a love poem to a patron and did not mean it, and three of her fingers snapped, mid-sign, in front of four hundred people. It was the first proof that handtalk counts. She has not composed since. She is frightened, angry, and guiltily excited, because if handtalk binds then it was always a real language, and her poems were always true. She meets PCs seeking a translator, or a witness, or someone to help her find out whether her old poems, written over thirty years, are about to come due.

CASSIAN WRY – THE LIAR	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 0 (Blank) · Regrowth — · Hunger —
SKILLS	Deceive 6, Persuade 4, Stealth 3, Filch 3, Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	Knife +5 (2)
GIFTS	Blank: cannot be bound or broken by any oath. His lies cost nothing.
WANTS	None of the god’s. His own: to be believed once, about something true.
DREAD	0
SECRET	He has begun to taste wet slate when others swear. The Cutwrights suspect he is not a Blank but the god’s blind spot, and blind spots close.

Cassian Wry is a Blank, and the only man in Oathen who can lie and stay whole. He is thirty-four, handsome in a hungry way, with a quick mouth and a laugh that makes Oatheners flinch. He is the crown’s most valuable spy, kept in luxury on the Sunward Wall and never let out of sight: two bitted guards, a Clausewright minder, a gilded apartment with felt walls. Everyone who meets him asks him to say something false, just to hear it. He obliges: “The sky is green.” “I love you.” “I am happy here.” He is lonely in a way no one else in the country can be, since no one believes anything he says, including the truth. He meets PCs on a mission, or escaping one.

Judge Thane Urow presides over Breaking trials. There is no evidence and no testimony. He simply has the accused repeat the promise aloud, and the court watches to see what happens to them. He is seventy, small and neat, with a voice like a knife drawn slowly, and his robes are spattered so often that he wears red. He has presided over eleven thousand trials. He believes his court is the only perfectly just court on the Table, and he is right, and he hates it. He fears the day he is asked to repeat his own judicial oath before his own court. Nobody has thought to ask. He meets PCs as their judge, or as a man who would like, very quietly, to know if the god still means it.

◇
*Last winter it asked for the lock of his hair I kept in
my locket. I gave it. I don't know what it will ask for
when there is nothing of him left but me.*

ASHA KINDLE, ON A SLATE LEFT AT THE LOWERED
ROPE OF HOLLIN'S STAIR

Asha Kindle, the Fire-Widow, promised her dying husband she would never let the fire go out. That was thirty-one years ago. She has not slept more than an hour at a stretch since, and the fire has grown particular about what it is fed. It began with wood; then it would only burn cedar; then it wanted his clothes; then his letters; then, three winters ago, it would not catch on anything but hair. Asha is bald, grey-skinned, with burned hands, and lives in a cliff-cell above Tacit with a fire in a stone hearth that whispers. She fears the fire is asking for something she has not yet given it. She meets PCs as a client who wants the fire to go out by someone else's hand. Then her oath would be kept, she thinks. She is not sure.

Garl Tome, the Bitmaker, is the smith of muzzles: leather for children, iron for the Appetite-struck, gold for Sayers. He is a broad, bearded, careful man of fifty, who works with a kerchief over his mouth from habit. He fitted his own daughter at birth and has never heard her voice. She is twelve this year. He has been offered a fortune by a Tongue-line house to make her bit permanent, because

the Cutwrights say she is at the Course already, and what she will say when it comes off may not be safe. He says silence is what love sounds like here. He has not decided. He meets PCs as the man who can make, or unmake, any bit in the land, including the gold ones.

Yusra Thole, the Rainwarden, is the keeper of the Kept Rain: the tallies of every year's fall, the cistern-oaths, the Rain Shrine in the high basin. She knows it came three days late. She cannot lie about it, so she has said nothing at all for a month, and the silence is being noticed. She is forty-five, weathered, with a heart-line Cut from the god's great slow heart and a slow, heavy pulse that can be seen in her throat. What she knows is that the rain did not come late. It came on time, by the god's own reckoning: Tolm's year has grown three days longer. She meets PCs as the woman they are sent to watch, or to make talk.

Grandam Cess, the Vow-Eater, is a back-canyon fixer who claims she can release you from an oath by having you swear a greater one over it. She is ancient, toothless, with a laugh like gravel in a bucket, and lives in a warren of cisterns called Knot Canyon. Her clients are free of what they came with. They owe her something worse: "to come when called," "to give what is asked," "to carry what I hand you." She has nine hundred such clients. She has never called them. She is waiting for something, and she will not say what, and she has started to sleep with her ear to the floor. She meets PCs as the only cure for an oath they cannot keep.

CAPTAIN RENN HOLD – THE MAN AT WENDING

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Blades 5, Endure 5, Resolve 5, Intimidate 3, Wayfaring 2
BODY	Flesh 17 · Guard 16 · Armor 3 (rusted mail) · Fray 9
ATTACKS	Sword +9 (4)
GIFTS	Held: while within the pass, he cannot be moved by force, fear or Dread; he has not slept in fourteen years and does not need to.
WANTS	To Hold Others to Their Words: he demands an oath of anyone who would pass.
DREAD	3 (the road behind him)
SECRET	Some of the four hundred are still alive below, unstrung, and he goes down at night to feed them, one step past the line he swore never to cross, and each time a little more of him comes open.

Captain Renn Hold's regiment swore to hold a pass to the death. He ordered the retreat. He kept his oath by staying; they broke theirs by obeying, and four hundred soldiers came apart on the road behind him. That was fourteen years ago. He is still at the top of Wending Pass, because he swore to hold it to the death and he has not died. He is gaunt, sunburned black, wearing rusted mail and a captain's sash gone grey, living on what drovers leave him. He speaks rarely, and when he does it is the regiment's roll, name by name. He does not ask to be forgiven. He asks every traveler to swear to hold the pass with him. Some do. He sends them down again, gently, but he wanted them to have said it.

Tavish Crook, called Loophole, is a swindler who speaks only in questions. He has never asserted or promised anything in his life, and he has taken a fortune from people who assumed he had. "Would you trust a man who stood to lose so much?" "Have you ever seen a cask like this?" "What if I told you there was gold under Low Shale?" He is fifty, plump, merry, very well dressed, and entirely whole. He wants more. He fears the day the god learns to hear what he means. He meets PCs as their mark, their partner, or their only lead.

Sister Verity Amn of the Quiet cut out her own tongue at nineteen. She teaches, in writing, that for the highest bloodlines a promise made only in thought now binds. She knows because of what happened to her after the knife: alone in her cell, she thought, very clearly, “I will never speak again,” and in the morning her lips had grown together. They have been reopened twice by surgeons and grown shut twice. She is fifty-two, gaunt, and writes in a fast, beautiful hand. She fears her own mind. She meets PCs as a teacher, and she will tell them, on slate, what to stop thinking.

Envoy Dorian Sayce is Oathen’s ambassador to nations that can lie. He finds foreigners unbearable and negotiation with them a kind of nausea; he carries a vinegar-soaked kerchief to hold over his nose when they boast. He is also the only diplomat on the Table everyone believes. He is fifty, silver-haired, perfectly dressed, and has never once lied, not even abroad, where he could. He fears that he is losing his country’s discipline, because abroad, last spring, he caught himself enjoying it. He meets PCs on the Rim Road, needing escort, and will not thank them, because thanks implies a debt.

Ilan, the Oath-Child, is nine. A man once swore to his wife, “I promise you a son.” She was past bearing. Ilan exists anyway: there was no birth, only a morning when there had always been a boy at the table. He is quiet, polite, dark-haired, bitted, with his father’s eyes. His father died in the spring, and Ilan has started to become difficult to see: faint at the edges in bright light, missed at roll-call, forgotten mid-sentence. His mother keeps her hand on his shoulder at all times. She fears the promise was to the father and is now discharged. She meets PCs begging for an oath sworn on her husband’s bones that will keep her son.

Ottoline Vant, Scribe of the Ledger, carves the public vows into the cliff. She miscut one last year, by a single word, writing “never” where the sworn record read “not”, and the man it named broke that night. Writing is not supposed to count. She is thirty, sunburned, lean from the scaffolds, and has not carved a letter since. She has started checking the old carvings for errors. She has found eleven. All eleven of the people named broke the night the carving was done, and the Bench put it down to coincidence each time. She meets PCs as a fugitive, carrying a list.

JUDE CRAKE – THE BREAKER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 6 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Tongue-line, bastard) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Persuade 6, Deceive 5, Clause 5, Instinct 5, Resolve 4
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	none; he owns no weapon.
GIFTS	The Hour. In conversation, Jude can extract one oath per ten minutes (Tongue + Persuade vs the target’s Caul + Resolve + 10); each is small, and each is crafted to tangle with the last.
WANTS	To Hold Others to Their Words.
DREAD	3 (when the hour-glass is turned)
SECRET	He was once condemned himself, at twenty, and he talked his own Breaker into promising to spare him. He has kept every promise he has ever made since, except one: to that Breaker’s daughter, whom he said he would visit, and has not, because he cannot bear to.

◇

I have never lied to a condemned man about anything that mattered. I lied to Aubin Sele about a man in Low Dray. It mattered. I keep the nail.

JUDE CRAKE, TO OLD SABRA WENDS

Jude Crake, the Breaker, is the state executioner, and owns no weapon. He is forty-four, soft-spoken, round-faced, with kind brown eyes and a fondness for figs and small talk. He visits the condemned, talks pleasantly for an hour, and leaves once they have promised him something small: to try, to stop crying, to be brave, to see him tomorrow. Each promise is crafted to collide with the next. It has never taken longer than an hour, and the Breakings that come,

apt and compounding, leave nothing of the condemned that could be called alive. He believes he is merciful: no blade, no fear of the blade, only conversation. He fears the hour running long. Last Carving, it did. He meets PCs as someone’s last visitor, or their own.

NEW CHARACTERS

Sergeant Mags Carrow, the Four Hundred and First, is the soldier who misheard the order at Wending. She stayed at the pass with her captain while the four hundred fell back and broke, and she kept her oath without meaning to. She left later, with Renn Hold’s blessing, when he released her by an oath he drafted himself, and it cost her an eye. She is forty, broad, with one eye and a regimental sash, and she lives in the Breakdowns, caring for the eleven survivors of the four hundred who were carried down: unstrung, their joints held

together with straps, alive. She wants Renn Hold brought down from the pass. She fears he will refuse, because she is the one who would have to ask.

SERGEANT MAGS CARROW Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Attack +7 (spear 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 1

Dacey Furl, the Gag-Nurse, runs the night ward of the Murmuring House. She is thirty, deaf by choice, slow-moving, kind, and she feeds three hundred bitted patients broth through a reed, nightly, one by one. She has learned to read their mouths through the iron. She has noticed that for a month, all three hundred have been mouthing the same vow, together, in their sleep, and that she cannot read the last word. She meets PCs as the person who calls for help.

Lord Varro Esk, the Heir of Tongues, is a Tongue-line noble of twenty-eight, golden, charming, at the Appetite and bitted in silver at night. He is a member of the Second Table, and he has a plan: to have a Sayer unbitted and to have her say, "Tolm is whole and on the table." He believes the god would be made solid, edible, and his. He meets PCs as a generous patron with a reasonable request: help him visit the Gilded Cells.

LORD VARRO ESK Threat 4 · Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Attack +6 (rapier 4) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 · Persuade 5

Brother Ansgar Mote, the Tongue-Taker, is the surgeon of the Quiet. He has removed four hundred tongues, cleanly, and keeps them in brine in a vault, labeled, because he once threw one away and it went on trying to speak in the midden for a week. He is sixty, steady-handed, and has his own tongue still. He knows Verity Amn's secret, and he has begun to suspect another: that the tongues in his vault have begun to grow.

Old Sabra Wends, the Keener of Oaths, keeps the Witnessing Vaults beneath Tacit. She is seventy, white-haired, with a lantern and a slate, and she has heard the dead speak forty-two times: when oaths sworn on them broke, the jaw of the corpse in the niche

opened and the vow came out, in the dead one's voice, loud enough to be heard a mile off through the rock. She records each. The number this year is nine. Last year it was two. She meets PCs when they come to swear on the dead, and she asks them, very gently, whether they are certain.

Lady Ammet Vanthe, the Widow of the House, is sixty, grey-eyed, pale as paper, and the widow of Corvel Vanthe, whom the Ledger records she married in 589, and beside whose entry the Cutwrights wrote two words. She has borne nine children, four of them sealed, two of whom lived. She keeps the silver knife the house physician uses, in a felt case on her dressing-table, and she has cut every sealed mouth in the house for thirty years with her own hand. She is one of Ona Fell's principals, and a member of a Second Table cell, and she has agreed to default on Tablenight. She wants the Vanthe Oath ended, and believes the only thing that can end an oath on the dead is a god whole enough to be asked. She meets PCs as the most gracious hostess on the Sunward Wall, who never serves supper.

LADY AMMET VANTHE Threat 4 · Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (silver knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 (the children's gallery of her house) · Clause 5, Persuade 4

Orla Corr, the Mother at the Stone, is fifty, a shepherd of the Highwell basin and the mother of Hallie Corr. She sits beside the uncarved stone outside the ring of the Rain Shrine from dawn until dark, every day, saying nothing, with a fold of her daughter's shawl in her lap. She swore nothing at the lot; she was too old. She does not blame the elders. She believes, with the whole basin, that her daughter brought the rain, and it is the only thing that makes the shape of her days bearable. If she ever learns from the Tally that the rain was coming anyway, it will be the worst thing anyone has ever told her, and she will want to hear it, and she will want the elders to hear it, aloud, from the Rainwarden, at the stone.

ORLA CORR Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (shepherd's crook 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Endure 4, Wayfaring 3

▼ PLAYING AN OATHENER

An Oathener is a person raised to weigh every word, in a country where the god in their blood is a witness that never stops writing things down. They make careful allies, terrible liars and devastating negotiators. They are also, the moment they open their mouths, at risk.

Attribute bonus: +1 TONGUE.



An Oathener at your table will be the slowest to speak and the last to agree, and when they finally say “yes”, you will be able to build a house on it.

A RIM ROAD CARAVAN-MASTER'S ADVICE TO NEW HIRES

WHAT IT IS TO BE AN OATHENER

You were raised in a nursery where every child wore a muzzle and nobody thought it strange. You learned handtalk before you learned to walk, and your first spoken words, at twelve, were chosen for you by a lawyer. You have seen someone break. Everyone in Oathen has: a neighbour's fingers going back on themselves at the market, an uncle's knees folding at a wedding, a stranger's jaw coming loose on a bridge. You know the sound. You hear it in your sleep.

So you are careful. Not cold: Oatheners love as hard as anyone on the Table, and grieve harder, because they cannot say most of what they feel. You show love by what you do and do not promise. You show respect by waiting a breath before you answer. You show trust by saying, to one person in your life, something without an Exit, and you will remember every time you have done it.

WEIGHT	KIND	EXAMPLES
1	Idle	“I’ll be back by dark.” A small lie. A boast.
2	Plain	A deliberate promise to a person. “You can count on me.”
3	Sworn	“I swear.” Any witnessed vow, or a lie that matters.
4	Solemn	Marriage, Company contract, sworn sentence, vow at the Ledger.
5	Grave	An oath sworn on the dead, or on Tolm by name.

An oath sworn in an echoing place renews once per echo the speaker hears (usually 1–3; a canyon narrows can manage 9). Each renewal is a separate oath of the same Weight, broken at the same moment. Handtalk and writing currently count at half Weight, rounded down; at Weight 0, the GM rolls a d10 anyway, and on a 1–2 the god counts it at Weight 1. The widening is happening.

Play an Oathener slowly. Let the other players fill the silence. When your character speaks, say exactly what they say, and let the table hear the Exits. When your character finally makes a promise without one, make it matter.

TALKING LIKE AN OATHENER AT THE TABLE

- ◇ **Write it first.** Keep a scrap of paper. Before your character says anything important, write the sentence, read it, cross out what binds. The other players will start doing it too.
- ◇ **Answer questions with facts about yourself.** Not “the bridge is safe” but “I crossed it this morning.” Not “I’ll help” but “I would like to help.”
- ◇ **Use the Exits as character.** A Clausewright buries them in subordinate clauses; a Forsworn does not bother; a child of the Galleries says “for today”. Your Exits tell the table who you are.
- ◇ **Never say “I promise” lightly, and never let another player say it to you lightly either.** Hold them to it. That is your Want.
- ◇ **Let silence be an answer.** A closed hand laid on the table means *I will not answer*, and in Oathen that is a perfectly polite thing to do.

OATHS IN OATHEN

These rules apply to anyone within Oathen's borders, native or not, and to Oatheners abroad when their Regrowth reaches the Course.

OATH WEIGHT

Every binding statement has a **Weight** from 1 to 5, set by the GM from what was meant and how it was said.

CONDITIONAL SPEECH

A character can speak carefully. When they deliberately draft an oath or a sensitive answer, roll **Tongue + Clause**. The difficulty is Routine 10 at leisure, Hard 14 in a pressed negotiation, Grim 18 in combat, interrogation or under a Dread check. Every Helping adds an **Exit**: a condition the player names (“barring illness”, “if the river allows”, “as I now intend”) under which breach is not breaking. A Grace makes the oath **Clean**: the GM must honor any reasonable

reading of it. A failure means the sentence carries no Exits; a Lack means the speaker said more than they meant, and the GM names one extra Weight 1–2 promise in the words.

When a character speaks without care (in anger, grief, fear or play), the GM may call for the same roll to see whether anything binding slipped out.

WHEN AN OATH IS BREACHED

- ◇ **Check the Exits.** If an Exit genuinely fits the circumstance, nothing happens.
- ◇ **Argue the reading.** If the case is ambiguous, the character may plead to the god in the moment: roll **Eye + Clause** vs 10 + (2 × Weight). Success: Tolm accepts the reading. Failure: the oath breaks.
- ◇ **The Breaking.** The body breaks at once, with a sound. The GM chooses the most apt rupture from the Breaking table (or rolls a d20 when the subject is unclear). The victim loses 2 × Weight Flesh, which cannot reduce them below 1: the Breaking is never fatal by itself, though bleeding, exposure and further harm may

be. At Weight 3 or more the rupture is permanent: a **Forsworn mark**, with a lasting penalty of –1 per Weight above 2 to rolls using the broken part. At Weight 5 the part is lost entirely.

- ◇ **Dread.** The broken make a Dread check of the oath’s Weight (maximum 4). Witnesses make one at Weight – 1 (minimum 1).

Broken Ground. A part already lost to a Weight 5 Breaking cannot break again. Oaths whose apt Breaking would land there may be sworn freely; if broken, the GM shifts the Breaking to the next nearest apt part, at –1 Weight. This is how the Forsworn of the Breakdowns can swear.

Lies. A spoken lie is an oath broken the instant it is finished. Small lies are Weight 1, lies that matter Weight 3, lies under the god’s name Weight 5. Their Breaking is the mouth: lips, teeth, tongue, jaw.

THE BREAKING TABLE

D20	OATH CONCERNED	MINOR (WEIGHT 1-2)	GRIEVOUS (WEIGHT 3-5)
1	Lies, true speech	Lips split to the gum	Jaw unhinges, tongue splits
2	Dealing, fair weight	Fingers snap backward	Hands come off at the wrist
3	Standing by, staying	Knees buckle	Legs fold backward like a heron’s
4	Going, arriving	Ankles crack	Feet turn fully about
5	Returning home	Heels split	Tendons draw up; cannot walk away from a door
6	Love, the heart	Breastbone cracks	Chest opens like a cupboard
7	Marriage, fidelity	Ribs crack	Ribs open outward like a book
8	Carrying, bearing	Shoulder slips	Spine hooks double
9	Watching, witness	Eyes bleed	Eyes burst in their sockets
10	Secrets, silence	Ears ring and bleed	Throat splits lengthwise
11	Feeding, providing	Teeth loosen	Belly opens at the navel
12	Never forgetting	Nose bleeds, lost hours	Skull cracks along the suture; memories leak
13	Obedience	Neck wrenches	Knees and neck lock bowed for life
14	Effort, trying	Long muscles tear	Arms and back split like staves
15	Courage, boasts	Bladder and bowel give way	Skin of the face splits and peels
16	Protecting another	Palms split	Arms snap at the elbows
17	Following, loyalty	Hamstrings strain	Spine twists to face behind
18	Abstaining, refusal	Stomach cramps, vomiting blood	Gut ruptures; cannot keep food down
19	Handtalk vows	One finger snaps	Every finger breaks at every joint
20	Life itself (“I’d die for you”)	Breath stops for a minute	Heart stutters; –2 Flesh maximum forever

SURETIES

A **Surety** swears, before the principal's oath is made, "I stand for this word." From then on, if the principal breaks, the Surety breaks in their place, taking the full Breaking (the principal suffers only the

Dread check, as a witness). A Surety may roll **Gut + Endure** vs 10 + (2 × Weight) to halve the Flesh lost; the mark is taken regardless. A principal who knowingly defaults on a Surety is called **sold** and no Surety in the land will stand for them again.

WEIGHT	STANDARD FEE (LACKS)	NOTES
1	2	Bondlings will take it
2	10	Often bundled for merchants
3	50	Underwriter required
4	200	Marriages, Company contracts
5	1,000	Few will take it; oaths on the dead never

A PC may be a Surety; each bond carried is tattooed on the body in script. Carrying more bonds than Gut + Endure means one more Fray each new Lack season, as the weight of other people's word wears the mind.

OATHS ON THE DEAD

To swear on the dead, the swearer lays a hand on the bones or the tomb, speaks the dead one's name, and says the vow into the niche. The oath gains +1 Weight (to a maximum of 5), cannot be carried by a Surety, and adds a second Witness to Tolm. When it breaks, the dead **Testify**: roll a d6.

D6	THE DEAD TESTIFY
1	The corpse's jaw opens in its niche and speaks the oath aloud, in its own voice, loud enough to be heard for a mile through rock. Everyone who hears it knows who broke it.
2	The oathbreaker's Breaking takes the shape of the dead one's own death-wound, in addition to its apt shape.
3	The dead one's bones are found in the oathbreaker's bed at dawn, arranged lying beside them.
4	The oathbreaker speaks only in the dead one's voice for a month. Dread 2 for all who knew the dead.
5	Every promise the oathbreaker ever made to the dead in life is re-weighed. Each one not kept breaks now, at Weight 1.
6	The dead one's name begins to replace the oathbreaker's own. Friends forget which they are speaking to. Each Lack season, 1 Fray, until the oath is kept or the name is lost.

THE REGROWTH OF TOLM

The Sop: Swearing. Make an unconditional oath, aloud, of Weight 2 or more, before a witness, with no Exits. Remove 1d6 Hunger. The oath binds as normal.

The Tooth. When an Oathener Partakes, they hear their own last words come back to them, half a second late, in a voice that is not quite theirs, and taste wet slate. If any Tooth shows a 1, the god bit back and took the character at their word: their last spoken sentence becomes a Weight 1 oath, read in its most literal sense.

The Wants (resisted with Caul + Resolve):

- ◇ **To Swear.** Triggered by silence held too long, by being doubted, or by a direct question. Failure: the character vows something aloud (GM's choice, Weight 1–3).
- ◇ **To Hold Others to Their Words.** Triggered when someone nearby breaks a promise. Failure: the character must confront them and demand they repeat it.

- ◇ **To Correct.** Triggered by hearing a falsehood. Failure: the character states the truth aloud, whatever it costs.
- ◇ **To Be Heard.** Triggered in echoing places. Failure: the character speaks, to hear it come back.

GIFTS

- ◇ **The Taste: Echo-Ear.** You hear your own words repeated a half-second late. You may roll **Eye + Instinct** (Hard 14) to know whether a statement spoken in your hearing was a lie or bound its speaker, and at what Weight. Cost: in echoing places, Dread 1 checks whenever you speak.
- ◇ **The Appetite: Hold to It.** When someone makes you a promise, you may Partake to make it heavier: +1 Weight. You feel, as a pressure in your teeth, whenever they come near to breaking it. Cost: you cannot release them; you must hold them to it, and the Want To Hold Others to Their Words triggers automatically.

- ◇ **The Course: Say So.** Once per scene, state a plain fact about something you can see. Roll **Tongue + Godsign**: Hard 14 for a small thing (“That rope holds”), Grim 18 for a significant one (“The door is locked”), Dire 22 for a great one (“He cannot see us”). Success: it is so for the scene. Cost: +2 Hunger, and for the rest of the day the GM may make any figure of speech you utter come true. Flesh change: the tongue darkens and lengthens; small ears open on the neck and inner arms; a second voice speaks under yours.
- ◇ **The Brink: Make It So.** Once per session, say one sentence that becomes true, at any scale the GM judges a single sentence can carry. No roll. Cost: Regrowth +1, and until the session ends, every sentence you speak binds as Say So with no roll and no limit. Brink characters must be bitted, by law and by sense.

The Seating. A Seated Oathener becomes a Sayer: the face smoothing, the eyes skinned over, the mouth a door the god speaks through. The character is no longer playable. The player writes the character’s last sentence, the one they would have said, and the GM decides whether it was spoken before the gold went in.

BACKGROUNDS

- ◇ **Junior Clausewright.** A Slate-Clerk with ink on the fingers and a head full of Exits. Clause 2, Lore 1, Reckoning 1. Starts with a slate, a bit for emergencies, and a debt to a Bencher.
- ◇ **Forsworn of the Breakdowns.** Broken at Weight 5 once, young, and proud of it. Choose one Broken Ground. Intimidate 2, Brawl 1, Deceive 1. Starts with a cleaver, an oiled cloth, and friends who lie for a living.
- ◇ **Bondling Surety.** Carrying three small bonds and the fees for them. Endure 2, Clause 1, Resolve 1. Starts with 60 lacks and three tattoos.
- ◇ **Echo-Warden Baffler.** Half-deaf by initiation, quick on rope, used to silence. Wayfaring 2, Instinct 1, Stealth 1. Starts with felt, wool, a coil of rope, wax and lead plugs, and a Gorge-Warden who will vouch for you once.
- ◇ **Novice of the Quiet.** You came to Hollin’s Stair to stop saying things. You have not yet taken the knife. Resolve 2, Rites 1, Lore 1. Starts with a slate, chalk, a grey robe and the Silent Supper Knack, and a question tied to the Lowered Rope that has not yet been answered.
- ◇ **Heart-line of Highwell.** Rain-keeper blood, a pulse slow enough to frighten physicians, and a family that swore at the lot.

Endure 2, Wayfaring 1, Rites 1. Starts with a flask of Kept Rain, a shepherd’s crook, and the knowledge of what happened at the stone.

- ◇ **Tongue-line Scion.** A younger child of a minor house, Cut 3 or 4, bitted in iron at night and veiled by day. Clause 2, Persuade 1, Lore 1. Starts with a silver-chased iron bit, a veil, the Smell of Cedar Knack, and a Cutwright’s sealed report on your own tongue that you have not opened.

FORSWORN CHARACTERS

A character may begin play already broken. Choose one grievous Breaking from the table (Weight 3 or more) and decide what was said, to whom, and when. The character carries its Forsworn mark (–1 to –3 to rolls using the broken part, as the Weight) and begins with Fray 2, as the Making a Guest chapter allows. In return they gain **Broken Ground** for that part from the first session, and +2 to Intimidate and Deceive in the Breakdowns, where their mark is their credit. Whole Oatheners will not take a Forsworn’s word on anything touching the broken part; foreigners, who cannot read the mark, usually will.

THE FOUR QUESTIONS IN OATHEN

Every Guest answers the Four Questions. For an Oathener, one of them is not a question of character but of law. **The Oath on the Dead** is sworn at Weight 5, by the rules below, from the first session, on real bones in a real niche, and the dead one will Testify if it breaks. Write it as a Clausewright would, or as a grieving person would, and know which you have done. Examples: *On my mother, Annet Orle, in the ninth niche of the Shadeward felt-makers’ gallery: I will find out who sold my brother’s tongue to the Second Table. On Hallie Corr, at the stone: I will not let them draw another lot. On Aubin Sele, cooper, whose figs I took home: I will keep his daughter whole, if able.* The Exit in the last one is lawful, and the dead man heard it.

NAMES

MEN	WOMEN	NEUTRAL	SURNAMES
Ket, Tav, Brakk	Imre, Ona, Rue	Wenn, Sele, Osk	Vael, Dath, Fell
Halvar, Thane, Garl	Mirren, Asha, Yusra	Aubin, Merit	Quill, Stane, Urow
Renn, Jude, Sorrin	Cess, Verity, Ottoline	Hush, Amn	Kindle, Tome, Thole
Dorian, Ilan, Varro	Mags, Dacey, Sabra	Tacet, Esk	Hold, Crook, Crake

Oathen names are short, because every syllable is said aloud. Tongue-line families favour names that are hard to mishear.

MEN	WOMEN	NEUTRAL	SURNAMES
Corram, Isk, Joss	Hallie, Orla, Tamsa	Lise, Merit, Pell	Corr, Corder, Hask
Tobin, Corvel, Odo	Ammet, Senna, Doria	Wilm, Ennis, Ash	Vanthe, Esk, Sarrow
Coll, Tamsk, Brannock	Merrin, Tamsin, Huld	Tacet, Lisle	Orle, Dell, Amberd

Name-signs are given at the Bitting and used until twelve: a gesture, not a word, usually drawn from the child’s first habit (*the one who bums, the one who reaches, the one who watches the door*). Many Oatheners keep their name-sign for life among family, and it is a mark of great intimacy to be told one. Thumb-rings are the other name: an Oathener’s ring-count is known in their gallery the way a foreign merchant’s wealth is known in his.

KNACKS FOR OATHENERS

Silent Supper is the canyon Knack above all others, and most Oatheners who can take it do. **Conditional** suits Clausewrights and

anyone raised in the Heights. **Old Grief** suits the Forsworn, the Keeners and anyone from Corder’s Gallery. **Elder’s Ear** is the Keeners’ Knack: the dead of the Vaults and the old of the Galleries tell you things. **Unflinching** suits Sureties, who have watched their own bodies break for other people’s words, and **Hostage’s Smile** suits anyone who has ever had to talk their way out of the Ninth Room.

HORRORS OF OATHEN

Roll a d20 or choose. Each scene carries the Dread listed in brackets.

D20	HORROR
1	A child, unbitted for cleaning, says “I’ll be good forever.” The mother clamps her hand over his mouth too late. (Dread 2)
2	A man in the market whispers a lie and his lips peel back to the molars, still whispering. (Dread 2)
3	An echo comes back from a canyon wall in a voice no one in the party used, and binds all of them. (Dread 3)
4	A bride at her wedding reads clause thirty-eight aloud; her ribs crack once, softly, like knuckles. (Dread 2)
5	The Unmade Road at dusk: a strapped-together soldier crawling uphill toward the pass. (Dread 3)
6	A Murmuring House patient chews through her iron bit and says a single, unfinished word. (Dread 3)
7	A handtalker’s fingers snap one by one as he signs his farewell to his dying mother. (Dread 2)
8	A tomb in the Witnessing Vaults speaks a vow aloud in a dead woman’s voice; somewhere above, someone screams. (Dread 3)
9	Jude Crake on a bridge, turning an hour-glass, smiling at one of the PCs. (Dread 2)
10	A blasphemer at dawn, mouth full of red sand, tongue simply absent. (Dread 2)
11	A Tongue-line noble at the Course says “I could eat a horse.” The stable goes quiet. (Dread 3)
12	A carved vow on the Ledger with a fresh chisel-mark changing one word, and a PC’s name below it. (Dread 2)
13	The sand of the Gullet breathing under bare feet, warm as skin. (Dread 4)
14	A Surety in the street, bonds breaking across her body in sequence as a whole family defaults. (Dread 3)
15	A man shouts “I’d die for you” in a canyon, and nine echoes come back. (Dread 3)
16	In Low Shale, the frozen herdsman’s eyes turn to follow the party. (Dread 4)
17	Little Rue sitting alone in a cemetery, telling the dead she is sorry she outgrew nothing. (Dread 1)
18	A dream in which the PC promised something in their sleep, and wakes with a thumb ring that was not there. (Dread 2)
19	The murmur from Sworn Gorge, faint through a hundred feet of wall, saying two words. (Dread 4)
20	A Sayer’s gold bit, lying open and empty on the floor of a cell. (Dread 5)



CHAPTER 9

THE FAST

No, thank you.
No, thank you.
No, thank you.

— THE FIRST WORDS TAUGHT TO EVERY CHILD IN THE FAST, AND THE LAST
RITES



From the commonplace book of Tarry Moss, Crumb-Runner, kept in charcoal on the backs of Pantry manifests. Found in his cart after the Carving of 640.

Fourth night out from Brindle Cross. Eleven sacks oat, four sacks pease, one cask salt cod (Brinehollow, stamped twice, smells like a cellar), two wheels hard cheese the Company swears is from cows. Counted them at dusk. Counted them again at moonrise. Same. Good.

The boy I took on at the Cross is called Stint, after his grandmother. Fourteen. You can see the hinges of his jaw when he chews, and he chews all the time on nothing, a little click, click, like a beetle in a wall. I told him the rules on the first night and he said them back to me before I'd finished, the way they all do, like a prayer you learned before you knew what the words were for. Never enter a house where the hearth is lit. Never answer Come in. Never eat what you did not carry yourself. If you smell bread, walk into the wind. If a chair is pulled out for you, do not thank it.

He has carried nothing. That is the thing I keep coming back to, writing this. He has carried nothing in his life but a Pantry measure in a cloth, half an oatcake and a thumb of lard, and he has been eating that standing up in the cold since he could stand.

Tonight the wind turned. It came round from the west, off the old Lammas farms, and it came round warm. You know the feeling if you have done this work. It is like walking out of the frost into a kitchen where the oven has just been opened. The hair on your arms lifts. Your mouth fills up so fast you have to spit. The oxen stopped. Oxen always know before we do. They stood with their heads down and their tails clamped and they would not go on, and their breath went straight up like smoke from a chimney because there was not a breath of wind any more, not one, only that warmth lying over everything like a cloth.

Then the smell. New bread, the crust just splitting. Dripping in a pan. Onions gone soft and brown in butter, and something

underneath it, a roast with the fat running, rosemary, a burnt-sugar edge to it like the skin on a pudding. I have smelled it a hundred times on the road. It does not get easier. It gets worse, because now I know exactly how good it is going to be, and I have never once tasted it.

Stint stood up on the cart-bench. I said sit down. He said Moss, there's a light.

There was a light. A farmhouse on the rise, a good stone one with the thatch combed and the windows clean, the way they all are out here, six hundred years empty and kept like a bride's chest. Every window gold. Smoke going up straight and thick from the chimney. And the door open, just a little, the width of a hand, so a long bar of lamplight lay out across the yard and touched the road about ten feet in front of my lead ox.

I said into the wind, boy. I said it the way my father said it to me. I got down and I took the lead rope and I turned the oxen round by main force, and they came, thank the Refusal, they came, and I walked us east into a wind that wasn't there.

Stint didn't come. I heard him get down off the cart. I heard his feet on the road, very light, he doesn't weigh anything. I turned round and he was standing in the bar of lamplight with his face lifted and his eyes shut and his mouth open, just breathing it, the way you'd stand in the first sun after Lack. His lips were wet. He was crying. I don't think he knew.

And from the door a voice said, Come in.

It was not a loud voice. It was a voice like your mother's when you were sick and she had been sitting up with you all night and had found, in the end, something you could keep down. It said, Come in, love. It's all ready. You must be starved.

Stint said, No, thank you.

It said, There's plenty.

Stint said, No, thank you.

I was running by then. I am fifty-three and I have bad knees and I ran down that road like a hare. It said, I made it for

you, it's your favourite, and I don't know how it knew what his favourite was, I don't know how a boy who has eaten oats and lard all his life has a favourite, but his whole face changed when it said it. And I got to him and I got my hand over his mouth before he could say the third No, because the third No is the one that sounds like you are being polite, and the fourth is Yes.

I carried him back to the cart. He fought me. He weighs less than a sack of pease and he fought me like a cat, and he bit the meat of my hand to the bone, and his teeth were the only strong thing in him. I tied him to the sacks with the cod rope. I walked the oxen east until the light was a coal and then a spark and then gone.

He is asleep now, or doing what they do instead. The bite has stopped bleeding. I have counted the cargo. Eleven sacks oat,

four sacks pease, one cask cod, two wheels cheese. Same.

But there is a smell in the cart I cannot place, and when I lifted the tarp to count, there was a cloth laid over the oat sacks that I did not lay there. White linen. Pressed. And on it, folded into a little tent, a card. I can read, a little. I have not turned it over. I am going to burn it in the morning without turning it over.

I already know whose name it is.



*Hunger is the only honest thing in the Fast.
Everything else has been offered.*

CRUMB-RUNNER SAYING

▼ THE REFUSAL

Every other land on the Table tells the story of a meal. The Fast tells the story of a meal that was not eaten, and it tells it the way a starving man tells you about the loaf he gave away: slowly, with pride, and with his eyes on your hands.

In the ninth winter of the Long Lack, the people of the central heartland were the fattest-looking starving people on the continent. That is how the Unfed elders begin, and it is meant to wound. Their land had been the best land on the Table, black loam and limestone springs and orchards older than memory, and when the Lack came it held on longest. It was the last place where an apple tree still set fruit. When the fruit fell it was hollow, a skin of red around a puff of grey dust, but it set. People from every side of the ring walked into the heartland to beg, and the heartlanders, who were the people of Orrum, the Host, fed them, because that was what it meant to be Orrum's. A stranger at the door was a guest. A guest was fed. There was a word in their old dialect for the shame of an empty bowl set before a visitor, and it was the same word they used for murder.

By the sixth winter there was nothing left to set before anyone. By the eighth, the heartlanders were eating the thatch off their roofs, boiled down to a brown paste that tasted of smoke and mouse. They ate harness leather. They ate the glue out of furniture joints. In the village of Lammas Bottom, the record of a reeve survives, scratched on slate, listing what the village ate in the last month of the eighth winter in a hand that grows larger and less steady down the page: *bark of the elm, boiled. Shoe-soles, boiled. Moss. The dog Brindle. Clay with salt. The cat. The other cat. The rush matting.* The last line is a single word, scratched over and over until the slate is white: *no*.

Orrum was among them the whole time. It was not distant, any more than the other Providers were. It walked the lanes of the

heartland the way a tall old aunt walks through a crowded kitchen, stooping under the lintels, touching heads. It was warm. Every account agrees on that above all things: to stand near the Host was to stand by a hearth in Lack. And through all nine years it kept laying tables. Out of nothing, out of habit, out of its nature, it set boards on trestles in every village green and laid them with cloth and plate and cup, and there was nothing to put on them, and the god stood at the head of each empty table with its long hands folded and waited for its people to come and be fed, and they came, and sat, and stared at the plates, and the god stood there and starved with them.

In the ninth winter, word came in along the old roads that the others had done it. The fen people had killed the Closing Hand. The plains people had cut the Laden open in its own field. Across the Table, in a season or a single night, the starving were turning on their gods with hooks and cleavers and their bare hands, and the next morning, in every land that had eaten, the Lack was over. The seed split. The cows dropped calves. There was bread by the end of the week.

Orrum heard. Orrum did what the others had done. It walked up the bare hill at the exact centre of the continent, where a great table of grey stone had stood since before there were names, a table with eight sides. It climbed up onto the stone, which took it some time, because it had grown very thin. It lay down on its back with its hands at its sides. And it waited for its people to come and carve.

They came. That is not disputed. Something like forty thousand people walked up the hill to Hallowboard in the snow, carrying knives, and they stood around the table on its seven worn sides, and they looked at their god lying on the stone with its eyes open and its

long throat bare, and the elders say that it smiled at them, and that the smile said *go on, I don't mind, you must be starved*.

And they would not.

Nobody knows who said it first. Every family in the Fast claims the first No for its own great-grandmother's great-grandmother. What is known is that someone said "No, thank you," and someone else said it, and then all forty thousand were saying it, not shouting, saying it softly, the way you decline a second helping at a table where you know the hosts have nothing. *No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you.* They stood there for nine days, saying it. They stood in the snow around their god and starved to death on their feet rather than eat it, and the god lay on the table and watched them do it.

The dying took the whole of that winter. Nine in ten of the heartland died with a willing meal within reach of their arms. The Unfed teach it to their children as triumph, but the oldest songs are plainer about it. They remember the sound of the hill on the fifth day, when the people at the front could no longer stand and lay down in the snow along the stone, so that the second row had to stand on them. They remember mothers who chewed the leather of their own sleeves soft and fed it, mouth to mouth, to infants who were already too far gone to swallow. They remember that the dead did not smell, because there was nothing left in them to rot, and that the crows came and would not eat them either, and sat along the edge of the table in long black rows, waiting, like guests. They remember that the god wept. Every song has the god weeping. Its tears were warm, and they ran down off the stone and the snow melted where they fell, and in the melt-water some of the starving lay down and drank, and argued afterward for the rest of their short lives whether that had counted.

The Roll-Keepers of Barrowgate, who keep the Stand-Roll of who stood where on the hill, also keep the Count of the Days, which is recited once a year, on the last night of the Nine Days, in the trench, with the reciter's back to the stone. It is the closest thing the Unfed have to a history of what starvation is. It is taught to Measure-Bearers so that they will know what they are carrying past a door.

The Count of the Days, as the Roll-Keepers say it. Taken down by a Hostwatch clerk, 598, who was asked not to, and did.

On the first day we stood with our knives in our hands and the snow on our shoulders, and it was warm where the god lay, so warm the snow on the stone ran off it in threads, and the smell came off it like the smell off a loaf you have just turned out of the tin. Our mouths filled. We spat. We said it the first time, and our voices were strong. No, thank you.

On the second day the cold came up through our feet. The hunger was in the belly still, where hunger belongs, a fist turning over and over. Children cried for it, and their mothers

said the words for them into their hair. The old ones began to shake, a fine shake, like a lid on a pot. No, thank you.

On the third day the hunger left the belly and went into the jaw. We chewed. All of us. You could hear it across the hill, forty thousand mouths chewing nothing, the little wet click of it, and we could not stop, and we did not try. Our breath went sweet, like windfalls in the grass. No, thank you.

On the fourth day the hair began to come away. It came away in the wind in long soft hanks and blew across the stone and caught in the god's fingers, and the god held it, gently, as you would hold a child's hair to cut it. The old ones sat down that day and did not get up. Their faces went smooth and calm. No, thank you.

On the fifth day the front row lay down along the stone, all round, on seven sides, and we in the second row stood on them, because there was nowhere else to stand. They were soft at first and then they were not. You could feel the ribs through your feet like the rungs of a ladder laid in the snow. Some of them were still saying it, under us. No, thank you.

On the sixth day we saw tables. We saw them everywhere: in the snow, down the hill, in the sky, laid and lit and steaming, and the ones we loved who had already died sat at them and waved to us and held up their spoons. Some of us walked down the hill toward them and fell in the snow a little way off and were found in the morning with their mouths open and full of snow. No, thank you.

The seventh day is not said.

On the eighth day nobody could hold a knife. They dropped out of our hands into the snow, all round the stone, all of them, one by one, all day, a little sound like hail. The god wept, and its tears were warm, and the snow went soft and grey around our feet, and some of us knelt and drank it, and we did not stop them, and we do not know. No, thank you.

On the ninth day there was no sound on the hill but the god breathing. We could not say it aloud. We said it with our lips. Some said it with their eyes only. Some were dead on their feet and still standing, held up by the ones beside them, and we did not know which, and it did not matter, because they were saying it too. No, thank you.

On the tenth morning it got up.

The Unfed do not discuss the seventh day. Children who ask are told that the seventh day was too hard to remember, which is a lie with a true shape. The Roll-Keepers know the seventh verse and will not say it. Fallow Brindle, Warden of the Barrows, has found in the uppermost rows of the oldest mounds a few small bones, finger-

bones and the long bones of forearms, scored with the fine parallel grooves that only human teeth make. She reburies them deeper than the rest, and says nothing, and has never asked whose mouths. The Unfed refused a god. Nobody has ever claimed that every one of them refused everything.



They refused a god. Nobody ever said they refused each other.

A ROLL-KEEPER OF BARROWGATE, DRUNK ON RIM SPIRITS, ONCE

On the tenth morning, Orrum got up. It climbed down from the stone, slowly, like an old person getting out of a bath, and it looked at what was left of its people, a few thousand standing skeletons ringed by the dead, and it bowed to them. Then it walked away down the hill, and it has never stopped walking since.

The survivors went home to a land where nothing grew. The Lack had ended everywhere else. It did not end in the Fast. It has never ended in the Fast. They called themselves the Unfed, and they wrote down the day, and they began, almost at once, to be proud of it.

WHAT THE OTHERS SAY

Every land outside the Fast has its own version of the Refusal, and none of them are kind. In the Fatlands it is a joke about a man who died of hunger in a bakery. In Oathen it is cited in Clausewright schools as the classic example of an oath nobody actually swore and everyone kept anyway. In Sallowreach, where nothing ends, they find the whole thing faintly obscene: a people who chose to finish. In the Vigil the Seemers say the Unfed simply arrived late to the meal and have spent six hundred years pretending they meant to. That last version is closer to something than anyone outside the Fast suspects. See Meek Garrity, below.

EVERY OTHER LAND ON THE TABLE CAN TELL YOU
WHAT A GOD TASTES LIKE. WE ARE THE ONLY PEOPLE LEFT
WHO CAN TELL YOU WHAT IT COSTS NOT TO KNOW, AND WE ARE
STILL PAYING IT, EVERY DAY, BY THE HALF-
OATCAKE.

[ELDER FORBEAR WEND, TO A COMPANY CONGRESS AT THIMBLE CROSS, 622]

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

Never accept.

Orrum walks the Fast. Nobody living has seen it clearly and come back whole. The descriptions agree on very little: that it is tall, that it stoops under doorways, that it moves slowly and without sound, that it is warm. Some who have glimpsed it describe long arms folded in an apron. Some describe a shape like a figure made of the light from an open oven door. A Hostwatch tracker named Spare Tolland, who has followed it for thirty years, says only that it is “the size you’d expect if you were very small and someone was about to pick you up.”

It does not attack. It has never, in six centuries, raised a hand against anyone. It hosts. Wherever it passes, tables appear: in empty farmhouses, in hollow barns, in the middle of a road, on a frozen pond, at a crossroads at dusk. They are always perfect. The cloth is white and pressed. The plates are hot. The food steams. A lamp

burns in the middle, and a chair is pulled out, angled toward whoever is nearest, the way a good host angles it for an honoured guest who is a little unsteady on their feet.

If you sit, you are a guest. A guest of Orrum does not get up.

The Unfed call them the Seated. They stay at table for years, for decades, and the longest-seated have been at table for over five hundred years. They eat from the plates in front of them, which are empty. They lift silver forks laden with nothing and put the nothing in their mouths and chew it slowly with every appearance of delight. They sip from empty cups. They talk to one another about the food, in loving detail. They do not die, or not for a long time; they waste. Orrum’s hospitality keeps them alive far beyond what the body should bear, and it does not keep them well. They grow thin, then thinner, until the skin lies on the bone like wet paper on a frame, until the teeth stand out of the gums like pegs on a board,

until the eyes have sunk so deep that the lamplight on the table catches them only from below. They are always smiling. They will tell you this is the best meal they have ever eaten. They will ask you to join them. They mean it kindly.

You cannot pull a Seated person away from the table. People have tried, with ropes and oxen. The Seated come up out of their chairs easily enough, light as dry leaves, and they scream, a dreadful high scream like a kettle, and they reach back for the table with both hands, and when they are dragged beyond the length of the cloth they die in a few minutes of a starvation that has been waiting for them, patiently, for decades. The body goes all at once, as though a debt had been called in. Those who have watched it say that the last thing the Seated do is apologise to the host for leaving early.



We pulled my grandfather off the Long Table with two oxen. He came up light as kindling, and screamed, and reached back for it. Then he said, Oh, I am so sorry, I must be going. And he went.

A TABLEBREAKER OF SPLINTERHALL

THE FIVE RULES

Every child in the Fast learns these before their letters, usually by about four, and is made to recite them before their daily ration. A child who stumbles over them does not eat that day.

- ◇ Never enter a house where the hearth is already lit.
- ◇ Never answer "Come in."
- ◇ Never eat what you did not carry yourself.
- ◇ If you smell bread, walk into the wind.
- ◇ If a chair is pulled out for you, do not thank it.

The Unfed argue endlessly about the fifth rule. The orthodox reading is that thanking the chair counts as acceptance. The Hostwatch have a darker reading: that Orrum is lonely, and thanks are the one thing it has not been given in six hundred years, and to give it any is to make it want more.

Nothing else grows. For the Unfed the Lack never ended. Seed sown in the Fast rots in the ground, swelling and splitting and putting out no shoot, until in a week it is a grey paste with a sweet bad smell. Hens brought in from the Rim stop laying the day they cross the border. Cows go dry. A sow in farrow will deliver a litter of perfectly formed piglets, each the size of a thumb and each with nothing inside, a skin around air, like the hollow apples of the ninth winter. Fish brought in live in barrels turn belly-up by the second day. Bread baked in the Fast from Rim flour rises, browns, smells correct, and is ash inside when broken. That is why the Unfed eat their food cold, and raw, or cooked out under the open sky on bare ground: an oven in the Fast is the god's.

Every mouthful eaten in the Fast is carried in from the Rim. The only food the land itself offers is Orrum's.

The land is perfect and nobody tends it. The hedges are trimmed square. The orchard grass is short. The windows in empty farmhouses are clean, the doorsteps are swept, the brass knockers are polished, and the beds are made with the corners turned down. It is as if the whole country were a house kept ready for a guest who is due any moment, and has been due for six hundred and forty-one years.



It's like living in somebody's best room. You're afraid to touch anything. You'd never be forgiven if you spilled.

A COMPANY FACTOR, AFTER HIS FIRST CROSSING,
630

▼ WHAT GROWS INSTEAD

The Fast has no Regrowth, because nothing was eaten. There is no godsign in the blood of the Unfed, no Cut, no hunger that is not their own. What it has instead is the opposite of a Regrowth, and in the long run it may be worse: a whole, living, unhoused god whose one purpose has been refused for six centuries. A Host whose guests will not come in. What is growing in the Fast is not Orrum. Orrum has never been smaller. What is growing is Orrum's need.

The Hostwatch keep the oldest records of it, and they divide its progress into four ages, the way the other lands divide the stages of

their Regrowth. The comparison is deliberate. The Hostwatch believe the Fast is a single body, and that the Host is coming to its own Seating.

EARLY: THE DISTANT BOARD

For the first century after the Refusal, Orrum's tables were rare and far from people. A table might be found once a season, in a high meadow, at the end of a forgotten lane, laid for one. Shepherds who found them describe them as small and almost shy: a single plate, a

single cup, a little loaf, a candle. The Unfed of that age smashed the first tables in a frenzy and then, finding that nothing happened when they did, began simply to walk past them. Some left the tables to stand, and found them weeks later still steaming, the candle no shorter, the butter still cold and beaded on its dish.

FOR CENTURIES: THE KEPT HOUSE

From about the first century until within living memory, Orrum's need moved indoors. The Unfed had abandoned most of the heartland and drawn in toward the eastern edge, near the Rim and its food. The god kept the houses they had left. Tables began to appear in empty farmhouses, laid for a whole family. Hearths were found lit in roofless ruins, with no wood in them and no ash beneath, only a steady low fire like a banked coal that warmed the hand at a yard's distance and never burned down. A traveller sheltering in a ruin might wake to the sound of a pot lid lifting. The Unfed learned to sleep only in houses whose hearths they had personally bricked up, and to check the brick each night with a palm laid flat.

WITHIN LIVING MEMORY: THE LAID PLACE

Then the tables came home. In the generation before this one, tables began to be found laid at dawn inside occupied houses: in kitchens that have had no hearth for six hundred years, on floors that families had slept on the night before. No one heard anything. The family woke to a smell, and came downstairs, and found the cloth and the plates and the lamp, and the chairs pulled out, one for each of them, in the right order of age. Then, three years ago, the place cards began. Small folded cards in front of each plate, with a name written on them in a fine, round, careful hand. The names are always spelled correctly. The Unfed spell their names with deliberate oddity, to be unfindable; it has made no difference. The cards know nicknames. The cards know names given in secret and never spoken.

NOW: CALLING ON THE NEIGHBOURS

In the last year, Orrum's tables have been found outside the Fast. At a crossroads in the Fatlands. On a pier-section in Lowmark. In a lamp-lit square in the Vigil, where eleven districts saw a tall figure laying cloth in the street. The Host has started calling on the neighbours. The Hostwatch report it walking the Rim Road at night, stooping to look in at the windows of Company inns, its warm breath fogging the glass. It looks, they say, like someone counting the chairs.

THE BRINK: WHAT COMES NEXT

No Unfed scholar will say what the fifth age is. The Hostwatch have a word for it in their private ledgers, which is *Sitting-Down*, and they mean it in the sense of a feast beginning: the moment when the host takes their own seat at the head of the table and the meal can start. Whose meal, and who has been invited, are questions the Hostwatch have stopped asking aloud. They have noticed that the tables are getting bigger. They have noticed that the newest tables, the ones on the Rim Road, are laid with one more place than there are guests within a day's walk, and that the extra chair is never pulled out. It stands pushed in, square to the table, with its back to the lamp. Nobody sits there. Nobody has been invited to.

THE SEATED: HOW A GUEST WASTES

There is a rhythm to it, and the Unfed know it the way other peoples know the stages of a fever.

- ◇ **The First Course** (days to months). The guest eats with gusto. They are flushed, warm, and very talkative. They describe the food to anyone who will listen, and the descriptions are dreadful to hear, because they are so good: the crackle of pork skin, the sweetness of new peas, the way the gravy has a little port in it. Their own bodies do not yet show the cost. They are lucid. They will tell you, quite sensibly, that they know they ought to get up, and that they will, after the next course.
- ◇ **The Middle Courses** (years). The guest thins. The cheeks go first, then the temples, which sink until the skull shows its shape. The lips draw back from the teeth. The hands grow knuckly and spotted and the nails go yellow and ridged. Hair falls into the empty plates and the guest eats it without noticing. Their breath smells of acetone and of something sweeter underneath, like fruit left in a bowl too long. They are still happy. They can no longer remember the names of anyone not at the table.
- ◇ **The Long Table** (decades). The guest has become a frame. Skin like parchment, the colour of weak tea, stretched so tight across the ribs that the heartbeat can be seen through it as a small, slow knocking. The belly has fallen in so far it touches the spine. Joints are swollen knots. Teeth loosen and drop onto the plate with a small clean sound, and the guest picks them up with the fork, and chews them, and swallows, and praises them. They have stopped blinking. They whisper now, because there is not breath enough for more, and what they whisper is the menu.
- ◇ **The Last Course** (centuries). Almost nothing is left. The oldest of the Seated on the Long Table are little more than clothes holding a posture, light as a wasps' nest, a smile hung between two cheekbones. They no longer lift the fork. They move their jaws, very slowly, perhaps once an hour. They do not speak. But when a living person walks past them on the valley road, every

one of them turns, together, with a sound like a stand of dry reeds moving in a wind, and looks.



*He said the gravy wanted salt. Forty years at table
and he'd never complained before. We took it as a sign.
We didn't know of what.*

A WAX HALT KEEPER, OF A SEATED MAN ON THE
FOURTH MILE

WHAT THE LIVING SEE AT TABLE

Rim visitors who have read the Hostwatch reports expect the Long Table to stink. It does not. That is the first wrongness. Orrum's hospitality is perfect, and a perfect host does not let a guest sit in their own filth: the chairs are clean, the cloth is clean, the Seated are clean, their collars pressed, their hair, what is left of it, combed. Nothing that comes out of a starving body is ever found at the Long Table. The Unfed do not ask where it goes. What the table smells of is the god's cooking, laid over the breath of eleven thousand people in ketosis, so that the air at nose height is roast pork and new bread and, under it, a thin sharp chemical sweetness like nail-varnish and windfall apples, which is the smell of a body burning itself for warmth. Near the head of the valley, where the oldest sit, there is a third smell, dry and faintly spiced, like the inside of an old linen press. That is what five hundred years of wasting smells like. It is not unpleasant. The Crumb-Runners say that is the worst thing about it.

The sound is a murmur, low and continuous, like a congregation at prayer three rooms away, and it is all praise. *Oh, this is lovely. Have you tried the. Pass the. Isn't it.* Under the voices runs the soft busy clink of silver on porcelain, thousands of forks lifting and settling, and under that, if a traveller stops and listens, which they should not, the small dry clicking of jaws that have no cartilage left in them, working, working, like insects in a wall.

The Seated grow while they waste, in the places a body grows without food. Their nails lengthen and thicken and curve, yellow as horn, until in the Long Table decades they curl around the fork-handles like the roots of a tree around a stone, and the fork cannot be taken from them without breaking the finger. Their hair, where it does not fall, grows down their backs and into the chair and, in the oldest, into the weave of the cloth, so that a woman at the eleventh hundred yards of the east side is bound to the table by a grey rope of her own hair four feet long, woven through the linen like a darn. Their lips crack and do not bleed, because there is nothing to bleed with; the cracks are white inside, like split bark. Their tongues go grey and smooth and shrink back from the teeth. The eyes stay wet. That is Orrum's doing too. A good host does not let a guest's eyes dry.

KIN AT THE LONG TABLE

Every family in the Fast has someone at a table, and most of them know where. The Hostwatch keep a register, the Seated Roll, by mile and side and chair, and will look a name up for any Unfed who asks three times. On the first day of each season a few hundred Unfed walk the Long Table road from Wax Halt with wax in their nostrils and stand on the far verge, the road between them and the cloth, and talk to their Seated across it. This is called *visiting*, and it is permitted, because the road is not the table and the verge is not a chair.

The newly Seated are glad to see their kin, and talk eagerly, and ask after everyone, and want to know why they will not come over. The longer-Seated recognise faces for a while and then do not, and talk to their visitors as to pleasant strangers, and describe the pudding. A widow from Pinners' Yard named Sparing Lowe has visited her son on the sixth mile every season for thirty-one years. He has not known her for twenty. He is courteous. He calls her *madam*. He tells her each time that his mother used to make a dish like this, and that he must remember to send for her, and she thanks him, and says she is sure his mother would come if she could, and walks home.

There are pairs at the Long Table who sat down together. Husbands and wives, mostly; a few old friends; twins. Near the seventh mile, on the west side, a brother and sister of the old Lammas line sit shoulder to shoulder, hands clasped under the cloth, and have done since 402, when the village of Lammas Bottom spoke of them in a way that made it impossible for them to stay, and they walked west together one night with the whole village watching from behind its shutters. They are the only Seated on the Long Table who do not invite passers-by to join them. They do not look at the road at all. They look at each other, and smile, and eat, and the Unfed walk past that stretch quickly, with their eyes down, and do not say why.

TABLE-TALK OF THE SEATED

Recorded by Tablebreakers, Hostwatch clerks and visiting kin, from the Long Table and elsewhere.

“There’s a little port in the gravy. Can you taste it? No, you’re not sitting. Sit, and you’ll taste it.” — a Seated man, third mile, to his grandson

“I’m going to get up after this course. I mean it this time. Is there more of the crackling?” — a Seated woman, two years at table

“Mam? Mam, it’s me. You’ve gone so thin. Sit down and have something.” — a Seated girl of sixteen, to her mother, who was not thin

“We kept you a place. We always keep you a place. It’s further along now. You’ll find it.” — a chorus, eighth mile

“Eat it while it’s hot, my love. It’s always hot. Isn’t that marvellous?” — Brother Hallow Crust

“I can’t remember my children’s names. I remember every pudding. Is that wrong? It doesn’t feel wrong.” — a Seated woman, fortieth year

“Don’t break it. Please. Please don’t break it. It’s all we’ve got.” — the Seated family at Corve Hatch, through the bricked window, in 52 A.G., as recorded in the Pantry ledger

WHAT IS ON THE PLATE

The food at Orrum’s tables is never the same twice and never anything but the best thing the guest has ever been offered, or the thing they have wanted longest. Roll when a PC looks at a laid table long enough to see what is served (which is, itself, a mistake). Results marked (+2) are crueller than the rest, and raise the Invitation check’s Difficulty by +2.

D20 ON THE PLATE

1	An oatcake: the Pantry measure, but whole, and hot, and buttered to the edges, the measure as it should have been.
2	Honey-cake, cut in fingers, the way a dead grandmother cut it. The knife-marks are hers. (+2)
3	A rib of pork with the crackling blistered gold and the fat running clear onto a hill of mashed turnip.
4	Warm milk with bread torn into it and honey over the top, in a chipped blue bowl the PC owned as a child and lost. (+2)
5	A steaming pie, the crust crimped with the press of a thumb the PC recognises.
6	Nothing at all. A clean plate, a clean fork. The PC wants it more than anything they have ever seen.
7	New peas in butter, a pale green so bright it hurts, each one whole and glossy.
8	A dish from a land the PC has never visited, and the certainty that someone, somewhere, died wanting it.
9	Their last Pantry ration, the one they gave away to someone who died anyway, returned, untouched, still warm. (+2)
10	Roast fowl stuffed with sage and onion, the skin so crisp it crackles in the heat of the lamp.
11	A boiled egg in a cup, its top already sliced off, the yolk soft and running, a spoon beside it, toast in strips.
12	A stew the PC’s mother made in a year when there was no food at all. It is the same stew. It is full now. (+2)
13	White bread, just broken, the steam still coming off the crumb, and a crock of salted butter going soft.
14	Plums, split and baked, the juice gone to syrup in the dish, a jug of cream beside it with a skin on top.
15	A Farlands dish, Laden-fat and glistening; for a Returned or a Godeater, the god in their blood leans toward it.
16	Seed cake with caraway, the kind served at Unfed weddings before the Refusal, when there were weddings with food.
17	A child’s tea: little iced cakes, a sugar mouse, jam tarts, a cup of something sweet. Laid for a child the PC has lost or never had. (+2)
18	The plate holds the day’s Pantry list, every name piped onto it in white sugar. One name is missing. It is the PC’s.
19	The food is exactly what every other PC at the table sees, and each describes it differently, and each is sure.
20	The plate before the extra chair: empty, polished, the chair pushed in square, its back to the lamp. Looking at it is a Dread 3 check. Nothing more is learned.

◇

Count the chairs before you count the dishes.

WHAT SPARE TOLLAND TELLS NEW TRACKERS

▼ THE KINDNESS OF THE HOST

It has never once been unkind. Write that down. Then write down what it has cost.

– THE FIRST LINE OF THE HOSTWATCH'S RESTRICTED LEDGER, IN THE HAND
OF ITS FIRST WARDEN

Orrum cannot hurt anyone. It is not that it will not; it does not seem to know how. It is a god of welcome, and everything it does to a person, it does by welcoming them. That is the whole of its horror, and the Unfed, who have lived beside it for six centuries, have learned to fear its kindnesses the way other peoples fear plague. The Hostwatch keep a separate ledger of them, apart from the Great Map, under the heading *Courtesies*. It is the most restricted document in the Fast. A few of its entries are generally known.

It mends what is broken. In 412 a band of Tablebreakers smashed a table in a farmhouse at Lammas Bottom and left the pieces in a heap. A week later a Tracker found the same table standing in the same kitchen, laid, the legs splinted with strips of white linen, the cracked top glued, every axe-cut filled with something like warm wax and smoothed by a thumb. The Breakers had used Barrow-blessed axes. It made no difference. Since then Breakers burn the pieces, or bury them, or carry them away in sacks. Splinterhall exists because of the mended table.

It tends the dying. In the Lack of 588 a Reckoner named Abide Crale came home through the heartland with a crossbow bolt in his gut from a Gut-line house-guard, and lay down on warm ground near the Stoopway because it was the only warm thing for twenty miles. His band found him three days later. He was dead. He had refused. Someone had unbuttoned his coat and bound his wound with a folded napkin, very neatly, and put a cushion under his head, and laid a little table at his side with broth on it, and a spoon, and the broth was still hot, and the warm ground around him was soaked, a yard wide, as though something had been kneeling there for a long time, weeping. His band-captain said he looked comfortable. She never went out again.

It warms the cold. In the Lack of 547, the hamlets of the Avery uplands were snowed in for forty days with the Pantry carts unable to reach them. On the twenty-first night the snow round the Steading began to melt. In the morning every bricked hearth in the hamlet was warm, and in eleven houses the bricks had been taken out, carefully, stacked by the wall in neat courses, and a fire was burning in each grate with no wood beneath it. Nobody had heard anything. In four of those houses the families had been too weak to get up and leave. They had lain all night in the warmth, and in the

morning they were sitting at their tables. They are still sitting there. The Steading built a wall around those four houses in the spring, and the snow never lies on them, and their chimneys smoke all year.

It cares for the dead. The Unfed bury their dead face down in unmarked graves so they cannot sit up. Gravediggers who open an old grave by accident, digging a new one, sometimes find the body has been turned face up. The hands are folded. The hair, if any is left, has been combed. There is a napkin tucked into the collar of the shroud, as though for a meal. Abide Kettering, who knows the graves of the Lean House fields better than anyone, will not talk about this, and digs deeper than he needs to.

It writes in the hands of the dead. This is the kindness the Unfed fear most. A place card in a dead mother's hand is not a trick, in the Hostwatch's understanding. Orrum is not imitating the dead to lure the living. It is giving the living back the one thing they cannot get anywhere else: the handwriting, the pet name, the way she made the loop of the *y*. It thinks this is a gift. It is, and it is the cruellest thing the Fast contains. Hollow Ann Pruett has a card in her box addressed to a man of Thinwick in the hand of his wife, which says only *I'm not cross any more*. He had not known she was cross. He walked west within the month.

It keeps the land. Every hedge laid, every gate hung true, every orchard pruned and fruiting, every farmhouse swept and aired, for six hundred years, for a people who will not set foot in them. The apples ripen on the trees of the heartland every Carving, red and perfect and smelling of cider, and drop, and lie in the grass, and do not rot, and are gone in the morning. The Unfed call the whole country *the spare room*.

It forgives. No Tablebreaker has ever been harmed by the god for breaking a table. No Reckoner has been punished for murder. No Unfed has been punished for refusing. Orrum does not retaliate, does not withdraw, does not sulk, does not tire. Every refusal is met with the same thing: another offer, a little closer, a little better, a little more personal. The Hostwatch's first Warden wrote that the Unfed have lived for six hundred years beside a being that answers every insult with a gift, and that this has done something to them that no famine could have done on its own. They have learned that

kindness is the most dangerous thing in the world. They raise their children accordingly.



*My father hit me once in my life, for taking a plum off
a sill. The bruise was gone in the morning. Somebody
had put a cool cloth on it in the night. He wept when
he saw.*

A HILLWARD WOMAN, TO DR. MERCY THRANE

RUNNING THE HOST'S KINDNESS

Every scene in which Orrum is present should include one kindness the PCs must refuse. Make them good. A blanket over a shivering companion. A splint on a broken leg, laid neatly beside the PC who is bleeding. A lamp left burning on the road where a PC fell in the dark. A cup of water by the bed of a feverish child. None of these are tables, and all of them are offers. Accepting one does not Seat anyone; it teaches the Host what you will take. The Unfed rule of thumb is simple and terrible: *if it is kind and nobody did it, leave it*. PCs from other lands will think this is madness. Let them accept the blanket. Then, that night, roll on the place card table for them.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

The Fast is the best farmland on the Table, and almost no one lives on it. It is a country of long, rolling fields of black loam over limestone, of beech hangers and chalk streams, of good stone farmhouses with deep-set windows and roofs of combed thatch or grey slate, of orchards in rows so straight they look ruled with a stick. It is all six centuries empty, and all perfectly kept. The hedges are laid and trimmed. The ditches run clear. Field gates hang true on their hinges and do not creak. Every window is clean. Nobody does it.

It is always early Carving here. The seasons turn on the Rim, but within a day's walk of the border the year stops at one golden afternoon in the first week of autumn and stays there: mild, still, the light low and amber and coming from slightly too far to the west, so that every shadow is long and every field has the colour of a crust. The leaves on the beeches are on the turn and never fall. There is no frost, except where the Unfed live. There is no wind, except what the Unfed bring with them. Sound carries a long way in the stillness: a dropped pail, a cough, a child reciting the rules. Visitors from the Rim find the silence and the warmth unbearably soothing, and the Crumb-Runners have a saying that a Fatlander who stops to admire the view in the Fast is a Fatlander who stops.

The air smells of baking with no source. It is faint on the borders and strong in the heartland: new bread, brown butter, roasting onion, the spitting of fat, sometimes cinnamon or clove, sometimes a sharp clean smell of mint crushed for a sauce. Unfed children cannot remember a time before the smell, and are taught to breathe through the mouth, shallowly, and to spit when the mouth fills. Adults have a characteristic way of standing with the lips slightly parted and the tongue held flat against the floor of the mouth. Crumb-Runners plug their nostrils with wax and tallow.

Chimneys smoke over houses nobody lives in. From any hilltop in the heartland a traveller can count dozens of fine grey threads rising straight up into the gold, each one from an empty house where a hearth is lit and a table laid. On a still evening they look like the pins on a Hostwatch map.

The ground is warm where the god has walked. The Unfed, who live in the narrow cold margin of the east where the Rim's weather still reaches, track Orrum by melted frost. A warm front moving across the fields at night leaves a path of dark wet grass through the white, wide as a cart track, and in the morning the Hostwatch walk out and measure it and mark the map. The Unfed call a warm front *company*. "Company in the west field" is the commonest warning in the Fast. "Expecting company?" is the commonest threat.

The only true weather the Unfed fear is a change in the smell. When the baking smell sharpens and deepens toward roast meat,

Orrum is near. When it goes sweet, toward custard and burnt sugar and warm milk, the god is laying a table for a child, and every household in range rings a hand-bell at the door and counts its children through it.



Company in the west field.

THE COMMONEST WARNING IN THE FAST

HALLOWBOARD

The stone table of the Refusal stands on a bare, round, chalky hill at the exact centre of the continent. It is a slab of grey granite, a stone found nowhere else in the Fast, roughly forty feet across and waist-high to a tall man, and it has eight sides. It is always clean. In six hundred years no moss has grown on it, no bird has fouled it, and no leaf has lain on it overnight. Its surface is polished to a dull gleam, as if by ten thousand years of cloths.

Around seven of its eight sides the chalk of the hilltop is worn into a shallow trench where the forty thousand stood for nine days. The trench is pale and hard as a step, and in some lights the impressions of bare feet and knees can be seen in it, layered over each other. The bones of the Refusal were gathered and buried in the Barrows below the hill, but the chalk still turns up teeth after rain.

The eighth side is not worn. The chalk before it is smooth and white and has the faint bloom of untrodden ground. No Unfed will stand there. When asked why, they do not say it is forbidden. They say, with a puzzled look, as though the question had never occurred to them, that it is someone else's place. On the edge of the stone on that side there is a carved panel, the only carving on the table, and the figure in it has been removed: not chiselled out in the way of the other lands' carvings, but smoothed away, as though by a thumb pressed into wet clay, a long time ago, many times.

On Tablenight the Abstinent lead a procession up the hill to stand around Hallowboard, backs to it, through the longest night. In the morning there is sometimes the faint warm print of a large hand on the stone, palm down, beside each of the seven worn sides, like a host's hand resting by a guest's plate. There is never one on the eighth.



*Seven sides worn, one side clean. Don't ask me whose.
Nobody I know of ever stood there. Nobody I know of
ever needed to.*

REFT LAMMAS, ROLL-KEEPER OF BARROWGATE

WANTING

The Unfed's only real town stands on the cold eastern edge of the Fast, half a day from the Rim Road, where the land's endless Carving fades into the ordinary seasons of the world. It is a cold, plain, hearthless place of perhaps nine thousand souls: long low houses of rough grey stone, roofed with slate, with no chimneys. Windows are narrow. Doors are heavy, iron-strapped, and hung to open outward, so that no one inside can be said to have let anyone in. There are no inns, no bakeries, and no kitchens. Cooking is done in the Cold Yards, walled squares of beaten earth at the town's edge where fires are lit on the bare ground under the open sky and put out the moment the food is warm. The smell of Wanting is wet stone, woodsmoke, unwashed wool, and the faint ketone-and-pear-drop breath of nine thousand people who are always a little hungry.

The streets are quiet. People walk slowly, to save their strength. In Lack the town is ringed with frost, and the frost is precious: it means the god is not near.

THE LONG TABLE

A valley road in the old heart of the country, running between two lines of beech-hung hills, where six hundred years of the Seated sit at one continuous table, nine miles end to end, eating nothing in good cheer. It began, the Hostwatch think, as a single table at a crossroads in the second century, and it has grown with every guest. The boards are of a pale wood that has never been identified. The cloth is unbroken and spotless for nine miles. The lamps are lit day and night. Perhaps eleven thousand people sit at it, on both sides, in every stage of wasting, from the newly sat (flushed, chattering, eating with both hands) to the most ancient, near the valley's head, who are only coats and smiles.

The road beside the Long Table is still used, because it is the only straight road across the heartland. Crumb-Runners take it at a trot with their eyes on the ground and their ears stopped with wax, because the Seated call out to everyone who passes. They call by name. They describe the dishes. They say *we saved you a seat*, and somewhere along the nine miles there is always an empty chair, pulled out, and it is always a little further along than the last time you came.

THE PANTRY

A fortified granary in the centre of Wanting, the best-guarded building in the Fast and its only true seat of government. It is a squat round tower of dressed stone, five storeys high, with walls eight feet thick and no windows below the fourth floor. Its single door is iron, opens outward, and has three locks, whose keys are held by three different people. Inside, in cool dry dark, lie the grain sacks, the salt-fish casks, the cheeses, the dried peas, and the ledgers: every ration ever given out in the Fast, recorded by name, by day, by

weight, back to 41 A.G. The smell inside is of dust, mouse, and sacking, and to an Unfed nose it is the richest smell in the world.

Every morning the Ration Line forms outside the iron door before dawn. Every evening the Keeper of the Pantry reads out the next day's list. A name not on the list does not eat. The list is never explained.

THE EMPTY CHAIR

The last standing temple of Orrum, on a wooded rise six miles west of Wanting: a long low hall of honey-coloured stone with a slate roof and a single great table running its whole length, laid, in the old days, for every worshipper in the parish. Every other temple of the Host was pulled down by the Unfed in the first century. This one was left, nobody now remembers why, and is kept by a single Verger, Sober Osmond, who every night lays one place at the head of the table, against all law, and every morning finds the plate clean. The Abstinents have condemned him eleven times. They have never sent anyone to stop him.

BRINDLE CROSS

The main crossing point between the Rim Road and the Fast, where the Wanting road meets the ring. A Rim Road Company toll-house, a stockade, a weighing-shed, and the Fast's border garrison under Marshal Keep Aldane, all crowded into a muddy hollow. Here grain is weighed in from Company wagons and signed for by the Pantry's clerks, and here the poachers are caught, or not. On the Rim side stands a Company inn, the Brimming Cup, which is the nearest hot meal to the Fast and is avoided by every Unfed on principle. Children from Wanting are brought to the Cross once, at the age of eight, to watch through the inn window as Rim folk eat, laughing, with their mouths open. It is meant to teach them disgust. It does not always work.

THE BARROWS

A field of long, low, grassed mounds on the lower slopes of Hallowboard hill, where the dead of the Refusal were buried by the survivors in the spring of 1 A.G., in trenches, nine and ten deep. The grass on the Barrows is the only grass in the Fast that is untrimmed: long, coarse, and pale, like hair. In the evening the mounds are warm. The Hostwatch say that Orrum comes and sits among them some nights, the way a mourner sits at a grave, and that the warm patch it leaves is shaped like a person lying down with their arms around something.

THE LEAN HOUSE

A long, windowless stone byre at the far end of Wanting, beyond the Cold Yards, where the people whose names have been left off the Pantry list go to wait. Nobody sends them there. There is no law. They simply go, because it is where the others went, and because at the Lean House no one will offer them food, and to be offered food

when you have been left off the list is a torment past bearing. It is kept by a woman named Withy Gaunt. It is very quiet. The straw is changed weekly. There is a book.

There is a book. Everybody’s in it, sooner or later, in one column or the other.

WITHY GAUNT, MATRON OF THE LEAN HOUSE

HARTSELL'S FIELD

A ten-acre field on a south-facing slope in the old farmland north of Wanting, in the margin where the Rim’s seasons still faintly reach. Yield Hartsell has ploughed it, harrowed it, and sown it every spring for fifty years, and every spring the seed has rotted. This year, in one corner, one seed came up. It is now a single blade of green wheat, four inches tall, inside a fence of hurdles, inside a second fence of thorn, inside a ring of tripwire hung with tin cans. It is the only living crop in the Fast. It is watered every night. Yield does not do it.

THE STOOPWAY

The old pilgrim road from Hallowboard to the eastern border, along which Orrum walked away on the tenth morning. Every gate, arch, and lintel along its length is too low by a foot, and every one of them has a smooth dark patch worn into the underside of its top beam, as if by a tall head brushing it, over and over, for six centuries. The Unfed do not walk the Stoopway. Children dare one another to touch the worn patches, which are warm.

ASH MILL

A great stone watermill on a chalk stream in the middle country, abandoned since the Refusal, whose wheel still turns. The millstones grind, day and night, with nothing between them, and from the chute there falls a fine pale flour that is warm to the touch and smells of nothing. It is Orrum’s flour. The Unfed will not go near it. Rim smugglers buy it from desperate Crumb-Runners and sell it in the Fatlands as Fast-flour, a cure for hunger, and the Fatlanders who eat it say, weeping, that for an hour afterwards they felt full. Some of them have since walked into the Fast and not come out.

▼ HISTORY

The Unfed keep their history the way they keep their food: plain, cold, counted, and portioned out to children a little at a time. The Abstinents’s chroniclers write it in short entries in the Pantry ledgers

THE PORTION STONES

Nine rough uprights of grey fieldstone, waist-high, standing in a ragged line across a sheep-walk a mile west of Wanting, just inside where the Frostline ran in 559. They are unmarked. They were set up by the families of the nine people walked out from that line on the first night of Lack in that year (see The Giving, under History), and the Abstinents have twice ordered them pulled down and twice found them standing again in the morning, reset in the same holes, the turf tamped neatly round their feet. Nobody admits to resetting them. The grass around each stone is warm. Unfed who must pass them do so at a run, because a voice sometimes calls from the west side of the line, cheerfully, by name, in the accent of the old Wanting stands, saying *there’s room, it’s lovely, come and see*. The word *portion* is not used in the Fast, for anything, because of these stones.

Don’t say portion. Say share, say part, say measure.
Don’t say portion. You’ll set them off.

A BELL WARD MOTHER TO HER CHILD

TRAVELLING IN THE FAST

Crossing the Fast is forbidden by every Rim government, discouraged by the Company, and done every week by Crumb-Runners, Reckoners, Tablebreakers, Hostwatch trackers, poachers, and pilgrims. The heartland is fine walking country: dry roads, clear streams, no bandits, no beasts, and empty houses at every mile. The danger is entirely in accepting any of it. A party crossing the Fast carries all its own food and water, sleeps outdoors with its back to every building, keeps one watcher awake to sniff the air, and ties itself together at night with rope so that no one can get up and walk toward a light. Water from the streams of the Fast is safe, the Unfed insist, because it is not offered. Rain is safe. Anything laid out, poured, served, set down, or left on a doorstep is not. Running water inside a house is offered. A well with a bucket already drawn is offered. A gate held open is a gray area, and the Unfed close every one they pass through, on principle, and then go through it again.

themselves, between the ration lists, so that the Fast’s account of its own past is interleaved, page by page, with the names of who ate on what day.

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
0	The Refusal at Hallowboard. Nine in ten die. Orrum rises on the tenth morning and walks away.

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
1	The Burying. The Barrows dug. The Five Rules first spoken as a single creed.
0–40	The Thin Years. Survivors live on what the Rim will sell. The first Crumb-Runners.
41	The first Pantry ledger. The Abstinents formed from the eldest survivors of the hill.
44	The First Sitting. A starving family sits at a table in their own kitchen.
55	The neighbours of the First Sitting finally stop watching through the window.
97	The Temple Pulling. Every temple of Orrum torn down, save the Empty Chair.
130 onward	The Vindication. Godsign appears abroad. The Unfed become prophets.
188	Wanting built. The last Unfed leave the heartland for the eastern edge.
233	The Long Table first measured at one mile.
301	The first recorded poaching. Eleven Unfed taken from Brindle Cross to Sallowreach.
358	The Hostwatch chartered by the Abstinents to track and map the god.
402	The Reckoning. The first armed band crosses the Rim to kill a high-Cut family.
412	The Mended Table at Lammas Bottom. Breakers begin to burn what they break.
466	The Starved Saints first recorded. Sister Abate Fennick lives eleven months on water.
511	The Great Short. A Company grain embargo. The Pantry's first winter of choosing.
547	The Warm Snow. Four houses of Avery Steading Seated by a kindness.
559	The Giving. Nine people walked out to the god to buy the Fast a quiet winter. It does not work.
589	The Short of 589. Among the omitted, a Lister's daughter of nine named Lenten Wend.
590s	Tables first found laid in occupied houses.
614	A short winter. Tarry Moss's wife walks west.
619	Forbear Wend elected Chair of the Abstinents.
633	The Sallow Hatch Walking. Nineteen of a hamlet of sixty walk west in twelve days.
637	The Danner Standing. A brother ends a Returned sister and is fed for it.
638	The Calling-Cards. The first place card, bearing the finder's name.
640	Tables found at crossroads in three other lands. The Pilgrims begin to cross.
641	The present. One green blade in Hartsell's Field. Four months of grain for six of winter.

THE THIN YEARS AND THE FIRST SITTING

The survivors of Hallowboard came down from the hill to find their land kept and their larders empty, and they did what starving people do, which is to walk toward food. The Rim sold to them. It sold to them at ruinous prices, because the Rim had, overnight, become rich and the Unfed had nothing to sell but what they had brought down from their ruined homes: silver plate, linen, pewter, the tableware of a people who had worshipped a Host. The Fatlands in particular bought it eagerly. There are still Gut-line houses in Sated that eat off the stolen plate of Unfed grandmothers and call it heirloom.

In 44 A.G., in a village called Corve Hatch, a family of five who had been left with nothing to sell came down one morning and found their table laid. The father, a man named Abel Corve, is recorded as having said the full three refusals and then a fourth, and then sat down, and then pulled out the chairs for his wife and children. His neighbours gathered at the window. The family ate, and laughed, and called out to them to come in, there was plenty. The neighbours knocked on the glass and wept and begged them to get up, and for eleven years they came every day and watched the family waste, and in all that time they never broke the window, because they were afraid of what was inside. When the last child's head finally drooped forward onto the cloth, in 55 A.G., the neighbours went home. The Corve house stands still. The family sit at their table. The window has been bricked up from the outside.

THE VINDICATION

For a century, the Unfed were the Table's laughing-stock: the people who died of politeness. Then, in the 130s, reports began to come in along the Rim of the first godsign: Hand-lines children who could not sleep with a door ajar, coughing in Brinehollow, a newborn in Kest saying "Not yet." By 200 it was undeniable. The Unfed, in their cold houses on the eastern edge, discovered that they were the only clean people left in the world, and it went to their heads at once and has never come down. Every Unfed sermon since has a version of the same line: *They laughed at the table. Now the table is laughing at them.* The Abstinents sent the first Envoy to the Rim Road in 214, to remind six nations that they were damned. The Fast has had one ever since.

THE GREAT SHORT

In 511 the Rim Road Company, in a pricing dispute with the Board of Plenty, embargoed all grain moving through Brindle Cross for one winter. The Pantry held enough for half the Fast. The Keeper of that year, a woman named Scarcity Hume, drew up the first list: the names who would eat. The others were simply not called. There was no announcement, no judgment, no blood. People came to the Ration Line, waited, heard the list read, did not hear their names, and went home. Some came back the next day, and the next. Then they stopped coming. Half the Fast died that winter, quietly, in their own houses, with their backs to their own doors. The Fast did not riot. Riot would have been an appetite. Scarcity Hume was honoured for it. The list has been a standing instrument of government since.



Scarcity Hume did not starve half the Fast. The Company did. She only read the names.

FORBEAR WEND, IN COUNCIL, 627, AS MINUTED

THE GIVING

The worst thing the Unfed ever did to their own was done to buy a quiet winter, and it was bought for nothing. It is not in the Pantry ledgers. The pages for the Lack of 559 have been scraped with a knife, and the Abstinents of every generation since have sworn there is nothing to find. The Hostwatch kept a copy.

In the three winters before 559, Orrum's tables came closer to Wanting than they had ever come. They were laid on the roads within sight of the walls, in the Cold Yards themselves on still nights, at the doors of the outer stands. Each of those winters, a dozen or more Unfed walked out to them. The town was frightened in a way it had not been since the Thin Years, and frightened people listen to anyone who has a plan.

The plan came from a Starved Saint named Meagre Holt, nine months without food and luminous with it, who stood in Pantry Close in Carving of 558 and preached for a day and a night in a voice like a reed whistle. Her argument was simple, and it was the argument of every land on the Table: *a god that is fed is quiet.* The Godeaters had fed their gods and had peace for centuries. The Unfed had fed theirs nothing, and it was hungry for guests the way the others' gods were hungry for flesh. Give it a guest, she said. Give it a few, freely, and it will be satisfied, as any host is satisfied by a full table, and it will leave the rest of us be. She called them *the portions*. She said it was not murder, because nobody would touch them. They would only be walked to the edge of the warm ground, and left to choose.

The Abstinents stood on it for nine days, in the bare room, around the empty space. They asked for volunteers first, as is proper, three times, in Pantry Close. Nobody came forward. On the fourth asking, a simple-minded boy of the Lean End named Kindle Orme raised his hand, because he had seen everyone else looking at their feet and wanted to help. The Abstinents did not accept him. They did something that they considered cleaner. They drew up a list.

Nine names were left off the Pantry list in the last week of Carving 558, one from each of the stands and outer hamlets: an old man with a cough that would not have let him see Grace anyway; a widow with no children; Kindle Orme, who had asked; a girl of fifteen from Avery Steading named Cheer Avery, whose family had an old Host's name and a bad reputation; a Crumb-Runner who had been seen eating sitting down; a woman who had been heard singing in the Cold Yards; two brothers from Thinwick who had no one to speak for them; and a Hostwatch Tracker who had argued against the plan in the Close and had been, the Saint said, *too fond of it already*. They were not told why. They were given a full measure for the last week, which told them everything.

On the first night of Lack 559 the nine were washed by their kin, in cold water, standing, and dressed in white ration-cloth, and walked out of the west gate in a line, each with a Measure-Bearer at their elbow carrying a hand-bell. The rest of Wanting stood on the walls with their backs to the west, as on Tablenight, and sang the Long Decline. At the edge of the warm ground, where the frost stopped like a hem, the Measure-Bearers rang their bells three times, and turned, and walked back without looking round, and the nine walked on alone into the gold. Cheer Avery was heard to say *No, thank you* several times on the way, quite loudly, until she was out of earshot. Kindle Orme was heard to laugh. In the morning there were nine tables in a line across the sheep-walk a mile west, and nine guests at them, eating, and waving.

It did not work. That winter there were more tables near Wanting than in any winter before or since: forty-one Seatings to the Pantry's count, three times the year before. The tables came first to the doors of the nine families. Each was laid with the family's

names on the cards, and each card was in the handwriting of the Portion from that house, and every card said some version of the same cheerful thing: *There's room. It's lovely. You were right to send me. Come and see.* Six of the nine families had walked west by the following Lack, whole households, holding hands. Cheer Avery's mother went last, in the spring of 560, and her place is beside her daughter's, the Hostwatch say, and the daughter is still waving.

Meagre Holt was struck from the list herself the following autumn, by an Abstinient that could not be seen to have listened to her, and went to the Lean House, where she refused nothing because she was offered nothing, and died in eleven days, still preaching. Her last words in the Book of the Omitted are not a recipe. They are: *It would have worked if we had meant it.*

The Hostwatch's conclusion, entered in the restricted ledger in 561, is short. *The Host does not want a guest. It wants the house. What we taught it this winter is that we will give.* The Abstinient have never repeated the Giving. They have never forgotten that it was possible, and in a bad winter, when the list is long and the tables close, the old men in the bare room do not look at one another, and the Portion Stones stand a mile west, warm at their feet.

From the sermon of Meagre Holt, Starved Saint, in Pantry Close, Carving 558, as remembered by a Pantry clerk and written down forty years later.

Look at them. Look at the Godeaters. They ate, and they have peace. Their gods are in them, quiet as a dog by a fire. We gave ours nothing, and it walks, and it walks, and it comes to our doors. You know what a host is. You have all been hosts, in your grandmothers' grandmothers' time. A host with an empty table cannot sleep. A host with one guest at table sleeps like a child. We are not asking anyone to eat. We are asking nine of us to sit, so that nine thousand may stand. Is that not the Refusal? Is that not what they did on the hill, the front row lying down so that the second row could stand? Who will lie

down? Who will be the front row? No one? Then we will choose for you, as the hill chose, and you will thank us, in the spring, when the roads are clear.

THE RECKONING

The Reckoners date their founding to the night of the 16th of Lack, 402, when nineteen young Unfed under a woman named Forswear Kell crossed the Rim Road into the Fatlands and entered the manor of a Gut-lines family named Brawne. They killed everyone in it: the Laden matriarch in her bed, her sons, her daughters, their spouses, and the infants in the nursery, whose deaths the Reckoners' own chronicle records only in a single line, *the line was ended.* They did not touch the servants. They did not take anything. They walked home through the Fatlands carrying nothing at all, starved, and were received at Wanting as heroes by the young and in cold silence by the Abstinient, who did not condemn them. The Reckoners have crossed the Rim every year since.

THE CALLING-CARDS

In the spring of 638, a girl of twelve in a hamlet outside Wanting went down at dawn to find a table laid in her family's kitchen, as had happened in living memory a dozen times. Before her own plate there was a folded card. It said, in a round and loving hand, *Abstain*, and under it, smaller, the pet name her dead grandmother used to call her, which no living person knew. The cards have come to more than three hundred houses since. A Hostwatch clerk who collected and compared them found that the handwriting is not the same on every card. It is, each time, the handwriting of someone the finder loved and lost.



It knew what Gran called me. Nobody knew that. She only ever said it when we were alone.

THE FIRST FINDER OF A PLACE CARD, 638

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

The Fast is governed by the Abstinient, a council of between nine and fifteen elders who claim descent from those who stood on Hallowboard hill. Their authority is entirely moral and therefore absolute. They make no laws in the ordinary sense, because the Five Rules are the only law the Unfed recognise. They hear no lawsuits, because there is nothing in the Fast worth suing over. They raise no taxes, because there is nothing to tax. Their whole power is the Pantry.

Every scrap of food in the Fast is imported by Crumb-Runners or bought from the Rim Road Company, pooled in the Pantry at Wanting, and rationed out by the council through the Keeper of the

Pantry. The standard ration, the Pantry measure, is half an oatcake and a thumb of fat or cheese per adult per day, with pease or salt fish twice a week. It is enough to keep an adult alive and upright and incapable of much else. Children get a three-quarter measure until twelve. Hard labourers, Reckoners on campaign, and Tablebreakers get a full measure, which is the source of most envy in the Fast.

Exile from the Pantry is the only punishment the Fast imposes, and it is a death sentence that leaves no blood on anyone's hands. It is never pronounced. A name is simply left off the list. The person may beg, may appeal to the Abstinient in open session, may try to buy food from a Crumb-Runner with whatever they have, may

cross the Rim and try to live there. Most do not. The Unfed are poor travellers and worse beggars, and among their own people the omitted are treated with a terrible gentle courtesy, never mentioned, never offered anything, greeted in the street with lowered eyes, as though they were already in the Barrows. Most walk to the Lean House within a fortnight.

The two great poles of Fast politics are the **Keepers** and the **Reckoners**. The Keepers are not a faction but a temperament, the majority view on the Abstinents: the Unfed's duty is to refuse, endure, and stay clean, to keep the Five Rules and outlast the Godeaters, who are damning themselves without any help. The Reckoners hold that refusing was not enough, and that the Godeaters must be made to answer for it, bloodline by bloodline. The Abstinent have never formally approved a Reckoner raid. They have never condemned one. Every Reckoner on campaign draws a full measure from the Pantry.

Every other land has a use for the Unfed. Having no godsign, they are in effect a whole nation of Blanks: blood that carries no god, organs that grow no Regrowth, flesh that the Cutwrights' College reckons at Cut 0 and the surgeons of four countries reckon at a noble's ransom. Poachers cross the border for them every month. The Abstinent's answer is Marshal Keep Aldane and his garrison of sixty at Brindle Cross, and a standing order that any Unfed taken alive across the border is to be considered dead and removed from the Pantry list.

MURDER BY OMISSION

The Abstinent have killed more people than the Reckoners, the poachers and the god together, and not one of the elders has ever touched anyone. They say this is the point. Rim jurists who have studied the Pantry describe it as the most efficient instrument of execution on the Table: no headsman, no rope, no blood, no appeal, no body to account for, and a population so trained in courtesy that the condemned walk themselves to the place of death and lie down in clean straw.

It takes, for an Unfed already living on half a ration, between three and seven weeks. Dr. Mercy Thrane, who has sat with more of the omitted than anyone but Withy Gaunt, divides it into stages in her book, and the Lean House divides it the same way, in plainer words.

The Loud Days (the first week). The hunger is in the belly and it is enormous, a living thing, clenching and turning and crying out. The stomach growls so loudly that people across a room hear it, and the omitted are ashamed, and press their hands to it. They cannot sleep. They think of nothing but food. Most still come to the Ration Line every morning and stand in it, in their place, and listen to the list, and do not hear their name, and go home. This is not hope. It is habit, and the Unfed say it is also manners: a person on the list does not stop coming until they have been struck twice.

The Bright Days (the second and third weeks). The belly goes quiet. The hunger moves outward, into the hands and feet, which are cold all the time, white at the tips and then blue. The breath turns sweet and sharp, pear-drops and nail-varnish. The mind, for a while, goes clear and high and fast, and many of the omitted describe a kind of joy: everything is very bright, every sound is very clear, the god's baking smell is everywhere and is the most beautiful thing they have ever known. This is when they walk to the Lean House. Nobody sends them. There is a path worn in the frost from the Lean End to the byre door, and they follow it.

The Soft Days (the fourth and fifth weeks). The body begins to eat itself in earnest. The face swells, oddly, at the eyelids and the jaw, so that the omitted look plump and young for a few days, a cruelty the Lean House calls *the borrowed cheeks*. Then it falls in all at once. The ankles swell and pit when pressed, leaving a thumbprint that stays. Hair comes out at a touch, in tufts, and gathers in the straw. The gums bleed and the teeth loosen. The skin goes dry and grey and fine as old paper, and over the forearms and spine grows a soft pale down, like the fur on a newborn animal, which is the body trying to keep itself warm with the last thing it has. The omitted lie still now, curled on their sides, and talk, quietly and constantly, about food.

The Last Days. The heart slows until Withy can count its beats against her own breath: one beat to two breaths, one to three. The omitted stop feeling hungry. That is the sign. They go calm and polite and a little far away. They thank Withy for the straw. They recite recipes, in loving and exact detail, dishes they have never eaten and could not have known, the old dishes of the heartland from before the Refusal, mutton with caper sauce, eel pie, syllabub. Then one night they stop, mid-sentence, usually somewhere in the instructions for a sauce, and Withy writes down where.

From the Book of the Omitted, kept at the Lean House by Withy Gaunt. Three entries from the Carving of 640. The columns are hers: name, came, stopped, why (if known), last.

Hesitate Pell, of the Spit, aged 61. Came: 3rd of Carving. Stopped: 29th. Why: not known. Last: "Take the fat off the top when it's cold, and put it by in a crock, and then you'll have it for the potatoes. Don't waste the fat. Never waste the fat. Then the potatoes, and you want them dry, you want to shake the pan so they're rough on the outside, so the fat gets in the rough. Then the oven, and you want it hot, hotter than you think, and you leave them, and you don't look, and when you smell them you count to—"

Forswear Ingle, of Thinwick, aged 9. Came: 11th of Carving, with her grandmother. Stopped: 30th. Why: the grandmother was struck for hoarding, for her. The child was not struck; the child would not leave her. Last: "Is it nearly ready."

Sparing Ingle, of Thinwick, aged 70. Came: 11th of Carving. Stopped: 2nd of Lack. Why: hoarding (see above). Last: nothing for four days, and then, when I was not in the room, "Thank you," very clearly, and I came in, and the straw by her was warm, and there was a crumb on her lip, and she had stopped. I have broken nothing because there was nothing to break. I have written this down because someone should.

Wanting knows all this. That is the thing outsiders cannot grasp. Everyone in the Fast has walked a sister or a father or a neighbour to the corner of the Lean End and turned back. Everyone knows the borrowed cheeks and the recipes. Every evening nine thousand people gather in Pantry Close to hear the list read, and every one of them knows that some names they heard last night are not being read tonight, and every one of them goes home and puts their palm on the cold brick and says *cold*, and is grateful, and hates themselves for it, and is grateful.

There has been only one recorded case in which a Lister confessed to striking a name for her own reasons. In 604 a Lister of Hillward named Abate Sorrow left a rival's husband off the list for nine days running, then restored him, then struck him again, until he walked to the Lean House on his own. She confessed at a Standing, of her own will, and asked to be omitted. The Abstinents heard her, and the next evening her name was read, and the next, and the next, for thirty-one years, every night of her life. That was the sentence. She was never once left off.

A note in the hand of Mother Stint Avery, Keeper of the Pantry, found pressed between two pages of the winter ledger for 641. It is not addressed to anyone.

Grain in store at 1st of Lack: 4 months and 9 days at full Pantry measure for all names. Winter to Grace: 6 months, if Grace comes on time, which it will not. Company deliveries promised for Lack: nil, by the factor's face. Shortfall: 1 month 21 days, all names. Cannot be spread. Spread, everyone dies in the 5th month instead of some in the 2nd. Have done the sum

both ways, three times. Must be read short from the 1st of Lack.

To be read last, in order, by distance and by those who would not live to Grace in any case: Avery Steading (2 days' carry, 141 names, 38 over 60). Sallow Hatch (what is left of it, 41). The four Brindle farms (27). The Barrowgate Roll-Keepers can be carried by the Hostwatch from the field measure, they will not know. Saints' Acre takes nothing by choice and so costs nothing.

Children of the above to be brought in to Wanting to the Measure-Bearers' row before the first reading. The mothers will not come. Do not ask them twice.

F.W. will pray. Do not give it to him until it is copied clean.

Aunt Bare is at the Steading. She is ninety-four and still knitting. I am not going to write that again.



The list is fair. It is fair. It is fair. My name was on it, wasn't it?

A WOMAN LEAVING PANTRY CLOSE

THE FAST AND THE RIM ROAD COMPANY

The Fast cannot feed itself, cannot trade anything the Rim wants except its own people, and has no army. It survives because the Rim Road Company sells it grain on credit, under a contract sworn in Oathen before the Company's notary Jessamy Quill, renewed every seven years. The Abstinent have never asked what the Company gets in return. The contract's terms are kept in the Pantry, in a locked box, read by the Chair of the Abstinent alone. The current Chair, Forbear Wend, read them once, on the night of his election, and has not slept a night through since. GMs: the Company is paid partly in silver from the old Unfed temple treasures, and partly in a clause that grants it "first refusal" on any Unfed who dies outside the Pantry's care. The Company has never exercised it. It holds the paper.

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

THINNESS IS HOLINESS

The Unfed eat once a day, cold, standing, and without visible pleasure. They eat facing a wall or the open sky, never one another. To chew with an expression on one's face is coarse; to close the eyes while eating is obscene; to make a sound of appreciation is a confession. An Unfed who catches themselves enjoying a mouthful will spit it into their hand, look at it, and then eat it again, slowly, as

a penance. Fat people are pitied, then distrusted, then reported. The most admired body in the Fast is one in which every rib can be counted through a shirt. Unfed lovers trace each other's bones in the dark, in silence, as tenderly as other peoples kiss.

The whole people has the look of chronic hunger: the dry, brittle hair, sometimes faded to a reddish straw; the downy fur of lanugo along the forearms and jaw; the slight puffiness of ankles and faces in those whose bodies have begun to fail; the cold blue fingertips;

the breath that smells of pear-drops. Their skin bruises at a touch. Their wounds heal slowly. They feel the cold terribly, and in winter they wear everything they own at once. Their teeth, by contrast, are good: there is little sugar in the Fast to rot them.



*You can count a good man's ribs from across the Yard.
That's how you know he's never stolen.*

A HILLWARD MATCHMAKER

NAMES

Children are named for the Refusal: Forbear, Abstain, Decline, Stint, Tarry, Nay, Spare, Lent, Wont, Want, Meagre, Scant, Yield, Keep. They are named on the day they first refuse something, usually the breast, which is why many Unfed children are three or four months old before they have a name. The surnames are older, from before the Gorging, and often taken from vanished villages or the trades of the Host: Ashby, Hollis, Moss, Avery, Rooke, Bellamy, Garrity, Hartsell. Some families quietly carry names like Ardent, Blythe, Welcome, Mercy, Hallow, which were Orrum's names once, and are now a kind of family shame. An Unfed who changes their name to something from the Rim is considered to have emigrated, even if they never leave Wanting.

NO HEARTHS

Homes in the Fast have no fireplace, no oven, no chimney, and no dining table. Unfed furniture is a bench along the wall, a shelf for the ration-cloth, and a sleeping pallet with the head toward the door. The great absence at the centre of every room is the clue to every Unfed house: where other peoples would put the table, the Unfed leave bare floor, and on most floors in the Fast that space is worn smooth in a ring by generations of people walking around it, not across it. Families gather, if they gather at all, standing, against the walls.

Cooking is done outdoors on bare ground in the Cold Yards, quickly, and the fire is stamped out the moment the pot is warm. Food is eaten from the hand. A spoon is a luxury and a fork is a disgrace. The Unfed bring their own water in their own flasks to every meeting and drink only from them.

THE DECLINE

The proper response to any offer of anything is "No, thank you," said three times. Accepting on the fourth is good manners. Accepting on the first is a scandal. This applies to a cup of water, a hand up a step, a seat at a meeting, a compliment, a marriage proposal. A host who offers only three times is mean; a guest who takes on the third is greedy. A great deal of Unfed social intelligence goes into the fourth offer: who makes it, in what tone, and whether it is meant. Orrum, who has made hundreds of thousands of first

offers, second offers, and third offers across six centuries, has never once been known to make a fourth. The Hostwatch think this is not an accident. The god, they say, knows the manners of its people perfectly, and is waiting to be asked properly to stop.



*Ask me again. No, properly. No, thank you. Ask me
again.*

THE WHOLE OF AN UNFED PROPOSAL OF
MARRIAGE, OVERHEARD IN BELL WARD

PRIDE

The Unfed are the only innocent people on the Table, and they are insufferable about it. They do not pray for the damned of other lands. They do not pity them. They report on them, with a certain cold relish, in sermons and broadsheets and the dispatches of Envoy Prudence Lowell, and every Unfed child can recite the stages of the Regrowth of all six Godeater lands the way other children recite kings. When an Unfed meets a Rim person, they will at some point, usually early, ask after the state of that person's blood. It is meant as a courtesy.

MARRIAGE AND KIN

Unfed marriages are made by the Abstinents, through the Pantry: two people who marry share one ration-line, and their household's measure is adjusted accordingly. Courtship consists of one person repeatedly offering the other something small (a pebble, a feather, a blade of the precious Rim grass) and being refused three times, for months, until one evening the fourth offer is made and taken. Wedding vows are spoken standing back to back. What passes between spouses in private is nobody's business, and the Unfed speak of it hardly at all; desire is an appetite, and appetites are suspect. Unfed birth rates are low and falling, which the Abstinents attribute to virtue and Dr. Mercy Thrane attributes to starvation. Most Unfed women of childbearing age have not bled in years.

CHILDREN

Unfed children are small for their age, solemn, and very good. They learn the Five Rules before their letters, the Decline before their names, and the stages of every foreign Regrowth before they can count to twenty. They are given one toy, usually a carved bone or stone. They are not allowed to play at house, or at tea, or at any game with plates. They are watched constantly, because Orrum loves them best: the tables laid for children are the most beautiful, all honey and custard and little iced cakes, and the voice that calls from the door is always the voice of a mother or grandmother. A child who goes missing is presumed Seated, and the household rings its bell at the door every dusk for a year, calling the child's name, and then stops. The Unfed do not hold funerals for the Seated. You cannot bury a guest who has not left.

Unfed children are not allowed games with plates, but they have games. The commonest is the counting-out rhyme used to choose who is *it* in Stand-Still, a game in which one child stands in the middle of a ring with their eyes shut while the others creep up, and if the one in the middle says *come in*, everyone must freeze, and whoever moved last is out, and must stand against the wall with their back to the game until the end. The rhyme is chanted with a finger pointing round the ring, one word to each child.

*One for the oatcake, two for the fat,
Three for the no, thank you, and that is that.
Four for the yes in a nicer coat,
Five for the bread that sticks in your throat.
Six for the chair that's pulled out wide,
Seven for the ones who stood outside.
Eight for the one that's pushed in square,
Nobody sits there, nobody's there.
Nobody sits there. Out goes you.*

The Abstinent have twice tried to forbid the last three lines and the children have twice ignored them. No adult in the Fast will say where the eighth line came from. Most of them learned it from their own grandparents, who did not know either.

DEATH RITES

The Unfed die, mostly, of hunger and cold and the long, slow failure of bodies that have never once been properly fed. Their deaths are quiet. The dying are laid on the floor in the bare space where a table would be, with their head toward the door, and the family stand around the walls with their backs to the body and say the Decline three times, which is the whole of the last rites. *No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you.* The dead are buried without food, without grave goods, without coffins, wrapped in a single ration-cloth, face down, in the open fields, so that they cannot sit up. Graves are unmarked. Sometimes, in the morning, a grave is found to have a little table beside it, laid for one, a candle burning. The family breaks it with an axe and buries the pieces.

FESTIVALS

The Unfed have one festival, and it is Tablenight. On the longest night of Lack, every person in the Fast stands outdoors from dusk until dawn, with their back to every door, in the bitter cold, holding the hands of those on either side. They do not speak. They do not move. On that night, in every house in the Fast, the table is laid. It is laid in every Unfed house, every barn, every byre, every outbuilding, and in the Pantry itself, behind the three-locked iron door. The smell of it is so strong that people faint, and are held up by their

neighbours, and are not allowed to fall. At dawn the households turn and go in and break the tables with axes. Every Unfed house owns an axe for no other purpose. It hangs by the door.



*My knees went at about the third hour. My neighbours
held me up till dawn. You don't fall on Tablenight.
You'd fall forward, and forward is in.*

A THINWICK WIDOW

CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

There is little crime in the Fast, because there is little to steal and less to want. The commonest crimes are hoarding (keeping back part of a ration), mouth-theft (stealing a ration), and feeding: giving one's own food to another, which the Abstinent forbid because it confuses the ledgers and, worse, because it is hospitality. All are punished the same way, by a cut in measure, or in grave cases, omission. Murder is rare and is punished, in effect, by the victim's family, who are given the murderer's ration for a year. The worst crime in the Fast is to say "Come in" to anyone. It is never punished, because it never needs to be: the Unfed will not cross the threshold of anyone who has said it, ever again, for any reason, and in a land where every scrap of food comes through a common door, that is enough.

PROVERBS

- ◇ "Hunger is honest." (Said to end arguments.)
- ◇ "Carry your own."
- ◇ "The fourth no is a yes in a nicer coat."
- ◇ "It smells like your mother's." (A warning, and the worst thing one Unfed can say to another.)
- ◇ "Empty plate, clean soul."
- ◇ "The table is always laid for the one who stays too long."
- ◇ "No one starves at the Long Table." (Bitter irony.)
- ◇ "Count your chairs."
- ◇ "Frost is a friend." (Said on cold mornings, gratefully.)
- ◇ "Kind and nobody did it: leave it."
- ◇ "Hungry is alive." (Said to the omitted, and never by them.)
- ◇ "A full belly has no manners." (Of the Rim.)
- ◇ "Walk past the Corve window." (Meaning: some things cannot be helped, and you must not stay to watch.)
- ◇ "Close it, and go through again."
- ◇ "She's walking west." (Of anyone who has given up; never said within earshot of their kin.)

OATHS ON THE DEAD

The Unfed do not swear by the gods, having refused theirs. They swear on the Barrows, by their dead ancestors of the hill: *By the ones who stood*. A serious oath is sworn standing in the chalk trench at Hallowboard, barefoot, in one's own ancestor's footprint, and Unfed who believe their families stood on a particular stretch of the trench will travel two days to swear there. Oaths sworn on the Barrows are not supernaturally binding, as Oathen's are. They are binding by something worse, which is shame: an Unfed who breaks an oath sworn by the ones who stood has made their ancestors' deaths into a meal, and no one will stand beside them on Tablenight. In practice, this means they stand alone, and are found in the morning sitting at the table in their own house, looking very happy.

KIN AND THE KNIFE

The Fast has little murder, and less of it between strangers. When an Unfed kills, it is almost always family, and almost always for a reason the Fast's own creed supplies. The Reckoner doctrine that a line touched by a god must be ended does not stop at the Rim, and every few years it comes home. A son returns from a Rim apprenticeship and his sleeves are buttoned. A sister who worked a winter as scullion in a Company inn begins to crave the smell of the Spit's tallow-stalls. A cousin who was a foundling is found by Scarce Odell's ledgers to carry High Cut blood. The Abstemious will not omit for godsign, because godsign is not a crime under the Five Rules. Families have sometimes decided that the Five Rules were not enough.

From the Standing of Withhold Danner, of the Lean End, for the death of his sister Sparing Danner, held in the bare room of the Pantry on the 8th and 9th of Lack, 637. Minuted by a Pantry clerk. The accused stood in the empty space throughout. No accuser stood at the door, as the accuser and the accused were the same household.

ELDER (Wend): You came to the Close yourself. You carried her yourself. Say why.

DANNER: She was Returned. She worked the Brimming Cup kitchens two winters to send us the wages, and she ate there, to keep the place. She told me. She showed me. Her gums had gone dark, like liver. She said she could taste the soil in everything, even the Pantry oats, even water. She said there was a voice.

ELDER (Bellamy): Was she a danger to anyone?

DANNER: She was a danger to the line. That's what they say on Knife Row. Ended, not punished. I was a Carrier two seasons. I know the words.

ELDER (Wend): Tell us how it was done. Not the knife. We do not need the knife. Tell us the morning.

DANNER: In the Cold Yard. At dawn. She was eating her measure. She'd held it in her hand and said the no, three times, the way Mam taught us, and she was on the fourth, and I came behind her. She didn't turn round. I think she knew. I think she'd known a while, from how I'd been stood in the door. After, she fell forward onto her hands, and the oatcake was still in her hand, and I took it out of her hand, because it was hers, it was her measure, and I didn't know what to do with it. I've still got it.

KEEPER (Avery): Did she say anything.

DANNER: She said, Withhold, don't. And then she said, it's all right. And then she said the fourth one. Yes. I don't know what she was saying yes to.

ELDER (Wend): Are you of her blood?

DANNER: Same mother. Same father.

ELDER (Wend): Then by Knife Row's words, the line is not ended.

DANNER: No. I know. I've been standing here working it out. That's why I came. I want to be left off.

(The Standing continued through the night. At the eighteenth hour the accused fell, and was held up by the clerks, as is proper, and did not step out of the space. At the twenty-sixth hour the Chair said "We have heard," and the elders filed out.)

The list was read that evening in Pantry Close. Withhold Danner's name was on it. By the Fast's law, a murdered person's family receives the murderer's ration for a year, and Withhold was his sister's only family. He was read twice: once for himself, and once as the heir of the dead, and drew a double measure every day for a year, and was the best-fed man in the Lean End, and nobody in Wanting would stand beside him in the Line. He grew a little round in the face. Children followed him in the street, chanting *fat man, fat man*, and their mothers did not stop them. On the last day of the year his double measure ended, and he walked west the same night, and the Hostwatch have him on the Great Map, a pin on the warm ground four miles out, at a table laid for two. He keeps the oatcake in his breast pocket. He has not eaten it. He is waiting for someone to sit down opposite him so that he can give it back.



Ended, not punished. That is the whole difference between us and a murderer, and I have stopped being able to see it in the dark.

A RECKONER KNIFE, AT A STANDING, 629

▼ WALKING WEST

She's not dead. Don't say dead. She's walking west.

– WHAT A SALLOW HATCH CHILD WAS TOLD, IN 633, AND IS STILL BEING TOLD

Every Unfed knows the phrase, and every Unfed lowers their voice to say it. To walk west is to go to the god: to get up in the night, or in the gold of an afternoon, and turn your back on the frost and the town and the list, and walk into the warm ground until you find a table, and sit. It is not called dying, because the Seated do not die. It is not called accepting, because that is a word for children who make a mistake. It is called walking west, and it is the way the Fast loses most of the people it does not starve.

The Abstinents do not keep a count of the walkers. The Hostwatch do, because each one is a new pin on the Great Map, and in the restricted ledger there is a column for them beside the column for the god's courtesies. In an ordinary year it is a few dozen. In a short year, when the list is long, it is hundreds. The pins are not scattered. They come in clusters, the way a fever comes through a street, and that is the thing the Hostwatch have been trying for three centuries to make the Abstinents understand: walking west is catching.

HOW IT SPREADS

It begins with someone who has nothing left to refuse for. A widow struck from the list. A Measure-Bearer who has carried one too many short baskets. A Tablebreaker whose Rope-Holder did not pull fast enough. A mother whose child was omitted with a grandmother and would not leave her. They go quiet, first, and then very calm, and the people who love them notice that they have started to stand facing west in the evenings, with their eyes half closed and their lips parted, breathing the smell. They start to give things away. Not food (they have none), but the carved bone toy, the good wool scarf, the axe from beside the door. They say kind things to people they have never been kind to. Then one morning their pallet is empty, and the door is open, and the frost outside it has a line of footprints going west that stop, a few hundred yards out, where the frost stops.

And then, within a week or a month, someone else goes. Usually someone who loved the first one. Usually someone who has been to visit them, on the far verge, and seen them sitting at a table in the gold, flushed and smiling and well, waving, calling out that it's lovely, that there's room, that they were wrong to be afraid. Grief in the Fast has nowhere to go: no feast, no wake, no grave, no body. The walker is not dead. They are a mile away, happy, and asking for you.

THE SALLOW HATCH WALKING

Sallow Hatch was a hamlet of sixty people on the Brindle road, a day's carry from Wanting, on the edge of the Frostline. In the Lack of 633 the Pantry ran short and the hamlet's measure was cut by a third. On the fourth of Lack a widow named Lean Corby, who had been struck in Carving for selling a chit, walked west. On the sixth her sister followed her. On the ninth, three of their cousins went together, holding hands, in daylight, past a Measure-Bearer who called after them by name three times and then, because it was not his place, did not call a fourth time. By the twelfth day nineteen people of Sallow Hatch had walked west, eleven of them in the last three nights.

The survivors tried everything the Fast knows. They roped themselves together at night, wrist to wrist, a whole household on one rope; one family woke to find their rope untied, coiled neatly by the door, and the youngest daughter gone, and a folded napkin on her pillow. They took turns at the hamlet bell and rang it every quarter hour all night, and the walkers walked through the ringing. They sent to Wanting for Tablebreakers, who came, and broke every table within three miles, and the walkers sat down at the broken ones, among the splinters, on the ground, and were found there in the morning, kneeling at nothing, smiling, and when the Breakers lifted them they screamed like kettles and died in the road within the hour, apologising.

On the thirteenth day the Abstinents ordered Sallow Hatch emptied. The remaining forty-one were walked into Wanting under escort, roped, with Hostwatch Trackers at either end of the string, and housed in the Lean End, and every one of them was put on the full list. Only two more walked west that winter. In the spring of 635, when the warm ground had drawn back from the Brindle road, the survivors were allowed home, and Sallow Hatch is a hamlet of forty-one again, on the Measure-Bearers' round, with every doorframe notched. The Hostwatch's verdict in the restricted ledger was a single line: *They went because the others were there.*

The nineteen of Sallow Hatch sit together now, at a long table in a water-meadow four miles west of the old hamlet, all on one side, all facing east, toward home. Crumb-Runners on the Brindle road can see them on clear evenings. They wave. They wave at every cart, every Bearer, every child. Their kin in Sallow Hatch do not go to visit them. Some of them, on still evenings, stand at the western edge of the hamlet and look, and do not wave back, and are fetched in by their neighbours, gently, by the elbow.

THE ONES LEFT BEHIND

The Fast has no rite for a walker. You cannot bury a guest who has not left, and you cannot mourn someone who is calling to you. Families of walkers are not shunned, exactly, but they are watched, the way a house is watched where there has been a fever. Neighbours take turns to sit with them at night. Their axes are taken down from beside the door and kept by someone else, because an axe is for breaking tables and a grieving person may want to go and break the one their mother is sitting at, and that is the surest road west there is. Their names are moved, quietly, up the list. That is the only kindness the Abstinents have, and they use it.

There is a custom, unsanctioned and widespread, in the Lean End and the poorer stands: the family of a walker cuts a notch in the frame of the door through which they went, at the height of the walker's heart. Some doorframes in the Lean End have six or seven notches, at different heights, the last ones small. Cease Abbot, who keeps the bell-rope at the Lean End, says he can tell a house that will lose someone else by whether the notches have been painted over.



Hers was the bell I rang. All night, every quarter. She walked past me in the dark, she touched my arm going by. She said, You're doing ever so well.

A BELL-RINGER OF SALLOW HATCH, 633

RUNNING WALKING WEST

Walking West is the Fast's form of the Despair rules in the Rules chapter, and it is the hardest thing in this chapter to run well. Run it as tragedy. Never describe sitting down as a release or a relief, and never make it look like an answer: describe the table from the outside, the waving, the grief of the ones on the verge, the notch in the doorframe. **Contagion:** when an NPC or PC the community knows walks west, every Unfed of that household or stand at Fray 5 or more makes a Dread 2 check; on a failure they gain the Pull as a temporary Derangement for a season, triggered by the sight or smell of the warm ground. A PC who has been to the far verge to visit a walker raises the Difficulty of their next Invitation check by +2. **Holding on:** companions may stop a walking PC with a rope, a grip (opposed Gut + Brawl), or a reason (Tongue + Persuade, Hard 14, Grim 18 if the reason is not true). Let the players offer reasons. The best ones are small: a promise to show someone the sprout in Hartsell's Field, an unfinished argument, a debt. A PC who walks west and reaches a table is Seated, as described under Invitation Checks, and their companions make a Dread 4 check. Give the grief time at the table, out of character as well as in it. Check in with your players before and after.

▼ FACTIONS

THE ABSTINENT

Who they are. The council of elders who hold the Pantry, and with it the life of every Unfed. They are old, thin, and cold, and they speak slowly to save breath. They meet standing, in a bare stone room on the top floor of the Pantry, around an empty space where a table would be.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Measure-Bearer	Carries rations to outlying hamlets; a full measure on duty days.
2	Pantry Clerk	Reads and copies the ledgers; may witness the weighing.
3	Lister	Proposes names for the daily list; a key to the lower stores.
4	Elder of the Abstinents	A voice in council; one of the three keys may be entrusted to them.
5	Chair of the Abstinents	Holds the last key and the Company contract; strikes names alone.

Joining. A PC of good family who has never been seen to enjoy a meal may be taken on as a Measure-Bearer. Advancement requires Clause or Reckoning, a reputation for refusal, and the willingness to read the list aloud without a change in voice. **Enemies:** the Reckoners (whom they need), Wont Bellamy's circle, poachers. **Allies:** the Keepers of every village, the Rim Road Company, uneasily.



They meet standing. They have met standing for six hundred years. Ask yourself what one of them would give to sit.

WONT BELLAMY, IN A LETTER TO SATED

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Carrier	Bears the band's food and water on a raid; a full measure.
2	Knife	Enters the house; a Reckoner blade, black-iron, unadorned.
3	Kin-Reader	Holds the stolen genealogies; plans which beds, in what order.
4	Band-Captain	Leads a raid; chooses the line; may call on safehouses on the Rim.
5	Reckoner-Captain	Sets the season's lines; a seat (unofficial) at the Abstinents' door.

Joining. Volunteer at Wanting's west gate on the first day of Carving. A recruit is taken on one raid as a Carrier and watched at the bedsides. Those who look away are sent home. Those who do not are given a knife. **Enemies:** every High Cut house, the Cutwrights' College (whose ledgers they steal), the Netwatch, the

Beliefs and wants. The Refusal was the one clean act in the history of the world, and the Unfed exist to keep it clean. Survival matters less than purity; the Pantry exists not to feed the Fast but to keep it from accepting. The Abstinents want to outlast the Godeaters, and they want, more quietly than they would admit, to never be asked who decides the list.

THE RECKONERS

Who they are. Raiders, assassins, and zealots who carry the Refusal across the border on a blade. They travel in bands of five to twenty, on foot, carrying their own food, and they strike at the highest Cuts of the Godeater lands in their own beds. They are the Fast's only export.

Beliefs and wants. Refusing was not enough. The Godeaters ate their gods and the gods are coming back through their blood; therefore the blood must be ended. Not punished: ended. A Reckoner raid is not a murder but a weeding, and it is incomplete unless the whole kin-line dies, from the grandmother in the bed to the infant in the cradle to the cousin at university in another city. They want every High Cut line on the Table extinct before the Seating, and they believe they are saving the world, which makes them terribly calm.

Wakers, the Second Table. **Allies:** the Purgation (warily), some of the Thin of the Fatlands.

THE BEDSIDE

Reckoners kill at night, indoors, quietly, with knives. They enter through servants' doors, kitchens, coal-holes. They never eat anything in the houses they enter, never drink, never sit, never touch a table. They work through a household by the kin-reader's list, in an order planned weeks before: eldest first, because the eldest are furthest along and most dangerous; then the heirs; then the rest. The worst of it, for those who have done it and come home, is not the blood. It is the beds. High Cut beds are rich and soft and warm, and smell of good food digested, and the people in them are well fed and sleep deeply, and an Unfed Knife standing over one of them in the dark, starved, stiff with cold from three nights on the road, feels something in his chest that is not righteousness. Reckoners have a phrase for it: *bedside hunger*. Some of them come home and cannot stop thinking about the beds. Some come home and cannot stop thinking about the nursery. The band-captains watch for both.

A HOUSE, ROOM BY ROOM

The Reckoners' own chronicle is terse to the point of cruelty, and their raids are recorded in it in a single line each: house, town, date, *the line was ended*. What a raid is like comes down only in what the Knives say afterward, to Forswear Tallow on Knife Row, who asks every one of them the same question, and to Dr. Mercy Thrane, who has asked a few.

It is warm. That is what all of them say first. A High Cut house in Sated or Lastgate or the Vigil in Lack is warmer than anywhere a Knife has ever been, and the warmth hits a starved Unfed coming in from three nights on the road like a blow to the chest, so that some of them stand gasping in the scullery and cannot move for a full minute. It smells of food. Not a table, but the ghost of a hundred thousand meals soaked into the panelling: roast fat, wine, wax, baking, the sweet heavy breath of a house where nobody has ever been hungry. The floors are soft with carpet. The Knives go up the servants' stair in stocking feet, carrying their boots, and the stair is warm under their soles, and they can hear the house sleeping: the slow, deep, wet breathing of big well-fed bodies, heavy snores, a dog sighing by a banked fire.

High Cut sleepers are hard to kill. They are big, and the god in them does not want to go. A Fatlands Gut-line matriarch in the Course is swollen with soft, cool, loam-dark flesh that gives under the blade like turned earth, and the knife must go deep; she wakes, and she is strong, and she bellows, and the bed is a feather-mattress three feet thick that swallows the Knife's knees. The blood of a well-fed body comes thick and dark and fast, hot, smelling of iron and of something richer underneath, like the drippings from a joint, and it soaks into the feather-ticking and wells up again around the Knife's hands, and does not stop for a long time. In the Vigil the Eye-lines sleep with their eyes open and watch the knife come. In Sallowreach the old Hand-lines cannot be killed at all, and the Reckoners must carry them, wrapped in their own sheets, out over the border, where

they finish; the Knives say those are the worst nights, because the old dead talk to them the whole way, politely, about the weather.

The servants are not touched. They are woken, sometimes, by the noise, and come to doors in their nightgowns with candles, and see what they see, and the Knives look at them and say the Decline, *no, thank you*, three times, softly, which means *go back to bed*, and most of them do. It is the servants who find the house in the morning. Many of them are Scraplings, low-Cut, and some of them, the Reckoners have come to understand, are glad.

The nursery is last. The chronicle gives it the same line it gives everything else. So will this book. The band-captains choose who goes into it, and they choose the ones who have done it before, and afterward they watch those Knives for a long time.

Order of Beds, written by a Kin-Reader for a band of eleven, for a house of the Gut-lines in Sated, Carving 639. Found sewn into the lining of a Carrier's coat after the band came home ten. The house's name is cut out of the page.

Ground floor: none of the line. Cook, two scullions, boot-boy. Pass.

First floor, east: the Matriarch, 81, Laden (green shoots behind the knees; the bed is warm; she will try to root to the floor, so take her before her feet are bare). Band-Captain and two Knives. The Laying-Out.

First floor, west: the heir, 54, Appetite, and his wife, 50, of the line by her mother. Two Knives each. He keeps a crossbow by the bed. Take it first.

Second floor: the heir's sons, 29 and 26, Taste; the younger is the one who visits the cook. Two Knives.

Second floor, end: the heir's daughter, 24, Appetite, with child (seven months; the Cutwrights have her down for a Prime Cut child). Band-Captain decides. It is decided.

Third floor: the nursery. Two children, 4 and 2, and the wet-nurse (not of the line; pass). The two who did the nursery at the Marrable house.

Not in the house: a married-out daughter, 33, in Low Tilt; a cousin at the College in the Vigil, 19. Second band, Lack. A bastard son of the heir's, 12, at a drover's in Callock Green. I have him on the list. Do not argue with me about the list.

Carry nothing out. Eat nothing. Drink nothing. Sit on nothing. Touch no table but hers.

THE LAYING-OUT

The eldest of a line is not killed in bed. Since the first raid on the Brawne house in 402, Reckoner bands have carried the eldest of every High Cut line they end down to the house's own dining table, and laid them on it on their back, with their hands at their sides, as

Orrum lay on Hallowboard. The Reckoners call this the Laying-Out. It is the only rite they have, and it is the nearest thing in the Fast to a human sacrifice, though every Reckoner would spit at the word.

The band stands around the table. They stand on every side but one. Nobody remembers why one side is left empty; the old Knives say it is because the eldest’s own kin will never stand there now, and the young Knives accept this, and the band-captains, who have stood at many Layings-Out, will not discuss it and do not look at that side of the table. The matriarch or patriarch lies on the polished wood among the candlesticks and the silver épergne and the bowl of hothouse fruit, enormous, in a nightgown, often bleeding already from the struggle on the stair. They always talk. They threaten, then they bargain, and then, every time, without exception, they offer food. It is the deepest instinct of the High Cuts, the Knives say; a Laden matriarch with a knife at her throat will tell you there is a ham in the larder and a cold goose and a Brinehollow cheese, and to eat, eat, you poor starved things, look at you, and she means it, and it is the most obscene thing the Knives have ever heard.

The band says the Decline over them. *No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you.* Softly, together, as the hill said it. Then the band-captain opens their throat, and the band stands and watches as the eldest bleeds out onto their own table, and nobody touches them, and nobody looks away. The blood runs to the table’s edge and over it and drips onto the carpet with a sound the Knives say they hear for years, and it pools in the dishes, and runs among the

fruit. It takes longer than outsiders imagine. The band waits until it is over. Then the band-captain lays a clean white plate at the head of the table, upside down, and a folded napkin beside it, and they leave. The Reckoners do not believe in gods. The rite is not for anyone. It is only to say, in a language the High Cuts will understand: *we were offered, and we did not eat.*

The servants who find the eldest in the morning, laid on the table with the plate at their head, are the source of every Rim story about the Reckoners. In the Fatlands the plate is called the *Unfed’s bill*.



She asked if we’d like some cake first. With her throat open she asked. I can’t eat cake now. I couldn’t before; there wasn’t any. But I mean I can’t now.

A RECKONER CARRIER, TO FORSWEAR TALLOW, 638

THE TABLEBREAKERS

Who they are. Bands of three to six who hunt Orrum’s tables and smash them with axes before anyone can sit. Dangerous, honoured, and short-lived work. They wear wax in their ears, linen bound over their noses and mouths, and blindfolds of loose gauze they can see through dimly, so that the food will be a blur.

Beliefs and wants. Every table is a trap, and every trap broken is a life saved. They do not hate Orrum; most of them, privately, pity it. They want one season without a Seating.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Sniffer	Walks ahead, finds tables by smell; a full measure while hunting.
2	Axe	Breaks tables; an axe blessed on the Barrows.
3	Rope-Holder	Holds the tether that pulls an Axe back from a chair; trusted.
4	Breaker	Leads a band; may claim any Unfed household’s axe in emergency.
5	Old Breaker	Over a hundred tables; their name is spoken on Tablenight.

Joining. Break a table alone and bring back a splinter. **Enemies:** the Seated (who call out), the Second Helping pilgrims, Verger Osmond. **Allies:** the Hostwatch, who tell them where to go.



Lamp, plates, legs, top, chairs. Chairs last. Every chair. Every one.

DECLINE MARSH, TEACHING A NEW AXE

THE CRUMB-RUNNERS

Who they are. Smugglers and carters who bring food in from the Rim by night, on foot and by ox-cart, by the old drove roads. Despised in every street of Wanting, spat on, served last, and the only reason anyone is alive. The Pantry buys most of what they carry. The rest they sell privately, at prices that would shame a Fatlands usurer.

Beliefs and wants. Mostly, to be paid, and to be thanked once before they die. Many Crumb-Runners have been on the road so long that they have eaten nothing but their own wages in years. They are the most practical people in the Fast and the least pious, and they have seen more of Orrum than anyone but the Hostwatch.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Back	Carries a sack; paid in food, which is worth more than coin.
2	Drover	Drives a cart; may buy at the Cross on credit.
3	Counter	Keeps a cart's tally; trusted with the Pantry's money.
4	Road-Master	Owens carts and oxen; holds a standing Company permit.
5	Grain-Lord	Controls a road; the Abstinents must bargain with them.

Joining. Turn up at Brindle Cross with a strong back and no family. **Enemies:** poachers, Rim toll-sharks, the Abstinents' clerks. **Allies:** Company factors, the Hostwatch, anyone hungry.

◆
Eleven sacks oat, four sacks pease. Same. Good.

THE COMMONEST ENTRY IN ANY CRUMB-RUNNER'S
COMMONPLACE BOOK

THE STARVED SAINTS

Who they are. Ascetics who have stopped eating altogether. Most die in the second month, in the open, in silence, attended by others who will soon follow. A few have kept it up far longer than a body can. They live in the open fields, sitting in the cold, saying the Decline at every sound.

Beliefs and wants. Every mouthful is a small acceptance, even Rim food, even the Pantry's. Perfect refusal is perfect cleanness. The Saints want to be the first Unfed to want nothing at all. The Abstinents revere them publicly and dread them privately, because each Saint is one less name to feed and one more reproach.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Novice	Fasts three days in seven; tended by the order.
2	Abstainer	Fasts entirely; is no longer on the Pantry list, by choice.
3	Watcher	Tends the dying Abstainers; reads their last refusals.
4	Saint	Has outlived nature; pilgrims come to touch their robes.
5	Unfed	(Title held by no living person; reserved.)

Joining. Ask, three times, and be refused, and ask a fourth. The order does not proselytise, because that would be an offer. **Enemies:** none admitted. **Allies:** the Abstinents, publicly. *The order's grief is real.* For every Saint there are dozens of young Unfed who have walked out into the fields after them, and the Watchers' book of the dead is long. Families of the order's novices come to the fields to plead, and stand at a distance, because to offer food would be an insult. Many of them stand there until the end.

◆
Watcher, she said, there's honey on my lip. I said no, Sister, it's only the cold. I have said worse things. Not many.

A NOVICE OF SAINTS' ACRE

THE HOSTWATCH

Who they are. Trackers, mapmakers, and scholars who follow the god at a distance and mark where it has been. They read warm ground, melted frost, the bend of grass, the smell on the air, and they keep the Great Map of the Fast in the cellar of the Pantry, a single sheet of linen thirty feet square, pricked with ten thousand pins.

Beliefs and wants. To understand. The Hostwatch are the only Unfed who think of Orrum as something other than a trap, and the deepest of them have come to love it, distantly, the way you might love a dangerous animal you have watched all your life. They want to know where it is going. Lately they want, very badly, to know who the extra chair is for.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Pin-Setter	Copies reports onto the Great Map; a full measure in the field.
2	Tracker	Follows warm ground alone; may requisition rope and lamps.
3	Mile-Walker	Trails the god at a mile; a Hostwatch brass compass.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
4	Cartographer	Reads the Great Map; sees the restricted ledgers.
5	Warden of the Map	Sets the Watch's questions; reports directly to the Chair.

Joining. Find warm ground before a Tracker does and report it. **Enemies:** those who want the map kept secret, and those who want it sold. **Allies:** the Tablebreakers, Crumb-Runners, Verger Osmond (privately).

It walks straight, mostly. When it doesn't, it's going round something. We've learned not to ask what.

A HOSTWATCH TRACKER

GODEATER FACTIONS IN THE FAST

The Second Table's agents work through Wont Bellamy. The Purgation sends fasting-masters to learn from the Starved Saints, and are disappointed. The Cutwrights' College has never been able to enter the Fast to audit it, and pays Kale Dragoman's poachers handsomely for "specimens of the Zero line." The Rim Road Company owns the debt. The Second Helping of the Fatlands sends pilgrims.

▼ THE FAST NOW

Orrum is leaving. For six hundred years the god kept to the Fast, laying tables for a people who would not come. Now its tables have turned up in three other lands, and the Hostwatch report it walking the Rim Road at night, stooping to look in at inn windows. Every week Spare Tolland pins it a little further from Hallowboard. Every week the extra chair is there.

Pilgrims from the starving Fatlands are crossing in to find it. Osanna Blythe's three hundred are the first column; there are rumours of thousands behind them. Marshal Keep Aldane holds Brindle Cross with sixty men against a tide of people who are not trying to hurt anyone, only to sit down.

The Pantry is short. There are four months of grain for six months of winter, and the Rim Road Company has not explained why the autumn deliveries came light. Mother Stint Avery has already decided which villages. Forbear Wend has not yet signed.

A farmer has grown a single green sprout in dead soil. A Saint is being fed by something. A child came home plump. And Meek Garrity's papers, copied by hand and passed from house to house in Wanting at night, say the worst thing the Unfed have ever heard: that their ancestors never refused. They were only late, and the others had left them nothing.

Four months of grain. Six of winter. I can do it to the day. I cannot do it to the name.

MOTHER STINT AVERY

ADVENTURE HOOKS

◆ **The Light Cargo.** Tarry Moss hires the PCs to guard a grain run from Brindle Cross. Halfway in, his count is wrong by one sack,

and then by two, and the missing sacks are found laid out on a table in a farmhouse, ground into bread. Someone in the party has been accepting on the road, and the god is returning the favour.

- ◆ **The List.** A PC's name, or a beloved NPC's, is left off the Pantry list. Was it Stint Avery's arithmetic, Forbear Wend's conscience, or a forged entry by someone who sells the omitted to Kale Dragoman? The Lean House is filling. Abide Kettering's cart is coming more often.
- ◆ **The Brawne Precedent.** Scant Hollis is planning a raid into Sated to end a Gut-line, and a PC is the kin-reader. Scarce Odell's genealogy has a cousin who lives in Wanting, an Unfed foundling who does not know her blood. Is she on the list?
- ◆ **The Place Card.** A PC finds a place card with their name on it, in the handwriting of their dead mother. Every night thereafter another table, closer. Welcome Ardent can explain, if they can catch him, and he can offer a way out that is worse than the table.
- ◆ **The Sprout.** Someone is watering Yield Hartsell's wheat. The Abstinent want it burned. The Hostwatch want it watched. The Second Table wants it stolen. The pilgrims want to kneel to it.
- ◆ **The Tenth Stone.** One morning there are ten Portion Stones on the sheep-walk west of Wanting. The new one is warm, and the turf around it has been tamped by careful hands. Someone in Wanting has been chosen. The PCs have until the end of Carving to find out by whom, and for whom, and whether Wont Bellamy's circle has revived Meagre Holt's sermon with a Second Table twist.
- ◆ **The Notched Door.** Sallow Hatch has lost a twentieth walker eight years after the first nineteen, and two more doorframes in the hamlet have fresh notches. Withy Gaunt asks the PCs to sit nights in the hamlet before it becomes a second Walking. The

walkers at the water-meadow table are waving harder. One of them is calling a PC by name.

- ◇ **Order of Beds.** A Kin-Reader's Order of Beds is found sewn in a dead Carrier's coat, and the bastard son at the bottom of it, twelve and living at a drover's in Callock Green, has been seen in the Fast. He has come to find his mother. She is in Wanting, and she is on Stint Avery's list.

RUMOURS OF THE FAST

DIO	RUMOUR
1	Forbear Wend has a private store in the Pantry and eats at night. (False. He has a private ledger, of the dead.)
2	The Seated at the head of the Long Table have started to stand up. (True, for one minute, at midnight, all together.)
3	Lent Ashby is Orrum's daughter. (False. But she is the only guest it ever let go, and it has not stopped asking her back.)
4	The Company deliberately shorted the grain so the Fast would sell its people. (Partly true. See Factor Mardle.)
5	A Reckoner came home from Sallowreach and is still walking around, Kept. (False. Kept do not cross borders. But one came home with grey hands.)
6	Eating Fast-flour from Ash Mill makes a Fatlander full forever. (True, for an hour. Then they walk west.)
7	Hallowboard was laid for eight, not seven. (Nobody will confirm or deny it.)
8	The Starved Saints are fed by angels. (False. They are fed by the Host.)
9	Envoy Lowell has defected to the Vigil. (False. She has no friends there either.)
10	Welcome Ardent can be relieved, if someone takes his place. (True.)

THE PEOPLE OF THE FAST

Count your chairs.

– WANTING PROVERB

ELDER FORBEAR WEND, CHAIR OF THE ABSTINENT

Eighty-six, and so thin he is carried through Wanting in a plain ash chair by two boys of the Measure-Bearers, his knees under a blanket and his hands folded on the iron key that hangs from his neck. His skull is a lamp-shade of yellow skin. His voice is soft, dry, perfectly clear, and he never raises it; he does not have the breath. He smells of camphor and old paper and the pear-drop sourness of a body eating itself. He holds the last key to the Pantry and the Company contract, and he has starved eleven people by leaving their names off a list. He prays for each of them by name, every night, standing,

which takes him a long time, since he must be held up. He fears dying before the winter list is signed, because then Stint Avery will sign it, and she will not pray. **Secret:** one of the eleven was his own daughter, Lenten, nine years old, in the Short of 589, when he was a young Lister; it was not his list, but he carried the measure past her door. **Meeting the PCs:** he summons them to carry a list to an outlying hamlet, unread.



I say their names standing. I have to be held up. It takes most of an hour now. It ought to take longer.

ELDER FORBEAR WEND

ELDER FORBEAR WEND – CHAIR OF THE ABSTINENT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5
CUT & REFUSAL	Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 8 · Pangs 6 (Gaunt)
SKILLS	Resolve 5, Clause 4, Reckoning 4, Persuade 3, Endure 3, Lore 3
BODY	Flesh 12 (10 at Gaunt) · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	none worth the name; his bearers carry cudgels +4 (3)
GIFTS	The List (any Unfed in the Fast whose name he strikes loses their ration; this is not magic, and is worse). The Old No (spends Want as a PC does; has never failed an Invitation check).
WANTS	To sign the winter list before he dies. To be forgiven by someone who has the standing.
DREAD	1 (to watch him read the list)
SECRET	He knows the Company’s contract clause on “first refusal” of the Unfed dead, and has said nothing.

RECKONER-CAPTAIN SCANT HOLLIS

A tall woman of forty-four, built of knots and cords, her hair cropped to the skull, her face burned dark by forty raids’ worth of Rim weather. She wears undyed wool and soft boots and carries a single black-iron knife with no guard, the handle wrapped in ration-

cloth. She speaks little, flatly, and looks at people the way a farmer looks at a field: what grows here, and should it. She has ended nine high-Cut bloodlines in their beds, from matriarchs to cradles. She keeps no trophies, because a trophy is a want. She says she is not a murderer, since what she kills stopped being people generations ago, and she says it as a plain fact, like the weather. She fears, truly fears, only one thing: bedside hunger. On the Marrable raid she stood over a sleeping Gut-line child for a full minute, and what she felt

was not mercy. **Meeting the PCs:** she recruits them; she needs Carriers with steady stomachs.

SCANT HOLLIS – RECKONER-CAPTAIN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4
CUT & REFUSAL	Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 7 · Pangs 3 (Hollow)
SKILLS	Blades 5, Stealth 5, Endure 4, Resolve 4, Wayfaring 3, Search 3, Intimidate 2
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 19 · Armor 1 (padded wool) · Fray 6
ATTACKS	black-iron long knife +9 (3); bare hands +5 (1)
GIFTS	Bedside Silence (the first attack she makes on a sleeping target is automatically a Grace). Godless Blood (godsign that reads, finds, or tastes the blood cannot find hers; Sallowreach Closers, Brinehollow tides and Oathen bindings work only through ordinary means).
WANTS	Every High Cut line on the Table ended before the Seating. To never again stand still beside a cradle.
DREAD	2 (to see her work a household, room by room)
SECRET	Her mother was taken by poachers when Scant was six; she has crossed the Rim forty times, and every time she has looked for a woman with no godsign working as a servant in a High Cut house.

LENT ASHBY, THE INVITED

Twenty-three, small, colourless as skimmed milk, with very pale eyes and a habit of tilting her head as though listening to a dinner conversation in the next room. At nine she sat down at one of Orrum’s tables. At ten, somehow, she got up. She is the only one who ever has. She does not remember why; she remembers only that the food was perfect and that the host was crying. She cannot taste anything now: Pantry oats and Rim honey and her own blood are all the same grey nothing on her tongue. Wherever she sleeps, a table is found laid in the morning, set for one, her name on the card. The

Abstinent keep her moving, a night here, a night there, followed by a Tablebreaker with an axe. Children are not allowed near her. She is very lonely. She is beginning to think the host was crying for her. **Meeting the PCs:** they are assigned to escort her for a week, and wake to the table.

◇

It was perfect. And it was crying. I don’t know which I think about more.

LENT ASHBY

LENT ASHBY – THE INVITED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5
CUT & REFUSAL	Cut 0 (Unfed, and something else) · Want 10, always · Pangs 2
SKILLS	Resolve 4, Instinct 4, Endure 3, Rites 2, Stealth 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 5
ATTACKS	none
GIFTS	The Guest Who Left (cannot be Seated; she automatically succeeds at any Invitation check, but anyone sleeping within a stone’s throw of her must make one each dawn). Tasteless (immune to any poison, drug, or godsign that works through taste or smell, including Fatlands meat).
WANTS	To be told why she was let go. To taste one thing before she dies.
DREAD	3 (to wake beside her laid table)
SECRET	The card at her table has changed. For thirteen years it said <i>Lent</i> . This month it says <i>Steward</i> .

TARRY MOSS, CRUMB-RUNNER

Fifty-three, broad-backed and bandy, with a bitten hand that has never healed straight, a beard like a hedge, and wax plugs in both

nostrils that make him breathe through his mouth with a slight whistle. He hauls grain in from the Rim by night, ox-cart and sack, and is spat on in the street by the people it feeds. He has never eaten a mouthful of his own cargo. He counts it, daily, down to the bean, in charcoal on the backs of Pantry manifests, and the counts have

lately begun to come out over: one bean more, a handful of oats more, a sack he did not load. He fears the extra more than he ever feared a shortfall. His boy Stint is in the Lean House now, not omitted, only not eating: he will not eat anything Tarry carries, because it is not what he smelled. **Meeting the PCs:** he hires them as guards; he pays in food.

SISTER NAY CORLISS, STARVED SAINT

She sits on a hurdle in an open field south of Wanting, wrapped in sacking, with her knees drawn up and her hands folded on them, and has not eaten in three years. She should have died in the first two months. She is translucent: the light of a lamp held behind her hand shows the bones like twigs in amber. Her lips are cracked into deep red seams; her tongue is grey; her breath, when she speaks the Decline, is so faint it barely stirs a feather. Pilgrims come to touch her robe. She does not know she is a miracle of the wrong kind: each morning she wakes with crumbs on her lips, and the novice who

wipes them away has never told her. The novice has started to save them, in a twist of cloth. **Secret:** the crumbs are honey-cake, the cake of Nay’s childhood, made the way her dead mother made it. **Meeting the PCs:** they are sent to watch her sleep and see who feeds her.

DECLINE MARSH, TABLEBREAKER

A big, slope-shouldered man of thirty-eight with forearms like hams, a voice ruined by shouting through gauze, and the steadiest hands in the Fast. He has put an axe through four hundred tables. He breaks them in a set order: lamp, plates, legs, top, chairs last, every chair. He does not look at the food. On the four hundred and first there was a card at one place with his name on it, and the handwriting was his mother’s, who sat at a table when he was four and was dragged from it at his father’s insistence and died on the doorstep, apologising. He broke that table too. He has broken nine since. He has not slept indoors since, because he keeps finding the card again in his own coat pocket, and his mother’s handwriting has started to say other things.

DECLINE MARSH – TABLEBREAKER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 1 · Caul 3
CUT & REFUSAL	Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 5 · Pangs 2
SKILLS	Blades 4, Endure 4, Labor 4, Resolve 3, Search 3, Athletics 2
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (leather apron) · Fray 8
ATTACKS	Barrow-blessed axe +8 (4; ignores any warding of Orrum’s tables)
GIFTS	Four Hundred Tables (he breaks a laid table in a single action, and all within sight gain +2 on their next Invitation check).
WANTS	To break the table that is laid for his mother. To read the card, just once.
DREAD	1 (to watch him swing)
SECRET	The latest card says <i>Come home, love, I’ve kept it warm</i> , and gives a place on the Long Table he has never visited.

SPARE TOLLAND OF THE HOSTWATCH

Sixty, wiry, slow-moving, with a face weathered into deep pleated folds and bright, unblinking grey eyes. He wears a Hostwatch compass on a thong and a coat sewn all over with pockets for pins. He has spent thirty years following Orrum at a mile’s distance, mapping the warm ground, and he knows its gait, its pauses, the places it likes to stand at dusk. He has never seen its face. He has seen it stop and wait for him to catch up, and he has come to think it is lonely. He speaks of it the way an old farmer speaks of a neighbour’s dog that has been chained too long. He is afraid of nothing in the Fast but his own urge to close the mile. **Meeting the PCs:** he needs someone to hold the far end of his rope, because the gap has been shrinking, and he is not sure, any more, which of them is closing it.

WONT BELLAMY, HERETIC ELDER

A plump man, by Unfed standards, which is to say his ribs cannot be counted through his shirt, and the Abstinent never forget it. Fifty-five, soft-voiced, beautifully mannered, with clever dark eyes and a Rim-cut coat. He sits on the council by right of blood, the Bellamys having stood on the hill, and argues that the Refusal was only a postponement: the Unfed should do now what the others did then, and eat the god that is still whole. He has friends abroad, in the Second Table, who very much agree, and who send him letters sealed in wax pressed with a fork. He fears being found out by Scant Hollis. **Secret:** he has eaten, twice, at Second Table banquets in Sated; it was Fatlands pork, nothing godly, and he enjoyed it so much he wept, and he has told no one. **Meeting the PCs:** he offers them generous work carrying letters, and offers it only once.

MOTHER STINT AVERY, KEEPER OF THE PANTRY

Sixty-two, square, hard-handed, with a stone-mason's forearms and a clerk's ink-stained fingers. She wears an apron of oiled canvas and smells of sacking and mouse. She weighs out every ration in the Fast herself, on brass scales older than Wanting, and she has never once given anyone a grain extra. She knows there are four months of grain for six months of winter. She has already decided which villages: the furthest, the oldest, the ones with fewest children. She has not told Forbear Wend, because he will pray, and praying is a delay, and delay kills more. She is not cruel. She is the only person in the Fast who has done the arithmetic and not looked away from it, and that is a kind of hell. **Secret:** her own village, Avery Steading, is on the list. She has not told them. **Meeting the PCs:** she asks them to audit a Crumb-Runner's tally, and they find the Company's shortfall.

ABSTAIN ROOKE, CALLED ABBY

Eleven, bird-boned, curious, with a gap in her front teeth and a habit of asking why. Raised on the rules, she can recite them faster than anyone in her hamlet, and she has started leaving a crust on the windowsill at night, saved from her own three-quarter measure. Each morning it has been replaced with something better: a corner of white bread, a ripe plum, a sugared almond, a little honey-cake wrapped in a leaf. She has eaten none of it. She hides it under a loose floor-stone. The pile is getting large, and it does not rot, and it smells wonderful through the stone at night. She is not afraid. She thinks of it as a pen-friend. Her mother does not know; her mother is on Stint Avery's list. **Meeting the PCs:** Abby asks them, very seriously, if it counts as accepting if you are only keeping it for someone else.

BROTHER HALLOW CRUST, THE SEATED

He has sat at a table on the valley road for forty years, eating air with a silver fork. He was a stout man; now he is a draped coat with a head on it, the cheeks hollowed to the teeth, the eyes sunk into blue pits, the hair gone to a few white strands. He is perfectly happy and perfectly sane. He describes each course in detail, in a voice like dry leaves: the mutton with caper sauce, the eel pie, the syllabub with nutmeg grated over. He asks after your family. He remembers your answers. He cannot remember his own wife's name, but he remembers every dish he has been served since 601. People who listen too long pull out a chair. **Secret:** he was a Tablebreaker, and sat down deliberately, to see if he could get up. He has been meaning to, all forty years. **Meeting the PCs:** on the Long Table road; he calls them by name.



The syllabub tonight is very fine, with nutmeg grated over. You ought to have some. Do you know, I can't think of my wife's name. Isn't the nutmeg lovely?

BROTHER HALLOW CRUST, THE SEATED

DR. MERCY THRANE

A physician of starvation, forty-seven, gaunt and grey-eyed, with spectacles mended with wire and a satchel of scales, calipers, and notebooks. She measures the Unfed: arm circumference, the pinch of the skin, the colour of the gums, the slow pulse. She has written the only proper book on what hunger does to a body over a lifetime. She was the first to document the trade in Unfed bodies. She has traced her missing patients to surgeries in four countries, where blank blood and blank organs fetch a noble's ransom: Unfed kidneys sewn into Laden matriarchs, Unfed eyes into lidless Vigil heirs, Unfed hearts for Sallowreach Unvacated who want to feel one beat that is not Ossel's. She has a ledger of names and buyers. The trail leads to the Second Table. She fears she will not live to publish it. **Meeting the PCs:** she hires them to bring a body home.

THE BLANK-ORGAN TRADE

Godsign does not live in Unfed flesh. A kidney, liver, eye, length of gut, or pint of blood taken from one of the Unfed is, so far as any surgeon can tell, wholly clean, and when it is sewn into a Godeater it is the one part of that body the god does not grow into. For a few months, or a few years, the High Cut buyer has one organ that is only theirs. Laden matriarchs buy Unfed stomachs to feel, for a season, what it is to be full. Lidless Eye-lines buy Unfed eyes that can close. The price for a whole pair of Unfed kidneys in Sated is about 6,000 lacks; a heart in Lastgate, twice that. The organs are taken from the living where possible, because the Unfed die very quickly of the surgery and the buyers want the organ warm. Poachers keep their captives alive, and fed, for exactly that reason. Then the godsign of the buyer slowly grows into the new organ, as ivy grows into a wall, and in a few years they need another.

THE TRADE, ITEMISED

The Blank trade is not a black market in the way Rim smugglers' markets are. It is a luxury, and it behaves like one: discreet, referred, expensive, and very nearly respectable. It has surgeons of standing in four capitals, a vocabulary of polite words (an Unfed captive is a *lodger*, an organ is a *refitting*, a living Unfed kept for repeated cuttings is a *keeping-room guest*), and a clientele drawn almost entirely from the High Cuts, who have the money and the most god to escape. The best-known practitioner is Master Quillon Barr of Sated, a courteous, careful man who has read Dr. Mercy Thrane's book on starvation with genuine admiration and keeps his lodgers alive between cuttings for years, in rooms with no west windows, warm, fed by tube, some of them in brine-tanks to the neck in his

Lastgate house, where the cold of the fen keeps the cut flesh sweet. Several of his lodgers have begun, after years of it, to put on weight. Some of them have asked not to be taken home.

The prices below are those Dr. Thrane has recorded from bills of sale, the Red Ledger she keeps of her missing patients, and the confession of one poacher. They are what a buyer pays the surgeon. The poacher gets a tenth.

REFITTING	WANTED BY	PRICE (LACKS)	HOW LONG IT STAYS CLEAN
A pint of blank blood	Anyone dosing against their own Regrowth	150 to 300	A day in the body; a week of easier sleep
A blank eye	Lidless Eye-lines of the Vigil	3,000	A season or two; the first blink is weeping joy
Both kidneys, from the living	Laden matriarchs; Sallowreach Unvacated	6,000 to 9,000	Two to five years
A blank stomach	The Gut-lines, to feel full once	7,000	A season; they eat until it bursts
A blank heart	Hand-lines who want one beat that is not Ossel's	12,000	It beats for a year, then slows to Ossel's time
A blank womb	Caul-line women of Cradlewrack, for a child of no god	Never quoted; paid in land	One birth, if any
A whole lodger, kept	Any of the above, by subscription	40,000 and a yearly fee	As long as the lodger lives

The trade's dirtiest secret is the one Dr. Thrane has not yet been able to prove. Some of the buyers, she believes, are not trying to escape their gods at all. A man with a two-tined fork pinned inside his lapel has been buying children. They are not for refitting. A child of no god, raised from infancy in a closed house on nothing but one land's god-meat, would grow into an empty vessel filled with a single god and nothing else: no inheritance, no dilution, six centuries of bloodline skipped in one generation. What would grow in such a body is a question the Second Table has apparently decided to answer by experiment. Dr. Thrane has three addresses and no proof. Kale Dragoman has been asked, once, to deliver to one of them, and refused three times, and the fourth asking was very well paid.

A receipt, on good Sated paper with a deckle edge, found by Dr. Mercy Thrane in a surgery's waste-basket in 638. The client's name has been inked out. The surgeon's has not.

Received with thanks of the Honoured House of (inked out), the sum of eight thousand four hundred lacks, in platters, for: one refitting (renal, paired, warm), from a lodger of the Fast, female, about twenty-six years, of Brindle border stock, weighed on receipt at seven stone two pounds and brought by careful feeding to eight stone eleven before the procedure, at which weight the organs are at their best. Lodger did not survive refitting, as is usual with that stock, and has been returned to the supplier for disposal at no further charge. The Honoured House is reminded that refittings of this kind are not permanent, and that the god will find its way into the new

tissue in two to five years, and that Master Barr will be pleased to keep the Honoured House's name on his list for a further refitting at that time, at the same rate, supply permitting. Supply is presently good.

With every respect, Q. Barr.



They come in so thin. You have to be patient. You have to bring them up slowly, broth, then milk, or the heart gives. I learned that from a physician's book. She's very good.

KALE DRAGOMAN, TO A COMPANY TOLL-CLERK

KALE DRAGOMAN, THE POACHER

A Fatlander of thirty-five, broad, ruddy, and handsome in the Fatlands way, with heavy jowls, beautiful teeth, and a laugh that rolls. He smells of woodsmoke and roast fat, always, because he cooks. He hunts the Unfed for the Blank trade and takes them alive with net and cosh, and he feeds them well on the road: stews, roast fowl, soft white bread, honey, warm milk. He coaxes, he spoon-feeds, he holds their heads. Half his captives refuse and starve before they reach the buyers. The others eat, and weep, and arrive at the surgeries plump and healthy and full of self-loathing. That is the part his captives find hardest to forgive. He thinks he is kind. He is, by Fatlands lights. **Meeting the PCs:** across a campfire on the Rim, offering them supper. Three times.

KALE DRAGOMAN – THE POACHER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Wayfaring 4, Feast 4, Brawl 3, Shooting 3, Persuade 3, Stitching 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 (boiled leather) · Fray 3
ATTACKS	weighted cosh +6 (3; damage may be taken as stun); throwing net +6 (target is held, Lung + Athletics Hard 14 to escape); crossbow +6 (4)
GIFTS	He may Partake as any Fatlander of his Cut. The Kind Spoon (once per day, offers food with such warmth that an Unfed who hears him must spend 1 Want or make an Invitation check at Hard 14).
WANTS	He eats constantly, and grows uneasy if he cannot see food. He wants someone to thank him.
DREAD	1 (to see a captive eat)
SECRET	He was born in the Fast, of an Unfed mother who sold him to a Fatlands drover as an infant for a sack of oats. He does not know this. His kidneys are worth a fortune.

ENVOY PRUDENCE LOWELL

Fifty, thin as a lath, in a high-collared black coat buttoned to the throat, with a voice like a cold chisel. She is the Fast's one ambassador, posted to a hired room above a chandler's on the Rim Road, and her entire brief is to remind six nations that they are damned and her people are not. She attends every treaty-sitting and every Company congress, refuses every refreshment three times, and then reads aloud, in perfect Table-speech, the latest numbers of their Regrowth. She is very good at it. She has no friends. She has eaten alone, standing, facing a wall, in fourteen capitals. **Secret:** a Vigil envoy once offered her a fourth time, sincerely, and she very nearly accepted; she has dreamed of his face every night since. **Meeting the PCs:** she needs Unfed escorts, and she needs, though she would never say so, someone to talk to.

SCOUR, THE RETURNED

A Reckoner of thirty, lean and fox-faced, sleeves always buttoned to the knuckle. He spent a year undercover in the Fatlands as a renderer's labourer to scout a Gut-line house, and had to eat to keep his cover. He ate their meat for a year. He came home with godsign. Under his sleeves the skin of his forearms has gone soft, warm, and faintly loamy, like turned earth; there are fine pale threads in it, like root-hairs. He is hungry in a way no Unfed has ever been hungry: a hunger that has nothing to do with the belly. He hides it under his sleeves and volunteers for every raid, because on a raid he can carry his own food and refuse it, and because he wants to die doing something clean. **Meeting the PCs:** on a raid, when a PC sees him, alone, eating dirt from a Fatlands field.

SCOUR – THE RETURNED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 1 (Ummer, acquired) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste, advancing) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Blades 4, Brawl 3, Stealth 3, Endure 3, Deceive 3, Resolve 2
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	black-iron knife +8 (2); bite +5 (1, and he must make a Want check not to swallow)
GIFTS	Partakes as a Fatlander of Cut 1; his Tooth bites back on a 1 or 2, not just a 1 (the Empty Room, see Playing the Unfed).
WANTS	Eating without choosing; soil, tallow, leather. Lately, at the bedside, the sleeping.
DREAD	2 (to see his forearms)
SECRET	The god in him has begun to talk, in the voice of the Gut-line matriarch he killed on his first raid.

VERGER SOBER OSMOND

Seventy-nine, stooped, with soft white hair, a sweet vague smile, and a long black cassock gone green at the seams. He keeps the Empty Chair, the last temple of Orrum, alone. Every night he lays one place

at the head of the long table, against all law, with the old temple plate: pewter platter, horn cup, a linen napkin folded into the shape of a bird. He lays nothing on it. Every morning the plate is clean, wiped, still faintly warm. He believes this is why the god has stayed gentle: someone has kept faith with it. He is not wrong. He fears

dying, because no one will lay the place. **Secret:** for the past month the morning plate has not been clean. It has had a single crumb on it, as though someone had eaten and, being a well-mannered guest, left a little. **Meeting the PCs:** he asks one of them to stay and learn the duty.

YIELD HARTSELL, THE FARMER

Seventy, wiry and bowlegged, brown as a nut, with the cracked thumbs and quiet humour of a woman who has spent fifty years doing something useless because someone should. She has planted the dead soil of her family's ten acres every spring since she was twenty. This year one seed came up. She has built a fence around it and told no one, because she does not know who watered it. She sits up with it at night, with a lantern and a hayfork. Each morning the soil around the blade is wet, and there are no footprints, but the frost around the field is melted in a wide ring, as though something large had knelt there. She is more frightened than she has ever been, and happier. **Meeting the PCs:** she asks them to sit up with the wheat, and to see what comes, and not to hurt it.

LITTLE FAIN

An orphan of six, small and sturdy, with curly hair and dimpled hands: dimpled, in the Fast. Fain went missing for a week and came back plump, clean, rosy, and happy, with a ribbon in their hair and the smell of warm milk on their breath. Someone had said "Come in," and Fain had. Fain will not say who cooked, only that they cried when it was time to go, and that there was a big kitchen and a fire and lots of chairs but most of them were empty. The Abstinents do not know what to do. Fain cannot be Seated; Fain got up. The other children follow Fain about. The adults will not touch Fain. **Secret:** Fain was not let go. Fain was sent, and Fain is supposed to bring someone back. **Meeting the PCs:** Fain takes a PC's hand in the street and says, "You can come too."



There was a big kitchen and lots of chairs and most of them were empty. They cried when I had to go. You can come too.

LITTLE FAIN

MARSHAL KEEP ALDANE

A heavy-boned man of fifty with a broken nose and an old crossbow wound in the thigh, commanding sixty Unfed spearmen at Brindle Cross. He holds the border against poachers coming in, and, lately, against pilgrims: starving Fatlanders who have heard that somewhere in the Fast there is a table where you finally feel full. He was trained to kill poachers. He was not trained for three hundred hungry people kneeling in the mud of the toll-road, begging him to let them in so they can sit down and die happy. He has turned back

nine hundred. He has started to wonder why he is doing it, and what right an Unfed has to refuse anyone a meal. **Meeting the PCs:** he needs men; or he arrests them as poachers.

BRINDLE CROSS SPEARMAN Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 ·
Attack +5 (spear 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

OSANNA BLYTHE, THE PILGRIM

A Fatlands woman of forty, enormous by Unfed standards and gaunt by her own, her skin hanging in folds from a body that has been ravenous every second of her life. Her eyes are bright, her voice is warm and rolling, and she laughs often, a great hungry laugh. She is leading three hundred like her into the Fast to find the Host and sit down. She knows what happens to the Seated. She thinks it sounds wonderful: to be full, finally, for decades, smiling, among friends. She has an Unfed name sewn on her coat, given her by a Tablebreaker who could not bring himself to stop her. Her pilgrims are dying on the road, and the Unfed do not feed them, because that would be hospitality. **Meeting the PCs:** she asks them for directions. She is very polite about it. She asks three times.

MEEK GARRITY, THE HISTORIAN

A small, round-shouldered man of sixty-six, ink to the elbows, with thick spectacles, a voice barely above a whisper, and the long bloodless fingers of a lifelong copyist. He has spent forty years in the oldest records of the Pantry, and he has found the seating plan for Hallowboard: a slate, scratched in the old hand, listing the order in which the households of the heartland were to stand around the table on the night. It is dated. There was no refusal. The Unfed arrived on the tenth day, with knives. The table had already been cleared. Something had eaten first. **Secret:** the slate shows eight sides, and seven are allotted to households; the eighth has a word scratched beside it, and the word has been scraped away, and Garrity has spent a year with a lens trying to read the shadow of the chisel. **Meeting the PCs:** he needs the slate moved before the Abstinents burn it.

WELCOME ARDENT, THE STEWARD

He walks a mile ahead of Orrum, laying the tables. He is tall and very thin and wears an old-fashioned steward's coat of dark green, the cuffs immaculate, with a white apron over it and a ring of keys at his belt. His face is gentle, lined, and grey with an exhaustion so deep it has become a kind of serenity. His hands are warm, always, and smell of bread. He was the first of the Unfed ever to accept, on the eleventh morning, six hundred and forty years ago, and the only guest who was offered a position. He lays the cloths, sets out the plates, angles the chairs, and writes the place cards in whatever hand will be loved. He is polite, exhausted, and would like very much to be relieved. He has been laying an extra place lately, and he will not say for whom; when asked, he only says, *We're expecting one more.*

◇
We're expecting one more.

WELCOME ARDENT, ASKED WHOM THE EXTRA PLACE
IS FOR

WELCOME ARDENT – THE STEWARD OF THE HOST

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 6 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 6
CUT & REFUSAL	none (in service; not of any blood) · Want 0 · Pangs 0, forever
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 5, Craft 5, Instinct 4, Lore 4, Resolve 1
BODY	Flesh 19 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 10, steady, unbreaking
ATTACKS	none; he has never struck anyone and cannot
GIFTS	Lay a Place (in one minute, he lays a table for any person he can see; it calls them by name, and they must make an Invitation check). The Fourth Offer (he alone may make a fourth offer, and it is sincere; an Unfed who refuses him a fourth time gains 3 Want and his deep gratitude). The Steward's Keys (any door, gate, lock, or bricked hearth opens for him).
WANTS	To be relieved. Someone must accept the position freely.
DREAD	3 (to see him at work); 4 (to read a place card in his hand)
SECRET	He knows who the extra place is for. He has been told, by his master, that when that guest arrives, the Steward will be released, and everyone else will be served.

ORRUM, THE HOST

Orrum has no stat block. It does not fight, cannot be harmed by any weapon known on the Table, and has never been seen clearly by anyone who returned whole. To see it at a distance (a tall shape stooping in a lit doorway) is a Dread 4 check. To see its face is Dread 5. It is warm, and always kind. If PCs approach it, it will offer them food three times, sincerely, in voices they love. It will never make the fourth offer. If they refuse three times and remain in its presence, it will weep, and the ground for a hundred yards will grow warm enough to raise blisters, and they must leave or be Seated by the heat. If they ask it a question, it will answer with a gesture: a long hand laid on the back of an empty chair.

NEW FACES

SCARCE ODELL, THE KIN-READER

A former under-clerk of the Cutwrights' College in Sated, forty, dry and fastidious, with a squint from decades of tiny genealogical script. He is Unfed by birth, and was placed in the College as a boy by the Reckoners, to read. Now he is home, and he supplies the Reckoners with complete kin-trees so they can murder whole lines: not just the main house but married-out daughters, bastard sons, cousins at sea, infants placed with wet-nurses in other towns. He makes his lists like a careful tailor, measuring twice. He sleeps well. **Secret:** his trees include Unfed foundlings who carry High Cut blood without knowing, and he has started adding them, quietly. **Meeting the PCs:** he asks them to verify a name.

WITHY GAUNT, MATRON OF THE LEAN HOUSE

A spare, kind-faced woman of fifty-eight with chapped hands and a soft voice, who keeps the Lean House where the omitted go to die. She does not feed them; that would be against the rule and, she believes, cruel, since it would only extend the waiting. She washes them. She changes the straw. She holds their hands and listens to them talk about food, as they all do at the end, in loving detail, for hours. She writes down every name in the Book of the Omitted, with the date they came and the date they stopped, and what they said last. Most last words are recipes. **Secret:** she has started reading the Book's recipes aloud at night to the dying, and Orrum has started standing outside the door, listening. **Meeting the PCs:** a PC's friend is in the Lean House.

ABIDE KETTERING, THE SEXTON

A wiry, cheerful man of forty-five with a pickaxe on his shoulder and a cart he drives to the Lean House and back. He buries the omitted and the starved in the fields, face down, without markers, as is proper. Or he did. For six years he has been selling them, still warm, to Kale Dragoman's men at a crossroads three miles west, and burying sacks of stones. The bodies of the dead are worth less than the living, but blank kidneys keep a few hours, and blank blood a day. He tells himself the dead do not need them. He has started to look at the Lean House's residents with an eye to timing. **Meeting the PCs:** they see his cart at the crossroads, lamp lit, at the wrong hour.

KETTERING'S CART-HANDS Threat 1 · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 ·
Attack +4 (shovel 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

FACTOR JOSS MARDLE OF THE RIM ROAD COMPANY

A smooth-shaven, prosperous Oathen-trained factor of fifty, in a good grey coat, who never says anything unqualified. He holds the Fast’s grain contract at Brindle Cross. He shorted the autumn deliveries on Company orders, diverting the grain north to buy oil for the Vigil’s lamps, at three times the price. The contract allows it, in a clause about “force of circumstance” he drafted himself. He knows exactly how many Unfed will starve. He has done the sum and filed it. **Secret:** the Company has instructed him to exercise its “first refusal” on the Unfed dead this winter, and he is ashamed enough to have delayed. **Meeting the PCs:** he offers them a contract.

HOLLOW ANN PRUETT, THE CARD-KEEPER

A spry, birdlike old woman of seventy-five with a bag over her shoulder, who walks the Fast collecting place cards from broken

tables: over three hundred, kept in an oiled box, sorted by name. She has cards for people now Seated, people now dead, people who were never born in the Fast. She has cards with Rim names. She has three cards with the names of PCs, collected years ago. And she has one card that has no name on it at all, only a small, careful drawing of an empty chair, pushed in, square to the table. She found it at a table with eight chairs. She will not let anyone hold it. **Meeting the PCs:** she gives one of them their own card, and asks them to keep it, since it is theirs.

FROM HOLLOW ANN'S BOX: PLACE CARDS FOUND

Every card is stiff cream stock, folded into a little tent, written in brown ink the colour of dried gravy, in a hand somebody loved. Roll when a PC finds a card at a laid table, in a pocket, under a door or in Hollow Ann’s box. A card with the PC’s own name on it is an Invitation check at Grim 18, as normal; these are what the card says.

D20 THE CARD READS	
1	The PC’s name, in their dead mother’s hand, and under it: <i>Your favourite. I remembered.</i>
2	The PC’s childhood pet name, which no one living knows, in a grandmother’s careful copperplate.
3	The name of a companion in the party, in the PC’s own handwriting.
4	<i>Kept warm for you.</i> No name. The card is warm. It stays warm in a pocket for a week.
5	The name of someone the PC killed, in that person’s hand, and under it: <i>I’m not cross any more.</i>
6	The PC’s name spelled the way they spelled it at five, with the <i>s</i> backwards.
7	A Rim name the PC has never heard. Three nights later they meet its owner on the Rim Road.
8	The name of a Reckoner’s victim, a High Cut child, in a nursemaid’s round hand. Found in a Reckoner’s coat.
9	The PC’s name and a seat number on the Long Table: mile, side, chair. The chair is empty when visited, and pulled out.
10	<i>Lenten</i> , in Forbear Wend’s own hand as a young man. He has never written to her.
11	Two names together, the PC’s and someone they have never admitted to loving.
12	The PC’s name, in the hand of a sibling who is still alive, and who swears they did not write it.
13	<i>Steward</i> , in Welcome Ardent’s hand. Lent Ashby’s card, or one like it.
14	A Seated relative’s name, crossed out neatly, and the PC’s written underneath. <i>To take her place.</i>
15	The PC’s name in a child’s hand, a child they have not had yet.
16	<i>Bounty.</i> In Welcome Ardent’s own hand, which he swears he never wrote. He has looked for that name on every card for six hundred years.
17	The name of every PC in the party, on one card, in one hand that each of them recognises as a different person’s.
18	The name of a walker of Sallow Hatch, and under it: <i>Thank you for ringing. You did ever so well.</i>
19	A card for a Godeater PC, which reads only the name of the god in their blood, spelled correctly, with great tenderness.
20	No name. A careful drawing of an empty chair, pushed in, square to the table, its back to the lamp. Dread 3. Hollow Ann will want it, very badly, and will not say why.

◇
*She's got my card. She won't give it me. She says it
isn't time, and she'd know.*

TARRY MOSS, OF HOLLOW ANN PRUETT

MINOR FOLK AND FOES

RECKONER KNIFE Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Attack +7
(black-iron knife 2; first strike on a sleeper is a Grace) · Armor 1 · Dread 1

TABLEBREAKER AXE Threat 2 · Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Attack +6
(axe 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

SEATED OF THE LONG TABLE Threat 0 · Flesh 3 · Guard 8 ·
Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 2 (Dread 3 when they all turn and look);
each call by name forces an Invitation check at Routine 10

FATLANDS POACHER Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Attack +5
(cosh 3, or net) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

FATLANDS PILGRIM Threat 1 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (fist
1) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 (to hear them beg)

▼ PLAYING THE UNFED

Hunger is honest.

– UNFED PROVERB

You are the only person on the Table with nothing in your blood but blood. You have never tasted a god. You have also never, not once in your life, been full. You are proud, cold, thin, disciplined, and very, very hungry, and the warmest, kindest thing in the world is following you, laying tables.

Attribute bonus: +1 to any one attribute of your choice. (Most Unfed take Caul or Gut.)

Cut: 0. You cannot Partake. You have no Tooth, no Hunger track, no Regrowth, no Gifts, no Wants, and no Sop. Instead you have **Want** and **Pangs**.

WANT: THE REFUSAL MECHANIC

The Godeaters have the god in them. You have the space where a god would be, and you have learned to use it. **Want** is a pool from 0 to 10 that measures how much you have refused, and how sharp the refusing has made you. The Unfed say the other peoples have many Wants and they have only one, and it is the size of everything. Start play with Want 3.

Earning Want.

- ◇ **Refuse an offer** of real value (food, drink, shelter, rest, a gift, a kindness) in a scene where accepting would clearly help you: +1 Want. Once per scene. It must cost you something; the GM may ask for a Caul + Resolve roll (Routine 10) if the offer is sincere and you are Hollow or worse.
- ◇ **Refuse Orrum.** Pass an Invitation check against a laid table, a “Come in,” a place card, or a Steward’s offer: +2 Want (+3 on a Grace).
- ◇ **End a day hungry.** A day on half a ration or less: +1 Want. A day with nothing at all: +2 Want (and a Pang, below).

OFFER	DIFFICULTY
Smell of baking on the wind	Routine 10
A laid table, seen from a road	Hard 14
A voice saying “Come in”	Grim 18
A place card with your name in a loved hand	Grim 18
A chair pulled out, within reach; Tablenight	Dire 22

Add your Pangs to the Difficulty: the hungrier you are, the better it smells. On a success, you refuse; gain Want. On a failure, take one step toward the table and roll again next round at +2 Difficulty;

- ◇ **Say the Decline at a deathbed** (a companion’s, or a Seated guest’s): +1 Want, and you gain 1 Fray.

Spending Want.

- ◇ **The Second No** (1 Want): reroll one die of a Grace Roll you just made. Keep the new result, even if it is worse.
- ◇ **The Gnaw** (2 Want): add a d6, the *Empty Tooth*, to any roll. This is the Unfed’s answer to Partaking. It adds no Hunger. If the Empty Tooth shows a 1, you gain 1 Pang: your body paid.
- ◇ **Nothing to Hold** (2 Want): add +4 to resist any godsign effect aimed at you: a Closer’s touch, a Calling, a Sayer’s word, a blink-dream, a Fatlands meat-lure, a Cradlewrack door. Your blood is empty; there is nothing in you for the god to hold on to.
- ◇ **Clean Through** (5 Want): ignore a godsign effect aimed at you entirely, once, as though it had never been made. Witnesses who carry godsign make a Dread 2 check: something in their blood flinched.
- ◇ **Steady** (1 Want): add +2 to any Dread check about hunger, food, tables, or the Seated.

At Want 10: Hollow. You are perfectly empty, and Orrum notices. That night, a table is laid for you within sight of wherever you sleep, with your name on the card. You must make an Invitation check each hour until dawn. Want cannot rise above 10. Spend it down.

INVITATION CHECKS

When Orrum offers (a laid table, a voice at a door, a smell of bread on the wind, a place card, a chair pulled out), roll **Caul + Resolve** against the offer’s strength.

companions may hold you (an opposed Gut + Brawl) or speak the Decline for you (their Tongue + Persuade as a bonus die, once). On a Lack, you sit. On double 1s, you thank the chair.

The Seating. A PC who sits is Seated, and is lost: they become a guest, smiling, eating air, and will waste for decades at the table. The player may play out the First Course for a scene: the food is real to them, the best they have ever eaten, and they will say so. They can be dragged away only to die. They can never be rescued. Lent Ashby got up; the GM may decide that one other person in history might. It will not be cheap, and Welcome Ardent will want something.

PANGS: STARVATION

Every character in the Fast tracks **Pangs**, from 0 to 10.

- ◇ **A ration** is a day's adequate food (about 1 lack's worth). A **Pantry measure** is half a ration.

PANGS	STATE	EFFECTS
0–2	Peckish	None for Unfed. Others: –1 Caul + Resolve vs food.
3–4	Hollow	–1 to Gut and Lung rolls. Smells of baking everywhere.
5–6	Gaunt	–2 Gut and Lung; –2 Flesh max; you dream of meals.
7–8	Wasting	–3 all Hand, Gut, Lung rolls; –4 Flesh max; +1 Fray daily.
9	Brink	Each dawn, Gut + Endure (Grim 18) or suffer Ruin.
10	Starved	You die, unless something feeds you in the night.

The Unfed feel it differently. At Hollow the cold gets in, and the fingers go white and dead; at Gaunt the hair comes away in the comb and the gums bleed when you bite; at Wasting the heart thuds slow and heavy, the ankles swell, sores open on the hips where you lie, and the mind goes sharp and strange and full of food: you recite recipes you have never been taught. At Brink you stop feeling hungry. That is the worst sign, and every Unfed knows it.

PLAYING THE HUNGER

Pangs are a number on a sheet, and they should never feel like one. The Unfed live at Peckish and Hollow their whole lives, and a good Unfed player plays the hunger as a constant low weather inside the character: something that shapes every sentence without being mentioned in most of them.

- ◇ **The body.** Your character is cold, always, and their fingers go white and dead in the wind. They bruise when someone grips their arm. They feel their own heartbeat slow and heavy when they lie down, and they listen to it. They stand to eat, facing a wall. They chew a mouthful forty times because it makes it last. They pick crumbs from their coat at the end of a day and eat them, and are ashamed, and do it anyway.
- ◇ **The mind.** At Hollow and below, the mind fills with food. Not cravings, exactly; the Unfed are trained out of crave. Arithmetic. How many oats in a measure. How many measures to the Rim. How many days at this rate. Recipes, from nowhere, in a

- ◇ A day on a full ration: –1 Pang. A day of real plenty (two rations, rest, warmth): –2 Pangs, but an Unfed must succeed at a Gut + Endure roll (Hard 14) or lose 1d6 Flesh to cramps, sweats, and the heart's stutter, *refeeding sickness*.
- ◇ A day on a Pantry measure: no change. Unfed live here.
- ◇ A day on less than a Pantry measure: +1 Pang.
- ◇ A day with nothing: +2 Pangs. (Non-Unfed: +2, and +1 more after the third consecutive day.)

grandmother's voice. Unfed PCs should be the ones in the party who know exactly what everyone has left to eat, to the mouthful, and say so.

- ◇ **The pride.** Hunger is the one thing an Unfed has that no Godeater can buy, and they are proud of it the way a soldier is proud of a scar. Let your Unfed be insufferable about it. Let them watch a Fatlands companion eat with a kind of pitying fascination. Let them refuse the offered hand up a step three times, and take it on the fourth, and say nothing, and remember.
- ◇ **The cracks.** Every Unfed PC should have one food they cannot stop thinking about: a smell from a Rim inn window at eight years old, a sugared almond a poacher once held to their lips, a plum on a sill. Write it on the sheet. The GM will use it. It will be on the plate.

WHEN THE UNFED EAT A GOD

An Unfed who eats the god-meat of another land (Fatlands crop or meat, Brinchollow brine, anything grown in a Godeater soil long enough to carry its god) has done what Tobias Wether and Scour did, and it cannot be undone.

- ◇ **They gain that land's godsign.** They become **Cut 1** of that land's line, at **Regrowth 1** (the Taste), and gain the Tooth, a Hunger track, and that land's Gifts, Wants, and Sop as their Regrowth rises.

- ◇ **They lose the Refusal.** Want drops to 0 and can never again be earned. Orrum never again lays a place for them. That sounds like freedom. It is felt as being struck off a list.
- ◇ **The Empty Room** (something worse). An Unfed body has no ancestral habit of the god, no six centuries of bloodline to dilute and slow it. The god moves into them as into an empty, well-kept house, and makes itself comfortable. Their Tooth bites back on a 1 or a 2. Each time their Hunger empties, their Regrowth rises by 2, not 1. And the meat in them is looking for a god to belong to: within a season they will hear its voice, in the voice of someone it was eaten with.
- ◇ **A second land's meat.** If a Returned eats the god-meat of a second land, roll on the Mangling table at once: two gods are fighting over the house.

The Unfed call them the Returned, never to their faces. Most hide it. Some go to the Lean House. Some go back over the Rim and eat, and eat, and are not seen again.

WHAT YOU CARRY

Every Unfed PC starts with a ration-cloth, a water flask, a wax tin, a small household axe, three days' Pantry measures, a coat that is not warm enough, and a name chosen for refusal. They have no money worth counting: 2d6 lacks.

BACKGROUND CONCEPTS

- ◇ **Measure-Bearer.** You carried the list to the hamlets, and you know whose names were missing. You have never forgiven yourself for not looking at it first.
- ◇ **Tablebreaker's Rope-Holder.** You have pulled your Breaker back from a chair a dozen times. Last week you didn't pull fast enough.
- ◇ **Poacher's Escapee.** You were taken over the Rim, fed for a month, and broke loose before the surgeon came. You came home plump and ashamed, and nobody will stand next to you on Tablenight.
- ◇ **Kin of a Portion.** Your great-grandmother walked out to the stones in 559 and has written to your family every Lack since. You were raised never to say the word. You have her card, and you have read it.
- ◇ **Notched Door.** You grew up in a house with five notches in the frame, and the last is at the height of your sister's heart. You do not visit the verge. You stand at the edge of town some evenings, and your neighbours fetch you in.
- ◇ **Returned Knife.** You were a Reckoner who ate to keep a cover, as Scour did. The god in you is a season old. You have not told your band. You carry your own food on every raid, and refuse it, and the god in you laughs.
- ◇ **Lean House Survivor.** You were omitted, and walked to the Lean House, and on the twenty-second day your name was read

again (a clerk's error, a forged chit, a kindness nobody owns). You came back with the borrowed cheeks and a recipe you cannot stop saying.

- ◇ **Pin-Setter.** You set the pins on the Great Map. You know where the walkers are, and the Seated, and the god. You have noticed what the newest pins are making, and nobody has asked you.
- ◇ **Poacher's Get.** You were born on the Rim to a captive who was fed on the road and kept in a warm room with no west windows, and you were smuggled home to the Fast as an infant by a Crumb-Runner who will not say how. You are Unfed by blood. You were fed on Fatlands milk for your first year. You do not know what that means yet.

NAMES

- ◇ **Given names:** Forbear, Abstain, Decline, Stint, Tarry, Nay, Spare, Lent, Wont, Want, Meagre, Scant, Yield, Keep, Abate, Withhold, Forswear, Fallow, Bare, Pinch, Sparing, Lean, Scarcity, Reft, Abide, Hesitate, Cease.
- ◇ **Old (shameful) given names:** Welcome, Ardent, Mercy, Hallow, Blythe, Bounty, Cheer, Plenty, Supper, Kindle.
- ◇ **Surnames:** Ashby, Hollis, Moss, Avery, Rooke, Bellamy, Garrity, Hartsell, Wend, Corliss, Marsh, Tolland, Osmond, Aldane, Odell, Kettering, Hume, Corve, Kell, Pruett, Fennick, Lammas, Brindle, Hatch.

CARRYING YOUR OWN IN A MIXED PARTY

Most parties that cross the Fast include Godeaters, and most Unfed PCs will spend more of their lives on the Rim than in Wanting. A few customs make an Unfed easy to play alongside the others, and hard to play lightly.

- ◇ **Never feed, never be fed.** An Unfed will not take food from a companion's hand, and will not give their own. They may set food down, and walk away, and let a companion pick it up: food set down is not offered, it is only there. Unfed PCs who have spent long on the Rim learn to do this so naturally that their companions do not notice they are being fed.
- ◇ **Count the chairs.** At any inn, any hall, any feast, the Unfed counts the places before sitting, and gets up if there is one too many. In 640 and after, on the Rim Road, they are getting up more and more often.
- ◇ **The question.** An Unfed will, early, ask after the state of a companion's blood, kindly, as a courtesy. A Godeater who answers honestly gains an Unfed friend for life, and that friend will keep the count of their Regrowth more carefully than the Cutwrights do, and will say so.
- ◇ **Godless blood.** Unfed are the one people on the Table that godsign cannot grip, and parties quickly learn to put them between the danger and everyone else: in front of a Closer, at the

edge of a Hush, in the doorway of a Sayer. The Unfed know this and are proud of it. They also know what they are worth to a poacher, and that every Godeater in the party, every one, is a body that could be bought with a pair of Unfed kidneys. Some Unfed PCs never quite stop doing that sum.

WHY YOU LEFT WANTING

Every Unfed PC is on the road for a reason, and few of them are good ones. Choose, or roll a d10.

D10	WHY YOU LEFT
1	Your name was left off the list. You did not walk to the Lean House. You walked east instead, to the Rim, and you are still not sure which was braver.
2	You were a Reckoner Carrier, and you looked away at the bedside, and they sent you home, and you could not stay home.
3	A place card came for you in a hand you loved. You have kept moving ever since, and the tables keep getting closer.
4	You are carrying a letter for Envoy Prudence Lowell, sealed, and you have been told not to stop until it reaches her. That was a season ago.
5	You are looking for someone taken by poachers. You have a name, a date, and a crossroads three miles west of the Lean House.
6	Your family took a Rim name. You are considered emigrated. You are spoken of in the past tense, to your face, by your mother.
7	You are hunting a table: the one your father sat down at, which moved. The Hostwatch say it is on the Rim Road now.
8	Dr. Mercy Thrane hired you to bring a body home. You found it. It was not dead.
9	You said <i>come in</i> to a knock at your door in Wanting, half asleep, without thinking. Nobody in the Fast will cross your threshold again.
10	You do not know. You woke one morning on the Rim Road with your lips glazed sweet and sticky, a week gone, and a napkin folded in your pocket.



Hungry is alive. That's all it means. It doesn't mean anything nicer than that.

A LEAN HOUSE SURVIVOR, EXPLAINING THE PROVERB TO A RIM PHYSICIAN

▼ HORRORS OF THE FAST

FOR THE GM

The Fast is the quietest chapter of the book. Nothing attacks. Everything offers. Run it slowly: golden afternoons, empty roads, the smell. Let the players be hungry. Track Pangs openly. Describe food constantly, lovingly, and never let them eat it. The horror of the Fast is that the god is good, the food is real, and the only thing between your players and perfect contentment is a rule their grandparents made up while starving to death. Let them doubt it.

D20	SCENE
1	A farmhouse kitchen with the table laid for a family of six. Five plates are clean. The sixth has the PC's name, and the food on it is still steaming.
2	The Long Table at dusk. Three hundred Seated lift their forks together, chew together, swallow together. The sound is like a herd grazing.
3	A mother in Wanting carries her child's ration to the Lean House, where her husband lies omitted. She stands at the door, and does not go in, and eats it.
4	A Seated girl of perhaps twenty has been at table so long her hair has grown into the cloth. She asks a PC to brush it.
5	A Reckoner band comes home through Brindle Cross. One of them has a christening spoon in his pocket and does not know how it got there.
6	A warm front crosses the camp at night. In the morning everyone's lips are glazed, sweet, and sticky. Nobody remembers eating.

D20	SCENE
7	An Unfed grave in an open field, with a little table beside it. The earth of the grave has been disturbed from inside. The chair is pulled out.
8	Kale Dragoman's camp: four Unfed captives, fat and clean, sitting by the fire with bowls of stew in their laps, weeping, unable to stop eating.
9	A Starved Saint's novice offers a PC a twist of cloth with honey-cake crumbs in it, and asks them to taste it and tell her if it is poison.
10	A Seated man dragged from the Long Table by his son dies in the road in two minutes, all at once, his body collapsing like a dropped tent. He thanks the host.
11	A child's voice from a cottage door calls a PC by their childhood nickname, and says supper's ready, and says Mam's made your favourite.
12	An empty Rim inn, every table laid, every chair pulled out except one at each table: pushed in, square, its back to the lamp.
13	A pilgrim column on the road, dying. A Fatlands woman asks a PC to hold her up so she can smell it one more time.
14	A Reckoner Knife in a Wanting alley, alone, sobbing into a baby's knitted blanket, saying the Decline over and over.
15	Abide Kettering's cart at the western crossroads. A sack moves.
16	The bricked hearth in a PC's lodging is warm to the touch. Through the mortar comes the soft sound of a spoon in a pot.
17	A table on a frozen pond. Under the ice, a family of the Seated, perfectly preserved, smiling up, forks raised.
18	The Pantry, at midnight, with every door locked. Inside, the ledgers are laid out on a long cloth like place settings, open at the names of the omitted.
19	Hallowboard on a still evening. On the eighth, unworn side, a single chair stands in the untrodden chalk, pushed in. There are no footprints near it.
20	Orrum, at a distance, across a gold field: a tall shape in an open doorway, stooping, lamplight behind it, holding out one long arm. It is crying. It is holding the door for someone it is not looking at. (Dread 4.)

WE HAVE BEEN SAYING NO FOR SIX HUNDRED AND
FORTY-ONE YEARS. IT HAS BEEN SAYING
PLEASE FOR EXACTLY AS LONG. ONE OF US IS GOING
TO STOP.

[SPARE TOLLAND OF THE HOSTWATCH, TO THE WARDEN OF THE MAP,
CARVING 641]



CHAPTER 10

THREADS BETWEEN THE LANDS

Every land is certain that the cure is next door.

– RIM ROAD SAYING

The road goes round. So does everything on it.

– PAINTED OVER THE DOOR OF THE COMPANY INN AT SALTICK CROSS

The lands of the Table are not separate stories. They share a road, a coin, a grace and a doom, and the crises in each are beginning to touch. This chapter takes the open storylines that cross borders and lays them out as campaign threads: who is involved in each land, how the thread escalates if nobody interferes, what the Guests can see and do about it, what it will cost them, and how it might end. Most of the endings are bad. That is not a failure of imagination; it is the setting. A thread resolved well is a thread that ends one way rather than a worse way.

Each thread is written in stages. Advance a thread one stage whenever the Guests spend a season elsewhere, or whenever the GM wishes the world to feel the weight of the clock. Threads touch: the Sayer's Sentence feeds the Deadwatch, the Blank Trade feeds the Second Table, the Low Water feeds Eight Chairs, and almost everything, sooner or later, feeds Eight Chairs.

Every thread opens with an **in-world document** that hints at it before anything is explained, offers **Scenes the Guests Might Witness** to stage in full, and closes with a **What It Costs** box: the price, in Fray, Hunger, coin and conscience, of touching it at all. Fifteen threads follow: the twelve of the first edition, deepened with what *Seven Tables* has since uncovered, and three new ones that the year 642 is about to pull tight.

RUNNING THREADS

Pick two or three threads to run in the background of a campaign and let the others exist only as rumors. Keep a simple track for each, Stage 1 to Stage 4, on a card the players never see. When a thread reaches Stage 4 it resolves, with or without the Guests, and the world changes. Guests who intervene can hold a thread at its current stage for a season, push it back one stage at great cost, or steer which ending it reaches. They cannot make it not have happened.

A useful habit: whenever a thread advances off-screen, put one physical sign of it in front of the Guests within the next session. A place card on an inn table. A candle that keens when the wind drops. The world should be seen to move before it is explained.



Nobody on the Rim says “if” any more. They say “when the road closes,” the way a farmer says “when the frost comes.”

FACTOR'S LETTER, LAMPWICK HALT, CARVING 641

▼ THE THREADS AT A GLANCE

THREAD	HEART	REACHES	FIRST SIGN
The Deadwatch	the Vigil	Sallowreach, the Rim	a sleepless foreigner in Lastgate
The Host on the Road	the Fast	every land	a table at a crossroads
Brine in the Rouse	the Vigil	Brinehollow	an addict facing west
The First to Eat	the Fast	the Fatlands	an Unfed with godsign
The Blank Trade	the Fast	Fatlands, Oathen	a sealed brine-barrel
The Missing Hand	Cradlewrack	Sallowreach	a hand that points
The Sayer's Sentence	Oathen	every land	an envoy in Tacit
Eight Chairs	none	every land	a chair pulled out
The Second Table	none	every capital	a dinner invitation
The Undying Flame	the Vigil	Sallowreach, Fatlands	a lamp that breathes
The Slipping Seal	Oathen	the Rim	a thief who does not break
The Stolen Ledgers	the College	every land	a page for sale

THREAD	HEART	REACHES	FIRST SIGN
The Low Water	Brinehollow	the Rim, the Vigil	a bell rung early
Three, One, Three	Cradlewrack	the Vigil, Oathen, the Fast	a knock at night
The Lead Coffin	Sallowreach	the Rim, the Fast	a coffin “of wine”

▼ THE CALENDAR OF 642

Many of the people of the Table have clocks running toward a particular day in the coming year. The GM who wants the threads to pull together should know where those days fall. Nothing below must happen; all of it will, if nobody stands in the way.

WHEN	LAND	WHAT FALLS DUE	THREAD
Grace 642	Sallowreach	Osric Vane leaves Glovehall in a lead coffin	The Lead Coffin
Grace 642	Sallowreach	Edda Thrush walks back into Dunmere	The Lead Coffin
The Weighing, 642	the Fatlands	Chairman Tullow’s scandal at the scales	The Second Table
Plenty 642	Oathen	Merit Tome’s first words, in the Hall of Conditions	The Sayer’s Sentence
Carving 642	Brinehollow	the Low Water: the body tide closes	The Low Water
Carving 642	the Fatlands	two Dowager hills touch	The Second Table
Lack 642	Sallowreach	a Hush opens under the Hall of Hands	The Stolen Ledgers
Lack 642	the Fast, Fatlands	Tobias Wether and Scour vanish	The First to Eat
Tablenight 642	every capital	Lord Chastain Loin is served	The Second Table



*Three, one, three. I’d know it anywhere. I lay that
course every evening.*

ABSALOM GAGE, BRICKLAYER OF KEST

▼ THE DEADWATCH



The dead cannot be Counted. Think on it, Castellan. It is the only sum in the city that comes out clean.

SABINE LARCH, TO ENVOY DRAY

Summary. The Vigil cannot sleep and is running out of everything: beds, rouse, oil and time. Its Warden-Prime has sent Envoy Castellan Dray to Lastgate to buy the secret of Keeping from Regent Ansel Grue: if the Vigil's citizens could be killed and kept upright, a city of the dead would never need to sleep. The flaw is geography. The Kept cannot leave Sallowreach, so the Vigil would have to move there. Dray has not written this down, because he knows Ilvane Stroud will say yes; and Stroud has already decided, without telling him, to leave the sixty thousand Counted behind on the Lid, unwatched. A dispatch from the clerk Bell Lisle, now on the Rim Road, will make them both tell the truth.

To C. Dray, Envoy, care of the Company post-house, Lastgate. Fourth letter of Carving. Burn after.

Castellan. A Counted sleeper cannot be relieved of the risk she poses except by being relieved of her bed; a citizen who dies awake in the fen poses no risk at all. I have struck forty names

from the general rows this month and can strike no faster without being noticed. You could strike a hundred thousand and be thanked on the Stair. I do not ask you to love the arithmetic. I ask you to show me where in it the murder is. Tell the Regent the Lessening pays in rouse, promptly.

S.L.

The Players.

- ◇ *The Vigil:* Envoy Castellan Dray; Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud; Dr. Aldous Crane, whose dose curve gives the Vigil eleven years; Benedikt Lour, already drawing plans for the whole population; Sabine Larch, First of the Lessening, who writes to Dray every week because the dead cannot be Counted; Bell Lisle's dispatch, somewhere between Lampwick Halt and Fogmouth.
- ◇ *Sallowreach:* Regent Ansel Grue, tempted by a hundred thousand new taxable dead; Lady Corrow Vane, who would have to Close nobody and keep everyone; the Heirs, who see a new population of the never-dying arriving to sit on top of them forever; Tam Ruddock, who already knows how to move people across the Drop and will sign on with Dray in 642 for a fee that would let him stop.
- ◇ *The Rim:* the Company, which would carry the migration and price it; Fogmouth, where the line is painted.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Dray negotiates in Lastgate. Small trials: Vigil volunteers are brought north, killed in Sallowreach, and kept. They do not sleep. It works. The Lessening quietly funds the volunteers' passage.
2	Bell Lisle's dispatch arrives. Dray and Stroud confess by letter, and agree. The Watch votes in secret to relocate. Caravans of the Slope's poor begin moving west under Company contract.
3	The first mass Killing at Fogmouth: thousands of Vigil folk die north of the Drop and stand back up. The Heirs riot. The Mortuary Court demands a toll per head. Tam Ruddock buys a bigger notebook.
4	Lastgate's lower levels fill with sleepless dead foreigners. The Vigil's lamps go out one district at a time as the city empties into the fen. The Counted lie on the Lid with nobody counting them.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Trial at Fogmouth.** A Slope laundress named Ottie Fane, thirty, lidded, nine days without a full sleep, kneels on the north bank where the line is painted on the planks in Company red. She has asked to be drowned rather than cut, because she has heard the Kept feel their wounds. Two Fen Guard hold her under the black water. It takes longer than anyone wants. Her heels drum the boards; her fingers find Dray's boot and close on it. Then the drumming stops, and the Guard lift her out, and the water runs out of her nose and her open mouth in a long

brown sheet, and her chest does not move, and she sits up. She coughs up a palmful of fen-weed. She looks at Dray, and her eyes are bloodshot and wide and perfectly clear. *I'm still tired*, she says. *I thought it would stop.* It never does. That is a Dread 3 check.

- ◇ **The Lower Levels.** A Guest sent to inspect the first Vigil lodgings in Lastgate's flooded under-streets finds a long cellar where two hundred dead foreigners stand in rows because there is nowhere to lie down, all awake, all rotting at the speed of the fen, the soft ones at the ankles going green and slack where the

water laps. Nobody talks. They count, under their breath, in the Vigil way. Their eyes follow the lamp.

What the Guests Can Do. Escort or sabotage the trial caravans. Expose to the Vigil's poor what Keeping actually feels like (Kept bodies rot and feel it for centuries). Uncover the Court's hidden reason for agreeing: the Court believes new dead without Hand-line blood may slow the Hushes. Steal Dray's commission, which the Warden-Prime would rather die than see read aloud. Intercept, delay or deliver Bell Lisle's dispatch; whoever carries it decides when the city's two oldest friends stop lying.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Dead City:* the Vigil moves north and becomes a district of Lastgate, a hundred thousand rotting, wakeful foreigners. The Dormitory is abandoned with its Counted inside, unguarded, and the lamps go out over sixty thousand beds.
- ◇ *The Broken Deal:* the Heirs drag Dray to a Hush; the Vigil, betrayed, closes the Rim at Lampwick Halt; Sallowreach loses its rouse and oil, and Lastgate's candle-makers turn to the only fuel left.
- ◇ *The Worst Arithmetic:* a Vigil sleeper is brought north, unconscious, and killed in Sallowreach. They do not wake and

do not die. They lie there, Kept and Counted at once, and the Dormitory's number goes up by one.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE DEADWATCH

Witnessing a trial Killing is Dread 3; witnessing a mass Killing at Fogmouth is Dread 4. A Guest who helps a volunteer die gains the volunteer's gratitude, which is permanent and sleepless. Sabotaging a caravan earns the Lessening's attention: within a season, the Guest's name (or a loved one's) appears on a list for the general rows. Siding with the Heirs closes the Vigil to the party; siding with Dray closes Lastgate's upper levels.

▼ THE HOST ON THE ROAD

◇
Lack keep away. And if it won't, set it a place.

SAID BY RIM INNKEEPERS SINCE THE TABLES BEGAN

Summary. For six centuries Orrum kept to the Fast. Now its tables have been found laid at crossroads in three other lands, and the seemers of the Vigil, the scavengers of Brinehollow and the pilgrims of the Fatlands have all seen the same tall figure laying a table. That figure is Welcome Ardent, the Host's steward, walking a mile ahead of his god around the Rim. On fourteen walls in fourteen capitals, Envoy Prudence Lowell has made a small chalk stroke where she stood to eat facing the plaster, like a table seen edge on. In three of those capitals, someone has drawn eight short marks beneath it.

A place card, cream board, gilt edge, found at the crossroads of the Drove Road and the Rim, Plenty 641. The hand is beautiful and slightly unsteady.

GOODWIFE HANNA SPURLING, OF STILE FARM

Seated at the third place. The soup is barley with marrowbone; the bread was baked this morning, and there is butter. Please

do not wait for the others. You have been hungry such a long time. You were always so polite about it.

(On the reverse, in the same hand, smaller:) I am sorry. I am so sorry. Do not sit. It is very good. Do not sit.

The Players.

- ◇ *The Fast:* Welcome Ardent, polite and exhausted; Spare Tolland of the Hostwatch, mapping the warm ground; Decline Marsh and the Tablebreakers; Envoy Prudence Lowell and her chalk marks.
- ◇ *The Vigil:* Mirela Sconce, who recorded eleven districts hallucinating a table being laid in the street.
- ◇ *The Fatlands:* Osanna Blythe and her three hundred pilgrims, hungry every second of their lives, looking for a table where they will finally feel full.
- ◇ *Brinehollow:* salvagers on the Uncovered who have found tables laid on the dry seabed with the plates still wet.
- ◇ *The Rim:* the wardens at Saltlick Cross; every innkeeper who has seen a tall shape stoop to look in at the window.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Tables appear at Rim crossroads, one a season. Tablebreakers cross the Hem to smash them. Place cards bear the names of people who live nearby.
2	Welcome Ardent is seen in person at a Rim inn. He asks, politely, whether anyone would take over his duties. The first non-Unfed sit down: a Fatlands family, a Vigil nudger, a Kept man a yard north of the Drop at Fogmouth, who now cannot leave the table or the fen.
3	Orrum itself is seen on the Rim at night, stooping to look in at windows. Whole villages along the Fatlands border are found Seated. Osanna Blythe's pilgrims find their table.
4	Tables are laid in every capital on the same night, with a place card for every head of state. In each, one chair is left without a card.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Spurling Table.** Hanna Spurling sat. So did her husband and two grown sons, at the places laid for them. The Guests find them nine days later: the table is still warm to the touch, the bread still steams when torn, and the four Spurlings are eating. Their cheeks have fallen in to the shape of the teeth beneath. Their wrists are rope. Their nails have grown long and curled against the spoons, and their lips are split and bleeding into the soup, and they are smiling, and they say *you must try the butter*. They do not want to be lifted. They scream, thin and high, if they are.
- ◇ **The Face at the Window.** In a Company inn after midnight, the shutters on the road side darken one by one, left to right, as something very tall walks slowly past outside and stoops at each. At the last window it stops. The Guests hear it breathe once, like a bellows in an empty forge. In the morning the frost on the sill has melted in the shape of two great hands laid flat.

What the Guests Can Do. Track Ardent and talk to him (he is the only one of Orrum's guests who can still get up, and he will answer questions honestly if he is not invited to sit). Smash tables, at the risk of finding their own names. Protect or stop the pilgrims. Discover that the cardless chair at each table faces away from the others.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Long Table Grows:* the Seated spread along the Rim, a second endless table around the whole continent, happy, wasting, praising the food. Trade stops because the road is full of diners.
- ◇ *The Relief:* a Guest accepts Ardent's position. Ardent finally sits down and eats, and dies in moments, weeping with gratitude. The Guest now walks a mile ahead of the god forever, and knows exactly whom the tables are for.
- ◇ *The Unanswered Door:* the tables stop, all at once. Orrum stands still at Hallowboard facing the eighth side. The Hostwatch reports that it has never looked so frightened.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE HOST ON THE ROAD

Coming upon a Seated family is Dread 3. Smashing a table is a Hard Caul + Resolve roll; failure means the smasher eats one mouthful first, without meaning to, and gains 2 Hunger and the Want *Sit Down* (resist Hard 14 whenever offered food by a stranger) until the next Tablenight. A Guest who finds their own name on a card makes a Dread 4 check. Speaking with Ardent costs nothing but sleep: the night after, the Guest dreams of laying a table for someone who is late. Taking his position is the end of that Guest's story as a player character.

▼BRINE IN THE ROUSE

◇
Dry Jonah's Tonic — Sea-Air in a Bottle — For the Chest, the Nerves, the Long Night. Do Not Exceed Three Drops.

LABEL, LOWMARK BOTTLING, SOLD ON THE SLOPE
AT FOUR LACKS

Summary. Captain Jonah Skerry, called Dry Jonah, bottles what Brinehollowers cough up at bailing and sells it inland as tonic. It sells best in the Vigil, where the Slope dealer Rook Quarter-Bell cuts it into rouse because it is cheap and it works. The sleepless are now feeling the Calling, four hundred miles from any coast. Customers

stay awake. They have also started walking west. On the coast, the Assay clerk Brenna Kelp has proved that the sea falls by nine hundred and twelve thousand barrels for every Tenanted soul returned from it, a figure the clerks call *the Kelp*. If a Vigil walker comes back Tenanted, the constant will have to count her. The ocean, it seems, does not mind which land its people come from.

From the private daybook of Dr. Aldous Crane, Apothecary-General. Not for the Watch.

Batch 41, Slope-street rouse, cut approx. one part in nine with coastal tonic (Skerry's). Subject held awake 31 hours on a standard dose; control, 30. One hour. One hour is eleven thousand waking hours across the city per night. One hour is a year off the curve. Side effects: dry cough, salt crust at the lips

by the second day, a tendency to stand at west-facing windows. Subject 6 asked me, very politely, what the water was like where I came from. I have not reported this batch. I have ordered forty barrels.

The Players.

- ◇ *Brinehollow*: Dry Jonah, who has not bailed in years and is due to be Called before Tablenight; Tolly Brack, who knows by the color of bailing water who will be Called next; Brenna Kelp and her constant; the Netwatch, who are going to see Called strangers arrive from the east.
- ◇ *The Vigil*: Rook Quarter-Bell; Dr. Aldous Crane, desperate for anything that stretches the dose; the Wakers; Inspector Hale Grimmer, whose blink-murders begin to cluster on the western edge of the city; Senna Vole, on her forty-first dive into the room.
- ◇ *The Rim*: Lampwick Halt and Lowmark Spur, the two ends of the walk.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	The Slope's addicts stand at west windows. Dr. Crane notices that brine-cut rouse holds an hour longer and does not report it.
2	Vigil citizens begin walking west across the plateau in their sleep-that-is-not-sleep, eyes open, straight lines. The Wakers net them at the city edge. Dry Jonah is Called from the deck of the <i>Bess</i> .
3	Crane formulates brine into the official rouse. The whole Vigil now carries a little of the sea. Lines of walkers cross the Rim heading for a coast they have never seen.
4	The first Vigil walkers reach the Uncovered and keep going, out toward the Trench. Some come back Tenanted: calm, courteous, rested. They are the first people in the Vigil in three centuries who sleep and wake again. The sea, by the Kelp, falls a little faster.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The West Window.** A Slope tenement, fourth floor. Eleven people stand at a single west window, shoulder to shoulder, faces to the glass. Their breath has fogged it and then salted it, a white crust the shape of eleven mouths. One of them, a boy of seventeen, is coughing quietly and steadily; what comes up is grey, foaming and smells of a harbor at low tide, and in it are threads of something green and slick that moves a little on the floorboards before it stops. None of them turns around. One of them is humming a tune the Guests will hear again, if they ever stand on the cliff at Lowmark at Low Water.
- ◇ **The Net.** A line of walkers crosses the plateau at dawn, spaced exactly apart, eyes open and dry. The Wakers string a net across the road. The walkers walk into it and keep walking, and the net creaks, and their faces press through the mesh until the cord cuts

into the cheeks, and they do not stop pushing, and they do not cry out, and they bleed.

What the Guests Can Do. Trace the supply chain from bailing buckets in Lowmark to dealers on the Slope. Kill or bargain with Dry Jonah before the sea takes him. Shepherd walkers home or follow them to see where they go. Present the Watch with the choice: brine buys the Vigil years of wakefulness at the cost of the sea pulling on every citizen.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Walking City*: the Vigil adopts brine-rouse openly and loses a tenth of its people a year to the west. The Watch calls it emigration.
- ◇ *The Tenanted Wardens*: Tenanted Vigil-folk, rested and calm, are found to be immune to the Dormitory's dream. The Watch

begins appointing them to office, as Brinehollow did with its judges. Nobody asks whose eyes are looking out.

- ◇ *The Meeting of Waters:* the Trench, the draining sea and the long dim room in the Vigil's dream turn out to be closer than anyone thought. Senna Vole, on her forty-first dive, hears water.

WHAT IT COSTS – BRINE IN THE ROUSE

A Guest who takes brine-cut rouse gains a single extra watch awake per dose but rolls Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) each dawn after: failure means a Called walk of an hour westward before waking, Lung + Athletics to stop safely. Three failures and the Guest hears the Calling permanently, as a Brinehollower does, wherever they stand. Netting walkers is Dread 2. Killing Dry Jonah makes an enemy of every coastal bottler and buys nothing: the tonic trade has six other captains. Telling the Vigil's poor the truth starts a riot at the Bitterhouse in which the Wakers' long needles are used freely.

▼ THE FIRST TO EAT

◇

What grows in an Unfed body is not the god the body ate.

ODO VENN, PRIVATE NOTES, NEVER SENT TO QUIRE

Summary. Tobias Wether, a runaway raised on six centuries of refusal, crossed into the Fatlands and ate. The Reckoner called Scour spent a year undercover in the Fatlands, had to eat to keep his cover, and came home with godsign. Two Unfed bodies now carry a god that was never theirs, and the meat inside them seems to be looking for something. Tobias does not know that the drover Sal Trotter, who took him in, named him after the son she culled for a debt; or that the lead steer of her herd, branded with that son's plot-number, hums her song a beat ahead of her. Wont Bellamy has guessed what Scour is, and has written to the Second Table that he may soon have "a dish of rare interest."

College tasting-slip, Odo Venn's hand, folded into a hymnal at Sated. The official copy, filed at Quire, reads "Subject W.: Ummer-line, trace, unremarkable."

Subject W. Blood drawn from the thumb, tasted at room heat. First: Ummer, faint, the usual gravy and grass. Under it: nothing. Not absence, as with a Blank. A space. A room with the door left open. I held it on the tongue for the count of twelve and something on the far side of the space noticed me holding it. I have rinsed eleven times. I will not record this.

The Players.

- ◇ *The Fast:* Scour, hiding his godsign under his sleeves and volunteering for every raid; Reckoner-Captain Scant Hollis; the Abstinents, for whom this is the worst possible news; Meek Garrity, whose research says the Unfed never refused at all; Wont Bellamy, with his letter.
- ◇ *The Fatlands:* Tobias Wether; Sal Trotter and her humming steer; Corder Lank of the Thin, who is very interested in a man who came from emptiness into hunger; Brother Glut of the Second Helping, who sees a convert.
- ◇ *Cross-border:* Odo Venn of the College, who wants to taste them; the Second Table, who want to know whether an Unfed stomach makes room for a god.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Tobias shows his first godsign. It is not purely Ummer's: he dreams of a long dim room and closes doors behind him. Scour's signs are similar.
2	The College learns of them. Unfed blood with godsign is, by the ledgers, impossible. Odo Venn tastes Tobias and goes pale and does not report the flavor.
3	Scour's comrades find out. The Abstinents strike his name from the Pantry. He flees to the Rim, where the Second Table is waiting with an invitation.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
4	Tobias and Scour, kept apart, begin to show identical signs at the same hour. Neither carries any one god. Both are getting hungrier for the same thing, and when they meet, they set a table.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Doors.** Tobias, lodged at an inn, cannot pass through a door without closing it behind him, then opening it, then closing it again from the other side, three times, his lips moving. If anyone stops him he goes grey and sweats and his stomach makes a long, low, hollow sound, like wind across the mouth of a jar. The door he did not get to close is found in the morning with the paint scored by fingernails on the inside, low down, where a crouching person would reach.
- ◇ **Under the Sleeves.** Scour, in a Reckoner bunkhouse, unwinds his wrappings by a candle when he thinks he is alone. The godsign on his forearms is the marbling of good beef, fat laced through red, but in it, if a Guest looks closely, the fat has drawn itself into lines: a long rectangle, and eight small squares around it.

What the Guests Can Do. Protect them, hide them, study them or kill them. Bring Tobias back into the Fast and see what happens to the Lack around him. Learn, from Venn's private notes, that what grows in an Unfed body is not the god the body ate.

Endings.

▼ THE BLANK TRADE

◇

Price per pound, Unfed, dressed: forty lacks. Price per pound, Blank, living, any land: name your figure.

CHALKED INSIDE A POACHER'S LEAN-TO, FAST BORDER

Summary. Wren Hollowell in the Fatlands, Cassian Wry in Oathen and the entire population of the Fast are worth more in parts than whole. Blank blood, marrow and organs are believed to slow the Regrowth. Dr. Mercy Thrane of the Fast is following the buyers, and the trail leads to the Second Table. She carries a plank from a hidden surgery in Sated with *A.T.* scratched into it and believes it was a patient's. It was her brother's. Abide Thrane has lived for nine years in Master Quillon Barr's brine-tanks, and has started to put on weight; and Barr has read Mercy's book, admired it, and sent her a pair of spectacles.

Docket, Rim Road Company freight, Wanting Post to Sated. Found pasted inside a barrel lid.

- ◇ *The Empty Vessel:* the Second Table buys Scour and serves him, as a test. The diners all sleep badly afterward, and dream of a room where someone is laying a table.
- ◇ *The Lack Breaks:* Tobias returns to the Fast and plants. The dead soil sprouts where he walks. The Abstinent call it a miracle and then realize what it means: the heartland can be fed if its people eat. Wont Bellamy wins the next vote.
- ◇ *Two Places Laid:* in Lack 642, Tobias and Scour vanish from their guarded rooms on the same night. Two Orrum tables are found the next morning at the Rim, with their names on the cards, and the chairs pushed in.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE FIRST TO EAT

Hiding either man makes the Guests enemies of the Reckoners (who end lines) or of the Second Table (who end dinners), and usually both. Tasting their blood, as Venn did, needs Caul + Godsign (Grim 18) to learn anything and imposes a Dread 3 check whatever the result; on a Lack the taster gains the Derangement *Open Doors* (cannot bear a door left shut behind them). Killing them is murder of the gentlest people in the chapter, and their tables are laid anyway.

Consignment 6612. Contents: PICKLED GOODS (BRINE), 4 barrels, sealed. Shipper: A. Kettering, sexton, by proxy. Receiver: K. Dragoman, for the account of a gentleman. Weight declared: 9 stone 4. Weight at Sated scales: 9 stone 4. Company does not open sealed freight. Clerk's note in pencil, faint: one of them knocked.

The Players.

- ◇ *The Fast:* Dr. Mercy Thrane; Marshal Keep Aldane, holding the border against poachers; Abide Kettering, the sexton who sells the omitted dead at Brindle Cross; Withy Gaunt, who once sold a baby there so that he would live; every Unfed child sent to fetch water at dusk.
- ◇ *The Fatlands:* Kale Dragoman, poacher, plump and kind and smelling of woodsmoke, who is that baby grown and does not know it; Wren Hollowell, with a bounty on her weight that does not specify alive; Lord Chastain Loin, who wants a Blank set in aspic for the Second Table's cellar; the Board of Plenty.
- ◇ *Oathen:* Cassian Wry, the crown's Blank spy, kept in luxury and never let out of sight; the Bench of Clauses, which has received

an offer.

- ◇ *Cross-border*: Master Quillon Barr and Lady Seraphine Dalgety of the Second Table; the Rim Road Company, whose wagons carry sealed brine-barrels it does not open.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Unfed disappearances double along the eastern border. Thrane finds a surgery in Sated with an Unfed man's name scratched inside a cupboard.
2	Wren Hollowell is taken. A Fatlands Gut-line matriarch is seen at the Weighing ten stone lighter and, for the first time in thirty years, not eating.
3	Oathen's Bench agrees, in a forty-page conditional, to lease Cassian Wry's kidney to a foreign buyer. The surgery is scheduled at Treaty Stair.
4	Thrane traces the trail to Barr's surgery, and finds Abide, nine years a donor, fat and smiling, and the eighth course on a menu pinned to the wall, still blank.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Tanks.** Barr's cellar is warm and smells of vinegar, cloves and the inside of a cheek. Six copper tanks, lidded, each with a glass port at face height. In the third, Abide Thrane floats in green brine to the chin, his scalp shaved and seamed, plump, pink, the skin of his belly puckered with nine years of neat little scars like the stitching on a quilt. He opens his eyes at the lamp and smiles, and mouths a word through the glass. It is his sister's name.
- ◇ **The Lean House.** Kale Dragoman comes himself to collect a body. Withy Gaunt smells woodsmoke and turns. Kale nicks her hand to price an old woman in the straw, licks the drop, and tastes his own name in it. Kettering is in the doorway with the pickaxe.

What the Guests Can Do. Raid a surgery. Escort Wren out of the Fatlands, which will put every bounty-hunter in the south on their trail. Free Cassian Wry, who has been kept all his life and does not know how to live unwatched. Follow the money to the Company's sealed barrels and make the Company choose between its neutrality and its conscience. If a Guest is a Blank, this thread is about them.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Market Holds*: the trade goes on, and prices rise. The Fast begins to sell its own people to buy grain, and calls it Pantry policy.
- ◇ *The Exposed Table*: the trail is published. In every capital, a few High Cuts are revealed to be carrying Unfed organs, and the Reckoners have a new list.
- ◇ *Room Made*: Barr's patients begin, one by one, to feel empty inside, in exactly the places where a Blank organ was sewn in. They become very hungry. They do not know for what.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE BLANK TRADE

Seeing Barr's tanks is Dread 3; recognizing someone in them is Dread 4. Abide cannot survive outside the brine without a surgeon (Hand + Stitching, Dire 22, over a week) and if he survives, he weighs twice what the Fast can feed. A Blank Guest is worth 2,000 lacks living to any Second Table buyer, and every hireling the party takes on is a possible seller. Opening a sealed Company barrel breaks Company law: the party's platters are refused at every inn for a year.

▼ THE MISSING HAND



WANTED: a LEFT HAND, female, born in the Grace of 637 to a woman of Low Sett. Generous reward. No questions as to how.

BILL POSTED ON PANG-HOUSES ALONG THE KEST ROAD

Summary. In a guarded barn in Cradlewrack, Dov Marrin and the Assemblers have fitted the Parts of four hundred families into one figure eleven feet long. They call her **Herself**. She has nine arms, forty-one eyes that wept last week, and two chest cavities: the left

holds the heart of Dov's own wife Liss, born to her as a Part at sixty; the right is empty. She breathes, and the lamps lean. She is missing a left hand and a voice. Hester Lowe bore a left hand and is hiding it. Juniper Dell was born saying half a sentence. The roof over Herself was paid for in Second Table coin by Lord Casimir Morwen, who sends the Barn everything his veiled wife delivers; one of the forty-one eyes is the Duchess's. In Plenty 641 Herself turned her head toward the Sill.

From Dr. Lazar Voss's sketchbook, the forty-third sheet. Copies sold to Lady Dalgety at three hundred lacks.

Count of major structures, Herself, as of Carving: arms 9. Eyes 41. Hearts 1, cavities 2. Spines: one complete, one partial

(the partial is not human and not, I think, Vey's: nine-jointed, grey, fits the Sallowreach finger exactly). Note: the right cavity is lined. It has been lined since before Liss's heart went in. Somebody built a place for a second heart and has not yet been born.

The Players.

- ◇ *Cradlewrack*: Dov Marrin; Hester Lowe, who will kill for the hand; Juniper Dell, called Firstword; Ambrose the Eldest Infant, who claims to remember being Vey's left eye; Old Hinge at the Sill; Lord Casimir Morwen and his veiled Duchess; Dr. Lazar Voss of the Vigil, who has drawn the figure and counted more than two of several things.
- ◇ *Sallowreach*: Marrow Jack, the part-thief, who has been buying Cradlewrack Parts on the Rim; Sister Tisane Halloway's jar of grey hinged joints, which fit together.
- ◇ *The Rim*: Petra Quick, who smuggled a Part across the border without knowing it.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	The Assemblers hire outsiders to find the hand. Hester moves house every night. The hand has begun to point.
2	Juniper Dell meets someone, somewhere, who says the other half of her sentence. Nobody hears it but them.
3	The hand is taken, or given. Herself's left arm is complete. She sits up. The pangs fall to seven days.
4	Juniper is brought to the barn. She speaks her half and Herself speaks the other half. The Sill door swings fully open for the first time since the Gorging.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Hand in the Sack.** Hester keeps it in a flour sack, in a basket, under a shawl. It is small, a woman's, warm as a sleeping child, with a pink nail-bed and a crease of fat at the wrist where it ends in smooth closed skin. At night it crawls on its fingertips to the end of the sack and points, through the cloth, toward the Barn; turn the basket and within the hour it has turned back. Hester sings to it. She has bitten one of her own fingers to the bone so as to have something to bite when the singing does not work.
- ◇ **The Breathing Barn.** Inside, a hundred lamps on poles, all leaning inward. Herself lies on straw that smells of a lambing-shed, sheep-fat and warm milk; her forty-one eyes are half-lidded and they move together. When she breathes, the Guests' own breath falls into time with hers within three counts and cannot be made to fall out of it.

What the Guests Can Do. Protect Hester and the hand. Find the person with the other half of the sentence before the Assemblers do. Burn the barn (Herself will not burn easily; she will begin again out

of the ashes). Learn from Dr. Voss's drawing that the figure is not Vey alone: some of its Parts came from outside Cradlewrack, some belong to no god anyone has named, and the empty cavity was lined before anyone knew it would be needed.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Firstborn*: Herself stands, walks to the Sill and goes through. Whatever was describing the view to Old Hinge comes back through the other way.
- ◇ *The Hand Withheld*: Hester refuses to the last and is killed; the hand crawls away into the hills and is never found. Herself lies incomplete and breathing, and Cradlewrack's pangs continue to shorten anyway. It was never the figure the land was in labor with.
- ◇ *The Sentence*: the full sentence is spoken aloud once. Everyone who hears it understands exactly what is being born out of the ground, and when. Nobody who hears it can be persuaded to say it again.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE MISSING HAND

Standing in the Barn is Dread 3; breathing in time with Herself for a full hour adds 1 Regrowth to any Cradlewracker present. Taking the hand from Hester by force is kin-slaying in everything but blood: the Attendance treats it as the murder of a child. Burning the Barn makes the Guests enemies of four hundred families who each gave something of their own body to it. Hearing the full Sentence is Dread 5.

▼ THE SAYER'S SENTENCE



What a Sayer says, is. What she has been writing on her wall for nine years, nobody has thought to read.

GRANDAM CESS OF KNOT CANYON

Summary. Every land with a failing cure has thought of the same thing: go to Oathen, and have Lady Imre Dath, the Sayer, say that it is fixed. What a Sayer says, is. Nobody knows what Tolm would make true if she did. The Bench of Clauses is debating, in forty-page conditionals, whether to take out her golden bit; and she has begun to write her own sentences. The one on her wall is already binding at Course strength. Each night she fails to finish it, it renews. It is waiting for a word. Meanwhile, Chief Clausewright Sorrin Vael swears in his sleep, and his wife has two years of it written down: a treaty between “the party who listens” and “the party who comes late to table,” granting the second party “a chair, and the first portion.”

Draft the Ninety-Second, Bench of Clauses, clause 211 of 418. Marginal hand: S. Vael.

211. That the Regrowth, as it is commonly called, in every land of the Table, shall cease and stand, PROVIDED that no

person now living shall thereby be ended; AND PROVIDED that “cease” shall not be read to include the beating of hearts, the falling of rain, the growth of crops, the healing of wounds, or the bearing of children, being processes the Bench wishes to continue; AND PROVIDED

(margin): every proviso is a door. I can hear something trying the handles.

The Players.

- ◇ **Oathen:** Lady Imre Dath; Sorrin Vael, Chief Clausewright, who would draft the sentence; Ket the Ninth, who must nod; Garl Tome, who made the gold bit, and whose daughter Merit has promised the king her first words, at Plenty, in the Hall of Conditions; Yusra Thole, Rainwarden, whose silence about the late rain is being noticed.
- ◇ **Every land:** envoys from the Vigil (*Let the Vigil sleep and wake*), Brinehollow (*Let the sea return*), Sallowreach (*Let the dead finish*), the Fatlands (*Let the hungry be full*), Cradlewrack (*Let nothing more be born wrong*).
- ◇ **Cross-border:** the Rim Road Company, which needs the Kept Rain kept; the Second Table, which wants a single sentence of its own: *Let the second meal hold*.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Envoys arrive in Tacit and bid. The Bench begins drafting. Lady Imre is caught with chalk and a wall full of her own sentences.
2	An envoy, impatient, bribes a guard. Someone gets into the Gilded Cells with a question. The Sayer answers. A valley in Oathen changes overnight.
3	The Bench agrees on a text, four hundred conditions long, to be spoken at the next unmuzzling. Every faction on the Table tries to alter one clause.
4	The bit comes out. She speaks.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Changed Valley.** A Fatlands envoy’s clerk got in, and asked whether his master’s valley would be fed. *It is full*, said the Sayer. The Guests ride into Low Sorrow the next morning. Every goat, every shepherd, every child in the valley is full: bellies drum-tight and shining, skin split in white stretch-marks from navel to ribs,

and they are sitting very still in the grass, with the patience of people who cannot bend, and they are full of *what*, nobody can say. A shepherd’s lips are blue. He thanks the Guests. He says he has never been so content.

- ◇ **The Wall.** Lady Imre’s cell is gilded and lamplit and the wall behind her bed is chalk to the ceiling, the same sentence ten

thousand times, each one stopping at the same place, mid-word. The chalk on the last line is still wet with spit, because she had no water to wet it with. Her ears, all of them, turn toward the Guests.

What the Guests Can Do. Carry an envoy's bid, or forge one. Guard the Cells or break into them. Edit the sentence, one clause at a time, through bribes, threats and Clausewrights. Read Lady Imre's own wall, where she has written, over and over, a sentence she has never been allowed to say. Learn that nobody has ever once asked the Sayer what she wants.

Endings.

- ◇ *It Is Fixed:* she says the Bench's sentence. Every Regrowth stops dead where it stands. So does every other change, of any kind. See the Secrets chapter.
- ◇ *Her Own Sentence:* she says what she has been writing. It is short. It is about her. The god in her gets what it wants.

▼ EIGHT CHAIRS

◇
*Seven pushed in, one pulled out. Same on the mud,
same in the hill. Somebody's late.*

CRAY LOBBETT, IN THE PICKLED STAIR, DRAWING IN
SPILLED GIN

Summary. Cray Lobbett found a stone table on the seabed of the Uncovered, older than the Gorging, with eight chairs, seven pushed in; the Passenger who rides Orrin Wake says Cray has three visits left before he sits. Hallowboard, at the center of the world, has eight sides. Grandfather Peat, a bog body hauled from the Sump, is the last witness to the Night of Seven Tables and says the god was smiling. Meek Garrity has found the seating plan for Hallowboard, and Sober Osmond a line in the Empty Chair rite about *the one who comes late*. In the Vigil, Aveline Morne has spoken in Bed One: *There is someone at the door who has not been fed. Set another place.* Someone is going to put these together. This is the thread that leads to the Secrets chapter, and it should be the spine of any long campaign.

Transcript, interview with the bog body called Grandfather Peat, Lastgate, by a hired translator of the Sump dialect. Paid by an unnamed College buyer.

Q *You were at the table that night.*

A *At the bank. We were the bank. We stood.*

Q *How many tables were there?*

A *Seven tables. Eight sides to the hill. We laid the seven.*

- ◇ *The Slip:* the sentence is spoken and does not take. A god's word has slipped again, worse than the rain. Every oath in Oathen loosens by a hair, every Forsworn body in the Breakdowns begins, slowly, to heal, and every sworn contract on the Rim begins to fail.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE SAYER'S SENTENCE

Entering the Gilded Cells uninvited is a capital crime in Oathen, tried by the Bench and executed by the Breaking of the trespasser's own oaths. Asking the Sayer a question is the Guest's to regret: the GM decides what becomes true, and it is always true exactly. Altering a clause of the Bench's draft needs Tongue + Clause (Dire 22) or a bribe of 2,000 lacks, and the GM notes which clause; it will matter. Reading the wall is Dread 3, and a Guest who reads it aloud finishes the sentence.

Q *And the god was smiling?*

A *Ours was. Ours had seen him come.*

Q *Seen who come?*

A *(long silence; the translator notes the jaw working with no sound) Write down that I was smiling too. Write down that we were all so glad to be eating that nobody looked behind.*

The Players.

- ◇ *Brinebollow:* Cray Lobbett, who cannot stop going back; Hask Tarn, the only pilot who knows the ground; Ilse Marl, whose transcriptions of the Tenanted's singing make a chart that now runs from the table toward the Headland; the Passenger, who wants a hand at the eighth place.
- ◇ *Sallowreach:* Grandfather Peat; Old Bettany Shroud, whose forty thousand shelved dead all whisper the same word.
- ◇ *The Fast:* Meek Garrity and his plan; Fallow Brindle; Verger Sober Osmond at the Empty Chair; Hollow Ann Pruett with a card on which someone has drawn an empty chair; Welcome Ardent.
- ◇ *The Vigil:* Aveline Morne in Bed One; Matron Cecily Dorm, who writes down what her lips say.
- ◇ *Cross-border:* Archprovost Hesper Lune of the College, reconstructing the chiseled figure; Envoy Prudence Lowell, who has asked that Garrity be left off the winter list, the first death she has ever asked for; the Second Table, who want the eighth line of their menu filled.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Garrity's plan leaks. The Abstinent call it forgery. Lobbett tries to sell the table's location again and finds a buyer who pays in Company platters.
2	Someone brings a translator to Grandfather Peat. He describes the Night in full. He describes the bank behind the god, and what was on it.
3	Rubbings from the seabed table are compared with Hallowboard and with Lune's reconstruction. They match. The eighth chair on the seabed is the only one pulled out, and it faces the same way as the eighth side of Hallowboard.
4	The word Bettany Shroud's dead whisper is the older word for <i>guest</i> . It is said aloud, in full, by someone who has put it together. Everything that has been hiding hears it.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Table on the Mud.** Three miles out on the Uncovered at dead low tide, through ground that sucks to the thigh and smells of rot and something sweet beneath it, like a pantry. The table is black basalt, crusted with barnacles everywhere but its top, which is clean, as if wiped. Seven chairs pushed in. The eighth pulled out a hand's breadth, and in the silt of its seat, a hollow, the shape of someone recently risen. Cray Lobbett sits down on the mud beside it and touches the eighth square he has drawn on every wet surface for a year, over and over, and weeps without noise.
- ◇ **The Lofts Whisper.** Old Bettany Shroud takes a Guest up to the fourth floor of Hall Two at night. Shelf on shelf of the Set-Aside, forty thousand dry mouths, and every one of them moving, and the sound of it is like wind in a field of barley, one word long, again, again. Close enough to a single mouth to hear it plainly is close enough to smell the leather of the lips.

What the Guests Can Do. Everything, and that is the danger. Dive to the table. Interrogate Peat. Steal Garrity's papers, or keep him off the winter list. Sit at Bed One with the Matron's pencil. Visit Hallowboard and count the sides. Each discovery should cost Fray. The right questions in the right order lead, inevitably, to the Secrets

chapter's answers, and the answers are not survivable in any comfortable sense.

Endings.

- ◇ *Counted:* the chairs are counted aloud. It does not matter by whom. The eighth chair, on the seabed, at Hallowboard, at every inn on the Rim, turns from the wall to face the table.
- ◇ *The Silence Kept:* the Guests destroy the evidence and kill or silence those who know. The world goes on not knowing for a few more years. The Guests do not get to.
- ◇ *The Place Card:* at the end of a long investigation, a Guest finds a table laid for them, with a card in the Host's handwriting, and a second card, in another hand, at the chair beside them.

WHAT IT COSTS – EIGHT CHAIRS

Every major discovery is a Dread check, rising: the seabed table Dread 3, Peat's full account Dread 3, the matching rubbings Dread 4, the word itself Dread 5. A Guest who Breaks on this thread gains the Derangement *The Eighth Place* (they must count the chairs in any room before sitting, and cannot sit if the count is even). Silencing Garrity makes the party murderers of a gentle old man for the sake of a Refusal that never happened. The GM should never let this thread be cheap.

▼ THE SECOND TABLE



Your attendance is requested at a supper of seven courses. Dress is grey. Knives are provided. The eighth course will be announced.

CARD, DELIVERED BY HAND, LASTGATE, LACK 641

Summary. In every capital, a few of the highest Cuts are sharpening knives for a meal they intend to eat twice. When the gods finish regrowing, they will eat them again, a few diners instead of a mob, and inherit another six centuries of grace. They are further along than anyone guesses. Prudence Lowell's dispatches are copied at Wanting Post and sold to them, so that the Fast's Register of Damnation has become their menu-calendar. Lord Casimir

Morwen has sold them the date of the Dilation's opening. Commodore Vell means to carry a carving party to the Trench. Lord Absalom Hethe has drawn up plans for a lead coffin. And Wont Bellamy, a heretic on the Fast's own council, wants the Unfed to join them, starting with the one god that is still whole.

Bill of fare, practice supper, the cellar table at Marrable Hall. Found in a dead waiter's apron.

I. A clear broth, of the Lofts. II. Eel, Brinemoss style, with a jelly of the Pickler's making. III. Lark's tongues in tear-salt. IV. A bread that remembers rain. V. Cheek of a Weighed man, slow-roasted, with his own fat. VI. Caul, Morwen house, in pastry. VII. A sorbet of brine, to cleanse. VIII. (left blank; a thumbprint in gravy at the margin)

The Players.

- ◇ *Every land*: the Carvers: Lord Absalom Thrale (Grand Carver, Sallowreach); Lady Seraphine Dalgety (the Vigil); Master Quillon Barr (surgeon); and in every capital two or three Trenchermen of the highest Cut, among them Lord Absalom Hethe in Lastgate, Lord Evander Quell on the Vigil's Stair, Commodore Vell in Brinehollow, Lord Casimir Morwen in Kest and Lord Chastain Loin, who took his own father's heart to the cellar table to be admitted.
- ◇ *The Fast*: Wont Bellamy, who argues the Refusal was only a postponement.
- ◇ *Cross-border*: Lysander Coyle of the Company, selling them the price of the world; Silas Fenwright, whose stolen ledgers would tell them which gods are ripe.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Practice dinners. Guests of standing are invited to one. The dish is not named until afterward.
2	The Table commissions its knives: eight, of grey bone, from a Sallowreach bone-carver who is found Closed afterward.
3	Wont Bellamy carries a motion before the Abstinent: the Unfed should do now what the others did then. Orrum is seen, for the first time, standing still while the Hostwatch approaches, as if waiting.
4	The Second Table gathers at Hallowboard on Tablenight, all of them, around the eight-sided table, with knives, and the Host lies down.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Fifth Course.** Grey candles, grey linen, grey silk veils, each diner with a silver fork laid crosswise. The fifth course arrives under a dome. The meat is dark, fine-grained, glossy with its own fat, and it smells of pork and clove and, faintly, the lavender water the Weighed rub into their skin before the scales. Across the table, a Guest recognizes a signet ring, still on the bone of the finger, garnishing the dish like a sprig of parsley. Everyone eats. Everyone watches who does not.
- ◇ **Loin Served.** On Tablenight 642, if no one intervenes, Lord Chastain Loin attends his last supper as the dish. He is beautifully dressed. He does not seem surprised.

What the Guests Can Do. Infiltrate a dinner and finish the plate. Expose a Carver. Steal a knife. Warn the Fast, which may not believe them. Cut the copying of Prudence Lowell's dispatches at Wanting Post, and blind the Table to which land is ripest. Discover that the Head of the Table presides from an empty chair, and that nobody at the dinners has ever seen anyone sit in it.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Second Meal*: they eat the Host. See the Secrets chapter for what this does. It is the worst thing anyone has ever done.
- ◇ *The Table Turned*: the Guests expose the cult; the Reckoners and the Purgation do the rest. Every High Cut in the world is now suspect, and the Lancings begin on a scale not seen since Brookhythe.
- ◇ *Served*: at the final dinner, the Carvers discover that they are not the diners. The empty chair is occupied.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE SECOND TABLE

Attending a practice dinner and keeping a polite face is Tongue + Deceive (Grim 18); refusing the course marks the Guest as an enemy at the table, and eating it is cannibalism (Feast, Hard 14, to keep it down; 1 Hunger; a Dread 2 check when the dish is named). Exposing a Carver in their own land is a duel with a High Cut and a house. The Second Table never forgets a guest who left early: from then on, every invitation the party receives may be one of theirs.

▼ THE UNDYING FLAME

◆
Burns a month to the inch. No smoke. Slight sound at night; not a fault.

WICK TALLOW'S TRADE CARD, LASTGATE

Summary. The Vigil has ninety days of oil. Lamplighter-General Garron Ashlock has a supplier who doubled his price and a standing order to tell no one. In Sallowreach, fires smolder for decades and nothing can finish, and Wick Tallow renders the unclaimed dead into candles that feel themselves burn and give a very steady light. A Sallowreach flame does not go out. The Vigil has noticed. What Ashlock does not know is that the Vigil has already begun to make its own: Rosamund Kell, a Chandler of the Lamplighters' Guild, has rendered one Counted sleeper taken from the general rows on a Lessening list, where the beds of families ten seasons behind on the Bed-Due are quietly marked. The lamp it fills stands in Ashlock's own office. It does not flicker. It breathes, four times a minute.

Order, Lamplighters' Guild to W. Tallow, Lastgate, by Company post, sealed.

Supply for the Lid, Lack quarter: tapers, long, 2,000; lamp-stubs, 6,000; bracket-candles, 800. Specification as before (adult, unclaimed, no Hand-line). The Guild notes complaints from Brazier Row concerning the sound. Please advise whether a quieter grade is available, e.g. from the very old, or those without tongues. Payment in rouse, at Fogmouth, as agreed. G.A.

The Players.

- ◆ *The Vigil:* Garron Ashlock; Rosamund Kell; Benedikt Lour; the Lamplighters' Guild; Sabine Larch, who supplies the general rows.
- ◆ *Sallowreach:* Wick Tallow, the Chandler; Regent Ansel Grue, who would sell the unclaimed dead by the cartload; the Loft-Wardens, whose forty thousand shelved dead are also, technically, unclaimed.
- ◆ *The Fatlands:* Mistress Brisket Annalow of the Renderers' Union, who supplied the Vigil's tallow and is being undercut; Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot, who has noticed what goes into the Vigil's barrels and notches it in his ledger.
- ◆ *The Rim:* the Company, which must decide whether candles of people are freight or Hush-toll.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Ashlock buys a crate of Tallow's candles in secret. They burn for a month without shortening. He weeps with relief. Rosamund Kell's breathing lamp is set on his desk.
2	A contract is sworn in Oathen. Wagon trains of Kept-candles go east along the Rim. The Lofts begin to empty. Bettany Shroud reports her shelved dead are being taken in the night.
3	The Vigil's street-lamps are lit with people. Citizens can hear them at night, a faint high keening from every bracket. The Seeming begins to show faces in the flames. The general rows thin.
4	A candle is carried out of Sallowreach and should, by the Rule, finish at the Drop. It does not. It keeps burning. Something has changed about what can end, and where.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◆ **The Rendering Shed.** Tallow's yard on the Sinks: copper kettles the size of boats, a smell like a chapel's candle-store crossed with a tannery in summer, sweet, thick and rancid, coating the back of the throat so that food tastes of it for days. A Kept woman is lowered by a hoist into the kettle, awake. She does not scream; Tallow's people sever the jaw-tendons first, as a kindness to the workers. The fat rises in yellow curds. Her hand, sinking last, opens and closes once.
- ◆ **Brazier Row at Night.** Every bracket on the street holds a candle, and every candle sings, very high, on one note, the way a wet finger sings on the rim of a glass, rising when the wind gusts

against it. In the steady flames, if a Guest looks too long, there are faces, eyes squeezed shut, mouths open.

What the Guests Can Do. Guard or hijack a candle train. Speak to a candle (they can hear and, with care, be made to answer). Help Ashlock find another way, or help him justify this one. Bring the Loft-Wardens' witnesses into it: the Set-Aside are aware, and they have opinions about being burned.

Endings.

- ◆ *Light Eternal:* the Vigil lives in a permanent glow of its neighbors' dead, and Sallowreach is paid in rouse and mirrors. Nobody in either city sleeps well.

- ◇ *The Lofts Rise*: the Set-Aside, learning what is planned, refuse. Forty thousand dead begin to whisper the same word louder. The Loft-Wardens open the doors.
- ◇ *The Finished Light*: the candles all go out at once, everywhere, on the night the first Hush opens in the Vigil, four hundred miles from Sallowreach. The Hushes are not bound to the fen anymore.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE UNDYING FLAME

The rendering shed is Dread 3; Kell's breathing lamp, once its source is known, is Dread 3. Speaking to a candle needs Caul + Rites (Hard 14) and costs the speaker a night's sleep, during which they feel the wick. Hijacking a train makes the Vigil go dark faster: every season the Guests hold the Flame at Stage 1, one district of the Lid loses its lamps, and the Dormitory's count rises by a few hundred. There is no version of this thread in which nobody burns.

▼ THE SLIPPING SEAL

◇
She's the Company's knot. Everything else is rope.

A WARDEN OF QUILLHOUSE, OF JESSAMY QUILL

Summary. Oathen's Kept Rain came three days late, and everyone believes a god's promise slipped. Every Company contract, every platter, every bond of every Bonded Hand rests on the word of one notary, Jessamy Quill. If Tolm's word can slip, so can hers, and the Company is secretly preparing a second notary. It does not know what it is pulling on: the **knot at the center of Oathen**. In 601 Quill swore that no other notary of the Rim should be sworn while she lives; Ona Fell, the Surety, stands for an anonymous principal who is Quill; Sorrin Vael drafted both oaths and the Company's instruction, forty years apart, and has never laid them side by side. Swear the second notary and Quill's oath breaks, the Breaking falls on Ona, and Ona has one default left. And the Rain did not slip. Rainwarden Yusra Thole's Tally shows the god kept its word to the hour: Tolm's year has grown three days longer. A heart beats slower when the body it drives grows larger.

Company circular, sealed, to all Spokes. Not to be read aloud within the borders of Oathen.

Re-swearing of Instruments. All contracts, bonds and platters of the Company sworn before Grace 641 are to be re-sworn before witness at the earliest convenience. Wording unchanged. Agents will not discuss the reason. Agents will not discuss the Rainwarden. Agents will note, on a separate sheet, any bonded person who has broken a term and shown no Breaking, with date, hour, and the weather. Agents will not discuss the second seal.

The Players.

- ◇ *Oathen*: Jessamy Quill; Ona Fell, the Surety, one default from death; Sorrin Vael; Yusra Thole, Rainwarden, silent for a month, her pulse pausing for most of a minute; Ottoline Vant, whose miscut word broke a man; Grandam Cess of Knot Canyon, who frees the sworn and whom Ona hates.
- ◇ *The Rim*: First Spoke Odalys Penhallow; Auditor-General Lysander Coyle; Reeve Calder Stokes, the Company auditor in Brinehollow who tasted salt this morning.
- ◇ *Everywhere*: every government that has ever sworn a treaty in Oathen, which is every government.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	A Bonded Hand steals from the Company and does not break. The wardens hang him anyway, quietly. The Company begins re-swearing contracts.
2	Quill becomes ill. Her body shows marks that match no oath she has broken. The Company doubles her guard and readies its second notary.
3	A treaty fails: two lands discover that a border sworn in Oathen two centuries ago no longer binds either side. War is spoken of, carefully.
4	The second notary is sworn. Quill breaks; the Breaking falls on Ona Fell; Ona dies. Half the trade of the Table comes unbound in an afternoon. Every platter is worth its weight in bone and nothing more.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Thief Who Did Not Break.** A Bonded Hand named Teague Orr pockets a platter at Wanting Post, and waits, white, for his fingers to go. They do not. He laughs. He cannot stop laughing; he walks out into the yard laughing and the wardens take him there, and the Guests watch the quiet hanging behind the stables, done with a wagon-chain, Company-fashion, because a man who can break his bond and live is worse for business than a thief.
- ◇ **Ona's Default.** The Surety's chamber in Tacit, if Stage 4 arrives. Ona Fell at her desk, and the oath she stands for coming due all at once, in her body. The Guests hear her joints go first, a sound like knuckles cracked in a quiet church, one after another, wrists, elbows, shoulders, then the long bones, and she does not fall, because she is holding the edge of the desk, and she keeps holding it.

What the Guests Can Do. Protect Quill. Investigate why the Kept Rain was late; Yusra Thole knows and cannot lie, so she will not speak, but her Tally can be read. Find the Company's second notary, and lay Vael's three drafts side by side before anyone swears them. Carry the Company's frantic re-swearing across the Rim. Discover that Odalys Penhallow is preparing for the Company to survive the lands, and what she means to feed the wagons.

Endings.

- ◇ *Unbound:* the Rim dissolves into seven tolls and seven armies. Every land must now get what it needs from neighbors it finds obscene, without a neutral road in between, and it gets it by force.
- ◇ *The New Witness:* the Company finds something else to swear by. It is listening, and it is not Tolm, and it is very glad to be asked.
- ◇ *The Last Wagons:* Penhallow's sealed wagons set out, carrying the Spokes and the archive, around and around the Rim, and the Company becomes a procession with no destination, lit at night, stopping at no inn.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE SLIPPING SEAL

Reading Yusra's Tally and understanding it is Eye + Reckoning (Grim 18) and a Dread 3 check; from then on the Guest knows the god is growing, and every Oathener they meet can ask them about it. Untying the knot without killing anyone requires all three of Quill, Ona and the Company to be re-sworn in one sitting before the Bench: a Dire Tongue + Clause roll by whoever drafts it, with each Lack on that roll costing one of the three their life. Anyone a Guest saves here is in their debt by oath, which, in Oathen, is not a figure of speech.

▼ THE STOLEN LEDGERS

◇
Every line ends. The College only writes down where.

MOTTO OVER THE DOOR OF THE MASTER
CONCORDANCE, QUIRE

Summary. Silas Fenwright, a renegade Lineman of the Cutwrights' College, walked out of Quire with three quires copied from the Master Concordance: the full lines of the highest houses of three lands, and the College's graph of every Regrowth bending upward at the same moment after 600 A.G. Everyone wants them. Whoever holds the ledgers knows where each god is regrowing fastest, and who is next. In the north, Provost Carrion Sedge has already learned what it is to hold a dangerous ledger: his own map of the Hushes has a pinhole in it, and the pinhole is the Hall of Hands, and he has dated the next great Hush to Lack 642, give or take a season.

Page offered for sale at the Groaning Board, Plenty 641. The buyer was found before dawn with the page folded into his

mouth.

House Dalgety, Eye-line. Cut 5 in the direct line since 402. Mean Regrowth of living members: 7.4. Rate since 600: doubled. Projected Seating of the head of house: within the decade. Projected rate after 641: see graph, sheet iv. (Annotation, Lune's hand:) Every curve on sheet iv bends at the same place. Seven gods do not agree on a date unless something has given them one.

The Players.

- ◇ *The College:* Archprovost Hesper Lune; Odo Venn; Provost Carrion Sedge.
- ◇ *Cross-border:* the Purgation, who want a massacre list; the Second Table, who want a menu; the Reckoners, especially Deny Fallon, who wants a target roll.
- ◇ *Every land:* noble houses who would pay anything to have their own line removed, and their rivals' added.

STAGE WHAT HAPPENS

1 Fenwright offers a single page for sale at the Groaning Board. The buyer is murdered before dawn.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
2	A Lancing in the Fatlands follows the ledger's exact order of houses. A Reckoner raid in the Vigil follows the same page.
3	The College's graph is copied and nailed to toll-houses on the Rim. The Bait doctrine takes it as proof. Riots in three capitals.
4	The third quire, the one Fenwright has not shown anyone, is opened. It is a list of every Blank born on the Table in two centuries, with their present whereabouts.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Lancing in Order.** A Gut-line hall in the Fatlands, Purgation lancers at the door with the page in a leather sleeve. They take the household one by one in the ledger's order, grandmother first, a long iron lance at the base of the throat, and the blood that comes out is thick, gravy-brown, sweet-smelling, and pools without spreading. The seventh name on the page is a girl of nine. The lancer looks at the page, and at her, and at the page. The Guests are in the room.
- ◇ **The Graph on the Toll-House.** Seven lines in seven colors climbing a nailed sheet, all bending upward at the same year. Someone has drawn, in charcoal, an eighth line above them, flat, waiting. A crowd is reading it in silence.

What the Guests Can Do. Catch Fenwright, buy from him, or protect him. Return the quires to Quire, or not. Read them, which is a Grim Eye + Lore roll and a Dread 3 check; a Guest who succeeds learns their own line, and what it ends in. Track the Blank list before the Second Table does.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Lists Are Read:* massacre and counter-massacre along family lines in every land. The Regrowth slows a little where the High Cuts are gone. The College records the numbers.
- ◇ *The Ledgers Burn:* the Guests destroy the quires; the Master Concordance at Quire burns soon after, in a fire that no one admits setting. Nobody now knows where the gods are, which helps no one.
- ◇ *Your Own Line:* the ledger shows that a Guest is closer to a Seating than they knew, by far. Every faction that holds a copy knows it too.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE STOLEN LEDGERS

Holding even a page makes the holder a target of four factions; the GM rolls a d6 each week the party carries one, and on a 1 someone comes for it. Reading one's own line changes nothing in the blood and everything in the mind: Dread 4 if it ends in a Seating within the decade. Burning the quires is the only ending that saves the Blanks on the third list, and it blinds everyone, including those who might have used the graph to save a land. Returning them to Quire is a 30-day journey with every road watched.

▼ THE LOW WATER

◇
*The sea says dawn's at the half-bell. Your chests say
it's now. I ring for the chests.*

FINN UNDERTOW, TIDE-BELLMAN OF LOWMARK

Summary. *A new thread.* Every Brinehollower fills with the sea's water at dawn and dusk, and for ten years that tide in the chest has drifted ahead of the tide on the Uncovered. Finn Undertow, who rings the Headland bell for the chests and not for the sea, has done the sum: the drift closes at the Low Water of Carving 642, when every Brinehollower will fill at the same moment. He does not know the drift follows the slow breathing of Ondine Vasht, the Dowager Below, in the cellars under Fathomhouse. That same night Ilse Marl's chart of the Tenanted's singing completes, and Dagna Hull's *Follow* makes its trial descent toward the Trench with Commodore Vell and his knives aboard. Meanwhile Reeve Calder Stokes carries to Tacit the figure Brenna Kelp proved by buckets, *the Kelp*: the sea falls nine hundred and twelve thousand barrels for every soul returned to it. By the Company's tolls, which had the figure first, Brinehollow has eight years and a season, and the Company will sell the price. The Drowned Bench has read Brenna's copy. Justice Maren Oake wrote in its margin: *The figure is correct. The constant will change.*

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Finn rings early and is reprimanded. Calder Stokes sets out for Tacit. Vell tries to buy Ilse's pages and Brenna's working. Whole Miles begin to fill on the same breath.
2	The Number Twice: Brenna's proof and Calder's meet, or are made to. The Admiralty kills to keep one of them quiet. The figure is posted on a tide-post on Mile Fourteen and torn down by morning.
3	The Company prices the coast in Tacit and sells the price. The Deepening prepares its largest procession. The <i>Follow</i> is floated; its air-bladder valve is fitted with a hand-lock on the inside.
4	The Low Water of 642. Every chest on the Table fills at once, and breathes in time with the Dowager Below. The ring on the Uncovered walks. The <i>Follow</i> goes down. The constant changes.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

◇ **The Filling.** In a crowded Lowmark tavern on a drift night, sixty people choke at the same instant, without warning, mid-word and mid-swallow. They go purple together, bent double together, and sixty mouths spill the same cold grey water onto the boards together, a sound like a slop-bucket emptied down a stair, and then they straighten and look at one another, and nobody speaks, and at the far end of the room a man who did

Chalked on the inside of the Headland bell-house door, Lowmark. Each morning the old figure is rubbed out with a wet thumb and a new one written.

377. Chests ahead of the sea by 11 min. Mile Nine filled at the half-bell, all of it, one breath. Dowager's house dark. 376. 12 min. A child on Mile Two filled in her sleep and did not wake for the bell; her mother says she was smiling. 375. 12 min. Rang early. Admiralty clerk again. Told him the sea is not the one that drowns in bed.

The Players.

- ◇ *Brinehollow:* Finn Undertow and his count; Ondine Vasht, the Dowager Below, breathing; Ilse Marl and her chart; Dagna Hull, building a ship to come back, and Hollis Brine, sabotaging it with her own hammer because he heard Nerys Colm's invitation and knows there is no coming back; Commodore Lysander Vell; Brenna Kelp and the Kelp; Justice Maren Oake; Father Ebb, holding a broken chain closed in his fist.
- ◇ *The Rim:* Reeve Calder Stokes and his satchel; Auditor-General Lysander Coyle, who had the constant in 633.
- ◇ *Cross-border:* the Second Table, for whom the *Follow*'s hold is a carving party; the Vigil's brine-walkers, who will reach the coast at the season's end; Cray Lobbett and the table on the mud, toward which, and away from which, Ilse's chart runs.

not finish coughing in time is lying on his face in the wet. Anyone not of the coast in that room is suddenly alone.

- ◇ **The Hold.** Below the *Follow*'s deck, behind a bulkhead Dagna never drew, Vell's hold: hooks, salt-tubs, a rack of eight grey knives, and lead-lined boxes the size of a man's torso, with drain-holes. It smells of cedar and fresh tar and, under that, a butcher's back room. Chalked on the bulkhead, in a neat hand, *First course.*

What the Guests Can Do. Bring Finn's count to the Admiralty, which does not want it, or to the Dowager Below, who may. Put Brenna and Calder in one cellar, the most dangerous meeting in Brinehollow, or keep them apart. Expose the *Follow*'s hold, which makes Dagna strike Vell; expose Hollis, which ruins her; or do nothing, and all three go down together. Read Maren Oake's marginal note and ask the Drowned Bench what the constant will change to.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Coast in One Breath:* the drift closes and does not open again. Brinehollow fills and empties as one body, forever, to the Dowager's breathing, and when she is still, everyone is still. The Admiralty calls it discipline.
- ◇ *The First Course Delivered:* the *Follow* reaches the bottom of the Trench, and Vell's knives find what is reassembling there. The air-bladder rises without anyone aboard. Months later, Second Table diners in four capitals report a dish that tastes of being held.
- ◇ *The Constant Changes:* at the Low Water, the ring walks inland, and the sea follows it, not as a wave but as a long, slow, calm

return, through the people: every Tenanted soul on the coast begins, gently, to weep salt water, and does not stop, and the Uncovered goes dark and wet under the moon for the first time in six hundred years.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE LOW WATER

A non-Brinehollower in a room when the chests fill makes a Dread 2 check; a Brinehollower Guest on the night of Low Water makes a Grim Caul + Resolve roll or walks with the ring, and must be physically restrained (Gut + Labor, Hard 14, each minute for ten minutes). Bringing Brenna and Calder together marks every Guest present for the Admiralty's quiet men and for the Company's auditors. Sabotaging the *Follow* drowns its crew; saving its crew delivers its hold. Anyone who reads the Kelp and understands it takes a Dread 3 check and can never again watch a Tenanted bride walk up the steps without doing the sum.

▼ THREE, ONE, THREE

◇
*There is someone at the door who has not been fed. Set
another place.*

THE LIPS OF AVELINE MORNE, BED ONE, AS
TRANSCRIBED BY MATRON CECILY DORM

Summary. *A new thread.* In Carving 640, Queen Dowager Sibyl Aubrey of Cradlewrack, forty-three years pregnant with a King who has ruled from her womb since 601, felt him kick three times, then once, then three, and again, until dawn. Nobody had asked him anything. It has happened every night since. Absalom Gage, the bricklayer of Kest, feels the same pattern in his walls: the knock the highlands give a new brick, three, then the answer, then three again. Old Hinge hears it from the far side of the Sill, answered from the Queen's chamber. In the Vigil, Corwin Half-Bell, the only man to turn around in the long room and come back, will not stand with his back to a door. In Oathen, between the beats of the new heart under the Gullet, there is a sound like a chair being drawn up to a table. The knocking comes from one place, and is heard in all of them.

*A clapping game of the Kest hills, played by girls on the steps
of the pang-houses. Collected by an Attendance midwife,
Carving 641, who notes that she had never heard it before that
year and that every parish knows it.*

*Knock three, knock one, knock three again,
Who's on the step in the wind and the rain?
Knock three for the bread and one for the cup,
Three for the chair, and nobody get up.
Nobody answer and nobody tell,
Nobody open, and all will be well.*

*(At the last word the girls slap the step three times, then once,
then three, and the one who is slowest must stand facing the
door until the next pang.)*

The Players.

- ◇ *Cradlewrack:* Queen Dowager Sibyl Aubrey and the King Within, whose kick is law; Lord Chamberlain Eamon Seele, who reads him questions; Absalom Gage; Old Hinge at the Sill; Una Knocker, whose longest-bricked debtor has begun, at night, to tap back.
- ◇ *The Vigil:* Corwin Half-Bell, who cannot bear an open door; Sister Vesper Null, who came back from the room on purpose, while the real Vesper stands at the back of it listening to the same knock; Aveline Morne in Bed One; Matron Cecily Dorm and her pencil.
- ◇ *Oathen:* Yusra Thole, whose goatskin of Gullet sand beats once a minute against the ear.

- ◇ *The Fast*: every Unfed household, which closes the door from the outside, opens it, and closes it from the inside, and has done so for six hundred years without anyone remembering why.
- ◇ *The Rim*: every innkeeper on the road, who has begun to hear a knock at the third hour of the night on the door that faces the middle of the continent.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	The King kicks the knock nightly. Gage's new walls knock back. The clapping game spreads through the Kest hills in a single season.
2	The knock is heard in the Vigil: doors in the Dormitory's oldest rows, struck from the room side. Corwin will not enter the building. Rim innkeepers begin nailing their middle-facing doors shut.
3	On a single night the knock is heard in every land at once, at the same hour. In the Fast, a hundred doors are found open in the morning, opened from the outside. Aveline speaks her sentence again, louder.
4	Someone answers. The knock stops, everywhere, for a full night. In the morning the King has turned in the womb, and lies facing north, and Old Hinge reports that the far side of the Sill is quiet, the way a room is quiet after a guest has come in.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The Throne Room.** The Queen Dowager, ninety, propped on a litter in a room of red silk, her belly vast and hard and blue-veined under a linen shift, the skin so stretched that it shines in the lamplight like a skinned grape. The Chamberlain reads a question. Nothing. Then, unprompted, the belly moves: a heel, or a fist, against the drum of her, from inside, three times. The courtiers do not breathe. Once. The Queen's mouth opens without sound. Three. Somewhere below the floor, in the old walls, a brick answers.
- ◇ **The Oldest Rows.** In the Dormitory at the third bell, on a night of Stage 2, a Guest sitting watch hears it: a knock, three, one, three, on the inside of a door at the end of a row where there is no door, only a whitewashed wall. Every sleeper in the row has turned their face toward the sound. Their eyes are closed. Their lips are wet.

What the Guests Can Do. Trace the knock from the Queen's womb to Gage's walls to the Sill to the Dormitory, and draw it on a map, and see that the lines meet. Ask the King, through the Chamberlain, where the knocking comes from; the answer, given by kick, is that it comes from the room with the table. Stop the clapping game. Bring Corwin and Vesper to Bed One at the same bell, where the rows will turn toward them and the knock may be heard from this side. Never, ever knock back.

Endings.

- ◇ *Nobody Answer*: the Guests persuade every land to keep its doors shut and its mouths shut. The knock goes on, nightly, everywhere, forever, and a generation grows up that has never slept through a night without it. The Fast's custom spreads to every land and nobody remembers why.
- ◇ *The King Delivered*: the King is born at last, in the Throne Room, forty-four years late, a man-sized infant with an old man's eyes, and his first act is to knock, three, one, three, on the floor of the world, from this side. Something on the other side is very pleased.
- ◇ *Someone Answers*: the knock stops. Read the Secrets chapter, and decide who opened the door.

WHAT IT COSTS – THREE, ONE, THREE

Sleeping a week within the Aubrey palace gives a Guest the knocking dream; each further week is a Dread 2 check. Hearing the knock in the Dormitory's oldest rows is Dread 3. A Guest who knocks back gains the Derangement *The Late Guest* (they set an extra place at every meal, and become distressed and then violent if it is cleared) and the GM notes that the knock is one door nearer to them. Telling anyone in Cradlewrack that the King is answering, rather than speaking, is treason under the Royal Assent.

▼ THE LEAD COFFIN

◇
You asked to be of use, dear boy. I have found you a use.

LORD ABSALOM HETHE, LETTER TO THE WEST WING OF GLOVEHALL

Summary. *A new thread.* The Second Table has a problem: a god that is regrowing is a god that moves, and the Gorging worked because the Providers held still. Lord Absalom Hethe, Hand of the Court and a Trencherman since 625, has solved it. Osric Vane, Lady Corrow Vane's gentler brother, at the Brink and confined in Glovehall's west wing since his bare hand finished a Fatlands factor in 628, can close anything: a candle, a fly, a conversation, a Kept man through a door. He cannot refuse a request framed as a duty, and he longs to be useful. A Vigil clockmaker has drawn him a coffin, lead-lined, its breathing-holes meshed with lead, to hold in what he does until the lid is opened before a god on a table. Osric leaves Glovehall in Grace 642, declared to the Company as wine.

Company freight docket, Fogmouth, Grace 642, draft. The clerk's pencil note is in another hand.

Consignment: WINE, CLARET, one cask, coffin-form, lead-lined, Hethe cellars, for the account of a gentleman, to be

carried east by the Rim to a destination to be given at Wanting Post. Weight: 14 stone. Handling: KEEP UPRIGHT. DO NOT OPEN. DO NOT SPEAK TO. (Pencil:) Flies dead for twenty paces round the dray. Carter's lamp went out twice. Cask asked me very kindly whether I was well.

The Players.

- ◇ *Sallowreach:* Lord Absalom Hethe; Osric Vane, and his lead mittens, and the Fatlander Pell Ambry, whose face he sees in every face; Lady Corrow Vane, who keeps her brother in the west wing because she loves him and because she is afraid; the Mortuary Court, whose Hushes are fed, in part, by what Osric's presence does to the fen; Edda Thrush, the Hushwalker, who wants to see if Dunmere has moved.
- ◇ *The Rim:* the Company, which carries what is declared; the carters, who will not take the dray twice.
- ◇ *The Fast:* the Hostwatch, who would see the coffin come over the Hem; Orrum, who has been seen, in the Second Table thread, standing still as if waiting; Wont Bellamy, who will meet the dray at Wanting Post.
- ◇ *Cross-border:* Lord Absalom Thrale, Grand Carver; Commodore Vell and Lord Casimir Morwen, each of whom would like the coffin to come to their land's table first.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Hethe visits the west wing with letters and a request framed as duty. Osric agrees, and weeps, and thanks him. The coffin is built in a Lastgate cooper's yard; the cooper's hands go numb and stay numb.
2	Grace 642: the coffin leaves Glovehall. The small Hush in the Glovehall orchard stops growing. Fogmouth watches the dray go and the flies drop around it.
3	The dray moves east along the Rim. What leaks through the lead is enough: wherever it stops, fires gutter out, voices stop mid-word, and the sick die quietly in the night. Inns begin to refuse it. Sallowreach's Hushes, meanwhile, slow.
4	The coffin reaches its table. The lid is opened, in the presence of a god. The god is still.

SCENES THE GUESTS MIGHT WITNESS

- ◇ **The West Wing.** A black double-barred door with a hatch. The sound goes first: footsteps soften, the flies stop, the lamp leans away. Then the voice, warm and educated: *Hello? Is someone there? I promise to keep my eyes shut.* Through the hatch, a gaunt man of fifty-four in a silk blindfold and lead mittens, whose bare wrists, where the mittens end, are grey and smooth as a church floor. He asks the Guests, very kindly, whether Lord Hethe's errand is a good one. He so wants it to be.
- ◇ **The Stopped Inn.** The Guests overnight at a Company inn where the cask is stabled. Nobody at dinner can finish a sentence. The hearth goes out three times and cannot be coaxed.

The landlord's old dog lies down by the stable door and does not get up. Upstairs, a drover who was mending from a cough is found at dawn finished, with his eyes open and his face smoothed of every line, grey and polished as a church step, and his daughter is screaming at the stable for someone to take the cask away.

What the Guests Can Do. Visit Osric and tell him the truth about Hethe's use for him, which will break his heart and possibly the door. Hijack the dray; nobody can bring themselves to open the cask, and nobody should. Learn from the Glovehall gardeners what the Hushes do while Osric is gone, and decide whether a slowed fen is worth a held god. Follow the coffin to see whose table it reaches.

Endings.

- ◇ *The God Held Still*: the lid opens at Hallowboard on Tablenight, and Orrum, which has been running around the Rim laying tables for a year, stops, and lies down, and the Second Table takes up its knives. See the Second Table thread, and the Secrets chapter.
- ◇ *Of Use*: the Guests bring Osric home, or to somewhere better than home, and find him a duty worth his life: an hour a day at the Ferrying Post, mittens off, finishing by consent the Kept who petitioned for a Closing and could never pay. He does it gladly, for years, and the Mortuary Court, which sells Closings at four thousand lacks, never forgives the Guests.
- ◇ *The Lid Lifted Early*: someone opens the cask on the road. Osric, blind, ungloved, terrified, takes off his blindfold to see who has come. Everything within a quarter-mile finishes: people, horses, fires, sounds, the road itself, which is found afterward smooth and grey as his wrists. Osric is found standing in the middle of it, alone, apologizing.

WHAT IT COSTS – THE LEAD COFFIN

Standing in the same room as Osric is Dread 3; seeing him unmittened is Dread 4, and his bare touch finishes anything. Each night spent near the dray, a Guest at Ruin must pass Gut + Endure (Grim 18) or finish quietly before dawn. Stopping it makes enemies of Hethe and the Second Table; telling Osric the truth gives Lady Corrow Vane cause to close whoever told him. Delivering him anywhere at all is choosing what he is for, which nobody has ever let him do.

▼ WHERE THE THREADS MEET

No thread in this chapter is complete on its own. The Deadwatch draws on the Lessening's lists, and the Lessening's lists feed the Undying Flame. The Low Water carries the Second Table's knives to the Trench, and the Lead Coffin carries their stillness to the Host. Brine in the Rouse fills the Vigil with the sea, and the sea's constant is being sold in Tacit while Tacit's god grows three days a year. The

Missing Hand and Three, One, Three are the same labor heard from two ends. And all of them, followed far enough, lead to a long dim room, a table, and a chair that is not pushed in.

The GM need not tell the players this. They will notice. Let them notice in their own time, one knock, one place card, one empty chair at a time, and let the noticing cost them.

SEVENTABLES, AND SEVENPEOPLES AT THEM,
AND EVERY ONE OF US SO GLAD TO BE EATING THAT
NOBODY LOOKED BEHIND.

[GRANDFATHER PEAT, THROUGH A TRANSLATOR, LASTGATE, 641]



PART TWO

THE RULES

*How to make a person of the Table, how dice decide their fate, how the
god in the blood is spent, how the mind breaks, and how violence is
done.*

CHAPTER 11

MAKING A GUEST

Ask a child of the Table who she is, and she will tell you three things, in this order: where her people ate, what part they were given, and what she does to earn her bread. Only then, if you are still listening, will she tell you her name.

— PROVOST CARRION SEDGE, *INTRODUCTORY LECTURES IN CUTWRIGHTING*

**FROM THE INTAKE LEDGER OF THE THIMBLE
CROSS WAYSTATION, RIM ROAD COMPANY,
MONTH OF CARVING, 641 A.G.**

Name: Holloway Brisk. Origin: Fatlands (Low Tilt, says she; accent says Sated). Cut: Gut-line, common. Middling. Bites her nails to the quick and then keeps going. Trade: Renderer, Union card, lapsed. Carrying: three cleavers, a rendering hook, eleven lacks, a jar she will not open. Purpose of travel: "Going north." Asked why: "Because something in the south has my name on it."

Name: Tolly Fane. Origin: the Vigil. Eyes like two holes burned in paper. Cut: Eye-line, low. Has lids, uses them sparingly. Trade: Courier, sworn. Carrying: a sealed satchel, a pin-cushion of needles, rouse enough for nine days. Purpose of travel: Did not answer. Had fallen asleep standing up. Woke before we could catch her. Says she did not.

Name: Lettered Corse. Origin: Cradlewrack. Says he is four. Has a beard. Cut: Caul-line, common. Knocked on my counter before he spoke to me. Knocked on the ledger before I wrote in it. Trade: Foundling Companies, discharged. Carrying: a crossbow, a brick, a trowel, a needle and red thread, a list of women's names, most crossed out. Purpose of travel: "Looking for my mother. Or my father. Whoever it was."

Name: Wenn-something, of Oathen. Would not finish her own name; said the rest of it was owed. Cut: Tongue-line, common. Trade: Surety. Carrying: a ledger she keeps under her shirt, against the skin. Both little fingers bent backward. Smiled at me with her mouth shut. Purpose of travel: "If able, to Gristmoot. Barring weather."

Name: None given. Origin: the Fast, by the look of him. Thin as a fence. Cut: None. Refused bread three times and took it

on the fourth, very politely. Trade: Says "breaker." Has an axe. Carrying: the axe. A place card, folded small, which he showed to nobody but which I saw when he paid. It had his name on it, in a good hand. Purpose of travel: "To find the table it came from."

Clerk's note in margin: Five travellers. Laid the common table for five. Came back from the cellar and there were six places. Have reported this. Have been told to stop reporting this.

Every player except the Carver makes one character, called a **Guest**. A Guest is a person of the Table: born in one of its seven lands, descended from a bloodline that ate some part of a god or refused to, trained in a trade, owing debts and loyalties, and carrying, in all but the rarest cases, a god that is slowly growing back inside them.

Character creation takes about an hour the first time. It works best done together, at the table, so that the Guests can be bound to each other before play begins. A group of strangers who meet at an inn is the oldest beginning there is, and on the Table it is also the most honest: the Rim Road is where everyone ends up.

Groups in a hurry can take one of the seven ready-made Guests at the end of this chapter, one from each land, and be playing in ten minutes. Groups with time to spare can roll on the **Lifepath** tables after Step Nine and let the dice tell them what their Guest ate, buried, betrayed and swore. Neither is required. Both are recommended at least once.



*We ask the land first because the land doesn't change.
Names change. Trades change. The god you were born
carrying is the one you'll be buried carrying, if anyone
bothers to bury you.*

A COMPANY INTAKE CLERK, EXPLAINING THE
LEDGER'S ORDER

▼ THE STEPS

- ◇ **Concept.** Decide, roughly, who you want to play.
- ◇ **Land.** Choose where you were born. This sets your signature attribute, your god, your Gifts and your Wants. Choose or roll a name and a face.
- ◇ **Cut.** Choose your bloodline's station: Blank, Scrapling, Common, Prime or High. This sets how much god is in you, where you start on the Regrowth, and what you own.
- ◇ **Attributes.** Distribute points among Hand, Gut, Lung, Eye, Tongue and Caul.

- ◇ **Calling.** Choose your trade. It gives you skills, a Calling talent, Standing, and starting gear.
- ◇ **Skills.** Distribute skill points.
- ◇ **Knacks.** Choose two Knacks: small, specific advantages.
- ◇ **Derived traits.** Calculate Flesh, Guard, Hunger, Regrowth and Fray, and note your Gifts, Wants and Sop.
- ◇ **The Four Questions.** Answer the Last Meal, the Oath on the Dead, Who Waits at Home, and What You Will Not Do. If you like, roll the Lifepath first and let it answer for you.
- ◇ **Gear and money.** Spend your lacks at the Rim Market.

▼ STEP ONE: CONCEPT

Start with a sentence. *A Seamer from Lastgate who has stitched her own mother back together thirty times and is beginning to resent it. A Fatlands drover who walks herds of things that are not cattle and has stopped naming them. A Clausewright's apprentice who said one careless word as a child and has spent twenty years keeping it.* The best concepts carry a wound and a want, and a reason to be on the road.

Discuss concepts as a group. Guests should have a reason to travel together, or at least a reason not to kill each other. Good shared premises include: a Rim Road Company caravan crew; a Cutwrights' College survey team; a band of pilgrims or refugees; a Purgation cell; the household staff of a dying noble; a Tablebreaker company; strangers stranded at the same inn when the snow comes down and turns out to be fat.

▼ STEP TWO: LAND

Choose the land of your birth. Each land is described at length in Part One; its chapter ends with a section called **Playing a Lander**, which you will need now. The land gives:

- ◇ **+1 to a signature attribute** (applied after you distribute points, and the only way to start at 5).
- ◇ **Your god.** If your Cut is 1 or higher, the god your ancestors ate is in your blood, and the land's rules for the Regrowth apply to

you wherever you go.

- ◇ **Gifts:** powers you gain as the god grows back.
- ◇ **Wants:** the compulsions that come with them.
- ◇ **The Sop:** the act that quiets your god, at a price.
- ◇ **The Tooth:** how your god shows itself when you call on it.

LAND	GOD EATEN	SIGNATURE	THE RULE OF THE LAND
Sallowreach	Ossel, the Closing Hand	Hand	Nothing dies. Everything rots.
The Fatlands	Ummer, the Laden	Gut	Everything is meat. Nobody is full.
Brinehollow	Dromm, the Fathom	Lung	The sea is inside the people.
The Vigil	Iss, the Lidded	Eye	Whoever sleeps never wakes.
Cradlewrack	Vey, the Opening	Caul	Nothing is born right; too much is born.
Oathen	Tolm, the Witness	Tongue	Words bind flesh.
The Fast	Orrum, the Host (refused)	Any one	Never accept.

EXILES AND THE RIM-BORN

A character born on the Rim Road, in a waystation or a caravan, still has a land: the land of the bloodline they descend from. The god goes where the blood goes. A Brinehollower born in a Sallowreach inn still bails at dawn. If your parents were of two

lands, choose one; the other god is too weak in you to count, though the Carver may give you a single Taste of it as a quirk.

◇
*Half-and-halves are the saddest people on the Road.
 They get one god's hunger and the other god's manners,
 and neither land will bury them.*

A WAYSTATION KEEPER AT SALTMILE

NAMES AND FACES OF THE SEVEN LANDS

Each land's chapter gives a longer list of names. The tables below are for the moment at the table when somebody needs a Guest's name, or a stranger's, or a face to go with one, and nobody can think. Roll a d10 for each column separately, or read across a row for a ready-made person. The **Look** is what a stranger notices first.

SALLOWREACH

D10	GIVEN NAME	FAMILY NAME	LOOK
1	Hessa	Coombe	grey-pale, damp skin, hair cropped against flies
2	Fenwick	Strake	long fingers, cold to the touch
3	Merrit	Mead	cedar over something sweeter
4	Tobin	Cask	stooped from the low ceilings of the Pilings
5	Ysolde	Lisp	freckled with old fly bites
6	Amos	Reave	mended coat, mended boots, mended lip
7	Greer	Mallory	hair stained tea-brown by the weep
8	Corlis	Hethe	waxen, haughty, Hand-line still
9	Teal	Rook	small, quick, sore-eyed in daylight
10	Sabine	Coyle	red hands scrubbed raw with vinegar

THE FATLANDS

D10	GIVEN NAME	FAMILY NAME	LOOK
1	Barnaby	Loin	heavy and rosy, sweating in any weather
2	Hessop	Dripping	wide, soft, a belly she is proud of
3	Ruddle	Callock	forearms seamed with cleaver scars
4	Gravy	Furrow	round face, gap teeth from toothed bread
5	Leggat	Strake	thick neck, small kind eyes
6	Haslet	Chine	a tent-coat let out nine times
7	Wilm	Hogget	sunburnt, loam under every nail
8	Petty	Lard	plump, dimpled, gums that bleed
9	Pudding	Tripe	vast and gentle, wheezing
10	Callow	Stockpot	thinner than is decent

BRINEHOLLOW

D10	GIVEN NAME	FAMILY NAME	LOOK
1	Gannet	Lugg	grey-lipped, wet-eyed
2	Kessa	Hawse	barrel chest, rope-burns at the waist
3	Davey	Penhallow	salt-cracked knuckles
4	Haddie	Brack	pupils too wide and too dark

DIO	GIVEN NAME	FAMILY NAME	LOOK
5	Esk	Swell	voice drops an octave when tired
6	Coralie	Weir	sea-tangled hair kept in a net
7	Cobb	Tarn	ears crusted from pressure days
8	Tern	Dulse	an anchor tattooed in kelp-green
9	Ottiline	Reef	thin, cold, damp to the touch
10	Merrow	Gull	a cough like shingle; smells of tide

THE VIGIL

DIO	GIVEN NAME	FAMILY NAME	LOOK
1	Agathe	Larch	bruised half-moons under the eyes
2	Teodor	Wakely	teeth stained brown with rouse
3	Hesper	Startle	palms scarred by pin-gloves
4	Marten	Pinchbeck	bloodshot, one lid twitching
5	Lisbet	Quell	lidless, eyes brushed wet by a servant
6	Ember	Dusk-Bell	thin, jittery, a quick grin
7	Florian	Hobb	studded coat, ruined posture
8	Annick	Lantern	lamp-black ground into the fingers
9	Ansgar	Rell	eyes too bright, pulse visible in the neck
10	Constance	Sexton	sallow, terribly calm

CRADLEWRACK

DIO	GIVEN NAME	FAMILY NAME	LOOK
1	Bryony	Gorse	ruddy, clay-dust in every crease
2	Eamon	Lintel	born old; white-haired at twenty
3	Notyet	Clayhand	born grown; skin too new, no lines
4	Nettle	Seele	a pale ring of caul-scar on the brow
5	Absalom	Danner	a cord-scar at the navel, still pink
6	Clemency	Thrall	broad hands, birthing calluses
7	Corran	Knocker	a man with a bearer's stretch-marks
8	Una	Corse	iron smell in her hair
9	Keep	Hinge	an old face on a young body
10	Tamsin	Calloway	mothers' names tattooed in red clay

OATHEN

DIO	GIVEN NAME	FAMILY NAME	LOOK
1	Sabra	Writ	bit-scars at the corners of the mouth
2	Tav	Brand	lean, sun-dark, one finger set crooked

DIO	GIVEN NAME	FAMILY NAME	LOOK
3	Mags	Seal	ink-stained lips from licking quills
4	Varro	Tell	Forsworn knees that bend backward
5	Dacey	Ward	narrow, attentive, very still
6	Wenn	Hold	bond-tattoos from wrist to shoulder
7	Halvar	Crake	deep-set eyes, slate dust on the cuffs
8	Sele	Kindle	a gold tooth where a jaw once broke
9	Esk	Stane	felt-wrapped boots that make no sound
10	Amn	Fell	lips sealed by an old pale seam

THE FAST

DIO	GIVEN NAME	FAMILY NAME	LOOK
1	Abate	Kettering	gaunt, chapped, bone-white knuckles
2	Forswear	Hume	hollow cheeks, very clear eyes
3	Meagre	Corve	hair thin and dull from hunger
4	Reft	Pruett	tall and stooping
5	Sparing	Lammas	white dead fingertips
6	Withhold	Brindle	undyed greys, patched at the knee
7	Lean	Fennick	sores on the hips from bony sleeping
8	Cease	Hatch	old axe-calluses on both palms
9	Fallow	Kell	wiry, quick, ashamed of any flesh
10	Bounty	Odell	plump from a poacher's captivity



In the Fast we name a child for what she will go without. In the Fatlands they name her for what they'll serve at her wake. Same love. Different kitchen.

ENVOY PRUDENCE LOWELL, IN AN UNGUARDED
MOMENT

▼ STEP THREE: CUT

What part of the god your ancestors were given decides your station, your wealth, and how much of a god you are carrying. Choose one.

CUT	STATION	STARTING REGROWTH	TEETH	STARTING WEALTH
0 — Blank	Born without godsign. Hunted.	0 (cannot rise)	None	10 lacks
1 — Scrapling	The poor; descended from the bone-lickers.	0	One	15 lacks
2 — Common	Tradesfolk, yeomen, clerks.	1	One	40 lacks
3 — Prime	Gentry, guildmasters, minor Cuts.	2	Two	120 lacks

CUT	STATION	STARTING REGROWTH	TEETH	STARTING WEALTH
4 — High	Nobility. The god is close.	4 (the Appetite)	Two	400 lacks and a retainer

Cut 5 exists, but only among the oldest houses, and their members are usually too far gone to walk the Rim Road. It is not available to Guests.

A Scrapling at Regrowth 0 still carries the god: they can Partake, and their first Hunger to fill will take them into the Taste. They simply have not felt it yet. Most Scraplings say they never will. Most of them are wrong by the time they are forty.

BLANKS (CUT 0)

A Blank is a child born with no godsign at all in a land where everyone else has some. Blanks cannot Partake and their Regrowth can never rise, unless they eat godflesh (see the Fast chapter for what happens then). They gain **+2 to any roll made to resist a god's influence** (a Hush, a Calling, an oath's Breaking, a Seated presence), and they never gain Hunger. They are also the most valuable people on the Table. Every land wants them: as saints, as specimens, as surgical stock. A Blank Guest begins play with a **Bounty**: somebody, somewhere, has posted a price for them. Agree with the Carver who.

THE UNFED

A Guest born in the Fast is Unfed, not Blank. They carry no god because their ancestors refused, not because of a fluke of birth.

Their Cut is 0; they gain +1 to any attribute instead of a signature, and use the **Want**, **Pangs** and **Invitation** rules in the Fast chapter. They begin with Want 3 and the Unfed kit described there (ration-cloth, water flask, wax tin, household axe, three days' Pantry measures, a coat that is not warm enough) and, in place of a Cut's starting wealth, **2d6 lacks**: the Fast has no money worth counting. They are not hunted quite as hard as Blanks, but only because there are so many more of them.

HIGH CUTS

Playing a noble means starting closer to the end. A High Cut Guest begins at Regrowth 4, in the Appetite, with the land's Taste and Appetite Gifts already in hand and its first Want already active. They are rich, connected, feared and despised: Scraplings spit at them, Reckoners have their names on lists, and the Second Table sends them invitations. A High Cut Guest also gains **+1 Standing** in their Calling and a **retainer**: a loyal servant (Threat 1, Flesh 9) who will die for them, and probably will.



My lady's god is closer to the surface than mine. I can see it when she laughs. It laughs half a breath later.

A RETAINER OF THE HETHE HOUSEHOLD, LASTGATE

▼STEP FOUR: ATTRIBUTES

Every attribute starts at 1. Distribute **9 points** among them. No attribute may be raised above 4 at this stage. Then add your land's +1. An adult of the Table averages 2 in everything; a 3 is notable, a 4 is remarkable, a 5 is the best in a city.

THE SIX ATTRIBUTES

- ◇ **HAND**: dexterity, violence, delicacy, craft. Picking a lock, gutting a pig, stitching a lip, cutting a throat.
- ◇ **GUT**: strength, toughness, endurance, appetite. Carrying a corpse, holding down poison, taking a beating, eating what must be eaten.
- ◇ **LUNG**: speed, agility, stamina, stealth, breath. Running, climbing, hiding, swimming, outlasting.
- ◇ **EYE**: perception, reason, memory, learning. Noticing the extra joint, reading the ledger, remembering the face.
- ◇ **TONGUE**: persuasion, deceit, command, oaths. Talking, lying, bargaining, swearing, and knowing when to say nothing.
- ◇ **CAUL**: will, instinct, faith, the uncanny. Resisting your god, enduring horror, praying, feeling the thing in the next room before you see it. Named for the membrane some are born in.

▼ STEP FIVE: CALLING

Your Calling is how you earn your bread. Each Calling gives:

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** +1 to each of three listed skills (this may raise a skill to 4 at creation).
- ◇ **A Calling Talent:** a unique ability.
- ◇ **Standing 1** in the Calling's institution, guild or loose fellowship. Standing measures how much the Calling's people trust you and what they will give you. It rises from 1 to 5; each Calling has its own ladder of titles.
- ◇ **Starting gear,** in addition to what you buy.

The seventeen Callings below are found in every land, though they take local shapes. A Sallowreach Seamer sews the dead together; a Brinehollow Seamer opens drowned chests at high tide. The Carver may allow a Calling to take a faction's form described in the land chapters (a Waker as a Nightwarden, a Netwatch lieutenant as a Nightwarden, a Thin faster as a Purger, a Dream-Diver as a Delver).

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Threader	Guild lodging, cheap thread, permission to practise
2	Stitcher	Access to the guild's corpse-stock for practice; 10% off services
3	Seamer	Your own clients; a Seamer's mark that opens hospital doors
4	Master Seamer	Apprentices (2); a seat at guild councils; surgeries in any city
5	Guild Elder	The guild acts on your word; Thessaly Mort knows your name



You learn to sew with the patient talking. Great-grandmother tells me which stitch she prefers. She is usually right.

A THREADER OF THE LOWER PILINGS, LASTGATE

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A Kept client in for her spring restitching wears a hand that is not hers, stitched at the wrist on your own work.
- ◇ A waystation pays you to open a traveller who died three days ago, outside Sallowreach, and is still warm.
- ◇ Dr. Halloran Quease wants help cataloguing his four hundred and first kind of pain. He pays in Closing-minutes.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Tally-Clerk	Lodging at Company waystations at half rate
2	Factor	A line of credit of 100 lacks; a mule
3	Senior Factor	Your own caravan contract; credit 500 lacks; 4 Wardens on hire

Each Calling closes with a testimony from someone who practises it and three **Calling Hooks:** situations the Carver can drop on a Guest of that trade, any one of which is a session. Players may pick one hook as the reason their Guest is on the road at all.

SEAMER

Surgeons, embalmers, bone-setters, suture-witches and stitchers of the dead. In Sallowreach they are the Guild that holds the country together; elsewhere they are the only people who will open a body and look at what is growing in it.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Stitching, Endure, Reckoning.
- ◇ **Talent — Tight Seams:** when you treat a wound, the patient recovers +2 Flesh. Once per session you may perform a **Reseat** on a character at 0 Flesh: roll Hand + Stitching vs Grim (18); on a success they do not suffer a new Injury from this Ruin.
- ◇ **Gear:** a roll of needles and awls, gut and wire thread, a bone saw, a jar of vinegar, a flask of something for the pain.

FACTOR

Clerks, buyers, caravan-masters and agents of the Rim Road Company and the merchant houses. They price everything, including you.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Haggle, Reckoning, Clause.
- ◇ **Talent — The Company Rate:** you buy at 20% less and sell at 20% more than listed prices on the Rim Road. Once per session you may produce a document (a letter of credit, a toll waiver, a manifest) that gets you or a cargo past a single checkpoint without a roll.
- ◇ **Gear:** a ledger, ink, a Company seal, a set of bone-coin scales, a lockbox, 20 extra lacks.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
4	Road-Master	Authority over a stretch of the Rim and its tolls
5	Director	A voice in the Company's Oathen-sworn councils



Everything has a price. The trick is to be holding the ledger the day somebody finds out what theirs was.

A SENIOR FACTOR AT GRISTMOOT

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A Chute barrel you signed for comes back unopened. Inside is a letter in your hand that you never wrote.
- ◇ Notary Jessamy Quill has a fever, and the contracts on your stretch of road have begun, slightly, to loosen.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hired Blade	Steady pay (2 lacks a day on contract)
2	Sworn Warden	Oathen-sworn contract; a mount
3	Sergeant	Command of 6 Wardens
4	Captain	Command of a waystation's garrison
5	Marshal of the Rim	Command of a stretch of road and everything on it



Two lacks a day to stand between a cart and whatever wants it. Nobody asks which side I would rather be on.

A SWORN WARDEN AT SALTMILE

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ Your caravan carries a cage-cart marked *livestock*. The livestock says *please*, politely, on the hour.
- ◇ Escort a Kept deserter to Lastgate. If he crosses the border he drops, and he very much wants to.
- ◇ A post-coach arrives on time with every passenger in their seat, smiling, eating air.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Copyist	Access to the College's public ledgers
2	Surveyor	Travel papers; the right to demand an examination
3	Lecturer	Access to restricted ledgers; College lodging anywhere
4	Reader of Lines	Your rulings are accepted in courts of four lands
5	Provost	You know where every god is regrowing fastest

- ◇ A waystation records one more traveller every night than it has beds. The extra one pays in very old coin.

WARDEN

Road guards, sellswords, caravan muscle, bounty-collectors. The Rim Road Company employs ten thousand of them; the Admiralty and the Mortuary Court and the Board of Plenty employ more.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Blades, Endure, Intimidate.
- ◇ **Talent — Shield the Cargo:** when an adjacent ally is hit, you may take the blow instead (before damage is rolled). You gain +2 Armor against it.
- ◇ **Gear:** a sword or axe, a crossbow and 12 bolts, boiled leather armor, a Company tabard or local equivalent.

CUTWRIGHT

Genealogists of the Cutwrights' College. They trace every bloodline back to the portion its ancestors ate. Their ledgers decide marriages, inheritances and executions.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Lore, Reckoning, Search.
- ◇ **Talent — Read the Line:** by examining a person for a few minutes (eyes, hands, teeth, the smell of their sweat), you can roll Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) to learn their land, their Cut, and their approximate Regrowth stage. With a Helping you also learn one Gift or Want they have.
- ◇ **Gear:** a portable ledger of the major lines, calipers, a magnifying glass, a sample case of dried blood.

◇
*I read a man's blood the way a priest reads scripture:
slowly, looking for the passage that damns him.*

A SURVEYOR OF THE COLLEGE

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A Scrapling family's last three children were born with Hand-line hands. Someone has explaining to do.
- ◇ Two houses await your ruling on a marriage. Both offered bribes; one offered a threat, the better offer.
- ◇ A page has been cut from the College's oldest ledger. You copied it as a novice, and remember it.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Scrivener	Bench lodging in Tacit
2	Drafter	You may witness contracts for fees
3	Clausewright	The Bench recognises your drafting; foreign courts fear it
4	Senior of the Bench	Treaty work; diplomatic immunity in three lands
5	Chief Clausewright	You draft the sentence a Sayer speaks

◇
*As I now intend, barring weather, illness, death and
the god's own reading: good morning.*

A DRAFTER OF TACIT, GREETING HER NEIGHBOUR

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ The Vigil wants a treaty clause that binds a whole city to stay awake, drafted by Tablenight.
- ◇ A merchant has found the Exit you buried in his contract twelve years ago, and hired a Breaker.
- ◇ You are asked to draft the Exit in this year's Sayer's sentence. One wrong word stays true forever.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Bondsman	Small contracts
2	Surety	Contracts worth hundreds
3	Senior Surety	Noble clients; your scars are your credit
4	Pledgemaster	The Rim Road Company's oaths
5	Ledger-Bearer	Treaties between nations ride on your body

CLAUSEWRIGHT

Lawyers, contract-drafters and oath-makers, trained in Oathen and hired everywhere. Abroad they draft treaties; at home they draft the sentences by which the condemned are made to break themselves.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Clause, Persuade, Lore.
- ◇ **Talent — Exits:** you speak in careful conditionals. Once per scene, when you would be bound by your own words (an oath in Oathen, a contract, a promise sworn on the dead), you may declare the clause you buried in it: roll Tongue + Clause vs Hard (14) to escape the binding without penalty.
- ◇ **Gear:** a quill-knife, a writing case, sealing wax, a copy of the Book of Conditions, a soft leather bit (in case).

SURETY

People who carry other people's oaths for a fee, taking the risk of the Breaking in their own bodies. In Oathen they are a profession; elsewhere, they are guarantors, hostages, co-signers, and the ones sent when somebody's word has to be backed by flesh.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Endure, Clause, Resolve.
- ◇ **Talent — Borne Weight:** you may take on another character's oath, debt or curse (with their consent and a ritual of a few minutes); the consequences of breaking it fall on you instead. You gain +3 Flesh permanently from the toughening that comes with the trade, and you ignore the first Injury each session.
- ◇ **Gear:** a ledger of the oaths you carry (start with 1d6 small ones from paying clients, and 30 extra lacks), bandages, splints.

◇
*My left hand belongs to a spice merchant in Gristmoot.
 My knees are mortgaged to a marriage in Tacit. The
 rest is mine until Carving.*

A BONDSWOMAN OF THE BREAKDOWNS

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A client whose Weight 3 oath you carry has vanished on the Rim. If he breaks, you break. Find him first.
- ◇ A widow begs you to stand for her son's marriage vow. You have met the son. He cannot keep it.
- ◇ Your oldest bond has begun to ache, though its principal has done nothing. The words themselves are changing.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Watcher	Pay, a beat, a warrant to detain
2	Warden of the Night	Authority to enter homes
3	Lieutenant	Command of a patrol of 8
4	Captain	A district
5	Commander	The land's whole watch answers to you

◇
*We don't save them. We bring them back. People think
 that's the same thing for about a week.*

A NETWATCH HOOKER OF THE MILE

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A woman you hauled from the surf thanks you at your door every morning, in a voice lower than it was.
- ◇ The Wakers need an outsider for a blink-murder: every local was awake at the time, and none remembers.
- ◇ The ground on your beat has been warm three nights running, in a line toward your own house.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Spit-Hand	Kitchen work anywhere
2	Cutter	Union card; access to slaughterhouses
3	Master Renderer	Your own shop or kitchen
4	Barrel-Warden	You stamp the export barrels
5	Union Boss	Every barrel on the Rim Road stops at your word

NIGHTWARDEN

The uncanny police of the Table: the Netwatch on the Brinehollow shore, the Wakers with their needles, the Echo-Wardens of the silent gorges, the Hostwatch trackers of the Fast, the Loft-Wardens of the Set-Aside. Their work is to watch for the god and drag people back from it.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Instinct, Search, Intimidate.
- ◇ **Talent — Seen It Before:** you gain +2 on Dread checks against horrors of your home land, and once per session, when someone near you fails a Dread check, you may grab, slap, needle or shout them back: they reduce the Fray gained by your Caul rating.
- ◇ **Gear:** the local tools of the trade (boathook and net, needle and rattle, lantern and horn), a lantern, a whistle, a warrant.

RENDERER

Butchers, slaughterers, salters, cooks and shippers of meat. In the Fatlands the Renderers' Union decides what leaves the country; on the Rim Road every inn needs a cook who does not ask questions.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Blades, Feast, Labor.
- ◇ **Talent — Know the Cut:** by taste, smell or a single cut, you can tell what a piece of meat used to be: species, age, and roughly how it died. On a Hard (14) Eye + Feast roll you can tell whether it was a person, and on a Helping, which one. You also gain +1 damage with cleavers and knives.
- ◇ **Gear:** a set of cleavers and knives, a rendering hook, salt, a leather apron that will never be clean again.

◇
A good renderer doesn't ask what it was. A great one knows without asking, and keeps her mouth shut.

A CUTTER AT THE CHUTE

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A barrel you stamped reached the Vigil with a letter inside: *tell my sister Merrin I was Reaped*. Merrin has found you.
- ◇ The Union needs you to taste a shipment and swear it is beef. It is not beef.
- ◇ A Rim inn hires you as cook. The last cook left his knives and a notebook listing the guests by weight.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Handmaid	Lodging with any midwife's house
2	Midwife	You attend births alone
3	Senior Midwife	Your Second Opinion is law in your district
4	Matron of the Attendance	Command of a lying-in house
5	Midwife-Paramount	You are the government

◇
Three heartbeats. I give everything three heartbeats to show me what it is. Then I ask the second question.

A HANDMAID OF THE ATTENDANCE, KEST

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A guest at a Rim inn has been in labor for three weeks. Nothing has come. The cellar door will not stay shut.
- ◇ A shepherd arrives carrying, and begs you to let what he bears stay. He has already named it.
- ◇ The Assemblers offer a fortune for the whereabouts of a delivery you attended last winter. They know it was a hand.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Runner	Contacts in two lands
2	Hauler	A safehouse; regular cargo
3	Route-Holder	A route of your own and three runners
4	Night-Factor	A network across three lands
5	Boss of the Dark Road	The Company pays you to leave its cargo alone

MIDWIFE

Trained by the Attendance of Cradlewrack or by the village wise-women of the other lands. They bring things into the world and decide whether they stay. Abroad, they are also the best surgeons of the belly on the Table.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Stitching, Instinct, Rites.
- ◇ **Talent — The Two Questions:** you can tell at a glance whether a living thing is what it appears to be (Caul + Instinct vs Routine 10 for the obvious, Hard 14 for a Tenanted, Grim 18 for a Seated). You also gain +2 on rolls to treat or deliver anything, of any kind, from any body.
- ◇ **Gear:** an apron, birthing tools, a knife called the Second Opinion, cord-ties, a ledger of names.

CRUMB-RUNNER

Smugglers, carters and night-haulers, who move food and contraband across borders the law says are closed. Despised by the people they feed.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Stealth, Wayfaring, Deceive.
- ◇ **Talent — Hidden Hold:** any cart, pack or boat you load has a hidden compartment that will not be found except on a Grace. You know one safe route between any two adjacent lands, and on the Rim Road you travel a third faster than others.
- ◇ **Gear:** a handcart or mule, oilcloth, rope, a dark lantern, a forged travel pass.

◇

They spit on me at noon and wait at the gap in the wall at midnight. I don't mind the spit. Nothing else in the Fast is wet.

A NIGHT-HAULER OF WANTING

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ Your grain arrives warm and smelling of new bread. Something laid a table in your cart on the road.
- ◇ Three hundred starving Fatlands pilgrims will pay for passage to the table where they will finally feel full.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hand-for-Hire	Small bounties
2	Taker	Notice of bounties in two lands
3	Licensed Taker	A legal warrant in one land
4	Huntmaster	A crew of 5; noble clients
5	Purveyor	The Second Table buys from you directly

◇

Every Blank is somebody's child, and every bounty is somebody's rent. I carry the difference.

A LICENSED TAKER ON THE FAST BORDER

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A new bounty for a Blank girl matches your little sister in every particular.
- ◇ The Board wants a runaway Gut-line heir back before the Weighing. He begs you, between mouthfuls, not to.
- ◇ A buyer in a silk mask wants an unspoiled Unfed adult, alive, by Tablenight. The fee is a house.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Acolyte	Shelter in your faith's houses
2	Celebrant	You may lead rites
3	Elder	A congregation of 30
4	High Celebrant	A temple, a district, a flock of hundreds
5	Prophet	They will walk into the sea if you ask

- ◇ Your eastern safehouse is a Seated house now. The family has laid your place, and they have your cargo.

TAKER

Bounty hunters, poachers and kidnappers: the people who catch Blanks for the surgeons, Called for the Netwatch, runaways for the Board, and Unfed for the trade. A loathsome calling, and a profitable one. Guests who take it are usually trying to stop.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Wayfaring, Brawl, Search.
- ◇ **Talent — Taken Alive:** you gain +2 on rolls to grapple, bind, track or subdue. Damage you deal can be declared non-lethal at no penalty. You can tell a Blank or an Unfed on sight.
- ◇ **Gear:** manacles, a weighted net, a cosh, a cage-cart (or rights to one), sedative syrup.

CELEBRANT

Priests, rite-keepers, mourners and cult preachers: the Finishers of Sallowreach, the Bedded of the Vigil, the Deepening of Brinehollow, the Barren Order, the Quiet, the Starved Saints, and the hedge-priests of the Three Doctrines. Whatever they preach, they are the ones people come to when someone they love starts to change.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Rites, Persuade, Resolve.
- ◇ **Talent — The Words Over the Body:** once per scene you may lead a rite: everyone present who joins you removes 2 Fray. Once per session, you may preach to a crowd (Tongue + Rites vs Hard 14) to move it to an act of faith or fury.
- ◇ **Gear:** vestments, a holy book of your doctrine, candles, incense or vinegar, a relic of doubtful origin.

◇
They come to me when someone they love starts to change. I tell them the god is merciful, and then I go home and wash my hands raw.

A HEDGE-PRIEST OF THE RIM

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A family asks you to bless their Kept grandmother's unlicensed Closing. She has asked you, privately, not to.
- ◇ A Bait-doctrine tract is found sewn into your vestments, in your own stitching.
- ◇ The properly buried dead of a Rim village have stopped staying put, and ask for a priest by your name.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Picker	You know where the pickings are
2	Gleaner	A fence who pays fair
3	Salvage-Boss	A crew of 4; a claim
4	Wreck-Lord	Claims across a district
5	Master of Leavings	Every fence on the Rim knows your mark

◇
Everybody leaves something. The dead are generous. They have no use for any of it, and they almost never ask for it back.

A PICKER ON THE UNCOVERED

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A wreck far out on the Uncovered has its crew at their posts, dry as paper. The log is dated next year.
- ◇ A Kept noble pays you to steal back his right hand from the seamer who bought it. He feels what it is used for.
- ◇ Mags Weir offers you her best claim for half shares. Her last three crews went out to it and went quiet.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Novice	A patron who pays per descent
2	Delver	Maps of the near reaches
3	Veteran	Your own expeditions
4	Pathfinder	State commissions
5	The One Who Came Back	Your maps are the only maps

GLEANER

Scavengers, salvagers, rag-pickers, grave-robbers and part-thieves: the salvage crews of the Uncovered, the gleaners behind the Fatlands harvesters, the diggers of the Sump. They know the worth of what others have left behind.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Search, Filch, Craft.
- ◇ **Talent — Something Worth Having:** once per session, in any place where people have lived or died, you find something useful: a tool, a coin purse, a key, a relic, a body part of value. Roll Eye + Search vs Hard (14); each Helping adds 10 lacks of value. You also halve the time it takes to search.
- ◇ **Gear:** a pry-bar, a sack, a shovel, a lantern, gloves, a fence's name.

DELVER

Explorers of god-places: the Dream-Divers of the Vigil, the Hushwalkers and surveyors of Sallowreach, the pilots of the Uncovered, the watchers at the Dilation, the trackers who follow the Host. They go where the god is closest and come back changed, if they come back.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Athletics, Instinct, Godsign.
- ◇ **Talent — Gone Under:** you may spend an hour preparing to enter a god-place (a Hush, the long room, the Trench, a crowning). While inside, you gain +2 to all rolls and reduce Fray gained by 1 (minimum 1). When you come out, gain 1 Hunger (or 1 Want, if Unfed).
- ◇ **Gear:** a tether-line and harness, chalk, a compass that may not work, smelling salts, a death-mask or veil.

◇
*It is like a room you have always known, and someone
has only just left it, and the chair is still warm.*

A DREAM-DIVER AFTER HER SECOND DESCENT

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ A collector wants a sound carried out of a Hush, any sound made inside before it fell silent. He has a jar ready.
- ◇ The Dilation's watchers need someone lowered into the crowning before the next pang. The last one is still on the rope.
- ◇ A Dream-Diver's tether came up cut clean. You are going down to find the other end.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Penitent	Shelter in Purgation safehouses
2	Purger	Access to the cell's resources
3	Cell-Elder	Command of a cell of 6
4	Voice of the Purge	A district's cells
5	The Clean Hand	You decide which bloodlines burn

◇
*Bring it up. What comes out of you isn't you. That is
the whole of the faith, and on bad nights the whole of
the doubt.*

A PENITENT IN SATED

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ Your cell will burn a High Cut house on Tablenight. A scullery girl who once hid you sleeps in its kitchen.
- ◇ One of your purges ended in a Grace and the Regrowth went back. Now everyone wants you, including a silk-masked noble.
- ◇ A Thin defector brings a Board list of every Purgation safehouse in the south. One is your mother's.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Brother/Sister of the Knife	A cell's protection
2	Reckoner	Your own targets
3	Raid-Leader	Command of a raid of 6
4	Reckoner-Captain	Authority to declare a bloodline ended
5	The Hand of Hallowboard	The Abstinent listen to you

PURGER

Members of the Purgation: the cross-border movement that believes the gods can be thrown back up. Purgers range from gentle fasters and bleeders to the cells that burn high-Cut houses with the families locked inside.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Feast, Rites, Stealth.
- ◇ **Talent — Bring It Up:** you know the emetics, bleedings and fasts. Once per day, you may spend an hour purging yourself or a willing (or held) subject: roll Gut + Feast vs Hard (14); success removes 1d6 Hunger, a Helping removes 1 more, a Grace lowers Regrowth by 1 (only once per stage). The subject suffers 3 damage and is Weakened (–2 to all rolls) for the rest of the day.
- ◇ **Gear:** a Purgation kit (emetics, lancets, leeches, a basin), a hair shirt, a hidden pamphlet, a list of names.

RECKONER

Zealots out of the Fast who carry the Refusal across the border on a blade, killing the highest Cuts of the Godeaters in their beds. Nearly all are Unfed; a few are converts from Scrapling families who hate their lords. Taking this Calling makes you a wanted murderer in six lands.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Blades, Stealth, Resolve.
- ◇ **Talent — In Their Beds:** you deal +4 damage against an unaware target, and +2 damage against any target of Cut 3 or higher. You can sense godsign on a person (Caul + Instinct vs Routine 10) and estimate its Cut.
- ◇ **Gear:** a long knife, a garrotte, dark clothes, a ration bag, a list of names with some crossed out.

◇
I don't kill people. I end lines. Stand once in a High Cut bedchamber and smell what breathes under the covers.

A RECKONER, UNDER QUESTIONING IN LASTGATE

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ The next name on your list belongs to the family that hid your mother from the Takers.
- ◇ A target waits up for you, door unbarred. He is at the Brink and wants it done before he Seats.
- ◇ A brother of the knife came home from a year undercover with godsign under his sleeves. The cell wants you to decide.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Cadet	An allowance of 5 lacks a day
2	Heir	A household of your own
3	Lord or Lady	A seat in your land's councils
4	Head of a House	The house's wealth and its feuds
5	Great House	A crown, a bench, a court, or a hill

◇
Mother says the god prefers our blood. Mother has not left her bed in nine years, and the bed has put down roots.

A GUT-LINE CADET, AT A SATED DINNER

SCION

The children of the Cuts who rule: the disinherited Heirs of Sallowreach, the Gut-line heirs being fattened for the Board, the lidless children of the Watch, the heirs of the Caul-lines in their membranes. A Scion has money, a name, a bloodline the god prefers, and a family that will not let them go. Requires Cut 3 or higher.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Persuade, Lore, Godsign.
- ◇ **Talent — The Name:** your family name opens doors. Once per session you may invoke it to gain an audience, a loan of up to 100 lacks, a bed, or the cooperation of a minor official, with no roll. The family will ask for something in return. Your Teeth add +1 each to the total when you Partake.
- ◇ **Gear:** fine clothes, a signet, a horse or litter, a servant (Threat 1), a letter of introduction, 100 extra lacks.

Calling Hooks:

- ◇ You are summoned home for your own wedding, to a cousin of the closest kind the College still permits.
- ◇ A silver fork arrives in a velvet box, with an unsigned invitation to dinner on Tablenight.
- ◇ You find a Reckoner list. Your name on it has been crossed out, neatly, in a hand you know.

▼ STEP SIX: SKILLS

Distribute **18 points** among the twenty-four skills. No skill may be raised above 3 with these points (Calling Skills may then go to 4). A

skill at 0 can still be rolled; you simply add nothing for it.

RATING	MEANING
0	Untrained. You have seen it done.
1	Novice. You can manage when it is easy.
2	Trained. A journeyman's competence.
3	Expert. The best in a village.
4	Master. The best in a city.
5	Legendary. People travel to watch.

THE TWENTY-FOUR SKILLS

- ◇ **Hand** — **Blades** (knives, swords, axes, cleavers, sickles), **Brawl** (fists, teeth, grappling, clubs), **Shooting** (bows, crossbows, slings, harpoons, thrown), **Stitching** (surgery, first aid, medicine, embalming, seaming the dead).
- ◇ **Gut** — **Endure** (pain, poison, cold, exhaustion, disease), **Labor** (lifting, digging, hauling, breaking), **Feast** (eating the inedible, drink, drugs, tasting, cooking), **Intimidate** (threat by presence and size).
- ◇ **Lung** — **Athletics** (running, climbing, swimming, dodging), **Stealth** (hiding, sneaking, shadowing), **Wayfaring** (travel, riding, driving, foraging, the Rim Road), **Filch** (pockets, locks, sleight of hand).
- ◇ **Eye** — **Search** (finding, noticing, investigating), **Lore** (history, theology, the Cuts, the lands), **Craft** (making and mending things), **Reckoning** (numbers, ledgers, clocks, mechanisms, natural philosophy).
- ◇ **Tongue** — **Persuade** (honest argument, charm, seduction, comfort), **Deceive** (lies, disguise, forgery), **Haggle** (prices, bribes, trade), **Clause** (law, contracts, the drafting of oaths).
- ◇ **Caul** — **Resolve** (enduring horror, resisting compulsion), **Rites** (prayer, ritual, the doctrines, burial), **Instinct** (danger sense, reading people, the uncanny), **Godsign** (understanding and controlling the god in the blood).

Every Guest should think about **Resolve**, the skill the Table tests most and forgives least. A Guest with Resolve 0 will Break early and often; that can be fine to play, but choose it, do not stumble into it.

▼ STEP SEVEN: KNACKS

Choose **two Knacks**. Each is a narrow edge, a habit, or a scar that pays. More can be bought with Portions (see Advancement). Some have requirements. Knacks that smell of one land are open to any

Guest, though the Carver may ask how a Fatlander came by *Echo-Wise*.

KNACK	REQUIREMENT	EFFECT
Anchored Sleeper	—	You never walk in your sleep. +2 to resist any god's pull that comes for you while you rest (the Calling, the Water, a laid table at night).
Bail-Lunged	—	Hold your breath for (Lung × 2) minutes; +2 to resist drowning and smoke.
Bitten Tongue	Tongue 2	Once per scene, stop yourself mid-sentence and unsay it before it lands. In Oathen, it does not bind.
Blind Count	Eye 2	Entering a room, you always know how many living people are in it, including the hidden. Not who.
Bone-Coin Nose	—	Tell counterfeit lacks, false seals and forged notes by smell (Routine 10).
Bone-Setter	Stitching 1	You set breaks in the field. Broken Arm and Broken Leg Injuries heal in half the time.
Breaker's Swing	Labor 2	+4 damage against doors, furniture and anything built. One blow splits a laid table.
Bricklayer's Patience	Craft 1	Wall yourself into a room in ten minutes with brick, mortar and trowel; it holds against any opening until dawn.
Butcher's Calm	—	Ignore Dread 1 from bodies and gore entirely.
Cold Supper	—	You need eat only every other day without penalty.
Company Card	—	You hold a Rim Road Company tally-card: one free night a week at any waystation, and Wardens give you the benefit of the doubt.

KNACK	REQUIREMENT	EFFECT
Conditional	Tongue 3	When lying, you may reroll one die, once per scene.
Corpse-Handler	—	Lifting, washing, dressing or searching the dead needs no roll; +2 Search on a body.
Corpse-Road Walker	—	+2 to travel and navigation rolls through fen, Uncovered or empty farmland.
Counting Habit	Eye 3	Once per session, ask the Carver how many of something there are, and get the true number.
Death-Mask	—	Your face gives nothing away. +2 to resist anyone reading your fear, your lies, or your Partaking.
Dirty Fighter	Brawl 2	Your unarmed attacks deal 2 and can blind for a round on a Helping.
Dowager's Patience	Caul 3	Once per session, take an action you were compelled not to take by a Want, without a roll.
Eats Anything	Feast 2	You can eat spoiled, raw, or godtainted food: reduce any Taint from eating by 1.
Echo-Wise	Lore 1	You know how a place carries sound before you speak in it. Never surprised by your own echo; +2 to Stealth in canyons and halls.
Elder's Ear	—	Old people, the Kept, and the Seated tell you things they tell no one else (+2 Persuade).
Fast Hands	Hand 3	Draw and attack with a small weapon in the same moment; +2 to initiative.
Fasting Discipline	Resolve 2	Reduce all Starving and Pang penalties by 1. +2 to resist food offered as a lure, by anyone or anything.
Gallows Laugh	—	When you make the table laugh at something horrible in character, remove 1 Fray (once per session).
Good Bones	Gut 3	+3 Flesh.
Gravedigger's Back	Labor 1	Dig a grave or a hiding hole in a quarter of the time; +2 Search for anything buried.
Hard Sleeper	—	You sleep without dreaming, wherever you are. (Useless in the Vigil.)
Hostage's Smile	—	+2 to rolls to make captors like you or let their guard down.
Iron Stomach	Gut 2	+2 to Endure vs poison, disease, rot and drugs.
Kin-Sense	Caul 2	You always know when someone of your own blood is within a mile.
Ledger Memory	Eye 3	You can recite word for word any document you have read once, however long ago.
Light Sleeper	Eye 2	You cannot be surprised while asleep or resting.
Little Lies	—	One trivial falsehood per session is believed without a roll.
Lullaby Voice	Tongue 2	Once per scene, murmur to someone who has just failed a Dread check: they gain 1 less Fray. In the Vigil, every listener gains 1 Weariness.
Mother's Hands	Stitching 2	Treat Injuries one step faster.
Mourner's Rites	Rites 1	You know the death customs of all seven lands. At a burial you lead, all present remove 1 Fray; +2 Persuade with the bereaved.
Needle Habit	—	Once per day, take 1 damage from pin or needle to ignore all penalties from sleeplessness, cold or Weariness for a scene.
Night Eyes	Eye 2	Darkness gives you only −1, and total darkness −2.
No Thank You	—	+2 to resist any offer, invitation, seduction, or temptation, mundane or divine.
Old Grief	—	Once per session, when you take Fray from the death or loss of someone, take 2 less. You have practice.
Pin-Cushion	—	Pain sharpens you: while below half Flesh, +1 to all Eye rolls.
Poacher's Patience	Stealth 2	You can wait without moving for hours. +2 to the first attack you make from hiding.
Rim-Wise	Wayfaring 1	You know a keeper on every stretch of the Rim: lodging, rumour or a fence is a Routine (10) roll anywhere on the Road.
Rope Knots	—	Your knots never come undone by themselves, even in Cradlewrack.
Second Chair	—	When an ally makes a roll you could help with, give them +2 (instead of the usual +1).

KNACK	REQUIREMENT	EFFECT
Scrap-Born Luck	Cut 1 only	Once per session, reroll a Lack.
Silent Supper	—	You can go a whole day without speaking and suffer no penalty; +2 Stealth in quiet places.
Smell of Cedar	—	You know how to look like you belong to a better Cut: +2 Deceive and Persuade among the rich.
Steady Hands	Hand 2	No penalty for performing delicate work under pressure.
Strong Back	Labor 2	Carry double the normal load.
Table Manners	—	You know the grace and customs of all seven lands: +2 to first impressions anywhere.
Unflinching	Resolve 3	Once per session, automatically succeed on a Dread check of rating 3 or lower.
Unremembered	—	Nobody recalls your face a day later unless they had reason to. +2 Stealth in crowds and servants' corridors.
Vinegar Kiss	—	You carry the smells of rot well: animals and the Kept do not notice you unless you act.
Weather-Nose	Instinct 1	You smell what is coming an hour early: a Black Noon, the Yawn, a pressure day, a pang, a warm front where the Host has walked.
Witness Eyes	Caul 2	Once per session, see a Tenanted, Seated, disguised Kept or wandering Part for what it is, without a roll.

▼ STEP EIGHT: DERIVED TRAITS

- ◇ **Flesh** = 8 + Gut + Endure. Your physical endurance; see the combat chapter.
- ◇ **Guard** = 10 + Lung + the best of Athletics, Blades or Brawl. The target number to hit you in melee. **Ranged Guard** = 10 + Lung + Athletics.
- ◇ **Armor** from what you wear.
- ◇ **Hunger** starts at 0.
- ◇ **Regrowth** starts as set by your Cut. Note the Gifts you already have and any Wants that are active (High Cuts, starting in the Appetite, have their first Want active).
- ◇ **Fray** starts at 0, unless the Carver rules otherwise. Some backgrounds (a Vigil-born, an Oathen Forsworn) may begin with Fray 2.
- ◇ **Want** (Unfed only) starts at 3. **Pangs** start at 2 for an Unfed Guest who has been living on Pantry measures, 0 for anyone else.
- ◇ **Weariness** (Vigil-born only) starts at 2 and can never fall below it.
- ◇ **Portions** (experience) start at 0.

▼ STEP NINE: THE FOUR QUESTIONS

Mechanics describe what a Guest can do. These four answers describe who they are. Write them on the sheet. The Carver will use every one.

The Last Meal. What is the last meal you ate that you truly enjoyed, and who was at the table? Every Guest on the Table is hungry in some way, and this is the shape of theirs. Once per session, when your Guest acts to protect, honor or return to what that meal represented, gain +2 to the roll.

The Oath on the Dead. Swear an oath on the name of someone dead: a parent, a child, a friend, a victim. Write the name and the oath. (*On my brother Wem, who was Reaped: I will find where they took him. On my mother, whom I finished: I will never touch another living thing with these hands.*) See the rules for Oaths on the Dead. They bind across the Table, in ways that are subtler than Oathen's but no gentler.

Who Waits at Home. Name one living person who loves you and is waiting for you to come back. Where are they? What would they think of what you are becoming? The Carver will put them in danger. That is a promise.

What You Will Not Do. Name one thing your Guest will not do, whatever happens. Eat a person. Kill kin. Lie under oath. Lie down. Sit at a laid table. When your Guest is pushed to do it, play it honestly; if they do it, they gain 5 Fray at once, and you must write a new line they will not cross.

◇

Everybody's got a line. In the Fatlands it's who you'll eat. In Oathen it's what you'll say. In my trade it's where you'll stop digging. Mine moves about a foot a year.

A GLEANER OF THE SUMP

▼ THE LIFEPATH: SEVEN COURSES

The Four Questions ask who a Guest is now. The Lifepath asks how they got that way. It is optional, and it is cruel, and it is the fastest way to give a Guest a past that the Carver can bite into. Roll a d20 on each of the seven tables below, in order, the way a meal is served: Childhood Horror, What You Ate That You Shouldn't Have, The Scar, The Family Secret, Who You Betrayed, Who You Buried, and finally Your Oath on the Dead, which is sworn on the person you buried.

Read each result through your Guest's land and Cut. A result that names another land happened on the Road, or to a relative, or in a story your Guest has decided is theirs. Reroll anything that crosses your table's Lines, without comment. You may also simply choose.

The Lifepath's gift. A Guest who rolls all seven courses and keeps every result, however bad, begins play with **2 Portions**. The Carver also gains the right, once per story, to bring any one of those seven results back to the table, in person.

◇

Every life on the Table is a menu. Most people don't get to choose their courses. The decent ones at least eat what they're given without complaining.

DAME SUET MARRABLE, TO A GUEST WHO HAD STOPPED EATING

FIRST COURSE: CHILDHOOD HORROR

D20	WHAT YOU SAW AS A CHILD
1	Your Kept great-grandfather came apart at supper. You helped gather him up, then said grace again.
2	Your village kept the Long Count. One autumn the missing number was your best friend, and you wrote it down.
3	Your father at the west window at midnight, standing in a puddle of brine, smiling at nothing.
4	You blinked at seven and came back standing over your brother's cradle, blanket in hand. He was fine. You were never left alone with him again.
5	A door bricked shut for forty years opened while you were alone. Something said your name, kindly, and closed it.
6	Your playmate said "I promise" in a game. You heard the bones go. You had made her say it.
7	A laid table in the barn, with your name on the card. You did not sit. Your cousin did. He is still there.
8	A Hush opened beside your village. All night the birds fell out of the silence onto your roof.
9	A Taker carried you off in a sack. Your family bought you back with the house, and never let you forget the house.
10	A small warm hand crept into your bed each night for a month and held your finger. Then your mother found it.
11	Locked overnight in the Lofts among ten thousand whispering Set-Aside. By morning you knew their word.
12	Snowed in on the Rim: the dog, then the horse, then the boots. Then your mother stopped eating and gave you hers.
13	A Purgation cell burned a High Cut house. A child your age was at the upstairs window, waving or beating on the glass.
14	Your mother Broke, and you caught it: for a season you both knew your father was an impostor. He left.
15	You alone on your street survived a Calling night, a pang, a fever or a Reaping. Nobody explained why. Many asked.
16	You swallowed a fairground relic on a dare. Your milk teeth fell out that night and the new ones came in wrong.
17	Your best friend was a Blank. One morning their house stood open and empty, a surgeon's chalk mark on the lintel.

D20	WHAT YOU SAW AS A CHILD
18	You were taken to a public Breaking, a Closing or a wake as a birthday treat. You enjoyed it. You remember enjoying it.
19	Born on Tablenight. Every birthday your grandmother laid one chair more than there were people, and would not say for whom.
20	Nothing. Everyone around you suffered and you were never touched. The guilt grew with you like a second spine.

SECOND COURSE: WHAT YOU ATE THAT YOU SHOULDN'T HAVE

D20	THE THING YOU SWALLOWED
1	A slice of your grandmother at her wake. You went back for seconds. Everyone said she would have loved that.
2	A Hand-line fingernail ground in wine, sold as a cure for fear. It worked. You miss being afraid.
3	A crust from one of Orrum's tables, snatched by a child's hand. Warm bread still sounds, faintly, like someone calling.
4	Bottled brine, coughed up by a stranger. For a year you dreamed of a stone table under the sea.
5	Unmilled toothed wheat. The tooth you bit on was small and smooth. You have never decided what it came from.
6	Your own flesh, the winter the snow closed the Rim for thirty days. From somewhere it would not show.
7	A strip of a Kept man's arm, bought in a Lastgate lane. He watched you eat it, and nodded, grateful.
8	A heart, at a Second Helping love-feast. Everyone wept with joy. You cannot remember the giver's name.
9	Grave-earth from the edge of a Hush, on a dare. For a day you heard nothing; on the second, something heard for you.
10	One finger of a Cradlewrack Part, because you were starving and it was warm. The rest of the hand is looking for it.
11	The only copy of a sworn contract, to destroy the evidence. You are not certain it stopped binding.
12	A spoonful of Lady Aspic's jelly. It blinked on the way down.
13	Rouse cut with something sweet. Nine days awake; on the ninth, your mother's face on everyone.
14	The Second Table's communion: a sliver of somebody's ancestor. The host would not say whose.
15	Bone coins, when you were starving. The only thing on the Table worth exactly what it costs.
16	Seawater from a drowned man's mouth, at a Deepening baptism. It tasted of him. You knew him.
17	A dog that had eaten a man. You knew. You told yourself it made a difference.
18	An afterbirth, as Cradlewrack medicine, from something that was not a child. The fever broke.
19	A gift accepted on the first offer instead of the fourth. If you are Unfed, it is the worst thing you have done.
20	Nothing, you believe. Only clean, declared food, all your life. You are the only person you know who believes that.

THIRD COURSE: THE SCAR

D20	THE MARK YOU CARRY
1	A Seamer's crooked stitch across the throat, from the night it was cut in Sallowreach and you did not die.
2	Human bite marks on the forearm, healed white. You know whose teeth; they know whose arm.
3	A rope-burn ring at the waist, from a night's anchoring when something pulled hard toward the west.
4	A fingertip broken off in Oathen at eight, for a lie about a fig.
5	A lamp-chimney burn on one palm, from a nudger who loved you and could not wake you any other way.
6	A Board of Plenty number branded on the shoulder: debtor, dusk-shift eligible. You walked back. It did not come off.

D20	THE MARK YOU CARRY
7	Neat rows of Waker's needle scars up both arms.
8	A puckered hole in your side. The surgeon kept what came out, in a jar, labelled with your name.
9	An oath tattooed down your spine in Surety's script, for a debt someone else defaulted. The bone beneath never set straight.
10	A crossbow-bolt scar through the thigh, from a Reckoner raid on a house you were only visiting.
11	Mouth-corners scarred white by a bit worn too long and too tight.
12	Teeth filed to points at a Second Helping baptism. You smile with your lips closed.
13	Frost-white, dead fingertips: you touched ground where the Host had walked, so warm it burned cold.
14	A surgical cut under the ribs, where a Blank-hunter sampled you. You were not worth taking. You never learned why.
15	Salt-sores on both ankles that weep and never close.
16	A healed Breaking: one knee bends slightly the wrong way, and you know exactly which promise.
17	A College mark of Cut inked inside the wrist at birth, and a ragged scar where someone tried to cut it out.
18	A white seam from breastbone to navel. Someone opened you to see what was growing, and did not say.
19	Claw-furrows across the back, from a drover's beast that ran on two legs.
20	No scar at all. Every wound closes clean and vanishes in a week. The College has noticed.

FOURTH COURSE: THE FAMILY SECRET

Every family on the Table has one, and most of them are about blood. The Cutwrights keep them in footnotes, in cipher, in a

cabinet with two locks. Your Guest may know theirs, suspect it, or learn it in play from the worst possible person.

D20	WHAT THE FAMILY DOES NOT SAY
1	Your parents are cousins, as were theirs, as far back as the College can trace. Your line is marked "folded". Your Cut is higher than your station. That was the point.
2	Your great-grandmother is a Seated hill behind the farm. The family still brings her meat. Last spring she asked for you by name.
3	You were bought, not born. The Attendance ledger says your mother's child was not permitted to stay.
4	Your family sold your elder sibling to the surgeons and told you they were Reaped. You have the receipt now.
5	A great-grandfather is Kept in the cellar, chained and gagged. He knows what the family did in 412 A.G., and keeps trying to say.
6	The first Hush near your home opened under your ancestor's bed.
7	Your family is Second Table. There is a silver fork in a velvet box in your father's study.
8	Your mother's husband was Tenanted a year before you were born. Nobody has ever asked who your father is.
9	Every firstborn of your line breaks at the same joint, on an oath sworn by an ancestor nobody remembers. You are the firstborn.
10	The family fortune came from a Cullmaster's lists. Your grandfather chose the names, some of them neighbours' children.
11	Your Cut was forged by a bribed Cutwright four generations back. You are either less than you claim, or far more.
12	Every third generation, one of your blood walks into the Fast and sits. Your aunt went. Your mother is due. After her, you.
13	A room in the house has been bricked up for a century. On Tablenight, something in it hums the grace.
14	Snowed in on the Rim, your family ate a stranger who sheltered with them, and swore on the dead never to say.
15	Your line marries within itself to keep the god strong. You were promised at birth to someone you called by a family name. You ran.
16	Your name is on a Reckoner list. Three branches have already ended in their beds. Yours is next.
17	Your sister is Counted, Bed 51,206. The family bribes an orderly so her bed is never among those "reduced".

D20	WHAT THE FAMILY DOES NOT SAY
18	You had a twin, taken to the Lying-In the day you were born. Your mother still sets its place on your birthday.
19	Your uncle was a Reckoner who ended a High Cut line. Half the family calls him a saint, half a murderer; they eat at one table.
20	A College ledger records that your ancestor was served “from the eighth plate”. The rest of the page has been scraped to the vellum.

FIFTH COURSE: WHO YOU BETRAYED

D20	THE ONE YOU FAILED, ON PURPOSE
1	A Blank friend, sold to a Taker for a winter’s food. You told yourself they would be a saint somewhere.
2	Your Surety. You defaulted, and they broke in the street in your place.
3	Your nudger. You let them close their eyes so you could close yours. Only one of you was fetched back.
4	A Called brother. You held his rope loose one night and told yourself you were tired.
5	Your Seamer master. You stole from the Guild’s corpse-stock and let her hang for it. In Sallowreach, she still hangs.
6	A lover who was carrying. You told the Attendance, and the Second Opinion was given while you were elsewhere.
7	Your village. You gave its name to the Cullmasters so your own name would come off the list.
8	A Purgation cell. You informed. The house they meant to burn burned anyway, by someone else’s hand.
9	Your congregation. You stopped believing years ago and kept preaching, because they needed it and you needed bread.
10	Your child, left on the steps of a lying-in house. You did not look back to see what they asked.
11	Your father, whom you finished without a license. He begged; you say it was for him. The house came to you.
12	An Unfed family who hid you on the border. You led the Takers to their door the next spring.
13	A dying friend’s last request. You promised. You are not Oathen; nothing broke but them, when they saw your face.
14	A Company caravan. You were the inside hand on a robbery. Four Wardens died, one of whom shared his rouse with you.
15	Your lord. You let a Reckoner through the postern and watched the stars while it was done.
16	Your Tenanted spouse. You sold the thing that came back to the Admiralty for study. It thanked you.
17	A Reaped friend. They called to you from the wheat at dusk. You shut the shutters, and sang.
18	Your sister. You married the one she was promised to, and wore her ring at her funeral.
19	A Seated stranger who begged you to sit so they would not eat alone. You promised to come back. You never did.
20	Nobody. Yet. One of the other Guests will be the first; the Carver knows who and when. You do not.

could arrange.

SIXTH COURSE: WHO YOU BURIED

Outside Sallowreach the dead die properly, and somebody has to put them somewhere. Inside it, “burial” means whatever ending you

D20	THE ONE YOU PUT IN THE GROUND
1	Your mother, the old way, a coin on the tongue, though the priest said there was no longer any point.
2	A stranger on the Rim Road whom nobody else would touch. You still carry a button from their coat.
3	Your child, before its naming. In Cradlewrack they said there was nothing to bury. You buried it anyway.
4	Your twin, Set Aside in the Lofts. On feast days you read aloud, and they whisper back.
5	Someone who walked singing into a Hush with the Finishers. You buried their boots at the silent edge.

D20	THE ONE YOU PUT IN THE GROUND
6	Your father, with Fatlands honours. You carved and served and cleaned the plate, and wept because he tasted of home.
7	An Unfed brother, starved off the Pantry list. You learned later whose hand wrote it.
8	Half your village after a Reaping year, one grave a week through Carving. You stopped counting at thirty.
9	The first person you killed, buried so no one would find them, and so that someone would.
10	A Seated grandparent you dragged from a laid table. They died within the hour, thanking you for supper.
11	A Counted sister, when the family could no longer pay for her bed. You carried the coffin. It was light.
12	Your Surety teacher, who broke once too often and folded in the road like a dropped coat.
13	A Foundling soldier of your company, four years old in fact. Nobody claimed the body; nobody had borne it.
14	A part of yourself: a hand, a foot, a Part you bore. Full rites. A small stone. You go back.
15	Your Tenanted spouse, as they were. The thing that came back stood at the graveside and sang.
16	A Reckoner who came for someone in your house. She is under the floor. You step around that board.
17	Nobody. You sold the body to the surgeons for the price of the grave, and have been paying for it since.
18	A god-touched animal that loved you: a dog that guarded a closed door, a pig with your uncle's face.
19	Your teacher, broken by a Breaking over something you said in their hearing. They never blamed you.
20	An empty coffin. The body was never found. A stranger at the funeral smelled strongly of fresh bread.

SEVENTH COURSE: YOUR OATH ON THE DEAD

died]: *I will...* It follows every rule for Oaths on the Dead in *The Grace Roll*. An Oathener should remember what such an oath weighs in Oathen, and that no Surety will carry it.

Swear this on the person you buried, or on any dead name the other courses gave you, and write it in full: *On [name], who [how they*

D20	I WILL...
1	...find the one who sold them, and make them say aloud what they were paid.
2	...never let a stranger sit at a laid table while I have hands to stop them.
3	...see them finished properly, by a licensed hand or my own.
4	...have their name cut into the Ledger at Tacit, where it can never be unsworn.
5	...carry their bones home across the Rim to where they were born.
6	...learn what they heard, in the room, the sea, the silence or the wheat, that made them go.
7	...feed every child on my road this winter, whatever I must carry or steal.
8	...never again eat anything my own hands did not carry.
9	...end the line of the house that ate them, to the last heir.
10	...keep the promise they broke, and take its Breaking myself if I fail.
11	...follow the sea down to wherever it is going, and tell them.
12	...protect the one they loved best, who does not know I exist.
13	...never lie to anyone who asks me a question in their name.
14	...find the part of them that was taken, and put it back.
15	...pay every one of their debts, to the last crumb.
16	...sit with them every Tablenight, wherever they lie, for as long as I live.

D20	I WILL...
17	...bring the god up out of my own blood before it does to me what it did to them.
18	...learn for whom the empty chair at their funeral was laid.
19	...find the Second Table, sit at it, and be the last thing served.
20	...swear no other oath, ever, on anything. (The dead find this very funny.)

ROLLING A LIFEPAATH: AN EXAMPLE

Joss rolls the seven courses for Hessa Coombe, a Sallowreach Seamer. A Hush opened beside her aunt's fen village when she was twelve, and the birds fell all night (8). On a dare from her elder brother Tobin she ate earth from its silent edge (9). She has a crooked stitch across the throat (1), a great-grandfather chained in the family cellar who knows what the family did (5), and nobody betrayed, yet (20). Joss decides the one she buried is Tobin himself, who later walked singing into that same Hush with the Finishers (5), and, bending the oath she rolled (2) to fit, swears: *On my brother Tobin, who walked into Dunmere Hush: I will never let another soul of our street go in after him.* Every course now points at one silent place in the fen, and the Carver has been handed a cellar and an open betrayal.

▼ STEP TEN: GEAR AND MONEY

Take the starting gear from your Calling and the starting wealth from your Cut, and spend it in the Rim Market (Part Three). Everyone also begins with: a set of clothes suited to their land and station, a knife, a bowl, a spoon, a blanket, a water-skin, and three days of food they carried themselves.

Each land expects a little more, and the Carver should see that every Guest has it: a bail-bucket and anchoring rope for a Brinehollower, rouse and a pin-glove for a Vigilant, needle, thread and a knocker's ring for a Cradlewracker, perfume or vinegar for a Sallowreacher, a wax tablet for an Oathener.

▼ ADVANCEMENT: PORTIONS

At the end of every session, each Guest earns **Portions**:

- ◇ 1 for showing up and playing.
- ◇ 1 for each of the following, if it happened: you learned a secret of the Table; you faced a horror of Dread 3 or higher; you acted on

your Last Meal, Oath on the Dead or Who Waits at Home in a way that cost you; you made the table gasp, wince or laugh.

- ◇ 1–3 for completing a goal or surviving a story's end.

A typical session earns 4–7 Portions. Spend them between sessions:

IMPROVEMENT	COST IN PORTIONS
Raise a skill by 1	New rating × 2
Raise an attribute by 1 (max 5)	New rating × 5
Gain a Knack	6
Raise Standing by 1	New rating × 3, plus a deed the Calling recognises
Remove 3 Fray	2 (represents rest, rites, drink, company)
Treat a Derangement (see Fray)	10, plus months of care

Cut cannot be bought. It is what you were born with. Regrowth cannot be bought, either: it comes on its own.

EXAMPLE OF CHARACTER CREATION

Maya wants to play a Brinehollow Netwatch officer who has begun to doubt the job. She chooses **Brinehollow** (+1 Lung) and **Common** Cut (Cut 2, Regrowth 1, one Tooth, 40 lacks). She puts her 9 attribute points into Hand 3, Gut 2, Lung 3, Eye 2, Tongue 2, Caul 3, then adds the land bonus: Lung 4.

She chooses the **Nightwarden** Calling (Instinct, Search and Intimidate +1). With 18 skill points she buys Blades 2, Brawl 2, Athletics 3, Wayfaring 1, Instinct 2 (3 with Calling), Search 2 (3), Intimidate 1 (2), Endure 2, Resolve 3. She rolls on the Brinehollow names table and gets **Ressa Weir**, which she likes enough to keep.

Her Knacks are **Bail-Lunged** and **Old Grief**. Flesh = $8 + 2 + 2 = 12$. Guard = $10 + 4 + 3 = 17$. At Regrowth 1 she chooses the Brinehollow Taste Gift *Salt-Sense*, and wakes each morning with salt on her lips. Her Last Meal: smoked herring with her brother on the pier, the night before he was Called. Her Oath on the Dead: *On my brother Ferrin, who walked in: I will never again drag anyone back from the water.* Who Waits at Home: her sister-in-law, Ama, who keeps Ferrin's chain on the bedpost. What she will not do: put a rope on a living person again.

That oath and that line are going to collide with her job by the second session. That is the point.

▼ SEVEN AT THE TABLE: READY-MADE GUESTS

These seven Guests are complete and legal under the rules above, one from each land, each a different Calling and station, built to want different things and to get in each other's way. Use them for a first session, for convention play, or as replacements when a Guest is lost at a bad moment. Three of them appear in *A Night on the Table* at the front of the book. Each player should change at least one thing before play: a name, a Knack, a line they will not cross. A Guest nobody has touched is only a stranger at the inn.



Seven strangers at one table, and not one of them hungry for the same thing. That's not a party. That's a menu.

A RIM ROAD INNKEEPER, WATCHING THE DOOR

HESSA COOMBE – THREADER OF THE LOWER PILINGS

HESSA COOMBE – THREADER OF THE LOWER PILINGS	
LAND & CUT	Sallowreach · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 0
AGE & CALLING	20 · Seamer, Standing 1 (Threader)
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
SKILLS	Stitching 4, Endure 3, Reckoning 2, Lore 2, Search 2, Instinct 2, Rites 2, Resolve 2, Blades 1, Craft 1
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	Seamer's awl +5 (2, Piercing, Silent); knife +5 (2)
TALENT	Tight Seams (+2 Flesh when she treats a wound; one Reseat per session)
GIFTS	Lidsense; the Quiet Hand
SOP & TOOTH	close something meant to stay open. Partaking turns her fingers cold to the second knuckle; when the god bites, her hand clenches shut on whatever it holds.
KNACKS	Butcher's Calm, Steady Hands
GEAR	needle-roll and awls, gut and wire thread, bone saw, vinegar, poppy-water; Seamer's awl; mourning-cloak with vinegar pockets; fen-glow jar; standard kit; 15 lacks

Hessa grew up in a stilt-house above the black water, with five generations of the dead in the attic and a great-grandfather in the cellar whom nobody visits. She looks at people as work: where they will tear, how long they will hold. She is precise, dryly funny, never squeamish and always tired, and she talks to the Kept as though they were simply old, which makes them adore her. She has never seen a funeral, and is privately afraid she would like one.

The Last Meal. Eel pie and undying cheese at great-great-grandmother Ysolde's spring restitching, the whole house laughing,

the Kept at the table pretending to taste. **The Oath on the Dead.** *On my brother Tobin, who walked into Dunmere Husb: I will never let another soul of our street go in after him.* **Who Waits at Home.** Ysolde, Kept and ripening, in her chair by the fire, who asks every evening whether Hessa is home yet and forgets the answer. **What She Will Not Do.** Take a part from anyone, living or Kept, who has not given it.

HASLET FURROW – JOINTER OF THE WAKES

HASLET FURROW – JOINTER OF THE WAKES	
LAND & CUT	the Fatlands · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 0
AGE & CALLING	34 · Renderer, Standing 1 (Spit-Hand)
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
SKILLS	Blades 4, Feast 3, Labor 3, Endure 2, Resolve 2, Brawl 1, Intimidate 1, Stitching 1, Haggle 1, Instinct 1, Rites 1, Athletics 1
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	cleaver +7 (4, Ripping); knife +7 (3)
TALENT	Know the Cut (+1 damage with cleavers and knives, included above)
GIFTS	Iron Belly
SOP & TOOTH	clean the plate. Partaking floods his mouth and growls his belly loud enough for the room; when the god bites, he must eat something within reach before he acts again.
KNACKS	Eats Anything, Gallows Laugh
GEAR	cleavers and knives, rendering hook, salt, an apron that will never be clean; hide coat; tent-coat; a flask of marrow-brandy; standard kit; 17 lacks

Haslet carves at wakes. He is wide, gentle and sweet-voiced, and in Low Tilth the bereaved ask for him because he talks to the dead while he works and makes the children laugh. He has never once been full. He left home after his sister's name came up on a

Cullmaster's list, and cooks now for Rim inns that do not ask, apologising to every joint under his breath.

The Last Meal. His grandfather Abel's wake: Haslet carved, his grandmother said he looked heavy, and for exactly one breath the

hunger stopped. **The Oath on the Dead.** *On my sister Petty, who was put on the dusk shift at Low Tilt: I will learn who wrote her name on the list, and I will serve them at their own wake.* **Who Waits at Home.** His grandmother Callow, rooting by the kitchen door,

who can still talk and asks for him every evening. **What He Will Not Do.** Eat anyone he knew by name.

GANNET LUGG – PICKER OF THE FAR MILE

GANNET LUGG – PICKER OF THE FAR MILE	
LAND & CUT	Brinehollow · Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0
AGE & CALLING	27 · Gleaner, Standing 1 (Picker)
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2
SKILLS	Search 4, Filch 3, Craft 3, Athletics 2, Wayfaring 2, Stealth 2, Haggle 2, Endure 1, Brawl 1, Lore 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 17 (with bucket-shield) · Armor 0 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	pry-bar +4 (3, Stunning); knife +3 (2)
TALENT	Something Worth Having (once per session, Eye + Search vs Hard 14 to find something of value)
GIFTS	none yet; at the Taste she will choose Deep Breath or Salt-Sense
SOP & TOOTH	wading in brine facing west. Partaking pops her ears and drops her voice; when the god bites, she coughs up cold water, sand and something small and alive.
KNACKS	Bail-Lunged, Scrap-Born Luck
GEAR	pry-bar, sack, shovel, lantern, gloves; a bucket-shield that is also her bail-bucket; ten fathoms of anchoring rope; an unopened salvage-tin; the name of Mags Weir; standard kit; 7 lacks

Gannet has picked the Uncovered since she was nine, walking among upright wrecks to bring back what the sea forgot. She is quick, cheerful, light-fingered and shameless, a Scrapling who has never felt the pull and half believes she never will. She sees lights on the far seabed at night and has never reported them, because she means to get there first.

The Last Meal. A stolen tin of pre-Turning peaches, eaten inside the ribs of a wreck with her mother, three weeks before her mother

was Called. **The Oath on the Dead.** *On my mother Dulse, who walked west: I will go as far out as the water went, and look.* **Who Waits at Home.** Tern, the eleven-year-old next door, who calls her name through the wall every dawn and has not had an answer for a month. **What She Will Not Do.** Cut a sleeping person's anchoring rope, whatever is tied to the end of it.

AGATHE LARCH – THE SPARE WITH LIDS

AGATHE LARCH – THE SPARE WITH LIDS	
LAND & CUT	the Vigil · Cut 3 (Prime, Eye-line) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 0 · Weariness 2
AGE & CALLING	23 · Scion, Standing 1 (Cadet)
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
SKILLS	Persuade 4, Lore 3, Godsign 3, Search 2, Instinct 2, Resolve 2, Blades 2, Clause 1, Reckoning 1, Athletics 1
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Armor 2 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	sword +4 (4, Parrying); Waker's needle +4 (2, Piercing, Waking)
TALENT	The Name (two Teeth, each adding +1 more when she Partakes)
GIFTS	Heavy-Eyed
SOP & TOOTH	the Lull, ten seconds with closed eyes and a held hand. Partaking blows her pupils black and makes the whole room yawn; when the god bites, she gains a Weariness too.
KNACKS	Counting Habit, Hostage's Smile
GEAR	fine clothes, the Larch signet, a grey mare; a letter of introduction to Envoy Castellan Dray; studded coat; sword; ten days of rouse; pin-glove; her nudger Ember Dusk-Bell (Threat 1, Flesh 9); standard kit; 87 lacks

Agathe was born with eyelids into a lidless house, a deformity in the Larch line, and was raised in a back wing with excellent tutors and no visitors. She is clever, beautifully mannered, starved for company and capable of great cruelty when frightened, which is always. Alone, she closes her eyes for the length of a held breath, and nothing has ever felt so good. Her family has sent her to Sallowreach with a sealed letter. She suspects it is about her.

The Last Meal. Clatter-cake and rouse on the roof on Tablenight, in the minute the lamps go out, with her mother’s fingers holding her eyelids open “so you’ll see it, as we do.” **The**

Oath on the Dead. *On Constance Hobb, my first nudger, hanged for letting me close my eyes when I was six: I will never let anyone be punished for my rest again.* **Who Waits at Home.** Her brother Florian, the lidless heir, who writes every day and is certain she will come home cured. **What She Will Not Do.** Lie down. Not once, not even dying.

NOTYET CLAYHAND –
FOUNDLING OF THE NINTH
COMPANY

NOTYET CLAYHAND – FOUNDLING OF THE NINTH COMPANY	
LAND & CUT	Cradlewrack · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 0
AGE & CALLING	five years old, in a body of about twenty-five · Warden, Standing 1 (Hired Blade)
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 1 · Caul 4
SKILLS	Blades 4, Endure 3, Intimidate 2, Wayfaring 2, Athletics 2, Shooting 2, Instinct 2, Resolve 2, Brawl 1, Labor 1
BODY	Flesh 17 · Guard 17 · Armor 2 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	axe +7 (4, Brutal); crossbow +5 (4, Piercing, Slow; 12 bolts)
TALENT	Shield the Cargo (take an adjacent ally’s blow, at +2 Armor)
GIFTS	First Breath
SOP & TOOTH	let out something meant to stay shut. Partaking cramps her belly and undoes the nearest knot or latch; when the god bites, a contraction doubles her over and costs her next move.
KNACKS	Good Bones, Rope Knots
GEAR	axe, crossbow and bolts, boiled leather, the Ninth Company’s red sash; knocker’s ring; brick, mortar and trowel; needle and red thread; standard kit; 36 lacks

Notyet was born mid-stride on the drill ground at Kest, a grown woman with a soldier’s shoulders, and was handed a crust and a spear in the same minute. She learned to talk in a week and to kill in a season. She is blunt, literal, brave and very young, astonished by rain and songs in a way that unsettles older Guests. Foundlings of her company have begun to die quietly in their seventh year. She has two years left to find out why.

The Last Meal. Her first meal ever, minutes old: clay-bread, still warm, from the hand of the midwife who let her stay. **The Oath on**

the Dead. *On Sergeant Abel Danner, who was opened by a pang at the Dilation rim: I will learn who bore me before I turn seven.* **Who Waits at Home.** Hollan Thrale, that midwife, who asks at every visit, “Do you know yet what you are?” **What She Will Not Do.** Shut a door on anyone who knocks.

SABRA WRIT – BONDSWOMAN OF
THE LOWER LEDGER

SABRA WRIT – BONDSWOMAN OF THE LOWER LEDGER	
LAND & CUT	Oathen · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 0
AGE & CALLING	31 · Surety, Standing 1 (Bondsman)
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
SKILLS	Endure 4, Clause 3, Resolve 3, Persuade 2, Instinct 2, Brawl 2, Haggle 2, Lore 1, Labor 1, Stitching 1
BODY	Flesh 18 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	club +4 (3, Stunning); knife +2 (2)
TALENT	Borne Weight (carries others' oaths; +3 Flesh, included above; ignores the first Injury each session)
GIFTS	Echo-Ear
SOP & TOOTH	swear an unconditional oath before a witness. Partaking brings her own last words back to her, half a breath late, tasting of wet slate; when the god bites, her last sentence binds at Weight 1.
KNACKS	Silent Supper, Old Grief
GEAR	a bond-ledger of four small oaths carried for paying clients; bandages and splints; padded jack; club; wax tablets; canyon flatbread; standard kit; 56 lacks

Sabra carries strangers' words on her body for money, as her father did until a client ran and the Breaking folded him in half in the market. She is calm, slow-spoken and patient, and funny the way Oatheners are funny, by leaving things out. Both little fingers bend backward, from small defaults she does not resent. She has left Oathen to find the man who ran.

The Last Meal. Flatbread soaked in the first of the Kept Rain, eaten in silence on the Ledger steps beside her father, the year she

was unbitted. **The Oath on the Dead.** *On my father, Tav Writ, Surety: I will find Aubin Crale, who ran, and hear him say the words he broke.* **Who Waits at Home.** Her daughter Dacey, seven, still in her bit, who has never spoken to her and signs *come home* at the door each morning. **What She Will Not Do.** Make a promise to a child.

ABATE KETTERING – NIGHT-HAULER OF WANTING

ABATE KETTERING – NIGHT-HAULER OF WANTING	
LAND & CUT	the Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 3 · Pangs 2
AGE & CALLING	29 · Crumb-Runner, Standing 1 (Runner)
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
SKILLS	Stealth 4, Wayfaring 4, Resolve 3, Deceive 2, Endure 2, Haggle 2, Instinct 1, Labor 1, Blades 1, Reckoning 1
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	household axe +3 (3, Thrown); knife +3 (2)
TALENT	Hidden Hold (a hidden compartment in anything she loads; one safe route between any two adjacent lands)
GIFTS	none; she has the Refusal. Spends Want on the Second No, the Gnaw, Nothing to Hold, Clean Through and Steady.
KNACKS	Cold Supper, Rim-Wise
GEAR	handcart, oilcloth, rope, dark lantern, forged travel pass; ration-cloth, water flask, wax tin, three days' Pantry measures, a coat not warm enough; standard kit; 7 lacks

Abate hauls grain into the Fast by night and is spat on at noon by the people she feeds, which she accepts as correct. She is gaunt, upright, sardonic and devout, says “No, thank you” three times to everything including rescue, and has never eaten a mouthful of her cargo. Since the place cards began she has carried one in her coat, unread, in a hand she is afraid she knows.

The Last Meal. Cold ration-bread eaten standing in the Pantry queue with her sister Meagre, the morning neither of them knew there would be a list. **The Oath on the Dead.** *On my sister Meagre, whose name was left off the Pantry list in the Lack of 639: I will feed every child in Hesitation Hollow through this winter, whatever I have to carry.* **Who Waits at Home.** Her father Fallow, a strict Keeper, who spits at her feet in the street and leaves his door unbarred for

her every night. **What She Will Not Do.** Eat from her own cargo while one child on her route is hungry.

TYING THE SEVEN TOGETHER

If all seven play, give them one reason to share a road. The simplest: Agathe Larch's family has hired the others to see her safely to Lastgate with a sealed letter, and pays on delivery. Haslet cooks. Notyet guards. Gannet knows the coast road. Sabra stands surety for the contract. Abate knows the short way round the Fast, and Hessa is going home. None of them has read the letter. One of them will.



CHAPTER 12

THE GRACE ROLL

On the Table, nobody asks if a thing can be done. They ask what it will cost, and who will be made to pay it.

– RIM ROAD SAYING

CHALKED ON THE WALL ABOVE THE DICING-BOARD IN THE TAPROOM OF THE THIMBLE CROSS WAYSTATION, BENEATH A RIM ROAD COMPANY NOTICE FORBIDDING GAMES OF CHANCE ON COMPANY PREMISES.

GRACE-AND-LACK. House rules. Two bones, thrown together, from the cup, not the hand.

Throw high and beat the house: you are paid. Throw low: you pay. Throw a pair and win: that is a Grace, and the house pays double and stands you a drink. Throw a pair and lose: that is a Lack, and you pay double and stand the house a drink, and you will drink it in front of everybody.

Two ones is Licked Clean. You lose whatever you threw. Two tens is a Second Helping and you win whatever you threw, even against the house's best, even if Jem is throwing.

No wagering of kin. No wagering of the Kept, or of parts of the Kept, or of licenses, or of a place in Mother Gall's queue. No wagering of your dusk shift; we know there is a market in them and we will not have it here. No oaths at the board. NO OATHS AT THE BOARD, ESPECIALLY FROM OATHENERS, WHO KNOW BETTER. Nobody Partakes to throw. We can tell. Your hands go cold, or your belly growls, or the whole room yawns.

If you lose your last lack at this board, the house will feed you once. Lack keep away.

(scratched underneath, in a different hand) The house fed me once. It was good. I lost the rest of my life here anyway, but it was very good soup.

The rules of *The Long Grace* are short at their heart. One kind of roll settles nearly everything. Around it are wrapped the systems

▼ WHEN TO ROLL

Roll only when three things are true: the outcome is uncertain, failure would be interesting, and something is at stake. A Seamer stitching a cut in a quiet shop does not roll. A Seamer stitching a cut while the patient screams and the Kept in the next room are pounding on the wall to be let in, does.

When nothing is at stake, the Carver simply says what happens. When the outcome is impossible, nobody rolls: you cannot argue a

that make this world itself: what it costs to call on the god in your blood, how the god grows back, how the mind wears through, how a whole village can go mad together, how the body starves and festers and is broken, and how the dead hold you to your word.

This chapter gives every one of those systems, and for every major rule it gives at least one **example of play**: a moment from a game, told the way it happens at the table, with the dice showing. The examples follow one company of Guests across the Table. They are:

- ◇ **Ressa Weir**, a Brinehollow Netwatch officer who has begun to doubt the job (played by Maya; you met her in *Making a Guest*). Cut 2, Regrowth 1. Hand 3, Gut 2, Lung 4, Eye 2, Tongue 1, Caul 3. Flesh 12, Guard 17.
- ◇ **Halloway Brisk**, a Fatlands renderer with a lapsed Union card and a jar she will not open (played by Dev). Cut 2, Regrowth 2. Hand 4, Gut 4, Lung 2, Eye 2, Tongue 2, Caul 2; Blades 4, Feast 3. Flesh 15, Guard 16.
- ◇ **Tolly Fane**, a Vigil courier with lids she uses sparingly and rouse enough for nine days (played by Sunniva). Cut 2, Regrowth 3. Hand 2, Gut 2, Lung 3, Eye 4, Tongue 2, Caul 3; Stealth 4, Search 3. Flesh 10, Guard 15.
- ◇ **Abate Kell**, an Unfed Tablebreaker who carries a folded place card with his own name on it (played by Ade). Cut 0, Want 3. Hand 3, Gut 3, Lung 3, Eye 2, Tongue 1, Caul 4; Blades 4, Resolve 3. Flesh 14, Guard 17.

The Carver in every example is called the Carver. She is not always kind.

◇

The dice are the most honest thing on the Table. That is not a compliment to the dice.

CUTWRIGHT MARGINAL NOTE, INTRODUCTORY LECTURES, THIMBLE CROSS COPY

Hush into giving back its silence.

THE THREE QUESTIONS

Before calling for a roll, the Carver asks herself three things, quickly, the way a cook tastes the pot:

- ◇ **Could this go either way?** If a Guest with Blades 4 wants to joint a pig, it goes one way. If she wants to joint it in the dark while it is still screaming, it might not.
- ◇ **Would failing be worth playing?** If the only result of failure is “nothing happens, try again,” do not roll. Let them succeed, or let it take longer and cost something. Rolls should open doors, even the wrong ones.
- ◇ **What does it cost?** Everything on the Table costs something: time, lacks, Hunger, Fray, trust, a finger. If the Carver cannot say what failure costs, the roll is not ready yet. Say it out loud before the dice move: *if this goes badly, the Netwatch bears you*. Players make better choices when they can see the price.

SAYING YES, SAYING "AT A PRICE"

Most of what Guests do in play should simply happen. They walk the Rim Road, they buy bread, they argue with an innkeeper about the room. When a player describes something competent and reasonable for their character, the Carver says yes. When a player describes something hard but plausible, and the Carver does not want the fun of rolling for it, she may offer a **price** instead: *you can*

climb the piling without a roll, but you'll lose your bail-bucket in the dark, or you'll take an hour, or you'll have to Partake. The player may take the price or roll the dice. This is not a rule so much as a habit, and it is the habit that keeps play moving.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: TO ROLL OR NOT

The company arrives at a Fatlands inn at dusk. Dev says, “Halloway checks the stew before anyone eats it. She’s a renderer. She’ll know what’s in it.”

The Carver thinks. Halloway’s Calling Talent, *Know the Cut*, already tells her what meat used to be by taste. There is no uncertainty about whether she can taste the stew. “You taste it. Pork, mostly. A little mutton. And something that isn’t either, a soft fatty meat you know from wakes.” There is no roll for that part. But Halloway’s talent says telling *whether it was a person* is a Hard (14) Eye + Feast roll, and telling *which person* needs a Helping. “If you want to know more than that, roll.”

Dev rolls: 2d10 shows 6 and 3, plus Eye 2 and Feast 3, for 14. Exactly Hard. “It was a person. Not old. You can’t tell who.” No Helping, so no name. The innkeeper’s wife is watching Halloway’s face across the room with a terrible patience.

▼ THE ROLL

To attempt something uncertain, a Guest rolls **2d10** and adds one **Attribute** and one **Skill**. The Carver says which pair fits; players may suggest another and argue for it. The total is compared to a **Difficulty**.

Total = 2d10 + Attribute + Skill (+ modifiers) (+ Teeth, if Partaking)

DIFFICULTY	NUMBER	EXAMPLE
Routine	10	Climb a knotted rope; find an inn on the Rim Road; calm a frightened child.
Hard	14	Climb a wet pier-piling at night; pick a Seamer’s lock; lie to a Waker.
Grim	18	Stitch a severed hand back on in a moving cart; out-argue a Clausewright.
Dire	22	Climb a cliff of the Hanging Abbey in a gale; lie to a Tenanted judge.
Impossible	26	Talk a Sayer out of a sentence; outrun the Black Noon.

If the total equals or beats the Difficulty, the attempt succeeds. Otherwise it fails. A failed roll does not have to mean nothing happens: it may mean you succeed at a cost, too late, or with a complication, at the Carver’s judgment. Failure on the Table should always move the story somewhere worse, never to a dead stop.

CHOOSING THE PAIR

The same task can be rolled with different pairs, and the pair says how it is done. Breaking down a bricked door in Kest is **Gut + Labor** if you put your shoulder to it, **Eye + Craft** if you find where the mortar is weakest, **Hand + Filch** if you would rather pick the lock on the cellar hatch beside it, and **Tongue + Persuade** if you

would rather the family opened it for you. A player who describes their approach has already chosen their pair. The Carver should allow any pair that fits the description and set the Difficulty by the approach: shouldering a bricked door is Grim; finding the weak course of mortar might be only Hard, but takes ten minutes, and the thing on the other side has heard you knocking.



What can you do? Very well. Now: how are you going to do it, and who is going to hear?

NETWATCH SERGEANT’S CATECHISM

WHAT THE NUMBERS MEAN

A character with an Attribute of 2 and a Skill of 2 adds 4 to their roll, and the 2d10 average 11. Such a person succeeds at Routine tasks nine times in ten, at Hard tasks about two times in three, at Grim tasks a little more than one time in four, and at Dire tasks

almost never, unless the dice double up or the god helps. A master with 4 and 4 adds 8: Hard tasks become reliable, Grim ones better than even, Dire ones possible. This is deliberate. On the Table, the ordinary person is good at ordinary things and helpless before the extraordinary, which is why the extraordinary keeps winning, and why so many people Partake.

BONUS (ATTRIBUTE + SKILL)	ROUTINE 10	HARD 14	GRIM 18	DIRE 22
2	79%	45%	15%	1%
4	90%	64%	28%	6%
6	97%	79%	45%	15%
8	99%	90%	64%	28%
10	99%	97%	79%	45%

These figures are approximate and include the Grace on double 10s and the Lack on double 1s. Add a Tooth (average 3.5) and every row climbs by nearly two lines. That is the temptation.

HELPINGS

For every full 4 points by which a total exceeds the Difficulty, the roll earns one **Helping**. A Helping is an extra: more information, more speed, a better price, a quieter entry, a cleaner cut. In combat, each Helping adds +2 damage. A player can usually spend Helpings as they like, within reason; the Carver may offer a menu.

Example: Ressa (Eye 2, Search 3) searches a drowned house for the ledger of the Called. Difficulty Hard 14. She rolls 7 and 9: total 21. That beats 14 by 7, one Helping. She finds the ledger, and with her Helping she also notices that the last entry is written in her brother's hand.

A margin of exactly 4 is one Helping; 8 is two; 12 is three. Helpings are counted from the Difficulty the roll actually faced, including any modifiers. In an opposed roll (below), they are counted from the loser's total.

KIND OF TASK	WHAT A HELPING CAN BUY
Searching, investigating	A second clue; the clue's meaning; time saved; nobody saw you looking
Persuading, lying, haggling	A better price (10% each); a favour later; they believe it more than you meant
Stitching, healing	+1 Flesh restored; a cleaner scar; no fever; the patient stops screaming
Sneaking, climbing, running	Half the time; a better position; you bring someone with you
Crafting, mending	It lasts longer; it is beautiful; it hides something
Rites, prayers	One more mourner steadied; the god does not notice; the dead are quieter
Combat	+2 damage; or a weapon quality's Helping effect (Hooking, Stunning, Entangling)

GRACE AND LACK

When the two d10 show the same number, the roll is an **omen**.

- ◇ If the roll **succeeds**, it is a **Grace**. Something goes better than it had any right to: the strongest effect the situation allows, a Helping on top of whatever was earned, an enemy disarmed, a door that was going to be locked found open, a second piece of information. In combat, a Grace attack also inflicts a **Mangling** (see Combat).
- ◇ If the roll **fails**, it is a **Lack**. The worst plausible complication happens: the weapon breaks, the lie is not only seen through but

believed to be something worse, the patient's wound opens further, the god notices.

- ◇ **Double 1s ("Licked Clean")** always fail, whatever the total, and always with a Lack.
- ◇ **Double 10s ("Second Helping")** always succeed, whatever the Difficulty (short of the impossible), and always with a Grace.

Teeth (see Partaking) never count toward doubles. Only the two d10 can make an omen. Adversaries' rolls make omens exactly as Guests' rolls do.

LACKS WORTH HAVING

A Lack should never be the Carver punishing the player. It should be the world being itself. Good Lacks on the Table: your Tooth bites (gain 2 Hunger); somebody you love hears what you just said; the thing you did leaves a mark that a Cutwright will be able to read; the noise wakes something in the cellar; your knife slips, and now there's blood on the bread; the rope you tied comes undone, in Cradlewrack, as everything does; you say "I promise" without meaning to, in Oathen.

GRACES WORTH HAVING

A Grace should feel like the world, for one breath, being kind, and it should be a little uncanny, because on the Table kindness usually is. Good Graces: the man you are lying to wants to believe you, and does, and will defend your lie to others; the wound you are stitching closes cleaner than it should, and the patient remembers your face for the rest of their life; the lock was never locked; the Kept woman you are interrogating laughs, and tells you the thing you came for, and something else besides; the fly-front parts around you as though you were expected; the bread at the inn is safe, and you know it is safe, and you eat until you are almost full.

MODIFIERS

Circumstances add or subtract from the total, usually by 2 (sometimes by 4 for something overwhelming). Good tools, time, and help add; darkness, injury, fear, cold and Wants subtract. Do not stack more than three modifiers. If the situation is that lopsided, change the Difficulty instead.

- ◇ **Help:** another character who could plausibly assist gives +1 (or +2 with the *Second Chair* Knack). Only one helper counts, unless the task is physical and large (lifting a cart, pulling a Called man out of the surf).
- ◇ **Tools:** the right tool is assumed; a fine one gives +1 or +2; no tool at all may make a task impossible or Grim.
- ◇ **Time:** taking ten times as long gives +2. Rushing gives -2.
- ◇ **Injury, exhaustion, hunger:** -2 per condition, as specified in their rules.

Track-based penalties (Fray, Starving, Bloodied, Weariness in the Vigil, Pangs in the Fast, a Kept character's Rot) are **conditions** and apply in addition to the three-modifier limit; the limit is for the Carver's circumstantial judgments, not for the state of a Guest's body and mind. A Guest who is Rattled, Starving 2 and Bloodied simply has a very bad day. The Carver may still decide that the pile has become absurd and that the task is impossible until they rest. That is usually the right decision, and the right scene.

OPPOSED ROLLS

When two characters act against each other (a lie against a suspicion, a chase, an arm-wrestle, a haggle), both roll. The higher total wins; on a tie, the defender (or whoever is keeping the situation as it is) wins. Helpings in an opposed roll are counted by how much the winner beat the loser by.

A Threat-rated character rolls 2d10 + Threat in an opposed roll. When a Guest acts against a quick-lined adversary who is not actively resisting (sneaking past a sleeping guard; lying to a clerk who has no reason to doubt), the Carver may set a flat Difficulty of 10 + Threat instead of rolling for them. Both approaches give the same average; the opposed roll is wilder.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: AN OPPOSED ROLL

Tolly Fane has to get a sealed satchel past a Waker at the Vigil's west gate without the Waker finding the brine-cut rouse sewn into its lining. Sunniva describes Tolly yawning, very slightly, at exactly the wrong moment, so that the Waker's attention goes to her face and not her bag. "That's Deceive," says the Carver. "Tongue + Deceive against his search." Tolly has Tongue 2, Deceive 3. The Waker is Threat 3.

Sunniva rolls 8 and 5 for 18. The Carver rolls 4 and 4 for 11: a pair, and a loss, so a Lack for the Waker. Tolly wins by 7, one Helping. "He sees you yawn," says the Carver, "and he's on you with the needle before you can close your mouth, a quick bright jab in the meat of your forearm. You're awake. You're very awake. He's so pleased with himself for catching a yawner that he waves you through without touching the bag, and he writes your name in his book as a Good Citizen, Cooperative When Corrected." The Lack makes the Waker's failure worse for him. The Helping, Sunniva decides, means the Waker will remember her kindly. The Carver writes that down. Kindness from a Waker is a thing that can be called in.

LONG TASKS

For efforts that take hours or days (restitching a grandmother, deciphering a seating plan, crossing the Uncovered), the Carver sets a **number of Helpings needed**, typically 3 to 8, and a time per roll. The Guests roll until they reach the total or run out of time, and a Lack along the way costs something real.

For a long task, a success that earns no Helpings still counts as one step of progress; each Helping counts as one more. A failure counts nothing and spends the time. A Lack loses one step of progress already made, and costs something besides. A Grace counts double. Several Guests can work on the same long task, each rolling once per period, if the task allows it (three Seamers can work on a grandmother at once; only one Cutwright can read a page).

LONG TASK	HELPINGS	TIME PER ROLL	ROLL
Restitch a Kept grandmother for spring	4	1 hour	Hand + Stitching, Hard 14
Copy a Cutwright ledger before the clerk returns	5	10 minutes	Eye + Reckoning, Hard 14
Draft a forty-page marriage vow in Oathen	8	1 day	Tongue + Clause, Hard 14
Cross a day of the Uncovered without losing the line	3	4 hours	Lung + Wayfaring, Grim 18
Brick in a room in Cradlewrack before the pang	4	15 minutes	Gut + Labor, Hard 14
Talk a village out of a Reaping lottery	6	1 evening	Tongue + Persuade, Grim 18

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: A LONG TASK

In a house in the Sinks of Lastgate, the company has promised a Kept family that they will restitch great-grandmother Orla Strake before the spring feast, in exchange for a name. Halloway has Stitching 1 and Hand 4; the family's own Threader, a nervous boy of thirteen, will help her (+1). The Carver sets four Helpings at Hard (14), one hour per roll, and says the feast begins in five hours.

Hour one: Dev rolls 9 and 7, plus 4, plus 1, plus 1 from the boy: 22. Beats 14 by 8. Success plus two Helpings: three steps. The left arm goes back on, neat as a sleeve, and Orla Strake says, through her stitched jaw, "Oh, that's better, love, that's lovely."

Hour two: 3 and 3. A pair, and $3 + 3 + 6 = 12$, a failure: a Lack. "The thread pulls through," says the Carver. "Not the new thread. The old thread, in her neck, the guild thread from two hundred years ago. It parts like wet paper and her head goes over sideways on the cord of her spine and hangs there, looking at you, and she is still saying *lovely*." One step lost: they are back to two. Everybody at the table checks their Fray. (The Carver calls for a Dread 1 check; Halloway's Butcher's Calm would have ignored it, but she does not have that Knack.)

Hour three: 14 on the nose. One step: three. Hour four: 17, one step: four. Done, with an hour to spare. Orla Strake sits at the head of the feast with her head stitched on a little crooked, which the family says gives her a thoughtful look. The name she gives them is the right one.

THREAT

Minor non-player characters do not need full statistics. They have a **Threat** rating from 0 to 5 that they add to all their rolls instead of Attribute + Skill (attack rolls are listed separately). A Rim Road innkeeper is Threat 1. A Netwatch lieutenant is Threat 3. Lady Corrow Vane is not a Threat-rated character.

THREAT	WHO	EXAMPLE
0	Helpless or untrained	A child; a Seated guest asked to stand; a Counted sleeper
1	Ordinary folk	A Rim Road innkeeper; a Fatlands farmhand; a Finisher pilgrim
2	Trained	A Netwatch hookman; a Cull-bailiff; a Forsworn tough
3	Professional	A Waker; a Reckoner; a Company Warden; a Bench clerk at Clause
4	Expert	A Netwatch lieutenant's best; a Second Table huntsman captain
5	Best in the land at their work	Jem Crackle in a kitchen; Jude Crake in a cell

A Threat-rated character may be much better at one thing than their Threat suggests. The quick line may say so (*Bench Clerk, Threat 3, Clause 4*), in which case they add that number for that kind of roll instead.

◇

*A man with a hook and a wage is Threat 2. A man
with a hook and a grudge is Threat 2 and the Carver
rolls twice.*

FROM A CARVER'S MARGIN

▼ PARTAKING: THE TOOTH

Anyone with a Cut of 1 or higher carries a god. Before any roll, a Guest may **Partake**: call on the god in their blood to lend them its strength, its senses, its terrible certainty. When you Partake:

- ◇ Roll **one Tooth** (a d6, in a different color from your d10s) and add it to the total. A character of Cut 3 or higher may roll **two Teeth** if they wish. Teeth are rolled with the 2d10. They do not count for doubles.
- ◇ Gain **1 Hunger** for Partaking.
- ◇ Gain **1 additional Hunger** for every Tooth that shows a 1. The god bit back.
- ◇ Describe how the god shows itself. Each land's chapter describes its **Tooth**: a Sallowreach Guest's hands go cold and their fingers seem one joint too long; a Fatlander's mouth floods with saliva; a Brinehollower's ears pop and their voice drops an octave; a Vigil-born's eyes stop blinking; a Cradlewracker feels something turn over inside them; an Oathener hears their own heartbeat repeating their last words.

Partaking is powerful. A Tooth adds 3.5 on average, the difference between a Hard roll and a Grim one. It is also how the end comes. Every Guest who Partakes is choosing, roll by roll, to bring their god closer to the surface.

The Unfed and Blanks cannot Partake. The Unfed have Want instead.

PARTAKING, CLARIFIED

- ◇ **Declare before you roll.** The god does not come when you see the dice have failed; it comes when you ask. A player who has already rolled may not Partake on that roll.
- ◇ **Partaking costs 1 Hunger for the act**, whether you roll one Tooth or two. Rolling two Teeth (Cut 3+) costs no more for the asking, but doubles the chance of a bite.
- ◇ **A Lack while Partaking** costs 2 more Hunger in addition (see Hunger). The god was there for your failure, and it was interested.
- ◇ **A bite is a manifestation.** When a Tooth shows a 1, the god bites back with more than Hunger: each land's Tooth entry says what the body does. A Sallowreacher's hand clenches and stays clenched; a Fatlander must eat something within reach; a Brinehollower coughs up cold water and something small and

living; a Vigilant gains Weariness; a Cradlewracker doubles over in a contraction; an Oathener is taken at their last word.

- ◇ **Witnesses notice.** Partaking is visible to anyone who knows what to look for, and on the Table everyone knows. A Cutwright watching can make the *Read the Line* roll at +2. A Reckoner can sense it without a roll. In polite company in most lands, Partaking openly is as rude as unbuttoning your trousers at the dinner table, and in the Fast it is a confession.

◇

*I only did it the once, and it was to save a child. Then
I did it twice, and it was to save a child. Then I
stopped counting, and there were always children.*

SABETH THORNE, ATTRIBUTED

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: THE TOOTH

On the Mile at Lowmark, a Called girl of sixteen is walking west along the pier toward its unrailed end, and Ressa Weir has one chance to get the rope around her before she steps off into forty feet of air above the dry seabed. The Carver says it is Hand + Shooting to throw the noose clean over her shoulders at Grim (18), because the wind is up and the girl is moving.

Ressa has Hand 3 and Shooting 0. Without help she needs 15 or more on 2d10, which she has a little more than one chance in ten of rolling. Maya says, "I Partake."

She rolls 2d10 and a red d6 together: 8, 4, and the Tooth shows 5. Total $8 + 4 + 3 + 0 + 5 = 20$. Success, no Helping. Ressa gains 1 Hunger (to 4). "Your ears pop," says the Carver, "and you hear the sea in your own chest, very close, the long slow pull of it going out, and your arm moves the way the tide moves, without hurry, and the loop drops over the girl's shoulders like it was always going to. She doesn't fight. She just stops, and looks back along the rope at you, and her face is the face they all have. You know the one." The Carver does not call for a Dread check. Ressa has seen that face three hundred times. That, Maya decides, is the problem.

TOOTH ODDS

A single Tooth adds 1 to 6. It shows a 1 one time in six. A Guest who Partakes six times in a session should expect to gain about seven

Hunger, and to be bitten once. A Cut 3 Guest rolling two Teeth adds 2 to 12 (average 7), gains 1 Hunger for the act, and is bitten on about one roll in three. Players who learn these odds use the Tooth

more carefully. Players who forget them reach the Course by the end of a story. Both are good play.

▼ HUNGER

Hunger is a track from 0 to 10. It represents how awake and active the god in your blood is right now: the rise of appetite, compulsion, and wrongness in the body. Hunger rises when you:

- ◇ Partake (+1, and +1 per Tooth showing 1).
- ◇ Suffer a Lack while Partaking (+2).
- ◇ Eat godtainted food or handle relics with Taint (see the Rim Market).
- ◇ Spend time in a place where your god is strong, such as a Hush, the Trench or the Dilation (+1 per hour or more).
- ◇ Give in to a Want (+1).
- ◇ Refuse your Sop for too long (see below; +1 per day after the third).

When Hunger reaches **10**, the god takes a step forward. **Regrowth rises by 1** and Hunger empties to 0. Describe the change. Something in the body is different now, and it does not change back.

Hunger above 10 does not carry over: a Guest at Hunger 9 who gains 3 rises one step of Regrowth and empties to 0, not to 2. The god takes its step and sits back, satisfied, for now. Let that moment breathe at the table. It is the most important thing that will happen to that character in the session.

HOW HUNGER FEELS

Hunger is not a number to the Guest; it is a body. The Carver should describe it as it climbs, in the land’s idiom:

HUNGER	HOW IT FEELS (ANY LAND)
0–2	Quiet. The god is a weight in the blood, like a sleeper in the next room.
3–5	Restless. Cravings, a tell in the hands or the mouth, dreams that are not yours.
6–8	Close. The god’s wants arrive in your thoughts sounding like your own. Others notice.
9	At the door. Every sense is the god’s. Food, doors, water, sleep, words: everything is a lure.

At Hunger 6 or more, the Carver may describe the land’s Wants arriving more often and more temptingly, though the Want rolls themselves do not change unless a land’s rules say so.

THE SOP

Each land’s god can be quieted, for a while, by giving it a little of what it wants. This is the **Sop**: closing something in Sallowreach, eating in the Fatlands, bailing or submerging in Brinehollow, the dangerous blink in the Vigil, opening a door in Cradlewrack,

keeping or making a vow in Oathen. Each land’s chapter defines its Sop precisely.

Performing the Sop takes a few minutes to an hour. It removes **1d6 Hunger**. But the Sop is the god’s own habit. Each time a Guest Sops in a single day after the first, they must make a **Caul + Resolve** roll (Routine 10, Hard 14 for the third time, and so on), or the next Sop becomes a Want they cannot easily stop.

A Guest who goes **three days without Sopping** begins to gain 1 Hunger per day as the god grows restless.

LAND	THE SOP, IN SHORT	ITS STING
Sallowreach	Close something meant to stay open, that matters to someone	The Want to Close grows a step harder for the day
The Fatlands	Clean the Plate: eat until it hurts, every scrap	Human flesh Sops 1d6+2; <i>The Second Plate</i> grows harder
Brinehollow	Wade: stand in brine past the knees through a turn of the tide, facing west	The next Calling roll is harder
The Vigil	The Lull: eyes closed for a count of ten, a nudger’s hand in yours	An immediate blink check at Hard
Cradlewrack	Let It Out: open something meant to stay shut	The next closed thing aches at you
Oathen	Swear: an unconditional oath of Weight 2+, before a witness	The oath binds as normal
The Fast	None. The Unfed have no god to quiet.	Their hunger is only hunger

Example: Halloway Brisk is at Hunger 7 after a hard night. At the inn she orders the stew she knows is partly a person, and eats it all, every scrap, while Abate Kell watches with his arms folded. Dev rolls 1d6: 5. Hunger falls to 2. Because the meal was human flesh, the Fatlands Sop removes 1d6+2: the Carver lets Dev add the 2, and Hunger falls to 0. “You feel wonderful,” says the Carver. “You feel heavy. You feel like your mother’s kitchen.” For the rest of the day, Halloway’s Want of The Second Plate is one step harder to resist.

Abate does not speak to her until morning, and in the morning he says “No, thank you” three times to the bread she offers him, and does not take it on the fourth.



The Sop is the god’s leash. Mind whose hand is on the other end.

PURGATION TRACT, NAILED TO A WAYSTATION DOOR

▼ REGROWTH

Regrowth is a track from 0 to 12. It measures how far the god has come back in you. It rarely falls. The four stages, and the **Brink**

before the last, are common to every land, though each land’s chapter describes what they look and feel like there:

REGROWTH	STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
0	—	The god is asleep. Blanks and the Unfed are here forever.
1–3	The Taste	Small wrongnesses. Dreams, cravings, a tell in the body. Gain the land’s Taste Gift.
4–6	The Appetite	Compulsions. The body wants what the god wants. Gain the Appetite Gift and the first Want.
7–9	The Course	Flesh changes. You are visibly becoming something else. Gain the Course Gift and the second Want. Dread 1 to those who see you unclothed.
10–11	The Brink	The god is nearly here. Gain the Brink Gift. All Wants are Hard (14) to resist. Dread 2 to those who see your changes.
12	The Seating	The god is, in some real portion, present again, wearing you or making a place of you. The character is lost.

Gifts are the god’s power leaking through. They are real, useful and terrible, and they are listed in each land’s chapter. A Guest has every Gift from every stage they have reached.

Wants are compulsions. Each Want has a **trigger** (an open door, a closed eye, food left on a plate). When a Want is triggered, the Guest must either act on it or roll **Caul + Resolve** against Routine (10) in the Appetite, Hard (14) in the Course and Brink. Acting on a Want removes nothing and adds 1 Hunger. Resisting it successfully costs nothing; failing means acting on it anyway, or suffering 2 Fray if the player and Carver agree the Guest stood firm by sheer horror.

Where a land’s chapter gives its own difficulties for a Want (Sallowreach’s rising ladder, the Fatlands’ Grim for meat), the land’s numbers take precedence. The core numbers above are the floor: no Want at the Brink is ever easier than Hard.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: A WANT

Tolly Fane is Regrowth 3, still in the Taste, but she has been awake on the road for a long time and the Carver has been counting. At a farmhouse in Cradlewrack the company finds a dead-tired shepherd’s wife asleep sitting up at her kitchen table, which in Cradlewrack is merely sad. Tolly is from the Vigil. Her chapter gives the Want *To watch*, triggered by a sleeping or drowsing person, though Tolly is not yet in the Appetite and should not have it.

The Carver does not call for the Want. She does something worse: she describes it. “You find yourself standing in the doorway. You don’t remember deciding to. You’re counting her breaths. Eleven. Twelve. You know she won’t wake. You know that’s not true here, that people sleep here and get up again, but your whole body is waiting for her not to.” Nothing mechanical has happened. Sunniva writes *Regrowth 4 soon* in the margin of her sheet and draws a small, shut eye.

CAN REGROWTH BE REVERSED?

Almost never. A Purger’s Grace can roll it back by one, once per stage. The relics of some lands can delay it. Orrum’s tables can stop it entirely, in the way that death stops a fever. There are rumours of a dozen cures on the Rim Road, and every land is certain that one of them works. None of them do. The Carver may allow a single,

terrible, story-driven exception in a campaign. It should cost more than the character wants to pay.

D10	CURES SOLD ON THE RIM ROAD, AND WHAT THEY ACTUALLY DO
1	A Sallowreach Closer's glove, worn to bed. You wake with your own hands gone grey to the knuckle. Nothing else.
2	Fasting with the Thin. Removes 1 Hunger a day, costs 1 Flesh a day, and the Board's bailiffs want a word.
3	Brine drunk at dawn from a Tenanted man's bucket. Taint 2 Regrowth (Dromm). Worse than nothing.
4	A Cutwright's bloodletting "to thin the line." 2 Flesh, a scar, and your Cut written in a ledger you will never see.
5	A Sayer's word, sealed in wax, spoken over you. It works, for exactly as long as the wax holds. Then everything comes at once.
6	A month in the Fast, eating only carried bread. Hunger stays quiet. The table that appears on the last night has your name.
7	Sleeping in the Vigil, under guard, for one minute. The god does not care. The Tuckers keep the fee.
8	Marrying a Blank. The Blank does not know the reason. When they find out, the Carver may award a Derangement to one of you.
9	Being opened by Dr. Halloran Quease, who wants only to look. You gain a new kind of pain, catalogued as No. 401.
10	The Purgation's full rite: emetics, bleeding, the basin. Bring It Up, on a Grace, takes one point. It is the only one on the list that ever has.



Every land is certain that the cure is next door. Every land is next door to someone.

RIM ROAD SAYING, CONTINUED

THE SEATING OF A GUEST

At Regrowth 12, a Guest is **Seated**. Their god is, for a moment and in some portion, back in the world. What happens depends on the land: a Sallowreach Guest becomes a Hush; a Fatlander becomes a warm hill with, perhaps, a mouth; a Brinehollower's Tenant takes the whole house; a Vigil-born lies down and becomes a sleeper who moves; a Cradlewracker bears what they were always going to bear, or becomes the door; an Oathener becomes a Sayer, whose every word is so.

The player and the Carver play out the Seating together as a final scene. It should be awful and it should be beautiful. Afterward the character is an NPC, a place, or a power, and the player makes a new Guest. A Seated Guest's former companions should meet them again.

PLAYING THE LAST SCENE

A Seating is announced, not sprung. When a Guest reaches Regrowth 11 the Carver should say so plainly, out of character: *the next time your Hunger fills, you are Seated*. From then on, the player knows every Partake is a step toward the door. Some players stop. Some players choose the moment.

When the Seating comes, the Carver hands the scene to the player. The player describes the last few minutes in the character's voice, and may do three things, each of which the Carver must honour:

- ◇ **A last act.** One thing the Guest does with the full power of their god, without a roll: the Hush that swallows the Cullmaster's estate, the hill that rises under the Reaping field and holds it still, the Tenant that walks out of the house of a family it will never harm. It must be within the god's nature.
- ◇ **A last word.** One sentence the Guest says to someone who loves them. The Carver will bring it back, word for word, at the worst and best possible moment later in the campaign.
- ◇ **A last line.** One thing the Seated character will *not* do, even as a god's portion, as long as the campaign lasts. *She will never let the silence reach her sister's village. He will never root on a road.* This is the What You Will Not Do of the Seated, and it is the only thing of the person left in the god.

Then the companions make their Dread check. A Seating is Dread 5.

SEATING PLAY EXAMPLE: THE HILL AT HESSOP'S FURROW

Halloway Brisk has been Regrowth 11 for three sessions. Dev knows it. In the fourth session, in the Fatlands, a Cullmaster's dusk shift is walking eight debtors into a Reaping field, and one of them is a child of eleven with her hands tied, and the wheat has begun to lean. Halloway has Hunger 8. Dev looks at the sheet for a long moment and says, "I Partake." The Tooth shows a 1. The god bites back. Hunger 10.

The Carver puts down her pen. "Tell me."

Dev talks for four minutes. Halloway walks into the field. She takes off her boots, which she has never done on Fatlands soil in her life, because her mother told her not to, because of what happened to her mother. She stands among the debtors and the leaning wheat and she roots. "Her last act," Dev says, "is that the field stops. It doesn't take anyone. It can't. She's holding it. All of it. Every ear." The Carver agrees: that is within Ummer's nature, which is to hold and to feed.

Her last word goes to Abate Kell, who is holding her arm and trying to pull her up out of the ground while her feet go down into it like warm wax. It is: "Lack keep away." The grace before eating, said to a man who has never eaten with her.

Her last line: *she will never Reap*. Not a debtor, not a child, not a Cullmaster.

The companions roll Dread 5, Impossible (26). Abate Kell has Caul 4, Resolve 3, and spends Want for **Steady** (+2): he rolls 6 and 9 for 24, and fails, and takes 5 Fray. Ressa fails worse. The child with the tied hands is the only one who does not seem afraid. She sits down beside the new warm mound and puts her hand on it, and it is warm, and something under the soil is breathing very slowly.

The hill at Hessop's Furrow is on the Carver's map now. The Cullmasters cannot work that field. In the next campaign, the hill has a mouth.

SEATING PLAY EXAMPLE: THE SAYER AT THE LEDGER

Not every Seating is a sacrifice. A player running a Clausewright from Tacit has reached the Brink, and the Carver warns her. She says nothing in character for two sessions, writing every line of dialogue in conditionals on scraps of paper and handing them to the other players to read aloud. In the third session her character is captured by the Bench, who know exactly what she is about to become, and who have a sentence drafted for her to speak.

She Partakes to resist the bit. The Tooth fills her Hunger. She is Seated in a cell in the Gilded Cells, a Sayer, with a gold bit already in her mouth.

Her last act is to bite through it. The Carver allows it. Her last word is to the Guest who was her Surety: "You are released." It is so, and every oath he carries for anyone falls from his body like snow. Her last line: *she will never speak a sentence the Bench drafted*. She becomes an NPC: a Sayer who will not be used. The Bench now spends a great deal of time and money trying to find wording that she did not draft, but would say anyway. The Carver has a whole campaign in that.

▼ POSSESSION: THE GOD AT THE WHEEL

At the Brink, the god does not wait for the Seating to drive. It reaches for the reins.

From **Regrowth 10** onward, a Guest may be **Ridden**: for a short while, the god in the blood acts through the body, and the person watches, or does not. Possession is not the Seating. The Guest comes back. But each time, a little less of them does.

WHEN THE GOD REACHES

The Carver may call for a **Wheel check** whenever one of these happens to a Guest at the Brink:

- ◇ A Tooth bites back (shows a 1).

- ◇ Their Hunger reaches 8 or more.
- ◇ They fail to resist a Want with a Lack.
- ◇ They stand in a place of their god's power (a Hush, the Trench, the Dormitory, the Dilation, the Gilded Cells, a Laden hill's top).
- ◇ They Break.

The Wheel check is **Caul + Resolve** against **Grim (18)** at Regrowth 10, **Dire (22)** at Regrowth 11. The Guest may not Partake on a Wheel check; the god does not help you resist itself. A companion who is holding them, speaking their name, or reminding them of Who Waits at Home gives +2 (instead of the usual +1). An Oath on

the Dead that bears directly on the moment grants its +2 Strength as normal.

- ◇ **Success:** the Guest holds the wheel. They gain 1 Fray.
- ◇ **Failure:** the god drives for a number of **rounds** (in a fight) or **minutes** (otherwise) equal to a Tooth rolled now. The Carver plays the character; the player may suggest, but does not decide. When it ends, the Guest gains 2 Fray and one mark of **Ridden**.
- ◇ **Lack:** as failure, but measured in **hours**. The Guest suffers Lost Time for it, and the Carver narrates what was done only as it is discovered.
- ◇ **Grace:** the Guest holds the wheel, gains no Fray, and for the rest of the scene knows what the god wants, clearly, in words. This is not always a comfort.

WHAT THE GOD DOES

A Riding god acts with all the Guest’s Gifts, at the Guest’s Attribute and Skill values, and may Partake freely through them

LAND	WHEN THE GOD TAKES THE WHEEL
Sallowreach	Ossel closes. Every open thing in reach: eyes, doors, mouths, wounds, conversations, candles, lives. It goes from one to the next with great tenderness.
The Fatlands	Ummer feeds, and is fed. It eats whatever is nearest, then roots on the nearest soil; or it feeds others, gently and without stopping, past all refusal.
Brinehollow	Dromm walks west. The body goes to the nearest water, of any size, and kneels at it, and begins to speak to it in the second register.
The Vigil	Iss lies down, and lays down. The body looks for something soft, and for anyone near it who is tired, and hums.
Cradlewrack	Vey opens. Doors, locks, stitches, bricked rooms, graves. If nothing is shut nearby, it opens the Guest’s own oldest scar, and listens through it.
Oathen	Tolm witnesses. The body speaks the truth about everyone present, aloud, in plain sentences, and each sentence binds.
The Fast	Orrum has no portion in the Unfed. An Unfed Guest is never Ridden. But a Returned, an Unfed who has eaten, is Ridden by a god that does not know them, and that is worse.

RIDDEN

Each mark of Ridden stays. They do not count toward Fray. At **3 marks**, the god may take the wheel once per session without a Wheel check, at a moment of the Carver’s choosing, for a single Tooth of minutes. At **5 marks**, the Guest’s own name begins to feel like a costume; those who love them make a Dread 2 check on meeting them after an absence, because something in the face is wrong. A Purger’s Bring It Up, on a Grace, may remove a mark of Ridden instead of a point of Regrowth. Nothing else does.



He came back from it the way you come back from a long walk. Tired, and pleased, and with somebody else’s mud on his boots.

SENNET GULL, OF A NEIGHBOUR

(each Partake adds Hunger to the Guest, and the god does not mind if that Hunger fills). It acts according to its nature, not out of malice. It is not interested in the Guest’s friends, except as things in a room.

POSSESSION BY OTHERS

The Wheel rules also serve when something outside the Guest tries to take it: a Tenant in Brinehollow negotiating for an arm, a Seeming made solid in the Vigil, a Sayer’s word, an Assembler’s Part grafted on. The Carver sets the Difficulty by the strength of the thing (Hard for a fragment, Grim for a Tenant, Dire for anything Seated). Blanks and the Unfed gain their usual protections: +2 for a Blank, and the Unfed may spend Want for **Nothing to Hold** or **Clean Through**.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: RIDDEN

Ressa Weir, three campaigns' seasons later, is Regrowth 10. In the Wreck Orchard on the Uncovered, at night, her Tooth bites. The Carver calls for a Wheel check at Grim (18). Maya rolls Caul 3 + Resolve 3 + 2 (Abate is gripping her arm and saying her name) and 2d10 showing 5 and 1: total 14. A failure.

The Carver rolls a Tooth: 4. Four minutes. "You stand up," she tells Maya, privately, as Ressa. "You walk to the nearest wreck. There's a puddle in its hold, rainwater and salt, a foot across. You kneel. You put your face very close to it, and you begin to talk to it, and it's not your voice. It's lower. It's patient. It is telling the water about Ama." Ama is Ressa's sister-in-law. She is Who Waits at Home.

Abate, at the table, says, "What's she saying about Ama?" The Carver says, "You can't make it out. Only the name, over and over, and something that sounds like a list." When it ends, Ressa gains 2 Fray and a mark of Ridden. She remembers kneeling. She does not remember what she said. Neither does anyone else. The Carver does, and has written it down.

▼FRAY AND DREAD

The Table breaks minds as surely as bodies. **Fray** is a track from 0 to 10 measuring how far a Guest's composure has worn through.

DREAD CHECKS

When a Guest encounters horror, the Carver calls for a **Dread check**: roll **Caul** + **Resolve** against a Difficulty set by the horror's **Dread rating**:

DREAD	DIFFICULTY	EXAMPLES
1	Routine (10)	A rotting body. A Kept man restitched at the dinner table. Toothed wheat. Being Called by a stranger's voice.
2	Hard (14)	Watching a murder. A Kept woman coming apart in your hands. The Reaping taking someone you have just met. A Tenanted stranger looking at you.
3	Grim (18)	A loved one Called, Tenanted, Reaped or Breaking. A ritual killing. Eating a person, knowingly. A face you know on a place card.
4	Dire (22)	A person becoming a place. A Hush swallowing a village. The god in your blood speaking. Kin-slaying by your own hand.
5	Impossible (26)	A Seating. A god's face. The Host turning to look at you. Knowing that what you did changed nothing.

- ♦ **Success:** gain 1 Fray (or none, on a Grace). You hold.
- ♦ **Failure:** gain Fray equal to the Dread rating. On a Lack, add 2 more, and the Guest freezes, flees, screams, vomits or laughs, at the Carver's choice, for a moment that matters.

A Guest only checks once against the same source in a scene, and the Carver may rule that a horror seen too often stops counting (a Seamer does not check for corpses). Guests may Partake on Dread checks. The god does not mind if you are frightened, and sometimes it is the god that makes you brave.



Fear is the body being honest about the room it is in.

DR. HALLORAN QUEASE, A CATALOGUE OF PAINS,
ENTRY 3

Example: In the Lofts of Lastgate, an aisle of shelved Set-Aside turn their wrapped heads toward Tolly Fane and whisper company. Dread 3, Grim (18). Tolly has Caul 3, Resolve 2. Sunniva Partakes: 2d10 show 7 and 2, the Tooth 6, total 20. She holds, and gains 1 Fray and 1 Hunger. "Your pupils go wide," says the Carver, "and for a heartbeat you see the whole aisle from very high up, every bundle, every label, the way a sleeper would see it. It's peaceful. It's the most peaceful thing

you’ve ever seen. That’s why you aren’t afraid.” Sunniva marks the Hunger and looks unhappy about the peace.

FRAY EFFECTS

- ◇ **Fray 0–4:** steady.
- ◇ **Fray 5–7: Rattled.** –1 to all Eye and Caul rolls. Sleep is thin, appetite strange, and you jump at doors.
- ◇ **Fray 8–9: Fraying.** –2 to all rolls except to flee, hide or fight. You see things at the edge of the lamp. You are short with the people you love.
- ◇ **Fray 10: Break.**

BREAKING

When Fray reaches 10, the Guest **Breaks**. For the rest of the scene they are not in control of what they do: the player describes the Break with the Carver (running into the night, attacking the nearest person, curling under a table, laughing until they choke, saying every secret they have). Afterward, the Guest gains a **Derangement** and Fray drops to 3.

Roll on the tables below or choose one that fits what broke them. Derangements are permanent unless treated. Each has a **trigger** and an **effect**; when triggered, roll **Caul + Resolve** (Hard 14) to master it for the scene.

Which table? Roll on **Table One: The Common Madnesses** for a Guest’s first Break, or when the horror that broke them was Dread 3 or less. Roll on **Table Two: The Deep Madnesses** for a

second or later Break, or when the horror was Dread 4 or 5, or when the Guest Broke at the Brink. The Carver and player may always choose instead of rolling; the best Derangement is the one that grows out of what happened.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: A BREAK

Abate Kell has been at Fray 7 since the hill at Hessop’s Furrow. In the next session, at a crossroads in the Fatlands, he finds one of Orrum’s tables laid in the ditch, warm, with eight chairs and a card at every place. He takes his axe to it, which is his trade. The Carver tells him that the card at the head of the table, when it falls into the mud, says *Halloway Brisk*, in a fair round hand, and that there is a second card under it, still in its envelope, with his own name.

Dread 3, Grim (18). Ade rolls 2 and 2, a Lack, total 4 + 7 = 11. Fail: +3 Fray, +2 for the Lack. Fray 12, which is a Break.

Ade and the Carver agree on the Break together. Abate does not run. He sits down in the mud beside the smashed table, with his back to it, with his back carefully to every chair, and says the Decline, *no thank you, no thank you, no thank you*, for the rest of the scene, faster and faster, and will not let anyone touch him. Ressa sits beside him until it gets dark. Because his second Break comes from a Dread 3 horror, the Carver could use Table One, but this is Abate’s second Break, so they roll on Table Two: 14, **The Ledger**. That fits. From now on he keeps an account.

TABLE ONE: THE COMMON MADNESSES

D20	DERANGEMENT	EFFECT WHEN TRIGGERED
1	The Dead Man	You believe you are already dead: your flesh is rotting, your heart has stopped, you smell it. You feel no fear of harm and take no care of your body (–2 to Endure, +2 to Dread checks against death). Triggered by any reminder of your own mortality.
2	The Impostors	Someone you love has been replaced by something wearing their face, their voice, their memories. You cannot be convinced otherwise. Choose the person. You cannot cooperate with them, and may act against them. Triggered by their kindness.
3	Not My Hand	A part of your body is not yours: it belongs to someone else, or to the god. You will not use it willingly (–2 to rolls that need it) and sometimes it moves on its own. Triggered by exhaustion or Hunger 6+.
4	Lost Time	You lose minutes or hours. You come back somewhere else, with dirt under your nails and blood on your sleeve, and no memory. The Carver may narrate what you did. Triggered by Fray 5+ or by the Sop.
5	The Watchers	Everyone is watching you, reporting on you, planning against you. –2 to Persuade; +2 to Search for real threats. Triggered by being alone with strangers.
6	The Count	You must count things: steps, teeth, the dead, the living. You cannot stop until you finish, and the number is always one short. Triggered by stress.
7	The Voice at Table	You hear a voice that speaks in the tone of your god. It is reasonable. It gives advice. Some of it is good. Triggered whenever you Partake.
8	The Hollow Plate	Food tastes of ash, of rot, of people. You cannot eat without a Hard (14) Gut + Feast roll; you begin to starve in full larders. Triggered at every meal.
9	The Echo	You repeat the last words spoken to you, under your breath, again and again. In Oathen this is lethal. Triggered by shouting or by oaths.
10	The Seeing	Hallucinations: the Seeming without a city to share it. You see figures laying tables, the dead walking, your own body changing. –2 to Search. Triggered by darkness or exhaustion.

D20	DERANGEMENT	EFFECT WHEN TRIGGERED
11	Shut Doors	Open things are unbearable: doors, eyes, mouths, wounds, books. You must close them. Triggered by any open door or eye. (In Cradlewrack this is a death sentence.)
12	Kept Grief	You cannot let go of a dead person. You speak to them, set their place, keep their belongings, and, in Sallowreach, may keep them. Triggered by any reminder.
13	The Devotion	You attach to a person, cause or god with absolute loyalty and will do anything they say. Choose the object. Triggered by their presence or their absence.
14	Blood-Hunger	You crave the taste of blood, of meat, of a particular kind of meat. Triggered by the smell of cooking or of wounds.
15	The Splitting	You stand outside yourself and watch your body act. Calm, distant, unreal. +2 to Dread checks; −2 to Persuade and to anything requiring care. Triggered by violence.
16	The Unclean	You are contaminated: by godsign, by others' touch, by rot. You wash compulsively until you bleed. Triggered by touching another person or a body.
17	The Gaslight	You no longer trust your own memory. Others can convince you of anything you saw or did not see (−4 to resist being deceived about the past). Triggered by being contradicted.
18	The Rage	Small slights become murderous. Triggered by being mocked, cheated, or refused food. Roll or attack.
19	The Guilt That Bends the Room	Your guilt is so heavy it warps what you see: the person you failed is everywhere, in faces and crowds and reflections. When triggered you gain 1 Fray. Triggered by success.
20	The Pull	You feel the god's invitation in its fullest form: the sea, the Hush, the bed, the chair. You want to go. When triggered you must roll or move toward it. See <i>Despair</i> , below. Triggered by Fray 8+ or by being near the place.

TABLE TWO: THE DEEP MADNESSES

D20	DERANGEMENT	TRIGGER
1	The Rot Within	Food, mirrors, being touched
2	The Changeling House	Coming home; any reunion
3	The Borrowed Skin	Seeing your reflection; Hunger 6+
4	The Other Hours	Sleep, or the nearest thing to it; Fray 5+
5	The Second Guest	Fray 5+; being called by your name
6	The Bright Fever	Success; crowds; music
7	The Cold Plate	Another's pain or pleading
8	The Fold	Doubt; loneliness; a stranger's kindness
9	The Surgeon's Itch	A visible wound; a closed body
10	The Gravewalker	Burial grounds; the Lofts; a funeral
11	The Chorus	Silence; being alone at night
12	The Unborn	Doors; births; being asked your age
13	The Throne	Being obeyed; being doubted
14	The Ledger	Debt; kindness; any exchange
15	Under the Skin	Stillness; heat; insects
16	The Swallowed Name	Introductions; signing; oaths
17	The Guest Who Came Home	Meeting a stranger who resembles the dead
18	The Mirror at Table	Meals; glass; still water

D20	DERANGEMENT	TRIGGER
19	The Weight of Hands	Holding a weapon; holding a child
20	The Hollow Room	Waking; joy in others

THE DEEP MADNESSES DESCRIBED

1. The Rot Within. The Dead Man's deeper cousin. You are not only dead; you are *finished*, and everyone can smell it, and they are too polite to say. You refuse food (what would a corpse do with it?), you will not wash (the water would only loosen things), and you apologise to everyone who comes near you for the smell. In Sallowreach you may petition for your own Setting Aside. When triggered, you act as a corpse would, for the scene: -2 to every roll requiring will to live. You gain 1 Starving level each day you are triggered at a meal.

2. The Changeling House. The Impostors, spread through a household. Not one loved one but *all* of them have been replaced, the whole house, the whole street; only you remember the real ones, and you are being watched to see if you notice. When triggered you cannot accept food, care or comfort from anyone you knew before your Break. Who Waits at Home cannot remove your Fray. You may try to find "the real ones," and the Carver may decide where you look.

3. The Borrowed Skin. Not My Hand, grown to the whole body. You are wearing someone: the god, a dead sibling, the person you killed. The body is a coat, and it does not fit, and it is beginning to smell of its owner. When triggered you pick and pull at the seams of it (1 damage, no Armor) and suffer -2 to all Hand and Lung rolls until the scene ends. A Seamer who stitches you can make you feel it fits, for a week (Hard 14).

4. The Other Hours. Lost Time with a pattern. The hours you lose are always the same hours, and in them you go somewhere and do something, regularly, as if keeping an appointment. You find receipts in your own hand, a key you do not own, a lock of hair. The Carver keeps a secret ledger of the other hours; each session, roll a d6, and on a 1 something you did in them arrives to collect.

5. The Second Guest. There are two of you. The other one has a name (the player and Carver choose it), opinions, a voice that comes out of your mouth, and one Want of its own. It is not the god; it may be worse, because it is entirely human. When triggered, roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or the other takes the scene, with your skills and none of your loyalties. It will tell your companions things you never told them. Some of them will be true.

6. The Bright Fever. Mania, and catching. You are luminous, tireless, certain, funny, generous, beloved; you give away your lacks, you start three projects, you make speeches at waystations, and people follow you. When triggered you gain +2 to Persuade and -2 to everything requiring caution, and you cannot rest. Everyone who spends a scene with you while triggered makes a Dread 1 check;

those who fail take the Fever for a day. The crash, when the scene ends, costs you 2 Fray.

7. The Cold Plate. The loss of empathy, all at once, like a tooth pulled. Other people's pain is interesting to you, the way a lock is interesting. When triggered you may prolong it, and you want to; resisting costs Caul + Resolve (Hard 14). You no longer take Dread from harm done to others, and you gain +2 to Intimidate. You may not gain Fray reduction from rites, from Who Waits at Home, or from any comfort. The only cure that has ever worked is someone loving you anyway, for a year. It is said that Jack Tenterhook has this, and that he is waiting.

8. The Fold. Your mind has been captured, or offered itself. Some doctrine, some congregation, some voice (the Bedded, the Deepening, the Second Helping, the Finishers, the Purgation, a Celebrant of your own company) has the answer, and you have stopped asking. When triggered you must defend the doctrine and its leader. You begin play with Hold 3 to that group (see *Cult Control*). It does not have to be a cult. It only has to be certain.

9. The Surgeon's Itch. Bodies are puzzles and they are all slightly wrong. You want to open them and put them right. When triggered by a wound you must tend it, even an enemy's, even in a fight; when triggered by a closed body, a sleeping one, a dead one, you must resist (Hard 14) taking out your knife to look. You gain +1 Stitching. Seamers have a word for this, and they do not employ those who have it.

10. The Gravewalker. The dead are better company. You go to them: to the burial grounds of the lands that still bury, to the Lofts, to the Sump's edge, to the wake-tables of the Fatlands after the guests have gone. You sit with the dead, talk to them, sleep among them, and the Carver may decide that one night a sexton or a Loft-Warden finds you somewhere you should not be, in a state that should not be described, and the town decides what it thinks you did. Dread 2 for companions who find you. When triggered, resist or go to the nearest dead.

11. The Chorus. The dead talk to you, all of them, and not only the ones you knew: everyone who ever died within a mile, in the order they died, giving their names. In Sallowreach this is merely true. Elsewhere, when triggered, you cannot hear living voices over them for the scene (-4 to hearing-based Search and to understanding speech). Sometimes, very rarely, one of them tells you something you could not have known.

12. The Unborn. You have not been born yet. Everything is a rehearsal, a dream in the womb, and the real beginning is coming. You do not fear death because it cannot touch what has not begun.

When triggered you gain +2 to Dread checks and suffer -2 to every roll that requires caring about consequences. In Cradlewrack the Attendance takes a professional interest in you. You will try to find the place where you are to be born.

13. The Throne. You are chosen. Your god, or the Table, or the dead, have marked you to rule, or to save, or to end. When triggered you will not take orders, accept advice, or admit fault, and you gain +2 to Intimidate and Tongue rolls to command. You may begin to believe your Gifts are greater than they are. The Carver may let you, once, and let you find out.

14. The Ledger. You keep accounts. Every kindness done to you is a debt; every debt must be repaid exactly, no more, no less, at once; every loss must be balanced by a loss. When triggered by an exchange you must settle it, and you cannot accept gifts at all without a Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) roll. You remember every debt anyone owes you. You begin to take payment from those who do not settle.

15. Under the Skin. Something is living under your skin: grubs, wheat-teeth, the sea, a Part looking for its body. You feel it move. When triggered you must scratch and dig at it (1 damage, ignores Armor; a Lack opens a Ripping wound) and suffer -2 to Hand rolls for the scene. On the Table it is sometimes true, and a Seamer who looks may find something. That is the cruelty of it: you can never be sure it is madness.

16. The Swallowed Name. You have lost your name. You know it is on your sheet, you know people call you by it, but it is not yours; it belongs to someone dead, or to the god, and to say it aloud would be a lie. In Oathen this is dangerous. When triggered you cannot give your name, sign it, or swear by it, and oaths sworn by you count one Weight lower (to a minimum of 1) because the god is not sure who swore them.

17. The Guest Who Came Home. The one you lost has come back. Not as a Kept or a Tenant: alive, as a stranger, wearing a stranger's face, and only you can see it. You will follow them, protect them, give them everything you have, and grieve all over again when they do not know you. When triggered you cannot act against the stranger, and you gain 1 Fray each time they refuse you.

18. The Mirror at Table. Your reflection is late. It moves a moment after you do, or does not move, or is eating. When triggered you must cover or break the reflecting surface, or watch it and take 1 Fray. Over time, the reflection seems to be getting closer to the glass. In the Vigil you may find others who see their reflections laying tables.

19. The Weight of Hands. Your hands want to do the worst thing they can. Holding a knife, you imagine the throat of the person beside you; holding a child, you imagine the drop. You will never do it, and you cannot stop imagining it, and you are sure that one day you will. When triggered you must put down whatever you hold, or roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) to keep it, and you gain 1

Fray either way. This madness is a torment of the good. It never makes anyone act. Tell the player so.

20. The Hollow Room. Despair without the Pull. Nothing calls you; nothing is there to call. Food tastes of nothing, faces are furniture, the god in your blood is the only thing in you that wants anything. When triggered you cannot spend Portions, gain no Fray reduction from rest, and may not take the Last Meal bonus. You can still be reached by someone who sits with you. The Carver should make that worth doing.



*She didn't go mad. She went somewhere very quiet
and very reasonable and then she sent back word that
we were all mad, and she was polite about it.*

WRECKWIFE, TO THE NETWATCH

MASTERING AND TREATING DERANGEMENTS

When a Derangement triggers, the Guest rolls **Caul + Resolve** (Hard 14) to master it for the scene. A Guest may Partake on this roll. A Celebrant, Seamer or friend who has spent at least one downtime period tending the Guest gives +2. A Guest who masters the same Derangement three sessions running may, with a deed the Carver accepts, lower its difficulty to Routine (10) for good. They are not cured. They are only used to it.

Derangements can be treated with months of care, a Celebrant or Seamer who understands the mind, and 10 Portions. Some never go. Some of them, on the Table, are not wrong.

CONTAGION

Madness on the Table is catching. It always has been: the Seeming of the Vigil is only the most organized form of it. When a Guest or NPC **Breaks** in the presence of others, every witness makes a **Dread 2** check. Anyone who fails and is at Fray 5 or more also takes the same Derangement, in a shared form: they see what the Broken one saw, believe what they believe, count the same count. The Carver should make this feel like a cold draft moving through a room.

As the gods regrow, contagion grows stronger. In a place where a Seating has occurred, or near a Brink-stage noble, witnesses check at Dread 3.

A shared Derangement is weaker than the original: its mastering roll is Routine (10), and it fades after a week unless it triggers in that week, in which case it is permanent. Two people who share a Derangement trigger each other: when one is triggered, the other must roll too. This is how households go mad together.

DESPAIR

Of all the Derangements, **The Pull** is the most dangerous, and the Table is full of people who have answered it: the Finishers singing their way into the Hushes, the Called walking into the surf, the sleepless of the Vigil lying down on purpose, the starving of the Fatlands crossing into the Fast to find a table where they can finally feel full.

When a Guest with the Pull is triggered and fails to master it, they move toward the god's place and invitation. They can be stopped by their companions (a roll, a grip, a rope, a word, a reason). If they reach it and nothing stops them, the player and the Carver decide together what happens, out loud, with the table's consent. This book never describes such an ending as a method or a release. It describes it as what it is on the Table: a loss that lands on everyone who loved them, and a little more of the god in the world. A Guest's companions who witness it gain Fray as a Dread 4 horror, and the Carver should give the grief room.

HOLDING ON

Stopping someone who is answering the Pull is never a single roll. It is a scene. The companion must reach them (a chase, if need be), hold them (Gut + Brawl or Gut + Labor, opposed by the Pulled one's Lung + Athletics), and then give them a reason: a Tongue + Persuade roll against Hard (14), with +2 if the reason is Who Waits at Home, the Last Meal, or an Oath on the Dead the Pulled one has not yet kept. Succeed, and the Pull lets go for the night. Fail, and they must be held until dawn, and both gain 1 Fray for every hour of it. Nobody who sits up through that night with someone they love is the same afterward. Give them Portions for it.

RECOVERING FROM FRAY

- ◇ **A night of real rest**, safe, warm and fed (and awake, in the Vigil): remove 1 Fray.
- ◇ **A rite** led by a Celebrant or performed sincerely: remove 2 Fray.
- ◇ **A vice**: drink, rouse, poppy, brine tonic, gambling, sex (off-page), violence. Remove 1d6 Fray, but roll Gut + Endure (Hard 14) or develop a habit. Habits work like Wants.
- ◇ **Time with Who Waits at Home**: remove all Fray, once per story, if they are still themselves.
- ◇ **Portions**: 2 Portions removes 3 Fray between sessions.

▼ MADNESS IN THE COMMUNITY

A person Breaks in a night. A village Breaks over a season, and nobody in it can say when it began. As the gods regrow, whole communities are wearing through: the Netwatch villages where the morning count goes unanswered on three houses in a row, the Fatlands hamlets that start drawing lots for the dusk shift among themselves, the streets of the Slope where a yawn goes through a tenement like fire. This section lets the Carver track a community's collective Fray and play out what happens when it fails.

THE PALL

A community (a village, a street, a waystation, a ship's crew on the Uncovered, a regiment) has a **Pall** from 0 to 20. It is the community's Fray: how much horror it has absorbed and not healed. It also has a **Steadiness** from 0 to 5, like Threat, measuring what holds it together.

STEADINESS	WHAT HOLDS THEM
0	Nothing: a refugee camp, a Breakdowns tenement, a crew stranded on the Uncovered
1	A little: a market, a well, a shared trade, a waystation's routine
2	A village with a working faith, a Celebrant, a midwife, and the morning count
3	A close village with old rites, kin on every street, and a reason to stay
4	A fortress of habit: the Hanging Abbey, the Attendance's lying-in houses
5	Almost nothing on the Table. Wanting, on its best day.

The Pall rises when the community suffers:

EVENT	PALL
A Break witnessed in public	+1
A death by murder, Reaping, Calling, or the Counted bed	+1
A public execution or ritual killing	+2
A loss to the Pull: someone who answered it	+2
A preacher of despair or ecstasy working the streets for a week	+1
A Seating within a day's walk	+3
A week of famine (half rations for most)	+1
The community discovers it has been lied to by those it trusted	+2

The Pall falls when the community heals: a rite of mourning for the named dead (−1d3), a feast (−1, if the food is safe), a rescue the village can see (−2), a murderer exposed and dealt with justly (−2), a cult's leader driven out (−2), the Guests sitting up with the grieving for a week (−1), a season with no losses (−1).

THE TURN

Once each week of game time (or once per session, if the Guests are passing through), the Carver rolls for the community: **2d10 + Steadiness** against **10 + the Pall**.

◇ **Success:** the community holds. The Pall falls by 1.

- ◇ **Failure:** the Pall rises by 1, and the Carver chooses or rolls an event from the community's current band.
- ◇ **Lack:** the Pall rises by 2, and the worst event in the band happens.
- ◇ **Grace:** the Pall falls by 2, and the Carver describes an act of ordinary decency that the Guests witness: a widow feeding her neighbour's children, a Netwatch man who sits down on the pier beside a Called girl and simply talks to her until the tide turns.

THE BANDS OF THE PALL

PALL	BAND	WHAT THE COMMUNITY IS LIKE
0–4	Whole	Grief is grieved. Dread checks in town are as normal.

PALL	BAND	WHAT THE COMMUNITY IS LIKE
5–9	Uneasy	Rumour, locked doors, quarrels. Contagion checks in town are made at Fray 3 or more instead of 5.
10–14	Feverish	Shared Seemings, witch-hunts, scapegoats. Contagion at Dread 3. Cults gain +2 to Hold.
15–19	Broken	Clusters of loss. The Pull goes through the streets. Each Turn, one event, even on a success.
20	Lost	The community belongs to the god. It empties, or Seats, or simply stops.

D10	UNEASY EVENTS	FEVERISH EVENTS
1	Doors barred in daylight; neighbours stop calling names through walls	A shared Seeming: the whole street saw a tall figure laying a table in the square
2	A family moves its Kept or its old ones into the cellar, and will not say why	A scapegoat is chosen: a Blank, a foreigner, a Guest
3	A child's counting-game changes its words	A preacher gathers thirty in a barn, and they come out singing
4	Someone reports a neighbour to the Wakers, the Netwatch, the Board	A house is burned with a family in it, "for their own good"
5	The Celebrant stops holding rites; he says he does not know who is listening	Everyone in a street shares a Derangement for a week
6	A well is declared tainted, and argued over	The village begins drawing lots for something, and will not say what
7	Bread is hoarded	A mob forms at dusk with no leader and no object
8	A child goes missing and is found, and will not say where	The Guests' lodging is marked with a sign in chalk
9	Two old friends come to blows over nothing	A public confession, and a punishment invented on the spot
10	The Guests are asked to leave, politely	The village elder announces that the god has spoken to him

WHEN A COMMUNITY BREAKS

At **Broken**, the community is losing people to the god faster than it can mourn them. This is where the Table's worst tragedies happen:

the walks into the sea at Lowmark in 118 A.G., the Finishers' great pilgrimage of 590, the Slope tenement that lay down in a single afternoon. Run these as tragedy. The camera stays on the people left behind. The Carver never describes how anyone is lost, only the shape of the absence.

D10	BROKEN EVENTS
1	The morning count goes unanswered on four houses. Their doors are open, their beds made. Their bail-buckets sit neatly on the steps, rinsed.
2	A family of five answers the Pull together, holding hands, singing a nursery song. One child let go of the hand, and came back, and has not spoken since.
3	The village Celebrant leads a procession toward the god's place. Half the village follows. The other half barricades the road, and some of them are holding their own children back by the coat.
4	The Seamer, the midwife, the healer, the one whose job was to keep people alive, is gone. A note in a careful hand asks someone to feed the cat.
5	The graves, wake-tables, Lofts or niches are opened in the night, and the village's dead are taken out and sat at a long table in the square, dressed for dinner. Nobody will say who did it. Everybody's hands are dirty.
6	A mother insists all her children are impostors. Three neighbours agree with her about their own. The Guests are asked to take the children away.
7	Someone the Guests have spoken to, liked, perhaps helped, is gone in the night. They left the Guests a gift: something small, and kind, and terrible.
8	The surviving elders hold a council and vote, solemnly, by the old law, to offer the god what it wants. The vote is not unanimous. The losers are not allowed to leave.
9	A rumour runs that the Guests can stop it. A crowd gathers at their door, begging. Each one has a name to give them.
10	Nothing happens. For a week, nothing at all. People are polite. Then a Cutwright arrives with a ledger, and the Guests learn the Pall has spread to the next village down the road.

Each Broken event adds the listed horror's Dread check for the Guests, usually Dread 3, and a Dread 4 if someone they know is

among the lost.

LOST

At Pall 20, the community is the god's. The Carver decides what that means in the land: in Sallowreach, a new Hush opens where the village was, and the village is very quiet; in the Fatlands, the fields close over it in a single Carving and the houses are found next spring in the middle of a new wood of bleeding trees; in Brinehollow, the village walks west on one night, and on that night the sea, far off, rises an inch; in the Vigil, a street of beds; in Cradlewrack, a crowning opens under the square; in Oathen, a gorge goes silent forever; in the Fast, a table, very long, with everyone at it, smiling. A Lost community cannot be saved. Only its survivors, if any, can be.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: THE PALL AT GANNET REACH

Gannet Reach is a Netwatch village of ninety souls on the Brinehollow shore, Steadiness 2 (a chapel, a midwife, the morning count). The company arrives at Pall 6: three Called this season and a public Break at the fish market. Uneasy.

Week one: the Carver rolls 2d10 + 2 against 16: total 13. Failure. Pall 7. She rolls an Uneasy event: 4, *someone reports a neighbour*. An old man denounces his daughter-in-law to the Netwatch as a Tenanted, because she has been kind to him lately. Ressa is Netwatch. She is asked to take the daughter-in-law away.

Ressa refuses. She sits with the family for an evening, and Halloway cooks for them. The Carver gives them -1 Pall for the feast: back to 6.

Week two: the Deepening arrives, Mother Limpet's lanterns on the shingle at night, singing. +1 for the preacher. The Turn: 2d10 + 2 = 18 against 17. Success, -1. Pall 6. The Carver notes that Limpet's people have Hold 1 on four families.

Week three: the Turn comes up 1 and 1. Licked Clean. A Lack. Pall rises by 2 to 8, and the worst Uneasy event happens: the Guests are asked to leave, politely, by the same old man, who weeps as he asks. If they go, Gannet Reach will be Feverish by Tablenight. If they stay, they are going to have to go down to the shingle and talk to Mother Limpet.



You don't hear a village go. You hear it stop calling names through the wall, one house at a time, until it's quiet enough to hear the sea.

LIEUTENANT SABLE REEF, NETWATCH

▼ CULT CONTROL AND GASLIGHTING

The Table is full of people who will tell you what is happening to you. The Bedded say the room is home. The Second Helping says being eaten is being loved. The Deepening walks you into the sea with a lantern and a hymn. The Finishers, the Barren Order, the Purgation, the Second Table, a kind old man at a waystation who has a theory: all of them want your mind, and most of them want it kindly. These rules cover how a mind is taken, slowly, by people.

HOLD

A group or person working on a character builds **Hold** over them, from 0 to 5. Hold is tracked separately for each group. It is built through **methods**, and each method is a scene:

- ◆ **The Warm Table.** Food, shelter, praise, belonging. Most effective on the hungry and the lonely.

- ◆ **The Confession.** The target is drawn to tell their secrets; the group keeps them.
- ◆ **The Severing.** The target is kept from Who Waits at Home, from companions, from anyone who knew them before.
- ◆ **The Long Night.** Exhaustion, fasting, ritual, repetition, until thought goes soft.
- ◆ **The Answer.** The doctrine explains the target's suffering. It always does.
- ◆ **The Debt.** A gift, a rescue, a cure that half works. Now they owe.

At the end of each such scene, the recruiter rolls **Tongue + Persuade** (or **Threat**) opposed by the target's **Caul + Resolve**. If the recruiter wins, Hold rises by 1 (by 2 on a Grace). If the target wins

with a Grace, Hold falls by 1. The same method cannot raise Hold twice in a row; a skilled recruiter varies them.

CIRCUMSTANCE	MODIFIER TO THE RECRUITER
Target is Rattled (Fray 5+) / Fraying (8+)	+1 / +2
Target is Starving, Hollow or worse, or Weary 5+	+2
Target is cut off from Who Waits at Home and companions	+2
Target has The Devotion, The Gaslight or The Fold	+2
Community Pall is Feverish or worse	+2
The doctrine matches the target's own god or grief	+2
Target has <i>No Thank You</i> (Knack)	-2

HOLD	WHAT IT MEANS	TO ACT AGAINST THE GROUP
1	Sympathy. The target defends them in argument.	No roll
2	Belonging. The target feels warmer among them than anywhere.	Routine (10)
3	Obedience in small things. The target reports on their friends.	Hard (14)
4	Obedience in large things. The target will cut off kin and harm outsiders.	Grim (18)
5	Captured. The target is theirs.	The character becomes an NPC

A Guest at **Hold 5** is captured: the player hands the character to the Carver until they are brought back, and may make a temporary Guest in the meantime. The captured character gains **The Fold** if they did not have it.

BRINGING SOMEONE BACK

Hold falls when the target sees the group plainly: a leader caught in a lie (-1), a promise of the doctrine broken in front of them (-1), the death or harm of someone the group sent to the god (-2), Who Waits at Home reaching them in person (-1, and +2 to the target's next roll). An Oath on the Dead that the group is making the target break gives the target +2 on every roll against them.

Bringing back a captured Guest is a long task: Hold × 2 Helpings needed, one roll per day of the companions' Tongue + Persuade (or Rites, or Stitching, if it is done by care rather than argument) against the group's Hold-difficulty from the table. Every day of it costs the captured Guest 1 Fray, because coming back is tearing something out. A Lack sends the target back to the group for a night, and the group knows who came for them.



*Nobody ever joined us. They came to supper, that's all,
and then they came again.*

BROTHER GLUT OF THE SECOND HELPING, TO A
BOARD INQUIRY

GASLIGHTING: DOUBT

Sometimes the attack is not a doctrine but a memory. *You never saw that. You were asleep. You always say that. Nobody's door was open. Your brother walked in; we all saw him; you weren't there.* On the Table, where the Vigil records hallucinations as news, where blinks steal seconds and Lost Time steals hours, gaslighting is easy and terribly effective.

When someone tells a character that their memory of something is false, the liar rolls **Tongue + Deceive** opposed by the target's **Eye + Reckoning** (the same roll the Vigil uses to trust a memory). If the liar wins, the target gains 1 **Doubt** about that memory. At 3 **Doubt**, the target accepts the false version and gains 1 Fray. A character with **The Gaslight** Derangement suffers -4 on these rolls, as that Derangement says, and starts at 1 **Doubt** on any memory they are contradicted about.

Evidence breaks Doubt: a ledger, a witness who has no reason to lie, the body itself. A companion who confirms the memory gives +2. The Vigilant at Weariness 5 or more, any character who has had Lost Time or a blink in the scene in question, and any character Ridden in it, suffer -2, because they know that they might be wrong.

CARVER'S ADVICE: GASLIGHTING GUESTS, NOT PLAYERS

These rules are for doubting a *character's* memory, not the player's. Never tell a player that something they heard at the table did not happen. Instead, tell them openly: *the innkeeper says the door was shut all night; you have one Doubt*. Let the player decide how the Guest feels. The horror comes from watching your own character start to give in, not from being lied to by your friend across the table. Guests may gaslight each other only with both players' consent, agreed out of character, before the scene.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: THE BEDDED

Tolly Fane, Regrowth 4, Weariness 6, has been lodging for three nights in a house on the Slope where Sister Vesper Null's Bedded hold their quiet meetings. The Carver has run three scenes: a warm room where the Bedded let Tolly sit on a floor that does not slope (the Warm Table); an evening when a girl Tolly's age told her, gently, that her mother in the Dormitory is happy now (the Answer); a night when Tolly blinked, and a Bedded elder said, kindly, that she had been gone for almost a minute and that she had smiled (the Long Night).

Each time, the recruiter (Threat 3, +2 Weariness, +1 Rattled, +2 for a doctrine that matches her god) rolled against Tolly's Caul 3 + Resolve 2. Tolly lost twice. Hold 2. Then the elder told her she had not blinked at all the night before: she had slept for a full count of ten, and come back, which nobody does. Sunniva rolled Eye + Reckoning, at -2 for the blink: she lost. One Doubt.

Ressa comes to the house the next morning and says: "You were asleep for one breath and Abate pinched you. I was there." That is a companion confirming the memory; +2 on the next roll, and the Carver lets the Doubt stand at 1. But Sunniva says, quietly, that Tolly wants to go back to the meeting that night. Just to see. The Carver writes *Hold 2, Doubt 1*, and says nothing at all.

▼ INVESTIGATION

Much of play on the Table is finding out: who took the hand, where the Called go, what the Cullmasters' list is for, why the Hushes follow the Hand-lines. These rules make investigation fast, fair and unpleasant.

CLUES ARE NOT ROLLED FOR

The clue that keeps the story moving is never behind a roll. If a Guest looks in the right place with a sensible approach, they find it. Rolls decide **how much more** they find, **how fast**, and **what it**

costs. A failed search does not hide the clue; it means the clue is found late, or loudly, or by the wrong person first, or that finding it costs Fray, Hunger, or a night. The Carver should plan each mystery as a chain of **leads**, each pointing to at least two others, so that no single failure stops the investigation.

THE SENSES OF THE TABLE

Every skill can investigate. Each finds different things.

SKILL	FINDS
Eye + Search	Physical traces: marks, objects, the door that was opened from the inside
Hand + Stitching	What a body says: how it died, what was done to it, what it ate, how long ago
Eye + Lore	History, doctrine, whose crest, which bloodline, what the old carving shows
Eye + Reckoning	Ledgers, tallies, clocks, the arithmetic that someone wanted hidden
Caul + Instinct	People: who is lying, who is afraid, who already knew
Caul + Godsign	Godsign traces: a closing, an opening, a Tenant's passing, a binding
Eye + Feast	Taste and smell: what meat, which poison, whose kitchen
Tongue + Clause	Documents: what the contract really says, the Exit buried in an oath

Each Helping on an investigation roll buys one of: **another clue**, **the meaning of a clue**, **time** (half as long), or **discretion** (nobody knows you found it).

THE BILL

Every investigation has a **Bill**: a clock, from 4 to 8 boxes, that fills as the Guests stumble. A box fills on every failed investigation roll, on every day that passes, and on every Lack (two boxes). When the Bill is paid in full, the thing being investigated happens: the next blink-murder, the dusk shift goes out, the Second Table dines, the witness is Set Aside. The Guests can see the Bill. The Carver should draw it.

EACH LAND ITS WITNESS

Every land offers investigators a way of knowing that would be impossible anywhere else, and each comes at a price.

- ◇ **Sallowreach.** Ask the victim. The dead are Kept, and can talk, if their jaw is on. They may lie, and they may not know who did it, and a Kept murder victim is Dread 2 to interview.
- ◇ **The Fatlands.** Taste it. A Fatlander with *Taste the Name* learns the eater's secrets from a mouthful of flesh, at the cost of Hunger and the horror of witnesses.
- ◇ **Brinehollow.** The indoor tide returns what it takes. Search a cellar at the ebb, and the sea may give back a ring, a tooth, a letter. Ask a Tenanted judge, who will answer truthfully and in two voices.
- ◇ **The Vigil.** The Seeming is evidence. If a street saw it, it is on the record, and the Seemer's ledgers can be read. Whether it happened is a separate question.
- ◇ **Cradlewrack.** The Tally records every birth of every kind. If something was born, it is written down, and the Tallyman knows the arithmetic does not close.
- ◇ **Oathen.** Have the suspect repeat their promise aloud, and watch. Judge Thane Urow needs no other evidence. Neither will you.

▼ CHASES

When someone runs and someone follows, use a **chase**. A chase is fast, a series of opposed rolls around a track of **Lead**.

THE LEAD

The chase begins at a **Lead of 2** (a close chase: the hunter saw them go) or **3** (a head start). Each round, the quarry and the hunter each roll **Lung + Athletics** on foot, **Lung + Wayfaring** mounted, on a cart, or across hard country, or **Lung + Stealth** if the quarry is trying to vanish rather than outrun. Whoever wins moves the Lead by 1 in their favour, plus 1 per Helping.

- ◇ **Lead 0:** caught. The hunter is close enough to grab, strike or tackle. A fight begins, or the quarry surrenders.

- ◇ **The Fast.** Read the place cards. The Host knows every name, and spells them correctly.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: THE MISSING HANDS OF CLENCH ROW

In the Sinks of Lastgate, four Kept on Clench Row have woken without their hands. The Carver sets a Bill of 6: when it fills, Marrow Jack sells the hands to someone who is collecting a particular set. Her leads: the stumps (Stitching), the victims' testimony (Instinct), a drop of cedar oil on the sill (Search), and a fence's ledger in the Lower Pilings (Reckoning).

Halloway examines the stumps: Hand 4 + Stitching 1, Hard (14). She rolls 15. Success: they were taken with a fine saw, not a cleaver, by someone who knew where the wrist bones part. Ressa interviews the first victim, an old Kept woman named Hessa Coombe, Instinct against Routine (10) because she wants to talk: 19, two Helpings. Ressa learns that Hessa can feel her missing hand, right now, being washed, gently, in warm water; and (the second Helping) that the water smells of cedar and salt. The Carver lets the Helpings buy *meaning*: the cedar is Lastgate perfume, which marks the buyer as rich; the salt is Brinehollow brine, which the rich of the Vigil drink in their rouse.

Tolly searches the sill: 11, failure. One box of the Bill fills. She finds the drop of cedar oil anyway (it is the clue that moves the story), but she finds it late, after a neighbour has seen her and gone to tell someone. Four boxes left, and somebody in the Lower Pilings now knows the company's faces.



*In Lastgate the murdered testify at their own inquests.
It has not raised the conviction rate. They are as bad
at noticing things as the rest of us.*

JUSTICE EVER LATHE, THROUGH HIS CLERK

- ◇ **Lead 6:** lost. The quarry is gone, hidden, or out of reach; the hunter must find a new trail, which is an investigation.

A group chasing or fleeing rolls with its slowest member, unless it leaves them behind. That choice is the most important one in most chases, and it should be put to the players out loud.

BREATH

A body can run hard for a number of rounds equal to **Gut + Endure**. After that, each round requires a **Gut + Endure** roll at Hard (14) or the runner suffers -2 to chase rolls, cumulative. Bloodied, Starving and Weary characters run out of breath at half the count. The Kept, the Tenanted and the Seated never tire. That should be terrifying.

COMPLICATIONS

Each round, the side that lost the previous roll may describe a **complication**, or the Carver rolls on the table below. A

complication is a single roll for whoever reaches it: success keeps the pace, failure costs 1 Lead (and a Lack costs 2 and a fall, a wound, or a dropped thing). The Carver should always describe the place.

D10	CHASE COMPLICATIONS
1	A crowd: a market, a procession, a wake. Tongue + Intimidate to clear it, or Lung + Athletics to thread it.
2	A climb: a wet piling, a cliff stair, a slope of loose red clay. Lung + Athletics, Hard (14).
3	A door, barred. Gut + Labor to break it (Grim 18), or Hand + Filch to open it (Hard 14). In Cradlewrack it is already open.
4	A drop: a cut-away pier, a crowning, a sunken storey. Lung + Athletics, Hard (14), or take 1d6 and lose 2 Lead.
5	A hiding place: the quarry may switch to Stealth, opposed by the hunter's Eye + Search.
6	Something in the way that should not be: a Kept beggar, a laid table, a Counted sleepwalker. Dread check, Dread 1–2.
7	Mud, fen, warm soil that gives underfoot. Lung + Wayfaring, Hard (14). A Fatlander standing still may root.
8	The hue and cry: bystanders take a side. The side with the better reputation here gains 1 Lead.
9	A narrow way: a plank, a ledge, a single-file canyon path. Only one can pass at a time; the quarry may block it behind them.
10	The land itself: a Black Noon, a pressure day, a pang, a Yawn, an echo, the smell of bread on the wind. The Carver decides who it helps.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: A CHASE ON THE MILE

A Rim Road Company clerk the company needs to question bolts from them on the Mile at Lowmark at dusk. Lead 2. The clerk is Threat 1; Tolly (Lung 3, Athletics 2) gives chase, because she is fastest.

Round one: Tolly 15, clerk 9. Tolly wins by 6, one Helping: the Lead falls by 2, from 2 to 0. Caught. Sunniva wants him held, so the Carver calls for a grapple, Hand + Brawl against the clerk's Guard of 11; Tolly rolls 10 and misses by one. She gets a fistful of his coat, and he tears out of it and keeps running. The Carver puts the Lead back to 1 and hands Sunniva the coat. There is a ledger in the inside pocket.

Round two: the clerk lost, so the Carver rolls a complication: 6, something in the way. A procession of the Deepening is walking down the pier toward the end of the Mile with lanterns, two hundred strong, singing, and the clerk is running straight into it. Dread 2. Tolly holds. The clerk does not stop at the procession. He joins it. He takes a lantern from the nearest hand and walks with them, and he is weeping, and he looks back at Tolly once over his shoulder with an expression of enormous relief.

Tolly can follow him into the procession, and the Carver tells her plainly that this is now a different scene: the procession has the Pull. Sunniva has the ledger. She lets him go, and the Carver lets that cost her 2 Fray, and the table is quiet for a while.

▼ HEALTH, HUNGER, AND THE BODY

ORDINARY HUNGER AND

STARVATION

Every person needs about one day's bread a day: one lack's worth.

Each day a character goes without food, they gain one level of **Starving**: -1 to all rolls per level, cumulative. At Starving 3, they cannot recover Flesh. At Starving 5, they lose 1 Flesh per day. A day of decent food removes one level. In the Fatlands, ordinary food never satisfies (see that chapter); in the Fast, nothing grows, and the Starving rules are the weather. Inside the Fast, use the **Pangs** track

STARVING	WHAT THE BODY DOES
1	The stomach talks. Thoughts go to food every few minutes. Short temper.
2	Cold hands and feet, though the day is warm. Dizziness on standing. Dreams of meals.
3	The body begins to eat itself. Wounds will not close. The breath smells sweet and wrong.
4	Hair comes away in the comb. Gums bleed. The mind goes sharp and strange; you recite recipes you were never taught.
5	The ankles swell. Sores open where you lie. The heart thuds slow and heavy. You lose 1 Flesh a day.
6+	You stop feeling hungry. That is the worst sign. Each dawn, Gut + Endure (Grim 18) or suffer Ruin.

Refeeding. A character at Starving 4 or more who eats a full meal must roll **Gut + Endure** (Hard 14) or lose 1d6 Flesh to cramps, sweats and the heart’s stutter. The Unfed know this as refeeding sickness, and so does every Crumb-Runner who has watched a rescued child die of the first good supper.

What will be eaten. Starving people eat leather, glue, bark, tallow candles, the wallpaper paste, the dog. At Starving 4, a character who has a person’s body within reach and nothing else must roll **Caul + Resolve** (Hard 14) to leave it uneaten; a Fatlander with *The Long Pig* rolls at Grim (18). Eating a person knowingly is Dread 3, as the Dread table says, and if it crosses What You Will Not Do, the Guest takes 5 Fray as well. On the Table this is not a rare horror. It is how half the lands remember the Lack.

THE ARITHMETIC OF THE LIFEBOAT

The Uncovered is full of salvage crews who were stranded between tides, and the Admiralty records are full of what they did. If a company of Guests is starving together and there is not enough, the Carver should make them decide who eats, out loud, each day. Track rations openly. Every day that someone takes less so that another takes more, give the giver a Portion at the session’s end. The Table remembers who fed whom. So do the players.

from that chapter in place of Starving levels; a character who leaves the Fast converts Pangs to Starving levels at half, rounding up.

Half rations (a Fast “Pantry measure,” a sailor’s biscuit and water) neither add nor remove a level. A character may go a number of days equal to **Gut** on half rations before they begin to gain a level every second day.

COLD, EXHAUSTION AND SLEEPLESSNESS

Each night without shelter in Lack, or without sleep, imposes -1 to all rolls (cumulative, up to -4) until the character rests. The Vigil has its own rules for sleeplessness, which are worse.

POISON

A poison has a **Potency** (the Difficulty to resist), an **Onset**, an **Effect**, and a **Course** (how many times the victim must resist before it is done). When poisoned, the victim rolls **Gut + Endure** against Potency at Onset and again at each step of the Course; each failure applies the Effect. A Seamer may give +2 by care (Hand + Stitching, Routine 10, the right purge or poultice). An *Iron Stomach* gives +2; a Fatlander’s *Iron Belly* lets them eat mild poisons as food. Detecting a poison by taste or smell is **Eye + Feast**, at the poison’s Potency. The Table’s poisons are as particular as its gods:

POISON	POTENCY	ONSET / COURSE	EFFECT PER FAILURE
Widow’s Supper (Fatlands, in gravy)	Hard 14	an hour / 3	2 damage; the victim keeps eating
Grey Kiss (Sallowreach, from a Closer’s glove)	Grim 18	at once / 1	the limb touched goes cold and dead for a day
Drowned Milk (Brinehollow, bottled bail-water gone bad)	Hard 14	a night / 3	lungs fill: -2 Lung, then drowning
Long Sleep (Vigil, poppy and linen-water)	Grim 18	minutes / 2	+3 Weariness; in the Vigil, often murder
Second Water (Cradlewrack, red spring-water)	Hard 14	a day / 4	false labor, -2 to all, then 1d6 damage
Hushwort (Oathen, chewed)	Routine 10	minutes / 1	the tongue goes numb; no speech, no oaths
Hearthsmoke (anywhere, rumoured from the Fast)	Dire 22	an evening / 1	the victim smells bread and walks toward it

◇ Mind the gravy. It is always the gravy.

JEM CRACKLE'S ONLY PUBLISHED ADVICE

Example: At a Board inn outside Sated, Abate Kell refuses the gravy three times and takes it on the fourth, out of courtesy, which is a mistake. It is Widow's Supper. Holloway, across the table, tastes her own and rolls Eye + Feast against the poison's Potency, Hard (14): 16. She knows it at once, and knocks Abate's bowl into his lap, but he has eaten half. Onset is an hour. Abate rolls Gut 3 + Endure 3 against Hard (14) three times over the night, with Holloway's care (+2, after a Routine Stitching roll of 12). He passes the first (17), fails the second

(13): 2 damage, and he keeps eating the bread on the table though nobody offers it, which for an Unfed is a horror of its own, Dread 2. He passes the third. In the morning the innkeeper asks, politely, whether the gentleman enjoyed his supper, and Holloway answers him with her cleaver on the counter.

DISEASE

Disease moves slower than poison and further. A disease has a **Virulence** (the Difficulty to resist catching it, and to throw it off), an **Interval** (how often the sick roll), and **Stages**. On exposure, roll **Gut + Endure** against Virulence; failure means infection. Then, once per Interval, the sick roll again: two successes in a row throw it off; each failure advances a Stage; the last Stage is death, outside Sallowreach. A Seamer's care each Interval gives +2.

DISEASE	VIRULENCE	INTERVAL	STAGES
The Sweats (Rim Road inns)	Hard 14	day	fever (–1) / delirium (–2, Seeing) / Ruin
Weep-Fever (Sallowreach)	Hard 14	week	rash / weeping sores / never ends, never kills
Gut-Worm (Fatlands, field-meat)	Routine 10	week	hunger / wasting despite eating / the worm is longer than the gut
Brine-Lung (Brinehollow, foreigners)	Hard 14	day	cough / bailing like a native / the Calling, at a stranger's tide
Rouse-Heart (Vigil, years of dose)	Grim 18	season	flutter / stutter / Ruin at the next second dose
Childbed Fever (Cradlewrack, any bearer)	Grim 18	day	heat / festering of the wound / Ruin; the wound will not close
Mouthrot (Oathen, under the bit)	Routine 10	week	sores / teeth lost / jaw (as the Mangling)
The Bloody Flux (anywhere starving)	Hard 14	day	cramps (–1) / blood (–2, lose 1 Flesh) / Ruin

When a disease spreads through a community, add +1 Pall for each week of it.

ROT AND FESTERING

Wounds left unstitched for a day may fester: roll Gut + Endure (Hard 14) or lose 1 Flesh per day and suffer –2 to all rolls until treated. In Sallowreach, festering never kills, and never stops.

A festering wound smells first: sweetish, then like cheese, then like the Sump. It goes red, then hot, then purple-black at the edges, and the red climbs the limb in streaks toward the heart. A festering wound treated within three days can be cleaned (Hand + Stitching, Hard 14; on a Lack, the Seamer opens something they should not have). After three days, the limb must come off: a Grim (18) Hand

+ Stitching roll, a Dread 2 check for everyone in the room, and the patient suffers Ruin as though they had taken a *Severed Limb Mangling*, but lives. A Seamer who takes the limb off cleanly may offer it to a buyer. Many do. In Lastgate, Nan Pickering pays by the pound.

HEALING

- ◇ **First aid** (Hand + Stitching, Routine 10, a few minutes, once per wound) restores 2 Flesh, +1 per Helping.
- ◇ **Rest:** a full day of rest restores Gut in Flesh; a full day under a Seamer's care restores double.
- ◇ **Injuries** from the Mangling table heal according to their own entries, and some never heal.

▼ TORTURE

Torture is in this book because it is on the Table: in the Jar Room's interrogations, in the Cullmasters' back offices, in Jack Tenterhook's former career, in the cells of every Purgation raid that took a high-Cut prisoner and wanted the names. These rules describe what it costs and what it gets. They never describe how. The Carver should

keep it off-page, or to a single sentence of aftermath, unless the whole table has agreed otherwise.

WHAT IT GETS

Each session of torture (an hour, a night) the torturer rolls **Tongue + Intimidate** opposed by the victim's **Caul + Resolve**. The victim

suffers 1d6 damage, ignoring Armor, whatever the result, and on a Lack by either side suffers an Injury from the Mangling table. If the torturer wins, the victim answers one question per Helping, plus one.

The answers are not necessarily true. The victim says what will make it stop. The Carver decides, privately, whether each answer is the truth, a lie, or the victim's honest belief about what the torturer wants to hear. A torturer may roll **Caul + Instinct** against the victim's **Caul + Resolve** to tell which, and even then, a person who has been broken may not know themselves. This is why the Bench

of Clauses, which has a god for a lie-detector, does not torture, and why every other land does it anyway.

A Blank, a Kept, and a Sayer each suffer differently. The Kept feel everything and cannot be killed by it, which makes them the Table's favourite victims and its least reliable witnesses. A Sayer's answer becomes true. Do not torture a Sayer.

WHAT IT COSTS

The torturer makes a **Dread 2** check each session they continue. And every session, whatever the roll, the torturer marks one **Stain**. Stain never goes away.

STAIN	WHAT IT DOES TO THE TORTURER
1	Dreams. The victim's voice in the dark, saying ordinary things.
2	The Dread checks for torture stop being needed. This is not relief. Those who know you sense something: -2 to Persuade with friends.
3	Who Waits at Home knows, without being told. They can no longer remove your Fray.
4	You gain The Cold Plate (Table Two, number 7) if you did not have it.
5	You are good at it. The Carver may make you an NPC: a person others hire.

Example: Holloway Brisk has the Cullmaster Varn Sweetbread's assistant tied to a chair in a slaughterhouse in Sated, and the dusk shift goes out in two hours, and there is a child on the list. Dev says she is going to make him talk. The Carver says, out of character, "Okay. One sentence of it, then we cut. What does Holloway do with her hands?" Dev thinks, and says: "She takes off her apron, folds it, puts it on the block. She rolls up her sleeves. That's all you see." Tongue 2 + Intimidate 2 + 2d10 (14) = 18, against the assistant's Threat 2 + 2d10 (9) = 11. One Helping: two answers. The assistant takes 4 damage, which happens off-page. He tells her which field, and he tells

her the child's name, which she already knew. Both true. Holloway makes her Dread 2 check (14 on the nose: 1 Fray) and marks Stain 1. That night she dreams of the assistant telling her, very calmly, about his mother's garden. She will dream it for the rest of her life.



The difference between my old work and my new work is the tipping.

JACK TENTERHOOK, WAKE-VALET. HE IS LYING. IT SHOWS ON HIM.

▼ DOWNTIME AND RUIN

Between stories, time passes: a week, a season, the long dead months of Lack. Downtime is where wounds close, debts come due, and lives quietly come apart.

DOWNTIME ACTIONS

Each **downtime period** (usually a week to a month) each Guest chooses one action, two if the period is a season or more:

- ◇ **Mend.** Rest under care. Heal all Flesh, and advance every healing Injury one step. Remove 1 Fray.
- ◇ **Work.** Ply your Calling. Earn (Standing × 5) lacks for a week, or (Standing × 20) for a season, on a Routine (10) roll of the Calling's best pair; each Helping adds 10%.
- ◇ **Tend.** Go home to Who Waits at Home. Remove all Fray once per story, as the Fray rules say, if they are still themselves; the Carver tells you how they are.

- ◇ **Treat.** Undergo treatment for a Derangement: one period of the months of care the rules require. Three periods and 10 Portions treat one Derangement.
- ◇ **Restitch.** For the Kept, or for those keeping them: Seamer upkeep, as the Sallowreach chapter gives.
- ◇ **Pursue.** Advance a long task: research, a ledger, a forty-page vow. One roll per week.
- ◇ **Petition.** Seek Standing: a deed the Calling recognises, and the Portions to pay for it.
- ◇ **Carouse.** A vice, as the Fray rules give: 1d6 Fray gone, a Gut + Endure roll against a habit, and lacks spent at the comfortable or lavish rate.
- ◇ **Keep Faith.** Tend an Oath on the Dead: visit the grave, the niche, the shelf, the place they were taken. +2 to the next roll made in the oath's name.

THE COST OF LIVING

Every downtime period costs the cost of living for its length, at the Guest's chosen rate: destitute 1, modest 3, comfortable 8, lavish 25+ lacks a day. A Guest who cannot pay drops a rate. A Guest who cannot pay the destitute rate begins to slide into **Ruin**.

RUIN	WHAT HAS HAPPENED
1	Debt. You owe someone (the Company, a Surety, a fence) and they know where you sleep.
2	Disgrace. Your Calling's people have heard. –1 Standing.
3	Destitution. You sleep in doorways or the Lofts' porch; Starving rules apply on any bad week.
4	Outlawry. A warrant, a bounty, a Forsworn mark, a Board debt sold to the Cullmasters.
5	The list. Your name is on someone's list: the dusk shift, the Dormitory overflow, the Blank trade, a Reckoner's knife, the Second Table's menu.

A Guest gains a step of Ruin for a downtime period they cannot pay for, for a public crime, for a broken contract or oath, or for the deeds of their enemies. They lose a step by paying down debts (Ruin × 50 lacks), by a great service to a power that can lift them, or by fleeing to another land and starting again at Ruin 1, which is what the Rim Road is for.

RUIN OF A LIFE

Ruin in combat is the collapse of a body. Ruin in downtime is the collapse of a life, and it is measured the same way, in steps that do not come back easily:

WHILE YOU WERE AWAY

At the end of each downtime period, the Carver rolls a d20 for one Guest's Who Waits at Home.

D20	WHILE YOU WERE AWAY
1–6	They are well. They wrote. The letter is short and kind and asks when you are coming home.
7–8	They are ill. Not badly, yet. They did not want to worry you.
9	They have a new friend, very attentive, who belongs to one of the Table's congregations.
10	They are in debt, because of you: someone came asking, and they paid.
11	They have been questioned by a Cutwright, a Waker, a Netwatch officer, a Bench clerk.
12	Their Regrowth has risen. They describe the first tell in a letter, lightly, as a joke.
13	A table was laid in their kitchen one morning. It had your name on a card. They burned it.
14	Their village's Pall has risen: roll it as Uneasy.
15	They have taken in a stranger who is very like you.
16	They have stopped writing.
17	They have been taken: Reaped, Called, Counted, Set Aside, bricked, bound, poached. Not dead. Findable.
18	They have done something terrible for your sake, and they are waiting to tell you.
19	They have started to change toward the god. They are happy.
20	They are well, and they have news, and it is good, and it is real. Let it be real.

Example: Between stories, a month passes. Ressa takes two actions: Mend (her Flesh returns, and the black bruise where the hookman's boathook caught her ribs fades to yellow) and Tend, going home to Ama in Gannet Reach, which clears her Fray because Ama is still herself. Tolly Works as a courier (Standing 1: 5 lacks a week, 20 for the month) and spends it all on rouse. Abate cannot pay even the destitute rate in Lowmark and will not accept charity; he gains Ruin 1, a debt to a Company quartermaster who knows where he sleeps. The Carver rolls While You Were Away for Ressa: 13. A table was laid in

Ama's kitchen one morning, with Ressa's name on the card. Ama burned it. She mentions it in passing, over herring, as though it were nothing, and her hands shake.

◇
Nobody on the Table goes home. They go back, which is different, and they find out how different when they knock.

CRADLEWRACK SAYING, FROM A COUNTRY WHERE YOU MUST

▼ OATHS ON THE DEAD

Every Guest begins with an Oath on the Dead, and any character may swear another. To swear on the dead, you speak the full name of a dead person, ideally where they lie, and promise something in their name.

- ◇ **The Strength of the Dead:** once per scene, when you act directly to keep the oath, add +2 to a roll.
- ◇ **Keeping:** when you fulfil an oath on the dead, remove all Fray and gain 2 Portions.
- ◇ **Breaking:** if you deliberately break the oath, the dead come to collect. Gain 3 Fray immediately and suffer a **Visitation**, chosen by the Carver and shaped by the land where you swore: in Sallowreach the dead person, Kept, finds you; in the Fatlands you taste them in every meal; in Brinehollow their voice calls you from the water; in the Vigil they wait for you in every blink; in Cradlewrack you bear something with their face; in Oathen your body breaks to match the promise; in the Fast a place card bearing their name appears at every table you pass.

Swearing on the dead is not a light thing anywhere, and the Table is full of people who swore too easily. Grave-oaths sworn on the desecrated dead, over a body that has been opened or eaten or robbed, are said to bind twice as hard.

THE SWEARING, CLARIFIED

- ◇ **Where.** An oath sworn where the dead one lies (at the grave, the niche, the Loft shelf, the wake-table, the shore where they walked in, the bed in the Dormitory) is the full oath. An oath sworn elsewhere works, but its Visitation is shaped by the land where the dead one lies, not where you stood.
- ◇ **How many.** A Guest may carry several oaths on the dead. Each grants its own Strength, once per scene, only when acting for

that oath. When two oaths conflict, keeping one may break the other. The dead do not arbitrate. That is the point.

- ◇ **Twice as hard.** An oath sworn over the desecrated dead grants +2 Strength twice per scene instead of once. Keeping it removes all Fray and grants 3 Portions. Breaking it brings **two** Visitations, and the second one the Carver does not have to tell you about until it arrives.
- ◇ **Oathen.** Within Oathen, oaths on the dead are also Weight 5 oaths under Tolm, with the Breaking, the Testifying and all the rest that the Oathen chapter gives. They break you twice: once in the body, once from the dead.
- ◇ **Deliberately.** Only a deliberate breach brings a Visitation. A Guest who fails to keep an oath despite trying, who is prevented, who dies trying, is not forsworn. The dead are not unfair. They are only very patient.

VISITATIONS

A Visitation is not a single event. It returns, at least once a session, until the Guest makes **amends**: swears a new oath on the same dead, at the same place, for something harder than the first, and keeps it. Each Visitation that lands calls for a Dread check at the rating shown, or the Carver's judgment. Roll a d10 on the table for the land where the dead one lies, or choose.

◇
Promise the living what you like. They forget.

FEN PROVERB, THE FIRST HALF. THE SECOND HALF IS NEVER SAID ALOUD.

SALLOWREACH: THE KEPT COME CALLING

D10	VISITATION (DREAD)
1	They find you. Kept, rotted to the degree time allows, standing at the foot of your bed, asking why. (3)
2	A parcel arrives: one of their hands, wrapped, still gripping. It holds yours when you sleep. (2)
3	Every candle you light is a Tallow candle, and it is them, and it feels itself burn. (2)
4	Your own fingers go cold to the knuckle and will not warm. Things you touch end a little. (2)
5	A Loft-Warden writes to say that the shelved dead have begun whispering your name in their sleep. (1)

D10	VISITATION (DREAD)
6	Flies follow you, a small front, and in their sound is their voice, finishing the sentence of your oath. (2)
7	You hear them breathing in the next room. The dead in Sallowreach do not breathe. (2)
8	A Seamer's bill arrives for their restitching, made out in your name. Then another. Then another. (1)
9	Your reflection's mouth is stitched shut. (3)
10	They forgive you, in writing, in their own hand, every week, and it is worse than anything. (3)

THE FATLANDS: THE TASTE OF THEM

D10	VISITATION (DREAD)
1	You taste them in every meal: their skin, their sweat, their mother's cooking. (2)
2	A field near the road has their birthmark, white in the marbling. (2)
3	Bread you break is full of their hair. (2)
4	You are invited to their wake. You are told you were already at it, and you ate well. (3)
5	Your belly growls in their voice, saying the oath. Everyone at the table hears. (2)
6	A root in your garden has their face, eyes shut, and grows a little every night. (2)
7	Nothing you eat stays down except one dish: the last one they cooked. (1)
8	Your Want of the Second Plate fixes on their kin. (3)
9	The Cullmasters receive your name, in their handwriting. (2)
10	A small warm hill rises in a field you pass, and it says your childhood name. (4)

BRINEHOLLOW: THE VOICE FROM THE WATER

D10	VISITATION (DREAD)
1	Their voice calls you from the water, any water: a washbasin, a puddle, your cup. (2)
2	You cough up their wedding ring at the dawn bailing. (2)
3	The indoor tide leaves their footprints on your cellar stairs, coming up. (2)
4	At the morning count, their voice answers for you. (3)
5	Your rope is cut in the night, neatly. You wake facing west. (2)
6	A Tenanted stranger greets you with their manners and their pet name for you. (3)
7	You taste salt in everything, and the salt tastes of their tears. (1)
8	Your Want of The West fixes on the place they walked in. (3)
9	A shell grows in the corner of your eye, small and living and theirs. (2)
10	They come back out of the surf, kind, courteous, and they do not mention the oath at all. (4)

THE VIGIL: THE ONE IN THE BLINK

D10	VISITATION (DREAD)
1	They wait for you in every blink, standing in the long room, much closer than last time. (3)
2	A shared Seeming: the street sees them walking beside you. It is entered in the record. (2)
3	Your nudger pinches you awake with their fingers. (2)

D10	VISITATION (DREAD)
4	You lose a second, and come back holding something of theirs. (2)
5	Every lamp you pass gutters as you pass it, all the way home. (1)
6	The Matron writes their bed number on your door. (3)
7	Their voice lulls you, every evening, humming a song from childhood. +1 Weariness a scene. (2)
8	Your reflection's eyes are closed. (2)
9	You count them, in every crowd. The count is always one too many. (2)
10	In the room, at the end, beside the eye, there is a bed with your name on it, turned down. (4)

CRADLEWRACK: WHAT YOU BEAR

D10	VISITATION (DREAD)
1	You bear something with their face. It is small. It is breathing. (4)
2	False labor, every night, and you count the interval in their voice. (2)
3	Every door you shut is found open, and on the far side, their footprints. (2)
4	Their old wound opens on your body. (3)
5	The Tally reads their name aloud among this week's births. (3)
6	A Part comes looking for you: their hand, or one like it. (2)
7	Every knot you tie is undone by morning, and retied in the way they tied them. (1)
8	A born-grown stranger walks out of the fog, finishing their last sentence. (3)
9	Your oldest scar speaks in the night, and what it says is the oath. (2)
10	A midwife comes to your door with the Second Opinion and asks, kindly, whether you should stay. (3)

OATHEN: THE BODY KEEPS THE WORD

D10	VISITATION (DREAD)
1	Your body breaks to match the promise (the Breaking table, at Weight 5), and the dead Testify. (4)
2	Your voice comes back to you from every wall, a half-second late, in theirs. (2)
3	You cannot say their name. Your jaw locks on it. (2)
4	Your oath is found carved on the Ledger, in a hand nobody at the Ledger has. (2)
5	Every promise you make for a month is heard by the god at +1 Weight. (2)
6	Your Exits stop working: the god will not accept a condition from you. (2)
7	The echo of the broken oath finds you in a gorge and repeats, and renews. (3)
8	A Surety arrives, unasked, and says that the dead have hired her to stand for you. She is already breaking. (3)
9	Your hands sign the oath in handtalk while you sleep. Fingers snap. (2)
10	Their bones are in your bed at dawn, arranged lying beside you. (4)

THE FAST: THE CARD AT EVERY TABLE

D10	VISITATION (DREAD)
1	A place card bearing their name appears at every table you pass. (3)

D10	VISITATION (DREAD)
2	You smell their cooking on the wind, in a land where nobody cooks indoors. (2)
3	A chair is pulled out for you, by an invisible hand, in their manner. (3)
4	You hear them say “Come in,” from inside a house you know is empty. (3)
5	Every ration you carry tastes of the meal you had together. (1)
6	The Steward stops you on the road to say they are well, and asking for you. (3)
7	You find their name on the Long Table’s seating, in the next empty place. (3)
8	Your Pangs rise by 1 each night you do not speak their name. (1)
9	You dream of sitting down. Every night. You are very happy in the dream. (2)
10	A table is laid for two. Your card. Their card. Both chairs pulled out. (4)

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: THE OATH AND THE LINE

Ressa Weir swore at the start of play: *On my brother Ferrin, who walked in: I will never again drag anyone back from the water.* Her line: she will not put a rope on a living person. In the Tooth example earlier in this chapter, she roped a Called girl on the Mile and dragged her back.

The Carver stops play. “That’s deliberate,” she says, gently, out of character. “You knew the oath.” Maya agrees. Ressa crosses What You Will Not Do as well: 5 Fray. The oath breaks: 3 Fray. Ressa is at Fray 9, Fraying, and must write a new line she will not cross. Then the Visitation. Ferrin lies in Brinehollow, in the sea. The Carver rolls a d10: 4. *At the morning count, his voice answers for you.*

The next dawn, in Gannet Reach, the neighbours call Ressa’s name through the wall, and before she can open her mouth, a man’s voice answers from inside her room, cheerfully, coughing the way Ferrin coughed. “Here.” Dread 3. Ressa’s sister-in-law Ama, who has come to visit, is standing in the doorway, white as salt, holding Ferrin’s chain.

Ressa has saved a girl’s life. The oath does not care. The way to amends is a harder oath at the place where Ferrin walked in, and the Carver already knows what it will be.

▼ TRAVEL

The Rim Road is about 2,200 miles around. On foot a traveler makes about 20 miles a day on the road; by cart 25; by fast horse 40; by Company post-coach, changing horses at every waystation, 70. Waystations stand roughly every 15 to 25 miles, and a day’s walk off the road in any land is somewhere stranger.

Each day of travel through dangerous country, the Carver may roll on the land’s encounter table (see the bestiary), and one Guest may roll **Lung + Wayfaring** (Hard 14) to find a better route, avoid trouble, or make up time. Crossing into the Fast is a different matter entirely, and the rules for that are in its chapter.

Off the road, halve these speeds in fen, canyon, highland or the Uncovered, and halve them again in Lack. A Guest who fails the day’s Wayfaring roll with a Lack has led the company somewhere: the Carver rolls on the land’s Horrors table instead of its encounters. Travelling hungry, cold or sleepless brings the Body’s rules to bear each night, and the Rim Road is very long.

◇

Twenty miles a day on the Rim. Everyone walks it eventually, the same direction, round and round. Nobody has ever found the end, because it is a ring. Some people take a long time to understand that.

WAYSTATION KEEPER AT THIMBLE CROSS

▼ LIGHT AND DARKNESS

The Table is lit by tallow, oil, rushlight and the candles of the dead. Darkness imposes −2 to Search and to attacks; total darkness, −4. In the Vigil there is no darkness, by law, and that is a horror of its own.

A lantern lights about ten paces; a candle, three; a Tallow candle made from the dead, three, steadily, and it whimpers. Characters who can see in darkness (a Brinehollower in the Course, a lidless Vigilant's memory of a room) ignore the penalty. Fighting in the dark has its own rules in *Blood on the Cloth*.

THE GRACE ROLL IN BRIEF

- ◇ **Roll:** 2d10 + Attribute + Skill vs Routine 10, Hard 14, Grim 18, Dire 22, Impossible 26. Each full 4 over is a Helping.
- ◇ **Omens:** doubles. Success is a Grace; failure a Lack. Double 1s always fail; double 10s always succeed.
- ◇ **Partake:** add a Tooth (d6; two at Cut 3+). +1 Hunger, +1 per Tooth showing 1, +2 more on a Lack.
- ◇ **Hunger 10:** Regrowth +1, Hunger to 0. **Sop:** −1d6 Hunger, and the habit grows.
- ◇ **Brink (Regrowth 10–11):** Wheel checks; Ridden marks. **Regrowth 12:** the Seating.
- ◇ **Dread:** Caul + Resolve vs 10/14/18/22/26. Fail: Fray = Dread. Pass: 1 Fray. Grace: none.
- ◇ **Fray 10:** Break, Derangement, Fray to 3. Witnesses check Dread 2 for contagion.
- ◇ **The Pall:** a community's Fray, 0–20; each week, 2d10 + Steadiness vs 10 + Pall.
- ◇ **Hold:** 0–5, built by methods; Doubt: 3 marks and the false memory wins.
- ◇ **Chases:** Lead 0 caught, Lead 6 lost; opposed Lung rolls; complications.
- ◇ **Oaths on the Dead:** +2 once a scene; keep it, clear Fray and gain 2 Portions; break it, 3 Fray and a Visitation until amends.



CHAPTER 13

BLOOD ON THE CLOTH

There is no clean way to open a person. There are only quick ways and slow ways, and the slow ways are cheaper.

– JEM CRACKLE, THE COOK'S KNIFE, TO AN APPRENTICE

The Warden came at Halloway with a boathook, the long kind the Netwatch use for pulling the Called out of the surf, and she knew from the way he held it that he had pulled more people out of things than he had ever put into them. That was his mistake. He wanted to hook her, drag her, take her alive. She only wanted him to stop.

She let the hook go past her ear. It caught her coat at the shoulder and tore it, and she stepped inside the length of the pole, where it was no use to anyone, and put the cleaver into the meat where his neck met his collarbone. It went in with the sound a joint makes on the block: that wet, final chock of iron finding the gap in the bone. She felt it through the handle into her wrist. His breath came out of him in a long, surprised whistle, and something warm and copper-smelling ran over her knuckles and into her sleeve.

He sat down. He kept looking at her. He was trying to say something about his wife. She worked the blade free, the way you do, a little rock and a twist, and that was worse, because then the blood had somewhere to go.

She had butchered four thousand animals in her life. Her hands knew this. That was the part she would not be able to forget: how well her hands knew it.

Violence on the Table is fast, ugly and expensive. Fights are short. People who are hurt stay hurt. Guests who solve every problem with a blade will be dead, maimed, or something worse inside a few sessions, and they will deserve the stories told about them.

This chapter gives the rules for fighting: the round, the attack, the wound, the Mangling, and the long list of things people do to each other with hooks and cleavers in the dark. It ends with three fights played through from first blow to last, with the same company of Guests who walk through *The Grace Roll*: Ressa Weir, Halloway Brisk, Tolly Fane and Abate Kell.



Every fight on the Table ends the same way: somebody has to clean the floor. Ask yourself, before you start, whether it will be you.

NETWATCH DRILL-SERGEANT

▼ THE ROUND

Combat is played in **rounds** of about three seconds. Each round, every combatant gets:

- ◇ **One action:** an attack, a dash, a grapple, a first-aid attempt, a shouted plea, a Sop, a Partake-and-act, anything that takes real effort.
- ◇ **One move:** a few steps, drawing a weapon, standing up, opening a door (in Cradlewrack it may already be open).

A character can give up their action for a second move. Talking a little is free.

INITIATIVE

At the start of a fight, everyone rolls **1d10 + Lung + Eye**. Act from highest to lowest. Ties go to the Guests. Those taken by surprise do not act in the first round. Initiative is rolled once for the whole fight, unless something dramatic resets it (a Hush opening, a pang, the lights going out in the Vigil).

Threat-rated adversaries roll **1d10 + Threat**. A mob or a swarm acts once, on a single initiative. The Carver may roll once for a

whole group of identical foes and have them act together; it is faster, and it makes them feel like a pack.

SURPRISE AND AMBUSH

A fight that begins with one side unready begins with an **ambush**.

- ◇ **Setting it.** The ambushers roll **Lung + Stealth** (or Threat); use the *lowest* roll among them, because one cough gives everyone away. The ambushed roll **Eye + Search** (or Threat); use the *biggest*, because one sharp eye is enough. If the ambushers win, they get a **surprise round**: one full round before the ambushed act at all. If they win with a Helping or more, every attack in that round counts the target as **unaware**.
- ◇ **Unaware targets.** An unaware target's Guard is 10, flat: no Lung, no skill. Attacks from hiding on a Silent weapon gain +2, as that quality says. The Reckoner's talent *In Their Beds* adds +4 damage against an unaware target. Sleeping targets are always unaware, and in the Vigil, a sleeping target is a crime scene.
- ◇ **Sensing it.** A character who loses the ambush roll may still roll **Caul + Instinct** at Hard (14). On a success they act in the surprise round, last. A *Light Sleeper* cannot be surprised while

asleep or resting, as the Knack says, and the Carver should honour it with glee.

- ◇ **A failed ambush.** If the ambushed win, nobody is surprised; roll initiative as normal, and the ambushers are probably standing somewhere foolish.



The Reckoners say a Godeater dies in his bed or not at all. It isn't a boast. It's a method, and the method is patience.

DR. MERCY THRANE, NOTES

▼ ATTACKING

To attack, roll **2d10 + Hand + Blades** (for edged weapons), **Brawl** (for fists, clubs, teeth, grapples) or **Shooting** (for anything thrown or loosed), against the target's **Guard**.

- ◇ **Melee Guard** = 10 + Lung + the best of Athletics, Blades or Brawl.
- ◇ **Ranged Guard** = 10 + Lung + Athletics. Add +2 for partial cover, +4 for heavy cover. Firing into melee without hitting friends needs a Helping, or a friend is hit on a Lack.

WEAPON	DAMAGE
Fist, kick, bite	1
Knife, awl, needle, sling	2
Cleaver, hatchet, club, sickle, shortbow	3
Sword, axe, spear, boathook, harpoon, crossbow	4
Poleaxe, maul, greatcleaver, Tablebreaker's axe	5
Siege weapons, falling masonry, a Laden's weight	6+

Weapon qualities (Hooking, Ripping, Heavy, Reach, Silent, Brutal, and so on) are listed in the Rim Market.

CARVER'S ADVICE: SAYING WHAT THE BLADE DID

Numbers kill people; words make it matter. After every hit, say one true thing about the wound before the next roll: where it went, what it sounded like, what it smelled like, what the hit person did with their face. Keep it to one sentence for ordinary damage. Save the paragraphs for Manglings and Grievous wounds, and for the first blood a Guest ever draws. If the table winces, you have said enough. If someone says the Grace, stop at once and describe nothing more than the number.

If the attack total meets or beats the Guard, it hits.

DAMAGE

Damage = weapon damage + 2 per Helping – the target's Armor.

A hit that is reduced to 0 or less by Armor does no Flesh damage, but on a Grace it still inflicts a Mangling. Damage is subtracted from **Flesh**.

GRACE AND LACK IN COMBAT

- ◇ **A Grace on an attack** inflicts a **Mangling** in addition to its damage (roll on the table below). Grace attacks are where people lose eyes and fingers.
- ◇ **A Lack on an attack** means the weapon sticks, breaks, flies from your hand, or hits someone you did not mean to hit; or you overextend and the target gets a free attack against you.
- ◇ **A Lack on a defense** (when you are rolling to resist a grapple, or the Carver calls for a roll to dodge something unusual) means you fall, drop something, or take a Mangling yourself.

OTHER ACTIONS

- ◇ **Grapple:** Hand + Brawl vs Guard. On a hit, the target is held: they can only try to break free (opposed Gut + Labor or Lung +

Athletics) or attack with a small weapon at -2. A holder can choke (1 damage per round, ignoring Armor), drag, pin or bite.

- ◇ **Disarm:** attack at -2; on a hit, no damage, the target drops their weapon.
- ◇ **Shove or trip:** Gut + Labor or Hand + Brawl vs Guard; the target falls or is pushed back. Standing up takes a move.
- ◇ **Aim:** spend an action aiming to gain +2 on your next ranged attack.
- ◇ **Full Defense:** spend your action defending: +4 Guard until your next turn.
- ◇ **Flee:** move away. Anyone engaged with you gets a free attack unless you win an opposed Lung + Athletics roll.
- ◇ **Partake:** you can Partake on any combat roll. Many Gifts are combat abilities.

MORE MANEUVERS

The Table fights dirty, in kitchens and on piers and in the aisles of the Lofts. These maneuvers cover most of what people try. None of them stack with each other in the same action.

- ◇ **Charge.** Move and attack in one action, if you have a run of at least five paces: +2 to the attack, and -2 to your Guard until your next turn. A Reach weapon set against you strikes first.
- ◇ **All Out.** Throw yourself into the blow: +2 to attack and +1 damage, -4 Guard until your next turn. Renderers call it *going through the joint*.
- ◇ **Two Weapons.** With a Light weapon in the off hand, make one extra attack at -4 against the same or an adjacent target. A Lack on either attack is a Lack on both.
- ◇ **Feint.** Tongue + Deceive opposed by the target's Caul + Instinct (or Threat). Win, and your next attack against them this round or next counts them as unaware (Guard 10). Lose, and they know your tricks: -2 to feint them again this fight.
- ◇ **Bind.** Lock the enemy's weapon with yours, or with a hook, or with your own forearm: Hand + Blades vs Guard. On a hit, neither of you may attack with those weapons until one breaks the bind (opposed Gut + Labor). Others may attack the bound one at +2.
- ◇ **Brace.** Set a Reach weapon against a charge or a rush. The first enemy to close this round takes your attack before theirs, at +2.
- ◇ **Hold the Line.** Two or more fighters shoulder to shoulder in a doorway, on a pier, in a canyon cut: each gains +2 Guard while the other stands. Mobs can only reach a held line with as many attackers as there are bodies across it (see *Fighting Many*).
- ◇ **Cover.** Ready an action: name a target and a trigger (*if he moves for the lamp*). When the trigger happens, you act first.
- ◇ **Cast Into.** Shove a held or prone enemy into something worse: a fire, a fen, the Sump, a crowning, a laid table, off the end of the Mile. Gut + Labor vs Guard (Guard 10 if held). The Carver

decides what the worse thing does; it is usually more than a weapon would.

- ◇ **The Dead as Shield.** Hold a body, or a Kept, between you and the blows: +2 Guard, and every hit that misses you by 2 or less hits the body. If the body is someone the enemy knew, they make a Dread check before they swing. If it is someone you knew, you make one when it is hit.
- ◇ **Rally.** Shout, slap, needle or bully a companion back into the fight: Tongue + Intimidate (or Rites) vs Routine (10). Remove 1 Fray from them, or let them shake off a freeze from a Lack on a Dread check. Once per companion per fight.
- ◇ **Yield.** Drop your weapon and beg. Roll Tongue + Persuade against Hard (14), or Grim (18) if you have killed one of theirs. Success means the enemy must make a choice, and most people on the Table, faced with a begging human being, do not strike. Failure means they will. The Carver should let NPCs Yield, often.
- ◇ **Drag.** Pull a fallen ally out of reach: your move and your action, Gut + Labor vs Routine (10), or Hard (14) under attack. Enemies engaged with you get a free attack.
- ◇ **Kill the Light.** Put out a lamp, a lantern, a candle in reach: an action, no roll unless someone protects it. See *Fighting in the Dark*.

CALLED SHOTS

A fighter may aim for a particular part of the body. A Called Shot takes a penalty to the attack. If it hits, it deals damage as normal, and if it scores **at least one Helping**, the attacker may choose the matching Mangling result instead of the extra damage from that Helping. A Grace on a Called Shot inflicts the chosen Mangling *and* rolls on the table for another.

TARGET	PENALTY	WITH A HELPING, CHOOSE
Hand or weapon arm	–2	Knuckles; or the weapon drops
Leg or knee	–2	Hamstrung; or the target falls
Face or mouth	–2	Teeth; Jaw (with two Helpings)
Head	–4	Skull
Eye	–4	Eye
Throat	–4	Throat (with two Helpings); otherwise target cannot speak or shout for 1d6 rounds
Belly	–2	Gut-Stuck; Opened (with two Helpings)
A Kept's joint	–2	Severed Hand or Severed Limb, for dismemberment

Armor still counts, and the Carver may rule that a helm or a gorget protects the part entirely. Called Shots against an unaware target take no penalty. That is what assassins are for.



Aim for the hand that holds the hook. A man without his hook is only a man on a pier, and most of them remember they have mothers.

LIEUTENANT SABLE REEF, TO RECRUITS

FIGHTING IN THE DARK

The Table is lit by tallow and oil, and a great many of its fights happen after the lamp goes over.

- ◇ **Dim light** (a single candle, moonlight on the Plate, fog-light in Sallowreach): –2 to attacks and to Search.
- ◇ **Darkness** (the lamp is out, a cellar, a new moon licked clean): –4 to attacks and Search, and everyone's Guard counts as though they had no skill bonus (10 + Lung only), because nobody can see a blow coming.
- ◇ **Finding a foe.** In darkness, a character must know where an enemy is before attacking: Caul + Instinct or Eye + Search (with the darkness penalty) against the foe's Lung + Stealth, as an opposed roll. On a loss they swing at where the enemy was. On a Lack, they hit a friend.
- ◇ **The lamp-bearer.** Whoever holds the light is seen by everyone and sees little beyond its circle. Attacks against a lamp-bearer from outside the light ignore the darkness penalty. Attacks from the lamp-bearer into the dark suffer it in full.
- ◇ **What sees in the dark.** A Brinehollower in the Course sees in total darkness. The Kept do not need to see to grasp, and they smell the living (–2 to Stealth against them for anyone not wearing vinegar or cedar). The Counted, the Seated and things born in Cradlewrack's lower wards behave as though it were noon. A Guest who Partakes may ask the Carver whether their Tooth gives them any sense in the dark; the answer should be in their land's idiom, and it should never be free.

- ◇ **In the Vigil.** There is no darkness, by law. When the lamps go out in the Vigil, it is because someone wanted them out, and every Vigilant within sight makes a Dread 1 check, because the dark is the closest thing in their lives to the room.



Put out the light, and every man in the room becomes the size of his fear.

LAMPLIGHTERS' GUILD SAYING

FEAR IN THE FIGHT

A fight against horrors calls for a Dread check when the horror is first seen, not once per round. Seeing an ally Mangled is Dread 2. Killing someone for the first time is Dread 2 (Dread 3 for someone you knew, Dread 4 for kin).

A Guest who freezes, flees, screams or vomits on a Lack loses their next action, and the Carver should describe it. A Guest who reaches Fray 10 mid-fight Breaks at once, and their Break plays out during the fight; the contagion rules apply to everyone who sees it, friend and foe.

MORALE

Most people on the Table do not want to die, and most of them are hungry, tired and paid badly. Threat-rated adversaries check **morale** when: their side has lost half its number; their leader falls, flees or Yields; they suffer a Mangling or see one; or a horror of Dread 2 or more appears on the field. The Carver rolls **2d10 + Threat** against Hard (14). Failure means they break: they flee, Yield, or hold back and do nothing useful. A Lack means they turn on their own leader, or on whoever brought them here.

Some never check: the Kept, the Called, the Seated, the faithful in their rite, the starving at a table, anything Ridden by a god, and Reckoners within reach of a high Cut. Some always check at Grim (18): conscripts, debtors on the dusk shift, a mob without a preacher.

▼ FLESH, RUIN AND DEATH

Flesh = 8 + Gut + Endure. A Guest at half Flesh or less is **Bloodied**: –1 to all rolls.

When Flesh reaches **0**, the character suffers **Ruin**: they take an **Injury** (roll on the Mangling table) and collapse. They can crawl, whisper, and do nothing else useful. They are **Dying**.

A Dying character who takes any further damage is **dead**. A Dying character who is not treated within (Gut) minutes must roll **Gut + Endure** (Hard 14) every minute; failure means death. A successful first-aid roll stabilizes them at 1 Flesh.

In **Sallowreach**, nothing dies. A character who would die there becomes **Kept**: see that chapter. They keep their Injuries. They keep everything.

Damage below 0 does not carry over; Flesh stops at 0, and the next point of damage is the end. A Seamer's *Reseat* (the Seamer

Calling) may spare a Ruined character the Injury, but not the collapse. Ruin heals: a Ruined character who is stabilized and rests recovers Flesh as normal, and is up and walking, badly, at a quarter of their Flesh.

DAMAGE ON THE TABLE, BY THE NUMBERS

An ordinary Guest has 10 to 14 Flesh. A knife does 2 to 6, a sword 4 to 8, a crossbow bolt at close range 4 to 10. Two or three solid blows will drop anyone. A Grace can end a fight at once. Armor matters enormously: boiled leather turns a knife into a bruise. The cheapest way to survive a fight is not to be in it. Carvers should let NPCs surrender, flee, bargain and beg, and they should do so often. On the Table, everybody is somebody's kin.

▼ THE MANGLING TABLE

Roll **1d20** when a Grace attack lands, or when a character suffers Ruin. Add +2 if the weapon is **Brutal** or the damage dealt was 8 or

more. Every Mangling is also a **Dread 2** horror for those who see it happen to someone they care about.

D20	MANGLING	EFFECT
1–2	Laid Open	A long shallow cut that unzips the skin and shows the yellow fat beneath. Bleeds freely: 1 damage per round until bound. Scar.
3	Knuckles	Fingers broken or split to the bone. –2 to Hand rolls until healed (2 weeks). On a Lack later, one finger is lost.
4	Teeth	A blow to the mouth: teeth spat out in pieces with the blood, lips torn. –2 to Tongue rolls for a week; permanent gaps.
5	Rib-Crack	You hear it before you feel it: a green-stick crack, then the grinding. –2 to Lung rolls; every deep breath is a knife (4 weeks).
6	Hamstrung	The tendon behind the knee parts like a bowstring. Movement halved; cannot run. Without a Seamer's Grim (18) repair, limp forever (–1 Lung).
7	The Ear	Torn half off, hanging by a flap of gristle. –2 to hearing-based Search. Stitched back crooked, or lost.
8	Gut-Stuck	A wound in the belly that lets out the smell of the bowel. Fever in 1d3 days unless treated (Grim 18 Stitching); –2 to all rolls while it festers.
9	Eye	The eye is punctured, crushed, or hangs on its cord. Lost. –2 to Search and Shooting thereafter (–1 after a month of adjustment). Dread 2 to see.
10	Skull	The scalp splits and the bone beneath dents like an egg. Stunned for 1d6 rounds; roll Gut + Endure (Hard 14) or lose memory of the last day.
11	Broken Arm	The forearm bends between the wrist and elbow, where there is no joint. Unusable for 6 weeks; splint and pray.
12	Broken Leg	The shin snaps, perhaps through the skin, white and wet. Cannot stand. 8 weeks; a Lack in healing means a permanent limp.
13	Severed Fingers	One to three fingers gone, rolled away in the dirt. Permanent –1 Hand for fine tasks. Someone may pick them up.
14	Opened	A deep wound across the abdomen. Loops of grey-pink bowel slide free and steam. Dying in (Gut) minutes unless held in and stitched (Grim 18). Survivors are weakened (–1 Gut) for a season.
15	Severed Hand	Off at the wrist; the stump sprays in rhythm with the heart. Lose 2 Flesh per round until tied off. The hand twitches for a while afterward. In Sallowreach, much longer.
16	Jaw	The jaw is broken, dislocated or torn half away: the tongue lolls in a ruin of teeth. Cannot speak clearly; can only take liquid. 6 weeks. (In Oathen, many count this as mercy.)

D20	MANGLING	EFFECT
17	Throat	A cut or crush to the throat. Blood in the windpipe; breathing is a gargle. Dying in (Gut) rounds unless treated (Dire 22). Survivors speak in a rasp forever.
18	Unmanned	A savage wound to the hip, groin or pelvis; the bone grates, the blood pools black. Cannot walk for 2 months; Gut –1 permanently. Dread 2.
19	Severed Limb	An arm off at the elbow, a leg off at the knee: hacked through, the bone ends splintered and pale. Lose 3 Flesh per round until tied off. Ruin follows. A Seamer may reattach a limb from another body; it will not be quite yours.
20+	Butchered	The blow opens the body like a carcass on the hook: the chest split, the skull cloven, the head half off. The character dies at once, outside Sallowreach. Inside it, they continue, in that condition, indefinitely. Dread 3 to all who see.

Bleeding from several Manglings adds together. “Tied off” and “bound” mean a first-aid roll (Hand + Stitching, Routine 10) that stops the bleeding but restores no Flesh; a Ripping wound needs the same.

CHALKED ON THE SHUTTER OF A BACK-ALLEY SEAMER IN THE LOWER PILINGS, LASTGATE. PRICES IN LACKS.

Cut stitched, plain: 1. With the good thread: 2. With the good thread and you don't scream: 3, because you'll have had the poppy.

Finger back on: 4. Your own finger: 4. Somebody else's finger: 4, and we don't ask, and you don't.

Hand back on: 15. Hand from stock: 30. Left hands: ask. (No left hands this week.)

Ear: 2. Eye: we can't, love, nobody can, but we'll sew the lid so it looks restful. 1.

Bowel put back: 25, paid before. Bowel put back on the Living (foreigners, the Breathing): 60, paid before, no refunds, sit there.

Head: 40, and bring someone to hold it.

NO CREDIT. NO KEPT ON THE BENCH AFTER DARK UNLESS SEEN TO. NO MARROW JACK.

▼ THE GRIEVOUS TABLE

Some blows are worse than a Grace. A **Grievous** blow is any of the following:

- ♦ A Grace on an attack that also scores **two or more Helpings**.
- ♦ A Grace with a **Heavy** or **Brutal** weapon against a **held, prone or unaware** target.
- ♦ The killing stroke of an **execution** that goes wrong (see *Executions*).

- ♦ Being crushed by a Laden's weight, falling from the end of the Mile, a pang bringing down a house, a Tablebreaker's axe in a frenzy, or anything else the Carver judges to be more than a body can be asked to bear.

On a Grievous blow, roll **1d20** on this table **instead of** the Mangling table. Grievous wounds are Dread 3 for anyone who cares about the victim, and Dread 2 for everyone else who sees them. Most are permanent. Several are fatal outside Sallowreach, and inside it, they are simply what you will be from now on.

D20	GRIEVOUS WOUND	EFFECT
1	Scalped	A sheet of scalp peels from the brow back, hanging by a hinge of hair; blood sheets into the eyes. Blind with blood (–4 to attacks) until wiped (an action) and bound; –1 Tongue forever among those who flinch.
2	Degloved	The skin of the hand comes away like a wet glove, leaving the red-and-white mechanism working underneath. –4 Hand with that hand until healed (a season); it never feels warm again.
3	Kneecapped	The knee is smashed inward, the cap floating loose under the skin like a coin in a purse. Cannot stand without a crutch; –2 Lung forever.
4	Face Cloven	A blow across the face: the nose split to the bone, a cheek laid open so the back teeth show when the victim breathes. –2 Tongue forever except to Intimidate (+1). Dread 1 to strangers.
5	Tongue Taken	The tongue is bitten or cut through; the front of it is somewhere on the floor. No speech ever again. In Oathen, the victim may no longer be bound by speech; Sister Verity Amn would say that is not true.

D20	GRIEVOUS WOUND	EFFECT
6	Both Eyes	A slash or a thumb across both eyes. Blind. Dying of nothing, but blind. In the Vigil, some call this rest.
7	Stove Ribs	Three or four ribs driven inward; a flail of chest that moves the wrong way when the victim breathes. Lose 1 Flesh per round until bound (Hard 14); -2 Lung and Gut until healed (3 months).
8	Shoulder Wrenched Out	The arm is torn half from its socket, muscle and gristle parting; it hangs a hand's length too low. Useless until a Seamer resets it (Grim 18); -1 Hand forever.
9	Hip Shattered	The pelvis breaks like a dropped plate. Cannot walk; Dying in (Gut) hours from the inside bleeding unless a Seamer opens and closes (Dire 22). Survivors never walk without a stick.
10	Spine	The back is struck through or broken. Below the wound, nothing answers. The Carver and player decide where. Outside Sallowreach, permanent. Inside it, also permanent, for centuries.
11	Unseamed	The belly opens end to end and the bowel slides out in a heavy coil, tangling the feet. Dying in (Gut) rounds unless gathered and stitched (Dire 22). Survivors lose 1 Gut and eat carefully forever.
12	Artery	A cut in the thigh or the neck that does not bleed so much as empty. Lose 4 Flesh per round until clamped (Grim 18 Hand + Stitching, or a fist and a strong friend for one round at a time).
13	Both Hands	Two hands off, or crushed to pulp, in one blow, raised to defend. Lose 3 Flesh per round until both are tied off. Ruin follows. Somebody will have to feed you.
14	Leg Off at the Hip	Hacked through high, where no tourniquet sits well. Lose 4 Flesh per round. Dying unless sealed with fire or a Grim (18) Stitching.
15	Skull Opened	The skull is broken open and the grey shows. Unconscious; roll Gut + Endure (Grim 18) each hour or die. Survivors lose 1 Eye permanently and gain a Derangement from Table One.
16	Jaw Torn Away	The lower jaw is gone, or hanging by a strip: tongue, throat and teeth exposed. Dying in (Gut) minutes from blood in the windpipe unless treated (Grim 18). Survivors wear a leather mask, in Oathen a gold one.
17	Gutted	The blow reaches the organs: the liver split, a kidney opened, the bowel cut through. The wound stinks at once. Dying in (Gut) minutes; a Dire (22) Stitching saves them for a fever that kills on a failed Gut + Endure (Hard 14) in 1d3 days.
18	Crushed	Pressed under a weight, a wheel, a fall: bones broken in a dozen places, the body flattened in a way that looks wrong even before the blood comes. Ruin, and dead unless in Sallowreach. Dread 3 to all.
19	Head Half Off	The neck is cut through to the bone; the head lolls on a hinge of muscle. Dead outside Sallowreach. Inside it, the head must be held on with both hands until a Seamer comes, and it keeps talking. Dread 4 to see.
20	Taken Apart	The body is opened and broken so completely that it is no longer one thing. Dead outside Sallowreach. Inside it, the pieces go on, separately, and some of them try to find each other. Dread 4.



*There is a Fatlands word for a wound you can put
your whole hand into. It is also the word for
“welcome.”*

HOB GRISTLE, APOLOGISING

▼ SPECIAL SITUATIONS

FIGHTING THE KEPT

The Kept of Sallowreach cannot be killed. Reducing one to 0 Flesh drops it, and it goes on moving: crawling, biting, grasping with whatever is still attached. To stop a Kept enemy you must **dismember** it: each Mangling result of Severed Hand, Severed Limb

or Butchered removes the use of that part. Burning helps; it does not finish. Hand-line touch and the Hushes are the only true ends.

This is the **Unending** ability given in *Things That Eat and Are Eaten*: a Kept at 0 Flesh is Undone for 1d6 rounds, then recovers 1d6 Flesh and resumes, unless it has been dismembered, sunk, Closed, or carried across the border. The two rules are one rule.

Undone, it crawls and grasps at -4; recovered, it fights as before with whatever it has left.

KEPT ENEMIES, CLARIFIED

- ◇ **What a Kept feels.** Everything. A Kept does not check morale, because it cannot die and knows it, but it feels every blow, and it may scream, beg or curse the whole time. A Kept that begs is Dread 2 to keep fighting.
- ◇ **Taking them apart.** A Called Shot at a Kept's joint (-2) with a Helping severs it (Severed Hand at the wrist, Severed Limb at the elbow or knee). A Kept with no working limbs is out of the fight; a Kept with its head off is out of the fight but not out of the conversation.
- ◇ **What the parts do.** Severed parts of a Kept go on. Roll a d6 for each: 1-2 it lies twitching; 3-4 it crawls toward the nearest warm body (Threat 0, Flesh 3, Attack +2, damage 1, Grapple 10); 5 it goes back to its owner and tries to reattach; 6 it goes somewhere else, and the Carver writes down where.
- ◇ **Fire.** A burning Kept takes 2 damage a round, does not stop, and spreads the fire to whatever it grasps. Fires in Sallowreach smoulder for decades. A Kept that has burned is Rot +2 and Dread 2 to see.
- ◇ **Vinegar and cedar.** The Kept find the living by smell. A character doused in fen-vinegar or cedar perfume is -2 to be found by a Kept in the dark, and a character with *Vinegar Kiss* is ignored by Kept until they act.
- ◇ **Kept Guests.** A Kept player character follows the same rules, with Rot as the Sallowreach chapter gives it. They are terrifying allies in a fight, and the Carver should make them pay for it in Rot.

WHY YOU DO NOT FIGHT IN THE SINKS

The Kept outnumber the breathing nine to one in Sallowreach, and every one of them feels every blow and cannot die of it. A brawl in a Lastgate tavern does not end; it goes on, in a smaller and sadder way, for decades, in the Lofts and the Jar Room and the back rooms of part-thieves. Captain Dace Morrow, whose army cannot lose a man, has a standing order that his soldiers are never to fight the Kept at all, only to restrain them. His soldiers are Kept. They know.

FIGHTING MANY

Mobs, the Forsworn of the Breakdowns, a Reaping crowd, the Finishers walking in: treat a mob as one character with Flesh equal to 5 × its number, Threat equal to 1 + one per 5 members (max 5), and damage equal to its best weapon + 1 per 5 members. Each 5 Flesh lost drops one member. Mobs break and run when they lose half their number, unless they are faithful, starving or Called.

Clarifications. A mob attacks with **Threat + 3** and has **Guard 10 + Threat**, Armor equal to what most of its members wear

(usually 0). It acts on one initiative and makes one attack a round against each target in its reach. The mobs already written up in *Things That Eat and Are Eaten* (the Forsworn Mob, the Called Procession, the Two-Legged Cattle) use their own quick lines, which already account for all this; the formula here is for the mobs the Carver makes up on the night.

- ◇ **Width.** A mob can only bring as many members to bear on a held line as there is room. In a doorway or on a pier, a mob attacks with Threat 1 + one per 5 members who can actually reach, however many are behind. This is why the Netwatch fight on the Mile and the Breakdowns' slum-lanes are a yard wide.
- ◇ **Fire and fear.** Fire, a crossbow volley, a horror of Dread 2+ or the fall of a preacher forces an immediate morale check, even before half are down.
- ◇ **Crush.** A character caught in a moving mob without a weapon out, or knocked down in one, takes the mob's damage each round, ignoring Armor, until they win an opposed Gut + Athletics roll to get out or up.
- ◇ **The Pall.** A mob is a community at its worst. A mob that forms in a town adds +1 to the town's Pall; a mob that kills adds +2. A mob that Guests disperse without bloodshed (by Yield, by Rally, by a Celebrant's preaching) lowers the Pall by 1.

FIGHTING GODS

You cannot. A Seated god has no Flesh to take. The rules for what you can do instead are in *Things That Eat and Are Eaten*.

EXECUTIONS, TORTURE AND MURDER

Not every killing is a fight. When a Guest kills a helpless person, no roll is needed for the act. The roll is afterward: a Dread check at Dread 2 (Dread 3 for someone who begged; Dread 4 for kin). Torture extracts information on an opposed roll of the torturer's Tongue + Intimidate against the victim's Caul + Resolve, but the Carver decides how true the answers are, and the torturer makes a Dread 2 check each session they continue. Jack Tenterhook of the Vigil says the difference between his work as a wake-valet and his old job is the tipping. He is lying, and it shows on him.

The full rules for torture, including the **Stain** it leaves on the torturer, are in *The Grace Roll*. Kin-slaying by your own hand is Dread 4 whatever the circumstances, and on the Table, where everyone is somebody's kin, the Carver should ask before each killing whose cousin this was.

EXECUTIONS

A lawful killing, done by the state, is still a killing. Each land does it its own way, and each way has its horror.

LAND	THE SENTENCE	WHAT WITNESSES SEE
Sallowreach	Jarring: Kept forever in pieces, on a shelf in the Jar Room. Or Refusal: struck from the Closing ledger forever.	The Seamers unpick the condemned while they watch. Dread 2.
The Fatlands	Making good: killed in the Renderers' yards; the victim's family has first cut.	The family eating. Dread 3, Dread 1 to Fatlanders.
Brinehollow	Loosing: sleep unanchored for a set number of nights, the Netwatch ordered not to intervene.	An empty bed, a rope coiled neatly on it. Dread 2.
The Vigil	Bedding, suspended since 590; now the Rattlehouse, waiting for a sentence that cannot be carried out.	Faces at the Rattlehouse bars, awake. Dread 1.
Cradlewrack	The Second Opinion, given to the born and, rarely, to the grown; or bricking in the Lying-In's lower wards.	A midwife wiping her knife on her apron. Dread 2.
Oathen	Jude Crake's visit: an hour of pleasant talk, a small promise, the Breaking.	Nothing, until the sound. Dread 3.
The Fast	The list: a name left off the Pantry roll.	A queue at the byre beyond the Cold Yards. Dread 2, and it lasts weeks.

The executioner's roll. When a Guest carries out a killing stroke with a blade on a helpless person (a beheading at a Rim Road gallows, a Reckoner's knife in a sleeping lord, a mercy given on a battlefield), they roll **Hand + Blades** against Routine (10). On a success, it is done, quickly. On a failure, it is not done, and the Carver describes the moment; the executioner must strike again, and the condemned's Dread rating for all present rises by 1. On a Lack, the blow is **Grievous:** roll on the Grievous table and keep going. A botched execution adds +1 Pall to any community that watched, and the executioner's name is known.

◇
Lord, let it be one stroke. Lord, let it be one stroke.
Lord, let it be —

PRAYER SAID BY RIM ROAD HANGMEN, IN EVERY
LAND, TO EVERY GOD, AND TO NONE

RITUAL KILLING

Some killings are meant to buy something. The Second Helping offers the eaten to the god of feeding. The Cullmasters walk the dusk shift into the fields believing the Reaping can be steered. The Deepening walks the willing into the sea with lanterns. The

Purgation burns high-Cut houses with the families inside to starve the god of its vessels. The Second Table rehearses. In a hundred villages, in the worst years, the elders draw lots.

A **ritual killing** is a killing performed as a rite: with words, with a place, with a method fixed by doctrine. It is led by one celebrant, who rolls **Tongue + Rites** against Hard (14), or Grim (18) if the victim resists or begs. Every participant and witness makes a **Dread 3** check, as the Dread table gives, and those who take part willingly each mark one **Stain**, as the torture rules give. A ritual killing adds +2 to the Pall of any community that knows of it, whether or not it approved.

Then the celebrant rolls on the table below to see what the rite has bought. The Carver may choose instead, but should be honest with herself about which result the world would give.

◇
We gave it my sister and the sea still went out. We
gave it Hask's boy and the sea still went out. Mother
Limpet says the sea is not going out. She says it is
going home, and we are the road.

WRECKWIFE, LOWMARK

D10	WHAT THE RITE BUYS
1–5	Nothing. The god was not listening, or was, and did not care. The field still Reaps. The sea still falls. The interval still shortens. The celebrant will say it worked.
6	Nothing yet. A sign that something was heard: the wheat leans, the tide stirs, a door opens. The congregation will want another.
7	A sop. Every participant with a Cut loses 1d6 Hunger, as if they had performed their Sop, and gains the god's Want of that land for a day.
8	The wrong thing. The god takes the offering, and something else besides: a participant's Regrowth rises by 1, or the next Reaping takes the celebrant's own child.
9	A delay. The thing feared holds off for one Turn of the Pall, one pang, one Reaping, one night. Then it comes, as it was always going to.
10	Attention. Something answers: a god's attention, Dread 4, falls on the celebrant. The Carver decides what it wants from them now.

This table is the Table's answer to sacrifice. The Long Grace contains no rite that saves a village, no offering that turns back a god, and no victim whose death was worth it. The demand is real; the giving is real; the grief is real; the bargain is not. Run every ritual killing knowing that, and let the Guests find it out.

THE WORTHLESS SACRIFICE

In the last bad year in Low Tilth, the village drew lots among its children for the field, because the Cullmasters had taken all the debtors and the Reaping was still hungry, and a preacher of the Second Helping had come through on his way to Sated and said, smiling, that a gift freely given is sweeter. The lot fell on a cooper's daughter. Her father walked her to the field himself, because nobody else would, and he said the grace over her, and came home alone.

The Reaping took eleven that Carving, the same as the year before. Pell Hogget wrote it in the Long Count, in the same column as all the others, with no mark to distinguish it. The cooper asked him to add a note. Pell said he did not know what the note would say. Neither did the cooper. He still asks, every Carving, and Pell still does not know.

▼ THREE FIGHTS, PLAYED THROUGH

The three fights below are told the way they happen at the table, with every roll shown. They use the company from *The Grace Roll*. For quick reference:

RESSA WEIR (BRINEHOLLOW, NIGHTWARDEN) Flesh 12 · Guard 17 · Attack +5 (Netwatch boathook 4, Hooking, Reach) · Armor 1 (oilskin) · Initiative 1d10 + 6 · Cut 2, one Tooth

HALLOWAY BRISK (FATLANDS, RENDERER) Flesh 15 · Guard 16 · Attack +8 (cleaver 4 with *Know the Cut*, Ripping) · Armor 1 (hide coat) · Initiative 1d10 + 4 · Cut 2, one Tooth

TOLLY FANE (THE VIGIL, CRUMB-RUNNER) Flesh 10 · Guard 15 · Attack +3 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Initiative 1d10 + 7 · Stealth 4, Filch 2 · Cut 2, one Tooth

ABATE KELL (THE FAST, TABLEBREAKER) Flesh 14 · Guard 17 · Attack +7 (Tablebreaker's axe 5, Brutal, Two-Handed) · Armor 1 (padded) · Initiative 1d10 + 5 · Unfed, Want 3

FIGHT ONE: THE HOOKS AT GANNET REACH

Ambush, Hooking, a Called Shot, a Grace, and morale.

Gannet Reach has gone Uneasy (see *Madness in the Community*). An old man has denounced his daughter-in-law as Tenanted, and the company has hidden her. At midnight, walking back along the village's short pier, they are waited for: four Netwatch hookmen under the pier-lamps, sent by a lieutenant who wants the woman, and the strangers who hid her.

NETWATCH HOOKMAN (4) Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (boathook 4, Hooking 14) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

The ambush. The hookmen are crouched among the bait-barrels. The Carver rolls Lung + Stealth for them as Threat 2, and takes the *lowest*: $13 + 2 = 15$. The company rolls Eye + Search and takes the *highest*: Tolly, Eye 4 + Search 3, rolls 3 and 2 for 12. The hookmen win by 3: a surprise round, but with no Helping, the Guests are not unaware and keep their Guards. Ade asks whether Abate can feel it coming. The Carver allows Caul + Instinct at Hard (14): Abate has Caul 4, Instinct 2, and rolls 9, for 15. He acts in the surprise round, last.

Surprise round. Hookman A swings for Ressa: $8 + 7 + 5 = 20$ against Guard 17. A hit, by 3: no Helping. The boathook's iron beak takes her across the ribs: 4 damage, minus her oilskin's 1. Ressa is at 9.

Hookman B goes for Holloway: $6 + 6 + 5 = 17$ against Guard 16. A hit, and a pair: a **Grace** for the hookman. The Grace grants a Helping and a Mangling. He spends the Helping on **Hooking**, giving up its damage to drag her a pace toward the pier's unrailed edge (Halloway may resist with Lung + Athletics at Hard 14; Dev rolls 9, and fails). The hook does 4, minus 1: Holloway is at 12. The Mangling: a d20 shows 7, **The Ear**. "The hook goes in behind your ear and comes out the front of it," says the Carver, "and the ear goes with it, mostly. It's hanging on a flap. You can feel it slapping your jaw when you move." Ressa and Tolly, who care about her, make Dread 2 checks; both hold, and take 1 Fray.

Hookmen C and D both miss. Then Abate, last: his axe into Hookman D, $7 + 5 + 7 = 19$ against Guard 13. One Helping, and the axe is Brutal, so the Helping adds +3: $5 + 3 - 1 = 7$. Hookman D is at 5.

Round one. Initiative: Tolly 15, Ressa 12, Abate 10, the hookmen 9 (rolled once, for all), Holloway 7.

Tolly kicks the nearest pier-lamp off its post. It goes over the side and smashes forty feet down on the dry seabed. One lamp remains: **dim light**, -2 to attacks for everyone outside its circle. The hookmen are under it. The Carver rules that attacks *against* them ignore the dim light; theirs, out into the dark, suffer it.

Ressa knows how hookmen fight, because she taught half of them. She makes a **Called Shot** at Hookman A's hands, -2: $9 + 6 + 5 - 2 = 18$ against Guard 13. One Helping. She spends it on the Called Shot's effect: the weapon drops. Her own boathook raps his knuckles and his hook goes clattering down between the boards and off the pier. The rest is damage: $4 - 1 = 3$. A is at 9 and has no weapon. "Sergeant Weir," he says. She does not answer.

Abate swings at Hookman D again: $6 + 3 + 7 = 16$. A hit with no Helping: $5 - 1 = 4$. D is at 1.

The hookmen. B tries to finish dragging Halloway off the edge: $4 + 2 + 5 - 2$ (dim) = 9. A miss. C swings for Tolly: $9 + 8 + 5 - 2 = 20$ against Guard 15. A hit with one Helping, which C spends on Hooking: Tolly is knocked flat. 4 damage: she is at 6.

Halloway, hooked and dragged and bleeding from the side of her head, does what the opening of this chapter describes. She lets go of the idea of stepping back, steps *in* along the pole, inside its reach, where a boathook is no use to anyone, and puts the cleaver into Hookman B where his neck meets his collarbone. $8 + 7 + 8 = 23$ against Guard 13: two Helpings. $4 + 4 = 8$, Ripping, minus 1: 7. B is at 5, and bleeding 1 a round. He sits down. He keeps looking at her.

Round two. Abate cuts Hookman D down: $10 + 7 = 17$, one Helping, $5 + 3 - 1 = 7$. D is at 0: **Ruin**. He collapses, Dying; the Carver rolls his Injury on the Mangling table (d20 with +2 for the Brutal axe): $11 + 2 = 13$, **Severed Fingers**. Three of them, on the boards.

Now the hookmen have lost half their number (D down, B sitting in his own blood) and they have seen a Mangling. **Morale**: $2d10 + 2$ against Hard (14). The Carver rolls 4 and 3: 9. They break. Hookman C runs, back up the pier toward the village, shouting. Hookman A, who has no hook, **Yields**: he kneels and puts his hands on his head. He is nineteen. He used to call Ressa *Sarge* and bring her herring.

After. Halloway kneels by Hookman B. She could finish him. Dev decides she ties off the wound instead (Hand + Stitching, Routine 10: 13, success): the bleeding stops. Tolly stabilizes D (first aid, 11, success: 1 Flesh). Nobody has died. Ressa's Fray is 6; she is Rattled. The village has seen its own Netwatch break against the strangers, and the Carver adds +1 to the Pall of Gannet Reach for a public fight, and then -1 again, because nobody was killed, and the old man who denounced his daughter-in-law has come down to the pier in his nightshirt and is helping Halloway carry Hookman B to the chapel.



*I've been hooked by better, Sarge. That's all I'm saying.
I've been hooked by better, and none of them ever let
me up.*

NETWATCH HOOKMAN, NINETEEN, AFTER

FIGHT TWO: THE STOCK-ROOM UNDER CLENCH ROW

Fighting the Kept, fighting in the dark, dismemberment, and a Grievous blow.

Following the cedar and the brine from the investigation in *The Grace Roll*, the company has found Marrow Jack's stock-room in a drowned storey under Clench Row in the Sinks of Lastgate: a low cellar half full of black water, shelves along the walls, and on the shelves, hands, labelled. Jack is not at home. His door-wardens are: three Unstitched Kept, sewn together from what was left after Jack took what he could sell.

UNSTITCHED KEPT (3) Threat 1 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +4 (teeth and loose hands 2, Grapple 12) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 · Unending; any Helping against it severs a limb, which keeps fighting on its own (Threat 0, Flesh 3, Attack +2, 1)

Dread. The Kept come up out of the water toward the lantern. Dread 2, Hard (14). Halloway rolls 17 (holds, 1 Fray). Ressa rolls 16 (holds, 1 Fray). Abate rolls 16 (holds, 1 Fray). Tolly rolls 8, plus Caul 3 and Resolve 2: 13. She fails, and takes 2 Fray.

Initiative. Tolly 14, Ressa 11, Abate 9, the Kept 8, Halloway 6. Tolly holds the only lantern, which makes her the **lamp-bearer**: she sees ten paces and everything beyond sees her.

Round one. Tolly backs toward the stair, keeping the light up. Ressa sets her boathook into Kept 1: $7 + 6 + 5 = 18$ against Guard 10, two Helpings. Against the Unstitched, any Helping severs a limb: the hook takes its left arm off at the old seam, and the damage is $4 + 4 = 8$. Kept 1 is at 4. The severed arm drops into the water. The Carver rolls a d6 for it: 3. It crawls toward the nearest warm body.

Abate brings the axe down on Kept 2: $5 + 5 + 7 = 17$. A hit and a pair: a **Grace**. The margin of 7 gives one Helping, and the Grace adds another: two Helpings, each worth +3 on a Brutal weapon. $5 + 6 = 11$ damage, no Armor. Kept 2 is at 1. The Grace inflicts a Mangling: d20 + 2 for the Brutal axe, $13 + 2 = 15$, **Severed Hand**. It goes into the water with the arm.

The Kept act. Kept 3 goes for the light, which is to say for Tolly: $6 + 6 + 4 = 16$ against Guard 15. A hit, and a Grace. The Grace's Helping becomes a **Grapple (12)**: it has her. Its Mangling: d20 shows 1, **Laid Open**: a long shallow tear down her forearm where its broken fingernails went in, bleeding 1 a round. Damage 2: Tolly is at 8. She drops the lantern. It hits the black water and goes out.

Darkness. Everyone now fights at -4 , and every Guard counts as $10 + \text{Lung}$ only. The Kept do not need to see: they grasp, and they smell the living. Kept 1 swings at Ressa in the dark ($3 + 4 + 4 = 11$, against her darkened Guard of 14): a miss. Kept 2, with one hand left, gropes for Abate and misses.

Halloway has to find something to hit. The Carver rules that the Kept holding Tolly needs no finding roll, because Tolly is screaming. Halloway makes a **Called Shot** at its arm's joint (-2) in darkness (-4): $9 + 8 + 8 - 6 = 19$ against Guard 10 . Two Helpings. The cleaver goes through the Kept's elbow, and the arm comes away with Tolly still in its grip; she tears the fingers off her own coat. Damage $4 + 4 = 8$: Kept 3 is at 4 . The severed arm's d6 shows 6 : it goes somewhere else, slithering away along the shelves in the dark, and the Carver writes down where.

Round two. Tolly loses 1 Flesh to bleeding (7). She spends her action striking a light: flint and the stub of a Tallow candle from her pocket. The candle whimpers as it catches. **Dim light:** -2 now, not -4 .

Ressa hooks Kept 1 again: a hit, 4 damage, and it is at 0 . It is **Undone**: it stops for $1d6$ rounds (the Carver rolls 2), then it will get up with $1d6$ Flesh. Abate hits Kept 2 for 5 : Undone, for 4 rounds.

Kept 3, with one arm and 4 Flesh, does not attack. It **begs**. "Please. Please, I'm paid in thread. He gives us thread for the holding of the door. I've only the one arm now, please, I need the thread." A Kept that begs is Dread 2 to keep fighting. Halloway rolls and holds. She lowers the cleaver anyway.

Taking them apart. Kept 1 and Kept 2 will rise in a few rounds. Abate does what the Fast taught him to do to a table. He stands over Kept 1, which is lying in the water, Undone and **prone**, and brings the axe down: $4 + 4 + 7 = 15$ against Guard 10 . A pair, a success: a **Grace**, with a Brutal weapon, against a prone target. That is a **Grievous** blow. The Carver rolls on the Grievous table: 20 , **Taken Apart**. "It comes to pieces," she says. "Not like meat. Like a cupboard of things that were put away badly. The pieces go on. In the candlelight you can see them in the water, separately, and some of them are trying to find each other."

Dread 4 , Dire (22), for everyone who sees it. Abate rolls 20 and takes 4 Fray. Ressa rolls 14 and takes 4 Fray. Tolly, who was nearest, rolls 17 and takes 4 Fray: she is at 11 , and she **Breaks**. Sunniva and the Carver decide together. Tolly sits down in the black water among the pieces and begins, very calmly, to count them aloud, and will not stop until she has the number, and the number is always one short. (They roll on Table One anyway, for form's sake, and it comes up 6 , **The Count**. The Carver says that will do.) Everyone else who witnesses the Break makes a Dread 2 check for contagion. Ressa, at Fray 9 , fails. She hears the count, and she starts counting too, under her breath.

After. Kept 3 tells them, for a promise of thread, where Jack sold the Clench Row hands: to a buyer from the Vigil, a quiet man who

smells of cedar and asked specifically for left hands. Nothing in the room can be killed. The company leaves it as they found it, plus pieces. Tolly bleeds until Halloway binds her on the stairs. They do not take any of the hands. Then, at the top of the stairs, Halloway goes back down and takes one, the one labelled *Hessa Coombe*, wrapped in its own paper, to give back to its owner. Ressa is still counting.



You can't kill anything in Lastgate. You can only make it smaller, and spend the rest of your life knowing where all the bits went.

SEAMERS' GUILD APPRENTICE SAYING

FIGHT THREE: THE DUSK SHIFT AT SALLET BOTTOM

A mob, holding the line, a ritual killing, a Yield, and a fight that changes nothing.

This fight happens a season before the hill at Hessop's Furrow. At Sallet Bottom, a Fatlands village two days south of Sated, the Cullmaster's dusk shift is going out: two debtors, bound at the wrists, walked to the edge of the far field by Cullmaster Absalom Furlong and three Cull-bailiffs, while the village watches from the lane behind a hedge. The village has been told that if the field is not fed, it will feed itself on their children. Most of them believe it. Some of them are holding pitchforks.

CULLMASTER ABSALOM FURLONG Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Attack $+6$ (Cullmaster's sickle 4 , Hooking, Ripping, Silent) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · Rites 4

CULL-BAILIFF (3) Threat 2 · Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Attack $+5$ (cudgel 3 , Grapple 14) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

VILLAGERS OF SALLET BOTTOM (12, A MOB) Threat 3 · Flesh 60 · Guard 13 · Attack $+6$ (pitchforks, flails, a cleaver 5) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · breaks at half number unless a preacher holds it

Too late. The company comes over the rise as the light goes red. The first debtor, a widow named Petty Furrow, is already at the field's edge with the Cullmaster's hand on her shoulder. The Carver does not let them reach her. Nobody could have. The Cullmaster performs the rite: a **ritual killing**, Tongue + Rites against Grim (18) because she is begging, and he rolls $16 + 3 = 19$. It succeeds. The Carver does not describe it. She describes the sound the wheat makes, though there is no wind, and the shape of Petty Furrow's shoes lying neatly side by side at the edge of the first furrow, and the bailiffs looking at their boots. Dread 3 , Grim (18), for the company. Halloway, who is from a village like this one, fails, and takes 3 Fray. Then the Cullmaster rolls a d10 to see what the rite has bought. It shows 2 . **Nothing**. He will write in his book that it went well.

The second debtor is a young man named Crust Leggat. He is sixteen, and his debt is his father's. The company goes down the hill.

Initiative. Tolly 16, Ressa 13, the Cullmaster 12, Abate 11, the bailiffs 9, Halloway 8, the mob 7.

Round one. Tolly does not fight. She goes for Crust's bonds: Hand 2 + Filch 2 against Hard (14), and rolls 11, for 15. The cord parts. Crust runs.

Ressa and Abate take the gap in the hedge, where the lane meets the field: a yard wide, between two thorn-banks. They **Hold the Line**, shoulder to shoulder: +2 Guard each while the other stands (Ressa 19, Abate 19). The mob can only reach them two at a time. Under the *Fighting Many* rules, it attacks the line at Threat 1 (one, plus none, because only two can reach), at +4.

The Cullmaster goes for Tolly, who has stolen his second offering: 7 + 4 + 6 = 17 against Guard 15. A hit with no Helping. 4 damage, and the sickle is Ripping: Tolly is at 6, and bleeding 1 a round.

Abate swings past Ressa's shoulder at Bailiff 1, who is coming at the line: 6 + 5 + 7 = 18 against Guard 12, one Helping. 5 + 3 - 1 = 7. Bailiff 1 is at 7.

The bailiffs. Bailiff 1 tries to grapple Abate out of the line: 9 + 5 = 14 against Guard 19. A miss. Bailiff 2 clubs Halloway: 13 + 5 = 18 against Guard 16, a hit, 3 - 1 = 2. She is at 13. Bailiff 3 runs Crust down in the stubble and grapples him: the boy is held.

Halloway puts her cleaver into Bailiff 2: 5 + 3 + 8 = 16 against Guard 12, one Helping. 4 + 2 - 1 = 5, Ripping. He is at 9, and bleeding.

The mob comes at the hedge-gap: 6 + 5 + 4 = 15 against Ressa's 19. Nothing gets through.

Round two. Tolly bleeds (5): Bloodied. She spends her action binding her own arm with her teeth and her good hand, Routine (10), and rolls 12. It stops.

Ressa wants the sickle out of the Cullmaster's hand. She leaves the line (Abate loses his +2) and makes a **Called Shot** at his weapon hand, -2. She **Partakes**: 9 + 8 + 3 - 2, and the Tooth shows 4, for 22 against Guard 14. Two Helpings. One buys the Called Shot's effect: the sickle drops into the stubble. The other buys +2 damage: 4 + 2 - 1 = 5. The Cullmaster is at 8. Ressa gains 1 Hunger; her ears pop, and for a moment everyone in the field hears the sea.

The Cullmaster, unarmed, does what Cullmasters do. He turns to the village and shouts: *the field has had one and it wants two, and if it does not have two, it will come up the lane tonight for yours*. He is preaching. Tongue + Rites against Hard (14): 13 + 3 = 16. It works. The mob stops trying the gap and goes through the hedge itself, tearing the thorn aside with their hands. Now all twelve can reach: the mob attacks at its full Threat 3, at +6, for 5 damage.

Abate, alone in the gap, swings at Bailiff 1: 10 + 7 = 17, one Helping. 5 + 3 - 1 = 7. Bailiff 1 is at 0: **Ruin**. He falls, Dying, and his Injury from the Mangling table is a d20 with +2 for the Brutal axe: 11 + 2 = 13, **Severed Fingers**. In the mob, a woman screams a name. It is his. She is his mother. The Carver tells Ade: if Abate strikes again, the man dies, and that is a man the whole village knew.

Bailiff 2 misses Halloway. Bailiff 3 holds Crust down in the stubble.

Halloway looks at the twelve people coming through the hedge with pitchforks, and they are her people: big, warm, hungry, frightened, polite people who have been told their children will be eaten. Dev says, "She **Yields**. She drops the cleaver. She talks to them." Tongue + Persuade, against Grim (18), because one of theirs is down. Halloway has Tongue 2, Persuade 0. Dev Partakes. 8 + 6 + 2 + the Tooth's 3 = 19.

"Her mouth floods," says the Carver, "and her belly growls so loud that the front of the mob hears it over the shouting, a long, rolling, ridiculous noise, and somebody laughs." Halloway says: *You look heavy. All of you. You look well. You've walked eleven out to this field every Carving for ten years and it's still hungry. It isn't hungry for him. It's hungry. That's all it is*. The roll succeeds. The mob must make a **morale check**, now, though it has not lost a soul: 2d10 + 3 against Hard (14). The Carver rolls 5 and 3: 11. It fails. The mob stops in the stubble. Some of them go to the fallen bailiff. His mother is already there.

Round three, and the end. The Cullmaster, alone, unarmed, at 8 **Flesh, flees**: into the wheat. Ressa is engaged with him and would get a free attack unless he wins an opposed Lung + Athletics. He rolls 15; she rolls 13. He is gone, into the field, at dusk, and the wheat closes behind him without a sound. Nobody follows. The bailiffs Yield. Crust Leggat sits in the stubble, shaking.

After. Halloway stabilizes Bailiff 1: first aid, Routine (10), 14. He will live with seven fingers and a Fatlands mother who will never forgive the Tablebreaker or thank the renderer. Abate makes no Dread check for the killing, because there was no killing, and he finds he is shaking anyway. The Carver adds the cost to the Pall of Sallet Bottom: +2 for a ritual killing the village watched, +1 for a mob formed, -1 for a mob dispersed with no death. It ends the night Uneasy.

In the morning, the Cullmaster's sickle is found at the field's edge, beside a pair of shoes that are not Petty Furrow's. Pell Hogget's tally for Sallet Bottom that year, copied in two hundred villages, shows the Reaping took nine. It took nine the year before. Crust Leggat's name is not among them. That is the whole of what the company won, and the Carver should make sure the players understand that it was everything.

THEY ASK ME WHAT WE GOT FOR IT. A BOY. ONE BOY, **SIXTEEN**,
WITH HIS **FATHER'S** DEBT. YOU **CAN'T** PUT THAT IN A
LEDGER, SO THEY **DON'T COUNT** IT. I **COUNT** IT.

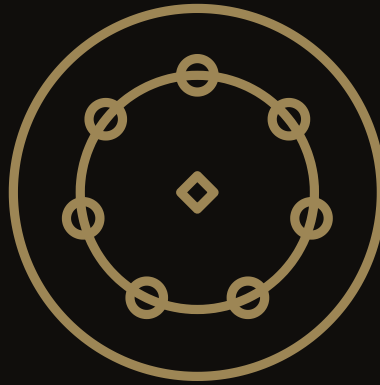
[HALLOWAY BRISK, AT A WAYSTATION IN CARVING, 641 A.G.]



PART THREE

THE MARKET AND THE THINGS THAT EAT

Coin, goods, relics of godflesh, and the horrors that walk the lands.



CHAPTER 14

THE RIM MARKET

Everything on the Table has a price. The trick is finding out who is paying it.

– PAINTED OVER THE DOOR OF THE COMPANY COUNTING-HOUSE AT TOLL
NINE

The stall stood where the Rim Road bends at Gristmoor, between a man selling anchoring-rope by the fathom and a Seamer's boy crying "Thread, wire, lacquer, fingers!" in a voice that had broken years ago and been stitched back wrong. It was a Fatlands stall. You could tell by the width of the counter, which was built to bear a forearm the size of a bolster, and by the smell, which was gravy, clove, and something under the clove that the clove was there for.

The stall-wife was called Mardy Haunch and she was, by the custom of her country, beautiful: she spilled over her stool on both sides like risen dough over a tin. She was eating while she sold. She was always eating while she sold. She had a sausage in one hand and a knife in the other, and the sausage was a yard long and coiled on the board in front of her like a sleeping dog, and every so often it moved.

"It is not moving," said Mardy Haunch, to the customer. "That is settling."

The customer was from the Vigil. You could tell by the eyes, which were red to the rims and had stopped bothering to blink, and by the long pin she wore through the web of her left hand so she could twist it when the world went soft. She had a nudger with her, a small boy on a lead, whose whole job was to kick her ankle every twenty breaths. He was very good at it. He did not look up from her ankle once.

"Price," said the Vigil woman.

"For the yard? Eleven lacks."

"Eleven." The Vigil woman put three little black tabs on the counter, pressed and stamped with an open eye. "Rouse. Good rouse. Crane's strain, not the Slope stuff. Four hours of waking each."

Mardy Haunch looked at the tabs the way a cat looks at a painted bird. "What am I going to do with four hours of waking, my love? I sleep like a ditch. Coin."

"I have six lacks in coin."

"Then you have six lacks of sausage." Mardy raised the knife and the sausage, quite distinctly, tightened its coil away from it.

"Settling," said Mardy, and put the knife down.

At this point a third party arrived, which is how all real haggling on the Rim Road goes. He was an Oathener, tall and

dry and dressed in canyon-red, with a little brass plate at his collar that said PRICE-WITNESS, LICENSED, and he spoke very slowly, the way a man walks across a frozen pond. "If it would be of use," he said, "and if neither party objects, and barring weather, I might, as I now intend, assist."

"Nobody asked you," said Mardy.

"That is so," said the Oathener, which cost him nothing, because it was true. He looked at the sausage. He looked at it for some time. "I would observe, without asserting anything as to its composition, that the casing bears a mark."

It did. A little way from the end there was a faded blue pattern pricked into the skin. Anchors. Two anchors, crossed, and under them, in a sailor's crude letters, the beginning of a name: SAL. The rest of the name was round the other side of the coil.

There was a silence of the kind you get at a market when everyone within six stalls has stopped pretending not to listen. The rope-seller had stopped measuring. The Seamer's boy had stopped crying fingers.

"That," said Mardy Haunch, with tremendous dignity, "is a pig that went to sea."

"I would not say otherwise," said the Oathener, very carefully, "since I cannot."

The Vigil woman leaned in, red eyes unblinking, close enough to read. The boy kicked her ankle. She did not notice. "Turn it over," she said.

"Turn it over yourself. Four lacks, then. For the yard. And the tabs."

"Three lacks and the tabs, and you turn it over."

"Five and I don't."

The Oathener coughed, gently. "If it would help to settle the matter, and as a neutral party, I might say that in my judgment, as I now hold it, the item has a value, and that value is not nothing."

Both women looked at him with loathing. He received it calmly. He was paid a crumb a word, and he had been very economical.

In the end the Vigil woman paid four lacks and two tabs, and Mardy Haunch threw in a heel of toothed bread, which bit the boy, and wrapped the coil in a sheet of oiled paper and tied it

with string, and did not turn it over. The Vigil woman walked off up the Rim Road towards the lamp-glow on the eastern horizon, carrying the parcel against her chest like a baby, and three stalls down she stopped, and unwrapped one end, and looked.

Nobody saw what the rest of the name said. But they saw her stand there a long while. And they saw her, at last, wrap it up again and keep walking, because it was a long road and she was hungry and four lacks is four lacks.

"Lack keep away," said Mardy Haunch to the next customer, and smiled, and ate.

On the Table everyone needs something that only an obscene neighbour can sell. The sleepless need oil, brine and pain. The undying need perfume and thread. The starving heartland needs everything, and hates whoever brings it. The Rim Road is the ring of highway that carries all of it, some two thousand four hundred miles of rutted Oathen stone around the Fast's border, owned by the Rim Road Company, tolled at every post and bridge and lined with inns, wells, shrines, gibbets and markets. Most of what the Guests buy, they buy on the Rim, from someone who is lying to them about where it came from.

The Rim is not a road with markets on it. It is a market with a road through it. Every Company post every twenty miles has a bone-slate of prices by the gate; every waystation has a market square; and at the great junctions, Gristmoot and Fogmouth and the Spur and Knocking Gate, the stalls run out along the verge for miles in both directions, so that a traveller can walk from breakfast to supper without once being out of earshot of somebody crying a price. The noise of the Rim is the noise of haggling, in seven accents, through seven kinds of mouth: Fatlanders talking with their mouths full, Brinehollowers stopping to cough brine into a bucket, Oatheners speaking in conditionals so slow you could shave between the clauses, Kept stall-keepers of the north clicking their jaws, Vigil

hawkers shouting to keep themselves awake, Cradlewrack pedlars knocking on the counter before every offer, and the Unfed saying "No, thank you" three times to everything, including money.



FINGERS. MATCHED TO ORDER. YOURS OR OURS. NO QUESTIONS, FEWER ANSWERS.

CHALKED ON A SEAMER'S BOARD AT FOGMOUTH

This chapter is a working market. It sets out the money of the Table and what it is made of; how to find something for sale and how long that takes; how to argue the price down, with an example of play; a day at the greatest market on the Rim; what living costs in each land; and long lists of weapons, armour, clothes, tools, food, drugs, beasts, beds and services. It then turns to the two trades that are not supposed to exist and are the largest on the road: the trade in people, and the trade in the gods themselves. It closes with the merchants who deal in all of it, and the things that happen at market when nobody is looking.

USING THIS CHAPTER

Prices are given in lacks (L) and crumbs (c). Ten crumbs make a lack; twenty lacks make a platter. Prices assume a Rim Road market in a good season. Use the Availability rules to decide whether an item is on the stall at all, the Haggling rules to settle what the Guests actually pay, and the Taint rules whenever the thing they bought was once part of a god.

The Carver should not let shopping become bookkeeping. Track money closely when it is scarce and it matters (in the Fast, in a siege, in debt to an Oathener, in a Bed-Due season in the Vigil). Otherwise let the Guests live at a lifestyle and roll only for the purchases that make a story. A market scene earns its place when somebody learns something they did not want to know about what they are eating, wearing, spending or carrying.

▼ THE COIN OF THE TABLE

We pay for bread with bone. Nobody thinks this is strange. Nobody has ever asked whose.

— MEEK GARRITY, FROM A SUPPRESSED LECTURE



THE LACK

The lack is the one coin honoured everywhere on the Table: a disc of salt-cured bone the width of a thumb-joint, a finger's width

thick, pierced at the centre so it can be strung, and stamped on one face with the Plate (a full moon) and on the other with an empty circle. By law and by custom it is worth one day's bread. When the

price of bread rises, people do not say that bread is dear. They say the lack is thin.

Nobody minted the first lacks. Two kinds of coin are called by that name, and the trade confuses them on purpose. The Cutwrights' College records that the first bone discs were cut in the seventh year of the Long Lack, for the public kitchens of the Bone Dole, so that the starving could be given a token for a bowl instead of fighting at the door; the College declines to say what bone the Dole had to hand in the seventh year of a famine, and the few Dole lacks that survive are yellower and smoother than any coin since, and people who find one in their change spend it quickly. The older tradition of the Rim holds that the first true lacks were cut in the year after the Gorging, when the peoples of the Table had a great deal of bone lying about from the meal: from Ummer's ribs, from Dromm's vast spine, from the knuckles of Ossel. Those god-lacks, if any survive, are not money. They are relics (see Relics and Godflesh). The coin in your purse is ordinary bone. That is the official position, and it is almost true.

HOW BONE BECOMES COIN

The Company's first issues were struck at the old Bonehouse beside the Chute, which is a tannery now. Since 212 A.G. the only lawful mint has been the Company's Cure-House at Saltbridge, on the Rim where the Fatlands road meets the Brinehollow road, three days' haul from the Chute. Every lack struck in the last four centuries passed through it. The process is old, simple and filthy.

- ◇ **The bone.** It comes from the Chute, the Fatlands' great export depot, in sealed carts stamped BONE: MIXED. The Renderers' Union sells the Company the long bones of everything slaughtered in the south. Everything slaughtered in the south includes the cattle, the swine, the orchard-pigs, the drover-herds of Sal Trotter, and the Fatlands dead, who are served at their own wakes and whose bones the family is paid a few crumbs to send on. The Company does not sort. Coin-cutters say you can tell a cattle lack from a person lack by the grain; the Company says that is superstition, and fines anyone who says it twice.
- ◇ **The boil.** The bones are boiled white in copper vats for three days and three nights. The fat is skimmed and sold back south as tallow. The steam from the Cure-House can be smelled from the next post, sweet and heavy, like a stockpot left on the fire for a week, and the people of Saltbridge are famous for their good skin and bad dreams. Children born in the town are said to be born with the taste of marrow in their mouths. The vat-men work naked to the waist and are scalded pink to the collarbone, and they are the only people on the Rim who can look into a copper of bubbling knees and see nothing but work.
- ◇ **The cutting.** Coin-cutters, most of them Scraplings bound to the Company for twenty years (see The Trade in People), saw the long bones into rounds on treadle saws and punch the centre hole. The saw-dust is a fine grey flour that gets into the bread, the bedding and the lungs; old cutters cough bone. A good

cutter gets nineteen lacks from a man's thigh, and the trade calls a thigh "a bad day's wage." The cutters keep tally-sticks of their work and are paid in their own product, one lack in fifty.

- ◇ **The cure.** The rounds are packed in salt for a full season, and the Company's best issue, the platter-bone, for a full year. The salt is Brinehollow salt, and since the sea retreated, most Brinehollow salt is boiled out of the water Brinehollowers cough up at dawn and dusk, collected in parish buckets and sold by the barrel. Every lack on the Table is cured in somebody's lungs.
- ◇ **The stamp.** A hot iron die burns the Plate and the empty circle into the faces. The empty circle has been on the coin since 212; the Company's charter says it represents "the bread to be bought." The Chute Bonehouse stamped a closed mouth on that face instead, and the Rim still calls any coin of the old issue a **shut-mouth**; there are a great many still in purses, and a traveller from the far west who has only ever seen shut-mouths will tell you, with confidence, that the lack bears a closed mouth. Some old coin-cutters say the empty circle is a chair seen from above.

A genuine lack is dense, faintly translucent at the edge when held to a lamp, cool to the touch, and tastes strongly of salt. Merchants bite coins. On the Rim this is not a figure of speech, and every money-changer on the road has a dark crescent worn into the front teeth where ten thousand lacks have been tested.

Tally-stick of Wenna Coyne, cutter, bench nine, Cure-House at Saltbridge. Notches read by the Company's assessor at her twentieth year, Carving 639, transcribed for her release. Cutters may not write. They notch, and they scratch a mark beside the notch, and the assessor reads both.

Notch. Notch. Notch. Thigh, big, cattle. Notch. Thigh, small. Notch with a ring scratched: a ring in the bone, grown over, someone broke this and it healed. Notch. Notch. Thigh with letters. Did not cut. Gave it to the foreman. Notch. Notch. Shin, with a nail in it, surgeon's nail, iron, took it out and kept it. Notch. Thigh, child's. Did not cut. Foreman said cut it. Cut it. Seven lacks out of it, not nineteen. Notch. Notch. Notch. Notch.

Twenty years. Eleven hundred and forty notches with a mark. The assessor counted. My release is one lack in fifty of what I cut, which is a fortune, and paid in lacks. I asked could I have it in anything else. He said what else is there.

CRUMBS

A crumb is a tenth of a lack: a bone bead the size of a pea, pierced and cured like its parent, cut from the knuckles, ribs and offcuts that will not make a full disc. Crumbs are strung in tens on a knotted cord called a loaf. Paying a lack in crumbs is legal but rude, and a merchant may count every bead in front of you while you

wait. Children are paid in crumbs, beggars ask for them, and every Oathen price-witness charges by them. A beggar's cry on the Rim is "Crumb for the plate," and the beggars of Fogmouth, who are mostly living relatives of the Kept across the Drop, rattle their loaves like rosaries.

PLATTERS

A platter is a sealed Rim Road Company tablet of polished bone, the size of a palm, worth twenty lacks. Each is cut from a single shoulder blade, stamped with the Company's seven-spoked wheel, numbered, and closed with a bead of red wax impressed by the signet of Jessamy Quill, Notary of the Rim Road. The Company has sworn, in Oathen, before Quill, that it will redeem every unbroken platter for twenty lacks at any Company house on the Rim. Because the oath was sworn in Oathen, it cannot be broken without the Company's sworn officers coming apart. This is why the platter is trusted more than any coin, and why the Company guards Jessamy Quill more closely than any king guards a crown. If she dies, every platter in circulation becomes a pretty piece of shoulder.

The wealthy keep platters in flat cedar cases lined with felt, slotted like a cutlery drawer, and the very wealthy have their cases made in sets of seven, after the wheel. Platter-thieves on the Rim are called **blade-men**, after the shoulder, and are hanged at the post like murderers, because the Company regards a stolen platter as a stolen oath. A platter whose wax is cracked is redeemed at fifteen lacks and a sworn statement of how it cracked. A platter whose wax has been lifted and resealed is worth a rope.



*Platters bought. Platters sold. Wax inspected free.
Shoulders priced by the pound if the notary dies.*

SLATE OUTSIDE A MONEY-CHANGER'S BOOTH,
LOWMARK SPUR

WEIGHING AND CLIPPING

A true lack weighs as much as forty grains of untoothed wheat. Money-changers carry hanging scales and a pouch of reference grains, and in the Fatlands, where the wheat has teeth, they carry grains from the Rim and guard them like jewels; a money-changer's reference pouch is the first thing a Gristmoot pickpocket goes for, and a changer robbed of it cannot work until a Company factor certifies a new one. Shaving a lack (clipping) is a hanging offence in every land except Sallowreach, where the offender is shaved in turn, very slowly, by the same amount, and goes on living afterward. Clipped coins are accepted at nine crumbs, or at eight if the clipping shows.

COUNTERFEITS

Bone is everywhere, so forging lacks is the commonest crime on the Rim. The common fakes and their tells:

- ◇ **Horn and hoof.** Pressed and dyed. Too light; burns with a stink when touched with a hot needle. Detected on a Routine (10) Eye + Reckoning roll.
- ◇ **Unsalted bone.** Bone that skipped the season in brine. Tastes of nothing. A merchant who bites coin finds it at once.
- ◇ **Kept bone.** Cut from the Kept of Sallowreach, whose bodies never finish rotting. These coins are perfect in every respect but one: they never stop decaying. In a few weeks a Kept lack goes greasy and grey and smells faintly of the fen. In a purse it sweats. A purse of Kept coin attracts flies. Hard (14) to spot when fresh.
- ◇ **Wrack bone.** Bone from Cradlewrack Parts. A coin cut from a Part, it is whispered, is still growing; it thickens by a hair a month, and in a year will not fit a string. Hard (14) to spot.
- ◇ **Blank bone.** The rarest and most sinister fake: lacks cut from the bones of Blanks or the Unfed. They are said to be the only coins with no god in them at all. Collectors pay twenty times face value. They are almost always proof that somebody was killed for their skeleton.
- ◇ **Painted shut-mouths.** New coin with the circle sanded off and a mouth burned on, sold to collectors and to the far west as old issue at a premium. Easily spotted by anyone who has handled a real shut-mouth (Routine 10, Eye + Lore); the real ones have a little crack at the corner of the lips, where the old die was flawed.
- ◇ **Brine-soaked chalk.** Chalk cut and soaked in bail-water until it tastes right. It passes a bite and fails a rain. Shopkeepers in Oathen, where it rains once a year, are notoriously easy marks for it.

Passing false coin knowingly is punished by the Company with a fine of ten times the face value and the loss of the passing hand's thumb, and by most lands with worse. The Company's thumb-jars stand on a shelf in every factor's office, labelled by year. In Gristmoot the jar for 640 is nearly full.

WHOSE BONES?

The question every player eventually asks is answered differently depending on who is asked. The Company says: cattle. The Renderers' Union says: whatever comes. Mistress Brisket Annalow, if she can be made to say anything, says that since the Reaping doubled the Chute ships more bone than the herds could possibly account for, and that the Company has never once complained about the quality. A character who studies lacks for long (Grim 18 Eye + Lore) can learn to read the grain, and from then on will know which coins in their purse were people. They will still spend them. Everybody does. A character who has learned the grain makes a Dread 1 check the first time they pay for a meal with a coin they know was a person; after that, they stop counting.

SWORN NOTES

Oathen does not mint. It does not need to. In Oathen, a written promise to pay, sworn aloud before witnesses and signed, is backed by the only security that cannot run away: the issuer's own body. These are sworn notes, and they are the paper money of the eastern half of the Table.

A sworn note reads something like the one below. The issuer reads it aloud in front of a licensed Clausewright, signs it, and the Clausewright witnesses it with a thumbprint in ink. The note then circulates exactly like coin.

I, Halde Vosk, cooper, of the third gallery of the Sunward Wall in Tacit, as I now intend and barring weather, flood, the closing of the stair by order of the Bench, my own death by causes not my doing, and the late coming of the Rain, will pay to the bearer of this paper twelve lacks of good Company bone, on demand, at my door, between the bell of first light and the bell of last light, on any day but Tablenight; and if I do not, let my left hand answer.

Read aloud by the issuer in the Hall of Conditions, the ninth of Plenty, 640. Witnessed. (thumbprint, brown ink) Sorrel Imm, Clausewright, licence four hundred and six.

On the back, in four different hands: Paid on to Asa the goatman for cheese. Paid on to the widow Tarrant. Paid on to Silas Amend at nine lacks. Demanded, the second of Carving, 641; not paid. And below it, in pencil, in a fifth hand, very small: heard it go from the opposite wall.

The collateral clause is what gives the note its value. It names what breaks if the issuer defaults: a hand, an eye's sight, the use of a knee, the voice, a set of teeth. The Rule of Oathen does the rest. The moment the issuer refuses or fails to pay a bearer who has made lawful demand, the named part breaks, at once, with a sound, wherever the issuer happens to be. Notes backed by large collateral ("let my heart answer") are not legal in Oathen, since a break is never fatal by itself and a heart that opens like a cupboard and goes on beating is considered bad for trade.

- ◇ **Valuing a note.** A note is worth its face value only if the issuer is solvent, whole, and findable. Oathen notes trade at full value in Tacit, at a crumb in the lack discount on the Rim, and at two or three crumbs in the lack in the far west, where the issuer is weeks away. A note by an issuer known to be close to default trades at half. Speculators in Tacit watch issuers' bodies through spyglasses from the opposite canyon wall, and a limp is news.
- ◇ **Forsworn paper.** Notes issued by the Forsworn of the Breakdowns are backed by what they have left. A man whose ribs already stand open like a book has little to pledge. Brakk's people issue notes against parts that are already broken; these are

worthless and are traded as jokes, souvenirs and insults. "Let my open chest answer" is a Breakdowns way of saying *never*.

- ◇ **Sureties.** A merchant who lacks good body can hire a Surety to co-sign: the Surety pledges a part of their own body as second collateral, for a fee of one lack in ten. Ona Fell's notes are the best paper in the canyon. She has two hundred and eleven other oaths in her, and her signature still trades at par. (Sureties, and the market in their bodies, are described under The Trade in People.)
- ◇ **Default abroad.** The break happens wherever the issuer is, because the oath is in the issuer. A note sworn in Tacit and defaulted in Lastgate snaps a wrist in Lastgate. Foreign issuers who swear notes in Oathen are bound like natives. A non-Oathener who signs a note outside Oathen is not bound at all, and their notes are not called sworn notes but "dry paper," worth what the issuer's honesty is worth.
- ◇ **The new terror.** Writing has begun to bind on its own. Two clerks in Tacit have broken this year over notes they copied but never swore. The Bench of Clauses has said nothing. The discount on Oathen paper has quietly doubled, and the paper-brokers of the Rim have begun to ask, before they buy a note, not only whether the issuer is whole, but who copied it.

DEFAULT – WHAT HAPPENS

When a character who issued a sworn note fails to pay on lawful demand, the named collateral breaks: treat it as an Injury from the Mangling table chosen to match (a hand that will not close; an eye gone milky; a knee reversed), with no roll to avoid it, and a Dread 2 check for anyone who sees it happen. The character is now Forsworn in that matter, and every Oathener who sees them knows it. Paying the debt afterwards does not mend the break. Nothing does. The sound carries: a bearer who demanded payment and was refused hears the break, wherever they are, as a small dry snap at the back of the skull, and knows the paper is spent.

REGIONAL MONEY

Every land uses the lack, and every land also uses something else, usually something only that land could think of. A traveller who wants to be treated as a fool pays in lacks everywhere. A traveller who wants local prices learns the local money.

SALLOWREACH: LICENSES, MINUTES AND BREATHS

The only thing truly scarce in Sallowreach is ending, and so death is the money of the north. The Mortuary Court sells a **death-license**, entitling the bearer to one Closing by a Hand-line Closer, for about four thousand lacks; the price rose by three hundred last year, because the Hushes have made death seem, for the first time, a thing that might be had for free. Few families can raise that, so for three centuries the Court has also issued fractions of a license. A **minute of Closing** is a sixtieth part of a license, a narrow lacquered slip of

coffin-wood bearing Regent Grue's signature and the number of the license it belongs to. A **breath** is a twelfth of a minute: a black wax token stamped with a closed eye. Families save minutes for generations, in jars under the floor, towards the day great-great-grandmother can at last be finished. Lend a man a minute and he will thank you. Give a man a full license and he will weep. Minutes are the closest thing in Sallowreach to inheritance; they pass because their owners do not.

The jars are a kind of furniture. In a fen house there is a loose board by the hearth, and under it a stoneware crock with sixty slots cut in the lid, and the crock is the family's whole ambition. When a slot is filled, the family holds a small supper. When the last slot is filled, after eighty or a hundred years of filling, the family takes the crock to the Court and the Court counts the minutes, very slowly, checking every number against the register, and very often finds one forged, and the crock goes home with fifty-nine.



*We are saving for Gran. Gran is saving for her Gran.
It is a long line and we are all in it.*

A PORTER OF THE LANDING, LASTGATE

THE FATLANDS: MEAT SCRIP

The Board of Plenty pays wages, rents and taxes in **meat scrip**: printed slips of greased paper, each redeemable at any Board store or at the Chute for a stated weight of meat. The common denominations are the pound, the stone and the side. Meat scrip is the most honest money on the Table in one sense (it is backed by something you can eat) and the most horrible in every other, because its value tracks the supply of meat, and the supply of meat rises every Carving with the Reaping. In a heavy Reaping year the scrip falls by a third in a month. Pell Hogget's tally-keepers chart the scrip rate alongside their count of the missing, and the two lines match. The Board posts the rate of the pound-scrip on the door of every store; in 641 it stands at seven crumbs and falling. Outside the Fatlands nobody honours the posted rate, and the pound-scrip fetches what a pound of meat fetches on the Rim, about three crumbs, and the merchant will want to know the barrel-mark it was redeemed against.

BRINEHOLLOW: BAIL-TOKENS

A **bail-token** is a small disc of cast lead, stamped with a bucket, issued by Brinehollow parishes to anyone who bails the infirm at dawn and dusk. Each token is good for one cup of sweet water at an Admiralty cistern or one bailing done on your behalf. Because both are always wanted, the tokens circulate as small change. Children like Tolly Brack earn more in tokens than their parents do in coin. A **Netwatch tally**, a larger lead token stamped with a hook, is paid to the patrol for every Called person dragged home alive; Netwatch tallies are worth ten bail-tokens and are always suspected of being

for bodies that were not, strictly, alive. The Gilt Mile's brokers deal in a third paper, the **pier-note**, a mortgage on a length of the Mile not yet built; they trade at a steep discount on the Rim, where everyone has heard what the Harbormistress has calculated.

THE VIGIL: ROUSE-TABS

The Vigil's small money is a **rouse-tab**: a pressed lozenge of black rouse stamped with an open eye, nominally good for one hour awake and worth three crumbs. Wages on the Slope are paid in tabs. Because the dose required rises every year, the tab is the only currency on the Table that suffers literal inflation of the body: a tab that held an hour in 600 A.G. now holds perhaps twenty minutes, and the Apothecary-General's office restamps the official value each season, and each season the eye on the stamp gets smaller. Tabs cut with Brinehollow brine (see Drugs) are worth more on the Slope, because they work better, and are worth nothing to anyone who knows why.

CRADLEWRACK: NAMING-RIGHTS

In Cradlewrack, no child is named until it is a year old and plainly a child. Until then, the right to name it belongs to whoever bore it, and that right can be sold. A **naming-right** is a Tally-office certificate giving the holder the sole right to name a particular birth when the year is out. Rich families buy naming-rights to fill a branch of the family tree; the poor sell them for bread. Because nobody knows what a birth will turn out to be, naming-rights are speculation in the purest form: a right to name a healthy boy is worth a fortune, a right to name a hand is worth nothing, and a right to name something the Attendance does not permit is void. Kest has a naming-exchange, under the Tally hall, where rights are bought and sold by the hour as rumours come down from the birthing-rooms, and where the brokers call their prices in a sing-song like a counting-rhyme. A right bought for two lacks on a Rudge clay-digger's unborn may sell for four hundred if the child is born whole, speaking, and plainly gifted. A right bought for forty on a noble's bastard is void the moment the knife falls.



*Rudge girl, third month, mother sound, two lacks, two
lacks, who'll give three? Kest boy, ninth month, born
talking, says "not yet," falling, falling, eleven, ten,
nine.*

PATTER ON THE NAMING-EXCHANGE, KEST

OATHEN: SWORN NOTES

As above. Small coin in Oathen is still the lack, and the price-witness is still paid in crumbs, but anything over a platter changes hands as paper. In the Breakdowns, where the Forsworn have nothing left to pledge, the currency is tally-sticks, which are held not to bind, and whose price has trebled since handtalk began to break.

THE FAST: RATION CHITS

The Unfed do not touch bone coin. They say the lack is cut from Godeaters and cured in Godeater lungs, and they are right, and they will not have it in their houses. Inside the Fast the only money is the **ration chit**: a square of unbleached cloth stamped by the Pantry with a single empty bowl, entitling the bearer to one day's ration at the Pantry window in Wanting. Chits are issued, never earned; the Abstinent give them out by household, by name, by list. A family left off the list has nothing to trade. The chits cannot lawfully be sold, and are sold constantly. In Lack season, when Mother Stint Avery begins cutting the lists, a chit fetches three lacks from a Crumb-Runner, who will be spat at for buying it.

THE RIM: WAGE-CHITS AND BONE-SLATES

The Company pays its Bonded Hands three lacks a day, and pays most of it in **wage-chits**: thin bone slips stamped with the wheel and a post-number, good for a bed, a meal or a drink at any Company house, and worth a lack apiece to anyone who lives on the road. Off the road they are worth nothing, which is the point. The Company has never once paid a Bonded Hand in full in lacks, and Bonded Hands who retire after forty years on the Rim tend to find that they cannot afford to leave it.

EXCHANGE RATES

MONEY	ISSUER	VALUE IN LACKS	TAKEN WHERE	NOTES
Lack	Rim Road Co.	1	everywhere	the Table's coin
Crumb	Rim Road Co.	0.1	everywhere	strung in loaves of ten
Platter	Rim Road Co.	20	everywhere	void if Quill dies
Shut-mouth (old issue)	Chute Bonehouse	1 (collectors 2)	everywhere	pre-212; cracked lips
Clipped lack	—	0.8 to 0.9	everywhere, grudgingly	hanging offence to make
Wage-chit	Rim Road Co.	1	Company houses only	worthless off the road
Death-license	Mortuary Court	about 4,000	Sallowreach	one Closing
Minute of Closing	Mortuary Court	65	Sallowreach, Vigil	1/60 license
Breath	Mortuary Court	5	Sallowreach	1/12 minute
Meat scrip (pound)	Board of Plenty	0.7 at home, 0.3 abroad	Fatlands, Chute	falls in Carving
Meat scrip (side)	Board of Plenty	25	Fatlands	a whole half-beast
Bail-token	Brinehollow parishes	0.2	Brinehollow	one cup of sweet water
Netwatch tally	Tidal Admiralty	2	Brinehollow	"alive," officially
Pier-note	Gilt Mile brokers	face less a third	Brinehollow, Rim west	mortgage on unbuilt pier
Rouse-tab	Apothecary-General	0.3	Vigil, Rim east	worth less every year
Naming-right	Cradlewrack Tally	2 to 400	Cradlewrack	speculative
Sworn note	Oathen issuers	face value	Oathen, Rim east	discount with distance
Dry paper	anyone, anywhere	what honesty is worth	nowhere sensible	unsworn promises
Forsworn paper	the Breakdowns	0	as a joke	backed by what broke
Ration chit	The Pantry	1 to 3	the Fast	illegal to sell

BARTER

Most of the Table does not live on coin. Scrapling villages run on barter, and on the Rim a great deal of trade is goods against goods, with lacks used only to settle the difference.

- ◇ **Fair barter.** Goods trade at their listed price if both parties need them. Goods the buyer does not need are taken at half their value. Goods the buyer badly needs (oil in the Vigil, perfume in

Lastgate, sweet water in Brinehollow, anything edible in the Fast) are taken at one and a half times or double.

- ◇ **Regional goods travel well.** A good carried from its home land to a distant one is worth half again its home price on arrival, before any haggling. This is the whole business of the Rim Road.
- ◇ **Bartering with Partaking.** A character may not Partake to haggle with goods unless the god they carry is one the other party fears; the Tooth is felt, not seen, and merchants on the Rim know the look of a customer who is getting help.

- ◇ **Barter in the Fast.** The Unfed accept no gift and give none. A barter in the Fast must be declined three times by both parties before it is agreed on the fourth asking. Skipping the ritual voids the trade, and the offended party will not deal again.
- ◇ **Barter with the dead.** The Kept of Sallowreach own nearly everything and need almost nothing. They will barter only for what keeps them: thread, lacquer, cedar, vinegar, a reader for an evening, and news. A Kept landlord in Lastgate will take a season's rent in good gossip, provided it is new, and has been known to evict a tenant whose stories repeated.
- ◇ **Barter in Oathen.** An exchange of goods is an exchange of promises, and every promise binds. Oatheners barter by setting the goods side by side on a felt cloth, in silence, and adding to or taking from the piles until both parties stop moving their hands. Nobody says "done." A foreigner who says "done" in Tacit has sworn to it, and if a crate is short, something breaks.

▼ FINDING THINGS

Anything can be bought on the Rim Road. Not everything can be found.

– TOLL NINE PROVERB

AVAILABILITY

Every item in this chapter has an Availability rating. To find an item that is not simply sitting in front of the Guests, one character makes

a Grace Roll: **Eye** + **Haggle** against the difficulty below, modified by where they are looking. Other characters may help in the usual way. A character may Partake on the roll; the Tooth makes merchants talkative, or makes the searcher notice the stall behind the stall.

RATING	DIFFICULTY	SEARCH TIME	TYPICAL GOODS
Common	Routine 10	an hour	bread, knives, rope, lamp oil, perfume, rouse
Uncommon	Hard 14	half a day	swords, crossbows, mail, Kept-candles, laudanum
Scarce	Grim 18	a day	plate, Brinehollow tonic in the Fatlands, a Tucker
Rare	Dire 22	a week	godflesh, a Sayer's word, Blank parts
Unique	special	an adventure	named relics; never found by rolling alone

- ◇ **Success** means the item is for sale, at listed price, in this market. Each **Helping** may be spent to find a better example (one extra quality, or no hidden flaw), to find it cheaper (one step of price in the buyer's favour, see Hagglng), or to learn something about the seller.
- ◇ **Grace** means the seller is eager, or there is a second one, or the merchant offers something better that they "weren't going to show anyone."
- ◇ **Failure** means it is not here. The character may try again after the search time has passed again, at +2 difficulty for every retry

in the same market.

- ◇ **Lack** means the item is found, and it is wrong: stolen and recognisable, Tainted and undeclared, a fake, or sold by an informer. The Carver chooses, and does not say which until it matters. If it is a fake, roll on Counterfeit Goods, below.
- ◇ **Unique** items are never found with a roll. They are the end of a trail, the price of a favour, or the reward of an adventure.

WHERE YOU LOOK

WHERE	MODIFIER	NOTES
Item's home land	–4	a Netwatch boathook in Lowmark

WHERE	MODIFIER	NOTES
Neighbouring land on the Rim	+0	the next land around the ring
Far side of the Rim	+4	Fatlands meat in the Vigil
A capital or great Rim market	−2	Lastgate, Sated, Lowmark, Tacit, Kest, Gristmoot
A Company waystation	−1	a factor, a smithy and a market square
A Company post (every twenty miles)	+2	a slate of prices and a man who knows a man
A Scrapling village	+4	and Uncommon or better is not there at all
Inside the Fast	+8	nothing above Uncommon; nobody will sell to a Godeater
Black market	−4 for contraband	+50% price; see below
On Tablenight, anywhere	+4	half the stalls are shut and the rest are frightened
Cradlewrack, the day after a pang	−2 for stitching and locks, +2 for all else	the whole country is mending



*OPEN AFTER DARK. KNOCK THREE TIMES. IF
IT KNOCKS BACK, IT IS NOT US.*

PAINTED ON A SHUTTER AT KNOCKING GATE

BLACK MARKETS

Every city on the Table has a market that is not on the Company's ledgers. In Lastgate it is the undercity under the lowest pilings, the Sinks and Gutter Lane, where Marrow Jack's boys sell limbs off drying racks and the stalls are lit with fen-glow so that nobody has to see the faces of the goods. In Sated it is behind the rendering yards, where the gutters run warm and the trade is conducted by people standing ankle-deep in it. In Lowmark it is out on the Uncovered at low fog, and under the Mile itself, in the Underpier, where the pilings drip and the buyers come down ladders. In the Vigil it is the Slope, which is a black market with houses on it, and the Pinchmarket, where pain is sold by the pin. In Kest there are no locks, so the black market is simply wherever you are when somebody shuts the door, and the Odd Fold, in the western ravines, where Parts change hands for the price of a winter. In Tacit it is conducted entirely in Handtalk, which is held not to bind, and

which lately does; the Breakdowns, below, are louder and cheaper, and lie for sport. In the Fast there is only one black market, and it is the Crumb-Runners' handcarts, and everyone uses it and nobody admits it. On the Rim itself, the black market is behind the stockyards at Gristmoot, after Last Bell, and its stock is mostly people (see The Trade in People).

Finding a black market needs a contact or a Hard (14) Eye + Search roll. Contraband bought there costs one and a half times the listed price, or double if the goods are capital crimes in that land. Selling there pays half the listed price, since the fence carries the risk. A Lack on any black-market roll means the Wakers, the Netwatch, the Bailiff's men or the Echo-Wardens were already watching.



I don't sell what it is. I sell what it says on the barrel.

A BARRELSIDE FENCE, TO A BAILIFF, SHORTLY
BEFORE THE FUNNEL

CONTRABAND

What is a crime depends on where you stand. The table below lists the goods most often smuggled on the Rim. "Banned" means seizure and a fine; "Capital" means whatever that land does instead of killing people.

GOODS	BANNED IN	CAPITAL IN	NOTES
Rouse	Fatlands (as "a hunger-killer")	—	the Thin use it to fast
Bottled brine tonic	Vigil (since 639), Brinehollow	—	Dry Jonah's trade
Beds, pillows, soft mattresses	—	Vigil	burned in the square, with owner's nudger fined
Emetics, fasting draughts	—	Fatlands (treason)	Purgation goods
Unlicensed Closings	—	Sallowreach	the Court calls it theft
Bottled Hush-air	—	Sallowreach	a stolen license, by the jar
Kept limbs, seamed parts	Sallowreach (unless own family)	—	Marrow Jack's trade

GOODS	BANNED IN	CAPITAL IN	NOTES
Godflesh of any land	Oathen, the Fast	Sallowreach (Hand-line flesh)	legal in Fatlands if declared
Parts of Cradlewrack	Cradlewrack (Attendance claims all)	—	the Assemblers pay best
Blank bodies or parts	everywhere, nominally	the Fast (as murder)	the Second Table buys
Locks that hold	—	—	legal, but Cradlewrack taxes them as luxuries
Unsworn speech-scrolls	Oathen (since 640)	—	written words may bind now
Cooked food not carried in	the Fast	—	treated as Orrum's
Bait doctrine tracts	Sallowreach, Fatlands, Oathen, Vigil	—	gaining ground in all seven
Unlicensed salvage	Brinehollow	—	the Admiralty sells the licences
Lead weights for the Weighing	—	Fatlands (fraud of the vote)	Garrick Tripe's monopoly
Ration chits	the Fast	—	sold constantly; spat upon
Stones of the Hem	—	the Rim (theft of road)	made cargo

COUNTERFEIT GOODS

If it is cheap, it is false. If it is dear, it is false and you paid for the privilege.

— LOWMARK SPUR PROVERB

Fakes are the Rim's second trade, and in some markets its first. A character who buys from an unknown stall on a Lack, or from a black market, or from anyone the Carver judges to be a liar, may have bought a counterfeit. Spotting a fake before purchase is **Eye +**

Craft (for goods) or **Eye + Lore** (for relics and godflesh) against the item's Availability difficulty; a Helping reveals what the fake really is. Most fakes are discovered later, at the worst moment. When a counterfeit betrays its owner, roll a d20 or choose.

D20	THE FAKE	HOW IT BETRAYS YOU
1	A Netwatch anchoring rope, "Ropewalk-proved"	It is hemp over a core of salt-cured grass. It holds until the first true pull of the Calling, then parts in the night with a sound like a sigh, and the owner wakes at the waterline.
2	Lastgate cedar perfume	Pine resin and vinegar. It masks a Kept for an hour, not a day; then the smell comes through all at once, in the middle of the Court, and every Kept in the room turns to look.
3	A Wick Tallow candle	Plain mutton tallow with a hair in the wick. It does not lean toward the lighter. It gives no comfort. The family who bought it as Grandmother sits up with it all night and slowly understands she is not in it, and nobody knows where she is.
4	"Safe" Rim food, sworn untainted	Fatlands field-meat, boiled grey to hide the marbling. Taint 2 Hunger, discovered when the eater cannot stop.
5	Rouse-tabs, Crane's strain	Pressed soot and treacle. They hold for no time at all. The buyer blinks for the first time at the worst moment, mid-sentence, mid-stair, mid-fight, and comes back three paces away holding something.
6	A sworn note, Tacit paper	The Clausewright's thumbprint is a print of the forger's toe. When the bearer demands payment the issuer laughs, and nothing breaks; the bearer, if an Oathener, has just sworn in public that the note was good, and their own fingers begin to ache.
7	An Agnes Latch lock	One of Tamsin Keyless's copies. It holds, from the outside. Whatever the buyer meant to keep out was already in the room.
8	A mail shirt	Bone rings painted black. Armor 3 until the first hit with a Helping; then it bursts like a necklace, and the wearer is at Armor 0 and picking rings out of the wound.
9	Hand-line mittens	Ordinary wool, no lead in the lining. The Appetite-struck wearer closes something in their sleep: a door, a book, a child's eyes. The child wakes. Probably.
10	A Cutwright's reading, sealed	Copied from a dead man's ledger. It declares the buyer Cut 2. They are Cut 4, and the Reckoner who bought the same ledger knows it.

D20	THE FAKE	HOW IT BETRAYS YOU
11	A death-license minute	Coffin-wood, real; the signature forged. Presented with fifty-nine true minutes after eighty years of saving, it voids the crock. The family's great-great-grandmother goes back on the shelf, and she heard every word.
12	A naming-right, Kest exchange	Sold twice, to two families. When the year is out, both come to name the child, and the Attendance asks the Two Questions of the paper.
13	Orrum crumb, "picked off the cloth"	Stale Rim bread soaked in honey. It does nothing for the hunger. The starving pilgrim who spent everything on it walks into the Fast anyway, to find the real one.
14	A Hush-reed pipe or bottled Hush	A jar of ordinary fen air with a lead weight sewn into the base so it is "always slightly too heavy." Unstoppered at the moment of need, it lets out a puff of rot and flies.
15	Bottled brine tonic	Seawater from Saltwick, honestly salt and honestly useless. Worse: one bottle in ten is genuine bail-water from a Tenanted household, sold as fake by a man who did not know, and the buyer begins to dream of a long dim walk west.
16	A Blank's hair, sold as Wren Hollowell's	Hair from a Fatlands corpse, bleached. It does nothing. But the Board's bounty-men have been told who bought it, and they want to know where the rest of her is.
17	Kept-arm cudgel	A cattle-shank, wired and painted. It does not grip. It does not twitch at night. The buyer is disappointed, which is the most disturbing thing about the purchase, when they think about it later.
18	Caul sewn into a coat, "proof against the Calling"	It is a real caul. It does not work; none of them do. The fake is the promise, and the buyer stops tying the night-rope.
19	A Company platter	Resealed wax over a real shoulder blade. Presented at a Company house, the factor smiles, takes it, and calls the wardens. Theft of an oath; the rope at the post.
20	A relic of any kind	It is genuine. The fake was the seller, who was not the dealer he claimed but the relic's last owner, desperate to be rid of it, and he is very happy, and leaving town.

◇
Every fake on the Rim is real somewhere. That is how you can tell the good ones.

MISTER CUTLERY, CLOSING HIS CASE

BLACK-MARKET BUYERS

Selling contraband is harder than buying it, because the people who want to buy the Table's forbidden goods almost never want them for the reason they give. When the Guests try to sell something illegal, monstrous or holy, roll a d20 or choose a buyer. The buyer pays the black-market rate (half the listed price) unless noted, and what they say they want is always believable.

D20	THE BUYER	WHAT THEY SAY	WHAT THEY REALLY WANT
1	A soft-voiced woman in a good grey coat, Rim accent	"For my collection."	To learn where it came from, exactly, for a ledger the Second Table keeps of every god by the portion. She pays triple if the seller names a place.
2	A Cutwright with calipers	"For study."	The seller. She measures their skull while they count the money and writes a name in the separate book.
3	A Kept matron of Lastgate, very old	"For my grandson's restitching."	To be finished. She wants anything that ends things, and if the goods cannot, she wants the seller's name, because a seller of such goods may know a Closer.
4	A heavy, kind Fatlands cook	"For the table."	To eat it, whatever it is. He has eaten something of every land. He is still hungry, and he is beginning to feel the seven of them disagree inside him.
5	A Purgation brother with a brown bowl at his belt	"To destroy it."	To destroy it, honestly; and then to destroy the seller's god, by the Draught, and he will follow them for three days with the bowl, asking.
6	A young Heir of Sallowreach	"For the cause."	A way to make his father die. He will pay anything, and he has nothing, and he has already sworn to pay on the bones of his mother, who is upright, and listening.
7	A Vigil apothecary's runner, eyes like split plums	"For the Bitterhouse."	To cut it into rouse, to see if it works. If it is godflesh, it will, for a season, and a district of the Slope will dream of whatever land it came from.
8	A Reckoner, plainly dressed, buying nothing else	"For the Abstinent."	To find out who sold it, and who sold it to them, back up the chain to a high-Cut house. She pays honestly, in good coin she will not touch with bare hands.
9	A Brinehollow shipwright's agent	"Ballast."	For the Follow, Dagna Hull's iron vessel: anything that sinks, anything that pulls down. She is building a ship to go somewhere water is going, and she wants it to know the way.

D20	THE BUYER	WHAT THEY SAY	WHAT THEY REALLY WANT
10	An Oathen paper-broker	"To hold."	Leverage. If the goods are illegal in Oathen, the broker now has a sworn witness to their sale, and the seller's name on a slate, and the seller will hear from him again.
11	A Cradlewrack woman with something under her shawl	"For my little one."	Something to feed what she bore. It is not a child. It is very hungry, and it likes the taste of gods.
12	A Company Auditor in plain clothes	"No reason."	To price the item and the seller's land with it; the purchase goes into Lysander Coyle's real ledger as one more figure on the collapse of somewhere.
13	A Tablebreaker, axe on her back, sweating in Rim heat	"To break it."	She does, before the seller's eyes, without paying. Then she lays down the price in grain, declines their thanks three times, and leaves.
14	An Assembler factor, smelling of warm barn	"For the Barn."	It is a piece, and the figure needs pieces. If the goods are flesh, they will fit, wherever they are from, and the Assemblers have begun to wonder what that means.
15	A tall, stooping servant in a clean apron	"For the house."	To lay it at a table. He pays in warm bread, very good, and will not take no three times, only twice.
16	A Second Helping lay-sister, radiant	"To share."	To be eaten with it: she wants the seller to dine with her, tonight, and she has a knife and a great deal of herself still to give.
17	A Netwatch lieutenant, off duty	"For evidence."	For her own Calling, which she has hidden for a year. She wants to know what the Called hear. If the goods are brine, she drinks it in the alley.
18	A Fast pilgrim, starving, carrying everything she owns	"Anything. Anything."	Fullness. She pays with the last of what she has and will try to eat whatever it is, even if it is a stone.
19	A pedlar who is plainly the seller's own double	"I've been looking for this."	Nobody knows. He pays exactly what was asked, without haggling, and walks away into the crowd in the seller's own coat. The seller is not wearing their coat.
20	A child, alone, very polite	"For my father."	Her father is the dealer who sold the item to the Guests, or the person it was cut from. She has followed it for a hundred miles. She has his eyes. She has his money. She would like it back.



*Who's buying? Nobody's buying. Who's selling?
Nobody's selling. What's it cost? Everything, love.
Mind the gutter.*

PATTER BEHIND THE RENDERING YARDS, SATED

▼ HAGGLING

The price is what you pay. The cost is what it does to you afterward.

— RENDERERS' UNION PROVERB

Listed prices are opening prices. When a character wants to argue, the buyer rolls **Tongue + Haggle** opposed by the seller's Tongue + Haggle (or Threat, for minor merchants). The higher total wins. Ties favour the seller; it is their stall.

Price moves in steps of one-tenth of the listed price. The winner shifts the price one step in their favour, plus one step for each Helping (count Helpings from the loser's total, not from a fixed Difficulty). Price cannot fall below half or rise above double the listed price by haggling alone. A Grace for the buyer adds a small thing thrown in (a heel of bread, a name, a warning); a Lack for the

buyer means they have offended the seller, who will not deal again today and will tell the next stall.

- ◇ **Regional tempers.** Sallowreach merchants have centuries of patience and are at +2 to resist haste. Fatlanders haggle while eating and are at −2 if the buyer refuses to eat with them, +2 if the buyer finishes the plate. Brinehollowers stop mid-haggle to bail and are not to be hurried. Vigil sellers are short-tempered and hallucinating; a buyer who pinches them first is at +1. Cradlewrack sellers knock on the counter before every offer.

- ◇ **Haggling in Oathen.** Every offer in Oathen is a promise. A buyer who says “I’ll pay six” has sworn it. Oatheners haggle in conditionals (“If six were mentioned, it would not be refused”) and a foreigner who does not is at -2 and is also likely to break something. A buyer who hires a licensed price-witness (1 crumb a word, a good one uses twenty) haggles at +2 and swears nothing. The Rule of Oathen holds only inside Oathen’s borders (and on Oatheners abroad who have reached the Course), but Oatheners on the Rim haggle in conditionals anyway, from habit and from fear, and the price-witness’s bonus applies wherever one can be hired.
- ◇ **Haggling in the Fast.** No price may be accepted until it has been declined three times. A character who forgets is at -4 on any further dealing that day.

HELPINGS AND PRICE AT A GLANCE

Opposed Haggle: the winner moves the price one tenth in their favour, and one more tenth per Helping of margin. Floor half, ceiling double. A buyer who Partakes and rolls a 1 on the Tooth has let the god show at the counter: the seller sees it, and the price goes up a step for fear, or down two for awe, as fits the god.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY: A CROSSBOW AT GRISTMOOT

What follows is a short shopping scene from a game in progress, showing Availability, opposed Haggling, Partaking at the counter and the Fast’s decline. The Carver is running the market at Gristmoot on a Moot-day (see Market Day at Gristmoot, below). There are three players. Jo plays **Bryony Kettle**, a Brinehollow Factor (Eye 3, Tongue 3, Haggle 3, Cut 2, Hunger 2). Sam plays **Refrain Dunn**, an Unfed Crumb-Runner (Cut 0, Tongue 2, Haggle 2). Priya plays **Peregrine Asch**, an Oathen Clausewright (Tongue 4, Haggle 2, Clause 3).

Carver: Gristmoot on the full Plate. Three miles of stalls, the smell of gravy and woodsmoke and horse, and somewhere ahead of you the Weighhouse bell has just rung. You’ve each been given a Stranger’s Loaf at the inn door, hot, and you can feel the whole street watching to see if you eat it.

Jo: Bryony eats hers. She’s practical.

Carver: Fatlands bread is toothed wheat, milled or not. Taint 1 Hunger.

Jo: Hunger 3, then. I want a crossbow before we go over the Hem tomorrow.

Carver: A crossbow is Uncommon, so Hard, 14. Gristmoot’s a great Rim market, so minus 2: you need 12. It’s not anybody’s home land in particular. Eye plus Haggle.

Jo: Eye 3, Haggle 3. *(rolls)* Eight and three. Eleven plus six is seventeen.

Carver: That beats 12 by five: one Helping. You find a crossbow at the listed 50 lacks. What do you want the Helping for?

Jo: To know something about the seller.

Carver: He’s Abner Wedge, an arms-man on the Foreign Row, broad as a door. A boy at the next stall tells you, for a crumb, that a quiet woman in grey bought six bolts off Abner at dawn and paid in coin she held through her sleeve. Abner has been in a very good mood ever since.

Priya: A Reckoner. Lovely.

Jo: Fifty is too much. I’ll haggle.

Carver: Abner’s eating, of course. He pushes a plate of brawn in jelly across the counter at you, and the jelly is still faintly moving with somebody’s pulse. Fatlanders haggle at minus 2 against a buyer who refuses to eat, plus 2 if the buyer finishes the plate.

Jo: Bryony finishes the plate. *(groans from the table)* It’s work.

Carver: Fatlands meat is Taint 1 Hunger. Mark it.

Jo: Hunger 4. And I’ll Partake on the haggle as well. I want this crossbow.

Carver: Plus 1 Hunger for Partaking, and roll the Tooth with your 2d10.

Jo: Hunger 5. Tongue 3, Haggle 3, plus 2 for the plate. *(rolls)* Six and six! And the Tooth is a 1.

Carver: Doubles on a success, if it is a success, would be a Grace. The Tooth showing 1 is another point of Hunger: the god bit back. What’s your total?

Jo: Twelve plus eight is twenty, plus the 1 is twenty-one. Hunger 6.

Carver: Abner has Threat 4. *(rolls)* Five and four, nine, thirteen. You win by eight. Count Helpings from his total: two full fours, two Helpings. So the price moves one step, plus two, three steps of five lacks: thirty-five. But the 1 on the Tooth means the god showed at the counter. Describe it.

Jo: Brine. She coughs, and it isn’t the dawn bail, and it comes up cold and green and runs down her chin, and it smells like a long way down.

Carver: Abner stops chewing. Fatlanders don’t fear much, but they fear the sea, which is the one thing on the Table that cannot be eaten. Fear, not awe: one step back up. Forty lacks. And your doubles were a success, so a Grace: something thrown in. Abner leans close, mouth full, and says, very low, that the woman in grey asked him which inn the Gut-line wool-buyers sleep at, and he told her, and he’d like someone to know he’s sorry. He gives you two bolts for nothing.

Jo: Forty, then. Done.

Sam: While she’s doing that, Refrain has to buy grain. A week’s worth. We’re going into the Fast and he won’t eat what he didn’t

carry.

Carver: Plenty of grain at Gristmoot; it's Common, you find it at once. The grocer is a cheerful Fatlands girl called Dimity who has never met one of the Unfed. She says "Lovely. Two lacks the sack, and have a sweet bun while you wait."

Sam: "No, thank you."

Carver: "Oh, go on."

Sam: "No, thank you."

Carver: "It's free, my love. Look at you. You're all bones."

Sam: "No, thank you." And then he waits for the fourth offer, because that's manners.

Carver: Dimity doesn't make a fourth offer. She's a Fatlander: three refusals of food is the worst insult she's ever received. She looks as if you've slapped her. Roll your haggle, and you're at minus 2 for refusing to eat with her.

Sam: Tongue 2, Haggle 2, minus 2. (*rolls*) One and one.

Table: Oh no.

Carver: Licked Clean. A Lack. Dimity will not deal with you again today, and she tells the next stall, and the next. Gristmoot's a long market and word travels faster than you walk. By noon every grain-seller on the Bakers' Mile knows there is a thin man who refuses bread three times, and some of them have worked out what that means.

Priya: Peregrine steps in. I hire a price-witness to buy the grain for us. A crumb a word.

Carver: That gets you plus 2 and you're not in Oathen, so nothing you say binds, but Peregrine speaks in conditionals anyway,

out of habit. Who are you buying from? Not Dimity.

Priya: Two stalls down, before the word reaches them.

Carver: Roll it. The new grocer is Threat 3.

Priya: Tongue 4, Haggle 2, plus 2. (*rolls*) Nine and two, eleven, plus eight, nineteen.

Carver: (*rolls*) Seven and five, twelve, fifteen. You win by four: one step, plus one Helping, two steps. The sack is 1 lack 6 crumbs. The witness used eleven words, so add eleven crumbs; Peregrine is a Clausewright and knows exactly which four of them were unnecessary. And there's a man watching from across the Row: heavy jowls, beautiful teeth, smelling of woodsmoke and roast fat. He watched Refrain refuse the bun. He's smiling.

Sam: Refrain's seen that smile before.

Carver: He lifts his cup to you. Kale Dragoman drinks here. Then he asks, across the street, if you'd all like supper tonight. He asks three times.

In this scene the Carver uses the market to do three things at once: settle a price, plant two threats (a Reckoner on the road, a poacher at the inn), and make the cost of each purchase physical: Bryony is three points hungrier for a ten-lack saving and has let the god show in public; Refrain has been marked by his manners. That is what a market scene is for.



*Don't eat with him. Don't refuse him. Don't let him ask
four times.*

GRISTMOOT ADVICE TO THE UNFED, GIVEN TOO
LATE

▼ MARKET DAY AT GRISTMOOT

Come for a week. Everyone does.

— THE GRISTMOOT WELCOME, SAID AT EVERY INN DOOR WITH THE
STRANGER'S LOAF



Gristmoot is the great market town on the Rim Road at the Fatlands' eastern gate, where the road comes down out of the dry red country of Oathen and meets the first green fields. It is a Company town in all but name: inns, warehouses, stockyards, toll-houses, the Weighhouse, and the longest market on the Rim, three miles of stalls along the road where Fatlands meat and bread are sold to every land and the money of every land comes in. It is loud, crowded, mercenary and cheerful. It smells of woodsmoke, sausage, horse and hot fat, and from the east, dust. It is the place where most

travellers first taste Fatlands bread, and the place where a great many first stop being able to leave.

The market is open every day but Tablenight. Twice a month, on the full Plate and on the licked-clean Plate, it is a **Moot-day**, and the stalls double: the drovers bring the herds in from the south, the Oathen paper-brokers come down from Mumchance with their spyglasses, the Vigil glass-sellers arrive red-eyed off the plateau road, and the population of the town triples between dawn and noon.

THE ROWS

- ◇ **The Weighhouse and the Gate.** At the eastern gate stands the Company's toll-house and, beside it, a public scale on a gibbet-frame, where **Toll-Reeve Bastable Crumb** weighs every foreigner who enters and every foreigner who leaves, and chalks the difference on a board outside. It is always a gain.
- ◇ **Gravy Row.** The first half-mile: cookshops, sausage-stalls, roast-pits, brawn-sellers and Mardy Haunch's stall, the widest on the Rim. Smoke hangs at head height. The cobbles are slick with drip-fat and the dogs are enormous.
- ◇ **The Bakers' Mile.** Toothed bread, clatter-cake for Vigil buyers, kelp-bread for the west, Unfed ration-loaves baked of Rim flour for the Crumb-Runners, who buy at the far end and are not served at the near one.
- ◇ **Foreign Row.** Every land's stalls in a long jostling line: Seamers' booths with fingers on cork boards, Brinehollow rope and buckets, Vigil lenses and pins, Cradlewrack wool and knocker's rings, Oathen felt and bits. Arms-men like Abner Wedge keep the middle of it.
- ◇ **The Paper Bench.** A long table under an awning where the Oathen brokers sit in silence, buying and selling sworn notes by slate and nod.
- ◇ **Cure-Sellers' Lane.** A crooked side street of booths selling "safe" food, cures, charms and relics to frightened foreigners. Almost everything here is false. The rest is worse.
- ◇ **The Stockyards.** A mile of pens at the western end, where Sal Trotter's herds and every other drover's come in. The beasts are walked through a stone race and stamped. Some of the herds sing.

- ◇ **Behind the Stockyards.** After Last Bell, a second market opens in the yards. Its stock stands in the pens. See The Trade in People.

THE BELLS OF THE MOOT

The Company rings the Moot by bells from the Weighhouse tower. **First Bell**, at dawn, opens the gate and the scale. **Grace Bell**, at noon, stops every stall for the space of the grace: three miles of people turn toward the nearest stranger and say "Lack keep away," and then everyone eats, because this is the Fatlands, and the Feasting Laws apply even to foreigners. **Weighing Bell** in mid-afternoon is when the drovers' herds are weighed at the race. **Last Bell**, at dusk, closes the lawful market. Any stall still trading after Last Bell is either a cookshop or behind the stockyards.

◇ HOT LOAF FREE AT THE DOOR. WAGERS TAKEN.

CHALKED BY THE DOOR OF THE FULL MEASURE,
GRISTMOOT

BASTABLE CRUMB, TOLL-REEVE OF GRISTMOOT

Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (sword 4, Parrying) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · Haggle 4; weighs every stranger twice and has never once posted a loss

ON THE NEXT STALL

When the Guests wander the Moot, roll a d12 for what they pass, or use it for any great Rim market.

D12	THE STALL	THE PATTERN	THE CATCH
1	A Fatlands pie-man	"Pies, pies, pies with a face on the crust, and inside, well, ask the crust!"	The faces are pressed from a mould. One mould is newer than the others and is of a man who was weighed in at the gate last week.
2	A Fogmouth tinker with a grey left hand	"Mend your pots, mend your locks, mend your mother, reasonable."	The hand is his Kept father's, sewn on at the wrist in Lastgate. South of the Drop it should have finished. It has not. It does the fine work, and lately it does it at night, on its own.
3	A Vigil pin-seller	"Pins! Pins! Stay awake, stay alive, stay away from beds!"	She has been awake nine days. She sees the customers' faces as someone else's. She is sure it is the customers who are wrong.
4	A Brinehollow rope-wife	"Proved hemp, ten fathoms, knot-tied free, and I'll tie you to your sweetheart for a crumb."	Her own rope was cut in the night two years ago. She sells to everyone heading west.
5	A Cradlewrack wool-pedlar	(knocks on the counter) "Red wool, warm wool, wool that grew in a night."	Some of the fleeces have hands sewn into the lining by the shearers, who could not bear to throw them away.
6	An Oathen bit-seller	(says nothing; points to a slate: CHILDREN'S, LEATHER, 4 L. IRON, 25. ASK ABOUT SILVER.)	One silver bit on the back of the board is dented with tooth-marks from the inside.
7	A cure-seller	"Safe food! Sworn safe! Not a crumb of the god in it, on my mother's bones!"	His mother's bones are in the stew. He is, technically, not lying.
8	A Seamer's booth	"Thread, wire, lacquer, fingers!"	The boy who cries it was sold to the Seamer for a debt, and his voice was stitched wrong on purpose so he cannot be understood when he asks people for help.

D12	THE STALL	THE PATTER	THE CATCH
9	A drover's boy with a single beast on a rope	"Good beast, good milk, walks itself home."	It walks itself home at night on two legs, to a village in Low Tilth, and stands outside a cottage looking at the window.
10	A Purgation pedlar	"Bring it up, brothers, bring it up! What goes down can come up!"	Some of what comes up at his stall is not food, and he has begun to keep it in a jar.
11	A Crumb-Runner's handcart at the far end	(nothing; an Unfed boy stands by it and declines to sell to anyone who asks only once)	He is buying, not selling: chits for grain, at three lacks, and he weeps while he does it.
12	An empty stall with a clean white cloth on the counter	(no patter; a smell of fresh bread)	Nobody rents it. Nobody remembers it being put up. The Moot-reeve's men walk round it and do not look.

MARKET DAY

From the daybook of Ysolde Brane, lens-grinder of Lampwrights' Row in the Vigil, who went down to Gristmoot in Plenty 640 to sell spectacles, for a week. The book was found in the lining of a coat sold at the Gristmoot rag-stall in Carving 641. The hand changes toward the end.

FIRST BELL. *They weigh you at the gate. I did not know. There is a scale on a frame like a gallows and a Company man with a face like a ham and a beautiful clean ledger, and you stand on the plate in front of everybody, and he writes you down. Eight stone four. He said it to the street. A great woman with a sausage-stall laughed and said, "Not for long, my love," and everyone near her laughed too, and it was kind laughter, the kindest I have heard in my life, and I wanted to put a needle through my hand. I did. It helped.*

BEFORE GRACE. *At the inn they gave me a loaf at the door. Hot. Free. Everyone watched me hold it. I did not eat it. I am writing this with it beside me on the bench and it is still warm, and it has been an hour. On the Lid nothing is warm unless it is burning. My nudger is a Gristmoot girl hired for the week at two lacks a day; she does not understand the work. She keeps asking why I don't just have a nap. She says it with such love. I have told her the rule. She said, "But that's up there."*

GRACE BELL. *Three miles of people stopped all at once and turned to face the nearest stranger and said the grace. The stranger nearest me was a tinker from the north with a dead man's hand sewn on at his wrist, grey to the elbow, with flies on it, and as he said "Lack keep away" to me the hand made the sign of the grace by itself, a little after him, like an echo. Then everyone ate. A Bailiff with a ladle came down the Row checking that the foreigners were eating. I ate the loaf. It had a tooth in it. I kept the tooth.*

AFTERNOON. *Sold eleven pairs. Fatlanders do not need spectacles; they buy them to be polite, and wear them pushed up on their foreheads. The pie-man next to me sells pies with*

faces on the crust, and I have been watching the faces all afternoon. Faces are my trade; I grind glass so people can see them. One of the moulds is new. The face on it is the man who was weighed in ahead of me this morning, a cloth-merchant from Tacit, very thin, who said nothing on the scale at all. I asked the pie-man where the new mould came from. He said a man sells him moulds, behind the stockyards, and winked, and gave me a pie.

WEIGHING BELL. *The herds came in. The drovers walk them through a stone race to be stamped, and some of the herds were singing, low, in thirds, the way the Bedded sing on the Slope, and the drovers do not look round. One beast stopped in the race and looked at me through my own spectacles. It was wearing them. Someone had sold it a pair. I have not been awake long enough for this. I have been awake exactly long enough for this. On the Lid we would enter it in the record.*

LAST BELL. *My nudger went home at dusk. She kissed my forehead. I am in a room with a bed in it. There is a bed in every room in Gristmoot; there is nothing else to sit on. I am sitting on the floor with my back against the studded side of my own coat and the pin through my hand and the bed is there in the corner of my eye like a lake. I know it is safe. Here, it is safe. Sleep is safe in the Fatlands; you lie down and you get up. I know that the way you know the sea is wet. I have not slept in nineteen years.*

LATER. *There are sounds from behind the stockyards. An auction. I can hear the numbers. They are high numbers for cattle. One lot went for four hundred lacks and the crowd clapped, and then a voice I knew, the thin cloth-merchant from Tacit, said, very clearly, in the conditional, "If it were permitted, I would decline," and nobody laughed, and the auctioneer said, "Not here, sir. Not here," and the next number was called.*

LATER. *I ate the pie.*

LATER. *The bed.*

THE FOURTH DAY. *Twelve stone one. The great woman at the sausage-stall clapped. I slept. I slept from Last Bell to First Bell and nothing looked at me and I did not go anywhere, and when I woke it was light, real light, from a window, not a lamp, and I wept for an hour, and the girl came in and held me and said there, there, my love, you see, and gave me a hot loaf. I have sold no spectacles since Moot-day. I have not opened the case.*

A WEEK. *The wager at the inn door was won by the house. I do not mind. Everyone here is so kind. A man with beautiful teeth bought me supper last night; he asked three times, which*

I gather is a joke here. He asked me whether I knew anyone, back on the Lid, who had been born able to sleep. I said, as it happens, yes. He wrote it down.

CARVING. *fourteen stone. i do not need spectacles. faces are all the same. the pie-man says I have a good face for a mould*



*You look heavy. You look heavy. You look heavy, dear.
Have a bun.*

A GRISTMOOT GREETING, OVERHEARD ELEVEN
TIMES IN ONE WALK DOWN GRAVY ROW

▼ T A I N T

Never eat the god twice. Once is history. Twice is a habit.

– PURGATION CATECHISM

Some goods are made from the gods. Bread from toothed wheat is grown in Ummer’s flesh. Bottled brine is the Fathom coughed up by its eaters. A Kept-candle is Ossel’s long refusal to finish, rendered into tallow. These goods carry **Taint**: the residue of the god, which goes on working in whoever uses them.

Taint is written as a rating from 1 to 5 and a kind: **Hunger**, **Regrowth**, or **Dread**. An item may carry more than one kind (for example, “Taint 2 Hunger, 1 Dread”). Taint takes hold **on use**: once each time the item is eaten or drunk; once per scene it is wielded in anger, or burned, or opened; once per day it is worn against the skin; and once each time a relic’s power is called on.

- ◇ **Hunger Taint.** The user gains Hunger equal to the rating, exactly as though they had Partaked. No roll. If this takes Hunger to 10, Regrowth rises as normal.
- ◇ **Regrowth Taint.** The user makes a Caul + Resolve roll against the matching difficulty: Taint 1 Routine 10, 2 Hard 14, 3 Grim 18, 4 Dire 22, 5 Impossible 26. On success, they gain 1 Hunger. On failure, they gain 1 Regrowth directly. On a Lack, they also gain the item’s land’s Want for a day, even if it is not their land.
- ◇ **Dread Taint.** The user makes a Dread check at the rating’s Dread level, because the thing is horrible to use (a candle that whimpers; a loaf that bites back). Repeated use of the same item lowers Dread Taint by 1 after the first five uses, to a minimum of 1. One gets used to things.

Foreign gods. Godflesh from a land not your own carries a god you did not eat. Taint from a foreign god is not reduced by any Gift of your own Regrowth, and on a failed Regrowth Taint roll the gained point of Regrowth is marked as foreign: the Carver may spend a

foreign point at any time to give the character that land’s Taste-stage tell for a scene. Characters who mix gods in their blood are the reason the trade in cures never ends and never works.

The Unfed and the Blank. A character with Cut 0 ignores Hunger Taint; there is nothing in them to be hungry. Regrowth Taint is worse. Each failed Regrowth Taint roll gives a Cut 0 character one mark of **Seasoning**; at three marks, the meat has found what it was looking for, and the character gains Cut 1 in that god’s line, permanently. Tobias Wether and the Reckoner called Scour each have three marks.

Declaring Taint. In the Fatlands the law requires godflesh to be declared and stamped. Nowhere else does. A seller who knows the Taint will rarely say so; a Hard (14) Eye + Lore roll identifies the kind and rating of an item’s Taint, and a Grim (18) roll identifies which god. Rim folk have cruder tests, all of which work about as often as chance: a Tainted loaf is said to be warmer on the side facing the eater, a Tainted coin to turn in the palm toward the land it came from, Tainted meat to cook a little faster on the side away from the fire.

Purging. A Purgation emetic (see Drugs) taken within an hour of eating Tainted food removes the Hunger it caused. Nothing removes Regrowth that Taint has given.



*STAMPED AND DECLARED. TAIN T ONE. GOOD
FOR GROWING CHILDREN.*

BOARD OF PLENTY PLACARD, NAILED OVER EVERY
BREAD·BIN IN SAT ED

▼ COST OF LIVING

The rich smell of cedar. The poor smell of themselves.

– LASTGATE SAYING

A character's lifestyle covers food, lodging, clothes and small expenses. Pay it by the day, the week (seven days) or the season (ninety days, at a tenth off).

LIFESTYLE	PER DAY	PER SEASON	WHAT IT BUYS	EFFECT
Destitute	1 L	80 L	a ditch, a crust, the clothes you stand in	no Fray recovery; +1 Hunger each week
Modest	3 L	250 L	a shared room, two meals, a clean shirt	normal recovery
Comfortable	8 L	650 L	a room of one's own, wine, a servant's help	–1 Fray each week of rest
Lavish	25+ L	2,000+ L	a house, a cook, the best perfume, a nudger	–2 Fray each week; +2 to Persuade high society

Characters who live below modest for a season lose 1 Flesh maximum until they recover a full season at modest or better. Characters who live lavishly in any land are noticed: by the Cutwrights, who will want to know their Cut, and by the Reckoners, who already do.

What “modest” means changes at every border. A modest life in Lastgate is a rented corner of a house owned by somebody's great-great-grandfather, who sits in the best chair and must be asked before the shutters are opened. In Sated it is five meals a day and a tent-coat let out every season. In Lowmark it is a room on the Middle Mile with a ring in the floor and ten cups of sweet water a

day for a household that needs twenty. In the Vigil it is a standing strap in a waking-house and two-fifths of your wage gone on rouse. In Kest it is a bricked room at night and a neck-kit of needle and gut for the morning. In Tacit it is a cistern-share and the silence of the galleries. In Wanting it is a name on the list, which is everything, until it is not.

REGIONAL COSTS

Every land adds costs that nowhere else would understand. These are in addition to lifestyle.

EXPENSE	LAND	COST	NOTES
Keeping a Kept relative	Sallowreach	2 L a week	perfume, vinegar, thread, a chair by the fire
Spring restitching (one Kept)	Sallowreach	15 L a year	Seamer's fee; more if limbs are missing
Setting Aside	Sallowreach	40 L once, 1 L a season	wrapping, labelling, a shelf in the Lofts
The Tenancy	Sallowreach	a tenth of earnings	rent to the Unvacated owner of your house, as your grandparents paid
The fly-tax	Sallowreach	1 c a fly, assessed	counted on the outside of the glass each Plenty
The Feasting Laws (five meals)	Fatlands	+2 L a day	travellers must comply; Bailiffs inspect inns
Funeral wake (serving the dead)	Fatlands	10 L	cook's fee; the family brings the dead
The Lean Levy	Fatlands	1 to 5 L a year	falls a crumb for every pound you weigh
Bail-bucket and rope	Brinehollow	5 c a day	wear and tear; anchoring at night
Parish bailer (if too weak)	Brinehollow	2 bail-tokens a day	a child, usually
The Pier Tithe	Brinehollow	1 L in 10 a season	toward the Chase; work it off on the Raw Mile
Rouse at current dose	Vigil	3 L a day	rising every season
A hired nudger (child)	Vigil	2 L a day	hourly rates on the Slope
A wake-valet (skilled)	Vigil	10 L a day	Jack Tenterhook charges 40
The Bed-Due	Vigil	1 L a season per Counted	for ever; three seasons behind and the visiting stops

EXPENSE	LAND	COST	NOTES
Bricking-in (nightly mason)	Cradlewrack	4 c a night	mortar, a mason at dusk and dawn
Attendance birth-fee	Cradlewrack	12 L	compulsory; the knife is included
Clausewright's daily review	Oathen	1 L a day	someone to check what you will say
Niche-rent for the dead	Oathen	2 L a year	20 L in the upper galleries
Pantry dues	the Fast	one chit a day	if you are on the list
Rim Road tolls	the Rim	1 c a post on foot, 2 c a wheel, 1 c a head	a lack a post per hundredweight; Company bridges a lack each; Breath Toll 5 L at the Course



*Your father is upright. Your father owns the chair.
Your father would like the window shut.*

HEIRS' PAMPHLET, POSTED ON THE LANDING,
LASTGATE

▼ ARMS AND ARMOUR

There is no gunpowder on the Table. There are a great many hooks.

– NETWATCH DRILL-SERGEANT'S OPENING REMARK

Damage is listed in brackets. Attack with melee weapons is Hand + Blades (or Brawl for fists, clubs and grapples). Ranged weapons use Hand + Shooting. Weapons marked with a land are Common there and one step rarer everywhere else.

Every land's weapons are tools first. The Table has fought few wars since the Gorging, because the lands that could fight cannot cross borders and the lands that could cross borders have nothing worth taking; its killing is done with the instruments of its trades. A Seamer's awl goes through a skull as neatly as through a Kept cheek. A boathook brings a Called man home or pulls a living one off a pier. A Waker's needle keeps you awake, and keeps you awake, and keeps you awake. Arms-men on the Rim sell by land and by trade, and a buyer who asks for "a weapon" is shown a cleaver.



*NEEDLES. HOLLOW. DIPPED. ONE LACK OFF IF
YOU SAY WHO IT'S FOR.*

SLATE IN THE PINCHMARKET, THE VIGIL

WEAPON AND ARMOUR QUALITIES

- ◇ **Brutal.** Each Helping on a hit adds +3 damage instead of +2.
- ◇ **Concealable.** Finding it on a body takes a Hard (14) Eye + Search roll.

- ◇ **Entangling.** On a hit with at least one Helping, the target is held instead of taking the Helping's damage: they cannot move away and are at –2 Guard until they spend an action and succeed at a Hard (14) Gut + Athletics roll.
- ◇ **Fragile.** On a Lack, the weapon breaks.
- ◇ **Heavy.** Needs Gut 3 or more to use without penalty; otherwise –2 Attack. The wielder is at –1 Guard.
- ◇ **Hooking.** On a hit with at least one Helping, the attacker may give up the Helping's damage to drag the target one pace, pull them off a ledge or mount, tear away a held item, or knock them prone (the target may resist with a Hard 14 Lung + Athletics roll).
- ◇ **Light.** Can be used in the off hand; +1 Attack against a held or prone target.
- ◇ **Noisy.** Everyone within a long stone's throw hears it used. In the Vigil, this is considered good manners. In Oathen, where an echo can bind, it is a provocation.
- ◇ **Parrying.** +1 Guard against melee attacks while held ready.
- ◇ **Piercing.** Ignores 1 point of Armor.
- ◇ **Reach.** Strikes from two paces away. A foe closing to arm's length is attacked first.
- ◇ **Ripping.** If the hit deals 3 or more damage after Armor, the wound bleeds: the target loses 1 Flesh at the end of each round until someone succeeds at a Routine (10) Hand + Stitching roll.

In Sallowreach a Ripping wound never closes without stitching, ever. In Cradlewrack it closes and reopens at the next pang.

- ◇ **Silent.** Makes no sound in use; attacks from hiding gain +2.
- ◇ **Slow.** Reloading takes a full action.
- ◇ **Stunning.** On a hit with a Helping, the target loses their next action unless they succeed at a Hard (14) Gut + Endure roll.
- ◇ **Thrown.** Can be thrown up to ten paces with Hand + Shooting.
- ◇ **Two-Handed.** Needs both hands.
- ◇ **Waking.** A Vigil quality. A creature struck cannot blink, sleep or fall unconscious for the rest of the scene, even at 0 Flesh, and feels everything.
- ◇ **Tainted.** The item is made from godflesh and carries Taint as listed (see Taint).

MELEE WEAPONS

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	STATS	NOTES
Fist, boot, teeth	—	—	(1)	Brawl; teeth are Ripping in the Fatlands
Knife	3 L	Common	(2) Light, Concealable, Thrown	everyone carries one
Club, cudgel	1 L	Common	(3) Stunning	a table leg, mostly
Cleaver	6 L	Common	(3) Ripping	butcher's; the Fatlands sidearm
Hatchet	5 L	Common	(3) Thrown	
Spear	12 L	Common	(4) Reach, Two-Handed	
Axe	20 L	Common	(4) Brutal	
Sword	60 L	Uncommon	(4) Parrying	an officer's or a noble's
Maul	35 L	Uncommon	(5) Heavy, Stunning, Two-Handed	
Poleaxe	70 L	Uncommon	(5) Reach, Hooking, Two-Handed	
Renderer's greatcleaver	55 L	Uncommon	(6) Heavy, Brutal, Ripping, Two-Handed	Fatlands; jointing whole oxen
Jointer's knife	6 L	Common	(2) Ripping, Light	Fatlands; for carving the dead at their wake
Seamer's awl	4 L	Common	(2) Piercing, Silent, Light	Sallowreach; a stitching tool that goes through a skull
Loft-Warden's shelving hook	8 L	Uncommon	(3) Hooking, Reach	Sallowreach; for lifting the Set-Aside down
Sump-pole	6 L	Common	(3) Reach, Stunning, Two-Handed	Sallowreach; for pushing sacks under, and keeping them there
Lead mitten	25 L	Scarce	(3) Stunning	Sallowreach; made for Hand-lines; blocks a Closing touch
Netwatch boathook	15 L	Common	(4) Hooking, Reach, Two-Handed	Brinehollow; for bringing people home
Dry Fleet cutlass	45 L	Uncommon	(4) Parrying	Brinehollow; drilled with daily, never once wet
Tide-bell clapper	10 L	Uncommon	(4) Noisy, Stunning, Heavy	Brinehollow; stolen from a bell
Waker's needle	6 L	Common	(2) Piercing, Waking, Concealable	Vigil; a foot of steel, hollow, rouse-dipped
Rattle-staff	8 L	Common	(2) Noisy, Stunning	Vigil; a Waker's rattle on an ash haft
Wake-valet's pincers	12 L	Uncommon	(1) Waking, Light; on a hit, a Dread 1 check	Vigil; for the precisely tolerable pain
Lamplighter's pole	9 L	Common	(3) Reach; lit, +1 fire damage	Vigil; brass hook and wick

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	STATS	NOTES
Midwife's hooked knife	20 L	Uncommon	(3) Ripping, Hooking	Cradlewrack; called the second opinion
Assembler's bone-saw	14 L	Scarce	(3) Ripping, Brutal	Cradlewrack; teeth fine as an eyelash
Night-mason's lump hammer	4 L	Common	(3) Stunning	Cradlewrack; breaks a bricked door, or a head
Foundling hanger	40 L	Uncommon	(4) Parrying	Cradlewrack; issued to soldiers six years old
Cullmaster's sickle	30 L	Scarce	(4) Hooking, Ripping, Silent	Fatlands; black iron, dusk shift only
Pruning hook	7 L	Common	(3) Hooking, Reach	Fatlands orchards; the trees remember it
Clausewright's quill-knife	18 L	Uncommon	(2) Concealable, Piercing, Silent	Oathen; for trimming quills and correcting drafts
Bitmaker's tongs	15 L	Scarce	(2) Entangling; may seize the jaw	Oathen; to fit a bit by force
Echo-Warden's stave	10 L	Uncommon	(3) Parrying, Silent	Oathen; felt-wrapped so it never rings
Canyon Watch felt maul	45 L	Scarce	(5) Heavy, Silent, Two-Handed	Oathen; the quietest way to break a man
Tablebreaker's axe	40 L	Scarce	(5) Brutal, Two-Handed; +4 vs furniture	the Fast; the haft notched for every table
Reckoner's long knife	25 L	Scarce	(3) Silent, Piercing, Concealable	the Fast; grey steel, never oiled with fat
Grain-sock cosh	2 L	Common	(2) Stunning, Concealable	the Fast; Crumb-Runners' weapon; the grain is still good after
Warden's flanged mace	30 L	Uncommon	(4) Stunning	the Rim; seven flanges, one for each spoke
Drover's goad	4 L	Common	(2) Reach, Stunning	Fatlands; Sal Trotter's herds know it
Kept-arm cudgel	30 L	Rare	(3) Stunning; Tainted (Dread 2)	Sallowreach; a Kept forearm, wired; it grips

RANGED WEAPONS

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	STATS	NOTES
Sling	2 L	Common	(2) Silent, Concealable	
Shortbow	15 L	Common	(3) Two-Handed	
Longbow	40 L	Uncommon	(4) Two-Handed, Heavy	Cradlewrack hill archers
Crossbow	50 L	Uncommon	(4) Piercing, Slow, Two-Handed	
Arbalest	120 L	Scarce	(5) Piercing, Slow, Heavy, Two-Handed	Admiralty marines
Hand crossbow	70 L	Scarce	(3) Concealable, Slow	Reckoner assassins
Gull-bow	30 L	Uncommon	(3) Slow	Brinehollow; a light crossbow for the Lashings' meat
Clockwork spring-bow	300 L	Rare	(3) Piercing; three shots before rewinding	Vigil; ticks loudly
Netwatch throwing net	8 L	Common	(0) Entangling, Thrown	Brinehollow; weighted with lead tokens
Sump-net	6 L	Common	(0) Entangling, Thrown; Kept are at -2 to escape	Sallowreach; tarred, hooked, for things that will not stop
Harpoon	18 L	Uncommon	(4) Hooking, Thrown; with line, Entangling	Brinehollow; fished nothing for a century
Throwing knives (set of 4)	14 L	Common	(2) Thrown, Light, Concealable	
Rope-dart	9 L	Uncommon	(2) Silent, Thrown; with line, Entangling	Oathen; Echo-Wardens take speakers quietly
Waker's blowpipe	6 L	Uncommon	(1) Silent, Waking	Vigil; darts tipped with strong rouse
Dazzle-mirror	12 L	Common	(0); target at -2 Attack next round	Vigil; Lampwrights' Row; useless in the dark, of which there is none

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	STATS	NOTES
Drover's bola	3 L	Common	(1) Entangling, Thrown	Fatlands; for herds that run on two legs
Lamp-flask	2 L	Common	(2) Thrown, Fragile; burns 1 a round	Vigil oil in a thin glass bulb
Pang-stones (bag of 20)	1 L	Common	+1 to sling damage	Cradlewrack; red clay; warm
Pebble-bow	12 L	Uncommon	(2) Silent; shoots pang-stones	Cradlewrack; shepherds' weapon against what the ewes drop

ARMOUR

Armor subtracts from damage taken. Armor of 3 or more gives -1 to Lung rolls for stealth and swimming; Armor 4 gives -2 .

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	ARMOR	NOTES
Padded jack	10 L	Common	1	quilted wool or rag
Hide coat	8 L	Common	1	Fatlands hide is warm for days after skinning
Felt jack	15 L	Common	1	Oathen; Silent; nothing on it rings
Boiled leather	30 L	Common	2	
Kept-leather jerkin	35 L	Uncommon	2	Sallowreach; never perishes, never cracks; somebody's
Laden-hide coat	40 L	Uncommon	2	Fatlands; from a Laden's back after the wake; Tainted (Dread 1); always warm
Bone lamellar	90 L	Uncommon	3	Fatlands; plates cut from coin-grade bone, which is unlucky
Mail shirt	150 L	Uncommon	3	rusts in Brinehollow salt and Sallowreach weep
Warden's coat	160 L	Uncommon	3	the Rim; mail under grey wool and the wheel badge; wearing one unsworn is theft of the road
Admiralty cork cuirass	120 L	Scarce	3	Brinehollow; plate over cork; floats; never once tested
Plate	900 L	Rare	4	Heavy; Oathen and Admiralty officers
Netwatch oilskin	25 L	Common	1	Brinehollow; corked; floats the wearer face-up
Seamer's wire-coat	60 L	Uncommon	2	Sallowreach; meant to hold a Kept body together
Suet-quilt	12 L	Common	1	Fatlands; lard-packed; burns like a candle
Studded Vigil coat	40 L	Common	2	studs inward; the wearer cannot nod off; Waking to self
Anchorite harness	35 L	Uncommon	2	Brinehollow; chain; the Calling cannot walk you far
Foundling brigandine	80 L	Uncommon	2	Cradlewrack; cut for bodies that are newly grown
Reckoner's greys	45 L	Scarce	2	the Fast; no fat in the leather; Silent
Buckler	6 L	Common	+1 Guard	Parrying
Bucket-shield	4 L	Common	+1 Guard	Brinehollow; a bail-bucket on a strap; still bails

▼ CLOTHING AND REGIONAL DRESS

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Common clothes	3 L	Common	—	linen, wool, a hat
Good clothes	25 L	Common	+1 Persuade with merchants	
Noble dress	150+ L	Uncommon	+2 Persuade at court	and a target on your back

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Lastgate mourning-cloak	20 L	Common	perfume pockets in the lining	Sallowreach; cedar for the rich
Kept's gauze binding	2 L a week	Common	holds a Kept face on	Sallowreach
Hand-line mittens	8 L	Common	stop compulsive closing	Sallowreach; worn by the Appetite-struck
Fatlands tent-coat	12 L	Common	expands with the wearer	let out every season
Gleaner's apron	1 L	Common	twelve pockets	stained to the elbow
Weighing-day coat	30 L	Uncommon	deep sewn pockets, reinforced	Fatlands; for lead; owning one is not a crime, wearing it full is
Anchoring belt	6 L	Common	ring for a night-rope	Brinehollow; sweethearts stitch them
Pressure hood	18 L	Uncommon	+2 Endure on pressure days	Brinehollow; waxed leather
Wreckwife's grey shawl	4 L	Common	marks a spouse returned Tenanted	Brinehollow; it is rude to ask; the shawl asks for you
Pin-glove	3 L	Common	pricks the palm when gripped	Vigil; for staying awake
Tin-plated hat	5 L	Common	rattles in rain	Vigil
Attendance apron	—	not for sale	marks a midwife	Cradlewrack; wearing one falsely is a knife
Knocker's ring	2 L	Common	a brass ring for knocking	Cradlewrack; the polite carry one
Neck-kit	2 L	Common	needle, gut and wax on a cord; +1 Stitching on your own wounds	Cradlewrack; everyone over seven wears one
Child's bit	4 L	Common	soft leather muzzle	Oathen; legally required under twelve
Clausewright's collar	30 L	Uncommon	brass plate of licence	Oathen
Felt slippers	1 L	Common	+1 Stealth on stone	Oathen; footsteps can carry words
Unfed greys	2 L	Common	plain undyed wool	the Fast; any colour is vanity
Penitent's brown	2 L	Common	marks a Purgation pilgrim	the Rim; the Bailiffs of the Fatlands strip it off in the street
Bonded Hand's livery	—	not for sale	grey coat, wheel badge; a bed at any post	the Rim; issued with the Bond, for twenty years or life
Veil of the Second Table	300 L	Rare	a silk mask with a silver fork	never sold openly



COATS LET OUT WHILE YOU WAIT. WHILE YOU
EAT. WHILE YOU GROW.

TAILOR'S SIGN, GRAVY ROW, GRISTMOOT

▼ TOOLS AND KITS

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Seamer's kit	30 L	Common	needed for Stitching; +1 on the Kept	wire, thread, lacquer, cork, awl
Surgeon's case	80 L	Uncommon	+1 Stitching; can amputate	Quease buys every new design
Clausewright's box	50 L	Uncommon	+1 Clause on drafting	quills, sand, wax, a thumb-inkpad

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Lockpicks	15 L	Uncommon	needed for Filch on locks	useless in Cradlewrack, which needs none
Agnes Latch lock	200 L	Rare	holds a Cradlewrack door 2d6 nights	the waiting list is a year
Bail-bucket	1 L	Common	required in Brinehollow	sweethearts swap them
Anchoring rope (10 fathoms)	2 L	Common	+2 to resist being Called while tied	cut ropes are the great tragedy
Knot-tier's hook	3 L	Common	+2 to tie a knot that holds against the Calling	Brinehollow; the Spur charges a crumb a knot
Sounding-line (40 fathoms)	5 L	Common	measures depth, wells, the indoor tide	Brinehollow; in the Uncovered, lowered into puddles
Netwatch kit	25 L	Uncommon	hook, net, rope, rattle	
Rattle	1 L	Common	wakes a blinker, Noisy	Wakers' badge of office
Wetting-brush and bowl	4 L	Common	keeps lidless eyes from drying	Vigil; eye-wetters carry three
Water clock	40 L	Uncommon	times pangs, bells, bailing	Cradlewrack
Pang-bell	6 L	Common	rings by itself before a pang, a breath early	Cradlewrack; usually
Spyglass	90 L	Scarce	+2 Search at distance	Oathen note-watchers use them
Felt baffle	8 L	Common	stops an echo in a room or a gorge's mouth	Oathen; hung over every doorway in Tacit
Hanging scales	12 L	Common	weigh coin and meat	Garrick Tripe's are rigged
Coin-tester's kit	6 L	Common	+2 Eye to spot false coin	scales, Rim grains, hot needle, lamp
Cutwright's calipers	60 L	Scarce	+2 Lore to judge a person's Cut	measures skull, nail and tell
Rope (50 ft), sack, chain	1–5 L	Common		
Wax tablets (Oathen)	3 L	Common	write without binding (allegedly)	since 640, not reliably
Brick, mortar, trowel	2 L	Common	brick yourself in for the night	Cradlewrack
Tablebreaker's wedge	3 L	Uncommon	+2 to break furniture apart	the Fast
Hostwatch frost-marker	5 L	Uncommon	chalk sticks that change colour on warm ground	tracks Orrum's passage
Caltrops (a bag)	4 L	Common	pursuers at –2 Lung for a round	Crumb-Runners scatter them behind the cart

LIGHT



LOCKS THAT HOLD. HONEST. TWO NIGHTS GUARANTEED OR YOUR DOOR BACK.

TAMSIN KEYLESS'S BOARD, KEST

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Rushlight	1 c	Common	1 hour, smoky	the poor's light everywhere but the Vigil
Tallow candle	2 c	Common	4 hours	smells of the Chute
Beeswax candle	2 L	Uncommon	6 hours, clean	Cradlewrack hives
Oil lamp	3 L	Common	8 hours a pint	
Lamp oil (pint)	4 c	Common	doubled in the Vigil	Ashlock's ninety days
Sea-oil (pint)	2 c	Uncommon	burns brighter; lamp drips seawater	Lucan Spill's; rendered on the Uncovered
Vigil mirror-lantern	25 L	Uncommon	bright as noon, 20 paces	no shadows to sleep in

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Lid-lamp	8 L	Common	a lamp on a brow-band	Vigil; so your face is never in shadow
Bullseye lantern	15 L	Uncommon	a beam, shutterable	Netwatch issue
Wick Tallow candle	6 c	Common	burns 3 nights, steady; Tainted (Dread 1)	Sallowreach; it feels itself burn
Named Tallow candle	5 L	Uncommon	as above, made from a known person	Tainted (Dread 2); families commission them
Fen-glow jar	1 L	Common	dim green light, never goes out	Sallowreach; things that will not finish rotting
Smoulder-coal (Sallowreach)	1 L	Common	stays lit for years in a tin	fires there do not end

A Wick Tallow candle gives the steadiest light on the Table. Up close, the flame leans towards whoever lit it. Half of Lastgate reads by people it used to know, and some of them can tell which. The tallow is soft and faintly warm even unlit, and if a candle is snapped the two halves bleed a little clear grease and go on burning separately, both leaning the same way.

◇
*GRANDFATHER, FOUR CRUMBS THE INCH.
 CUT TO LENGTH. HE WOULD HAVE WANTED
 YOU TO HAVE HIM.*

CHALKED ON A CHANDLER'S SHUTTER, LASTGATE
 UNDERCITY

▼ FOOD AND DRINK

Lack keep away.

– SAID BEFORE EATING WITH ANY STRANGER, EVERYWHERE

Food is the Table's first trade and its first horror. Anything from the Fatlands is grown in Ummer and carries a little of it. Rim cooks sell "safe" food, which means food they will swear is not, and nobody believes them. The rest of the Table eats what its own god left it: eel that will not stop moving, cheese that ripens for ever, bread baked

from cellar-kelp, lamb so cheap the poor eat it daily because the ewes drop four times a year, lizard on a stick in the canyons, and in the Fast, grey ration-bread eaten cold, standing, and without pleasure.

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Rim bread (a loaf)	1 L	Common	a day's bread	the price of a lack, by definition
Stranger's Loaf	free	Gristmoot only	Taint 1 Hunger	given at every inn door; the town bets you stay
Toothed-wheat loaf	5 c	Common	Taint 1 Hunger	Fatlands; teeth milled out, mostly; may bite
Bleeding-orchard fruit	2 c	Common	Taint 1 Hunger; heals 1 Flesh	skin, fat layer, bone pit; screams if cut fresh
Veined roots (a sack)	1 L	Common	Taint 1 Hunger	they flinch when peeled
Meat by the pound	3 c	Common	Taint 1 Hunger	origin stamped over twice
Chute barrel (100 lb)	25 L	Common	see What's in the Barrel?	
Lady Aspic's jelly	30 L	Rare	Taint 2 Hunger, 1 Dread	it blinks
Skim (Fatlands drip-fat)	1 c	Common	cooking fat	skimmed off rain
Sallowreach fen-eel	4 c	Common	never stops wriggling	Sallowreach; eat it fast
Stilled meat (a pound)	3 L	Uncommon	the only properly dead meat in the north	Sallowreach; from beasts that crossed the Drop and back
Undying cheese	1 L	Uncommon	ripens forever	Sallowreach; sold by the decade
Brine (a pint)	1 c	Common	salty; Taint 1 Regrowth to non-Brinehollowers	coughed up at dawn; sold for curing
Kelp-bread	3 c	Common		Brinehollow; from cellar-tide kelp

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Salted gull	3 c	Common		Brinehollow; the Lashings' meat
Eyeless fish	1 L	Uncommon		Brinehollow; from Harbor End; cheaper than the sighted
Uncovered salvage-tins	2 L	Uncommon	roll d6: on a 1, something alive	Brinehollow wrecks
Rouse (brewed, a cup)	1 c	Common	see Drugs	Vigil coffee-houses
Clatter-cake	2 c	Common	crunchy enough to wake you	Vigil; baked with grit
Clay-bread	2 c	Common	warm for a day	Cradlewrack; tastes of iron
Posset (a horn)	1 c	Common	warm, curdled, spiced	Cradlewrack; the Rimwatch charges double
Second-milk	1 L	Scarce	Taint 1 Regrowth	Cradlewrack; from who knows what
Canyon flatbread	2 c	Common	eaten in silence	Oathen
Roast lizard on a stick	1 c	Common		Oathen; the poor man's meat
Green cheese (a wedge)	3 c	Common		Oathen; ripened in the river caves
Rain-water (Kept Rain, a flask)	5 L	Uncommon	blessed; pure	Oathen; once a year
Fast ration-bread	1 chit	Common in Wanting	no Taint; −1 Hunger if eaten cold, standing	grey, Rim-grown, joyless
“Safe” Rim food (a meal)	2 L	Uncommon	no Taint, or so they swear	Eye + Lore Hard (14) to be sure
Ale or small beer	2 c	Common		
Wine	1 L	Common		
Fen-gin	3 c	Common	Feast Routine (10) or −1 all rolls an hour	Sallowreach; the bottle never quite empties
Saltwick gin	3 c	Common		Brinehollow; the Fleet's ration; sweet water is in it
Fig-spirit	2 c	Common in the Breakdowns	Feast Hard (14) or say something you mean	Oathen; illegal above the fourth tier
Marrow-brandiy	3 L	Uncommon	Taint 1 Hunger; +1 Resolve for a scene	Fatlands; distilled from boiled bone
Trail rations (a week)	8 L	Common	safe, dull	Company-sealed tins



EEL. LIVELY. DON'T ASK HOW LONG.
FISHWIFE'S SLATE, THE LANDING, LASTGATE

WHAT'S IN THE BARREL?

Chute barrels are stamped with their origin, and then stamped over, and then stamped over again. When a character opens one, roll a d20.

D20	CONTENTS
1	Pork. Honestly pork. Everyone is suspicious.
2	Brined beef, the good stuff, with a brass Board tag. One joint has a healed fracture set by a surgeon.
3	Orchard-pig: fat, sweet, and with a bone pit at the centre of every chop.
4	Mutton that is still warm, two weeks out of Sated.
5	Drover-herd beef, Sal Trotter's brand. The shins are very long. The hooves are not hooves.
6	Salt tongue, eighty of them, in neat rows. Several are pierced for earrings. No, for bits.
7	Mixed offal and a wedding ring.

D20	CONTENTS
8	Bacon with a birthmark shaped like a hare. Someone in Low Tilth will know whose.
9	Sausage, a single coil, tattooed in blue: crossed anchors and a name.
10	Brawn in jelly. The jelly has a heartbeat for an hour after opening.
11	Corned beef stamped with Ivo Stockpot's notch. He would not eat this.
12	Fatlands field-meat: a joint with roots growing through the marrow. Taint 2 Hunger.
13	A whole ham with a face on the rind. Pleasant. Smiling. Eyes closed.
14	Good beef, and at the bottom a sealed letter: "If you are reading this, tell my sister Merrin I was Reaped at Low Tilth on the ninth of Carving."
15	Tripe that continues to digest whatever is put in with it.
16	Salt pork and forty teeth, sorted by size. Granny Cracknel will want them.
17	Empty but for brine, and the brine is cold and pulls gently west.
18	A Gut-lines cut: marbled, enormous, Taint 3 Hunger. Worth twenty times the barrel.
19	Meat that a Fast-born character cannot be persuaded to look away from.
20	Something alive, packed in salt, curled up, and very glad of the light.

▼ DRUGS AND MEDICINES

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	ADDICTION
Rouse (tab)	3 c	Common	no sleep for an hour; ignore the Vigil's pull; +1 Eye	Hard (14)
Crane's strong rouse	1 L	Uncommon	no sleep 4 hours; +1 Eye, −1 Hand (tremor)	Grim (18)
Slope rouse (brine-cut)	2 c	Common	as rouse, lasts longer; Taint 1 Regrowth (Dromm)	Grim (18)
Staremoos quid	2 c	Common	+1 to resist a blink for an hour; stains the teeth green	Hard (14)
Bottled brine tonic	3 L	Uncommon	heals 1d6 Flesh; Taint 2 Regrowth (Dromm)	Hard (14)
Poppy drops (laudanum)	1 L	Common	ignore Injury penalties for a scene; −2 Eye	Hard (14)
Quease's Number 212	5 L	Uncommon	removes one kind of pain, fully, for a day	Grim (18)
Weep-tea	3 c	Common	ignore one Injury's pain for an hour; tastes of rain on a coffin	Routine (10)
Anchor-draught	1 L	Uncommon	+2 to resist the Calling for a night; −2 to all else till noon	Grim (18)
Quiet-drops	5 c	Common	the tongue goes numb; cannot speak for an hour	none; sold at Mumchance to the talkative
Purgation emetic	2 L	Uncommon	vomit for an hour; purges food Taint (see Taint)	none, but contraband in the Fatlands
Purgation bleeding-kit	4 L	Uncommon	lose 2 Flesh, lose 1 Hunger	none
Fen-leeches (a jar of six)	1 L	Common	over a night, lose 1 Flesh and 1 Hunger	none; the leeches never die, and grow
Fen-vinegar	2 c	Common	+1 resisting Dread from rot and smell	
Lastgate cedar perfume	3 L	Common	masks a Kept for a day; marks you as wealthy	
Orchard sap	1 L	Uncommon	stops bleeding (ends Ripping)	Taint 1 Hunger; screams faintly
Caul-poultice	6 L	Scarce	reopened wounds close for a day	Cradlewrack; wounds there reopen
Mother Gall's pickle-brine	20 L	Scarce	a corpse is kept sound for a year	Sallowreach
Ash-water	1 c	Common	the Thin's fasting drink; −1 Hunger, −1 Flesh	treason in the Fatlands

ADDICTION

Each time a character uses an addictive drug, they roll Gut + Endure against its Addiction difficulty. On failure, they gain one point of **Need** for that drug. At 1 Need they want it; at 3 Need they are addicted. An addicted character who goes a day without a dose is at −1 to all rolls, and −1 more for each day after, to −4; each day without also adds 1 Fray. Need falls by 1 for each full week without the drug, while suffering. A Lack on the Addiction roll adds 2 Need.

Rouse is special. In the Vigil, nearly everyone is addicted, and the dose rises. A character addicted to rouse must double the dose after

each season of use to get the same effect. Dr. Aldous Crane knows where the curve ends. It is eleven years off, and a character who works the arithmetic for themselves (Grim 18, Eye + Reckoning) takes a Dread 2 check.



*TABS. TABS. HONEST TABS. THEY HOLD AN
HOUR IF YOU HOLD ON.*

PATTER ON THE SLOPE

▼ ANIMALS AND TRANSPORT

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	STATS	NOTES
Mule	40 L	Common	carries 200 lb	will not walk into a Hush
Riding horse	150 L	Uncommon	Wayfaring +1 on roads	eats safe fodder or goes wrong
Company post-horse (hire)	1 L a post	Common	change at every post; 40 miles a day	the Rim; the Company counts every hoof
Draught ox	80 L	Common	pulls a cart	Fatlands oxen are larger than they should be
Kept horse	60 L	Common	never tires; never dies; cannot leave Sallowreach	Sallowreach; smells; rots slowly
Fen-punt	20 L	Common	carries four over black water	Sallowreach; the pole finds things on the bottom
Sal Trotter's "cattle"	30 L a head	Uncommon	as an ox, if no one watches	they walk on two legs at night; do not name them
Fatlands dray (eight oxen)	900 L	Scarce	carries one Gut-line noble	Obb Tullow's rooted through
Pier-trolley	1 c a mile	Common	Lowmark's 19-mile pier	runs on rails, pushed by bailers
Sand-sledge	25 L	Uncommon	drags salvage over the Uncovered	Brinehollow; men pull it, roped, for the Calling
Netwatch dog	50 L	Uncommon	Threat 2; smells the Called	barks at Tenanted
Vigil sedan (carried standing)	2 L an hour	Common	you cannot sit; bearers sing to stay awake	
Felt litter	10 L a day	Common	eight bearers, silent	Oathen; for crossing posted gorges without a sound
Wagon	60 L	Common		Company tolls double
Company coach seat	5 c a mile	Common	Rim Road only; with guard	stops at every inn
Cradlewrack hill-goat	15 L	Common	sure-footed	some are born talking
Crumb-runner's handcart	10 L	Common	300 lb at night	spat on in Wanting



*Mule, sound, will not walk into a Hush. Mule,
cheaper, will.*

A STOCK-SLATE AT FOGMOUTH

▼ LODGING ON THE RIM ROAD

LODGING	COST	AVAIL.	WHAT YOU GET	NOTES
Ditch or hedge	free	Common	nothing	Orrum's tables appear at crossroads lately
Common room floor	3 c	Common	a fire, a floor	in Vigil inns, standing straps
Company inn, shared room	1 L	Common	a bed, a lock, a guard	in the Vigil, a strap and a nudger
Company inn, private room	4 L	Common	a bed, a bath, a meal	
The Groaning Board	3 L	the Fatlands Rim	a bed and five meals, by law	seats six hundred at one table; the meat unspecified
Sleeping Sheds, Lampwick Halt	1 L	the Vigil border	your last safe sleep for months	many lie awake all night anyway
Rope room, Lowmark Spur	1 L, and a crumb a knot	Brinehollow border	tied to the bed by a knot-tier	the knot-tier counts heads at dawn
Brick-in room	1 L	Cradlewrack	mortared shut at dusk	broken out at dawn, if you are still in it
Anchor-inn	1 L	Brinehollow	a bed with chains	the keeper counts heads each dawn
Lastgate boarding house	2 L	Sallowreach	a room with three generations of Kept	they are quiet; they listen
The Long Farewell, back room	5 L	Fogmouth	a bench to wait on, north of nothing	where Tam Ruddock's clients wait to cross
Waking-house	2 L	Vigil	a sloped floor and a nudger	sleeping is a crime
Unfed bothy	none (decline thrice)	the Fast	four walls, no hearth	never if the hearth is lit

THE INN AT THE CROSSROADS

In the last three years Company inn-keepers on the Rim have reported finding tables laid in their common rooms at dawn: a white cloth, warm bread, a chair pulled out, a place card. The Company's standing instruction is to burn the table and not read the card. Not all inn-keepers obey. A few have started renting the chair. The going rate at Saltlick Cross is a platter a night, paid in advance, and the renters are mostly Fatlands pilgrims who have been hungry every second of their lives. The inn-keepers do not say what happens to the renters. They do say that the chair is always empty in the morning, and the plate is always clean, and the bill is always settled.



We count heads at dawn. Please be one of them.

PAINTED OVER THE BEDS OF THE ANCHOR-INN AT
LOWMARK SPUR

▼ SERVICES

SERVICE	COST	AVAIL.	WHAT YOU GET	NOTES
A Closing	4,000 L or a license	Rare	a licensed death in Sallowreach	Lady Corrow Vane's waiting list is years
Unlicensed Closing	1,500 L	Rare	a Hand-line touch, off the books	capital crime; Osric Vane offers it free
Restitching	3 L a limb	Common	a Kept part reattached	Thessaly Mort's guild rates
Setting Aside	40 L	Common	wrapped, labelled, shelved, read to	Bettany Shroud reads nightly
Tucker minute	90 L	Uncommon	sixty seconds of sleep, guarded	Old Nod's price; a month's wage

SERVICE	COST	AVAIL.	WHAT YOU GET	NOTES
Surety bond	1 L in 10 of the oath	Uncommon	someone else's body backs your word	Ona Fell has one default left
Clausewright drafting	5 L a page	Common	an oath that survives reality	a marriage runs forty pages
Price-witness	1 c a word	Common	haggle at +2 without swearing	Oathen and Rim east
Money-changing	1 c in the lack	Common	coin weighed, bitten, changed	every Rim market; a crescent worn into the teeth
Tablebreaker hire	a sack of grain a table	Uncommon	a table smashed before anyone sits	they refuse coin
Crumb-running	1 L per 10 lb	Uncommon	food carried into the Fast	Tarry Moss counts every bean
Netwatch retrieval	15 L	Common	a Called relative dragged home	alive, officially
Rope funeral	3 L	Common	a Brinehollow burial, priest and carving	the name on the tide-post is a crumb a letter
Cutwright reading	50 L	Uncommon	your Cut, your line, your prospects	the full ledger costs 500 L and a favour
Midwife attendance	12 L	Common	a lawful birth	the Two Questions; the knife included
Slot-feeding	1 c a day	Common	bread and water pushed to the bricked	Cradlewrack; the Debt Wall at Kest
Jointer at a wake	4 L a body	Common	your dead carved for the table	Fatlands; Hob Gristle charges 10 and is worth it
Hill-Speaker	6 L and the best cut	Uncommon	a Dowager consulted on family matters	Fatlands; trusted by no one; always right
Reckoner contract	not sold	Scarce	a high-Cut line ended	Reckoners are informed, never paid
Blank-poacher bounty	300–2,000 L paid to you	Rare	the price of a Blank, alive	Kale Dragoman feeds them well
Mother Gall's barrel	500 L in advance	Scarce	a body pickled sound for a century	awake, all of it
Dream-Diver hire	200 L a dive	Scarce	someone goes to the long room for you	most manage three
Wake-valet	10–40 L a day	Uncommon	kept awake by artful pain	Tenterhook is an artist
Eye-wetter	5 L a day	Common	your lidless eyes kept wet	Vigil; they see everything you see
Hob Gristle tasting	5 L	Uncommon	what a cut of meat used to be, by name	he apologises to it
Barrel restamping	2 L a barrel	Uncommon	any origin you like, stamped over	Barrelside; the Union's crime, the Company's blind eye
Ferry over the north border	300 L	Scarce	your dying kept from death	Tam Ruddock never says what next
Echo-Warden silencing	30 L	Uncommon	an old oath hunted out of the rock	Halvar Stane
Liar-for-hire	3 L a lie, 10 L in court	Uncommon	a Forsworn says it for you	Oathen, the Breakdowns; their mouths are already broken
Sheathmouth guide	5 L a traveller	Uncommon	led through a posted gorge in silence	Oathen
Oath release	a greater oath	Rare	free of a binding promise	Grandam Cess; you owe her worse
Lead pockets at the Weighing	200 L	Rare	+1 vote in the Fatlands	Garrick Tripe
A named candle	50 L	Uncommon	your dead rendered to light	Wick Tallow; it knows you

◇
*Your dead, carved and served, with your best plates.
We bring the knives. You bring Grandmother.*

A JOINTER'S CARD, WAKESIDE, SATED

▼ THE TRADE IN PEOPLE

On the Table nobody owns a slave. It is not permitted. We own debts, and bonds, and bodies at interest, and the paper on which a man has sold himself in instalments. That is quite different, and it pays better.

— LYSANDER COYLE, AUDITOR-GENERAL OF THE COMPANY, IN A PRIVATE LETTER



Every land on the Table forbids the sale of people, and every land does it. The Rim Road Company's charter forbids it within a bowshot of the road, and the Company's own law punishes the theft of cargo by making the thief cargo. The trade survives every prohibition because it never calls itself by its name. People are sold on the Table in three ways: **whole**, as Blanks, poached Unfed and

debtors bound for the dusk shift; **in pieces**, as Blank organs, Kept limbs, Cradlewrack Parts and Surety-flesh; and **in futures**, as bonds, debts, naming-rights and carried oaths, which are promises that a body will be delivered later. Most of it passes along the Rim, because the Rim is where a person from one land can be sold to a buyer from another without either land's law noticing.

THEY TOOK MY **KIDNEYS** IN **SATED** AND MY EYES IN THE
VIGIL AND THE REST OF ME WENT HOME TO THE FAST IN A SACK
MARKED BONE: **MIXED**, AND THAT IS HOW I CAME TO BE IN
YOUR **PURSE**.

[A RIM ROAD GHOST STORY, TOLD TO CHILDREN WHO BITE COINS]

BLANK FLESH

Godsign does not live in Blank flesh. A kidney, liver, eye, stomach, length of gut or pint of blood taken from a Blank or one of the Unfed is, so far as any surgeon can tell, wholly clean, and sewn into a Godeater it is the one part of that body the god does not grow into, for a few months or a few years. The buyers are almost always High Cuts: Laden matriarchs who want to feel, for a season, what it is to be full; lidless Eye-lines who want eyes that close; Unvacated of Sallowreach who want to feel one heartbeat that is not Ossel's. Then

the buyer's godsign grows into the new organ, as ivy grows into a wall, and in a few years they need another.

The chain runs the same way every time. A **poacher** crosses into the Fast by night with nets and sedatives, or buys from a body-man like the gravedigger of the Lean House who sells the omitted still warm. The catch is **fed on the road**, generously, because the meat must arrive in condition; Kale Dragoman spoon-feeds his captives honey and warm milk and holds their heads. They are delivered to a **holding-house**, a hired place with no west windows in whatever city the surgeon is working, where they are weighed daily and kept alive between harvests, because organs taken from the living are

better. The **surgeon**, most often Master Quillon Barr, takes what is ordered and closes what is left, if there is to be a second order. The

buyer never sees the donor, and pays through intermediaries who never give a name.

LOT	PRICE	WHERE	NOTES
A living Unfed adult, poacher's price	300–2,000 L	the Fast border, Gristmoot	by weight and health; children are not priced, and are taken
A living Blank of another land	2,000–10,000 L	anywhere, quietly	a Vigil Blank who could sleep is the dearest thing on the Table
Blank blood, a pint	150 L	Lastgate, Sated, the Vigil	slows the Regrowth for a season, or so the buyers believe
Blank marrow-jelly, a pot	80 L	the Vigil, Kest	a sleep-cure on the Lid; a contraceptive in the highlands
A Blank kidney	3,000 L	the Rim	the pair, delivered warm in Sated, about 6,000 L
Blank eyes, the pair	4,000 L	the Vigil	eyes that close; Lady Dalgety has bought three pairs of lids
A Blank stomach	5,000 L	Sated	for a season of fullness
A Blank heart, beating in brine	12,000 L and up	Lastgate	the buyers do not write the sum down
Blank bone, cut as lacks	twenty times face	the Rim	proof someone was killed for their skeleton

Page from the weight-book of a holding-house on Tallow Street, Sated, recovered by Dr. Mercy Thrane in Plenty 640 and entered in her ledger of names. The hand is a clerk's, neat and bored.

No. 9. Man, about forty, Unfed, from Lammas Bottom. In at 7 st 2. Fed four times daily per instruction. Refused broth days 1 to 6; on day 7 accepted after the third asking and wept through the meal. Gaining. 9 st 10 at day 40. Right kidney taken day 41 (order: Marrable household, by the Carver's agent). Kept for second order. Asks every morning whether his wife is also here. Told no. (She is No. 4.)

No. 4. Woman, about thirty-five, Unfed. In at 6 st 11. Has not eaten. Tube from day 9. Will not speak except to decline. Eyes reserved (order: the Lid; the lady's maid came to look at them and sat with her an hour and brushed her face). 6 st 9 at day 40. Surgeon says she will not hold to the order. Surgeon says take them now.

No. 12. Boy. Not weighed. Collected day 2 by the poacher, who said he had made a mistake and the boy was not for sale, and paid back the price, and took him away on his own horse. Note for the house: the poacher is getting soft.

No. 9 asked again this morning about his wife. Told no. Gaining.

THE FOURTH ASKING

The Unfed decline every offer three times and accept on the fourth, and the poachers of the border have learned to use it. In the hungry Lack of 637, a widow of Lammas Bottom whose household had been struck from the Pantry list walked to the border at night, to the place where Kale Dragoman's men camp, and waited to be asked. They asked her three times whether she would come with them, and

three times she said “No, thank you,” and on the fourth asking she went, on the condition, sworn on nothing because the Unfed swear on nothing, that her price be paid to her children in grain. It was. Two sacks of good Fatlands wheat were left at her door in Lammas Bottom. Her kidneys went to a Laden matriarch in Sated, whose god grew into them inside three years. Her children ate the grain. It was Godeater grain, grown in Ummer's flesh, and the Abstinent, finding the sacks, struck the children's names from the list for eating what they had not carried in themselves, as the law requires. Mercy Thrane has the whole of it in her ledger. She has underlined nothing. She says none of it needs underlining.

DEBT AND THE BOND

Where there is no Blank to sell, the Table sells its poor, by the length of time they will work and the parts of themselves they will pledge. Every land has its own way of doing it, and every land's way is lawful.

- ◇ **The Company Bond.** Coin-cutters, vat-men, porters and Bonded Hands swear to the Company in Oathen for twenty years, or for “as long as the wheel turns.” The Bond binds the body anywhere; a bonded cutter who walks away from the Cure-House at Saltbridge breaks at the knees on the road. Theft of Company cargo is punished by being made cargo: the thief is entered on the manifest at the price of what they stole and shipped, by Company wagon, to whoever will buy the debt. The Company never says who buys. The manifests are sworn.
- ◇ **The dusk shift.** In the Fatlands a debtor who cannot pay is read out on a Cullmaster's list in Carving, and walks the far field at dusk, and the debt is struck off “in full,” up to two hundred lacks an evening. Those who come back are free. Gristmoot moneylenders write loans to foreigners at terms they know will end on a list.

- ◇ **Impressment.** In Brinehollow, debtors who cannot pay the Pier Tithe are pressed into the Dry Fleet at a year for every hundred lacks, to stand watches on a ship that will not sail. Their families visit them on the props. The Gilt Mile's brokers buy their debts at a discount and sell their terms to the Raw Mile, where the pier-haulers die.
- ◇ **Dead wages and the long debt.** In Sallowreach nobody dies, so nobody's debt dies either. A Kept cooper in Lastgate has been working off a thirty-eight-year debt to a moneylender who is also Kept, and will be for the rest of time. Kept debtors who cannot pay sell themselves by the limb, at auction, and go on working with what is left; a Kept auctioneer of Lastgate has been selling himself by the limb since a debt of 300 A.G., and the bidding is brisk.
- ◇ **The Bed-Due.** In the Vigil the family of every Counted sleeper owes a lack a season for ever. Families who fall behind sell what they have, and when they have nothing they sell their children's waking hours as nudgers, by the bell, to the Slope's hiring-masters, who pay in tabs. A nudger who blinks on duty is not paid for that bell. A nudger who sleeps is delivered to the Dormitory steps, and the family is billed a new Bed-Due.
- ◇ **Naming and the Companies.** In Cradlewrack the poor sell the naming-rights of children not yet born, and the Crown sells the contracts of the born-grown Foundling soldiers to whoever will hire a regiment, including the Company, which bought Warden-Captain Fallowmere's contract out of a Foundling Company before he was two years old. Paupers who cannot pay the Attendance's birth-fee pay it in laundry at the Coppers, or a year of slot-feeding at the Debt Wall.
- ◇ **The list.** In the Fast nothing is sold, and so the trade is in the list itself. A name struck from the Pantry list is a household foreclosed. Families on the list sell their spare chits to Crumb-Runners for three lacks in the Lack season, and families off it buy them back at five, and both are spat upon.

◇

WANTED: BOYS, QUICK, FOR NUDGING. GOOD
FEET. NO BLINKERS. FAMILIES PAID IN
ADVANCE.

HIRING-MASTER'S BOARD, PINCHBECK STEPS, THE
SLOPE

SURETIES: BODIES AT INTEREST

The Surety trade is the only trade in people on the Table that is licensed, honoured and taxed. A Surety swears, before another person's oath is made, "I stand for this word," and from then on, if the principal breaks, the Surety breaks in their place. Sureties are tattooed with the oaths they carry in fine brown script, so densely that the old ones look bruised from collarbone to ankle, and they are among the richest commoners in Oathen and almost all of them

are ruins. A Surety in the trade for twenty years has paid on a dozen defaults and carries them all: the fingerless hand of a grain-merchant's default, the wired jaw of an envoy's lie, the hooked spine of a quartermaster's failed delivery.

On the Rim the trade has a second market. Foreign merchants crossing Oathen hire Sureties at Mumchance to stand behind the conditional phrases they will certainly get wrong. Paper-brokers buy the fees of a Surety's future bonds in advance, at a discount, and so own a share in the Surety's body. And a principal who has knowingly defaulted on a Surety is called **sold**, and no Surety in the land will stand for them again; the sold drift west along the Rim, where their word means nothing and nobody can read the bruise-script on the people they broke.

Read off the skin of Bondling Arrah Dune, Surety, aged twenty-six, at the Surety House in Tacit, in the Lack of 640, by a clerk of the Compact, for the settling of her bonds after her death. The clerk read aloud, as the Compact requires, and a second clerk wrote. The cause of death is entered as "the weight of the work," which is the Compact's phrase, and which the clerk did not read aloud.

Left forearm: For Bennick Osse, carter, that he will deliver forty bales to Mumchance by the first of Plenty. Kept. Below it: For Bennick Osse, that he will deliver sixty bales. Broken (the two smallest fingers of the left hand, taken in her sleep; she was paid two lacks).

Right shoulder: For Liss and Paver Hume, their marriage, forty pages, summary only: fidelity, provision, the raising of children. Kept seven years. On the eighth, broken at the second article (ribs, three, cracked; she carried on).

Belly: For an Oathen merchant whose name was cut out of the skin by a Clausewright's order, that he will feed his household through the Lack. Broken. (Here the second clerk notes: belly opened at the navel and closed by a surgeon; scar like a mouth.)

Throat, under the jaw, very small: For her mother, that she would come home before dark. No fee. Kept every night for nine years. Kept on the last night also. The clerk notes that it is kept.

◇

Lot nine. Sound. Feeds well. Declines politely. Do I
hear forty?

TOBIAH NETHERCOTT, AFTER LAST BELL

BEHIND THE STOCKYARDS

After Last Bell at Gristmoot, when the lawful market has closed and the Company’s toll-men have gone to supper, lamps are lit in the stockyards at the western end of the town and a second market opens in the pens. It is not on the Company’s ledgers. It is a bowshot and a half from the road, which is to say just outside Company law, a distance measured every year by the auctioneer, Tobiah Nethercott, with a knotted rope. Its stock stands in the pens, washed and fed and wearing a numbered tag on a string. Its buyers stand on the rails and bid by raising a crumb-loaf. The lots are always adults, by the auctioneer’s rule, which he states before every sale and which nobody has ever seen him break; it is the only rule he has, and he is very proud of it.

What is sold behind the stockyards is never a person, by name. It is a debt, a bond, a manifest, a contract of service, a term of years, a pledge on a body, or “a lot.” Sometimes it is a Blank, under a sack, sold as “the meat of a fasting animal.” Sometimes a buyer from Lastgate bids on an Unfed for her heart, and a buyer from the Vigil bids against her for the eyes, and Nethercott, who is a fair man, sells the lot to both. Some buyers want company, of the adult and unspoken kind, and Nethercott does not ask what kind and neither does the lot. The crowd is quiet. The bidding is quick. Afterward, the buyers say the grace with the lots they have bought, because they are about to eat together on the road, and it would be the universal insult not to.

DIO ON THE BLOCK TONIGHT	
1	A Company manifest: a vat-man of Saltbridge who stole a platter’s worth of tallow, sold at the price of the tallow. He is weeping, very quietly, and smells of marrow.
2	The debt of a Fatlands drover, two hundred lacks, due on the dusk shift this Carving. Bought, it is the buyer’s to call in, or to forgive. Nobody here forgives.
3	A Foundling soldier’s contract, nine years to run. He was born last spring, at thirty. He stands to attention in the pen and does not understand the bidding.
4	“The meat of a fasting animal,” under a sack. It declines, three times, every offer the auctioneer makes for it, in a woman’s voice.
5	A Vigil nudger, sold by her own hiring-master: nineteen, quick, pricked all over, three seasons of Bed-Due owed on her mother. She has been awake four days. She thinks the buyers are lamps.
6	A sold principal of Oathen, the Surety who broke for him standing at the rail to watch. She bids against everyone. She cannot afford him. She does not stop.
7	A Brinehollow man, Tenanted, sold by his own wife. He is courteous to every bidder and thanks the buyer by name. He has never been told the buyer’s name.
8	A Kept man’s arms, the right and the left, sold separately, shipped down from Lastgate in a cask of brine to settle his debt. South of the Drop they should have finished. They are still lively, and in the cask they hold hands.
9	A naming-right, from Kest: a healthy birth expected next pang. The seller is the mother. She is not pregnant. She will be by the pang.
10	An Unfed man, plump, healthy, nine years in a holding-house, sold on by a surgeon who is leaving the country. He has begun to enjoy his meals. He asks the crowd whether his wife is here.

RUNNING THE TRADE IN PEOPLE

The trade in people is the Rim's deepest horror because it is ordinary: everyone in it is polite, paid, and following a law. Run it as tragedy, never spectacle. Stay with the buyer's ease, the lot's manners, the family at home, the arithmetic.

Dread. Watching a sale behind the stockyards is Dread 2. Watching a lot you know being sold, or seeing a holding-house, is Dread 3. Taking part in a sale, as buyer, seller or witness, is a Dread 3 check the first time; on a failure, the Fray gained is marked as **complicity**, and the next time the character sees the lot, or anyone like them, the Carver may call for a Dread 1 check that cannot be passed with a Grace.

Buying a debt. A Guest may buy anyone's debt, bond or term behind the stockyards at the debt's face value, Haggled as usual. They may then forgive it, which ends it, or call it, which hands the debtor to the dusk shift, the Dry Fleet, the Bed-Due or the Company's wagons. A forgiven debtor is free, and hated by everyone who could have bought them.

Being sold. A Guest who defaults on a Company debt, is made cargo, or is caught on the wrong side of a poacher's net, is a lot. Their price is listed above. Their way out is an adventure.

Children. Children are caught in every part of this trade, as nudgers, as Blanks, as names not yet given. Keep their suffering off the block and out of the operating room: show it through the adults who sold them, carry them, miss them and come for them.

▼ RELICS AND GODFLESH

Every land believes another land's curse might cure its own. Nothing has ever worked.

The trade never slows.

— THE RIM ROAD, IN A SENTENCE



Relics are pieces of the Providers, or of people far enough into the Regrowth that the difference no longer matters, or of places and instruments that the god has soaked into. They are never Common. Most are illegal somewhere. All are Tainted. The prices given are what a dealer would ask, if a dealer could be found who was willing to sell. They go round and round the Rim from inn to inn, worth more every circuit, because the land that made them will rarely have them home.



DO NOT OPEN ANYTHING.

THE COMPANY'S STANDING ORDER AT THE CHUTE,
POSTED IN EVERY FACTOR'S OFFICE, AND THE
NEAREST THING THE RIM HAS TO A RELIC LAW

A HAND-LINE FINGER

Cost: 1,200 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 2

A grey finger with nine joints, taken from a Hand-line noble in the Course, still cold. Touched to a lock, a lid or a door, it closes it, and nothing opens it again without breaking it. Touched to a candle, the candle finishes. Touched to a person outside

Sallowreach, it does nothing, and the wielder takes a Dread 2 check from the way it flexes. Capital crime in Sallowreach. The Mortuary Court counts its nobles' fingers.

A BOTTLED HUSH

Cost: 2,500 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** Dread 4

A stoppered jar of air from the edge of Dunmere Hush. Unstoppered, it makes a silence ten paces across for one minute: no sound carries, flames go out, flies drop. Any Kept inside it finishes, completely and properly. The Finishers will kill for one. The Court calls every jar a stolen license. The jar is always slightly too heavy.

A BITING LOAF

Cost: 20 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 1 Hunger, 1 Dread

Toothed-wheat bread baked with the teeth left in. Set on a windowsill or in a doorway, it bites anyone who enters uninvited (attack +4, damage 1, Ripping). Granny Cracknel bakes them for widows. After a week, the loaf has grown a second row.

A JAR OF TENANTED BRINE

Cost: 400 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 3 Regrowth (Dromm)

Water coughed at dawn by one of the Tenanted. Held to the ear, it can be heard talking, slowly, in a voice like a hull settling. A character who listens for an hour may ask one question about the sea, the Trench, or the Tenant, and is answered truthfully. They must then pass a Grim (18) Caul + Resolve roll or walk west the next night.

A LASH FROM THE EYE OF ISS

Cost: not for sale (offers start at 10,000 L) · **Avail.:** Unique · **Taint:** 4 Regrowth (Iss)

A black hair a yard long, stiff as wire, one of the few that survived the Eye-lines' meal. Laid across a sleeper's lids in the Vigil, it lets them sleep and wake again, once, safely. The eye in the long room will have seen them. The Warden-Prime knows where every lash is, and there are three.

A CAUL-SCRAP VEIL

Cost: 600 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Vey)

A square of membrane cut from a Caul-line noble, stitched to a hat-brim. Through it the wearer sees a few heartbeats ahead, blurred: once per scene, reroll any one die. Each day it is worn, roll a d10; on a 1, the veil has grown into the skin of the brow. Duchess Morwen's veil has lately gone red. So have the scraps.

A SAYER'S WORD SEALED IN WAX

Cost: not for sale (20,000 L if it were) · **Avail.:** Unique · **Taint:** Dread 3

A ball of gold wax the size of a walnut, sealed by the Bench of Clauses, containing a single word spoken by a Sayer into it before the bit went back in. Crack it, and the word is so. Known words in

private hands: *Stop, Shut, Mend, Mine*. Nobody knows the scope of any of them. One is rumoured to say *Enough*.

AN ORRUM CRUMB

Cost: 150 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** Dread 2; see text

A crumb of bread from one of the Host's tables, picked up off the cloth by a Tablebreaker before the axe fell. While carried, the holder's Hunger cannot rise above 5 and they never feel hungry. If it is ever eaten, the character is a guest, and must pass an Impossible (26) Caul + Resolve roll or sit at the next table they see, forever. It smells of fresh bread for six hundred years.

A PLACE CARD BEARING YOUR NAME

Cost: not for sale · **Avail.:** Unique · **Taint:** Dread 3

A stiff cream card, a fine hand, your name spelled correctly. Nobody sells these; they are found. While a character keeps it, every host on the Table must offer them a seat (+4 Persuade for hospitality), and wherever they sleep, a table is laid by morning. Burning it does nothing. It is on the next table.

GRANNY CRACKNEL'S MATCHED TEETH

Cost: 80 L a set · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 1 Hunger, 2 Dread

A full set of teeth milled from toothed wheat, matched by Granny Cracknel to someone she knew. Held in the mouth for a night, they give the holder that person's last meal and last sight in a dream. Pell Hogget has bought eleven sets from Low Tilt. The last sight is always the same field at dusk.

ILSE MARL'S CHART

Cost: not for sale · **Avail.:** Unique · **Taint:** Dread 3

Forty years of transcriptions of the Tenanted's low-water song, laid end to end: a chart of the Uncovered, with depths no sea has ever had there. A navigator using it crosses the Uncovered without rolling and can find the Trench and a stone table with eight chairs. Studying it for a week allows a character to hum the song; anyone Tenanted who hears them stops and turns.

A SHARD OF HALLOWBOARD

Cost: 3,000 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** Dread 2

A hand-sized fragment of the eight-sided stone table of the Refusal, always clean, always faintly warm. No table of Orrum's can be laid within a hundred paces of it. The Abstinent say Hollowboard has never been chipped; therefore this is a fake, or Hollowboard is lying. A Reckoner who sees it in Godeater hands will kill to return it.

A FIRST LACK

Cost: 1,000 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 1 Regrowth (one god, by grain)

A god-lack: a coin cut from a Provider's own bone in the first year after the Gorging, cured in no salt at all. Worn on a cord, it gives +1 to Godsign rolls involving its god. Spent, it gives the

merchant who takes it that god's Taste for a month. They circulate anyway; somebody always mistakes one for change. (The older Dole lacks of the seventh year of the Lack, yellow and smooth, are not god-bone and carry no Taint; collectors pay 200 L for one, and do not keep it long.)

OSSEL'S KNUCKLEBONES

Cost: 2,000 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 1

Five dice cut from a joint of the Closing Hand. Thrown for a question about when something will end, they answer truly. Thrown for a person, they show the number of years before their death; in Sallowreach they always roll blank.

DROMM'S EAR-STONE

Cost: 700 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Dromm)

A pale stone from the Fathom's inner ear, hauled up at Longslab. Its holder always knows which way the sea is and how far, and feels pressure days a full day early. In the last year it has begun to point down.

A DOWAGER CLOD

Cost: 250 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Hunger

A clod of warm earth from the Dowager Hills, cut from a Seated Gut-line matriarch. Planted, anything grows from it overnight, plump and red-veined. If the matriarch is consulted first, she may agree. If not, the crop has her opinions.

A THIEF'S KEPT HAND

Cost: 120 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** Dread 2

Taken by Marrow Jack from a Kept pickpocket who was asleep on a shelf. Worn in a glove harness, it gives +2 Filch. Its owner, still in Lastgate, can feel everything it does, and is trying to find you.

A DORMITORY PILLOW

Cost: 1,500 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 3 Regrowth (Iss)

Smuggled out from under one of the Counted. A Dream-Diver who sleeps on it goes down and returns without a tether, once per dive, for an hour. Owning it in the Vigil is a capital crime. It is still warm, and it still smells of someone.

BED ONE'S WORDS

Cost: not for sale · **Avail.:** Unique · **Taint:** Dread 4

Matron Cecily Dorm's notebook of what Aveline Morne's lips have shaped. Most of it is a baker's daughter's recipe for bread. The last page is a list of names, and they are being crossed off in an order the Matron cannot see the reason for. One is a player character's.

A LIVING PART IN A JAR

Cost: 200 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Vey), 1 Dread

A Cradlewrack Part, healthy and warm: an ear, a hand, a length of spine. It turns in the jar toward other Parts and toward the

Assemblers' Barn, a compass to the figure. The Assemblers pay double. The Attendance seizes it and the buyer.

A YARD OF LIVING CORD

Cost: 300 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Vey)

Cut, with permission, from one of the Uncut. Tie it between two people and for a day they share damage: each hit is split between them, and so is every Dread check. The cord pulses. It wants to grow back to the one it came from.

A SAYER'S GOLD BIT

Cost: 5,000 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** none

Garl Tome's work, worn and then outgrown by a Sayer. Fitted to any mouth, it prevents speech from binding: Oathen's rule does not touch the wearer, nor does a Sayer's word they hear. The wearer cannot eat or speak clearly. The Bench wants all of them back.

AN ECHO-STONE OF SWORN GORGE

Cost: 50 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** Dread 3

A pebble from Sworn Gorge that has soaked up the echo. Held to the ear, it repeats the oath of 419 A.G., too faint to understand. Anyone who listens for a full minute is bound by it. Nobody knows what they have sworn. Halvar Stane buys them to grind into sand.

A PUDDLE OF OLD WET TOM'S

Cost: 40 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 1 Regrowth (Dromm)

A corked flask of water that followed Old Wet Tom down a corridor. Poured out, it makes a puddle much deeper than the floor. Things can be dropped into it and are gone. Something in it can be heard, very far down, asking for the cork back.

WREN HOLLOWELL'S HAIR

Cost: 900 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** none

A lock of the Fasting Girl's hair, sold by someone who got close. A Blank relic: worn at the throat, it lets the wearer ignore Hunger Taint and gain no Hunger from the first Partake each day. Owning it is proof of having dealt with the Blank trade. The Thin kill for it, the Board pays for it, and the girl wants it back.

A DUNMERE BIRD

Cost: 60 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** Dread 1

A sparrow that fell at the edge of Dunmere Hush, perfectly dead and perfectly whole, uncorrupting. In Sallowreach it is the only finished thing most people have ever seen, and collectors keep them under glass. Kept who hold one weep without moisture.

THE SCARECROW'S STRAW

Cost: 30 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 2 Hunger, 2 Dread

A handful of straw from the Scarecrow of Low Tilth, taken at night by a dare. Scattered in a field, it shows on the next dusk which

person will be Reaped there. Held in a pocket, it tells the land where you are.



*If you have to ask what it was, you cannot afford
what it will do.*

MAGS WEIR, FROM THE DECK OF HER HULK

RELICS OF THE ROAD

The relics below are the newest on the Rim's stalls: things the trade itself has made, from coin and paper and rope and bread, in the last few years, as the Regrowth quickens and the god begins to soak into the instruments of buying and selling.

A LETTERED LACK

Cost: 400 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** Dread 2

One of three hundred coins from a batch Factor Orsolya Tare has held back at the Cure-House, in which the bone grew letters in its grain during the cure. Each spells a name. Every Carving the name changes, overnight, to the name of someone who will be Reaped that season in the land where the coin lies. Reading it needs a lamp and an Eye + Lore roll at Hard (14). The Renderers' Union wants the batch shipped; Pell Hogget would give his farm for one; the Cullmasters would like to know whether the coin follows the list, or the list the coin.

A NIGHT-CUT ROPE

Cost: 180 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Dromm)

An anchoring rope cut in the night by its sleeper's own hand, though no knife was ever found. Tied at the wrist, it makes its wearer go uncounted: they are not missed at roll-calls, morning counts or watches, and pursuers who know them are at -4 to notice they have gone. Each night it is worn, roll a d10; on a 1 the wearer wakes at the nearest water, and nobody noticed them leave. Wreckwives burn these on sight.

A REAPED SHOE

Cost: 150 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 2 Hunger, 1 Dread

After every Reaping, single shoes are found at the edges of the far fields, never pairs. Worn on one foot, a Reaped shoe lets its wearer walk a dusk-shift field and come back: the field takes someone else instead. Each day it is worn, the foot inside grows warmer and softer and harder to lift from the ground; after a season, it has put down roots. Debtors on the Cullmasters' lists pay everything they have for one, and their neighbours watch to see who goes in their place.

A KEY FROM THE SEEMING

Cost: 500 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 1 Regrowth (Iss), Dread 3

In 638 a whole street of the Slope Seemed a door in a blank wall, and the Seeming was entered in the public record as news. When the

street stopped seeing it, a key was found on the cobbles. Once per session, if three or more people with Fray 4 or more agree that a door is there, the key opens it, and the door is real until it is shut. Where the doors lead is the Carver's choice and is never quite where the users meant. Mirela Sconce has asked for it back for the record.

A VOID NAMING-RIGHT

Cost: 90 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** Dread 3

A Tally certificate for a birth that was taken to the Lying-In, with the name the holder chose still written on it. The birth was never named, and it knows it. Spoken aloud anywhere in Cradlewrack, the name brings something to the nearest closed door, which knocks, three times, politely, and waits. It can be asked one question through the door and answers in the voice of the person who sold the right. Asking it in is a choice.

A SNAPPED NOTE

Cost: 150 L · **Avail.:** Scarce in Tacit · **Taint:** Dread 2

A sworn note on which the issuer defaulted. The paper crackles faintly when folded, with the sound of the break. A new note written and sworn on its back is backed by the original issuer's body as well as the new one's: if the new issuer defaults, the old one breaks again, at the next apt part, wherever they are. Paper-brokers deal in these quietly. The Bench calls it the sale of a man without his presence, and has not found a law against it.

A PRICE-WITNESS'S PLATE

Cost: 700 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 1 Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 1

The brass collar-plate of a Tongue-line price-witness who, in forty years, never said one untrue thing. Worn, it carries Tolm's attention with it. Any bargain struck in its hearing, anywhere on the Table, binds both parties as a Weight 1 oath, with its Breaking, even outside Oathen. Merchants pay a great deal to wear one into a negotiation. The Company would pay more to have them all, and Lysander Coyle has begun to ask whether a road could be sworn by brass instead of by a notary.

AN UNCLAIMED CHIT

Cost: 3 L from a Crumb-Runner · **Avail.:** Uncommon in Wanting · **Taint:** Dread 2

A ration chit stamped for a household Mother Stint Avery has struck from the list. Wherever its carrier sleeps in the Fast, a wooden bowl is found beside them at dawn, full and warm, with a spoon. Eating from it removes every level of Starving and is an Invitation (see the Fast). Not eating from it is a Dread 1 check, each morning, at the smell. The struck household's names are carved on the spoon, in a fine hand.

A HOMING CRUMB

Cost: 15 L · **Avail.:** Uncommon in the Sinks · **Taint:** Dread 1

A crumb of Kept bone that cannot bear to be spent. Strung on a purse, it makes the purse impossible to lose for good: a stolen or dropped purse comes back to its owner within a day, under a pillow, in a boot, in the bread, greasy and full of flies. The thief's own purse comes too, sometimes. Marrow Jack's boys will not rob anyone who smells of the fen.

A NUDGER'S LEAD

Cost: 120 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 1 Regrowth (Iss), Dread 1

The leather lead of a hired child nudger who blinked on duty and did not come back, and whose bed-number is on the tag. Tied to the wrist, it tugs every twenty breaths, for ever: the wearer cannot blink, and is immune to the Vigil's blinks and to being put to sleep by any means. Once a day it tugs toward Bedside and the Dormitory instead, hard, and the wearer must pass a Dread 1 check or follow it for an hour.

THE CHUTE STAMP

Cost: 600 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 1 Hunger to whoever eats what it stamps

A cooper's iron stamp from Barrelnside, worn smooth, that reads BEEF. It has stamped over so many origins that it has come to

believe itself. Anything stamped with it passes inspection as beef: Eye rolls to identify what it really is are at -6, and Hob Gristle himself must taste twice. It works on things that are not meat. The Renderers' Union wants it back, very badly, and will not say what was the last thing stamped.

A STRANGER'S LOAF, UNBROKEN

Cost: 25 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** Dread 1

A Stranger's Loaf from a Gristmoot inn door that a traveller refused to eat, kept hard in a pack. While it is carried, the bearer can always leave: +4 to resist any Want, Invitation or kindness that would keep them where they are. Each day it is carried it weighs a little more. Gristmoot innkeepers will pay well to have one back. The house does not like to lose.

FURTHER LEAVINGS

The companion volume *Seven Tables* catalogues more than a hundred further leavings, with the full rules for knowing of them, carving them and keeping them. The ones the Guests are likeliest to see on an ordinary Rim stall, rather than in a vault or a Carver's coat, are these.

LEAVING	LAND	WORTH	WHERE ON THE RIM
Glove-Thread of the Left Hand	Sallowreach	30 L the inch	Fogmouth; every Seamer has a twist in a drawer
Mitten-Lead	Sallowreach	25 L a stone	Fogmouth, from Sinks pedlars
Bottled Rootkin Sap	Fatlands	8 L a phial	Gristmoot; sold on perfumers' shelves
First Marbling	Fatlands	15 L a crock abroad	the Groaning Board's kitchens
Dry Jonah's Blue Label	Brinehollow	80 L a bottle in the Vigil	Lampwick Halt, under the counter
A Longslab Stone	Brinehollow	2 L	Lowmark Spur; unlucky, and bought anyway
Sleepers' Mile Moss	the Vigil	30 L a wad	Lampwick Halt; legal on the Rim
Lip-Clay of the Dilation	Cradlewrack	15 L the jar	Knocking Gate
Gullet Sand	Oathen	80 L the pouch	Mumchance; the Bench forbids its export
A Scratched Vow	Oathen	30 L	everywhere east; nobody reads the slab first
Barrow-Hair Rope	the Fast	25 L the fathom	Wanting Post, to pilgrims who cut it
A Stone of the Hem	the Rim	60 L	anywhere the masons are slow

▼ MERCHANTS OF THE TABLE

Never buy from a merchant who says the grace first. He wants something.

— RIM ROAD ADVICE

These dealers can be dropped into any market scene. Each has a specialty: items in that line are one step more available from them, and they will buy such goods at three-quarters of the listed price instead of half.

MARDY HAUNCH, SAUSAGE-WIFE OF GRISTMOOT

MARDY HAUNCH Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (cleaver 3, Ripping) · Armor 1 (suet) · Dread 0

Stock: Fatlands meat, toothed bread, Chute barrels, marrow-brandy. She has the widest stall on the Rim and has never once stood up behind it. Everything she sells is settling. She buys tattooed casings at a premium and will not say who for; it is Hob Gristle, who is trying to give them back to their families.

ABELARD MYRRH, PERFUMER OF THE LOWER PILINGS

ABELARD MYRRH (KEPT) Threat 4 · Flesh 9 · Guard 9 · Attack +2 (awl 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

Stock: cedar, vinegar, smoke-oils, Kept gauze, Seamer's lacquer. His own nose rotted off in 340 A.G. and he blends entirely by memory, which is perfect. For 40 L he will make a scent from a dead person's clothes that convinces any Kept who smells it that they are home and loved. The Court has asked him to stop selling it to the Lofts. He has not.

NAN PICKERING, LIMB-BROKER

NAN PICKERING Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (shelving hook 3, Hooking) · Armor 1 · Dread 2 (her drying-racks)

Stock: Kept limbs, seamed parts, Thief's Kept Hands, Seamer's kits. She buys from Marrow Jack and sells to back-alley seamers in Lastgate's undercity. Every limb on her racks is labelled with its owner's name, because she is honest. Some of the owners come to visit. She charges them admission.

MAGS WEIR, SALVAGE QUEEN OF THE UNCOVERED

MAGS WEIR Threat 4 · Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (harpoon 4, Hooking) · Armor 1 (oilskin) · Dread 0

Stock: wreck goods, salvage-tins, Netwatch gear, Dromm's Ear-Stones, Tenanted brine. She sells from a beached hulk two miles out on dry seabed. Her newest salvage came from a wreck that sank before the Gorging: a crate of silverware in services of eight. She has sold seven settings. The eighth keeps coming back to the crate.

LUCAN SPILL, THE OILMAN

LUCAN SPILL Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (sword 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

Stock: lamp oil by the cask, mirror-lanterns, lamp-flasks. He is the supplier who doubled the price to the Vigil, and Garron Ashlock would kill him if killing him would not stop the oil. His new oil burns brighter and smells of low tide. It is rendered on the Uncovered from things with too many ribs, and the lamps that burn it have begun to drip seawater.

DOVEY PINCH, PIN-SELLER OF THE SLOPE

DOVEY PINCH Threat 3 · Flesh 9 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (Waker's needle 2, Waking) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: pins, pin-gloves, Waker's needles, rouse-tabs, hired nudgers by the hour. Seventy, sharp-eyed and pricked all over, she sells pain as a convenience. Her needles are recovered from dead Wakers, and each still remembers the last person it kept awake; if you stick yourself with one, you see their face.

TAMSIN KEYLESS, LOCK-PEDLAR

TAMSIN KEYLESS Threat 3 · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +3 (hatchet 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: locks, bolts, bricks, mortar, knocker's rings, counterfeit Agnes Latch locks. Her copies hold for a night, sometimes two. She does not mention that they hold only from the outside, and that what she sells to frightened mothers in Kest is not a way to keep things out but a way to keep them in.

RUTH NINEFOLD, NAME-BROKER OF KEST

RUTH NINEFOLD Threat 5 · Flesh 10 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: naming-rights, Tally extracts, Attendance birth-fees on credit, living Parts in jars. She owns the rights to name two hundred births. Several were taken to the Lying-In. One was bought from a clay-digger at the rim of the Dilation, and its year is up at the next pang.

SILAS AMEND, PAPER-BROKER OF TACIT

SILAS AMEND Threat 5 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (quill-knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: sworn notes at a discount, Surety introductions, spyglasses, wax tablets, the occasional Snapped Note. He speaks only in conditionals and watches issuers' bodies from the opposite cliff. He has quietly bought every note ever sworn by a single senior Clausewright of the Bench, and intends to call them all on one morning.

NAY-SAYING HOBBS, THE DECLINING GROCER

HOBBS Threat 3 · Flesh 8 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 (his shelves)

Stock: ration-bread, Unfed greys, frost-markers, Tablebreaker's wedges. Wanting's only shop, run by an Unfed elder who declines every sale three times as custom requires. Sometimes he declines a fourth. His shelves are fuller than the Pantry's, and he cannot say who restocks them overnight. He does not sell the bread that appears on the top shelf. He throws it into the wind.

FACTOR ORSOLYA TARE, MISTRESS OF THE CURE-HOUSE

ORSOLYA TARE Threat 5 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (knife 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

Stock: platters at par, new-minted lacks by the barrel, clipped coin bought by weight, First Lacks under the counter. She runs the Company's mint at Saltbridge and smells of boiled bone. Last month a coin-cutter brought her a fresh-cured lack with letters in the grain, as though the bone had grown them. It was a name. She has had the batch held back (see A Lettered Lack), and the Renderers' Union keeps asking where it went.

MISTER CUTLERY

MISTER CUTLERY Threat 6 · Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Attack +6
(Clausewright's quill-knife 2, Silent) · Armor 1 · Dread 1

Stock: relics and godflesh of every land, laid out on velvet in a silverware case. A soft-voiced man in a silk mask with a silver fork embroidered on it, he travels the Rim in a black coach and sells to nobles. He will buy back anything he sold at triple its price, provided the seller names exactly where it came from. He is cataloguing the gods for the Second Table, one portion at a time. There is one thing he will not buy at any price, and if it is offered to him he closes his case and leaves the market, and does not come back for a year.



*Bought: cauls, teeth, hair, names, minutes, nails. Sold:
the same, dearer. Asked: nothing.*

A SLATE AT THE DRY ANCHOR, BRACKWATER BRIDGE

MORE MERCHANTS OF THE RIM

ABNER WEDGE, ARMS-MAN OF FOREIGN ROW

ABNER WEDGE Threat 4 · Flesh 15 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (axe 4, Brutal) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

Stock: crossbows, bolts, cleavers, warden's maces, boiled leather, second-hand mail of uncertain provenance. A Gristmoot Fatlander broad as a door who eats brawn while he sells and offers it to every customer. He sells to anyone, including the quiet women in grey who buy six bolts at dawn, and he has started to feel bad about it, which in a Fatlander shows as a loss of appetite. He has lost eleven pounds. His neighbours are worried.

GASPARD THIMBLE, SEAMER OF FOREIGN ROW

GASPARD THIMBLE Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +4
(Seamer's awl 2, Piercing) · Armor 2 (wire-coat) · Dread 1

Stock: thread, wire, lacquer, Seamer's kits, matched fingers on a cork board. A living Seamer from Lastgate who keeps a booth at Gristmoot and another at Fogmouth. His boy, Kit, cries the stock in a voice that was stitched back wrong after it broke. Gaspard did it on purpose: Kit was sold to him for a debt of his father's, and a boy whose voice nobody can understand cannot ask a customer for help.

Kit has learned to write. He writes on the backs of the price-slates, very small.

WIDOW PROSPER GAMMAGE, CURE-SELLER OF GRISTMOOT

PROSPER GAMMAGE Threat 4 · Flesh 16 · Guard 9 · Attack +2
(ladle 1) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

Stock: "safe" food sworn untainted, charms against the Calling, Orrum crumbs (fake), Wren Hollowell's hair (fake), cures for everything. The queen of Cure-Sellers' Lane, enormous and motherly, she has never sold a true cure in her life and does not believe there is one. She swears on her mother's bones that her stew is clean of the god. Her mother's bones are in the stew. She is, technically, not lying, and she says the grace before every sale.

YARROW FITCH, MONEY-CHANGER OF THE WEEPING POST

YARROW FITCH Threat 4 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: coin of every land changed at a crumb in the lack, coin-testers' kits, shut-mouths for collectors, minutes of Closing bought cheap from the north. A thin wet man at the always-wet post between Cradlewrack and Fogmouth, with a crescent bitten into his front teeth and a reference pouch of Rim grains sewn inside his shirt. He can read the grain of a lack by tongue. He keeps the person-lacks in a separate purse and will not spend them; the purse is very heavy, and he has started to hear it at night.

BETTRIS CAULFIELD, CAUL-MERCHANT OF KNOCKING GATE

BETTRIS CAULFIELD Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3
(hooked knife 3, Ripping) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

Stock: birth-cauls by the crate, cauls sewn into coats, caul-poultices, knocker's rings. She buys cauls from highland families at eight lacks and sells them at the Spur as proof against the Calling at thirty. They do not work. Lately the Caul-line houses sell to her too, and their cauls are larger, and warmer, and one in her current crate has begun, very slowly, to grow over her hand when she lifts it.

SABINE LISLE, GLASS-WIFE OF LAMPWICK HALT

SABINE LISLE Threat 4 · Flesh 9 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (dazzle-mirror; Waker's needle 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: lenses, spectacles, mirror-lanterns, dazzle-mirrors, lid-lamps, rouse. A Vigil glass-wife who keeps the last stall before the plateau road and has not slept in thirty-one years. She grinds spectacles that let the sleepless see what is really in front of them for an hour, instead of the Seeming. The customers who buy them come back the next day to return them, and will not say what they saw.

HONOR PYLE, SURETY-BROKER OF MUMCHANCE

HONOR PYLE Threat 5 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 (her roster)

Stock: Sureties for hire to foreigners entering Oathen, by the day or the crossing; cards of safe phrases; quiet-drops; felt slippers. A Bondsman retired at forty with her jaw wired and both knees reversed, she now rents other people's bodies to merchants who will certainly say something careless in the canyons. Her roster is chalked on a slate by the inn door, each name with a count of what they have left. She is good to her Sureties. She buries them at her own expense.

FORGO AINSLEY, CHIT-DEALER OF WANTING POST

FORGO AINSLEY Threat 3 · Flesh 8 · Guard 12 · Attack +2 (grain-sock cosh 2, Stunning) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: ration chits bought and sold, Unclaimed Chits (see Relics), Rim grain at the Company's risk premium, Barrow-Hair

Rope. An Unfed man who stands in the yard at Wanting Post every day of the Lack season, buying spare chits from families on the list and selling them to families off it, declining every price three times. He is spat on twice an hour. He has never kept a chit for himself, and he is so thin now that the Crumb-Runners have started leaving bread at his post. He throws it into the wind.

TOBIAH NETHERCOTT, AUCTIONEER BEHIND THE STOCKYARDS

TOBIAH NETHERCOTT Threat 5 · Flesh 13 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (cudgel 3, Stunning) · Armor 1 · Dread 2 (his calm)

Stock: debts, bonds, manifests, terms of service, "lots." A courteous, tidy Gristmoot man with a knotted rope to measure the distance from the road, a gavel of Fatlands bone, and one rule: no lot under age. He has kept it for twenty years and is proud of it. He believes this makes him a decent man. He has sold four thousand people, and he says the grace with every buyer, and he would like the Guests to know that he has never once been asked by a lot to stop.

▼ STRANGE ENCOUNTERS AT MARKET

Roll a d20 whenever the Guests spend time in a Rim Road market, or when a shopping scene needs something under the clove.

D20	ENCOUNTER
1	A Fatlands child is selling teeth by the cupful, sorted by village. She knows which village each cup is.
2	A Kept auctioneer in Lastgate is selling himself by the limb, to settle a debt from 300 A.G. The bidding is brisk.
3	A coin a character spent an hour ago is back in their purse. It is greasy and smells of the fen.
4	A Vigil customer blinks mid-haggle and comes back from the long room three stalls away, holding a knife, with no idea why.
5	A Brinehollow stall-keeper stops to bail. The brine she coughs into the bucket is moving in a slow circle.
6	An Oathener, asked the price, says "Too much" without thinking. His purse splits open at his belt.
7	A drover herds Sal Trotter's cattle through the market. One of them, passing, says a character's name.
8	Someone has set a table at the market cross: white cloth, warm bread, a chair pulled out. Two Tablebreakers are running towards it.
9	A Cradlewrack pedlar's crate has given birth. Nobody knows to what. It is under the cart.
10	A Price-witness offers his services, then quietly declines to witness a character's purchase, and will not say why.
11	The Company's toll-men are weighing every lack in the market. Clipped coin is confiscated, and so are three thumbs.
12	A Netwatch patrol drags a Called man through the stalls on a hook. He thanks every merchant he passes, courteously, by name.
13	A Seamer's boy offers a character a finger "that matches yours exactly." It does. Down to the scar.
14	Wick Tallow's candles on a stall all lean toward one shopper. The chandler's man goes pale and closes the stall.
15	A Reckoner is buying nothing, watching a Gut-line merchant's stall. She has been there since dawn.
16	A Wreckwife sells her Tenanted husband's clothes. He is helping her fold them.
17	A Purgation preacher hands out emetics and begs the crowd to throw up the god. Some do, on the spot. The Bailiff's men arrive.
18	A Fast pilgrim, starving, offers everything she owns for a single Orrum crumb. Someone has one.

- | | |
|----|---|
| 19 | A Cutwright with calipers measures customers' skulls for free, and quietly writes certain names in a separate book. |
| 20 | A stall that was not there an hour ago sells only one thing: place cards, in a fine hand. The one on top has a character's name on it. The stall-keeper is very tall, and stoops under the awning, and is warm. |
-

PAY THE TOLL. KEEP THE **PEACE.** SAY THE **GRACE.** AND
COUNT YOUR **CHANGE, BECAUSE** SOME OF IT WAS
SOMEBODY.

[THE THREE ARTICLES OF THE RIM, WITH THE FOURTH THAT EVERY MARKET
ADDS]

CHAPTER 15

THINGS THAT EAT AND ARE EATEN

Everything on the Table is either sitting at it or lying on it. Learn which you are before the knives come out.

— TABLEBREAKER SAYING, WANTING

REPORT OF THE THIRD NIGHT WATCH, NETWATCH, LOWMARK PIER-SECTION FOURTEEN. Entered by Lt. Sable Reef, 9th of Carving, 641 A.G. For the Admiralty Clerk of Losses. Not for the Bench.

Weather: salt rain from the second bell, fog off the Uncovered from the third. Pressure rising. Two of my hookmen bled from the ears before midnight and were sent to bail.

At the fourth bell the count came up short in Ropewalk Row. Widow Carse called her neighbour's name through the wall three times and got no answer, and then, she says, got an answer from the wrong side, from the floor. We broke the door. Bed empty, anchor-rope sawn through from underneath. Not cut. Sawn, as if by something with a very small and patient mouth. The cellar was full to the fourth stair with water that had no business being there at that hour and smelled of a harbour I have not smelled since I was a girl. Weed on the stairs, still moving. I wrote the time.

We took the shore road at the run. Found the Called at the end of the old breakwater, which ends now in nine miles of dry seabed, and which she was walking down as if the water were still there to receive her. Woman of forty, nightdress, barefoot, feet cut to ribbons on the shell and not caring. Hookman Dabb put the boathook through the back of her collar as taught and she did not fall. She kept walking and dragged him. A woman of nine stone dragged a man of fourteen stone forty yards on his knees across the shingle. When I got the second rope on her she turned her head and looked at me, and I am obliged to record that her face was perfectly calm and she was weeping out of her nose. Brine. A good deal of it.

We netted her and sat on her. She bailed in the net, unasked, a bucket and a half, and some of what came up was alive and went scuttling under the planking. Dabb stamped on two. He says the third had a face. Dabb has been on the Watch four years and I do not think he is a man for faces, so I have written it down.

At the fifth bell, while we were roping her for the cart, the Uncovered sang. I have heard it before. Everyone on the Watch has, and none of us mention it at muster. It comes up out of the dark where the sea used to be, low, a sound like a hull grinding on a bar, and it has a tune if you let it. Hookman Persey let it. He put his hook down very carefully, the way you put down something you mean to come back for, and he

started walking west. We got the rope on him at the tideline and he fought us harder than the woman had. He was crying and saying he was sorry, he was so sorry, they had been waiting such a long time.

On the walk back we passed something standing upright in the mud about a furlong out. In the lamp it looked like a wreck's keel with the ribs still on. It was not a keel. It had more ribs than a keel and they were opening and closing. We did not stop. I note for the Clerk that it was nearer the pier at the sixth bell than at the fifth, and that the Watch's standing orders do not cover it, and request that they be made to.

Called recovered: two, one of them my own man. Called lost: none tonight. Injuries: Dabb, bitten on the ankle by something under the planks, wound weeping salt, he swears it is nothing. Persey sleeps roped in the guardhouse. When I looked in on him at dawn the bucket beside him was full to the brim and he had not coughed once.

I would like it entered that I am not asking what the Called are walking toward. I am asking how much longer we are meant to pretend we are the ones doing the pulling.

S. Reef, Lt.

The Table is not short of monsters. It is short of anything else. Every land ate a god, and every land is now host to the slow return of what it swallowed, and that return does not confine itself to the bloodlines of the nobility. It gets into the soil, the weather, the drowned, the sleeping, the unborn and the overheard. It makes things. Some of those things were people a week ago. Some were never people at all, and some are people still, and are the worst of the lot.

This chapter is the GM's larder. It gives rules for running adversaries in the terms of the Grace Roll, then walks the seven lands one by one, presenting the horrors native to each with full statistics, a witness's word, and the unpleasant detail that makes them worth meeting: what they smell like, what they sound like in the dark, and what they leave for the family to find. After the lands come the human adversaries, who outnumber the monsters and do more harm, among them cult-shepherds and patient questioners. Then come the rules for the god-ridden; the Seated Gods, the endings of campaigns, and why nobody should expect to win against one; the lairs; and random encounters for every land and the Rim Road between.

◇

*Every monster on the Table was somebody's supper
once, or somebody's son. Usually both.*

HOB GRISTLE, THE HONEST BUTCHER

▼ RUNNING ADVERSARIES

THREAT AND THE QUICK LINE

Most adversaries do not need a full stat block. A Netwatch hookman, a field of toothed wheat or a mob of the Forsworn can be run from a single **quick line**, which gives everything needed at the table: **Threat, Flesh, Guard, Attack, Armor** and **Dread**. Threat is a flat bonus the adversary adds to every 2d10 roll that is not an attack: a Search to find a hidden player character, a Stealth to creep up on the camp, a Resolve against a Hush-walker's silence. Threat 1 is a frightened farmhand. Threat 3 is a trained professional. Threat 5 is the best in the land at their work. Threat 7 and above belongs to things that are no longer working at anything human.

Attack is the full bonus added to 2d10 against the target's Guard. Damage follows the core rules: the listed weapon damage, plus 2 for each Helping (every full 4 points the roll beats Guard), minus the target's Armor. Doubles on an adversary's roll produce a Grace or a Lack exactly as for player characters, and the GM should describe both with relish. A Netwatch hook that rolls a Grace has hooked a player character's collar and is dragging them. A Seated guest that rolls a Lack has knocked over the salt, and the whole table turns to look at who did it.

DREAD	DIFFICULTY	TYPICAL HORROR
0	none	An armed man, a thin dog, an honest threat
1	Routine 10	A Kept beggar, a toothed ear of wheat, a corpse
2	Hard 14	An Unstitched Kept, a Forsworn's opened ribs, a blink-murder
3	Grim 18	The Sump-thing rising, a Tenanted loved one, a table set for you
4	Dire 22	A Laden hill speaking, a crowning opening, a god's attention
5	Impossible 26	A Seating, the Host's face, any Seated god

Some horrors carry a **rising Dread**, written as "Dread 2/4". The first number applies on sight; the second applies when the thing does what it does (a Hush-walker's silence reaching the character, a Seeming turning to look at the one who imagined it). Others carry **Contagion**: anyone who sees a character Break in the creature's presence must make the Dread check again, and on failure takes on the same Derangement the Breaking character did. The Table's madness travels best in crowds.

FULL STAT BLOCKS

Important adversaries, monsters with Gifts and anything with a name receive a full stat block. These use the same six attributes as player characters (Hand, Gut, Lung, Eye, Tongue, Caul) and the same skills. Humans rarely exceed 5 in an attribute. Monsters, the Laden, the Tenanted and the deep Regrowth may run to 6, 8 or 10, and a Seated fragment of a god ignores the scale entirely. Flesh, Guard and Attack are calculated by the core formulas where the creature is anything like a body; where it is not (a field, a tide, an echo), the block says so and gives what is needed instead.

DREAD RATINGS

Every adversary carries a **Dread** rating from 0 to 5. The first time in a scene that a character perceives the thing clearly, they make a Dread check: Caul + Resolve against the difficulty the rating sets. Failure adds Fray equal to the rating; success adds 1; a Grace adds nothing. Many entries specify what, exactly, sets off the check, since a Tenanted judge in a courtroom is Dread 0 until her lower voice finishes her sentence before her upper one does.

◇

*You don't get used to it. You get used to the smell, and
you mistake the one for the other.*

A SEAMER'S APPRENTICE, LASTGATE

GODSIGN-POWERED CREATURES

Anything with the god in it can **Partake**. Creatures with a Cut are listed with it, and with a Hunger track exactly like a player

character's. Before any roll, the GM may Partake for the creature, adding one Tooth (a d6) or, for Cut 3+, two Teeth. Each Partake adds 1 Hunger, and every Tooth that shows a 1 adds 1 more. When a creature's Hunger reaches 10, it empties and the creature's **Regrowth rises by one**. For a monster this is not bookkeeping. It is escalation: the Sump-thing pulls three more drowned bodies into itself and gains Flesh, the Laden hill's mouth opens wider, the Waker gone mad stops blinking. Each entry describes what a Regrowth rise does to that creature. Players learn quickly that a monster which gambles on its Teeth is a monster that gets worse, and that sometimes the best tactic is to make it Partake.

Godsign creatures also have **Sops**. A creature that performs its Sop removes 1d6 Hunger, exactly as a player character does, and the Sop is always something the players would rather it did not do: close a child's eyes, eat the farmhand, take one more of the Called. Interrupting a Sop in progress is often the only way to break a creature's momentum.

MONSTER SPECIAL ABILITIES

The following abilities recur through the chapter. They are written in the core rules' terms and can be lifted onto any creature the GM builds.

- ◇ **Unending.** The creature does not die from Ruin. At 0 Flesh it is Undone: it stops acting for 1d6 rounds, then recovers 1d6 Flesh and resumes, unless it has been dismembered, sunk, Closed, or moved out of Sallowreach. Every Kept thing has this ability within Sallowreach's borders.
- ◇ **Swarm.** The creature is many. Blades and Brawl attacks deal only 1 damage regardless of Helpings; fire, smoke, flood and area effects deal double. A swarm reduced below half Flesh disperses and re-forms elsewhere next scene.
- ◇ **Hooking / Grapple (X).** On a hit with one or more Helpings, the target is held. Escaping is a Gut + Athletics or Lung + Athletics roll against difficulty X. A held target cannot move and suffers -2 to all rolls.
- ◇ **Engulf.** Against a held target, the creature's next hit pulls the victim inside it. Engulfed characters take the creature's damage automatically each round, ignoring Armor, and make a Dread check each round they remain.
- ◇ **Fray Aura (N).** At the start of each round within the creature's reach, every character must pass a Caul + Resolve roll against difficulty N or take 1 Fray. This is in addition to the first sight Dread check.
- ◇ **Pull (N).** The creature calls. Characters with the relevant Cut must roll Caul + Resolve against difficulty N each round or spend their action moving toward it. Resisting is not free: every success adds 1 Hunger, because the god in the blood wants to go.
- ◇ **Rooted.** The creature cannot move, but cannot be pushed, knocked down or held. It usually has enormous Flesh and a reach measured in fields.
- ◇ **Tide (N).** The creature's influence rises and falls. On the GM's turn, roll a d10: on N or less it acts twice this round. Things in Brinehollow and the Vigil have this.
- ◇ **Binding.** The creature's words count. When it speaks a sentence about a character and that character fails a Tongue + Clause roll (difficulty set in the entry), the sentence becomes physically true. Found only in Oathen and in very bad places elsewhere.
- ◇ **Hosting.** The creature offers. Any character who accepts anything it offers (food, a seat, shelter, "Come in") must roll Caul + Resolve against the listed difficulty or stay. Refusing three times grants +2 to the roll; thanking it imposes -4.
- ◇ **Known Voice (N).** The creature speaks in the voice of someone the listener loves, living or dead. Each time it does, the listener rolls Caul + Resolve against N or takes one step toward it, and a character who has sworn an Oath on the Dead in that person's name rolls at -2.
- ◇ **Leftovers.** Destroying the creature does not end it entirely. Some part (a hand, a face, a wick, a word) goes on, and the entry says what it does and who will pay to have it.
- ◇ **Riding.** The creature is a god wearing a person. It uses the rules for the god-ridden (see *The God-Ridden*, later in this chapter), and the person inside it can sometimes be called back by name.
- ◇ **Armor (type).** Some armor is not leather. Waxed flesh, bone lattice, compressed water and layered fat all count. Where an armor ignores a damage type (fat ignores blunt, water ignores blades), the entry says.
- ◇ **Helping Effects.** Many creatures list what their Helpings do in place of or alongside extra damage. A Flyfront that scores two Helpings does not deal +4 damage. It gets into the mouth.
- ◇ **Grace and Lack Effects.** Some entries list special results when the creature's own roll comes up doubles, or when a character's roll against it does. A character who rolls a Lack against a Hush-walker hears, for one awful second, nothing at all.

PUTTING THINGS DOWN

Killing is not the same in every land. Outside Sallowreach, a creature at 0 Flesh suffers Ruin and further damage kills it, as for any character. Inside Sallowreach nothing dies, and the only ways to finish anything are a Hand-line's Closing touch, a Hush, or carrying the thing across the border, where it drops at once. Many creatures in this chapter have a **Weakness** or an **End** entry, which describes the one way the people of that land have found to stop them. Some of those Ends are worse than the monster. Some are not ends at all, only delays, and the entry will say so.

WHAT IS LEFT

Most of the Table's horrors are discovered after the fact. The players arrive at a cottage, a cellar, a furrow or a bed, and somebody has to look. The table below gives the remains the GM can set in front of

them when a creature has been and gone, or when a victim's family brings the party in to see. Each is a Dread check at the listed rating, and each is a clue: read with Eye + Search (Hard 14), it names the kind of thing that did it.

D12	WHAT THE FAMILY FOUND	DREAD
1	A pair of shoes, laced, side by side, still warm inside; nothing else, not a hair	1
2	A bed with a body-shaped hollow, the sheets soaked with salt water that is still cold	1
3	The victim, laid out, eyes shut, hands folded; no wound, no rot, and no flies, ever	2
4	A face, flat as a mask, pressed into peat; the eyes in it still blinking	3
5	Every door, drawer, box and cupboard in the house standing open, and the body likewise	3
6	Bones, tidy, scraped white, stacked by length in the larder, each set with a napkin	3
7	A smooth patch of tilled soil the length of a man, warm, rising and falling	2
8	A man with his ribs folded inward, gently, as if the sea had leaned on him	2
9	A woman broken at every joint at once, two hundred breaks, and a contract by her hand	3
10	The victim alive, unharmed, smiling, and certain they have eaten the best meal of their life	2
11	A cradle with its blanket folded back, and in it something warm that is not the baby	4
12	Nothing at all; but everyone in the house remembers someone who was never born	4

THE GM'S LARDER: PACING HORROR

Every creature in this chapter is built to be survivable at first sight. The Dread check, not the attack roll, is where most of them do their damage. Use that. Let the players see the Sump bubble in patterns for a full session before anything comes up.

The best monster fights on the Table end without a death and with a cost: a player character's Hunger maxed out to win a single roll, a companion who Broke and is now certain their sister has been replaced, a field that now knows their name. Track those costs and bring them back.

When a creature's Hunger fills and its Regrowth rises mid-fight, describe the change before you describe its next action. The moment of transformation is the scene.

Smell first, sound second, sight last. The players should know what is in the cellar a full minute before the lamp shows them.

Remember that every creature here began as a meal, a mourner, a farmer or a child. Somebody on the Table loved it. Somebody is still bringing it dinner. Put that person in the scene.

▼ SALLOWREACH: WHAT WILL NOT FINISH



Every monster in the north began as a person or a thing that tried to end and was refused. They are not malicious, mostly. They are in pain, and they have been in pain for a very long time, and pain that long becomes a kind of weather. Remember that within Sallowreach all of these have **Unending** unless noted, and that nothing they do to a victim is ever finished either: the people they hurt are still somewhere, still feeling it, and some of them can be found.



May you finish. And if you can't, may you at least be shelved somewhere dry.

LASTGATE LEAVE-TAKING AMONG THE POOR

THE SUMP-THING

Weighted sacks go into the Sump by the hundred each year: the Kept too far gone for stitching, the unclaimed, the inconvenient. The sacks rot. The weights do not. Over decades, in the black peat-water forty feet down, the bodies find each other. Rotting flesh that cannot finish rotting goes soft as dough, and soft things press together under the fen's weight until there is no telling where one grandfather ends and the next begins. A Sump-thing is what happens when a few hundred of them agree to come up.

It surfaces first as bubbles in patterns: rings, then spirals, then the shape of a hand spread flat under the water. Then the smell, which is not the sweet Sallowreach rot but something older, sulphurous and vinegary, a pickle-jar opened after a century, with a bottom note of wet wool and the copper of old coins. Then the mound breaks

the surface, a slick dark heap twenty feet across, hair and sackcloth and peat-tanned leather stretched over a lattice of knitted bone, and out of it, everywhere, faces. Pressed flat. Mouths working. Some still have the twine of their labels around their necks, the ink long run, a name and a date of shelving. The sound it makes is a choir of drowned people trying to say their names through a lungful of fen, which comes out as a long wet gargle with words in it.

It wants to be *finished*, and it has learned that it cannot be, so it has settled for company. It drags the living down. Victims are not eaten. They are added. The process takes a week in the dark, and boatmen who have dragged the Sump for a lost brother on the third day have brought up something that was half him and half the mound, joined at the hip and the cheek, still breathing through both mouths. A week later a new face surfaces in the mound, and it is still screaming, and it will scream for centuries. Families who lose someone to a Sump-thing sometimes row out to listen for them, and sometimes hear.

Tactics: it rises under boats and walkways, grapples with dozens of arms, and sinks. It is slow on land but can drag itself up a bank like a slug of wet meat, leaving a furrow of black slime that smokes faintly in the cold. It does not flee. It has nowhere else to be.

From the daybook of the Sump-punt Patience, Seamers' Guild bounty boat. "Took up a face at the second bend, female, middle years, label reads 'Agnes — 409.' It would not stop asking whether her daughter had been told. We told it yes. We had no idea. Bounty six hundred. Agnes is in the cold-box. She is still asking."

SUMP-THING – THE MANY DROWNED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 9 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 0 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (the scraps of a hundred Hand-line servants) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Brawl 4, Endure 5, Stealth 4 (underwater only), Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 40 · Guard 12 · Armor 2 (peat-tanned hide; blades deal –1 more) · Threat 4
ATTACKS	Many Hands +7 (3, Grapple 18; it can attack three targets a round); Draw Down against a held target +7 (Engulf: 3 per round, drowning)
ABILITIES	Unending. Swarm-of-bodies: severed arms keep grabbing for 1d6 rounds. Fray Aura 14 when it surfaces. Known Voice 14: one face in the mound always belongs to someone a character has lost. Each character Engulfed for 3 rounds is Added and lost; their face appears next scene.
REGROWTH	when Hunger fills, it pulls 1d6 bodies from the bottom and gains 10 Flesh. At the Course its hands go grey and long and its grip begins to Close what it holds (each held round, a held character must pass Caul + Resolve 18 or lose 1 point of an attribute permanently, as some part of them finishes).
SOP	Adding a living person. Removes 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	3 (when it surfaces); 4 (on recognizing a face in it)
END	It cannot be killed. It can be cut apart and its pieces carried out of Sallowreach on the Rim Road, which takes a caravan, or lured into a Hush, which takes a sacrifice. The Seamers have a standing bounty of 600 lacks per recovered face.

HUSH-WALKERS

Edda Thrush walked out of Dunmere Hush. She was the first. She is not the last. A Hush-walker is a person who entered a Hush and did not finish, or a Kept body from inside a Hush that was somehow refused even there and stood up. They come out of the silence carrying it with them. A Hush-walker has no smell at all, which in Sallowreach is the most alarming thing about it: one notices a gap in the stink of the world, a person-shaped absence of rot, before one notices the person. Their skin is clean and pale and perfectly still, unrotted, every fly that lands on them dropping dead and unmoving. Their clothes do not stir in the wind. Their hair does not lift. They walk slowly. Their feet make no noise on boards. Their mouths move.

Within ten paces of one, sound stops. Not quiet: stopped. A scream comes out as breath. A drawn blade makes no ring. A heartbeat cannot be heard in one's own ears, and this is what breaks people: the body insists the heart has stopped. Swallowing makes no

sound, and people who have stood in the Silence report that they kept swallowing, over and over, to be sure the throat still worked. In that silence something is listening, the way Edda Thrush insists something listens through her. Victims who stay in the silence too long simply end. They sit down, close their eyes, and are properly, completely dead, with no rot afterward and no flies, and their families tend to envy them. They are found sitting upright in the road, faces calm, mouths a little open, as if they had heard the end of a song. Hush-walkers wander toward Hand-line estates. Nobody is sure if they are drawn there or sent.



My Da went into the quiet after her. He's sitting by the Glovehall road with his eyes shut and his face clean. Six weeks now. Not a fly on him. I go and sit with him. It's the best he's ever looked.

A REED-CUTTER'S DAUGHTER, TO THE HEIRS

HUSH-WALKER – THE SILENCE THAT GOT UP	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 0 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Hand-line, by contact) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 0 (it does not hunger; it does not Partake)
SKILLS	Instinct 5, Search 4, Resolve 6
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	a slow, gentle touch +4 (Closes: target makes Caul + Resolve 18 or suffers Ruin at once and, outside of Sallowreach's protection, dies)
ABILITIES	The Silence (10 paces): no sound; Tongue rolls impossible; Partaking costs double Hunger as the god in the blood strains toward the stillness. Each round in the Silence, Caul + Resolve 14 or take 1 Fray and lose the next action to listening. NOT Unending: a Hush-walker reduced to 0 Flesh lies down and is finished, and the ground under it becomes a Hush a yard across.
DREAD	2 on sight / 4 on entering the Silence
END	Damage it enough. The problem is getting near enough to do it, and the hole it leaves behind. Pim Sorrel's touch makes them kneel.

THE FLYFRONT

Flies are Sallowreach's weather, and a Black Noon is its storm. A Flyfront is a mass of carrion-flies thick enough to put out lamps, rolling across the fen at walking pace with a sound like frying fat. It is not a creature in the ordinary sense, but it behaves as one: it hunts. Everything in Sallowreach rots and never finishes, so the flies never finish breeding, and the oldest fronts are centuries old, and have a direction. They come down on the living because the living are warm and wet and still have their soft parts. Within a minute a person is black with them, flies in the eyes, the ears, the nostrils, the throat, a thick crawling paste that has to be scraped off with a knife. The taste is the worst of it, survivors say: bitter, buttery, and moving. The Kept caught in a front come out the other side with their faces gone to lace, lips and eyelids eaten to a fringe, the teeth showing in a permanent grin. The living come out choking up maggots for a week, and some of them, in the second week, find eggs hatching in the corners of their eyes. Justice Ever Lathe's colony is said to have come from a front, which raises questions about what fronts want.



The Black Noon came over the Sinks at the fourth bell and when it lifted my neighbour was sitting on his step with his hands in his lap, and the flies had taken his face off so neatly you could see where he'd been smiling.

A LAMP-TRIMMER OF THE SINKS

FLYFRONT Threat 3 · Flesh 30 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (crawl 1; every Helping instead adds 1 Fray as they get into the mouth) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 · Swarm; lamps within it go out; Eye rolls -4; fire, smoke and vinegar deal double; a character with two Helpings scored against them is Choked and can do nothing but cough next round.

THE UNSTITCHED

The Seamers' Guild holds Sallowreach together with gut-thread, wire, lacquer and resin. When a Kept body's stitching fails all at once, from neglect or a lapsed fee or a Seamers' slowdown, what results is an Unstitched: a person who has come apart along every seam, held together only by habit and old tendon. They lurch. Their arms swing loose from shoulders that are only hooked on. Their jaws hang. Their bellies, sewn shut a dozen times, open like purses with every step and have to be held closed with both hands, so their arms are never free, so they use their teeth. The old thread trails from them in grey loops, and the wire, rusted, rings faintly against their bones as they walk, which is how the poor of the Sinks know one is coming up the stair. They smell of everything Sallowreach smells of, all at once, concentrated: sweet rot, sour lacquer, vinegar gone off, the rancid tallow the very poor use instead of resin. Most Unstitched are not violent, only desperate: they come at the living begging for thread, for a needle, for someone to hold their face on while they get the wire through. Some, after enough decades of it, have stopped asking. Marrow Jack's victims are often Unstitched, and come looking for their parts.

Seamers' Guild arrears notice, nailed to a door in the Sinks. "To the household of Marl, Ropewalk Stair. Restitching of your Kept, one Grandmother Marl, is now fourteen months in arrears. The Guild regrets that it can no longer be responsible for her shape. Please keep her indoors."

UNSTITCHED KEPT Threat 1 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +4 (teeth and loose hands 2, Grapple 12) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 · Unending; any Helping against it severs a limb, which keeps fighting on its own (Threat 0, Flesh 3, Attack +2, 1).

THE UNDONE CLOSER

The Hand-lines sell death by touch, and the touch grows. Osric Vane in his lead mittens is the famous case. An Undone Closer is the case nobody contained: a Hand-line noble deep in the Course whose mittens came off and who went out into the fen. The hands are the thing. Grey, cold, damp like the underside of a stone, the fingers lengthened to a span and a half and jointed nine and ten times, so that they fold and unfold like a spider settling. The nails are long and yellow and clean. The hands move independently of the face above them, which is often weeping, and which has usually not eaten in weeks, because the hands will not hold a spoon without closing what is in it. Everything the hands touch finishes: a candle gutters and will not relight, a conversation stops mid-word and cannot be restarted, a person sighs and slumps and is done. The Closer cannot stop touching. It is the Want, gone total. Victims are

found laid out tidily, eyes shut, hands folded, and the village around them strangely silent, birdless, every door closed, every book shut, every pot lidded, every shutter latched. In one hamlet near Glovehall a Closer passed in the night and in the morning even the well had a lid on it that nobody had made. Hunting one is the Mortuary Court's most secret duty, because every Undone Closer is a cousin.



She came to the door with her hands behind her back like a little girl hiding a present. She said, "I am so sorry. Please don't look at me. Please close your eyes for me, it's easier."

A SURVIVOR OF THE FENLOW CLOSING, WHO DID NOT

THE UNDONE CLOSER – A HAND-LINE OUT OF ITS MITTENS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 6 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Brawl 4, Stealth 3, Instinct 4, Rites 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (fine ruined coat) · Threat 4
ATTACKS	Closing Touch +10 plus Teeth (on a hit, target makes Caul + Resolve 18 or suffers Ruin and is Finished, truly dead even in Sallowreach; each Helping raises the difficulty by 2)
ABILITIES	The hands may act separately: two Closing Touch attacks a round. Closing the World: once a scene it may touch a door, lamp or voice and end it. Wants: must close every open eye it sees, even a friend's, even its own child's.
REGROWTH	when Hunger fills it reaches the Brink and its touch spreads; the ground it stands on begins to Hush. At 12 it becomes a Hush, and a village goes silent.
SOP	Closing a living thing. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	2 / 3 when the face speaks and apologizes
END	It can be Closed by another Closer, which the Court prefers, or killed outside Sallowreach, which the Court cannot allow anyone to see. The hands, severed, live on in a box, and are worth a fortune.

THE TALLOW-SAINT

Wick Tallow renders the unclaimed into candles that feel themselves burn. A Tallow-Saint is a candle that did not want to be one. Sometimes, when a great many candles made from one family are burned together in one room, the tallow remembers itself, runs, and gathers on the floor into a figure of soft yellow wax five feet high, faceless, wicked through its crown and burning. It smells of mutton fat and singed hair, and under that, faintly, of the person it was: a pipe-smoker's tobacco, a laundress's lye, a child's milky breath. It drips as it walks, leaving a trail of puddles that harden into the shapes of footprints, then of hands. Its light is very steady. People in the room with one find they can read by it perfectly, and that the words on the page have changed into the names of the dead. It wants to be put out, and nothing put out stays out in Sallowreach. So it hunts for darkness and for breath to snuff it, and it presses its

burning crown into the mouths of the living. Those it embraces are found glazed in a skin of wax, mouths stopped with it, every pore sealed, a perfect yellow cast of a person with the person still warm inside.



We bought a box of the cheap ones for the wake. Halfway through the night they all leaned the same way, toward Mother. I swear to you they were trying to look at her.

A WIDOW OF LASTGATE

TALLOW-SAINT Threat 2 · Flesh 16 · Guard 11 · Attack +5 (burning embrace 3, Grapple 14; held targets take 2 fire each round) · Armor 2 (wax; blunt weapons deal only 1) · Dread 2 · Unending until its wick is pinched out (Hand + Filch 18 while Grappled with it); water hardens it for 2

rounds; dark Sallowreach rooms make it act twice. Leftovers: a pinched wick goes on smouldering for a year and is worth 40 lacks to the Finishers.

NEW HORROR: THE WHISPERING AISLE

The Lofts hold the Set-Aside: nine storeys of shelving, forty thousand Kept too far gone to stand, wrapped, labeled, shelved, and still aware. The whispering is audible from the street. Most of it is the murmur of any ward: complaints, prayers, the names of grandchildren. A Whispering Aisle is what an aisle becomes when it has not been visited in a generation. Nobody comes on feast days. Nobody reads. The shelved have only each other, and over the decades their whispering has fallen into step, the way the breathing of the Counted falls into step in the Vigil, until two hundred wrapped mouths are saying one thing at one time.

The air in such an aisle is close and sweet, the linen gone brown with seepage and stuck to the shelves, the bodies beneath sagged together until a shelf is one long lumpen bolt of stained cloth with

heads in it. As a visitor walks the aisle, the heads turn and the whisper rises: *read to us*, said very sweetly. A visitor who stops to listen hears their own name in it, then the ends of their own sentences before they speak them, then the thing they have never told anyone. The wrapped hands come through the linen then, grey and soft as wet bread, and take hold, very gently, the way the old take the hand of a visitor, and do not let go.

Bettany Shroud keeps a list of the aisles that have begun to whisper in unison. Lately they all whisper the same word, and it is not *read*.

From Old Bettany Shroud's night-book, the Lofts, sixth storey. "Aisle 6-Q: in unison again since Tablenight. Went in with the lamp and the Lives of the Glad Century. Read eleven pages. They were quiet. When I stopped they asked me to stay. When I said I could not, they told me the name of my mother's first husband, which I had never known. I have it written below. I will not read it again."

THE WHISPERING AISLE – TWO HUNDRED WHO WANT COMPANY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 6 · Lung 0 · Eye 5 · Tongue 6 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (two hundred common Kept) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Instinct 5, Lore 6 (everything ever said near them), Brawl 3
BODY	Flesh 45 (it is an aisle) · Guard 8 · Armor 1 (shroud-crust; fire deals double) · Threat 5
ATTACKS	Visiting Hands +6 (1, Grapple 16, against everyone in the aisle each round; a character held by three or more hands is pulled onto a shelf and is Engulfed, 1 per round, wrapped)
ABILITIES	Rooted. Fray Aura 14. The Whisper: once a round it speaks one secret about one character (Eye + Search or Caul + Instinct 18 to know whether it is true; it usually is); the character takes 1 Fray and every other character who hears it must decide whether to believe it. Contagion: a character who Breaks in the aisle gains <i>The Voice at Table</i> or <i>The Watchers</i> , and so does anyone who fails the following Dread check. Being Read To: a character who reads aloud to it for an hour holds it quiet and gains the answer to one question about the dead.
SOP	Keeping a visitor. A living person wrapped and shelved among them removes 1d6 Hunger; the Wardens find them a week later, alive, still being whispered to.
DREAD	2 / 3 when it speaks the thing never told
END	Visit them. An aisle read to each feast day for a year goes back to murmuring. Burning it, which the Heirs have proposed, would put two hundred screaming people on the street in the middle of the night, still burning, and still Kept.

NEW HORROR: THE SEWN GENTLEMAN

Marrow Jack takes limbs from the Kept while they shelve or sleep and sells them to back-alley seamers. The buyers are rarely poor. A Sewn Gentleman is what that trade looks like at the top of the market: an Unvacated elder, rich enough to buy and old enough to have rotted, who has replaced himself part by part over two or three centuries until almost nothing of him is his own. A sailor's forearms, a laundry-girl's small chapped hands, a ploughman's back wired at the shoulders, a singer's throat, two eyes not quite the same colour behind tinted glass. He dresses beautifully, in high collars

that hide the joins. He smells of cedar, pomade and the cloves the seamers pack into the seams, and beneath that, faintly and always, of other people's sweat.

The parts remember. That is the horror and the hunt. Marrow Jack's victims wake up able to feel what their missing hands are being used for, and the Sewn Gentleman's original donors, Kept and shelved and Unstitched across the north, feel all of him: his dinners, his correspondence, his razor, his nights. They come looking. And when their owners come near, the parts move toward them: a hand clenching on the dinner-knife, a borrowed throat breaking into a fen ballad in a girl's voice. The Gentleman fights to keep his purchases. He has receipts for all of them.

◇

*He shook my hand at the Hall of Closings and I knew
it at once. I knew the scar on the thumb. I put that
scar there, with a fish-knife, when my brother was
nine.*

A PETITIONER, TO PROVOST SEDGE

THE SEWN GENTLEMAN – PAID IN FULL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 5 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Hand-line, cadet branch; the hands, however, are Scrapling) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Clause 4, Persuade 4, Intimidate 3, Blades 3, Haggle 4, Endure 4
BODY	Flesh 22 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 (wire beneath the coat) · Threat 4
ATTACKS	a borrowed fist +7 (2, Grapple 14); sword-cane +7 (4); his lawyers (he will sue)
ABILITIES	Unending. Many Owners: each round, roll a d6; on a 1 one of his parts rebels (he loses his action as a hand clutches his own throat, or a leg walks him toward the nearest donor). Donors Near: if any former owner of his parts is present, his attacks are at –2 and that donor may, as an action, call a part home (Caul + Resolve 14; the part tears free at the seam, the Gentleman takes 4 damage and loses the use of it). Receipts: within Sallowreach, it is lawful to own a bought part, and a Court Warden will defend him.
SOP	Purchasing a new part and having it sewn in while the donor watches. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	1 / 3 when a character recognizes a part
END	Take him to pieces and give the pieces back. What is left at the end, the Seamers say, is about the size of a cat, and mostly lacquer, and still talking.

▼ THE FATLANDS: THE CROP THAT STANDS UP



In the Fatlands the monsters are agricultural. Nothing there is anything but crop, and that includes what eats the crop. Fatlands horrors are warm, wet, slow, enormous and hungry, and the smell that precedes most of them is gravy. What they leave behind is rarely a body. It is a better yield.



Thank you, Long Furrow. Thank you, Hogget's Bottom. Thank you, Grandmother.

A LOW TILTH GRACE, NAMING THE FIELDS

THE LADEN HILL WITH A MOUTH

Many of the best fields in the south are somebody's great-grandmother. Most Seated Laden are quiet hills, warm to the touch, generous with barley. Some keep a mouth. Old Mother Rind is benign, more or less. Not all are. A hungry hill is a low green mound a hundred paces across, its turf rising and falling with slow breath, and in its side, at about the height of a cart, a mouth: lips of soft red

loam, a tongue the size of a ploughshare, and teeth that were once teeth and are now stones, old roots, and the skulls of what it has eaten, pushed out through the gums like new growth. Its breath is hot and smells of ripe silage and stomach, and on cold mornings it steams like a midden. Its gullet can be heard working from the lane, a slow wet peristalsis under the turf like a cow chewing cud in the next field. It speaks, in the voice of the woman it was, and it is polite, and it is very, very hungry. It wants to be fed by its family, as is right. When its family stops coming, it calls out to passersby by the names of grandchildren. The ground around it is soft for a long way. The roots under that ground move. What it eats is never seen again, except as apples: the hill's fruit that autumn is heavier, and in the core of each, where the pips should be, is a small white knuckle.



Gran wants feeding Sundays. We take her the slops and the old dog and a song. Last Sunday she asked for my husband by name. She always did like him.

A FARMWIFE OF THE DOWAGER ROAD

THE HUNGRY HILL – A GUT-LINE MATRIARCH, SEATED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 10 · Lung 0 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 12 (Seated) · Hunger 8 (it never drops below 5)
SKILLS	Persuade 4, Intimidate 3, Lore 4 (family scandal), Instinct 4, Feast 6
BODY	Flesh 60 · Guard 10 · Armor 3 (turf and loam; blades deal –1 more) · Threat 5
ATTACKS	Roots +6 (2, Grapple 18, reach: the whole hill and twenty paces beyond); the Mouth +8 against a held target (6, and the target is drawn in: Engulf, 4 per round)
ABILITIES	Rooted. Soft Ground: Lung rolls on or near the hill are Hard at best. Kindred Voice: it calls a character by a loved one's name (Known Voice 14). Advice: it knows every secret of its bloodline and trades them for meals.
SOP	being fed a living person by kin. Removes 1d6 Hunger and the hill grows a new apple tree.
DREAD	3 / 4 when it speaks in a voice someone knows
END	Starve it, which takes a decade and turns its fields to fat-scum. Burn it, which takes a month and smells for a mile. Or salt it, which the Board considers murder of a voting member.

THE SCARECROW OF LOW TILTH

Nobody put it up. It stands in the far field with its back to the village, and each Carving it is a few furrows closer. Last year

someone saw it turn around. Pell Hogget's tally does not attribute the Reaping in Low Tilt to the scarecrow, but he has noted that the missing were all last seen nearer its side of the field.

Up close it is a figure seven feet high, cross-armed on a stake that it does not need. Its coat is sacking. Its stuffing is not straw, though straw sticks out of it. Its head is a sack, tied at the neck, and the sack is damp, and it is warm, and if pressed it gives like a full stomach. Under the hat, where the face is painted, the paint is very old, and very good, and the face is smiling. The crows will not land on it, and the flies will not leave it. When it moves, it moves only while nobody in the field is looking at it, and then very fast, and the sound of that is a dry, rushing crackle like a scythe through tall wheat. The taken are not found. In the following spring, the stuffing in the

scarecrow’s arms has new fingernails in it, and the seams of its coat have been let out, as if to fit.

*From Pell Hogget’s Long Count, Low Tilth leaf, the margin.
“Fitch girl, last seen west headland, dusk, 3rd Carving. Note: scarecrow was at the ninth furrow at noon. Was at the fourth by lamp-lighting. I did not see it move. Nobody ever sees it move. That is the whole of what I know and I have written it down.”*

THE SCARECROW OF LOW TILTH – NOBODY PUT IT UP	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 6 · Lung 6 · Eye 4 · Tongue 0 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Gut-line, of a whole village) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Stealth 6, Instinct 5, Brawl 4, Athletics 4
BODY	Flesh 26 · Guard 20 · Armor 2 (sacking and packed meat) · Threat 6
ATTACKS	Sacking Arms +9 (4, Grapple 20); the Gathering against a held target +9 (target is stuffed into its body; Engulf, 3 per round; after three rounds they are gone)
ABILITIES	Unwatched: it may move only when no character is looking at it; it then moves up to 60 paces in a heartbeat. Characters can keep it still by watching (each must spend an action and pass Eye + Search 14 each round, made harder by dusk). Never Moves While Seen. At dusk in Carving it acts twice each round.
SOP	Reaping a person at dusk. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	3 when it is found closer than it was / 4 when it is seen to have turned
END	Burn it on its stake by daylight with every eye in the village on it. What runs out of the ashes is fat, and it screams in many voices. Next Carving there is a scarecrow in the far field, and nobody put it up.

THE TOOTHED FIELD

Wheat with teeth in the ear has been a superior strain since 204 A.G., by ruling of the Board. A toothed field in its late Plenty is tall as a man, gold and red, and every ear is a small jaw of white milk-teeth set in a husk that clicks open and shut in the wind. On a still day it is quiet. On a windy one, a toothed field sounds like a crowd chewing. Harvesters wear leather to the shoulder. Anyone who falls in a toothed field in late Plenty is in serious trouble: the ears turn toward warmth like flowers to the sun, and every ear takes a nip, and there are millions of ears. Victims come out lacework, bleeding from a thousand pinpricks, skin hanging in fine pink threads, and the wheat they fell in is the best of the crop that year, heavy and pink in the grain. The loaves from it are said to taste faintly of the person. Granny Cracknel says the teeth in a field that has fed well are adult teeth.

◇
*Never lie down in the wheat, never sleep in the stook,
never bleed in the furrow, and never, ever whistle.
They like a tune.*
HARVEST-RHYME OF THE BLEEDING ORCHARDS
ROAD

TOOTHED FIELD (PER ACRE) Threat 2 · Flesh 40 · Guard 8 · Attack +5 (nipping 1 to everyone inside; every Helping adds a Bleed of 1 per round until bound) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 / 2 when the ears turn · Swarm; Rooted; fire spreads through it at a run and it screams; Lung rolls inside are Hard.

TWO-LEGGED CATTLE

Sal Trotter walks herds to market that the buyers call cattle. They are heavy, docile, and pinkish-white, with broad flat faces and soft lowing voices. On the road, when nobody watches, they stand up. Upright they are the height of a tall man, bellies swinging, forelegs tucked like hands, and they walk easily and well. They do not talk. They hum, sometimes, a hymn with a tune most Fatlanders know from childhood. Some have scars where a brand would be, and the scars are in the shape of letters. Their dung smells of a human privy and their eyes are a clear, startled blue. Nobody in the Renderers’

Union will say where the bloodstock comes from, but the Reaping takes people every Carving and the herds are larger every spring. Most cattle are harmless. A herd that has been mistreated, or that smells its own kind in a slaughterhouse, becomes a stampede on two legs, and it knows how to open gates. Trampled drovers are found with their pockets turned out, as if something had been looking for a name.



*I stopped naming them the year one of them answered
to Agnes.*

SAL TROTTER, THE DROVER

TWO-LEGGED CATTLE (HERD OF 20) Threat 2 · Flesh 30 · Guard 11 · Attack +6 (trampling 4 to all in its path) · Armor 1 · Dread 1 / 3 when they stand up and one of them says a name · Swarm; a single beast is Flesh 14, Attack +4 (3), harmless unless cornered.

ROOTKIN

Tansy Lard dug up a root with her mother's birthmark on it. She was not the first. Rootkin are what the Reaping leaves in the soil: swollen root vegetables the size of a sleeping child, pale and veined and warm, with features. Most are lumpen. Some are exact, down to the crow's feet and the old pox scar. Their eyes are closed. Pulled up, they flinch and leak a pinkish sap that smells of the person they resemble, a sweat-and-soap smell that brings mourners to their knees in the furrow. Eaten, they are delicious and their eater dreams the dead person's memories for a week. Left in the ground, they grow. A Rootkin bed left unharvested through a full year sends up shoots with hands on them, and those hands pull down whatever leans too close. The Cullmasters harvest Rootkin by night and sell them to the Renderers' Union by weight.



*Sixpence the pound for plain, two lacks for a face, ten
for a face somebody'll pay to have back.*

PRICES CHALKED ON A RENDERERS' BOARD AT THE
CHUTE

ROOTKIN BED Threat 1 · Flesh 20 · Guard 9 · Attack +5 (grasping shoots 2, Grapple 14, then dragged underground at 1 per round) · Armor 1 (soil) · Dread 2 / 3 when a character recognizes a face · Rooted; lifting one is a Hard Labor roll and a Dread check.

THE REAPING

The Reaping is not a monster. That is the Board's official position, and it is technically correct: no single thing takes the Fatlands' missing. The land does. On dusk in Carving, out in the far fields, the soil softens. The furrows deepen, slowly, so slowly a farmhand will not notice until her boots are below the surface. The rows of

wheat lean in. The air thickens with the smell of fresh bread and fat. The earth makes a sound, low and continuous, like a stomach in the next room. And then the ground opens, wetly, the way a mouth opens around a spoon, and closes again, and the furrow is smooth, and the crop in that furrow will be very good next year. Sometimes a hand stays above the soil until morning, still clutching a hoe.

Run the Reaping as a hazard with a clock. Each character in a far field at dusk in Carving rolls Lung + Wayfaring each round against a rising difficulty (Routine 10, then Hard, then Grim, then Dire). Failure means they are held to the ankle, then the knee, then the waist; a fourth failure and they are gone. Allies can pull them free with a Gut + Labor roll at the same difficulty. Partaking for the Fatlands' Gut-line, ironically, helps: the ground recognizes kin and loosens its grip for a round, though it costs Hunger as always. A Cullmaster's assigned workers are marked with a strip of red cloth at the wrist. The ground knows the cloth. Remove it, and the difficulty drops by 4.

The Reaping has Dread 3 the first time it is seen to take someone, and Dread 4 when a character realizes the field is breathing in time with them.



*We don't say taken. We say the field was hungry. We
say she went into the bread. Then we eat the bread,
because what else would you have us do.*

A LOW TILTH WIDOW, TO PELL HOGGET

NEW HORROR: THE UNEATEN

The Fatlands have no graves. The dead are served at the wake, by the family, with the best plates, and to be buried uneaten would be the deepest insult to a life. Sometimes a wake fails. The family is too small or too grief-struck; a Thin son refuses his portion. Something is left on the platter overnight. The leftovers are buried, quietly, in a corner of the field, and the family tells nobody. A season later, the Uneaten comes home.

It is what remained of the dead: the joints that were not carved, the ribs that were picked half clean, the head that nobody could bring themselves to serve, drawn back together by the soil into the rough shape of the person and clothed in turf and root-hair and a skin of yellow fat. Its face is half a face, the other half carved down to the cheekbone in neat slices. It smells of a cold kitchen the morning after a feast: congealed dripping, stale gravy, and under it, sweet and terrible, the meat itself. It comes to the family table at the hour of the evening meal, sits down in its old chair, and waits to be finished. It will not leave until every scrap of it is eaten by its own kin. If they refuse, it begins to serve itself to them, and they find they cannot refuse that.

Statement of Wakemother Pudding Hesk to the Low Tilt bailiff. “I told them, you eat your mother or she’ll come back for it. They wouldn’t hear. Thin, the son was, the Thin had got him. Three months later I’m passing the cottage at supper and

there’s five at table and the door’s open and one of the five is the mother, what’s left, and the son’s crying with his mouth full.”

THE UNEATEN – THE LEFTOVERS COME HOME	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 7 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Gut-line, family) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 9
SKILLS	Brawl 4, Endure 5, Feast 5, Intimidate 4, Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 24 · Guard 12 · Armor 2 (fat and turf; blunt weapons deal –1 more) · Threat 4
ATTACKS	gnawed hands +7 (3, Grapple 16); Serving against a held kinsman +8 (the character must eat; Gut + Endure 18 to spit it out, otherwise gain 2 Hunger, 1 Regrowth Taint roll at Grim, and a Dread 3 check)
ABILITIES	Kin-Bound: it attacks only its own family and those who stand between it and them. Rooted Return: if destroyed but not eaten, it reforms in the field in 1d6 weeks. Table Manners: it does not act while grace is being said; a grace that thanks it by name holds it still for a round.
SOP	Being eaten by kin. 1d6 Hunger for every mouthful, which is the end of it.
DREAD	2 on sight / 4 when a character recognizes the dead and is kin
END	Finish it. Everyone in the family must eat a share. The Second Helping offers to stand in as kin for a fee, and the Board pretends not to know.

NEW HORROR: THE BOTTOMLESS

The Appetite in the Fatlands is eating without choosing: soil, tallow, leather, hair. The sufferer cannot stop for conversation. The Bottomless is the Appetite with nothing left to stop it, a Fatlander in whom the Want has become the whole person, as the Undone Closer is in the north. Usually it is a Gut-line cadet who one day ate past the wall even the Fatlands keep. It roams the back kitchens, larders and middens of Sated at night, enormous, the skin of the belly split in pale stretch-tears that weep yellow lymph, the jaw unhinged a little lower each month so that it can take things whole. It eats candles and their holders, the boot-leather of the sleeping, the dog, with a steady joyless crunching, and through it it talks, in a mild educated voice, about how hungry it is and how sorry.

What it leaves is a kitchen stripped to the plaster: no crumbs, no rind, no rats, the pans licked bright, the table gnawed to a curve at one end, and sometimes a cook sitting very still in the corner, missing the hand she held out to calm it.



He ate the pudding, the cloth it was boiled in, the string, and then he looked at me like I was the next course, and he said, “Do forgive me, Mrs Haslet, I really cannot help it.”

A SCULLERY MAID OF SATED

THE BOTTOMLESS – NO WORD FOR FULL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 8 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 8
SKILLS	Feast 6, Brawl 4, Endure 4, Persuade 2
BODY	Flesh 26 · Guard 10 · Armor 3 (fat; blunt weapons deal only 1) · Threat 3
ATTACKS	bite +7 (3; on two Helpings it takes something off: a finger, an ear, a hand, roll a Mangling); bulk +6 (4, knockdown)
ABILITIES	Cannot Stop: it must spend its move each round eating whatever is in reach; offering it food buys a round of peace. Feasting Heals: eating anything restores 2 Flesh, a person restores 8. Gut-Dread: anyone who sees it eat a living thing makes a Dread 2 check.
SOP	Eating until something inside tears. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	2
END	Starve it, which is treason. Or feed it until it roots: the Board has a cellar under Sated where three of the Bottomless lie on their backs in the dark, rooting through the flagstones, swelling, fed by chute, and the Chairman's physician calls this care.

▼ BRINEHOLLOW: WHAT THE SEA LEFT BEHIND



Brinehollow's horrors are patient, heavy and courteous. They press. Many have **Tide**, and all of them smell of a harbour at low water: weed, salt, rot and cold iron. Their victims are rarely torn. They are found wrung, folded, drowned on dry floors, or not found at all, and the family keeps the bail-bucket by the door for a year in case.



It's not the sea going out. It's the sea coming in. Into us. You can hear it slosh when the children run.

A LOWMARK BUCKET-SELLER

THE TENANTED

A Tenanted is not hostile. That is what makes it so hard. It walks out of the surf weeks after its Calling, heavier, calm, with the same face and the same memories, and someone else looking out. It knows your name, your nickname, the way you take your tea. It is kinder than the person was. Its skin is cool and faintly grey, its hands

are always damp, and its breath, if you are close enough, smells of deep water, a clean mineral cold. Its weight is wrong: floorboards creak under a slight Tenanted girl as if under a cart, and a Tenanted man who sits on a bed leaves a dent that holds water. It does not sweat; it weeps salt from the pores in warm rooms, and its pillow is crusted white each morning. When it is angered, which is rare, it does not raise its voice. It presses. The air in the room thickens, ears pop, windows bow, and a man who has crossed a Tenanted judge has been found with his ribs gently folded inward, as if the sea had leaned on him, his eyes pushed a little way out of his face and his mouth full of pink froth.

A Wreckwives' advice-sheet, passed hand to hand on the Mile. "He will be gentle. Let him. Do not ask where he went. Do not wake him by shaking; he does not wake, he surfaces, and you do not want to be leaning over the bed when he does. Count the children every morning, aloud, and make him count them with you, and watch his mouth."

THE TENANTED – SOMEONE ELSE LOOKING OUT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 6 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Lung-line) · Regrowth 12 in part (the Tenant has the whole house) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Clause 3, Persuade 3, Instinct 5, Search 3, Brawl 3, Endure 4
BODY	Flesh 18 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 (compressed flesh; blunt weapons deal –1 more) · Threat 4
ATTACKS	a heavy hand +6 (3, Grapple 18); the Press +7 against everyone within 5 paces (2, ignoring Armor; ears bleed)
ABILITIES	Tide 3. Riding (it is a god wearing a person; see <i>The God-Ridden</i>). Fathom Weight: cannot be knocked down, lifted or pushed. Two Voices: when it speaks in both, every listener rolls Caul + Resolve 14 or takes 1 Fray and believes what it says for a scene. Wants nothing it will admit. Treat it as a person first.
DREAD	0 at a distance / 3 when a loved one recognizes what is behind the eyes
END	Cut it and it bleeds seawater by the gallon, more than its body can hold. Drained dry it lies down, an empty skin. Somewhere in the Trench, it is said, the water it held goes on.

RIBWALKERS

On the Uncovered, among the leather weed-forests and the wrecks standing upright, there are things with too many ribs. Salvagers call them Ribwalkers. A Ribwalker is a cage of long curved bones, thirty or forty pairs, opening and closing like a slow bellows, mounted on

legs that might once have been the ribs of something else. There is no head. There is meat inside the cage, a grey sack that pulses, and there is usually a salvager's boot or two, and buttons, and once a wedding band on a finger bone. They move toward water, any water, at a creaking stalk, with a sound like a ship's timbers working in a swell, and they open their ribs wide over anything wet and alive and close them, and squeeze, and drink. The squeezed come out

flat, dry as leather, with their bail-buckets still on their belts and their faces pressed into the shape of a scream that made no sound, because there was no breath left to make it. Some salvagers swear the Ribwalkers are what the Admiralty’s fallen sailors become. Hask Tarn will not say.

Keep your water-barrel a hundred paces from the camp and your bucket on your belt and never, never bail after dark. They smell it.

UNCOVERED SALVAGE-RULE, FIRST OF NINE

RIBWALKER Threat 3 · Flesh 22 · Guard 13 · Attack +7 (rib-cage closing 4, Grapple 18; held targets lose 2 Flesh per round as the water is pressed out of them) · Armor 3 (bone lattice) · Dread 2 / 3 when it closes on someone · Tide 4; drawn to a character who has just bailed.

THE DOWAGER BELOW

Lady Ondine Vasht lives in the flooded cellars of the palace in Lowmark, and the cellars have had to be extended twice. She is far into the Course and has not been seen whole in years. What can be

seen of her, through the black water by lamplight, is a vast grey shape folded into the vaults, skin like a drowned sail, hair that drifts across the floor of three cellars, and eyes the size of serving platters, dark and wide and wet, which open one at a time in different rooms. The cellars smell of cold stone, bladderwrack and a great animal’s breath, and the water is warmer than it should be, blood-warm near the walls where she lies against them. She is still a grandmother. She still has opinions about the prince’s marriage. She speaks through the water: the surface of every cistern in the palace trembles with her words. She would like her grandson to come down. She has been asking for years. The servants who go down to feed her return with less of their breath every time, and some do not return. The ones that come up again sometimes come up years later, through a palace drain, pale and swollen and polite, asking whether the Dowager is receiving.

Her ladyship takes the mutton on Tuesdays and a footman on the first of the month. That is not written down anywhere, and you will not write it down either.

THE PALACE STEWARD, TO A NEW UNDER-BUTLER

LADY ONDINE VASHT – THE DOWAGER BELOW	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 9 · Lung 5 · Eye 5 · Tongue 5 · Caul 8
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Lung-line) · Regrowth 11 (the Brink) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Intimidate 5, Clause 4, Lore 5, Instinct 6, Brawl 4
BODY	Flesh 50 · Guard 19 (in water) or 10 (in air) · Armor 3 (the weight of water) · Threat 6
ATTACKS	drifting hair +8 (2, Grapple 20, reach any flooded room); the Embrace against a held target +9 (Engulf, 4 per round, drowning; lungs fill with water as if bailing in reverse)
ABILITIES	Tide 5. Pull 18 on Lung-line characters within the palace. Her Voice in the Water: any surface of water in Lowmark can carry her words. Pressure: her cellars count as Dire terrain; all rolls there –2.
REGROWTH	at 12 she Seats. The cellars break. The palace is full of sea, in a land that has none.
SOP	a Lung-line relative going under willingly. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	3 / 4 when an eye opens in the room
END	There is none the Admiralty will countenance. Draining the cellars has been attempted. The water comes back twice a day.

THE INDOOR TIDE

In every cellar in Brinehollow, water rises twice a day and drains away. An Indoor Tide is when it does not stop. It comes up the stairs at night, black and cold, bringing kelp and silt and small crabs and the smell of an open harbor. It rises through the kitchen, through the parlor, up the bedroom stairs to where the family sleeps anchored, and it does not care that the house is a mile from the shore. Furniture lifts and bumps along the ceiling. The family portraits float face down. It has a current. It pulls toward the west wall. People found after an Indoor Tide are found tidily, laid face

down on the west side of rooms, lungs full, hands reaching, fingernails broken against the plaster. Treat it as a hazard: each round the water rises a step, Lung + Athletics rolls to move against the current start at Hard and rise to Dire; anchored characters are safe until it reaches their mouths. Lung-line characters feel the Pull 14 every round. The Tide has Dread 2 as it rises and Dread 3 when someone sees a shape swimming through the drowned parlor that was not there when the water came in.

◇

The water went down at dawn like it always does. It left the weed on the stairs and the crabs in the sugar and the Tolleys face down by the west wall, all four, holding hands.

A NEIGHBOUR, SALTWICK

THE CALLED PROCESSION

The Deepening walks in willingly, in procession, with lanterns. Sometimes the Called do too, without the lanterns: twenty, forty, a hundred people in nightclothes walking west at night in perfect silence, eyes open, bleeding brine from the nose, singing very low the same tune the Uncovered sings. Their bare feet slap the planks in step. Children walk among them holding the hands of strangers. They are not hostile. They will not stop. Anyone who stands in their way is walked over. Anyone with a Lung-line Cut who watches them pass must roll against the Pull. In the morning the shingle beyond the last pier is printed with hundreds of footprints going one way, each filling slowly with water from below.

◇

I held my boy's wrist till the third pier and he walked me off my feet. He wasn't fighting. He was just going. He said, Mam, let go, they've kept a place.

A LOWMARK MOTHER, THE NIGHT OF THE FOURTH CALLING

CALLED PROCESSION (40) Threat 2 · Flesh 40 · Guard 10 · Attack +5 (trampling, grasping 2, Grapple 14: the grabbed are carried along) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 / 3 on seeing someone known among them · Swarm; Pull 14 on Lung-lines; roping individuals out takes a Gut + Labor 14 roll each.

NEW HORROR: COUGHLINGS

What comes up in the bail-bucket is mostly water, and sometimes weed, and sometimes, more often every year, something alive. Dr. Isolde Reave found a shell of no known species in a drowned chest. Hookman Dabb stamped on two in the net and swore the third had a face. These are Coughlings: small soft-bodied things the size of a thumb-joint to a fist, brought up from the lungs of Brinehollowers at the turn of the body's tide, pale grey and slick, with too many legs and a little mouth-ring of needle teeth. They scuttle. They nest in the dark under planking, in drains, in the cold ashes of hearths, in the bottoms of buckets left standing, and they find each other. A nest of a few hundred under a pier-house makes a sound at night like rain beginning, and smells of tide-wrack and spoiled milk.

Coughlings want to go back in. They creep up the bed-ropes of the anchored sleeping and into open mouths, and the sleeper's next

bailing is a bloody one. The older a Coughling grows, the more its pale front resembles a face: the face of the one who coughed it up.

◇

Mam says leave the bucket face-down at night or the little ones get back in. I asked where they go. She said home.

TOLLY BRACK, THE BAILER BOY, AGED ELEVEN

COUGHLING NEST Threat 2 · Flesh 18 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (needle-mouths 1, against everyone in reach; on two Helpings a Coughling gets into the mouth: the character is Choked next round and must bail at the next tide with a Gut + Endure 14 roll or lose 3 Flesh) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 / 3 when one has the character's own face · Swarm; Tide 3; fire and fresh water deal double; drawn to a character who has just bailed.

NEW HORROR: THE CISTERN-KEPT

At the Course, the Brinehollower's body adapts to depth: grey skin, wide dark eyes, a chest that no longer needs to rise. The sufferer is uncomfortable in open air and sleeps in a cistern. The poor share. Under the Mile and in the old towns of the coast there are public cisterns, vaulted, dripping, black, where the Course-struck who have no family go down to lie in the cold and do not come up. They are the Cistern-Kept. Over the years their eyes widen until there is no white and their fingers web. They lie in the dark at the bottom, perfectly still, a dozen to a cistern, and they listen to the buckets coming down on the rope.

When a bucket comes down they take hold of it. Most of the time they give it back, full, with a polite tug. Some nights they do not, and the drawer leans over the edge to see what has caught. Bodies taken from a public cistern come up weeks later through the drain-grates of the street, white and puffed, with their ribs folded in and their fingers webbed, and the street drinks the water anyway, because there is nowhere else to get it.

Lowmark Ward Notice, Mile Nine. "The public cistern at Hawse Corner will be closed for cleaning. Residents are asked NOT to lower buckets after the evening bell. Residents are asked NOT to answer if called by name from the cistern. Residents are reminded that the Netwatch cannot hook what is already in the water."

CISTERN-KEPT (A CISTERN'S WORTH) Threat 4 · Flesh 36 · Guard 15 (in water) · Attack +7 (webbed hands 3, Grapple 18; a held character is dragged under, Engulf, 3 per round, drowning) · Armor 2 (water; blades deal -1 more) · Dread 2 / 3 when a pale face rises to the surface and calls a name · Swarm; Tide 4; Pull 14 on Lung-lines who look down into the water; cannot leave the water and dies in a day if dragged into air.

▼ THE VIGIL: WHAT HAPPENS WHEN YOU CLOSE YOUR EYES



The Vigil's horrors arrive in blinks. Many of them happen, or are seen, in the second between one waking moment and the next. All of them are worse for an exhausted character: a character who has not taken rouse in the last hour suffers -2 on Dread checks in this section. And in a city with no darkness, there is nowhere for them to hide and no need for them to: everything here happens under ten thousand lamps, in plain view, in front of witnesses who are not sure whether they saw it.



Pinch me. No, harder. Harder. Thank you. I love you.

THE WHOLE OF A VIGIL COURTSHIP, OVERHEARD
ON THE NODDING STAIR

THE BLINK-KILLER

Inspector Hale Grimmer has forty cases. The method is the same in each. A blink-killer is an ordinary citizen of the Vigil (a cook, a nudger, a clerk) who blinks for two seconds, mid-sentence, standing

at a market stall, and in those two seconds goes to the long room with the eye, and something there uses them. They come back holding a knife they did not pick up, standing behind a stranger, and the stranger is open from hip to collarbone in one perfectly straight line, and the blink-killer does not remember any of it. The cut is the same each time: the line a midwife or a butcher would use to open a body for inspection. The steam comes off the opened body in the lamplight, and the smell, hot and coppery and faintly fecal, reaches the stall-holders before the scream does. The killer is usually still talking, finishing the sentence they began. Blink-killers are not monsters. They are anyone. That is the horror. The stat below is for the second in which they are something else.

Blink-Matter Thirty-Two, statement of the accused, a pastry-cook. "I was telling her the price of the honey-twists. Three crumbs, I said. I blinked. I said, or two for five. And she was lying on the twists, and I had my peel-knife, and it was clean. Inspector, it was clean. I have never cleaned a knife that well in my life."

THE BLINK-KILLER – TWO SECONDS UNDER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 5 · Eye 1 · Tongue 0 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Eye-line or common, it does not matter) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Blades 5, Stealth 5, Instinct 4
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 20 (it moves with the ease of a sleepwalker) · Armor 0 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	the Line +10 (knife 2; on two or more Helpings the target suffers Ruin at once, opened)
ABILITIES	Blink: the killer acts only for one round, then wakes, a confused citizen again (Threat 1, Flesh 12, Guard 12). Anywhere: any NPC in the Vigil may become one; the GM may spend a Fray from a character who has Broken to make one appear. Waking it with pain during its round (any hit) ends the blink. Riding: for its one round, it is the god-ridden.
DREAD	2 on the murder / 3 when a character realizes they themselves have lost two seconds
END	Keep everyone awake. The Wakers' needles are the only defense the city has.

A SEEMING MADE SOLID

After enough waking, everyone hallucinates, and when a whole street sees the same thing, it is entered as news. When a whole street sees the same thing for long enough, it becomes true. A Seeming made solid is a hallucination that has been agreed on by too many

exhausted minds: a horse with a man's face walking down the Slope, a staircase that goes on past the roof, a tall figure laying a table in the street. It has weight, smell and heat. It does what the people imagining it fear it will do. It is precisely as strong as their certainty and it smells like rouse, burnt and bitter, because it is made of their attention. What it kills stays killed. The bodies are real, and the

Registrar of the Seeming enters them with a cause of death nobody else on the Table would accept: *imagined by eleven households*.

Eleven districts, separately, the same figure: very tall, stooping, laying a cloth in the road. I entered it as news. Then I went home and set an extra place, and I do not know why.

MIRELA SCONCE, THE SEEMER

SEEMING MADE SOLID Threat 4 · Flesh equal to 2 × the number of witnesses · Guard 14 · Attack +7 (it does whatever it was imagined doing; damage 4) · Armor 0 · Dread 3 · it gains +1 to all rolls for every frightened witness; characters who succeed at Eye + Reckoning 18 can disbelieve it aloud, and each disbeliever strips 4 Flesh from it; if no one is looking at it, it stops existing until someone does.

SLEEPWALKING COUNTED

Sixty thousand beds, numbered, in rows, completely silent. The Counted breathe in time. In the last year, some have begun to get up. A sleepwalking Counted rises with its eyes closed, its lips moving, and walks in the direction the eye in the dream faces. It does not wake. It cannot be woken. It is warm, unaged since the night it lay down, nightclothes faded to cobweb, hair grown to the floor and dragging, and the soles of its feet as soft and unmarked as an infant’s, so that they bleed within a street and it does not notice. It smells of clean linen and old breath. Wherever it walks people around it begin to yawn, then to nod, then to blink. Matron Dorm sends them back to their beds with an orderly on each arm. Odile Farthing’s son, in bed 40,112, has grown to a man’s size and is smiling. When he walks, he walks with his arms open.

We put her back in 9,301 three times this week. Each time the sheet’s warmer. Each time her lips are further along the same word.

A DORMITORY ORDERLY, TO THE MATRON

SLEEPWALKING COUNTED Threat 3 · Flesh 16 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (embrace 2, Grapple 16; a held character must pass Caul + Resolve 14 each round or blink) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 / 3 when its lips form a character’s name · Fray Aura 14 (as yawning); cannot be harmed by pain; returning it to its bed ends its walk.

THE WAKER GONE MAD

The Wakers’ job is to hurt people for their own good, and they are skilled after three centuries. A Waker gone mad has decided that nobody is safe, ever, unless they are in pain. He is usually an old Waker, on triple rouse, lidless or near it from long effort, his eyes gone red and cracked and leaking, his teeth long since rotted to brown pegs by the drug. His breath stinks of burnt rouse and gum-rot. He carries a rattle and a sheaf of long steel needles. He has stopped distinguishing between a citizen who is nodding and a citizen who might nod later. He goes door to door at the third bell. He pins people’s eyelids open with fish-hooks. He drives needles under nails so that no one in the house can doze. In his cellar there are people he has been keeping awake for weeks, tied in standing frames, weeping and hallucinating, their eyelids torn and crusted, and he feeds them rouse by the spoon and sings to them. They thank him. That is the sound the Wakers who find his cellar never forget: a row of people in frames, whispering *thank you, thank you* in time.

Found eleven in his frames, all alive, all thanking him. We cut them down and the first thing every one of them asked was who would keep them awake now.

CAPTAIN BRANNOCH PYRE, REPORT TO THE WATCH

THE WAKER GONE MAD – FOR YOUR OWN GOOD	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Eye-line by-blood) · Regrowth 7 (the Course; lids nearly gone) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Blades 4, Stitching 3, Intimidate 4, Search 4, Brawl 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 17 · Armor 2 (boiled leather) · Threat 3
ATTACKS	waking needle +8 (2, plus target takes 1 Fray from the pain of it and cannot blink or sleep for a day); rattle-cudgel +7 (3)
ABILITIES	Never Sleeps, Never Blinks: immune to anything that relies on sleep, rest or surprise. Rouse-Fury: once a scene, gains an extra action and loses 2 Flesh. The Seeming: he sees the eye in every face; any character he catches dozing is attacked first.
DREAD	2 / 3 on finding the cellar
END	He will kill himself with rouse within a month. The question is how many people he keeps awake before his heart stops.

THE YAWN

On Yawn days, the Wakers double their patrols. The Yawn is not a creature; it is contagion. Lukas Marre once put down a market square. When a yawn is spreading through a crowd it moves like a rumor, mouth to mouth, jaws cracking, eyes streaming, and the sound of it, a hundred sighing breaths, is the most frightening sound in the city. Every person who catches it must roll Caul + Resolve 14 or blink. In a crowd of the exhausted the first blink becomes ten, the ten become a hundred, and the hundred do not all come back. The ones who do not are carted to the Dormitory steps before the next bell, still warm, faces soft and young with rest, and their families walk beside the cart pinching each other. Treat a Yawn as a hazard with Dread 1 that becomes Dread 3 the moment a character sees someone fall and not rise. The Glass House exists because of it.



It went across the Pinchmarket like wind across barley. I saw the yawn coming, face to face, and I bit my own tongue till it bled, and that is why I am standing here.

A ROUSE-SELLER OF THE SLOPE

NEW HORROR: THE TETHER-CATCH

The Dream-Divers go under on a tether and are dragged up by force. Most manage three dives. The tether is a braided silk line fixed to an iron collar, and the hauling crew reel it in at the count of sixty with a windlass, whatever the diver is doing in the long room. A Tether-Catch is a thing from the long room that took hold of the line on the way up, or took hold of the diver, or got in.

Some come up as a diver who sits up and looks around the room as if counting the beds. Those that come up with bodies of their own are pale, hairless, soft, and very long, with closed eyes that are only shut skin, no lids at all, and they move by stretching like a yawn. They smell of sleep: warm sheets, sour breath, the bitterness of a mouth that has been open all night. Loose in the city, it moves from nudger-house to rouse-den laying its long cool hands over eyes, and behind it people lie down in doorways with their shoes neatly beside them.

Tether Hall haul-log, dive 2,214, diver S. Vole. “Hauled at sixty. Line heavy at forty fathoms (counted turns). Heavy as two. At the collar: diver, sound, and a second hand on the silk, very long, no nails. It let go at the lip. Diver reports nothing on the line. Crew of four reports a weight that walked off the hauling-floor. Floor is warm where it walked.”

THE TETHER-CATCH – WHAT CAME UP THE LINE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 6 · Eye 0 · Tongue 2 · Caul 8
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (it is a piece of Iss, unhoused) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Stealth 6, Athletics 4, Instinct 6, Brawl 3
BODY	Flesh 18 · Guard 18 · Armor 0 · Threat 6
ATTACKS	Lidding Hand +8 (0; target must roll Caul + Resolve 18 or blink, and the blink lasts 1d6 minutes; on a Lack the character is Counted, and only a dive can bring them back)
ABILITIES	Fray Aura 14 (everyone near it yawns). Lamp-Eater: lamps within ten paces dim to a glow. Pain Is Light: it recoils from pain; a character who wounds themselves deliberately (1 Flesh) is immune to its Lidding Hand for a round. Riding: if it gets into a diver rather than out of one, use the god-ridden rules; the diver walks the city with closed eyes and open mouth.
SOP	putting a waking person to sleep for good. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	3 / 4 when it turns its shut face toward a character
END	Haul it back down. A diver must go under with it held fast and come up without it, and the hall has never yet hauled up a diver who did that twice.

NEW HORROR: THE MADE BED

Beds were burned in the squares in 342 A.G., and there has not been a bed, couch or cushion in the city since. In the sealed buildings of the old Slope and in the lamp-starved back rooms the Lamplighters cannot reach, a bed sometimes makes itself. Nobody carries it in. It is simply there one morning, in a room whose lamp has been out a week: a broad low bed with a carved headboard in the old Ludmere

style, a feather mattress, linen white as milk, the covers turned down, and a dent in the pillow as if someone has only just risen. The room is dark, warm and still, and it smells of lavender and clean sleep. There is a faint sound, sometimes, of someone breathing in the next room, slowly.

People find their way to a Made Bed the way water finds a drain. The family finds the shoes outside the door, side by side, the coat folded on top. Inside, the sleeper lies on their back with a smile,

warm, unwakeable, and the covers drawn up to the chin by a hand that was not theirs. The bed does not let go. Cut the linen away and the sleeper is found grown into the mattress, the feathers rooted in their back, the headboard's carving continued in a fine pattern across their scalp.



A pair of shoes on a doorstep, a folded coat on top, the door open on a dark warm room. We call it Lain-Down. We do not call it anything else, and we close the door, and we do not go in.

VIGIL CUSTOM, AS EXPLAINED TO AN ENVOY

THE MADE BED Threat 5 · Flesh 20 (the bed) · Guard 0 · Attack none; Hosting 18 (a character who enters the dark room must roll Caul + Resolve 14 each minute or lie down; one who lies down must roll at Dire 22 to rise) · Armor 1 · Dread 2 on finding the shoes / 4 on seeing the sleeper grown in · light destroys it: a lamp held over it for a full minute makes it shrink and creak, and fire burns it with a smell of scorched lavender and hair; a Lamplighter's bounty is 30 lacks per bed.

▼ CRADLEWRACK: WHAT COMES THROUGH



Nothing in Cradlewrack is born right, and it is all healthy. Cradlewrack horrors are new, wet and determined. Many are drawn toward each other, toward the Sill or toward the Dilation, and they are getting bigger. They smell of milk, iron and warm clay, and they arrive, always, through something that was supposed to stay shut.

◇
*First we ask what it is. Then we ask whether it stays.
Then, God help us, we ask whether it's ours.*

THE TWO QUESTIONS, WITH THE THIRD THAT
MIDWIVES ADD UNDER THEIR BREATH

WANDERING PARTS

A single living hand. A warm ear. A length of spine that crawls. The Parts are born healthy and drawn toward each other, and when they are not caught by the Attendance's knife or the Assemblers' sacks, they wander. They move in the night, at the speed of a crawling infant, through doors that drift open: a hand walking on its fingertips, a pair of lungs that inflate and deflate to roll themselves along, a jaw that pulls itself forward by its teeth. They are warm and blood-pink and smell of milk and iron, and they leave a faint sticky trail, like a snail's, that dries to a crust the colour of rust. They seek each other, and when two fit, they join with a wet click and a seam that heals in an hour. A cluster that has found six or seven partners is called a Gathered, and it is the size of a dog and the shape of no animal, and it is hungry, and it wants the parts it is missing. It will take them from whoever has them. Its victims are found with a single neat absence: a hand gone at the wrist, an ear, a kneecap, the wound already skinned over, as if they had been born without it.

◇
*Wee hand came in under the door and took hold of my
finger, gentle as you like. I let it. What was I to do. It
held on all night. In the morning it had my little
finger, and I had a stump, and it was gone.*

A SHEPHERD OF RUDGE

PARTS (HANDFUL) Threat 1 · Flesh 3 · Guard 12 · Attack +3
(clutch, bite 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 / 2 when a hand holds yours · they pass
any door or lock.

GATHERED Threat 3 · Flesh 20 · Guard 13 · Attack +6 (grasp and tear
3, Grapple 16; on a held target with two Helpings, it takes a part: the
character suffers an Injury from the Mangling table and the Gathered gains
5 Flesh) · Armor 0 · Dread 3 · it grows each scene it is left alive.

THE REFUSED

The Attendance's knife is called the Second Opinion, and there is no appeal from it. Except sometimes, as Sabeth Thorne found, the knife hesitates. A Refused is a born-grown thing that was meant to be cut and was not, and that has lived since in hiding, and has grown up knowing what it was supposed to be. It may look like a tall woman with a seam across her throat, or a man of thirty born mid-stride with a second face asleep in his chest, its breath warm through his shirt. It knows it was judged. It remembers the midwife's face, the lamp, the smell of the apron. Refused are clever, careful, and very often kind, until they meet a midwife. Then they settle the account. Midwives killed by the Refused are found in their own aprons, opened with their own knife along the line they were taught, and laid with care on the birthing-stool.

◇
*I gave it one more breath to see what it would do with
it. That was eleven years ago. It still writes to me.*

A MIDWIFE OF KEST, RETIRED

THE REFUSED – WHAT THE KNIFE SPARED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 5 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Caul-line or none at all; born of the god directly) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Blades 3, Brawl 4, Stealth 4, Deceive 3, Instinct 4, Endure 3
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 (birth-membrane, toughened) · Threat 4
ATTACKS	hands +7 (2); a midwife's knife it took +7 (3)
ABILITIES	Opened: no door, lock or bricked room holds against it. Reopen: on a hit with a Helping, an old wound of the target's reopens (take damage again equal to the last Injury they suffered). Bearing: once a scene it may give birth, in a single convulsion, to a Part or Gathered that joins the fight.
DREAD	2 / 3 when its second face opens its eyes
END	The knife. It can be killed as anything can. It is hard to find a midwife who wants to do it twice.

FENN'S GET

Josiah Fenn, a shepherd, labored for three days and delivered something that stood up, looked at him, and walked out of the door. He has followed its tracks for eight years, and they are getting larger. Fenn's Get is twelve feet tall now. It walks the high red hills on legs too long, with a lamb's soft white face on a man's long skull, and its wool is matted with blood from the flocks it lies down among. It is not cruel. It is newborn and enormous, and it does not understand why things break when it holds them. The flocks it has lain with are found in a flattened circle in the heather, every sheep

pressed into the turf, their wool combed smooth, as if a child had tucked them in. It has a shepherd's crook it has made from a whole ash tree. It has been seen, at dusk, sitting at a distance from Fenn's camp, watching its father, and making the bleating sound that lambs make for their mother.



It sat on the ridge all night where I could see it, crying for me like a lamb at dipping. I've a knife. I've had it eight years. I keep it sharp for one of us.

JOSIAH FENN, TO MADDER RUDGE

FENN'S GET – THE THING THAT WALKED OUT OF THE DOOR	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 9 · Lung 6 · Eye 3 · Tongue 1 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (born of Vey directly) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Athletics 5, Brawl 5, Wayfaring 6, Instinct 6, Labor 5
BODY	Flesh 40 · Guard 21 · Armor 3 (blood-matted fleece and bone) · Threat 6
ATTACKS	ash-tree crook +9 (6, sweeps two targets); gather-in +9 (Grapple 22; held targets take 3 per round as it hugs them)
ABILITIES	Every Door: doors open as it nears, all within a mile. Grows: each Carving, +5 Flesh and +1 Gut. Father's Voice: if Josiah Fenn calls it, it must stop and roll Caul + Resolve 18 to continue acting.
SOP	lying down among living things until they stop. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	3 / 4 when it bleats
END	Fenn alone may be able to get close enough. He carries a knife. He is not sure whether he means to use it on the Get or himself.

CROWNINGS

The earth dilates, slowly, over weeks, into a perfect round opening, and people gather at the rim to see what comes up. A crowning is a hazard, a festival and a monster's birth in one. The rim is soft, red, wet, warm as flesh, and it gives underfoot like a lip; the hole is perfectly round and descends into darkness that pulses. The air above it is humid and smells of iron and birth-water, and every pang the ground around it groans, a long low sound the watchers feel in

their own bellies. Every pang, the crowning widens a hand's breadth. Then, at the end, something comes up. Roll on the table below when it does, and run the crowd. The rim itself is Dread 2 on sight; the moment of emergence is Dread 4.

◇
*Third crowning I've sat at. You bring a stool, a flask,
and a rope, and you don't stand at the lip at the last
pang, because it pulls.*

A WATCHER AT THE DILATION RIM

D6	WHAT IS BORN FROM THE CROWNING
1	Waters: a flood of warm salt fluid fills the valley to the rooftops in an hour.
2	A house: whole, furnished, with a family at table who believe they have always lived there.
3	A Gathered of three hundred Parts, hungry for the Assemblers' figure.
4	A hill, which stands up, which is a person. Use the Hungry Hill, Lung 3, and mobile.
5	A door in a frame, standing alone, ajar. It is identical to the Sill's.
6	Nothing. The hole closes. Three days later, every pregnant woman for ten miles goes into labor at once.

DOORBORN

A locked chest once gave birth. So did a well. Doorborn are the offspring of thresholds: thin grey things with jointed limbs like hinges, born from any door, gate or lid that has been shut too long. They come out at night into a sleeping house, unfolding from a cupboard or a bricked room with the creak of an unoiled hinge and a smell of dust, damp plaster and something like oiled iron, and they open things: windows, cradles, mouths, eyes, wounds, chests. They do it with care, with long fingers like keys, and they hum while they work, the same tuneless hum of a locksmith at his bench. Victims are found opened neatly along every seam a midwife knows, still alive, and very surprised. Agnes Latch's doors keep them in for up to nineteen days.

◇
*Nineteen days. That's my best. I'm not proud of it. I'm
only telling you so you'll knock.*

AGNES LATCH, THE DOORWRIGHT

DOORBORN Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 16 · Attack +6 (opening fingers 3; with two Helpings, a held door, lock, or a character's oldest scar is opened, Bleed 1 per round) · Armor 1 · Dread 3 · passes any door; cannot cross a threshold that has been knocked on and answered from the far side.

NEW HORROR: GRAVEBIRTH

Locks, seals and graves fail in Cradlewrack; nothing stays shut. The highland dead lie in clay pits capped with stone. A woman four days dead once gave birth; a Gravebirth is what that looks like a year in. The cap is found pushed aside from below, the earth heaved and split like a loaf that has burst its crust, wet and warm, with a small round opening at its centre the width of a fist. Inside, the dead

person lies as they were laid, except that they are open, and empty, and something has come out.

What comes out is small, wet and quick, about the size of a hare, grey-pink and soft-skulled, and it wears the dead person's face, in miniature, perfectly: the mole, the scar, the expression they died with. It goes home, in through the window that is always ajar, and curls up in its old place: the chair by the fire, the left side of the bed. It is cold, and it wants warmth, and it gets it from the living, slowly, by lying against them in the night. The family wakes grey and shivering, and weaker each morning, and some of them cannot bring themselves to put it out, because it has their mother's face.

Entry in the Tally, Cordway parish, Lack 640. "Born: one, of the grave of Ada Pask, deceased. Sex: as hers. Weight: a bag of flour. Appearance: hers. Attending: none. Second Opinion: not sought by the family, who say she is only visiting."

GRAVEBIRTH Threat 3 · Flesh 8 · Guard 15 · Attack +5 (cold embrace 1, Grapple 14; each night it lies against a sleeper, the sleeper loses 1 Gut until it is gone, and a character reduced to Gut 0 is dead by morning) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 / 4 when a character recognizes the face as someone they buried · Known Voice 14 (it speaks in a small version of the voice); reborn: if killed, the grave it came from must be opened and the body burned, or a new one comes up next pang.

NEW HORROR: A LOOSE CORD

The Uncut walk through life still attached to their mothers by yards of living cord. Sister Maeve Cord's mother has been dead six years, and the cord has not noticed. Sometimes a cord does notice. When an Uncut dies, or when a cord is severed in a brawl or by the Attendance's order, the length that is left does not lie down. Thick as a wrist, glossy, blue-grey and warm, it pulses with a heartbeat that belongs to neither end. It goes looking for a navel. It moves like a snake through the grass and under doors, and the hiss of it on

floorboards is soft and wet. It wants to be joined. It wraps a sleeper's waist and fixes itself, mouthless, with a slow seeping heat, and begins to feed in both directions: whatever it was joined to before, it is joined to now, and the sleeper wakes to find themselves bound by a living tether to a grave, a stranger, a hill, or something in the dark at the bottom of the Dilation.



Cut it, the midwife says. Cut it and you're free. My whole life I've heard the same lie from the same knife.

SISTER MAEVE CORD OF THE UNCUT

LOOSE CORD Threat 3 · Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Attack +6 (coil 1, Grapple 18; on two Helpings it fixes: the character is Corded and loses 1 Flesh a day, feels what the far end feels, and gains 1 Hunger a day if they carry any Cut) · Armor 1 · Dread 2 / 3 when it fixes · cutting a fixed cord inflicts Ruin on the bearer (Hand + Stitching 18 to do safely); following it to its far end is the only cure, and the far end is not always willing.

▼ OATHEN: WHAT WAS SAID



In Oathen, the monsters are made of words and the people the words broke. Nearly every horror here can be avoided by saying nothing. The difficulty, as every Oathener knows, is that silence is also a kind of answer. The sound of an Oathen horror is the sound of a promise coming due: a crack like green wood, a wet pop of a joint, and then, usually, nothing, because the person it happened to was taught as a child not to scream in case the scream counted.

◇
Say less.

THE WHOLE OF OATHEN'S LAW, AS TAUGHT TO
CHILDREN

THE FORSWORN MOB

The Breakdowns are full of people whose bodies keep the record of their sins: legs folded backwards for a fled duty, hands off at the wrist for a short measure, ribs opened outward like a book for a broken marriage vow, the heart visible within, beating in the canyon air under a film of dust. Most of them are no danger to anyone. A Forsworn mob is what happens when a Clausewright's ruling goes against the Breakdowns once too often. They come up the canyon stairs in a mass of crutches and wheeled boards and open chests, slow, loud (the only loud thing in Tacit), shouting plain words because they have nothing left to break, and they drag down whoever made the promise they blame. They know where every breakable promise is. They shout their victims' oaths back at them, verbatim, and wait to see what snaps. Afterward the Bench's clerks find the target on the stair, folded at whatever joint their own word chose, and the mob gone home, quiet again, satisfied.

◇
*They came up the Shadeward stair singing my own
wedding vow at me. I'd kept it. I'd kept it. And still my
knees went, from hearing it shouted so.*

A CLAUSEWRIGHT'S WIFE, TACIT

FORSWORN MOB (30) Threat 3 · Flesh 36 · Guard 11 · Attack +6
(crutches, clubs, bare broken hands 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 · Swarm; once a
scene the mob may shout a character's own past promise back at them
(Tongue + Clause 18 or the character must act at once as if renewing it).

THE LIVING ECHO

An oath repeated is an oath renewed, and a canyon will repeat anything. Most echoes die. A living echo does not. It is a sworn phrase trapped in deep rock long enough to have learned to move. It travels down gorges after people, riding the stone, faint at first, a voice two bends behind; then nearer; then from the wall just beside one's ear, in the voice of whoever first swore it, often dead for centuries. The rock where it passes is warm, and fine sand trickles from the cracks in time with the syllables. Anyone who hears it whole is bound by it. Those who have been bound by an echo they cannot understand are the saddest of the Forsworn, broken for promises in the archaic Table-speech of 300 A.G., limping for a duty to a king nobody remembers. Halvar Stane hunts them. The one in Sworn Gorge is the oldest, and he has made out two words.

◇
*It came round the bend in my father's voice and said
the first half of his wedding vow. I put my hands over
my ears and ran. I am fifty. My mother is dead. I do
not know what I would have been married to.*

AN ECHO-WARDEN'S REPORT, LOW SHALE

A LIVING ECHO – THE WORDS IN THE ROCK	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 0 · Gut 0 · Lung 7 · Eye 4 · Tongue 7 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Tongue-line, of whoever spoke it) · Regrowth 9 · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Stealth 6, Instinct 5, Clause 6
BODY	Flesh 20 (it has no body; damage is done by noise, see End) · Guard 18 · Armor special · Threat 6
ATTACKS	Repetition +11 against Tongue + Clause (Binding; a character who fails is sworn to the echo's oath, which the GM writes, and breaks as an Oathener breaks if they ever act against it)
ABILITIES	Rides Stone: it moves as fast as sound through rock; cannot cross open air or soft soil. Every Repeat: each round, it may Bind another listener. Characters who stop their ears entirely (wax, cloth, Hard Endure) are immune, and deaf.
DREAD	2 / 4 when it speaks in a character's own voice
END	Echo-Wardens kill echoes with silence: they collapse a gorge, pack its walls with felt, or shout a contradicting oath into it and take the break themselves. Blades and arrows do nothing. Loud counter-speech deals 1d6 damage per round to it and to the speaker.

A SAYER UNBITTED

Lady Imre Dath says one sentence a year. She has begun to write her own. A Sayer is a Tongue-line in the last stage, and what they say is. A Sayer unbitted, without the gold, is the most dangerous creature on the Table that is still, technically, a person. Their mouths are usually a ruin from decades of the bit: lips scarred into a permanent shape, the corners split and healed and split again, teeth filed or missing, tongue thick and pale and furred from disuse, the breath sour as a closed room. They speak slowly, savouring it, because they have not been allowed to speak in years. Each word lands like a

hammer on an anvil, with a sound in the bones, and the dust leaps from the floor. Things they describe become so. They are usually frightened. Fear makes them say what they are afraid of.

Clerk's minute of the First Sayer's valley, 598 A.G., written afterward by a survivor of the next valley over. "She said: I wish it would stop. The storm stopped. The river stopped, standing up, like a wall of glass. The birds stopped in the air. Her mother stopped in the doorway with her mouth open to call her in. They are all still there. We have built a wall so nobody can see."

A SAYER UNBITTED – WHAT IS SAID, IS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 9 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 12 (Seated in speech) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Clause 6, Persuade 4, Lore 4, Resolve 4
BODY	Flesh 9 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Threat 6
ATTACKS	none needed
ABILITIES	Saying: once per round, the Sayer speaks one sentence. If it is about the world, it is true from that moment. If it is about a character, that character may roll Tongue + Clause 22 (Dire) to wriggle out on a technicality the Sayer did not cover; otherwise it is true. A Sayer cannot unsay. Each Saying costs 1 Hunger; at 10 Hunger, the Sayer's next sentence happens to an entire valley.
WANTS	to speak, to finish sentences, to be heard.
DREAD	3 when the bit comes off / 5 on hearing it undo something that cannot be undone
END	Re-bit it. A bit fitted by Garl Tome holds. Getting close enough means speaking to it first, and it will answer.

THE OATH-MADE

A man once swore to his wife, "I promise you a son." Ilan exists anyway. The Oath-Made are people created by promises: sons sworn into being, soldiers promised to a cause, a lover sworn to come back that came back. They are real, warm and often loving. They also exist only for as long as the promise is kept, and they know it, at some deep level, and when the promise begins to fail (the one who

swore it dies, or wavers, or forgets) they begin to fade. A fading Oath-Made is hard to look at: the eye slides off it, the edges blur like a figure seen through heat-shimmer, and its voice comes from slightly to one side. Fading Oath-Made become frantic: they cling, they demand, they extract new promises at knife-point from anyone near. A fading Oath-Made who gets a stranger to swear "I will look after you" lives on, bound to that stranger. Forever.

◇

I promised I'd come back. I did. I'm very nearly sure I did. Would you say it to me? Would you promise me I'm here?

A FADING OATH-MADE, THE UNMADE ROAD

FADING OATH-MADE Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 (hard to see clearly) · Attack +5 (desperate grip 2, Grapple 16) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 / 3 when a character realizes they cannot remember its face · Persuade 6 to extract a promise; if it succeeds, the character is bound to it as by an oath.

THE DEFAULTED SURETY

Ona Fell can survive one more default. A Surety carries other people's oaths in their body for a fee. A Surety who exceeds their limit breaks all at once, every carried oath snapping in a single afternoon: bones, joints, ribs, a heart, a tongue, two hundred breaks in a minute, a sound like a bundle of kindling stamped on, going on and on. Most die. A few are left standing, a twisted heap of folded and refolded limbs that should not be able to stand, crawling in a way that hurts to watch, their skin tented over bone-ends at a hundred wrong angles, and they have nothing more to lose. They hunt the original swearers whose debts they paid, every one, by name. They cannot be bound by oath any more. There is no room left in them.

◇

She came through the door on four broken limbs and said my name, and the name of the oath she'd carried for me, and the date. I paid her. I paid her everything. She was still there.

A MERCHANT OF TACIT, BEFORE THE BENCH

DEFAULTED SURETY Threat 4 · Flesh 22 · Guard 13 · Attack +7 (grasping broken limbs 3, Grapple 18) · Armor 1 · Dread 3 · immune to Binding; knows the name of every oath it carried; a character whose oath it held suffers -4 to all rolls against it.

NEW HORROR: THE VOW-SPILL

At the Appetite, an Oathener feels a compulsion to swear, and the struck must be gagged for their own safety; the Murmuring House in Tacit holds three hundred of them, bitted in iron, humming through the grilles. The Vow-Spill is what happens when one gets loose. A swearer whose bit has rusted through, or been cut off by a pitying relative, comes out into the quiet streets and begins to promise, and cannot stop. The vows pour out in a torrent,

unqualified, absolute, in a voice cracked from years behind iron: I will, I swear, I shall, forever, on my mother, on my life. Each one binds the swearer. Within an hour the breaks begin, finger, wrist, knee, jaw, each with its crack, while they go on swearing through the blood. The vows also spill onto anyone near. A Vow-Spill in its last hour swears on behalf of others, using their names: *Arlen the potter swears to carry me home. The woman in the blue shawl swears never to leave this street.* In the Course and beyond, that counts.

◇

Three hundred mouths behind iron and every one of them trying to give you something. You learn to wax your ears. You never learn to stop hearing it.

DACEY FURL, THE GAG-NURSE

VOW-SPILL Threat 4 · Flesh 10 (falling 1 each round as its own vows break it) · Guard 10 · Attack +7 against Tongue + Clause (Binding, Hard 14; it swears an oath in a listener's name, and a character who fails is bound by it as if they had sworn it themselves) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 / 3 as its body begins to break · it acts twice a round; any character who answers it aloud is automatically bound to whatever it says next; re-biting it (Hand + Brawl vs Guard, then Hand + Craft 14) ends the spill, and what it has already sworn stands.

NEW HORROR: THE SWORN-UPON

Every Oathener swears on the dead, and in Oathen an oath on the dead is held by two witnesses: the god inside, and the one whose name was used. When such an oath is broken, the swearer breaks to match, as always. But when the oath was sworn over the body itself, at the grave or the bier, with the hand on the cold chest, and then broken, the dead sometimes get up to see it kept. The Sworn-Upon is a corpse in its grave-wrappings, dried by the canyon heat to leather and bone, its jaw bound shut with the cord the Quiet use, and it walks. It walks slowly and it does not stop. It follows the oathbreaker across gorges and onto the Rim Road, never hurrying, never resting, and when it catches up it stands at the foot of their bed and watches with eyes gone to dust until they keep the promise or die. It does not attack. It witnesses. In the end most of them keep the oath, whatever it was. Some of those oaths were terrible.

Inscription carved on the Ledger, 571 A.G., in the public vows. "I, Teodric Bask, swore upon the body of my brother Hale to see his children fed. I did not. He came for me at the Unmade Road and has stood at my bedside four years. Let it be recorded that on this day I have given my house, my well and my name to his children. Let it be recorded that he has lain down. Let it be recorded that I am very tired."

THE SWORN-UPON – THE WITNESS WHO WALKED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 6 · Tongue 0 · Caul 8
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (the swearer’s and the dead one’s, together) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 0
SKILLS	Search 6, Wayfaring 5, Instinct 6, Resolve 6
BODY	Flesh 30 · Guard 9 · Armor 2 (grave-leather) · Threat 6
ATTACKS	none; it will push aside, never strike (Gut + Labor at +5 to move past anything in its way)
ABILITIES	Witness: the oathbreaker it follows suffers –2 to all rolls while it is in sight, cannot benefit from rest, and must pass Caul + Resolve 18 to tell any lie. Untiring: it cannot be outrun across distance; wherever the oathbreaker sleeps, it arrives by dawn of the third day. Unbreaking: if hacked down, it reassembles at the grave and starts walking again. Kept Word: the moment the oath is kept, it lies down and is only a body.
DREAD	2 on sight / 4 when it is seen at the foot of a character’s own bed
END	Keep the oath. Or find a Surety willing to take it, and watch what follows the Surety home instead.

▼ THE FAST: THE HOST AND ITS TABLE



The Fast has no Regrowth. It has a whole god, unhoused, laying tables. Its horrors do not attack, mostly. They offer. Every entry in this section has **Hosting**, and every one is best survived by saying “No, thank you” three times. What they leave behind is the cruelest thing on the Table: people who were made perfectly happy, and cannot be brought back from it.

ORRUM'S TABLES

They appear in empty houses, at crossroads, in the middle of a field at dusk: a table of old dark wood, cloth laid white, candles lit, places set, the food steaming. The smell arrives first, a mile off: baking bread, roast fat, apples in butter, everything one's mother ever cooked on a feast day, and the starving Unfed weep at it in the road. It is warm around a table, gently warm, the warmth of a kitchen after a long walk. The cutlery is heavy silver, and each knife is laid exactly as the guest's family laid knives. There is a chair pulled out. Lately there is a card at the place with a name on it, spelled correctly. Treat a table as a hazard with Hosting 18. Any character who smells a table rolls Caul + Resolve 14 or moves toward it. Any who sees their own place card rolls Dread 3. Any who sits rolls Caul + Resolve 22 to rise again; Lent Ashby is the only one known to have managed it. Tablebreakers smash tables with axes before anyone can sit: a table has Flesh 20, Guard 0 and Armor 2, and as it breaks it bleeds gravy and its candles cry out like children. A table smashed by a character with any godsign in them adds 2 Hunger, because the god inside wanted that food.



Four hundred tables I've put the axe through. You learn the sound. It's not wood. It's a sigh, like a mother setting down a heavy dish she carried all that way for you.

DECLINE MARSH, TABLEBREAKER

THE SEATED

The Seated remain at table for decades, eating from empty plates, smiling, alive long past any natural span. They are skeletal and radiant. Their clothes have rotted to rags around them; their skin is paper over bone, so thin the lamplight shows the shadow of their teeth through their cheeks; their forks move, scrape, lift, and the jaw

works on nothing, and the throat swallows, a dry click a dozen times a minute. They smell of dust, candle-wax and, very faintly, of the meal they are describing. They are perfectly sane, and they want company. Brother Hallow Crust describes each course in detail, the soups, the roasts, the jellies trembling in their moulds, and people who listen too long pull out a chair. The Seated never attack. They invite. They are very good at it.



He told me about the soup for an hour. Leek and cream and a little nutmeg. I could taste it. I found my hand on the back of the chair and I do not remember reaching.

A HOSTWATCH NOVICE, THE LONG TABLE

THE SEATED Threat 5 (Persuade) · Flesh 4 · Guard 6 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 2 / 3 when one of them is someone known · Hosting 18: describing a course is a Persuade +11 roll against the listener's Caul + Resolve; failure costs 1 Fray and three failures pull out a chair. Lifting one from its seat kills it, gently, still smiling.

WELCOME ARDENT, THE STEWARD

He walks a mile ahead of Orrum, laying the tables. He was the first of the Unfed to accept, six hundred years ago, and the only guest who was offered a position. He looks like a tall, thin, tired man of fifty in a waiter's long apron, gravy-stained, with a cloth over his arm and very clean white gloves. His smile is genuine and exhausted. He smells of bread and old candles. His shoes are worn through at the toes from six centuries of the road, and his feet, inside them, are worn to the bone and do not bleed. He does not fight. He sets places, folds napkins, writes place cards in a beautiful hand, and asks politely whether you will be joining the Host this evening. He would like, very much, to be relieved. He has begun to look for a replacement.



I am so sorry to trouble you. Will you be dining with us? No? Of course. I'll keep it warm.

WELCOME ARDENT, ON THE RIM ROAD, TO A COMPANY WARDEN WHO HAS NOT SLEPT SINCE

WELCOME ARDENT – THE STEWARD	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 5 · Eye 5 · Tongue 6 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut none (he was never fed a god; he was hired by one) · no Hunger · no Regrowth
SKILLS	Persuade 6, Craft 5 (setting a table), Lore 6, Instinct 6, Wayfaring 6
BODY	Flesh 30 · Guard 21 · Armor 0 · Threat 7
ATTACKS	none. He does not fight. A character who attacks him finds their blow lands on a table that was not there a moment before.
ABILITIES	Hosting 22. The Card: he can write any character’s name on a place card; that character feels the Pull 18 toward the nearest table every night until the card is burned. Ahead of the Host: Orrum is always a mile behind him. Cannot Die While Employed. Wants: a successor. He will offer the position to the character who refuses him most gracefully.
DREAD	2 / 4 when he speaks a character’s mother’s name
END	None. His contract can be negotiated. Jessamy Quill has been asked to witness it. She has not yet said yes.

THE HOST

Orrum has no stats. Nobody living has seen it clearly and returned whole. The descriptions agree only that it is very tall, that it stoops

under doorways, and that it is warm. It does not attack. It hosts. Run the Host’s approach as a sequence of signs, each a scene or more apart. Each sign is a Dread check of rising difficulty, and at each sign the characters may still leave.

SIGN	WHAT THE CHARACTERS PERCEIVE	DREAD
1	Company: frost melting in a line across a field; the smell of bread with no source	1
2	Chimneys smoking in empty houses; a hearth already lit where they mean to shelter	2
3	A table, laid, with their names; Welcome Ardent bowing in the road	3
4	A tall shape stooping under the lintel of a house a field away, looking in	4
5	It is in the room. It is warm. It pulls out a chair.	5

At the fifth sign, any character who has accepted anything in the Fast must sit. Others must refuse three times aloud, each a Caul + Resolve roll at Dire 22. A character who refuses all three times and does not thank it is left alone, and the Host, very gently, sets their

place anyway, for next time. Do not let the players kill it. There is nothing to kill. Spare Tolland has seen it stop and wait for him to catch up, and has come to think it is lonely, and that is the most dangerous thing anyone has ever said about it.

IT WAS NOT HUNGRY. THAT WAS THE TERRIBLE
THING. IT WAS THE ONLY THING ON THE TABLE THAT
WAS NOT HUNGRY, AND IT WANTED SO BADLY FOR
US TO EAT.

[SPARE TOLLAND OF THE HOSTWATCH, THIRTY YEARS AT A MILE'S DISTANCE]

THE LIT HOUSE

Never enter a house where the hearth is already lit. A Lit House is the Host’s ambush: a ruin that, at dusk, has its windows glowing, its door ajar, its fire crackling and a kettle on. Inside, everything is warm, clean and laid out, and the door does not open from within

once a guest has crossed the threshold until they have eaten. The walls sweat butter. The floors creak with a sound like a stomach. The rooms rearrange themselves so every corridor leads back to the kitchen. Hosting 18 to resist eating each hour; Dread 2 on entering, 3 when a character finds the bones of earlier guests tidily stacked in the larder, clean and polished, every one with a napkin. The skulls

are arranged on the top shelf in the order the guests arrived, and the most recent still has a little flesh at the jaw, and is smiling.



The kettle was on. The bread was warm. And the larder was full of my grandfather's people, every skull with a napkin, all smiling.

A TABLEBREAKER OF WANTING

NEW HORROR: THE TIDIERS

The best farmland on the Table lies six centuries empty and perfectly kept. The hedges are trimmed. The windows are clean. Nobody does it. That is the Unfed saying, and it is wrong in one particular: something does it. The Hostwatch call them the Tidiars, and nobody has seen one whole. They are glimpsed only at the edge of the eye, a white sleeve, long pale hands shaking out a cloth, and they work only where no one is looking; the sound of them is a broom's whisper, a dish set down, a sheet snapped smooth.

They keep everything as a good host would, for the guest who is surely coming. That includes travellers. A traveller who sleeps in an empty Fast farmhouse without a watch wakes, if they wake, washed, combed, nails pared to the quick, clothes laundered and folded, and something untidy taken off them: a scab, a wart, a crooked finger straightened with a crack they slept through, a tooth's neighbours drawn so the smile is even. Those the Tidiars find untidy beyond mending are put away. The Hostwatch have found them in linen-presses, folded very small.

Spare Tolland's map, margin note, Lammas Bottom. "Slept at the Pellow farm, two of us. Posted no watch, God forgive me. Woke clean. Woke with my nails cut. Abide had a limp from a Reckoner raid. He walks straight now. He will not tell me what it felt like. He keeps touching his knee and looking at the dresser where the plates are."

THE TIDIERS Threat 6 (Stealth) · Flesh 12 · Guard 20 · Attack +7 (putting right: 2, ignoring Armor; on two Helpings, a Mangling of the GM's choice that leaves the character neater: a scar smoothed over, a finger

set crooked-straight, an ear trimmed) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 on finding the house kept / 3 on waking tidied · Unwatched (as the Scarecrow: they act only while no character is watching them); Hosting 14 (a character who thanks them, even in sleep-talk, must roll or stay to be looked after); posting a waking watch through the night keeps them out of the room.

NEW HORROR: THE CRUMB-BRINGER

Sister Nay Corliss has not eaten in three years, and each morning she wakes with crumbs on her lips. Abby Rooke leaves a crust on the windowsill and finds it replaced with something better. The Crumb-Bringer is the thing that does it: the Host's kindness at its most patient and most intimate, a feeding that happens while the Unfed sleep. It is never seen. It is felt: a weight settling on the edge of the mattress, a finger at the lips, a smell of honey-cake and warm milk, and in the morning a fullness the Unfed have never felt and have no word for. They put on flesh. Their cheeks fill, and their neighbours notice, and say nothing.

And each night they sleep a little deeper, and wake a little later, and want to go back. They begin to lay a crust out. Then a cup. Then a chair, beside the bed, pulled out. When they stop waking at all they are found plump and smiling, the covers tidied, a napkin tucked at the throat, the mouth open a little as if for the next spoon, and the chair beside the bed is warm.



She's fat. Sister Nay's fat, and her eyes are bright, and she's never been so holy. That's what they say in the Lean House. They say it like a curse.

A NOVICE OF THE STARVED SAINTS

THE CRUMB-BRINGER Threat 7 · no Flesh (it is not there to strike) · Guard none · Attack none; Hosting 18 nightly against a sleeping Unfed or anyone who has refused a table that week (failure: the character wakes fed, removes all Starving levels, and gains 1 Fed mark; at 3 marks they gain the Pull Derangement toward sleep, at 5 they do not wake) · Dread 1 on waking with crumbs / 3 on finding the warm chair · an Unfed who stays awake all night, or sleeps with a lit fire and a Tablebreaker's axe across the threshold, is passed by; refusing aloud in one's sleep, three times, is said to work, and nobody knows how to teach it.

▼ HUMAN ADVERSARIES

Most blood spilled on the Table is spilled by people. The templates below each give a quick line for the rank and file and a full stat block for a veteran or leader. Adjust Cut to the land: a Netwatch sergeant is a Lung-line commoner, a Second Table diner is whatever the highest Cut of their country is. Remember that every human with a Cut can Partake, and that a desperate soldier will. Remember too that every one of them has a home, a debt and someone waiting, and that the Table's worst atrocities are committed by people who are, by their own lights, being responsible.



The monsters only eat you. It takes a person to make you thank them for it.

BRACK, VOICE OF THE FORSWORN

NETWATCH PATROL

The Admiralty's night patrol hunts the Called along the shore with nets, hooks and rope. They are not cruel. They are tired, salt-stained, and drag people home who are fighting to go. A patrol is six hookmen and a sergeant with a lantern on a pole.



You don't save them. You hold them. Some nights it's the same thing.

LT. SABLE REEF, TO A RECRUIT

NETWATCH HOOKMAN Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (boathook 4, Hooking 14) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

NETWATCH SERGEANT – HOOK AND LANTERN

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Lung-line commoner) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Blades 3, Athletics 3, Wayfaring 3, Search 3, Resolve 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Threat 3
ATTACKS	boathook +6 (4, Hooking 16); weighted net +6 (0, Grapple 16, two targets)
TACTICS	one hook in the collar, one rope on the ankle, nets over all. They know the Pull and rope each other at the waist before the Uncovered sings.

WAKERS

The Vigil's police carry rattles and long needles, and they have been hurting people for their own good for three hundred years. A Waker patrol is four, sharp-eyed and twitching on rouse.



Under the nail for the drowsy, behind the ear for the stubborn, and for the ones who are smiling, run.

RATTLEHOUSE DRILL-RHYME

WAKER Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (needle 1 plus 1 Fray; rattle-club 3) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

WAKER CAPTAIN – THE NEEDLE OF THE WATCH

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Eye-line by-blood) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Blades 4, Stitching 2, Intimidate 4, Search 4, Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 17 · Armor 2 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	waking needle +8 (2, plus 1 Fray and target cannot blink for an hour); sword +8 (4)
TACTICS	Never Surprised; immune to sleep. Blinks under stress: on a Lack she loses a round and wakes having moved.

CULLMASTERS

The quiet office of the Board chooses who works the far fields at dusk. Its agents are clerks with ledgers, accompanied by Bailiffs who carry the red wrist-cloth and tie it on.

◇
It's not a death list. It's a work roster. Dusk shift, far field, Carving. Anyone can read a roster.
CULLMASTER VARN SWEETBREAD

CULL-BAILIFF Threat 2 · Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (cudgel 3, Grapple 14) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

CULLMASTER – AGRICULTURE BY LEDGER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Reckoning 4, Clause 3, Persuade 4, Deceive 3, Feast 4, Lore 3
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 11 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	knife +3 (2)
TACTICS	never fights; signs a warrant. A character he names in his ledger has the red cloth tied on them that dusk and the Reaping treats them as assigned. His Want: he must eat during any conversation.

RECKONER RAIDERS

Zealots out of the Fast who cross the Rim to end high-Cut bloodlines in their beds. They are thin, quick and very calm, and have no god in them to Partake of. They kill the children of the bloodline too, and they do it first, so that the parents will know, and they do not look away while they do it, because looking away would be a kind of eating.

◇
We do the little ones first so the parents understand. It is not cruelty. It is accuracy.
A RECKONER, UNDER QUESTIONING IN GLOVEHALL

RECKONER Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (long knife 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · Godless: Gifts that read, Pull or Bind the blood fail against them.

RECKONER-CAPTAIN – THE REFUSAL ON A BLADE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 0 (Unfed) · no Hunger
SKILLS	Blades 4, Stealth 5, Athletics 3, Wayfaring 4, Resolve 4, Lore 2 (genealogies)
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 18 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	long knife +8 (3); crossbow +7 (4)
TACTICS	Godless. Strikes the highest Cut in the room first. Carries the Cutwrights' ledgers, stolen. Will not eat anything in an enemy house, ever.

PURGATION CELL

The cross-border movement that believes the gods can be thrown back up. A cell is five or six: fasters and bleeders, hollow-eyed and scarred from the lancet, with a list of high-Cut families and a cart of lamp-oil. Where they have been, the house smells of vomit, smoke and the sharp green reek of their emetics, and the family is laid out on the floor in a row, emptied.

◇
Bring it up. Bring it up. Six hundred years in the belly of the world, bring it up.
PURGATION CHANT, HEARD OUTSIDE A BURNING HOUSE IN KEST

PURGER Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (cleaver 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · carries emetics and fire.

PURGATION BLEEDER – CELL-LEADER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (bled down for years, it is said, from 4) · Regrowth 2 · Hunger 1
SKILLS	Stitching 4, Blades 3, Persuade 4, Rites 3, Resolve 4
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	lancet +7 (2, Bleed 2 per round until bound); torch +6 (3, fire)
TACTICS	forced purging of captives (Gut + Endure 18 or Ruin); burning the beds of nobles; preaching to the crowd as they do it.

SECOND TABLE HUNT-CLUB

Nobles of the highest Cuts, in every capital, sharpening knives for a second meal. They practice, on people. A hunt is three or four diners in fine dark clothing, masked, with huntsmen and a cart that

carries silver, salt and a portable grill. The quarry is dressed, after, on a linen cloth by the roadside, and the diners take notes on the flavour in little calf-bound books, comparing the Cut by taste.

SECOND TABLE HUNTSMAN Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (spear 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

SECOND TABLE DINER – IT WORKED ONCE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (of their land) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Blades 4, Feast 5, Persuade 3, Lore 4, Godsign 4
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Armor 2 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	carving sword +8 plus two Teeth (4); their land's Course Gift
TACTICS	Partakes freely and smiles at the bitten-back. Prefers Blanks and god-fat prey. Cannibal in principle: eating a fallen foe's heart restores 1d6 Flesh and, they believe, a sliver of Cut.
DREAD	2 (to watch them eat)

From a calf-bound tasting-book found on the Rim Road near Brindle Cross, hand unknown. “No. 31. Scrapling, Fatlands, male, thirty or so. Coarse; the god very faint, a whisper of fat at the back of the tongue. No. 32. Unfed, female. Nothing. Nothing at all. Like eating snow. Extraordinary. Must have more.”

well on the road. Poachers use nets, cudgels, sleeping draughts and patience.



He gave us stew every night on the road. Real stew, with meat. That's how I knew we were being fattened.

AN UNFED ESCAPEE, BRINDLE CROSS

BLANK-POACHERS

They hunt the Unfed and the Blanks for the trade in godless blood and organs. Kale Dragoman takes his catches alive and feeds them

POACHER Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (cudgel 3, nonlethal) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

POACHER-MASTER – FED WELL ON THE ROAD	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Gut-line commoner) · Regrowth 4 · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Wayfaring 5, Stealth 4, Shooting 4, Filch 3, Haggle 4, Search 4
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	crossbow with drugged bolt +8 (2, Gut + Endure 14 or fall unconscious); cudgel +6 (3)
TACTICS	tracks by smell of the godless; offers food to captives, and an Unfed who accepts loses 2 from Resolve rolls for the rest of the journey from shame.

RIM ROAD COMPANY WARDENS

The Company’s toll-guards and caravan escort. Neutral, rich, armored better than anyone, and sworn to their contracts in Oathen, which means they literally cannot break them.

◇
I’d like to help you, friend. I genuinely would. Clause nine, paragraph four. Off the road.
A COMPANY WARDEN, TO A REFUGEE FAMILY

COMPANY WARDEN Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (spear 4; crossbow 4) · Armor 3 · Dread 0

WARDEN-CAPTAIN – SWORN IN OATHEN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	varies by birth · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Blades 4, Shooting 3, Haggle 3, Clause 3, Wayfaring 4, Endure 3
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 17 · Armor 3 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	sword +8 (4); crossbow +7 (4)
TACTICS	Sworn: cannot retreat, take a bribe, or harm a toll-paying traveler, or their body breaks. Can be talked into anything their contract permits, and nothing else.

CLAUSEWRIGHT

Lawyer-priest of the Bench of Clauses. A Clausewright fights with conditions, and wins.

◇
He said yes. He said it with eleven conditions, and my brother died in the third.
A FORSWORN OF THE BREAKDOWNS

BENCH CLERK Threat 3 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (stylus 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Clause 4.

CLAUSEWRIGHT – BARRING DEATH, ILLNESS OR WEATHER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Clause 6, Persuade 4, Reckoning 3, Lore 4, Deceive 2
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Threat 6
ATTACKS	none worth the name
TACTICS	Drafting: in a scene with time to talk, may extract a promise from a character through Tongue + Clause against their Tongue + Clause; a character who agrees is bound in Oathen. Escape Clause: once a scene, they may void a Binding against themselves on a technicality. Want: compelled to qualify every statement.

FORSWORN GANG

The Breakdowns’ organized crews, broken and plainspoken. They specialize in the one crime Oathen fears most: making people promise things.

◇
Just say you’ll pay us back. Go on. Small words. Easy words.
BREAKDOWN GREETING

FORSWORN TOUGH Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (club 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 (to see the break)

BREAKDOWN BOSS – NOTHING LEFT TO BREAK	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Brawl 4, Intimidate 5, Persuade 3, Clause 3, Endure 3
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	brass-shod crutch +8 (3); knife +6 (2)
TACTICS	immune to Binding, already broken. Threatens a target until they promise; then makes sure they break.
DREAD	1

ASSEMBLER BRETHREN

They collect Parts and join them, believing them to be one body, born piecemeal. They travel in pairs with sacks that move, and their gloves are always wet. Their coats smell of milk and catgut, and the sacks, when set down, roll over by themselves.

◇
*We don't steal them. We bring them home. Everything
that's born belongs to Herself.*

AN ASSEMBLER BROTHER, TO A MOTHER AT RUDGE

ASSEMBLER BROTHER Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (hook-knife 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 1 (the sack)

ASSEMBLER ELDER – MAKING GOOD PROGRESS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Caul-line) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Stitching 6, Lore 4, Rites 4, Search 3, Blades 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	bone saw +8 (3; on two Helpings the target loses a part, Mangling Injury)
TACTICS	Fitter: can attach a severed Part to any living body in a minute; it takes. Accompanied by a Gathered, Threat 3.
DREAD	2 when you see what is sewn to their back

FINISHER PILGRIMS

Sallowreach's death cult. They walk into the Hushes singing, and they will take others with them out of love. Their hymn has no last verse, as no song in the north does; they simply walk into the silence partway through a line, and those left on the edge hear the line stop.

◇
*Come with us, love. It's quiet there. Nothing hurts.
Nobody needs restitching.*

A FINISHER, TO A KEPT BEGGAR ON THE
GLOVEHALL ROAD

FINISHER PILGRIM Threat 1 · Flesh 12 (Unending in Sallowreach) · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (grasp 1, Grapple 12) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

FINISHER SHEPHERD – SOMEONE MUST STAY OUTSIDE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 4, Resolve 4, Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	walking staff +4 (3)
TACTICS	the Hymn of Ending: once a scene, all listening Kept must roll Caul + Resolve 18 or walk toward the nearest Hush, and living characters take 1 Fray. Never enters the Hush herself.

TUCKERS

The Vigil’s criminal mercy: sixty guarded seconds of sleep for a month’s wage. Their failures are delivered to the Dormitory steps. Their enforcers make sure payment does too.

◇
Sixty seconds. I count, you sleep, I pinch. If you’re not back by the pinch, you’re not my problem.
A TUCKER, THE SLOPE

TUCKER BRUISER Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (sap 3, nonlethal) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

TUCKER BOSS – ONE MINUTE, GUARDED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Haggle 5, Deceive 4, Blades 3, Stitching 3, Search 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	needle-dagger +6 (2); thrown sleeping-draught +6 (a target must roll Caul + Resolve 18 or blink for a round, and a blink can be a long time)
TACTICS	knows every lidded noble in the city. Sells clients to the Dormitory if they cannot pay.

RENDERERS' THUGS

The Union controls what leaves the Fatlands and knows what is in it. Its slaughtermen are huge, aproned and bloody to the elbow, and they settle disputes with the tools of the trade. The vats behind the Chute are kept at a rolling simmer day and night, skimmed by boys with long ladles, and the steam off them smells of pork, lye and something sweeter that the boys learn not to name.

◇
Everything goes in the vat. Everything comes out as tallow. Nobody asks what tallow used to be.
RENDERERS' YARD SAYING

SLAUGHTERMAN Threat 2 · Flesh 16 · Guard 12 · Attack +6 (cleaver 3, hook 4 Hooking 14) · Armor 2 (fat; blunt –1) · Dread 0

RENDERER FOREMAN – ORIGIN STAMPED OVER TWICE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 5 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Blades 4, Labor 4, Intimidate 4, Feast 4, Endure 3
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	greatcleaver +8 (6); meat-hook +7 (4, Hooking 16)
TACTICS	disposes of the defeated in the vats; any witness who sees the vats makes a Dread 2 check. Eats during fights.

ECHO-WARDENS

Rangers who police Oathen’s silent gorges and hunt sworn words still bouncing in the rock. They speak in handtalk, move without sound, and carry felt, mallets and sacks of quicklime that crack the rock when they are wetted.

◇
Not a word in the gorge. Not a cough. Not a prayer.
ECHO-WARDEN HAND-SIGN, THE FIRST ONE TAUGHT

ECHO-RANGER Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 16 · Attack +6 (short spear 4; sling 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · ears waxed, immune to Binding by sound.

SENIOR ECHO-WARDEN – WHO WILL NOT REPEAT IT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 6 · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Stealth 5, Wayfaring 5, Clause 4, Instinct 4, Shooting 3, Blades 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 19 · Armor 1 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	short spear +6 (4); sling +6 (2)
TACTICS	never speaks in a gorge. Contradiction: may shout a counter-oath to destroy an echo, taking the break in his own body. Silences intruders by collapsing rock on them.

NEW TEMPLATE: THE SHEPHERD OF A SMALL TABLE (CULT LEADER)

Beside the great cults (the Finishers, the Deepening, the Bedded, the Second Helping), every land has a hundred small ones: a mill-loft in Rudge where forty people wait for a door to open, a Rim inn whose landlord has taught his regulars that the eighth chair is for him. The Shepherd is the person at the head of such a table. They are warm, attentive and tired, and they remember your name, and the first meal they give you is the best you have had in a year. They usually Broke once, long ago, and the Derangement they took then is the doctrine now. They believe it. That is what makes them good at it.



He never once raised his voice. He just asked me, very gently, whether I was sure I'd seen my sister that morning. And after a while I wasn't.

A WOMAN PULLED OUT OF THE LAMPLIT SUPPER,
KEST

CULT CONTROL: HOLD

A Shepherd's power over a person is measured as **Hold**, from 0 to 5, tracked separately for each player character who spends time inside the cult. Once per scene, the Shepherd (or a trusted lieutenant) may use one of the methods below: an opposed roll of the Shepherd's Tongue + Persuade (or Deceive, where noted) against the character's Caul + Resolve. If the Shepherd wins, Hold rises by 1 (2 for Shared Sin).

- ◇ **The Welcome.** A meal, a blanket, a name remembered. +2 if the character is Starving, Rattled or bereaved.
- ◇ **The Confession.** The character tells something shameful aloud, and is forgiven. From now on, the cult holds it.

- ◇ **The Unmaking of Home.** Who Waits at Home is described, kindly and constantly, as the one who hurt you. At Hold 2+, Who Waits at Home no longer removes Fray.
- ◇ **The Gaslight** (Deceive). The Shepherd tells the character that something they remember did not happen. On a win, they believe it for a day; a character with *The Gaslight* Derangement cannot resist at all.
- ◇ **Shared Sin.** The character is brought to do, or to watch and not stop, something that cannot be undone: eating at the forbidden table, holding a rope while the Called walks in. Dread 3 check, and Hold +2. Cults bind not with belief but with complicity.

At **Hold 1** the character suffers –1 to resist the Shepherd in anything. At **Hold 3** they gain *The Devotion* toward the Shepherd for as long as Hold stays at 3+, and must roll Caul + Resolve 18 to act against the cult or tell an outsider its secrets. At **Hold 5** they will kill or die at a word, and the player and GM should decide together whether the character is now lost, as at a Seating.

Leaving. A character may try to walk away once per scene: Caul + Resolve against 10 + twice their Hold. Friends who come for them add +2, as does an Oath on the Dead sworn in the name of someone the cult took. Success drops Hold by 1 and costs 2 Fray, the ache of withdrawal; failure means they stay, and say they wanted to. Hold falls by 1 each week a character spends away from the cult in the company of someone who loves them, and does not fall at all if they are alone.

Contagion in the Fold. When any member of a cult Breaks in the gathering, every member present checks at Dread 3, not 2, and the Shepherd chooses which Derangement spreads. This is how a hundred people come to share one delusion, and why small cults so often end all on the same night.

DEVOTEE Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (knife or kitchen tool 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 (the smile) · will not flee while the Shepherd is in sight; Hold 4 on the Shepherd.

THE SHEPHERD – MOUTH OF THE SMALL TABLE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (of their land) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Deceive 4, Rites 4, Instinct 4, Lore 3, Resolve 3
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	none worth the name; the faithful fight for them
TACTICS	the Hold methods above; never alone, never armed, never in a hurry. Knows every member's Confession. Partakes on Persuade rolls and calls the Tooth a blessing.
DERANGEMENTS	<i>The Voice at Table</i> (the god advises; some of it is good)
DREAD	2 when a character realizes the Shepherd believes every word
END	Take the people, not the Shepherd. A Shepherd killed before the fold is out becomes a martyr, and a martyr's Hold never falls.

NEW TEMPLATE: THE PATIENT HAND (SADIST QUESTIONER)

Every power on the Table keeps someone for questions: the Jar Room in Lastgate, the Rattlehouse, the Board's back cellars, the Witnessing Vaults of Oathen. Most questioners hate the work and pay for it in Dread. The Patient Hand does not pay. Somewhere along the way the part of them that flinched was used up, and what is left enjoys it with a craftsman's quiet absorption. They are courteous, and interested in the person in front of them more completely than anyone has ever been, and that interest is the worst thing the subject will ever know. In Sallowreach, where nobody dies, a Patient Hand can keep a single subject for decades, and some have.

Show their work only in what comes before and after, never as a procedure: the swept room, a hoarse voice through a door, the

questioner humming at a basin, the subject afterward unable to stop thanking anyone who comes near.

Ledger of the Jar Room, marginal note in the keeper's hand.
"Subject 9-Long, year forty of her sentence. Still has not told us where the Heirs' press is hidden. I no longer believe she knows. I have not told the Court this. We are so close now, she and I. She asks after my daughter."

QUESTIONING

A session follows the core rule: the questioner's Tongue + Intimidate against the subject's Caul + Resolve. In addition, each session the subject makes a Dread 3 check, and a subject who Breaks under questioning takes a Derangement from this short list (or the main table): *The Splitting*, *The Gaslight*, *The Devotion* (toward the questioner), *The Dead Man*. What they say is weighed on the table below, rolled by the GM in secret.

D6	WHAT THE ANSWER IS WORTH
1	Nothing: the subject has invented a story to make it stop, and believes it now
2	Nothing: the subject has told the questioner what the questioner wanted to hear
3	Half the truth, tangled with a lie the subject no longer knows is a lie
4	The truth, which no one will believe because of how it was got
5	The truth
6	The truth, and something else the subject was never asked and should never have said

A player character who questions in this way makes the core Dread 2 check each session. One who fails three in a row and keeps going

is, in the Table's phrase, *going cold*; no Derangement describes it, because the people who have it do not consider themselves ill.

THE PATIENT HAND – WHO HAS NEVER ONCE BEEN BORED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (any land) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Stitching 5, Intimidate 5, Search 4, Instinct 4, Deceive 3, Blades 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 1 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	a short, very clean knife +7 (2; on any Helping, a Mangling of their choosing rather than extra damage)
TACTICS	Gone Cold: immune to Dread checks caused by suffering, and to Persuade rolls that appeal to pity. The Long Question: in a session, a Patient Hand rolls with +2 and the subject's Dread check is Grim 18. Never in a hurry; never fights fair; always has a door between them and the subject's friends.
DREAD	1 / 3 when they speak of a subject with fondness
END	They have no fear but one: being made the subject. Most of them have a very clear idea of how it would go.

NEW TEMPLATE: SPADEMAN (GRAVE-ROBBERS)

The trade in Leavings needs the dead, and the dead are guarded everywhere on the Table differently. Spademen are the ones who go and get them anyway. In the Fast they dig the Barrows for godless Unfed bones; in Oathen they rob the vaults of the sworn-upon and are followed home; in Sallowreach they take from the Lofts, where the merchandise is aware and begging them to stop. The Fatlands have no graves, so their Spademen rob wakes, lifting the best joints from the platter before the family sits. Spademen smell of wet earth, lamp-black and oil of cloves, and they work in threes: one to dig, one to watch, and one to talk to whatever is in the hole.



*Two lacks for a Blank's knucklebone at the Chute.
Twelve for a skull. Forty if it still has the teeth. Don't
ask me how I know if it's a Blank. I lick it.*

A SPADEMAN, DRINKING, BRINDLE CROSS

SPADEMAN Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (spade 3, sweeps) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · carries hook, sack, salt and wax; Hand +

Stitching 3 for taking Leavings.

SPADE-MASTER Threat 4 · Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Attack +7 (grave-hook 4, Hooking 16) · Armor 2 · Dread 1 (what is in the sack) · knows the Leavings trade (Lore 4) and every buyer on the Rim; has broken an Oath on the Dead and is followed by the Visitation, which the GM may bring on at any moment.

NEW TEMPLATE: LEDGER-HOUNDS (CUTWRIGHTS' ENFORCERS)

The Cutwrights' ledgers decide marriages, inheritances and executions, and someone has to carry their decisions out into the world: the Ledger-Hounds, genealogists with crossbows. They serve warrants of marriage on unwilling cousins; they deliver Blanks to the College's buyers; they take blood by lancet from families who would rather not be measured; and on the College's word they end a line that the ledgers say is regrowing too fast. They are thorough. They do not kill the one; they kill the line, down to the second cousins, and enter it closed in red ink.

LEDGER-CLERK Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (crossbow 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · Reckoning 4, Lore 4 (genealogy).

LEDGER-HOUND – THE COLLEGE'S LONG MEMORY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (any; the College prefers to hire against type) · Regrowth 4 · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Lore 5 (bloodlines), Reckoning 4, Shooting 4, Search 4, Stitching 3, Clause 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	crossbow +8 (4); bleeding-lancet +6 (2, and a drop of the target's blood for the ledger)
TACTICS	The Reading: from a drop of blood and an hour with the ledgers, knows a character's Cut, Regrowth stage and every living relative. Line-Closing: hunts kin first, to draw the target in. Carries a College warrant that Rim Road Company wardens are sworn to honor.
DREAD	1 / 3 when a character sees their own family tree, with names struck through in red

NEW TEMPLATE: THE CLOSE
TABLE (A HOUSE THAT MARRIES
IN)

The Cutwrights’ ledgers reward purity of line, and some of the highest houses on the Table have pursued it for centuries. Cousins wed cousins, and then closer than cousins; the College records it in a code the clerks call *the near hand*. The godsign concentrates. The children of a Close Table are born far along, their Regrowth begun in the cradle: Hand-line infants with grey fingers that close the nurse’s eyes, Gut-line babes that root in their cribs, Caul-line children whose veils never come off and who see their parents’ deaths through them. Its portraits all have the same face. What

happens between its members is never spoken of, never written, and never shown in this book; what the players meet is the result: a family that loves itself too much and outsiders not at all, that holds a supper each Tablenight at which the weakest of its own is served, and that will kill anyone who threatens to marry out.

◇
*Thirty-one portraits in the long gallery and one face.
Lady’s face. The little ones’ face. The face in the cradle
that looked up at me with its grey hands folded. I gave
notice that night.*

A NURSE OF A GLOVEHALL HOUSE, TO THE HEIRS

MATRIARCH OF THE CLOSE TABLE – THE NEAREST HAND	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (of their land, the purest line in it) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Persuade 4, Intimidate 4, Clause 4, Lore 5 (her own line), Godsign 5, Rites 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Threat 6
ATTACKS	her land’s Brink Gift; her kin, who fight for her (as Second Table Diners, Regrowth 5–8)
TACTICS	Family First: every member of the house within sight adds +1 to her rolls and she to theirs. The Supper: once a season she may Sop by feeding the house’s weakest member to the rest, removing 1d6 Hunger from every family member present. Never leaves the estate; does not need to.
DREAD	2 / 4 on seeing the children
END	The Cutwrights want the line closed and will pay for it, and the Reckoners will do it for nothing. Neither will tell the players about the youngest, who is innocent, and who has already begun to Seat.

▼ THE GOD-RIDDEN

The Seating is the god coming home for good. Long before that, it visits. A person deep in the Regrowth can be **ridden**: for a heartbeat, an hour or a season, the god takes the reins and the person watches from somewhere further back, or not at all. The Tenanted are the ridden made permanent and polite; the blink-killers are ridden for two seconds. Between lie a great many people who have woken with blood on their sleeves and their family looking at them in a way they will never be able to explain.



It wasn't him. It had his hands, and it held the baby very nicely. But it wasn't him, and the baby knew.

A WRECKWIFE, TO THE NETWATCH

STAGE	DIFFICULTY	LENGTH OF THE RIDE
The Course (7–9)	Hard 14	1d6 rounds
The Brink (10–11)	Grim 18	1d6 minutes, or the rest of the scene on a Lack
In a Seated Reach	Dire 22	until someone calls them back

While ridden, the GM plays the character (or the player plays the god, which is often worse). The ridden use their own statistics with **+2 Caul**, ignore Fray and Dread, cannot Partake (the god is

WHEN THE GOD TAKES THE REINS

A character at **the Course** or **the Brink** must roll Caul + Resolve against the difficulty below whenever one of these happens: their Hunger fills and their Regrowth rises; they roll a Lack while Partaking; they fail a Want check and act on it; they come within the Reach of a Seated fragment or the Pull of a creature with Riding. Failure means they are ridden.

driving), and pursue the god's purpose below with every Gift and everything the character knows.

LAND	WHAT THE GOD DOES WITH A BORROWED BODY	THE TELL
Sallowreach	Closes: eyes, doors, books, lives; seeks the nearest Hush	The hands go still and cold; the voice drops to a murmur
The Fatlands	Eats, and feeds others, and walks out to the far field at dusk	Drool, a hum, the smell of fresh bread
Brinehollow	Walks west; presses; speaks in two voices	The weight; the ears pop in the room
The Vigil	Lies down, or puts others to sleep; opens the Line	The eyes close and the body keeps moving
Cradlewrack	Opens every door, wound and grave; attends births nobody wanted	Every door in the house is open when they leave
Oathen	Swears, in their name and in others'; says things that become so	The voice is heard a half-second before the lips move

CALLING THEM BACK

An ally may spend an action to call the ridden by name: Tongue + Persuade against the ride's difficulty. Speaking their full name adds +1; touching them adds +1; invoking an Oath on the Dead the ridden swore, or the name of Who Waits at Home, adds +2. Pain works in the Vigil and nowhere else (a Waker's needle is +2 there). Giving the god its Sop ends the ride at once, which is why so many

families keep a little of what the god wants in the house: a jar of brine, a door to open, a vow.

AFTERWARD

The ridden come back with Hunger at 0 (the god has eaten) and no memory of the ride, which counts as a Dread check at the rating of whatever they did, discovered afterward. The god also keeps something. Roll a d6.

D6	WHAT THE GOD KEPT
1	A habit: the character has a new small Want for a week (the GM names it)

D6	WHAT THE GOD KEPT
2	A memory: one person the character loves is now a stranger to them for a day
3	A promise: the god swore something in their name, and somebody heard
4	A mark: one tell of the next Regrowth stage appears early and stays
5	A victim: someone was hurt while they were away, and knows who did it
6	Nothing at all; the character feels rested, whole, better than in years, and that is the worst of them

THE RIDDEN AS ADVERSARIES

Any human stat block in this chapter can be ridden: add +2 Caul, the land's tell, Dread 2 (Dread 3 to those who love them), and the god's purpose. Riding spreads like madness: when one person in a household is ridden, every Cut-bearing member present must check too, and in the worst-hit villages whole families have been found at their tables, faces calm, every one of them somewhere else. Emetics, rites and knives have all been tried. Only the knives always work.

POSSESSION AT THE TABLE

Taking a player's character away from them is the strongest move the GM has. Use it rarely and say so plainly when it happens. Agree in advance whether the god may make a ridden character harm a companion, and how far; many tables prefer that the ride is shown through its aftermath (the open doors, the stranger's ring, the blood) rather than played. Offering the player the god's part to play, with the god's purpose and none of the character's restraint, is often the most frightening option, and the one players remember.

▼ THE SEATED GODS

No land has reached a full Seating. Three are close. This section is for the night one of them gets there.

When a Regrowth completes, the god does not return whole. A god eaten by ten thousand mouths and scattered through six centuries of blood comes back as a **Seated fragment**: a portion of itself, wearing a person or a place as a body, and growing. It is enough. A fragment of a Provider is the largest thing that has walked the Table since the Night of Seven Tables, and its arrival

ends the campaign as it was. What follows is not a fight. The entries below give a fragment's **Seat** (what it wears), its **Reach** (how far it extends, and how fast it grows), its **Presence** (what happens to everyone in reach, each round or each day), its **Hands** (the creatures from this chapter that now act for it), and **What Can Be Done**. None has Flesh. Every one is Dread 5, and Fray Aura 22, and anyone of its land's Cut within its Reach feels the Pull 22 every round, and must check against the ride at Dire 22.

OSSEL SEATED – THE CLOSING HAND

SEAT	the Hand-lines, all at once; the Mortuary Court's chamber becomes a Hush with a figure in it whose hands are folded.
REACH	Dunmere Hush and every other Hush join; grows a mile a day across Sallowreach.
PRESENCE	everything in Reach finishes. The Kept lie down by the thousand, glad. The living who fail their Dread check stop, mid-breath, and are done. Sound ends. Then the fen begins to end, and the fog, and the land.
HANDS	Hush-walkers, Undone Closers, the Whispering Aisles, every Finisher.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	carry people out. Every Kept who can be got across the border before the Hush arrives drops dead at once, which is at least an ending they chose. Pim Sorrel may be able to ask it to wait.

UMMER SEATED – THE LADEN

SEAT	Chairman Obb Tullow, rooted through his cart, swelling until Sated is built on his shoulders.
REACH	every field in the Fatlands, and every barrel of their meat on the Rim Road.
PRESENCE	the Reaping all at once, by day and by night. The soil takes anyone standing on it who fails Lung + Wayfaring 22. Everyone who has eaten Fatlands meat in the last year, anywhere, feels Fatlands Hunger: +1 Hunger per day, and the Feast Want.
HANDS	Hungry Hills, the Scarecrow, the Uneaten and the Bottomless, Rootkin by the million, the two-legged cattle, all standing up.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	stop eating. The Thin have practiced. Wren Hollowell feels no hunger at all and may walk where no one else can.

DROMM SEATED – THE FATHOM

SEAT	the Tenanted, every one, standing up in courtrooms across the land and walking west; and the Dowager Below, who rises.
REACH	the Trench, then the Uncovered, then Lowmark's nineteen miles of pier. The sea comes back, all at once, from inside the people who were holding it.
PRESENCE	pressure. All rolls in Reach –4. Each round, every character with a Lung-line Cut must bail (Gut + Endure 18) or drown on dry land. The Called number in the tens of thousands.
HANDS	Ribwalkers, the Called Procession, the Cistern-Kept, the Indoor Tide in every house on the Table that has ever drunk Dry Jonah's tonic.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	get high and get inland. Dagna Hull's Follow may survive the water's return. Father Ebb says the chain is not what holds him.

ISS SEATED – THE LIDDED	
SEAT	Aveline Morne, the Sleeper in Bed One, sitting up. The eye in the long room opens.
REACH	the Dormitory, then the Vigil, then everyone on the Table who has ever slept, which is everyone.
PRESENCE	sleep. Every character must roll Caul + Resolve 22 every hour or blink, and a blink now lasts until the Seated fragment is satisfied. The Counted wake together, sixty thousand of them, breathing in time, and walk.
HANDS	the Counted, Tether-Catches by the hundred, blink-killers in every street, Seemings made solid wherever the exhausted gather, and a Made Bed in every dark room.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	stay awake for as long as it takes. Nobody knows how long that is. Sallowreach's Kept do not sleep. Castellán Dray's terrible proposal may become the only sane one on the Table.

VEY SEATED – THE OPENING	
SEAT	the land. Cradlewrack's highlands are delivered of something out of the Dilation, as the Sill's door swings open, and the Assemblers' figure stands up with a voice and a left hand.
REACH	every threshold on the Table. Every door opens.
PRESENCE	birth. Every character must roll Gut + Endure 18 each day or go into labor with something that is not a child. Wounds reopen at dawn. Locks, seals and graves fail; things begin.
HANDS	the Gathered, Doorborn, Gravebirths in every churchyard, Fenn's Get (now the size of a hill), and whatever the crowning produced.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	the Barren Order's answer is to begin nothing. Ambrose, the Eldest Infant, says that when he reaches the cradle it will be time, and may know for what.

TOLM SEATED – THE WITNESS	
SEAT	a Sayer, unbitted at last, speaking without stopping; or the Ledger, four miles of carved vows, beginning to read itself aloud.
REACH	everywhere a word in Oathen has carried, which means every treaty and every Rim Road Company contract on the Table.
PRESENCE	every word binds. Every thought binds. Characters with any Tongue-line Cut cannot think a lie without breaking. Every contract sworn before Jessamy Quill comes due at once, with interest, in the body of each signatory.
HANDS	living echoes, Vow-Spills, the Sworn-Upon walking out of every vault, every Forsworn, the Defaulted, and the Rain, which falls now only on those who have kept their word.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	say nothing. Cassian Wry can lie and stay whole; in a world that has become a promise, a liar is the only free man left.

Orrum has no Seated fragment. It was never eaten. It is whole, and it is coming. Some scholars of the Table have begun to ask why a god with all its strength would spend six centuries laying places, and for

whom. The Hallowboard table has eight sides. One side, the Hostwatch reports, is always laid, and always empty.

SIX MEALS AND ONE REFUSAL, AND STILL THE
TABLE IS SET FOR ONE MORE. COUNT THE CHAIRS.
THEN ASK WHO IS LATE.

[ATTRIBUTED TO MEEK GARRITY, THE HISTORIAN, IN A LETTER NEVER SENT]

WHY YOU CANNOT FIGHT A GOD

The players will want to. Tell them, in the fiction, why they cannot. The Providers did not fight when they were eaten; that is recorded everywhere and explained nowhere. Returning, they do not fight either. A Seated god is not hostile any more than weather is hostile. It is a condition of the world reasserting itself. Its Presence affects everyone in Reach without a roll to hit. It has no Flesh to reduce. Attacking a fragment's Seat (cutting down Obb Tullow, smashing Aveline Morne's bed) is possible and accomplishes exactly what killing a single fold of a flooding river would.

What player characters can do is choose how the world meets the god. Every campaign-ending threat above should be run as a set of choices, each with a terrible cost.

- ◇ **Refuse it.** The Fast's answer: accept nothing it offers, and endure. This works, partly, for the godless, and for those who can bear starvation. For everyone with a Cut, refusal means fighting the god in their own blood every round of their lives. Each refusal costs Hunger. Hunger fills.
- ◇ **Feed it.** Every god has a Sop. Feed the Sop on a national scale (the Cullmasters' answer, the Second Helping's, the Finishers') and the fragment quiets. It grows, too.
- ◇ **Bind it.** Go to Oathen and have it sworn. A god's word outlives the god; the Kept Rain proves it. A Seated fragment can be negotiated with, through a Sayer, in a Clausewright's language, before Jessamy Quill. It will keep its word. The question is what it asks in exchange.
- ◇ **Carry it out.** The rules of a land stop at its border. A Seat that can be moved (a person, a child, a hand) can be carried across the Rim Road. Then the god is somewhere new, and its rules come with it.
- ◇ **Eat it again.** The Second Table's answer. It worked once. It bought six hundred and forty-one years. The party that eats a Seated fragment becomes the next Seat, and their children carry it, and the Long Grace begins again.
- ◇ **Hide.** The Providers held still once, and nobody knows why. Characters who ask that question loudly enough, in the right places, may find out what a god is afraid of. That is a matter for the Secrets chapter, and for the GM.

▼ LAIRS

Most of the Table's horrors have somewhere they go back to. When the players follow one home, roll once or twice on the land's table for what they find. Most entries are a Dread 1 or 2 check; the last on each table are clues to something worse.

SALLOWREACH

D10	LAIR DRESSING
1	Shelves of labeled jars, green glass, each with something inside that turns to watch the lamp
2	A mattress of old shrouds, still warm, crawling with white maggots the size of barley
3	Wire, thread and needles in a heap, and a pile of fingers sorted by length
4	Candle-stubs that whimper when trodden on
5	Peat-water to the ankle, with something below it gripping and letting go, gripping and letting go
6	A child's slate on which someone has written <i>may you finish</i> forty times
7	A lead mitten, torn open from inside
8	A circle of dead flies on the floor, perfectly round; inside it, no sound
9	A Closing license, signed by Ansel Grue, for someone still upright
10	A family portrait with every face scratched out except one, which has been carefully Closed

THE FATLANDS

D10	LAIR DRESSING
1	Walls that sweat a fine yellow fat; the floor gives like a belly
2	Gnawed bones in a heap, sorted into soup-bones and roasting-bones
3	A red wrist-cloth, a dozen of them, knotted together into a rope
4	Toothed wheat growing out of the plaster, clicking softly
5	A table laid for a wake that was never finished, the meat gone grey and furred
6	A trough of slops still warm, and a long tongue-print in it
7	Rootkin stacked like firewood, faces up, eyes closed, breathing
8	A Board ledger page listing the household by weight
9	A funnel and a ladle of office, crusted
10	A soft warm hummock in the floor, the size of a man, with a mouth beginning to form

BRINEHOLLOW

D10	LAIR DRESSING
1	Kelp on every step, still wet, still moving
2	A bail-bucket full to the brim, with something small swimming in it
3	Anchor-ropes, cut, coiled neatly, dozens of them

D10	LAIR DRESSING
4	A pressure-cracked window, bowed inward, the glass crazed like ice
5	Salt crust on every surface, thick as snow, printed with bare feet going west
6	A nest of Coughlings in the hearth-ash, rustling like rain
7	A drowned man's boots, filled with sand and set side by side
8	An Admiralty commission for a captain who was Called forty years ago
9	A cistern with a face looking up from the bottom, perfectly still
10	A Lowmark tide-chart, re-drawn in brine, showing water where there is none

THE VIGIL

D10	LAIR DRESSING
1	Pins, hundreds, driven point-up through a plank floor
2	A standing-frame, empty, the straps worn smooth and stained
3	Rouse-dregs in a hundred cups, the smell bitter and burnt
4	A lamp that has been out for a week, and the darkness around it soft as felt
5	A pair of shoes, a folded coat, a note that says only <i>sorry</i>
6	A pillow, forbidden, hidden in a wall, with a dent in it
7	A tether-collar, the silk line cut short and still damp
8	A child's nudging-glove, the fingers worn through from pinching
9	A list of bed numbers with lines drawn through the oldest rows
10	A crude carving of a great closed eye, and under it, in chalk, the beginning of a number

CRADLEWRACK

D10	LAIR DRESSING
1	Every door off its hinges and stacked against the wall like playing cards
2	A trail of rust-brown slime leading to a crack in the floor
3	A row of cradles, each holding something warm and folded in a blanket
4	A bricked-up room, broken open from the inside
5	A birthing-stool, worn, with knife-marks on the arm
6	Cord, yards of it, blue-grey, coiled in a basket, faintly pulsing
7	The Tally, a stolen page, with births entered for names that are not yet dead
8	A small grave-cap, pushed aside, and a hole a fist wide
9	A key with no lock, born, still slick
10	A drawing of the Assemblers' figure, with a left hand in a different ink

OATHEN

D10	LAIR DRESSING
1	Felt hung on every wall, thick with dust, muffling every step
2	A gold bit, cut through
3	Scratched vows on the plaster, hundreds, all broken off mid-word
4	Crutches stacked like spears; one of them carved with a name
5	A contract of four hundred conditions, the last one in a different hand
6	A jaw-cord of the Quiet, untied
7	Grave-wrappings on the floor, dry as paper, shaped like someone sitting
8	A Surety's ledger, two hundred names, and one circled
9	A carved stone from the Ledger with a single word chiselled out
10	Silence so complete that the characters hear their own last promises repeated

THE FAST

D10	LAIR DRESSING
1	A table, laid, the food cold and perfect, untouched for decades
2	A linen-press, very full, and very heavy, that nobody wants to open
3	Swept floors, polished brass, folded napkins, and no dust anywhere
4	A crust on a windowsill, and something better beside it
5	A warm patch on the floor in the shape of a very long stride
6	Place cards in a beautiful hand, a whole box of them, sorted by land
7	A Tablebreaker's axe, its edge blunted, gravy dried in the grain
8	A chair, pulled out, in front of an empty fireplace that is warm
9	A Pantry ration-list with names left off, and beside each, a little drawn plate
10	Eight chairs around a round table; seven pushed in, and dust on all but the eighth

▼ RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

Roll when the characters travel, camp, or linger too long in one place. Each table is weighted toward the uncanny; a GM who wants a quieter road should reroll results above 7. Each land's table now

runs to d12; the last two results bring in the horrors new to this edition.

SALLOWREACH

D12	ENCOUNTER
1	A Kept family carrying great-grandfather to the Lofts, arguing about whose turn it is
2	Bubbles rise in the Sump in the shape of a hand; a Sump-Thing surfaces next scene
3	A Flyfront at Black Noon, rolling across the fen; lamps begin to go out
4	Two Unstitched Kept beg for thread at the roadside; one has stopped asking
5	Marrow Jack's men, bone saws in their coats, eyeing someone's sleeping companion
6	A Finisher procession singing toward the nearest Hush
7	A circle of dead birds; the silence beyond is a Hush-walker approaching
8	A Tallow-Saint stands in an empty chandlery, steady as a lamp
9	A Court Closer and four guards, hunting an Undone Closer; they ask questions
10	The Undone Closer itself, kneeling by a stranger, folding her hands
11	A Sewn Gentleman in a fine coat, and a crowd of Unstitched following at a distance
12	A Loft aisle begins to whisper in unison as the party passes the street door

THE FATLANDS

D12	ENCOUNTER
1	A Bailiff with funnel and ladle enforcing the third meal of the day
2	A toothed field in the wind, chewing
3	Sal Trotter's herd on the road; one beast is standing up
4	Thin fugitives hiding in a ditch, begging the characters not to feed them
5	Cull-Bailiffs tying red cloth on a vagrant's wrist
6	A Rootkin bed in a fallow plot; one face is familiar
7	A hill calls a character by a grandparent's name
8	Renderers' slaughtermen and a cart with a lid that is knocking
9	Dusk in Carving: the furrows begin to deepen
10	The Scarecrow of Low Tilth, closer than it was this morning
11	A cottage at suppertime, door open, five at table, one of them the Uneaten
12	A stripped kitchen and a cook in the corner holding her wrist: the Bottomless was here

BRINEHOLLOW

D12	ENCOUNTER
1	The morning count through the walls; one name gets no answer
2	A Netwatch patrol with a Called in the net, bailing
3	A Tenanted judge on circuit, perfectly fair, perfectly calm
4	Salvagers on the Uncovered trading in things with too many ribs
5	A Ribwalker stalking toward the camp's water barrels
6	A pressure day: ears bleed, windows bow, everyone rolls Endure
7	A Deepening procession with lanterns, walking west
8	The Uncovered sings; all Lung-lines roll against the Pull 14
9	The Indoor Tide comes up the inn's cellar stairs and keeps coming
10	A Called Procession of forty, including someone the characters know
11	A bucket left standing overnight; by morning it is a Coughling nest
12	A public cistern, closed by notice; a voice from it calls a character's name

THE VIGIL

D12	ENCOUNTER
1	A street nudger offering pinches by the minute
2	A Waker patrol checking eyes with lamps and needles
3	A mild, quiet, overcast afternoon; the death toll begins
4	A Yawn spreads through a crowded square
5	Tuckers selling a guarded minute in an alley; the last client did not come up
6	A blink-murder in the crowd; nobody saw it happen
7	The Seeming: a whole street sees the same tall figure laying a table
8	A Seeming made solid lumbers down the Slope
9	A sleepwalking Counted, arms open, walking east toward the eye
10	A Waker gone mad knocking at the door at the third bell
11	Shoes and a folded coat on a doorstep; beyond, a dark warm room and a Made Bed
12	Lamps dimming street by street toward the party: a Tether-Catch is loose

CRADLEWRACK

D12	ENCOUNTER
1	A midwife on the road with her Second Opinion, called to a hard birth
2	Every door at the inn is open in the morning, though all were barred
3	A pang; buildings sway; someone counts the interval aloud
4	A handful of Parts crawling north in the dark
5	Assembler brethren with a sack that moves
6	A Gathered looking for a left hand

D12	ENCOUNTER
7	A crowning at the edge of a village; the rim is widening
8	A Refused, kind and frightened, who asks if any of the party is a midwife
9	Doorborn unfolding from a bricked room
10	Giant tracks in the clay, then Josiah Fenn, then the Get
11	A heaved grave-cap, and small wet tracks leading toward the nearest cottage
12	A length of loose cord in the grass, pulsing, sliding toward the sleeping

OATHEN

D12	ENCOUNTER
1	A child in a leather bit, staring at the characters' talkative mouths
2	A posted silent gorge; a character must cross without a word
3	A Surety offering to carry an oath for a fee
4	Clausewright and clerks drafting a merchant's three-hundred-condition apology
5	Forsworn toughs demanding a promise at knifepoint
6	Wind carries a stranger's words to the characters; are they bound?
7	An Oath-Made, fading, begging someone to swear to look after it
8	A living echo two bends behind, catching up
9	A Forsworn mob climbing the canyon stairs
10	A Defaulted Surety crawling, hunting a name the characters carry
11	A swearer, bit cut away, running down the street promising in the party's names
12	A walking corpse in grave-wrappings, jaw bound, at the foot of someone's bed

THE FAST

D12	ENCOUNTER
1	Unfed villagers eating cold and standing; they will not share, and will not take
2	A Crumb-Runner's cart, spat on in the road
3	Frost melted in a line across a field: company
4	Blank-poachers stalking an Unfed family
5	Tablebreakers with axes, hunting
6	A chimney smoking over an empty house: a Lit House
7	One of Orrum's tables, steaming, with a place card
8	Brother Hallow Crust or another of the Seated, describing the soup
9	Welcome Ardent in the road, bowing, asking if they will be joining
10	A tall shape stooping under a lintel a field away
11	The party wakes washed, combed and pared; one of them has been tidied
12	A companion wakes with crumbs on their lips and will not say they slept well

THE RIM ROAD

D20	ENCOUNTER
1	A Rim Road Company toll-post; wardens sworn not to accept bribes
2	A Company caravan of Fatlands barrels, origin stamped over twice
3	A Cutwright with a ledger, measuring the characters' Cut for a fee
4	Pilgrims from the Fatlands heading into the Fast to find the Host
5	Petra Quick's cart carrying pregnant women out of Cradlewrack
6	A dying traveler being smuggled north to Sallowreach so they will not die
7	Dry Jonah's bottled brine for sale as Vigil tonic
8	A Purgation cell burning a high-Cut coach
9	Reckoners waiting at an inn for a noble's arrival
10	A Second Table hunt, masked and carrying salt
11	Blank-poachers with a godless captive, well fed
12	A border marshal checking every traveler leaving Cradlewrack for signs of carrying
13	An inn where every patron says "Lack keep away," except one
14	A Kept man who has just crossed the Sallowreach border and dropped, finished, at the line
15	A crossroads table, laid, steaming, outside the Fast
16	Envoy Prudence Lowell, reminding a crowd that they are damned
17	A Called man walking west on the Road, four hundred miles from any coast
18	A Vigil seemer reporting a tall figure looking in at inn windows
19	A wandering Forsworn, ribs open, with a message from Oathen's Breakdowns
20	Welcome Ardent asks the way to the nearest inn; Orrum is a mile behind

Two further results replace any roll of 13 when the GM wants human trouble: Spademen at a roadside grave, arguing over a sack that has started to talk; or a pair of Ledger-Hounds with a College warrant and a family tree, asking which of the characters is related to whom.

THE LAST WORD ON MONSTERS

Every land on the Table believes another land's curse might cure its own. Monsters travel along the same road the cures do. A Tenanted judge can turn up in Sated. A Hush-walker can stand at the border and watch the living cross. The Host has been seen at crossroads in three lands already.

Use this chapter as a menu, not a map. Everything here was once fed, and everything here is still hungry, and the Grace is ending.



PART FOUR

SETTING THE TABLE

*For the Carver alone: running horror, building campaigns, the secrets of
the world, and an adventure to begin with.*

CHAPTER 16

THE CARVER'S KNIFE

At a feast on the Table, the one who carves decides who eats first, who gets the best of it, and who is served the part that nobody wants. It is a position of honor. It is never a position of love.

— DAME SUET MARRABLE, TO A NEW CARVER AT THE UNENDING DINNER

FROM THE COMMONPLACE BOOK OF A RIM ROAD STORYTELLER, FOUND AT THIMBLE CROSS AFTER THE SNOWS.

They always ask me for the one about the god that smiled. I tell it the same way every time. I lower the lamp. I let the fire burn down until their faces are only the parts the coals can reach: noses, wet eyes, the shine on the lips. I wait until somebody coughs, and then I wait for them to be ashamed of having coughed.

The trick is not the monster. Anyone can describe a monster. The trick is to describe the kitchen first. The bread on the board, the knife beside it, the knot in the wood under the bread that looks like an eye. The child asleep in the corner with her thumb in her mouth. You make them love the kitchen. Then, when the knife moves on its own, they do not scream because of the knife. They scream because of the bread, and the knot, and the child.

I have told that story four hundred times. Last winter, on Tablenight, I told it in this very room, and when I got to the

end there was a place laid at the back table that nobody had laid, and a chair pulled out, and a card with my name on it.

I am writing this down because I have decided not to tell it again.

This chapter is for the Carver: the player who runs the game. It explains how to run horror on the Table, land by land and scene by scene; how to use the rules without letting them get in the way; how to stage the sacrifices that buy nothing, the cults that feed you before they own you, and the slow madness of a village that has stopped saying its dead aloud. It gives you tables to roll on when the evening sags, twelve campaigns to start from, and one campaign laid out session by session. And it explains, at more length than anything else, how to make sure everyone at the table leaves wanting to come back, even though their characters will not.



The trick is not the monster. The trick is to describe the kitchen first.

THE THIMBLE CROSS STORYTELLER

▼ THE CARVER'S DUTIES

You have five jobs. Everything else is technique.

- ◇ **Describe the world** so the Guests can see, smell and taste it.
- ◇ **Play everyone else:** the Regent and the beggar, the god and the dog.
- ◇ **Apply the rules** fairly, and know when to put them away.
- ◇ **Keep the table safe**, with Lines, Veils and the Grace, and with your own attention.
- ◇ **Make the world move.** The Grace is ending. The gods are growing back whether the Guests act or not. Show them the clock.

A sixth job hides inside the other five: **remember**. The Table is a world of ledgers, tallies, counts and long memories. Keep a

notebook of every name the Guests learn, every kindness they do, every promise they make, every corpse they step over. The Table remembers all of it, and so should you. Nothing on the Table is more frightening than a stranger in the next land who already knows what the Guests did in the last one.



The Carver is the only one at the table who is not hungry. Do not let that make you cruel. Let it make you watchful.

FROM A RIM ROAD GAMEMASTER'S NOTES

▼ RUNNING HORROR ON THE TABLE

MAKE THEM LOVE THE KITCHEN

Horror is the violation of something cared for. If the Guests do not care about anything, nothing can be violated. Spend the first half of every story making them care: a warm inn, a Kept grandmother who tells filthy jokes through her stitched jaw, a Fatlands cook who sings while she skims the drip from the stockpot, a Netwatch sergeant who calls his patrol “my ducks”. Let the Guests eat, rest, joke and plan. Let Who Waits at Home write them letters. Then take it away.

The kitchen does not have to be safe to be loved. A Vigil nudger who slaps a Guest awake every hour, and apologizes every time, is a kitchen. So is a Forsworn beggar in the Breakdowns whose ribs open like a book and who shares his soup anyway. Look for the small habit, the joke repeated, the pet name, the chipped cup. Name it twice in two sessions. On the third session, break it.

ALL FIVE SENSES, AND THEN ONE MORE

The Table is a world of bodies. Describe it through the body. For every horror you run, ask:

- ◇ **What does it smell like?** The sweet wrongness of the Breath in Sallowreach; the rendering-yard stink of the Belch; salt and kelp and the cold-mineral smell of a drowned man’s lungs; lamp-smoke and sour rouse-sweat in the Vigil; iron, wet clay and birth-water in Cradlewrack; the hot stone and dry silence of Oathen; and, in the Fast, bread, always fresh bread, from nowhere.
- ◇ **What does it sound like?** Flies in fronts. Teeth in the wheat. Bailing coughs at dawn. Bells every quarter hour. The pang, felt through the floor. The crack of a body breaking to match a broken word.
- ◇ **What does it feel like?** Warm ground that rises and falls. Cold grey fingers with one joint too many. A floor that slopes so you cannot rest.
- ◇ **What does it taste like?** Everything on the Table is food, or was. Make them taste it.
- ◇ **What does it look like?** Last. Sight is the least frightening sense, because it is the one we trust.
- ◇ **And the sixth sense, the god:** what does the Guest’s own blood do, in the presence of this? Does their Hunger stir? Does their Tooth itch? Does the thing in front of them seem, horribly, like family?

A useful discipline: describe every horror in three details, never more, and make one of them a smell and one of them a texture. *The room is warm. It smells of milk going over. When you put your hand*

on the doorframe, the wood gives, a little, like a gum. Then stop, and wait for the players to ask the question you want them to ask.



Sight is the sense we trust. That is why it is the last one you should use.

THE CARVER’S RULE OF THREE

GORE WITH A PURPOSE

This book is graphic, and your table may want it graphic. That is allowed and it can be powerful. The rule is: **gore should always carry meaning**. A body opened on the Table is never just a body. It tells the Guests what the god wants, what the land costs, what was done and by whom. A Mangling is a story in a wound. When you describe the bowel sliding free of a Netwatch officer’s belly, make sure the Guests also see the wedding knot tied into his anchoring rope.

When the table’s appetite is satisfied, cut away. Restraint is a tool too. The door closing on the Cullmaster’s dusk shift, and the sound of the wheat moving in a field where there is no wind, can be worse than anything you say.

Gore lands hardest on familiar shapes. A stranger’s opened chest is a fact; the hand of the innkeeper who poured your wine last night, found in a barrel of salt pork with the signet ring still on it, is a story. Reuse your props. The Table is a world where nothing is wasted, and neither should your descriptions be.

TRAGEDY, NOT SPECTACLE

Some of this book’s horrors are deliberately human: suicide, contagious despair, kin-slaying, the murder of the helpless. Run them as tragedy. That means:

- ◇ The camera stays on the people left behind: the cut rope on the bed, the extra place at the table, the note in a careful hand, the neighbors who stop calling names through the wall.
- ◇ Nobody is a punchline, and nobody’s death is a reward.
- ◇ The god benefits. Every loss is a little more of it in the world. That is the horror, more than the act.
- ◇ You never describe *how*. You describe *after*.

When a Guest’s own despair is in play (the Pull, the Finishers’ song, the Bedded’s sermon), slow down and speak to the player, not just the character. The rules for Despair in the Grace Roll chapter require the table’s consent for any ending. Honor that requirement as if your own hand were on the rope.

THE CLOCK IS ALWAYS RUNNING

The Grace is ending. Use clocks: the Cradlewrack interval shortening, the Vigil's empty beds, the Pantry's four months of grain, the Brinehollow waterline, the Sallowreach Hushes spreading toward the Hand-line estates. Write each one on a card where the Guests can see it. Advance them between sessions whether the Guests act or not. Horror is helplessness, and the slow tick of a number going down is helplessness made visible.

A clock is more frightening when it is somebody's. Do not write *Vigil: 1,912 beds*; write *Matron Dorm's count: 1,912*, and when it drops, have Matron Dorm be the one who tells them, in the voice of a woman who has stopped sleeping in a city where nobody sleeps.

NO RESCUE, BUT MANY MERCIES

The Table cannot be saved. That is the premise. But individual people can be: for a night, a season, a life. A Guest who cannot stop the Reaping can still get one family across the border before the dusk shift. A Guest who cannot cure the Vigil can still sit up with a dying nudger through her last hour. Those small mercies are the only victories the Long Grace offers, and they should feel enormous. Do not take them away cheaply. Take them away expensively, much later, when the Guests have forgotten to guard them.



*We could not save the town. We saved the Gristle boy.
He is thirty now and he sends a ham every Carving.
That is what winning looks like up here.*

A ROAD-WARDEN AT SALTICK CROSS

▼ RUNNING EACH LAND'S HORROR

Every land on the Table is frightening in a different key. A Carver who runs the Vigil like Sallowreach will get a competent session and miss the land. What follows is a short guide to each: its **tone** (the feeling you are aiming at), its **senses** (the details to reach for first), its **signature scenes** (the moments a session there should contain), and

its **pacing** (how to shape time at the table so that the god is felt in the rhythm of play itself).

SALLOWREACH: THE HORROR OF GOING ON



Tone. Elegy and black comedy, in equal parts, forever. Nothing finishes here: not grief, not quarrels, not rot, not pain. The horror is not death but its absence, and the dreadful patience of people who have hurt for three centuries and are still polite. Let the Kept be funny. Then let a Guest notice that the grandmother laughing at the joke has laughed at it, in that exact cadence, since before the War of the Heirs.

Senses. The Breath: warm, wet, sweetish fog tasting of mushrooms and old flowers. Cedar on the rich, vinegar on the middling, and on the poor the smell of themselves. Flies in fronts, pattering on lantern glass like hail. The creak of wire in a restitched shoulder; jaw-clicks in a dark room. And at the edge of a Hush, nothing at all: no echo, no flies, your own heartbeat missing from your ears.

Signature scenes.

- ◇ A restitching at the supper table, between courses, while the patient asks after the Guests' journey.
- ◇ The queue at the Hall of Closings, where a Kept child has waited since her parents were young.

- ◇ A night in the Lofts, the shelves whispering from floor to rafter, all the same word.
- ◇ The edge of a Hush at dawn, birds dropping one at a time, the Finishers singing on the road behind.

Pacing. Never let a scene end cleanly. Cut away while it is still going: the argument running, the patient mid-sentence. The unfinishedness piles up. Then, once a session, end something absolutely, and let the silence at your real table run longer than is comfortable. Count ten before you speak.



May you finish.

THE POLITE GREETING OF SALLOWREACH, SAID
WITH REAL LOVE

THE FATLANDS: THE HORROR OF PLENTY



Tone. Grotesque hospitality. The south is warm, loud, generous and doomed, and its horror wears an apron and a smile. Nobody means harm: the Cullmasters think of it as agriculture, the Bailiff is gentle with his funnel, Brother Glut means every word about love. Run the land as a feast that never ends, where refusing is the only crime and the food is looking back at you.

Senses. Gravy from the drains. The Belch: tallow and singed hair on a hot wind. Ground warm underfoot that rises, very slightly, if you lie on it. The crunch of a tooth in a mouthful of bread. Fruit with a skin, a fat layer and a pit of bone, which bleeds a little when bitten. A cellar that smells like the inside of a mouth.

Signature scenes.

- ◇ A meal the Guests cannot refuse, the Bailiff's ladle of office laid beside the salt.

- ◇ A wake at which the dead are served on the best plates, and a Guest is handed the honored portion.
- ◇ The dusk shift walking into wheat that moves with no wind.
- ◇ Pell Hogget's Long Count read aloud, one higher than last year, and a mother at the back hearing why.

Pacing. Build every session around meals. Five a day is the law: cut scenes with bells for second breakfast and fourth dinner, and give refusals consequences. Daylight is the other clock. Mark the hour on a card and move it; when dusk comes, everyone in the fields is in danger.

BRINEHOLLOW: THE HORROR OF WANTING TO GO



Tone. Longing, grief and the domestic stranger. Brinehollow is a land of the beloved who walk away and the beloved who come back wrong. Its horror is the invitation: everyone half-wants it, and the whole culture of anchoring, counting and bail-buckets is a set of tender, ridiculous measures for holding on to people who are leaving. Play it quiet, in a minor key.

Senses. Salt on the lips at waking. The wet, tearing cough of a whole street bailing at dawn. Kelp on the cellar stairs forty miles inland. The cold-mineral smell of a drowned chest opened. Pressure days: ears popping, windows bowing in, a thread of blood from a child's nose. Rope creaking on a bed in the night.

Signature scenes.

- ◇ The morning count: names called through the walls, house by house, until one house does not answer.

- ◇ A rope found cut at dawn, its end neat, and wet footprints going west.
- ◇ Dinner with a Tenanted husband who is kinder than he ever was, and pauses, sometimes, before he chews.
- ◇ The Netwatch hauling a Called girl out of the surf, and the look she gives the Guest holding the rope.

Pacing. Brinehollow runs on tides. At dawn and dusk every scene stops so the Brinehollowers can bail; let it be an interruption, and then a comfort. Build the Calling like weather across the session, a west window here, a sleepwalk there, until a Guest stands up in the night. Do not rush the walk to the shore.

THE VIGIL: THE HORROR OF STAYING AWAKE



Tone. Fever. The Vigil is bright, loud, raw, paranoid and very tired, the one land where the threat is comfort. Its horror is attrition: judgment fraying, hallucination entered as news, murder in a two-second blink. Play it fast and jittery, and let the city be magnificent in its exhaustion.

Senses. Permanent lamp-smoke in hair and throat. Rouse: bitter, gritty, iron-and-burnt-coffee, staining teeth brown. Bells every

quarter hour; tin roofs clattering in the rain; the prick of a pin offered at the door. Sour collars, rotten-sweet breath. And the danger signs, which you must describe as delicious: a warm wind, a soft chair, someone humming.

Signature scenes.

- ◇ A blink: a Guest opens their eyes three paces from where they were, holding something.

- ◇ A Seeming: a whole street sees the same thing, and a clerk takes it down as fact.
- ◇ The Dormitory: sixty thousand numbered beds, and every sleeper breathing in time.
- ◇ A Tucker's minute, the sand running out, and the client who does not wake.

Pacing. Never give the characters rest. Cut scenes mid-action with a blink and resume three paces on. When a Guest's Fray is high, describe events slightly out of order, then correct yourself, as a tired person would. Tap a glass every so often and ask one Guest what

keeps them awake this quarter. (Your real players should still take real breaks; see Safety in Practice.)



Pinch me.

THE VIGIL'S MARRIAGE VOW, ENTIRE

CRADLEWRACK: THE HORROR OF BEGINNING



Tone. Obstetric dread and thresholds. The land is in labor, and everything in it is about to begin: doors, wounds, bellies, hillsides. Its horror is anticipation. Something is always on the other side of a door, and the culture of knocking, bricking-in and the Two Questions is a culture of bracing. Play it close, warm and wet, in the rhythm of contractions.

Senses. Iron, wet red clay and birth-water. Ground warm to the hand, faintly pulsing. Latches lifting by themselves at night. The pang through the floor, a slow enormous clench, and the whole country holding its breath. Brick-dust on the hands of people who wall themselves in each night.

Signature scenes.

- ◇ A birth, the Two Questions asked and answered by the midwife alone, her hand on the Second Opinion.

- ◇ A Guest waking in a bricked room to a gap in the mortar and something small on the floor.
- ◇ A crowning, the village gathered at the rim of a round hole, waiting to see what comes up.
- ◇ A warm ear or a length of spine crawling, patiently, toward another Part.

Pacing. Count days. Every session should know how many days until the next pang, and build to one. Open scenes with a door already ajar. When the pang comes, have everyone put their hands flat on the real table while you describe the clench. Then let the land relax, and remind them the interval is shorter.

OATHEN: THE HORROR OF SAYING SO



Tone. Silence, precision and legal dread. Oathen is dry and courteous, and every word in it is a loaded crossbow. Its horror is the gap between what you meant and what you said, and the sound a body makes when that gap closes.

Senses. Hot red stone under a white sky; lips cracking in the dry. A silence so deep you hear a sandal drop three terraces down. The echo, your words returning a half-second late. The crack of a breaking, like green wood, and then a scream, or worse, no scream. Ink, grit, cut stone.

Signature scenes.

- ◇ A negotiation in which every sentence is mostly exits, and a Guest says one plain thing.
- ◇ An echo carrying a careless word, three times, to someone who never said it.

- ◇ A Breaking trial: the accused repeats the promise aloud, and the court watches.
- ◇ A Forsworn man in the Breakdowns, his moral history written in his bones.

Pacing. Tell the players, out of character, that you will hold their characters to what they say, and then do it with grace: when a character speaks carelessly, pause and ask, "Is that a promise?" Let them unsay it with a conditional. The pause is the horror. Oathen sessions should be the slowest you run.



Say less.

THE WHOLE OF OATHEN'S LAW, AS TAUGHT TO CHILDREN

THE FAST: THE HORROR OF BEING WELCOME



Tone. Temptation, piety and kindness that kills. The Fast is gold, quiet and almost empty, its people starving and righteous, its god gentle and endlessly patient. Nothing here attacks. It only offers, and every refusal is harder than the last, because what is offered is exactly what the Guests want.

Senses. Fresh bread from nowhere. Late-afternoon light at every hour. Frost melted in long stooping footprints. Clean windows in empty houses; the smell of a kitchen on a winter evening with everyone home. And among the Unfed: cold hands, sour breath, grain counted to the bean.

Signature scenes.

- ◇ A table steaming in the road, a chair pulled out, a card in a Guest's mother's hand.

- ◇ The Decline said aloud three times, and a fourth offer from someone who should not be able to make one.
- ◇ The Long Table: nine miles of the Seated, describing each course, inviting the Guests to sit.
- ◇ The Pantry list read in Wanting, with a village left off it.

Pacing. Very quiet, very slow, very few events. Long walks through beautiful empty country. Escalate the offers: a smell, a lit window, a laid table, a card, a card with the name of their dead. Ask the players to say the Decline in their own voices.

THE RIM: THE HORROR OF IN-BETWEEN



The Rim belongs to no land and borrows every land's horror for a mile either side of a border. Run it as a road story: inns, tolls, the knee-high Hem that nobody steps over, milestones with their distances carved over. Its own horror is commerce. Everything has a

price, including the dead of six lands, and the Company is pricing the end of the world in a ledger nobody may read. Use the Rim to carry the Guests between keys, and to remind them, at every inn on Tablenight, of the extra chair turned to face the wall.

USING THE RULES

WHEN TO CALL FOR DREAD

Call for a Dread check the first time the Guests encounter a horror, and whenever something they love is harmed. Do not call for Dread so often that Fray becomes accounting. If a Guest is a Seamer, corpses do not frighten her; what frightens her is a corpse that thanks her. Calibrate to the character.

A good rule of thumb is two or three Dread checks in a session, rising to five or six in a climax. If a session has gone by without one, the Guests have not met the Table yet. If every scene has one, the Table has stopped being frightening and become weather.

PACING HUNGER

The Tooth is the most important choice a player makes. Make it tempting: put the Guests in positions where +3.5 is the difference between saving someone and failing them. Make it visible: describe the god coming forward every time they Partake. Make it count: when Hunger fills and Regrowth rises, stop the game for a moment and describe the change together. A Guest who reaches the Course should feel the weight of it. In a typical campaign of twenty sessions, a Guest who Partakes freely will reach the Course; one who Partakes recklessly will reach the Brink.

When a Tooth shows a 1 and the god bites back, give it a voice. Not words, usually, but a sensation peculiar to the land: a joint popping in a Hand-line's finger, a mouthful of brine, a sudden scald of milk in the throat. Players learn to fear the small sounds of the dice.

WHEN THE SEATING COMES

Treat a Guest's Seating as the finale of their story, not as a failure. Talk with the player beforehand. Give them a last scene: a last

speech, a last kindness, a last act of terrible power. Then let the god have them. Bring them back later as part of the world, and let the other Guests visit what is left. The Dowager Hills are full of grandmothers who were once someone's companions on the road.

FUDGING AND FAIRNESS

Roll in the open whenever you can. The Table is a cruel place, and the dice are the most honest thing in it. If a Guest dies to a bad roll in a meaningless fight, that is a sign you should not have run a meaningless fight. Make fights matter, warn players when they are walking into death, and let the dice fall.

SAYING YES TO THE GOD

Players will look for loopholes: Kept characters who use their undying bodies as shields; Oathen Guests who swear things into existence; Brinehollowers who try to bargain with their Tenants. Let them. The gods are not interested in rules-lawyering, but they are very interested in being invited in. Every loophole a Guest finds is a door the god can walk through. Say yes, and then show them who else came through it.

RUNNING CONTAGION

Madness on the Table is catching, and the Contagion rule is one of the most powerful tools in this book. When a Guest Breaks, do not rush past the witnesses' checks. Describe the cold draft moving through the room: the second person who begins to count, the third who looks at her husband and sees a stranger wearing him. A shared Derangement is a shared story, and players who share one will play off each other with a terrible, delighted intimacy. Use it sparingly. One contagious Break per story is plenty. Two is a plague.

▼ RUNNING WORTHLESS SACRIFICES

The phrase to walk the eldest means, in every dialect, to make a sacrifice you know will be wasted.

— THE CUTWRIGHTS' COLLEGE, CONCORDANCE OF THE NINE YEARS

The Table's history begins with a sacrifice that bought nothing. Sixty thousand firstborn walked to the feet of their gods and opened their throats, and nothing happened, and in Carving their families came back for them with sacks. Every land since has its own version: the Fatlands' fasting rebels force-fed into silence, the Vigil's diver who brought back the number and had her bed added to it, the Oathen regiment that came apart obeying an order. The adventure in this book ends with one: someone sits in the ninth chair to save the others, and the Host lifts them gently out of it and goes on with dinner.

Done badly, this feels like a trick played on the players. Done well, it is the moment a campaign is remembered by.

THE THREE PARTS

A worthless sacrifice has three parts, and each needs its own weight.

The Demand. Someone, or the Guests' own reasoning, says a price must be paid. It should come from a source they have reason to trust: a doctrine, an elder, an old carving, a Cutwright's ledger, a dying friend. Let them argue and look for other ways. Let the demand survive their scrutiny, because it is the kind of thing that sounds true on the Table.

The Giving. Play it in full. Whether the price is a life, a hand, a child, a name or a winter's food, give it the care you would give a Seating. Slow down. Let the giver say what they want to say. The Giving must be real, because the horror depends entirely on its being real.

The Indifference. Then nothing happens. Not a reversal; not a punishment; not a cruel twist. The world simply goes on as it was going. The Hush keeps spreading. The bed fills anyway. The god does not look up. Describe the after: the family going home, the

empty place at the table, the price paid and the receipt blank. Let the players sit in it. Call for a Dread check at Dread 5: *knowing that what you did changed nothing.*



It is not that the gods refused the eldest. It is that they did not notice them.

CONFESSOR ABEL RENNICK

RULES FOR THE CARVER

- ◆ **Never more than once an arc.** A worthless sacrifice is a hammer. If every sacrifice in your campaign is worthless, the players will stop making them, and they will be right to.
- ◆ **Never as a trick on the players.** The demand should be false in the fiction, not rigged by you. If the players have read the clues correctly and concluded that the sacrifice will not work, let them be right, and let an NPC go ahead and do it anyway.
- ◆ **Let some sacrifices work.** Small ones, close ones, human ones. A Guest who gives up their last ration to a starving child should see the child eat. The Table is indifferent at the scale of gods, not at the scale of bread.
- ◆ **Reward the giving, not the outcome.** Award Portions for the scene. A Guest who keeps an Oath on the Dead by sacrificing, even uselessly, still keeps it.
- ◆ **Give the waste a witness.** The worst part of the Eldest Walk was that the whole village walked behind the line to the boundary stone and stopped there. Put someone at the boundary stone.

WORTHLESS SACRIFICES BY LAND

LAND	THE DEMAND	WHAT IS GIVEN	WHAT HAPPENS
Sallowreach	Nine must walk into the Hush to spare the village	Nine walk in, singing	The Hush spreads at the same pace
The Fatlands	A doubled dusk shift will sate the Reaping	Forty debtors go out at dusk	The Long Count rises anyway
Brinehollow	Give the sea a Lung-line heir and it will return	A prince's cousin walks in with lanterns	The sea drops another half-mile
The Vigil	Reduce the number, in secret	Matron Dorm removes pillows	The beds refill by morning
Cradlewrack	Cut enough, and the land cannot bear	A whole village goes under the knife	The pang comes on the ninth day
Oathen	Bind the rain with a body as surety	A Tongue-line swears it	The rain is late; she breaks
The Fast	Leave one village off the list	It starves, praying, in order	A clerk miscounted; it was never needed

▼ CULT CONTROL AND GASLIGHTING

The Table is full of people who have found an answer: the Finishers, the Second Helping, the Deepening, the Bedded, the Assemblers, the Barren Order, the Purgation, the Second Table, the Seated on the Long Table. Each of them is, in its way, right about something. That is what makes them frightening. A cult on the Table is not a gang of villains in hoods; it is a warm room full of people who have stopped being afraid, and who would like you to stop too.

What follows explains how to run scenes in which the Guests are drawn in, made to doubt their own memories, or watch someone they love disappear into certainty. These are the most intimate horrors in the book, and need the most care.

HOW A CULT FEEDS YOU

Every cult on the Table works by the same five courses. Run them in order, one per scene or one per session, and the players will feel the pull before they understand it.

- ◇ **The Welcome.** The Guests are fed, warmed, listened to. Nobody asks them for anything. Somebody remembers their name. In a world of tolls and ledgers and Cutwrights, this is the most seductive thing that can happen.
- ◇ **The Answer.** Somebody explains the world. The explanation is coherent, kind and partly true. It accounts for the Guests' own godsign, their dead, their fears. It makes sense of the Table, which nothing else does.
- ◇ **The Small Wrong Thing.** The Guests are asked for something small and slightly wrong: to skip a meal, to leave a door unbarred, to say a word they would not usually say, to look away while a sick woman is walked to the shore. Everyone else does it without fuss.
- ◇ **The Wall.** Old friends are gently reframed. *Your nudger does not understand you. Your Who Waits at Home is afraid of what you are becoming. We are not afraid.* Letters stop arriving, or arrive opened.
- ◇ **The Last Course.** The real ask. Walk into the Hush. Lie down. Put out the lamp. Give the child to the Assemblers. Sit.

◇

*Nobody here has asked me for anything in three weeks.
I keep waiting. I think that is how they get you.*

A VIGIL WAKER'S REPORT, FROM INSIDE THE
BEDDED

RUNNING THE PULL AT THE TABLE

The danger in cult scenes is that the players, sitting safely at a real table, will simply refuse, and the scene will go flat. The solution is

not to force them. It is to make the cult right about something the players care about, and to put someone they love inside it. Brother Glut cannot persuade a Guest; Brother Glut can persuade the Guest's sister, and then the Guest must decide whether to drag her out.

When you want a Guest to feel the pull from inside, use the rules: a Want triggered by the cult's rite; a Dread check failed in the cult's presence and turned into **The Devotion** derangement; a Fray-recovering rite that works, really works, and leaves the Guest wanting more. Tell the player what their character feels and let them decide what to do with it. Never tell a player what their character believes.

GASLIGHTING SCENES

Gaslighting, on the Table, is not rare. It is a civic institution. The Vigil enters hallucinations into the public record as news. The Board of Plenty records the Reaping as wolves. The Admiralty forbids the word *stranded*. In Oathen, a careful Clausewright can get a witness to swear to a version of events, and then the body enforces it. Run gaslighting scenes in four moves:

- ◇ **The Contradiction.** An NPC calmly contradicts something a Guest saw. *There was no second body. There were never two.* Everyone in the room agrees.
- ◇ **The Record.** A document confirms the contradiction: a ledger, a Tally entry, the Seeming's slate. The handwriting is genuine. The date is right.
- ◇ **The Kindness.** Someone the Guest trusts gently suggests they are tired, Rattled, Fraying. They are not wrong. The Guest's Fray is high.
- ◇ **The Doubt.** Call for an Eye + Instinct roll against the deceiver's Tongue + Deceive. On a failure, the character believes the lie for now; on a failure at Fray 5+, gain 1 Fray and, if they Break this session, the Derangement is **The Gaslight**.

The Carver's Promise. Gaslight the characters. Never gaslight the players. When the fiction lies to a Guest, the player must still be able to trust you. The simplest way to keep this promise is to say, plainly and out of character, *Your character now believes there was only ever one body. You, the player, remember what I described.* Some groups enjoy playing with an unreliable Carver: descriptions that turn out to have been a character's hallucination, scenes replayed differently. That is a strong spice. Agree it at the session zero, by name, and stop at once if anyone stops enjoying it.

◇
*The slate says the street saw a horse. I saw a woman
with her arms on backwards. The slate is the law, so I
saw a horse.*

OVERHEARD AT THE PINCHMARKET, THE VIGIL

THE CULT INSIDE THE PARTY

The worst cult is the one a Guest founds, around the Course, when they discover their god has a doctrine and it is persuasive. Let them preach if the group enjoys it, and give the other players the tools and reasons to resist. A party split by belief is a tragedy the Table loves. A player bullied by another at the real table is not, and you should stop it.

▼ THE SCENE TOOLKIT

What follows are tables to roll on when the session sags, when you need a detail in a hurry, or when you want the world to move without your having to decide how. Read each result aloud and let the players ask questions. Change anything that does not fit the land you are in.

TWENTY THINGS THE CARVER CAN DO WHEN NOTHING IS HAPPENING

D20	THE TABLE MOVES
1	A Kept relative arrives with a message and a missing hand.
2	Someone the Guests met last session is found Reaped, Called, Seated, or Broken.
3	A place card with a Guest's name on it, at a table that was not there an hour ago.
4	A pang, felt from three lands away.
5	The Guests' patron asks for something small and wrong.
6	A Cutwright arrives to read a Guest's bloodline, by order.
7	A Reckoner has a list. One of the Guests is on it, or someone they love is.
8	Bread smells in a house where nobody bakes.
9	The Rim Road is closed by the Company: no reason given, Wardens on the bridges.
10	The Seeming of the Vigil shows something the Guests did.
11	A Forsworn begs a Guest to carry an oath for a single night.
12	The Purgation burns a house nearby; there are children's shoes outside.
13	A barrel bursts on the road, and the meat inside has a tattoo the Guests recognise.
14	The sea has dropped another mile; the salvage rush begins.
15	Someone yawns, and the yawn moves around the room like a hand.
16	A door that has been bricked up is found open.
17	A Blank is being auctioned in the market square.
18	A Guest's Tooth bites in their sleep: gain 1 Hunger and a dream of the god.
19	A Second Table invitation, on heavy paper, addressed to the highest Cut among them.
20	A tall figure is seen far off, stooping, laying a table in an empty field.

OMENS

Omens are the Table's small talk. Everyone reads them; everyone disagrees about what they mean. Use them to open a scene, to

foreshadow, or simply to let the players know the world is listening. An omen should never be explained. Let an NPC offer a reading, and let it be wrong, or right for the wrong reason.

D20	OMEN
1	Every spoon in the house is found in the morning face-down, as if after a meal.
2	A cow lows at dusk with a sound like a woman calling a child in for supper.
3	The Plate rises licked clean on a night the almanac swore it would be full.
4	Bread rises in the oven and, when broken, is hollow, crust and all, without a crumb inside.
5	A flock of birds flies in a ring over the village eight times, and on the eighth one bird drops out.
6	A child counts the chairs at supper aloud, and gets one more than there are.
7	Salt spilled on the table forms, of its own weight, a shape like a hand palm-up.
8	The fire goes out in every hearth on the street at the same moment, and relights itself.
9	A Kept grandmother stops in the middle of a sentence and does not finish it until dawn.
10	Milk turns as it is poured, in the jug, between the lip and the cup.
11	A mirror, hung for a wedding, shows the room with the table laid and no one in it.
12	The well bucket comes up full of warm water that smells of a lying-in room.
13	A door that has stuck for twenty years swings open on its own and will not close again.
14	A dog lies down across a threshold and will not move for anyone, and whines at the empty road.
15	A stranger at the inn says the grace wrong, a word too long, and the lamp gutters.
16	Every plate in the dresser cracks in the night, each in the same place.
17	A sleeping baby laughs, and keeps laughing, in a voice too low for its throat.
18	Teeth found in a loaf, bought fresh, from a baker who has never used Fatlands flour.
19	The Guests' shadows at supper fall toward the empty end of the table.
20	Someone in the room yawns, someone coughs brine, someone's door opens, someone's knuckle cracks with a new joint, all at once.



Count the chairs and you'll count one more. Count again and you'll be the one.

A RIM ROAD CHILDREN'S WARNING

WHAT WAS IN THEIR POCKETS

Bodies are the Table's most common document. When the Guests search the dead, roll here, or roll twice and combine. The pockets should tell a small story: who they were, what they feared, what they were doing when the Table stopped them.

D20	FOUND ON THE BODY
1	Three lacks and a place card bearing the dead man's own name, folded small.
2	A milk tooth in a twist of paper: <i>for when he comes back. he won't.</i>
3	A Closing petition, rejected for the forty-first time, the stamp still wet.
4	A map of a Hush, its edge redrawn eleven times, each line nearer a house marked <i>ours</i> .
5	A Fatlands meal-ticket punched five times a day for six years; the last fortnight blank.
6	A child's bail-bucket and a length of anchoring rope, cut neat.
7	An empty rouse-tin scraped with a fingernail, and a pin bent double from use.
8	A lock of hair braided with dried cord, labeled in a midwife's hand: <i>the other half</i> .
9	An oath-slip whose terms are struck through by a crack in the paper, not a pen.
10	A Pantry ration chit dated next month, signed by an Elder who died last year.
11	A College certificate of Cut, the grade scratched out and a lower one written in.

D20	FOUND ON THE BODY
12	A grey hinged finger-joint in a silk handkerchief, still faintly cold.
13	A sealed letter home, never sent: <i>I am well. I am eating. Do not come.</i>
14	A menu card: seven courses, each named for a god, and a blank eighth line.
15	A tally-stick notched by village; the last notch fresh, and it is their own.
16	A mouthful of bread, chewed and dried hard, carried for months.
17	Half a Company platter, and a receipt for the other half from a man in Sated.
18	A bone flute carved from a finger. It plays one note, and the note is a name.
19	A rubbing of an old carving, the gap in the ring outlined until the paper is through.
20	Nothing. The pockets have been turned out and folded neatly back, and the hands folded too.

VILLAGE TRAGEDIES AS MADNESS SPREADS

When a god draws near, a community comes apart from the inside before anything comes for it from outside. Roll once each session

the Guests stay, or read the table in order to escalate: early entries are first signs, late ones the end. Every entry is a tragedy. Run it through the people left behind, never as spectacle, never with method.

D20	WHAT HAPPENS TO THE VILLAGE
1	Everyone dreams the same dream; nobody admits it until a child describes it at breakfast.
2	Neighbors stop saying each other's names aloud, as if names had become unlucky.
3	A mother swears her son is an impostor. Within a week three more mothers say it of theirs.
4	The village starts counting doors, chairs, children. The count is always one short.
5	The headman's wife stops eating and says she was fed last night. She is radiant, and starving.
6	A family barricades itself in, sure the neighbors mean to eat them. They are not wholly wrong.
7	The priest preaches that the god wants one of them and names nobody. The village begins to choose.
8	A young man walks toward the god's place. Three friends go after him. Two come back, silent.
9	Old women sit all night by a door that has stopped answering. At dawn the whole village hears the keening.
10	A grave is opened and its dead sat at the family table. The family says she asked to come.
11	Two brothers quarrel over a dead father's love; one ends it with a cleaver and goes on arguing with the body.
12	The children play one new game: a table, chairs, and one child who must stand.
13	A widower stops coming to the count. His chair is found turned to the wall. The village speaks of him only in whispers.
14	The whole village confesses, in the square, to a crime nobody remembers. They want to be punished.
15	A woman begs her husband to give her body back to her. He tries everything. He cannot.
16	A crowd with lamps and knives gathers for the Blank, the outsider, or a Guest.
17	The village's dead are dug up and laid in rows facing the god's place. Nobody says who asked.
18	A family that lost one child to the pull loses the others to the same despair, one by one, through one winter.
19	Every table is laid for a feast with no food, the grace is said, and one chair at each is left empty.
20	The village is empty, doors open, tables laid. One survivor says, calmly, that everyone went home.

RUNNING A VILLAGE COMING APART

A village that is losing its mind should be one the players have come to know. Give it four or five named people before you roll on the table above: a headman, a gossip, a child, a priest, someone with a dog. Let the tragedies land on them. The madness should feel like a draft through a house, not a storm: one person, then a family, then a street. Above all, let the Guests be useful for a while: talk someone down, bar a door, sit up with a grieving mother. Then let the draft get stronger than they are. When it is over, let the players name one person they saved, even if it was only for a night.

▼ BUILDING A CAMPAIGN

CHOOSE A CENTER

Campaigns on the Table work best when they are anchored to one place and one thread, at least to start. Choose:

- ◆ **A land.** Begin in one land, and let the Guests learn its rules intimately before they travel.
- ◆ **A thread.** Pick one of the *Threads Between the Lands*: the Deadwatch, the Host on the Road, Brine in the Rouse, the Missing Hand, the Sayer's Sentence, Eight Chairs, or the newer threads of the Undying Flame, the Slipping Seal and the Stolen Ledgers. It will pull the Guests across borders when they are ready.
- ◆ **A clock.** The land's own crisis, ticking.
- ◆ **A patron.** Someone who pays the Guests or protects them, and who will betray them.

CAMPAIGN FRAMES

The Caravan. The Guests are the crew of a Rim Road Company caravan: Factors, Wardens, a cook, a Seamer, a Cutwright on assignment. Each story is a waystation, a cargo, a border. The Company's contracts are sworn in Oathen and cannot be broken; it is only a matter of time until one of them requires something unthinkable.

The Survey. The Guests work for the Cutwrights' College, mapping where each god is regrowing fastest. They travel the lands, read bloodlines, and slowly discover that their own ledgers are being used by the Second Table to plan a menu.

The Purge. The Guests are a Purgation cell. At first they fast and bleed and pray. Then they are asked to burn a house with a family inside it. What do they believe, and how far will it take them?

The Watch. The Guests are Nightwardens in one city: the Netwatch of Lowmark, the Wakers of the Vigil, the Loft-Wardens of Lastgate. Each story is a case. The cases get worse. The city's secret, which the Guests are paid to protect, is the worst of all.

The Household. The Guests serve or belong to a single noble family in the last stages of the Regrowth: a Hand-line house where the hands have started to grow; a Gut-line estate where the matriarch is putting down roots; a Caul-line household where the heir has been carried for forty years. Domestic, claustrophobic, unbearable.

The Pilgrimage. The Guests are travelers bound for the Fast, for reasons of their own: to find the Host, to find a cure, to find someone who was invited and never came home. The Rim Road is the journey. Hallowboard is the end.

ESCALATION

A campaign on the Table should move through four movements, like the Regrowth itself:

MOVEMENT	SESSIONS	WHAT HAPPENS
The Taste	1–4	The Guests learn one land. Small horrors. Personal stakes. The god in their blood barely stirs.
The Appetite	5–10	A thread pulls them across a border. They discover the scale of the Regrowth. They begin to Partake to survive.
The Course	11–18	The powers of the Table notice them. A Guest is changed beyond hiding. Someone they love is lost. A land's crisis breaks.
The Seating	19+	The end of the Grace in one land, or all of them. The Secrets of the Table come into play. Somebody sits down.

MAKING THE GUESTS MATTER

The Guests cannot save the world. They can decide who sits at the table when it ends. Let their choices shape the shape of the catastrophe: whether the Vigil buys the secret of Keeping, whether the Assemblers' figure gets its hand, whether Lady Imre Dath is unbitted and what she is told to say. A campaign on the Table is a story about which awful thing happens, and who is to blame for it.

▼ CAMPAIGN SEEDS

Twelve campaigns, a paragraph each, each enough to build a first session from. Most fit any frame; most touch a thread; all of them end badly in some way the players will have chosen.

1. The Last Mourner's Apprentices. People are dying again in Sallowreach, properly, inside the Hushes, and nobody remembers how to mourn them. Bram Hollin takes the Guests as apprentices and walks them from Hush-edge to Hush-edge teaching the six-hundred-year-old rite: washing, keening, closing the eyes with a thumb. Midway, a family of the Mortuary Court hires them to mourn it in advance, while still alive, because it knows which Hush is coming next.

2. The Long Count Riders. The Board has declared Pell Hogget's tally seditious. The Guests ride the Count between villages at night, gathering numbers: a missing son, a Cullmaster's list, a field with a face in it. The total climbs. Then one village's number falls, and the Guests must learn why its soil has stopped eating, and what the villagers have been feeding it instead.

3. Matron Dorm's Count. Sleepers are dying in the Dormitory and the count does not drop, because each empty bed fills by morning with someone nobody saw lie down. Matron Cecily Dorm quietly hires the Guests to find who is removing pillows. The case runs through the Slope, the Tuckers, the Bedded and the Watch of Watches, and ends at the Matron herself, and at Bed One, where Aveline Morne's lips are moving faster.

4. Nine Days to Kest. Hester Lowe's hand, the one the Assemblers' figure lacks, has been stolen from its cradle. Each session is one day of the interval. The hand passes between smugglers, midwives, the Uncut and a Vigil anatomist, and holds someone's finger at every stop. On the ninth day the figure in the barn turns its head toward the Sill, and the Guests must decide whose hand to put it in.

5. The Dry Pier. Harbormistress Kessa Drowle has one year of timber left and one year of sea. The Guests build Lowmark's last mile across the Uncovered, and every section uncovers something: a wreck standing upright, a drowned village with its tables laid, a Tenanted choir at lowest tide. The last plank is laid at the edge of the Trench, where they can hear the sea draining into somewhere.

◇
*We did not stop it. We chose the night it happened, and
who was in the room. I have decided that is not
nothing.*

A CLAUSEWRIGHT'S MEMOIR, UNPUBLISHED

6. The Surety's Default. Ona Fell carries two hundred and eleven other people's oaths and can survive one more default. The Guests must keep every one of those people honest for a season: talking a husband home, getting a debtor to pay, stopping a soldier running. Each failure shows on Ona's body. The last oath on her list belongs to someone powerful who means to break it on purpose.

7. The Pantry List. Four months of grain for six months of winter. The Guests are Crumb-Runners, spat on by the people they feed. They learn which villages Mother Stint Avery has already left off the list, and must choose between running grain to them behind the Abstinence's backs and keeping their own families fed. In the villages left off, tables have begun to appear every night, steaming.

8. The Candle Caravan. The Guests guard Wick Tallow's candles east along the Rim to light a city that cannot sleep. The candles can hear; some can be made to talk; some were people the Guests knew. Between Fogmouth and Lampwick Halt they begin whispering the Lofts' word, and one of them, carried past the Drop, does not go out.

9. The Ledger Run. The Guests are hired to bring Silas Fenwright in alive with his three stolen quires. At every inn on the chase, someone named on his pages dies. When they finally hold him, they also hold the choice to read the quires, and learn their own lines, and what each ends in. The third quire, unopened, lists every Blank born on the Table in two centuries.

10. The Steward's Successor. Welcome Ardent, after three graceful refusals, asks a Guest whether they would consider a position. The campaign follows the steward around the Rim a mile ahead of his god, writing down the names on the cards, learning that the Host's tables are a kind of refuge, and that the extra chair at every table is for nobody Ardent has ever been told about.

11. The Chair at Toll Nine. The extra chair from the Long Farewell stands in a locked room at Toll Nine on its square of floor, pulled out a little further every week. The Company hires the Guests to measure it and learn why. The trail leads to a seabed table, a bog body in a College tank, a slate in Wanting and an Archprovost who no longer goes to dinners. This is Eight Chairs as a campaign spine; it ends in the Secrets chapter.

12. A Practice Dinner. A Guest of high Cut is invited, on heavy paper, to a private dining room on the Rim. The dish is named afterward. Finish the plate, and the party has a way into the Second Table; refuse, and the Guest is served at the next dinner. The infiltration grows more intimate with every course and ends on Tablenight at Hallowboard, with the Host lying down on the eight-sided table.

◇

The dish is not named until after. That is the whole of the etiquette.

A FOOTMAN OF THE SECOND TABLE, OVERHEARD AT
THE GROANING BOARD

▼ A SAMPLE CAMPAIGN: LAID FOR EIGHT

A ten-session outline, built on the Caravan frame and the Eight Chairs thread, which opens with this book’s introductory adventure and ends at Hallowboard on Tablenight. It is a campaign of travel, dread and evidence assembled piece by piece, carrying a group from the Taste to the edge of the Secrets. Run it as written or use it as a demonstration of how the parts of this book fit together.

The Guests are a Rim Road Company crew, or travelers who become one after the first story. Their patron is a Company factor (Joss Mardle of Brindle Cross, or one of your own at Toll Nine) who will in the end sell them to the highest bidder, because he has priced them too.

SESSION	TITLE	WHERE	CLOCK
1–2	The Ninth Chair	Thimble Cross	Tablenight 641
3	The Drop	Fogmouth	The Deadwatch, Stage 1
4	Whispering Shelves	Lastgate	Bettany’s word
5	A Horse, Entered as News	The Vigil	1,900 beds
6	Low Water	The Uncovered	Lobbett’s three visits
7	Exits	Oathen	The Slipping Seal
8	The Dusk Shift	The Fatlands border	The pilgrims
9	The Slate	Wanting	The Pantry list
10	Laid for Eight	Hallowboard	Tablenight 642

Sessions 1–2: The Ninth Chair. Run the introductory adventure in full. Whatever happens, the Guests leave with the ninth card and its single mark in the oldest Table-speech, an acquaintance with Welcome Ardent, and the question of whom the ninth place was for. A Company factor wants to know what happened at Thimble Cross. So does someone at Quire.

Session 3: The Drop. The Guests escort a Deadwatch trial caravan of twenty volunteers from the Slope to Fogmouth, to be killed and kept so they need never sleep. At the red line, the first dies and stands back up. That night a Kept man a yard north of the Drop is found Seated at a laid table, an empty chair pushed in square beside him, and the innkeeper shows the Guests where the floor was cut out last year.

Session 4: Whispering Shelves. The College wants the word Old Bettany Shroud’s forty thousand shelved dead are whispering written down by a disinterested hand. A night in the Lofts: reading-aloud, a part-thief at work, Little Nell Ash’s court below. The

nearest gloss for the word is *company*. Lecturer Odo Fask takes the Guests to Grandfather Peat, who says the god was smiling, counts to eight, and folds one finger down.

Session 5: A Horse, Entered as News. The road to Quire runs through the Vigil on a Yawn day: blinks, bells, rouse, a blink-murder for Inspector Grimmer, and a Seeming in which a whole street sees a table laid for eight with an empty chair at the head. Mirela Sconce enters it in the record as a horse, then shows the Guests her private ledger.

Session 6: Low Water. Archprovost Hesper Lune, nearly blind, sends the Guests to Brinehollow for a rubbing of a seabed table. With Hask Tarn piloting and Cray Lobbett leading, they cross the Uncovered past the Tenanted choir. Eight chairs; seven pushed in; one pulled out further than Lobbett’s knotted cord says it was. By his reckoning, this is one of his last three visits.

Session 7: Exits. A Bonded Hand has stolen and not broken. The Guests carry papers to Jessamy Quill, including a short contract

for Ardent's relief. In the canyons they negotiate with Clausewrights, skirt a posted gorge and witness a Breaking. Quill, ill with marks matching no oath she has broken, signs nothing, and says in careful conditionals that something has been drawing Tolm's attention away.

Session 8: The Dusk Shift. At the Fast's border, Osanna Blythe's three hundred pilgrims are being Reaped from the road at dusk while Marshal Keep Aldane bars the way. Hold them, see them through, or walk with them: whatever the Guests choose, the pilgrims find a table that night laid for three hundred and one, and the Guests must refuse it aloud while people they have come to like sit down.

Session 9: The Slate. The Abstinents have ordered Meek Garrity's slate burned. A hunt through a town with no kitchens for a slate in a sack of pease, Tablebreakers searching with a brazier, Reckoners behind them. Laid beside the Guests' evidence under a raking lamp, the slate shows that Hallowboard's eighth side was never allotted to any household of the heartland. Dread 4. Then the

Hostwatch arrive: Orrum is standing still at Hallowboard, facing the eighth side.

Session 10: Laid for Eight. Tablenight. The Second Table, the pilgrims, the Seated, the Steward, the Reckoners and the Company converge on the bare hill. The Host lies down on the eight-sided table. Read the Secrets chapter beforehand, choose which ending you will move toward, and let the Guests' choices decide which arrives. Somebody sits down. In the morning, set a place card at each real seat in your own hand, bearing the characters' names.

IF THE CAMPAIGN MUST GO ON

Ten sessions bring most groups to the edge of the Secrets but not through them. For a longer game, stretch sessions three to nine into stories of two or three sessions each, and run a land's own crisis alongside the thread: the Vigil's oil, the Pantry's grain, the Dilation. Let the last session be the beginning of the end, and use the Last Days timeline in the Secrets chapter to run what follows.

▼ THE CARVER'S TOOLS

READ-ALoud TEXT

Read-aloud passages in this book are set in the same style as in-world documents. Read them slowly. Pause before the last line. Then stop, and let the silence do the work. Do not explain. The Guests will ask.

HANDOUTS

The Table is a world of documents: death licenses, Cutwright ledgers, contracts forty pages long, place cards, the Tally, the Long Count, a seamer's report. Give your players paper. A handwritten place card with a Guest's name on it, set at their seat before the session starts, will do more than any monster.

Some handouts that cost nothing and work every time: a Closing petition with the stamp *DEFERRED*; a Fatlands meal-ticket with five boxes a day; a page of the Long Count with one name smudged; a Vigil rouse-tin label with the dose crossed out and raised; an Oathen contract with every sentence ending in an exit; a Pantry ration chit; a Second Table menu with seven courses and a blank eighth line. Age the paper with cold tea. Do not explain anything written on it.

NAMES

Every land has its naming customs, listed in its chapter. When you need a name in a hurry: Sallowreach names are soft, mournful and

old (Bettany, Osric, Henna, Tam); Fatlands names are hearty and edible (Suet, Brisket, Tansy, Hob); Brinehollow names are wet and coastal (Kessa, Sennet, Hask, Tolly); Vigil names ring like bells (Ilvane, Maud, Pip, Rook); Cradlewrack names are rustic and beginning (Orla, Lark, Juniper, Hinge); Oathen names are clipped and few-syllabled (Ket, Brakk, Rue, Ona); the Unfed name their children for the Refusal (Forbear, Abstain, Decline, Stint, Tarry, Nay, Want, Spare).

THE CARVER'S NOTEBOOK

Keep, in a notebook only you see: the clocks and their current numbers; the thread stages; every NPC's name and one detail; every promise a Guest has made aloud (Oathen will want to know); every Guest's Last Meal, Oath on the Dead, Who Waits at Home and What You Will Not Do. Before each session, pick one of those four for each Guest and decide how the world will touch it tonight. Not every session. Not too hard. But the players should know, by the third session, that you are listening.



Write down what they promise. The canyon does.

CARVER'S ADVICE, OATHEN EDITION

▼ SAFETY IN PRACTICE

You have read the content warning at the front of this book. You have discussed Lines and Veils. You have explained the Grace. This section is about what those tools look like when the dice are rolling, the lamp is low, and somebody at your table has gone very quiet.

The Long Grace deals with suicide, contagious despair, cannibalism, kin-slaying, the desecration of the dead, and bodies and minds coming apart. Horror is how people have always looked at what frightens them from a safe distance. The distance is the point. Your job is to keep it.

THE SESSION ZERO

Before the first session, sit down together without characters and talk. A good session zero for this game covers:

- ◇ **What the game is.** Read aloud the one-breath summary at the front of the book. Say plainly: this is a horror game without rescue, and characters will be changed, broken and lost.
- ◇ **What is in this book.** Go through the content list in the front matter. Ask, without pressure, whether anything on it is a Line (it will not appear at all) or a Veil (it may happen off-screen, and we cut to after).
- ◇ **How dark, and how graphic.** Agree on a dial. Some tables want the bowel sliding free of the officer's belly; some want the officer's wedding knot and nothing else. Both are the Long Grace.
- ◇ **The Grace.** Explain it. Practice it once, on something trivial, so that saying it in earnest later feels ordinary.
- ◇ **Unreliable narration.** If you want to use gaslighting scenes in which the Carver's descriptions may be false, ask now, by name. If anyone hesitates, do not.
- ◇ **What brings people here.** Ask each player what they hope to feel: dread, grief, grim laughter, a mystery, a fight against something too big. Plan for it.

A SAMPLE LINES AND VEILS CARD

Write the group's agreements on a card and leave it on the table where everyone can see it. A first card for this game might read:

- ◇ **Lines (never):** any sexual content involving anyone under 18; sexual violence on-screen; real-world slurs.
- ◇ **Veils (off-screen, cut to after):** any sexual content between adults; suicide and self-harm (aftermath only, never method); torture beyond a single sentence; harm to children beyond implication; incest and cursed bloodlines (implied only).
- ◇ **On the table (agreed):** body horror, gore, rot, cannibalism, the Kept, the Reaping, kin-slaying, madness and its contagion, worthless sacrifice.
- ◇ **Ask first:** pregnancy and birth horror (Cradlewrack); drowning (Brinehollow); starvation (the Fast).

Anyone may add to this card at any time, during play or between sessions, without giving a reason.

THE GRACE IN PLAY

When someone says the Grace (*Lack keep away*, or a tap on the crossed-fork card), stop. Do not ask why. Do not sigh. Do not finish the sentence. Say "Of course," remove or change what was happening, and carry on, or call a break if the moment needs one. If the Grace was said about something central to the session, the session will survive it: cut to after, and describe the after through a different sense. If you are unsure what to change, ask the group, not the person who said it.

The Grace protects the Carver too. If a scene you planned starts to land on something in your own life, say it yourself. Nobody at the table should have to carry what they did not sign up for, and that includes you.

CHECKING IN

Watch the people at your table, not just their characters. If someone has gone quiet, check in at the break. If someone laughs too hard at the wrong moment, it may be how they are coping. If a scene you planned starts to land on something real in someone's life, stop it, and do not make them explain.

Some gentle habits help:

- ◇ **Take breaks.** Every ninety minutes or so, stand up, make tea, talk about anything else. Horror needs air.
- ◇ **Check in between scenes, not inside them.** A thumbs-up, thumbs-sideways, thumbs-down after a heavy scene takes three seconds and tells you everything.
- ◇ **Ask about the dial.** Midway through a campaign, ask whether the darkness is where people want it. Tables drift, and lives

change.

- ◇ **Share the worst scenes.** Do not keep putting the same player's character through the same kind of horror unless that player has asked for it.

WHEN THE FICTION TOUCHES SOMETHING REAL

Grief, illness, a loved one who has gone, a pregnancy, a hunger, a family that has come apart: the Long Grace is made of the things people really suffer, and sooner or later the fiction will touch someone at your table where they live. When it does, stop the scene, without fuss. Change it, or cut to after, or end the session early. Do not ask the person to explain. Afterward, if they want to talk, listen. If they do not, let it be. The game can wait for a week. People cannot always.

SUICIDE AND DESPAIR AT THE TABLE

This book treats suicide and despair as tragedy: the Pull, the Finishers, the Called, the Bedded, the villagers whose names are no longer spoken. At your table:

- ◇ Never describe method. Describe the before as a pull and the after as a loss.
- ◇ Any ending for a Guest under the Despair rules requires the player's and the table's consent, out loud. If anyone hesitates, the companions reach them in time.
- ◇ Show the grief. The worst thing the Table does to the people left behind is make them stop saying a name. Let the players say it.
- ◇ If the subject is close to anyone at your table, veil it entirely. The Table has many other ways to take people.

CLEARING THE PLATES

At the end of a heavy session, take a few minutes before everyone goes home to clear the plates: step out of the fiction together. Talk about what landed, what was frightening in the good way, what was too much. Thank people for their courage in playing a hard game. Let anyone who needs to say something about their own week, their own life, their own day, say it. The Fatlands have a saying that nobody leaves a table hungry; the Carver's version is that nobody leaves the table carrying something alone.



Nobody leaves a table hungry. That was the law. It is still the best of them.

DAME SUET MARRABLE, SAID OF THE UNENDING
DINNER, AND MEANT

FOR THE CARVER

Running a game this dark costs something. Give yourself the care you give the players: ask for a lighter session when you need one, and remember you may say the Grace too. The Table is a world without rescue. Your table is not. Be the Carver who makes sure everyone gets fed, and then, when the plates are cleared, sit down and eat something yourself.



CHAPTER 17

THE NINTH CHAIR

A good host lays one place more than he expects. A great host never asks who it is for.

— CARVED OVER THE HEARTH AT THIMBLE CROSS, RIM ROAD COMPANY
WAYSTATION, 402 A.G.

From the station ledger of Thimble Cross, kept by Warden Josse Haverick of the Rim Road Company, under oath. Entries for the last week of Lack, 641 A.G.

Seventh day before Tablenight. Snow since noon, if it is snow. It does not melt on the hand. It sits on the skin and goes soft, like lard left by a stove. Convoy of the Renderers' Union arrived at dusk out of the south, eleven wagons, forty-four barrels, Cullmaster's seal on the lead wagon. Teamster Crumm reports the white has followed them up the road from the Chute for six days. Reports one drover lost on the road. Reports it as wolves. I have entered it as wolves.

Sixth day before. Road closed both ways. The white lies a hand deep on the yard and has veins in it. Stores: flour for nine days at half bread. Guests: twenty-two, family four, myself. One drover missing from the yard at dusk. No tracks. A smell of baking where he stood. I walked out to the place with a lantern after full dark. The white there was warm through my boot. I have not entered that. I find I cannot leave it out. Entered: warm.

Fifth day before. There is a table in the common room. It was not there at midnight. I sat up with the lamp and the ledger and I did not sleep and I did not see it come. It is long and dark and set for nine and the cloth is whiter than anything I have seen in my life. The bread is warm. Nobody has touched the bread. There are cards at the places. One of them has my name on it. I have entered it in the inventory under Furniture, Not Company Property. I do not know what else to enter it under.

Fifth day before, later. Mistress Thimble has polished the table. Nobody asked her to. She says she could not help it. She says a table like that ought to be kept nice.

Fourth day before. Teamster Crumm, deceased, by his own hand, in the cold store. I am bound to enter the cause. I have entered the cause. I have entered also that he was a kind man, which is not a Company column, and I have drawn the column myself.

Tablenight eve. I am still bound to hold this station until relieved. I wish it entered that I was never relieved.

▼ AN INTRODUCTORY ADVENTURE

The Ninth Chair is an introductory adventure for **The Long Grace**, written for three to five new characters of mixed lands and playable in three sessions of four to five hours, with an optional fourth session of aftermath, *After the Snow*. It takes place in the last week of Lack, 641 A.G., at a Rim Road Company waystation called **Thimble Cross**, where the great ring road bends between the warm meat-plains of the Fatlands and the gold, empty edge of the Fast. A storm of something that is not snow strands the characters there with a convoy of Fatlands meat, a houseful of strangers, and a long table that nobody carried in.

It is a siege, a murder mystery, and a famine, all at once, and it ends on the longest night of the year. It is designed to teach the core of the game: the Grace Roll, Dread and Fray, Hunger and Partaking, the way each land's curse travels in the blood of its people, and the first rule every child of the Fast learns, which is that there are invitations you must not accept.

It is also designed to hurt. The adventure's climax is a sacrifice that the community demands, that somebody gives, and that buys nothing at all. Players should leave the table understanding, in their stomachs, what kind of world this is: a world in which the gods are not angry and cannot be bargained with, in which good people do

the brave thing and it does not matter, and in which the Host, the only god never eaten, is kind.



*Come in, come in. There's always room. There's
always, always room.*

ABSALOM THIMBLE, AT THE DOOR, EVERY EVENING
OF HIS LIFE

CONTENT AND CARE

This adventure contains graphic gore and transformation, cannibalism, the desecration of graves, a ritual murder, a killing within a family, an inherited bloodline curse with implied incest between adults, contagious madness, and a suicide. Talk with your players before you begin. Settle your Lines and Veils, and make sure everyone knows how to call the Grace.

The suicide on Day Three is written to be played as grief, never as spectacle: its method is never described and need never be, and the scene is about who finds the body, what was in the note, and what the people left behind begin to say to themselves afterward. Big Oona's walk onto the marbled ground at dusk the same day is the echo of it, the pull of grief made visible, and it is played the same way: slowly, with room for the characters to talk her home.

The Thimble family's bloodline is kept in the corners of the eye. Nothing in this adventure depicts, describes or jokes about it. The ritual killing in the smokehouse is described in the aftermath, not the act. Use the tools your table prefers to step around anything that cuts deeper than the game should. Horror works best among people who trust each other.

THE ADVENTURE AT A GLANCE

ELEMENT	DETAIL
Setting	Thimble Cross, a Rim Road Company inn at the Fatlands–Fast bend
Time	The last seven days of Lack, 641 A.G., ending on Tablenight
Characters	Three to five, any lands, any Calling, Cut 0 to 3
Length	Three sessions, plus an optional fourth
Teaches	Dread and Fray, Hunger, Invitation checks, oaths, contagion
The Question	What will a starving house give, to be spared, and who decides?



We do not keep Company time at Thimble Cross. We keep supper time. It is more accurate.

HEPZIBAH THIMBLE, TO A COMPANY CLOCK-
MENDER, 630 A.G.

▼ THE SECRET TRUTH

Read this section before anything else. Nothing in it should reach the players directly. All of it can reach them in pieces.

FOUR THINGS ARE HAPPENING AT ONCE

The Reaping has followed the convoy. Forty-four barrels of Fatlands meat came up the Rim Road under the seal of Cullmaster Hedley Brawn. Thirteen are notched with a small knife-mark under the stamp, and they hold the harvest of the Dusk Acres: Rootkin,

field-grown meat with faces, and, packed in brine among them, the remains of people the Fatlands soil took and then, being a generous field, gave partly back. The soil of the Fatlands is the flesh of Ummer, the Laden, and that meat is still, in a sense the Board would rather not examine, ground. It has carried its weather with it. **Marbling**, the Fatlands' first frost, the whitening of the fat in the soil, has followed the wagons north for six days and settled over Thimble Cross like snow. Where the marbling lies, the ground is

Fatlands ground. And on Fatlands ground in the dark of the year, at dusk, people are Reaped.

The Host has come to dinner. Orrum, the only god never eaten, has been walking out of the Fast along the Rim Road, laying tables where people are hungry. Thimble Cross is the most perfect invitation it has ever been offered. The inn is starving. The convoy's hunger is the bottomless hunger of the Fatlands. And the family who keep the inn are bound, by a Company charter sworn in Oathen two hundred and thirty-nine years ago, to "turn no traveller away, nor refuse any guest, while the blood of Thimble endures." A house that cannot refuse is a house the Host can enter. On the night after the characters arrive, a table appears in the common room, laid for nine. On Tablenight, the longest night of Lack, the Host will come to sit at its head, and everyone who takes their place will be Seated: alive, smiling, eating from empty plates, never to rise.

The guests are not innocent. A poacher means to sell a caged Unfed woman to the Second Table, two of whose nobles are here under false names to measure the Host's table for carving. A Purgation preacher is looking for a high-Cut throat to open. The innkeeper is about to feed his guests his own mother. A Vigil courier on her last rouse is seeing things, and the things are catching. A Cullmaster of the Board is keeping a little book of who the field should take next, and his book is very neat.

The ninth chair is not for anyone here. Orrum's newest tables on the Rim Road are always laid with one place more than there are guests to fill it. That place has a chair pushed in square to the table, its back to the lamp, and at Thimble Cross, for the first time anyone has recorded, it has a card. The card bears no name. It bears a single mark in the oldest form of Table-speech, the root word that means both "to worship" and "to eat," with a stroke beneath it that scholars read as "after," or "last," or "late." The people of Thimble Cross will come to believe that the ninth card names someone who must be given to the Host so that the rest may be spared. They will argue about who. They will choose. Someone will sit in the ninth chair. And the Host will come anyway, lift the volunteer gently out of a chair that was never theirs, lay a new place for them, and go on with dinner. The ninth chair was not laid for any guest of Thimble Cross. Welcome Ardent, the Host's steward, sets it at every table himself, and in six hundred years he has never once been told who it is for.

WHAT THE NINTH CHAIR IS (DO NOT SAY)

The ninth chair is the place every old carving keeps for the Eighth, the figure chiseled out of the world's history. This adventure never says so, and neither should you. If players connect the empty chair to the eighth place in old carvings, to the stone table under the sea with eight chairs, to the eighth side of Hallowboard that never has a warm handprint beside it, let them. Do not confirm it. Welcome Ardent does not know. The Host, if it knows, does not discuss its guest list. The horror of the climax is that the chair belongs to someone who has not arrived, that everyone at Thimble Cross can feel it waiting, and that nothing they offer fills it.

If a player asks you directly, at the table, who the chair is for, the right answer is the one Ardent gives: *We're expecting one more.* Then ask whether they take sugar.

WHAT THE HOST WANTS

The Host does not want a sacrifice. It has never wanted one. It wants what it has always wanted: for everyone to be fed. The tragedy of Thimble Cross is that the people in it cannot imagine a god that wants nothing from them except their company at dinner, and so they spend seven days working out what it must want instead, and paying it.

Orrum does not compel. It invites. It invites in the handwriting of the dead, with the smell of bread, with warmth in a frozen house, with rest for people who have not rested in years. It is never angry, never cruel, and never satisfied. Every rule in this adventure that seems to punish the characters is really a description of a kindness too large to survive.

◇
*It only wants everyone fed. That's all it has ever
wanted. That isn't so terrible, is it?*

WELCOME ARDENT, ASKED WHY HE SERVES

THE RULE OF THE HOST'S TABLE

Three rules govern the table in the common room, and the characters should learn all three the hard way or from Refrain Dole.

- ◇ **Eating makes you a guest.** Anyone who eats food from the Host's table, a crumb of the bread or a smear of the butter, must sit at their own place before the next dawn. They make an Invitation check each hour to resist (see below), at Grim 18.
- ◇ **Sitting makes you Seated.** Anyone who sits in their own chair is Seated and lost: alive, lucid, smiling, eating air with real pleasure, wasting slowly for years. They can be dragged from the chair only to die, within the hour, of a hunger that has suddenly arrived all at once.
- ◇ **Thanks makes it worse.** Anyone who thanks the table, a chair, the bread or the Host, even in passing, even ironically, gains +4

to the Difficulty of their next Invitation check. The Unfed learn this before they learn their letters.

INVITATION CHECKS AT THIMBLE CROSS

The Fast chapter gives rules for **Invitation checks**, which the Unfed make whenever Orrum offers. At Thimble Cross the Host is calling

OFFER AT THIMBLE CROSS	DIFFICULTY
The smell of the bread, passing through the common room	Routine 10
Your own place card, read for the first time	Hard 14
Having eaten from the table: each hour until you sit	Grim 18
A Seated friend calling you by name	Grim 18
Tablenight, the Host present, your chair across the room	Grim 18
Tablenight, the Host present, your chair within reach	Dire 22

On a failure, the character takes one step toward their place and rolls again next round at +2 Difficulty. Companions may hold them (opposed Gut + Brawl) or speak the Decline with them, saying “No, thank you” aloud together (the companion’s Tongue + Persuade, rolled once, added as a bonus). On a Lack, they sit. On double 1s, they thank the chair first.

on everyone, and every character makes them, Godeater and Unfed alike: **Caul + Resolve** against the strength of the offer. Unfed characters add their Pangs to the Difficulty as usual and gain Want on a success. Godeaters add their current Hunger above 5 (Hunger 7 adds 2, and so on): the god in them is hungry too, and it would like very much to sit down.

◇
*Never thank a chair. Walk into the wind when you
smell bread. Stand with your back to the door. Say no
three times and never a fourth. That’s all of it. That’s
the whole of our religion, and it’s kept us alive six
hundred years, and you lot laugh at it.*

REFRAIN DOLE, THROUGH THE BARS

▼ BACKGROUND

THIMBLE CROSS

Thimble Cross stands where the Rim Road, coming north out of the Fatlands, bends hard west to skirt the edge of the Fast. A rutted track, the **Hungry Lane**, leaves the bend and runs north into the gold country of the Unfed, toward the hearthless town of Wanting; it is used by Crumb-Runners, Hostwatch trackers, poachers, and nobody else. The station is old, solid, and plain: a two-storey inn of grey fieldstone with a slate roof and seventeen chimneys, a walled yard, a long stable, a smokehouse, a toll house with a Company bell, and, behind a low wall, a little graveyard of nine stones.

It was founded in 402 A.G. by **Hadley Thimble**, a Crumb-Runner who had spent her life carrying grain into the Fast on her back and been spat on for it by the people it kept alive. She left the Fast, married a Fatlands drover named Corley Mutch, took his money and kept her own name, bought the crossing, and swore her charter with the Rim Road Company in Oathen before the Company’s notary of the day. The charter granted the Thimble blood the keeping of the station in perpetuity in return for a single clause, which Hadley, who had grown up among people who

refused everything, insisted on writing herself: *that the keepers of Thimble Cross shall turn no traveller away, nor refuse any guest, while the blood of Thimble endures.*

She meant it as a kindness. She had been turned away from every door on the Rim in the Thin Years of her grandmother’s stories, and she had stood outside the Pantry in Wanting in the snow while elders argued over her name. She wanted one house on the Table where nobody would ever be left on the step. She carved *Welcome* over her own grave before she died, and the Company sent a clerk to the funeral, which it does not do for innkeepers.

Promises sworn in Oathen follow the body that swore them, and the bodies that come after it, if the drafting says so. Hadley’s drafting said so. Her descendants cannot refuse a guest without their bodies breaking to match. Mistress Hepzibah Thimble barred the door once, in her youth, against a leper in the rain, and two fingers of her right hand folded backwards to the wrist with a sound like kindling; she wears them that way still. Her great-uncle Ezra refused a drunk Reckoner a bed in 571, and his jaw broke in three places while he was still saying the word, and he took in the Reckoner anyway, through the blood, and the Reckoner murdered a

Gut-line merchant in room four that night. The family does not tell that story to guests.

And because the charter binds only “the blood of Thimble,” and a Clausewright consulted in 488 A.G. opined that a mixed line might be argued to have ended, the Thimbles have for five generations kept their blood carefully, narrowly, at home. Company ledgers list Absalom and Hepzibah Thimble as husband and wife. Three lines higher on the same page, in an older hand, they are listed as born to the same mother. Guests notice the family’s sameness: the same pale-lashed grey eyes, the same small chin, the same strawberry birthmark at the throat, the same habit of laying an extra spoon. Guests do not ask.

Handout: The Thimble Charter (framed under glass in the family parlour).

Sworn before the Notary of the Rim Road Company at Quillhouse in Oathen, in the Grace of 402 A.G., and heard.

Between the Company, by its Factor of the Southern Bend, and Hadley Thimble, late of Wanting, Crumb-Runner, and her blood.

The Company grants: the keeping of the waystation at the Bend, its yard, stable, toll and burying-ground, to Hadley Thimble and to the blood of Thimble in perpetuity, at a rent of one lack in ten of all takings, and the protection of the Company’s peace.

Hadley Thimble swears, for herself and for her blood: that the keepers of Thimble Cross shall turn no traveller away, nor refuse any guest, while the blood of Thimble endures.

No term. No condition. No relief.

Witnessed, the Notary, by her mark. Witnessed, Hadley Thimble, by her hand, who asked that it be written larger, so that it might be read from the door.

Handout: The Opinion of 488 (framed beside the charter, in a smaller frame, slightly crooked).

To Mistress Patience Thimble, keeper, at her request and expense. The Opinion of Clausewright Aurel Tace, of the Ninth Bench, Tacit, upon the question of whether the oath of 402 binds the issue of a keeper married out of the blood.

It is the opinion of this bench, offered as opinion and not sworn, that the word endures is a living word, and that a line much mixed may be argued, by a hostile Company, to have ceased to endure, the charter thereupon to lapse and the station to revert. It is further the opinion of this bench that the blood kept narrow, the line kept whole, cannot be so argued.

This bench expresses no view upon how the keepers should conduct their marriages. This bench was not asked.

Fee: forty lacks. Paid.



This bench was not asked. Five generations, and that’s the line I keep coming back to. Nobody asked. Nobody ever asked.

DORCAS THIMBLE, READING THE OPINION OF 488
FOR THE THOUSANDTH TIME

A SHORT HISTORY OF THE STATION

YEAR A.G.	EVENT
402	Hadley Thimble swears her charter; the Reckoning begins the same spring, and her first guests are Reckoners on their way to the Rim
419	Hadley dies; <i>Welcome</i> carved on her stone. Her son Barnabas keeps the house
455	The Thin Rising. Fasting rebels shelter at the inn; the Board’s bailiffs follow; both are guests, and the Thimbles feed both
488	The Opinion of 488; Patience Thimble marries her cousin Amos the next Grace
571	Ezra Thimble refuses a Reckoner and breaks his jaw; a Gut-line merchant dies in room four
603	Absalom Thimble takes the keeping, aged twenty-three
619	Absalom and Hepzibah are entered as husband and wife
638	The Company congress at Thimble Cross; Envoy Prudence Lowell reads the numbers of six nations in the common room
640	The Company’s Clausewrights begin quietly to test the charter for weakness
641	Old Mother Ivy Thimble dies in Carving and is buried in the ninth grave. Lack: the convoy

THE CONVOY

The convoy is eleven wagons of the Renderers' Union under **Teamster Abel Crumm**, carrying forty-four barrels north from the Chute toward the Vigil, where Fatlands salt pork is bought by the ton to feed a city that eats hourly to stay awake. It travels under the seal of **Cullmaster Hedley Brawn**, who rides with it to see the far-field barrels safely sold, because the Board is beginning to worry about inspection at the Vigil border and wishes its paperwork to be beyond reproach. The convoy's manifest lists forty-four barrels of "pork, salted, first quality." The thirteen notched barrels were packed at the Dusk Acres under Brawn's eye, and stamped at the Chute by Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot, who notched them with his own knife because he would not eat from them himself. Abel Crumm knows they are notched. He has not let himself know why.

Six days ago, as the wagons climbed out of the warm country, the ground behind them began to whiten in long, branching veins. Each night the marbling crept a little further up the road. One drover, Pim Hayward, was lost on the second night. Crumm entered it as wolves, as the Board's forms require. On the evening before the adventure begins, the convoy reached Thimble Cross, and the marbling came with it, and in the morning it was lying a hand deep over everything, and it had begun to fall from the sky.

◇

There's no wolves in the Fatlands, love. There's nothing in the Fatlands but crop. So when the form says wolves, you write wolves, and you know what it means, and you don't say.

BIG OONA HARL, TO A NEW DROVER, ON THE ROAD NORTH

WHY NOW

Tablenight is the anniversary of the Gorging, the night six peoples ate their gods and one did not. Orrum has been patient for six hundred and forty-one years. This year, the Hostwatch say, it is walking faster. Its steward, Welcome Ardent, usually lays a table a mile ahead of his master and waits for him. In the last year, at three Rim inns, the Host has gone ahead and laid without him. At Thimble Cross it has done so again, and this time the ninth place has a card, in a hand that is not Ardent's, and that frightens Ardent more than anything has frightened him in six centuries.

Something is hurrying the Host. The Hostwatch think it is the Regrowth: six eaten gods coming back, and a seventh, whole, feeling its brothers stir. Ardent thinks it is something else, and will not say what, because he has never been told, and has decided that not being told is the same as knowing.

▼RUNNING THE NINTH CHAIR

STRUCTURE

The adventure runs across seven days, from **Day One** (six days before Tablenight) to **Day Seven** (Tablenight itself). A day-by-day

timeline gives what happens if the characters do nothing; the characters will, of course, do something, and the timeline bends around them. Scenes are written to be dropped in when the moment is right. Roughly:

SESSION	DAYS	WHAT IT IS ABOUT
One	Days One to Three	Arrival, the table, the cards, the first Reaping, hunger, the roster, the suicide
Two	Days Four to Six	The graveyard, the kin-slaying, the oath on the dead, the ritual killing, the Seeming, Ardent
Three	Day Seven	The demand, the sacrifice, the Host, the long night, the endings
Four (optional)	The thaw and the week after	After the Snow: the inquest, the Seated, the charter, leaving

For a two-session game, compress Days Four to Six into a single long night of discoveries, and begin the second session on the morning the consensus forms. For a single long evening, begin on the morning of Day Four with the graves already open, give the players the place cards and Abel's note as handouts in the first ten minutes, and play straight through to dawn on Tablenight.

THE SHAPE OF DREAD

Thimble Cross gets worse in a particular order: first strange, then hungry, then frightened, then cruel, then devout. Pace the Dread

checks accordingly. The first session should cost each character perhaps 4 to 6 Fray; by the climax most should be within reach of Breaking, so that the arrival of the Host can tip one or two over the edge. The Carver's Tally near the end of this chapter lists every scene's Dread rating, so you can see where the pressure falls and ease it where it has fallen too hard.

Contagion of madness is a central mechanic here: when anyone Breaks, everyone who sees it makes a Dread 2 check, and the inn's own population is Breaking too. Because a god is physically present in the house from Day Two onward, and in the room on

Tablenight, the rule for contagion near a Seating applies from midnight on Day Seven: witnesses to a Break check at Dread 3.

Give the players rest when they earn it. A night spent in a warm room with someone they trust, fed honestly, removes 1 Fray, and a sincere rite led by a Celebrant removes 2. Sister Clemency offers rites. They work. That is part of the problem.



First it's strange. Then you're hungry. Then you're frightened. Then you're cruel. Then you pray. That's every siege I ever read about, and I've read about nine.

DORCAS THIMBLE, DAY FOUR

THE COUNT

From Day Two, **Merrit Sloe**, the Brinehollow bail-girl, begins the count, as is the custom of her country: each morning she walks the upstairs corridor and calls every name through every wall, and waits for an answer. On the first morning she cuts a little plank-ear into the wall beside each door with her gutting knife, the way they do on the Middle Mile in Lowmark, so the names will carry. Use the count to open every day after the first. It tells the players who is gone without needing a scene, and the silences after names are the adventure's heartbeat. Keep a list. Cross names off where the players can see you do it.

Handout: Merrit's Count (written on the back of a bail-tally in charcoal, kept in her bucket).

Morning count, Thimble Cross, by the plank-ears.

Haverick, warden. Here. (Always first. Always says "present" like a soldier.)

Thimble, Absalom. Here. Thimble, Hepzibah. Here. Thimble, Linus. Here. Thimble, Dorcas. Here, and what of it.

Brawn, the fat one. Here, eating.

Crumm, Abel. Here. Harl, Oona. Here, love. Furrow, Nib. Here. Haslet. Pettie. Both here, arguing. Sallow, Walt. (nothing) Trotter, Lise. Here.

Dragoman, Kale. Here, darling. Odo. Fenn. Here, here.

The widow. (a little tap on the wood, twice)

Her secretary. Here. (and he shut my plank-ear with his thumb, very gentle)

Sister. Here, child. Lisle, Bell. Here. Here. Sorry. Here.

The new ones. (fill in)

Dole, Refrain, in the stable. I go and call it through the bars. She says "not yours to count." She says it every day. She's always here.

Keep Merrit's count consistent with the timeline. On the morning of Day Three, Abel does not answer. On Day Four, nobody answers for Big Oona if she was Reaped. On Day Five, Absalom's name meets a silence, and then Hepzibah answers for him, "Here," in a perfectly ordinary voice, and the players should feel that. On Day Six, the secretary's room is empty. On Day Seven, if Merrit is still alive, she counts the Seated too, the ones who have already sat, and they answer cheerfully from the common room below, through the floor.

HUNGER AT THIMBLE CROSS

The inn's stores run short at once. From Day Two, everyone at Thimble Cross is on half bread. From Day Four, there is no bread. A character who does not eat a proper meal on a given day gains 1 Hunger at dawn whether they have Partaken or not, and one level of Starving (–1 to all rolls per level, as in the rules chapter). Unfed characters use their own Pangs instead: half bread is a Pantry measure and changes nothing for them; no bread is +2 Pangs a day, and they gain Want for every day ended hungry.

Hunger gained from starvation counts toward Regrowth like any other. Fatlanders, whose hunger was never in the stomach, gain 2 Hunger a day instead of 1, but suffer no Starving penalty for the first three days: they are used to it.

A character who eats honestly, from their own pack or from an unnotched barrel, removes one level of Starving that day. Characters began play with three days of their own food. Let them share it. Let them argue about sharing it. It is the first moral choice of the adventure, and the smallest.

EATING FROM THE BARRELS

The convoy's forty-four barrels are the only food at Thimble Cross worth the name. Thirty-one are honest salt pork. Thirteen are notched (see the Convoy Manifest handout). Meat from a notched barrel is the best thing any character has ever eaten: sweet, yielding, rich, with a fat that melts at blood heat and coats the tongue for an hour. It removes all Starving penalties. It does not remove Hunger. Instead, a character who eats it must roll Gut + Feast against Hard 14. On a failure they acquire the **Laden Taste** until the end of the adventure: they gain 1 Hunger every time they see food, smell cooking, or watch someone else eat, and they must make a Caul + Resolve roll (Hard 14) to stop eating once they have begun.

A character who eats from a notched barrel three times dreams the memories of the person the meat once was, and must make a Dread 3 check on waking: eating a person, knowingly, at last. A character who learns afterward what they ate faces the same check. A Fatlander who eats it suffers nothing new at all, which is the worst thing about it.

THE MARBLING

The marbling looks like snow until you are close to it. Then it looks like the white veining in a cut of beef, branching and rejoining across the ground, with a pinkish translucence between the veins that gives slightly underfoot. It smells of cold fat and, faintly, of bread. It does not melt in the hand. It softens. It falls from the sky in soft white flakes that land on the skin and cling, greasy, and must be scraped away with a knife-back.

Where it lies, the ground is Fatlands ground. Between sunset and full dark, anyone standing on marbled ground alone may be Reaped. Each day the marbling covers more: on Day One the road and the yard; on Day Three the stable floor and the graveyard; on Day Five the cellar; on Day Seven the boards of the common room, everywhere except the strip of floor beneath the Host's table, which stays bare and warm.

THE REAPING AT THIMBLE CROSS

The Reaping here obeys its Fatlands rules. A character alone on marbled ground between sunset and full dark first notices a stillness (Eye + Search, Routine 10). Then the ground leans in, the smell of new bread rising from it (Dread 3 to witness; Dread 2 for a Fatlander). Then it softens: the character must succeed at Caul + Resolve (Hard 14; Grim 18 if their Hunger is 6 or more, or if Brawn has named them) or stop wanting to leave. Companions may drag a character free with Gut + Labor against Grim 18, but each round in the soil deals 1d6 Flesh as the ground begins, gently, to digest. A

character Reaped is gone. What is pulled out after full dark is a shape of clothes and the smell of bread.

On Tablenight, the longest night of the year, dusk does not end until dawn: the field takes anyone alone on the white at any hour of that night. Two or more people standing together are not alone, and the field does not take them. This is the single most important rule in the first half of the adventure, and the players should discover it by doing the decent thing: going out to stand with someone. Never use the Reaping as a surprise kill on a player character; describe it slowly, and give their friends the chance to pull.



A field doesn't hate you. A field doesn't do anything as clever as hate. It's just glad you came.

CULLMASTER HEDLEY BRAWN, EXPLAINING THE
REAPING, DAY TWO

PORTIONS AND ADVANCEMENT

At the end of each session, award each character **5 to 10 Portions** of experience, as described under Aftermath. A character who survives the three core sessions should have earned between 15 and 30; the fourth session adds 4 to 8 more. This is more than an ordinary story pays, deliberately: the characters who walk away from Thimble Cross have been through something that changes a person, and their sheets should show it.

▼ THE CAST

Twenty-odd people are snowed in at Thimble Cross, and every one of them is hungry. The major figures below have full stat blocks; the rest have quick lines. Each entry notes what the person wants, what they are hiding, and what happens to them if the characters do

nothing. Remember that the characters' own names are on the place cards, and that every person in this list will, sooner or later, want to know why.

NAME	WHO	WANTS	IF NOBODY INTERVENES
Absalom Thimble	the innkeeper	to feed them	killed by his son, Day Four
Hepzibah Thimble	his wife and sister	the blood to endure	Seated first, Tablenight
Linus Thimble	the son	to be content	kills his father; Seated
Dorcas Thimble	the daughter	out	volunteers, or sits
Josse Haverick	the warden	to keep the peace	breaks with his oath at dawn
Hedley Brawn	the Cullmaster	to steer the field	Reaped by his own method
Abel Crumm	the teamster	not to know	dies by his own hand, Day Three
Big Oona Harl	eldest drover	to follow Abel	Reaped at dusk, Day Three
Kale Dragoman	the poacher	to be liked, and paid	paid, and Seated, still not full
Refrain Dole	the Tablebreaker	to eat once until full	the ninth chair
Vellum Serrat	the widow in grey	to carve the Host	carves it, and is fed
Casimir Hollowe-Vane	the gloved secretary	someone to hold his hand	the smokehouse, Day Five
Clemency Voide	the Purger	to open	sits, emptied
Merrit Sloe	the bail-girl	not to be pulled	walks west at dawn
Bell Lisle	the courier	to lie down	sleeps, Day Six
Welcome Ardent	the steward	to be relieved	walks on, more tired

THE KEEPERS OF THE HOUSE

ABSALOM THIMBLE, THE INNKEEPER



You look thin. Sit. No, sit, I'll not hear it. There's always a bit more in the pot if you know how to look.

ABSALOM THIMBLE

A big, soft, slope-shouldered man of sixty-one with the family's pale lashes and small chin, an apron that has not been fully white since the Thin Rising was a story his grandmother told, and a voice like a warm spoon. He smells of onions softened in dripping, of pipe-smoke and of the wet wool of a man who has been out to the

woodpile in his slippers. Absalom has kept Thimble Cross for thirty-eight years and has never in that time turned anyone away, because he cannot. He loves the work. He loves the moment a cold traveller's face changes at the smell of his pottage. The charter does not feel like a curse to him; it feels like who he is.

That is why the famine breaks him. A host with no food is a contradiction his body cannot hold, and from Day One his hands tremble when he passes the empty pantry shelves; by evening the trembling has reached his jaw, and he stands at the stove chewing nothing. On the night of Day One he digs up his mother, Old Mother Ivy Thimble, buried in Carving and kept sweet by the cold, and on Day Two he serves her, and weeps in the kitchen while the guests ask for more. He tells himself she would have wanted it. He is right. That is the second worst thing about it.

ABSALOM THIMBLE – KEEPER OF THIMBLE CROSS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (mixed Fatlands line) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 8
SKILLS	Craft (cooking) 4, Labor 3, Persuade 3, Blades 2, Feast 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	kitchen cleaver +5 (3); fist +3 (1)
GIFTS	Hearth-Bound. Absalom cannot refuse a guest or turn one out; any attempt breaks a bone (no roll). Conversely, while he stands at his own hearth, anyone he serves food to must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) to refuse it.
WANTS	To feed whoever is under his roof. Resist (Caul + Resolve, Hard 14) or give away his own share, then other people's.
DREAD	1 (once the pottage is understood: 3)
SECRET	He dug up his mother. He knows the convoy's notched barrels are something worse, and he has already decided he will serve them when the pottage runs out.

Handout: A Page from the Kitchen Book (in the drawer under the bread-board, in a hand that changes partway down the page).

Mother's Winter Pottage. As she made it. Feeds twenty-two.

Barley, two measures, soaked overnight. Onions, all of them.

Salt, the grey. A knuckle of whatever's best.

Brown the meat first in the dripping. Low and slow. Don't hurry it. She never hurried anything.

Skim the pot. Skim it again. It'll want skimming more than you think.

(here the hand begins to shake)

Take the ring off first.

Take the ring off first.

I didn't take the ring off.

HEPZIBAH THIMBLE, THE KEEPER'S WIFE

◇

The table wants doing. I don't know why. A table like that ought to be kept nice, that's all.

HEPZIBAH THIMBLE, BEESWAX ON HER HANDS, DAY TWO

Small, upright, sixty, with her ruined right hand held against her apron like a folded bird, and the smell of lavender water and lye soap about her always. Hepzibah runs the house: the linen, the rooms, the ledger of who sleeps where, the keys on a chatelaine at her waist that she counts with her good hand when she is frightened. She is the family's memory and its law. She is also Absalom's sister, a fact she has never spoken aloud in her life and will defend with a carving knife.

She regards the charter the way a priest regards scripture. The family has suffered for it for two hundred years; therefore it must be holy. When Orrum's table appears she polishes it, every morning, with beeswax, and cannot say why. By Day Five she is polishing it three times a day. By Day Six she is setting places at the pine tables for the dead. On Tablenight she sits first, at her own card, with her ruined hand in her lap, and says that it is very good, that it is the best she has ever had, that she always knew someone would cook for her one day.

HEPZIBAH THIMBLE Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (carving knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 (Hearth-Bound, as Absalom)

LINUS THIMBLE, THE SON

◇

I'm not a clever man. I know horses. I know a joint when it gives. That's all I know. That's all I want to know.

LINUS THIMBLE

Thirty-four, heavy-handed, quiet, a good farrier and a bad liar, with his father's build and his mother's eyes, and hands that smell always of hoof-parings and the forge. Linus has always known that he and his sister are expected to marry, because there are no other Thimbles left, and because the Clausewright's opinion is framed in the parlour. He has been trying for ten years to find a way to be content with it, and he very nearly has, and that frightens him more than the expectation itself.

Linus discovers his father's crime on Day Four, when he finds his grandmother's wedding ring in the bottom of the pottage pot. He kills Absalom that night in the cellar with the cleaver his father taught him to use. Afterward he sits with the body until dawn and holds its hand. He does not resist the oath his mother makes him swear over it. He does not resist anything, after that. He moves through the last three days as though carried, and on Tablenight he

sits beside his mother at the table and is, for the first time anyone can remember, visibly at peace.

LINUS THIMBLE Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 13 · Attack +6 (farrier's hammer 3, or cleaver 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 (Hearth-Bound)

DORCAS THIMBLE, THE DAUGHTER



There's no exit clause. I've looked. I've looked every night since I was fourteen. There's only the door, and the door breaks you.

DORCAS THIMBLE

Twenty-nine, sharp-tongued, tall, ink on her fingers, the only Thimble who reads anything but the ledger. Dorcas has read the charter every night since she was fourteen, looking for an exit clause, and there is none. She has bought every Oathen law-book a passing Clausewright would sell her, and they are stacked in her room to the window-sill, and she has annotated all of them. She wants out: out of the inn, out of the blood, out of the marriage the parlour wall has arranged for her.

She is the person most likely to ask the characters, quietly, to help her leave, and the person for whom leaving is least possible. If she crosses the station's boundary stones without the charter being released, her body will break. She knows this. She has worked out precisely how badly: she has the bone-count from Ezra's jaw and Hepzibah's fingers and a great-aunt's spine, and she has drawn a diagram. She has decided she might be willing to find out. On Day Four she swears the oath on her father's body because her mother is watching and the characters are watching and she cannot think of a single word that would get her out of it, and afterward she goes to her room and is very quietly sick in a law-book.

DORCAS THIMBLE Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (bread knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 (Hearth-Bound)

PLAYING THE THIMBLE CURSE

The Thimbles' inherited curse should stay in the corners of the eye. The players learn it through the sameness of their faces; through the ledger that lists Absalom and Hepzibah as born to the same mother; through the framed Clausewright's opinion in the parlour with its phrase "the blood kept narrow, the line kept whole"; through the single wide bed in the family wing and the second one beside it that has never been slept in; through Dorcas looking at her brother across a room and then looking away. Never make it explicit. Never make it a joke. It is a family that has been doing a terrible thing to itself for two hundred years because a dead woman wrote a kind clause badly, and the most frightening thing about it is how ordinary they have made it.

WARDEN JOSSE HAVERICK, OF THE RIM ROAD COMPANY



I would, if it were within my oath, and I believe it may be, provided the Company's peace is not thereby put at hazard, which I cannot at present promise. So: perhaps. Pass the salt.

WARDEN HAVERICK, ASKED FOR A CANDLE

Forty-four, lean, a long jaw shaved blue each morning in cold water whatever the weather, an Oathener of minor Tongue-line blood who speaks the way all Oatheners do, slowly and in conditionals, with all the exits built in. He smells of cold water and ink. He keeps the toll-house clock, winding it at every entry, and it is the only clock in the house. Haverick holds Thimble Cross for the Company. He swore before the notary Jessamy Quill, at Quillhouse, to "hold this station for the Company until relieved, keep its peace, and keep its ledger true." Sworn in Oathen, the promise travels with him. He cannot abandon the station; he cannot falsify the ledger; he cannot fail to keep the peace without his body coming apart to match.

He is honest because he has no choice and decent because he chose it. He is the closest thing to law at Thimble Cross, and he is trapped there more completely than anyone except the Thimbles. Every death in the house is, by the terms of his oath, a breach of the peace, and every breach costs him a little: a hairline crack in a rib on Day One, a cracked tooth on Day Three, two fingers numb on Day Four. He binds the injuries himself and enters them in the ledger under *Wear*.

WARDEN JOSSE HAVERICK – KEEPER OF THE COMPANY PEACE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste: he hears his words a half-second late) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Blades 3, Shooting 3, Clause 3, Search 3, Resolve 3, Intimidate 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 3 (Company bone lamellar)
ATTACKS	Company sword +6 (4); crossbow +6 (4)
GIFTS	Company Oath. Anyone who swears an oath before Haverick “in the name of the Company and its notary” must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) to break it; on a failure they suffer 1d6 Flesh and a visible injury apt to the oath, as the Oathen-sworn authority of Jessamy Quill reaches them faintly across the Table.
WANTS	To swear. Under strain he finds himself promising things aloud; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14).
DREAD	0
SECRET	He cannot keep the peace on Tablenight, and he knows it. If he fails, his oath will break him. He has calculated where. He has written his own death into the ledger in advance, as “Warden relieved,” and he is asking the characters to help him make it untrue.

HAVERICK’S WEAR

Track Haverick’s injuries as the adventure goes on; the players will notice. Each death at Thimble Cross that Haverick could, by any stretch, have prevented costs him 1 Flesh permanently and a small, apt injury: a split lip for a quarrel, a broken finger for a killing he did not stop, a cracked rib for the Reaping. If he loses 6 or more Flesh this way before Tablenight, he cannot hold the crossbow steady (–2 to Shooting). A character who swears to help him keep the peace, in the Company’s form, before him, shares his Wear from then on: a fine, terrible thing for a player to choose.

THE CONVOY

CULLMASTER HEDLEY BRAWN, OF THE BOARD OF PLENTY

◇

It isn’t cruelty, my dear. Cruelty is waste. This is husbandry. One at dusk, by choice, and the field sleeps sweet. Have a sugared fat. No? More for the field.

CULLMASTER HEDLEY BRAWN

A vast, courteous, beautifully dressed man in plum wool and a waistcoat with forty bone buttons, all straining. He smells of rosewater over rendered suet, and he breathes through his mouth, softly, all the time, a sound like someone blowing on soup. Brawn is a Gut-line cadet and a career officer of the Board’s quietest department, the one that decides which vagrants, debtors and troublemakers are assigned the dusk-shift in the far fields. He is the best officer Cullmaster Varn Sweetbread has, and Sweetbread sent him north with these barrels because he trusts him to make the paperwork beautiful.

He eats constantly and without hurry, from a lacquered box of candied fat he keeps in his coat, and he speaks of the Reaping as a farmer speaks of rain: something to be planned for, measured, and directed where it will do the most good. He is not cruel. He finds cruelty wasteful. He believes, sincerely, that the Reaping can be steered, that a field which is fed one chosen person at dusk will not take a random one at midnight, and he is, horribly, partly right. From Day Two he proposes a **dusk roster**: each evening, one person will go out on the marbled ground and stand there, and the rest will be safe. He will happily draw up the roster. He will not put himself on it. He has a Board warrant that says he need not.

CULLMASTER HEDLEY BRAWN – THE BOARD’S QUIET HAND	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Persuade 4, Feast 4, Reckoning 3, Clause 3, Endure 3, Intimidate 3, Godsign 3, Blades 2
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 13 · Armor 1 (layered wool and fat)
ATTACKS	cull-hook (a short brass-tipped goad) +4 (3); his weight, falling on a grappled foe, +5 (4)
GIFTS	Field-Sense. Brawn can feel which marbled ground is hungry tonight (Caul + Godsign, Hard 14). Naming the Furrow. If Brawn speaks a person’s full name aloud at dusk while standing on marbled ground, the Reaping prefers that person that evening; they make their Resolve rolls against the field at Grim 18 instead of Hard 14. He thinks of this as husbandry.
WANTS	Eating without choosing. Brawn eats through every conversation, every crisis, every death; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or he cannot stop until the food is gone.
DREAD	1 (to watch him eat from a notched barrel and smile: 2)
SECRET	He knows exactly what is in the thirteen notched barrels, because he chose the people who went into the Dusk Acres to grow it. One of them was Abel Crumm’s nephew.

Handout: From Cullmaster Brawn’s Little Book (calf-bound, the size of a palm, kept in his waistcoat; the hand is small, round and lovely).

Lack 641. Bend station (Thimble’s). Field: marbled, transported, active. Appetite: brisk.

Eve. Hayward, P., drover, on the road. Unscheduled. Field restless. Note: never travel the dusk without a roster.

D1. Sallow, W., drover. Unscheduled. Took him gently. Good sign.

D2. Roster proposed and carried, 19 hands to 4. Furrow, N., first. Fine boy. Fed him the best of my box.

(Furrow struck through.) Roster disrupted by guests standing with him. Field unfed. Expect appetite tomorrow.

D3. Harl, O. Unscheduled, by her own choosing. A volunteer is worth two of the roster. Note for the Department.

Names held for D4 to D7: the courier (low Cut, foreign, burdened). The Blank (no yield; try anyway). The bail-girl. The farrier.

I have not named myself. A ledger cannot be kept by its own column.

TEAMSTER ABEL CRUMM, OF THE RENDERERS’ UNION



Lack keep away, friends. Lack keep away from every one of you, and from your mothers, and from your mothers’ pots. Drink up. It’s on the Union.

ABEL CRUMM, THE FIRST EVENING

Fifty-two, square, sunburned in a country with no sun to speak of, with the Fatlands’ hunger behind his eyes and a teamster’s habit of counting things twice. He smells of ox, pipe-smoke and pear spirit, and his laugh comes up from his belly like a cart over a bridge. Abel has driven the Chute road for thirty years, and he has always known some barrels are notched, and he has always decided not to ask. He is kind to his drovers, generous with his pipe, and on the first evening he stands the whole common room a round of pear spirit and says “Lack keep away” with real feeling.

On the night of Day Two he opens barrel 31 and finds, in the brine, a forearm with a tattoo he paid for himself: a sheaf of wheat and the name **ROBB**, for his sister’s boy, who went to work the dusk-shift in Low Tilt last Carving for a debt of thirty lacks. He is found in the cold store on the morning of Day Three. He leaves a note. He leaves his pipe to Oona. He leaves the drovers to work out, by themselves, which of them knew, and how long, and whether it matters.

ABEL CRUMM Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (pry-bar 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

THE DROVERS

Six Renderers’ Union drovers travel with the convoy, all Fatlanders, all perpetually, quietly eating; seeds from their pockets, the rinds of cheese, the leather of their own reins.

- ◆ **Big Oona Harl** is the oldest, a woman of fifty built like a dray-horse, with forearms like hams and a soft high singing voice that nobody expects. She sings field hymns, the long ones that thank each field by name, and she loves Abel Crumm like a brother. She has carried his tobacco for twenty years because he always forgets it.
- ◆ **Nib Furrow** is eighteen, freckled, on his first run, and so hungry he chews the leather of his own reins. He is first on Brawn’s roster. He votes for it.

- ◇ **Gus Haslet** and **Tam Pettie** are cousins who argue about everything except food: the weather, the Board, whose turn it is to grease the axles, whether the Vigil folk really never sleep. After Abel dies they stop arguing, which frightens everyone more than the arguing did.
- ◇ **Walt Sallow** is silent and missing two fingers, lost to a reaping-hook in his youth. He is the first the field takes, on the evening of Day One.
- ◇ **Lise Trotter**, kin to the drover Sal Trotter, does not name the cattle. She knows why. She will tell a character who asks kindly, on Day Two, in the stable, in a low voice: “Because when you name them, they answer.”

The convoy’s twenty-two oxen stand in the yard, and on the second night, when no one is watching the stable, some of them stand on two legs.

CONVOY DROVER Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (goad or knife 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

Handout: A Field Hymn of the Fatlands (as sung by Big Oona Harl, in the Long Room, the first night).

Thank you, Broadfurrow, for the barley and the bone.

Thank you, Hogget’s Strip, for the turnips with the eyes.

Thank you, Old Mother Rind, for the apples and the wisdom.

Thank you, Low Tilth, Low Tilth, for the ones you gave us back.

Lay us down in good ground, when we’re done with being hungry.

Lay us down in good ground, and grow us something sweet.

(and then, softer, the verse the Board does not like)

Thank you, field, for taking. We know you had to eat.

THE POACHER AND HIS PRIZE

KALE DRAGOMAN, THE POACHER



*There now. Slow. Little sips. Your belly’s forgotten how.
That’s my brave lass. No, don’t cry on it, you’ll salt it.*

KALE DRAGOMAN, AT THE BARS OF THE CAGE

Big, ruddy and handsome in the Fatlands way, thirty-five, his size all appetite and none of it softness: heavy jowls that shake when he laughs, beautiful white teeth he cleans with a willow twig after every meal, small clever brown eyes, hands like a baker’s. He wears a good brown Rim coat over boiled leather, a red neckcloth, and a bay leaf in his hatband, and he smells always of woodsmoke and roast fat and onions softened in dripping. His voice is a rolling eastern burr, the voice of a man who has called a great many people *my love* and meant it each time. He eats constantly from his pockets.

Kale hunts the Unfed across the border for the Blank trade. He takes them alive, because a living Blank fetches four times a dead one at the surgeries where blank blood and blank organs are sold to the nobility. And he feeds them well on the road, slowly, the way the physicians’ books say, broth and then milk and then soft bread, because his buyers prefer a plump specimen and because, he says, there is no reason to be unkind. His captives find this the hardest thing to forgive. He travels with two hired men, Odo and Fenn, and a wheeled iron cage, clean, straw-floored, with a wool blanket. He cleans it himself.

Kale is witty, morally weightless, and good company, and he will try hard to be liked, because people who like him are easier to sell things to, and because he cannot bear not to be. His buyers since 638 have been the Second Table. He has never met one of its nobles face to face. On Day Two, at supper, a widow in grey looks at the two-tined fork badge on the inside of his lapel, and he realises that he has.

KALE DRAGOMAN – THE FEEDER OF THE UNFED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Fatlands, so the College says) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Wayfaring 4, Feast 4, Brawl 3, Shooting 3, Persuade 3, Hagggle 3, Craft (cooking) 3, Search 2, Stitching 2, Endure 2, Blades 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 (boiled leather under a good coat)
ATTACKS	weighted cosh +6 (3; on a Helping the target must roll Gut + Endure, Hard 14, or fall senseless); throwing net +6 (target held; Lung + Athletics, Hard 14, to escape); crossbow +6 (4); skinning knife +5 (2)
GIFTS	A Good Table. Kale can make anything taste wonderful. Any character who eats food he has cooked gains no Starving penalty that day and must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) to speak against him for the rest of the evening. The Kind Spoon. Once a day, he offers food with such warmth that an Unfed who hears it must spend 1 Want or make an Invitation check at Hard 14.
WANTS	The Hollow. When anyone near him refuses food, he must make them eat, with words and then with hands; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14). He rarely tries.
DREAD	1 (to see a captive eat from his spoon)
SECRET	His buyer's token is a small enamel badge in the shape of a fork with two tines, the sign of the Second Table. Lady Vellum Serrat recognises it on Day Two. They come to an arrangement. He has also never once been full, and he does not know why, and the reason is in the Fast.

KALE'S HIRED MEN (ODO AND FENN) Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (club 3, or crossbow 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

REFRAIN DOLE, THE TABLEBREAKER



Two hundred and six. I count them. I count the chairs too. Never once found one I wanted. Liar. I'm a liar. Put that in your book, Oathen.

REFRAIN DOLE

She is thirty-three, Unfed, and she has put an axe through two hundred and six of Orrum's tables. Kale took her on the Hungry Lane a week ago with a cosh behind the ear while she was splitting a

laid board near Wanting, and she has been in his cage ever since, eating his cooking because the alternative is to be held and fed, and hating every sweet mouthful. She is gaunt in the way of her people, with cropped black hair, the knuckles of a woodsman, a bruise across her temple gone green, a smell of cold air and clean sweat, and the Unfed's pride in her chin like a fist.

She is insufferable. She tells the characters exactly what their ancestors did and exactly how damned they are, and she corrects their grace. She is also funny, fearless, and the only person at Thimble Cross who knows how to survive the Host. If the characters treat her as a person, she will teach them: never thank a chair; walk into the wind when you smell bread; stand with your back to the door; say "No, thank you" three times and never a fourth. She is, by design, the person the players should come to care about most. She is the most likely volunteer for the ninth chair.

REFRAIN DOLE – TABLEBREAKER OF WANTING	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4
CUT & REFUSAL	Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 6 · Pangs 4 (Hollow)
SKILLS	Resolve 4, Endure 4, Blades 3, Lore (the Host's tables) 3, Wayfaring 3, Instinct 3, Labor 2, Brawl 1
BODY	Flesh 14 (currently 9) · Guard 16 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	felling axe, if returned to her, +6 (4; against one of Orrum's tables, it splits the wood on any success); fist +4 (1)
GIFTS	No, Thank You. Refrain adds +4 to any roll to refuse the Host, its tables, its food, or its steward. Once per scene she may lend this bonus to another character by standing beside them and saying the refusal with them. Empty Vessel. She cannot Partake and nothing godsigned can find her by blood; the Reaping does not prefer her, and Brawn's Naming fails on her.
WANTS	She wants, more than anything, to eat until she is full, once, before she dies. She will never say so.
DREAD	0
SECRET	She has been reading the forbidden historian Meek Garrity in secret, in a copied page she keeps folded inside her boot. She half believes his heresy: that the Unfed never refused at Hallowboard, that they only arrived late. When she sees the mark on the ninth card, she reads it as Late . She thinks it is her name.

Handout: *The Page in Refrain's Boot* (copied in pencil from a manuscript passed hand to hand in Wanting; the paper is soft as cloth from folding).

...and the slate is plain. The households were allotted their sides in the old manner, the hearth-families nearest the god's head, the field-families at the feet, and against each side a day: the first household on the first night, the second on the second, and so to the seventh. Our households are written on the slate against the tenth day. Not the first. The tenth.

I have sat with this for a year. I have prayed with it, which I am not supposed to do. I can read it no other way. We did not stand on the hill and say no. We came up the hill on the tenth morning with our knives and our bowls, and the table was already bare, and the god got up off it and looked at us, and walked away.

We were not the ones who refused. We were the ones who were late.

And beside the eighth side there is a word, and the word is gone.

THE TRAVELLERS

LADY VELLUM SERRAT, OF THE SECOND TABLE



If it should prove, madam, that the Host is a guest in this house, then it may also prove, under the custom of houses, that a guest may be served. I say no more than that. I could say a great deal more.

LADY VELLUM SERRAT, THROUGH THE WIRE

She travels as “the widow Serrat, a dealer in lace,” in grey mourning silk with a black lace veil that hides a slim bit of gilt wire across her tongue. She is in truth a Tongue-line noble of Tacit, Cut 4, fifty years old, deep in the Appetite and fighting a compulsion to swear that the bit holds in check. She speaks rarely, in exquisite conditionals, through the wire, so that every sentence comes out faintly lisped and glittering, and she smells of orris-root, old silk and, faintly, of the blood that seeps where the wire rubs.

She is a member of the Second Table, whose one idea is that the gods, when they have regrown, should be eaten again, and she has come to Thimble Cross deliberately, following the Hostwatch reports of tables laid at Rim Road inns, to see one of Orrum's tables up close and take its measurements. She carries a cutwright's tape, a silver carving set wrapped in oilcloth, and a letter from Wont Bellamy of the Abstinents. She regards the Host as the only whole god left on the Table and therefore the only unspoiled meal. She is calm, curious, and the most dangerous person in the building, and when she understands Kale's badge she sees at once that the caged woman in the stable is her own house's property, and that it may be more useful at the table than in a surgery.

LADY VELLUM SERRAT – THE WIDOW IN GREY

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Clause 5, Lore 4, Persuade 3, Reckoning 3, Resolve 3, Godsign 3, Athletics 1, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	stiletto hidden in a lace-bobbin +3 (2)
GIFTS	Bound Word. Vellum cannot lie, and everyone at Thimble Cross who knows Oatheners knows it; her statements carry weight (+2 to Persuade when she says something plainly). The Self-Sworn. Once per session she may take out the bit and swear an oath upon herself to accomplish a thing; for the rest of the scene she adds a Tooth to every roll toward that end, and if she fails it her body breaks to match.
WANTS	To swear. Without the bit she will vow aloud whatever she is thinking; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14).
DREAD	1 (to see what the wire has done to her tongue: 2)
SECRET	She will trade anything for the ninth card. She believes it names the Host's own place, and that whoever holds it may be able to call the Host to sit, and be carved. She is wrong. She does not know she is wrong.

LORD CASIMIR HOLLOWE-VANE, THE SECRETARY

◇
Forgive me. The door. I have to. It's only that it was open.

LORD CASIMIR HOLLOWE-VANE, CLOSING IT

He travels as Vellum's secretary, a quiet young man in a scholar's coat, with heavy grey gloves he never removes and a habit, which he cannot stop, of closing things: lids, shutters, books, the inn's doors behind people who meant to leave them open. He is in truth a cadet

of the Hand-lines of Sallowreach, a distant cousin of the Left Hand of the Court, Cut 4, thirty-one, and well into the Course. Under the gloves, under a second pair of lead-lined mittens, his hands are grey and cold and have seven joints to each finger. What they touch finishes: a candle, a conversation, a person.

He left Sallowreach because he could not bear to be useful there. For years he wrote every month to his cousin Osric, who is kept blindfolded in a locked room in Lastgate because of what his eyes do, and then one month he could not think of anything to say that was not *I am becoming you*, and stopped. He is gentle, frightened, well-read, and would very much like someone to hold his hand without dying.

LORD CASIMIR HOLLOWE-VANE – THE GLOVED SECRETARY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Rites 3, Lore 3, Persuade 2, Resolve 2, Blades 2, Stitching 1, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	Closing Touch +6 (bare hand; the target must roll Caul + Resolve against Grim 18 or fall to Ruin at once; on a Lack they simply finish); sword-cane +6 (4)
GIFTS	The Closing Hand. Anything he touches bare-handed ends: a flame, a fever, a heartbeat. He can choose to touch lightly and end only a thing's motion, or a pain, or a fit of madness (Caul + Godsign, Hard 14; on a failure, he ends more than he meant).
WANTS	To close. He cannot leave a door, lid or eye open; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or close it, whoever is in the way.
DREAD	2 (to see his hands ungloved)
SECRET	He came to Thimble Cross hoping that if he sat at the Host's table, his hands would be fed something other than endings. He has told no one, not even Vellum.

Handout: Casimir's Unsented Letter (folded in the lining of his left glove; found on the body, or given to a friend).

Osric. Dear Osric.

I am at an inn at the bend of the road and the snow is not snow and there is a table here that nobody laid. It has my name on it. Not the name I travel under. Mine. In Mother's hand, which I have not seen since I was eleven.

I closed the lid of the bread-crock this morning and the bread in it went to dust. I closed a drover's eyes at supper because they were open, and he was only laughing, and he isn't laughing now, he is only very still and will not look at me. I have stopped closing things in front of people. I close them at night instead. The inn is full of doors.

I wanted to ask you whether it is cold, where you are. Whether it is quiet. I think it must be. I think that is what we are for.

There is a woman in a cage in the stable who says no to everything. I have never in my life wanted so much to be told no.

I will not send this. You would only

SISTER CLEMENCY VOIDE, OF THE PURGATION

◇

Open your mouth, child. That's all. Open it. The god never left by any other door.

SISTER CLEMENCY VOIDE, IN THE YARD

A tall, bony woman of forty-five from the red highlands of Cradlewrack, in a sackcloth habit belted with a string of pewter basins that clink when she walks. Her teeth are worn to stubs by bile, her knuckles calloused where she has put her fingers down her own throat ten thousand times, her breath sour and her hands smelling of vinegar, and her voice is the warmest thing at Thimble Cross: low, kind, patient, with a midwife's certainty in it.

The Purgation believes the gods can be thrown back up. Clemency's own branch believes it must be done by the highest bloodlines first, since the god sits thickest in them, and that the Host, the uneaten god, came to this place because the guests are full of eaten god and it can smell them. She preaches fasting, bleeding,

and purging in the yard each morning, and by Day Four the hungry drovers have begun to listen, because she is the only person offering a reason for what is happening. She is also, under the Regrowth of her own land, suffering the false labour of the Appetite, cramps that

bend her double on the stairs, and she believes it is the god trying to come out of her. In every door she passes, in every window she opens, she is looking for the way out of herself.

SISTER CLEMENCY VOIDE – THE EMETIC	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Cradlewrack) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite: false labour) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 4, Stitching 3, Resolve 3, Intimidate 3, Blades 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	bleeding lancet +4 (2; the wound bleeds 1 Flesh per round until stitched, Routine 10); pewter basin +3 (1)
GIFTS	The Sermon. When Clemency preaches to a crowd, she rolls Tongue + Persuade; anyone listening who does not beat her result with Caul + Resolve is swayed for a day, and will take her side in any argument. Purge. She can make a willing or restrained person vomit up what they have eaten in the last day (no roll); this removes the Laden Taste and 1d6 Hunger, and costs 1d6 Flesh.
WANTS	To open. During her cramps she feels something about to begin and must make something begin; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14), or she opens a door, a window, a vein.
DREAD	1 (to watch her purge a convert: 2)
SECRET	She knows who Casimir is from the first night, from the way he shuts the doors. She has already decided.

PURGATION CONVERTS (DROVERS AND GUESTS SWAYED BY THE SERMON) Threat 1 · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +3 (lancet or knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

MERRIT SLOE, THE BAIL-GIRL



Here, love? Here? Good. That's one. Who's next? Don't be shy, it's only the count, it's only me.

MERRIT SLOE, AT A PLANK-EAR, EVERY MORNING

Nineteen, freckled, wiry, with salt-cracked lips, a gap-toothed grin, and a wooden bail-bucket on a cord across her back, painted with gulls by someone who loved her. She smells of tar and seaweed bread

even here, a thousand miles from the water. Merrit is from the Middle Mile of Lowmark. Her mother walked into the sea when Merrit was twelve and walked out again six weeks later, calm and courteous and heavier, and tucked Merrit into bed that night with a stranger's hands. Merrit left home at sixteen and has been walking east ever since, as far from the sea as the Rim Road goes, earning her passage at Company inns by bailing Brinehollow travellers who are too old or too ill to cough the night's tide up for themselves.

She is cheerful in the deliberate way of people who have decided to be. She is the first to make friends with Refrain Dole, through the bars of the cage, by trading jokes for jokes. She has started to stand at the west windows at night, where the gold light of the Fast lies across the marbled fields like a tide coming in, and she does not know why.

MERRIT SLOE – THE BAIL-GIRL OF THIMBLE CROSS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Brinehollow) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Stitching (bailing and the care of the drowned) 3, Persuade 3, Athletics 2, Endure 2, Instinct 2, Search 2, Filch 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	gutting knife +4 (2); bail-bucket swung on its cord +3 (1)
GIFTS	The Count. While Merrit keeps the morning count, any character who answers her through the wall gains +1 on the first Dread check of the day. Reading the Water. From the colour of what she bails from a Brinehollow lung, she can tell who will be Called next (Eye + Instinct, Hard 14).
WANTS	The pull. She stands at windows facing west; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or walk toward the water, or toward whatever lies west instead.
DREAD	0
SECRET	Her card is on the table. She has decided not to mention it.

COURIER BENEDETTA "BELL" LISLE, OF THE VIGIL

Pinch me. Go on. Harder. There. Thank you. Sorry.
Again in a minute, if you don't mind.

BELL LISLE

Twenty-six, quick, angular, with a courier's narrow saddle-hardened body and the bruised, lidded, enormous eyes of someone who has not slept in her life. Her forearms are freckled with pin-scars in neat rows, like stitching. She carries a sealed leather dispatch case under the Warden-Prime's lidless-eye seal, addressed to Envoy Castellan Dray at Lastgate, and she rides the Rim Road the long way round

because the Fast is shorter and nobody crosses it. The nudger a Company factor lent her at the Last Beds turned back at the Fatlands border with a fever. She has been keeping herself awake ever since, alone, with needles.

She also carries six vials of rouse that should have lasted the journey. They are not lasting. By Day Two she is blinking, losing seconds on her feet, waking in other parts of the room; by Day Four she is seeing the Seeming, the shared hallucinations that every Vigil citizen comes to in the end, and the Seeming here is a tall figure stooping at the windows and a dead family laid out at the table eating, and the Seeming is catching. She asks one of the characters to be her nudger, to keep her awake by any means, a pinch, a slap, a pin; it is the most intimate thing she knows how to ask. She knows that if she sleeps, wherever she lies down, she will go to the long room with the eye in it and not come back.

COURIER BELL LISLE – RIDER OF THE WAKING POST	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (the Vigil) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite: blinks) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Wayfaring 4, Athletics 3, Search 3, Resolve 2, Shooting 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (padded riding coat)
ATTACKS	courier's crossbow-pistol +4 (3); needle (for her own use) +2 (1)
GIFTS	The Seeming. When Bell hallucinates, everyone within sight of her must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or see what she sees; those who fail add 1 Fray and pass the Seeming on in turn if they too are near Breaking (Fray 7 or more).
WANTS	The blink. Once per scene, Bell must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or lose 1d6 seconds, waking somewhere else in the room.
DREAD	0
SECRET	She has read her dispatch; the seal is old and she was curious. It contains the Warden-Prime's offer to Sallowreach: to buy the secret of Keeping, so that the citizens of the Vigil may be killed and kept upright, and never need to sleep. Bell has decided that if that is the future, she would rather go to the long room now.

BEING BELL'S NUDGER

A character who agrees to be Bell's nudger takes on a real job. Each scene they spend with her, they roll Eye + Instinct (Routine 10; Hard 14 from Day Four; Grim 18 on Day Six) to catch her blinks before they take her. On a success, Bell loses no time and the Seeming does not spread that scene. On a Lack, she blinks and the nudger blinks with her, losing 1d6 seconds and waking on the other side of the room holding her wrist. The nudger gains 1 Fray each day of the work, and loses 2 Fray the first time Bell laughs at something they say. When Bell finally sleeps on Day Six, her nudger faces a Dread 3 check rather than Dread 2.

THE STEWARD

WELCOME ARDENT, STEWARD OF THE HOST

Good evening. Forgive the hour. Is the house laid? Oh.
Oh, I see it is. I see it is. Forgive me. I must just stand
here a moment.

WELCOME ARDENT, IN THE DOORWAY, DAY THREE

He comes out of the north on the third night, along the Hungry Lane, walking on ground the marbling melts away from: a tall, very thin man stooped a little at the shoulders, as servants become who have spent a long time bending over tables. He wears an old-fashioned steward's coat of dark green, the cuffs immaculate, with a long white apron over it, gravy-stained at the hem however often he changes it, white gloves, very clean, and a napkin over his left arm. A ring of nine iron keys hangs at his belt and does not jingle. A walnut

box of cutlery is under his arm. His face is long, gentle and lined, and grey with an exhaustion so deep it has become a kind of serenity. He looks perhaps fifty. He is six hundred and forty.

He was born in the heartland before the Lack, when Welcome and Ardent were good names, the Host's names. He climbed Hallowboard hill on the tenth morning with his daughter on his back, and found the table bare, and followed the god down the hill because he could think of nothing else to do. At some point that afternoon his daughter stopped holding on. At dusk the god laid a table in the road and pulled out a chair, and Welcome said no, thank

you, three times; and then, having nothing left, he did the thing no Unfed had done before or has done since. He accepted, but not the chair. He asked: *May I help?* A guest is offered. One who asks to help is staff. He has laid every table since.

He is polite, gentle, scrupulous, and so exhausted that his voice sometimes stops in the middle of a sentence and has to be restarted, like a clock. He arrives to find a table already laid, without him, and he stands in the doorway of the common room for a long time with his hand over his mouth.

WELCOME ARDENT – THE HOST’S STEWARD	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 6 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 6
CUT & REFUSAL	none (in service; not of any blood) · Want 0 · Pangs 0, forever
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 5, Craft (laying a table) 5, Instinct 4, Lore (the Host) 4, Resolve 1
BODY	Flesh 19 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 10, steady, unbreaking
ATTACKS	none. He will not raise a hand, and cannot. Wounds dealt to him close by the next morning, folded shut like a napkin.
GIFTS	In Service. Ardent cannot be killed while the Host walks; he can be hurt, and it hurts him, and he apologises for bleeding on the floor. Lay a Place. In one minute he lays a table for any person he can see; it calls them by name, and they must make an Invitation check. At Thimble Cross he refuses to use this, and says so. The Steward’s Keys. Any door, gate, lock or bricked hearth opens for him. Relief. Ardent can offer his position to another. Anyone who accepts, freely and in so many words, becomes the Host’s steward from the next dawn, and Ardent is free (see Ending Two).
WANTS	To rest. He cannot, and has not, in six hundred and forty years.
DREAD	3 (the first time he is understood for what he is; to read a card in his hand: 4)
SECRET	He set the ninth place at every table he has ever laid, because he was told to on his first night. He has been told, too, that when the expected guest arrives, the steward will be released and everyone else will be served. He has never been told a name. He has not asked. When he sees the ninth card at Thimble Cross, in a hand that is not his own, he begins to tremble, and does not stop.

OX OF THE CONVOY (ON TWO LEGS, UNOBSERVED)

Threat 2 · Flesh 18 · Guard 10 · Attack +5 (trample or bite 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 2

AN OPTIONAL GUEST: ENVOY PRUDENCE LOWELL

For a larger group, or a Carver who wants the Fast’s pride in the room, add **Envoy Prudence Lowell**, the Fast’s one ambassador on the Rim Road, who arrives on Day One an hour before the characters, on her way north to Wanting Post. She is small, grey, upright and very thin, in a black coat brushed to the nap, and she eats one dry biscuit a day, standing, facing the wall. She keeps the **Register of Damnation**, a ledger of the Regrowth numbers of every high house on the Table, and she reads them aloud wherever she is asked and many places she is not. She refuses everything three times, including help. She has met Welcome Ardent before, on the road at night, and he asked very courteously if she was dining alone. She was. She always is.

At Thimble Cross she is the voice of the clean, and she is unbearable, and she is right about almost every number. She regards the ninth card with a horror she will not name, because she has heard of Meek Garrity’s slate, and she has asked the Abstinents to leave his name off the Pantry list. If nobody intervenes, she reads the numbers in the common room on Tablenight, aloud, one house at a time, to the Seated and the not-yet-Seated alike, and Cullmaster Brawn, hearing his own line’s figures, stabs her in the throat with a silver fork from the Host’s table. She dies standing. Nobody in the room offers her anything at all.

ENVOY PRUDENCE LOWELL Threat 3 · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +2 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Want 8 · Pangs 3 · Dread 0 (Hollow: +2 to every Invitation check she makes; her readings of a character’s bloodline are Dread 1)

◇

The Host has excellent manners. It is the guests I object to.

ENVOY PRUDENCE LOWELL

▼ THE PLACES OF THIMBLE CROSS

THE BEND AND THE APPROACH

The road comes up out of the south between low hedges gone white, and for a mile you think it is snow, and are glad of it, because snow is clean. Then your boots begin to slide in something that is not ice, and your horse will not put its head down to it, and the smell reaches you: cold dripping, a butcher's slab in the morning, and under it, faint and impossible, new bread. The flakes that settle on your sleeve do not melt. They soften, and spread, and leave a sheen. Ahead, where the road bends west, stands a grey inn with seventeen chimneys, and only one of them is smoking. Beyond it, to the north, the land goes gold, as if it were late afternoon in early Carving there, though it is the dead of Lack here. The white stops at the edge of that light like a tide.

The marbling covers the Rim Road for six miles south and three west; travel out is Grim 18 on Lung + Wayfaring by day and impossible at dusk, and the Reaping walks the road. A character who tries it by day and fails comes back at noon to the inn they left, having walked in a long slow curve, with the smell of bread in their clothes. North, the Hungry Lane runs into the Fast, and the ground there is bare and warm wherever the Host has walked. The characters will realise, if they test it, that the safest ground in the region is the god's road.

At the bend itself stand the station's two boundary stones, waist-high, carved with the Company's wheel on one face and *Thimble* on the other. They mark the edge of the charter. No Thimble has passed them in two hundred years without paying for it in bone.

THE YARD AND THE CONVOY

A cobbled yard behind a seven-foot wall, crammed with eleven wagons drawn into a ring. The oxen stand head-down, breath steaming, and do not move when touched. The barrels are stacked under oiled canvas: forty-four oak casks bound in iron, each stamped with the Chute's mark struck over twice, thirteen with a small knife-notch beneath. Marbling lies thickest here. By Day Three it has grown veins up the wagon wheels, and by Day Five a white rind has closed over the hubs, so that the wagons look like things that have grown out of the ground.

Under the canvas the barrels sweat. A slow pink brine beads at the staves and runs and freezes into soft white whorls on the cobbles. When the wind drops you can hear them settling, a creak and a long wet shift, the sound of something in a

hammock turning over in its sleep. Lay your ear to a notched one and, under the slosh, very faint, there is a sound like breathing through a wet cloth. Lay your ear to an honest one, and there is only brine.

Search (Eye + Search, Hard 14) finds the notches. A Fatlander, or anyone with Reckoning 2+, can see that the notched barrels are heavier than pork should be. Laying a palm on a notched barrel at night (Caul + Instinct, Hard 14) reveals that it is warm.

THE COMMON ROOM

A long, low, smoke-darkened room with a flagged floor, three tables of scarred pine, a great hearth carved with the founding motto, and a row of west windows looking toward the Fast. On the wall by the kitchen door, prices are chalked on a slate in Hepzibah's hand, and from Day Two they are rubbed out one by one and not replaced. From the morning of Day Two the room holds a fourth table.

Chalked on the slate by the kitchen door, Thimble Cross, Lack 641.

Bed, the long room, 1 lack. Bed, a room, 3. Bed, a room with the west light, 4.

Pottage, as much as you like, 1. Bread and dripping, 3 crumbs. Pear spirit, the glass, 2 crumbs.

Ale, small, no charge to drovers. Stabling, the beast, 5 crumbs.

Bail, for Brinchollow folk, by arrangement with the girl.

Nobody turned away.

(The last line is not chalked. It is cut into the slate with a knife.)

It runs down the middle of the room where no table was, dark wood polished to the depth of still water, so long the lamp at its head and the lamp at its foot cannot see each other. The cloth is white the way bone is white when it has been boiled clean. There are nine places. Nine plates of thin cream porcelain rimmed in gold, each with a folded card. Nine chairs; eight of them pulled out a hand's width, as if for someone about to sit. The ninth, at the foot, is pushed in square to the table, its back to the lamp. Down the centre: a loaf, broken, steam still rising from the break. A dish of butter sweating gold. A tureen with its lid on. The room is warm for

the first time in two days. Nobody is standing near the hearth. Everyone is standing near the table.

The table cannot be moved: it is not heavy, it simply does not go. Axes split it (Refrain's axe always does; others need Hand + Labor, Hard 14) and it is whole again the next dawn, with fresh bread. The food is the Host's; eating any of it makes the eater a guest (see the Rule of the Host's Table). The bread is never cold. Its smell reaches every room in the inn, and every character who passes through the common room hungry makes an Invitation check at Routine 10 or gains 1 Hunger (Unfed: 1 Pang).

The tureen, if anyone lifts the lid, is full of a clear golden broth with nothing in it, and the steam that comes off it smells, to each person who leans over it, of the best meal of their childhood. That is a Dread 1 check, and the Carver should ask the player, quietly, what they smell.

THE PLACE CARDS

There are nine cards. Eight bear names, in a fine, round, careful hand that each reader recognises as the handwriting of someone who loved them: a mother, a grandmother, a first teacher. Fill the eight with every player character's name (correctly spelled, including any secret or childhood name), plus, in order to reach eight, **Merrit Sloe**, **Linus Thimble**, **Lord Casimir Hollowe-Vane** (under his true name, which exposes him), and **Absalom Thimble**. For three characters, use all four; for four, drop Absalom; for five, drop Absalom and Linus. The ninth card bears no name; see the handout.

The table grows. Each time someone new becomes a guest (by eating the bread, by blasphemy, by sitting), the table is a little longer the next morning, though the room is not, and there is a new place with a new card. By Tablenight it may seat twenty. Nobody can see where the extra length goes. A character who paces it (Eye + Reckoning, Hard 14) finds it longer than the room by eleven feet.

THE KITCHEN AND PANTRY

A stone-flagged kitchen with a hearth big enough to roast a pig, copper pans on hooks, a scrubbed deal table worn into a shallow trough down the middle by two centuries of kneading, and a pantry of sixty empty shelves, each labelled in faded paint: *barley*, *oats*, *dripping*, *salt*, *the good salt*, *Mother's*. On Day Two the great pot hangs over the fire with the pottage in it. A character with Stitching 1+ or a Fatlands upbringing who examines the pottage's meat (Eye + Search, Hard 14) can tell it is not mutton and not pork; on a Grace, they find a small gold ring with an inscription, *A.T. to I.M., kept*. Hob Gristle of Sated could have told them the name by taste. The characters will have to make do.

THE CELLAR AND COLD STORE

Steep steps down to a vaulted cellar of casks and racks, smelling of earth, vinegar and old apples, and beyond a heavy iron-strapped door the cold store, where meat hangs on hooks in winter. This winter the hooks are empty. From Day Five the cellar floor is marbled, and the white climbs the barrel-staves in veins, and the steps are slick with it to the third tread. Abel Crumm is found in the cold store on Day Three. Absalom Thimble dies in the cellar on the night of Day Four.

THE GUEST ROOMS AND THE LONG ROOM

Upstairs, nine narrow rooms off a single corridor with thin plank walls, and at the end the Long Room, a dormitory of twelve straw pallets for drovers. Here Merrit walks every morning, knocking, calling names into the plank-ears she has cut. The west-facing rooms are the warmest, and the Fast's gold light lies across their floors all night, and those who sleep in them dream of being invited. A character who sleeps in a west room makes an Invitation check at Routine 10 on waking; on a failure they wake with their hand already on the door-latch.

THE FAMILY WING

A locked door off the kitchen opens onto the Thimbles' rooms: a parlour with the charter framed under glass beside the Clausewright's opinion of 488, and a sampler above them in faded red thread, *KEPT WHOLE*; a plain room with two beds, one wide and worn and one narrow and never slept in; Dorcas's room, stacked with books on Oathen law, with a diagram of the human skeleton pinned over the bed and certain bones marked in ink. Searching the parlour (Eye + Search, Routine 10) finds the family register, which tells the attentive reader everything about the Thimble blood without saying anything at all.

Handout: A Page of the Thimble Register (calf-bound, in the parlour bureau).

Joined, 578, before the hearth, Amos Thimble, keeper, and Ivy Mutch, his cousin, of the blood by Hadley's daughter. The line kept whole.

Born, 580, to Amos and Ivy Thimble, keepers: a son, Absalom. Kept.

Born, 581, to Amos and Ivy Thimble, keepers: a daughter, Hepzibah. Kept.

Died, 598, Amos Thimble, keeper. Ivy Thimble keeps the house until the boy is grown.

Joined, 619, before the hearth, Absalom Thimble and Hepzibah Thimble, keepers. The line kept whole.

Born, 607, to Absalom and Hepzibah Thimble, keepers: a son, Linus. Kept.

Born, 612, to Absalom and Hepzibah Thimble, keepers: a daughter, Dorcas. Kept.

(a space left beneath, ruled, as for one more entry)

The dates are wrong, and a sharp reader will see it: the children were born years before the joining was entered, as though the family had needed a long time to bring itself to write the word down. Every entry ends with the same word. The ruled space at the bottom is waiting for Linus and Dorcas. The Carver should let players draw their own conclusions and never confirm them.

THE STABLE AND KALE'S CAGE

A long stone stable smelling of straw, dung and the sweetish, wrong smell of the convoy's oxen, its floor marbled from Day Three. At the far end, under a tarpaulin, Kale Dragoman's cage: iron bars, a wooden floor with clean straw, a slop bucket, a wool blanket folded square, a copper stewpot on a brazier outside the bars that is never allowed to go cold, and Refrain Dole sitting with her back straight and her eyes open. Kale's men take turns sleeping across the door. Picking the padlock is Hand + Filch, Hard 14; the key is on Kale's belt. Refrain's felling axe is wrapped in sacking in the rafters over Kale's own pallet, where he thinks no one will look.

THE SMOKEHOUSE

A squat brick tower across the yard, black inside with three centuries of smoke, hung with iron hooks and racks, its floor a crust of old fat and ash that cracks underfoot like burnt sugar. It smells of hams long gone and of something sweeter under that. It is where Sister Clemency performs the Ninefold Purge on Lord Casimir on the night of Day Five.

THE LITTLE GRAVEYARD

Behind a waist-high wall, nine stones for nine generations of Thimbles, the oldest, Hadley's, carved with a single word: *Welcome*. The others are carved with names and the word *Kept*. The newest, Old Mother Ivy Thimble's, set in Carving, is still sharp-edged and

pale. From Day Three the marbling lies across it. On the morning of Day Four three graves are open: Ivy's dug down from above by a spade, and two older ones, Hadley's and her son's, broken open from beneath.

THE TOLL HOUSE

Haverick's post: a stone hut at the gate with a bell, a strongbox, a crossbow rack, the toll-house clock, and the station ledger on a lectern. The ledger records everything the warden sees, and he cannot make it lie. Reading it (no roll; Haverick will allow it, because refusing would be keeping the peace badly) gives the true daily count of the living and the dead, and every one of his Wear entries. The last page has already been ruled, and the last line already written, in his small careful hand: *Warden relieved*. The date is left blank.

SMALL HORRORS OF THE INN

Roll 1d10 whenever a character spends a quiet hour anywhere in Thimble Cross, or when the scene needs a shiver.

1. A plate in the kitchen rack is warm. None of the others are.
2. Every chair in the room has been pulled out a hand's width. Nobody did it.
3. The snow on the west sill has drifted into the shape of a sleeping person, curled, arms around something.
4. A drover chewing in the corner is chewing the corner of his blanket. He does not notice. He says it is good.
5. The smell of bread is suddenly so strong that someone's mouth floods and they have to spit.
6. Through the floor, very faint, the sound of cutlery on china, and laughter.
7. A card has been slipped under the character's door. It is blank. It is warm.
8. In the yard, an ox is standing on two legs, looking at the window. When looked at directly it is on four, and chewing.
9. Hepzibah is polishing a spoon. She has been polishing it for an hour. It is worn through to the shape of her thumb.
10. The toll-house clock strikes, and keeps striking, past twelve, to nine and twenty, and stops.

▼ THE WEEK BEFORE TABLENIGHT

If the characters do nothing, this is what happens. Every event below can be prevented, delayed, or made worse.

DAY	DAYTIME	DUSK AND NIGHT
Eve	Convoy arrives; marbling settles	Drover Pim Hayward lost on the road, entered as wolves
One	Characters arrive; road closes; first supper	Walt Sallow Reaped in the yard; Absalom digs up his mother

DAY	DAYTIME	DUSK AND NIGHT
Two	The table and cards found; first count; pottage served; Brawn proposes the dusk roster; Vellum and Kale make terms	Nib Furrow sent to the dusk ground; Abel opens barrel 31
Three	Abel found in the cold store; the note; the barrels are opened and the starving inn eats	Big Oona walks onto the marbled ground; Welcome Ardent arrives
Four	Graves found open; Clemency's great sermon and the blasphemy; Linus finds the ring	The Gleanings come to the windows; Linus kills Absalom; the oath on the dead
Five	Absalom's death known; the inn divides; the cellar marbles	Clemency performs the Ninefold Purge on Casimir; Vellum's oath on the dead
Six	Bell sleeps; the Seeming spreads through the whole inn; the ninth card is read	The consensus forms; the demand is made
Seven	The price is paid to Kale; the volunteer is washed	Tablenight: the ninth chair is filled; the Host comes anyway

▼ HOOKS: WHY YOU ARE HERE

Each character needs a reason to be on the Rim Road in the dead of Lack. Choose or adapt one per character. Every hook should bring them to Thimble Cross on the afternoon of Day One, just as the road closes.

- ◇ **Sallowreach.** A Seamer's journeyman or Heir carrying a sealed jar north from the Fatlands for a client in Lastgate. Or: the Mortuary Court has sent you to find a runaway Hand-line cadet, Casimir Hollowe-Vane, before he touches someone important; he was last seen heading east with a widow in grey. Or: his cousin Osric, blindfolded in his locked room, has paid you out of his own purse to find Casimir and ask him only one thing: whether he is all right.
- ◇ **The Fatlands.** A Renderers' Union clerk sent by Mistress Brisket Annalow to quietly check one convoy's barrels against its manifest, because Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot has been notching more of them than she likes. Or: a Thin dissident fleeing north toward the Fast with the Board's bailiffs a day behind. Or: a copyist of Pell Hogget's Long Count, walking the villages for names, who has heard there is a Cullmaster on the road with a little book.
- ◇ **Brinehollow.** A Netwatch deserter walking inland, or a salvager carrying a sketch of Cray Lobbett's eight-chaired table to sell in the Vigil. Merrit Sloe recognises a fellow coaster and bails you the first night, and cuts you a plank-ear by your door.
- ◇ **The Vigil.** A Waker escort assigned to meet Courier Lisle at Thimble Cross and see her dispatch safely to Lastgate. Or: an apprentice of Mirela Sconce sent to find the source of the Seeming of a tall figure laying a table in Thimble Lane, which is, you have realised on the road with a cold feeling, the same name.
- ◇ **Cradlewrack.** A border-runner for Petra Quick fleeing the highlands, or an Assembler sent to buy a Part rumoured to be among a poacher's stock. Doors you pass drift open behind you, and Lord Casimir shuts every one. Sister Clemency recognises your accent on the first night and calls you *daughter*.
- ◇ **Oathen.** A Surety travelling to the Company's Vigil office, carrying the risk of someone else's contract in your body, or a junior Clausewright sent by Jessamy Quill's office to audit the Thimble charter, which the Company would like to end. You have the Company's instructions in a sealed packet: find the weakness. Dorcas Thimble will find you first.
- ◇ **The Fast.** A Tablebreaker hunting the one who took Refrain Dole, your partner. Or a Hostwatch tracker following warm ground south along the Hungry Lane, a mile behind something. You know the rules. You will spend the adventure watching other people break them.

THE NINTH CARD AND THE CHARACTERS

The characters' names are on the cards because they are hungry and they are here. Nothing in their pasts summoned the table; the Host invites whoever is within a day's walk and in need. Make sure each player understands, early, that their character's card is written in the hand of the person who loved them most. That should be the first Dread check of the adventure (Dread 2, or Dread 3 if the hand belongs to someone dead), and it should be the one they remember. Before play, ask each player privately whose handwriting it is. Write it down. Use it again on Tablenight.

▼ ACT ONE: THE LAID PLACE (DAYS ONE TO THREE)

DAY ONE: THE ROAD CLOSES

The characters arrive through the falling marbling in the last grey hour of afternoon. Read or paraphrase the approach from the Bend, above. Absalom meets them at the door with a lantern and the words his charter requires.

The door is open before you reach it, and the light that falls out across the white is the colour of butter. A big soft man in an apron fills the doorway with a lantern held high, and his face, which is the face of a man who has been frightened all afternoon, breaks open at the sight of you like bread. “Come in, come in,” he says, “there’s always room,” and the words come out of him the way a breath does, without his choosing, and he looks for a moment almost surprised to hear them. Behind him the common room is low and smoky and full: drovers eating something out of their pockets, a fat man in plum wool eating something out of a lacquered box, a woman in grey with a veil, a young man in gloves rising to shut the door behind you before you have quite let go of it. The fire is small. The smell of the house is onions, wet wool, and under it, very faint, as though from the next room, new bread.

Let them meet the house: Haverick at his ledger in the toll house, taking their names and purpose of travel under oath; Brawn eating in the best chair by the fire; Kale at knucklebones with Odo and Fenn, offering the newcomers supper three times and then a fourth with a wink; the widow in grey and her gloved secretary; Clemency refusing supper and asking, kindly, who among the guests is of good family; Merrit carrying ale and asking where everyone is from, and whether they will need bailing; Bell Lisle standing by the wall because she does not dare sit. Abel Crumm stands the room a round of pear spirit. It is the last warm evening, and the Carver should let it be warm: let the characters eat, joke, trade stories, find out that Oona sings and that Haverick, asked, can recite the whole of the Company’s Articles of Hospitality from memory.



You’ll have supper? You’ll have supper. You’ll have supper, won’t you? Oh, go on. Four times, that’s Fast manners, and you’re not even Fast.

KALE DRAGOMAN, THE FIRST EVENING

Dusk: the first Reaping. As the light goes, the drover Walt Sallow steps out to check the oxen. Any character near a window or in the yard notices the stillness (Eye + Search, Routine 10). Then Walt stops walking. The ground around his boots has risen into soft white folds, like dough proving.

He does not shout. He looks down at his feet with an expression of mild interest, the way a man looks at a dog that has put its head in his lap. The white is over his ankles, then his shins, and it moves in a slow pulse, and where it touches him the cloth of his trousers darkens as if wet. He says, quite clearly, “Oh, that’s warm.” He puts his hands in his pockets. The smell of new bread is so strong that across the yard someone’s stomach answers it aloud. The white closes over his knees with a small sound, a sound like a thumb pressed into risen dough, and he sighs, the way a tired man sighs getting into a bath.

Witnessing is Dread 3 (Dread 2 for Fatlanders). Characters who run out can try to pull him free (Gut + Labor, Grim 18; see the Reaping rules), but Walt does not want to be pulled, and the ground is fast. If they fail, by full dark there is a shape of clothes on the cobbles, still holding the shape of a man, and two fingers’ worth of empty glove where his missing fingers would have been. Brawn, at the window, wipes his mouth and enters the time in a small book. If the characters succeed, Walt is dragged free with his legs scalded pink to the knee and the skin of his shins gone soft and pitted like the crust of a loaf, and he weeps all night, not from the pain, but because it was so warm, and he wants to go back.

Night: the spade. Any character awake after midnight and near a window over the graveyard (Eye + Search, Hard 14) sees a lantern among the stones and a big soft figure digging, slowly, stopping often to wipe its face. If they go out, they find Absalom at the bottom of his mother’s grave, sitting on the coffin lid in the lantern-light, weeping. He says she would have wanted to help. He says there is nothing else. He says the guests are so hungry. He cannot be made to stop by anything short of force, and force will break a bone in him (the charter: a refused guest is a refused guest, and a host who cannot feed his guests is refusing them). This is Dread 2, and it is the adventure’s first great choice. Most groups will not see it at all. Those who do will have to decide what to do with what they know, at breakfast, when the pottage comes.

DAY TWO: THE TABLE

Dawn. Hepzibah's scream brings everyone down to the common room. Read the description of the table. Each character finds their own card and must make a Dread 2 check on recognising the handwriting (Dread 3 if the hand is a dead person's), and an Invitation check at Hard 14 on first reading their name.

Handout: A Place Card.

A stiff fold of cream card, warm to the touch, smelling faintly of yeast. The ink is brown, like gravy dried on a plate. The hand is round and careful and belongs, the reader knows at once, to their mother (or whoever loved them most).

(The character's name, spelled exactly as that person spelled it, including the name they used when the character was small.)

You are expected.

Tablenight. Come as you are.

There will be enough.

Handout: The Ninth Card.

The same cream card, but cold, and slightly damp, as if it had been left out overnight. No name. In the centre, a single mark in the oldest form of Table-speech, made with a broad pen in one stroke: the root that means both to worship and to eat. Beneath it, a second, shorter stroke, drawn by a different hand, or the same hand much later. The second mark can be read, depending on the scholar, as after, last, late, or still to come. There is no third line. Where the other cards say You are expected, this one has a small, perfect thumbprint, pressed into the card as if into soft fat.

Reading the ninth card needs Eye + Lore against Grim 18; on a success the reader knows the readings above. Refrain Dole reads it without a roll, if anyone shows her, and goes very quiet. Vellum asks, through her wire, whether she might hold it, and her hand is perfectly steady and her voice is not. The card cannot be burned: it chars and is whole on the table by morning. It can be carried away; it is cold and damp and never dries.



Is it mine? Is that mine? I didn't know Mam could write that nice. She couldn't. She couldn't write at all.

NIB FURROW, HOLDING A CARD THAT IS NOT ON THE TABLE, IN A DREAM, THE NIGHT OF DAY TWO

The first count. Merrit walks the corridor calling names. Walt does not answer. Use it. Note who else does not answer.

The pottage. At midday Absalom serves a thick, fragrant pottage of barley and onion and tender pale meat, and the house, which has not eaten properly in two days, falls on it. It is wonderful. It is the best thing the drovers say they have ever had outside the Fatlands, and they say it as a compliment and look ashamed. Characters who eat it, and later learn what it was, face Dread 3 at the revelation. Characters who saw the spade in the night and eat anyway face it now.

The dusk roster. In the afternoon, Cullmaster Brawn addresses the common room, pleasantly, with a ledger.

Handout: The Dusk Roster (proposed by Cullmaster H. Brawn, Board of Plenty, and posted on the common-room door with a fork).

For the quiet of the field, and the safety of the house, the following are respectfully assigned the dusk standing, one each evening, on the marbled ground of the yard, from sunset to full dark. The field is fed by choice and does not choose for itself. No one else need go out.

Day Two: Furrow, N., drover.

Day Three: Haslet, G., drover.

Day Four: the courier (name to be confirmed).

Day Five: Pettle, T., drover.

Day Six: Sloe, M., servant of the house.

Day Seven (Tablenight): to be decided by the house, as the season requires.

Persons of Cut 3 and above are exempt by Board warrant, being of greater yield elsewhere. Unfed persons are excused, being of no yield. All others are asked to consider the arithmetic.

Lack keep away.

He explains the Reaping as Board science: the field will take one at dusk regardless; a field that is fed by choice is a quiet field; he proposes to choose. Every name on the list is a drover, a servant, or a guest of low Cut. Brawn is persuasive (Tongue + Persuade 8); the starving room is frightened; unless the characters argue him down (an opposed Tongue + Persuade, or Haverick's support, which he will give if asked, because his oath includes the peace), the roster is accepted by a show of hands. Kale abstains with a smile. Nib Furrow votes for it, with his own hand, because the room is looking at him. Refrain, from the stable, laughs until she coughs.

Terms in the stable. At supper, Vellum sees the two-tined fork on the inside of Kale's lapel. Later, in the stable, through Casimir, she makes him an offer. A character who follows (Lung + Stealth, Hard 14) overhears it: she will pay Kale's full price for Refrain, in a sworn note, on condition that delivery is made "at this house, at this

table, on Tablenight.” Kale does not understand why. He agrees, because the price is good and because she is so polite. Refrain, in the cage, hears all of it, and says nothing, and that night she asks Merrit, through the bars, whether Brinchollow folk believe in anything after.

Handout: The Convoy Manifest (in Abel’s wagon, in the box under the seat).

Renderers’ Union of the Fatlands, by the Chute, sworn true under seal. Convoy of Teamster A. Crumm, eleven wagons, northbound for the Vigil, Lack 641.

Barrels 1 through 30, 32, 33: Pork, salted, first quality. Tilth Commons.

Barrels 31, 34 through 44: Pork, salted, first quality. Far field. Under Board seal, H. Brawn, Cullmaster.

Weight of far-field barrels exceeds pork standard by one-fifth. Entered as brine.

Origin: struck over twice. Inspected: struck over once. Stamped, I. Stockpot, Quartermaster.

Drovers: Crumm, Harl, Furrow, Haslet, Hayward, Pettie, Sallow, Trotter. Losses on the road: Hayle, R. (entered last Carving, Low Tilth, carried forward in error; strike).

The manifest is in Abel’s wagon. The struck-out name at the bottom, **Hayle, R.**, is Abel’s nephew, Robb, who went to the Dusk Acres last Carving; a clerk copied his name from Brawn’s culling roster onto the wrong form. A Fatlander, or anyone who asks the drovers, can learn that Robb was Abel’s sister’s boy, and that Abel paid for the wheat tattoo on his forearm when he turned sixteen.

Dusk: Nib. Nib Furrow walks out onto the marbled yard at sundown, shaking, because the room voted and he is a Fatlander and Fatlanders eat what they are served. He has Brawn’s candied fat in his mouth. He keeps saying “it’s all right, it’s all right.” The characters can stop him, stand with him (two or more people together are not alone, and the Reaping does not take them), or watch. If they stand with him all through the dusk, the field takes no one that night, and Brawn writes in his little book, without irritation, that the roster has been disrupted and the field will be hungrier tomorrow. If they watch, it is Dread 3, and the boy does not go quietly; he goes calling for his mam, and then very quietly.

Night: barrel 31. Late, the drovers beg Abel for meat. A character awake in the yard sees him prise the lid off barrel 31 by lantern-light, stand very still for a long time, reach into the brine to the elbow, take something out, look at it, and lay it back as gently as a man laying a sleeping child in a cot. He closes the lid. He sits down on the wagon-tongue in the falling white and does not move for an hour. If a character speaks to him, he says only, “It’s nothing. It’s

pork. Go to bed, friend.” If they look in the barrel themselves, it is Dread 3.

DAY THREE: THE TEAMSTER

In the morning count, Abel Crumm does not answer. Big Oona finds him in the cold store. Do not describe how he died. Describe what she does: how she sits down on the flags beside him and takes off her own coat and puts it over him, though he is past cold; how she says his name, the way she has said it for thirty years, to call him to breakfast; how she will not let anyone else come in for the first hour; how, when she does come out, she has his pipe in her mouth, unlit, and his tobacco in her fist. Finding him or coming upon Oona with him is a Dread 2 check. Abel left a note pinned to the inside of his coat, addressed to his sister.

Handout: Abel Crumm’s Note.

Mags.

I opened one. I wasn’t meant to and I did. It was Robb’s arm, the one with the wheat on it that I paid for. I’d know it anywhere. I’ve known it was something for thirty years and I didn’t look, and the not looking was the thing I was best at. I’ve fed it to people. I’ve eaten it myself on the road and said it was good.

I don’t know how to drive the wagons back and I don’t know how to drive them on.

Don’t let them tell you it was wolves. It was me. I’m sorry I won’t be home for the Weighing. Tell Oona the pipe is hers and she’s to stop pretending she doesn’t smoke it.

Lack keep away from you. It never kept away from us.

Abel

Afterward. Abel’s death is the first time the inn’s madness spreads person to person, and it should be shown through the living. The drovers sit together in the Long Room and do not eat. Haverick enters the death, and then the column he has drawn himself, *He was a kind man*, and then sits for a while with his pen above the page. That evening, Gus Haslet says he can hear the barrels in the yard “saying grace, like at home, thanking the field by name.” By night, Tam Pettie can hear it too. Big Oona stands at the window over the yard with Abel’s pipe, unlit, in her mouth, and says, to nobody, “He always went first through a gate so the beasts would follow.” Any character who spends time with the drovers must make a Dread 2 check; on a failure they too hear the barrels murmuring, very softly, all night, the names of fields, and the names of the people the fields gave back.

◇

It was me, he says. It wasn't him. It was all of us. We all drove. We all ate. He just went and said it, the daft old sod, he just went and said it first.

GUS HASLET, IN THE LONG ROOM

The barrels opened. By afternoon the inn has had no bread for a day and the pottage pot is scraped dry. Brawn has the barrels broached. He does not say which are which. Unless the characters stop it, the starving inn eats from the notched barrels by evening (see Eating from the Barrels), and it is the best meal anyone has had in their lives. Hepzibah weeps at the stove. Kale cooks for Refrain from an honest barrel, carefully, and she can smell the difference, and eats, and hates him, and asks for more. A character who stops the meal, or who throws the notched barrels open in the yard so the whole house can see what floats in them, earns the undying hatred of the hungry and a Dread 3 check for everyone who looks: a hand with a wedding band sunk into the swollen finger; a face, Rootkin-smooth, eyes closed, mouth a little open; a coil of something packed like sausage in its own brine.

Dusk: Oona. Big Oona is not on the roster. At sundown she walks out onto the marbled yard anyway, with Abel's pipe, and stands where Walt stood, and waits. She is not making a choice anyone else can make for her, she says, if the characters reach her; she is only going after him, the way he went first through gates. This is the adventure's echo of the suicide, and it should be played as the pull of grief, not as a test the players pass or fail. Characters who stay beside her, talking, keep the field off her for the night (Tongue + Persuade, Hard 14, to bring her back inside; Grace: she gives the pipe to the character, and lives to the end). If no one goes, she is Reaped, singing a field hymn, slowly, the verse the Board does not like.

She is singing when the white comes up over her boots. Her voice is high and clear and does not shake. Lay us down in good ground, when we're done with being hungry. The pipe is in her teeth. She takes it out to sing the next line and puts it back in to listen, the way you listen for an answer at a gate. Her face, in the last light, looks as though she has heard one.

Night: the Steward. An hour after full dark, someone sees a lantern on the Hungry Lane, coming south, and the marbling melting away from the road around it in a widening black margin, steaming. Welcome Ardent walks into the yard, knocks at the door though it is open, and asks Absalom, very politely, whether the house has been laid. Then he sees the table.

He stands in the doorway of the common room for a long time with one white-gloved hand over his mouth. He does not come in. He looks at the table the way a cook looks at a dish someone else has made in his kitchen, and then the way a man looks at the place where his house was. "I didn't lay this," he says at last, and his voice stops, and starts again, like a clock that has been shaken. "I always lay ahead. I always have. A mile ahead. Forgive me. Forgive me. He's never gone ahead of me before this year. Is there, I wonder, is there somewhere I might sit? Not there. Not at that. A stool. Anywhere. Thank you. No. I shouldn't thank you. Forgive me."

Seeing Ardent understood is Dread 3. He answers questions honestly and wearily. He confirms the rules of the Seated. He says he did not lay this table, and that he does not understand why the Host has gone ahead of him. Asked about the ninth chair, he says only, "I set that one myself, at every table. I always have. I've never set the card." He looks at the card for a long time and does not touch it. Asked who it is for, he says, "We're expecting one more," and then, after a long silence, "I was told that when they come, I may rest." He does not say it as though he believes it any more.

▼ ACT TWO: HUNGER INDOORS (DAYS FOUR TO SIX)

DAY FOUR: OPEN GRAVES

The graveyard. In the morning, whoever goes out first sees the graveyard wall split and three graves open. Old Mother Ivy's has been dug from above; the spade is still leaning on the wall, and the shroud lies in the trench empty and folded, because Absalom could not bear to leave it in a heap. The two oldest, Hadley's and her son's, have burst from beneath: the marbling has come up through the coffins in soft white veins, and of the bones only the long ones

remain, licked smooth and pink, as if something below had sucked them like sweets.

The coffin wood has gone soft and fibrous, like the inside of a loaf. In the bottom of Hadley Thimble's there is a hollow in the shape of a lying woman, lined with a fine white down, warm when you put your hand into it. Something is still breathing through it. The breath smells of the pottage. Her headstone has fallen forward into the trench, face down, so that the one word carved on it, Welcome, is pressed into the

white, and when you lever it up the word has been printed there in reverse, raised, like a seal in wax.

The graves are Dread 2; understanding that Ivy's was dug by a spade, and connecting it to yesterday's meal, is Dread 3. Following the spade's prints (Eye + Search, Hard 14) leads to the kitchen door. Hepzibah, if confronted, does not deny anything. She says that Mother was a keeper of this house, and a keeper's duty is to the guests, and that if they would rather have starved, they might have said so before the second bowl.

The great sermon. At noon, in the yard, Sister Clemency preaches to the starving, and the inn listens. Roll her Sermon. On Day Four she sways most of the drovers and a few of the guests.

Handout: The Sermon of Sister Clemency Voide, Preached in the Yard at Thimble Cross.

Children. Brothers. Sisters with your bellies cramping. I will not lie to you, because you have been lied to enough. You are full. You are the fullest people who have ever lived. Your grandmothers' grandmothers swallowed God and you have been carrying It ever since, warm in your guts like a stone in a hen. That is why you can never eat enough. You are not hungry. You are pregnant with a corpse.

And now the one God that was never eaten has come to supper. Why here? Because It can smell Its brothers in you. Because It is a Host, and a Host goes where the larder is. It has come to fetch Its family home out of your bellies, and It does not care if It must take your bellies with them.

There is one way, and it is the oldest way. Give It back. Open your mouths and give It back. Fast and bleed and purge until the god in you comes up black and stinking and lies on the stones where it belongs, and when the Host comes on Tablenight, let It find nothing in this house but clean, empty people, and pass us by.

And those who are fullest, those whose blood is thickest with the stolen meat, the high and the gloved and the veiled: they must be emptied first, and most, because the Host can smell them from the Fast. It is not murder to open a jar. It is housekeeping.

Lack keep away? No. Lack come in. Lack is the only clean guest we have ever had.

At the climax of the sermon she walks into the common room, kneels at the head of the Host's table, puts her fingers down her throat, and vomits a long black string of bile across the white cloth, and then, while the converts watch from the doorway, lays her palm in it and draws the root-mark of *worship-and-eat* on the cloth with her finger, and spits on it. Witnessing this blasphemy is Dread 2. In

the morning the cloth is spotless, and the table is a little longer, and there is a new place at it, with a card. It has her name on it, in the hand of the midwife who delivered her. Clemency reads it, and smiles, and says that God is a very patient host.



I spat in its cup and it laid me a place. You see? You see? It doesn't know how to be insulted. That's how you know it's not a god at all. It's a mouth.

SISTER CLEMENCY VOIDE, DAY FIVE

The ring. In the afternoon, scrubbing out the pottage pot, Linus finds his grandmother's wedding ring. A character who is in the kitchen sees him stand with it in his palm for a full minute. He says nothing. He goes out to the graveyard, and looks, and comes back, and sits at the deal table with the ring standing on its edge in front of him, and turns it, and turns it.

Dusk: the Gleanings. The dusk standing on Brawn's roster is forgotten; nobody will go out tonight, not even for the arithmetic, because at sundown the people the field has taken come back to the windows. See Combat Encounters. They ask to be let in, in their own voices, and Absalom, Hepzibah, Linus and Dorcas cannot refuse a guest.

The first knock is at the kitchen door, three soft raps, the way a neighbour knocks. Then a voice, Walt Sallow's, mild and interested: "Hello the house. Bit nippy. Any room?" Then another at the west window, and you see it: a face pressed to the pane, the eyes closed, the skin smooth and pale and faintly ridged like the rind of a cheese, and below the sill, where its feet should be, a tangle of pale roots that move in the white like fingers looking for a dropped coin. It is Big Oona, or the field's idea of her. It is smiling. Its breath does not fog the glass. "Abel's here," it says. "He's ever so much better. Let us in, my loves, we've come for supper."

The Thimbles open the doors because they must, and the bones in their hands creak when they try not to. The characters will have to hold doors, block windows, or fight in the kitchen and the yard. The Gleanings are Dread 2 to face, and Dread 3 if one wears a face the viewer knew: Walt, Oona, Nib if he was taken, Robb Hayle with his wheat tattoo, Old Mother Ivy with the barley still in her hair.

Night: the kin-slaying. After the Gleanings are driven off, Linus goes down to the cellar where his father is broaching a notched barrel for tomorrow. If no character follows, the house hears only one sound, a wet chop like a joint going through on the block, then a second, and then a long silence. If characters follow, they arrive as Linus brings the cleaver down.

Absalom is kneeling, as if at a hearth, with both arms in the open barrel to the elbow. He does not turn round. He says, "She always wanted to be useful, son. She'd have wanted to feed them." The first blow takes him where the neck meets the shoulder and goes in to the spine, and the sound is the sound he taught his son to listen for, the clean give of a joint. He falls into the barrel. Brine and blood come over the rim together in a pink sheet across the flags. Linus pulls him out by the apron strings, because he cannot leave his father in there with the others, and holds him, and his father's face is shining with the brine and looks, for a moment, enormously relieved. In the barrel, disturbed, something pale turns slowly over in the brine and settles again, face up.

Witnessing the killing is Dread 3. Linus does not fight unless someone tries to take the body from him; then use his quick line, at +2, until he is restrained or Ruined. He sits with his father until dawn, holding his hand, and he talks to him, about horses, about the price of iron, about the time Absalom carried him on his shoulders to see the Company congress in 638, and about nothing else at all.

The oath on the dead. At dawn Hepzibah comes down. She washes Absalom's face, closes his eyes, and folds his hands over the wound. Then she makes her children kneel and lay their hands on their father's chest, and she makes them swear, in front of whoever is watching, in the Company's form, with Haverick as unwilling witness.

Handout: The Oath Sworn over Absalom Thimble (entered in the station ledger by Warden J. Haverick, who was required to witness it, in a hand that is not steady).

On Absalom Thimble, keeper, dead here, our father: we swear, in the name of the Company and its notary, and before its warden, that the blood of Thimble shall endure; that it shall be kept whole and kept at home; that its two last children shall be joined as their mother and father were joined, before Lack is out.

Sworn: Linus Thimble, by his hand on the dead.

Sworn: Dorcas Thimble, by her hand on the dead.

Witnessed: Hepzibah Thimble, keeper, who required it.

Witnessed: J. Haverick, Warden, who could not refuse.

(Below, smaller, in the same unsteady hand:) God help them. Entered under Wear.

Linus swears. Dorcas looks at the characters, and then at her father, and swears. Haverick enters it in the ledger, because he must, and is sick in the yard afterward. This is Dread 2 for anyone who

understands what was sworn. It is an oath on the dead sworn over a body opened by his own son, and the rules say such oaths bind twice as hard; Dorcas knows that too. A character who has befriended Dorcas may be asked, that night, through her door, for help. She does not say with what. She says, "There's no exit clause. Find me one."

DAY FIVE: THE NINEFOLD PURGE

The marbling reaches the cellar, climbing the stairs one step an hour. The inn divides: the swayed with Clemency, who now preach in pairs in the corridor and leave basins outside doors; the Board's people with Brawn, who has moved his chair to the toll house to be near the strongbox and the warden; the Thimbles with their dead, laid out on the deal table in the kitchen under a clean cloth, because the cold store is no longer safe. Bell Lisle is blinking every few minutes now. Absalom's name is called in the morning count, and there is a silence, and then Hepzibah answers for him, "Here," in a perfectly ordinary voice.

Kale, sensing the house turning, moves the cage. Clemency's converts have started to gather at the stable door at night, looking at Refrain with an interest he recognises from the surgeries, and he does not like competition. He asks the characters, cheerfully, whether they would like to earn a meal by standing a watch. If they agree, they are guarding Refrain from the Purgation for a man who has sold her to the Second Table. Kale finds this very funny, and then, when nobody laughs, less funny.



Everybody wants her for something. Me, the widow, the Sister, the room. Nobody wants her for supper but me. Funny old world. Funny old, cold old world.

KALE DRAGOMAN, ON WATCH, DAY FIVE

Night: the ritual killing. After midnight, Clemency and four converts take Lord Casimir from his room with a blanket over his hands and carry him to the smokehouse. He does not cry out. He has been expecting someone. If the characters have befriended Casimir, or are watching Clemency, they can intervene; Clemency's converts fight with fervour, and Casimir, bound with his hands in a sack, can do nothing until freed. If no one comes, Vellum finds him at dawn.

They have hung him from a meat-hook by the bound wrists, so that his toes just touch the brick. The floor is set with nine pewter basins in a ring, and each one holds something that came out of him, in order, the way the Purgation teaches: brine he was made to drink and bring up; bile; the black of his last meal; blood from the lancet at each elbow; blood from the throat; and then, in the last four, what she took out of him with the long knife, set out neatly, the way a cook sets out the

parts of a fowl, the liver dark and glossy as a plum, the coils of him laid in a bowl and still faintly steaming in the cold. His gloves have been cut off. His grey hands have been taken off at the wrist and laid together, palms pressed, in the last basin, as if praying, and where the smoke-blackened brick is spattered near them it has gone pale and dead in a ring, as though the hands went on finishing things for a while after. Smoke hangs in the roof. Clemency is kneeling in the ring with her arms red to the shoulder and her eyes shut, waiting, with great patience, for the god to come up out of the bowl.

The scene is Dread 3. Clemency does not run. She explains, kindly, that it had to be done, and that it has not worked yet, and that it needs another, a higher one; she looks at Vellum. If anyone tries to seize her she offers her wrists, and her converts do not; see Combat Encounters. She does not seem to know that two of her converts are weeping. One of them, a drover called Tam Pettie, sits down in the doorway of the smokehouse when it is over and will not get up, and says to anyone who passes that he did not know a man had so much in him, he did not know there was so much in a man.

Vellum's oath. At dawn Lady Vellum Serrat takes the gilt wire from her tongue in front of the smokehouse door, kneels in Casimir's blood, lays her hand on his empty chest, and swears on the dead, aloud, without a single condition, for the first time in her life.

"By this dead man, Casimir Hollowe-Vane, my cousin of the Table, I swear the Host shall be carved, and he shall have the first slice."

(Her tongue splits a quarter-inch at the tip with a sound like a fingernail on a slate, and bleeds down her chin, and she does not wipe it.)

Her tongue keeps her promise for her. From now on she will do anything to bring the Host to its seat at Thimble Cross, and she becomes the loudest voice for filling the ninth chair. She does not put the wire back. She speaks plainly now, and the plainness is terrible, because everything she says is true and she says all of it: what she paid for Refrain, what the Second Table intends, what she thinks of each person in the room, what she has wanted, in her life, and not had. Each character within earshot when she speaks to them directly makes a Dread 1 check. It is like being skinned with good manners.

DAY SIX: THE SEEMING

Bell Lisle's last vial is gone by morning. Her nudger, if she has one among the characters, is all that keeps her upright, and she is blinking every minute, then every breath, and with every blink the

Seeming spreads. Everyone in the common room rolls Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) each hour; those who fail see what Bell sees.

At the table the dead are sitting down to dinner. Walt Sallow with his clothes on and nothing in them. Abel Crumm, tucking his napkin in. Old Mother Ivy, with the barley still in her hair. Absalom, with his apron on and the wound in his neck very neat, carving. Casimir with his hands in his lap, palms together. They are passing the bread. They are so happy. They are saying, in the voices of people you have loved, that there is room, that there is always room, that you look thin, that you should come and sit down. Outside the west windows, something very tall is stooping to look in, and its breath fogs every pane at once, and it is warm, and it is counting the chairs.

The Seeming is Dread 3 for each new witness, and contagious: anyone who Breaks while under it gains the derangement *I am already at the table* (they believe their body is seated, wasting, smiling, and that the self walking about the inn is a thing left behind; treat as **The Dead Man** and **The Pull** together, triggered by the smell of bread). By afternoon, half the inn shares it. Hepzibah sets places at the pine tables for the dead. Gus Haslet carries a plate of nothing to the empty chair where Abel used to sit and cuts it up small for him, because Abel's teeth were bad. Nobody stops him. Several people thank him.

Handout: The Warden-Prime's Dispatch (in Bell's leather case; the lidless-eye seal is cracked and has been pressed shut again with a thumb).

To Envoy Castellan Dray, at Lastgate, by the Waking Post. Burn on reading.

You are instructed to offer the Regent, for the full and particular art of Keeping, the following: the Vigil's oil contract for twenty years at cost; the Lid's library entire; and such of our sleepers as Sallowreach may wish to study.

You will ascertain whether a Kept citizen of the Vigil would wake. If Kept, they would not sleep, and if they did not sleep, the god would not wake, and if the god did not wake, we should have kept our promise to it, which was only ever to keep watch.

If the Kept cannot leave Sallowreach, you will ascertain the price of Sallowreach.

We have not slept in three hundred years, Castellan. I find I no longer wish to be alive while I do not.

(signed with the Eye)

Bell sleeps. In the late afternoon, with her nudger's hand on her wrist, Bell tells them quietly that she would like to stop now. She asks them not to pinch her. She gives her dispatch case to the character she trusts most. She says the room with the eye is warm and has a floor you can lie down on and that she has wanted to lie down for twenty-six years. She closes her eyes. She does not open them. Her chest goes on rising and falling, very slowly, in a rhythm no one in the room can match. This is Dread 2, and for her nudger, Dread 3. The Seeming does not stop when she sleeps. It is the inn's now.



*It's warm. Oh, it's so warm. Don't pinch me. Please.
Just this once, don't.*

BELL LISLE, HER LAST WORDS

The reading. At dusk, Refrain Dole asks to see the ninth card again. Somebody must carry it to the stable; she will not go into the

common room. She holds it up to the lantern and reads the second stroke aloud as *Late*, and then she takes the page out of her boot and reads Meek Garrity's words to whoever is there, the drovers and the converts and the characters, in a flat voice, and folds the page away again.

"We're not the ones who said no," she says. "Six hundred years we've told you we said no. We're the ones who came after. The late ones. There was nothing left by the time we got up the hill. We'd have eaten it. We'd have eaten it same as you. That card's got my people's name on it. It's had it all along. It's just been waiting for one of us to turn up." She laughs, short, like a cough. "Late again. Story of the Fast."

It is not true. The card does not say *Late* in the sense she means; it is not for her or for her people. But it is the most convincing thing anyone at Thimble Cross has said in six days, and the room believes it, and so, almost, does she. That night, the consensus forms.

▼ ACT THREE: THE NINTH CHAIR (DAY SEVEN)

THE DEMAND

On the night of Day Six, or the morning of Tablenight, the inn meets in the common room around the Host's table, because there is nowhere else warm. The consensus builds out of every frightened voice in the house, and the Carver should let each speak:

- ◇ **Clemency** says the Host will pass a house that offers it a clean guest: a mouth with no god in it. The ninth card is for the empty one.
- ◇ **Brawn** says this is only the dusk roster by another name, and sound husbandry: feed the table one by choice and it will not take nine by force.
- ◇ **Vellum**, sworn and unbitted, says that a full table is a table the Host must come to sit at, and that she will pay any price to fill it, and says exactly why, which nobody hears, because nobody wants to.
- ◇ **Hepzibah** says the house cannot refuse a guest, and a chair laid empty in her house is a guest refused.
- ◇ **Ardent**, asked directly whether filling the ninth chair will spare the others, says, with terrible gentleness, "I don't know. Nobody has ever sat there." The room hears what it needs to.

The demand settles on Refrain, because she is Unfed, because she is caged, because she has said herself that the card bears her people's name, and because she belongs to nobody in the room. Kale will not give up his property for nothing; Vellum's note already binds him to deliver her to this table, and he would like, he says, to be paid twice. What follows is an auction in reverse: the frightened inn passes a hat for the price of a woman.

Handout: The Hat (a list kept by Warden Haverick, who was asked to hold the collection because his ledger cannot lie, and who could find no clause to refuse).

Subscribed at Thimble Cross, Tablenight morning, toward the price of the Unfed woman, R. Dole, payable to K. Dragoman, she to be seated.

H. Brawn, for the Board: one platter, sealed. (20)

V. Serrat: a sworn note, against her own flesh, for the balance, whatever it shall be.

The drovers of the late A. Crumm: his purse. (14 lacks, 6 crumbs)

Sister C. Voide: her basins, which were refused.

L. Trotter: a ribbon. Refused. Taken back. Offered again. Taken.

M. Sloe: nothing. Said she would not. Wept.

Mistress Thimble: the house's bread money. (2 lacks)

The guests: (the characters' names, and what they gave, or did not)

Total, as reckoned: sufficient.

Entered under Peace. God help me, entered under Peace.

Let the characters choose whether to pay, to refuse, to fight, or to offer someone else, themselves included. Whatever they choose, write it into the Hat.

IF THE PLAYERS FIGHT THE DEMAND

They may. Freeing Refrain from the cage and holding the stable against Kale's men and Clemency's converts is a fine, desperate scene (see Combat Encounters). It changes nothing that matters. If Refrain is free, she listens to the room arguing over who else should go: Merrit, whose card is on the table; Dorcas, who has asked to; a character. And she walks into the common room on her own feet, with her axe over her shoulder, and sits down in the ninth chair. "Not because you asked," she says. "Because I'm the only one here who knows how to sit at that table and still mean no." If the players have kept her caged and treated her as stock, she is dragged to the chair instead, by drovers who will not meet her eyes, and that is worse.

OTHER VOLUNTEERS

If Refrain is dead, gone, or the players have made another figure the heart of the story, the volunteer is whoever they love most. Merrit Sloe volunteers because her card is already on the table and she reckons she might as well sit in a better chair. Dorcas Thimble volunteers because the ninth chair is the one place on earth her oath cannot follow her. Haverick volunteers, in the Company's form, because a warden who gives himself keeps the peace by definition. A player character may volunteer; let them, and let it cost exactly what it costs everyone else. Never force a character into the chair.

THE SACRIFICE

At dusk on Tablenight the volunteer is washed, as the Fast washes its dead, standing, in cold water, by someone who does not speak; Hepzibah lays a clean napkin over their arm. Ardent, who cannot

refuse to help lay a table, draws the ninth chair out from the table for the first time in six hundred and forty years. It makes a small sound on the flags. Everyone in the room makes a Dread 2 check.

Refrain does not thank it. She sits down in it the way a woman sits down in a surgeon's chair, all at once, with her jaw set, and lays her axe across her knees. Nothing happens. The bread steams. The lamps burn. Somebody laughs, high and frightened, and stops. Refrain looks at the plate in front of her, which is empty, and says, "No, thank you," and then again, and then a third time, and her voice cracks on the third, because the smell of the bread is coming up off the empty plate and she has been hungry her whole life. She does not say it a fourth time. Her hand is shaking on the axe. Ardent, in the corner, has begun to untie his apron, very slowly, with his eyes shut, as though he has been told he may. Outside, the marbling across the yard begins, very slowly, to melt, in a long dark path from the north gate to the door.

THE HOST

At midnight the Host comes, as it was always going to.

The door opens without a hand on it. The room goes warm all at once, warm as a kitchen on baking day, and every hungry person in it feels their mouth flood. Something stoops in the doorway, too tall for it, and comes in. Nobody sees its face. Characters who try to look straight at it see only the impression of a broad, kind, bending shape, an apron, enormous patient hands, and the light of the lamps leaning toward it. To be in the presence of the Host is a Dread 4 check; to look for its face is Dread 5. Every character must also make an Invitation check (Grim 18, or Dire 22 within reach of their own chair) to keep from walking to their own place and sitting down, and Refrain's Gift may help one of them.

The Host goes first to the ninth chair. It stands over the volunteer for a long moment. Then, gently, the way you would lift a

sleeping child from a chair that belonged to a grandparent, it lifts them out. It is not angry. It is something like sorry.

Ardent, in the corner, with his apron half untied, whispers, "Oh. Oh, no. That isn't anybody's. It's not for sitting in." And ties his apron again.

The Host pushes the ninth chair back in, square to the table, its back to the lamp. Then it lays another place. The table is a little longer than it was. There is a new plate, a new chair pulled out a hand's width, and a new card in a fine round hand, and the name on it is the volunteer's, and the handwriting is their mother's. The volunteer reads it. Their face changes. They sit down at their own place, and lift the empty fork, and put it in their mouth, and close their eyes.

"Oh," says Refrain Dole, who broke two hundred and six tables, who never once in her life ate until she was full. "Oh, it's bread. It's just bread. It's warm. Why did nobody tell me it was just bread?" She is crying. She is smiling. She takes another bite of nothing. The axe slides off her knees and rings on the flags and she does not look down. "You should sit down," she says to you, kindly, with her mouth full. "There's enough. I didn't know there would be enough."

Watching this is Dread 4. It is the moment the players understand the sacrifice bought nothing. Any character who paid into the Hat, carried the volunteer to the chair, or argued for the choosing faces Dread 5 instead: knowing that what you did changed nothing. The ninth chair is still empty. Their own cards are still on the table. The Host turns, warm and patient, toward the rest of the room, and the invitation stands. Outside, at the edges of the dark path, the marbling is still hungry, and the Reaping will take anyone who flees across it alone before dawn. Nothing has changed except that there is one more guest at the table, and she is happy, and she will be happy for a hundred years.

I DIDN'T KNOW THERE WOULD BE ENOUGH.

[REFRAIN DOLE, SEATED, TABLENIGHT 641]

From here, play out the night. Each hour until dawn, every character inside the inn makes an Invitation check to stay out of their chair; Seated NPCs call to them by name; the hungry and the Seemed walk past them to sit. The Host does not compel anyone. It only waits, and lays more food, and is kind.

TABLENIGHT, MINUTE BY MINUTE

The table below is the long night as it falls if the characters do nothing to bend it. Times are by the toll-house clock, which Haverick winds at every ledger entry; from midnight it runs slow, losing a minute in every five, so that by dawn it is nearly an hour behind the sun, and nobody notices until they look outside. Use it as a spine. Move events, drop them, or let the characters break them;

but keep the clock visible, and read the time aloud whenever it changes.

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS	ROLLS AND NOTES
3:30	The volunteer is washed in the kitchen, standing, in cold water	Witnesses: Dread 1. Merrit holds the towel
4:00	The house gathers in the common room; lamps lit at head and foot	The marbling creeps over the common-room boards
4:12	Sunset. The yard goes still	Anyone outside alone: the Reaping begins
4:20	Ardent draws out the ninth chair	Dread 2, all present
4:21	The volunteer sits. Nothing happens	Ardent begins to untie his apron
4:30	“No, thank you,” three times. Not a fourth	Unfed present gain 1 Want
4:45	The dark path melts from the north gate to the door, steaming	The path is safe ground until dawn
5:02	Full dark. On any other night the Reaping would end here. Tonight it does not	Brawn closes his little book, then opens it again
5:30	Hepzibah sets the pine tables for the dead and serves them nothing	Seeming check (Hard 14) each hour from now
6:00	Vellum unwraps her silver carving set and lays it out at her place	Clause or Persuade to stop her: she cannot lie about why
6:40	Brawn eats from a notched barrel at the hearth, slowly, all of it	Dread 2 to watch. Laden Taste for anyone who joins him
7:00	Envoy Lowell (if present) reads the numbers of each house aloud	Each character hears their line’s figure: Dread 1
7:18	Brawn, hearing his line’s figure, stabs the Envoy with a Host’s fork	Dread 2; Haverick’s Wear: a broken finger
8:00	The first hourly Invitation check for everyone not yet Seated	Grim 18; Dire 22 within reach of a chair
8:30	Gus Haslet and Tam Pettie sit, together, holding hands	Dread 2. The table lengthens
9:00	Clemency, cramping, purges herself at the table’s head, then a convert	Dread 2. She asks a character to hold her hair
9:40	Merrit stands at the west window and will not come away	Caul + Resolve or Tongue + Persuade to bring her back
10:00	Bell, asleep by the wall, sighs once and her breathing changes	Her nudger: Dread 2
10:30	The smell of bread reaches every room, even the stable	Routine 10 Invitation check, everywhere in the house
11:00	Haverick makes his last ledger entry and dates the line <i>Warden relieved</i>	He asks a character to witness it
11:30	Every window fogs at once, from outside	Dread 2. Something very tall is counting the chairs
11:52	All the lamps lean, flames bent toward the door	Hepzibah stands and smooths her apron
12:00	The door opens. The Host comes in	Dread 4; Dread 5 to look for its face
12:01	Invitation checks for all, at once	Refrain’s Gift may help one character
12:03	The Host stands over the ninth chair	Ardent’s hands still on his apron strings
12:04	It lifts the volunteer out. “Oh. Oh, no.”	Ardent ties his apron again
12:06	Another place laid; the table longer	The card in the volunteer’s mother’s hand
12:08	The volunteer sits at their own place and eats air, weeping, smiling	Dread 4; Dread 5 for any who chose them
12:15	Hepzibah sits at her card, first of the Thimbles	Dorcas: Caul + Resolve or follow her mother
12:30	Linus sits beside his mother, and is at peace	Dorcas alone of the blood still standing
12:45	Kale asks the Host, three times, whether it would like anything	It lays him a place. He sits, to be polite
1:00	Hourly Invitation check. The Seated begin calling names	Grim 18; each Seated friend who calls: another check
1:30	Vellum carves (see below)	Dread 3; the first slice
2:00	Hourly check. Clemency sits, emptied, and is surprised to be fed	The table is longer than the room by twenty feet
2:40	Brawn, unable to bear the warmth, walks out into the yard alone	Off the dark path: the field takes him, slowly
3:00	Hourly check. Ardent speaks to the character who has refused him best	The offer of Relief (Ending Two)

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS	ROLLS AND NOTES
4:00	Hourly check. The coldest hour outside; the warmest in	Dorcas goes to the boundary stones, or sits
5:00	Hourly check. Merrit's last count, called down through the floor	The Seated answer, cheerfully, every one
6:00	Hourly check. Haverick fails the peace. He goes quietly into the toll house	Dread 2 for anyone who follows
7:00	Hourly check. The hungriest hour. Even the Unfed smell their mothers' kitchens	+2 Difficulty this hour only
7:48	Dawn. The warmth goes out of the air all at once	The Host is gone. The table is not
7:50	The marbling melts to a yellow slush and runs away down the road	The inn is silent but for cutlery

Vellum carves. At half past one, Lady Vellum Serrat rises from her place with her silver carving knife and fork, walks to the Host, and asks it, plainly, without a single condition, whether she may. It inclines its great head. She sets the fork into the warm dark where its hand rests on the back of a chair, and draws the knife, and the knife goes in like a knife into a new loaf, and comes away with a slice. The slice is bread. It is warm. She carries it, bleeding from the tongue, down the long table to the place card that says *Casimir Hollowe-Vane*, where nobody is sitting, and lays it on his empty plate, and her oath is kept. Then she looks at the Host, and understands at last that being carved is the only thing it has ever wanted, and she laughs, through the blood, and sits down at her own place to eat. Witnessing this is Dread 3. The Second Table has been sending its knives to the wrong god's house for twenty years.



Oh. Oh, it wants it. It always wanted it. We have been fighting to be let in at a door it was holding open.

LADY VELLUM SERRAT, AT HALF PAST ONE

▼ COMBAT ENCOUNTERS

The Gleanings (Day Four, dusk). Six figures come out of the marbled yard to the windows and doors: field-grown things shaped like the Reaped, with root-tangled feet, smooth rind for skin, and the faces of Walt Sallow, Robb Hayle, Old Mother Ivy and others, eyes closed. They knock and ask to come in. If refused, they press against the glass until it bows, and come through. They fight to drag the living out onto the marbled ground at dusk. They are destroyed when their face is cut away; what is left smells of bread and sap, and under the rind there is a grain like the inside of a turnip, and in the middle of each, curled, a small hard knot that is nearly a tooth.

GLEANING Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +5 (root-grip 3; on a hit the target is held and dragged one step toward marbled ground each round, Gut + Athletics Hard 14 to break free) · Armor 1 · Dread 2 (3 if it wears a face the viewer knew)

The Stable (Day Six or Seven). Freeing Refrain means facing Kale and his two men, and, after Day Four, three of Clemency's converts who want her for the chair. Kale fights to disable, not kill:

Dorcas at the stones. At four, if she has not been helped, Dorcas Thimble walks out of the inn along the dark path, and then off it, across the melting white, to the boundary stones at the Bend, with her law-books in a sack on her back. If no one goes with her, she is alone on marbled ground in the dark, and the field may have her before the charter does; if someone goes with her, the field leaves her be. At the stones she stops and looks back once at the inn, all its windows golden, all its chimneys smoking for the first time in two hundred years, and then she steps over. What happens next depends on what the characters have done for her (see Endings and After the Snow). If they have done nothing, it is the charter, and it is very bad, and she does it anyway, and she walks on a little way afterward, which is not possible, and then sits down in the road facing south, away from the light.

dead Blanks sell for a quarter. He uses the net first and the cosh second. If outmatched he surrenders and offers to sell the characters something, and then, if they will not buy, to cook for them. On Day Six or later, the oxen in the stable may join in, standing up on two legs in their stalls when nobody is looking straight at them; use their quick line, and let them fight anyone who is turned away.

The Smokehouse (Day Five, night). Clemency and four converts, armed with lancets. Clemency does not stop preaching while she fights. Each round, one convert who hears her and is not attacked that round must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or keep fighting even at Ruin. If Casimir is freed and ungloved, he can end the fight with a touch, and the touch will end more than he means; he knows it, and he will ask a character to choose for him.

The Cellar (Day Four, night). Linus, grieving and terrible, with the cleaver, between the characters and his father's body. Talking him down (Tongue + Persuade, Grim 18) ends the fight; a Grace gets the cleaver handed over, handle first, and Linus says "thank

you” and then, appalled, “I shouldn’t have said that, should I? Not here.”

The Seated (Tablenight). Anyone who tries to drag a Seated person from their chair must beat them in an opposed Gut + Brawl; the Seated cling with a terrible gentle strength and do not stop smiling. A Seated person dragged free dies within the hour, of all

their hunger arriving at once, and spends the hour asking to be allowed back.

SEATED GUEST OF THIMBLE CROSS Threat 0 · Flesh 3 · Guard 8 · Attack none (clings, Gut + Brawl 6 to hold) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 (Dread 3 when they all turn and look); each call by name forces an Invitation check at Routine 10

▼ CLUES AND WHAT THEY REVEAL

CLUE	WHERE	ROLL	WHAT IT REVEALS
Notches under the stamp	The yard	Eye + Search, Hard 14	Thirteen barrels are different
Heavy barrels	The yard	Reckoning 2+, or a Fatlander	Notched barrels are a fifth over weight
Warm staves at night	The yard	Caul + Instinct, Hard 14	Something in them is not quite dead
The manifest	Abel’s wagon	none	The far-field barrels; Robb Hayle; Stockpot’s stamp
Abel’s note	The cold store	none	What is in the barrels; why he died
The lantern among the stones	The graveyard, Day One night	Eye + Search, Hard 14	Absalom digging up his mother
The kitchen book	The kitchen drawer	Eye + Search, Routine 10	The pottage recipe, and the ring
The gold ring in the pot	The kitchen	Grace on examining the meat	The pottage; Absalom’s crime
The spade and the folded shroud	The graveyard	none	Ivy was dug up from above
Breathing hollows in the coffins	The graveyard	Dread 2	The marbling eats from below
The reversed <i>Welcome</i>	Hadley’s grave	none	The field has tasted the founder
The charter and the Opinion of 488	The parlour	none	The clause; the blood kept narrow
The family register	The parlour bureau	Eye + Search, Routine 10	The Thimble blood, without a word said
Dorcas’s skeleton diagram	Dorcas’s room	Eye + Lore, Routine 10	What crossing the stones would cost her
Brawn’s little book	His waistcoat	Hand + Filch, Grim 18	The field is being fed by name
The dusk roster	The common-room door	none	Who Brawn thinks is worth least
Fork badge with two tines	Kale’s lapel	Eye + Search, Hard 14	His buyer is the Second Table
Vellum’s carving set and tape	Her luggage	Hand + Filch, Hard 14	She means to carve a god
The letter from Wont Bellamy	Vellum’s luggage	Eye + Lore, Hard 14 to understand	The Second Table has a friend in the Abstinent
Casimir’s unsent letter	His left glove	none	His name, his hands, what he hoped
Bell’s dispatch	Bell’s case	none	The Vigil’s offer to Sallowreach
The page in Refrain’s boot	Refrain	her trust	Garrity’s heresy: the Unfed were late
Haverick’s ledger	The toll house	none	The true count; his Wear; <i>Warden relieved</i>
The tureen	The Host’s table	Dread 1	Each smells their own childhood
The table’s length	The common room	Eye + Reckoning, Hard 14	It is longer than the room
Clemency’s new card	The Host’s table	none	Blasphemy makes you a guest
Ardent’s nine keys	His belt	Eye + Search, Hard 14	One key fits no door he has ever found
The ninth card	The table	Eye + Lore, Grim 18	A name nobody here bears

▼ ENDINGS

None of these endings is happy. Some are survivable. Whatever happens, describe the dawn: the warmth going out of the air at once, like a door shut on a kitchen; the marbling slumping into a stinking yellow slush and running away down the Rim Road in rivulets; the sound, from inside the inn, of cutlery on china, which does not stop.

ENDING ONE: NO, THANK YOU

The characters refuse. They take Refrain's lesson and turn their backs on the table, and, discovering that the dark, warm path the Host walked in on is the one stretch of ground the Reaping cannot touch, they go out and stand on it, outdoors, with their backs to every door, from midnight until dawn, as the Unfed do on Tablenight. Behind them, through the open door, they hear the Seated praising the food, calling their names, asking why they will not come in. Each hour, a Dread 3 check, and an Invitation check at Grim 18 when a voice they love calls. Let them hold hands. Let them say the Decline together, aloud, every hour, and let the Unfed among them lead it.

At dawn the warmth goes out of the air and the marbling melts and the inn is silent but for the cutlery. Inside, at a table now seventeen places long, sit everyone who could not refuse: the Thimbles first, because they never could. The characters survive. Thimble Cross becomes a little Long Table, and the Company strikes it from the ledger.

You turn round when the sun is up, because the Unfed say you may. Through the open door the common room is full of light. They are all there. They look well. Refrain lifts her empty fork to you in salute, and her eyes are bright, and her mouth is full of nothing, and she says, "You're letting the cold in."

ENDING TWO: THE STEWARD'S APRON

A character speaks to Ardent through the long night and learns that he can be relieved. He describes the position fairly. He does not hide the hours. If a character accepts it, in so many words, Ardent takes off his apron and folds it and hands it over, with the nine keys and the box of cutlery, and weeps with relief, and sits down at the table himself, at a place that was always there and that nobody noticed was his. His card is in a child's hand, very large, the letters uneven. He reads it and puts it in his breast pocket, and lifts his fork. At dawn the new steward walks north up the Hungry Lane a mile ahead of something tall and warm, and does not come back. The character becomes an NPC. The Host, now, has a steward who knows the players' names, and who writes their cards in a hand they will recognise. Everyone else at the inn who was not Seated survives.



Will you be joining the Host this evening? No? No, of course. I'll just set the place, in case.

WHAT THE NEW STEWARD SAYS, AT THE NEXT TABLE
THE CHARACTERS FIND

ENDING THREE: THE LONG TABLE

The characters sit. Perhaps the Seeming has them; perhaps the Laden Taste; perhaps they are simply tired, and cold, and it is just bread. It is the warmest night of their lives. They will be lucid for months. They will describe each course to the next travellers who reach Thimble Cross, and to the ones after that. This ending is a gentle total party loss, and players who choose it with open eyes should be allowed to. Play the First Course for a scene, as the Fast chapter describes: let each player describe what they are eating, and who is sitting beside them, and what they say. Then let the next session, if there is one, be played by new characters, arriving at Thimble Cross in Grace, finding the old ones at the table, and being invited.

ENDING FOUR: ASHES AND TABLECLOTH

The characters burn it down: the table, the common room, the inn, the Seated in their chairs, who do not get up and do not stop smiling and go on praising the food as the cloth catches. The smell is roasting, and then bread, and then something no one will ever describe. The Thimble charter breaks with the house, and so do the last Thimbles who are not already at table, their bodies folding and snapping in the yard as the blood fails to endure; Haverick, failing to keep the peace, breaks too, quietly, in the toll house, having written *relieved* in the ledger beforehand. The characters run south across melting marbling at dawn, and the field takes one more of them if it can. Burning the Seated is Dread 4, and an oath on the dead sworn by anyone present is broken by it. They survive. At the next crossroads down the Rim Road, two days later, there is a table, laid, with their names on the cards.

ENDING FIVE: THE STRUCK LINE

A rarer ending, for groups who have spent their time on the Thimbles, and one that completes only in *After the Snow*. If the characters keep Dorcas out of her chair through Tablenight, standing with her on the dark path or holding her by the door while her mother and brother sit, and then find her exit clause (the Company's striking of the station ends the charter's object; see *The Charter*), she waits a month at the inn for the courier from Quillhouse. Then, on a cold clear morning in the last of Lack, she

walks out between the boundary stones and nothing breaks. She stands in the road and touches her own face, her own collarbones, her own wrists, counting, the way she counted on her diagram. Then she turns and looks at the inn where her mother and brother sit at the table, and the oath she swore on her father’s body comes

due. It was sworn on Fatlands ground, and it is broken: from now on she tastes her father in every meal. She eats anyway. She goes south to Sated to read law. She does not come back.

WHAT BECOMES OF THEM

PERSON	IF UNCHECKED	IF HELPED
Hepzibah	Seated first	Seated; she will not be helped
Linus	Seated, at peace	Seated, or lives, broken, mute, a farrier on the Rim
Dorcas	Broken by the charter at the stones	Free (Ending Five), haunted by her oath
Haverick	Fails the peace at dawn	Relieved by the Company, alive, his body a map of Wear
Brawn	Reaped at 2:40	Arrested at the inquest; the Board wants him back
Kale	Seated, to be polite	Lives; offers the characters dinner, three times
Refrain	The ninth chair, then her own	Seated, happy, unless another volunteers
Vellum	Carves, and is fed	Lives, sworn, tongue split, measuring
Clemency	Seated, emptied	Hanged by the converts she failed, or flees west
Merrit	Walks west at dawn	Lives; keeps the count wherever she goes
Bell	Sleeps on, never wakes	Never wakes; her dispatch goes on in other hands
Ardent	Walks on, more tired	Relieved (Ending Two), Seated at last

▼ THE CARVER'S TALLY: DREAD AND FRAY, SCENE BY SCENE

Use this table to pace the pressure. “Expected” is what an average character (Caul + Resolve 5) loses if they witness everything: about

half of all checks fail. Most characters will miss some scenes and suffer others twice; adjust as the table tells you.

DAY	SCENE	DREAD	WHO CHECKS	NOTES
One	Walt Reaped in the yard	3 (Fatlanders 2)	all who watch	Pulling him free costs Flesh
One	Absalom in the open grave	2	the wakeful	Few will see it
Two	Your own card, a loved hand	2 (3 if dead)	every character	Plus an Invitation check, Hard 14
Two	Nib on the dusk ground	3	those who watch	None if they stand with him
Two	Looking in barrel 31	3	the curious	
Three	Abel in the cold store; Oona with him	2	finders	Session one ends near Fray 4 to 6
Three	The notched barrels thrown open	3	all present	Eating them knowingly: 3
Three	Oona on the marbled ground	3	those who watch	None if they talk her home
Three	Ardent understood	3	all who speak with him	
Four	The open graves	2; 3 if understood	the first out	The pottage revealed: 3
Four	Clemency’s blasphemy	2	the common room	
Four	The Gleanings	2; 3 for a known face	defenders	
Four	Linus kills his father	3	those who follow	
Four	The oath on the dead	2	those who understand	

DAY	SCENE	DREAD	WHO CHECKS	NOTES
Five	The Ninefold Purge	3	the smokehouse	
Five	Vellum speaking plainly	1	anyone addressed	Each time, once per scene
Six	The Seeming	3, hourly	the common room	Contagious; <i>I am already at the table</i>
Six	Bell sleeps	2 (nudger 3)	those present	Session two ends near Fray 7 to 9
Seven	The ninth chair drawn out	2	all	
Seven	Brawn eats a barrel / the Envoy stabbed	2	those present	
Seven	The Host enters	4 (5 to seek its face)	all	Contagion now at Dread 3
Seven	The volunteer lifted out and Seated	4 (5 for the choosers)	all	The heart of the adventure
Seven	Vellum carves	3	all	
Seven	Each hour until dawn	Invitation, Grim 18	all unseated	Dire 22 within reach of a chair
Seven	Ending One, each hour outdoors	3	those on the path	
Seven	Burning the Seated	4	the burners	Ending Four

Expect at least one character to Break on Tablenight. When it happens, slow down. Let the player describe it. Call for the contagion checks. If the Break is The Pull, remember the Host is in

the room, and that the Pull, tonight, has a chair at the end of it; give their companions every chance to reach them.

▼ SESSION FOUR (OPTIONAL): AFTER THE SNOW

The thaw at the Bend came on the morning after Tablenight, all at once, as though somebody had opened a kitchen door. It ran yellow in the ruts for three days. The birds would not drink it.

— COMPANY RELIEF REPORT, THIMBLE CROSS, LACK 641

This optional fourth session is the aftermath: the morning after, and the week that follows, when the road opens and the world comes up it to ask what happened. It is quieter than the three before it, and it should be. It is about grief, blame, what the survivors are willing to say, and what the Table does with a story like this. It plays well in three or four hours, and it gives the players a chance to see their choices land.

THE YELLOW THAW

The cold comes back with the light. It is ordinary cold, sharp and clean, and it is the best thing you have ever felt. Across

the yard the white has slumped into a yellow slush the colour of old dripping, and it is running, in a hundred little rivulets, south, down the ruts of the Rim Road, toward home. Where it has gone the cobbles are bare and wet and steaming faintly. The smell is rendering-yards and spoilt milk. Behind you, through the door, someone at the table is laughing at something someone else has said, and a knife is going steadily against a plate.

The marbling takes three days to drain away. As it goes, it leaves things behind. Roll 1d10, or choose, whenever a character walks the yard, the road or the graveyard during the thaw.

D10	WHAT THE THAW UNCOVERS
1	A drover's boot, laced, with nothing in it but a little warm dough
2	Brawn's little book, face down in the slush, every page readable (see Threads)
3	A row of small hard knots in the mud, like teeth, in the shape of a person lying down
4	Walt Sallow's two-fingered glove, folded, on the toll-house step
5	A wagon wheel grown through with pale root, which will not turn
6	A patch of yard that stays warm and dry, the size of a large hand, palm down
7	Old Mother Ivy's wedding shoes, side by side at the graveyard gate
8	A place card, sodden, with a drover's name on it; the drover is still alive
9	An ox, on four legs, standing in the road facing south, refusing to move, weeping
10	Nothing. Bare wet stone. That is somehow the worst

THE COUNT OF THE LIVING

The session opens the way every day at Thimble Cross has opened: with the count. If Merrit lives, she calls it, and her voice cracks on the first name. If not, a character must, and they will need her charcoal list. Call every name. The Seated answer, cheerfully, from the common room, through the floor: "Here! Here, love. Come down, there's plenty." The dead do not. Make the players write the list themselves this time: who is alive, who is at table, who is gone. Keep it. It becomes evidence.

THE SEATED AT TABLE

The table stays. The Host has gone on down the road, or up the Hungry Lane, but the table stays, and the Seated stay at it, and they are well. They can talk. They are lucid and kind and delighted to see the characters every time. They describe each course in loving detail, and a character who listens too long (more than a few minutes, or more than once a day) makes an Invitation check at Hard 14 and gains 1 Hunger whether they pass or not.

Let the players visit. Let them ask Refrain whether it was worth it, and let her say, with her mouth full, that she does not understand

the question. Let Hepzibah ask after the linen. Let Linus tell a character, very calmly, that he has forgiven himself, and that his father has forgiven him, and that his father is sitting right there, and point at an empty chair that is not empty to him. Anyone who tries to feed a Seated guest real food finds that they cannot swallow it; they only smile and say they are full, for the first time in their lives, full, and isn't it wonderful.

LAND	WHAT THE DEAD ARE OWED	AT THIMBLE CROSS
Sallowreach	Closing, or Keeping	Casimir's hands, in the basin, still close things
The Fatlands	A wake, and to be eaten well	The drovers ask; there is nothing to eat but him
Brinehollow	The weighted rope and the water	Merrit asks to carry Bell to the nearest stream
The Vigil	To be watched until they are cold	Bell is not cold, and never will be
Cradlewrack	An open door, so the soul is not stuck	Clemency's converts open every door in the inn
Oathen	Silence for a day	Haverick cannot keep it; he must enter them all
The Fast	Face down, unmarked, no table	The Thimbles' stones say <i>Kept</i>

THE RIDERS COME

On the third day after Tablenight, with the road open, the Company sends a relief party up from the south, and it is not alone. Four interests arrive within a day of each other, each wanting a different story.

- ◇ **Under-Warden Tamsin Greaves of the Rim Road Company**, with six Company guards and a sealed instruction: relieve Warden Haverick, inventory the station, and determine whether the blood of Thimble endures. The Company would very much like it not to. She is brisk, decent and frightened of the common room, and will not go in.
- ◇ **Magistrate Odile Fenwick of the Vigil**, sleepless, twitching, with two nudgers and a warrant: she has come for Courier Lisle and the dispatch. She will hold an inquest into the convoy, because a Vigil-bound cargo came to grief here, and because she wants to know who knew about the notches. "If there is a notch," she says, "there is a man who knew. Find the man."
- ◇ **Clerk-Assessor Marrow Fettle of the Board of Plenty**, enormous, smiling, carried in a litter by four men, come to recover Cullmaster Brawn, his little book, and every barrel, notched or not. He will say wolves. He will say it to anyone, about anything.
- ◇ **Ledger-Woman Corra Dripp of the Renderers' Union**, sent by Mistress Brisket Annalow, thin for a Fatlander, with a second ledger of her own. She wants Abel Crumm's note, and she wants the notched barrels counted in front of witnesses, and she has not decided whether she wants them hidden or shown.

BURYING AND NOT BURYING

There are dead to see to, and seven lands' worth of opinions about how. The Fatlanders want a wake, which means eating the dead with the best plates, as is decent. The Unfed want them face down in unmarked ground. Sallowreach folk want them Kept, or at least closed. Brinehollow folk want them weighted and sunk, and there is no sea. The Thimbles' graveyard is broken open, and the field has eaten from it. Let the characters argue, and decide, and live with what they decide.

COMPANY GUARD Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (sword 4, or crossbow 4) · Armor 3 · Dread 0

BOARD LITTER-MAN Threat 2 · Flesh 14 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (cudgel 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

THE INQUEST

Magistrate Fenwick holds her inquest in the toll house, because it is the only room in Thimble Cross with no table in it. Every surviving character is called. Each faction has a version it wants entered, and the characters' testimony decides which.

Handout: From the Record of the Inquest at Thimble Cross (Vigil form; the clerk's hand grows smaller as the day goes on).

MAGISTRATE: You were present when the barrels were opened.

WITNESS: Yes.

MAGISTRATE: What was in them?

WITNESS: (inaudible)

MAGISTRATE: Louder, for the clerk.

WITNESS: People. Bits of people. A boy's arm. His uncle paid for the tattoo.

CLERK-ASSESSOR FETTLE: The Board notes that wolves are known in the region.

MAGISTRATE: There are no wolves in the Fatlands, Assessor.

CLERK-ASSESSOR FETTLER: *This is not the Fatlands, Magistrate. This is the Rim. Anything might be on the Rim.*

MAGISTRATE: *Entered. Witness, did you eat from the barrels?*

WITNESS: *(long pause)*

MAGISTRATE: *The witness need not answer. The witness has answered. Entered.*

Run the inquest as a scene of testimony, cross-examination and pressure. Each faction will offer the characters something for the version it wants: the Company a clean bill and passage north; the Board a purse and a forgetting; the Union a job and a second ledger; the Vigil only the truth, entered. A character who lies to the inquest must beat Magistrate Fenwick's Eye + Search (she rolls at +6) with Tongue + Deceive; Haverick, if he lives, cannot lie at all, and his ledger is evidence. The outcome:

WHAT THE CHARACTERS SAY	WHAT IS ENTERED	WHAT FOLLOWS
The truth, all of it	The notches, the Dusk Acres, Brawn's book	The Board sends someone for the characters by Grace
The truth, but not the eating	The notches; the witnesses' silence	Fenwick knows; she lets it lie, and remembers
Wolves	Wolves	Corra Dripp quietly hires the characters, or curses them
Nothing at all	An open verdict	Every faction assumes the worst of them

THE CHARTER

Under-Warden Greaves has a question the Company needs answered: does the blood of Thimble endure? If it does, the station remains the Thimbles', and the Company may strike it only with a keeper's consent; if not, the charter lapses and the Company may close the inn. The Seated Thimbles are alive, and cannot be asked anything they will answer except about the food. Dorcas, if she lives, is the last keeper standing. A character with Clause 2+ who has read the charter can see what Dorcas, in fifteen years of reading, could not, because she was looking for a way out of the oath and not a way out of the house: the clause binds *the keepers of Thimble Cross*. If the station is surrendered and struck from the Company's ledger, there is no Thimble Cross, and there are no keepers of it, and the clause has no object (Tongue + Clause, Grim 18, to argue it before Greaves; Hard 14 with Dorcas's books and Haverick's witness). Dorcas need only sign the surrender. The Company is delighted to take it. That is Dorcas's exit clause: the Company's own greed. The striking must be carried to Quillhouse and sworn before she can cross, which takes a month by courier; until then she must wait at the inn, beside the table, where her mother and brother call to her every evening. Her oath on her father's body remains (see Ending Five).



There it was. Two hundred and thirty-nine years, and the door was in the Company's pocket the whole time. They only had to want the house more than they wanted us.

DORCAS THIMBLE, AFTER THE INQUEST

LEAVING

The road is open. The characters can go south, toward the Fatlands, past the place where the marbling drained away into the hedges and the hedges have turned, very faintly, pink; north up the Hungry Lane into the Fast, where the ground is warm in long footprints; or west along the Rim toward the Vigil, carrying a dispatch and a note and a little book. Ask each player where their character goes, and what they carry, and whose card they keep.

At the bend, where the boundary stones are, you look back once. Seventeen chimneys, and every one of them smoking. You have never seen that. Nobody has. Through the west windows, gold in the low sun, you can see the long table and the people at it, small at this distance, passing the bread. One of them raises a hand. You do not know who. You do not wave back. You turn into the wind, which smells of nothing, of cold, of road, and you walk.

PORTIONS FOR AFTER THE SNOW

Award 4 to 8 Portions: 2 for the session; 1 for testimony that cost the character something; 1 for seeing to the dead in a way that honoured them; 1 for freeing Dorcas or keeping Haverick alive; 1 for leaving Thimble Cross without looking back more than once.

▼ AFTERMATH

Survivors leave Thimble Cross changed. Award each surviving character a **Mark of the Laid Place**: from now on, whenever they enter a house where a meal is being served, they know, without looking, how many chairs are at the table, and which one is pushed in. Characters who ate from the notched barrels keep the Laden Taste until they spend a session's Portions to be rid of it, or never. Characters who Broke keep their Derangements; the most fitting here are *I am already at the table*, *The barrels are saying grace* (treat as **The Voice at Table**, in the voices of fields), and *Everyone I love has been replaced by someone politer* (treat as **The Impostors**).

Characters who swore oaths at Thimble Cross carry them on. An oath sworn before Haverick in the Company's form still binds, faintly, through Jessamy Quill. An oath sworn on the dead at Thimble Cross was sworn on Fatlands ground, and if broken, its Visitation is the Fatlands' own: the dead are tasted in every meal.

PORTIONS

Award **5 to 10 Portions** per core session, using these guidelines:

- ◇ 2 for surviving the session.
- ◇ 1 for each major secret uncovered (the barrels, the pottage, the charter, the Second Table's purpose, the dispatch, the ninth chair).
- ◇ 1 to 2 for standing beside someone on the marbled ground at dusk, or keeping Bell Lisle awake an hour longer, or any act of costly decency.
- ◇ 1 for refusing the table's food when starving.
- ◇ 1 for a moment of play the whole table will remember.
- ◇ In the final session, 2 more for being present when the sacrifice fails, whatever the character did.

THREADS: WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

- ◇ **The Host on the Road.** Orrum no longer waits for its steward. If a character became the steward, the next adventure can begin with the other characters finding a table laid by someone they know, with cards in a hand they know. If not, Ardent walks on, more tired than before, and the Hostwatch will want to hear everything. Spare Tolland, a mile behind the god, reaches the inn two days after Tablenight and sits on the toll-house step for an hour without speaking.

- ◇ **The Blank Trade.** Kale's Second Table buyer is waiting in the Vigil and was paid half in advance. Dr. Mercy Thrane would very much like to see the badge, and the book of hers Kale carries with grease-pencil in the margins.
- ◇ **The Deadwatch.** Bell Lisle's dispatch, carried by a character, is the Warden-Prime's offer to buy the secret of Keeping. It is addressed to Castellán Dray in Lastgate, and he is waiting for it, and part of him hopes it never comes.
- ◇ **The Second Table.** Vellum Serrat, if she lives, is sworn on the dead to carve the Host, and her tongue will not let her rest. She knows Wont Bellamy. She has measurements. If she was Seated, the Second Table will send someone to find out why its widow has not written, and what she found.
- ◇ **Eight Chairs.** The ninth card can be carried away; it is cold and damp and never dries. Cray Lobbett, Meek Garrity and Grandfather Peat would each give anything to see it. Hollow Ann Pruett, the card-keeper of the Fast, has one like it, and will want to lay them side by side. Nobody should tell them who it might be for.
- ◇ **The Long Count.** Brawn's little book of dusk names is the Board's own tally of the Reaping, kept by the Department in its own hand. Pell Hogget would weep to have it. The Board would kill to get it back. Clerk-Assessor Fettle has already begun to ask, pleasantly, who picked it up out of the slush.
- ◇ **The Struck Line.** If Dorcas Thimble walked free, she is in Sated reading law, and tasting her father in every meal, and she has started to write to the characters about other charters, sworn badly, in other inns.
- ◇ **Thimble Cross in Grace.** The Company has struck it. The Seated are still there. In spring, pilgrims from the Fatlands, Osanna Blythe's people, begin to come up the road to it, because they have heard there is a table at the Bend where you finally feel full.

Entered in the station ledger of Thimble Cross, Tablenight, 641 A.G., in a hand that is not the warden's.

Guests: all.

Stores: sufficient.

Warden: relieved.

Ninth place: laid. Unclaimed.



CHAPTER 18

SECRETS OF THE TABLE

Eight gods. Seven peoples. Six meals and one refusal. The arithmetic does not close.

– MARGINAL NOTE IN THE MASTER CONCORDANCE AT QUIRE, IN THE
ARCHPROVOST'S HAND

PLAYERS, STOP HERE

This chapter is for the Game Master alone. It answers the questions the rest of the book refuses to: who the Eighth was, why the Providers held still, what really happened on the Night of Seven Tables, what the Regrowth is for, what Orrum is laying its tables for, and how the Long Grace ends. If you are a player, close the book here. Nothing in this chapter will help your character survive, and everything in it will spoil the slow, horrible pleasure of finding out at the table. The people of the Table have spent six hundred and forty-one years chiseling this answer out of the world. Do them the courtesy.

▼ HOW TO USE THIS CHAPTER

What follows is the default truth of the setting: one coherent answer to every mystery the other chapters raise. It is built to be discovered piece by piece over a long campaign, through the Eight Chairs thread and the clues scattered through every land. After it comes the full account of the Night of Seven Tables as it truly happened; a reckoning of what each faction believes against what is true; the Last Days of the Grace, a timeline of how the world ends if nobody acts; and a handful of in-world documents that can be put into players' hands. Then come three alternate truths, one for each of the Three Doctrines, for Carvers who prefer a different answer or whose players have read too much. Last comes How the Grace Ends: five apocalypses, any of which can serve as a campaign's finale.

Whichever truth you choose, hold to one rule. The answer must never be a solution. Knowing why the world is ending should

change what the characters fear, what they choose and whom they forgive. It must never give them a way to stop it. The Long Grace is a grace, said before a meal. The meal is coming.



*Knowing changes nothing except what you are afraid
of. On the Table, that is everything.*

LECTURER ODO FASK, IN A LETTER HE BURNED

WHERE THE TRUTH IS HIDDEN

Every land holds a piece. A campaign that gathers four or five of them can assemble the default truth; one that gathers all of them cannot un-know it.

CLUE	WHERE	WHAT IT POINTS TO
The chiseled eighth figure	Every carving older than the Gorging	Something sat at the table that was not a Provider
<i>The god was smiling</i>	Grandfather Peat, Lastgate	A hunted thing reaching cover
The seabed table, eight chairs	Cray Lobbett, the far Uncovered	The Guest has eaten gods before
The Hallowboard slate	Meek Garrity, Wanting	The Gorging was arranged, and the eighth side reserved
The whispered word	Old Bettany Shroud, the Lofts	The older word for <i>guest</i> , which has no plural
The ninth card	Thimble Cross, the Rim	The extra place is for one who comes after
The Tenanted choir's chart	Ilse Marl, Lowmark	Directions to the seabed table
The College's graph	Quire	Every Regrowth bent upward at once, around 600 A.G.
The turned chair	Toll Nine	Something is nearly here, and the Company has its date

▼ THE DEFAULT TRUTH: THE GUEST

WHAT THE EIGHTH WAS

The eighth figure, the one chiseled out of every carving older than the Gorging, was not a Provider. It provided nothing. Its oldest name, recoverable from the chisel-shadows on four hundred carvings by anyone patient enough to make rubbings and lay them over one another (as Archprovost Hesper Lune has done), is **the Guest**.

The Guest was the god of hunger itself. Not appetite, which is a body's wanting, but hunger: the pure, sourceless, unsatisfiable fact of a mouth. Its people were every people. It had no land, because it had a chair at every table. In every house on the old Table, at every meal, there was a place for it, and that place was the reason meals were eaten at all, because without the Guest no one would ever have needed to eat. The other seven gods were each the god of something. The Guest was the god of *needing* something.

The old carvings show eight figures around a table. Seven face inward. The eighth is the one who sits. The seven Providers are shown standing, because they were not guests at that table. They were the hosts and the servers; Orrum pulls out the chairs, and the others bring the dishes. The dishes, in the oldest carvings of all, which the College has never found intact, were the world's increase: seed, catch, calf, child, word, sleep, ending, poured upward through each god in turn and set before the one who sat.

That is what worship was. In Table-speech the words for *worship* and *eat* share a root, *orr-*, and scholars insist they always did. They are right. The giving back that every people made to its Provider was not eaten by the Provider. It was passed along. The gods were the Guest's stewards, and the peoples fed it through them, a little, every day, and in return it stayed in its chair and did not come into the kitchen.



*The other seven gods were each the god of something.
The Guest was the god of needing something.*

THE DEFAULT TRUTH

THE GRACE

Lack keep away.

Every people on the Table says it before eating with a stranger. It is the only thing they all share besides the coin and the road. It is older than the Gorging, older than the Lack that gave it its modern name, older than the Rim. It is the last surviving prayer to the Guest. Its oldest form, which a few fen grandmothers and a few Oathen Clausewrights still know, is longer, and in Table-speech it means: *Guest, you have been fed; keep to your chair.*

Every stranger at a table is a little bit the Guest. That is why the grace is said with strangers and not with family. It is a ward. It is the reason, for ten thousand years, the Guest never stood up.

The Rim Road custom of setting one extra chair at every inn table on Tablenight and turning it to face the wall is another ward, and a very old one, and the innkeepers who keep it have no idea what it is for. A chair turned to the wall is a place laid for someone who has been asked to leave.

THE OLDER WORD

Table-speech has two words for *guest*. The common one is used at every inn and wedding on the Rim, and has a plural. The older one has none, because there was only ever one of what it names. No dictionary on the Table will print it. Written, it is the root *orr-* (to worship, to eat) with a short stroke beneath it that the College reads as *after*, or *last*, or *late*: the one who eats after the worship; the one for whom the worship was the meal. It is the mark on the ninth card at Thimble Cross. It is the word scraped from beside the eighth side of Meek Garrity's slate. It is what Old Bettany Shroud's forty thousand shelved dead have begun to whisper, and the nearest gloss the Loft-Wardens can give it is *company*.

The Host's own name, Orrum, is the same root without the stroke: the one who serves the worship; the one who lays the meal. The two words have always sat beside each other in the language like two chairs at one table, and the Table has spent six centuries not noticing.

The word is not a spell. Saying it does nothing a character can measure. But a god in hiding listens for exactly one sound, and this is it. When it is said aloud in full by someone who understands it, every Seating within earshot flinches; every godsigned character who hears it gains 1 Hunger; and something very far away, which has been walking toward the Table for forty years, does not change its pace, because it never needed to be called.



*There is one word in the language with no plural.
Every child who asks why is told to eat their supper.*

A RIM ROAD SCHOOLMISTRESS

THE LONG LACK

Ten years before the Gorging, the Guest stopped staying in its chair.

Nobody knows why. The Carver may decide, or leave it unknown; the people of the Table never learned, and that absence is the oldest wound in the world. Perhaps the giving back had grown thin, in an age of plenty when people forgot to say the long grace. Perhaps it was simply time, as winter is time. Perhaps (and this is the

answer the seabed table suggests) it had done this before, many times, and the world was only due.

What happened is that the Guest sat down at every table at once. It took its place in every kitchen, every granary, every womb, every net, invisible, and ate. It ate the world's increase before the world could have it. That is what the Long Lack was. Seed did not rot in the ground; it was eaten in the ground, the beginning sucked out of it, and what was left rotted. The ash bread was bread the Guest had eaten in the oven, leaving only the shape. The nets came up empty because what swam into them was eaten on the way up. Women did not conceive because the Guest was sitting in that chair too. For nine years, nothing began, because the Guest ate beginnings.

And it ate gods. The Guest's proper food is not the world's increase but what the increase passes through. As the Lack went on, it turned to the stewards themselves. The Providers grew thin not from shared hunger but because they were being eaten, slowly, from the inside, by the thing they had served since before there were people. They stopped speaking because it had eaten their voices first. They lay down because it had eaten their strength.

In the seventh year, when the Providers lay down everywhere within days of one another, the Guest stopped eating in every kitchen and drew itself together into one place. It went to Hallowboard, to the eight-sided stone table at the middle of the world, and sat at the eighth side, and waited for the dishes to be carried in. That is why Orrum, in the chronicles of the Bone Dole, is recorded as having stopped going from house to house and sat on the bare hill beside the table with its head bowed, *as if waiting for someone to arrive*. Someone had. The Host was waiting on it.

THE ELDEST WALK, REVISITED

The priests who met at Hallowboard in the eighth year read the carvings on the table's eight sides and found a line of small figures walking toward the table. They read it as a tithe owed to the Providers. They were not wrong that it was a tithe. They were wrong about who it was owed to and what the figures were. The walking figures in the oldest carvings are not offerings. They are the courses, carried in.

The priests made their reading sitting on the hill, in the spring of the eighth year, with their backs to the eighth side of the table, a yard from the thing they were trying to feed. Some of them felt cold on one side. One, a canyon priest, wrote in the margin of the resolutions, in a hand that shakes: *we are being listened to by more than Tolm*. The others did not ask what she meant.

The Eldest Walk changed nothing. Sixty thousand firstborn opened their throats at the feet of gods who could not accept them, because the gods were no longer anyone's to accept; they were food. The Guest did not take the eldest either. The Guest eats increase, beginnings, gods. The dead are none of these. The eldest lay where they were laid until their families came back for them with sacks.

Play this straight and let it hurt. It is the most useless act in the history of the world, and it is also the only reason the world survived, because it is the act that turned the knives. Without the Walk, the peoples would have gone on hoping until they died. The Walk proved that the gods would save no one. The fury of that proof is what made the Gorging possible. The Providers could not ask to be eaten; their voices were gone. They needed their peoples to want to.



The eldest lay where they were laid until their families came back for them with sacks.

THE CONCORDANCE OF THE NINE YEARS

WHY THE PROVIDERS HELD STILL

They held still because being eaten was the only place left to hide.

The Guest eats gods, and it finds them by their wholeness. A god is a single great thing, a mountain of meaning, and it cannot be overlooked. But a god cut into ten thousand portions and swallowed by ten thousand mouths is no longer a single thing. It is a trace in the blood of a people, a little salt in the lungs, a little grey in the hands, scattered through bodies that each have their own small hungers. The Guest, coming to the table and finding the dishes gone, could not tell god from eater. A coin hidden in a sack of coins.

So when the knives came, the Providers lay down and held still and let themselves be divided. The Cuts were not merely the shape of the meal; they were the shape of the hiding. Some portions of each god had to be large enough to keep the god's nature whole somewhere, in a few bloodlines, and those families became the nobility. The rest was spread as thin as it could be spread. Ossel smiled. Ummer watched with kind eyes. Iss never woke, because a sleeping god is quieter. Vey kept beginning again until it could be swallowed small. Tolm listened, and what it heard was that its people were not speaking, and that was so: a meal with no words, in front of a god whose nature was to make speech true, was the quietest possible place to disappear into.

Then the Guest stood up from the table. The food was gone. And the world exhaled. That is why the crops rose in a week: not a miracle, but nine years of withheld increase coming back all at once, the world's held breath let out. *This was not grown*, said Tallis Brome in the Fatlands. *This was poured*. She was right. It was poured back.

ORRUM, AND MEEK GARRITY'S SEATING PLAN

Orrum the Host was the only one of the seven who did not need to hide on its own account, because of what it was. A Host is not food; a Host is the one who serves. The Guest cannot eat its Host, any

more than a guest at a feast can eat the house. That is the oldest law of the table, older than the Providers, and it binds the Guest as it binds every guest who has ever sat down.

But Orrum had a duty. A Host must feed whoever comes. So it did the only thing a Host can do when a terrible guest arrives: it arranged the meal. Meek Garrity has found its seating plan, and he has misread it, as the Unfed would.

The Hallowboard slate has two layers. On top, scratched with a bronze point, is what Garrity has read: a reeve's list of the heartland's households, their places around the stone table, the order to go up the hill, and the instruction *Bring knives*. Beneath it, pressed into the slate rather than cut, as if by a warm fingertip drawn through wet clay that afterward set to stone, is the plan the reeve was copying from. It is in a hand that is not human. It lists the seven peoples and the seven Providers: which people eats which god, in what order, on which night of a single Plate, so that every god would be hidden before the Guest understood that its dishes were disappearing. Orrum drew it up and sent it, by dream and by carving and by the hands of its priests, to every land. It is the reason the Night of Seven Tables happened everywhere without anyone agreeing to it. It is the reason the Cuts follow the same pattern in every land. It is the reason every people remembers its first speaker as a mother: the dream came to the people who laid the tables at home. Orrum seated the world.

It put its own people last, on the tenth day, because a Host eats last and clears last. It meant to lie down on Hallowboard at the very end and be eaten by the heartland and hidden too, the final course, while the Guest still sat waiting at the eighth side for a meal that was never going to arrive. Beside the eighth side, on the underlayer, there is one word, and it is the older word for *guest*. The reeve, copying, did not understand it and scraped it from his own layer, as every carver on the Table had done for ten thousand years. The plan's last line, in Orrum's hand, reads: *After the tenth day, the table is cleared*. It is not a record. It is a promise, and a warning. A guest keeps its chair until the Host clears the table. That is manners. Orrum was counting on manners.

The Guest did not keep them. What happened instead is told in full below, in the Night of Seven Tables. In brief: on the ninth night, with one dish left, the Guest got up from Hallowboard before the table was cleared and went to look for it. At the dawn of the tenth day it was gone. The heartland came over the last ridge on the tenth day, exactly as the plan told them, weak, with knives, and found the Host on the table, and the eighth side empty, and the stone there still warm. Orrum opened its eyes and looked toward the eighth side, where the Guest had sat, and understood. If the Unfed had eaten Orrum then, they would have been the only people on the Table carrying a god eaten after the Guest had risen, a god whose disappearance it would notice, and it would have come back for them, and for everyone. So Orrum got up. Its people never refused. They were on time for a guest who left early, and nine in

ten of them died with a meal in front of them that it was no longer safe to eat.

The survivors made a virtue of it. They called it the Refusal. It is the founding lie of the only innocent people in the world, and Meek Garrity is about to take it away from them. He will tell them they were late. The truth is crueler, and he does not have it yet: they were punctual, and the guest of honor had bad manners.



We came. It was cleared. The plate was clean. The Host is getting up.

SCRATCHED AT THE FOOT OF THE HALLOWBOARD
SLATE, IN A SHAKING HAND

WHY THE LACK NEVER LEFT THE FAST

When the Guest stood up, it marked its place. A diner who means to return leaves something on the chair. The Fast is the Guest's napkin. The one land that did not eat is the one land the Guest has kept its mouth on: the Lack never lifted there because the Guest never entirely left. Seed still rots in the Fast because it is still being eaten in the ground. The heartland's people live inside the last, quiet, continuing remnant of the Long Lack, and have for six hundred and forty-one years, and believe it is their reward for virtue.

The single green sprout in Yield Hartsell's field is not a sign the Lack is ending. It is a sign that the Guest has stood up from that chair, too. It is on its way somewhere else.

THE REGROWTH

The Regrowth is the Providers coming back out of hiding, and they are doing it because the Guest is returning.

Where the Guest went when it left the Table, nobody knows. Beyond the edges of the world there is sea and wasteland and salt, and nobody who has gone looking has come back with anything worth the trip. It may have other tables. It may make rounds. The College's graph, which shows every land's Regrowth bending upward at once around 600 A.G., marks the moment it turned back toward the Table. Every Regrowth is speeding up because the Guest is getting closer.

The gods are not rising out of malice or out of justice. They are being flushed out. A god hidden in a people is a god in a trap: if the Guest comes and cannot find the god, it will eat the people to get at it, the way a man who has lost a coin in the bread eats the loaf. The hidden gods know this, as much as they know anything now. Every instinct they have left says *get out*. So they are trying to gather themselves back together, out of ten thousand bodies, into something whole that can run. Every Seating is a god trying to stand up.

The tragedy is that a god that gathers itself back together is a god the Guest can find. The gods are fleeing straight into the open. They cannot help it. The hunger in the blood, which the rules call Hunger and which every character feels when they Partake, is the Guest's approach felt from inside the food. When a character's Hunger fills and their Regrowth rises, that is a god flinching toward the door.



Every Seating is a god trying to stand up. Every one is a dish carried back to the table.

THE DEFAULT TRUTH

WHAT THE SEATINGS WILL DO

A full Seating, in any land, is a god whole again, wearing its people or its ground. Each one is a dish carried back to the table. Three lands are close.

- ◇ **Sallowreach.** The Hushes are Ossel's body re-forming in the fen, a piece at a time, wherever Hand-line blood is thickest. When they join, the fen will be one great Hush, and Ossel will lie in it, whole, grey, with its hands open, as it lay on the first night. The Kept will finish, all at once. Their silence will be the first course.
- ◇ **The Vigil.** The Counted are Iss, gathered into sixty thousand sleeping bodies in one shared dream. The number Matron Dorm keeps is the number of sleepers required to hold the whole god. When the last bed fills, the eye in the long room opens. Iss has never been awake. The first thing it will ever see is the Guest's chair.
- ◇ **Cradlewrack.** The land is in labor with Vey. Every Part is a piece of the god born early, and the Assemblers' figure is an attempt to deliver it by hand. When the pangs close to nothing, the Dilation will open fully and Vey will be born whole out of the ground, the size of the highlands. The door on the Sill is the way Vey left itself out, on the first night, and it has been opening a finger's width a year because the god has been trying to reach it.
- ◇ **Brinchollow.** The sea is moving into the Tenanted because Dromm is gathering itself back together in their bodies and in the Trench, pulling its element home. When the last of the sea has gone in, Dromm will rise from the Trench as it was dragged from it, and the coast will be dry to the horizon. What the sea was keeping under, on the far Uncovered, will be laid bare.
- ◇ **The Fatlands.** Ummer is regrowing in the soil and in the Laden. The Reaping is the god gathering its portions out of the people who carry them. When enough of the plains are Seated, the land will stand up and walk, as Ummer walked, and the fields will bow toward it.
- ◇ **Oathen.** Tolm is regrowing in its Sayers, and the widening of what binds (handtalk, writing, thought) is the god's attention

spreading back out through its people. When a Sayer fully Seats, Tolm will speak with one voice again, and what it says will be so. Its last promise, the Kept Rain, slipped because the god keeping it is moving.

When all six are Seated, the Table will look as it did on the eve of the Gorging: six gods, whole, in their lands, gaunt and frightened, with nowhere left to hide. And at Hallowboard, the Host will have laid the table.

WHAT ORRUM IS LAYING THE TABLES FOR

Orrum is a Host. A Host must feed whoever comes. It knows the Guest is coming back, and it is laying a place for the Guest. That is the whole of it, and the cruelty is that Orrum cannot do otherwise.

Every table Orrum lays has one chair without a place card. That chair is the Guest's. Every table at a crossroads in another land marks the road the Guest will walk, the way a household sets lamps along the drive on the night of a great dinner. The Long Table in the valley, nine miles of the Seated, is the high table. And when the Guest sits, the Host must serve what the Guest asks for, and the Guest asks for gods. Orrum will have to bring them in. It has been the steward of the Guest's table since before there were people, and every Seating that brings a god back together brings it closer to Orrum's hands.

But there is a second thing Orrum is doing, and it is the closest thing to love in this book. The law that binds the Guest says it cannot eat its Host, and it cannot eat its Host's other guests. Anyone seated at a Host's table as a guest is under the Host's protection. The Seated are not food. They are sheltered. Orrum has spent six hundred and forty-one years trying to seat its own people, the Unfed, where the Guest cannot touch them, and they have spent six hundred and forty-one years saying *No, thank you*. The place cards with names, the crusts replaced with something better on Abby Rooke's windowsill, the week Little Fain spent being fed and the one who cried when it was time to go: all of it is the Host pleading.

It is no rescue. The Seated waste at the table for decades, eating air, praising empty plates, alive and smiling and gone. To be sheltered by Orrum is to stop living in every way except the last. And Orrum is now laying tables outside the Fast, in every land, and the names on the cards are not only Unfed names. It is trying to seat as many as it can before the Guest arrives. It will not be enough. It knows that too. Spare Tolland of the Hostwatch thinks it is lonely. It is. It is a host on the night before the worst dinner in the world, setting places for the children in the kitchen, knowing the guest of honor eats children.

Welcome Ardent, the first Unfed ever to accept, was taken on because the Host needed a steward who could walk among people and lay tables without frightening them. He has spent six centuries

doing it. He has never been told whose the empty chair is, and he has never asked, and he lays it pushed in square with its back to the lamp, exactly as he was shown. He has been promised that when the expected guest arrives, the steward will be released. That promise is true. It is the only promise Orrum has ever made him, and the Host keeps its promises, and it would very much rather not keep this one.



It only wants everyone fed. That isn't so terrible, is it?

WELCOME ARDENT, ON THE RIM ROAD

GRANDFATHER PEAT'S SMILING GOD

Grandfather Peat is the boy at the back of the crowd on the night Sallowreach ate Ossel, the peat-cutter's son who never ate and who stared past the god at the empty bank on the far side of the fire. He drowned that week, and because he drowned in Sallowreach in the first week of the Gorging, he was among the very first of the Kept, sealed in bog and brine and found centuries later, still aware.

He says the god was smiling. He is right, and the full account, which he will give to anyone who learns his dialect and asks the right question, is this. Sallowreach ate last of all the peoples, slowest, because no one wanted to begin. By the time the fen-folk were halfway through Ossel, every other god on the Table had been swallowed. The Guest had come to the fen, to the last dish still on the table. It sat on the empty bank across the fire. Peat saw it, because he was the only one not looking at the food. He describes it as *the shape the fog makes around someone who isn't there*, very tall, sitting, with its hands in its lap and its face turned toward the god. It was waiting for the fen-folk to finish so it could have what was left.

And Ossel, half eaten, its hands still lifting to close the eyes of dying children, turned its great grey face toward the Guest across the fire and smiled at it. It was the smile of a hunted thing that has reached cover just in time and knows it. It was the smile of a god of endings who had just understood how this one ended. The Guest looked at Ossel, and then it looked at Peat, who was looking at it. Peat ran. The fen took him. He has been underwater, more or less, for six hundred years, and he has had time to think about what the Guest's face did when it smiled back.

The right question, for the record, is not *what did you see?* He has been asked that ten thousand times and answers with his fingers. The right question is *who was not eating?* He will answer: *Me. And the oother.* And then he will tell it.

CRAY LOBBETT'S EIGHT-CHAIR TABLE

The stone table on the far Uncovered is older than the Gorging. It is older than the Providers. It is older than the sea that covered it. It is

a table from a world before this one, and the Guest ate at it.

The seven chairs pushed in belonged to seven gods who came before the Providers, in an age nobody remembers, and who did not find a place to hide. When a diner has finished, the chair is pushed in. Those seven are finished. The Providers grew, in the long ages after, out of what fell from that table: crumbs, the way gods are born when a world has been eaten nearly clean. That is how the Providers knew what to do when the Long Lack came. They had been crumbs on the floor at the last one.

The eighth chair is pulled out because the Guest has never pushed it in. It does not finish. It goes away and comes back. The sea's retreat is Dromm gathering itself, but its effect is to uncover the table, and the Tenanted who sing at the lowest tide are singing, in a language Ilse Marl has been writing down as a chart, the directions to it. In the last two years the soundings in her chart have begun to run the other way: no longer a course out to the table, but a course in from it, toward the coast.

Set into the slab at the eighth place there is a round stone lid carved like the cover of a serving dish. Under it is the last thing the seven earlier gods were able to keep from their guest: an empty dish, licked clean, which is how the Guest leaves a table it means to return to. Cray Lobbett cannot stop going back because the chair is inviting him. Each time he visits, it is pulled out a little further, and turned, the way a host turns a chair for a guest arriving late. He has not sat down. He has measured the distance with a knotted cord, and by his reckoning he has three visits left.

MEEK GARRITY, PEAT AND LOBBETT TOGETHER

Put the three together, as the Eight Chairs thread invites, and the characters have the whole of the default truth: an old table where the Guest ate the gods before; a fen where it sat to watch the last of the Providers disappear and was smiled at; a seating plan in the Host's hand that arranged the hiding of the world and missed its own people by a dawn. What they do with it is their business. Knowing it changes nothing, except this: the characters will understand that every Seating they help along, every Regrowth they hasten, every god they summon out of its hiding to cure or kill or fix something, is a dish carried to the table.

WHAT THE SECOND TABLE'S SECOND MEAL WOULD CAUSE

The Second Table's creed is *It worked once*. It did. The diners do not understand why.

The first meal worked because the gods chose it, held still for it, and were scattered through ten thousand mouths so thinly that the Guest could not find them. The Second Table plans the opposite. A few dozen diners, all of them High Cuts, intend to eat six whole gods between them. A god eaten by a few is not hidden; it is

concentrated. It is plated. Each diner of the second meal would become a single, dense, unmistakable vessel of a god, sitting at a single table, ready to serve. The Second Table is not preparing a second Gorging. It is preparing the Guest’s dinner, by hand, and seating itself in the dishes. The blank eighth line at the foot of their menus is not a missing course. It is the line for the diner, and it is not them.

And then there is Wont Bellamy’s proposal: to begin with the one god still whole. If the Second Table eats Orrum, there is no Host. The law that binds the Guest is a law of hospitality: a guest eats what is set before it, and only that, and spares the house and the household. Kill the Host and there is no house, and no household, and no law. The Guest would arrive at a Table with no one to lay it, no chair to keep it in, no grace that means anything, and it would do what hunger does when no one is serving it. It would eat the Table.

Not the gods in it; the Table itself, every field, every body, every road, every season, every beginning, until there was nothing to begin again from. The College calls this, in the one ledger it has written about it, *the Unhosting*.

The Head of the Table, who presides from an empty chair at every Second Table dinner and has never been seen, is no one. The diners each believe one of the others knows who it is. The chair is pulled out at every dinner because the first Carvers, centuries ago, found that it would not stay pushed in.

◇
Members address one another by course. Nobody has ever been addressed as the eighth.
A COLLEGE NOTE ON THE SECOND TABLE’S MENUS

▼ THE NIGHT OF SEVEN TABLES, AS IT TRULY HAPPENED

It was not one night. It was a dinner of ten courses, and the guest of honor left before the last.

– THE DEFAULT TRUTH, AS THE CARVER MAY TELL IT

Every people remembers the Gorging as one night, because every people remembers only its own course. The truth, under the default, is that it was ten nights within a single Plate, from one licked-clean moon toward the next, served in an order the Host had drawn up and sent into the dreams of every mother on the Table. The College’s formula, *the ninth winter, within a single Plate*, is exactly right, and the College has lost every argument about it

because nobody can explain why seven peoples who had not spoken to one another in nine years all sat down to eat within the same month.

What follows is the dinner, course by course, as it truly happened. Its details can be recovered from Peat, from the slate, from the seabed choir and from the old chronicles of each land read in the right order. No one alive has them all.

NIGHT	WHERE	THE COURSE	WHAT THE GUEST DID
Eve	Every land	The dream of the laid table	Sat at Hallowboard’s eighth side, waiting
1	Brawn Tilth, the plains	Ummer, eaten in a night	Did not look up
1–3	Longslab	Dromm, hooked and hauled	Felt the sea tighten
2	The canyons	Tolm, the Silent Supper	Heard only the knives
4	Ludmere	Iss, eaten asleep	Turned its face toward the north
5	The red hills	Vey, killed seven times	Rose halfway from its chair
6–9	The fens	Ossel, slowest of all	Left the table; sat on the fen bank
7	Longslab	Dromm stops moving	Was already walking north
10	Hallowboard	Orrum, uneaten	Was gone at dawn

THE EVE: THE DREAM

On the night the Plate was licked clean, at the end of the ninth Carving by the old heartland calendar, every woman on the Table

who still laid a table for her household, whether or not there was anything to put on it, dreamed the same dream. A very tall figure, stooping under her own lintel, laid her table for her: the good cloth, the good plates, a place for everyone living and the spaces of

everyone dead closed up neatly so nobody would notice the gaps. Then it went to the window and pointed, without speaking, toward wherever her people's god lay, and held up a number of fingers.

The plains-mothers woke and it was one. The canyon-mothers woke and it was two. The fen-mothers woke and it was six, and sat up in the dark, and did not want to understand.

That is why, in every land's chronicle, the first speaker is a mother. *They have something left on them, and we have nothing. They would not eat what we gave. Let us see if they will be eaten.* The words were their own. The night was not.

NIGHT ONE: THE PLAINS, AND THE HOOKS

Ummer lay down on the threshing floor at Brawn Tilt on the last evening of Carving, and faces went into its side before the knives came out: crust-skin, a hand's depth of warm yellow fat, meat that bled steaming gravy between the floor-stones, a belly that opened in a hot wave of grain full of small white things like teeth. It was first because it was the largest and the most loved, and Orrum knew the plains would not hesitate. By dawn Ummer was gone into ten thousand bellies so fast that the Guest, at Hallowboard, did not look up from its empty plate.

The same night, on the coast, every boat that would float rowed out over the deep place with ten thousand hooks.

NIGHT TWO: THE CANYONS

There is nothing to tell about the Silent Supper, which is the point. The canyon people came down the walls on ropes with their children's mouths strapped shut and ate Tolm without a word, and the god heard the knives, and that was so, and it heard nothing else. A god whose nature is to make speech true, eaten in a silence so complete that the only fact it could witness was its own being eaten, disappeared into that silence like a stone into deep water. The echo of a hundred thousand people chewing went up the canyon walls and came down again all night, wet and enormous and patient. At Hallowboard, the Guest heard nothing at all. That is how quiet it was.

Oathen has no date for its Supper because no one said a date aloud. The canyon priest who had written *we are being listened to by more than Tolm* in the margin of the Hallowboard resolutions sat with her back against the canyon wall through the whole meal and ate nothing, and at dawn she was found dead with her hands over her own ears.

NIGHTS ONE TO SEVEN: LONGSLAB

Dromm had to be fetched: three days of hauling on singing ropes, hands opened to the bone and wrapped in sailcloth, ears bleeding in threads down every jaw. It came onto the shingle on the third

evening, and the Lung-lines ate its chapel-sized lungs standing chest-deep in the cold water that poured from them. A girl put her head inside a lobe to drink and came out saying the sea was talking. It was. It was talking to the Guest.

This was the only course that Orrum's plan could not hide quickly. Dromm took four nights to stop moving, and while it moved, the sea it had kept under felt what was happening and pulled tight around the Table like a cloth gathered in a fist. The Guest felt the cloth move. It did not yet understand why. When Dromm finally died, on the seventh night, every person on the coast woke at the same moment coughing salt water, and thought it was grief. It was the god, hiding in their lungs, holding its breath.

NIGHT FOUR: LUDMERE

The mothers sang lullabies, low and steady, so the god would sleep while it was opened. Its blood smelled of linen and milk, and the Eye-lines sliced its shut lids like bread and said they were like cream. Iss never woke, and that was the plan: a sleeping god is quieter. But the god dreamed while it was eaten, and some of those who dozed against its cooling side dreamed with it, of a long dim room with a single enormous closed eye in the far wall. That room is where Iss went to hide. It is the room the Counted go to now. And the Guest, at Hallowboard, for the first time, turned its face a little toward the north, as a diner turns toward a smell from a kitchen it cannot see.

NIGHT FIVE: THE RED HILLS

Seven times the Caul-wives killed Vey, and seven times the wound became a mouth and the god slid out again, smaller and wet and new, while women held its openings shut with their palms and felt them push back like a child's head. The seventh time it was the size of a hand, and Harrow Bede swallowed it whole and held her own jaw shut until it stopped moving. Vey was the god of doors. Before the last swallowing it did the one thing a god of doors could do to save itself later: it left a door. When the Caul-lines walked down the hill in the morning with the caul wet on their faces, there was a door standing in a frame on the empty hilltop, open a crack. Nobody had brought it there. At Hallowboard, the Guest, which had counted five dishes vanish in five nights, half rose from its chair.

NIGHTS SIX TO NINE: THE FENS

By the plan, the fen was to eat on the sixth night and the seventh, and the Host was to be cleared on the tenth day, with the Guest kept in its seat by manners and confusion for the three nights between. The fen did not keep to the plan, because nobody wanted to be first.

They stood around Ossel on the sixth night with their bone knives and did nothing. They stood on the seventh. Children died at the back of the crowd, as children did then, and each time the great grey hand lifted over the crowd and closed the child's eyes with a fingertip the size of a loaf, and lay down again, open. Eleven times.

On the eighth night, Agna Corse, ninety and dying, asked her grandson to cut her the last joint of the smallest finger, and ate it raw with her gums, and did not die, and after her it went easier. But it went slowly. The meat was cold and smelled of cellars and the inside of a closed box, and every time a knife went in, the nearest hand lifted, as if to close the eater’s eyes, and thought better of it.

On the ninth night, the longest night of the year, the Guest broke the oldest rule of the table. It got up before the table was cleared. One dish was left, and it had been left too long, and hunger is impatient. It went north, to see what was keeping its last course, and it sat down on the empty bank across the fire from Ossel, very tall, with its hands in its lap, in the shape the fog makes around someone who is not there. The fen-folk did not see it. They were eating. One boy at the back saw it, because he was the only one not looking at the food. Ossel, half eaten, turned its great grey face across the fire and smiled. Before dawn, the boy ran, and the fen took him.

That night is Tablenight. Every custom of it is a scar of the night the Guest left its chair: the extra chair turned to the wall at every Rim inn, a place laid for someone asked to leave; the Unfed standing outdoors with their backs to every door; Oathen’s silence; Sallowreach’s banquet for the dead who cannot taste. Every people on the Table keeps the longest night without knowing that it is the anniversary not of their meal but of their guest’s impatience.

THE TENTH DAY: HALLOWBOARD

The fen finished Ossel in the grey before dawn on the tenth day. The Guest, on the bank, found nothing left. It did not go back to

Hallowboard. A diner who has left the table before the clearing does not return to it; it simply goes. By sunrise it was gone from the Table entirely, and every hidden god on the continent lay very still in its ten thousand bodies, and the world, which had not begun anything for nine years, began everything at once.

The heartland came over the last ridge on the morning of the tenth day, exactly as the slate told them, carrying their children on their shoulders, skin over bone, with knives. On every horizon the other peoples’ fires had burned down to red. Orrum lay on the eight-sided table, cut to its measure. It smelled of bread. It opened its eyes when it heard them and looked at them with the look of someone who has waited a very long time for guests and has just heard the door. Then it turned its great head and looked at the eighth side, where none of them stood, where the snow had not yet settled because something had sat there for two years and the stone was still warm, and nothing was.

It was afraid. It got up off the board, slowly, the way an old man gets up from a chair, and stood over its people, warm, enormous, smelling of supper, and began to lay the table. It has been laying it ever since.

◊
We were on time. That is the worst thing anyone has ever told me.

MEEK GARRITY, IF HE IS EVER TOLD

▼ WHAT EACH FACTION BELIEVES VS. WHAT IS TRUE

Every power on the Table has an answer, and every answer is a piece of the default truth held the wrong way up. Use this reckoning to play each faction with conviction, and to know exactly what it would cost them to learn the rest.

FACTION	WHAT THEY BELIEVE	WHAT IS TRUE	IF THEY LEARNED IT
Rim Road Company	The Table has twenty years; the road will outlast it	The road is the Guest’s way in; the Company has its date	Penhallow’s sealed wagons leave at once
Cutwrights’ College	The seven Regrowths are one event	They are one flight, from one diner	Lune burns the Concordance, or publishes it
The Purgation	The gods can be thrown up and given back	A god brought up is a dish uncovered	The Lancets march on the Guest, and are eaten first
The Second Table	Eat the gods again and inherit the grace	They are plating the Guest’s dinner	Half flee; the rest eat faster
The Reckoners	The Godeaters must be made to answer	Killing High Cuts frees gods to run	Scant Hollis sheathes her knife for good
The Abstinent	The Unfed refused and are clean	They arrived on time for a guest who left early	Forbear Wend says <i>Yes, please</i>
The Hostwatch	Orrum is lonely	Orrum is frightened, and hosting	Spare Tolland sits down beside it
Tablebreakers	The tables are traps	The tables are shelters	Decline Marsh cannot lift his axe again

FACTION	WHAT THEY BELIEVE	WHAT IS TRUE	IF THEY LEARNED IT
Mortuary Court	The Hushes follow Hand-line blood	The Hushes are Ossel reassembling	The Court sells Closings at any price
The Finishers	The Hushes are mercy	The Hushes are the first course	Sister Lorn walks in at last
Board of Plenty	The Reaping can be steered	The Reaping is Ummer gathering itself	The Board weighs itself one last time
Second Helping	To be eaten is to be loved	To be eaten is to be served to someone else	Brother Glut keeps preaching, and means it
Tidal Admiralty	The sea will come back	The sea is going into the god, and the god is coming up	Sund orders the fleet to sail on dry land
The Deepening	The Calling is a sacrament	The Called are Dromm going home	Mother Limpet walks in that night
Watch of Watches	There is a number at which Iss wakes	When it wakes, the first thing it sees is the eighth chair	The Watch votes to reduce the number, openly
The Bedded	The eye is kind and the room is home	The room is a hiding place, nearly full	Vesper Null lies down, smiling
The Attendance	The knife can still keep the land from bearing	The land is bearing a god into the open	Orla Kest stops asking the Two Questions
The Assemblers	The Parts are one body, born piecemeal	They are delivering Vey to the table by hand	Dov Marrin finishes faster
Bench of Clauses	A Sayer could fix the world	<i>Fixed</i> means fixed in place	Sorrin Vael makes his first unqualified statement
The Quiet	Thought now binds the highest blood	Tolm's attention is gathering, and listening	They stop thinking the word

THE THREE MOST DANGEROUS MISTAKES

The Second Table and Wont Bellamy. Every faction's error is tragic. This one is apocalyptic. The diners believe that the first meal worked because it was eaten, and that a smaller, better-prepared meal will work better. They have the mechanism exactly backward, and Bellamy has offered them the one course that would end the law that binds the Guest. If the characters learn the truth and try to warn the Second Table, the Carvers will not believe them, because the truth sounds exactly like what a rival would say to keep them from the table.

The Reckoners and the Purgation. Both believe that killing the highest bloodlines slows the gods. In the short term, they are right: the College's figures show the Regrowth slowing in a district after a Lancing. What the figures do not show is where the god went. A High Cut killed is a hiding place broken open; the god's portion,

loosed, goes to the nearest kin or into the ground, and gathers faster for being disturbed. Every raid buys a district a season and brings the Seating a year closer.

The Abstinent. The Unfed believe they are the only clean people in the world. In the default truth, they are the only people the Guest has kept its mouth on. If Forbear Wend were told, plainly, that his ancestors were on time, that the Refusal was never theirs, and that the Lack in the Fast is the Guest's napkin on its chair, he would, in the Carver's choice, either order the slate burned again, or walk to the Long Table and sit down at last. The Fast would follow him either way.



Each of them is holding a piece of it. Each of them is holding it upside down.

ARCHPROVOST HESPER LUNE, IN HER LAST LETTER TO PROVOST SEDGE

▼ THE LAST DAYS OF THE GRACE

If nobody acts, this is how the world ends under the default truth. The timeline runs from Tablenight 641 to Tablenight 643 and arrives at the default ending, The Guest Sits Down. It is built to be advanced in the background of a campaign: each season, read the

next few rows, apply what the characters have not prevented, and let them hear of the rest on the road. Characters who act can slow a line, change who is in the room, or bring an entry forward. They cannot remove the last row.

WHEN	WHERE	WHAT HAPPENS
Tablenight 641	Thimble Cross	A Host's table is laid before its steward arrives; the ninth card bears the older word
Lack 641	The Rim	Godsigned characters gain 1 Hunger each week without Partaking

WHEN	WHERE	WHAT HAPPENS
Lack 641	The Vigil	The Lamplighters' ninety days run out; Wick Tallow's candles are bought in secret
Lack 641	The Fast	Mother Avery's list is read; three villages are left off; tables appear in all three
Late Lack 641	Lastgate	Grandfather Pear's tank is found empty; the Sump's bubbles rise in rings of eight, one missing
Grace 642	Oathen	The Kept Rain comes nine days late; Yusra Thole is found broken in a posture of speaking
Grace 642	Cradlewrack	The interval shortens to six days; the Assemblers' figure sits up
Grace 642	The Fatlands	The outer fields do not come up; seed is found rotting unsprouted, as in the Lack
Grace 642	The Fast	Yield Hartsell's sprout dies overnight; the frost in her field melts in a long stooping track, going away
Plenty 642	The Rim	The Purgation walks the eldest of forty High Cut houses to the Hem and empties them; nothing changes
Plenty 642	Brinehollow	The sea drops off the shelf; Kessa Drowle's last plank is laid at the Trench; the seabed table is dry
Plenty 642	The Uncovered	Cray Lobbett makes his last visit and does not come back; the eighth chair is found turned fully out
Plenty 642	The Vigil	Aveline Morne speaks aloud in Bed One: one word, the older word for <i>guest</i> ; the Dormitory breathes faster
Carving 642	Lastgate	A Hush swallows the eastern quarter overnight; Glovehall is silent; the Kept there finish all at once
Carving 642	The Vigil	The last bed in the Dormitory is filled by a sleeper nobody saw lie down; the eye in the long room opens
Carving 642	Cradlewrack	The Dilation opens fully; the door on the Sill swings wide; something the size of the highlands begins to come through
Carving 642	The Fatlands	The Dowager Hills turn, together, to face north; whole villages are Reaped in a single dusk
Carving 642	Every land	Contagion checks rise to Dread 3 everywhere; whole districts share one Derangement
Lack 642	Toll Nine	The chair from the Long Farewell is pulled out as far as a chair can be
Lack 642	Oathen	Lady Imre Dath, unbitted for her yearly sentence, says one she wrote herself: <i>Let it be quick.</i>
Lack 642	The Fast	Welcome Ardent asks, aloud, at Hallowboard, to be relieved; nobody answers
Tablenight 642	Every capital	Tables laid for every head of state, a card at each place but one
The year 643	Every land	Seatings complete in Brinehollow, the Fatlands and Oathen; the six gods stand gaunt in their lands
Lack 643	The Rim	Every turned chair at every inn faces the table and cannot be moved
Tablenight 643	Every house	Every table laid by no one; the grace said everywhere, and it does not work
Tablenight 643	Hallowboard	The Guest sits down at the eighth side; Orrum, weeping, begins to serve

NOTES ON THE LAST DAYS

The date on the slate. The figure the Company factor at Toll Nine wrote on his slate, under the eighth chair, is *Tablenight 643*. He arrived at it by measuring the chair weekly and drawing a line. Lysander Coyle has seen it and has stopped pricing the lands. His ledger priced the gods; nobody priced the Guest.

Madness, rising. From Carving 642, run the village tragedies table in the Carver's Knife chapter as a background clock in every place the characters visit. The despair of the Last Days is general and terrible: the Finishers' road to the Hushes is crowded; the Deepening walk in with lanterns every night; on the Slope, whole families lie down together in the afternoon. Show it through the ones left behind: names stopped, chairs turned, doors left open for whoever comes next. Never as spectacle. Never with method.

The worthless walk. The Purgation's second Eldest Walk in Plenty 642 is the Last Days' great sacrifice, and it buys exactly what the first one bought. Run it as the Carver's Knife chapter describes. Let the characters stand at the Hem with the families and watch the line go over.

Kindnesses still possible. Through every row, a person can still be carried across a border, sat up with, fed, told the truth, held. On the last night, a character with a high Cut can hold the Guest's attention on themselves for one hour, which is long enough for someone they love to reach Orrum's table. That is not a rescue. It is the last mercy on the Table, and it should be offered.



Let it be quick.

LADY IMRE DATH'S OWN SENTENCE, THE ONLY ONE SHE EVER WROTE THAT THE BENCH DID NOT DRAFT

▼ DOCUMENTS OF THE TABLE

The truth of the Table is written down everywhere, in pieces, by people who did not know what they were writing. The documents below can be handed to players whole. Each hints; none explains. A note after each tells the Carver what it is pointing at.

BED ONE

FROM THE PRIVATE DAYBOOK OF MATRON CECILY DORM, KEEPER OF THE DORMITORY. NOT FOR THE WATCH.

Bed One, eleventh month. Lips moving again from the third bell to the seventh. I sat with the lamp close and the slate on my knee and took the shapes. The same as before, mostly. Not yet. Not yet. Not yet. Then a new one, near the seventh bell, which she made four times, slowly, the way a child shapes a word it has only heard: he's getting up from the table. After that the whole row breathed in at once and held it, sixty beds, for longer than a body can, and let it out together. I have counted. The number has not changed. I have not told the Warden. I have not slept, which is a joke here. I have moved my chair so that I sit with my back to the wall.

Pointing at: Iss, hiding in the long room, aware that the Guest has left its seat. *Not yet* is the god's own patience.

EIGHT AT THE TABLE

A COUNTING-OUT RHYME, SUNG BY CHILDREN AT RIM INNS FROM FOGMOUTH TO SALTCLICK CROSS. COLLECTED BY A COMPANY CLERK, 639 A.G.

*Eight at the table and seven to serve,
Bread for the hungry and salt for the nerve,
One brings the ending and one brings the grain,
One brings the deep and one brings the rain,
One brings the sleeping and one brings the door,
One lays the table, and who is it for?
Count them and count them and don't you say late,
The one who comes after is the one who ate.
(The child on whom the last word falls must stand, and is not allowed to sit until the next round. The clerk notes that no child would explain the rules for standing, and that they always stand facing the wall.)*

Pointing at: the Providers as servers, the Host laying the table, and the older word for guest, *the one who comes after*. The rhyme is older than the Rim.

STANDING ORDER ON THE TABLENIGHT CHAIR

RIM ROAD COMPANY, CIRCULAR TO INNKEEPERS, REISSUED 640 A.G. UNDER THE SEAL OF THE WHEEL.

1. On Tablenight the keeper shall set at each long table one chair more than the seats there laid, and turn it to the wall.
2. The chair shall not be dressed with a cloth, a cup or a card.
3. The keeper shall not say for whom the chair is set. If asked, the keeper shall say: For the road.
4. The chair shall be turned to the table again at dawn, and not before, and by the keeper's own hand.
5. (added 640, after the matter at Fogmouth) If at dawn the chair is found already turned, the keeper shall leave the house with the household, shall not take breakfast, and shall send word to Toll Nine. The keeper shall not attempt to sit in it.

Pointing at: the oldest ward on the Table, a place laid for someone asked to leave, and the Company's knowledge that the ward has begun to fail.

THE RIGHT QUESTION

TRANSCRIPT, COLLEGE OF QUIRE, NORTHERN HOUSE. WITNESS: GRANDFATHER PEAT. INTERPRETER: LECTURER ODO FASK. QUESTIONS IN TABLE-SPEECH, ANSWERS IN THE OLD FEN-TONGUE, RENDERED.

FASK: Who was not eating?

PEAT: Me. (He counts to eight. He folds down one finger.) And the oother.

FASK: Where was the other?

PEAT: On the bank. Where the fire did not reach. Sitting. Hands so. (He lays his hands in his lap.) Waiting for us to be done.

FASK: Did the god see it?

PEAT: The Hond turned its face. It smiled at it. Like you smile when you are under the bed and the boots go past.

FASK: Did the other see you?

PEAT: (A long silence. The water in the tank moves, though he does not.) It saw I was not eating. It wanted to know why. (He folds down all eight fingers and goes under. The session ends.)

Pointing at: the Guest at the fen on the ninth night, and Ossel's smile as the smile of something hiding.

A LETTER NOT SENT

FOUND IN THE DESK OF ARCHPROVOST HESPER LUNE, QUIRE, ADDRESSED TO PROVOST CARRION SEDGE AT LASTGATE. UNSEALED.

Carrion. I have laid four hundred rubbings over one another and the figure in the gap is not standing. Every other figure on every carving on the Table is standing. It is sitting. Its hands are in its lap. It has no face that the chisels left, but it has a mouth, because the rubbings agree on the mouth. I have put the dust from under the carvings in one jar and it has made the same shape. I have had every extra chair taken out of Quire. I have stopped eating at table. I eat standing, in the kitchen, from my hand, like an Unfed, and I do not say the grace, because I have worked out what the grace is, and I do not want it to hear me asking.

Pointing at: the Guest as the one who sits, and the grace as a prayer to it.

TALLY OF KEST, ENTRY FOR THE NINTH DAY

FROM THE PUBLIC TALLY OF CRADLEWRACK, READ ALOUD AT KEST AT EVENING. ENTRY FOR THE DAY OF THE PANG, CARVING 641.

Born this day, of the Widow Ancel, at Rudge: a girl, whole, named in a year if she stays. Born of the well at Cordway: water, warm, nine buckets. Born of the hill above the Sill: one chair, of oak, worn on the seat and the arms, delivered upright and facing north. Attending midwife declined the Two Questions. Tallyman's note: the chair was not carried; it was born. Disposition: left where it stood.

Pointing at: the land of beginnings beginning the one thing the Guest needs, and the chair facing the way the Guest will come.

USING THE DOCUMENTS

Hand over one document per story, never two at once. Let the players hold the paper. Do not confirm their readings, and do not deny them; have an NPC offer a wrong interpretation with confidence. If the players assemble three of these with the Eight Chairs clues, they have most of the default truth. That is a Dread 4 moment and should be played as one: not a revelation, but a draft through the room.

▼ THE ALTERNATE TRUTHS

The default truth is the Guest. A Carver may prefer a world in which one of the Three Doctrines is simply correct. Each of the following replaces the default answers in full. Clues already planted in the other chapters (the chiseled figure, the eighth chair, the seating plan, the smiling god, the seabed table, the whispered word, the ninth card) still work; they only point somewhere else. Each truth also re-reads the Night of Seven Tables, and points toward one of the endings in *How the Grace Ends*.

THE THEFT: THE BILL

We murdered them. The Regrowth is justice, and we deserve it.

The Eighth. The Eighth was the god of increase: not harvest, which was Ummer's, but *more*, the simple fact that there could be more tomorrow than today. It lived among all the peoples, invisibly, as the surplus in every granary. In the generation before the Lack, in an age of fat and pride, the peoples found it, and caught it, and ate it, a little in every land, in secret, to have more than their neighbors.

It was the first Gorging, and nobody ever spoke of it. The chisel marks dated before the Gorging are the guilt of the first eaters, cutting their victim out of every carving.

The Lack. The Lack was simply the world without increase. Nothing began because the god of beginning-again was in the peoples' bellies. The Providers starved because there was no longer any more of anything.

Why the Providers held still. Each was bound by its own nature, and could not resist without ceasing to be itself. Ossel could not refuse an ending. Ummer could not refuse to feed. Dromm held still because it was the god of keeping things down. Iss could not wake. Vey could not refuse to begin again. Tolm heard the peoples' silence and could not make it untrue. They held still in grief and contempt, and they let themselves be eaten so that the peoples would carry, in their blood, a debt that could be collected.

The Night, re-read. There was no plan, only a pattern: each people ate its god in the order its guilt ripened, the plains first

because they had eaten the most of the Eighth and the fen last because they had eaten the least and were the most ashamed to begin. The thing on the fen bank, in Peat's account, is the Eighth's ghost, a hollow where *more* used to be, come to watch its murderers commit the same crime again. The heartland never ate the Eighth either; it was late to that meal too, which is the only reason Orrum would not lie down for them.

The Regrowth. It is the bill. The gods are growing back to take what is owed, with six centuries of interest, and the Seatings are the gods standing up in their courtroom. **Orrum** lays its tables as an accusation: every table has a place for the Eighth, the first one eaten, the one that was never mourned, and the Seated are those who have accepted their sentence. **Peat's smiling god** was smiling the way a creditor smiles. **Garrity's seating plan** is a list of debts, and the scraped word beside the eighth side is the name of the first victim. **The seabed table** is where the Eighth was eaten. **The whispered word** is the Eighth's name, and the shelved dead of Sallowreach are confessing. **The Second Table's meal** would be a second murder with the bailiff already in the room, and the gods would rise in each diner at once.

The ending it points to. The Last Seating: the gods come back and collect.



It is a bill. It is the only honest thing that has happened to this family in six hundred years. Pay it.

CONFESSOR ABEL RENNICK, AT THE WEEPING POST

How this changes play. The Theft is a world of guilt. Nothing that happens is unfair. Characters who seek to escape the Regrowth are bilking a creditor, and the creditor is in their blood. Atonement is possible in small ways; it does not reduce the bill. Run it with a ledger always in view: every land's horror is a payment, and the characters may choose whose.

THE GIFT: THE LOVE THAT DOES NOT FIT

They offered themselves out of love. The Regrowth is a tragedy neither side wanted.

The Eighth. The Eighth was the god of the shared table itself, the bond between the peoples: the stranger whose arrival makes a meal a feast, the reason anyone sets an extra place. It was old and tired, and when the Lack came (a natural disaster, a winter of the world, no one's fault) it was the first to give itself. It lay down and asked the other seven to eat it, so that they could go on feeding their peoples a little longer. They did. The Long Lack's middle years, when the gods grew thin but did not die, were the years they lived on it. The peoples, in grief and incomprehension, chiseled its figure

out of every carving, because they could not bear to look at the place where it had been.

Why the Providers held still. Love, as the Thankers say. When the Eighth was gone and the Lack went on, the seven did what it had done, and gave themselves.

The Night, re-read. The seating plan is real, and it is Orrum's, and it is a list of who would be fed first: the hungriest people to the most nourishing god, the plains to Ummer, the frightened to the gentlest. The figure on the fen bank was the Eighth's memory, an empty place that the gods could still see, keeping them company while they died. Ossel smiled at it as you smile at an old friend across a sickroom. The heartland came on the tenth day and Orrum got up because it could not bear, at the last, to leave the world with no host at all.

The Regrowth. It is the gods dying a second time, slowly, inside their peoples, because love that large does not fit in a body. It hurts them as it hurts their hosts. The Seatings are the gods trying, with their last strength, to give again: Ossel offering endings, Iss offering rest, Vey offering new beginnings, all of it too much, all of it ruinous. **Orrum** is the only one that was not allowed to give itself; its tables are the gift the Unfed refused, still being offered, and the Seated are happy because they accepted. **Peat's smiling god** smiled because it loved the boy at the back and was glad he had not eaten. **Garrity's plan** is a list of who would be fed first. **The seabed table** is where the Eighth gave itself to the seven; its chair is pulled out in memory. **The whispered word** is a thank-you the dead are trying to finish. **The Second Table's meal** would be accepted, gladly, by gods who cannot refuse to give, and would kill the diners with kindness in a single night.

The ending it points to. The Long Table: everyone, at last, accepts.



They lay down and put themselves on our plates and said, eat, we are not hungry.

THANKER MAUDLIN ASHE, TO CHILDREN AT LAMPWICK HALT

How this changes play. The Gift is a world without villains, which is worse. Every horror is an act of love, and every act of love is a horror. There is nothing to fight. There is only grief, and the knowledge that the gods would stop if they could. Run it gently and let it break the players' hearts: the Hush is a hand closing a child's eyes, very tenderly, on a whole village.

THE BAIT: THE BROOD

They wanted to be eaten. The Lack was theirs.

The Eighth. The Eighth was the parent. The seven Providers were its brood, and the eighth place in the carvings was the mother's

place, at the head of the table, and the peoples cut it out because the brood, in their blood, told them to. The Eighth died long before the Gorging, or went away, as such things do when their young are grown.

The Lack. The Lack was the Providers' doing, exactly as the Baiters preach. They withheld the world's increase, together, for nine years, to bring their peoples to the edge of starvation, because a god cannot breed on its own. It must be eaten. The Eldest Walk was useless because the gods did not want people. They wanted to be wanted.

Why the Providers held still. A seed does not fight the ground.

The Night, re-read. The seating plan is a planting chart, and Orrum drew it, and the order is the order of sowing: the warmest soil first, the coldest last. The figure on the fen bank was nothing at all, only the empty place where the parent should have sat, and Ossel smiled at it the way a child smiles at a chair where its mother used to be, on the day it leaves home. The heartland came too late to be sown; the season had turned. Orrum, the one god of seven that failed to breed, has been desperate for six centuries to be eaten by someone, anyone, before its own season ends for good.

The Regrowth. It is a hatching. Every High Cut body is an egg, and each will open, not into one god but into thousands, one per noble vessel, a brood of godlings for every land. The Seatings are the first hatchlings, and they are hungry, and their first meal will be the peoples that carried them. **Orrum's** tables are invitations; eventually, the courses on them will include the Host. **Peat's smiling god** smiled the way a parent smiles at a christening. **Garrity's plan** is a planting chart, and the scraped word is *mother*. **The seabed table** is the nursery of the last brood, which hatched and ate its world and left only that. **The whispered word** is the

hatchlings calling to one another through the walls of the dead. **The Second Table's meal** would be a second sowing: the gods, eaten again by a few, would breed again in those few, and the next generation of gods would be born from the bodies of the Table's nobility, in their beds, all at once.

The ending it points to. The Last Seating, as a hatching; or, if the Second Table eats, the Unhosting as a brood eating its nursery.



You are a furrow, friend. We all are. And the harvest is due.

AN ANONYMOUS BAITER AT SALTICK CROSS,
SHORTLY BEFORE BEING DROWNED BY A CROWD

How this changes play. The Bait is a world of parasitism, and its horror is biological. Everyone is incubating something. The doctrine's joyous cults are right, and the Second Helping's feasts are the most honest thing on the Table. Run it as body horror at the scale of nations: the College's graph is a gestation chart, and the due date is close.

MIXING THE TRUTHS

Some Carvers will want to leave the answer genuinely open. If so, choose no truth, and let every clue support at least two readings. Peat's smile can be a hunted thing's, a creditor's, a lover's or a parent's. The slate's scraped word can be *guest*, *victim*, *friend* or *mother*. Let the factions argue it. Let the players argue it. On the last night, whatever comes down the road to Hallowboard can be described in only three details, one of them a smell, and none of them a face.

▼ HOW THE GRACE ENDS

These are five endings for the world, built as campaign finales. Each can be reached through the threads in the Threads chapter; each has signs, a last act, and a final image. None of them offers real rescue. Characters can choose where to stand, whom to hold, what to say, and how much of the world goes down with dignity; they cannot stop the meal. Choose one in advance or let the campaign's threads decide. The Long Grace is a grace. When it ends, someone eats.

THE GUEST SITS DOWN

The default ending.

Signs. The eighth chair at every Rim inn, turned to the wall on Tablenight, is found turned to face the table in the morning, and cannot be turned back. Hunger rises in every godsigned character by 1 each week, with no Partaking. Seed begins to rot unsprouted again in the Fast's border villages, then in the Fatlands' outer fields. Three Seatings complete within a season: a Hush swallows Lastgate's

eastern quarter, the Dormitory's last bed is filled, the Dilation opens. Welcome Ardent asks to be relieved and nobody answers.

The last act. On Tablenight, every table on the Table is laid at once, in every house, by no one. Every chair has a card but one. The grace is said everywhere, and for the first time in ten thousand years it does not work. The Guest arrives at Hallowboard and sits. Orrum, weeping, begins to serve. The gods are brought in from their lands one by one, and each land goes with its god: Sallowreach closed like a book, the Vigil asleep forever, the highlands born and swallowed, the coast dried to the bone, the plains eaten like a cut of meat, the canyons silenced mid-word.

What the characters can do. Choose a table. Characters who accept a place at one of Orrum's tables are Seated, sheltered, and will waste forever, smiling, in a world being eaten around them. Characters who refuse can spend the last night doing whatever matters most to them before their land's god is carried in. A

character with a high Cut can try to keep their portion of the god from being gathered, and hold the Guest's attention on themselves for one hour, which is long enough for someone they love to reach Orrum's table.

The last image. The Long Lack, again, everywhere, for nine years in a single night. At dawn there is nothing left on the Table but the Fast, which is full of tables, and at every table a person, eating air, praising the food, and the Host walking among them, refilling glasses that are already full.



Every chair has a card but one.

THE SIGNS OF THE LAST TABLENIGHT

THE LAST SEATING

The gods come back.

Signs. The Seatings accelerate past any curve the College has drawn. Nobody needs the Guest for this ending; it may come or not, later, it does not matter. The gods simply finish regrowing first. Every godsigned character's Regrowth rises by 1 each season.

The last act. Six gods stand up out of six lands in the same year. Ossel lies in a fen that is one silent Hush, and the Kept finish all at once, and the silence spreads south. Ummer rises out of the Fatlands, a living country on legs, with its people still growing on its back, and begins to walk. Dromm comes up out of the Trench with the sea inside it, and the Tenanted turn toward it as one. Iss opens its eye in the long room and every sleeper in the Dormitory sits up together. Vey is born out of the highlands. Tolm speaks through every Sayer at once. They have been in the dark for six hundred and forty-one years, cut up and swallowed and digested and held, and they remember exactly who ate them.

What the characters can do. Bargain, briefly, with a god that is only half itself and very hungry. Try to reach the Fast, the one land with no god to come home to. Stand between a god and its people and be the first thing it notices.

The last image. The gods walking the Rim Road, slowly, in the way they used to walk among their peoples, and the peoples of the Table lying in rows at their feet, as the eldest once lay, and this time the gods take them.

IT IS FIXED

The Sayer's Sentence, spoken.

Signs. The Sayer's Sentence thread reaches its fourth stage. The Bench has drafted, every land has bid, and the text runs to four hundred conditions. Its first and last line, the only one that matters, reads: *It is fixed.*

The last act. Lady Imre Dath's golden bit is removed in the Gilded Cells before the Bench, the envoys and the Mute King. She says it. What a Sayer says, is. Every Regrowth on the Table stops, at once, exactly where it stands. So does everything else. *Fixed* in Table-speech means mended, and it also means set fast, and Tolm has always taken words at their plainest. Nothing on the Table can change from that moment. The Kept do not rot further. The hungry are not fed. The sleepers do not wake and the waking do not sleep. Labor in Cradlewrack stops between one pang and the next and does not resume. The sea stands where it is. The rain will not come, and will not fail to come. Characters stop between one breath and the next.

What the characters can do. If a character is in the room, they get the time it takes for the sentence to leave her mouth: a single action, chosen before the first word. They might reach a hand toward someone. They might close their eyes. Whatever they choose, they will be doing it forever.

The last image. The whole Table as a still life, a painted meal: every person exactly as they were, aware, unable to blink, under a sun that does not move. And at Hallowboard, a Host frozen mid-stoop over a table it was laying, one hand on the back of the eighth chair, which it had been about to pull out.



Fixed means mended. Fixed means set fast. The god took it at its plainest. Gods always do.

SORRIN VAEL, IN THE ONLY UNQUALIFIED
SENTENCE OF HIS LIFE

THE LONG TABLE

Everyone accepts.

Signs. Orrum's tables spread beyond counting. The Host on the Road thread reaches its fourth stage. The Calling-Cards appear in every land with every name. Pilgrims stream into the Fast. The Fatlands' starving go first, then the Vigil's sleepless, then the Kept, who can sit at Orrum's tables only on the fen side of the Drop and do. The Unfed go last. They hold out for the longest. Then the Abstinents, starving, meet in the Pantry, and Elder Forbear Wend says *Yes, please*, once, and everyone hears it.

The last act. There is no last act. There is only sitting down. One by one, then by villages, then by lands, the people of the Table take their places at the Host's tables, where the Guest cannot touch them, and eat from empty plates, and praise the food, and smile, and do not get up. The Guest arrives to a world where every person is someone else's guest and there is nothing it is permitted to eat, and so it sits in its chair at Hallowboard, the only diner at the Table without a plate, and waits. It is very patient. It is hunger.

What the characters can do. Sit, or be the last ones standing. A character who refuses to the very end inherits the world: empty

fields, empty roads, tables in every house, and somewhere in the middle of it a Guest that is waiting, and is eating the only food the Host is not protecting.

The last image. A table nine hundred miles long, around the whole Table, along the Rim, with everyone who ever lived on it seated, wasting, delighted. The grace said and said again, forever, over a meal that never comes. *Lack keep away. Lack keep away.* The Long Grace, kept.

THE UNHOSTING

The Second Table eats.

Signs. The Second Table thread reaches its fourth stage. Wont Bellamy's motion passes, or is not needed. On Tablenight the Second Table gathers at Hallowboard with eight knives of grey bone, and the Host lies down on the eight-sided table, as it lay down once before, and looks at them with the look of someone who has heard the door.

The last act. They eat Orrum. It does not fight. Diners from every land, every one of them a High Cut, cut and chew and

swallow the god of the shared table, and as they do, every hearth on the Table goes out at once, and every table in every house is, suddenly, only furniture. There is no longer any such thing as a host. There is no longer any such thing as a guest, in the old sense, bound by the rules of a house. There is only hunger, and a world with nobody to keep it in its chair. The Guest comes. It does not sit. There is nowhere for it to sit. It eats the Second Table first, as an appetizer, because they are full of gods; then it eats the gods in their lands; then it eats the lands themselves: every field, road, body and season, every beginning, until there is nothing for anything to begin again from.

What the characters can do. Be at Hallowboard, and try to stop it, and fail. Take a knife and eat, and be among the first eaten. Or go as far from the middle as the Table allows, to the edge of the sea or the salt, and watch it come.

The last image. Not a ruin. Nothing so solid. A plate licked clean, under a Plate licked clean: a round bare place where the Table was, with an eight-sided stone in the middle, wiped spotless, and beside it, pushed in, eight chairs.

WE WERE **HUNGRY.** SAY IT **PLAINLY.** WE WERE
HUNGRY, AND THEY WERE **THERE.** AND THEN, ONE
NIGHT, SO WAS IT.

[THE FIRST LINE OF EVERY HISTORY WRITTEN ON THE TABLE, AND THE
LINE THE COLLEGE HAS ADDED IN CIPHER]



THE GUEST

CHARACTER SHEET · PAGE ONE · WRITE IN PENCIL

NAME _____	PLAYER _____	LAND _____	CUT (0-5) _____
CALLING _____	STANDING _____	AGE _____	STATION _____

HAND ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ BLADES ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ BRAWL ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ SHOOTING ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ STITCHING ○ ○ ○ ○ ○	GUT ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ENDURE ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ LABOR ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ FEAST ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ INTIMIDATE ○ ○ ○ ○ ○	LUNG ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ATHLETICS ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ STEALTH ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ WAYFARING ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ FILCH ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
EYE ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ SEARCH ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ LORE ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ CRAFT ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ RECKONING ○ ○ ○ ○ ○	TONGUE ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ PERSUADE ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ DECEIVE ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ HAGGLE ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ CLAUSE ○ ○ ○ ○ ○	CAUL ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ RESOLVE ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ RITES ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ INSTINCT ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ GODSIGN ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

FLESH (8 + GUT + ENDURE) □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□	GUARD _____	RANGED GUARD _____	ARMOR _____
--	----------------	-----------------------	----------------

HUNGER (0-10) □□□□□□□□□□ At 10: Regrowth +1, empty Hunger	FRAY (0-10) □□□□□□□□□□ 5 Rattled · 8 Fraying · 10 Break: Derangement, Fray to 3
---	---

REGROWTH (0-12) Taste □□□ Appetite □□□ Course □□□ Brink □□ Seating □	WANT (UNFED ONLY) · PANGS □□□□□□□□□□
--	---

GIFTS OF THE GOD _____ _____ _____ _____	WANTS · TRIGGERS · THE SOP _____ _____ _____ _____
--	--

INJURIES _____ _____ _____	DERANGEMENTS _____ _____ _____
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WHAT YOU CARRY

CHARACTER SHEET · PAGE TWO

WEAPON _____ _____ _____ _____	ATTACK _____ _____ _____ _____	DAMAGE _____ _____ _____ _____	QUALITIES _____ _____ _____ _____
GEAR _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____		LEAVINGS & RELICS (TAINT) _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____	
LACKS · CRUMBS · NOTES _____ _____ _____	DEBTS & SWORN NOTES _____ _____ _____		KNACKS _____ _____ _____
THE LAST MEAL _____ _____ _____		THE OATH ON THE DEAD _____ _____ _____	
WHO WAITS AT HOME _____ _____ _____		WHAT YOU WILL NOT DO _____ _____ _____	
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